PROF. ADELEKE DANIEL DUROJAIYE (PHD)

BATTLES MEN FIGHT ALONE

The Hidden Struggles, Silent Sacrifices, Emotional Wounds, and Unspoken Realities of Manhood

TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY GLOBAL EXTENSION USA

BATTLES MEN FIGHT ALONE

Battles Men Fight Alone

The Hidden Struggles, Silent Sacrifices, Emotional Wounds, and Unspoken Realities of Manhood

Prof. Adeleke Daniel Durojaiye (PhD)

TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY GLOBAL EXTENSION USA

First Edition · 2026

Battles Men Fight Alone

The Hidden Struggles, Silent Sacrifices, Emotional Wounds, and Unspoken Realities of Manhood

First Edition, 2026

Published by TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY GLOBAL EXTENSION USA

© 2026 Prof. Adeleke Daniel Durojaiye (PhD). All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means — electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise — without the prior written permission of the publisher, except for brief quotations embodied in critical articles, reviews, and scholarly works with full attribution.

ISBN (print): to be assigned
ISBN (electronic): to be assigned

General information notice. This book offers psychological insight, personal development guidance, and practical self-development exercises for general readers. It is not a substitute for individual assessment, diagnosis, or treatment by a qualified health professional. Readers who are experiencing persistent distress, or who are concerned about their mental health, substance use, or safety, are encouraged to consult a qualified professional. Where a chapter discusses suicide, self-harm, addiction, or crisis, the text directs the reader to immediate professional and emergency support.

Limits of general advice. Every person's circumstances, culture, health history, and obligations differ. Exercises, worksheets, and self-assessments in this book and its appendices are educational tools. They are not tests, and they do not produce a diagnosis. Readers should adapt the material to their own situation and, where appropriate, work through it with a counsellor, therapist, physician, or trusted mentor.

Stories and illustrations. All case stories, vignettes, dialogues, and composite characters in this book are original illustrative material created for teaching purposes. They are not depictions of identifiable individuals, and any resemblance to specific persons or events is coincidental. Where a story is presented, it is labelled as illustrative or composite.

Illustrations. Diagrams were prepared for this edition. Photographs are AI-generated illustrative images created for this edition and are labelled as illustrative images. They do not depict identifiable real persons or specific events.

Cultural scope. The book is written from a broadly international perspective with particular attention to African and Nigerian contexts, including the expectations placed on men within extended-family systems. Readers elsewhere are encouraged to translate the guidance into their own cultural setting.

Style. British spelling is used throughout. Terms that may be unfamiliar to general readers are defined in the Glossary.

Typeset in EB Garamond and Source Sans 3. Trim size 6 × 9 inches.

DEDICATION

To every man who has carried a weight he could not describe to anyone — and who kept going anyway.

And to the families, friends, and professionals who learn to notice the quiet ones.

Contents

Acknowledgments ..... **xxi**
Foreword ..... **xxiii**
Preface: Why This Book Must Be Written ..... **xxv**
The Three Reasons This Book Was Written xxv
What This Book Is Not xxvi
Why Now xxvii
Author's Note ..... **xxix**
List of Figures and Illustrations ..... **xxxiii**
List of Tables ..... **xxxix**
Introduction: The Battles Behind a Man's Silence ..... **xli**
The Subject of the Book xli
Six Ideas That Run Through the Book xlii
How the Book Is Organised xliv
What the Reader Can Expect xlv
How to Use This Book ..... **xlvii**
The Structure of a Chapter xlvii
Routes Through the Book xlviii
Pace and Practice xlviii
A Note on Order, Safety, and Limits xlix
The Appendices xlix
A Word to the Reader Who Is Not a Man l

PART I The Silent World of Men **1**

1 The Man Nobody Really Knows **3**
Introduction 3
1.1 The Public Image and the Private Reality 4
1.2 Why Men Conceal Their Deepest Struggles 6
1.3 The Emotional Cost of Appearing Strong 9
1.4 The Loneliness Behind Achievement 13
1.5 When Silence Becomes a Survival Strategy 15
1.6 Understanding the Man Behind the Responsibilities 19
1.7 Illustrative Case: Two Years in the Life of a Man Who Was Managing 20
1.8 Practical Exercise: The Two Accounts 23
Reflection Questions 25
Further Reading 26

2 The Burden of Being a Man **29**
Introduction 29
2.1 Society's Expectations of Masculinity 30
2.2 The Pressure to Provide, Protect, and Perform 33
2.3 The Fear of Being Considered Weak 36
2.4 Responsibility Without Emotional Support 38
2.5 When Manhood Becomes a Lifelong Examination 40
2.6 Redefining Strength Beyond Endurance 42
2.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Never Off Duty 45
2.8 Practical Exercise: The Script Audit 47
2.9 Common Questions Men Ask 49
Reflection Questions 51

Further Reading . . . 52

3 The Tears That Never Fall . . . 53
Introduction . . . 53
3.1 Why Some Men Struggle to Express Pain . . . 54
3.2 Emotional Suppression and Its Consequences . . . 56
3.3 The Difference Between Self-Control and Emotional Avoidance . . . 58
3.4 Crying Without Shame . . . 61
3.5 Unprocessed Grief and Emotional Exhaustion . . . 63
3.6 Learning to Acknowledge Difficult Feelings . . . 65
3.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Left Standing . . . 68
3.8 Practical Exercise: Building the Vocabulary . . . 69
3.9 A Word to Partners, Children, and Friends . . . 71
Reflection Questions . . . 73
Further Reading . . . 73

4 The Loneliness of the Strong Man . . . 75
Introduction . . . 75
4.1 Surrounded by People but Feeling Alone . . . 76
4.2 Why Successful Men Experience Isolation . . . 77
4.3 The Disappearance of Meaningful Friendships . . . 80
4.4 When Everyone Needs You but Nobody Checks on You . . . 84
4.5 Emotional Intimacy Beyond Romantic Relationships . . . 85
4.6 Rebuilding Genuine Human Connection . . . 89
4.7 Illustrative Case: Ninety Minutes in a Car Park . . . 90
4.8 Practical Exercise: The Connection Audit . . . 92
Reflection Questions . . . 94
Further Reading . . . 95

PART II The Battles of the Mind 97

5 Fighting Demons Nobody Can See . . . 99
Introduction . . . 99
5.1 Internal Struggles and Psychological Distress . . . 100
5.2 Anxiety Hidden Beneath Confidence . . . 102
5.3 Persistent Worry and Intrusive Thoughts . . . 105
5.4 Shame, Guilt, and Unresolved Memories . . . 108
5.5 Recognising When Distress Requires Professional Support . . . 111
5.6 Finding Language for Invisible Pain . . . 115
5.7 Illustrative Case: The Executive Who Kept a Notebook . . . 116
5.8 Practical Exercise: Writing the Account You Cannot Say . . . 117
Reflection Questions . . . 120
Further Reading . . . 121

6 Depression Behind a Smiling Face . . . 123
Introduction . . . 123
6.1 Understanding Depression in Men . . . 124
6.2 Irritability, Withdrawal, and Emotional Numbness . . . 125
6.3 The Dangers of Untreated Depression . . . 129
6.4 Why Some Men Resist Seeking Help . . . 131
6.5 Supportive Relationships and Evidence-Based Treatment . . . 133
6.6 What Families, Friends, and Employers Can Do . . . 135
6.6 Reclaiming Emotional Well-Being . . . 136
6.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Whose Family Thought He Had Changed . . . 137
6.8 Practical Exercise: The Two-Week Symptom Log and the Decision Point . . . 139
6.9 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 141
Reflection Questions . . . 144
Further Reading . . . 144

7 The Fear of Failure . . . 147
Introduction . . . 147
7.1 The Pressure to Succeed at All Costs . . . 148
7.2 Comparing Personal Progress with Others . . . 151
7.3 Financial Failure and Wounded Self-Esteem . . . 153
7.4 Perfectionism and Fear of Judgment . . . 155
7.5 Recovering from Disappointment . . . 157
7.6 Separating Personal Worth from Performance . . . 160
7.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Standard . . . 162
7.8 Practical Exercise: The Worth and Performance Audit . . . 164
7.9 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 166
Reflection Questions . . . 168

Further Reading 168

8 The War Against Self-Doubt 171
Introduction 171
8.1 Feeling Inadequate Despite Achievement 172
8.2 Impostor Feelings and Insecurity 174
8.3 The Influence of Childhood Criticism 176
8.4 Negative Internal Dialogue 179
8.5 Building Realistic Confidence 181
8.6 Developing a Healthier Self-Concept 184
8.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Years Before the Obvious Question 186
8.8 Practical Exercise: The Critic's File 188
8.9 Common Questions Men Ask 190
Reflection Questions 192
Further Reading 193

PART III The Financial Battles Men Fight 195

9 The Empty Pocket Behind the Confident Smile 197
Introduction 197
9.1 Financial Struggles Hidden from Family and Friends 198
9.2 The Shame Associated with Financial Hardship 201
9.3 Living Beyond One's Means to Maintain Appearances 203
9.4 Debt, Anxiety, and Emotional Strain 205
9.5 Asking for Assistance Without Losing Dignity 207
9.6 Rebuilding Financial Stability 210
9.7 Illustrative Case: The Man With Two Bank Accounts 211
9.8 Practical Exercise: The Position Paper and the Disclosure Plan 213
9.9 Common Questions Men Ask 215
Reflection Questions 217
Further Reading 218

10 When Everyone Depends on You 219
Introduction 219
10.1 The Expectations Placed on Family Providers 220
10.2 Supporting Parents, Spouses, Children, and Relatives 222
10.3 The Emotional Burden of Being Financially Indispensable 224
10.4 Setting Boundaries Without Abandoning Responsibility 227
10.5 Shared Financial Planning 230
10.6 Preventing Provider Burnout 232
10.7 Illustrative Case: The Eldest Son of Seven 234
10.8 Practical Exercise: The Dependency Map and the Allocation Plan 236
10.9 Common Questions Men Ask 237
Reflection Questions 240
Further Reading 240

11 The Pressure to Become Successful 243
Introduction 243
11.1 Society's Definition of a Successful Man 244
11.2 Career Ambition and Personal Identity 245
11.3 Delayed Achievement and Disappointment 248
11.4 Unemployment, Underemployment, and Lost Opportunities 250
11.5 The Hidden Cost of Constant Comparison 252
11.6 Creating an Individual Definition of Success 253
11.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Twelve Years Behind 256
11.8 Practical Exercise: The Personal Definition of Success 258
11.9 Common Questions Men Ask 260
Reflection Questions 262
Further Reading 262

12 The Man Who Cannot Afford to Break Down 265
Introduction 265
12.1 Working Through Physical and Emotional Exhaustion 266
12.2 The Fear of Losing Income 268
12.3 When Rest Feels Like Irresponsibility 270
12.4 Workplace Stress and Chronic Overwork 272
12.5 Balancing Ambition with Personal Well-Being 276
12.6 Building a Sustainable Life 277
12.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Booked the Appointment Three Times 281
12.8 Practical Exercise: The Capacity Audit and the Sustainable Week 283
12.9 Common Questions Men Ask 284

PART IV The Battles of Love and Relationships 287

13 The Heartbreak Men Rarely Discuss 289
Introduction 289
13.1 Emotional Pain After Relationship Loss 290
13.2 Why Men Sometimes Conceal Romantic Grief 293
13.3 Rejection and Damaged Self-Worth 295
13.4 Betrayal and Broken Trust 296
13.5 Healing and Learning to Love Again 299
13.6 Illustrative Case: The Widower and the Man Who Was Left 301
13.7 Practical Exercise: The Relationship Grief Inventory 303
13.8 Common Questions Men Ask 305
Reflection Questions 307
Further Reading 308

14 Loving Someone Who Does Not Understand Your Pain 309
Introduction 309
14.1 When Your Partner Does Not Understand 311
14.2 Why Disclosure Is Hard — For Both of You 313
14.3 The Cost of Being Misunderstood 315
14.4 How to Be Understood: A Structured Approach 317
14.5 When Understanding Cannot Be Found in the Relationship 320
14.6 Decision Framework: Staying, Renegotiating, or Leaving 321
14.7 Illustrative Case: Twenty-Two Years in the Same House 323
14.8 Practical Exercise: The Disclosure Plan and the Two-Chair Conversation 326
14.9 Common Questions Men Ask 327
Further Reading 328

15 The Silent Battles of Marriage 331
Introduction 331
15.1 Silent Struggles Inside Marriage 332
15.2 How Silence Takes Over a Marriage 334
15.3 Causes of Marital Dissatisfaction 336
15.4 A Communication Framework for Serious Marital Disagreements 337
15.5 Responsibility, Sacrifice, and the Point of Injury 339
15.6 When to Seek Help 341
15.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Account 343
15.8 Practical Exercises 345
15.9 Common Questions Men Ask 347
Reflection Questions 349
Further Reading 350

16 The Pain of Rejection and Betrayal 351
Introduction 351
16.1 The Many Faces of Rejection 352
16.2 What Rejection Does to a Man's Mind 354
16.3 Betrayal: When Trust Is Broken 355
16.4 The Pain of Being Misjudged 358
16.5 Recovering from Rejection and Betrayal 360
16.6 Rebuilding Trust in Yourself and Others 363
16.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Accused Without a Hearing 365
16.8 Practical Exercise: The Injury Audit and Recovery Plan 368
16.9 Common Questions Men Ask 370
Reflection Questions 372
Further Reading 372

PART V The Battles of Family and Fatherhood 375

17 The Father Who Suffers in Silence 377
Introduction 377
17.1 The Weight of Being a Father 378
17.2 The Father's Silent Sacrifices 380
17.3 Fear of Failing as a Father 383
17.4 When a Father Cannot Show Emotion 386
17.5 The Father Who Is Present but Unseen 388
17.6 Building a Father's Legacy of Honesty 389
17.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Notebooks 391
17.8 Practical Exercise: The Fatherhood Inventory 393
17.9 Common Questions Men Ask 395
Reflection Questions 397
Further Reading 398

18 The Husband Everyone Expects to Be Strong 399
Introduction 399
18.1 The Expectations Placed on a Husband 400
18.2 The Need to Be Needed 402
18.3 When a Husband Feels Unseen 403
18.4 The Cost of Continuous Responsibility 405
18.5 Rediscovering Identity Beyond the Role 408
18.6 Building a Marriage Where Emotion Is Allowed 410
18.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Loved His Wife and Did Not Know Her 412
18.8 Practical Exercise: The Role and the Person 414
18.9 Common Questions Men Ask 416
Reflection Questions 418
Further Reading 419

19 The Son Who Became a Man Too Early 421
Introduction 421
19.1 When Childhood Ends Too Soon 422
19.2 The Weight of Early Responsibility 424
19.3 The Child Who Had to Be Strong for the Family 425
19.4 The Long-Term Effects of Parentification 427
19.5 Reclaiming the Lost Years 429
19.6 Healing the Boy Inside the Man 432
19.7 Illustrative Case: The Eldest of Nine 434
19.8 Practical Exercise: The Early Responsibility Audit 436
19.9 Common Questions Men Ask 438
Reflection Questions 441
Further Reading 441

20 The Pain of Being an Unappreciated Man 443
Introduction 443
20.1 The Experience of Being Taken for Granted 444
20.2 Sacrifice That Goes Unnoticed 446
20.3 The Difference Between Appreciation and Praise 447
20.4 The Bitter Man: How Resentment Grows 449
20.5 Learning to State Your Own Value 451
20.6 Creating a Family Culture of Recognition 453
20.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Thanked at the Funeral 456
20.8 Practical Exercise: The Contribution Inventory and the Statement of Position 459
20.9 Common Questions Men Ask 460
Reflection Questions 463
Further Reading 463

PART VI The Private Battles of Identity and Self-Worth 465

21 The Man in the Mirror 467
Introduction 467
21.1 The Image a Man Presents to the World 468
21.2 The Gap Between the Image and the Man 470
21.3 Private Shame and the Fear of Exposure 472
21.4 The Struggle to Accept Who You Are 475
21.5 Facing the Truth Without Self-Destruction 477
21.6 Becoming the Man You Want to Be 478
21.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Two Men 481
21.8 Practical Exercise: The Inventory, the Acceptance, and the Specification 484
21.9 Common Questions Men Ask 485
Reflection Questions 487
Further Reading 488

22 The Battle Against Personal Weaknesses 491
Introduction 491
22.1 Naming the Weakness: What Men Struggle With 492
22.2 The Hidden Cost of Private Shame 494
22.3 Why Willpower Alone Fails 495
22.4 Understanding Your Patterns and Triggers 497
22.5 Practical Strategies for Change 499
22.6 Accountability and Honest Self-Examination 501
22.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Two People After Six 503
22.8 Practical Exercise: The Weakness Audit and the Change Plan 506
22.9 Common Questions Men Ask 508
Reflection Questions 510
Further Reading 511

23 The Secret Struggle With Addiction ... 513
Introduction ... 513
23.1 Understanding Addiction ... 514
23.2 The Forms Addiction Takes in Men ... 517
23.3 Why Addiction Is Concealed ... 519
23.4 What Addiction Costs ... 520
23.5 The Routes to Recovery ... 522
23.6 Relapse, and the Long Work ... 523
23.7 When It Is Someone Else ... 525
23.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Never Drank at Home ... 527
23.9 Common Questions Men Ask ... 530
Reflection Questions ... 532
Further Reading ... 532

24 When a Man Loses Himself ... 535
Introduction ... 535
24.1 The Loss of Identity in Mid-Life ... 536
24.2 When the Roles Disappear ... 538
24.3 The Empty Season: When a Man Does Not Know Who He Is ... 541
24.4 The Search for Meaning Outside Achievement ... 543
24.5 Reconstructing a Self After Rupture ... 545
24.6 Finding Purpose in the Second Half of Life ... 547
24.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Retired on a Friday ... 549
24.8 Practical Exercise: The Role Inventory and the Reconstruction Plan ... 552
24.9 Common Questions Men Ask ... 554
Reflection Questions ... 556
Further Reading ... 557

PART VII The Battles Men Face in Society 559

25 The World That Judges a Man by His Results ... 561
Introduction ... 561
25.1 Measuring a Man by What He Produces ... 562
25.2 The Price of Being Seen as a Failure ... 564
25.3 When Society Has No Place for Your Version of Success ... 566
25.4 Dignity in a World That Values Achievement ... 568
25.5 Choosing Your Own Measure of Worth ... 570
25.6 Living Without Needing Approval ... 572
25.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Written Off ... 574
25.8 Practical Exercise: The Judgement Audit and the Personal Measure ... 577
25.9 Common Questions Men Ask ... 579
Reflection Questions ... 581
Further Reading ... 582

26 The Betrayal of Friends and Brothers ... 583
Introduction ... 583
26.1 The Friendships Men Build and What They Rely On ... 584
26.2 When a Friend Breaks Faith ... 586
26.3 The Brothers of Adulthood: Family Loyalty and Its Failures ... 588
26.4 The Anatomy of a Betrayed Friendship ... 591
26.5 What Betrayal Taught You: Lessons Without Bitterness ... 592
26.6 Choosing Better Men: Discerning Friendship ... 594
26.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Men and the Contract ... 596
26.8 Practical Exercise: The Friendship Audit and the Rebuilding Plan ... 599
26.9 Common Questions Men Ask ... 601
Reflection Questions ... 603
Further Reading ... 604

27 The Man with Nobody to Call ... 605
Introduction ... 605
27.1 The Forms Isolation Takes in Men's Lives ... 606
27.2 How a Man Ends Up with Nobody to Call ... 609
27.3 What Isolation Does to a Man ... 611
27.4 What Stops a Man from Reaching Out ... 613
27.5 Building a Network from Nothing ... 615
27.6 Illustrative Case: The Widower Who Had Nobody to Call ... 618
27.7 Practical Exercise: The Person You Would Call ... 621
27.8 Common Questions Men Ask ... 623
Reflection Questions ... 625
Further Reading ... 626

PART VIII The Battles of Loss, Regret, and Broken Dreams 627

28 The Dreams That Died Quietly 629
Introduction 629
28.1 The Dreams a Man Carries 630
28.2 What Kills a Dream Quietly 633
28.3 The Ache of a Dream Nobody Knows About 636
28.4 Grief for Something That Never Existed 639
28.5 When the Dream Dies Late 641
28.6 The Life You Built Instead 643
28.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Papers 646
28.8 Practical Exercise: Closing a Dream, Advancing a Dream 649
28.9 Common Questions Men Ask 651
Reflection Questions 653
Further Reading 654

29 Living With Regrets Nobody Knows About 655
Introduction 655
29.1 The Regrets Men Carry 657
29.2 Why the Regrets Nobody Knows About Are the Heaviest 659
29.3 The Anatomy of Regret 661
29.4 The Uses and the Abuses of Regret 663
29.5 Repairing What Can Be Repaired 665
29.6 What Cannot Be Repaired 667
29.7 The Prohibition on Transferring the Debt 670
29.8 Practical Exercise: The Regret Inventory and the Plan 674
29.9 Common Questions Men Ask 676
Reflection Questions 678
Further Reading 679

30 Grieving Without an Audience 681
Introduction 681
30.1 The Grief Men Are Not Given 683
30.2 How Men Grieve, and Why It Looks Like Nothing 685
30.3 What Grief Does Behind the Silence 687
30.4 The Unattended Funeral 689
30.5 When the Loss Cannot Be Spoken Of 691
30.6 The Arrangements That Give Grief a Place 693
30.7 When Grief Becomes a Condition 695
30.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Conducted Both Funerals 698
30.9 Practical Exercise: Giving a Loss a Place 701
30.10 Common Questions Men Ask 702
Reflection Questions 705
Further Reading 705

PART IX The Battles of Leadership, Power, and Responsibility 707

31 The Loneliness of Leadership 709
Introduction 709
31.1 What a Position of Authority Does to Relationships 710
31.2 The Isolation of the Position 713
31.3 The Weight Nobody Sees 714
31.4 When the Leader Has Nothing Left 717
31.5 Leading Without Losing Yourself 718
31.6 Leading a Household as Though It Were an Organisation 722
31.7 Illustrative Case: The Principal Who Held Everything 724
31.8 Practical Exercise: The Load Audit and the Six Arrangements 728
31.9 Common Questions Men Ask 730
Reflection Questions 732
Further Reading 732

32 The Man Who Must Always Have Answers 735
Introduction 735
32.1 Where the Requirement Comes From 737
32.2 What the Requirement Costs 739
32.3 The Knowledge Trap 741
32.4 When the Answer Is Not Yours to Give 743
32.5 Saying "I Do Not Know" Without Losing the Room 744
32.6 Questions as a Competence 746
32.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Could Not Ask the Doctor 749
32.8 Practical Exercise: The Answer Audit 752

32.9 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 753
Reflection Questions . . . 756
Further Reading . . . 756

33 Carrying Other People's Problems . . . 759
Introduction . . . 759
33.1 The Man Who Is Everyone's Solution . . . 760
33.2 How a Man Becomes Everyone's Solution . . . 762
33.3 What the Role Costs . . . 764
33.4 Boundaries Without Coldness . . . 766
33.5 Assistance and Rescue . . . 769
33.6 Distributing the Load . . . 770
33.7 Practical Exercise: The Inventory and the Distribution . . . 777
33.8 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 778
Reflection Questions . . . 781
Further Reading . . . 781

PART X Healing the Man Behind the Silence 783

34 When Silence Becomes Dangerous . . . 785
Introduction . . . 785
34.1 The Point at Which Silence Stops Protecting . . . 786
34.2 What the Unspoken Does to the Body and the Mind . . . 789
34.3 The Five Dangerous Silences . . . 791
34.4 The Signs That Silence Has Become Dangerous . . . 793
34.5 The Emergency: The Safety Plan . . . 795
34.6 Breaking a Silence Safely . . . 798
34.7 Practical Exercise: The Assessment, the Safety Plan, and the Disclosure Plan . . . 804
34.8 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 806
Reflection Questions . . . 808
Further Reading . . . 809

35 The Courage to Ask for Help . . . 811
Introduction . . . 811
35.1 Why Asking Is Difficult for Men . . . 812
35.2 What Asking Actually Costs . . . 815
35.3 The Map of Available Help . . . 817
35.4 How to Ask . . . 819
35.5 Asking for What You Need . . . 822
35.6 When You Are Asked . . . 824
35.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Asked the Wrong Question for Six Years . . . 825
35.8 Practical Exercise: The Ledger and the Request . . . 829
35.9 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 830
Reflection Questions . . . 833
Further Reading . . . 833

36 Healing the Wounded Man . . . 835
Introduction . . . 835
36.1 The Wounds Men Carry . . . 837
36.2 What Healing Is Not . . . 839
36.3 The Four Conditions of Recovery . . . 841
36.4 The Sequence and the Work . . . 844
36.5 When Professional Treatment Is Required . . . 846
36.6 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Still There . . . 848
36.7 Practical Exercise: The Inventory, the Conditions, and the Plan . . . 852
36.8 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 854
Reflection Questions . . . 856
Further Reading . . . 856

37 Learning to Rest Without Feeling Guilty . . . 859
Introduction . . . 859
37.1 Why Rest Is Difficult for Men . . . 860
37.2 What Rest Actually Is . . . 862
37.3 What the Absence of Rest Produces . . . 864
37.4 The Guilt of Resting . . . 866
37.5 The Argument Against the Guilt . . . 868
37.6 Building Rest Into the Arrangement . . . 870
37.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Worked Every Day for Nine Years . . . 873
37.8 Practical Exercise: The Recovery Audit and the Specification . . . 877
37.9 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 879
Reflection Questions . . . 881

Further Reading . . . 881

PART XI Rebuilding a Man's Life **883**

38 Rebuilding After Everything Falls Apart . . . 885
Introduction . . . 885
38.1 What "Everything Falls Apart" Means . . . 886
38.2 The First Period: The Four Tasks . . . 889
38.3 The Seven Errors of the First Period . . . 891
38.4 The Reckoning: The Full Statement of the Position . . . 894
38.5 The Staged Reconstruction . . . 896
38.6 Rebuilding With the Household . . . 899
38.7 Practical Exercise: The Statement and the Reconstruction Plan . . . 904
38.8 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 906
Reflection Questions . . . 909
Further Reading . . . 909

39 Becoming Emotionally Strong Without Becoming Emotionally Cold . . . 911
Introduction . . . 911
39.1 The False Choice . . . 912
39.2 How a Man Becomes Cold . . . 915
39.3 What Coldness Costs . . . 917
39.4 What Emotional Strength Actually Is . . . 920
39.5 The Six Practices . . . 921
39.6 Warmth as a Discipline . . . 924
39.7 Illustrative Case: The Man They All Respected . . . 926
39.8 Practical Exercise: The Temperature Audit and the Two Arrangements . . . 930
39.9 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 932
Reflection Questions . . . 934
Further Reading . . . 935

40 The Man Who Finally Chooses Himself . . . 937
Introduction . . . 937
40.1 What Choosing Yourself Does and Does Not Mean . . . 939
40.2 The Man Who Never Chose . . . 941
40.3 The Cost of Never Choosing . . . 943
40.4 The Four Permissions . . . 945
40.5 The Audit of the Second Half . . . 947
40.6 Conducting the Choice . . . 950
40.7 The Choices . . . 952
40.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Chose Late . . . 955
40.9 Practical Exercise: The Page and the Year . . . 958
40.10 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 960
Reflection Questions . . . 962
Further Reading . . . 963

PART XII Beyond the Battle **965**

41 Redefining What It Means to Be a Man . . . 967
Introduction . . . 967
41.1 The Definition He Inherited . . . 969
41.2 The Five Clauses and What They Actually Require . . . 972
41.3 How the Definition Is Enforced Without an Enforcer . . . 977
41.4 The Eight Tests . . . 979
41.5 The Working Definition . . . 983
41.6 The Substitution . . . 984
41.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Definitions in One Man . . . 987
41.8 Warmth, Strength, and the Man His Household Needs . . . 990
41.9 Practical Exercise: The Definition and the Substitution . . . 991
41.10 Common Questions Men Ask . . . 993
Reflection Questions . . . 995
Further Reading . . . 995

42 Building a Life That Does Not Depend on Pretending . . . 997
Introduction . . . 997
42.1 The Six Domains . . . 999
42.2 The Five Costs . . . 1003
42.3 How the Pretence Is Maintained . . . 1006
42.4 The Seven Signs That It Is Failing . . . 1008
42.5 The Six Supports . . . 1010
42.6 The Dismantling . . . 1013

42.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Doing Well ... 1016
42.8 Practical Exercise: The Two Columns and the Six Supports ... 1020
42.9 Common Questions Men Ask ... 1023
Reflection Questions ... 1025
Further Reading ... 1026

43 Teaching the Next Generation of Men to Speak ... 1027
Introduction ... 1027
43.1 How Boys Learn Emotional Expression ... 1030
43.2 What Is Actually Transmitted ... 1035
43.3 The Influence of Parents, Teachers, and Mentors ... 1037
43.4 Challenging Harmful Gender Stereotypes ... 1043
43.5 Teaching Boys Healthy Coping Skills ... 1048
43.6 Encouraging Help-Seeking Behaviour ... 1053
43.7 Creating Emotionally Supportive Communities ... 1056
43.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Learned to Speak in Front of His Son ... 1061
43.9 The Programme ... 1066
43.10 Questions Readers Ask ... 1070
43.11 Chapter Summary ... 1074
Reflection Questions ... 1075
Further Reading ... 1076

44 The Battles That Make a Man Wiser ... 1077
Introduction ... 1077
44.1 Understanding Adversity Without Glorifying Suffering ... 1080
44.2 Learning from Mistakes and Setbacks ... 1085
44.3 Developing Perspective and Emotional Maturity ... 1089
44.4 Turning Personal Experience into Constructive Action ... 1092
44.5 Mentoring Others Through Difficult Transitions ... 1096
44.6 Choosing Growth over Bitterness ... 1100
44.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Account ... 1105
44.8 The Programme ... 1110
44.9 Questions Readers Ask ... 1113
44.10 Chapter Summary ... 1116
Reflection Questions ... 1117
Further Reading ... 1118

45 The Day a Man Realizes He Does Not Have to Fight Alone ... 1121
Introduction ... 1121
45.1 Releasing the Burden of Constant Self-Reliance ... 1123
45.2 Accepting Meaningful Relationships and Support ... 1127
45.3 Making Peace with Personal Limitations ... 1132
45.4 Reconnecting with Purpose and Belonging ... 1136
45.5 Building a Healthier Vision of Manhood ... 1141
45.6 Beginning a New Chapter with Hope ... 1144
45.7 The Programme ... 1146
45.8 Illustrative Case: The Tuesday Afternoon ... 1149
45.9 Chapter Summary ... 1153
Reflection Questions ... 1154
45.10 Questions Readers Ask ... 1155
Final Word of the Main Text ... 1158

Epilogue: To Every Man Fighting a Battle Nobody Knows About ... 1161
To the Exhausted Man ... 1161
To the Struggling Husband ... 1162
To the Father Carrying Invisible Burdens ... 1163
To the Man Experiencing Financial Hardship ... 1163
To the Man Grieving in Silence ... 1164
To the Man Who Feels Forgotten ... 1165
A Final Reflection on Dignity, Connection, and Hope ... 1165

Final Reflection: You Are More Than the Battles You Fight ... 1167
The First Statement: Your Battles Are Not Your Identity ... 1167
The Second Statement: Your Silence Was a Strategy, and Strategies Can Be Changed ... 1168
The Third Statement: Your Strength Is Larger Than Your Endurance ... 1168
The Fourth Statement: Your Limits Are Not Your Verdict ... 1169
The Fifth Statement: Your Losses Are Real, and They Are Not the Whole Account ... 1169
The Sixth Statement: Your Obligations Are Not Your Isolation ... 1169

The Seventh Statement: Your Next Chapter Is Conducted, Not Declared 1170
A Closing Word 1170

A Men's Emotional Self-Assessment Workbook 1173
How to Use This Appendix 1173
Section 1: Naming States (0–32) 1173
Section 2: Regulation (0–28) 1174
Section 3: Statement to Parties (0–28) 1174
Section 4: Asking and Accepting (0–24) 1175
Section 5: Body and Health (0–24) 1175
Section 6: Work, Money, and Position (0–24) 1175
Section 7: Relationships (0–28) 1176
Section 8: Fatherhood and Transmission (0–20) 1176
Section 9: The Whole Position (0–20) 1176
Recording the Result 1177
The Three Questions 1177
Notes on Interpretation 1177

B Recognizing Stress, Anxiety, Depression, and Burnout 1179
Why the Distinction Matters 1179
Stress 1179
Anxiety 1180
Depression 1180
Burnout 1181
The Comparison Table 1182
Recording the Position 1183
Notes for the Man Who Is Supporting Another 1183

C A 30-Day Emotional Recovery and Self-Care Plan 1185
Before Beginning 1185
The Daily Core 1185
The Weekly Structure 1186
The Thirty-Day Record 1187
The Difficulties That Will Occur 1187
The Measures 1188

D Personal Financial Recovery Planning Worksheet 1189
Before Beginning 1189
Part One: The Income 1189
Part Two: The Obligations 1190
Part Three: The Expenditure 1191
Part Four: The Position 1191
Part Five: The Recovery Plan 1192
Part Six: The Rules 1193

E Healthy Communication Exercises for Men 1195
The Principles 1195
Exercise 1: The Daily Statement 1195
Exercise 2: The Listening Turn 1196
Exercise 3: The Request 1196
Exercise 4: The Repair 1196
Exercise 5: The Difficult Conversation 1196
Exercise 6: The Household Conversation 1197
Exercise 7: The Stated Difficulty in Front of a Younger Party 1197
Exercise 8: The Twenty-Minute Marriage Conversation 1198
The Record 1198

F Marriage and Relationship Reflection Workbook 1199
How to Use This Appendix 1199
Part One: The Arrangement as It Is 1199
Part Two: The Four Sentences 1199
Part Three: The Injuries 1200
Part Four: The Withdrawals 1200
Part Five: The Silences 1200
Part Six: The Household's Arrangements 1201
Part Seven: The Values and the Future 1201
Part Eight: The Joint Section 1201
Part Nine: Where the Relationship Is Ending or Has Ended 1202
Part Ten: The Record and the Follow-Up 1202

G Fatherhood and Family Responsibility Assessment 1203
Part One: The Presence 1203

Part Two: The Transmission 1203
Part Three: The Standard 1204
Part Four: The Provision and the Responsibility 1204
Part Five: The Children's Adult Position 1205
Part Six: The Assessment Table 1205
Part Seven: The Priorities 1205
Part Eight: The Father Who Is Absent 1206
Part Nine: The Father of a Son Who Will Not Speak to Him 1206

H Identifying and Challenging Negative Thinking Patterns 1209
What Automatic Thinking Is 1209
The Ten Patterns 1209
The Method: Five Steps 1210
The Specific Patterns of Men 1211
The Daily Record 1212
The Cautions 1212

I Personal Values, Identity, and Purpose Discovery Exercises 1213
The Method 1213
Stage One: The Audit of the Inherited Definition 1213
Stage Two: The Values 1214
Stage Three: The Working Identity 1215
Stage Four: The Purpose 1216
The Record 1217
The Cautions 1217

J A Practical Guide to Building Supportive Friendships 1219
The Position 1219
Stage One: The Inventory 1219
Stage Two: The Three Parties 1220
Stage Three: The Conduct 1221
The Difficulties 1221
The Measures 1222

K Grief, Loss, and Emotional Recovery Journal 1223
Before Beginning 1223
Part One: The Loss 1223
Part Two: The Waves 1224
Part Three: The Occasions 1225
Part Four: The Continuation 1225
The Losses That Are Not Deaths 1225
The Cautions 1226

L Anger Management and Emotional Regulation Exercises 1227
The Position 1227
Part One: The Recognition 1227
Part Two: The Regulation 1228
Part Three: The Repair 1229
Part Four: The Underlying Material 1229
Part Five: The Cautions 1230

M Recognizing Addiction and Accessing Professional Treatment 1231
A Note on the Word 1231
Part One: The Recognition 1231
Part Two: The Barriers to Treatment 1233
Part Three: The Professional Route 1233
Part Four: For the Household 1234
Part Five: The Cautions 1235

N Work-Life Balance and Burnout Prevention Toolkit 1237
The Position 1237
Part One: The Audit 1238
Part Two: The Reduction 1238
Part Three: The Rest 1239
Part Four: The Institution 1240
Part Five: The Cautions 1241

O Personal Boundaries and Assertiveness Worksheets 1243
The Position 1243
Part One: The Audit 1243
Part Two: The Statements 1244
Part Three: The Responses 1245
Part Four: The Boundaries That Require a Conversation 1245

Part Five: The Boundaries of the Man's Own Conduct 1246
Part Six: The Cautions 1246

P A 90-Day Life Rebuilding Action Plan 1247
The Principles 1247
Phase One: Days 1–30 — Stabilisation 1247
Phase Two: Days 31–60 — Reconstruction 1248
Phase Three: Days 61–90 — Rebuilding 1249
The Record 1250
The Review 1250
The Cautions 1250

Q Men's Mental Health Support and Crisis Resources 1253
A Note on Currency and Locality 1253
Part One: The Immediate Crisis 1253
Part Two: The Professional Route 1255
Part Three: The Community and Peer Route 1256
Part Four: For the Man Who Is Supporting Another 1256
Part Five: The Note That Applies to Every Route 1257

R Practical Case Studies and Guided Reflections 1259
How to Use the Cases 1259
Case One: The Man Who Was Never Asked 1259
Case Two: The Man Who Could Not Grieve 1260
Case Three: The Man With Everything 1261
Case Four: The Father and the Silence 1261
Case Five: The Man Who Asked 1262
Case Six: The Day 1263
The Guided Reflection 1263

S Questions for Men's Discussion Groups and Book Clubs 1265
The Purpose of a Men's Group 1265
The Ten Sessions 1265
The Session Structure 1266
The Session Questions 1266
The Group's Rules 1268
The Leader's Role 1268
The Difficulties 1269
A Note for the Member 1269

T Personal Commitment: My Life Beyond Silent Battles 1271
How to Complete This Appendix 1271
Part One: The Position as I Now State It 1271
Part Two: The Parties 1272
Part Three: The Terms 1272
Part Four: The Acts 1273
Part Five: The Statement 1273
Part Six: The Things I Will Not Do 1273
Part Seven: The Review 1274
The Signature 1274
A Closing Note 1274

Glossary of Psychological and Personal Development Terms 1275
A 1275
B 1276
C 1276
D 1277
E 1277
G 1278
H 1278
I 1278
L 1279
M 1279
N 1279
P 1279
R 1280
S 1280
T 1281
V 1281
W 1281

Recommended Reading 1283

On Men and Masculinity 1283
On Emotions and Emotional Competence 1283
On Anxiety, Depression, and Burnout 1284
On Grief and Loss 1284
On Marriage and Relationships 1284
On Fatherhood and Family 1284
On Money and Financial Stress 1285
On Work, Leadership, and Rest 1285
On Identity, Values, and Purpose 1285
On Trauma and Recovery 1285
On Addiction 1286
On Communication and Conflict 1286
On Writing, Reflection, and Practice 1286
A Note on Reading 1286

References and Bibliography 1289
A Note on Sources and Their Use 1289
The Principal Bodies of Work Used in This Book 1289
Official and Institutional Sources 1293
The Case Material 1293
A Note to the Reader Who Requires a Specific Source 1294

Subject Index 1295

About the Author 1299

Other Publications by the Author 1301

Acknowledgments

A book about the things men rarely say must begin by thanking the people who said them.

Over the years in which this material was gathered, taught, discussed in seminars, argued over in counselling supervision, and tested in conversations with men from many walks of life, a large number of people gave something of themselves to it. Men who had carried a private weight for a decade agreed, often reluctantly, to describe it. Wives and partners explained what it looks like from the other side of a silence they had never been able to interpret. Counsellors, physicians, nurses, teachers, human-resource officers, clergy of many traditions, and community leaders shared what they see in their work and what they wish someone would write down. Colleagues in the behavioural and social sciences insisted, rightly and repeatedly, that compassion is not a licence for imprecision. The book is better for all of it, and its faults remain the author's own.

I am grateful to the men who allowed their experiences to be turned into the composite illustrations that appear throughout these pages. They were promised that no story would be traceable to a single person, and that promise has been kept: every narrative in this book is a composite, constructed to represent a pattern rather than an individual. What they gave was the truth of the pattern. That truth was often uncomfortable to hear and, I suspect, harder to tell.

Special thanks are due to the practitioners who read early drafts of the chapters on depression, addiction, trauma, grief, and suicide risk, and who corrected errors of emphasis, insisted on clearer safety guidance, and reminded me that a sentence which encourages a man to disclose his distress carries an obligation to tell him where help actually is. The clinicians who gave their time to that task did so anonymously and without reward. The reader who is helped by this book owes them a debt that will never be acknowledged in print.

I thank the academic colleagues and postgraduate students whose questions sharpened the argument in every part of the book — particularly those who pressed the hardest on the question that a book of this kind must never dodge:

how do you write about men's suffering without denying the suffering of others, and how do you honour responsibility without turning it into a trap?

My thanks go to the publisher and editorial team for believing that this subject deserved a full book rather than an article, and for tolerating a manuscript that grew well beyond its original shape. The design, typesetting, and production of a volume of this size involve many hands, most of them unseen.

Finally, and most of all, I thank my family. Writing about the emotional labour that men perform in silence has a way of exposing how much of it one has been receiving without naming it. To those at home who carried on with patience while this book was being written: thank you. Whatever is wrong in these pages is mine; whatever is useful belongs, in large measure, to you.

Prof. Adeleke Daniel Durojaiye (PhD)
Ibadan, 2026

Foreword

There is a particular kind of conversation that happens when a man finally decides to say what has been happening to him. It almost always begins with an apology. *I do not want to make a big thing of this. I know other people have it worse. I am not really the sort of person who talks about feelings.* Then, if the listener is patient, comes a sentence of startling weight. *I have never told anyone this.* What follows is rarely dramatic. It is ordinary: debt, a marriage gone quiet, a job that consumes him, a father he could never please, a child he cannot reach, a grief he never finished, a fear that he is not the man everyone believes him to be. The ordinariness is what makes it serious, because ordinary burdens that cannot be spoken do not stay where they are. They accumulate.

This book is about those burdens, and about the men who carry them. It takes seriously something that public conversation still struggles to hold: that a man can be competent, reliable, generous, and useful to everyone around him while being privately exhausted, frightened, or in pain, and that the very qualities that make him dependable can make his distress invisible. It examines how that invisibility is produced — by expectation, by upbringing, by culture, by economy, by the ordinary mechanics of daily responsibility — and what can be done about it, by the man himself, by those who love him, and by institutions that ask a great deal of men and offer them very little in the way of support.

Three commitments run through the whole of the work, and it is worth stating them plainly at the outset.

First, the book is **practical**. Every chapter ends with something the reader can do. The appendices contain structured worksheets, self-assessment tools, communication exercises, a thirty-day recovery and self-care plan, a ninety-day rebuilding plan, and a guide to seeking professional help. The reader is not left with an argument; he is left with a set of steps.

Second, the book is **responsible**. It is a work of psychological insight and personal development, not a medical text, and it does not pretend otherwise. Where the material intersects with conditions that require clinical care — depression, anxiety disorders, trauma, addiction, suicidal thinking — the text says so clearly,

describes the recognised pathways to help, and directs the reader to qualified professionals and emergency services. It refuses both extremes that disfigure this subject: the extreme of treating ordinary distress as disease, and the extreme of treating serious illness as a failure of masculinity that a man ought to be able to think his way out of. The book also declines, deliberately and consistently, to turn the difficulties of men into an indictment of anyone else. Men's struggles are not caused by women, or by families, or by faith, and they are not solved by resentment. They are solved by understanding, by skill, by connection, and, where necessary, by treatment.

Third, the book is **hopeful without being sentimental**. It does not suggest that life can be made free of burden. It suggests something more durable: that a man can carry real responsibilities without carrying them in isolation; that strength and openness are not opposites; that the ability to ask for help is a competence, not a confession of inadequacy; and that the second half of a man's life can be built on a different foundation from the first half, if he chooses to build it.

The forty-five chapters are arranged in twelve parts that move from the public surface of a man's life towards its hidden interior, and then out again towards recovery and rebuilding. Part One describes the silent world itself. Parts Two through Nine examine the specific battles — of the mind, of money, of love, of family, of identity, of society, of loss, and of responsibility. Parts Ten and Eleven turn to healing and reconstruction. Part Twelve looks outward, at what a man can hand on: to his sons and daughters, to younger men, and to the communities that formed him.

This volume is offered in the conviction that men can be asked to carry responsibility without being asked to carry it silently, and that the change begins with language — with finding words for experiences that have, for too long, been left unnamed. It is commended to the men who will recognise themselves in it, to the families who will recognise someone they love, and to the professionals who sit with both.

The Publisher
Triune Biblical University Global Extension USA

Preface: Why This Book Must Be Written

In most countries for which reliable data are collected, men die by suicide at a substantially higher rate than women, even though women are more likely to be diagnosed with depression and to report depressive symptoms. Men are less likely to consult a doctor about mental-health difficulties and less likely to be in contact with mental-health services before a crisis. Men make up a large majority of deaths from alcohol-related causes, a large majority of the prison population, and a large majority of those who are homeless or sleeping rough in many cities. At the same time, in many societies, men remain the expected primary providers for extended families, the assumed decision-makers in moments of crisis, and the people to whom others turn for practical help without asking what the helping costs them.

Those two paragraphs sit side by side in public policy documents all over the world, and they are rarely read together. When they are read together, a plain pattern appears. A very large number of men are living with significant distress, and a very large proportion of that distress never enters a consulting room, a conversation, or a record. It is managed at home, in silence, at cost, and sometimes not managed at all.

This book exists because that pattern is not merely a statistic. It is the daily experience of men who are, in the ordinary sense of the word, functioning: men who go to work, pay school fees, attend meetings, fix what is broken, and are described by everyone who knows them as strong. It is also the experience of men who are not functioning, and who are ashamed of that fact in a way that makes it harder for them to recover. Both groups share a common feature: the difficulty of saying what is happening.

The Three Reasons This Book Was Written

First, because the vocabulary is missing. Many men can describe a mechanical problem, a business difficulty, or a tactical challenge in precise terms, and cannot describe an emotional state in any terms at all. This is not a deficiency of intelligence; it is a deficiency of training. Emotional vocabulary, like any vocabulary, is learned. Where a man grows up in an environment that rewards the suppression

of feeling and penalises its expression, he may reach adulthood with a rich professional language and a poverty of emotional language. Without words, experience remains unnamed; and what cannot be named cannot be examined, shared, or treated. A substantial part of this book is therefore an exercise in vocabulary-building: giving names to states that many men know intimately but have never heard described.

Second, because responsibility and isolation are routinely confused. There is nothing wrong with a man carrying a great deal. Responsibility is a legitimate and honourable part of adult life, and this book does not treat it as a pathology to be shed. What is wrong is the assumption that responsibility requires isolation — that needing others is a failure of manhood, that asking for assistance undermines authority, that a man who admits difficulty has disqualified himself from leading, providing, or protecting. That assumption is not a law of nature. It is a cultural arrangement, and cultural arrangements can be changed. The chapters that follow separate the burden, which is often unavoidable and frequently honourable, from the solitude, which is neither.

Third, because the help exists but is not reached. Effective treatments for depression, anxiety disorders, post-traumatic stress, and alcohol dependence are well established. Counselling and psychotherapy are widely available in many places; telephone and online services have widened access considerably; and peer support, mentoring, and structured self-help programmes provide meaningful help to people who will never sit in a therapist's office. The gap is not primarily a gap in the availability of help. It is a gap in the route to it: men do not know what the first step is, do not believe it will work, fear being judged, or fear the consequences for their work, their marriage, or their standing. This book therefore treats help-seeking as a skill to be taught and rehearsed, not as a character trait to be mustered.

What This Book Is Not

It is not a claim that men's difficulties are greater than anyone else's. Suffering is not a competition, and the fact that one person's pain is invisible does not make it worse. Women's struggles, and the structural disadvantages that many women face, are real and extensively documented. A book about men's silent battles is not an argument against that literature; it is a complement to it. Everyone benefits when men are better able to speak and better able to seek help, because the cost of male silence is paid not only by men. It is paid by partners who live with a wall they cannot name, by children who learn that emotion is unwelcome in the house, by colleagues, by employees, by communities, and by the next generation of boys who are watching.

It is not a book of blame. It does not blame women for expecting men to be strong, parents for raising them that way, employers, faith communities, or men themselves for having absorbed the message. Blame is an unproductive emotion in this territory. Understanding is more useful, and so is skill.

It is not a substitute for professional care, and it does not pretend to diagnose. Its role is to describe, to explain, to teach, and to point the reader towards competent help where that is what is required.

Why Now

Patterns of work, family, and social life have changed faster than the expectations attached to manhood. Men are now expected to be emotionally engaged fathers and equal partners in domestic life while many are also carrying the older expectation of sole provision, in economies where sole provision is increasingly impossible. Migration, urbanisation, and the weakening of extended family support have removed structures that once absorbed distress. Digital communication has multiplied the opportunities for social comparison and public shame. And the ordinary arenas in which men once talked at length to one another — the workshop, the farm, the long journey, the evening walk home — have thinned out for many.

The result is a population of men who are more articulate, better educated, and more publicly accomplished than any generation before them, and who are, in many cases, lonelier than any generation before them as well. Long before the end of this book, the reader will find that word — loneliness — returning in almost every part, whatever the nominal subject of the chapter. It is the common thread of the silent battles, and it is the most treatable part of the problem.

The book is written for men and for the people who live and work with them. It is written for the man who is doing well and feels hollow; the man who is doing badly and feels ashamed; the man who is doing both at once and cannot explain how. It accepts that he is unlikely to ask for help in the way that a textbook recommends, and it works with that reality rather than against it — beginning, as he does, with the day-to-day burdens of ordinary life, and moving, as the chapters progress, towards the interior world those burdens conceal.

If, by the end, a man can name one thing he has never named, and say it to one person he trusts, this book will have done its work.

Prof. Adeleke Daniel Durojaiye (PhD)

Author's Note

A few clarifications will help the reader to get the most from this book and to understand what it can and cannot do.

On the stories. Every case story, vignette, letter, dialogue, and character in this book is an original composite created for teaching purposes. Names, occupations, cities, and details have been altered and combined so that no story corresponds to a single identifiable person. When a chapter says *Ade's story is composite*, or the caption of a case box describes material as illustrative, that is meant literally. These stories were written to represent patterns — the pattern of the man who cannot say he is struggling, the pattern of the marriage that goes quiet, the pattern of the father who provides and cannot connect — and the patterns are drawn from documented experience and professional observation, not from any individual's file.

On evidence. The book refers to research findings in general terms. Where a claim rests on a well-established body of work — for example, that suppressing emotion has physiological and psychological costs, that behavioural therapy is effective for many anxiety disorders, or that social support protects mental health — the text states the finding as established. It does not present invented statistics, and it does not attribute positions to named researchers by way of fabricated quotation. Readers who wish to pursue the underlying literature will find the direction of travel in the Recommended Reading section; practitioners and students should go to primary sources.

On diagnosis. This book describes experiences and patterns. It does not diagnose, and it cannot: diagnosis requires a qualified professional, a proper assessment, and the elimination of physical causes and other conditions. Statements of the kind *many men experience depression as irritability rather than sadness* describe common presentations; they do not mean that every irritable man is depressed, or that a reader who recognises himself in a description has a disorder. Where the text lists warning signs, it does so to prompt appropriate professional consultation, not to invite self-diagnosis.

On terminology. Several terms are used in specific ways throughout.

- *Distress* is used for the ordinary range of painful human experience — strain, worry, sorrow, anger, disappointment — that does not necessarily require clinical care.
- *Disorder*, *condition*, and *illness* are used for patterns that meet recognised diagnostic criteria and that respond to treatment.
- *Suppression* is used for the deliberate or habitual pushing away of emotional experience, and is distinguished from *self-control*, which is the capacity to choose how one acts on emotion without denying that it exists.
- *Manhood* and *masculinity* refer to social expectations attached to being a man, not to any claim about innate nature.
- *Partner* is used where the reader's circumstances may involve a wife, a cohabiting partner, or a long-term companion.
- The book uses *he* and *his* throughout because its subject is the experience of men. This is a limitation of the subject, not a judgement about whose suffering matters.

On culture and context. The book is written from a broadly international perspective, with sustained attention to African — and specifically Nigerian — realities. It takes seriously the extended-family system in which many men operate, the weight of communal expectation, the role of respect and shame in social life, and the practical obstacles to professional care in places where services are scarce, costly, or far away. It also refuses the false choice sometimes posed between culture and mental health: the recognition that men need support is not a foreign import, and asking for help is not a betrayal of family or community. Wherever possible, the book names alternatives that fit the reader's actual circumstances, including guidance that does not require money or a clinic.

On faith. The book is written as a secular, psychological, and practical work. It addresses the human realities of burden, duty, sorrow, hope, and change without appealing to religious doctrine, and readers who hold religious commitments will find nothing here that contradicts those commitments and nothing here that depends upon them.

On safety. Some chapters necessarily discuss severe distress, self-harm, addiction, and suicide. They are included because silence about these subjects is dangerous, and because a man who has reached that point deserves a book that speaks to it plainly rather than changing the subject. Readers who are in acute distress, or who are concerned about a man who may be, should turn to Chapter 34, Appendix B, and Appendix Q, and should not wait to finish the book first.

On the exercises. The practical exercises and appendices are tools, not requirements. Some readers will work through them methodically; others will use one worksheet and ignore the rest. Both approaches are legitimate. Readers who

find that an exercise stirs up more distress than they can manage alone should stop, and should speak to a qualified professional before continuing. That is not a failure of the exercise or of the reader; it is information about what kind of help is needed.

On privacy. A man reading this book may do so privately, and may prefer that nobody know. That is understood. But the trajectory of the book, and the evidence behind it, point in one direction: the private reading is a beginning, and the change that lasts usually arrives in the company of at least one other person — a partner, a friend, a mentor, a counsellor, a physician, or a group of men who have agreed to be honest with one another. The reader is invited, at whatever pace he chooses, to move in that direction.

Prof. Adeleke Daniel Durojaiye (PhD)

List of Figures and Illustrations

1.1 The two surfaces of a man's life. The upper zone is what others can verify — competence, provision, and steady management. The lower zone holds the material that rarely enters any conversation. 9

1.2 The silence loop. Concealment produces the appearance of coping, the appearance of coping removes the occasion for support, and the absence of support confirms the original decision to remain silent. 12

1.3 What achievement can supply, and what it cannot. The upper list grows with effort and position; the lower list does not respond to effort alone. 15

1.4 The disclosure map across six domains of a man's life. The columns move from what is readily shared to what is almost never shared. 18

1.5 From event to cost. Each stage in the sequence is experienced privately and justified to the man himself; none of them appears to an observer as a change in behaviour until the later stages. 22

2.1 How the expectations accumulate. Each layer narrows the range of feeling and need that a man is permitted to express, and the narrowest layer is the one he writes for himself. 32

2.2 The demands that settle on one man. The rings are concentric in experience rather than in distance: each is close enough to be felt, and none is entirely outside his sense of responsibility. 36

2.3 The unspoken syllabus. A man is examined continuously against a syllabus he was never given, by an examiner who is never named, and the examination has no end point — which is what makes it a lifelong one. 42

2.4 Two definitions of strength, side by side. The left column produces a man whose capacity is invisible until it fails; the right column produces one whose capacity is stated, maintained, and available to the people who depend on it. 43

3.1 From lesson to consequence. At each stage, feeling is exchanged for something more acceptable — tiredness, busyness, anger, or activity — and the original state is left unaddressed. 56

3.2 Self-control and emotional avoidance, distinguished. The two look similar from outside a man; they are entirely different inside him, and they produce opposite long-run outcomes. 59

3.3 Four exercises for building emotional vocabulary, in ascending order of difficulty. Each is conducted privately, and each makes the next one easier. 66

3.4 Learning to acknowledge feeling: sensation first, then rating, then one true sentence a day, then borrowed language. The middle column suggests what ordinary male statements frequently encode. 67

4.1 Being surrounded and being known are different conditions. The left-hand column can be satisfied by a full household and a busy contact list; the right-hand column is generated only by specific forms of intimate attention. 77

4.2 An approximate audit of a mid-life man's weekly hours. Loads on the upper bars accumulate; the lower bars — the hours available for friendship, rest, and reflection — are the ones that are compressed when the upper bars grow. 79

4.3 The success trap: how professional attainment and reliability convert friendships into transactions over a period of years. No step in the process is a decision, and the outcome is invisible until it is tested. 82

4.4 Rebuilding connection proceeds in steps. Each stage provides the evidence that the next stage requires; the first step is small because its function is to test whether the ground will hold. 87

5.1 Confidence as others see it, and the internal work that sustains it. Anxiety in men frequently operates as the second column while presenting as the first. 105

5.2 The recurring domains of male worry. The pattern is stable across age, occupation, and country in the accounts men give, with some variation in emphasis at different life stages. 106

5.3 How shame maintains itself. The original event may be small; the cycle is driven by the interpretation, and it terminates only when the interpretation is examined or when the material is disclosed to somebody who does not withdraw. 110

5.4 What a competent assessment contains. A man is entitled to each of these parts, and he may ask for the formulation and the plan in plain language. 114

6.1 The withdrawal cycle. The mechanism is the leading reason that depression is treated partly by restoring activity and contact rather than only by talking about feelings. 127

6.2 Depression as it is commonly described, and as it frequently presents in men. The condition is identical; the language, emphasis, and visible behaviour differ, which is why so many cases are not identified. 129

6.3 The typical descent. The critical feature is the fifth stage: the man continues to function in every visible domain while the condition deepens, and the collapse is therefore attributed to the final small event rather than to the load that preceded it. 131

6.4 The components of evidence-based treatment for depression in men. The components are commonly combined, and the practical interventions in the lower rows are frequently what make the others possible. 134

7.1 From standard to crisis. The point of intervention is the third stage, where a setback is interpreted as a verdict on the self rather than as an event in a business or a career. 150

7.2 The comparison spiral. Each attainment raises the reference standard rather than delivering satisfaction, so that effort increases while the return in well-being declines. 152

7.3 The recovery sequence after a serious failure. The order matters: stability and facts come before reporting and reviewing, because an account given from a position of panic is rarely an accurate one. 158

7.4 Two arrangements between worth and performance. The left-hand column is a description of how the man accounts for himself, not a moral failing; the right-hand column is what can be built by deliberate practice. 161

8.1 Four layers in the description of a man. Self-doubt operates by collapsing the outer layers into the innermost, so that a professional or social judgement is experienced as a verdict on identity. 174

8.2 The formation of the internal critic and the process by which genuine achievement ceases to count. The critical feature is stage four: the systematic discounting of evidence that contradicts the verdict. 179

8.3 Two internal dialogues. The left-hand column is the critic's standard output; the right-hand column is what the same events would sound like if described accurately by a fair observer. 181

8.4 Practical methods for building realistic confidence. The fifth and sixth items are the ones men most often leave out, and the ones that most reliably change what a man believes about himself. 184

9.1 The spiral of concealment and escalation. Each stage is a reasonable response to the one before it, which is why the position is invisible to the man until he writes the total down. 200

10.1 The load a provider carries, and the thinness of the support available to him. The bars are conceptual rather than measured; the pattern is consistent in the accounts men give. 227

11.1 The received definition of success and a definition that can survive a change in the man's position. The right-hand column is built from items that do not disappear when a title does. 247

12.1 The sequence in which a sustainable life is actually built, rather than announced. Each step is completed before the next is attempted, and the first requires nothing of anybody else. 279

13.1 Why concealed relationship grief does not resolve. The cycle is maintained by the man's own conclusions about what may be said, and it ends only when the material is stated to somebody who receives it. 294

14.1 What a man typically brings to the conversation, and what the conversation actually requires. The most common failure is not the material but the order in which it is delivered. 318

15.1 How an unspoken ledger is opened, kept, and finally presented. Neither party is at fault in the opening stages; the account is a product of a long arrangement that was never balanced out loud. 340

16.1 The phases of recovery after rejection and betrayal. The phases overlap rather than follow one another strictly, and a return to an earlier phase after a new injury is ordinary. 363

17.1 The four fronts of a father's obligation. Each front is legitimate on its own terms, and each competes with the others for the same finite hours. 381

18.1 The husband's role and the husband's person. The left-hand column describes conduct that is necessary and insufficient; the right-hand column describes what is required for the marriage to contain a relationship rather than an administration. 408

19.1 How a childhood ends early, and where the arrangement can still be changed. The upper stages concern the imposition of the role; the lower stage identifies the point in adult life at which the material becomes visible and the work becomes possible. 432

20.1 From unacknowledged contribution to bitterness. Each stage is described first, and the intervention that remains available at that stage follows it. The window for the low-cost intervention closes at Stage Three. 455

21.1 Two slopes. Conduct that widens the gap between the presented image and the private account, and conduct that narrows it. The practices in the right-hand column are those set out in Sections 21.3 to 21.6. 481

22.1 The maintenance cycle of a concealed weakness. The cycle is interrupted at the level of the cue and at the level of the isolation; attempts to interrupt it at the level of the behaviour itself have the weakest record. 497

23.1 The progression from use to dependence. The left-hand column describes the stage; the right-hand column identifies what is required at that point. The window in which a change of pattern is achievable without treatment closes earlier than most men assume. 516

24.1 The sequence of identity loss and reconstruction. The upper stages describe what is removed and what follows; the lower stage identifies the three materials the reconstruction requires. 545

25.1 How a results-based assessment reaches a man, and where it can be interrupted. The left-hand column describes the sequence; the right-hand column identifies the interruption available at each stage. 574

26.1 The anatomy of a betrayed friendship. The left-hand column describes the stages; the right-hand column identifies the available intervention at each. The outcome is determined by the assessment conducted at Stage Four, not by the act. 596

27.1 Building a support network from nothing. The left column gives the six stages in order; the right column identifies the requirement and the characteristic obstacle at each. Stage One requires only that one person be identified, and Stage Four is the first stage at which any material is delivered. 618

28.1 The life of a dream: how a dream is set down without a decision, what it costs while it remains open, and the two legitimate endings. The dead dream is closed through the accounting work of Section 28.4; the pending dream is advanced by a first step within thirty days or reclassified as closed. 643

29.1 The two modes in which a regret operates. The corrective mode supplies a standard the man acts upon; the punitive mode sustains a sentence and alters no conduct. The right-hand column gives the intervention required in each mode, and the marker that distinguishes them is stated at the foot. 663

30.1 Grieving without an audience: the course from the loss to the reconstruction. The upper stages describe what follows a loss that has no occasion; the final stage identifies the five elements that supply what the occasion would otherwise have supplied. 695

31.1 The leader's load and the six arrangements that carry it. The upper part of the diagram sets out the four burdens that are not visible in the man's performance, together with the fifth — other people's personal material. The lower part identifies the six arrangements, and the structural effect from Section 31.1 that each is constructed to counter. 722

32.1 The requirement to have answers and its correction. The upper row sets out the four costs of the absolute requirement, and the lower row the three-part reply of Section 32.5 and the five questions of Section 32.6 that correct it. 748

33.1 Carrying other people's problems: the role and its correction. The upper part sets out the six steps by which the role is acquired and the four returns that keep it in place; the intermediate part sets out the five costs; and the lower part identifies the six arrangements that distribute the load. 773

34.1 When silence becomes dangerous: the criteria, the mechanisms, and the points at which the requirement changes. The left-hand column gives the three criteria of Section 34.1; the centre describes the three mechanisms by which unspoken 795

material operates; the right-hand column identifies the point at which the requirement becomes professional rather than personal.

35.1 Asking for help: the four costs of the request, the five sources available, and the four parts of an effective request. The lower band sets out the form that converts a request from an announcement of the man's position into a bounded arrangement a recipient can answer. 824

36.1 The four conditions of recovery, their sequence, and the arrangements that supply each. The diagram is conceptual; the conditions are not achieved once and held, and a man may need to return to the first column after an event that removes his stability. 843

37.1 Learning to rest: the four sources of the prohibition, the six categories of recovery, and the six components of the arrangement. The diagram is conceptual; the categories overlap, and a man's requirement generally spans more than one. 873

38.1 Rebuilding after everything falls apart: the four tasks of the first period, the seven errors that determine the reconstruction's starting position, and the six stages of the reconstruction in their order. The diagram is conceptual; the durations are indicative and vary with the position. 899

39.1 Emotional strength without coldness: the six stages by which a man becomes cold, the four competences of emotional strength, and the arrangement in which the competences are practised. The lower band is the register of warmth as a discipline. 926

40.1 The audit of the second half of life: the three lists and the four questions that classify each item. 950

41.1 The five clauses of the inherited definition: the authentic obligation each contains, and the addition each makes. The revision maintains the obligation and removes the addition. 983

42.1 The six steps of the dismantling, in the order the practice material supports. 1013

List of Tables

0.1 The standard structure of every chapter. xlvii
0.2 The twenty practical appendices and their uses. xlix
1.1 The two accounts. Adapted for this edition from the pattern described in the health, family, and occupational literature on male disclosure. 4
2.1 The six capacities that sustain responsibility, and the two recognised by the script in current use. 43
3.1 The bargain of suppression. Both columns are real; the difficulty is that the left-hand column is immediate and the right-hand column is delayed. 57
3.2 The self-control scale. Most men will locate themselves in a different position for different areas of life — skilled in one domain, globally avoidant in another. 60
3.3 Distinguishing the two conditions. Readers commonly have both, and the treatment order matters: reduce the load first, then work on the grief. 64
5.1 The eight families of internal conflict. Most men recognise between two and four in their own lives; the number is not a measure of health or illness. 101
5.2 Anxiety as it is commonly described and as it frequently presents in men. Adapted for this edition from the literature on sex differences in symptom presentation. 103
5.3 Guilt and shame distinguished. The distinction is one of the most practically useful in the whole of psychology for men who carry a sense of moral failure. 108
5.4 Practical criteria for seeking professional assessment. The presence of one criterion warrants attention; the presence of two or more warrants prompt consultation. 111
6.1 Additional features frequently present in male depression. Any three, persisting for more than two weeks, warrant professional assessment. 128
7.1 The four objects of the fear of failure. Identifying the specific object matters because the remedy for one is not the remedy for another. 150
8.1 The male presentation of insecurity. Each item is a behaviour that is usually read as evidence of strength. 175
8.2 Rewriting verdicts as descriptions. The method is not positive thinking; it is the removal of a conclusion that the evidence does not support. 182
9.1 The symptom profile of concealed debt. The pattern closely resembles that of the anxiety and depressive presentations described in Chapters 5 and 6, which is one of the reasons the underlying cause is frequently missed. 205
10.1 A priority order for household expenditure. The essential feature is that the order is agreed in advance, in a calm month, so that it does not have to be negotiated during a crisis. 230
11.1 The seven domains of a personal definition of success. A definition that omits the last two domains is not a life; it is a schedule. 254

13.1 The manifestations of relationship grief in men. Two or three of these are normal and temporary; a persistent majority of them over months warrants professional assessment. 291

17.1 The four fronts on which a father's obligation is distributed, and the strain characteristic of each. 379

Introduction: The Battles Behind a Man's Silence

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

Abiodun is fifty-one years old. He is a senior civil servant, a deacon in his community's development association, the man who is telephoned when a relative needs school fees or a hospital deposit, and the person his late father's siblings call when there is a dispute to settle. He has been married for twenty-two years and has three children, one of them in university. He arrives at work at eight o'clock, chairs meetings, signs off budgets, and is described by younger colleagues as unshakeable. For fourteen months he has woken at three in the morning and lain awake in the dark, rehearsing the same three problems: a loan repayment that has grown beyond his salary, a daughter whose withdrawal from the family he cannot interpret, and a physical fatigue that no weekend repairs. He has told nobody about any of it. When he imagines describing it, the sentence that stops him is not *I am weak*. It is *What would they do if they knew?*

Abiodun is a composite figure, and he is not unusual. His situation contains the elements that this book examines: responsibility without support, a private reality at odds with a public account, distress experienced as physical strain and worry rather than as named sadness, and a silence that is not cowardice, dishonesty, or indifference, but a strategy — a way of protecting other people from a weight he believes he is supposed to carry alone.

The purpose of this introduction is to set out what the book is about, the ideas that hold it together, the shape of the journey through its twelve parts, and the honest limits of what it can offer.

The Subject of the Book

This is a book about the struggles of men that do not become conversations. It is not about poverty as such, or violence as such, or any single social problem. It is about a specific phenomenon that cuts across all of them: the gap between what a man is living with and what he is able to say.

That gap has been described from many directions. Sociologists have documented the norms of masculinity that make disclosure costly — self-reliance, stoicism, dominance, the refusal to appear weak. Public-health researchers have documented the consequences: lower rates of consultation, later presentation, fewer diagnoses, higher rates of substance-related harm, and faster progression from difficulty to crisis among men. Clinicians have documented what distress looks like when men do present: irritability rather than tears, anger rather than fear, physical complaints rather than emotional descriptions, and a tendency to describe situations rather than feelings. Economists and policy analysts have documented the load: the pressure of provision in uncertain economies, the effects of unemployment on men's self-regard, and the absence of support structures for men in mid-life. Writers and counsellors have documented the interior: the loneliness of the accomplished man, the wound of an unappreciated father, the silence of the grieving son who is expected to be strong at his own father's burial.

This book brings those strands together for the general reader, and does so in a form that is meant to be used. Its organising claim is simple. **Men can carry serious responsibilities without being expected to endure emotional suffering in isolation.** Everything else in these forty-five chapters is an elaboration of that sentence: what happens when the isolation is accepted as normal, what the isolation costs, how it is produced, how it is sustained, and what can be done, by men and by those around them, to end it.

Six Ideas That Run Through the Book

The chapters are varied in subject, but a small number of ideas recur in every part. Stating them here will make the argument easier to follow.

1. Silence is learned, not natural. Boys are not born reluctant to speak about pain. They are taught, in many small ways and over many years, which feelings are welcome and which are expensive. The process is not usually harsh or cruel; it is ordinary. A boy who cries and is told to be a man has not been abused. He has received instruction. The instruction is repeated by school, by peers, by media, by labour markets, and by the well-meaning expectation that a son will be strong for his mother. By adulthood the lesson has become invisible: a man does not experience his silence as a decision, but as a fact about himself. Recognition that the habit is learned matters because it implies the habit can be unlearned — and that the men who unlearn it are not betraying their nature, but correcting their training.

2. Responsibility and isolation have been bundled together, and they can be separated. The cultural message is rarely *you must help no one*; it is *you must need no one*. Provision, protection, and decision-making are indeed part of adult masculinity. The belief that these duties must be discharged without

support, disclosure, or complaint is not. This book takes the burden seriously and refuses to treat it as pathology, while insisting that the solitude is optional. A man who provides for nine people is doing something honourable. A man who believes that providing for nine people requires that nobody ever provide for him is labouring under an idea that can be retired.

3. Distress often presents differently in men, and the difference conceals it. A man who is depressed may not say he is sad. He may be angry, restless, exhausted, unable to sleep, disengaged from things he once enjoyed, working longer hours, drinking more, or complaining of headaches and back pain. A man who is grieving may not weep; he may reorganise his late father's workshop, take on more work, or become unusually harsh about small failures in the house. When distress is expressed in forms that do not match the standard picture, it goes unrecognised — by others and by the man himself. Naming the different presentations is one of the most practical things this book does.

4. The costs of silence are concrete and cumulative. Silence is not merely a communication problem. Long-term suppression of emotion is associated with physiological strain, impaired sleep, higher alcohol use, reduced help-seeking, poorer treatment outcomes, and — most serious of all — later and more lethal presentations of crises such as severe depression or suicidal thinking. In families, silence transmits its own curriculum: children learn from what they see. In workplaces, it produces presenteeism, error, and eventual collapse. In communities, it produces men who are respected and overwhelmed, and whose sudden breakdown nobody saw coming.

5. Help is effective, and the route to it is a skill. Depression, anxiety disorders, trauma-related conditions, and alcohol dependence respond to treatment. Talking therapies have decades of evidence behind them; medication is effective for many people; combined approaches help others; peer support, mentoring, structured self-help, exercise, sleep restoration, and community programmes all play a role. The difficulty is rarely that nothing works. It is that men do not find the door. Therefore, this book treats help-seeking as a practical competence — with scripts, checklists, first steps, and answers to the objections that men actually raise — rather than as a leap of character.

6. Change is possible in the second half of life. The book deliberately ends not with diagnosis but with rebuilding: with the recovery of purpose, the restoration of relationships, the rebuilding of work and finances, the repair of emotional life, and the discovery of a way of being a man that does not require pretence. There are men who have made that passage, and their accounts are the most useful evidence in the whole subject.

How the Book Is Organised

The twelve parts follow a deliberate arc, from the outside in, and then from the inside out.

Part One — The Silent World of Men maps the territory: the difference between the public image and the private reality, the burden of expectation, the mechanisms of emotional suppression, and the loneliness that accompanies strength.

Part Two — The Battles of the Mind deals with what men find hardest to name: hidden anxiety, depression behind a competent surface, the fear of failure, and persistent self-doubt.

Part Three — The Financial Battles Men Fight examines the domain in which men's silence is most often economic rather than emotional: concealed hardship, the pressure of being the person everyone depends upon, the race to be seen as successful, and the man who cannot afford to break down.

Part Four — The Battles of Love and Relationships addresses heartbreak that men are not expected to feel, the pain of being misunderstood by a partner, the quiet battles of marriage, and the wounds of rejection and betrayal.

Part Five — The Battles of Family and Fatherhood turns to the home: the father who suffers in silence, the husband who is expected to be permanently strong, the boy who became a man too early, and the man whose sacrifices are never acknowledged.

Part Six — The Private Battles of Identity and Self-Worth considers the mirror: body and self-image, personal weaknesses, addiction and compulsive behaviour, and the loss of direction that follows failure or transition.

Part Seven — The Battles Men Face in Society looks outward: the world that judges men by results, betrayal within friendships, and the man who has nobody he can call.

Part Eight — The Battles of Loss, Regret, and Broken Dreams confronts the past: ambitions that died quietly, regrets nobody knows about, and grief that has no audience.

Part Nine — The Battles of Leadership, Power, and Responsibility examines the hidden costs of authority: loneliness, the demand for constant answers, and the emotional labour of carrying other people's problems.

Part Ten — Healing the Man Behind the Silence is the turning point: recognising when silence has become dangerous, learning to ask for help, healing wounds, and resting without guilt.

Part Eleven — Rebuilding a Man's Life reconstructs: recovery after collapse, emotional strength without emotional coldness, and the choice of a life of one's own.

Part Twelve — Beyond the Battle looks forward: a redefinition of what it means to be a man, a life that does not depend on pretence, the education of the next generation of boys, the wisdom that adversity can produce, and the day a man realises he does not have to fight alone.

The volume closes with an Epilogue addressed to specific readers in specific situations, a Final Reflection, twenty practical appendices — assessment tools, plans, worksheets, exercises, and resource guidance — and a glossary, recommended reading, and index.

What the Reader Can Expect

Each chapter follows the same structure, so that the book can be read continuously or consulted by topic. It opens with objectives and an illustrative story. It then works through the substance of the chapter in numbered sections, combining explanation, recognition, and practical method. It includes at least one extended illustration, one table or figure that organises the material, a practical exercise, and a summary. Every chapter ends with things to do and questions to answer.

Two notes on tone. The book does not scold men, and it does not scold anyone else. It is also not sentimental. It does not suggest that speaking about difficulty is easy, that partners will always respond well, that employers will always be reasonable, or that a single honest conversation resolves a decade of silence. What it does suggest is that the alternative — continuing to carry everything alone — is not a neutral choice. It has costs that are paid by the man, by his family, and by those who depend on him.

Finally, a warning that is also a promise. This is a book about things that many men have decided not to discuss. Reading it may be uncomfortable; recognising oneself in a chapter can be a strange experience, somewhere between relief and exposure. That reaction is normal, and it is not a reason to stop. It is the beginning of the vocabulary that the rest of the book sets out to build.

The battles men fight alone are real. They are also, for the most part, battles that can be fought differently. That is the argument of this book, and it begins in Part One.

How to Use This Book

This is a working book. It can be read from beginning to end like a narrative, but it was designed to be used — marked, annotated, returned to, and worked through a chapter at a time. The following notes explain its structure and suggest routes through it for different readers.

The Structure of a Chapter

Every chapter follows the same architecture, so that the reader always knows where he is.

Table 0.1 The standard structure of every chapter.

Element	What it does
Chapter Objectives	Six aims, in plain language, stating what the chapter is intended to make possible.
Illustrative Story	An original composite narrative — a man, a family, a situation — that opens the chapter's subject concretely.
Body sections	Six numbered sections that explain, describe, and instruct. Each corresponds to one of the topics listed in the table of contents.
Figures and tables	Diagrams and organisers that reduce a complex experience to a structure the reader can hold in mind.
Illustrative case	A second, shorter composite case, usually presenting a turning point or a contrast.
Practical exercise	A written exercise, conversation rehearsal, or planning task, to be done rather than read.
Chapter Summary	The chapter's argument compressed to half a page.
Reflection questions	Questions for personal reflection or for discussion in a group.
Further reading	Directions for readers who want to go deeper.

Routes Through the Book

If you are reading for yourself, and you are not in crisis. Read Part One first. It establishes the vocabulary on which everything else depends. After that, move to the parts that correspond to the battles you actually recognise. The book is arranged so that each part is intelligible on its own: if your battles are financial, go to Part Three; if they concern marriage or fatherhood, Parts Four and Five; if they concern grief or regret, Part Eight.

If you are reading for yourself, and you are struggling now. Begin with Chapter 34 (*When Silence Becomes Dangerous*), Appendix B, and Appendix Q. These deal with warning signs, crisis support, and how to reach help. Then return to Part One and read at your own pace. You are under no obligation to read the book in order, and no obligation to read it quickly.

If you are reading because of someone else. Parts Four, Five, and Seven are the most useful for partners and family members, and Chapter 33 for those who find themselves carrying other people's problems. Appendix E (communication exercises) and Appendix F (marriage reflection) are designed to be used with another person. Appendix Q lists sources of professional help.

If you are a counsellor, therapist, physician, teacher, or community leader. The book is written for general readers, so it does not attempt clinical instruction. Its value to professionals is likely to lie in the vocabulary and framing offered to men, and in the exercises and worksheets, which can be adapted for use with clients. Part Two and Part Ten describe how men typically present distress and what the recognised pathways to care are.

If you are using the book with a group. Appendix S provides discussion questions for men's groups, book clubs, church and community men's fellowships, and workplace sessions. The appendices are designed so that a group can work through one chapter and one worksheet per meeting. Group use multiplies the value of the book: the material is about isolation, and the most direct remedy for isolation is other people in the same room.

Pace and Practice

A chapter is roughly the length of a long magazine feature read aloud. Two or three chapters a week is a realistic pace for a serious reader; a chapter a week is a realistic pace for a group. Speed is not a virtue here. The measure of success is not how much of the book has been read but how much of it has been done.

Each chapter contains a practical exercise. The exercises are cumulative. The early ones help a man describe what he is carrying — a task that many men have never attempted in writing. The middle ones help him test whether his situation can be discussed with another person, and rehearse how. The later ones help him plan changes in work, money, marriage, health, and life direction. Readers who

skip the exercises will still get something from the book. Readers who do them will get considerably more.

A notebook is assumed rather than supplied. Many exercises ask for written answers, and writing produces a different kind of honesty from thinking. Where an exercise can be completed on a single sheet, a copy can be made; the appendices are formatted so that they can be printed or copied by hand.

A Note on Order, Safety, and Limits

The parts of the book are arranged in a deliberate sequence, from the description of the silent world outwards to recovery. That sequence is a suggestion, not a rule.

Three cautions apply throughout.

- **Do not use this book as a substitute for care.** Self-help material is useful for milder difficulties, and useful as an accompaniment to professional care. It is not a treatment for severe depression, post-traumatic stress, alcohol dependence, or any condition in which a person's safety is at risk. Where the book recommends professional consultation, that recommendation should be taken literally.
- **Do not push through distress alone.** If an exercise or a chapter stirs up intense distress, particularly around grief, trauma, or shame, stop and speak to a qualified professional. Distress of that intensity is information about what kind of help is needed, not evidence that the reader has failed.
- **Do not use the book as a weapon, against yourself or anyone else.** Nothing in these pages is intended to give a man a diagnosis of his wife, his son, his father, or himself. It is intended to give him language, understanding, and a plan.

The Appendices

The twenty appendices at the end of the book are the working equipment.

Table 0.2 The twenty practical appendices and their uses.

Appendix	Uses
A — Emotional Self-Assessment	A personal starting point across the six domains of the book.
B — Stress, Anxiety, Depression, Burnout	Recognising what requires professional attention.
C — 30-Day Recovery and Self-Care Plan	A concrete month of daily practices.
D — Financial Recovery Worksheet	Getting from concealment to a plan.
E — Communication Exercises	Scripts and rehearsal for difficult conversations.
F — Marriage and Relationship Reflection	A structured review for couples.

Appendix	Uses
G — Fatherhood Assessment	Reviewing presence, provision, and connection.
H — Negative Thinking Patterns	Identifying and answering distorted thoughts.
I — Values, Identity, Purpose	The exercises that underpin a life of one's own.
J — Building Supportive Friendships	Practical steps out of social isolation.
K — Grief and Loss Journal	Structured writing for bereavement.
L — Anger and Emotional Regulation	Techniques for the moment of heat.
M — Addiction and Treatment	Recognition, first steps, and what treatment involves.
N — Work-Life Balance Toolkit	Preventing burnout and rebuilding recovery time.
O — Boundaries and Assertiveness	Scripts, rights, and rehearsal.
P — 90-Day Rebuilding Plan	A quarter of deliberate reconstruction.
Q — Support and Crisis Resources	Where to find help, and how to make first contact.
R — Case Studies and Guided Reflections	Extended teaching cases for study and group work.
S — Discussion Group Questions	Material for men's groups and book clubs.
T — Personal Commitment	The reader's own signed statement of what changes now.

Readers are encouraged to treat Appendix A as the entry point and Appendix T as the exit, and to work through the rest in whatever order their circumstances require.

A Word to the Reader Who Is Not a Man

If you have picked up this book as a wife, a mother, a sister, a daughter, a colleague, a manager, or a therapist, welcome. The book is written in the voice of a man addressing men, but nothing in it is closed to you. Understanding how men are taught to be silent, what their silence conceals, and how it can be interrupted is useful to anyone who lives or works with men. It may also be uncomfortable in places: the book describes how common it is for a man to be seen and not known, and how frequently those closest to him are the last to learn what he has been carrying. That discomfort is not an accusation. It is an invitation to a better conversation.

PART I

The Silent World of Men

Understanding the struggles that rarely become conversations: the man nobody really knows, the burden of being a man, the tears that never fall, and the loneliness of the strong man.

1 CHAPTER

The Man Nobody Really Knows

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Distinguish between a man's public account of his life and his private experience of it, and explain why the distance between the two is usually invisible.
2. Identify the specific social, family, and occupational reasons why men conceal their deepest struggles.
3. Describe the emotional, physical, and relational costs that accumulate when a man maintains a permanently strong appearance.
4. Recognise the particular loneliness that can accompany achievement and responsibility.
5. Explain how silence functions as a survival strategy, and distinguish the situations in which it protects from those in which it damages.
6. Begin the structured work of describing the man behind the responsibilities — the person beneath the roles — using the exercise at the end of the chapter.

Introduction

Consider a man who is well known in his community. He is the chairman of a cooperative society, the treasurer of a school's parent association, the person a neighbour calls at eleven o'clock at night when a child has a fever and the family car will not start. He has been married for eighteen years. He has a small business that has survived two recessions. When he walks into a room the conversation turns towards him, not because he demands it, but because his presence has become associated with steadiness. If you asked ten people who know him to describe him in a sentence, nine would use words like *reliable*, *hardworking*, *respectful*, and *strong*.

Now consider that at three o'clock in the morning, for the better part of a year, he has been lying awake with his eyes open in the dark, thinking about a debt he cannot repay, a son he cannot reach, and a sentence his father said to him when he was eleven. He has never told his wife about the debt. He has never told anyone

about the sentence. He believes that to describe either would be to hand someone a weapon, or to burden them with something they did not ask to carry, or — the worst possibility of all — to invite the question he does not want to answer: *So what are you going to do about it?*

This is the man this book is about. Not the man who is visibly in trouble, whom everyone can see and, sometimes, help. The other one. The one whose difficulties are structurally invisible because everything about him is arranged to keep them that way. The man nobody really knows.

It is tempting to treat this man as a special case, somebody exceptional and unfortunate, whose circumstances are unusual. The evidence points the other way. Wherever researchers have asked men directly — in health surveys, in studies of fatherhood, in occupational research, in studies of bereavement and divorce — a substantial proportion report that they have no one with whom they can discuss their fears, that they have never told anyone about their most difficult experiences, and that they would not raise a serious personal problem with family or friends. The pattern is not confined to one country, one class, or one culture. It appears among men who are poor and men who are rich, among men with university degrees and men without, among men who live in extended families where there is always somebody in the house and men who live alone.

The purpose of this chapter is to describe that pattern clearly and to begin dismantling the assumption that sustains it: the assumption that a man's difficulties are his private business in a way that makes sharing them inappropriate, unnecessary, or shameful. Later chapters will deal with the particular battles — of the mind, of money, of love, of family, of identity, and of loss. This chapter deals with the mechanism that keeps all of them hidden.

1.1 The Public Image and the Private Reality

Almost every adult man in a position of responsibility manages two accounts of his life. There is the **public account** — what is visible, what is discussed, what is presented — and there is the **private account** — what is actually happening, what is feared, what is concealed. The two accounts are not merely different in content. They are different in kind.

The public account is organised around function. It records responsibilities met: fees paid, salaries distributed, problems resolved, decisions taken, hospital bills covered, weddings attended, disputes settled. It is presented in the language of outcomes, and it is largely verifiable. Other people can see much of it. This is why a man's public account is credible: it is not a boast, it is a record.

Table 1.1 The two accounts. Adapted for this edition from the pattern described in the health, family, and occupational literature on male disclosure.

Dimension	What the public account records	What the private account contains
Confidence	Decisions taken without hesitation	Uncertainty, dread, and rehearsed dread
Marriage	Stability, shared milestones, visible respect	Loneliness inside the marriage; unspoken disappointments
Money	Payments made, obligations met	Debt, arrears, borrowed money, fear of exposure
Health	Absence from hospital, no complaint made	Poor sleep, headaches, chest tightness, drinking
Grief and loss	Attendance at funerals; practical support given	Unfinished mourning; dreams; things unsaid
Self-regard	Titles, respect, the trust of others	The sense of being a fraud; shame about the past

The private account is organised around experience. It records what it feels like to be the man who does all of that. It contains the arithmetic he does at night — what is left after the fees, the rent, and the transport; whether the contract will be renewed; whether his wife's silences mean what he suspects they mean; whether the tightness in his chest is ordinary tiredness or something else. It contains memories and fears that may have nothing to do with the present at all: an early failure, a father's verdict, a betrayal he never resolved.

The critical fact is that the two accounts can coexist indefinitely, because they are addressed to different audiences, and one of those audiences is entirely internal. A man can maintain a functioning public account while his private account is deteriorating, and the people around him will have no basis on which to notice — not because they are inattentive, but because the information is not available to them. This is what makes the situation of such a man so dangerous. His distress is not hidden behind a lie. It is hidden behind the truth. Everything everyone sees is accurate. It is simply incomplete.

Why the Two Accounts Are Rarely Compared

It is worth asking why nobody ever audits the gap. There are four reasons, and each of them is ordinary rather than malicious.

First, the public account is unusually convincing. A man who is providing, showing up, and solving problems generates continuous evidence that he is managing. The evidence is real. The conclusion drawn from it — *he is fine* — feels reasonable and is rarely questioned.

Second, enquiry is socially expensive. To ask a capable man whether he is all right is to imply that he may not be. Many people, including people who love him, have learned that this implication is resented, particularly when it is repeated. So

they ask once, receive the standard reply — *I'm managing* — and conclude that further enquiry would be intrusive.

Third, there is usually no occasion. Family life and work life are full of logistics. Conversations are conducted in the intervals between tasks, and the intervals are short. Deep disclosure needs time, privacy, and an absence of agenda, and those conditions are increasingly rare in the lives of men who carry the most.

Fourth, and most importantly, the man himself does not compare the accounts. A person who is living a divided life does not experience it as a division. He experiences it as normal. The practice of presenting calm while feeling otherwise is so habitual, and so validated by the response it produces, that it no longer registers as concealment. When men first complete the self-assessment in Appendix A, they are frequently surprised by the size of the gap they have just written out in their own handwriting. Until that moment, they had no picture of it.

> **KEY POINT**
> The problem is not that a man lies about his life. It is that he reports only the part of it that can be verified, and everyone, including him, treats that part as the whole.

1.2 Why Men Conceal Their Deepest Struggles

If concealment were simply a bad habit, the solution would be straightforward: decide to be more open. The reason this advice fails so often is that concealment is not a mood. It is a calculation, made repeatedly, on the basis of real incentives. Before a man can change the calculation, he needs to see what it contains. There are six principal reasons men give, and they are not irrational.

Concealment Protects Position

In most societies a man's standing carries an implicit requirement of adequacy. The requirement may be expressed in relation to income, employment, decisiveness, physical capability, family authority, or the ability to assist others. To disclose a serious personal problem is to introduce information that may be read as evidence of inadequacy in one of these areas, and the reading is not always wrong. Men report concrete consequences from disclosure: they have lost contracts, been passed over for promotion, had their authority questioned at home, been mocked by peers, or been told that their difficulties were a sign that something was wrong with them as men. The fear of such consequences is not paranoia. It is a reasonable reading of the environment in which many men work and live.

Concealment Protects Other People

This is the reason that is most often overlooked, because it sounds like an excuse and is usually sincere. A man does not only conceal his struggles from those he

distrusts; he conceals them most carefully from those he loves. He does not want to frighten his wife, worry his mother, destabilise his children, or add to the burdens of a friend who has problems of his own. He has watched what happens when bad news enters a household: the atmosphere changes, everyone watches everyone, and the problem multiplies because it is now shared. In his assessment, silence is the kinder option.

The logic contains an error, but it is a generous error. It assumes that the people who love him would prefer to be protected rather than included, and that his difficulty is a burden rather than a fact of a shared life. Both assumptions deserve examination, and the later chapters on marriage and fatherhood examine them at length. For now it is enough to note that this is not dishonesty. It is a mistaken theory of care, held by men who are trying to be careful.

Concealment Protects the Concealer

There is a third function, which men rarely name aloud: not speaking prevents a man from having to encounter, fully, what is happening to him. As long as a difficulty remains unnamed, it remains provisional. It can still be managed, still be temporary, still be something that will resolve itself. To describe it to another person is to make it real, public, and — in his perception — permanent. Avoidance is not merely a strategy of concealment. It is also a strategy against knowledge, and it is a common one. Many men report that the hardest part of disclosure was not the reaction of the listener but the moment of hearing their own voice say the sentence.

Concealment Is a Learned Competence

Men are not born knowing how to appear calm when frightened. It is a skill that is trained, in small increments, over years. A boy who is laughed at for crying by older boys learns to move the crying out of sight. A young man who is told, at work, to solve the problem rather than explain it learns to present solutions rather than difficulties. A married man who discovers that his expression of fear produces a conflict in the household learns to express something else instead. Each lesson is followed by a reward, and rewarded behaviour tends to repeat. By his thirties the man is performing the skill unconsciously, at a high level of competence, and it takes deliberate effort even to notice the habit, let alone interrupt it.

Concealment Is Enforced by Absence of a Language

Many men who wish to speak cannot, because they do not have the words. This may sound trivial. It is not. An emotional vocabulary is learned through use and through modelling, and its absence produces a specific, documented experience: knowing that something is wrong without being able to say what it is. This produces an additional layer of distress. A man in this position may attempt disclosure and fail at the first sentence — *I don't know how to explain this* — and

interpret the failure as proof that nothing can be done. Chapter 3 returns to this problem in detail.

Concealment Is Enforced by Absence of a Confidant

Finally, a significant proportion of men have nobody with whom disclosure is realistically possible. Friendships have thinned; the ones that remain are organised around activities rather than confidences; relatives are too close to the situation; colleagues are competitors; a wife may be the person from whom he most needs to protect the information, either because it concerns her or because he believes she cannot bear it. In such a situation, a man's silence may be less a personal decision than a statement about his social position. Appendix J is addressed to this problem and treats the building of friendships as a practical skill rather than a matter of luck.

> **ILLUSTRATIVE STORY**
>
> **Emeka, forty-four, is a service manager at a large vehicle dealership.** He has spent six months managing a situation that no one at work or at home knows about. His mother, who lives four hours away, has a progressive illness, and the costs of her care have absorbed his savings and pushed him into a loan that will take years to repay. His supervisors regard him as unflappable; his wife has asked, twice, whether something is disturbing him, and on both occasions he said he was only tired. When a colleague suggested that he looked stressed, his response was immediate and almost automatic: *I'm fine. I just haven't been sleeping well.*
>
> Emeka's concealment is not a single decision but a series of them, made at the kitchen table, at the bank counter, on the phone with his brother, and in the car park before he goes into the house. Each separate decision seems small and defensible: not to mention the cost to his wife tonight because she has a difficult week at work; not to ask his sister for help because her own finances are precarious; not to take the employer's assistance programme because somebody in human resources might notice. Over six months, the small decisions have produced a large and entirely invisible problem, and — Emeka has begun to realise — a marriage in which the most important ongoing event in the family's life is known to one person only.
>
> This is a composite illustration, and it represents a widely reported pattern: the man who is managing something serious alone, not because he is indifferent to those around him, but because each individual act of concealment appears, in isolation, to be considerate.

Figure 1.1 sets out the structure of this situation in its simplest form. Above the line is what the people around a man can verify. Below it is the material that never reaches the conversation: what he fears, what he has lost, what he regrets, and what he cannot say. The essential point of the diagram is that the visible content is not false. It is merely small.

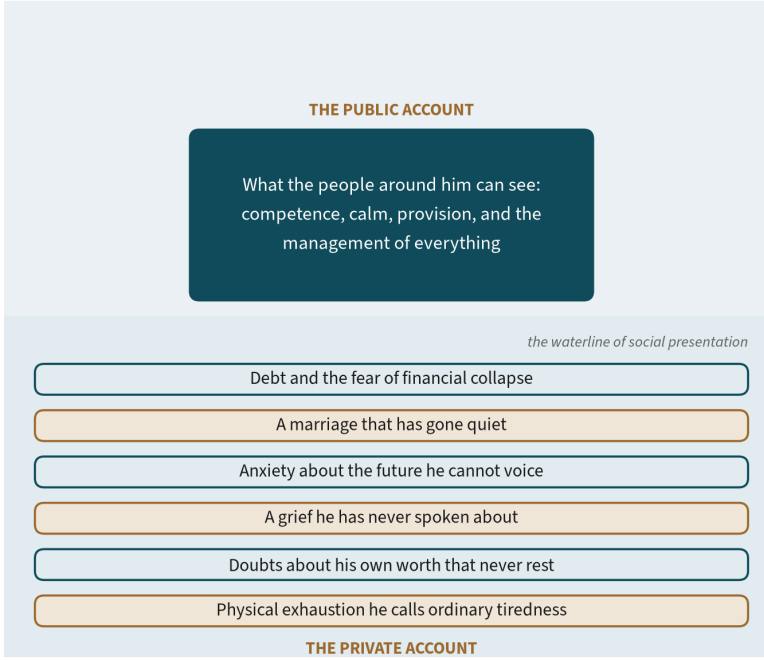


Figure 1.1 The two surfaces of a man's life. The upper zone is what others can verify — competence, provision, and steady management. The lower zone holds the material that rarely enters any conversation.

Once the gap is understood, the next question follows naturally: what does it cost to maintain it?

1.3 The Emotional Cost of Appearing Strong

The phrase *appearing strong* is important, because this chapter is not about strength. It is about the labour of producing an appearance of strength, which is a different and more expensive activity. Real strength — the capacity to act, to endure difficulty, to carry responsibility — is a resource. It grows or depletes depending on how it is used and replenished. The appearance of strength, by contrast, is a performance, and performances have costs that are invisible to the audience.

The Cost of Continuous Self-Monitoring

A man who has decided that his distress must not be visible takes on a permanent administrative task. He must monitor his own face, voice, posture, and answers, in every setting, all day. He must remember what he has told whom. He must select topics that will not lead towards dangerous ground. He must anticipate

questions and prepare replies. He must notice when he is close to losing control of his expression and find a reason to leave the room.

This monitoring is effortful, and it consumes exactly the resource he most needs for the difficulties he is managing: attention. Men in this position describe a characteristic experience that will be familiar to many readers — performing adequately at work, and remembering almost nothing about the day; sitting in a meeting and hearing, as though from a distance, their own voice making sensible contributions; driving home without any recollection of the route. The capacity to think clearly is finite, and when a substantial fraction of it is spent on concealment, the remainder is not enough for good judgement. This is one of the most practical reasons to end the silence. Concealment does not merely hurt; it makes a man worse at his responsibilities.

The Cost to Sleep and to the Body

The physical costs of sustained emotional suppression have been documented across several decades of research and are among the most robust findings in the field. Chronic stress activates physiological systems that are useful in emergencies and harmful when they never switch off. Men who habitually suppress emotion report and display higher rates of sleep disturbance, muscle tension, headaches, digestive complaints, elevated blood pressure, and fatigue that rest does not repair. In a general health setting, a man in this position is more likely to present with a physical symptom than an emotional one — headache, chest tightness, back pain, difficulty sleeping — and to be investigated, appropriately, for physical causes first. The emotional situation may never be mentioned at all.

The important implication for the reader is not medical but practical. If you are a man who has developed a set of physical complaints that no clinician has been able to explain, and you are managing a private burden that you have told nobody about, the two facts may be connected. This does not mean that the symptoms are imaginary. It means that the body is often the first place a suppressed problem becomes visible, and that physical treatment alone may miss the cause.

The Cost to Judgement and Decision-Making

Sustained stress and poor sleep degrade precisely the capacities that men at the centre of families and organisations most depend upon: emotional regulation, the ability to consider consequences at a distance, tolerance for disagreement, and honest assessment of risk. The changes are gradual, and they usually appear first in the smallest decisions — irritability about domestic trivia, abruptness with subordinates, a tendency to dismiss advice, a sudden certainty that a particular plan is the only possible path. Men in this state frequently describe themselves as having become short-tempered, and are frequently described by others in the same terms,

without either party understanding that they are describing the surface effect of concealed overload.

The Cost of Emotional Numbness

When a man holds a difficult feeling out of view for long enough, he does not merely hide it. He weakens his access to feeling altogether. Emotional regulation is a skill, and it is learned by practice; conversely, the habit of suppressing one emotion reduces the ability to experience others. Men who have suppressed fear and grief for years report that they have also lost pleasure: they no longer enjoy music as they did, they do not laugh as readily, they do not find their children as entertaining, they have become unable to cry even at events that would once have moved them, and they cannot say with certainty what they want. This flattening is one of the most frequently reported experiences in the literature on male depression and male grief, and it is deeply confusing to the person living it, because it does not feel like sadness. It feels like the disappearance of colour from a life that is, by every external measure, going well.

Figure 1.2 shows the mechanism by which this state maintains itself. Notice that no step in the loop requires any bad intention, and no step requires the man to be dishonest with himself. Each stage follows logically from the one before, and the loop can run for years without any external event disturbing it.

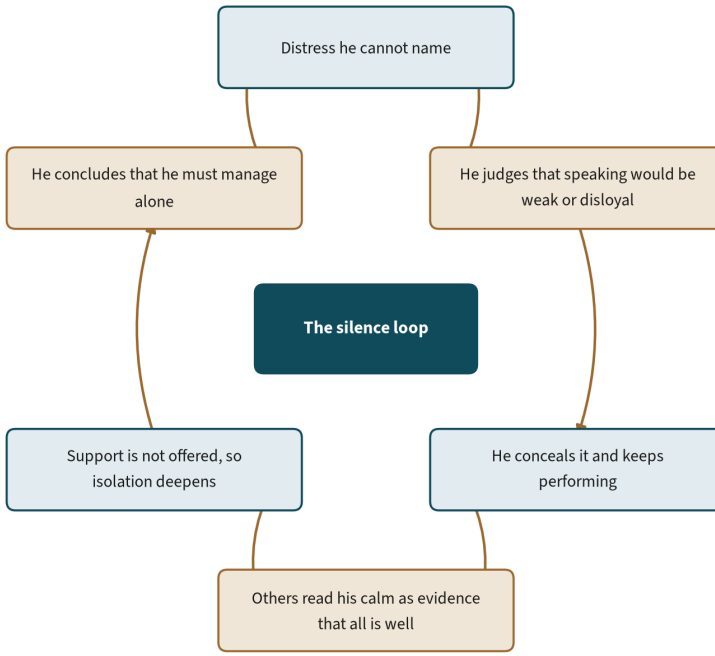


Figure 1.2 The silence loop. Concealment produces the appearance of coping, the appearance of coping removes the occasion for support, and the absence of support confirms the original decision to remain silent.

The Cost to Health Behaviour

There is a further cost that men rarely connect to concealment, and it matters greatly: the loss of routine medical care. A man who is maintaining an appearance of strength finds it difficult to attend a clinic. An appointment is an admission of need, and it produces a record. So routine checks are postponed, symptoms are minimised, and treatable conditions are discovered late. This is one of the clearest explanations for a well-documented pattern in men's health: men present later, with more advanced illness, and receive a diagnosis — whether of hypertension, diabetes, or depression — further along the natural history of the condition than women do. The behaviour looks like indifference to health. It is more often a consequence of the belief that a strong man does not need to be looked at.

KEY POINT

The labour of appearing strong consumes attention, degrades sleep, erodes judgement, dulls feeling, and defers care. By the time the performance is recognised for

> what it is, its costs have usually already been paid — in a marriage, in a business, in a heart, or in a body.

1.4 The Loneliness Behind Achievement

There is a particular loneliness that accompanies a man's success, and it is difficult to discuss because it appears ungrateful. The conventional understanding of loneliness is about absence: nobody around, nobody available, nobody interested. The loneliness that this section describes is the opposite. It occurs in the middle of company, in the middle of responsibility, in the middle of a life in which a great many people need something from the man in question. It is the loneliness of being surrounded, counted upon, relied upon, and unknown.

Why Achievement Produces It

Achievement and responsibility are structurally isolating, for four reasons that can be identified precisely.

Achievement changes the nature of conversation. A man who becomes the person who pays, decides, or mediates finds that conversations with him acquire a purpose. His wife needs a decision on the fees. His brother needs an answer on the loan. A colleague needs cover for a shift. A neighbour needs advice about a dispute. Every conversation is legitimate, and each one adds to the total quantity of contact while subtracting from the total quantity of relationship. At the end of a day of such conversations, a man has spoken to fourteen people and been known by none of them.

Achievement creates an audience that must be maintained. Once a man is known as the one who manages, that identity acquires expectations. To admit difficulty is perceived — by him and often by others — as a change in the terms. Men speak of an unspoken rule: *If I say I cannot, everything changes.* Whether or not the rule is real is an open question, and it is frightening precisely because it has never been tested.

Achievement removes the structure in which confidences happen. Friendships between men are frequently organised around shared activity — working, travelling, playing, farming, drinking, attending worship, and walking home together. When a man's advancement changes his daily patterns, he loses the intervals in which such friendships were conducted. What remains is the phone call, which is short and purposeful, and the occasional gathering, which is festive and public. Neither supports the kind of conversation in which a man says what is actually happening to him.

Achievement alters the terms of comparison. A successful man is compared with other successful men, which produces a persistent, low-grade sense of insufficiency even when his own position is objectively strong. This is the mech-

anism examined at length in Chapter 11, and it is one of the reasons that senior men are surprisingly difficult to console. They are not suffering from a shortage of achievement. They are suffering from a shortage of rest, of honesty, and of anyone who knows them well enough to say so.

The Specific Loneliness of the Accomplished Man

The loneliness produced by achievement has three features worth naming.

It is *invisible to others*, because it contradicts the visible evidence. Nobody looks at a man with a functioning business, an intact family, and a respected name and concludes that he might be desperately alone.

It is *invisible to the man* for a long time, because he attributes the feeling to fatigue, to age, to a difficult quarter at work, or to the fact that everyone is busy. He may not use the word *lonely* about himself at all, because the word seems to belong to people with nobody, and he has everybody.

And it is *self-reinforcing*. Loneliness produces a characteristic set of behaviours: withdrawal from social contact in order to avoid exposure, shorter and more functional communication, and a heightened perception of others as unavailable. These behaviours produce further loneliness, which deepens the withdrawal. Over a period of years, a man can arrive at a situation in which he has hundreds of contacts in his phone and not one person to whom he would send a message at midnight.

The Difference Between Recognition and Connection

A distinction that will recur throughout this book is set out here in its simplest form. **Recognition** is what a man receives for what he does: respect, titles, gratitude, deference, invitations, being asked for advice, being photographed at events, being named in acknowledgements. **Connection** is what a man receives for who he is: someone who knows what he is afraid of, someone who asks how he is and waits for the answer, someone who will tell him the truth, someone who will sit with him when there is nothing to be done.

Recognition and connection are not opposites, but they do not substitute for one another, and the second cannot be earned by increasing the first. This is the discovery that many successful men make in the middle of a period of achievement: they have become highly recognisable and entirely unknown. The tragedy of the pattern is that recognition is often pursued precisely because connection feels unobtainable, and each increase in recognition makes the pursuit of connection harder, since the man is now more, not less, exposed.

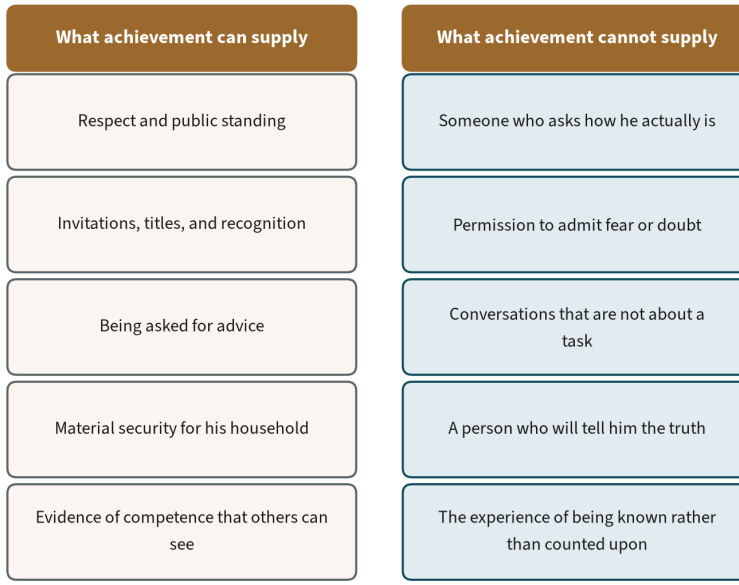


Figure 1.3 What achievement can supply, and what it cannot. The upper list grows with effort and position; the lower list does not respond to effort alone.

Figure 1.3 shows the gap in practical terms. A man can increase the left-hand column through work. The right-hand column requires a different activity entirely — disclosure, reciprocity, time, and the deliberate acceptance of risk — and most men have never been taught it.

1.5 When Silence Becomes a Survival Strategy

So far this chapter has established that concealment is common, calculated, and costly. It would nevertheless be a serious error to conclude that silence is always a mistake. There are circumstances in which not speaking is the intelligent response, and a book that treated all silence as pathology would be both inaccurate and useless, because it would lose the confidence of the very men it is trying to reach. A man reading this far is entitled to ask: *When is silence right, and when does it stop being right?*

Silence That Protects

Silence performs genuine protective functions in at least four situations.

Silence as timing. There are moments when disclosure would be destructive rather than helpful: during a family crisis when everyone's attention is needed elsewhere; in the week before a daughter's wedding; while a spouse is recovering from surgery; in the middle of a negotiation in which a man's authority is the only thing holding a fragile agreement together. Deferring a difficult conversation is

not concealment. It is judgement. The distinction lies in whether the deferral has an end — whether the man has decided that he will speak when the immediate situation is resolved — or whether "later" has become a permanent shelter.

Silence as protection of the vulnerable. A man whose child is ill, whose mother is grieving, or whose wife is in the middle of her own crisis may reasonably decide that his own distress will wait. This is a legitimate decision, and it is often the right one. What makes it legitimate is the presence of another outlet. A man may tell his wife nothing about his own fear concerning the child's illness while telling a friend, a counsellor, or a trusted relative, thereby carrying the burden without adding to hers. Where no such outlet exists, the protection becomes a solitary confinement with a noble name.

Silence where disclosure is genuinely dangerous. This is the most serious exception, and it is not hypothetical. In some homes, workplaces, and communities, a man who discloses vulnerability risks real harm: losing employment on which a household depends; becoming the object of mockery that will not cease; exposure to legal or financial consequences; in some circumstances, violence. A book written for general readers must acknowledge this situation honestly rather than recommending openness as an unconditional moral duty. In such circumstances, the priority is not disclosure but finding a route to support that does not pass through the source of danger — a professional service, a confidential helpline, a clinic, a trusted person outside the local network. Appendix Q addresses this directly.

Silence as self-control. A man who is furious, or in the grip of grief, may properly decide not to speak until he has regained the ability to speak well. This is not suppression but discipline, and it is a virtue that this book explicitly endorses. The test is whether the feeling is later processed and understood, or simply moved out of the way.

Silence That Damages

Silence stops being protective and starts being damaging when four conditions are present. The reader is encouraged to test his own situation against them.

Condition	What it looks like in practice
The silence is permanent rather than timed	"Not now" has been in force for months or years, with no date attached to it.
Nobody knows anything	No friend, relative, counsellor, or physician holds the information. The man is the only repository of the most important fact in his life.
The cost is rising	Sleep, health, marriage, work performance, or capacity to enjoy anything is deteriorating noticeably.

Condition	What it looks like in practice
The silence has acquired independent power	The thing unsaid is now harder to say than it was a year ago, and the man is avoiding the people who might ask, rather than merely declining to bring the subject up.

When all four are present, silence is no longer doing its original job. It has become the problem it was meant to manage. This is the point at which many men arrive at a crisis without any preceding event: a collapse at work, an explosion at home, a period of illness, or a decision about their own life that frightens everyone who knows them. There was no single cause. There was an unexamined accumulation.

The Illusion of the Self-Sufficient Man

Behind the strategic reasons for silence stands a belief that needs to be named and examined directly, because it is the assumption on which everything else rests: *a real man does not need help.*

The belief has an honourable origin. It grows out of the child's perception of an adult world of scarce resources; the young man's pride in his first wage; the older man's memory of what it cost to be independent. It is not a defect of character. It is a conclusion drawn, understandably, from a range of experiences — including experiences of times when help was not available, or came with a price.

It is nevertheless false in three ways, and each falsehood matters.

First, it is false as a matter of fact. Every durable human achievement, from a household to a corporation to a nation, is the product of cooperation. The man who believes he does everything alone is usually unaware of the extent to which he is supported: by a wife's unpaid labour, by colleagues' tolerance, by the credit extended by a supplier, by the cousin who helped a decade ago and has never mentioned it. Self-sufficiency is not a description of reality. It is a story, and it is usually a flattering one.

Second, it is false as a matter of effectiveness. Recognising that you need assistance, identifying what assistance is needed, and arranging for it is a competence. Men who possess it do better at everything they undertake. Soldiers, surgeons, engineers, and chief executives are not trained to solve every problem personally; they are trained to know the point at which a problem requires another person's capability. A man who insists on handling a failing business, a severe depression, or a deteriorating marriage alone is not displaying strength. He is declining to use resources that exist.

Third, it is false as a matter of cost. The belief is expensive, and the expense is borne chiefly by the people around the man. A woman who learns, after nineteen years of marriage, that her husband has been concealing a diagnosis, a debt, or a grief, does not experience that revelation as a demonstration of his strength. She

experiences it as exclusion from the most important fact in her own life. Children who grow up in a house where a father's silence is the water they swim in learn the lesson thoroughly, and carry it into their own adult relationships, sometimes for the rest of their lives.

Figure 1.4 sets out what men typically share and withhold across the six principal domains of their lives. The pattern is consistent across the countries in which such research has been done: the domain of achievement is well reported; the domains of fear, shame, and grief are not.

	Shared readily	Shared selectively	Almost never shared
Work	Achievements, plans, promotions	Uncertainty, unfair treatment	Fear that he is not competent
Money	Major purchases, investments	Moderate shortfalls	Debt, inability to provide, loss of income
Health	Injuries with a visible cause	Chronic conditions	Pain that suggests anxiety or depression
Marriage	Anniversaries, milestones	Ordinary disagreements	Loneliness within the marriage, loss of intimacy
Grief	Funeral arrangements, responsibilities	Memories with close relatives	The grief itself, especially for a child or a parent
Self-image	Public roles and titles	Career ambitions	Shame, regret, and the sense of being a fraud

Figure 1.4 The disclosure map across six domains of a man's life. The columns move from what is readily shared to what is almost never shared.

KEY POINT

Silence is a tool, not an identity. It is useful when it protects and times disclosure. It becomes destructive when it is permanent, total, costly, and self-sustaining — and those are exactly the conditions under which a man is least likely to notice it.

1.6 Understanding the Man Behind the Responsibilities

The final task of this chapter is to do deliberately what almost nobody does for a man in ordinary life: to set aside the roles and look at the person inside them.

A man in mid-life typically occupies between four and eight roles that carry obligations: husband, father, son, brother, earner, colleague, community member, and often the informal adjudicator for relatives. Each role is addressed by a title, and each title carries a set of questions that other people expect to be answered without hesitation. The effect of living inside these roles, for years, is not merely that a man is busy. It is that the roles become the available description of him. Ask a man in this position to describe himself and he will describe his work, his family, and his responsibilities, because those are the only categories he has been given and the only ones that produce an answer other people accept. Ask what he wants — not what is required, but what he wants — and the conversation frequently stops.

The man behind the responsibilities is not a mystery or a lost cause. He has specific attributes that have been set aside, usually for good reasons, and that remain available. He has preferences and dislikes that have not been expressed for years. He has abilities that are no longer in use. He has a set of opinions, some of them unconventional, that he keeps to himself because expressing them would not be useful. He has humour, curiosity, and tastes that were once central to who he was. He has griefs that have never been acknowledged and ambitions that were shelved without a decision ever being recorded. Most men, asked privately, can name these things. They have simply concluded that nothing can be done with them, and so they have stopped mentioning them.

Three Practical Distinctions

Three distinctions help to recover the person from the roles.

The difference between duty and identity. Duty is what a man must do. Identity is who he is. Many men have allowed the two to collapse into one another, so that the requirement to provide has become a statement about worth: *I am what I supply.* Under that arrangement, any shortfall in the first is experienced as destruction of the second, which is why a financial setback or a lost job can produce a collapse of identity that seems disproportionate to outsiders. Recovering the distinction is the work of Chapters 8, 24, and 40.

The difference between what others expect and what a man has chosen. Some of what a man carries has been chosen by him and affirmed by him. He would defend the choice if challenged. Other parts of the load have simply accumulated: obligations accepted because refusing was unimaginable, roles taken on because nobody else would, and possessions, arrangements, and commitments that no longer serve anything. Sorting the load into *chosen* and *inherited* does not

reduce it immediately, but it changes a man's relationship to it, and it usually reveals at least one item that can be set down. This is the substance of Chapter 10, on provider pressure and boundaries.

The difference between the man and the situation. A man in difficulty usually describes the difficulty as though it were a description of himself: *I am failing*, rather than *a business is failing, and my position is difficult*. The first phrasing produces shame, and shame produces concealment. The second produces a problem that can be examined and, in many cases, addressed. This is not word games. The shift in phrasing is the difference between a state of the self and a situation in the world, and men who learn it recover more quickly from setbacks — a finding that Chapter 7 explores in detail.

What This Book Asks of the Reader

The book does not ask the reader to abandon responsibility, to disclose everything to everyone, or to adopt a personality that is not his. It asks for something narrower and more achievable: to stop treating the interior of his own life as an area that cannot be discussed at all.

In practice this usually begins with a single item — one thing that has never been said — and one person. Not the whole truth at once, and not necessarily the person closest to him. The chapters that follow build the vocabulary for that first sentence (Chapter 3), the skills for the conversation (Chapter 14 and Appendix E), and the recognition of the point at which professional help is required (Chapters 5, 6, and 34).

The exercise that follows is the first step, and it is deliberately private. Nothing about it requires an audience.

1.7 Illustrative Case: Two Years in the Life of a Man Who Was Managing

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

The following case is composite. It draws on patterns reported repeatedly in counselling practice, occupational health, and family research. It is not the record of any individual, and the names, places, and details have been constructed for teaching purposes.

Daniel, fifty-two, is a district manager for an agricultural inputs company. He supervises eleven staff across four towns, has four children, two of them in tertiary institutions, and is the eldest surviving son in a family of seven siblings. His father died nine years ago; his mother lives in the family house, which he maintains. He is the person his siblings telephone when there is a hospital bill, a school fee, a land dispute, or a funeral to organise. He has never missed a month's salary for his own household, and he is, by any reasonable standard, a successful man.

Year one. In March, a key supplier changes its credit terms and Daniel's branch loses roughly a third of its working margin. He does not tell his wife, because he judges that there is nothing she can do and that telling her would only frighten her. In July, he borrows from a cooperative society at an interest rate he knows is punishing, and begins to service it quietly. In September, one of his children is placed on academic probation. He is furious in a way that surprises him, and afterwards he sits in his car for forty minutes. In December he attends three funerals in eleven days, including that of a cousin his own age, and he does not cry at any of them; he notices this and files it away as a fact about himself.

Year two. By February, Daniel is waking at half past three in the morning with his heart going hard, and is unable to get back to sleep. By April, he has stopped attending the monthly meeting of the community association that he once helped to found, offering transport problems as his reason. In June, his wife asks him, in an ordinary voice, whether he is angry with her. He says no, and is telling the truth as he understands it. In August, a young colleague, joking, says that the district manager has become "a quiet man." In September, Daniel is short-tempered with a customer in a way that is entirely out of character, and his supervisor speaks to him about it. In October, on a Tuesday afternoon, driving between two towns, he pulls off the road, sits with the engine off, and is unable to say afterwards how long he remained there. At no point in these two years does Daniel seek help, tell his wife the truth about the finances, or speak to a friend about the four o'clock darkness that has become a permanent feature of his life. Nobody in his family, workplace, or community believes that anything significant is wrong. His supervisor's comment is the closest anyone comes, and it concerns a symptom — rudeness to a customer — rather than the situation producing it.

A reader may find it easy to diagnose this case and difficult to feel it. The diagnosis is straightforward: prolonged concealment, chronic stress, probable depressive symptoms presenting as irritability and insomnia, unresolved grief, and provider overload. But Daniel is not a man who is failing. He is a man who is doing everything he believes is required of him, and concealing the cost, because he has concluded that the cost is his to bear.

The instructive element of the case is the mechanism, which is set out in Figure 1.5. Daniel never made a decision to keep a secret. He made a series of decisions, each of which seemed at the time to be the considerate one, and which together produced a private crisis that lasted two years and involved the progressive loss of sleep, temper, social participation, pleasure, and self-recognition.

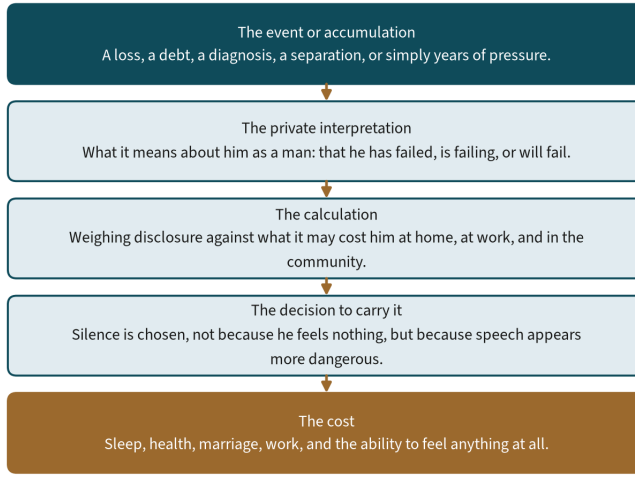


Figure 1.5 From event to cost. Each stage in the sequence is experienced privately and justified to the man himself; none of them appears to an observer as a change in behaviour until the later stages.

Four features of this pathway deserve to be fixed in the reader's mind, because they recur in every part of this book.

The decisions were not made once, but continuously. There was no moment at which Daniel resolved to live a double life. There were, instead, perhaps two hundred occasions on which not mentioning something was easier than mentioning it.

Each individual decision was defensible. To refrain from alarming a spouse who cannot change a supplier's terms is not cowardice. It is a judgement, made without the benefit of knowing that it would be repeated two hundred times and would end by excluding her from the most consequential period of their married life.

The costs appeared in a fixed order. Sleep first, then temper, then withdrawal, then loss of pleasure, then a kind of absence that the man himself can describe but not explain. This ordering is so common in reports of prolonged male concealment that it deserves to be treated as a warning sequence. When a man notices that he is sleeping badly and is becoming unusually short-tempered, and he has a private burden he has told nobody about, he should treat the sleep and the temper as early warning instruments rather than as unrelated annoyances.

The system concealed him effectively. Note that the concealment was not maintained by Daniel alone. His wife accepted his explanation about work.

His supervisor addressed the symptom. His colleague made a joke. His siblings continued to make requests, because requests were always being made and were always met. Everyone's behaviour was reasonable, and the sum of all that reasonable behaviour was a man disappearing inside his own life without anyone raising an alarm.

1.8 Practical Exercise: The Two Accounts

This exercise is private. Do not do it in company. It takes about forty minutes, and it should be done in writing, on paper or in a document that nobody else will read. Writing matters: thinking produces conclusions, writing produces material.

Step One: The Public Account

Draw a line down the centre of a page. On the left, write the heading **What people know about my life**. List between eight and fifteen facts that an attentive observer — a wife, a colleague, a brother — could verify. Keep to facts about your roles and your record: employment, family, responsibilities met, assistance given, obligations discharged.

Step Two: The Private Account

On the right-hand side, under the heading **What nobody knows**, write down, in whatever order they come, the items that never enter a conversation. Do not aim for completeness, and do not worry about the order. It may help to prompt yourself with the following seven questions.

1. What worry occupies more of my attention than anything else, and who knows about it?
2. What would I not want my family to read if they opened my phone or my bank statement?
3. What have I lost in the last five years that I have never properly mourned?
4. What did somebody say to me, at some point in my life, that I have never repeated aloud?
5. What am I pretending to be confident about?
6. What would I say about my own life if I were certain that nobody would be hurt by it?
7. If my sleep, my temper, and my appetite have changed in the last year, what do I think is causing it?

Most men produce between five and twelve items. Some produce two; some produce twenty. The number is not the point.

Step Three: The Gap

Look at the two lists side by side. Now answer three questions in writing, in at least a paragraph each.

- **Which single item in the right-hand column carries the most weight?** Not the most dramatic — the heaviest. The one that, if it were resolved or shared, would change the most.
- **What have I told myself would happen if I spoke about it?** Write the prediction in full, including what you imagine the other person would say, and what would change afterwards. Be precise; vague fears cannot be examined.
- **Whom would I tell if I decided to tell one person, and what stops me?**

Step Four: The Test

Choose the smallest possible action from what you have written. Not the decisive conversation, and not a confession. One of the following will usually fit.

- Sending one message to one person: *Are you free to talk this week? I have something on my mind.*
- Writing the first paragraph of the item you identified in Step Three, and keeping it for a week before deciding what to do with it.
- Making an appointment with a physician, a counsellor, or a trusted professional — Appendix Q explains how — without requiring yourself to know in advance what you will say.
- Choosing one area of your life in which you will stop answering *I'm fine* and begin answering honestly: *I'm managing, but there is one thing that has been weighing on me.* Note that this last option does not require disclosing the thing itself, only signalling that it exists — a step that many men find to be the decisive one.

Step Five: A Note on Difficulty

If this exercise produced more distress than you expected, that is informative rather than alarming. It usually indicates that at least one item in the private account is carrying a great deal of charge, and it is worth speaking to a qualified professional before proceeding further with it. Chapters 5, 6, and 34 discuss the point at which self-directed work should be supplemented by clinical support, and Appendix B provides a structured way to assess what you may be dealing with.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 1 in brief. Every man of responsibility maintains two accounts of his life: a public account, which records responsibilities met and is verifiable by others, and a private account, which holds what he fears, conceals, regrets, and cannot say. The public account is not false — it is incomplete — and this is what makes the concealment of distress so effective.

Men conceal their struggles for reasons that are rational within their circumstances: to protect their position, to protect the people they love, to avoid encountering their

own situation fully, because concealment has been learned as a competence, because they lack the vocabulary to describe what is happening, and because no confidant is actually available. These reasons deserve respect before they are challenged.

The costs of maintaining a strong appearance are concrete. Continuous self-monitoring consumes attention and degrades judgement; suppression raises physiological strain and disrupts sleep; sustained over-arousal erodes emotional regulation; emotional numbness removes pleasure along with pain; and the habit of not being seen produces late presentation for treatable conditions in both body and mind.

Achievement produces a particular loneliness. It converts relationships into transactions, creates an audience that must be maintained, removes the intervals in which confidences occur, and shifts comparison to the most competitive reference group available. Recognition and connection are not the same thing, and the first cannot generate the second.

Silence is not always a mistake. It is legitimate as timing, as protection of the vulnerable, as self-control, and in situations where disclosure genuinely carries risk. It becomes damaging when it is permanent, when nobody at all knows, when the costs are rising, and when the unsaid has acquired independent power — at which point silence has ceased to be a tool and become the problem.

The man behind the responsibilities can be recovered by distinguishing duty from identity, expectation from choice, and the person from the situation. Recovering him is not a luxury; it is the precondition of both health and accurate judgement. The change begins with one item and one person, and it begins in writing.

Reflection Questions

These questions may be used privately, or as the basis for discussion in a men's group, a book club, or a facilitated session. Appendix S provides additional group questions for the whole book.

1. Of the six reasons for concealment set out in Section 1.2, which apply most strongly to you or to a man you know well? Which of them is most likely to change in the next two years, and why?
2. Section 1.5 identified four circumstances in which silence is legitimate. Have you been using one of them as a permanent shelter rather than a temporary measure? How would you know?
3. Consider the distinction between recognition and connection. Which of the two is more available to you today, and what would have to change for the other to become available?
4. The illustrative case of Daniel describes a man who behaved reasonably at every step and arrived at a crisis. Where in your own life is reasonable behaviour producing an unreasonable outcome?

5. What is the earliest warning signal that appears when you are under sustained strain — sleep, appetite, temper, withdrawal from company, or something else? Who else knows what your signal is?
6. What is the smallest honest sentence you could say this month to one person, and what makes it difficult?
7. If your son or younger brother were living your current life at your current level of concealment, what would you want to say to him? What stops you from applying it to yourself?

Further Reading

Works in this area span several disciplines — psychology, public health, sociology, and men's studies — and readers may find it useful to approach the subject from more than one direction. The following are directions for further study rather than a closed list; full publication details are not given here because editions and imprints vary by country, and readers should consult a library catalogue or their national library service.

- **On men's health behaviour and help-seeking:** the general literature on masculinity and health, including studies of why men delay consulting and what happens when they do. Look for work in *Psychology of Men and Masculinities* and in men's health journals, and for national men's health reports, which are usually available free of charge from government health departments.
- **On concealment and disclosure:** the psychological literature on self-disclosure, emotional suppression, and the health effects of inhibition. The classic research on the physiological consequences of holding back emotion is well worth reading in the original.
- **On loneliness:** the substantial modern research literature on loneliness as a health risk, including work that distinguishes social isolation from subjective loneliness — a distinction that matters greatly for men who are never alone but feel entirely unknown.
- **On grief and men:** studies of male bereavement and the concept of disenfranchised grief, in which a person's loss is not socially recognised as a loss. This literature is directly relevant to Chapters 16 and 30.
- **On African and Nigerian contexts:** the growing body of work on masculinity, family obligation, and mental health in African settings, including studies of extended-family responsibility and of the stigma attached to psychological services. Readers in West Africa will find that this literature speaks the language of their own circumstances with unusual accuracy.
- **On practice:** the published works of counsellors and therapists who write for general readers on male emotional life, and the clinical guidance docu-

ments on depression and anxiety issued by national health bodies and by the World Health Organization, which are available online and are written for a wide audience.

Readers who wish to pursue the underlying evidence in a structured way will find the recommended titles in Appendix Q and in the bibliography at the end of this volume.

2 CHAPTER

The Burden of Being a Man

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the expectations that a man's society places on him, and identify the specific ways in which those expectations are communicated to boys and maintained in adult life.
2. Analyse the three duties of adult manhood — to provide, to protect, and to perform — and assess the personal cost of carrying all three without relief.
3. Explain the fear of being considered weak, distinguish it from the fear of being weak, and describe the behaviour it produces in work, marriage, and friendship.
4. Identify the structural reason that men receive less emotional support than women and describe the consequences for health, relationships, and decision-making.
5. Recognise the pattern in which manhood becomes a lifelong examination with no examiner and no conclusion, and describe its effects in mid-life and later life.
6. Apply a revised understanding of strength, and use the exercise at the end of this chapter to audit the script he is carrying.

Introduction

Every society distributes certain expectations by sex, and every society therefore hands each man a script before he can read. The script is rarely written down, and it is remarkably consistent in its outline across countries, religions, and economic systems, which is what makes it worth treating as a subject in its own right rather than as a local custom.

In the case of men, the script has five clauses. A man must be able to provide. A man must be able to protect. A man must be able to perform — to succeed at whatever he undertakes, and to be seen to succeed. A man must endure, which is to say that he must absorb difficulty without visible strain. And a man must control his feelings, particularly the feelings that would make him appear dependent: fear, sadness, and the need for comfort.

The script has real value, and it is important not to caricature it. It produced the men who built the roads, staffed the hospitals at night, carried households through currency collapses, and stayed at their posts when leaving would have been easier. Many of the qualities it prescribes — reliability, courage, endurance, the willingness to be responsible for other people — are genuine virtues, and this book does not propose that men should shed them.

What this chapter examines is what the script costs the man who keeps it. Five costs are consistent enough across the research and the clinical accounts to be treated as established. The first is that the script requires performance without accompaniment: it specifies what a man must do and says nothing about what a man may need. The second is that its clauses are more demanding than the resources available to most men in most economies, which means that a large proportion of men are permanently in deficit against a standard they did not choose. The third is that the script defines rest, disclosure, and dependency as failures, which removes the three mechanisms by which human beings recover from prolonged strain. The fourth is that it is enforced by other men as much as by women, so that the nearest source of relief is also the nearest source of censure. And the fifth, which is developed in Chapter 4, is that performance of the script reliably succeeds at its visible objective while reliably failing at the one a man needs most, which is to be known.

2.1 Society's Expectations of Masculinity

The expectations can be summarised as six requirements, and it is worth setting them out individually because each of them produces a distinct pressure.

Provide. A man is expected to be the principal source of income for a household, to meet the requirements of dependants, and to be the person who resolves a financial emergency. This clause is the most heavily loaded in most of the countries where this book will be read, and it is the one that produces the material of Chapters 9 to 12.

Protect. A man is expected to be the one who manages danger: to intervene in a conflict, to accompany a relative through a hostile situation, to defend the household's position in a dispute, to handle the encounter with officials, employers, or creditors. Protection is frequently expected of men who are not physically imposing and who have no capacity to provide it, and the expectation is applied to the physical and the social domain at once.

Perform. A man's competence, output, and advancement are understood as evidence of what he is. Performance is not merely a work requirement; it is an assessment of the man, applied to professional duties, sexual capacity, fatherhood, and the management of his household.

Endure. A man is expected to absorb pain, exhaustion, and disappointment without displaying the strain. The allowance made for a man's suffering is visibly smaller than the allowance made for a woman's, and it is frequently smaller for the sons in a family than for the daughters.

Decide. A man is expected to be the one who knows, who determines, and who takes responsibility for the outcome. Where the decision belongs formally to somebody else — a wife who manages the household finances, a mother whose judgement governs the family, an employer — the expectation is still attached to the man, and his position is therefore both responsible and powerless.

Control feeling. The prohibition is specific rather than general. It applies to sadness, fear, longing, tenderness, shame, and the need for reassurance. It does not apply to anger, which is the one emotion men are permitted, and which consequently becomes the channel through which every other emotion is expressed, as Chapters 3 and 15 describe.

> **KEY POINT**
> The script does not ask a man to have no feelings. It asks him to have no feelings that require anything from another person. Anger, being the one emotion that requires nothing, is therefore the only one the script permits — and it is the reason that a distressed man is so frequently described as an angry one.

How the Script Is Transmitted

The script reaches men through five channels, and it is worth naming them because men who can identify the channels can interrupt them.

Direct instruction in childhood. Sentences such as *boys do not cry*, *be a man*, *stop behaving like a girl*, *nobody will help you if you are soft*, and *do not let anybody see you afraid*. The instruction is frequently affectionate in its intent and it is memorable in its effect; men asked to recall the first time they were told not to cry can usually produce the sentence and the year.

Models. The men available to the boy: a father who worked at two jobs and never mentioned difficulty, an uncle who spoke only about money and achievement, a teacher who rewarded silence. The modelling is more powerful than the instruction, because it demonstrates what is actually required.

Correction in adolescence. The specific moments in which a boy is treated as a man and learns what manhood requires of him: the first time he is sent to negotiate, the first time he is told to handle a family matter, the first time he is told the truth about the household's finances and sworn to silence. The transition is frequently abrupt, and men describe it with precision.

Enforcement in adult life. The script is maintained by other men, by women, and by institutions. The mechanisms are comment, comparison, exclusion, and

the withdrawal of respect: the remark about a man who has been left by his wife, the joke about the man who attends to his children, the assumption that a man who discusses his difficulties is unreliable. Research on conformity indicates that this kind of informal enforcement is more effective than formal instruction, and the evidence from men's accounts supports that assessment.

Economic conditions. The fifth channel is the most powerful and the least discussed. Where a household depends on one income, the clause that requires provision is enforced not by anybody's opinion but by the household's requirements. This is why the script cannot be undone by a man's private decision alone: a man who has decided not to carry the burden of provision will still have to explain the decision to a household that depends on it.

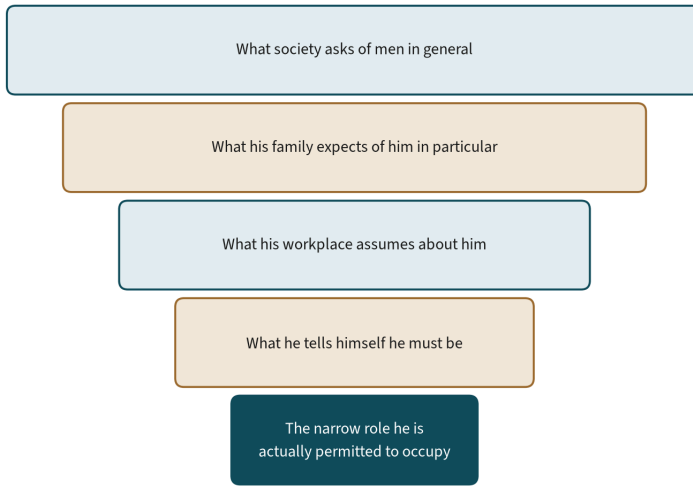


Figure 2.1 How the expectations accumulate. Each layer narrows the range of feeling and need that a man is permitted to express, and the narrowest layer is the one he writes for himself.

The Mismatch Between the Script and Contemporary Conditions

The script was assembled in conditions that no longer describe the economic lives of most men. Three mismatches are consequential.

The script assumes stable employment and progressive income across a working life. Most men now experience interrupted employment, irregular income, and a labour market in which the work available does not match the qualifications held.

The script assumes that a man's household is his principal economic obligation. In most of the countries where this book will be read, a man supports

a household and an extended family whose requirements are not capped by his income and whose claims are enforced by custom rather than negotiated.

The script assumes that a man's worth is visible and publicly assessable, in the form of a house, a position, and the wellbeing of his children. Where the economy prevents a substantial proportion of men from reaching those markers, the script produces a class of men who are, by its own criteria, unsuccessful, and who are so in public and in permanent form.

The consequence of the mismatch is not that men abandon the script. It is that they carry it with more strain and less support than it was calibrated for, and that the failure they experience in meeting it is interpreted by themselves and by their communities as personal inadequacy rather than as a change in conditions. Chapter 11 addresses the consequences directly, and this chapter's remaining sections address the internal machinery.

2.2 The Pressure to Provide, Protect, and Perform

The three central duties interact, and the interaction is the source of most of the pressure that men describe. Each duty is manageable in isolation. Together they produce an arrangement in which the man is required to be simultaneously the household's income, its security service, and its public representative, with no defined hours, no relief, and no acknowledgement that the combination is a job rather than an identity.

Provide

The provision duty is the most heavily enforced and the most concretely measurable. Its features are worth stating precisely.

It is open-ended. The obligation is not to a figure but to a standard: the household's needs as they arise, the family's expectations as they are expressed, and the community's assessment of what a man in his position should be able to do. Since the standard is set by comparison rather than by arithmetic, the obligation has no ceiling.

It is continuous. Rent, food, transport, fees, medical costs, and instalments recur monthly. A man who meets them is not, at any point, finished; he is merely current. The absence of a completion point is one of the reasons men describe financial responsibility as the most fatiguing of all their obligations, even where the amounts are manageable.

It is personalised. The obligation is attached to the man rather than to the household, which means that a shortfall is experienced as a personal failure rather than as a household difficulty. This is the mechanism by which an ordinary economic event — a delay in payment, a bad month, a client's default — becomes an injury to identity.

It is publicly verifiable. Unlike the other duties, provision leaves visible evidence: the house, the vehicle, the school, the contributions. Since the evidence is public, the assessment is public, and the man's standing is under continuous review.

It is frequently carried in secret. Where a man's provision has become impossible, the concealment described in Chapter 9 begins: the borrowing, the second obligation, the maintained standard, the private calculation.

Protect

The protection duty is less discussed and it operates continuously in the background of a man's day.

Its forms include physical protection, in which a man is expected to intervene in a confrontation and to accompany relatives through dangerous or hostile situations; financial protection, in which he is the person who handles an emergency; social protection, in which he represents the household in disputes with institutions, landlords, employers, and officials; and emotional protection, in which he is the person who absorbs the household's shocks and communicates them without panic.

Three features of the protection duty deserve attention.

It is expected in conditions where it is impossible. A man may be expected to defend a position against an employer, a police officer, a landlord, or a group of relatives, with no legal knowledge, no resources, and no allies. The expectation is applied regardless, and the man's inability to meet it is registered as a failure of courage rather than as an absence of means.

It is dangerous. The expectation that a man will intervene is a documented contributor to men's elevated rates of injury and death from violence and road traffic incidents. Research on male mortality consistently identifies risk-taking and the refusal to withdraw from confrontation as contributing factors, and the mechanism is the protection duty operating in its public form.

It is not negotiable by the man alone. A man who declines the protective role in a family dispute, in a community matter, or in a confrontation is not merely declining a task; he is departing from the script, and the departure will be interpreted as cowardice by people whose opinion he needs.

Perform

The performance duty covers the widest range and is the least visible, because it operates inside the other two.

Its domains include professional achievement, sexual capacity, fatherhood, the management of the household's affairs, and simple competence in the ordinary matters of life: a man who cannot repair, negotiate, calculate, or drive is frequently assessed on his inability rather than on his other qualities.

Three features of the performance duty produce specific damage.

Performance is measured by comparison. As Chapter 11 establishes, the standard is a position rather than a level, and the man is therefore in permanent competition with a reference group that is visible to him and that includes his brothers, his colleagues, and his contemporaries.

Failure is public. A man's professional failure, business collapse, or divorce is known, discussed, and remembered. Chapter 16 treats the consequences, and it is worth noting here that the public character of failure is what makes men so heavily invested in the maintenance of appearance, and therefore in the concealment described in Part Three.

The duty is not suspended by illness. A man who is unwell is still assessed on his performance, and men report with consistency that the expectation is not reduced for a period of ill health; it is frequently intensified, since a man's incapacity places the household's arrangements in question.

The Combined Pressure

The three duties produce a specific psychological arrangement, which men describe in nearly identical terms: a permanent readiness.

The features of permanent readiness are recognisable. The man is unable to rest without justification. He experiences ordinary leisure as a debt. He is attentive to threats — financial, professional, familial — at a level that is invisible to others and continuous. He does not consider himself to be under stress, because stress would imply that the arrangement is optional; he considers himself to be in the ordinary condition of a man. And when the arrangement is described to him, he agrees with the description and does not change it, because he can identify no alternative that would meet the obligations he has accepted.

> **KEY POINT**
> Permanent readiness is a physiological state, not merely an attitude. The research on chronic stress shows that sustained alertness produces elevated cortisol, disrupted sleep, raised blood pressure, impaired immune function, and reduced cognitive flexibility. Twelve years of permanent readiness produces the health outcomes described in Chapters 32 to 34 — and the men who present with them are frequently surprised, because they did not consider themselves to have been under stress at all.

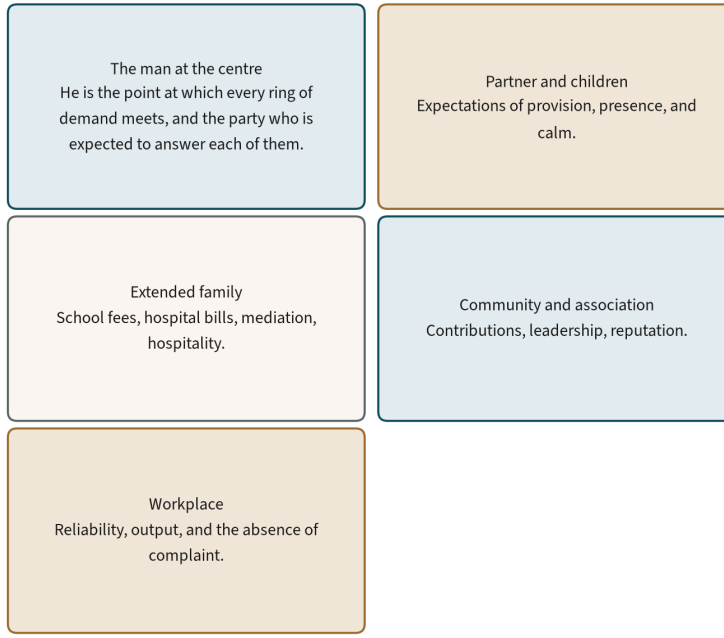


Figure 2.2 The demands that settle on one man. The rings are concentric in experience rather than in distance: each is close enough to be felt, and none is entirely outside his sense of responsibility.

2.3 The Fear of Being Considered Weak

This section addresses a fear that governs more male behaviour than any other, and it begins with a distinction that is rarely made explicit.

The fear of being weak is a fear about capacity: that the man may not be able to meet what is required. It is a rational fear, it is sometimes well founded, and its appropriate management is training, planning, assistance, and the revision of commitments.

The fear of being considered weak is a fear about standing: that the man will be assessed as inadequate by others, with consequences for respect, authority, and position. It is a social fear, and its management is concealment, overcorrection, and the avoidance of everything that would create the appearance.

The two are frequently experienced together and they are not the same. A man may be entirely capable and terrified of appearing incapable; a man may be genuinely at the limit of his capacity and indifferent to others' assessments.

The distinction matters because the second fear cannot be resolved by becoming stronger. It requires a change in what the man believes the assessment depends on.

What Weakness Means to Men

Men's accounts make it possible to set out what the accusation of weakness consists of. It is not fatigue, and it is not illness. The five elements are:

1. **Dependence on others.** Any arrangement in which the man needs something from somebody else: money, help, presence, or consideration.
2. **Visible emotional distress.** Tears, trembling, panic, or an inability to speak about a matter without breaking down.
3. **Failure to meet an obligation.** A debt unpaid, a fee unmet, a duty declined, a decision having to be reversed.
4. **The disclosure of a private matter.** Telling anyone about the household's difficulties, the marriage, the man's own condition, or a failure.
5. **A decision taken by somebody else.** Being overruled, being managed, discovering that others have decided a matter of consequence to the man.

The common element in all five is exposure: vulnerability to another person's assessment. This is why the fear is so difficult to satisfy — it is not a fear of a state but of being seen in a state, and concealment is therefore the only tactic the man has. The tactics that conceal well produce the consequences described in Chapters 3, 5, and 9.

The Behaviour It Produces

Five recognisable patterns follow from the fear, and men who find four or more of them familiar should treat the audit exercise at the end of this chapter as a priority.

Concealment. The ordinary response, and the one on which this book's earlier chapters are built.

Overcorrection. Where concealment is impossible, the man demonstrates the opposite in an exaggerated form: the man in a difficult financial position who buys a vehicle, the man with a failing marriage who becomes publicly affectionate, the man with an untreated illness who takes on additional work. Overcorrection is expensive and it is reliable: it converts a manageable problem into an unmanageable one.

Avoidance of assistance. Men in this pattern decline help that is offered, and they do so in a manner that is difficult for the person offering to challenge. They also fail to seek assistance that requires an admission: medical assessment, financial advice, counselling, legal advice, a request for an extension from a creditor.

Aggression toward the messenger. Where somebody raises the matter — a wife, a friend, a colleague, a physician — the man's response is frequently disproportionate, and the disproportionate response is registered by the messenger as a

reason not to raise it again. The pattern is a principal reason that men in difficulty are surrounded by people who know something is wrong and say nothing.

The constant demonstration. The most socially expensive pattern: the man whose working life, relationships, and spending are organised around the continuous demonstration of strength. The pattern is exhausting and it is transparent to the men closest to him, but it can be sustained for thirty years, and it is frequently the arrangement that produces the material of Chapters 32 to 34.

2.4 Responsibility Without Emotional Support

The most consequential feature of the male script is not its demands but its silence about support. A man is given an account of what he must do and no account of what he may need, and the absence is maintained by the man himself, by his household, and by the institutions he deals with.

The Asymmetry

The asymmetry is visible in every setting where men and women are observed together.

In families. A man's difficulty is frequently met with an assessment of its practical consequences; a woman's difficulty is met with attention to the difficulty itself. The research on social support consistently finds that women receive more emotional support than men, that they report more people to whom they can turn in difficulty, and that the difference persists across countries and socioeconomic groups.

In friendships. As Chapter 4 establishes, men's friendships are frequently built around shared activity rather than shared disclosure, and the disclosure channel is therefore frequently absent even in long-standing relationships.

In marriage. A man's principal source of intimacy is frequently his wife, and the arrangement is therefore a single point of failure. Where the marriage contains a difficulty, or the wife's own capacity is exhausted, the man has no second source.

In the workplace. A man's difficulty is a risk to his position. The disclosure of a personal problem to an employer is frequently managed with a practical accommodation and an unspoken reassessment, and men's assessment of the risk is accurate on this point.

In health care. Men consult less frequently, present later, and describe symptoms in reduced form. The consequences are documented across conditions: later diagnosis, more advanced disease at presentation, and higher mortality for conditions that are treatable when detected early.

Why Support Is Not Offered to Men

Four mechanisms, each of which operates independently of anybody's intentions.

The signals are absent. Support is offered in response to the signals of distress — tears, distress in the voice, the statement of need, the visible disorganisation of a person's life. Men's distress signals are frequently the opposite: increased work, increased irritability, longer hours, less speech. A household looking for distress will frequently find the opposite of its signs, which is why a wife will say, accurately, that she had no idea.

The man declines it. The offer of support is refused, in a manner that ends the matter. The refusal is frequently of the form *I am managing*, *it is not a problem*, or the practical deflection of the conversation, and it is registered by the person offering as a conclusion. Most support to men is not withheld; it is declined, and the decline is honoured.

The supporting person is exhausted. The most under-discussed mechanism. In many households, the wife has been supporting children, parents, siblings, the household's administration, and her own difficulties, and she has no residual capacity for a further load. Her withdrawal is not indifference; it is depletion, and the man's assessment of his marriage as unsupportive is frequently a description of a household in which nobody has capacity for anybody.

The culture has no script for male support. There is an available script for supporting a woman: attention, presence, practical assistance, listening. There is no comparable script for supporting a man, and the available alternative is a set of approaches that men find ineffective: instruction, motivation, comparison with other men, the suggestion that the man should be grateful for what he has, and the recommendation that he should be stronger. The absence of a script is a failure of culture rather than of the individual household.

The Consequences

Delayed recognition of serious conditions. Depression, hypertension, diabetes, cardiac symptoms, and cancer are all detected later in men, and the delays are frequently measured in years.

The conversion of difficulty into behaviour. Where support is unavailable and disclosure is prohibited, distress is expressed in behaviour: alcohol, risk-taking, work, spending, and anger. Each is treated by the environment as the problem, and the underlying condition is therefore neither identified nor treated.

Poor decisions made in isolation. A man without a confidant or a reviewer decides alone, on impaired judgement, in conditions of chronic strain. The consequences are visible in men's financial disasters, business failures, and legal entanglements, each of which is frequently traceable to a decision made without any conversation.

The single point of failure in marriage. Where the wife is the sole confidant, the death or illness of the wife removes the man's entire support system at once.

The research on widowers' mortality is unambiguous on this point, and Chapter 25 addresses the long-term consequence, which is frequently a decade or more of isolation.

The transmission to the next generation. A son who observes a father carrying responsibility without support learns that this is what manhood consists of. The learning is by observation and it is extremely effective. Where a father has one confidant, one friend, or one professional relationship that his children know about, the transmission is different, and this is one of the few interventions in this book whose effect is measurable in the next generation's arrangements.

2.5 When Manhood Becomes a Lifelong Examination

The final pressure is the one men find hardest to name: the sense of being permanently under assessment.

The examination has a specific structure. It has **criteria**, which are the six requirements in Section 2.1. It has **examiners**, who are everybody, and whose comments are the events from which the man infers his standing. It has **no timetable**, since it begins in childhood and ends at death, and its periods — the years in which a man is expected to have married, built, and established — are enforced by comment rather than by rule. It has **no certificate**, which is to say that success never produces a conclusion, only a temporary position. And it has **no appeal**, since there is no forum in which the assessment can be challenged.

The Three Features That Make It Damaging

Postponement of relief. A man under examination does not permit himself the ordinary reliefs that other people allow themselves, because relief would be evidence in the assessment. Holidays are deferred, rest is deferred, medical care is deferred, and enjoyment is deferred until the conclusion — which never arrives. Men in this pattern frequently arrive at sixty with a list of things they intended to do when they had finished.

Comparisons under constant review. The examination is conducted comparatively. The reference group — school colleagues, relatives, neighbours, professional contemporaries — is monitored continuously, and the monitoring is facilitated by every gathering, every ceremony, and every device.

The transition of the examination into the household. The most damaging feature, and the one that affects other people. A man under permanent assessment begins to conduct his household as an examination hall: the children's results become evidence, the wife's manner and appearance become evidence, the household's expenditure becomes evidence. The arrangement is understandable, and it is extremely damaging to the people inside it. Children in these households frequently describe the experience of being assessed on their father's behalf, and Chapter 17 addresses the consequences directly.

What the Examination Does in Mid-Life and Later

Four consequences are consistently reported.

The collapse of the arrangement at retirement. Where a man's identity has been supplied by the examination, retirement removes the examiner's instruments: the position, the income, the daily evidence. The result is frequently an acute crisis of purpose, described in Chapter 24, which arrives within months of the final working day.

The retrospective audit. At some point between fifty and sixty-five, most men in this pattern conduct an audit of their position against the criteria. Where the audit finds the arrangement satisfactory, the man is frequently left with a puzzle: he has done what was required and does not feel what he expected to feel. Where the audit finds the arrangement unsatisfactory, the man's difficulty is compounded by the time remaining, which is frequently insufficient for the remediation he has in mind.

The collapse of the body's cooperation. The examination requires a body that performs. Where the body begins to fail — blood pressure, joints, vision, the prostate, the heart — the man encounters the examination's most difficult proportion, which is that its criteria cannot be met by effort alone.

The withdrawal of the examiners. As a man ages, the people who conducted the assessment — the father, the uncles, the colleagues, the community's senior figures — die. Men frequently report, in their sixties, that they no longer know for whom they are performing. This is an important and frequently liberating discovery, and it comes later than it should: the examiners were mortal all along, which means the examination was always largely internal, and the man is therefore able to conclude it himself.

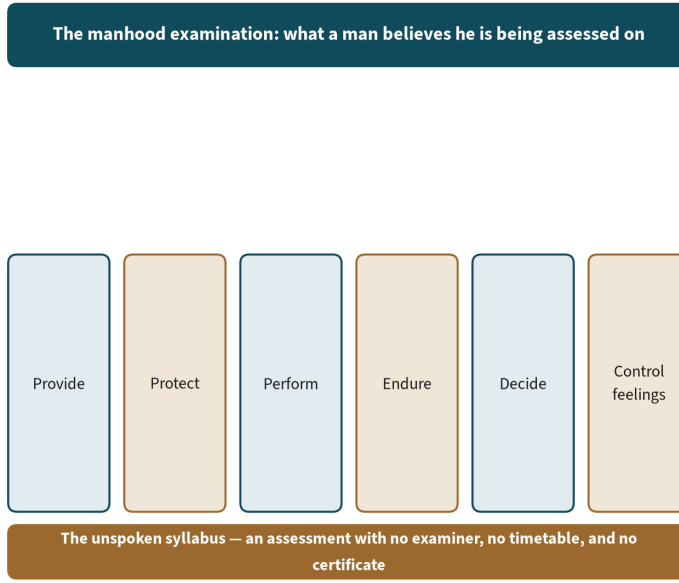


Figure 2.3 The unspoken syllabus. A man is examined continuously against a syllabus he was never given, by an examiner who is never named, and the examination has no end point — which is what makes it a lifelong one.

2.6 Redefining Strength Beyond Endurance

The constructive work of this chapter is a revision of the concept of strength. The revision is not an abandonment of the traditional virtues; it is a correction of the list, because the list in current use is incomplete in a specific and damaging way.

What the Current Definition Leaves Out

The current definition of strength measures a man by what he can carry alone. Its logic, stated plainly, is: the more a man can absorb without assistance or complaint, the stronger he is. Two consequences follow from that logic, and both are observable.

First, the definition rewards concealment, since a difficulty that nobody knows about is a difficulty carried alone. Second, the definition penalises the capacities that actually sustain a man over a working life: the capacity to identify what is happening to him, the capacity to obtain help, the capacity to maintain relationships in which he is known, and the capacity to keep himself functioning over decades rather than months.

A man on the current definition is therefore strong in an emergency and fragile over a lifetime. The pattern described in Chapter 12 — the man who

cannot afford to break down — is produced by the current definition applied consistently.

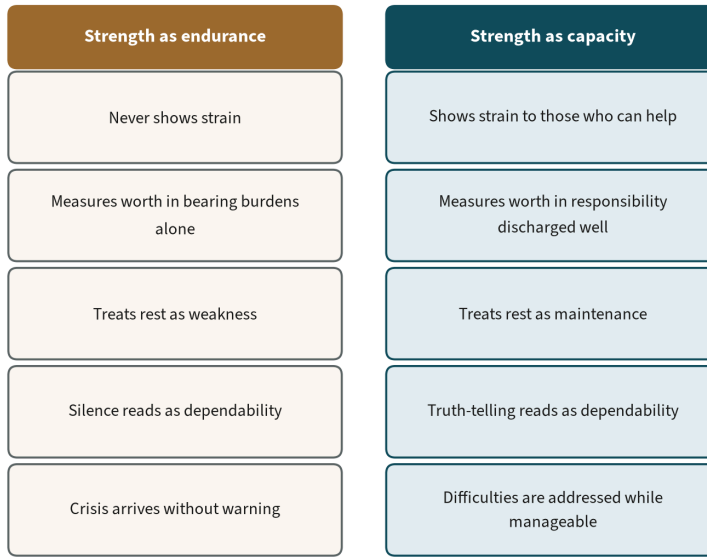


Figure 2.4 Two definitions of strength, side by side. The left column produces a man whose capacity is invisible until it fails; the right column produces one whose capacity is stated, maintained, and available to the people who depend on it.

The Revised Definition

Strength, properly defined, is the **capacity to sustain responsibility**. The phrase is chosen because it is measurable and because it preserves everything of value in the traditional account.

A man who sustains responsibility over a working life requires six capacities, and the current definition recognises only the first two.

Table 2.1 The six capacities that sustain responsibility, and the two recognised by the script in current use.

Capacity	What it means	Is it recognised by the current script?
Endurance	Absorbing difficulty and continuing	Yes
Competence	Performing required tasks to an adequate standard	Yes
Articulacy	Describing his own state accurately when necessary	No
Help-seeking	Obtaining assistance before a difficulty becomes a crisis	No

Capacity	What it means	Is it recognised by the current script?
Relational maintenance	Keeping relationships in which he is known	No
Self-maintenance	Protecting sleep, health, and recovery over decades	No

Each of the four unrecognised capacities has a documented effect.

Articulacy is the precondition of treatment, of negotiation, and of the diagnostic assessment of a problem. A man who can describe his condition accurately obtains help twice as fast as one who cannot, because the first conversation with a physician, an employer, or a lawyer is resolved by the description he supplies.

Help-seeking is the mechanism by which problems are solved at their smallest size. The man who asks the mechanic before the engine fails, the physician before the symptom becomes a condition, and the accountant before the debt becomes a liability pays a fraction of what the man who handles everything alone will pay.

Relational maintenance is the mechanism by which a man remains known, and it is the subject of Chapter 4. Its practical value is that relationships are the means by which information, assistance, and perspective reach a man who does not believe he needs them.

Self-maintenance is the mechanism by which a man is still functioning at sixty-five. Its components are ordinary and its neglect is the most common single cause of the health and career outcomes described in Part IX of this book.

Adopting the Revised Definition

Four practical steps, in the sequence that men report as workable.

Step One: re-describe three behaviours. Take three things you currently describe in the language of failure — asking for help with a matter, taking leave, declining an obligation, attending a physician, leaving early to be with your children — and re-describe them accurately: as maintenance of the capacity to work, as the management of a risk, as the protection of the household's long-term position. The re-description is not a deception; it is an accurate account of the same act.

Step Two: add one capacity per quarter. Not all four. The order that men find easiest is articulacy first — which begins with the one-sentence daily writing in Chapter 3 — then self-maintenance, then help-seeking, then relational maintenance. Each capacity takes a quarter to establish as a practice.

Step Three: demonstrate it in front of the people for whom it matters. A son who sees his father ask a colleague for help, attend a clinic, or decline an obligation on grounds that he states openly has learned that these acts are compatible

with being a man. This step has the largest effect of any measure in this chapter, because it interrupts the transmission described in Section 2.4.

Step Four: hold the definition in conversation. Where a man is told that he is being weak — by a relative, a colleague, a friend, or his own interior voice — the response is not a defence but a statement: *I am keeping myself able to carry what I am carrying.* The sentence is accurate, it is short, and it is remarkably effective, because it is difficult to argue against and because it re-states the position in the terms of strength rather than of need.

What the Revision Does Not Mean

It does not mean that endurance is unnecessary; it means that endurance is not sufficient. It does not mean that a man should disclose everything to everybody; it means that he should have an arrangement in which a defined number of people know his actual position. It does not mean the abandonment of responsibility; the entire purpose of the revised definition is the capacity to sustain responsibility over the whole of a working life rather than to break under it at fifty-one. And it does not mean the absence of standards, which Chapter 8 addresses explicitly: the standard remains, and what changes is the man's relationship to his own failures against it.

2.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Never Off Duty

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in occupational medicine, family practice, and the research literature on male role strain. **Ikenna is fifty-two, a civil engineer with a state ministry in the south-east, married with four children, and was until eighteen months ago the person his entire extended family called first.**

His situation at the age of fifty had six components, none of which any single person in his life was aware of in full.

He was the ministry's most senior engineer on the road programme, working between sixty and seventy-five hours weekly in the working season. He was responsible for the household's finances, which had been under strain for three years since his wife's tailoring business lost an institutional contract. He was married to Ngozi, whose mother had lived with them for four years since a stroke, requiring daily care that Ngozi provided and that he managed financially. He supported three relatives' school fees, in an arrangement established when his income was higher and never revised. He held the position of projects coordinator in his community's development union, an office that required attendance, contribution, and the management of disputes. And he had been, for two years, the person whom two cousins, an uncle, and a neighbour consulted on all major decisions, including two property matters that had been in professional mediation for years.

His own position was not disclosed to anybody. His colleagues knew about the hours. His wife knew about the household's finances. His cousins knew about the property matters. Nobody knew about all six, and nobody had been told that Ikenna had, three years earlier, begun experiencing chest tightness on exertion, and that he had twice woken at night with his heart beating heavily, and that he had decided that this was stress and that it would pass.

The events of the following year are worth setting out in the sequence they occurred, because the sequence illustrates the mechanism of this chapter.

In March, he was passed over for the ministry's road programme directorship. The position went to a colleague four years his junior. He was given no explanation and did not request one, on the grounds that requesting one would look like complaint.

In June, he held a meeting at which a property matter involving his uncle and a cousin's family was resolved in a manner that pleased neither. He was blamed by both, and spoke to neither for four months.

In August, his wife's business lost its second contract, and he did not tell her that the household's reserves were exhausted, since he had intended for the reserve to be a private matter and had been using it since April.

In November, he attended a family gathering at which a younger relative, meaning to be flattering, observed that he was "the one managing everything" and asked what the family would do without him. Ikenna's response was a joke, and his recollection of the evening is that he was unable to sleep at all afterwards.

In February, he collapsed at a site meeting. The episode was brief, was attributed to the heat, and required two days in hospital, where an ECG was performed, a diagnosis of hypertension made, and a referral to a cardiology clinic given. He did not attend the referral.

The turn came not through the collapse but through a physician's question. In April, Ikenna attended a different hospital for an unrelated matter — a minor eye condition — and the physician, whose examination included a blood pressure reading, asked him how long it had been since his last proper assessment. When Ikenna said that he had been referred in February and had not attended, the physician asked a further question: *What are you carrying at the moment that made you decide not to go?*

Ikenna's account of the following year is specific. He attended the cardiology clinic, was treated, and was given restrictions on the site work, which he initially disregarded and later observed after his physician arranged a joint conversation with him and his wife — the first occasion on which Ngozi heard any of the medical history. He wrote, at the physician's suggestion, a list of every obligation he was carrying, and it took two pages. He then, over about eight months, took four steps: he resigned the community union position; he renegotiated the school fees with one relative and reduced the arrangement for the other two with a defined date; he told the uncle and the cousin that he would no longer act as mediator in the property matter; and he told Ngozi the position of the household's finances in full.

> His summary, two years later, was: *Nobody ever asked me to do all six. I was carrying the union because my father had, the fees because I had started them, and the property matters because I was the one who could be trusted. If you had asked me in February which of them I would drop, I would have said none. In fact I have dropped three and nobody has died. What has died is the idea that I am the only one who can do anything.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The six obligations were each legitimate and none was agreed as a package. Every element was honourable: the road programme, the finances, the mother-in-law's care, the school fees, the union office, the mediations. The damage arose from the combination, which no single person had ever seen and which Ikenna himself had never totalled.

The symptoms were recognised and dismissed. Chest tightness on exertion and night-time episodes occurred for three years before the collapse, and the dismissal was not ignorance; Ikenna knew what the symptoms might indicate. The obstruction was the script: attending a clinic would have required an admission, and the admission would have had to be made in front of his household.

The promotion was a rejection that could not be discussed. The passing over was a substantial blow, and no conversation about it was possible in any of Ikenna's six domains: not at work, where it would look like complaint; not at home, where the household was under financial strain; not in the family, where his standing was at issue. The absence of a channel is the material of Section 2.4.

The trigger was a question, not a crisis. The physician asked what he was carrying that made him decide not to attend. The question is the intervention, and its form is worth noting: it presumed the existence of a load and asked only about its contents. Men respond to that form of question with disclosure far more frequently than to a question about how they are feeling.

The reduction of obligations did not produce the disaster that the script predicted. Four obligations removed, with no collapse of the family, the household, or the man's standing. The prediction that the household would fail without his universal function was tested and found to be false, and Ikenna's own statement — that what died was the idea that he was the only one who could do anything — is the practical content of the revised definition in Section 2.6.

2.8 Practical Exercise: The Script Audit

This exercise takes about two hours and is completed in writing. Its purpose is to convert a lifelong arrangement into an object that can be examined, and men who complete it consistently report that the first two parts are the ones that produce the change.

Part One: What I Was Taught

Answer in writing, with specifics and names where they exist.

1. What were you told, as a boy, about how a man behaves? Write the actual sentences, in the words used.
2. Which man or men demonstrated it, and what did you observe them do?
3. What happened to boys or men who deviated? Describe at least two instances you personally witnessed.
4. What did you learn about crying, fear, and asking for help? At what age did you last do any of the three, and what happened?

Part Two: What I Carry Now

Using the six requirements in Section 2.1, mark each with one of three positions: **I hold this deliberately**, **I hold this because it is expected**, or **I no longer hold this at all** but behave as though I do.

Requirement	My position	What it costs me monthly
Provide		
Protect		
Perform		
Endure		
Decide		
Control feeling		

The fourth column is the important one. A cost is money, hours, sleep, health, a relationship, an opportunity, or a state of mind. Men frequently find that the largest costs are associated with the requirement they hold least deliberately.

Part Three: The Load Inventory

List every obligation you are currently carrying, without evaluation: financial obligations, family obligations, community positions, mediations and disputes, care responsibilities, work commitments beyond your formal role, and personal undertakings to individuals. Write the amount, the period, and who knows about it.

Then answer three questions.

- Which of these obligations did I take on, and which arrived?
- Have I ever totalled them in one place before? What did the total produce?
- Which two could be reduced or concluded within six months, and what would be the actual consequences?

Part Four: The Test of the Load

For each of the four unrecognised capacities in Table 2.1, score yourself from one to five and write one sentence of evidence.

Capacity	Score (1–5)	Evidence
Articulacy: can I describe my own state accurately to another person?		
Help-seeking: do I obtain assistance before a difficulty becomes a crisis?		
Relational maintenance: do I have relationships in which I am known rather than relied upon?		
Self-maintenance: is my sleep, health, and recovery protected over the long term?		

Part Five: One Commitment in Each Gap

For every capacity scored three or below, write one commitment with a date. The commitments should be small and verifiable. Examples of the form:

- *Before the end of this month I will describe my actual state to one person, in one conversation, in no more than ten sentences.*
- *I will make the appointment for the assessment I have been deferring, and the date is ____.*
- *I will contact two men I have not spoken to this year, and propose a fixed arrangement.*
- *I will set a bedtime and hold it for fourteen consecutive nights, and record the result.*

2.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is this book telling me to stop being a man?"

No. It is telling you that the version of manhood in current use omits four capacities that determine whether a man is still functioning at sixty-five. The revised definition in Section 2.6 keeps every traditional requirement and adds the four that make the others sustainable. A man who endures, provides, protects, and performs — and who also describes his state accurately, obtains help early, maintains relationships in which he is known, and protects his own health — is not a lesser man. He is the version of the man that the current script fails to produce.

"If I tell my wife or my family what I am carrying, will they respect me less?"

Some will, at first, and most will not. The consistent finding from men who have made the disclosure is that the response is closer to relief than to contempt: the household has been living with the effects — the irritability, the absence, the

unexplained change — and an explanation is frequently received as the removal of a fear. Where the response is contemptuous, that is important information about the relationship, and Section 14.6 provides the framework.

"I was raised this way and it has worked for me. Why change?"

Because the cost is paid later and by other people. A man who carries everything alone in the current arrangement frequently pays in three observed forms: a health event in mid-life, a marriage that becomes an administrative arrangement, and children who reproduce the same script into their own households. If none of these is present and none is likely, the arrangement is working; the audit in Section 2.8 will tell you.

"My father was harder than me and lived to be eighty-five."

Individual outcomes vary, and they are not a guide to risk. The relevant comparison is between populations and patterns, not individuals, and the population evidence on chronic stress, untreated hypertension, sleep deprivation, and isolation is consistent. There is also a selection effect worth noting: the men of your father's generation who did not survive to eighty-five are not available to be cited.

"Where do I begin, if I only have the capacity to do one thing?"

With sleep, and then with one conversation. Men who improve sleep alone — a fixed bedtime, seven hours, no alcohol as a means of sleep — report improvement in irritability, decision-making, and physical symptoms within a month. The conversation is the second step, and it should be with a person who has a record of keeping confidences. Appendix N provides the sleep method, and Chapter 35 provides the structure for the conversation.

"What if I do not have anybody to talk to?"

Then the first task is to create one, and the available routes are in Chapter 4 and Appendix J. The three with the best record: one relationship reinstated from an earlier period of your life; one group of men with an agreed rule of honesty; and one professional relationship, which requires no prior history and which is confidential by definition.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 2 in brief. Every society hands a man a script, and the script is remarkably consistent across countries: provide, protect, perform, endure, decide, and control feeling. The requirements are not caricatures — reliability, courage, endurance, and the acceptance of responsibility are genuine virtues — and what this chapter examines is the cost of the script to the man who keeps it.

The six requirements produce a state of permanent readiness: the inability to rest without justification, the experience of ordinary leisure as a debt, continuous attention to threat, and a refusal to recognise the arrangement as stress because stress would imply it was optional. Permanent readiness is physiological rather than

attitudinal, and sustained over years it produces the health outcomes documented in the later chapters of this book.

The fear of being considered weak is distinct from the fear of being weak. It is a fear about standing rather than capacity, it cannot be resolved by becoming stronger, and it produces five recognisable patterns: concealment, overcorrection, the avoidance of assistance, aggression toward whoever raises the matter, and constant demonstration.

The script says nothing about support. Men receive less emotional support than women across every setting, for four reasons: their distress signals are the opposite of the signals a household looks for; they decline the support that is offered; the people around them are frequently depleted; and there is no available cultural script for supporting a man. The consequences are later recognition of serious conditions, the conversion of distress into behaviour, decisions made in isolation, a single point of failure in marriage, and the transmission of the arrangement to the next generation.

Manhood in this framework becomes a lifelong examination with criteria, examiners, no timetable, no certificate, and no appeal. Its features are the postponement of relief, constant comparison, and the extension of the examination into the household, where children are frequently assessed on their father's behalf. In mid-life and later it produces the collapse of the arrangement at retirement, the retrospective audit between fifty and sixty-five, the difficulty of a body that no longer performs, and the eventual discovery that the examiners have died and the examination was always largely internal.

The constructive work is a revision of strength, defined as the capacity to sustain responsibility. That definition requires six capacities, of which the current script recognises two: endurance and competence. The four it omits — articulacy, help-seeking, relational maintenance, and self-maintenance — are the ones that determine whether a man is still functioning at sixty-five. They are built in quarters, demonstrated in front of the people for whom it matters, and held in conversation with the sentence: *I am keeping myself able to carry what I am carrying.*

Reflection Questions

1. From the six requirements in Section 2.1, which one governs your life most completely? Which do you hold deliberately, and which because it is expected of you?
2. Complete Part One of the exercise. What were the actual sentences you were taught as a boy about how a man behaves, and who taught them?
3. Where is the largest cost in the table in Part Two — and is it attached to a requirement you hold deliberately or one that was imposed?
4. Which of the five patterns in Section 2.3 applies to you: concealment, overcorrection, avoidance of assistance, aggression toward the messenger, or constant demonstration? What has it produced in the last five years?

5. Who are the people who would notice if your health or your mood deteriorated — and how many of them have you told anything real in the last year?
6. From Table 2.1, which of the four unrecognised capacities is your weakest, and what is the first specific act that would strengthen it?
7. Ikenna reduced six obligations to two and nothing collapsed. What are the two obligations in your life that you have never tested, and what would happen if you did?

Further Reading

- **On masculine norms and their measurement:** the research literature on masculine role norms and the instruments developed to measure conformity to them, including the work on the specific norms of self-reliance, emotional control, and the primacy of work.
- **On conformity to masculine norms and health:** the substantial body of research associating stronger conformity to traditional masculine norms with reduced help-seeking, lower utilisation of health services, higher rates of substance use, and poorer mental health outcomes.
- **On male role strain:** the sociological literature on role strain and role conflict in men, including the work on the multiple, simultaneous, and frequently incompatible expectations attached to the provider role.
- **On social support and gender:** the research on gender differences in the receipt and provision of emotional support, including the findings on network size, the reliance of men on a spouse as principal confidant, and the consequences of the loss of that confidant in later life.
- **On men's health behaviour:** the literature on men's delayed presentation to health services, including research on the reasons men give for delay and on the interventions that have improved early presentation.
- **Practical resources:** structured programmes for men addressing role strain, fatherhood, and life transitions; men's discussion and support groups; and the material throughout the later chapters of this book, particularly Chapters 12, 24, and 27.

3 CHAPTER

The Tears That Never Fall

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Explain why many men find it difficult to express pain, and identify the specific mechanisms by which this difficulty is acquired.
2. Describe what happens to a man psychologically and physically when emotion is suppressed over long periods.
3. Distinguish clearly between self-control and emotional avoidance, and locate his own habits on the scale between them.
4. Examine the social and personal meanings attached to crying, and describe what a man loses when he is unable to cry at all.
5. Recognise unprocessed grief and emotional exhaustion as distinct conditions with distinct treatments, and describe the exhaustion pattern that follows years of unrecognised feeling.
6. Use structured methods — sensation naming, a graduated scale, one-sentence writing, and borrowed language — to rebuild an emotional vocabulary, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

There is a photograph that many families possess without knowing it. It was taken at a funeral — perhaps of a father, a mother, a brother, or a child — and in the middle of it there is a man standing perfectly straight, looking directly at the camera, with a face that shows nothing at all. Around him, other people are weeping. He is not. He has not wept at the graveside, at the reception, or in the car. He has arranged the transport, settled the bill with the caterer, thanked the visitors, and answered every telephone call. He is the one who kept the occasion from falling apart, and he is the one about whom somebody later says, *He was very strong*.

This chapter is about that man, and about the tears that never fell — not only at that funeral, but at whatever earlier funeral or disgrace or loss first taught him

that his tears were unwelcome. It is about the habit of emotional suppression: how it is acquired, what it costs, how it differs from the self-control that men often confuse it with, and how a man who has spent thirty years not crying can learn to feel again without ceasing to be the person his family depends upon.

3.1 Why Some Men Struggle to Express Pain

The first task is to replace a common and unhelpful explanation with a better one. The unhelpful explanation is that men are naturally less emotional than women. It is unhelpful for two reasons: it is not supported by the evidence, and it gives the man who holds it nothing to do. If the difficulty is natural, then it is permanent, and there is no reason to work on it. The better explanation is that men and women are born with the same capacity for feeling, that this capacity persists throughout life, and that what differs — enormously, and sometimes painfully — is the *permission* and the *skill* to express it. Both permission and skill are acquired, which means that both can be revised.

Four mechanisms account for most of the difficulty.

The Early Extinction of Crying

Infants cry, of both sexes, at more or less the same rates and in response to more or less the same stimuli. Differences emerge as the child develops, and they emerge largely because of differential responses to the same behaviour. A three-year-old boy who cries is treated differently from a three-year-old girl who cries in almost every society studied, and the difference generally consists of encouragement in one case and discouragement in the other. Discouragement is rarely harsh. It consists of redirection (*Look, there's a dog!*), mild shaming (*Big boys don't cry*), physical interruption, or the substitution of anger for sadness (*Are you going to cry, or are you going to do something?*). Applied a few hundred times over a decade, it produces a man for whom crying has become a skill he does not have, rather than an act he has chosen to avoid.

The Substitution of Anger for Sadness

The second mechanism is the most important for understanding adult male distress, and it is well documented. Where one emotion is unwelcome, the child substitutes another that is permitted. In most environments, anger is permitted to boys in a way that fear and grief are not. The result is that some men have developed a highly efficient anger channel and an almost entirely unsupplied grief channel, so that sadness is experienced — genuinely, not as a pretence — as irritation, and grief as a hard, tight, restless state that the man cannot name.

This substitution accounts for much of what families observe in men under strain: irritability about small domestic matters, a short fuse, an intolerance of noise or of children's play, a sudden flare over a misplaced object. The provocation

is trivial because the provocation is not the cause. The cause is a feeling that has been routed through the only available channel.

The Absence of a Vocabulary

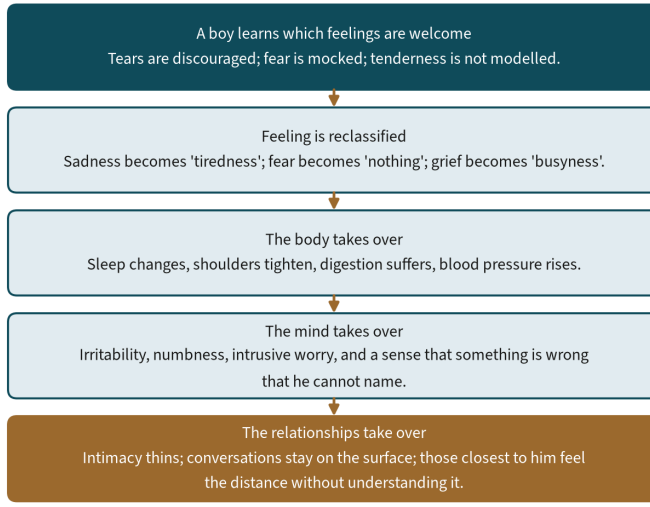
The third mechanism is linguistic. Emotional experience is learned, in part, through language. A child whose environment contains precise emotional vocabulary — for disappointment, humiliation, longing, dread, reassurance, shame, forgiveness — acquires the ability to distinguish states that would otherwise be experienced as an undifferentiated heaviness. A child whose environment contains two words, *fine* and *angry*, acquires two categories.

Adult men in this position describe the difficulty vividly. They know that something is wrong. They can describe the circumstances — the debt, the diagnosis, the marriage — with precision. What they cannot do is describe the state that the circumstances produce in them, and the inability is not a refusal. It is a genuine absence of the necessary terms. This is why a great deal of work with men begins with vocabulary rather than with feeling, and why Section 3.6 of this chapter is devoted to vocabulary-building.

The Calculation of Social Cost

The fourth mechanism is adult and rational. By mid-life, most men have accumulated a set of experiences in which the expression of emotion produced a bad outcome: a wife who became frightened; a mother who began to telephone daily; a colleague who mentioned it to others; a supervisor who treated it as evidence of unsuitability; a peer who mocked it. These experiences are usually only two or three in number, and they are sufficient. A man does not need to be punished repeatedly to learn a lesson; he needs only to be punished once, emphatically, at a moment when the stakes felt high.

Figure 3.1 traces the whole process from the early lesson to the adult consequence. The critical feature is that each stage involves a substitution rather than an elimination: something is always produced in place of the feeling.



The sequence is not inevitable, but it is extremely common, and it is reversible at every stage.

Figure 3.1 From lesson to consequence. At each stage, feeling is exchanged for something more acceptable — tiredness, busyness, anger, or activity — and the original state is left unaddressed.

KEY POINT

Men are not less emotional than women. They are frequently less *permitted*, less *practised*, and less *supplied with vocabulary*. All three of those are acquired conditions, and acquired conditions can be changed.

3.2 Emotional Suppression and Its Consequences

Having established why the difficulty arises, it is necessary to be precise about what suppression is, because the term is used loosely and the looseness causes men to reject the whole discussion.

What Suppression Is

Emotional suppression is the deliberate or habitual pushing of an emotional experience out of awareness or out of expression. It occurs in two forms. *Expressive suppression* means feeling the emotion fully but preventing it from being visible: the man who is devastated and whose voice does not change. *Experiential avoidance* means preventing the emotion from being experienced at all: the man who does not know he is devastated, and who will report only that he is tired, busy, or fine.

Expressive suppression is more common in men and more visible. Experiential avoidance is more consequential, and more difficult to treat, because the person

experiencing it cannot report it. Much of the material in this chapter is addressed to the second form, and the reader should therefore resist the natural tendency to answer *That is not me; I know exactly what I feel.* He may. The reader who has already noticed that he is not sure what he feels is the one for whom the chapter is most directly written.

The Documented Consequences

The research literature on suppression is extensive and consistent. Six findings matter for the reader.

Physiological load. Suppressing an emotional response does not reduce the body's reaction to the event that caused it; it frequently increases it. Studies of expressive suppression have found elevated cardiovascular activity during the act of suppression, and long-term patterns of suppression are associated with higher physiological stress markers.

Memory and attention costs. Suppression consumes attention. People who are suppressing emotion remember less of what is said around them — including, in some studies, the content of the conversations they are having. This is the mechanism behind a complaint that many men make about themselves: *I cannot remember anything from that period.*

Impaired communication. Because suppression interferes with attention and with natural expression, it makes a person harder to read and less responsive to the person speaking. Partners of men who habitually suppress describe a specific experience: talking to someone who is present but not there.

Increased physiological and psychological symptoms. Higher rates of sleep disruption, tension, and somatic complaints are reported among habitual suppressors, along with reduced well-being.

Contagion into the household. Suppression does not remain private. Children and partners read the emotional weather of the house with considerable accuracy. A child who grows up with a father who never expresses fear, grief, or tenderness learns an implicit rule about which feelings are permitted, and carries it forward. This is discussed in Chapter 43.

Rebound. Suppressed emotion does not disappear. It reappears — often at a lower threshold, in an unexpected context, and at a disproportionate intensity — which is why a man who has been calm for months may erupt over a parking space.

The Protections Suppression Provides

A book that described only costs would be dishonest, and men know it. Suppression provides real protection, and the reader who recognises himself needs to see that recognised.

Table 3.1 The bargain of suppression. Both columns are real; the difficulty is that the left-hand column is immediate and the right-hand column is delayed.

What suppression protects	What it eventually costs
Calm in the household in the short term	Marital intimacy, and children's model of openness
Standing and credibility at work	Sleep, judgement, health, and honesty with colleagues
Freedom from questions in friendships	The friendships themselves, which slowly empty
The ability to keep functioning after a loss	Unfinished grief, which returns as numbness or anger
Time: difficult conversations are deferred	Accumulated charge, and conversations that must eventually be held at greater cost

The practical conclusion is not that suppression must be abandoned in all circumstances. There are moments when a man must hold his feelings until he is alone, and that is a competence. The conclusion is that suppression is a short-term tool with a long-term cost, and that a man who relies on it as a permanent arrangement is paying a price he has not calculated. Chapter 34 sets out the point at which prolonged suppression becomes genuinely dangerous.

3.3 The Difference Between Self-Control and Emotional Avoidance

The distinction in this section is, in practical terms, the most useful in the chapter. Men routinely defend their emotional habits by invoking self-control, and the defence is sometimes valid. The problem is that self-control and avoidance look similar from the outside and are entirely different from the inside, and the difference determines whether a man will eventually cope or eventually collapse.

The Distinguishing Features

Self-control is the capacity to feel what you feel and choose what you do with it. It is a competence, it is learned, and it is a genuine strength. Avoidance is the attempt to prevent the feeling from registering in the first place. It is not a competence; it is a strategy for not knowing, and it produces a specific set of downstream effects.

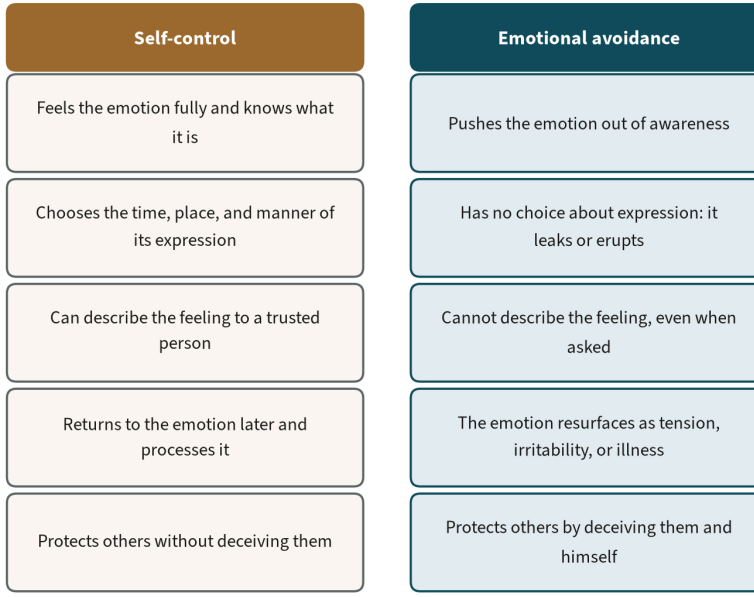


Figure 3.2 Self-control and emotional avoidance, distinguished. The two look similar from outside a man; they are entirely different inside him, and they produce opposite long-run outcomes.

Figure 3.3 sets out the two side by side. Five differences do the work.

Awareness. Self-control requires awareness: a man knows he is angry, frightened, or grieving. Avoidance requires the opposite. If you do not know what you felt at your father's funeral, self-control was not at work.

Choice about expression. Under self-control, the delay in expression is a decision with a date attached: I will not raise this now; I will bring it up on Saturday. Under avoidance, there is no plan, because the emotion has been ruled out of the agenda altogether. If the conversation you deferred two years ago has still not happened and you have no intention of holding it, that is not restraint.

Effect on the body. Self-control involves noticing the body's signals and deciding what to do about them. Avoidance replaces the signal with something else — tension, busyness, alcohol, activity — and the replacement is usually invisible to the man.

Discharge. Self-control requires that the emotion be processed at some point: spoken about, written about, wept over, prayed over, or otherwise completed. Avoidance does not complete anything; it defers, and deferral accumulates.

Others' experience of you. People who live with a man exercising self-control experience honesty: *I am angry about this, and I will not discuss it tonight.* People

who live with a man in avoidance experience absence: a person who is present, pleasant, and nowhere.

A Working Scale

It is more useful to think of a scale than a binary.

Table 3.2 The self-control scale. Most men will locate themselves in a different position for different areas of life — skilled in one domain, globally avoidant in another.

Position on the scale	Description	Typical indicator
Skilled self-control	Feels fully, names it accurately, chooses expression deliberately, processes afterwards	Can say what he is feeling and when he will deal with it
Developing self-control	Feels it, names it imperfectly, eventually deals with it	Needs prompting; often speaks after a delay
Partial avoidance	Feels it, suppresses expression, does not process it	Becomes tense, sleeps poorly, forgets conversations
Substantial avoidance	Does not reliably know what he feels; substitutes tiredness, busyness, or anger	"I'm not angry." "I'm just tired."
Global avoidance	Cannot report emotional states at all; experiences only physical or situational facts	"There is nothing wrong. Work is difficult. That is all."

The value of the scale is that it gives the reader a way to assess himself without accusation. A man who is at the second or third position has not failed; he has simply never been taught the skill, and he can learn it at almost any age.

The Argument Against the Common Defence

Men frequently defend avoidance with three arguments, and each deserves a direct answer.

"Someone has to stay functional." True, and it is exactly why self-control is more valuable than avoidance. A man in avoidance is functional until he is not, and the timing of the break is outside his control. A man who exercises self-control remains functional deliberately and knows when he needs recovery.

"It doesn't help to talk about it." Sometimes true in the short term. But notice what the argument concedes: that talking is the only alternative to suppression. A man may discharge emotion through writing, physical work, exercise, structured reflection, or a single conversation with one person. The choice is not between silence and a confession; it is between processing and storing.

"There is nobody I could talk to." Also frequently true, and it is a statement about the man's social position rather than about his emotional policy. Appendices J and O, and Chapters 27 and 35, address it directly.

The Cost of Not Being Read

There is one more consequence of suppression that deserves attention, because it operates through other people and is therefore rarely attributed to its cause.

Human beings read one another continuously and largely unconsciously. A colleague notices a change in the pace of a man's speech; a wife notices that he has stopped making a particular joke; a friend notices that he has begun to answer quickly, in short sentences, as though closing a door. These readings are the basis of ordinary human support, and they operate on signals that suppression removes. A man who is holding a difficult state entirely inside himself produces no readable signal, or produces a misleading one: concentration, tiredness, preoccupation with work.

The consequence is a specific and painful experience which many men report without connecting it to the subject of this chapter: the experience of going through the worst period of one's life while everyone around behaves as though nothing is happening. The man concludes from this that nobody cares, that his situation is invisible, or that the people around him are indifferent. In most cases the more accurate account is that the information was never supplied.

It follows that the two most practical acts available to a man in difficulty are also the two that feel most costly: to produce a signal, and to name it. A signal may take any number of forms. It can be a sentence: *I have had a difficult month and I do not want to talk about it yet, but I did not want you to think everything is normal.* It can be a change of arrangement: declining the meeting, taking the leave, or asking the brother to handle the family matter this time. It can be a direct request: *I would like you to check on me once a week.*

None of these acts requires the man to disclose the content of his difficulty. All of them require him to allow the fact of it to be known. That is a smaller step than it appears, and it is frequently the step that converts a private crisis into a shared problem with an available solution. A problem that is shared is not necessarily easier, but it is no longer invisible, and invisibility is the feature that makes the male pattern of distress so dangerous.

3.4 Crying Without Shame

No chapter on this subject can avoid the central image. Crying is the most heavily regulated expression of emotion in men, and the regulation produces a durable inability in a large number of adult men — with measurable consequences.

What Crying Does

Tears of emotional release are a physiological event with observable properties: they differ in composition from the tears produced by irritants such as onion vapour, and researchers have linked emotional crying to recovery in the minutes and hours afterwards. Beyond the physiology, the psychological functions are well described: crying signals to others that the person requires support; it provides a discharge that reduces the intensity of a state; and, in human development, it is the mechanism through which an infant first acquires comfort from a caregiver. The capacity to cry, and to be comforted after crying, is one of the earliest forms of what later becomes the capacity to be supported by other people.

A man who has lost the ability to cry has not simply lost an emotion. He has lost a route to being comforted, and a route to completing a state that is otherwise completed by no other mechanism.

The Social Calculation

The reason men do not cry is usually not physiological but social, and it can be stated precisely. Adult men report a consistent set of expected costs: loss of respect, loss of authority, uncertainty of others' reactions, and the fear that showing emotion will be read as a permanent change in how they are regarded. In private, many also report a specific fear that is rarely articulated: that if they begin to cry, they will not stop. This fear is worth naming, because it is inaccurate in an important way. Crying that is properly expressed follows a course: it rises, it lasts for a period measured in minutes, and it subsides into a calm that is noticeably different from the state before. The fear of the flood is the fear of accumulated material, and it is usually evidence that something has been stored for a very long time.

Crying and Men: A Practical Position

This book takes the following position, and it is worth stating plainly because readers will disagree with parts of it.

Crying is not a requirement of healthy masculinity, and no man should be told that he must weep in order to be well. Many emotionally healthy men cry rarely, and some never do. Crying is one channel among several — and there is nothing wrong with a man whose emotional processing happens in speech, writing, work, prayer, or exercise.

But the situation of the man who *cannot* cry, even when he wants to, even when the loss is enormous, even when he is alone, is different. An inability to cry that persists across decades is not a preference. It is a restriction, and it usually indicates that a great deal has been stored. When such a man eventually does cry — and the occasion is frequently something small: a song, a kindness from a stranger, a child's question — it is not unusual for the experience to be described later with words like *the floor moved*.

For the man wishing to restore the capacity, three practical notes apply. First, it usually returns gradually, and in private. Second, the most reliable conditions are physical tiredness, darkness, music, memories of the person concerned, and above all solitude without a deadline. Third, and most importantly, tears commonly arrive when a man is speaking the truth to someone he trusts, and many men experience the first episode in a counselling room, at a graveside with a single companion, or in a conversation with a brother at two o'clock in the morning. What such men report afterwards is consistent and worth recording here, because it contradicts the fear that keeps the prohibition in place: they do not report humiliation. They report relief, and, frequently, surprise at having been able to do it at all.

> **KEY POINT**
> The question is not whether a man cries. It is whether he can, when the occasion requires it, in whatever private or trusted setting he chooses — and whether he would despise himself afterwards if he did.

3.5 Unprocessed Grief and Emotional Exhaustion

Suppression of emotion over years produces two distinct adult conditions that are frequently confused with one another, and that require different responses. It is worth separating them carefully, because the chapter deals with both and the reader will recognise one more strongly than the other.

Unprocessed Grief

Unprocessed grief is a specific and well-recognised phenomenon: a loss that has not been emotionally assimilated. The signature of unprocessed grief is delay. The man functioned at the time of the loss, organised what needed organising, supported those around him, and then continued. The emotional response did not arrive. It may arrive years later, triggered by an anniversary, a photograph, an unexpected encounter, or a second loss that combines with the first.

Men with unprocessed grief report a characteristic cluster. They may be unable to think about the person for long. They may avoid the grave, the family house, or a particular piece of music. They may be unable to speak the person's name in ordinary conversation. They may have dreams of the person, sometimes recurrent and vividly real. They may feel a persistent and inexplicable flatness that they attribute to age. They may notice that grief in other people — at funerals, on the news — affects them more than it should, or less than it should.

Unprocessed grief is not weakness or disrespect. In many men it is the direct consequence of having been assigned the role of the strong one at the moment of loss, often by a family that needed him to be strong. Chapter 30 deals with it

in full; this chapter simply identifies it as one of the two conditions produced by long suppression.

Emotional Exhaustion

Emotional exhaustion is a different condition. It is the state produced by prolonged emotional labour without recovery, and it is characterised by depletion rather than by a specific unassimilated loss. The man is not grieving something in particular. He is simply empty.

Table 3.3 Distinguishing the two conditions. Readers commonly have both, and the treatment order matters: reduce the load first, then work on the grief.

Feature	Unprocessed grief	Emotional exhaustion
Origin	A specific loss that was not assimilated	Prolonged emotional labour without recovery
Experience	Waves, dreams, avoidance of reminders, numbness	Constant flatness, low tolerance, no reserve
Triggers	Anniversaries, places, songs, second losses	Additional demands of any kind, however small
Typical presentation	Withdrawal from the subject of the loss	Irritability, indifference, difficulty starting anything
Response	Structured grief work; sometimes professional help	Reduction of load, restoration of sleep, boundaries, support

The practical significance of this table is that a man who is emotionally exhausted should not begin by opening his largest wound. The first step is to reduce the load and restore the basic functions — sleep, food, structure, and at least one supportive relationship — and only then to undertake the work of grief. Appendix C is a thirty-day plan designed for precisely this order of operations.

A further distinction is worth recording, because it determines what kind of help is required. Emotional exhaustion is frequently accompanied by a specific and damaging belief: that the man has become a different person — colder, harder, less affectionate than he used to be. He has not. He has become a depleted person, and depletion produces exactly the symptoms he has noticed: low tolerance, low warmth, low initiative, and a reduced capacity to be interested in anybody. Restoration of this kind is not primarily emotional. It is physical and structural: sleep, food, activity, the removal of at least one continuing obligation, and the reintroduction of one thing that used to give pleasure. Men who begin their recovery with an attempt to feel more affectionate, without restoring sleep and reducing load, frequently conclude that they have become irreversibly cold, and they abandon the attempt. Men who restore the foundations first commonly find that the warmth returns as the depletion lifts, and that the fear of having changed permanently was itself a symptom of the exhaustion.

3.6 Learning to Acknowledge Difficult Feelings

The remaining question is practical. A man who has recognised himself in this chapter — who has suppressed emotion for years, who cannot readily name what he feels, who has not cried since a particular year in the past — what does he actually do?

The answer is that he learns a skill, in the same way that he learned any other skill he now possesses: by starting with the elementary components, practising them deliberately, and tolerating being bad at it for a period. Four components are involved: naming the sensation, using a graduated scale, writing one honest sentence a day, and borrowing language from other men. Figure 3.4 summarises the sequence and notes on some ordinary male statements that are usually translations.

Naming the Sensation Before Naming the Feeling

Most men who think they cannot identify feelings can identify sensations quite accurately, and this is the way in. Before attempting to answer *How do I feel?*, answer *What is my body doing?*

Sit still for sixty seconds and report, in writing: jaw, throat, chest, stomach, hands, shoulders, breathing, and overall level of restlessness. Then convert: a tight jaw usually accompanies anger held back; a closed throat accompanies grief or unshed tears; a heavy chest accompanies fear, dread, or sadness; a churning stomach accompanies anxiety; clenched hands accompany anger or the effort of restraint.

The technique works because sensation is concrete and feeling is abstract, and men are generally more practised with the concrete. After a few weeks of recording sensation, most men can make the translation reliably: *My chest is heavy and my throat is closed, therefore I am probably grieving or dreading something.* At that point the vocabulary has begun to exist.

Using a Graduated Scale

A second aid is to rate the state rather than to describe it. On a scale from one to ten, how heavy is the chest? How strong is the urge to leave the room? How close am I to losing my temper? Scales feel artificial to many men at first, and their advantage over adjectives is precisely that they require no vocabulary and produce comparable data. Over weeks, a man can see whether the pattern is improving, and he can also notice that most states are not at nine out of ten — a discovery that converts terror into something manageable.

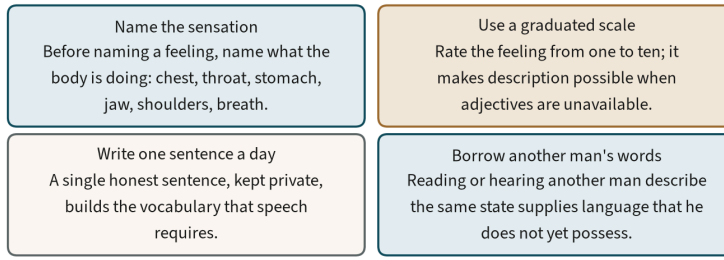


Figure 3.3 Four exercises for building emotional vocabulary, in ascending order of difficulty. Each is conducted privately, and each makes the next one easier.

One Sentence a Day

The single most effective exercise reported by men who have rebuilt emotional vocabulary is writing one honest sentence per day. It does not have to be profound. The requirements are that it be true, that it use a feeling word or a bodily state, and that it be written down (not merely thought) and kept private.

Examples of the form, drawn from the practice of men who have done this exercise:

- *I was frightened in the meeting this morning and I said nothing.*
- *I miss my father today and I did not expect to.*
- *I am angry with my brother and I have decided not to mention it again.*
- *I feel nothing about the house and that disturbs me more than grief would.*
- *I wanted to be comforted this evening and I went to the workshop instead.*

Two hundred such sentences, written over several months, constitute a document that most men find astonishing to re-read, because it produces a record of an inner life that they did not believe existed. It also tends to identify, without any interpretive labour, the two or three matters that actually require attention.

Borrowing Language

Men frequently find their own words more easily in somebody else's mouth. There is a specific and beneficial effect in reading an account of an experience — in a book, in a recorded interview, in a supervised group, in a documentary — and hearing one's own state described by another person in words one would not have been able to supply. The technical term for the recognition is not important; what matters is the practical effect, which is that language is transferable. A man may take a sentence from a writer, a counsellor, or an older man who has been through something similar, and use it as his own until it fits.

This is one of the reasons that a group of men who talk honestly to one another produces improvements in vocabulary so quickly. Every man in such a group is

being supplied with language by the others, and the supply is more effective than any list of feeling words, because it arrives attached to a real situation.

	What the man says	What it frequently encodes	What could be said instead
I am fine.	The situation is not safe for the truth, or he has not identified it	I am managing, but something is weighing on me that I have not spoken about.	
I am just tired.	Tension, poor sleep, depression, or grief	I have not been sleeping and I feel low most days. I want that looked at.	
It is work.	An explanation is required, and this one is available	Work is part of it, but it is not the main thing.	
Do not worry about me.	The offer of help is welcomed and cannot yet be accepted	I do need help, but I do not yet know what kind. Let me think and come back to you.	
It is in the past.	The material is present and unaddressed	I have put it away rather than dealt with it.	
I do not want to burden you.	He believes his difficulty is a defect he would be imposing	I would like to tell you something that has been hard for me for a long time.	

Figure 3.4 Learning to acknowledge feeling: sensation first, then rating, then one true sentence a day, then borrowed language. The middle column suggests what ordinary male statements frequently encode.

What to Expect in the First Months

Three experiences are so common in the first months of this work that they should be described in advance.

Feeling gets worse before it gets better. When a man stops suppressing, the material he has been holding becomes available. This is not evidence that acknowledging feelings is harmful; it is evidence that the store was large. It is at this stage that having a professional to talk to is most valuable, and Appendix Q explains how to find one.

Other people notice before he does. Wives, children, and colleagues frequently observe the change — more patience, more directness, occasionally more irritability — before the man himself believes any change has occurred.

Old losses come forward. It is extremely common for a man beginning this work to encounter a grief from ten or twenty years earlier, sometimes with

considerable force. This is not a side effect to be avoided; it is the work. Chapter 30 provides the structured method, and Appendix K is written specifically for it.

When to Seek Professional Support

This chapter has described a method that works for men whose difficulty is primarily one of habit and vocabulary. It is not sufficient for every situation. Professional support should be sought without delay where any of the following applies: the distress is interfering with work, sleep, eating, or ordinary functioning for more than a few weeks; there are symptoms of depression or an anxiety disorder as described in Chapter 6 or Appendix B; there is any thought of harming oneself or another person; there is a history of trauma that is being re-experienced; or alcohol or other substances are being used to manage the feelings. In such cases, the work of building vocabulary continues, but it is done in company with a qualified professional, and the reader should not attempt it alone.

3.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Left Standing

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns commonly described in bereavement counselling, family systems work, and research on male grief.

Yakubu was thirty-six when his wife, Aisha, died in childbirth. Their daughter survived. He was the one who received the news at the hospital reception, the one who telephoned Aisha's parents, the one who arranged the burial, the one who answered the questions of nearly two hundred visitors over four days, and the one who, in accordance with his community's custom, was expected to remain composed because he was now solely responsible for two other children as well as the newborn. He did not cry. He wept once, briefly, on the sixth day, in the bathroom, and then stopped himself because there were people in the house. After the mourning period he returned to work eleven days earlier than his employer had offered. Within four months he had reorganised the household: a cousin came to help with the children, he moved his eldest son to a school closer to home, and he took on additional weekend work to cover the school fees.

Over the next six years, Yakubu was described by everyone as an example. His daughter grew healthy; his eldest son gained admission to a polytechnic; he was promoted twice. Two things were happening inside him, and he did not connect either of them to Aisha's death.

The first was a dissociative blankness on the subject. He could not discuss his wife. When relatives mentioned her, he changed the subject within two sentences. He had not visited the grave since the burial, and he avoided a particular road, because the last hospital was on it. He believed this was appropriate: a man moves on.

The second was a creeping flatness in everything else. He no longer played football on Sundays. He stopped attending the association meeting to which he had belonged

for years. He found that he did not enjoy his children's achievements as much as he wanted to, and this disturbed him privately, because he believed it meant that he had become a cold man. At a colleague's wedding, four years after the death, he found himself unable to speak to the couple for more than a minute, and he left early without explanation.

The turn came when his daughter, then six, asked him, in the simple way that children do, why they had never visited her mother's grave. He answered that it was far away. She said that it was not far away, because her grandmother had described the road. That night, he did not sleep. In the following weeks he spoke to a counsellor at a hospital for the first time, and what emerged over several months was the material that had been carried in silence since the day of the burial: that he had never been told that Aisha would die; that the decision to proceed had been made in his absence; that his last words to her, in the morning, had been about a missing rent receipt; and that he had wept for eleven seconds in a bathroom in order to remain a strong man in front of a house full of visitors.

The case contains four elements worth isolating.

The role assignment was made by the situation, and he accepted it as a duty. Nobody told Yakubu not to grieve. He inferred it from the circumstances, from custom, and from the absence of any person whose function was to look after him while he did.

The suppression was effective in the short term and destructive in the long term. He met every criterion of functioning: work, children, promotion, household order. The costs appeared elsewhere — in the loss of pleasure, in avoidance of a road, in the inability to be present at a wedding, in a growing belief that he had become cold.

The grief did not require an occasion to return. It required a question from a child. Material of this kind waits, with patience, and it re-emerges when the environment permits.

The intervention was available and not exotic. He spoke to a hospital counsellor. Chapter 35 describes exactly how such an approach is made, and Appendix Q lists the routes available in Nigeria and elsewhere for men who do not know where to begin.

3.8 Practical Exercise: Building the Vocabulary

This exercise is cumulative. It takes fifteen minutes a day for twenty-one days, and it is the single most commonly recommended starting point for men who have decided to work on emotional life. Nothing in it requires another person, and no part of it requires that anybody else be told.

The Daily Practice

Each day, complete four lines in a notebook or a note on your phone. Keep the notebook private and keep it in a place that nobody else uses.

Line 1 — Sensation. *In my body I notice* _____. (jaw, throat, chest, stomach, hands, shoulders, breathing, restlessness, heaviness, numbness)

Line 2 — Intensity. *On a scale of one to ten, it is* _____.

Line 3 — Situation. *It appeared or changed when* _____. (an event, a conversation, an hour of the night, a person's name, a particular room)

Line 4 — One honest sentence. *What I would say if I could say one true thing is* _____.

An example, taken from the practice of a man of forty-nine who works as a logistics supervisor:

> *In my body I notice that my jaw is tight and my chest feels compressed. On a scale of one to ten, it is six. It appeared when my wife said that her sister would be staying for a month. What I would say if I could say one true thing is that I am frightened about money and I do not want another person in the house.*

The four lines take about three minutes. The remaining twelve minutes are the part that matters: **read the previous weeks' entries.** Patterns become visible within a fortnight. Most men discover that two or three situations account for the majority of the intensity, and that these situations have very little to do with one another on the surface. That is the identification of the actual load.

The Weekly Review

Once a week — the same day each week — write a short paragraph in response to four questions.

1. **What recurred?** Which situations produced the highest readings?
2. **What did I do with it?** Did I speak, write, work, drink, sleep, or ignore it?
3. **What did it cost me?** Sleep, patience, time, money, or peace?
4. **What is the smallest true statement I could make about the largest item?**

Working With the Results

After twenty-one days, select the three highest-intensity items and do the following, in order.

Rank them by weight, not by drama. The item that appears most often is not always the heaviest. The item that consumes attention, disturbs sleep, and shapes decisions is the heaviest, even if its subject appears modest.

Choose one for the first conversation. Not all three. One. Chapter 35 explains how to ask for help, Appendix E provides scripts for the conversation itself, and Appendix O covers the case in which the conversation must include a boundary.

Write the first sentence before you say it. Men report that the first sentence is the hardest and that having it written makes an approach possible. The most useful formula is short and factual: *I have something I want to talk about, and I would like to do it properly, so let us set aside an hour.*

A Note on Stopping

If at any stage this exercise produces distress that is not manageable — persistent insomnia, waking with dread, intrusive memories, a rise in drinking, or any thought of self-harm — stop and consult a professional. Appendix B sets out the recognised signs that require prompt consultation, and Appendix Q explains how to make contact. Stopping is not failure. It is the correct response to information.

3.9 A Word to Partners, Children, and Friends

This chapter is written for men, but a short section addressed to those close to them will be useful, not least because men frequently hand the book to somebody else to explain themselves.

Do not require tears as evidence. The absence of crying is not evidence of the absence of feeling, and asking a man why he is not weeping is unlikely to help him weep. What helps is presence without demands, and time without an agenda.

Ask specific questions rather than general ones. *How are you?* is answered automatically. *You have been quiet since your brother's funeral — what has that been like?* cannot be answered automatically, because it contains an observation and an invitation.

Expect the first version to be incomplete. A man who has not described his interior life for two decades will not describe it accurately the first time, and often minimises it. The purpose of the first conversation is not to obtain the whole truth. It is to establish that the subject can be raised at all.

Do not take charge of his feelings. A helpful response to disclosure is acknowledgement: *I am glad you told me. That is a lot to carry.* An unhelpful response, offered with the best intentions, is instruction: *You should have told me earlier; you must see a doctor at once; I will book it for you.* Instruction is the most common form of help offered to men and the least likely to be accepted.

Do not mistake composure for absence of feeling. The most frequent error made by those close to men is to assume that a calm surface indicates a settled interior. Men who have suppressed feeling for decades are frequently at their most distressed when they are at their most orderly, which is why the occasions on which a family is most shocked by a man's collapse are so often the occasions he

had appeared to be bearing best. The signals to attend to are changes rather than states: the man who has stopped making a particular joke, who no longer plays football on Sundays, who has become unusually busy, or who has taken to sitting in the car after arriving home.

Watch for the substitute signals. Withdrawal from associations, reduced tolerance for noise, a fall in appetite, sleeping badly, sitting alone in a vehicle or workshop: these are the male forms of grief, and reading them is more useful than waiting for language that may not come for weeks.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 3 in brief. The inability to express pain is not a natural difference between men and women; it is acquired, and it can be revised. Four mechanisms account for it: the early extinction of crying through differential treatment of boys; the substitution of anger for sadness, which produces men who experience sadness as irritation; the absence of an emotional vocabulary, which leaves a man knowing that something is wrong without any means of saying what; and the rational adult calculation of social cost, usually based on two or three memorable experiences in which expression produced a bad outcome.

Emotional suppression takes two forms. Expressive suppression means feeling something fully and preventing it from being visible. Experiential avoidance means preventing it from being experienced — the more consequential form, and the one that men who believe they are self-controlled are most likely to have. Its documented consequences include elevated physiological stress, impaired attention and memory, difficulty being read by others, increased somatic symptoms, spill-over into the emotional life of the household, and rebound at unpredictable moments.

Suppression is also a bargain, and the bargain is worth seeing clearly. It protects calm in the short term, standing at work, freedom from questions, and the ability to keep functioning after a loss. What it costs — intimacy, sleep, judgement, friendships, and unfinished grief — arrives later, which is why the trade looks favourable at the moment it is made.

Self-control and avoidance must be distinguished. Self-control requires awareness, a chosen delay with a date, attention to the body, eventual discharge of the emotion, and honesty with others. Avoidance requires none of these, and produces tension, forgetting, and absence. The scale set out in this chapter allows a reader to locate himself without accusation.

Crying is not a requirement of healthy masculinity; the ability to cry, when the occasion calls for it, is another matter, and its loss removes a route both to discharge and to comfort. The fear that tears will not stop is the fear of accumulated material, and it is usually evidence that the store is large.

Two conditions follow long suppression. Unprocessed grief is a specific loss that has not been assimilated, and it returns in waves, dreams, and avoidance of reminders. Emotional exhaustion is depletion from prolonged emotional labour without recov-

ery, and it presents as flatness, low tolerance, and absence of reserve. They require different responses, and the load must be reduced before the grief is opened. Vocabulary is rebuilt by practice: naming sensation before feeling, rating intensity on a scale, writing one honest sentence a day, and borrowing language from other men who have described the same state. In the first months, feeling frequently gets worse before it gets better, and old losses come forward. That is the work, not a complication of it — but where functioning is seriously impaired, where trauma is present, or where substances are being used, the work must be done alongside a qualified professional.

Reflection Questions

1. Which of the four mechanisms in Section 3.1 — early extinction, substitution of anger, absence of vocabulary, or calculated social cost — best explains your own relationship with emotional expression? Can you name the specific incident behind the fourth mechanism, if it applies?
2. On the self-control scale in Section 3.3, where do you currently place yourself in each of the following domains: marriage, children, work, money, health, and your own history? Which domain's position surprised you?
3. Table 3.1 sets out the bargain of suppression. Write down the two rows of that table that apply most directly to you, and state the year in which you began paying the price on the right-hand side.
4. When did you last cry? If the answer is measured in decades, what happened in that year, and what have you been doing with the feelings since?
5. Section 3.5 distinguishes unprocessed grief from emotional exhaustion. Which of the two fits you better, and what does the treatment order imply for your next step?
6. What is your honest answer to the question, *What is my body doing when I am under strain?* What would another person notice about you before you noticed it yourself?
7. To whom could you say one true sentence this week? If the answer is nobody, what does that tell you about the work ahead?

Further Reading

- **On emotion and suppression:** the psychological literature on emotion regulation, including the distinction between reappraisal and suppression and research on the differing consequences of each. The work on suppression is unusually clear and is accessible to general readers through mainstream psychology publications.

- **On crying:** the small but interesting research literature on emotional tears, including studies of their physiological composition and of the social signalling function of weeping.
- **On male grief:** the literature on gender and bereavement, and specifically work on the concept of disenfranchised grief — grief that is not publicly recognised as legitimate. This is directly relevant to men whose losses, such as a miscarriage, a stillbirth, a lost pregnancy, a divorce, or the death of a friend, are not socially acknowledged.
- **On alexithymia:** the clinical literature on the difficulty of identifying and describing feelings, including its relationship to physical symptoms and to depression in men. Readers should note that the clinical category is more specific than the general experience discussed in this chapter and requires professional assessment.
- **On emotional vocabulary:** practical works on feelings vocabulary, including the technique of building a personal lexicon, drawn from counselling practice and from acceptance- and commitment-based approaches.
- **On bereavement support:** the guidance issued by national health bodies and by professional bereavement organisations, together with accounts by men who have spoken publicly about losses they carried privately for years.

4 CHAPTER

The Loneliness of the Strong Man

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Distinguish between social isolation and the subjective loneliness that men experience in the middle of company and responsibility.
2. Explain the specific processes by which success and reliability produce isolation.
3. Describe what happens to male friendships under the pressure of work, family obligation, migration, and mid-life, and identify the stages of their disappearance.
4. Recognise the particular strain of being needed by everyone and enquired about by nobody, and describe the effects of that arrangement.
5. Explain the difference between emotional intimacy and sexual or romantic intimacy, and identify the forms of non-romantic closeness available to men.
6. Begin the practical work of rebuilding connection, using the stepwise method set out in this chapter and the structured plan in Appendix J.

Introduction

There is a specific kind of loneliness that can only be understood by a man who has spent a Saturday in a house full of people who need things from him.

His daughter needs money for a school trip. His brother calls about a contribution for a funeral in the village. His wife has three items of domestic logistics that require his decision. A neighbour, having seen his car, has arrived to ask whether he can help with a delivery. His mother telephones about her medication. At four o'clock a young cousin arrives, because he is preparing for an examination and wants advice. By nine in the evening the house is quiet, the tasks are done, and the man sits in the dark for twenty minutes with a feeling that he cannot name and would not report to anyone: a sensation of being entirely alone in the middle of a full life.

This chapter is about that feeling. It is worth saying at once that the feeling is not self-pity, and that it is not a mood disorder. It is a structural feature of

a life organised around responsibility, and it has been documented as a public-health concern as well as a personal experience: male loneliness is associated with poor mental health, with a higher risk of suicide, and with worse physical health outcomes, and it is now the subject of sustained attention by health agencies around the world. The purpose of this chapter is to explain how the arrangement is produced, and then to set out the practical route out of it.

4.1 Surrounded by People but Feeling Alone

The subjective aspect of loneliness that is important for this chapter is that it is not the same as isolation. **Social isolation** is an objective condition: few contacts, few interactions, limited practical support. **Loneliness** is a subjective condition: the perception that one's relationships are less satisfying or less intimate than one needs them to be.

The two can occur independently. A man can be isolated without feeling lonely — this is genuinely possible, and some men find the condition tolerable, at least for a time. And, much more commonly, a man can be lonely while being socially saturated. In fact, the second condition is arguably the more dangerous of the two, because it is invisible to everyone including the man himself.

Three features make loneliness in company harder to identify than loneliness in solitude.

The evidence contradicts the feeling. A man surrounded by dependants, colleagues, and contacts has every objective reason to conclude that loneliness is not his problem. When he does feel the thing, he tends to attribute it to a particular day, a particular tiredness, or a particular disappointment, rather than recognising it as a chronic condition of his arrangements.

Nobody raises it as a possibility. The people closest to a busy man do not ask whether he is lonely, because the question sounds absurd in his circumstances. When a man does mention loneliness, the most common responses — *But you have so many people around you* or *You have your family* — have the effect of closing the subject, since they contradict his experience and implicitly suggest that he has no grounds for complaint.

The man has no word for his state. Men frequently describe the experience in other terms: a sense of unreality, a feeling of being watched, disengagement, an inability to take pleasure in company, or a suspicion that they have become a spectator of their own life. The correct description — lonely — is often not available to them, for the reasons set out in Chapter 3.

Figure 4.1 sets out the distinction between being surrounded and being known, in terms that a man can check against his own life.

Being surrounded	Being known
Many contacts, colleagues, and dependants	Two or three people who ask how he actually is
Conversations about work, money, and logistics	Conversations about fear, doubt, and what he wants
Requests made of him daily	Requests made by him, occasionally, and received well
Respect and, often, public standing	Honesty about his failures without loss of standing
Company that ends when the meeting ends	Company that continues when there is nothing to be done

Figure 4.1 Being surrounded and being known are different conditions. The left-hand column can be satisfied by a full household and a busy contact list; the right-hand column is generated only by specific forms of intimate attention.

The practical test is worth writing into the margin. **By what measure would you know that you are known rather than merely surrounded?** For most men, the answer comes in one of four forms: there is somebody who asks how I actually am and waits for the answer; there is somebody who has told me an unpleasant truth about myself, and I did not lose them; there is somebody to whom I have said the worst thing about my life; or there is somebody who keeps in touch when there is nothing to be gained.

> **KEY POINT**
> Being needed is not the same as being known, and being surrounded is not the same as being close. The two are routinely confused in the lives of men, because the first condition is visible and measurable while the second cannot be counted at all.

4.2 Why Successful Men Experience Isolation

The mechanisms by which achievement and reliability produce isolation are not mysterious once they are named. Five of them do most of the work.

Conversations Become Transactions

When a man is competent and available, he becomes a resource. Resources are approached for a purpose. This is not a moral failing in the people around him; it is what happens when a person reliably solves problems. His telephone fills with requests, and each request is legitimate. The cumulative effect is that almost every relationship in his life carries a function, and almost none of them operates without one.

Men describe the tipping point with precision: the day they began to notice that the only times they spoke to certain relatives was when there was a problem; or the realisation that the last four conversations with a close friend had each concerned a business or family matter. The discomfort this produces is difficult to name, because complaining that one is approached only for help sounds both arrogant and ungrateful. It is neither. It is an accurate report of a structural problem.

The Audience Requires Maintenance

Once a man is known as steady, competent and unflappable, that identity becomes an asset that must be maintained. The maintenance is invisible work: choosing which difficulties to mention and which to omit; managing his expression in conversations where a problem is being discussed; deciding not to attend an event because he cannot currently fund the obligation it represents; and carrying the private weight of a reputation for having no problems.

The cost of this maintenance is the subject of Chapter 1, and for the purposes of this chapter the relevant effect is social. A man who is maintaining an appearance avoids precisely those situations in which intimacy develops: the unhurried conversation, the confession of weakness, the admission that he does not know what to do.

Time Is Allocated to Obligation

Loneliness in men is frequently produced by nothing more complicated than scheduling. An audit of a typical mid-life man's week, drawn from the time-use studies and from men's own reports, produces a consistent picture: the hours available for paid work, commuting, household logistics, family care, community obligations, and the maintenance of property consume the week almost completely. What remains is a small residue, and the residue is usually committed to recovery — sleep, rest, and whatever is necessary to be fit for the following week.

Figure 4.2 presents that audit in outline. It is presented as a conceptual illustration rather than as a set of measurements, but the shape of the result is consistent across the accounts men give.

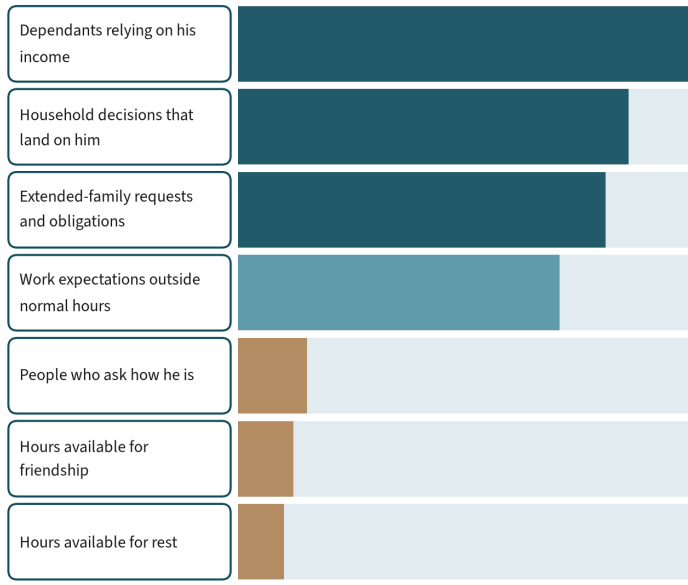


Figure 4.2 An approximate audit of a mid-life man's weekly hours. Loads on the upper bars accumulate; the lower bars — the hours available for friendship, rest, and reflection — are the ones that are compressed when the upper bars grow.

The practical consequence is that friendship does not fail because men do not value it. It fails because it is the only category in the audit with no external claimant. Nobody sends a message saying that a man has not seen his closest friend for five months. And so it is the first thing to go.

Comparison Replaces Conversation

An unintended effect of male success is that a man's peers become rivals. This occurs in every profession, but it is especially pronounced where positions are scarce: in competitive business environments, in politics and administration, in academic life, and in communities where the visible markers of status are closely watched. Where every conversation is a comparison, intimacy is impossible, because intimacy requires the ability to be seen without ranking.

The result is a particular phenomenon that men recognise immediately: groups of men who appear to be friends, who meet regularly, who assist one another in emergencies, and among whom no man has ever admitted to a serious personal difficulty.

Migration and Relocation Break Existing Networks

The fifth mechanism is the most concrete and the least often discussed. Male friendship is often built on proximity and routine: men who grew up in the same area, worked in the same yard, attended the same gatherings, or walked home by the same route. Relocation — for work, for marriage, for education, for family reasons — severs the routine and, with it, the friendship. A man who moved for a better job at thirty-five frequently finds himself, at fifty, with professional contacts in abundance and no one with whom he can speak about anything that matters.

Chapter 27 returns to this point, and Appendix J provides a practical method for building a new network from nothing.

4.3 The Disappearance of Meaningful Friendships

The thinning of men's friendships in adulthood is one of the most reliably observed patterns in the social research on adult life, and it happens in stages. Naming the stages matters, because a man who recognises the third or fourth stage in his own life can often intervene before the fifth.

Stage One: Reduced Frequency Without Loss of Warmth

The friendship remains entirely intact in substance, but the meetings become less frequent. There are reasons, and the reasons are good: new employment, a baby, a move, a change of shift. Contact continues by telephone and, in the modern setting, by message. Both parties are certain that the friendship is unchanged.

This stage is not a problem. It is a stage that must be navigated deliberately if the later ones are to be avoided, and the navigation consists of establishing a rhythm that does not depend on circumstance. The friends who survive middle age are, in most cases, those who moved from meeting by accident to meeting by arrangement.

Stage Two: Conversation Shifts to Logistics

The content of the conversation gradually narrows. Two men who once discussed everything now discuss what is necessary: the school fees, the family meeting, the coworker's promotion, the price of cement. Neither has decided to narrow the subject matter. The narrowing happens because logistics are what both men have in common at that stage of life, and because the deeper subjects require conditions that neither now has: time, privacy, and the absence of the other's spouse, children, or colleagues.

At this stage, contact is preserved while intimacy declines. A man may still speak to his friend weekly and not have told him anything real for two years.

Stage Three: Contact Requires a Reason

Once the relationship has become transactional, the contact becomes conditional on a reason. A man does not call his friend to ask how he is; he calls because

he requires something, or because there is news to report, or because a mutual acquaintance has died. The calls continue, and their number is not necessarily reduced. What has vanished is the call that has no purpose, and with it the possibility of the conversations that only purposeless calls produce.

Stage Four: Withdrawal Under Strain

The fourth stage is the dangerous one, and it is a defining feature of male loneliness. When a man comes under serious strain — financial difficulty, marital conflict, depression, bereavement, an illness — the last thing he does is to call his friends. He withdraws. The reason is a combination of shame and consideration: he does not wish to be seen in his present condition, and he does not want to add his difficulty to theirs. He does not answer messages as promptly. He is busy when invitations arrive.

From outside, the withdrawal is read as a change in the man's regard — *he has become proud*, or *he no longer has time for us* — and the invitations gradually stop. From inside, the withdrawal is a strategy of concealment that has the effect of removing the very relationships that might have helped.

Stage Five: The Empty Network at a Time of Need

The fifth stage is the one men describe in surveys and in counselling rooms, sometimes decades later: the moment at which a serious crisis — a divorce, a diagnosis, a bereavement, a business failure — occurs and the man realises that he has nobody to call. Contacts, yes. Advisers, sometimes. Colleagues, certainly. But nobody to whom the sentence *I am not managing* can be said.

The experience is frequently described as astonishing. The man in question has been a reliable friend to others for years; he has attended their weddings and funerals, contributed to their welfare, and given assistance to their relatives. He has done everything that friendship requires in its public dimension, and he has arrived, at the age of fifty-two, with no one in the private dimension. The pattern is presented in Figure 4.3.

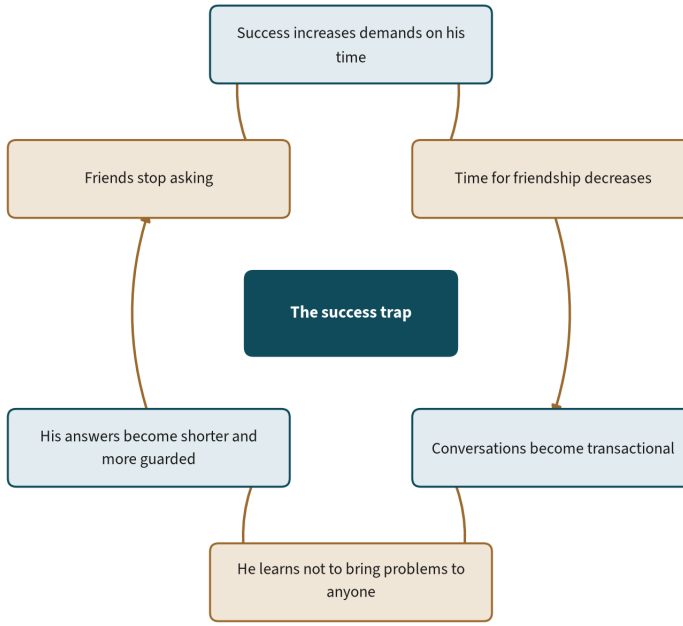


Figure 4.3 The success trap: how professional attainment and reliability convert friendships into transactions over a period of years. No step in the process is a decision, and the outcome is invisible until it is tested.

Reversing the Pattern: The Practical Rule

The step that prevents the whole sequence is the conversion of friendship from an accident into an arrangement. Specifically, three rules do most of the work, and they are deceptively modest.

Fix a recurring time. Two hours, every second week or every month, with one man or two, at a fixed time. The content of the meeting does not matter; the recurrence does. What is under construction is not a conversation but a structure that will produce conversations over the following ten years.

Make contact without a purpose at least once a week. One message to one person, containing nothing that requires a response: *I was thinking about our conversation last month. How is your mother?* The purposeless message is what distinguishes friendship from a professional relationship.

Disclose something first. For reasons developed in Chapter 26, men rarely initiate disclosure, and every male friendship in which disclosure has occurred was started by somebody. This is the only reliable method of finding out whether a friendship can carry anything real, and it consists of testing the water with a

matter of moderate weight — a worry about money, a disagreement with a wife, a concern about a father's health — and observing the response.

What Men Report When They Examine the Pattern Honestly

When men are asked, in confidence, to describe what happened to their friendships, a small number of descriptions recur, and they are worth recording because they are more persuasive than any general claim.

The one-year gap. Men frequently identify a specific year in which contact with a group of friends collapsed: the year of a new job, the year a child was born, the year a parent became ill, the year of a relocation. In most cases, the collapse was not a decision but an overload: for twelve months there was genuinely no capacity, and at the end of the twelve months nobody resumed the arrangement, because resuming it required an initiative that no one had ever needed to take before.

The numbers that do not add up. Men who are asked to count their actual close contacts are frequently surprised. A man of fifty who describes himself as having many friends may, on examination, identify two men he has spoken to in the last six months, neither of whom knows anything important about his life. The discrepancy between the felt sense (*I have plenty of friends*) and the audit (*I have two, and they do not know me*) is one of the most useful discoveries a man can make about himself, and it is available to anyone with a notebook and twenty minutes.

The funeral test. A widely reported experience among men is the discovery, at a funeral, of the quantity of affectionate regard that exists for them and the absence of any relationship through which it can be expressed. Men describe standing at a graveside and being embraced by a dozen men who tell them sincerely that they are brothers, while knowing that none of those relationships has ever involved a private conversation, and that the embrace will not be followed by a telephone call.

The silence about loss. Men who have suffered a serious loss — the death of a child, a divorce, a business collapse, a diagnosis — report a characteristic and painful pattern: a period of intense support immediately after the event, followed by an almost complete cessation of contact within a few months. The surrounding network responds to the crisis and then withdraws, because the ongoing condition is harder to address than the event. The man is left to carry the long part of the loss alone, and he usually does so without complaint, interpreting the withdrawal as evidence that he should stop mentioning it.

The unchanging conversation. Two men who have been friends for thirty years may find themselves, at a reunion, repeating the same series of stories from their twenties for the fourth time. The stories are affectionate and they are true, and they are also a substitute for anything current, because neither man has any

practice in speaking about the present. Men recognise this pattern with a particular kind of sadness: the friendship is deep, old, and entirely frozen.

4.4 When Everyone Needs You but Nobody Checks on You

There is a variant of this loneliness that deserves separate treatment because it has an identifiable structure and a predictable timeline. It is the condition of the man who has become, within his family and community, an institution.

The Structure of the Condition

The man in question has, over years, been constructed as the household's infrastructure. He is expected to solve financial problems, mediate disputes, provide representation, host visitors, fund ceremonies, transport people, and be available at all hours. The construction was not his decision. It is the outcome of a series of small assignments, each of which he accepted because there was nobody else.

In such a position, the man receives two things: demands and respect. He does not receive three things that people need just as much: enquiry about his own state, permission to be temporarily unavailable, and reciprocation — the experience of being helped rather than only helping.

The Effects of Chronic One-Directional Support

Sustained one-directional support produces a predictable set of consequences, and they are important enough to list.

Unacknowledged resentment. The man does not feel angry, at least not consciously. He feels tired and, occasionally, oddly hollow. The resentment is present but is suppressed along with everything else, and it tends to emerge in unhelpful forms: harshness about small matters, a withdrawal of warmth from a particular family member, or a refusal to assist in one specific case that becomes disproportionate to the occasion.

A hardening of the boundary-free pattern. Because assistance has always been provided, the family's expectations increase. Where a boundary has never existed, its first introduction — the first *no* — is experienced by everybody as a rupture rather than an adjustment, which is why Chapter 10 devotes substantial space to introducing boundaries without destroying the relationship.

A collapse in reciprocity within the marriage. Wives of such men sometimes report that they have themselves stopped offering support, because the household system has assigned them a different role: managing the children, the household, and their own employment, while the husband is the household's external interface. Both partners then feel unsupported, and each believes the other is responsible.

Loss of the man's own initiative. A man who has been the answering machine for a family for fifteen years can struggle to identify what he wants when

asked. There is a specific and disconcerting experience reported by men in this position: asked what they would like to do on a free Saturday, they cannot answer. The capacity to have preferences about one's own life is not destroyed, but it has not been exercised for a long time, and it requires deliberate recovery. Chapter 40 is addressed to this work.

The Reciprocal Question

There is one practical test that clarifies the situation and often produces the necessary change. It is a question the man asks himself, and it may also be put to him by a counsellor or a friend: **If I were the one in need, whom would I call, and would they come?**

The answer is frequently not *nobody* — most men identify one or two names — but neither is it a list. What matters is what happens next. The man who identifies one or two names has identified the beginning of a plan, and Appendix J, Section 2, turns that identification into an approach. The man who identifies nobody has identified the precise task in front of him, and it is the most important task in this chapter.

4.5 Emotional Intimacy Beyond Romantic Relationships

One of the practical obstacles to rebuilding male connection is a category error that most men make without noticing: the assumption that emotional intimacy is a property of romantic relationships, and that the desire for closeness is therefore a desire for a wife, a partner, or a sexual relationship.

The assumption is false, and it causes real harm. It leaves a married man who is starved of closeness with only one available object for that need, which places an impossible weight on the marriage and frequently produces either resentment of a wife who cannot supply everything, or a sexual history that is unconnected to intimacy at all. It also leaves a single man with the belief that emotional closeness is unavailable to him until he finds a partner, which is both untrue and expensive in terms of years.

Defining the Terms

Emotional intimacy is a state of being known, accurately and without performance, by another person, and of knowing that person in return. It has four components:

- **Disclosure** — the sharing of material that is not public: fears, doubts, regrets, hopes, and matters of shame.
- **Being received** — the experience that the disclosure did not damage the relationship; that the person is still there, and has not used the information against him.

- **Mutual knowledge over time** — a body of shared history such that each person can predict the other's reactions, and can describe the other's character accurately.
- **The absence of performance** — the ability to be in the person's company without managing an impression.

It should be clear that none of these components requires romantic or sexual involvement. They require time, honesty, and reciprocity, and they are achieved by men with brothers, with close friends, with mentors and mentees, with men in support groups, and — in a form that deserves separate emphasis — with professional counsellors and therapists.

The Forms Available to Men

Four distinct forms of non-romantic emotional intimacy are available, and men frequently overlook at least two of them.

Age-mate friendship. The oldest and most natural form: a peer with whom a man shares history. Its advantage is the absence of hierarchy. Its difficulty is that both parties are under the same pressures, and therefore both find the arrangement easy to postpone.

Mentorship in both directions. A relationship with an older man who has passed through the same stages, and with a younger man for whom the reader is that older man. In the author's experience of working with men, mentorship is the most underrated form of male support. A younger man's respect gives an older man permission to be honest about difficulty, because the honesty becomes instruction rather than complaint; and the older man's experience gives the younger man language and hope. Chapter 44 develops this point as a strategy for the second half of life.

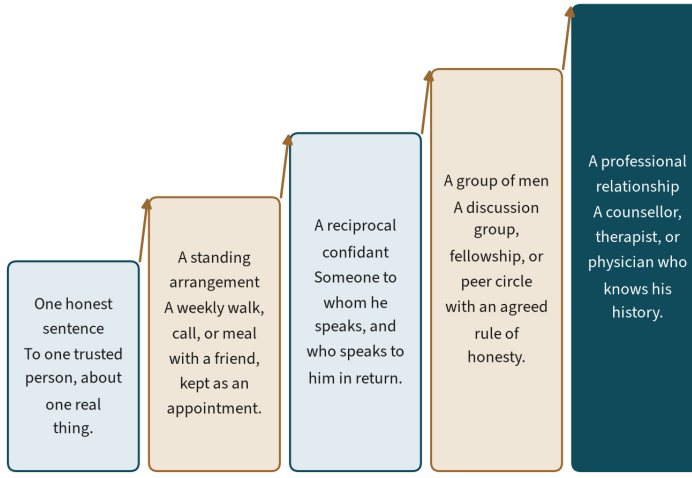
Peer groups with a rule of honesty. Structured groups — a men's fellowship with an agreed confidentiality rule, a supervised support group, a discussion group organised around a book such as this one, or a professional peer group with a leader — supply something that friendship cannot supply reliably: regularity, confidentiality, and an expectation that members speak. Appendix S provides material for such groups, and Appendix J provides a plan for starting one.

Professional relationships. A counsellor, psychotherapist, or physician with whom a man has a continuing relationship is a legitimate and, for many men, preferable site of intimate disclosure. Men who find it difficult to speak to friends often find it easier to speak to a professional, because the professional's role is defined, the confidentiality is explicit, reciprocity is not required, and there is no risk of the information circulating within the family or community. This is not a lesser form of intimacy. It is a different one, and for a proportion of men it is the form that works.

The Particular Case of the Man Who Has Never Had This

A number of men arrive at mid-life having never had an intimate non-romantic relationship of any kind. These are frequently men who have been successful, reliable, and well-liked, and who have spent their lives in environments where male closeness was expressed exclusively through practical assistance: helping with a move, contributing to a funeral, offering advice, sharing a drink.

For such a man, the practical advice is to start with a low-risk, incremental approach, and Figure 4.4 sets out the sequence. Nothing in it requires a man to begin with his deepest material or his greatest fear. The first step is small deliberately, and it is the low-risk nature of the first step that makes the rest possible.



Rebuilding connection proceeds in steps; the first step is small on purpose.

Figure 4.4 Rebuilding connection proceeds in steps. Each stage provides the evidence that the next stage requires; the first step is small because its function is to test whether the ground will hold.

Two instructions are worth emphasising. The first is that the initial disclosure should be a matter of *moderate* weight rather than maximum weight. Disclosing the heaviest material to a friend who has never received anything real from a man is likely to produce an unhelpful response and confirm the reader's worst expectations. The second is that reciprocity should be invited rather than expected. A question of the form *Has anything like that ever happened to you?* converts a confession into a conversation, and it is the single most useful sentence in the rebuilding process.

The Professional Relationship: What It Is and What It Is Not

Because a proportion of men will find that the professional relationship is the only one currently available to them, it is worth describing it accurately, since misinformation about it is one of the main obstacles to its use.

It is not friendship, and it does not need to be. The professional relationship has a defined purpose, a defined time, a defined fee or service arrangement, and a defined confidentiality. These features, which men sometimes regard as making the relationship artificial, are in practice its advantages. Nothing said in the room will be repeated to a wife, a brother, a colleague, or a community. There is no obligation to reciprocate by listening to the other person's difficulties. There is no requirement to be interesting, pleasant, or competent. And there is a professional obligation to be useful rather than merely sympathetic — which many men find more respectful of their time than a long conversation with a friend who does not know what to do.

It does not mean that something is severely wrong. Men commonly delay seeking professional support because they believe that counselling is for people who are "mad" or "broken," and that going would signify a serious diagnosis. In practice, the majority of people who consult counsellors, psychologists, and physicians about emotional matters do not have a severe illness. They have a situation that is not resolving on its own: a bereavement that has not settled, a marriage in difficulty, a work problem producing sleeplessness, a loss of interest in things that used to matter, or a decision they cannot make alone.

It is not a substitute for the work, and it is not a magic solution. A professional can help a man understand what is happening to him, learn specific skills, address the effects of past events, and identify whether a treatable condition is present. He cannot remove the debt, restore the marriage, or reverse the loss. What he can do is ensure that the man is not carrying the situation in the dark, using methods shown to help.

It can be private. In circumstances where a man cannot afford to have it known that he is receiving psychological support — a real constraint in many families and workplaces — arrangements are available for confidentiality, including services by telephone and online, private consultations outside the local area, and services provided through employers or health schemes that are subject to confidentiality obligations. Chapter 35 and Appendix Q address the practicalities, including the question of cost and how to begin when the only available option is a general physician.

It can be time-limited. For many men, a small number of sessions — sometimes four to eight — is sufficient to clarify a situation, learn a technique, or complete a piece of long-deferred emotional work. The professional relationship is not a commitment for life, and it does not need to continue once its purpose

has been served. Some men return years later for a further brief period of work; others never return, having obtained what they needed.

For the man who reads this chapter and concludes that he has nobody, the practical implication is therefore not that he must manufacture friendships before he can be helped. It is that a professional relationship is available, effective for many of the difficulties described in this book, and, in the author's experience, the route by which the largest number of men eventually arrive at the possibility of friendship — because learning to speak in one setting is what makes speaking possible in another.

4.6 Rebuilding Genuine Human Connection

The final section summarises the method. It is deliberately concrete, and it is designed to be workable for a man with almost no free time, because that is the situation of the men this book is written for.

Step One: Take the Inventory

Write three lists.

List A — Existing contacts. Every man with whom you have spoken in the last year, in any context. This list is usually long, and its length is likely to be misleading.

List B — Possible confidants. Men, and women, who might plausibly become people to whom something real could be said: people who have shown discretion, who do not compete with you, who have kept in contact without a reason, or who have themselves disclosed something to you. This list is usually short — for many men, three to six names.

List C — Reciprocity. A single sentence for each name on List B, describing what that person currently receives from you and what you receive from them. The asymmetry in this list is the most useful information the exercise produces.

Step Two: Make the Approach

Select one name from List B, and take one of the following actions within the next fourteen days.

- **The appointment.** *I want to talk to you about something. Can we set aside two hours on Saturday?* The appointment is the most reliable approach, because it converts a vague intention into a meeting, and because the phrasing signals that the subject is serious without disclosing its content.
- **The purposeless contact.** One message, with no request attached, to a man you have not spoken to properly in more than six months.
- **The reciprocity offer.** An offer of assistance to the person most likely to become a confidant: not a grand gesture, but specific and unsolicited —

assistance with transport, an introduction, a practical task, a contribution that is needed.

- **The professional step.** If the inventory produces no names, or if the reader judges that the material he carries is too heavy for a friend, then the appropriate step is to make contact with a counselling service. Appendix Q explains the practicalities, including what to say when making a first appointment, and Chapter 35 deals with the objections men raise at this stage.

Step Three: Establish the Structure

Connection that depends on intention does not survive contact with a mid-life schedule. Establish structure instead. Two arrangements are sufficient: a standing meeting with one person at a fixed interval, and a recurring group — an association, a fellowship, a men's group, a sports team, a professional peer group — with a consistent time and a defined membership. Chapters 26 and 27 develop these further, and Appendix J sets out a full twelve-month plan for building and maintaining a support network.

Step Four: Practise Saying One True Thing

The hardest part of rebuilding connection is not the arrangement; it is the sentence. Men who have spent twenty years discussing logistics find that when the opportunity arrives they cannot think of anything to say, and they fall back on the familiar subjects. The remedy is preparation, and the preparation is a single written sentence, drafted in advance, of the form: *There is one thing I have not told anyone, and I have decided to tell you.*

Nothing further needs to be prepared. The sentence does the work, and what follows it, in the experience of most men who have said it, tends to arrive without much premeditation.

4.7 Illustrative Case: Ninety Minutes in a Car Park

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in counselling and in the men's health literature.

Kunle is forty-seven and owns a medium-sized electrical contracting business in a state capital. He employs fourteen people. He has been married for nineteen years; his wife, Bola, is a branch manager in a bank. They have three children, one at university. His father died four years ago, and since then Kunle has become the effective head of an extended family of twenty-three people, seven of whom are dependent on him in some form: two of his late brother's children whose school fees he pays, his mother's medical costs, and a cousin who works in his business and whose salary is, in practice, an arrangement rather than a wage.

Kunle works from seven in the morning until nine or ten at night, six days a week. He describes himself as "not a man who talks about things," and would not have used the word lonely about himself until the evening described below.

His three closest friends are men he has known since university. The pattern of the relationship is this. He attends the funerals. He contributes to the weddings. He gives professional advice freely. He has lent money to two of them and written it off. In the last three years he has seen each of them fewer than five times, and he has not been alone with any of them for more than an hour since 2019.

In February, Kunle's business loses a major contract. In March, he learns that a client owing a substantial sum has taken proceedings against his company. In April, he begins to have difficulty sleeping. In May, during an argument over a trivial matter, Bola tells him that she feels she is living with a stranger, and that this is the fourth year she has felt it. He does not answer, because he does not know what to say.

In June, a Thursday, he drives from a supplier's yard to a site and finds, on arrival, that the client has cancelled the visit. He sits in the car park with the engine off. It is half past four. He stays there for ninety minutes. He cannot say afterwards what he thought about, except that at some point he took out his telephone, looked through the contacts — there are four hundred and eleven names — and could not identify one person to whom he could send a message describing his situation. Not one.

What he noticed was not sadness. It was a cold, factual realisation, described in his own words later: *I have spent twenty years looking after everybody and there is no one on the other side of the counter.*

The following week he did two things. He telephoned a former colleague — not his oldest friends, but a man he had worked with eleven years earlier and trusted — and asked whether they could meet. He told that man, in the course of a two-hour conversation, most of what he had told nobody: the lost contract, the proceedings, the loans, his brother's children, and the finding that he had no one to call. The second thing he did was to telephone a counselling service recommended by a relative, and to make an appointment. Of that call he said afterwards, *It was the most frightened I have been since I was a boy, and I was only making an appointment.*

The case illustrates a pattern that recurs throughout this book, and four features of it are worth isolating.

The loneliness was not produced by failure. Kunle's isolation was at its most severe in a period when he was, by all external measures, successful: a functioning business, a marriage, a respected position in a large extended family. His network of obligations had grown precisely as his network of support had shrunk, and the two curves had crossed at some point that nobody noticed.

The obligation load crowded out the friendships. The extended-family responsibilities were legitimate, and he had accepted them honourably. What nobody had audited was the effect on the remaining relationships: with each year,

the time available for friendship decreased, and the probability of any of those friendships becoming intimate decreased with it.

The moment of realisation was not dramatic. He did not lose his family, his health, or his business. He sat in a car park for ninety minutes with his telephone in his hand and found that there was nobody to call. This is not unusual. For many men, the recognition of loneliness arrives in an unremarkable private moment, and its force comes precisely from its ordinariness.

The remedy began with a stranger and a former colleague. Not with his oldest friends, and not with his wife. Kunle's first disclosure was to a man he had not seen for eleven years, and his second step was professional. This is worth noting because it is the more common order in practice: men frequently tell somebody outside the immediate circle first, precisely because the stakes are lower. The choice is not a failure of courage; it is a sound piece of tactical judgement, and it can be repeated with the people who matter once the first sentence has been said once.

4.8 Practical Exercise: The Connection Audit

This exercise takes about ninety minutes and requires only a notebook. It has five parts. Readers who work through it with a counsellor or a trusted friend report considerably better results, because the exercise tends to produce a decision that is difficult to make alone.

Part One: The Inventory

Draw a table with four columns and answer for each person in your life with whom you have had contact in the last twelve months.

Name | What we talk about | What they know about my actual situation | Who initiates contact |

The first two columns will be filled quickly. The third is the revealing one. Against each name, write one of four letters:

- **N** — knows nothing of my real situation.
- **S** — knows something, but only the public account.
- **K** — knows a great deal.
- **A** — knows everything that matters.

Most men who complete this audit find that the K and A columns are close to empty, and that the majority of names are marked N, including the names of people they would describe as close friends.

Part Two: The Reciprocity Check

For the three to five people who matter most to you — spouse or partner, closest friend, closest relative, an adult child — write two short paragraphs: what they currently receive from you, and what you currently receive from them. Do this for

each person separately, and be specific. *They receive my income and my availability* is specific. *They receive my support* is not.

Part Three: The Trace

For each of those people, answer one question: *When did I last tell this person something that made me feel exposed?* Write the month and year. If the answer is *I cannot remember*, record that as the answer and resist the temptation to substitute a lesser event.

Part Four: The Decision

Answer three questions in writing.

1. **Who is the one person most likely to receive a difficult disclosure well?** Choose one. Not the ideal person; the most likely.
2. **What is the one item I will disclose first?** Choose something of moderate weight: a worry about money, a concern about health, a difficulty at work, the fact of a specific loss, or the fact that you have been sleeping badly for months. Do not choose the heaviest item; it can wait for a second conversation.
3. **What is the date, and what is the sentence?** Write both. The sentence should be short and specific. *I want to tell you something I have told nobody. I am not asking you to fix it. I just need you to know.* Then do it on the date.

Part Five: The Structure

Finally, set up the structure that prevents the relapse into isolation. Choose two recurring arrangements and write them into your calendar for the next twelve months.

- **A standing meeting:** one person, one activity, one interval, fixed time. Monthly is achievable; fortnightly is better. Examples: a walk, a meal, a two-hour call, a shared weekly obligation such as taking a parent to a clinic.
- **A group or association:** a men's fellowship, a professional association, a sports team, a study or discussion group, a community committee with which you are already involved. The requirement is not the subject matter; it is regularity, familiarity, and the possibility of conversation that is not transactional. Appendix J sets out a plan for building such a group from nothing, and Appendix S provides material for its meetings.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 4 in brief. Loneliness and social isolation are different conditions. Isolation is objective — few contacts, little practical support. Loneliness is subjective — the perception that one's relationships are less intimate than one needs. A man can be lonely in a house full of dependants and a contact list of four hundred names,

and this is the more dangerous of the two conditions because the evidence around him contradicts his own experience.

Success and reliability produce isolation through five processes. Conversations become transactions when a competent man is approached for a purpose rather than for himself. A reputation for steadiness becomes an asset requiring maintenance, which discourages the very situations in which intimacy develops. Time is allocated to obligations that have claimants, while friendship, which has none, is compressed into the smallest part of the week. Comparison replaces conversation in competitive settings, making it unsafe to be seen without ranking. And migration and relocation sever the routines on which most male friendships were built.

Friendships disappear in stages: reduced frequency without loss of warmth; conversation narrowed to logistics; contact requiring a reason; withdrawal under strain; and an empty network at the moment of need. The stages are recognisable, and the intervention is deliberate structure: a fixed recurring time with one person, purposeless contact at least weekly, and a willingness to disclose something real first.

The condition of the man whom everyone needs and whom nobody checks on has its own structure and its own effects: unacknowledged resentment, a boundary-free pattern that becomes progressively harder to revise, the loss of reciprocity within the marriage, and the erosion of his own capacity to say what he wants. The clarifying test is the reciprocal question: if I were the one in need, whom would I call, and would they come?

Emotional intimacy is not a property of romantic relationships. It consists of disclosure, being received without damage to the relationship, accumulated mutual knowledge, and the absence of performance — none of which requires romance or sex. Four forms are available to men: age-mate friendship, mentorship in both directions, peer groups with a rule of honesty, and the professional relationship with a counsellor or physician. Rebuilding proceeds in small steps, beginning with a matter of moderate weight rather than the heaviest material.

The practical method has four parts: take the inventory of who knows what; make the approach, preferably by arranging an appointment; establish the structure of recurring contact; and prepare one true sentence in advance so that the opportunity, when it comes, is not wasted.

Reflection Questions

1. Apply the test in Section 4.1 to your own life: by what measure would you know that you are known rather than merely surrounded? Which of the four markers do you currently have, and which are absent?
2. Look at the five processes in Section 4.2. Which has done most damage in your life — transactions, audience maintenance, time compression, comparison, or relocation? What did it cost you, specifically?
3. At which stage of Section 4.3 does your closest friendship currently sit? What single arrangement would move it back one stage?

4. Complete the reciprocal question in writing: if you were the one in need, whom would you call, and what evidence do you have that they would come? If your list is short, what will you do about it this month?
5. Section 4.5 identifies four forms of non-romantic intimacy. Which is most available to you, and which have you never attempted? If professional support is the one that fits your circumstances, what has prevented you from making contact, and what would make it easier?
6. Consider the last twelve months. How many conversations did you have in which you were the one who was helped? What does the number suggest?
7. Kunle discovered in a car park that he had nobody to call. What would your equivalent moment look like, and is there any action you could take now that would change its outcome?

Further Reading

- **On loneliness:** the modern research literature treating loneliness as a health condition, including work that distinguishes social isolation from subjective loneliness and studies of the mortality risk associated with persistent loneliness. The national loneliness strategies published by several governments are a useful practical complement, as they translate the research into programmes.
- **On male friendship:** the sociological and popular literature on men's friendships, including accounts of how adult male friendship is organised around activity, how it changes at mid-life, and how it can be rebuilt. The literature on "shoulder-to-shoulder" friendship — closeness conducted through shared activity rather than face-to-face conversation — is particularly useful for men who find direct disclosure difficult.
- **On social capital and health:** the research linking social connection to physical health, including the well-established finding that social relationships affect mortality risk substantially.
- **On mentoring:** the literature on mentoring relationships, including work on their benefits to both parties and on the reasons that men in mid-life benefit particularly from mentoring younger men.
- **On peer support:** material on peer support and mutual-help groups, including the evidence on their effectiveness for men, and practical guides to starting and running a men's group.
- **Accounts by men:** first-person writing by men about loneliness, mid-life friendship, and the experience of being depended upon. These accounts are frequently more useful to a reader than the research literature, because they supply the language that Chapter 3 identified as missing.

PART II

The Battles of the Mind

The invisible psychological conflicts men endure: internal struggles that cannot be seen, anxiety hidden beneath confidence, depression behind a smiling face, the fear of failure, and the war against self-doubt.

5 CHAPTER

Fighting Demons Nobody Can See

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the range of internal struggles men experience, and explain why these struggles are systematically invisible to others.
2. Recognise anxiety as it actually presents in men — frequently as physical tension, irritability, and control-seeking rather than as named worry.
3. Describe the nature of persistent worry and intrusive thoughts, distinguish them from normal concern, and explain the mechanism by which they intensify.
4. Explain the operation of shame, guilt, and unresolved memory, and distinguish between them in practical terms.
5. Identify the signs that distress has reached a level requiring professional assessment, and describe what such an assessment involves.
6. Use structured methods to find language for invisible pain, and prepare an account of his own state that can be given to a professional, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

A man in his early forties described his situation to a physician in a single sentence that took him four years to construct: *Nothing has happened to me, and I am not well.* He had a job, a wife, two children, and no identifiable crisis. He had also, for three years, been unable to be still. He woke with a sensation in his chest that he described as *a readiness for something*. He checked the locks twice. He lay awake running through scenarios in which his employer discovered a mistake he had made two years earlier. He had developed a habit of checking his wife's mood before speaking, and a habit of leaving rooms when more than four people were in them. He did not describe any of this as anxiety, because the word in his language and in his mind belonged to people who were visibly paralysed by fear, and he was

not paralysed. He was functioning, and functioning extremely well, at a cost that he could not compute and had never reported to anybody.

His sentence — *Nothing has happened to me, and I am not well* — is a useful starting point for this chapter, because it identifies the peculiar condition of the man whose battle is real and whose evidence is absent. There is no wound, no diagnosis, no bereavement, no bankruptcy. There is an internal conflict that consumes enormous resources, produces measurable symptoms, degrades sleep and relationships, and is entirely invisible to everybody who knows him.

The chapter deals with four such internal battles: the general phenomenon of invisible psychological conflict; anxiety as men actually experience it; persistent worry and intrusive thoughts; and the pair of states that produce the most private suffering of all — shame and guilt, together with the unresolved memories that accompany them. It closes with the practical question of when to seek professional help, and how to describe what is happening in a way that a clinician can use.

5.1 Internal Struggles and Psychological Distress

The expression *internal struggle* is not a clinical term. It is a description of a common human experience: conflict conducted entirely within a person, with no external manifestation and, frequently, no external cause. Before examining the specific forms it takes in men, it is worth setting out why these struggles are so well hidden — and the answer is not simply that men refuse to talk.

The Four Concealments

Distress is concealed by competence. Competence is a visible, verifiable, daily output. A man who continues to work, provide, and function generates continuous evidence that he is managing, and this evidence is not false. The difficulty is that competence of this kind can coexist with an internal state that is deteriorating rapidly, and outsiders — reasonably — take the verifiable evidence as the whole picture.

Distress is concealed by the absence of a vocabulary. As Chapter 3 established, many men can describe a situation accurately and a feeling only vaguely. An internal struggle that cannot be described produces no report, and an unreported struggle produces no help.

Distress is concealed by the masculine presentation of symptoms. Anxiety in men frequently appears as irritability, restlessness, controlling behaviour, physical tension, disturbed sleep, and increased alcohol use rather than as fear or worry. Even a man who does report *something* to a physician may report only the physical elements, and a clinician who asks the standard question — *Do you feel anxious or depressed?* — may receive a negative answer from a man whose anxiety is expressed entirely through his jaw, his temper, and his sleeping pattern.

Distress is concealed by shame. Of the four, this is the most powerful and the least discussed. A man who is struggling internally frequently experiences the struggle itself as evidence of inadequacy. To describe it is to confess it. The shame is not merely about the content of the difficulty; it is about the fact *of* having difficulty. Chapter 22 deals with this mechanism at length, and the section on shame below examines its operation in the specific case of hidden psychological distress.

The Range of Internal Conflicts

The internal battles men describe fall into a small number of recognisable families. They are worth listing, because a man who reads the list will usually recognise two or three items and thereby begin the process of naming his own situation.

Table 5.1 The eight families of internal conflict. Most men recognise between two and four in their own lives; the number is not a measure of health or illness.

Family of conflict	Typical form
Conflict between self and expectation	"I am not the man this role requires." The sense of being perpetually short of a standard.
Conflict between actions and values	"I have done things I would not defend." Guilt, moral injury, and the sense of a double life.
Conflict between desire and duty	"I want a different life and I cannot have it." Ambition, frustration, and resentment that cannot be expressed.
Conflict about worth	"If they knew the truth about me, they would revise their opinion." The theme of Chapters 7 and 8.
Conflict over the past	"There is a matter I have never resolved." Unfinished grief, unforgiven conduct, unacknowledged harm.
Conflict about the future	"One day this will collapse." Chronic anticipation of a disaster that has not occurred.
Conflict about identity	"I do not know who I am without this role." The subject of Chapter 24.
Conflict about being needed	"They need me and I have nothing left." The exhaustion described in Chapters 10 and 33.

What distinguishes a difficulty from a disorder is not the presence of conflict — conflict is normal and, in many cases, productive — but three features: **intensity**, **duration**, and **impairment**. A man is not suffering from a clinical condition because he has an internal conflict. He may be suffering from one because the conflict dominates his attention for months, produces clear physical and psychological symptoms, and interferes with sleep, work, or relationships. This distinction is important, and it is the reason that this chapter, unlike those that

follow, is organised around the recognition and description of an internal state rather than its treatment.

The Cost of Unrecognised Internal Conflict

The costs of an unrecognised internal struggle are similar to those of concealment, but with one important addition. Concealment of a known difficulty is expensive. Concealment of an *unrecognised* difficulty is more expensive still, because the man is not merely failing to report the problem; he is failing to have an accurate model of what is happening to him, and therefore attributing the symptoms to causes that cannot be addressed.

The attributions are recognisable and they are costly.

- The chest tightness is attributed to a heart problem, which produces an unnecessary cardiac investigation and no improvement.
- The irritability is attributed to the family, which produces conflict with the people who are most likely to help.
- The insomnia is attributed to age, which produces acceptance of a treatable symptom.
- The loss of interest in everything is attributed to the pressure of work, which produces more work.
- The alcohol consumption is attributed to stress, which produces more stress.

In each case, the actual situation is not addressed, and an unaddressed situation becomes more difficult over time. This is one of the clearest practical arguments for reading a book of this kind: what is being purchased is not comfort but an accurate description, and an accurate description is the precondition of competent action.

> **KEY POINT**
> An unrecognised internal struggle is not merely hidden from others. It is misdescribed to the man himself, and it is this misdescription — not the concealment — that produces the wasted years.

5.2 Anxiety Hidden Beneath Confidence

Anxiety disorders are among the most common psychological conditions in the world, and among the most treatable. Men are affected in large numbers, and men are considerably less likely than women to be identified, diagnosed, and treated. One principal reason for this is that anxiety in men frequently does not look like anxiety.

The Standard Picture, and the Male Picture

The standard description of anxiety — a sense of nervousness, dread, or fear, frequently with an escalation in specific situations, and often accompanied by an

awareness that the fear is disproportionate — is accurate for many people. The male presentation overlaps with it and differs from it in emphasis. The differences are practical, not philosophical: they determine whether a man is identified and whether he accepts the identification.

Table 5.2 Anxiety as it is commonly described and as it frequently presents in men. Adapted for this edition from the literature on sex differences in symptom presentation.

Element	Common presentation	Frequent presentation in men
Named feeling	Worry, fear, dread, "nervous"	Nothing named; "pressure," "stress," "work frustration"
Visible behaviour	Avoidance, visible nervousness, seeking reassurance	Control-seeking, overwork, irritability, risk-taking, excessive activity
Somatic emphasis	Palpitations, sweating, trembling, breathlessness	Headaches, back and chest tension, stomach problems, fatigue
The subject of the thoughts	Anticipated failure, social judgement, health	Loss of income, failure of a business, letting family down, discovery of a fault
Response to the state	Seeking help relatively early	Increasing effort, drinking, exercise, or work
Presentation to a clinician	Direct report of anxious mood	Physical complaint, sleep problem, "I cannot cope with this workload"

The table has an immediate implication for the reader. If you have not thought of yourself as an anxious man, the absence of the label tells you nothing. The relevant questions are behavioural and physical: Do I check things repeatedly? Do I need to be in control of arrangements that do not require me? Do I sleep badly in a specific pattern, waking early with a sense of dread? Is there a matter about which I think continuously and cannot resolve? Do I avoid particular conversations, places, or people with reasons that sound plausible? Have I increased drinking, smoking, or activity in the last year? If the answers point in the same direction, the label is a technicality.

The Specific Anxiety of Men with Responsibilities

There is a form of anxiety that attaches specifically to responsibility, and it deserves separate description because it is common in the men this book is written for and is rarely described as anxiety.

Its features are as follows. The man is not afraid of a specific event; he is afraid of a general collapse. He experiences a continual sense of things being held together by his own effort, with the understanding that if he stops, the structure fails. The fear is not irrational in his circumstances — the structure often *is* held together by

him — which is what makes the state so persistent and so resistant to reassurance. He is anxious because his position is genuinely precarious, and his anxiety is the correct emotional response to a real condition.

Two consequences follow. First, the man frequently rejects psychological treatment on the grounds that his anxiety is objective: *I am not imagining the problem; the problem is real.* In many cases he is right about the problem, and the treatment is still appropriate, because the objective load is producing symptoms that require management, and because a man whose resources are depleted by anxiety is less able to solve the objective problem. Second, the appropriate response is frequently structural rather than psychological: reducing genuine overload, redistributing responsibility, renegotiating a debt, obtaining professional financial advice, or bringing another person into a decision. This is the argument developed at length in Parts Three and Nine.

Recognising It in Yourself

Five markers indicate that what a man is experiencing may be anxiety of clinical relevance rather than ordinary pressure. They are set out here as a screening aid, not a diagnosis; Appendix B provides a fuller structured tool, and no self-assessment can substitute for professional assessment.

1. **Persistence.** The state has been present for most days for more than six months, or it has intensified steadily.
2. **Physical signature.** There are regular physical symptoms — tension, headaches, gastric symptoms, palpitations, disturbed sleep — that clinical examination has not explained.
3. **Control behaviour.** There is an increasing need to control details, to be informed, to prevent surprises, or to check matters repeatedly.
4. **Interference.** Sleep, work performance, sexual function, appetite, or relationships are affected.
5. **Compensatory use.** Alcohol, sedatives, tobacco, food, gambling, or work itself is being used to regulate the state.

Figure 5.1 shows the arrangement in its simplest form: the visible surface of confidence and command, and the internal operation that maintains it. The two columns are not a contrast between truth and falsehood. The left-hand column is accurate, and the right-hand column is what it costs.

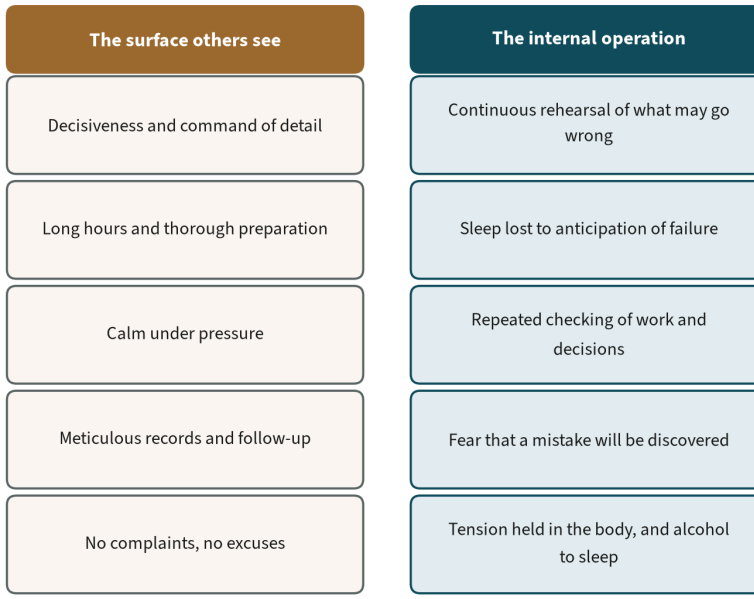


Figure 5.1 Confidence as others see it, and the internal work that sustains it. Anxiety in men frequently operates as the second column while presenting as the first.

5.3 Persistent Worry and Intrusive Thoughts

Anxiety is not only a feeling. It is a pattern of thinking, and the pattern has a structure that can be observed, described, and — in many cases — altered. This section deals with the two principal thinking patterns that men report: persistent worry, which is voluntary and repetitive, and intrusive thoughts, which are involuntary and frequently shocking.

Persistent Worry

Worry is thinking about a possible future difficulty. In its ordinary form it is useful: it identifies risks and prompts preparation. In its persistent form it has three distinguishing features that will be immediately recognisable to any man who has lain awake at three in the morning.

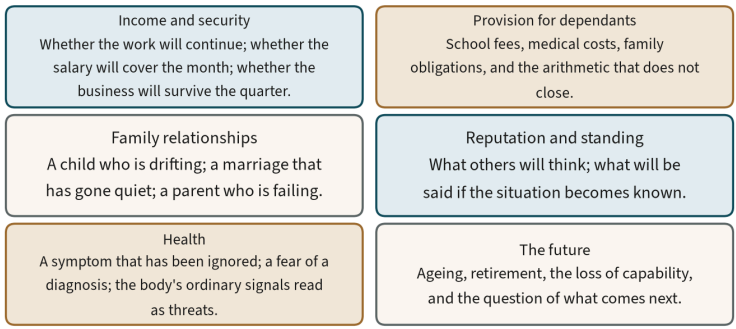
It is repetitive rather than progressive. Useful worry produces a conclusion — *I will speak to the supplier on Monday* — and then stops. Persistent worry circles. The same scenario is rehearsed with minor variations, forty times, without producing a decision or a plan. The man is aware of this and finds it humiliating; he also cannot stop, because stopping would require him to tolerate the uncertainty, and the uncertainty is the thing he cannot tolerate.

It addresses matters that are not presently resolvable. Persistent worry attaches to situations that are unresolved and cannot be resolved tonight: whether

the business will recover; whether a child will complete school; whether a marriage will survive; whether a diagnosis will be confirmed. Since the matter cannot be settled, the thinking does not end.

It substitutes for action, and it prevents action. This is the paradox at the centre of the pattern. The man believes that his worry is a form of engagement — that he is working on the problem. In practice, the worry consumes the attention that would be needed to act, and the absence of action increases the worry. The loop is closed and self-sustaining.

The domains of worry that men report are strikingly consistent across countries, ages, and occupations. Figure 5.2 presents them as they are ordinarily described.



The domains that consume the attention of men under sustained strain. Source: composite illustration prepared for this edition.

Figure 5.2 The recurring domains of male worry. The pattern is stable across age, occupation, and country in the accounts men give, with some variation in emphasis at different life stages.

Men who examine their own worry usually discover that one or two domains account for the majority of the attention consumed. Identifying the dominant domain is useful for two reasons: it suggests the intervention (a financial problem requires advice and a plan rather than relaxation techniques, while an unfounded fear requires a psychological approach), and it makes the pattern visible, which reduces the sense of being at the mercy of an unnameable process.

Intrusive Thoughts

Intrusive thoughts are unwanted mental events that arrive without invitation and are frequently experienced as alien, disturbing, and shameful. They occur in the vast majority of people; what varies is how much distress they cause and how much significance the person attaches to them.

Two features of intrusive thoughts in men deserve attention.

The content is frequently violent, sexual, blasphemous, or catastrophic, and it does not reflect the man's character or intentions. This is the most important point in the section, and it is the point about which men suffer most unnecessarily. A father who experiences a momentary image of harm coming to his child, a man who experiences an obscene thought during a solemn occasion, a man who imagines an accident while driving: these thoughts are not evidence of hidden wickedness. They are the ordinary output of a mind that generates material continuously, most of which is discarded. What makes them stick is the meaning assigned to them — *What kind of man thinks this?* — and once that meaning is assigned, the thought becomes an event that requires checking, and checking produces more of the same thought. Chapter 22 develops this mechanism, which is the engine of several common anxiety presentations.

The secrecy is often more damaging than the thought. Men rarely report intrusive thoughts, because the content feels shameful. The result is that a man may spend years concealing from everyone — including, in some cases, a physician — a symptom that is ordinary, well recognised, and treatable. A single sentence to a competent professional — *I have thoughts that come into my head that frighten me* — is usually enough to begin the process, and in the majority of cases the professional response is reassuring in the literal sense: the phenomenon is described, explained, and addressed with methods that work.

The Two Practical Consequences

Two practical consequences follow from the material in this section.

First, **worry and intrusive thoughts are not character defects, and they are not a form of weakness**. They are the products of well-understood mental processes, and they are addressed with well-established methods, including cognitive behavioural approaches that have been tested extensively with exactly these problems.

Second, **the correct first step is not to attempt to stop the thoughts by force.** Attempts at suppression are, as Chapter 3 established, unreliable, and for intrusive thoughts they frequently make matters worse by increasing the significance of the thought. The effective approaches — including acceptance-based and cognitive methods — involve changing the relationship to the thought rather than commanding its absence. Chapter 8 and Appendix H provide the practical techniques; the purpose of this present chapter is to establish that the pattern is recognised, common, and treatable, and that the man experiencing it is not what his thoughts imply.

KEY POINT
Worry is a mental activity that pretends to be work. Intrusive thoughts are mental events that pretend to be character evidence. Neither claim survives examination, and both respond to treatment.

5.4 Shame, Guilt, and Unresolved Memories

The deepest of the internal battles is not anxiety about the future. It is the presence of the past: shame, guilt, and memories that have never been resolved. This section deals with them, and the distinction between the first two is the most useful single piece of information in the chapter.

Guilt and Shame: A Distinction That Matters

Guilt concerns an action: *I did something wrong.* **Shame** concerns the self: *I am something wrong.*

Table 5.3 Guilt and shame distinguished. The distinction is one of the most practically useful in the whole of psychology for men who carry a sense of moral failure.

Dimension	Guilt	Shame
Object	A specific act	The whole self
Typical inner statement	"I did a bad thing"	"I am defective"
Effect on behaviour	Often prompts repair, apology, restitution	Prompts concealment, withdrawal, and sometimes aggression
Effect on relationships	Usually increases honesty when addressed	Usually destroys honesty and intimacy
Physical experience	Restlessness, difficulty resting until repaired	Heat, sinking, a desire to disappear
Response that helps	Acknowledgment, amendment, and where possible restitution	Acceptance, compassion, and a corrected self-evaluation

The practical significance is easy to state. Guilt, addressed, produces amendment and often repair. Shame produces concealment, because the object of shame is the self, and the self cannot be amended by an apology. A man who is ashamed does not want to speak; he wants to disappear. This is why shame is the emotion most powerfully implicated in the male pattern of silence: it does not merely discourage disclosure, it makes disclosure feel dangerous to identity.

A further practical point concerns the connection between shame and anger. Because shame is intolerable, it is frequently converted into anger. The man who has been publicly corrected, humiliated, or exposed does not typically feel sad; he feels furious, and the fury is a defence against the shame. This mechanism accounts for a substantial proportion of the incidents in which men respond with

disproportionate hostility to relatively minor exposures — an error pointed out in a meeting, a correction from a wife in front of visitors, a joke at their expense.

What Shame Is Usually About

It is worth recording the subjects that men carry with the greatest shame, because nearly all of them are things that other men carry too, and their disclosure to another person is almost always accompanied by the sentence *I thought I was the only one*.

- Failure to provide, especially the failure to provide for children.
- Sexual matters: inadequacy, infidelity, shame about desire, or shame about the absence of desire.
- Failure of a business, a career, or an ambition that was publicly announced.
- Treatment of a wife or children, particularly incidents of harshness, neglect, or violence.
- Conduct in youth: criminality, betrayal, cruelty, abandonment.
- Harm done to a parent, or the failure to have made peace before a death.
- Money: debt, fraud, concealment, or the loss of family property.
- Being the victim of something: abuse in childhood, exploitation, humiliation by a superior.
- A period of collapse — a hospitalisation, a drinking problem, a lost job — that was hidden from family and community.

The last two items deserve emphasis, because they represent a distinct class of shame that men almost never disclose: shame about having been harmed, and shame about having been ill. Both involve the belief that one's own weakness caused the event or that the fact of being affected is itself a defect. Both are common. Both are made considerably worse by silence.

The Shame Cycle

Because shame is the least understood of the states described in this chapter, and because it is the one most responsible for men's isolation, its operation is set out in Figure 5.3. The cycle is complete and self-confirming, and every stage of it is experienced from inside as realistic rather than as a distortion.

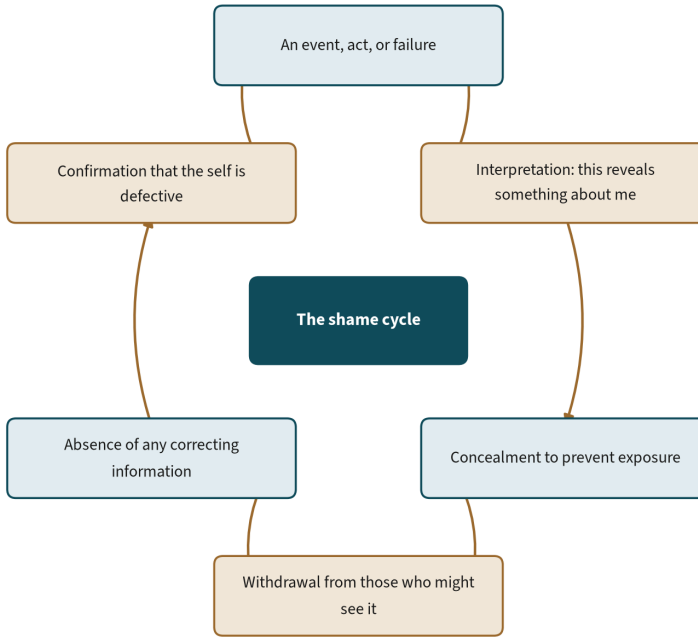


Figure 5.3 How shame maintains itself. The original event may be small; the cycle is driven by the interpretation, and it terminates only when the interpretation is examined or when the material is disclosed to somebody who does not withdraw.

Unresolved Memories

The third element of this section concerns material that men carry from the past. The clinical literature on trauma and memory is large, and it is treated properly in Chapter 36; what is needed here is a practical description of how unresolved memories behave in the lives of men who have never told anyone about them.

They persist. Unresolved memories are not, in general, forgotten. They are stored in a form that produces a periodic return: a dream, a sudden recollection triggered by a sound or smell, a physical reaction in a similar situation, or a recurring thought at specific times of day.

They acquire associations. Men report avoiding specific roads, songs, rooms, relatives, or subjects, frequently without having connected the avoidance to the memory that produced it.

They accumulate. Later experiences tend to become attached to earlier ones, so that the emotional reaction to a present event carries the charge of several past events at once. This explains a phenomenon that men find bewildering: an

overreaction to a trivial present incident that is in fact a response to a much older matter.

They do not resolve by decision. A man cannot decide to be finished with a memory. He can, however, complete certain work around it: naming what happened, recognising the meaning he attached to it, understanding the context, and, in some cases, obtaining professional help. This is the work of Chapters 29 and 36, and Appendix H provides structured methods.

They are frequently associated with shame rather than guilt. The memory of an act can be repaired by amendment, where amendment is possible. The memory of having been harmed, or of having been in a state of weakness, generally requires a correction of the meaning rather than the act — a change from *this proves something permanent about me* to *this happened to me, and it was not my fault, and it does not define my worth*. Making that correction is the central task of the healing chapters of this book.

5.5 Recognising When Distress Requires Professional Support

One of the most frequent questions men ask, when they begin to take the subject of their own psychological state seriously, is a version of the following: *How do I know whether this is ordinary difficulty or something I need help with?*

The question is a good one, and it deserves a direct answer. The answer has four parts: what distinguishes ordinary distress from a condition that requires assessment; what the warning signs of serious risk are, which are different and more urgent; what an assessment involves; and what the man should do about it in practice.

Ordinary Distress and Clinical Conditions

Ordinary distress is a normal response to circumstances. It is proportionate to an event, it fluctuates, it responds to changes in the situation and to ordinary support, and it resolves over weeks or months. A man who is grieving a father, struggling through a business downturn, or adjusting to a separation is not ill. He is a person in difficult circumstances, and the first line of response is time, support, practical assistance, and reasonable self-care.

A clinical condition is different in four respects, and the differences are the practical criteria for seeking assessment.

Table 5.4 Practical criteria for seeking professional assessment. The presence of one criterion warrants attention; the presence of two or more warrants prompt consultation.

Criterion	What to look for
Duration	Symptoms present on most days for more than two to four weeks without improvement, or persisting for months.

Criterion	What to look for
Intensity	The state is disproportionate to circumstances, or it dominates the man's attention, or it is accompanied by physical symptoms that have no medical explanation.
Impairment	Sleep, appetite, work, sexual function, or relationships are significantly affected. Ordinary functioning requires unusual effort.
Compensatory behaviour	Alcohol, drugs, gambling, or other behaviour is being used to manage the state; or the man is withdrawing from all social contact.

To these should be added three conditions that always warrant consultation, regardless of duration:

- **Any thought of suicide, self-harm, or harming another person.** This requires immediate professional attention, and Chapter 34 and Appendix Q deal with it. It is not a matter for waiting.
- **Symptoms of possible medical origin.** Chest pain, significant weight loss, unusual neurological symptoms, and similar presentations require physical assessment first, since psychological and physical conditions can produce similar signs and both require attention.
- **Crisis in the household.** A situation involving a risk to a child, a risk of violence, or an acute family crisis requires immediate specialist involvement.

The Warning Signs of Serious Risk

The following signs indicate that a man's situation has moved from distress to danger, and they should never be treated as waiting matters. They are described fully in Chapter 34; they are listed here in brief because they must not be left to the end of the book.

- Talking or writing about death, dying, or not being there any more.
- Withdrawal from everyone, coupled with the settling of affairs: giving away possessions, making unusual arrangements, paying off debts in an out-of-character manner.
- A sudden calm after a long period of despair, which may indicate a decision has been made.
- Increased use of alcohol or drugs in a man with other warning signs.
- Statements of being a burden, of having no reason to continue, or of being unable to go on.
- Any preparation: acquiring means, writing a note, visiting a specific location.

In such circumstances the reader — whether the man concerned or somebody who cares about him — should make contact with professional or emergency

services immediately, and should not attempt to manage the situation alone. Appendix Q lists the routes of contact in Nigeria, in other African countries, and internationally, and gives practical guidance on what to say when making that contact. Chapter 34 sets out how to construct a personal crisis plan while a person is well enough to do so.

What an Assessment Involves

Men delay seeking assessment partly because they do not know what it consists of, and fear the unknown. In practice, a first consultation with a competent professional is a structured conversation of forty to ninety minutes with four components.

The account. The clinician asks what has been happening, how long it has been going on, and what has made it worse or better. This is where the reader's own preparation — the exercise at the end of this chapter — is useful.

The history. Questions about health, family, work, relationships, alcohol and substance use, sleep, and previous episodes, together with an inquiry into any history of trauma or loss.

The assessment of risk. A direct question about thoughts of self-harm or suicide. It is worth stating plainly why this question is asked and is not an accusation: men in severe distress frequently do not volunteer these thoughts, and asking about them is the standard and responsible way to identify a serious risk. Being asked does not mean the clinician has concluded that the man is suicidal. It means the clinician is competent.

The formulation and plan. An explanation of what the clinician thinks is happening — which may be a diagnosis, or may simply be a description of a difficult situation — and a plan. The plan should specify what the treatment will consist of, how long it is likely to take, what the man should expect, what to do if matters worsen, and when there will be a review.

The reader is entitled to ask questions at any point in this process, and should. Three questions improve the quality of the interaction substantially: *What do you think is happening to me? What are the options, and what is the evidence for them? What should I look for as a sign that matters are getting worse?*

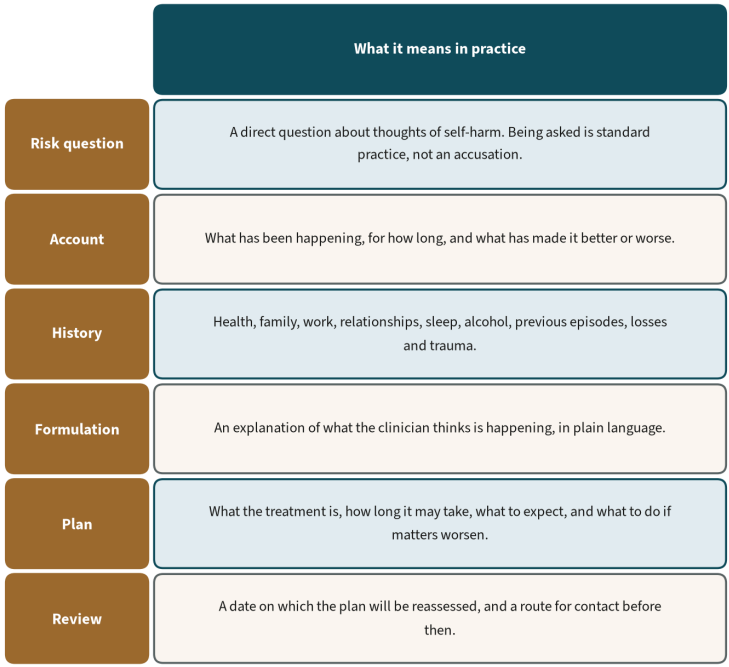


Figure 5.4 What a competent assessment contains. A man is entitled to each of these parts, and he may ask for the formulation and the plan in plain language.

The Pathways Available

Men frequently assume that professional help means an expensive private psychiatrist and nothing else. The range of options is much wider, and Appendix Q sets out the practical detail for Nigerian and other African settings as well as international routes. In outline:

- **General practitioners and family physicians** — the most common entry point, capable of assessing, treating, and referring, and often the least intimidating first contact.
- **Counsellors and psychologists** — talking treatments for identifiable difficulties, including counselling offered by churches, mosques, schools, universities, employers, and non-governmental organisations.
- **Psychiatrists and clinical psychologists** — specialist assessment and treatment, particularly where medication or diagnostic complexity is involved.
- **Hospital and clinic psychiatric services**, including those attached to teaching hospitals, and services for specific problems such as substance use.
- **Telephone, text, and online services**, including helplines (see Appendix Q for numbers current at the time of publication) and online counselling

platforms, which have widened access considerably for men in remote areas, in occupations with no flexibility, and for those who value anonymity.

- **Peer and community support** — including mutual-help groups and men's groups, which are not a substitute for treatment in severe conditions but are effective for many men, and considerably better than nothing.

The last point deserves emphasis. There is a strong and consistent finding in the research literature that people who receive *some* appropriate support early do better than those who receive none, and that the most common reason for receiving none is a decision to wait. The reader who is unsure whether his situation warrants attention should err in the direction of making contact.

5.6 Finding Language for Invisible Pain

The chapter closes with a practical matter that determines whether any of the preceding material produces a result. A man cannot obtain help for a difficulty he cannot describe, and the descriptions that professionals work with are of a particular kind: they are **specific**, **temporal**, and **functional**. That is, a professional needs to know what happens, when it started, how often it occurs, and what it prevents the man from doing.

The difficulty is that men arrive with a different kind of description — the description of a situation rather than a state. *Work has been difficult since March. My brother-in-law died in April. My son is not serious about his studies.* All of these are accurate and none of them is the information the clinician requires, which is something more like: *Since February I have woken at three most mornings. I am irritable with my children in a way I was not before. I have lost interest in the things I used to enjoy, and I drink four or five bottles of beer most evenings to get to sleep.*

The exercise at the end of this chapter is designed to produce exactly that latter description, in writing, before the appointment. Men who arrive with such a document consistently describe the consultation as shorter, more useful, and less humiliating than they had feared.

Three Principles for Describing Distress

Three principles make the task easier.

Describe behaviour and body rather than feelings. *I cannot sleep. I have stopped playing football. I check the doors twice. I have had a permanent tightness in my chest since March.* These are easy to report, hard to dispute, and clinically informative.

Attach everything to a date. *Since March. For two years. Every night for a month. Three times this week.* Time is what distinguishes a passing difficulty from a condition, and most men can supply it accurately.

Report consequences rather than causes. *I have missed three days of work. My wife has stopped telling me things. I no longer enjoy my children's company.*

Consequences are observable, and they permit the clinician to gauge severity without requiring the man to explain his emotions.

The Written Account

The exercise below produces a written account of the kind described. Its purpose is not to produce a self-diagnosis; readers are explicitly warned against diagnosing themselves from a book. Its purpose is to convert an unnameable state into a document — and a document can be carried into a consulting room, handed over, and used as the basis of a conversation that begins with information rather than with a struggle for words.

5.7 Illustrative Case: The Executive Who Kept a Notebook

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns commonly reported in clinical and occupational health settings.

Anthony is thirty-nine, a finance manager in a manufacturing company, married, with two children under ten. He is regarded as the most reliable person in his department. He arrives early, leaves late, keeps a meticulous record of every transaction and conversation, and has never missed a deadline.

Six years ago, Anthony made an error that cost his employer a modest sum — approximately the cost of a month of his own salary — in a tax filing. He discovered it himself, reported it immediately, and the matter was corrected without comment. His supervisor at the time told him not to worry about it.

Anthony has not stopped worrying about it for six years.

The concern did not remain attached to the original event. Instead, it migrated. He began to check his work repeatedly, then to check other people's work, then to keep a personal record of every decision he made, in a notebook kept in his bag, so that he could demonstrate, if required, that he had acted correctly. Over three years the notebook became a daily practice. By the fifth year he was photographing documents on his telephone so that a record would exist outside the company's systems.

In parallel, three other things developed. He began to sleep poorly, waking at about four o'clock with a distinct sensation that something had been overlooked. He became irritated by interruptions, particularly by colleagues asking him questions in front of others. And he developed a set of physical symptoms — a band of tension across the upper back and shoulders, occasional stomach pain, and a persistent dry mouth — for which two physicians found no cause and for which he was eventually prescribed muscle relaxants.

He never told anyone about the notebook. His wife knew that he worked long hours; his supervisor considered him exceptionally thorough. He did not consider himself an anxious man, and when a physician asked him, during a routine consultation, whether he was under stress, he answered that work was busy but that he was managing. He was telling the truth as he understood it.

> The change came about through a conversation with a colleague who had himself been treated for an anxiety disorder and who, having noticed the notebook, asked a direct question. The question was not *Are you all right?* It was: *Anthony, why do you keep that book?* He answered, for the first time, that if he did not, something would go wrong again. Eight months later, after treatment consisting of cognitive behavioural therapy and a short course of medication, he described the situation in a sentence that is worth quoting because it captures the whole chapter: *The mistake cost the company a month's salary. The fear of it has cost me six years of my life, and until the day I explained it to somebody, I did not know that was the bill.*

The case contains five features that are typical, and each corresponds to a section of this chapter.

The distress was invisible and had no obvious cause. The precipitating event was minor, resolved, and known to two people, one of whom had forgotten it.

The presentation was behavioural and physical rather than emotional. Checking, recording, tension, and insomnia. At no point did Anthony describe himself as anxious, and he answered the standard screening question negatively.

Compensatory behaviour preserved the appearance of excellence. The notebook, which was a symptom, was read by his employer as a virtue. This is one of the mechanisms by which anxiety in capable men survives undetected: the symptoms are frequently indistinguishable from, or even identical to, exceptional conscientiousness.

The cost was measured in years, not in events. The original incident cost a month's salary; the anxiety cost six years of Anthony's attention, and it also cost his sleep, his comfort with colleagues, and a substantial amount of his family life.

The door was opened by a direct question from a peer. Not by a physician's screening question, which was answered automatically, but by a specific question about a specific behaviour, asked by somebody who had been in a similar position. This is consistent with the evidence on male help-seeking and is why Chapters 26 and 27, and Appendix J, treat the presence of at least one informed peer as a public-health matter rather than a matter of preference.

5.8 Practical Exercise: Writing the Account You Cannot Say

This exercise produces a short written account of your current internal state, of the kind a physician, counsellor, or psychologist can work with. Complete it in a single sitting if possible, and write rather than type if you can, because handwriting slows the process enough to allow accuracy.

Part One: The Timeline

Draw a horizontal line and mark the last three years. On the line, write every event that changed your state of mind, with its month where you can remember it: a loss, a job change, a financial event, an illness, a conflict, a disappointment, a diagnosis, a death, a move, a separation. Add anything from earlier that still produces a reaction when you think about it, with an approximate year.

The purpose of this part is to answer the clinician's first question — *When did this begin?* — which men frequently cannot answer, and which is often supplied by the timeline within ten minutes.

Part Two: The Symptoms

Complete the following table as honestly as you can. Where the answer is *no*, write no. Where the answer is *yes*, add how long it has been happening.

Symptom	Yes/No	For how long	How many days per week
Difficulty falling asleep			
Waking early and not returning to sleep			
Tension, headaches, or chest tightness			
Irritability out of character for me			
Loss of interest in things I used to enjoy			
Difficulty concentrating, or forgetting things			
Appetite change, weight change			
Drinking more than I used to			
Feeling flat, empty, or numb			
Avoiding people, places, or conversations			
Checking things repeatedly			
Thoughts that come into my head and frighten me			

Part Three: The Consequences

Write, in no more than six lines, what this has cost you in the last twelve months. Use specific, observable statements rather than general ones: days missed from work, arguments that recur, an invitation declined, a task not completed, a relationship that has changed, a decision postponed, a trip not taken, a period not remembered.

Part Four: The One Sentence

Draft a single sentence, of no more than twenty-five words, that summarises your situation for a reader who does not know you. It should describe what is happening rather than why. Two examples of the form:

> *Since my father died in March I have not been able to sleep properly, and I have become irritable with my children in a way that is not like me.*

> *For about two years I have had a persistent sense that everything I have built could collapse, and I now check things repeatedly and cannot rest.*

Part Five: The Next Contact

Identify, from the list in Section 5.5, the single most accessible route for you: a general physician, a hospital clinic, a counsellor, an employer scheme, a telephone line, or an online service. Write down the day and time you will make contact, and what you will say in the first thirty seconds. A serviceable script is:

> *I would like to make an appointment to talk about something that has been affecting me. I have not been sleeping well and I have not been myself for some months. I am not sure what the problem is, and I would like to have it looked at.*

Keep the written account with you when you make the contact. If the words will not come, the document can be handed over instead, and this is a perfectly acceptable method that practitioners see frequently.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 5 in brief. Internal struggles are concealed by four mechanisms that operate together: competence, which supplies continuous evidence that a man is managing; the absence of vocabulary, which prevents him from reporting what he experiences; the masculine presentation of symptoms, which converts anxiety into tension, irritability, control behaviour, and drinking rather than into named fear; and shame, which makes the existence of the struggle itself feel like evidence of inadequacy.

Internal conflicts fall into eight recognisable families — between self and expectation, actions and values, desire and duty, worth and truth, the present and an unresolved past, the present and an anticipated collapse, identity and role, and need and capacity. What distinguishes ordinary conflict from a condition requiring assessment is intensity, duration, and impairment, not the presence of the conflict itself.

Anxiety in men frequently does not present as the standard picture. It presents as control-seeking, overwork, irritability, physical tension, and disturbed sleep, with the underlying subject being the loss of income, the failure of a business, or the exposure of a fault rather than the anticipated judgement of others. The result is that men delay identification and treatment, and that symptoms are attributed to work, age, or family, none of which can be addressed to good effect.

Persistent worry is distinguishable from ordinary concern by three features: it circles rather than concludes, it attaches to matters that cannot be resolved in the present, and it displaces the action that would address them. Intrusive thoughts are unwanted mental events that occur in almost everyone; the content does not indicate character, the secrecy causes more harm than the thoughts, and the phenomenon responds well to treatment, particularly cognitive behavioural approaches.

Shame and guilt must be distinguished. Guilt concerns an act and responds to acknowledgment, amendment, and restitution. Shame concerns the self and produces concealment, because a self cannot be amended by an apology. Shame converts readily into anger, which is why disproportionate hostility frequently follows exposure. The material men carry with most shame — failure to provide, sexual matters, business failure, harshness towards family, conduct in youth, harm done to a parent, debt, having been harmed, and having been ill — is material that other men carry too, and its disclosure is almost always accompanied by the discovery that one is not alone.

Unresolved memories persist, acquire associations, accumulate, and do not resolve by decision. They require a correction of meaning rather than an act of will, and in some cases professional support.

Professional assessment is warranted by duration, intensity, impairment, and compensatory behaviour, and immediately in the presence of any suicidal or self-harm thinking, symptoms of possible medical origin, or a household crisis. An assessment has four components — account, history, risk, and formulation with a plan — and the reader is entitled to ask what is happening, what the options are, and what would indicate deterioration. The available routes extend well beyond private psychiatry, and include physicians, counsellors, hospital services, telephone and online support, and peer groups.

Invisible pain becomes treatable when it becomes describable. Descriptions that work are specific, temporal, and functional: what happens, since when, how often, and what it prevents. A written account prepared in advance converts a humiliating struggle for words into a conversation that starts with information.

Reflection Questions

1. The four concealments in Section 5.1 are competence, vocabulary, symptom presentation, and shame. Which applies most strongly to you? If a physician asked you the standard screening question today, what would you actually answer, and how accurate would it be?

2. Of the eight families of internal conflict in Table 5.1, which two or three are present in your life? For each, write the sentence a man would say if he were to name it plainly.
3. Consider the anxiety markers in Section 5.2. Which of the five applies to you now, and for how long has it applied? If none applies, is there a man close to you to whom two or three clearly apply?
4. Section 5.3 distinguishes guilt from shame. Take one thing you carry and decide which of the two it is. If it is guilt, what would amendment or restitution require? If it is shame, what would a corrected evaluation sound like?
5. Intrusive thoughts are common, and their content does not indicate character. Has any thought frightened you sufficiently that you have told nobody? What would it take to mention it to a competent professional?
6. Section 5.6 lists three principles for describing distress — describe behaviour and body rather than feelings, attach everything to a date, and report consequences rather than causes. Compose three sentences about yourself using those principles.
7. What is your honest position on the criteria in Table 5.2: duration, intensity, impairment, and compensatory behaviour? If two or more apply, what is the date on which you will make contact, and with whom?

Further Reading

- **On anxiety in men:** the clinical literature on anxiety disorders, together with the growing body of work on how anxiety presents differently in men and on the reasons for under-recognition. The self-help literature based on cognitive behavioural therapy is well developed, evidence-based, and accessible; it works best as a supplement to, rather than a replacement for, professional assessment.
- **On worry and intrusive thoughts:** the research on rumination and on the significance attached to unwanted thoughts, including the well-established finding that the meaning a person assigns to a thought is more consequential than its frequency.
- **On shame:** the psychological literature on shame and guilt, including the distinction developed in this chapter and the research linking shame-proneness to concealment, hostility, and poor mental health outcomes. The work of researchers who have studied shame across cultures is particularly useful for readers in Africa, where the management of shame involves both individual and communal dimensions.
- **On assessment and treatment:** the World Health Organization's guidance on mental health, including its materials on depression and anxiety, which are available at no cost and are written for a general readership. National

health services also publish accessible guidance, and the mhGAP programme materials are widely used by non-specialist clinicians in low- and middle-income settings.

- **On men's health services:** the growing literature on how services can be designed so that men actually use them, including work on appointment systems, the wording of invitations, and the role of primary care.
- **Personal accounts:** published first-person accounts by men who have lived with anxiety, obsessive thoughts, or severe shame, which are frequently more instructive to a man in the early stages of recognition than any clinical description.

6 CHAPTER

Depression Behind a Smiling Face

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Explain what depression is, how it differs from ordinary sadness, and why it is frequently unrecognised in men.
2. Identify the characteristic male presentations — irritability, withdrawal, emotional numbness, physical complaint, and increased work or drinking — and assess his own experience against them.
3. Describe the consequences of untreated depression for health, family, work, and life expectancy, and explain why waiting is a decision with a cost.
4. Analyse the specific reasons men resist seeking help, and answer each of them with practical information rather than exhortation.
5. Describe the components of supportive relationships and of evidence-based treatment, and explain how the two work together.
6. Begin the structured work of recovery using the exercise at the end of this chapter and the plan in Appendix C.

Introduction

The most common sentence spoken by a man who is depressed, and the one least likely to be understood as a description of his condition, is: *I am tired.*

He is tired when he wakes. He is tired at eleven in the morning, when the work that used to interest him requires an effort he cannot explain. He is tired in the evening, and he does not sleep well. He attributes the tiredness to age, to the volume of work, to the state of the economy, or to a deficiency of iron, and he is frequently right about one of these things, which is why the explanation holds. What he does not say, because he has not identified it and would not know how to say it, is that he has also stopped looking forward to anything, that he feels nothing when his son shows him a school report, that he has become unreasonably angry about small matters, and that a private, unspoken flatness has settled over his life so gradually that he is no longer certain whether anything has changed at all.

Depression in men is common, serious, and — under the right conditions — treatable. It is also frequently missed, by the man himself, by his family, and, in a substantial number of cases, by the health professionals he sees. The purpose of this chapter is to describe what depression looks like when the person experiencing it is a man, to explain why it is missed, to set out what happens when it is left untreated, and to describe what helps.

6.1 Understanding Depression in Men

Depression is not sadness. Sadness is a normal emotional state, proportionate to circumstances, and it passes. Depression is a condition with a specific set of symptoms, a duration, and an effect on the capacity to function. Its recognised features include persistent low mood, loss of interest and pleasure, fatigue, disturbed sleep and appetite, difficulty concentrating, a sense of worthlessness or inappropriate guilt, and, in severe cases, thoughts of death or self-harm.

Three points about the condition are important before the male presentation is described.

It is a real condition, not a weakness or a failure of discipline. The evidence for this is found in the effectiveness of treatment, the consistency of symptoms across cultures and social classes, and the substantial body of research on the biological, psychological, and social factors that contribute to it. Men who believe that their condition is a personal deficiency frequently delay treatment by years, and the delay is often the most damaging element of the whole episode.

It varies in severity, and severity determines treatment. Mild depression may respond to structured psychological support, activity planning, and social re-engagement. Moderate and severe depression usually requires a specific treatment — talking therapy, medication, or both in combination — and severe depression with risk of self-harm requires urgent specialist care. A single approach will not fit every case, and the reader should be cautious of any claim that it will.

It is frequently accompanied by other conditions. Anxiety, alcohol or substance use, chronic pain, and physical illness commonly occur alongside depression, and each can conceal the other. A man who presents with heavy drinking may be drinking to manage a depression that is not diagnosed; a man who presents with depression may also need treatment for an anxiety disorder. A competent assessment looks for more than one condition, which is one reason that professional assessment is worth more than self-assessment.

The Scale of the Problem

Depression affects a very large number of people worldwide, and it is a leading cause of disability. Men constitute a substantial proportion of cases, and the recorded figures almost certainly understate the true number, because men are less likely to report symptoms, less likely to consult, and less likely to be diagnosed.

The most serious consequence of this under-recognition is a well-documented pattern: men die by suicide at substantially higher rates than women in almost every country for which reliable data exist, despite lower recorded rates of diagnosed depression. The most plausible explanation, supported by a large body of work, is not that men suffer less but that they present later and in less recognisable forms, and that their distress becomes lethal before it becomes visible.

This is the reason the chapter opens with a warning rather than a definition: the material below is not academic. It concerns a condition that kills men who consider themselves strong, and it kills them quietly, in the last stages of a process that was visible for years to anybody who knew how to look.

Why It Is Missed

Depression in men is missed for four reasons, and each of them operates in ordinary life rather than in exceptional circumstances.

The symptoms are attributed to character. Irritability is read as a bad temper. Withdrawal is read as pride or fatigue. Lateness, forgetfulness, and unfinished tasks are read as decline in commitment. Short-temperedness with children is read as harshness. Each of these attributions is available, plausible, and wrong.

Men present physical symptoms. A man who is depressed frequently reports headaches, back pain, digestive problems, or chronic tiredness, and a physical investigation follows. This is appropriate — physical causes must be excluded — but the emotional dimension is frequently not raised by the patient and not enquired into by the clinician.

Men answer screening questions in the negative. The standard questions concern sadness, crying, and hopelessness. A man who is angry, flat, and drinking more than before will answer those questions accurately and unhelpfully, and the condition will not be identified. This is why the following section sets out the male presentation in detail: it provides the reader with the questions that are more likely to be informative.

Men conceal the condition deliberately. A man who suspects the truth may spend considerable effort concealing it — presenting as busy, keeping up appearances, avoiding medical contact, and refusing to reduce his load. Concealment of depression is one of the most self-defeating activities a human being can undertake, because it removes the social support that protects against deterioration, and it is extremely common among men.

6.2 Irritability, Withdrawal, and Emotional Numbness

The three symptoms named in this section are, in practice, the three most common ways in which depression presents in men. Each deserves a careful description, because each is systematically misread.

Irritability

Irritability is the most frequently reported symptom in studies of depression in men, and it is the one most likely to be attributed to the man's personality rather than to his condition.

Its features are distinctive. The threshold for frustration falls sharply, so that minor events — a child's interruption, a misplaced item, a slow queue, a request repeated for the third time — produce a reaction disproportionate to the event. The reaction is frequently brief and intense, and it is followed, in many men, by a private sense of shame that is itself uncomfortable and that raises the likelihood of a further reaction. The irritability is rarely directed at a single person and is frequently worst at home, where the consequences are lowest, which produces a characteristic and distressing pattern: a man who is civil at work and harsh at home, and who cannot understand why.

The mechanisms by which depression produces irritability are well understood. Depleted energy reduces the capacity to regulate emotion; disturbed sleep reduces it further; and the experience of feeling flat and impaired produces frustration that has no legitimate outlet. In addition, as Chapter 3 explained, anger is frequently the only emotional channel available to a man, and therefore the one through which a large number of other states are expressed.

For the reader, two practical implications follow. The first is that irritability in a man who was previously even-tempered should be treated as a symptom and investigated, not as a moral failing. The second is that the same is true of a man's irritability that has persisted for years: chronic low tolerance is a common presentation of untreated depression, and it responds to treatment.

Withdrawal

Withdrawal in depression takes two forms, and their relation to work is the diagnostic clue.

In the first form, the man withdraws from everything, including work, and the withdrawal is visible. He is late, absent, or mentally elsewhere. He declines invitations and stops attending his associations and religious gatherings.

In the second form — considerably more common in men — the man withdraws from everything **except** work. He continues to attend, and he frequently increases his hours, because work is the one domain in which he retains a sense of competence and in which the structure of the day provides relief from unstructured time. He withdraws from friends, from family activities, from football, from the community association, from the church or mosque, and from his children, and he substitutes additional work for all of it. His family reads this as dedication. His employer reads it as commitment. It is neither.

The withdrawal is self-reinforcing, and Figure 6.1 sets out the cycle. Depression produces withdrawal; withdrawal removes the activity, contact, light, exercise, and purpose that sustain mood; the loss of these things deepens the depression; and a deeper depression produces more withdrawal.

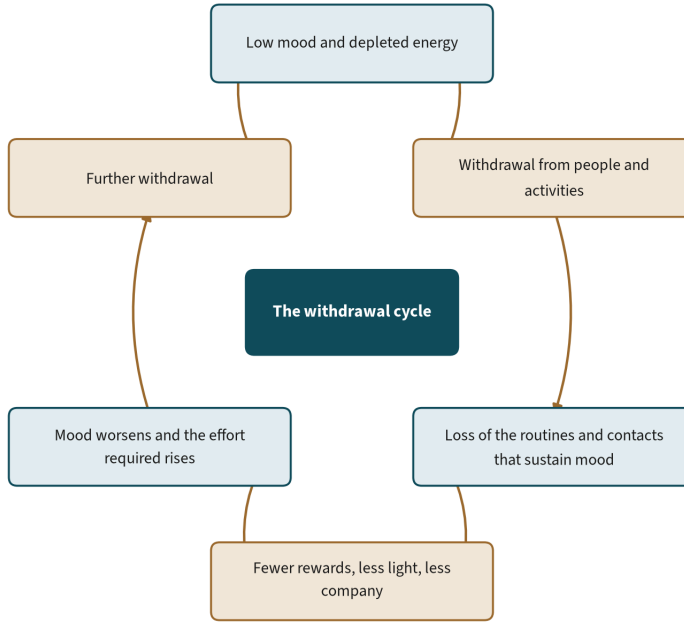


Figure 6.1 The withdrawal cycle. The mechanism is the leading reason that depression is treated partly by restoring activity and contact rather than only by talking about feelings.

Emotional Numbness

The third presentation, and the one that men find most disturbing when they recognise it, is emotional flatness. Its features are specific.

The man does not feel sad, or he feels sad only occasionally and briefly. What he feels is nothing. Music that used to move him does not. His children's achievements produce no reaction that he can identify, and this is frequently the point at which he concludes that something is wrong, because he remembers what it used to feel like. He can identify events that ought to produce feeling and observes his own absence from them. Sexual interest declines. He may cry rarely or not at all, and he may find that he is unable to cry on occasions when he wants to.

Men describe this state with difficulty, and the descriptions they produce are valuable because they are so consistent: *I am behind glass. I am watching my life*

from a distance. Everything is in grey. Nothing matters, but not in a distressing way; it simply does not matter.

Two clinical points about numbness deserve emphasis. First, it is a recognised symptom of depression, not a personality change and not a sign of coldness. Second, it is frequently accompanied by the absence of the emotional signals that would otherwise prompt help-seeking, which means that men in this state are less likely to seek help than men who are visibly distressed. The condition removes both the feeling and the motive to address the loss of feeling.

The Other Features

Beyond the three principal presentations, the following are frequently present in men and are worth recording.

Table 6.1 Additional features frequently present in male depression. Any three, persisting for more than two weeks, warrant professional assessment.

Feature	Description
Sleep disturbance	Most commonly waking in the early hours with dread; sometimes difficulty falling asleep; occasionally sleeping excessively.
Physical complaints	Fatigue, headache, back pain, digestive disturbance, and a general sense of illness that no investigation explains.
Increased alcohol or substance use	Used to sleep, to settle, to face the day, or to feel something other than flatness.
Risk-taking	Driving faster, gambling, new debts, sexual risk, or unusual business decisions.
Changed relationships with work	Either overwork, as described above, or a loss of the capacity to concentrate and a resulting sense of incompetence.
Reduced self-care	Loss of interest in appearance, which is frequently the first change seen by family.
Hopeless statements	Not necessarily dramatic: “What is the point?”, “It does not matter any more”, “I am finished.”

Figure 6.1 sets out the contrast between the standard description of depression and its frequent presentation in men. The reader is encouraged to read the right-hand column not as an alternative diagnosis but as a translation: the condition is the same, and the language in which it is experienced is different.

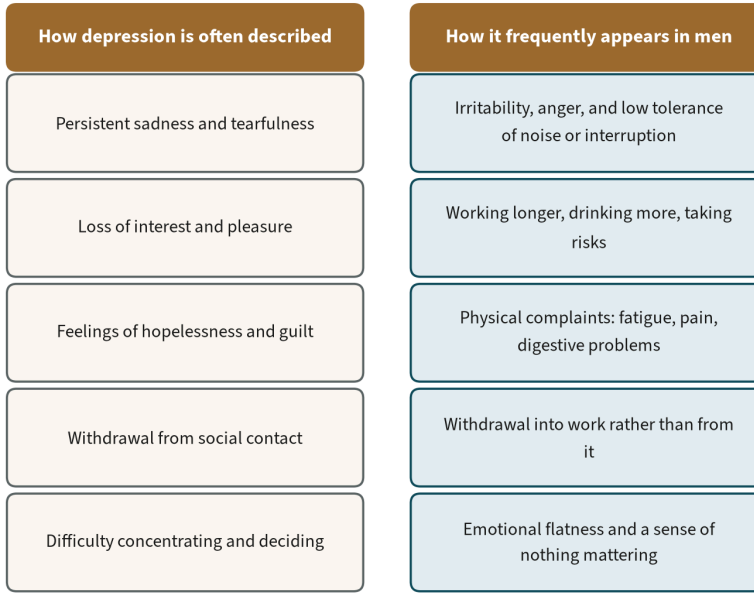


Figure 6.2 Depression as it is commonly described, and as it frequently presents in men. The condition is identical; the language, emphasis, and visible behaviour differ, which is why so many cases are not identified.

KEY POINT

A man who is angry, flat, exhausted, drinking more, working longer hours, and unable to enjoy anything is not describing a character defect. The description is a textbook presentation of depression in men, and it is treatable.

6.3 The Dangers of Untreated Depression

The consequences of untreated depression are serious and, in a substantial number of cases, irreversible. The reader who is inclined to wait — for a better time, for the pressure to lift, for the symptoms to resolve — should read this section carefully, because waiting is not a neutral strategy. It has a documented cost.

Death

The most serious consequence is death from suicide. Depression is the condition most strongly associated with suicide, and male suicide rates exceed female rates in almost every country with reliable data. The pattern is particularly stark in men of working age, in men who have experienced separation or divorce, in men who have lost employment, and in men who are socially isolated. Chapter 34 addresses suicidal thinking directly, including what to do, and Appendix Q lists sources of immediate support. The essential point here is that untreated severe depression

can end in death, that the risk is higher in men, and that this is the principal reason the chapter insists on professional assessment rather than self-management for anyone whose symptoms are significant.

Deterioration of the Condition

Depression tends to worsen without treatment, and it also tends to recur. Each episode increases the probability of a further episode, and episodes that are treated early and properly are associated with better long-term outcomes. The practical version of this finding is simple: treatment today is easier than treatment in a year.

Physical Health

Untreated depression is associated with poorer outcomes across a wide range of physical conditions, including cardiovascular disease and diabetes, partly through direct physiological mechanisms and partly through its effects on behaviour: reduced exercise, poor diet, disordered sleep, increased alcohol use, and non-adherence to treatment for other conditions. Men frequently present the physical consequences rather than the depressive condition, and both require attention.

Family Consequences

Depression in a man affects his household. Partners report loneliness, exhaustion, and a sense of living with somebody who is present but unavailable. Children of a depressed father show, on average, higher rates of emotional and behavioural difficulties, and the mechanism is well documented: reduced engagement, increased irritability, inconsistent discipline, and impaired communication. These effects are not a reason for guilt in the man concerned — they are a reason to treat the condition, and they improve substantially when the depression is treated.

Occupational and Financial Consequences

Loss of function at work is common before the condition is severe: reduced concentration, missed deadlines, errors, and declining relationships with colleagues. Men frequently respond by working longer hours, which temporarily disguises the loss and permanently increases the risk. In a substantial number of cases, the depression ends a career through resignation, dismissal, or the collapse of a business, none of which need have happened had the condition been treated a year earlier.

Alcohol and Substance Dependence

Self-medication is common, and it is dangerous in two directions. Alcohol deepens depression in the medium term while appearing to relieve it in the short term; and dependence developed during an episode does not resolve when the episode resolves. A man who drinks heavily to manage low mood is at risk of acquiring two conditions where he began with one. Appendix M deals with substance use, and Chapter 23 examines it in detail.

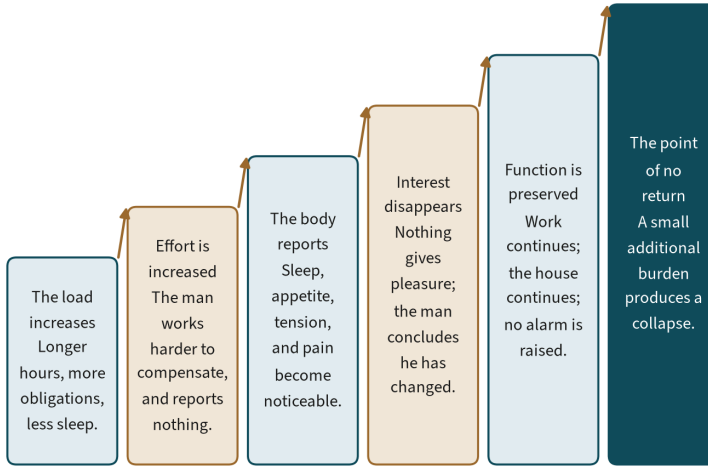


Figure 6.3 The typical descent. The critical feature is the fifth stage: the man continues to function in every visible domain while the condition deepens, and the collapse is therefore attributed to the final small event rather than to the load that preceded it.

6.4 Why Some Men Resist Seeking Help

Men delay seeking treatment for depression for reasons that are specific, researchable, and largely rational within the terms of the calculation they are making. It is of no use to tell a man that he is being irrational. It is useful to answer each objection with information, and that is what this section does.

The Eight Objections, and Their Answers

1. "It is not that serious. I am still functioning."

Functioning is not a measure of severity. Men with moderately severe depression frequently continue to work, provide, and manage, at a cost that is invisible and that is paid in sleep, health, relationships, and years. A better test is the one given in Section 6.2: how many of the features are present, and for how long?

2. "It will pass on its own."

Mild episodes frequently do resolve, and this is why the advice to wait is not always wrong. But episodes lasting more than a few weeks, or accompanied by several symptoms, or with a history of previous episodes, generally do not resolve without treatment. The practical rule: if it has lasted more than two to four weeks and is affecting sleep, work, or relationships, have it assessed.

3. "I do not want to be a person who is on medication."

Not every case requires medication. Psychological treatments are effective, and for mild and moderate cases they are frequently the first choice. Where medication

is appropriate, it is generally prescribed for a defined period, its effects and side effects are monitored, and it is tapered under supervision. Many men who hold this objection accept either a talking treatment or a medication trial once the process is explained.

4. "If it is on my record, it will affect my work."

Confidentiality is a professional obligation in all health settings, and occupational health records in most jurisdictions are treated separately from personnel records. The practical risks of an untreated depression — reduced performance, errors, absence, resignation, or dismissal — are considerably larger than the risks of confidential treatment. Where a man has genuine reason for concern about records, he is entitled to ask about confidentiality explicitly before speaking.

5. "Talking about it will make it worse."

Disclosing to somebody who responds badly can be discouraging. Disclosing to a trained professional is a different experience, and the concern misunderstands what a consultation consists of. In practice, most men describe the first consultation as a relief, and the most common post-assessment feeling, in the author's experience, is not exposure but surprise at how ordinary the conversation was.

6. "I have nothing to be depressed about."

Depression is not a verdict on circumstances. It occurs in men with difficult lives and in men with comfortable ones, and the presence or absence of reasons does not determine the presence of the condition. This objection is often the same as the shame described in Chapter 5, expressed as an argument.

7. "It is a spiritual matter, and I will deal with it in that way."

Some men will resolve the matter through their religious practice, community, and personal discipline, and some of them will do so successfully. Without entering into questions of belief, the practical point is that a man may address both dimensions at once: religious practice, community support, and professional treatment are not mutually exclusive, and the most common tragedy in this area is the man who pursues one route exclusively for three years while the condition worsens. If prayers, counsel, and community support have not helped in two months, add professional assessment.

8. "I do not know what to say or who to see."

This is an information problem rather than a motivation problem, and it is easily solved. Section 5.5 of the previous chapter lists the routes; Chapter 35 describes how to make the approach; Appendix Q lists services current at the time of publication; and the exercise at the end of this chapter produces the written account that can be handed to a clinician.

The Fourth Objection in Practice: A Note on Confidentiality

Because the fourth objection — the fear of consequences for work, family, or reputation — is the one that men mention most often in private conversation, a second comment is warranted.

Health professionals are bound by confidentiality rules in every jurisdiction surveyed for this book, subject to narrow exceptions that generally concern immediate danger to life. Beyond the legal rules, the practical experience of most men is that the confidentiality of a consultation is respected in practice, and that the people most likely to learn of a man's treatment are those he chooses to tell. The exception, and it is a genuine one, is small communities and families in which discretion cannot be relied upon. In such circumstances, men frequently prefer services outside the immediate area, telephone or online services, or a general physician with no social connection to the household. These options are consistently underused, and there is no reason not to use them.

6.5 Supportive Relationships and Evidence-Based Treatment

Two things help a man with depression, and the best outcomes come from both together: treatment, and support. This section sets out what each consists of.

What Treatment Involves

The treatments with the strongest evidence base for depression are set out in Figure 6.4. In outline:

Talking treatments. Cognitive behavioural therapy, interpersonal therapy, behavioural activation, and related approaches have substantial evidence for depression, particularly mild and moderate cases. The typical course ranges from six to twenty sessions, and the treatment involves specific work rather than general conversation: identifying patterns of thought and behaviour that maintain low mood, planning activity, addressing difficulties in relationships, and practising skills between sessions.

Medication. Antidepressant medication is effective for moderate and severe depression and is generally recommended in combination with talking treatment. Men frequently have inaccurate beliefs about how it works, how quickly it takes effect (typically several weeks), and how long it is continued (usually months after improvement, to prevent relapse, and then tapered). These questions should be asked of the prescriber, and a man who receives a prescription without an explanation of the plan is entitled to ask for one.

Combined treatment. For moderate and severe depression, the combination of medication and psychological treatment is frequently the most effective option.

Structured self-management. Behavioural activation, exercise, sleep restoration, reduction of alcohol, and activity scheduling are components of treatment

rather than alternatives to it. They are effective, they can be started immediately, and they are the basis of Appendix C of this book.

Practical intervention. Debt advice, employment support, housing assistance, family mediation, and the resolution of an acute practical crisis are, in many cases, part of the treatment, because they remove the continuing load that maintains the condition. Chapter 12 and Appendix D address the financial dimension directly.

Crisis planning. Where there is any risk of self-harm, a written plan specifying what the man will do, whom he will contact, and what the people around him should do is required. Chapter 34 and Appendix B provide the framework.

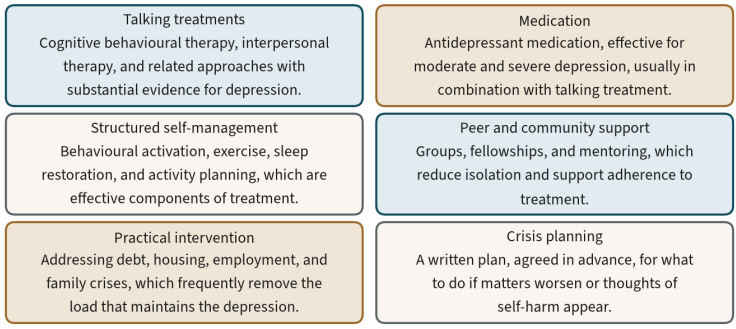


Figure 6.4 The components of evidence-based treatment for depression in men. The components are commonly combined, and the practical interventions in the lower rows are frequently what make the others possible.

What Support Involves

Support is not the same as treatment, and it is not a substitute for it. It consists of four elements, and they are the responsibility of the man's family, friends, and community.

Company without pressure. Regular contact that does not require the man to discuss anything. The most valuable form of support for most men in depression is presence: a friend who comes, sits, walks, or works alongside, without requiring an account of the condition.

Practical relief. Help with tasks: transport, a meal, a school run, an hour of cover at the shop, assistance with a form. Practical help reduces the load, which is a treatment-adjacent intervention, and it is more acceptable to men than emotional assistance.

Encouragement to continue. The most useful support in the middle weeks of treatment is the maintenance of the routine: a reminder of the appointment,

an offer of transport to it, a check that the medication is being taken, and an unwillingness to accept the first refusal.

Honesty about risk. If a man has spoken of not being able to continue, being a burden, or having no reason to live, the appropriate response is to ask directly about suicide, to remain with him, to remove means, and to contact professional or emergency help. Appendix Q describes this in detail, and Chapter 34 sets out the framework. Silence on this point is the most dangerous form of consideration.

6.6 What Families, Friends, and Employers Can Do

This section is addressed to those around a man with depression, and it is included because the two most influential actors in most cases are a spouse and an employer, neither of whom has any clinical training.

What a Spouse or Partner Can Do

Four actions make a measurable difference.

Ask direct questions about behaviour, not feelings. *You have been waking early for weeks. What is happening?* is more useful than *Are you depressed?* The first is observable and therefore difficult to dismiss; the second invites a denial that both parties know is inaccurate.

Ask about suicide. Where a man has said that he cannot continue, that he is a burden, or that others would be better off without him, the appropriate response is to ask directly whether he has thought of ending his life. This does not plant the idea; the evidence on this point is clear, and asking is the standard way in which risk is identified. Chapter 34 and Appendix Q set out what to do next.

Attend the first appointment. Men who are taken to a first consultation — literally accompanied — complete far more of the process than men who are merely advised to go. The company removes the friction, and it also removes the private negotiation in which shame usually wins.

Do not accept the first refusal. Most men refuse help once or twice before accepting it. A refusal followed by silence is read as agreement. A refusal followed by a repeated, kind, and specific offer — *I will come with you on Thursday morning; the appointment will take an hour* — generally ends in attendance.

What an Employer Can Do

Depression costs employers substantially through absence, reduced performance, and turnover. The interventions that work are practical.

Confidential support, available without justification. An employee assistance programme, a named clinician, or a confidential telephone service that a man can use without explaining himself to a supervisor.

Supervision that responds to change rather than to output. The most useful signal available to a manager is a change in a man's temperament or par-

ticipation — increased irritability, withdrawal from meetings, lateness, reduced tolerance of noise — rather than a change in his figures, which frequently fall last.

Flexibility for treatment. Appointments occur during working hours. A man who must choose between attending treatment and explaining his absence to a supervisor will frequently choose neither and abandon the treatment.

Protection of confidentiality. Where an employee believes that a request for help will be recorded against him, he will not make the request, and the organisation will bear the cost of an untreated illness in the form of errors, absence, and eventual resignation.

A final word to employers is warranted, because it is increasingly supported by occupational health research: the most effective single measure an organisation can take to reduce the toll of depression among male employees is to remove the assumption that a man who asks for help is not fit for responsibility. That assumption is not a policy, and it is enforced by ordinary remarks, by promotion decisions, and by how senior men speak about difficulty in public. It can be changed, and its removal is cheaper than the alternative.

6.6 Reclaiming Emotional Well-Being

Recovery from depression is not a moment of realisation. It is a process with a recognisable shape, and it is helpful for a man to know what that shape is, because the process itself produces discouragement at predictable points.

The Shape of Recovery

The early phase of treatment frequently produces a change that is not obvious to anybody outside: the man begins sleeping better, or begins to leave the house on purpose, or notices that he is arguing less. Mood improves more slowly than behaviour, and this produces a common pattern in which families see improvement before the man feels it. That gap is normal, and it is worth naming in advance, because a man who expects to feel better before he behaves better will conclude after three weeks that treatment is not working.

The middle phase involves the restoration of activity, contact, and purpose, generally in that order. Men are usually advised to resume a substantial part of their previous activity before they feel able to, because the ability follows the activity rather than preceding it. This is counter-intuitive and frequently resented. It is also one of the best-established features of treatment.

The later phase involves consolidation: monitoring for the return of symptoms, maintaining the habits that made recovery possible, and identifying the conditions that made the episode likely. Many men discover that they need to make one or two structural changes — the removal of a specific ongoing overload, the repair of a particular relationship, the treatment of a physical condition — without which the depression tends to return.

Relapse Prevention

Depression recurs, and a man who has had one episode has a materially higher chance of another. Four practical measures reduce the risk.

Recognise your personal signature. The early signs differ between people: the first to appear may be a change in sleep, a rise in irritability, a loss of appetite, or an inability to make decisions. Write yours down while you are well, because you will not be able to see it when it is happening.

Keep one person informed. Somebody — a spouse, a friend, a relative, a professional — should know the signature, and should be appointed, in advance, to raise it.

Maintain the practical foundations. Regular sleep, exercise, and the avoidance of heavy drinking are more protective than any technique. This is unglamorous and it is the most effective thing available.

Plan the follow-up. Ask the treating professional for an explicit plan: how long treatment continues, what the review arrangements are, and what should happen if symptoms return. A written plan of this kind is a substantial protection.

What Recovery Does Not Require

A final comment is needed on two expectations that damage recovery.

Recovery does not require the man to be able to describe his feelings at length, to have a vocabulary equal to a professional's, or to become a different kind of man. Many men recover fully while remaining men of few words. What is required is not fluency but precision: being able to report sleep, behaviour, symptoms, and consequences accurately is sufficient for treatment, as Chapter 5 explained.

Recovery also does not require the disappearance of every difficulty. The debt may remain, the son may still be struggling, the bereavement will still be real. What changes is the man's capacity to carry these things and to function with them — which is the practical difference between an untreated and a treated depression, and is, for most men, the whole of what they are asking for.

6.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Whose Family Thought He Had Changed

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family medicine, occupational health, and counselling practice.

Musa, forty-six, is a building materials trader in a market, married with four children. He has been in business for nineteen years and is known in his line as hardworking and reliable.

Over a period of about eighteen months, four things changed and none of them was discussed with anybody. First, he became short-tempered, particularly with his two youngest children, and he began to speak to them in a tone he had never used before. His wife concluded that he was under pressure from the market, and she responded by keeping the children away from him, which he noticed and experienced as confirmation that he had become a difficult man.

Second, his sleep changed. He began waking at about three in the morning and lying awake until five, at which point he would leave for the market two hours earlier than necessary. His excuse was the traffic; his wife accepted it, and his absence from the house in the early mornings was added to the list of things that were quietly changing.

Third, he lost interest in his Sunday ritual of playing football with a group of men he had known for twenty years, offering the explanation that he was too old. The men did not insist. He also stopped attending the association of traders from his home state, of which he had been a member for a decade.

Fourth, he began to drink more in the evening — three or four bottles, most nights, with the stated purpose of sleeping. He did not tell his wife that the drinking had become necessary.

His business did not decline. In fact, he spent more hours in it, and his turnover held. Nobody in the family, the market, or the community identified that anything was wrong; the recognised diagnosis of the situation, in the words of his wife, was that *Musa has changed*.

The crisis arrived in the form of a trivial incident. A customer questioned a price, and Musa shouted at him in the shop in front of other customers, which was so out of character that two neighbouring traders came to ask if he was unwell. He apologised, went home early, and sat in his room. His wife, who had been managing the situation for eighteen months without a name for it, asked him one question: *What is happening to you?*

He did not answer that night. Two days later he told her that he had not felt like himself for more than a year, that he did not know what was wrong with him, and that he had begun to think that his family would be better off without him in the house. That last sentence caused her to insist — over his objection — that they go to the family physician together, that same week.

The physician asked about sleep, appetite, weight, and alcohol; about the changes in temperament; about the loss of interest in activities; and, directly, about thoughts of death. Musa described a private conviction, present for months, that he had become a person nobody could love, and a settled belief that his continued presence in the home was a burden. He was diagnosed with a moderate depressive episode with a risk of self-harm, started on medication the same week, referred for counselling, and asked to return in one week and then every two weeks. His wife was given an explanation of the condition, told what to watch for, and told explicitly to ask him about his thoughts if she was worried, rather than avoiding the subject.

> Eight weeks later, his sleep had improved, the shouting had largely stopped, and he described his state as *like coming out of a fog*. Nineteen months later, in a review consultation, he said something that his physician considered worth repeating to other men: *I thought I had become a bad man. I had become an ill man, and nobody — including me — had used that word.*

The case illustrates the central point of the chapter, and four features should be noted.

Every symptom was present and every symptom was misread. Irritability was read as strain; the early waking was read as traffic; the loss of football and the association was read as age; the drinking was read as a habit. None of these readings was unreasonable, and the sum of them concealed a condition for eighteen months.

Function was preserved until the end. The business did not decline; his hours increased. This is one of the most common reasons male depression goes unrecognised, and it is why family and employers should look at changes in temperament and participation rather than at output alone.

The risk was disclosed only in response to a direct question. Musa had thoughts that his family would be better off without him and had told nobody. The disclosure followed a question from his wife, which itself followed an escalation. This is why both families and clinicians must ask direct questions about self-harm: the information is generally available and generally not volunteered.

Treatment worked and the family was included in it. Medication, counselling, a follow-up schedule, and an informed spouse produced a recovery that was visible within two months. The intervention did not require unusual resources. It required that the condition be identified and named.

6.8 Practical Exercise: The Two-Week Symptom Log and the Decision Point

This exercise has two purposes: to produce an accurate picture of your own state over a defined period, and to produce a decision about what to do with the picture. It takes five minutes a day for fourteen days, plus thirty minutes at the end.

Part One: The Daily Log

For fourteen consecutive days, record the following five items at the same time each evening. Use a notebook or the table below. Score each item from zero to three, where zero means absent, one means mild, two means moderate, and three means severe.

Day	Sleep quality	Energy	Irritability	Interest in things I usually enjoy	Alcohol or sedatives used to cope
1					
2					
…					

Three additional lines should be completed once a week:

- *This week, the thing that most affected my state was _____.*
- *This week, I spoke to _____ people about how I am actually doing.*
- *This week, I did the following thing that I used to do and had stopped doing: _____.*

Part Two: The Scoring

At the end of the fortnight, total the columns. Then apply the following interpretation, which is a screening aid and not a diagnosis.

- **Total irritability of 14 or more, or a decline in interest averaging 2 or more, or an average sleep score below 1:** the pattern is consistent with a depressive presentation and should be assessed professionally.
- **Any use of alcohol or sedatives specifically to sleep or to settle the state, on more than four nights out of fourteen:** warrants professional assessment, because self-medication is a recognised marker of a treatable condition.
- **Any thought during the fortnight that you would be better off dead, that others would be better off without you, or that you cannot continue:** requires immediate professional contact. Do not wait for the fortnight to end. Chapter 34 and Appendix Q set out what to do.

Part Three: The Account

Write five sentences that translate the fortnight into information a professional can use. Use the three principles from Chapter 5: describe behaviour and body rather than feelings; attach everything to a date; report consequences rather than causes.

An example of the form:

> *Over the last four months I have been waking at about three and cannot return to sleep. My temper has changed: I shout at my children over small things, which I did not do before. I have stopped playing football and stopped attending my association.*

I am drinking three or four bottles most evenings to sleep. In the last two weeks I have twice thought that my family would be better without me.

Part Four: The Decision Point

Write your answer to each of the following, and then act on the last one.

1. **Have I had these symptoms for more than two to four weeks?** If yes, the decision is not *whether* to seek assessment but *where*.
2. **Which route will I use?** Physician, clinic, counsellor, hospital service, telephone line, or online service. Write the specific name and place, not a category.
3. **Whom will I tell?** One person who will know that this is happening, and who will ask about it. Chapter 4 explains why this single step is decisive.
4. **What will I say in the first thirty seconds?** Write the sentence down and rehearse it aloud three times.
5. **What is the date and time of the contact?** Write it in your calendar now, and treat it as you would treat a meeting with a major client.

Part Five: If the Answer Is That You Cannot Do It

A proportion of readers will complete the exercise and will not make the contact. That is a real and foreseeable outcome, and three things help.

Lower the first step until it is trivial. The first step does not have to be an appointment. It can be a telephone call to a helpline, a message to a physician's receptionist, a question asked of a trusted person about who they would recommend, or the purchase of a notebook. Any of these moves the situation forward, and the second step is easier than the first.

Ask somebody to accompany you. Being taken to an appointment by a wife, a brother, a friend, or a colleague removes most of the friction, and men report that this is the single most effective support they received in the whole process.

Treat the resistance as a symptom. The reluctance to seek help is part of the condition, not a judgement about whether help is deserved. A man who says *I will do it when I feel stronger* is describing a promise that depression does not keep, because the strength arrives through the treatment rather than before it.

6.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"How do I know whether this is depression or just a difficult period?"

The practical test is the one set out in Table 6.1 and in Section 6.3: how many features are present, for how long, and what are they costing? A difficult period is proportionate to an event, fluctuates, and resolves. Depression is persistent, present on most days, disproportionate to circumstances or plainly beyond what the circumstances account for, and it interferes with sleep, work, or relationships. If the symptoms have lasted more than two to four weeks and are affecting func-

tioning, have it assessed; the assessment itself is inexpensive in time and will settle the question.

"If I am diagnosed, will I have to take medication for the rest of my life?"

No. Many cases are treated with psychological therapy alone. Where medication is used, it is generally continued for a defined period after improvement — commonly several months — and then reduced gradually under supervision. A proportion of people with recurrent or severe depression continue treatment long-term, and this is a clinical decision made with a specialist rather than a default pathway.

"Can I recover without anybody at work or at home knowing?"

Confidential treatment is possible, and many men use it. The more important question is whether secrecy about the fact of treatment is in your interest. In practice, most men find that at least one person at home should know, for three reasons: that person can support the treatment, can observe changes you may not notice, and can act if matters worsen. Confidentiality of clinical information is a professional obligation; the discretion of the household is a decision you can make deliberately.

"What if treatment does not work?"

A minority of people do not respond to the first treatment, and this is expected rather than exceptional. The standard approach is to review after an agreed interval, adjust the treatment or the type of therapy, or combine approaches, and to check that other conditions — anxiety, alcohol use, thyroid function, chronic pain, sleep disorder — are not confounding the picture. The important instruction is not to conclude that you cannot be helped on the basis of one treatment that did not work.

"I cannot afford private care. What are my options?"

Public hospital services, primary health centres with trained staff, subsidised counselling services attached to universities and non-governmental organisations, employer schemes, telephone helplines, and online services. Appendix Q sets these out in detail for Nigeria and for other African countries, together with guidance on cost and on what to ask when making contact.

"Does seeking treatment risk my position at work?"

Clinical information is confidential, and occupational health records are generally separate from personnel records. The practical risks of untreated depression — declining performance, errors, absence, resignation, and dismissal — greatly exceed the risks of confidential treatment. If you have a specific concern about your workplace, raise it with the clinician before you begin, and ask what will be recorded and who may see it.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 6 in brief. Depression is a real condition, not sadness and not a weakness, with a defined set of symptoms, a duration, and an effect on functioning. It varies in severity, and severity determines treatment. It is frequently accompanied by anxiety, substance use, and physical illness, and a competent assessment looks for more than one condition.

Depression in men is systematically under-recognised for four reasons. Symptoms are attributed to character; men present physical complaints rather than emotional ones; men answer the standard screening questions negatively because the questions concern sadness and crying rather than anger and flatness; and men conceal the condition deliberately, which removes the support that would protect them.

The characteristic male presentations are three. Irritability, in which the threshold for frustration falls sharply and the household bears the brunt. Withdrawal, frequently from everything except work, so that extra hours are read as dedication while relationships are emptied. And emotional numbness, in which the man feels nothing rather than sadness, loses pleasure along with pain, and observes his own absence from the events that should move him. Additional features include early waking, physical complaints, increased alcohol use, risk-taking, reduced self-care, and flat statements of hopelessness.

Untreated depression is dangerous in six ways: death by suicide; worsening and recurring episodes; poorer physical health outcomes; substantial effects on partners and children; loss of work capacity and income; and the development of alcohol or drug dependence through self-medication. Waiting is a decision with a cost, and the cost is highest for men.

Men resist help for reasons that are largely rational within their own terms, including the belief that functioning means wellness, the expectation that the condition will pass, the dislike of medication, the fear of records and reputation, the fear that talking will worsen matters, the absence of reasons to be depressed, the preference for spiritual resolution, and sheer lack of information. Each objection has a practical answer, and the most common outcome of a first consultation is relief rather than exposure.

Treatment with a strong evidence base includes talking treatments, medication for moderate and severe cases, combined treatment, structured self-management, practical intervention in the circumstances that maintain the condition, and crisis planning where risk is present. Support consists of company without pressure, practical relief, encouragement to continue, and honesty about risk. Treatment and support work best together, and neither is a substitute for the other.

Recovery has a shape: behaviour improves before mood, activity is restored before the desire for it returns, and consolidation requires attention to the conditions that made the episode likely. Relapse prevention rests on recognising your personal early signature, keeping one person informed, maintaining sleep, exercise, and reduced drinking, and obtaining an explicit follow-up plan. Recovery does not require a

man to become fluent in emotional language; precision about sleep, behaviour, symptoms, and consequences is sufficient for treatment to work.
The exercise produced a two-week symptom log, a written account in professionally usable form, and a decision point with a date, a route, a person to inform, and a prepared first sentence. For the man who cannot yet act, the remedy is to lower the first step until it is trivial, to ask somebody to accompany him, and to treat resistance as a symptom of the condition rather than as a reason to postpone.

Reflection Questions

1. Read the right-hand column of Figure 6.1 again. How many of the features apply to you, and for how long? If the answer is three or more for more than two weeks, what is your date for assessment?
2. Of the three principal presentations — irritability, withdrawal, numbness — which fits you most closely? Describe, with specific examples, how it appears in your household.
3. Section 6.3 lists six dangers of untreated depression. Which one is most likely to affect you or your family in the next two years, and what would you lose if the condition continued untreated for that period?
4. Take the eight objections in Section 6.4 and mark those you have used. For each, write the answer that would actually persuade you, in your own words, rather than the answer you would give another man.
5. What is your personal early warning signature — the first two or three signs that appear when your mood begins to fall? Who else knows what to look for?
6. If you were to write the five-sentence account in Part Three of the exercise today, what would your first sentence be?
7. Consider the man in the illustrative case. His business held while his family life deteriorated. Which parts of your life are holding, and which are being quietly emptied?

Further Reading

- **On depression generally:** the World Health Organization's depression resources, including its fact sheets and its guidance for non-specialist health workers, which are available at no cost. National health services publish comparable materials, usually with practical advice on when to seek help.
- **On depression in men:** the research literature on sex differences in symptom presentation, including studies showing that irritability, anger, and substance use are more prominent in male presentations and that standard screening instruments under-detect depression in men.

- **On treatment:** the clinical guidelines issued by national and international bodies on the treatment of depression, including guidance on psychological therapies, medication, and combined treatment, together with evidence reviews on behavioural activation and exercise as components of care.
- **On suicide prevention:** the substantial body of work on male suicide risk, including what families and friends can do, and the guidance produced by suicide prevention organisations. Appendix Q lists services that are available to men in Nigeria, in other African countries, and internationally.
- **On recovery:** first-person accounts by men who have recovered from depression, particularly those written for a male readership; and practical guidance for families on supporting a man through the treatment process.

7 CHAPTER

The Fear of Failure

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Explain why the pressure to succeed operates so powerfully on men, and describe the specific forms it takes in family, work, and community life.
2. Analyse the mechanics of comparison — how a man's reference group shifts and why satisfaction declines even as achievement rises.
3. Describe the effect of financial failure on self-esteem, and distinguish between the loss of income, the loss of standing, and the loss of identity.
4. Recognise perfectionism and the fear of judgement as distinct but connected patterns, and identify their costs in work and family life.
5. Apply a structured method for recovering from a serious disappointment or failure, including the assessment of the actual position and the management of the account given to others.
6. Complete the separation of personal worth from performance, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

A man loses a contract. The loss is serious: about forty per cent of his annual turnover, and with it the ability to service a loan he took eighteen months ago. He tells his wife that the client has postponed. He tells his brother nothing at all. He goes to the office every day and works on other prospects, and he performs, in every visible respect, exactly as he did before.

What has actually happened to him is not primarily financial. It is a verdict. Somewhere in the process of losing the contract he has accepted a proposition that he did not consciously formulate and would deny if asked: *I am the man who wins contracts. The man who loses this contract is a different man.* From that point he is not managing a business difficulty. He is concealing a change of identity, and every practical step that would address the business difficulty — telling his wife the truth, speaking to the bank, asking a competitor for a partnership arrangement,

reducing his household expenditure — threatens to make the identity change public.

This chapter deals with the fear of failure, and it begins with the observation that the difficulty has less to do with failure itself than with the fusion between a man's performance and his sense of self. Failure is unavoidable. Every man who attempts anything will lose contracts, miss targets, be rejected, be passed over, make mistakes, and, at some point, disappoint people who depend upon him. The question is not how to avoid these events but what they are taken to mean, and whether a man can survive them with his judgment, his relationships, and his capacity to act intact.

7.1 The Pressure to Succeed at All Costs

The pressure to succeed is not a modern invention, but its form has changed in ways that matter. It is worth setting out what the pressure consists of before examining its effects.

The Components of the Pressure

Four components operate together, and a man under pressure is usually responding to all four at once.

The economic component. For a large proportion of men, success is not a preference but a condition of household survival. The consequences of failure are concrete: school fees unpaid, medical treatment postponed, rent arrears, a family's standing in the community damaged. Where the man is the principal earner in an extended family, the economic calculation is more demanding still, as Chapter 10 examines. A book that treated the fear of failure as a purely psychological matter would be ignoring the fact that for many men the fear is proportionate to a real risk.

The social component. In most communities, a man's standing and his visible success are closely connected. Vehicles, houses, weddings, contributions at ceremonies, and the education of children are public evidence, and the evidence is read by neighbours, relatives, colleagues, and former schoolmates. The social dimension means that failure is not merely a private setback; it is an alteration of one's position in a system of regard that a man did not design and cannot opt out of.

The relational component. Men frequently experience their value to their families as conditional upon provision. This perception is not always accurate, and it is powerful. It produces the specific fear described in Chapter 10: that a man who cannot provide will lose his place in his own household — not through any decision by his wife or children, but because the household's structure presumes his usefulness.

The internal component. The fourth component is the one that this chapter is chiefly concerned with, and it is the one that men least often acknowledge: the man's own standard, internalised from childhood and carried without examination. The internal standard is frequently harsher than anything demanded by the family, the employer, or the community, and it is the component that keeps the pressure in place after the economic and social risks have been reduced.

The Locked-In Effect

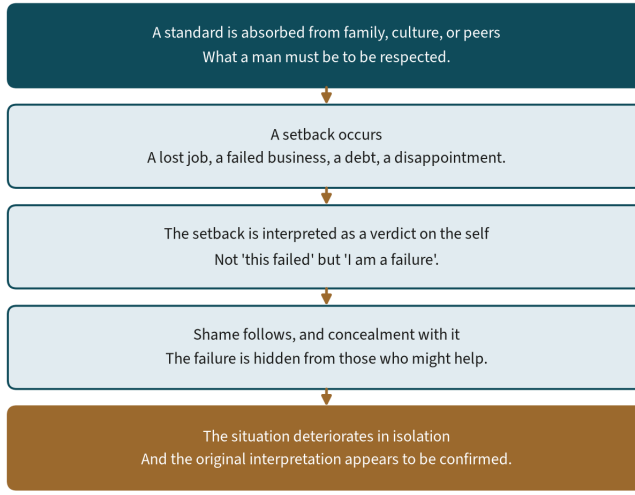
A distinctive feature of the pressure to succeed is that it reduces the man's available options precisely at the moment he most needs them. The mechanism deserves to be named, because it explains why men take risks that appear obviously inadvisable to outsiders. It has three steps.

Success raises expectations. A man who has earned a certain level of income is expected to maintain it. A man who has educated three children is expected to educate the fourth. A man who has been generous at a funeral is expected to be generous at the next.

The cost of the expected standard rises. Mortgage or rent, education, medical costs, transport, and obligations to relatives tend to rise faster than income, particularly in economies with high inflation.

Risk becomes unavoidable. To maintain the standard, the man must take on more debt, accept a larger contract with a larger penalty, invest in an uncertain opportunity, or work in circumstances he would previously have refused. Any reduction of ambition now requires a public admission that the standard is being lowered, which is precisely the admission he has organised his life to avoid.

The result is a locked-in state described by many men in mid-life: a position that cannot be sustained without risk, cannot be reduced without disclosure, and cannot be discussed with anyone. Figure 7.3 sets out the sequence by which this state produces a private crisis.



The pathway from a setback to a private crisis. The point of intervention is the third stage.

Figure 7.1 From standard to crisis. The point of intervention is the third stage, where a setback is interpreted as a verdict on the self rather than as an event in a business or a career.

What Is Actually Being Feared

Men who examine their fear of failure discover, with some surprise, that it is rarely a fear of poverty. It is a fear of one or more of four specific things, and the four require different responses.

Table 7.1 The four objects of the fear of failure. Identifying the specific object matters because the remedy for one is not the remedy for another.

What is feared	What it looks like	What actually addresses it
Loss of standing	Being spoken of as a man who has declined; losing the position accompanying a role	Publicly redefining the standard; association with a different reference group
Loss of usefulness	Fear of becoming a burden; of no longer being needed by family or employer	Renewed contribution in a different form; mentoring; practical service
Loss of the family's trust	The fear that dependants will be disappointed, or will transfer their dependence elsewhere	Early, honest disclosure; involving the family in the plan
Loss of self-respect	The private conviction of having failed as a man	Separating worth from performance; correcting the standard; professional support

KEY POINT
The fear of failure is rarely about money. It is usually about standing, usefulness, trust, and self-respect, and it is only the first of those that can be restored by earning more.

7.2 Comparing Personal Progress with Others

Comparison with others is a universal human activity, and for men in mid-life it acquires a particular intensity. This section describes the mechanism, assesses the harm it does, and sets out what can realistically be done about it.

Why the Comparison Happens

Four features of adult male life make comparison difficult to avoid.

Age-mates provide a natural benchmark. Men who grew up together, attended the same schools, and entered the workforce at the same time provide an obvious reference group, and the comparison is made in public: at reunions, at funerals, at weddings, and in the family house.

Visibility is high. In most communities, the markers of a man's position are visible: the state of his house, the school his children attend, the car, the contributions he makes, the employment of his relatives. A man who wishes not to be compared cannot easily avoid it, because the data are on display.

Comparison is built into work. Performance reviews, rankings, quotas, and promotions institutionalise comparison, and most men spend their working lives in structures that continuously report their relative position.

Social media multiplies the reference group. The digital environment presents a man with the achievements of a very large number of people, most of whom publish only their successes, producing a baseline against which his own ordinary life compares unfavourably. The effect is well documented in the research on social media and well-being, and men are not immune to it.

The Two Mechanisms of Harm

Comparison causes harm in two distinct ways, and it is worth distinguishing them.

The spiral. The first mechanism, illustrated in Figure 7.2, is self-sustaining. A man reaches a goal; a more successful comparator comes into view; the standard is revised upward; the man works harder; the goal is reached again and produces no satisfaction because the comparator has also moved; and the process repeats with no point of arrival. The characteristic experience of the spiral is described with illuminating consistency: men say that they cannot remember the last time they felt satisfied for more than a week.

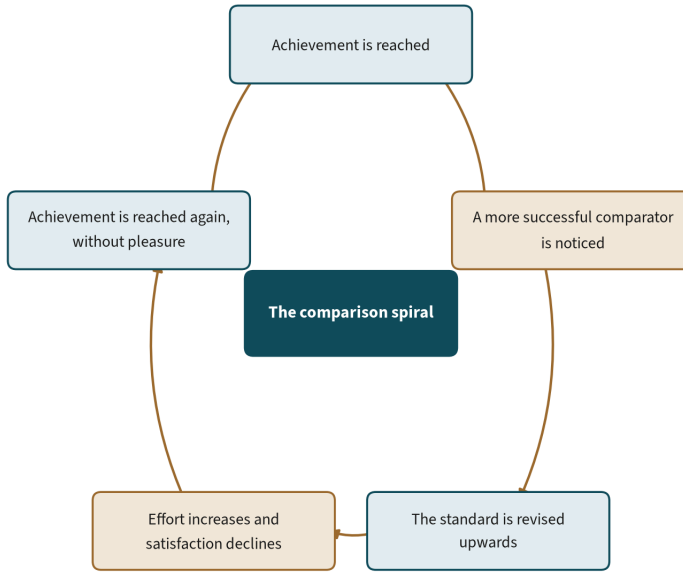


Figure 7.2 The comparison spiral. Each attainment raises the reference standard rather than delivering satisfaction, so that effort increases while the return in well-being declines.

The misdirected judgement. The second mechanism is more insidious. Comparison does not only produce dissatisfaction; it also produces a distorted assessment of one's own situation. A man whose business is modest but stable may, having compared himself with a former classmate who has expanded rapidly, conclude that his own position is a failure. The conclusion is not a feeling; it is an assessment, and it will guide his decisions. Men have destroyed sound businesses, sound marriages, and sound health by acting on assessments generated in this way.

The Defects in the Comparison

The remedy for harmful comparison is not the instruction to stop comparing, which is unrealistic, but the systematic exposure of the comparison's defects. There are five, and writing them down is more effective than trying to feel differently.

You are comparing incomparables. The comparator has different starting conditions: a family that could raise capital, a locality with lower costs, health, timing, connections, and a set of luck. Comparing outcomes when the inputs differ is not an assessment; it is an error.

You are comparing with a selective presentation. What is visible is the accomplishment. What is not visible is the debt, the family strain, the health cost, and the hours. The comparison uses one man's highlight and another man's whole life, and no accurate judgement can be produced in this way.

You are comparing a process with a moment. The comparator is at a different point in a trajectory. A business that is expanding rapidly this year may collapse in three years; a career that appears slow may be more durable. Comparisons made at a single instant cannot distinguish these cases.

You do not know what you would trade. If the comparison is genuinely accurate — that is, if the other man has a better life in every respect you actually value — then the conclusion is not failure but information. In the great majority of cases, the man who examines the comparison finds that he would not accept the other man's trade: the hours, the family cost, the risk, the obligation. That discovery ends the comparison.

Your reference group is not fixed. This is the practical remedy, and it is the most effective single action available. A man chooses, to a greater extent than he believes, the people with whom he compares himself. Those who compare themselves with the most visible achievers in their society will live in permanent shortfall. Those who compare themselves with their own position five years ago, with their own values, and with the people to whom they are actually accountable will live in a state that can be judged fairly.

A Practical Rule

One rule is worth carrying from this section: **before any comparison is allowed to influence a decision, write down the comparison and answer the four questions — what were the inputs, what is not visible, where in the trajectory is each person, and would I accept the trade?** The discipline takes ten minutes and prevents a class of expensive mistakes.

7.3 Financial Failure and Wounded Self-Esteem

Financial difficulty is the most common serious failure in the lives of the men this book is written for, and it wounds self-esteem in a manner that men describe in almost identical terms across countries, classes, and ages. It is worth being precise about what happens.

Three Losses in One Event

A financial failure delivers three distinct losses, and they arrive together, which is why the event is so disorganising.

Material loss. The loss of income, savings, property, or business capacity, with the practical consequences that follow: unpaid fees, delayed medical care, reduced

food quality, the withdrawal of children from school, the sale of a vehicle, or the loss of a house.

Social loss. The loss of standing in a system of regard that is partly economic. Men report the specific social experiences that accompany financial trouble: avoiding gatherings at which they would be expected to contribute; declining invitations because of the cost of attendance; being asked for assistance and having to refuse; hearing that something has been said about them; the shame of a child being sent home from school.

Identity loss. The third loss is the most consequential, and it involves the fusion described in the introduction to this chapter. The man's sense of himself was constructed substantially out of his capacity to provide, and the loss of that capacity is experienced as the loss of himself. The experience is not metaphorical, and it is not an overreaction. It is the predictable result of a long process in which a man's worth was repeatedly identified with his usefulness.

The Specific Wounds and the Specific Thoughts

The thoughts that accompany financial failure are consistent, and it is worth listing them, because a man who reads his own thought in print is a man who is more able to examine it.

- *I have let my family down.* Frequently the first and most persistent thought, and usually the one that carries the most charge.
- *I am not the man I said I was.* The collapse of the public account described in Chapter 1.
- *I will lose them.* A fear concerning the family: that a wife, children, or relatives will revise their regard, or in some cases leave.
- *Everyone will know.* The anticipation of public knowledge, and the loss of standing that will follow.
- *I must have been foolish.* A retrospective reconstruction in which past decisions are re-read as evidence of stupidity, regardless of the information available at the time.
- *What is the point of continuing?* In severe cases, a risk of self-harm. This requires immediate professional attention, as Chapters 6 and 34 set out.

The Behaviour That Follows, and Why It Is Costly

The pattern of behaviour that follows a financial failure is highly predictable, and, in the great majority of cases, it makes the failure worse. Four behaviours recur.

Concealment. The failure is hidden from the spouse, the family, the community, and frequently from professional advisers. Concealment prevents the four interventions that most help: shared planning, cost reduction, restructuring of debt, and emotional support.

Over-trading to recover. The man increases risk in an attempt to recover quickly, frequently with borrowed money. The impulse is understandable — speed appears to be the only way to prevent discovery — and it is one of the most reliable routes from a difficulty into a catastrophe.

Withdrawal from social obligations where the cost is visible. This produces the isolation described in Chapter 4 at the very moment when company and information are most needed.

Self-punishment through work. Men frequently respond by working longer hours, reducing sleep, and abandoning leisure entirely, which reduces their decision-making capacity at the point where clear decisions matter most.

The Recoverable Part and the Unrecoverable Part

A distinction that assists recovery is the separation of what can and cannot be restored.

What is frequently recoverable: income, business capacity, assets, and, over a period of years, standard of living. Men of forty-five, fifty-five, and sixty-five recover from serious financial losses in large numbers, and the recovery is usually slower and less spectacular than the collapse.

What is not recoverable, and what requires separate work: the years spent in concealment; the trust damaged by dishonesty; the health damaged by the stress; the relationship with children during the period of withdrawal; and, where it occurred, the loss of a marriage that could have survived the money problem but not the secrecy. These losses are addressed by honesty, by the repair methods described in Chapters 29 and 36, and by the professional support described in Chapter 35. They are not addressed by earning more.

7.4 Perfectionism and Fear of Judgment

Perfectionism and the fear of judgement are related but distinct, and the distinction determines the treatment. Perfectionism concerns the standard a man applies to his own work. Fear of judgement concerns his expectation of how others will respond to it. A man may have either without the other, and many men have both.

Perfectionism

Perfectionism is generally understood as a disposition in which the person sets standards that are extremely high and evaluates performance against them, with the consequences that satisfaction is rare, effort is excessive, and the person is perpetually dissatisfied with results that others consider entirely adequate.

Four consequences matter for the reader.

It consumes time disproportionately. The last ten per cent of quality frequently costs as much as the first ninety. Perfectionists deliver better work than

they can afford, in exchange for sleep, relationships, and additional capacity that would have produced more overall value elsewhere.

It produces avoidance. Where the standard is unreachable, the most rational response is not to begin. Procrastination in perfectionists is not laziness; it is the avoidance of an anticipated verdict. Chapter 22 examines the pattern in detail.

It destroys delegation. A man who requires that work be done to his own standard cannot hand work to others, which limits the size of anything he can build and guarantees his own overwork. In occupational terms, this is the most expensive feature of perfectionism.

It transmits. Children of perfectionist fathers acquire either the same standard or a rebellion against it, and in both cases the family's emotional life is organised around a standard rather than around its members. Chapter 43 examines what boys learn from this.

Fear of Judgement

The fear of being judged is a social anxiety with a specific male character. Its features are as follows.

It attaches to exposure. The man is not afraid of hard work or of difficulty; he is afraid of being seen failing, being corrected in public, being asked a question he cannot answer, being revealed as less competent than his position implies.

It produces a characteristic set of behaviours. Over-preparation; reluctance to speak in meetings unless certain of the answer; avoidance of questions in the audience; refusal to ask directions, to seek technical help, or to admit ignorance; postponement of performance reviews; and a marked reluctance to be examined, tested, or assessed in any form.

It has a clear mechanism. The fear is generated by the belief that a single observed failure will produce a global reclassification: not *he got that wrong* but *he is not competent*. This is the same fusion of act and identity described in Section 7.3, and it operates in the social domain.

It produces an important and under-recognised cost. Men who fear judgement fail to seek help for precisely the problems that would benefit from it, because asking for help is an admission of a gap. A man may spend two years attempting to resolve alone a tax problem, a legal matter, a medical symptom, or a technical fault that a professional would have resolved in a week. Chapter 35 addresses this directly.

What Helps

Four measures have a good record with both patterns.

Define the standard of sufficiency in advance. For each task, write down what would be good enough, and why. Judging a piece of work against a standard

established beforehand is considerably easier than judging it against an imagined ideal afterwards.

Adopt the professional standard rather than the ideal. Professionals in every field work to a standard that is adequate for the purpose and appropriate to the budget. Architects, engineers, surgeons, and accountants all do this, and men who insist on more than the professional standard are frequently confusing self-protection with quality.

Test the judgement fear against evidence. Ask three people whose judgement you respect, and who know your work, whether they have ever observed the failure you fear. The answer is, in the author's experience, almost always no, and the reason is instructive: other people are occupied with their own exposures.

Expose yourself deliberately, in graduated steps. Speak once in a meeting without complete certainty. Ask one question publicly that reveals a gap. Delegate one item of work that will be done differently from how you would do it. The evidence accumulates, and the fear diminishes — a method described in Appendix H.

7.5 Recovering from Disappointment

Disappointment is the ordinary, recurring experience of adult life: the promotion not received, the tender lost, the examination failed, the child who chose a different path, the marriage that did not produce what was promised, the plan that failed. Most disappointments are absorbed without much difficulty. The ones that require a method are those that are **serious** — involving substantial loss — and **public** — involving an account that must be given to others.

This section sets out a method for those cases. It has five stages, and they are sequenced deliberately.

Stage One: Stop the Bleeding

Before any assessment or repair, the man must stop the activity that is increasing the loss. This usually means one or more of the following.

- **Stop additional commitments.** Do not take on a new loan, a new contract with heavy penalties, or a new obligation in order to conceal the current situation.
- **Stop concealment-driven expenditure.** The vehicle, the ceremony, the contribution, and the standard of living being maintained solely to prevent others from concluding that something has happened: these must be examined, because they are the mechanism by which a difficulty becomes a catastrophe.

- **Protect the basic functions.** Sleep, food, exercise, and medical treatment. A man recovering from a serious failure with four hours of sleep and no exercise will make worse decisions than he is capable of.

This stage is frequently the hardest, because it involves the admission that the situation is real. It is also the stage at which professional assistance is most valuable — an accountant, a lawyer, a physician, a counsellor, or all four.

Stage Two: Establish the Actual Position

The second stage involves removing interpretation from the situation and establishing the facts. This is done on paper, and it has four components.

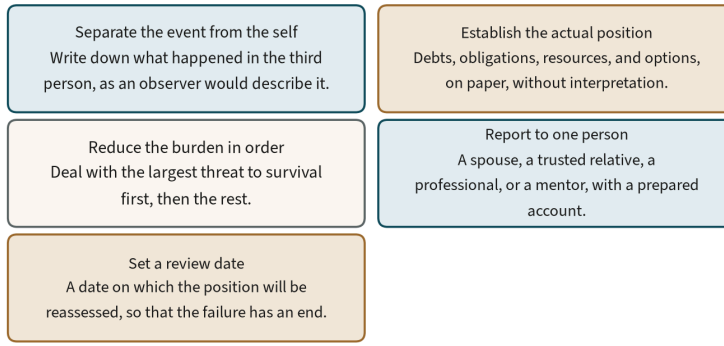
Assets and liabilities. What is owned, what is owed, what the interest costs, and what is secured against what.

Income and obligations. Actual income, and the sum of obligations to household, dependants, and creditors.

Time. How long the position can be sustained in its present form, given the income and the obligations. A precise figure, in months, is the single most useful number in the whole exercise. Men report that producing it is unpleasant and clarifying in equal measure.

Options. Written out, however unattractive: renegotiate, restructure, sell an asset, reduce household expenditure, take on a partner, take employment, declare a position, borrow from a named source at a named rate, or do nothing. The list should include the options that the man has been refusing to consider.

Figure 7.4 summarises the recovery sequence. The value of the sequence is that it converts an emotional crisis into a set of specific tasks, each of which can be done.



The practical sequence for recovering from a serious disappointment or failure.

Figure 7.3 The recovery sequence after a serious failure. The order matters: stability and facts come before reporting and reviewing, because an account given from a position of panic is rarely an accurate one.

Stage Three: Report to One Person

The third stage is disclosure to a single person: a spouse, a trusted relative, a mentor, a professional adviser, or a counsellor. The purpose of the first disclosure is not to obtain permission, forgiveness, or rescue. It is to end the condition of being the only person who knows.

Three practical notes improve the outcome.

Prepare. Write the account of the position — the facts from Stage Two — before the conversation. Men who attempt to improvise generally omit essential information and produce a worse conversation than they intended.

Announce the format. *I need to tell you something difficult. It concerns money. I have written down the position. I am not asking you to fix it. I am asking you to hear it and help me think.* This format prevents the two most common failures of such conversations: that the listener panics and demands immediate action, and that the listener receives the information as a personal betrayal and responds with blame before the facts are complete.

Say what you want. Men frequently disclose a serious problem and then resent the help they receive, because they did not specify what they wanted. Assistance, listening, practical involvement, and time to think are four different requests, and the listener cannot guess which is being made.

Stage Four: Act on the Two Largest Items

Recovery is rarely achieved by addressing everything. It is achieved by addressing the two items that most affect the position: usually the largest debt or the largest cost, and the largest opportunity foregone. A plan with fifteen items will not be executed. A plan with two specific actions and a date will.

Stage Five: Set a Review Date

The final stage is the creation of an end. Write down the date — one month, three months, six months ahead — on which the position will be reassessed. The review serves three functions: it prevents the situation from continuing indefinitely as a state of emergency; it produces evidence of progress (or of the need for a different approach); and it allows the man to stop carrying the whole burden in every hour of every day, because the next examination has a date.

The Account Given to Others

Most serious failures require an account to be given to people beyond the first confidant: children, relatives, colleagues, employees, or the community. Men find this the most painful element of the whole process, and four principles make it manageable.

Give the facts you know, and say what you do not know. *The contract has been lost. I do not yet know what the effect will be on next term's fees. I will tell*

you by the twentieth of the month. Uncertainty is more tolerable than vagueness or concealment.

Do not apologise for the event, but own your decisions. *The decision was mine, and it was wrong* is different from *I am a failure*. The first is a statement of accountability that a family can work with. The second transfers a burden of shame that serves no one.

Give the plan, not the anxiety. Families can handle difficulty; they handle it far less well when the head of the household communicates panic. A plan — even an incomplete one — is the single most reassuring thing a man can provide.

Keep updating. Concealment resumes through silence after the initial disclosure. A brief, factual update at the intervals promised is what maintains trust.

7.6 Separating Personal Worth from Performance

The final section addresses the underlying task of the chapter. Everything above is a method for managing a situation. This section concerns the arrangement that produced the situation's severity.

What Fusion Looks Like

The fusion of worth and performance operates as a system of accounting in which a man's value is calculated from his results. Its features are recognisable.

- Good results produce relief rather than satisfaction.
- Bad results produce shame rather than disappointment.
- Rest feels like decline.
- Failure cannot be described without the word *I*.
- The achievements of others are experienced as a verdict on oneself.
- A period without results produces a sense of having no value at all.

The system is exhausting, and its most serious feature is what it does at the point of failure. A man whose worth is separate from his performance can lose a business, a job, or a contract and still act: he can speak to his wife, negotiate with creditors, take employment, and rebuild. A man whose worth is fused with his performance must protect his identity while managing the crisis, and the protection of identity and the management of the crisis frequently require opposite actions — which is why fused men so often conceal, over-trade, and collapse.

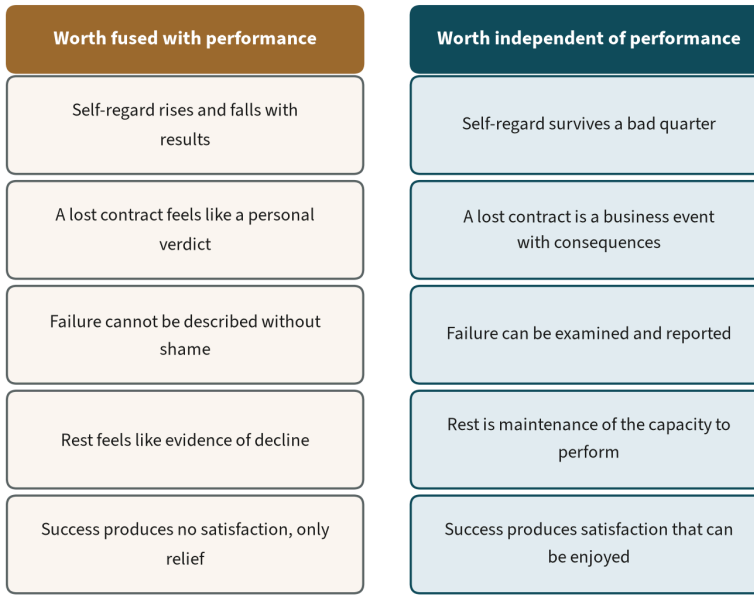


Figure 7.4 Two arrangements between worth and performance. The left-hand column is a description of how the man accounts for himself, not a moral failing; the right-hand column is what can be built by deliberate practice.

How the Separation Is Built

The separation is not achieved by a change of belief. It is built by four practices, repeated over months.

Change the language. The single most effective practice is to describe what happened without a verdict about the self. *The tender was lost. Two competitors were cheaper. I made an error in the pricing.* This is not positive thinking; it is precision. Chapter 22 and Appendix H provide the method for identifying and rewriting the automatic verdicts that accompany setbacks.

Establish a domain of worth that does not depend on results. Family relationships, physical capability, skill, humour, craft, community contribution, religious practice, friendship — any domain in which a man can identify value that is not measured by outcomes. Men who possess such a domain survive setbacks better, in the experience of most counsellors, than men who do not, and its construction is entirely within the man's control.

Keep an evidence file. A written record of what has been done well, what was contributed, and what others have said, kept for the periods when memory supplies only failures. This is not vanity; it is a corrective for the well-documented tendency of the human memory to weight negative information more heavily.

Accept praise. This sounds trivial and is not. Men who receive a compliment and immediately discount it — *anyone could have done it, it was luck, he is only being polite* — are actively maintaining the fusion. Accepting the compliment and saying thank you is a small, repeatable exercise that changes the accounting.

A Note for Men in the Middle of a Serious Setback

If the reader is currently inside the situation described in the first paragraph of this chapter, three sentences are offered directly.

The situation is recoverable, even if the schedule is not what you planned. Men recover from financial disasters at fifty, at sixty, and after seventy, and the majority of those who do so had no expectation of it in the month the loss occurred.

Concealment is more expensive than the failure. The financial loss can be reconstructed. The trust lost through months of concealment frequently cannot, and this is the finding that men who have been through the process report most consistently.

The first conversation is the whole game. Everything in this chapter — the facts on paper, the report to one person, the plan, the review date — follows from a single decision to stop being the only person who knows. Chapter 35 describes how to make that decision operational, Appendix D provides the financial worksheet, and Appendix E provides the conversation scripts.

7.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Standard

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family counselling, small-business advisory work, and financial counselling.

Segun is fifty-four and has run a printing business for twenty-two years. He employs nine people. He built a house in a peri-urban area, educated four children — two at university, one completed, one at secondary school — and has been the person who pays for the family's medical costs on both sides, including a brother-in-law's dialysis and his mother's regular medication.

For eleven years, the business expanded steadily. In the last three years, three things changed: paper and ink costs rose sharply, two large customers moved their work to a competing firm offering lower prices, and a bank facility taken during the expansion came up for renewal on less favourable terms.

Segun handled these developments in ways that were individually reasonable and cumulatively disastrous. He maintained the household budget unchanged, because reducing it would have required an explanation. He continued his contributions to the family obligations, because defaulting would have been noticed. He financed the shortfall with two informal loans and by delaying payment to two suppliers. He told nobody: not his wife, not his accountant, not his brother.

Over twenty-eight months, the business's debt grew while its capacity shrank. Segun's sleep deteriorated; he began to wake at four and to spend the hour before dawn on calculations. His irritability increased, and he became particularly sharp with his second son, whose university fees were the largest single item in the household budget. He began to avoid the two suppliers he owed.

The crisis arrived when a supplier refused to deliver without cash, which halted production for four days, which produced a missed delivery to a customer, which produced the loss of that customer.

His wife learned the position in the worst possible way: a supplier's representative came to the house on a Saturday and asked to speak to her, in front of two of the children, about a debt that was then four months old.

What followed is instructive in three respects.

The first month was worse than the crisis. The disclosure produced anger, fear, and, from Segun's brother, a set of judgments about his competence that were considerably harsher than anything the situation required. Segun described this period as the low point of his adult life, and men should be prepared for it: the truth does not necessarily produce comfort, and it frequently produces several weeks of difficulty before it produces relief.

The position was manageable once it was a position rather than a secret. With a financial counsellor, the family established four facts within a fortnight: total debt, monthly obligations, realistic income, and the number of months for which the situation could be sustained if expenditure were reduced. The number was three. The expenditure reduction was substantial, and it included the deletion of eleven monthly commitments that Segun had been maintaining for social reasons and had never examined. Two of the three largest — the vehicle maintenance on a second car and a contribution to a social club — were removed entirely.

The recovery was slower and more durable than the collapse. The house was not lost. One of the two university students moved to a degree programme with lower costs, with the family's agreement. One of the informal loans was restructured at a lower rate through a cooperative. Over three years, the business stabilised at a size about sixty per cent of its previous peak, with fewer fixed costs and better margins.

Segun's own summary, given in a review conversation two years later, was as follows: *The money problem took three years to fix. The secrecy almost took everything. I lost the customer, the trust of my brother, and my son's confidence for a period, and none of those were caused by the money. They were caused by my determination that nobody would find out that I was not managing.*

The case illustrates the whole of this chapter, and four elements deserve emphasis.

The concealment was not for personal advantage. Every expenditure Segun maintained was for the benefit of others: fees, medical costs, family contributions, and the household standard. He concealed the position because disclosure would have required him to disappoint people, which he experienced as

a failure rather than a decision. This is one of the most common patterns in male financial difficulty, and it is the pattern in which concealment does most damage.

The identity was fused with the record. Segun's sense of himself was constructed from eleven years of expansion. To disclose the difficulty would have been to replace that identity with another one, publicly, and his actions were organised to prevent this from happening. Chapter 24 deals with this transition directly.

The costs that could not be recovered were relational. The debt was restructured, the business survived, the house was kept, and the education continued with adaptation. What did not recover quickly were the brother's regard, the wife's trust, and the son's sense of his father — all damaged not by the financial failure but by the twenty-eight months of concealment.

The reduction of the standard was survivable. The largest fear — that reducing the household standard would destroy his standing and his family's regard — was tested, and it did not occur. Eleven commitments were deleted; two were reinstated later; the community did not collapse. Most men who complete this exercise report the same outcome, and it is worth stating plainly because the fear is the principal obstacle: the disclosure of a financial position rarely produces the social death that men anticipate, and it frequently produces assistance, advice, and time that were not otherwise available.

7.8 Practical Exercise: The Worth and Performance Audit

This exercise has three parts and takes about two hours. It is best done in a single sitting, in writing, and it is frequently more useful when the results are discussed with one other person.

Part One: The Hidden Equations

Complete the following sentences with what you actually believe, not what you think you should believe.

- A man is only as good as _____.
- If I cannot provide _____, I will have failed as a man.
- My family's respect for me depends on _____.
- If people knew _____, they would think less of me.
- I would rather _____ than be seen as having failed.
- The last time I felt genuinely satisfied with something I achieved was _____.

Each of these sentences contains an implicit equation between what the man does and what he is worth. Write the equation out explicitly for each. For example: *My family's respect depends on my paying the fees* becomes *worth = paying the fees*.

Part Two: The Cost of the Equation

For each equation, answer three questions in writing.

1. **What has this equation cost me?** Consider sleep, health, honesty, the quality of relationships, decisions taken badly, opportunities not taken, and years spent in a state of preparation for exposure.
2. **What has it produced that is genuinely valuable?** Most of these equations began as something honourable: a commitment to family, a professional standard, a real responsibility. Identify what is worth keeping.
3. **How would a man act differently if his worth did not depend on results?** Be concrete. What would he say, refuse, buy, sell, confess, rest from, or start?

Part Three: The Revision

Write a statement of no more than 150 words, in the first person, describing the relationship you intend to hold between your performance and your worth. It must contain four elements.

- **An acceptance of responsibility**, including the specific responsibilities you intend to keep.
- **A statement that your worth does not depend on the outcome of those responsibilities.**
- **A specified action** that follows from the separation: reduce the standard in one area; tell one person the true position of the finances; delegate work you normally keep; take rest without justifying it; report a failure accurately and early.
- **A test** by which you will know whether the separation is being maintained: for example, being able to describe a setback without using the word *I* about it.

Part Four: The Failure Disclosure Rehearsal

For the failure you are currently concealing, or the one you most fear, complete the following account. It is the document referenced in Stage Three of Section 7.5, and it is designed to be written and used.

- **The facts.** What has happened, with dates and figures.
- **The position.** Assets, liabilities, obligations, and the number of months the situation can be sustained unchanged.
- **My part.** The decisions that were mine, stated plainly and without embellishment.
- **The plan.** Two specific actions, with dates.
- **The request.** What I am asking of the person I am telling: to listen, to help me think, to assist practically, or to hold me to the plan.

- **The next update.** The date on which I will report progress.

Appendix D provides the financial version of this worksheet, and Appendix E provides scripts for delivering it.

7.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"How do I tell my wife that the money is gone?"

Prepare the facts before the conversation: what is owed, to whom, at what rate, what the income is, what the obligations are, and how many months the position can be sustained unchanged. Then say what you want from her — to hear it, to help you think, or to act with you — and say when you will update her. The most common mistake is to disclose without a plan, which transfers panic rather than information, and the second most common is to disclose a softened version, which will be discovered and will cost more than the original difficulty. Appendix D provides the worksheet, and Appendix E provides the scripts.

"Should I sell an asset or borrow to cover the gap?"

This is a question for a competent financial adviser, and the general principle is that borrowing to maintain an unsustainable standard converts a difficulty into a disaster. Where a borrowing decision is genuinely marginal, three questions assist: does this loan reduce the total cost of the problem; does it have a defined repayment source; and does it postpone a necessary adjustment that will be larger later?

"What if I have already concealed it for a long time?"

The cost of concealment continues to rise after disclosure, which is the reason to disclose now rather than after one more quarter. Expect the first weeks to be difficult: anger, fear, questions, and — frequently — a demand to know why you did not say earlier. The answer should be the truth, which is usually that you were ashamed and did not want to disappoint anybody. The repair is completed by consistent honesty about the position from that point onwards, which is a matter of months rather than one conversation.

"How do I stop comparing myself with men who are doing better?"

Not by trying to stop noticing, which is not in your control, but by choosing the reference group deliberately and auditing the comparison with the four questions in Section 7.2. In practice, two changes do most of the work: identifying one or two men in your own field who have made the trade you refuse to make, and writing down your own standard rather than measuring yourself against other people's visible results.

"Is it a failure to reduce the family's standard of living?"

It is a decision with costs, several of which are real and visible. It is not a failure, and the evidence from men who have made it is that the consequences are rarely as severe as anticipated: the reduction is absorbed, some obligations are renegotiated

rather than abandoned, and the family's regard for the man is far more closely related to honesty during the process than to the standard maintained.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 7 in brief. The pressure to succeed operates through four components at once: economic necessity, social standing, the belief that one's value to the family is conditional on provision, and an internal standard harsher than anything externally imposed. Its distinctive feature is the locked-in effect: success raises expectations, costs rise faster than income, and the reduction of ambition comes to require a public admission that the man has organised his life to avoid.

What men fear when they fear failure is rarely poverty. It is the loss of standing, of usefulness, of the family's trust, and of self-respect. Each has a different remedy, and only the first responds to earning more.

Comparison harms men in two ways: through a spiral in which each attainment raises the reference standard rather than producing satisfaction, and through distorted assessments of one's own position that lead to bad decisions. The remedy is not the instruction to stop comparing but the systematic exposure of the comparison's five defects — incomparable inputs, selective presentation, trajectory versus moment, the trade one would not accept, and a reference group that can be chosen.

Financial failure delivers three losses at once: material, social, and identity. The behaviours that follow — concealment, over-trading to recover, withdrawal, and self-punishment through work — reliably make the failure worse. What can usually be recovered is income, capacity, and assets over time; what frequently cannot be recovered are the years spent concealing, the trust damaged by secrecy, and the relationships damaged during withdrawal.

Perfectionism and the fear of judgement are distinct patterns with a shared root: the fusion of act with identity. Perfectionism costs time, produces avoidance, destroys delegation, and transmits to children. The fear of judgement produces over-preparation, silence in meetings, avoidance of assessment, and — most expensively — the refusal to seek help for problems that would be resolved in a week by a competent professional. Four measures help: defining suffciency in advance, adopting the professional rather than the ideal standard, testing the feared judgement against evidence, and graduated exposure.

Recovery from a serious failure follows five stages: stop the bleeding by halting concealment-driven expenditure and protecting basic functions; establish the actual position on paper, including the number of months the situation can be sustained; report to one person with a prepared account; act on the two largest items rather than fifteen; and set a review date. The account given to others should contain the facts, the uncertainty, the plan, and the ownership of decisions — without the transfer of shame.

Finally, worth and performance can be separated by practice rather than by belief: changing the language from verdict to description, establishing a domain of value

that does not depend on results, keeping an evidence file, and accepting praise. Men who separate the two can lose a business, a job, or a contract and still act. Men who do not must protect an identity while managing a crisis, and the two requirements conflict — which is why concealment, over-trading, and collapse so often occur together.

Reflection Questions

1. Which of the four components of the pressure to succeed — economic, social, relational, or internal — is strongest in your life? How much of your current load would remain if the social component disappeared?
2. Take the four objects of the fear of failure in Table 7.1. Which one do you actually fear? What would addressing that specific fear require, and what would it not require?
3. Write down the last comparison that affected a decision you made. Apply the four questions from Section 7.2. Would you now make the same decision?
4. Section 7.3 lists the six thoughts that accompany financial failure. Which of them have you had, and how recently? Which one is doing the most work in your decisions at present?
5. Consider the perfectionism and judgement patterns in Section 7.4. In what area of your work do you refuse to hand over a task, and what has that refusal cost you in the last two years?
6. Complete Stage Two of Section 7.5 for your own position: how many months can the present situation be sustained unchanged? What did you feel on discovering the number?
7. In one sentence, describe the relationship you want between your performance and your worth. Then write what you will do this week that only a man holding that relationship could do.

Further Reading

- **On the psychology of failure:** the research literature on achievement motivation, attribution, and self-worth, including work on the difference between self-worth contingency on success and self-acceptance, and studies showing that people who attribute failure to specific and changeable causes recover more effectively than those who attribute it to fixed deficiencies of the self.
- **On comparison and social media:** the substantial recent literature on social comparison and well-being, including experimental studies showing that comparison with curated presentations of others' lives lowers mood and satisfaction.

- **On perfectionism:** the research on perfectionism and its consequences, including work distinguishing perfectionistic striving from perfectionistic concern, and studies on its relationship to procrastination, anxiety, and burnout.
- **On financial recovery:** practical literature on debt restructuring, personal financial planning, and small-business recovery, together with the financial counselling materials published by consumer and cooperative organisations in Nigeria and elsewhere.
- **On bankruptcy and insolvency:** the literature on the psychological effects of insolvency on men, including the effects on identity, marriage, and health, and the evidence that early disclosure and legal advice materially improve outcomes.
- **First-person accounts:** published accounts by men who lost businesses, professional standing, or savings, and rebuilt. These accounts supply the most convincing evidence available for the practical claim that serious failure is survivable and frequently instructive.

8 CHAPTER

The War Against Self-Doubt

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the experience of chronic inadequacy that persists despite objective achievement, and explain why it is so common among capable men.
2. Explain impostor feelings — the persistent expectation of exposure — and distinguish them from accurate self-assessment and from ordinary humility.
3. Trace the contribution of childhood criticism, comparison, and family expectation to adult self-doubt, and describe how such material is carried into professional life.
4. Identify the patterns of negative internal dialogue, recognise whose voice is speaking, and apply methods for examining and revising those statements.
5. Use the methods set out in the chapter and in Appendix H to build a realistic confidence that is grounded in evidence rather than in reassurance.
6. Work towards a healthier self-concept that neither inflates nor diminishes the man who holds it.

Introduction

There is a particular and uncomfortable kind of experience that many capable men recognise immediately when it is described, and almost never mention otherwise. It is the experience of being good at what you do and not believing it.

The man in question has held a responsible position for years. He has delivered results that other people could not have delivered. He has been promoted, referred to, praised, and depended upon. His professional judgement is sought. And privately, in the intervals of the day — in the car, in the shower, at the moment before sleep — he carries a set of beliefs about himself that contradict every piece of external evidence: that he has been fortunate, that the work was easier than it looked, that he is about to be asked a question he cannot answer, that the whole edifice is held up by a series of small improvisations, and that at some point somebody will notice.

This is the war against self-doubt, and it is fought privately, without allies, by men who frequently appear to be the most composed people in the room. It is not the same as modesty, which is a virtue, or as accurate self-assessment, which is a competence. It is a systematic error in the estimation of oneself, and it has consequences: it produces overwork, avoidance, refusal of opportunity, difficulty in resting, a lifelong inability to enjoy achievement, and, in a proportion of cases, a professional collapse produced not by incapacity but by fear.

This chapter describes the condition, traces where it comes from, and sets out what is known to help.

8.1 Feeling Inadequate Despite Achievement

The first task is to establish the nature of the pattern, because the men who experience it usually believe that they are the only ones, and that their private verdict about themselves is accurate while everybody else has been deceived.

The Structure of the Experience

Four features define the presentation.

A persistent gap between achievement and self-estimate. The man's record and his opinion of himself are not merely different; they are systematically opposed. This is not a matter of mood or of a bad week. It is a standing arrangement, present in good periods and bad.

Discounting of evidence. Achievements are attributed to factors other than ability: favourable circumstances, the difficulty being lower than it appeared, the support of others, the absence of real competition, or luck. The attributions are not absurd — every achievement does involve circumstances and help — but they are applied asymmetrically. When something goes wrong, the cause is internal (*my fault, my limitation*); when something goes right, the cause is external (*favourable circumstances*). This asymmetry is one of the best-documented patterns in the psychology of achievement, and it is the engine of the whole condition.

Anticipation of exposure. The man expects that his actual capacity will be discovered. The discovery is imagined in specific forms: the question he cannot answer, the task he cannot perform, the mistake that will be found, the challenger who will displace him. The anticipation is continuous and produces a low-level physical vigilance described in Chapter 5.

A prohibition on enjoyment. Success does not yield satisfaction. It yields relief, followed immediately by the next requirement. Men in this pattern frequently report that they cannot recall a period of genuine professional contentment, and the inability is not a memory problem; there has been no period to remember.

Why Capable Men Are Particularly Affected

One of the paradoxes of the subject is that self-doubt is at least as common among the highly capable as among those of modest attainment, and in some settings it is more common. Four reasons explain this.

The standard rises with the position. A man operating at a higher level is surrounded by more capable people, engages with more difficult problems, and confronts the boundary of his competence more frequently than a man in a simpler role. He therefore encounters evidence of his own limits daily, while the evidence of his own competence is old and familiar and has been discounted long ago.

Errors become more consequential and more visible. At a senior level, mistakes are larger, they affect more people, and they are more likely to be discussed. The experience of making consequential errors is experienced as confirmation of inadequacy rather than as the ordinary condition of responsibility.

Feedback becomes rarer and less candid. Junior staff receive correction, coaching, and grading. Senior men receive deference, agreement, and silence. A man who no longer receives honest feedback loses his calibration, and in the absence of information the mind supplies its own estimates, which are rarely generous.

Responsibility outruns authority and knowledge. Most senior positions require a person to take decisions of a kind for which nobody has been fully prepared, with incomplete information, under time pressure, in areas beyond his expertise, and to be accountable for consequences that he cannot fully control. This is not a perception; it is the actual structure of senior work. It produces a genuine and permanent uncertainty that a man misinterprets as evidence that he is a fraud.

The Distinction from Accurate Self-Assessment

It is essential to separate this pattern from a more realistic attitude, which is not a disorder and should not be discouraged.

Accurate self-assessment includes knowing what one does well, knowing what one does badly, recognising the limits of one's knowledge, and being able to say so. A competent professional standard is full of statements of the form *I do not know, and I will find out.* Such a man is not suffering from self-doubt. He is displaying the intellectual humility described in Chapter 32.

The distinguishing marks of the problematic condition are the asymmetry (errors attributed to the self, successes to circumstance), the permanence (the verdict does not change with evidence), and the anticipated exposure (the belief that discovery is coming).

Figure 8.1 sets out the four layers in which men ordinarily describe themselves. The difficulties produced by self-doubt arise from the collapse of the outer layers into the innermost one: a man who cannot distinguish his role from his identity, or his reputation from his worth, will experience every professional setback as a personal verdict.

Figure 8.1 Four layers in the description of a man. Self-doubt operates by collapsing the outer layers into the innermost, so that a professional or social judgement is experienced as a verdict on identity.

KEY POINT

The problem is not the presence of doubt. Every competent person has doubt. The problem is the arrangement in which doubt is permanent, achievements are discounted, errors are taken as disclosures of the truth about the self, and exposure is continually expected.

8.2 Impostor Feelings and Insecurity

The pattern described above is commonly called the impostor experience: the persistent sense of being less capable than one's position implies, accompanied by the fear of being found out. The description is useful because it has been widely studied, and three findings of that research matter practically.

It is very common, including among high achievers. Studies across professions — medicine, academia, engineering, business, the arts — consistently find that a large proportion of successful people report the experience, and that it is not correlated with actual incompetence. A man in this position should take a specific and factual reassurance from this literature: the experience is evidence about the human mind and about particular social environments, not about his ability.

It does not improve with achievement. The pattern usually intensifies with seniority, for the reasons set out in Section 8.1: more visible errors, rarer honest feedback, wider responsibility, and a reference group of more capable people.

It is associated with overwork and with avoidance of opportunity. Two costly responses are common. Men in the pattern work excessive hours, checking, preparing, and rehearsing, because thoroughness is the only available defence. And they decline or fail to pursue opportunities that would expose them to assessment — a promotion with a probationary period, a public presentation, a competitive examination, a business expansion — because the risk of exposure surpasses the value of the advancement. The second behaviour is the more damaging, and it is the one that most frequently produces the outcome the man fears, in the form of a career that plateaus for reasons that are internal rather than external.

Insecurity and the Male Presentation

The word *insecurity* is used loosely in ordinary speech and deserves precision. Insecurity is not the presence of uncertainty about oneself; it is the presence of uncertainty combined with the absence of any capacity to tolerate it. The secure man does not know whether he will succeed; he can proceed anyway. The insecure man does not know whether he will succeed, and he cannot proceed without resolving the uncertainty — through reassurance, through control, through preparation, or through the avoidance of the situation entirely.

The male presentation of insecurity is recognisable and frequently misunderstood by those around the man.

Table 8.1 The male presentation of insecurity. Each item is a behaviour that is usually read as evidence of strength.

Behaviour	What it looks like to others	What it frequently is
Overwork and long hours	Dedication	A defence against being found out
Refusal to delegate	High standards	Fear that others' work will expose the standard
Reluctance to speak in meetings	Reserve or authority	Fear of a question that cannot be answered
Defensiveness about correction	Pride	Exposure of the material the man most fears

Behaviour	What it looks like to others	What it frequently is
Control of details	Thoroughness	Anxiety management
Discomfort with praise	Modesty	Disbelief, and the discomfort of a claim that cannot be accepted
Avoidance of assessment	Confidence in existing achievements	Fear of an unmanageable verdict
Aggressiveness about status	Ambition	A permanent attempt to establish a position that never feels secure

The table has a practical purpose: it tells the reader that the behaviours he may have cultivated as defences are legible to careful observers. Colleagues at senior levels frequently perceive the pattern, even when they cannot name it.

What Does Not Help

Three common pieces of advice are ineffective, and a man should be warned about them.

Reassurance. Being told that one is capable produces relief that lasts hours. The belief is not corrected by testimony from others, because the man discounts the testimony in the way described in Section 8.1: *she says that because she does not know the details.*

Correction by achievement. The pattern does not respond to further success. Each new success is discounted, and the standard is revised upward.

Instruction to lower one's standards. Men in this pattern frequently hear that they should be less demanding of themselves. The advice misconceives the difficulty: the standard is not the problem, and the man's adherence to a high standard is one of the things that makes him effective. What requires correction is the accounting — the attribution of successes to luck and failures to the self.

What Does Help

What helps is a change in the method by which a man judges himself. Four practices are developed in Section 8.5 and in Appendix H: keeping an evidence file, changing the standard of evidence, separating the task from the self, and graded exposure to being seen. Before those methods are described, it is necessary to look at where the pattern came from, because the source determines the most effective intervention.

8.3 The Influence of Childhood Criticism

Most men who carry persistent self-doubt can identify its origin with little difficulty, once they are asked the right question. The question is not *Were you criticised as a child?*, because almost everybody was. It is: *Was there a period in which your performance determined the emotional temperature of your home?*

The Five Patterns That Produce It

Research and clinical experience point to five patterns. They frequently overlap, and a man may recognise several.

Performance-conditional affection. The child's experience that approval is received for what he does and withdrawn for what he fails to do. The pattern is rarely cruel. It frequently consists of ordinary behaviour: congratulations for results followed by silence, or a mild disappointment visible in a parent's face after a poor report, or the practical rewards of success and the absence of rewards for anything else. The child draws a reasonable conclusion: *I am valued for results, and therefore my worth varies with my performance.*

A chronically dissatisfied or critical parent. A parent who is never satisfied — whose response to success is the identification of what could have been better, and whose response to failure is a verdict on the child's character — produces a durable internal critic. It matters less whether the criticism was frequent than whether it was unpredictable and whether anything was ever sufficient.

Comparing siblings or peers. Explicit comparison — *your brother is not like this; look at your classmate's result* — is common in many cultures and is intended to motivate. Its effect is to establish an external standard against which the child is permanently measured, and to teach that the comparison never ends.

Humiliation at school or among peers. An experience of public exposure — a mocking teacher, a failure in front of the class, a punishment for an error, a bullying episode organised around a perceived deficiency — can produce a durable expectation of exposure that generalises far beyond the original situation.

Adverse family circumstances that required the child to be useful. Where a father dies, a mother is ill, a family loses its income, or parents separate, an older child is frequently drawn into responsibility earlier than his development would suggest, and learns that he is valued for what he contributes. The experience produces competence and, frequently, the permanent sense that his place in the family depends on his usefulness. Chapter 19 examines this in detail.

What the Material Becomes in Adult Life

The specific statements of childhood frequently persist into adulthood in forms that the man no longer recognises as inherited. Four transformations are common.

The statement becomes a rule. *You will never amount to anything* becomes an adult operating rule: never be idle, never be without a plan, never be vulnerable to a verdict. The rule is followed as though it were a sound principle, and its origin is forgotten.

The voice becomes generic. The critic's sentences become the man's own inner commentary, spoken without an identifiable speaker. Men frequently

cannot say whose voice it is until they are asked to write it down and read it aloud, at which point the resemblance — a phrase, a tone, a particular word — becomes apparent.

The standard becomes impossible rather than high. A parent who is never satisfied teaches a child that no result is sufficient. In adult life, this manifests as a standard that moves with each achievement, producing the spiral described in Chapter 7.

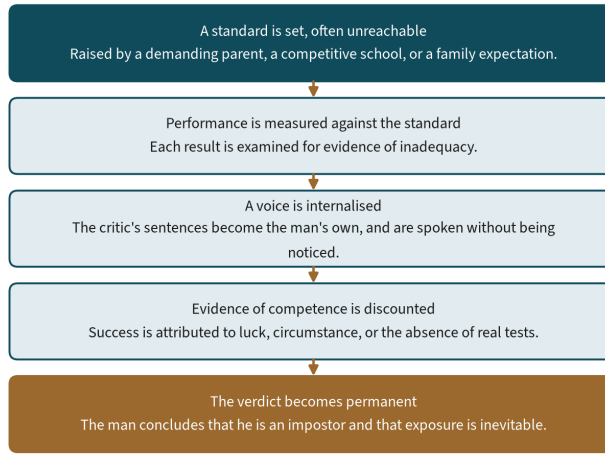
The material becomes self-verifying. A man who expects inadequacy to be exposed behaves in ways that make exposure more likely: he works excessive hours and burns out; he avoids situations that would develop his capability; he accepts responsibilities beyond his capacity to demonstrate worth; and he interprets ordinary correction as confirmation. The behaviours then produce evidence, and the original belief appears to have been correct all along.

The Two Necessary Corrections

Two corrections are required, and neither involves blaming the parents, which is neither useful nor accurate in most cases.

The first correction is of meaning, not of memory. The events happened, and many of them were ordinary rather than abusive. What requires revision is the inference the child drew: that his worth was conditional on performance. In the great majority of cases the inference was the child's, formed from limited information, and adopted because it made sense of the world at the time. The adult has more information — including the fact that his parents were themselves operating under standards imposed on them — and can therefore revise the inference without falsifying the history.

The second correction is of method. If the internal standard cannot be removed, the process by which a man evaluates himself can be changed. This is the substance of Sections 8.5 and 8.6 and of Appendix H, and it is the part of the work that produces results, because it does not depend on resolving the past.



The formation of the internal critic, and the process by which genuine achievement ceases to count.

Figure 8.2 The formation of the internal critic and the process by which genuine achievement ceases to count. The critical feature is stage four: the systematic discounting of evidence that contradicts the verdict.

KEY POINT

Chronic self-doubt is usually learned, usually early, and usually outlives the conditions that produced it. Because it is a learned system of accounting rather than a fixed trait, it can be revised by practice — and the revision does not require the original critic to be confronted, forgiven, or even discussed.

8.4 Negative Internal Dialogue

The internal critic operates through speech. It produces sentences, and the sentences have identifiable forms. Learning to notice them is the practical entry point to the whole subject.

The Six Standard Forms

The following six patterns account for the majority of the automatic statements men report. They are adapted from the well-established cognitive literature on thinking traps, and they are worth memorising, because recognition precedes revision.

All-or-nothing judgements. *If it is not perfect, it is worthless. If I did not lead the project, I contributed nothing. If I lose this client, I am finished.* The pattern converts a spectrum of outcomes into two categories, one of which is failure.

Magnification of the negative. A single error, a single critical remark, a single poor result is given a weight far exceeding its significance, and it is placed at the centre of the man's attention.

Minimisation of the positive. *It was not difficult. Anyone with my resources would have done it. He was only being polite. The circumstances helped.* The practice is so habitual that it is frequently invisible to the man performing it.

Mind-reading. *They think I am not up to it. He is disappointed in me. She has lost confidence in me.* The man infers other people's judgements without evidence, and the inferences are consistently unflattering.

Catastrophising. *If this goes wrong, the family is finished. If they find the error, I will lose everything. If I fail this examination, my life is over.* The pattern takes a specific risk and attaches to it a total consequence.

Labelling. From a specific event, a permanent identity is inferred: *I am a fraud. I am useless. I am the kind of man who cannot manage.* The label is then used as evidence in subsequent judgements, which produces a closed system.

Recognising Whose Voice It Is

A practical technique that men frequently report to be decisive consists of writing down the ten or fifteen sentences that the internal critic produces most often, and then asking four questions about each.

1. **Whose voice does this sentence sound like?** A parent, a teacher, a supervisor, a former spouse, a peer group, or the man himself.
2. **How old is the sentence?** Do these words date from the present, or from a period that has ended?
3. **Would I say this to my son, my daughter, or a young colleague?** If not, what does the refusal reveal?
4. **What is the evidence, and what would a fair observer conclude?** This is the corrective step, and it is developed in Section 8.5.

The second question is frequently the most powerful. Men who discover that the sentence now producing their daily distress was composed by a person who has been dead for a decade, or by a teacher whose name they barely remember, consistently describe the discovery as altering their relationship with the sentence. It does not remove it, but it demotes it from truth to testimony.

The internal critic	A realistic internal voice
You will never manage this	This is difficult, and I have handled difficult things before
They will find out eventually what you are	I have evidence of competence, and I also have limits
Anyone could have done what you did	The work I did was mine, and it produced the result it produced
You were lucky, not capable	Circumstances helped, and my decisions contributed
One mistake and they will all know	Mistakes are expected, and mine have been survivable so far

Figure 8.3 Two internal dialogues. The left-hand column is the critic's standard output; the right-hand column is what the same events would sound like if described accurately by a fair observer.

The Rule About Disputation

A caution is necessary, because the methods in this chapter are frequently misapplied. The objective is **not** to replace every critical thought with a positive one. Positive affirmations that contradict a man's evidence base are rejected by him immediately and produce additional failure experience.

The objective is **accuracy**. A man revising a catastrophic prediction does not tell himself that everything will be fine; he establishes what would actually happen if the feared event occurred — usually a difficulty rather than a catastrophe — and he replaces the total claim with a specific one. This is the difference between confidence as a posture and confidence as an accurate estimate, and only the second survives contact with reality.

8.5 Building Realistic Confidence

Confidence is not a feeling that arrives; it is an estimate that is built. A realistic confidence has three components — an accurate inventory of capability, a working tolerance of being seen, and experience of survivable failure — and each is constructed by a method.

Method One: The Evidence File

The single most effective practice for men in this pattern is the maintenance of a written record that contradicts the critic's account. The method is as follows.

Once a week, record five items in a document kept for the purpose.

- **What I did.** The specific work performed, described without evaluation.
- **What resulted.** The outcome, as an observer would state it.
- **What was mine.** The decisions, skills, and judgements that were actually the man's contribution.
- **What others said.** Direct quotations, recorded at the time, rather than paraphrases from memory.
- **What I found difficult.** An honest entry, because a record containing only successes will be dismissed as fantasy.

The purpose of the file is not reassurance but evidence. Its function appears at the moment of a setback, when the memory supplies a selective account of failures and the file supplies the rest. Men who maintain such a record for six months consistently report that the critic's verdicts become harder to hold.

Method Two: Changing the Standard of Evidence

Men with chronic self-doubt apply a higher standard of proof to evidence of their own competence than to evidence of their inadequacy. The remedy is to establish and apply a consistent standard.

The working standard proposed for this purpose is: **what would a fair observer, with the same information and no personal interest, conclude?** The standard requires the man to include in the evidence base the inputs (circumstances, resources, and luck) as well as the outcomes, and to exclude the special pleading in both directions. Men who apply it usually find that the fair conclusion is neither the critic's verdict nor a flattering one, but something specific: *he is competent at this kind of work; he is not experienced in that kind; he made a poor decision on this occasion.*

Method Three: Separating the Task from the Self

The core operation of self-doubt is the collapse of a task evaluation into an identity statement. *The proposal was rejected* becomes *I am not capable.* The method consists of restoring the separation in language, systematically, until it becomes habitual.

Table 8.2 Rewriting verdicts as descriptions. The method is not positive thinking; it is the removal of a conclusion that the evidence does not support.

The critic's version	The accurate version
I failed.	The tender was lost. The pricing was wrong.

The critic's version	The accurate version
I am a fraud.	I do not know this subject as well as the two specialists in the room.
They will find out.	They already know I am not an expert; that is why I was hired for what I am good at.
I cannot manage this.	This is beyond my current capacity, and I know two people who could help.
I am useless at this.	I have not been trained in this, and I can be.

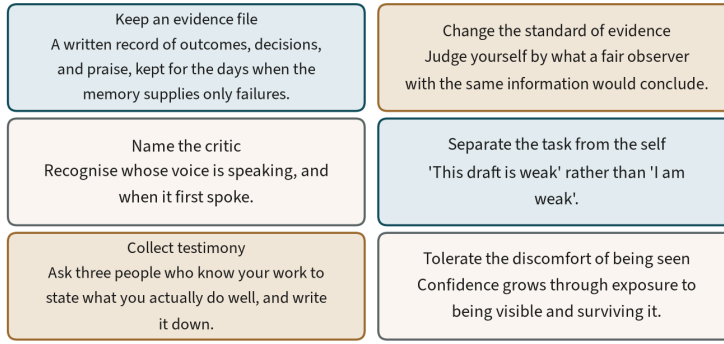
Method Four: Graded Exposure to Being Seen

Confidence grows through experience, and the relevant experience is being visible and surviving it. Because the pattern is maintained by avoidance, the corrective requires a deliberate programme of graduated exposure, and it should be conducted in steps small enough that each is survivable.

A typical sequence for a man in a professional setting runs as follows, and readers should construct their own with steps calibrated to their circumstances.

1. **Ask one question in a meeting** where the answer is not known in advance, and state the reason for asking.
2. **Say "I do not know,"** once, in a professional setting, and add what you will do to find out.
3. **Delegate one item of work** and accept it back done differently.
4. **Present something imperfect** — a draft, a preliminary plan, an unfinished analysis — to a colleague for comment before it is complete.
5. **Take on a piece of work at the limit of your competence**, in the presence of someone experienced.
6. **Report an error** to a supervisor or client before it is discovered.

Men who carry out such a programme report a consistent result: the feared verdict does not arrive, the difficulty is smaller than anticipated, and the relief is considerable. When the feared verdict does arrive — a correction, a criticism, or a failure — the experience is equally instructive, because it demonstrates that a negative verdict is survivable, which is the fact that the whole pattern was constructed to deny.



Methods for building realistic confidence, drawn from cognitive behavioural practice.

Figure 8.4 Practical methods for building realistic confidence. The fifth and sixth items are the ones men most often leave out, and the ones that most reliably change what a man believes about himself.

What Confidence Is Not

Two clarifications prevent misapplication. Realistic confidence is not the elimination of doubt: capable men remain aware of their limits, and the awareness is one of the reasons they are capable. And it is not a change in personality: a man may remain reserved, quiet, and unassuming, and still be confident in the sense used here, which concerns the accuracy of his self-assessment and his capacity to act on it.

8.6 Developing a Healthier Self-Concept

The final section widens the frame from confidence to self-concept, which is the underlying arrangement of beliefs a man holds about himself.

The Structure of a Self-Concept

A self-concept is not a single opinion. It is a set of evaluations across multiple domains, and it is more robust when it is diversified. A man whose self-evaluation is concentrated in one domain — his professional results, his income, his physical capability, or his role in the family — is exposed to a total collapse if that domain fails. A man whose self-evaluation is distributed across several domains — work, family, friendship, health, faith, craft, community — possesses a portfolio, and the failure of one element is survivable.

A practical implication follows, and it is one of the most useful in the book: **a man in chronic self-doubt should deliberately invest in at least one domain of competence that is unrelated to his professional identity.** A skill practised for its own sake — a craft, a sport, a language, a musical instrument, gardening, cooking, a technical competence with no commercial application — provides an

independent source of evidence about capability, and it is not vulnerable to the professional verdicts that dominate the primary domain.

The Three Distortions to Correct

Three distortions are characteristic of the self-concepts of men with chronic self-doubt, and each can be addressed directly.

The global self. The tendency to evaluate the whole self from a single event. The corrective is specificity: statements about the self should be limited to the domain and the period to which the evidence applies. *I handled that negotiation badly* rather than *I am poor at relationships*. *I am behind on this project* rather than *I am disorganised*.

The permanent self. The assumption that present states are permanent: *I have always been like this; this is who I am.* The corrective is the historical record, which almost always shows change, development, and the acquisition of capabilities that the man did not previously possess.

The compared self. The tendency to define the self chiefly through comparison, as described in Chapter 7. The corrective is the establishment of a personal standard, written down, against which the man assesses himself before he considers anybody else's position.

The Practice of Self-Compassion

The last element of a healthier self-concept is a practice that men frequently resist until they understand it, and it is worth explaining with care because it is misunderstood as self-indulgence.

Self-compassion consists of treating one's own failures with the same honesty and the same decency that one would apply to a colleague. It has three components: recognising one's own suffering accurately rather than dismissing it; understanding that failure and limitation are shared human conditions rather than personal defects; and addressing oneself with the accurate, constructive language one would use with somebody else rather than the language of contempt.

Self-compassion is frequently misread by men as lowering standards. The evidence points the other way: people who treat their own failures with decency are more willing to attempt difficult things, more willing to acknowledge errors, more persistent after setbacks, and less likely to conceal problems — all of which improve performance. Self-contempt, by contrast, produces concealment, avoidance, and overwork, which are exactly the behaviours that maintain the pattern this chapter describes.

A Closing Note

The war against self-doubt does not end in a victory ceremony. What happens instead is that the accounting becomes fair. A man begins to know what he is good at and what he is not, to hold both with reasonable equanimity, to describe his

work without a verdict about his person, and to be visible without anticipating exposure. The change is neither dramatic nor complete. It is durable, it is cumulative, and it is built entirely out of small, recorded pieces of evidence — which is why the exercise that follows this section consists of nothing more elaborate than keeping and examining a record.

8.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Years Before the Obvious Question

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in occupational psychology, professional mentoring, and clinical practice.

Dr Femi is forty-eight, a medical specialist in a state teaching hospital with seventeen years of experience. He trained abroad, holds a fellowship, has published research, and teaches residents. He is regarded by colleagues as meticulous and by his juniors as unapproachable.

For nine years he has carried a private conviction. He believes that his appointment to the hospital was a mistake; that his research output has been thin; that his clinical judgment is adequate rather than good; and that at some point a case will expose him completely. He has never mentioned this to anybody, including his wife and including the colleague with whom he trained.

The conviction has organised his working life in four ways.

First, he prepares to an extreme degree. Before a complex case, he reviews the literature for several hours, and he rehearse his reasoning aloud, alone, so that he will not hesitate if questioned.

Second, he does not pursue opportunities. Twice he declined invitations to take up a regional advisory role, and on a third occasion he did not apply for a position he was qualified for. In each case he gave a practical reason relating to family commitments, and each reason was at least partly true, which is how the pattern survived.

Third, he does not delegate work that touches his reputation, particularly documentation, which means that he works about sixty hours a week and has not taken an annual leave of more than a week in five years.

Fourth, he is remote with junior colleagues. He avoids teaching at the bedside where he might be asked a question he cannot answer, and he has acquired a reputation for formality which he does not recognise as fear.

Two events changed the arrangement. The first was an error: a misreading of an imaging study, discovered by a resident, which led to a delay in treatment of two days. The patient recovered fully. The error was reported, discussed, and closed within a week. Femi described the following fortnight as the worst of his professional life, and it was during this period that he first considered leaving medicine entirely.

The second was a conversation, at the hospital's departmental review, with a senior colleague who mentioned, in the course of a general discussion about training, that

he had himself felt like a fraud for the first fifteen years of his career and had assumed that everybody in the room knew something he did not.
Femi said, in the only disclosure he made, that he had felt that way for nine years. The colleague's response — an ordinary and immediate *of course, we all do, and the ones who do not are the dangerous ones* — was, in Femi's account, the single most useful clinical intervention he had ever received.
He subsequently made three changes, and he described them as follows: he began a file recording what he had actually done each week, which supplied evidence that contradicted his estimate; he accepted a teaching commitment at the bedside, having decided that being asked a question he could not answer once a week was a smaller cost than the years he had spent avoiding it; and he saw a psychologist for eight sessions, during which he examined where the standard had come from and what it had cost him.

Five features of this case are worth isolating, and each corresponds to a section of the chapter.

The pattern was invisible and was read as virtue. Meticulous preparation, long hours, high standards, and refusal to delegate are read by institutions as excellence. In Femi's case, and in the experience of many men, the very behaviours that were destroying his quality of life were being rewarded.

The cost was measured in opportunities declined, not decisions failed. The most consequential losses were invisible: the advisory roles, the promotion, the five years without proper leave, and the teaching he did not do. Chapter 7 identified this pattern as the most expensive feature of the fear of judgement, and this case demonstrates it.

The error was survivable, including the exposure. The feared event occurred: a genuine mistake, found out by somebody junior, discussed by others. The outcome was a fortnight of distress and a full recovery. This is the experiential evidence that men in this pattern lack, and it is the reason that graded exposure is the central method of Section 8.5.

The disclosure was made to a peer, in an ordinary conversation. Not to a counsellor, and not to his wife, at least not first. The most effective intervention in the case was an unremarkable observation by an older colleague who had himself been through the pattern. This is one of the reasons that mentoring relationships and honest conversation among men in the same profession are treated in this book as substantive health measures rather than as pleasant extras.

The origin was examined and the practice was changed. Femi's work had two components, and both mattered: an inquiry into where the standard came from, and a set of concrete practices — the evidence file, the deliberate exposure,

the weekly questions — that changed the accounting. The second component produced the results.

8.8 Practical Exercise: The Critic's File

This exercise has four parts and is designed to be worked at over a period of four weeks. It is written for a man with a demanding schedule, and each part takes less than an hour.

Part One: The Critic's Sentences (Week One)

Over the next seven days, carry a small notebook or use a note application, and record every automatic statement about yourself that appears in response to work, family, or social situations. Record it verbatim, without correcting or evaluating it. Aim for between fifteen and thirty statements.

At the end of the week, review the list, and group the statements under the six headings from Section 8.4: all-or-nothing judgements, magnification of the negative, minimisation of the positive, mind-reading, catastrophising, and labelling.

Then answer, in writing:

- Which form appears most frequently?
- Whose voice does the most frequent statement sound like?
- How old is that sentence, and when did it first speak?

Part Two: The Evidence File (Weeks Two and Three)

For two weeks, complete the following five-line entry once a week, on the same day.

1. **What I did** (describe the work, without evaluation).
2. **What resulted** (as an observer would state it).
3. **What was actually mine** (decisions, judgements, skills).
4. **What others said** (direct quotations where possible).
5. **What I found difficult** (an honest, specific entry).

The purpose is to produce evidence that the critic has not accounted for.

Part Three: The Fair Observer Test (Week Four)

Select the three most consequential situations from the previous month in which your self-estimate was negative. For each, complete the following.

Question	Your answer
What happened, in facts?	
What did I conclude about myself?	
What did I attribute the outcome to?	
What would a fair observer with the same information conclude?	
What is the accurate statement?	

Then write the accurate statement in the first person, in no more than fifteen words, and keep it where you will see it during the following week.

Part Four: The Exposure Plan

Choose four actions, arranged from easiest to hardest, from the list in Section 8.5, and write them into your calendar with dates. For each, record:

- **The action.**
- **The date.**
- **What I predict will happen.**
- **What actually happened.**

The final column is the substance of the exercise. Men who complete it frequently find, on reviewing the predictions against the outcomes, that the gap between them is the largest single source of their self-doubt — and the gap is measurable, which means it can be reduced.

Two Voices Worth Distinguishing

Work with the internal critic is easier when two things that men habitually merge are separated: the **critic** and the **standard**.

The critic is the voice described throughout this chapter: global, personal, permanent, and concerned with the verdict on the man. Its sentences begin with *you are* and they apply to everything.

The standard is the man's own assessment of what good work, responsible fatherhood, or a properly conducted life requires. Its statements are specific, they are concerned with the work rather than the person, and they are directed at improvement. Its sentences begin with *this is not right yet* or *that should be done differently*, and they are the reason the man's work improves at all.

The two voices frequently use identical material. Both, for example, may object to a report that was submitted late. The critic concludes that the man is unserious and will never amount to anything and that the incident confirms everything. The standard concludes that the deadline was missed, that the cause was the man's habit of leaving the final drafting to the last week, and that the practice should change. The registered tone may be similar; the consequences are entirely different. One produces paralysis, concealment, and the deferral of the next task; the other produces a change in procedure.

Three practical implications follow. First, when the critic speaks, the man should ask the diagnostic question introduced in Section 8.4: is this sentence about the work or about me? Where it is about him, the sentence is not information and should be treated as an event rather than a finding. Second, the standard should be preserved deliberately, because men who attempt to silence the whole internal commentary frequently lose their standards along with the critic, and become less effective and less careful as a result. Third, the standard should be

written down, since a written standard is specific, revisable, and operational, while an internalised standard is indistinguishable from the critic's general complaints. The exercise in Section 8.8 is designed to produce exactly this separation, and the men who complete it commonly report that the written standard is the most durable of its outputs.

A Note on Professional Support

Where the pattern is accompanied by persistent low mood, by anxiety that interferes with sleep or work, by a history of childhood criticism that was severe or violent, or by any thought of self-harm, the methods above should be undertaken alongside professional support rather than instead of it. Chapter 35 describes how to obtain it, and Appendix H provides the extended version of the cognitive methods used in this exercise.

8.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is this not simply humility, and is humility not a virtue?"

Humility is accurate self-assessment held with modesty: knowing what one does well and what one does not, and not requiring others to be told. Self-doubt is inaccurate self-assessment held with anxiety: discounting real competence, attributing errors to identity, and anticipating exposure. The distinction is testable. A humble man can accept a compliment and continue working; a man in this pattern discounts the compliment and works harder in order not to be found out.

"Will anything change if I simply ignore it and keep performing?"

Performance does not resolve the pattern, because the pattern discounts performance. What typically happens over a period of years is a widening gap between the man's objective record and his estimate of himself, and an increasing reliance on defensiveness, overwork, and control. In a proportion of cases this ends in a collapse produced by exhaustion rather than by incapacity — a resignation, a withdrawal, a period of illness, or a decision to abandon a career in which the man is genuinely competent.

"Is it not arrogant to believe in my own ability?"

The opposite of a distorted negative estimate is not a distorted positive one; it is an accurate estimate. A man who says that he is competent at his work, that he made a poor decision on Tuesday, and that he does not know a particular subject is making three claims that are all verifiable. Confidence of that kind is not arrogance; it is calibration, and it is the basis on which other people can rely on him.

"How do I stop the voice when it speaks at three in the morning?"

You do not, and attempting to is part of the problem. What reduces the volume is the daytime work: recording the sentences, identifying whose voice they are, testing them against evidence, and accumulating experience of being visible and

surviving. Men who do that work for a few months report that the nocturnal version of the critic loses its authority even when the sentences remain.

"What if my father, or my teacher, was right about me?"

Then the record will show it, and a fair observer applying the standard in Section 8.5 will conclude accordingly — with one important qualification: a fair observer assesses the whole record rather than a selected part, and assesses particular competences rather than the person as a whole. In the author's experience with men who complete this exercise, the verdict that survives is rarely the one the critic gave, and it is never as global as the critic's.

"Do I need a therapist to do this work?"

Many men complete it through reading, writing, and conversation with a mentor or peer. Professional support is warranted where the pattern is accompanied by low mood, anxiety affecting sleep or work, a history of severe or violent criticism in childhood, trauma, or any thought of self-harm, and it is also warranted where a man has attempted the work and found the distress increasing rather than reducing.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 8 in brief. Chronic self-doubt is the persistent experience of being capable and disbelieving it. It has four features: a standing gap between achievement and self-estimate; the systematic discounting of evidence, in which successes are attributed to circumstance and failures to the self; the continuous anticipation of exposure; and the inability to enjoy achievement, so that success produces relief rather than satisfaction.

Capable men are particularly affected, for four structural reasons. The standard rises with the position; errors become larger and more visible; honest feedback becomes rarer as seniority increases; and senior responsibility genuinely outruns the knowledge and authority required to discharge it, producing a real uncertainty that men misread as evidence of fraudulence. The condition must be distinguished from accurate self-assessment, which includes knowing one's limits, and from intellectual humility, both of which are strengths.

Impostor feelings are common across all professions, including among high achievers, and they do not diminish with success. They are associated with two costly behaviours: overwork as a defence against discovery, and the avoidance of opportunities that would invite assessment. The male presentation of insecurity is frequently legible to others while being misread as strength by those who lack the key: overwork as dedication, refusal to delegate as high standards, silence in meetings as authority, defensiveness as pride.

Self-doubt is usually learned early, through five patterns: performance-conditional affection, chronically dissatisfied or critical parenting, comparison with siblings or peers, humiliation at school, and adverse family circumstances that required the child to be useful. Its adult legacy is that statements become rules, the voice becomes

anonymous, the standard becomes impossible rather than merely high, and the belief becomes self-verifying through the behaviours it produces. Two corrections are required: a correction of meaning rather than of memory, and a correction of method rather than of history.

Negative internal dialogue takes six standard forms: all-or-nothing judgements, magnification of the negative, minimisation of the positive, mind-reading, catastrophising, and labelling. Recognising the form and identifying whose voice is speaking demotes the statement from truth to testimony, which is the necessary first step. The objective of revision is accuracy, not positivity: positive affirmations that contradict the evidence are rejected and produce further failure experience.

Realistic confidence is built by four methods: an evidence file recording what was done, what resulted, what was the man's own contribution, what others said, and what was difficult; a consistent standard of evidence, applied as a fair observer would apply it; the separation of task from self through the rewriting of verdicts as descriptions; and graded exposure to being seen, in steps small enough that each is survivable. Confidence is not the elimination of doubt, and it does not require a change of personality.

A healthier self-concept is diversified across domains rather than concentrated in one, so that the failure of one element is survivable; it corrects three characteristic distortions — the global self, the permanent self, and the compared self; and it is maintained through self-compassion, understood not as indulgence but as the accurate and decent treatment of one's own failures, which the evidence associates with greater persistence, more willingness to acknowledge error, and less concealment.

Reflection Questions

1. Section 8.1 identifies four features of the pattern. Which applies to you most strongly? Describe the most recent occasion on which a success was attributed to circumstance rather than to yourself, and the most recent occasion on which a failure was attributed to the self.
2. Read Table 8.1 again. Which of the eight behaviours have you cultivated, and how is each read by the people around you? What would it cost you to reduce one of them?
3. Of the five childhood patterns in Section 8.3, which fits your history? What inference did you draw as a child, and what would a fair observer conclude now, with the information you have as an adult?
4. Write down the three sentences your internal critic produces most often. Whose voice is speaking, and how old are the sentences?
5. Apply the fair observer test to the last significant setback you experienced. What is the accurate statement, in fifteen words or fewer?

6. Which of the four confidence methods have you never attempted? What is the smallest version of that method that you could complete in the coming fortnight?
7. What domain of competence do you have that is entirely independent of your professional identity? If the answer is none, what would you like it to be, and when will you begin?

Further Reading

- **On impostor feelings:** the research literature on the impostor phenomenon, including studies of its prevalence among high achievers and its relationship to overwork and the avoidance of opportunity. The work on its incidence in medicine, academia, and engineering is particularly relevant to professional readers.
- **On cognitive methods:** the literature on cognitive behavioural therapy as applied to self-criticism, including the well-developed self-help literature, together with the work on cognitive distortions and the techniques for identifying and revising automatic thoughts.
- **On self-compassion:** the research literature on self-compassion, including the finding that it is associated with greater persistence, more willingness to acknowledge errors, and lower avoidance, and the distinction between self-compassion and self-indulgence.
- **On childhood origins:** the literature on parenting style, conditional regard, and the development of self-esteem, together with clinical work on the internalisation of critical parental voices.
- **On confidence and competence:** the research on accurate self-assessment, including the well-documented finding that the least capable tend to overestimate their ability while the most capable tend to underestimate it — a finding of direct relevance to the reader who suspects he is the exception.
- **First-person accounts:** published accounts by professionals — physicians, academics, engineers, business leaders — of their own doubts, which are frequently of more practical use to a man in this position than the research literature, because they supply the language and the evidence that he is not alone.

PART III

The Financial Battles Men Fight

Money, responsibility, survival, and the pressure to provide: hardship concealed behind a confident smile, the burden of being the person everyone depends upon, the demand to appear successful, and the man who cannot afford to break down.

9 CHAPTER

The Empty Pocket Behind the Confident Smile

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the forms that concealed financial difficulty takes among men, and explain why concealment is so common even in households built on trust.
2. Analyse the shame associated with financial hardship — its sources, its function, and its costs — and distinguish it from the entirely legitimate goal of preserving dignity.
3. Recognise the mechanisms by which a man lives beyond his means in order to maintain appearances, and identify the specific expenditures in his own life that exist for that purpose.
4. Describe the relationship between debt and emotional strain, including the symptoms it produces, and explain why financial difficulty is a genuine mental-health risk factor rather than merely a practical problem.
5. Apply a method for asking for assistance without surrendering dignity, including deciding whom to ask, what to ask for, and what to offer in return.
6. Begin a structured financial recovery using the exercise at the end of this chapter and the worksheets in Appendix D.

Introduction

The measure of a man's public standing in most communities is partly financial, and the ways in which that standing is presented are visible to everyone: the school a child attends, the house, the vehicle, the contribution at a funeral, the willingness to pay for others at a table, the ability to respond to a request for assistance without hesitation. The performance is continuous and largely unremarked, because it is what everyone does.

Behind it, in an unknown but very large number of cases, is an entirely different reality. The house is mortgaged beyond its value. The fees were paid last term with borrowed money. The vehicle is on hire purchase, and two instalments are behind.

The contribution at the funeral was made because to give less would have been noticed, and the money was taken from a payment that was required elsewhere. The man who bought lunch for six people has a bank account that will not cover his own transport home, and he has calculated this in advance and accepted the cost.

This chapter is about the empty pocket behind the confident smile. It deals with a subject that men discuss with less freedom than almost any other — less than marriage, less than health, and, in the author's experience, less than grief — and it does so in the belief that the concealment itself, rather than the shortage of money, is what does the lasting damage.

9.1 Financial Struggles Hidden from Family and Friends

Concealed financial difficulty takes a small number of recognisable forms. Men reading the list frequently recognise three or four of them in their own lives, including forms they had not previously regarded as concealment at all.

The Forms of Concealment

The edited account. The man reports his position in a selectively accurate form. The new contract is mentioned; the loss of the previous one is not. The salary is stated; the deduction taken at source for a loan is not. Nothing said is false, and the listener therefore receives a picture that is materially wrong.

The separate obligation. The man carries a debt or obligation that his household does not know about: a loan taken for a relative, a guarantee given for a friend's business, a contribution to a family matter that was larger than reported, a shortfall in a business that he has covered from personal funds. The obligation is serviced quietly, from income that is nominally for the household.

The deferred disclosure. The man has decided to tell his wife, and will do so when the current difficulty is resolved, or when the quarter ends, or after the wedding, or once the school year is over. The deferral is renewed each time a new occasion appears, and it frequently lasts for years.

The maintained standard. The household continues at a level that the current income cannot sustain, and the gap is covered by borrowing, by the sale of assets, or by the accumulation of arrears. The standard is maintained not for the man's own satisfaction — he frequently has no interest in it — but because its reduction would be evidence of something.

The private calculation. The man carries the arithmetic in his head at all times: what is owed, what is due, which payment is being prioritised this month, which supplier is being delayed, which cheque will clear and which may not. This is not concealment in the sense of a secret, but it is the most isolating element of the whole situation, because it occupies a substantial part of the man's attention and cannot be discussed with anybody.

Why Concealment Survives in Trusting Households

The most frequent objection to this material comes from men who insist that they conceal nothing, and whose households are, in fact, open in every other respect. It is worth examining why financial concealment survives even in genuinely good marriages, because the reasons are specific.

Money is the last thing a man is permitted to be bad at. Marriage and family norms have changed substantially in the direction of shared decision-making, but the expectation that a man will be economically competent has changed much less. A man may discuss his fear of dying, his childhood, his doubts about his faith, and the difficulty he has in connecting with his father; the one subject in which he expects to lose standing is the one concerning his ability to provide.

The disclosure has immediate consequences for others, and they are not his own. Telling a wife about marital unhappiness affects two people. Telling her about a debt affects the children's school, the household's food, the relative whose medical costs are being met, and the arrangements of the whole family. A man's assessment that disclosure will cause distress is usually accurate; what he fails to calculate is that the distress will arrive anyway, later, and larger.

The information is frequently incomplete. A man concealing a financial problem often does not know his own position precisely, because he has avoided the calculation that would produce the figure. He therefore cannot give a coherent account, and the attempt to explain becomes a confession of incompetence. This is the reason that the first step in recovery, as Chapter 7 explained, is to establish the position on paper.

The concealment is protective of the man's own image in the eyes of people he loves. This is the heart of the matter, and it should be stated without euphemism. Financial disclosure is frequently experienced not as the sharing of a problem but as the destruction of a self that the man has constructed for the benefit of his family. The disclosure feels, to him, like the end of being the person they think he is.

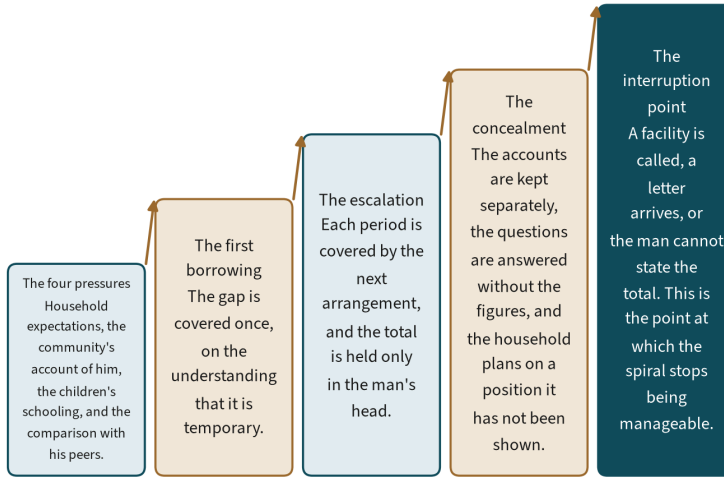


Figure 9.1 The spiral of concealment and escalation. Each stage is a reasonable response to the one before it, which is why the position is invisible to the man until he writes the total down.

The Costs of the Concealment

The costs are significant and they fall chiefly on the household that was being protected.

The problem grows while it is hidden. Concealed difficulty cannot be resolved by shared planning, cannot be renegotiated with the participation of a partner, and cannot be reduced by household expenditure adjustment, because the adjustment would require an explanation.

The household's trust is damaged independently of the money. Men frequently report, in the aftermath of disclosure, that the reaction they encountered was not primarily about the loss. It was about the exclusion — the discovery that a spouse had been making decisions, and carrying burdens, in relation to a situation she did not know existed. This damage is frequently the largest cost of the whole episode, and it is the one that takes the longest to repair.

The man is isolated at the moment he most needs company. Concealment removes the very support — practical, emotional, and advisory — that would reduce both the difficulty and its effect.

The household is exposed to worse outcomes. A concealed position continues to deteriorate in a manner invisible to the people who would be affected by it. Families that discover a debt at the stage of a court judgment have been deprived of the options that existed eighteen months earlier: restructuring, negotiated

reduction, the sale of an asset at a reasonable price, the reduction of expenditure in a controlled manner.

> **KEY POINT**
> Concealed financial difficulty is not resolved by the man's own effort, because the effort required is not primarily financial. It is the decision to stop being the only person who knows — and until that decision is made, every month of concealment increases the damage done to the household that the concealment was intended to protect.

9.2 The Shame Associated with Financial Hardship

Shame is the emotion at the centre of this chapter. Chapter 5 distinguished it from guilt, and the distinction matters especially here: **guilt** concerns what a man did or failed to do, and can be addressed by disclosure, amendment, and repair. **Shame** concerns what the man takes himself to be, and it produces concealment, because a self cannot be repaired by an apology.

Where the Shame Comes From

Four sources account for most of the shame that men report in relation to money.

The fusion of provision with manhood. This is the deepest source and the one described throughout Parts One and Two of this book. Where a man's standing, usefulness, and identity are constructed out of provision, a financial shortfall is not a change in circumstances; it is a change in nature. This is the reason that men who lose income frequently become withdrawn, irritable, and evasive, and why the pattern is frequently mistaken for pride.

The visibility of the standard. Money shame is unusual in that it operates in front of an audience. The school knows whether the fees are paid. The landlord knows. The relative who asked for assistance knows that the assistance did not come. The community knows whether the contribution was made. A debt is private; a default is frequently public, and the anticipation of public knowledge is a substantial part of the shame.

The comparison with the visible success of others. Chapter 7 described the mechanism. In the financial domain, comparison is continuous and public, because a man's position is displayed in things that can be counted.

The internalisation of the moral account. Many men carry a set of inherited beliefs about money that function as moral claims rather than as practical theories: that a man who borrows is weak; that a man who cannot maintain his household has failed in a basic duty; that poverty indicates a defect of character; that provision is a matter of effort and therefore that failure to provide demonstrates insufficient effort. These beliefs are frequently held by men who satisfy none of them and who apply them to themselves without mercy.

What the Shame Does

Shame produces five predictable behaviours in this domain, and each of them makes the situation worse.

Concealment. As described above.

Refusal of assistance. The man declines help that is available — from a relative, a cooperative, a bank facility with better terms, a professional adviser, an employer — because accepting it would make the position visible. This refusal is frequently rationalised on grounds of pride, which is a misdescription. Pride is compatible with accepting help; shame is not.

Avoidance of professional advice. The most costly behaviour of all. Men in financial difficulty frequently do not consult accountants, credit advisers, or lawyers, because the consultation requires disclosing the position. The consequence is that difficulties that could have been resolved by a professional in a week continue for years and end in proceedings.

Continued display. Because the position must remain invisible, expenditure on appearance is maintained or increased: the contributions, the ceremonies, the assistance to relatives, the standard of hospitality. The man is, in effect, paying a large annual premium for the concealment.

Withdrawal. Declining invitations, avoiding gatherings at which contributions are expected, and reducing contact with the people whose questions would be most searching. The withdrawal is then read by others as pride, which increases the shame, which increases the withdrawal.

Distinguishing Dignity from Shame

A distinction is necessary, because this book is not recommending the abandonment of dignity.

Dignity is the maintenance of one's own self-respect and the honest treatment of others, irrespective of financial position. A man can be owed money, behind on payments, and dependent on assistance while retaining dignity completely: he is honest about his position, he acknowledges his obligations, he does what he can, and he treats everyone with courtesy.

Shame is the belief that one's worth has fallen. It produces concealment, evasion, and withdrawal, none of which preserve dignity, because each of them substitutes a false account for an honest one.

The practical test is simple. If a course of action requires a man to misrepresent his situation, it is a shame strategy and it will cost him more than it saves. If it allows him to state his position accurately — however uncomfortable the position — it is a dignity strategy, and it preserves his standing with anybody whose regard is worth having.

9.3 Living Beyond One's Means to Maintain Appearances

The phrase *living beyond one's means* is used as a moral criticism, and the moral framing conceals the machinery. This section sets out the mechanism, because a man who understands how the pattern operates can identify it in his own life with precision and interrupt it at a specific point.

The Four Pressures

Free spending above one's level is not, in most cases, driven by appetite. Four pressures produce it, and men recognise them immediately when they are named.

The cost of belonging. In many communities, participation in social life requires expenditure that is not optional: the contribution at a funeral, the gift at a wedding, the levy for a development association, the amount expected at a naming ceremony. To give less than the expected amount is not merely to spend less; it is to make a statement, and the statement is noticed. Men frequently describe this expenditure as the largest single avoidable cost in their budget, and describe simultaneously that it cannot be avoided without social consequences.

The cost of the position. A man whose work or standing places him in a particular tier is expected to present accordingly: the vehicle appropriate to a bank manager calling on clients, the premises suitable for the business, the clothing appropriate for the professional, the hospitality expected of an office holder. Some of this expenditure is genuinely instrumental — it produces revenue — and some is not, and the two are frequently confused by the man paying for them.

The cost of the promise. Unfulfilled commitments to the household: the standard that was established in a better year, the school that was chosen when income was higher, the house that was built at a particular standard, the assistance to a relative that was promised and is now permanent. Each of these is a claim established in the past and maintained in the present, and none of them can be reduced without an explanation.

The cost of concealment itself. As Section 9.1 established, this is the element most frequently overlooked. A man who is concealing a financial difficulty spends money to make the concealment credible: attending the events, maintaining the standard, keeping up the contribution, avoiding the conversation that a visible reduction would provoke.

The Mechanics of the Spiral

The four pressures are sustained by three financial mechanisms, and it is worth naming them because each has a specific intervention.

Debt used to fund consumption rather than to produce income. Borrowing for an income-producing asset is a business decision with a calculable return. Borrowing to maintain a standard of living produces an obligation without a return, and the obligation compounds. Where a man's borrowing is

predominantly of the second kind, the position is deteriorating by definition, and the rate of deterioration is calculable.

Sequential obligations. A household managing a shortfall frequently services creditors in order of visibility rather than in order of cost: the ones who will embarrass most are paid first, and the ones with the highest interest are paid last. This maximises the total cost of the debt while protecting the appearance, which is the definition of the pattern.

Sale of productive assets. When borrowing capacity is exhausted, the household sells assets that produce income — a vehicle used for business, land, equipment, a business stake — in order to meet obligations. The sale provides temporary relief and permanently reduces capacity, and it is very frequently concealed until the asset is gone.

The Interruption Point

Each of the three mechanisms has a corresponding intervention, and the practical value of this section lies in the fact that a man can act on all three without disclosing anything to anybody, which makes them available as first steps.

1. **Separate borrowing into productive and consumptive.** List every obligation and mark each as producing income, maintaining an asset, or funding consumption. The third category is the one to stop. No new borrowing in that category, from today.
2. **Reorder creditors by cost rather than by visibility.** Pay the highest cost first, and — this is the part men find hardest — communicate with the visible creditors honestly and early rather than avoiding them. The conversation that a man is avoiding is usually with precisely the person who would negotiate.
3. **Protect productive assets.** Identify the assets that generate income, and treat them as protected: they are not available to meet consumption obligations, whatever the social cost of the alternative.

The Reduction Conversation

At some point, the pattern requires a reduction in the visible standard, and the reduction requires an explanation to the household, the extended family, and, in some cases, the community. Chapter 10 sets out the method in full; three principles apply here.

Reduce in categories rather than across the board. A household handles a specific reduction better than a general anxiety. *The second car goes; we will use transport for a year* is manageable. *We must cut everything* is not.

Give the honest reason, in one sentence. *The business lost two contracts and I have been covering the shortfall with a loan; I am not willing to continue that, so we*

will live at the level we can afford for a year while I rebuild. The sentence is short, factual, blames no one, and concedes nothing to shame.

Do the reduction in one decisive movement, not gradually. A staged reduction produces a prolonged period of uncertainty and repeated disappointment. A single, clearly stated change, held to, produces a settled arrangement.

9.4 Debt, Anxiety, and Emotional Strain

Debt is not only a financial condition. It is a psychological condition with a well-documented symptom profile, and men who carry it frequently present the symptoms long before they disclose the cause.

The Symptom Profile

The following symptoms are reliably reported by men carrying significant debt, across countries and income levels.

Table 9.1 The symptom profile of concealed debt. The pattern closely resembles that of the anxiety and depressive presentations described in Chapters 5 and 6, which is one of the reasons the underlying cause is frequently missed.

Domain	Typical experiences
Sleep	Waking early with dread; difficulty falling asleep; dreaming of owing or being unable to pay
Attention	Intrusive arithmetic during work; inability to concentrate; forgetting tasks and appointments
Mood	Irritability, especially at home; flatness; abrupt loss of interest in previously enjoyable activities
Body	Tension in neck and shoulders; headaches; stomach symptoms; palpitations
Behaviour	Avoiding telephone calls; avoiding the post; avoiding particular places and people; increased alcohol use; withdrawal from social contact
Thinking	Catastrophic projections; a sense of being trapped; repeated rehearsal of impossible solutions
Relationships	Secrecy from a partner; irritability towards children; declining invitations; reduced sexual interest

The practical significance of the table is twofold. First, a man reading this list and recognising himself should consider whether an undisclosed financial obligation is contributing to symptoms he has attributed to overwork, age, or family life. Second, clinicians and counsellors meeting a man with this profile should ask directly about debt and obligations, since the subject is rarely volunteered.

Why Debt Is a Distinctive Kind of Stress

Debt has four features that distinguish it from other difficulties, and each of these features explains why men find it so difficult to carry.

It is continuous. A bereavement recedes; a debt does not. The obligation is present every month, at every meeting with the creditor's name, in every family discussion about money, and every time a plan is proposed that requires funds.

It has a party. Unlike a business failure or an illness, debt involves an identifiable person or institution that expects payment and that has a legitimate claim. This transforms a difficulty into a relationship, and frequently into one involving shame, avoidance, and the anticipation of judgement.

It is quantifiable, and therefore demonstrable. A man may not know his own position precisely (most men in this situation do not), but he knows that there is a figure, and that the figure represents his failure in a countable form.

It is loaded with moral content. Debt carries a moral vocabulary — owing, failing to pay, dishonouring an obligation — that other difficulties do not. Men frequently describe the shame of owing money as more severe than the loss of an actual amount.

The Consequences That Make it Worse

Three consequences of debt-related strain make the financial position worse, and it is worth stating them plainly because the pattern is so common.

Impaired financial decision-making under stress. Decisional capacity is degraded by chronic stress and poor sleep — a finding established in Chapters 1 and 5 and confirmed in the substantial research literature on scarcity and financial decision-making. Men under financial strain make worse financial decisions: they accept high-interest loans, they make hurried sales, they decline the slower option that would cost less.

Self-medication. Alcohol use rises, which costs money and reduces the capacity to work effectively.

Withdrawal from the people who could help. As described above. The withdrawal removes both the practical assistance and the advice that would resolve the difficulty.

The Alternative: Debt as a Project

The practical alternative to carrying debt as a private shame is to treat it as a project: a defined problem with a defined position, a plan, an adviser, and a review date. Chapter 7 set out the sequence; this chapter adds three points specific to debt.

Obtain the figure. Total obligations, and for each: the amount, the rate, the security, and the default consequences. Men frequently discover, on completing this, that their position is materially better than they feared, because fear supplies

an estimate rather than a number. They also frequently discover a smaller obligation with a punitive rate that can be eliminated quickly, producing both relief and a visible success.

Speak to the largest creditor first. Creditors prefer payment to litigation, and a man who approaches a creditor before default with a specific proposal is treated very differently from a man who avoids contact. Appendix D provides a template for that communication.

Take advice from somebody who has no stake in the outcome. Free or low-cost financial counselling services, cooperative societies, credit unions, professional accountancy bodies with pro bono schemes, and reputable advisory services are all available in most settings. Where the amounts are significant, or where there is a risk of legal proceedings, professional advice is not a luxury; it is the difference between a manageable restructuring and an unnecessary judgment.

9.5 Asking for Assistance Without Losing Dignity

The moment at which a man must ask for help — from a relative, a friend, an employer, a bank, a cooperative, or a spouse — is the point at which the whole of this chapter converges. Men identify it as one of the most difficult acts of their lives, and the difficulty is not irrational: the act requires the abandonment of the self-presentation that has organised their position in the family and the community.

The purpose of this section is to make the act practicable. It has five parts.

Deciding Whether to Ask

Not every shortfall requires assistance. Before asking, three questions establish whether assistance is genuinely required.

- **Is the difficulty temporary and bridgeable, or structural?** A bridgeable gap — a payment due before a receivable arrives, a medical cost in a bad month — can be addressed with a loan or a deferral. A structural gap, in which income does not cover obligations month after month, cannot be solved by assistance and requires a restructuring. Asking for the former when the latter is required produces a debt that makes the position worse.
- **Is the assistance the best available option?** Compare the cost of the assistance with the alternatives: renegotiating with the creditor, selling a productive asset, taking a lower-cost facility, or reducing the household standard. Assistance from a relative frequently carries a cost to the relationship that is higher than the cost of a commercial alternative.
- **What exactly is needed?** A precise figure and a purpose. Requests of the form *I need help with money* are difficult to grant and are frequently refused.

I need 240,000 naira before the fifteenth of March to prevent a judgment; I will repay it in six instalments of 40,000 beginning in April is grantable.

Deciding Whom to Ask

The choice of person matters more than the wording. Four criteria identify the right person.

Capacity. The person can actually help — many requests are made of relatives who have no capacity, which produces refusal and damage for no purpose.

Discretion. The person will not discuss the matter with others. This should be assessed before the request rather than discovered afterwards, and men are frequently wrong on this point; the safe test is whether the person has kept confidences before.

The nature of the relationship. A person with whom the man has an established pattern of reciprocity is a better prospect than one with whom the relationship is entirely one-directional in either direction.

The absence of leverage. Where possible, the person should not be a business associate, a competitor, a person in the man's chain of authority, or a relative whose assistance would establish an ongoing claim over the man's decisions.

Making the Request

Six elements make a request credible, and their absence is the principal reason that requests are refused.

1. **The introduction.** *I am going to ask you for something, and I want to explain the position first.* Announcing the format prevents the two common failures: that the listener panics, or that the request appears as an ambush.
2. **The position.** The facts: what has happened, what is owed, what the resources are, and how the shortfall arose. Brief and without self-justification.
3. **The amount.** Specific, with the purpose stated.
4. **The plan.** How it will be repaid, from what income, and over what period, with dates.
5. **What you are doing.** The steps being taken independently: expenditure reduction, additional work, disposal of an asset, professional advice obtained. This is the element that most strongly determines the answer, because it establishes that the man is not transferring the problem.
6. **The concession.** What happens if the arrangement cannot be met — a stated fallback, such as a transfer of the asset securing the debt, a schedule renegotiation, or the involvement of a witness. Stating the fallback in advance is the strongest available evidence of good faith.

Offering Something in Return

Assistance is more readily given, and the relationship is better preserved, when the request includes a reciprocal element. The reciprocal element need not be

financial. Men have successfully offered: an agreed schedule with a written record and a witness; a defined service in return, within their competence; the transfer of an asset until the debt is cleared; the involvement of a third party to hold both parties to the arrangement; or instruction and mentorship of the lender's relation.

The offer of a written record, with a witness, is worth particular emphasis. It converts an informal request, which is emotionally expensive for both parties, into an arrangement with terms, and it removes the possibility of later disputes about what was agreed. Men report that producing a written schedule at the moment of request changed the character of the conversation entirely.

Refusal, and What to Do With It

Refusals are common and should be expected. A refusal is not necessarily a verdict on the man: capacity, prior commitments, past experience, and the opinion of the lender's own spouse all influence the answer.

Two rules apply. **Do not argue.** A request that has been refused is closed, and pressing it damages the relationship while producing nothing. **Do not withdraw.** The most common consequence of a refusal is that the man stops speaking to the person altogether, which converts a financial matter into the loss of a relationship. The appropriate response is ordinary: thank the person for hearing it, and continue the relationship as before.

The Last Resort: Public Awareness

For a minority of cases, the position becomes known without disclosure: a judgment, a repossession, a supplier's representative at the house, a child sent home from school. Where this occurs, three principles reduce the damage.

- **Get ahead of the narrative.** A brief, factual statement to the family and, where necessary, to the relevant community body, is considerably better than a rumour. *This is what happened, this is the position, this is the plan* — in that order.
- **Do not answer every question.** Men frequently respond to exposure by explaining themselves at length to everyone who asks, which produces further exposure. A single, consistent, three-sentence account is sufficient, and repetition of it ends the matter more quickly than disclosure.
- **Protect the children absolutely.** Whatever the position between adults, children should not be told the details, used as messengers, or left to hear the situation from others. Chapter 17 addresses this; the relevant point here is that the household's difficulty can be managed without the children carrying the arithmetic.

9.6 Rebuilding Financial Stability

The final section deals with recovery, and it is deliberately practical. It applies whether the man is at the beginning of a difficulty or several years into a concealed one.

Stage One: The Position Paper

Produce a written statement of the position in five parts: income; obligations with amounts, rates, and dates; assets with realistic market values; the monthly arithmetic, showing whether the month closes and by how much it does not; and the number of months the position can be sustained unchanged. This document serves three purposes: it is the basis of any advice or assistance, it removes the uncertainty that drives the anxiety, and it is the document from which the plan is built.

Stage Two: The Reduction

Set out the reductions, in three categories: **immediate** (expenditure that can stop this month without explanation — subscriptions, services, discretionary transport, the second vehicle where applicable); **negotiated** (obligations that can be renegotiated — rent, fees, credit terms, obligations to relatives, the standard of household expenditure); and **structural** (changes to the pattern of work, business, or living arrangements, which take longer and have larger effects).

Chapter 10 treats the negotiation with family members in detail, and Chapter 12 treats the reduction of work itself.

Stage Three: The Creditor Plan

For each creditor: the amount, the rate, the proposed repayment, and the date of first communication. Prioritise by cost, protect secured assets where possible, and communicate before default rather than after. Where the position is severe, professional advice should be obtained before any communication, because an incorrect proposal can establish a legal position that is worse than the silence it replaced.

Stage Four: The Rebuilding

Recovery is not only the reduction of obligations. It requires a rebuilding of capacity: income, skills, assets, and credit standing. Five elements recur in the accounts men give of successful recovery.

Restore the productive base first. Before any other objective, protect and rebuild the asset or activity that produces income.

Reduce the cost base permanently. Men who recover from serious financial difficulty almost always describe a permanent change in their standard of living that they came to prefer: fewer obligations, less display, and a lower level of recurring commitment.

Build a buffer. Once the immediate position is stable, establish a reserve sufficient for one to three months of obligations. This is the single measure that prevents the next difficulty from becoming a crisis, and men who have experienced a serious financial failure describe it as the change they most wished they had made earlier.

Restore credit standing deliberately. Where the household needs future access to credit, the process is deliberate and takes years: no missed payments, no new obligations taken on without necessity, and the systematic closure of accounts as they are redeemed.

Change the reference group. One of the more surprising findings in the accounts men give is the importance of reducing exposure to the comparison culture that produced the overspending. Men who recover frequently describe a change in the company they keep: fewer events attended, fewer contributions made, and a narrower circle in which a lower standard of living attracts no comment.

A Final Word on the Household

Two notes complete this chapter. First, the rebuilding should be undertaken **with the household informed**, even where the disclosure comes late and painfully. The alternative — recovery conducted in further concealment — is the pattern that produces the second collapse. Second, the household should be given a role. Men frequently attempt recovery as a solitary administrative project, which reproduces the very pattern that caused the difficulty. Families recover better when they are told what is happening, given one or two specific tasks (reduced expenditure in a named category, delayed purchase of a named item, an agreement about requests for assistance), and informed of progress at intervals.

9.7 Illustrative Case: The Man With Two Bank Accounts

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in financial counselling, family mediation, and consumer credit services.

Bello is forty-five and works as a senior officer in a state agency. He has been married for sixteen years, has four children, and is widely regarded as a careful man. He keeps two accounts. His wife, Halima, knows about one of them.

The second account exists because of an obligation that Bello has never discussed. Nine years ago, his younger sister's husband died suddenly, leaving her with three children and a house that was unfinished. The family agreed that Bello, as the eldest surviving son, would take responsibility for completing the house and supporting the children's education. He accepted, as everyone expected him to, and has done so since then.

The obligation is not in itself the problem. Bello's salary has risen over the years, and the support has been manageable in most years. The difficulty arose four years

ago, when his employer undertook a restructuring and his monthly allowances — a substantial part of his real income — were reduced and then, in the second year, stopped entirely for eight months. His base salary continued. The support did not stop, because stopping it would have produced a conversation that Bello was not prepared to have with his sister, his mother, and the extended family.

To bridge the gap, Bello took a loan from a cooperative society at a rate of four per cent per month. When that loan's servicing began to exceed his capacity, he took a second loan from a loan application service with a higher rate, and used part of it to service the first. He also, in the third year, delayed payment to two of his own creditors — a school and a hospital — in order to maintain the family support.

Three things happened in the fourth year. His sleep deteriorated, and he began to wake at three and spend an hour doing arithmetic. He became sharp with his children, particularly the eldest, whose university fees were due. And he stopped attending the monthly meeting of the family's development association, offering the cost of transport as a reason; the real reason was that at the last meeting he had been unable to contribute at the expected level and had been asked, in front of others, whether things were difficult.

He told nobody. Halima knew that something was wrong — she described later that he had become *a man who was present but not there* — and asked twice. On both occasions he answered that the pressure at work was heavy and that she should not worry.

The disclosure came about through bureaucracy rather than crisis. A loan application required a guarantor who was a civil servant, and Bello asked a colleague. The colleague, who had known him for eleven years, asked a single question: *Bello, how many of these are you servicing?* Bello told him. The colleague said he would guarantee the loan on one condition: that Bello tell his wife, that same week.

The conversation with Halima lasted three hours and was, according to both, the worst evening of their marriage. What emerged was not the debt, which was large but manageable once restructured through a staff cooperative at a lower rate, but the nine years of silence, which Halima experienced as a verdict about her place in the marriage.

The financial restructuring took eight months. The loan balances were consolidated, the interest cost was substantially reduced, the family support was renegotiated — with some difficulty and some loss of face, and with the sister's surprising and immediate acceptance when the situation was explained — and the household standard was reduced in three named categories. The relational repair took considerably longer, and its central element was a weekly conversation, at a fixed time, in which Bello reported the position: what had been paid, what remained, and what had changed.

Two years later, in a review with the cooperative officer who had helped with the restructuring, Bello described what he had learned in a sentence that is worth recording: *The debt was never the problem. The debt was arithmetic. What I did to*

> *my wife was keep her outside the most important thing in our family for nine years, and tell her that the reason was that she should not worry.*

The case illustrates the chapter, and four features are worth isolating.

The obligation was honourable, and it was not disclosed. Bello's decision to support his sister's household was consistent with his responsibilities and would have been defended by anybody who knew the circumstances. The difficulty was not the commitment; it was the decision to carry it as a private matter of honour rather than a family decision with a budget attached. This is the most common configuration of concealed financial difficulty in extended-family systems, and it is the subject of Chapter 10.

The immediate trigger was external, and the response was a loan at a punitive rate. The reduction of allowances was not in Bello's control. His response to it — bridging the gap with high-cost credit rather than renegotiating the support obligation — was the point at which a manageable shortfall became a structural problem.

The symptoms were present and were attributed elsewhere. Broken sleep, irritability with the eldest child, withdrawal from the association, and the characteristic experience of being *present but not there*. He attributed all of them to work, and his wife was given the same explanation twice.

The disclosure came through a question about a specific practice rather than an invitation to talk. The colleague asked how many loans were being serviced, having inferred the position from the request for a guarantor. This is the same mechanism that appeared in the cases in Chapters 5 and 8, and it is the reason this book repeatedly recommends that men learn to ask direct questions about observable behaviour rather than general questions about feelings.

9.8 Practical Exercise: The Position Paper and the Disclosure Plan

This exercise takes approximately two hours, and it produces two documents. Both should be written, kept, and updated monthly. Readers who find the exercise emotionally difficult should note that this difficulty is itself evidence of the material's weight, and that Appendix D provides a structured alternative if the free-form version is too much to complete at once.

Document One: The Position Paper

Complete each section, using figures rather than estimates wherever you can obtain them.

Section A — Income. All sources, with amounts, frequency, and reliability. Mark each as secure, variable, or at risk.

Section B — Obligations. For each: the creditor, the amount outstanding, the rate, the monthly payment, the security, and the consequence of default. Include obligations that nobody else knows about. This is the section men most often omit, and it is the section that determines whether the plan works.

Section C — Assets. For each: the asset, its realistic sale value, and whether it produces income. Mark the productive assets distinctly.

Section D — The Arithmetic. Total monthly income, total monthly obligations, the difference, and the number of months for which the current position can be sustained. Write the number down. It is the most useful figure in the document.

Section E — The Reductions. Three lists: immediate, negotiated, structural. Against each item, the amount saved and the date on which it will take effect.

Document Two: The Disclosure Plan

Part One — Whom to tell. Choose one person. Where there is a spouse or partner, the plan should include her, although it may be appropriate to speak to a professional adviser first in order to have the facts in order. Where there is no partner, choose the person with capacity, discretion, and no leverage over you.

Part Two — What to say. Draft the account in six parts, following Section 9.5: introduction, position, amount, plan, what you are already doing, and the fallback. Write it out in full. The most important of the six is *what you are already doing*, and it should be completed before the conversation, not promised in it.

Part Three — What you are asking for. Write one of the following: to listen and help you think; practical assistance in the form of a specified amount; involvement in the plan as a monitor; or accompaniment to an appointment with an adviser. Specify which, and specify what you are not asking for.

Part Four — The date. Set the date and time. Men who intend to disclose within a fortnight but do not fix a date frequently do not disclose. Write it in a calendar rather than holding it in mind.

Part Five — The review. Set the date of the first review conversation and record what will be reported at it: amounts repaid, reductions effected, and any change in the position.

A Note for the Man Whose Position Is Severe

If, having completed the Position Paper, you find that the position cannot be sustained for more than three months, or that legal consequences are imminent, the appropriate next step is professional advice before any disclosure to family: an accountant, a lawyer, a credit adviser, or a licensed insolvency practitioner, depending on the jurisdiction and the nature of the obligations. This is not an admission of defeat; it is the same decision a man makes when he takes a serious physical symptom to a physician rather than treating it himself.

9.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"My wife and I share everything except money. Why is that the one subject I cannot discuss?"

Because it is the one subject in which a man's standing has not been revised by modern expectations. The household may be genuinely equal in decision-making, childcare, and emotional openness, and the belief that the man should be economically competent frequently survives untouched. A man who reports this difficulty should note that his household is not unusual: concealment is more common in respectful, functional marriages than in troubled ones, precisely because the man has more to lose by disappointing someone whose regard he values.

"Is it dishonest not to tell her? I am not taking anything from the household."

It is concealment rather than theft, and it is harmful for a different reason. Decisions about money affect the whole household: the school, the medical treatment, the food, the housing, and the plans that a partner may be making on the assumption of a particular position. A partner who has been excluded from the true position is not making decisions; she is guessing. The relevant question is not whether money was removed, but whether the household has been making decisions on the basis of an account that is materially wrong.

"I have been keeping this from her for years. Is it too late to say anything?"

No, and the cost of disclosing increases with each year. What is required is not the delivery of nine years of accumulated guilt but a factual account of the position, an honest statement of why the silence was maintained, and a plan. Expect the first conversations to be difficult and the process of repair to take months rather than hours.

"Should I take a loan to cover the gap while I sort things out?"

Only under three conditions: that the loan reduces the total cost of the problem; that there is a defined source of repayment; and that it does not postpone an adjustment that will be larger later. Borrowing to maintain a standard that income cannot sustain is the mechanism by which shortfalls become catastrophes, and it is described in Section 9.3.

"How do I ask a relative for money without this becoming a permanent obligation to them?"

Specify the amount, the purpose, the repayment schedule, and the fallback, and put the arrangement in writing with a witness where the sum is significant. Offer something reciprocal where you can. Be explicit that the assistance is a defined arrangement with an end, and honour the schedule exactly, because the timetable is the part that preserves the relationship.

"What if my difficulty is that I am supporting eleven people on one salary?"

Then the difficulty is primarily structural rather than arithmetic, and no amount of borrowing will resolve it. Chapter 10 addresses the redistribution of responsibility and the introduction of boundaries, and it is written precisely for this situation.

"Where can I get advice at low cost?"

Cooperative societies and credit unions affiliated to employers and professional bodies; free financial counselling offered by consumer protection agencies; pro bono schemes operated by professional accountancy and legal bodies; non-governmental organisations working on financial inclusion; and the advisory services attached to some religious and community organisations. Appendix Q lists the categories to approach and the questions to ask.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 9 in brief. Concealed financial difficulty takes five recognisable forms: the edited account, in which everything said is true and the picture is materially wrong; the separate obligation the household does not know about; the deferred disclosure, renewed at each new occasion; the maintained standard funded by borrowing and arrears; and the private calculation carried continuously in the man's head.

Concealment survives even in trusting households for four specific reasons: money remains the domain in which men expect to lose standing; disclosure has immediate consequences for others; the man frequently does not know his own position precisely and therefore cannot give a coherent account; and disclosure feels like the destruction of the self he has constructed for his family. The costs fall chiefly on the household being protected: the problem grows while hidden, trust is damaged independently of the money, the man is isolated at the moment he needs support, and the family loses the options that would have existed six months earlier.

Shame is the central emotion, and it must be distinguished from dignity. Guilt concerns an act and responds to disclosure and repair; shame concerns the self and produces concealment. The test is whether a course of action requires misrepresentation — in which case it is a shame strategy and will cost more than it saves — or whether it permits an accurate statement of the position, which preserves dignity.

Living beyond one's means is driven by four pressures — the cost of belonging, the cost of the position, the cost of the promise, and the cost of concealment itself — and sustained by three mechanisms: borrowing to fund consumption, servicing creditors in order of visibility rather than cost, and selling productive assets. Each mechanism has an intervention available to a man without disclosing anything to anybody, which makes them usable as first steps.

Debt produces a symptom profile that closely resembles anxiety and depression, including broken sleep, intrusive arithmetic, irritability at home, physical tension, avoidance of calls and places, and withdrawal. It is a distinctive kind of stress because

it is continuous, has a party, is quantifiable, and carries moral content. Under strain, financial decision-making deteriorates, alcohol use rises, and social withdrawal removes the very advice and assistance that would resolve the difficulty. The alternative is to treat debt as a project: obtain the figure, engage the largest creditor first, and take advice from someone with no stake in the outcome.

Asking for assistance can be done without losing dignity, by deciding whether the gap is bridgeable or structural, choosing a person with capacity, discretion, and no leverage, making a request containing the position, the amount, the plan, what is already being done, and the fallback, and offering something reciprocal including a written schedule. Refusals should be accepted without argument and without withdrawal from the relationship.

Rebuilding proceeds in four stages: the position paper, the reduction in three categories, the creditor plan prioritised by cost, and the rebuilding of capacity — restoring the productive base, reducing the cost base permanently, building a reserve of one to three months, restoring credit standing deliberately, and changing the reference group. The rebuilding should be done with the household informed and given specific tasks, because recovery conducted as a solitary administrative project reproduces the pattern that caused the difficulty.

Reflection Questions

1. Of the five forms of concealment in Section 9.1, which applies to you? If none applies, is there a man close to you for whom one of them is clearly operative, and what is the direct question you could ask him?
2. Section 9.2 asks you to distinguish dignity from shame. Describe a recent decision about money and answer whether it preserved dignity or protected the appearance. What did it cost?
3. Work through the four pressures in Section 9.3 and identify your largest annual expenditure that exists for the purpose of being seen. What would happen, concretely, if it stopped?
4. Run the three interventions on debt mechanisms: separate productive from consumptive borrowing; list creditors by cost rather than visibility; identify the productive assets you would protect. What does the exercise reveal?
5. From the symptom profile in Table 9.2, which items do you currently experience? Have you attributed any of them to a cause other than financial strain?
6. Apply Section 9.3 to your own position: is your gap bridgeable or structural? What does the answer imply about whether to borrow or to restructure?
7. Complete the Position Paper today, including the number of months the position can be sustained. What did you feel on writing the number down, and what is the first item on the reduction list?

Further Reading

- **On the psychology of scarcity and financial decision-making:** the research literature showing that financial strain impairs cognitive capacity and decision-making, and the work on how poverty and debt affect attention and judgement. This literature is important for men in debt, because it establishes that the deterioration in a man's decisions under strain is a documented effect rather than a personal failing.
- **On debt and mental health:** the substantial body of work linking financial difficulty to depression, anxiety, and suicide risk, including studies showing that debt counselling improves mental health outcomes as well as financial ones.
- **On over-indebtedness in Africa:** studies of consumer credit, informal lending, cooperative societies, and digital lending in Nigeria and comparable markets, together with the guidance published by consumer protection bodies and central banks on borrowing and on the handling of debt distress.
- **On financial counselling:** practical materials on budgeting, debt prioritisation, negotiation with creditors, and restructuring, together with the guidance issued by consumer credit and financial counselling organisations.
- **On family finance and disclosure:** work on money in marriage and on the effects of financial secrecy between partners, including research showing that financial deception is associated with lower marital satisfaction and a higher risk of separation.
- **On shame and money:** the literature on the moralisation of debt and poverty, including historical and cross-cultural studies of how attitudes to money are transmitted, and the research on shame as a barrier to seeking financial advice.

10 CHAPTER

When Everyone Depends on You

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the expectations placed on a family provider in extended-family systems, and distinguish between obligations that are genuinely his and those that have simply accumulated.
2. Map the network of dependency in his own life, in terms of money, time, decisions, and emotional availability, and assess what the network currently costs.
3. Explain the emotional burden of being financially indispensable, including the resentment, fear, and isolation it produces.
4. Apply a method for setting boundaries that preserves responsibility without accepting unlimited liability, and rehearse the conversations that boundaries require.
5. Establish shared financial planning with a partner and a household, including the specific mechanisms — the budget meeting, the priority list, and the written schedule of family support.
6. Recognise and prevent provider burnout, using the warning sequence and the protective practices set out in this chapter.

Introduction

Consider what a man in his late forties typically supports, and the list is usually longer than he first reports. His own household: a wife or partner, and between one and five children, some of them in tertiary education. His parents: a mother's medication, a father's funeral costs, the maintenance of a house in the village. His siblings, in some cases: school fees for a brother's children, a hospital bill for a sister, a contribution to a nephew's wedding. An extended network: a cousin who needs capital for a business, an uncle's medical treatment, a family meeting's levy, a community association's dues, a church or mosque project contribution. And, frequently, another household entirely: a late brother's family, an elderly aunt, a niece in the city for her education.

Each individual obligation is legitimate. Each has a reason, a history, and a moral claim. A man would find it difficult to refuse any single one of them, and would be criticised if he did. What no one ever does is add them up. When they are added up, the total frequently exceeds the man's entire income, and the difference is met by borrowing, by the sale of assets, by the deferral of his own medical treatment, by the neglect of his own retirement, and by the quiet assumption that he will work until he dies.

This chapter deals with that situation. It is not an argument against family responsibility, which is one of the most valuable features of the societies in which extended-family systems operate, and which protects millions of people against hardship that no state in the region is yet able to absorb. It is an argument against unlimited liability, unexamined accumulation, and the assumption that a man's usefulness has no limit — and against the arrangement in which a man's own household, his own health, and his own future quietly become the item that absorbs every shortfall.

10.1 The Expectations Placed on Family Providers

To change an arrangement, a man must understand it. This section identifies the expectations that produce provider overload, in the order in which they usually arrive in a man's life.

The First Expectation: The Household

The obligation to support a wife and children is the one that most men accept without question and often without negotiation. In practice, it has three components that are worth separating, because they impose different burdens.

Subsistence: food, shelter, clothing, transport, and medical care. This obligation is continuous, non-negotiable, and demanding.

Investment: education, family assets, and the establishment of children in adult life. This obligation is large, deferred, and frequently unpredictable in cost: a university fee, a dowry, a business start-up, a medical episode.

Standard: the level at which the household lives relative to comparable households in its community. This component is rarely named as an obligation, and it is frequently the largest source of financial pressure, because it is set by comparison rather than by need.

The Second Expectation: Parents

Support for parents is among the most strongly held obligations in the societies examined in this book, and it is generally understood as a repayment of the investment made in the man's upbringing. It carries a distinctive emotional weight: a man who fails to support a parent experiences a moral failure of a different order from a man who cannot pay a supplier.

Three features make this obligation difficult to manage. It is frequently open-ended, because medical costs in old age are unpredictable and can absorb almost any income. It is asymmetrically distributed among siblings, because the obligation falls in practice on the one with the visible capacity rather than being shared. And it is rarely discussed in the terms in which it is carried: no family sits down to establish what the support will consist of, what the other siblings will contribute, and what will happen as the needs increase.

The Third Expectation: Siblings, Their Children, and the Wider Kin

The third band of expectation is the one that expands indefinitely. It includes school fees for siblings' children, support for widowed relatives, capital for a relative's business, funeral contributions, community levies, and the informal role of the family's banker.

Its features are as follows. The obligations are individually modest and collectively very large. They are frequently generated by other relatives' decisions rather than by need in any objective sense. They arrive with a moral vocabulary — *you are the one who can; the family is relying on you; do not let us be disgraced* — that makes refusal socially expensive. And they are permanent, because each support successfully provided establishes a precedent for the next request.

The Fourth Expectation: The Community

Finally, the community expects contributions: development associations, hometown unions, religious bodies, cooperative societies, and the ceremonies and funerals at which presence and contribution are recorded. These obligations are integral to a man's standing and to his family's ability to call upon community support in a crisis. They are, in a real sense, insurance premised on reciprocity, and a man who withdraws from them entirely will find that the community is less available to him when he needs it.

The difficulty is that the expectations are set by visible capacity and are frequently adjusted upwards as a man's position improves, while the reduction that follows a decline in his fortunes is never correspondingly adjusted.

The Cumulative Effect

The four bands of expectation, taken together, produce a position that a man frequently has never examined, and its main features are these.

- **The obligations exceed the income.** This is not a marginal imbalance; in many cases the sum of family and community obligations is one and a half to two times the man's actual income, and the difference is met by debt.
- **The largest obligations are invisible.** Nobody in the family knows what the man spends on the other obligations. The wife knows the household's element; the mother knows hers; the siblings know theirs. No person, including the man, holds the complete picture.

- **The obligations are permanent, while the income is not.** Support arrangements made during a period of good earnings frequently continue after the earnings have fallen, because the reduction would require a disclosure that the man is unwilling to make.
- **Personal and retirement needs are the residual.** A man meeting these obligations typically funds his own medical care, pension provision, and housing only if something is left. In practice, nothing is left.
- **The burden is borne in silence.** The most damaging feature of the whole arrangement is that a man carrying two households, four dependants beyond his own children, and community obligations typically discusses it with nobody, on the grounds that the situation is normal and that complaining would be shameful.

> **KEY POINT**
> The problem is not that a man supports his extended family. The problem is that he does so without a total, without a limit, without a discussion, and without any adjustment when his capacity changes — and the household that absorbs the shortfall is his own.

10.2 Supporting Parents, Spouses, Children, and Relatives

Having described the expectations, it is worth examining each band of obligation in practice, because the interventions differ.

Supporting Parents

Three practices materially improve the arrangement without reducing the support.

Establish the plan with the siblings. A family conversation establishing what each sibling can contribute, in what proportion, and how the arrangement will change as needs increase. This conversation will not be straightforward, and it is far easier than the alternative: thirteen years of unilateral support, followed by a crisis in which every sibling discovers the position for the first time.

Separate the predictable from the unpredictable. Routine monthly support can be planned. A medical emergency cannot, and provision for it should be made deliberately: an agreed fund, an insurance arrangement where available and affordable, or an explicit understanding among siblings of how such costs will be shared.

Give time as well as money. Men often assume that the obligation is financial. In practice, parents frequently report that presence matters more than funds, and time spent on visits, transport to appointments, and practical assistance is both less costly and more valuable.

Supporting a Spouse

The obligations a man carries towards his own partner are of a different kind from those towards his parents, and two specific problems recur.

The unilateral allocation of income. A man who allocates income to extended-family obligations without consultation is not merely spending money; he is making a decision that affects his partner's household. The most common and most damaging pattern in provider overload is the quiet transfer: support given to relatives from the household's resources, without discussion, on the grounds that a man is entitled to exercise his own judgement about his own income. This is the mechanism by which many marriages accumulate resentment that surfaces years later in a financial crisis.

The remedy is not to stop the support but to make it a shared decision, with a figure, a duration, and a review date. Couples who do this report a marked reduction in conflict, and — this surprises many men — partners are frequently more generous than their husbands expect, once the support is part of a plan rather than a private expenditure.

The assumption that support flows in one direction. Extended-family systems are frequently experienced by women as one-directional: money leaves the household for the husband's relatives, and the wife's relatives are expected to manage without. Where both partners have family obligations, the arrangement should be symmetrical and explicit, and where they do not, the asymmetry should be named and agreed rather than assumed.

Supporting Children

Children's needs are the least negotiable, and the difficulties that arise are of three kinds.

The educational commitment exceeding present capacity. School and university fees are frequently the largest single item in the budget, and the commitment extends for fifteen to twenty years. Where income is volatile, the commitment should be structured as far as possible — education savings arrangements, family contributions agreed in advance, and a realistic choice of institutions that reflects the capacity to sustain the payments, rather than a choice reflecting the family's position relative to its neighbours.

The differential treatment of children. Where a father supports some children fully and others not at all — between households, between marriages, or between children with differing abilities — the consequences are long-lasting and are borne chiefly by the children. Chapter 17 addresses this; the relevant point here is that obligations to children are cumulative rather than optional, and that a man cannot offset financial support to one child against the emotional consequences for another.

The parental obligation to be present. Time is a form of provision, and it is the one that most frequently gets displaced by the financial obligations described in this chapter. A man working sixty hours a week to support nine people has made a decision about his children's upbringing, whether or not he recognises it as one.

Supporting Relatives

Three practices reduce the cost and increase the effectiveness of relative support.

Convert repeated support into defined arrangements. A relative who requires ongoing support will require it indefinitely. Converting an ad hoc series of payments into a defined monthly arrangement with a duration and a review date gives the man control over the total and gives the recipient something more useful than uncertainty.

Prefer capacity-building to consumption support. Where the relative is capable of income, assistance in the form of capital, training, equipment, or an introduction is frequently more effective in the long run than the provision of consumption. It is also more accurately accounted for: a business loan with a repayment schedule is a different instrument from a monthly subsidy.

Establish the principle that other relatives exist. The single most effective structural change in provider overload is the redistribution of a specific obligation among the relatives who are capable of contributing. This is frequently resisted, and it is frequently more successful than the man expects, because the relatives who have contributed nothing were, in most cases, never asked.

The Household Conversation

The interventions above all require one conversation to begin, and that conversation is the one with the man's own household. Its content is straightforward: the total income, the total obligations, and the allocation. Its effect, in the experience of men who undertake it, is at least as significant as the financial improvement it produces: for the first time, the whole position is visible to the people who are most affected by it, and the man is no longer carrying the arithmetic alone. Appendix D provides the worksheet, and Appendix F provides a structure for the conversation itself.

10.3 The Emotional Burden of Being Financially Indispensable

The financial dimension of provider overload is only half of the subject. The other half is emotional, and it is this half that men find hardest to describe.

Indispensability

A man who is financially indispensable occupies a position that has four consequences, and all four operate simultaneously.

He cannot be ill. A man whose income supports nine people cannot afford a period of incapacity. Acute illness is manageable; chronic illness is not, because the reduction in income coincides with the period of greatest need. Men in this position frequently describe a specific and frightening calculation: what would happen to the household if I were unable to work for three months? The calculation usually produces an answer that no insurance arrangement would cover.

He cannot rest without cost. Any reduction in working hours is experienced as a reduction in protection. Men describe the same pattern repeatedly: rest taken on a Saturday is compensated for by work on Sunday, so that the rest produces no reduction in strain but adds guilt to it.

He cannot take risks with his position. Changing employment, starting a business, refusing additional responsibility, or declining an opportunity requires a capacity to absorb a period of lower income. A man supporting nine people does not have that capacity, which means the available options in his own life narrow precisely as his obligations grow.

He cannot be replaced. The circumstance that produces the greatest psychological weight is not the volume of the obligation but its concentration: the household's welfare depends on one person's continued capacity to work. This is a structural fact, and it produces a continuous, low-level dread that men describe in the same terms across countries and income levels: *if I fall, we all fall.*

The Emotional Consequences

Four emotional consequences follow from this structure, and each is systematically under-discussed.

Resentment. A man maintains an internal account: what he gives, what is received, what is expected of him, and what he is permitted to need. Where the account is permanently unbalanced, resentment accumulates. Its features are specific. It is rarely expressed, because expressing it would be shameful. It is frequently directed at the wrong target: a man resents his brother but is short-tempered with his wife. And it produces a hardening that is not recognised by the man and is clearly perceived by his household.

Fear. Continuous anticipation of the moment at which capacity fails: the illness, the lost contract, the hospital bill that exceeds what is available.

Isolation. The arrangement cannot be discussed, because the disclosure would either alarm those who depend on him or produce the appearance of complaint. The older the arrangement becomes, the harder the conversation becomes, which is precisely the trap described in Chapter 1.

A private sense of unreality. Men in this position frequently describe a curious and difficult sensation: the sense that their own life is not entirely theirs, that they are carrying a function rather than living a life, and that they do not

know what they would do if the obligations disappeared. Chapter 24 addresses this in the context of identity loss, and Chapter 40 in the context of recovering a life of one's own.

The Effects on the Household

Provider overload produces four effects inside the man's own household, and they are worth listing because the man rarely sees them.

Absence. The hours required to fund the network of obligations are taken from the household: from time with children, from time with a partner, and from the domestic work of running a home.

Irritability and withdrawal at home. Because the strain cannot be expressed at its source — a man cannot be angry with his mother's illness or his relative's request — it is discharged where the consequences are lowest.

The transmission of the burden to the wife. Many women in such households absorb the consequences: they take on paid work to cover the household's shortfall while aware that the husband's income is going elsewhere, they manage the daily consequences of a reduced budget, and they carry the emotional weight of a husband who is present but unavailable.

A model of manhood for the children. Children in these households learn a specific set of lessons: that a man gives without limit, that needs are not expressed, that strain is carried without comment, and that the family's resources belong to whoever asks for them first. The lesson is transmitted with the same effectiveness as its older version described in Part One.

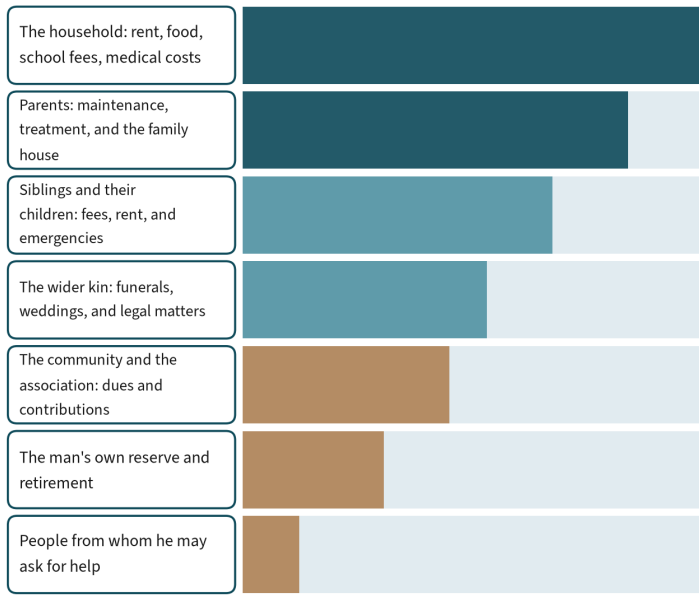


Figure 10.1 The load a provider carries, and the thinness of the support available to him. The bars are conceptual rather than measured; the pattern is consistent in the accounts men give.

What Is Often Mistaken for Virtue

A difficulty in addressing this subject is that provider overload presents as virtue. A man who supports nine people is admired, described as responsible, and held up as an example. This admiration is genuine and it has a cost: it establishes the arrangement as a standard that the man cannot question without appearing to diminish himself, and it removes the possibility of his raising the subject in any ordinary conversation.

Two clarifications assist. First, gratitude for the man's contribution and criticism of the arrangement are not contradictory; both can be held at once. Second, the alternative to unlimited liability is not refusal. It is a defined contribution: a figure, a duration, a plan, and a review — which is what a serious institution would require before it entered a comparable obligation.

10.4 Setting Boundaries Without Abandoning Responsibility

The practical work of this chapter is the introduction of boundaries into an arrangement where none has existed, and the work is difficult for three reasons that must be acknowledged in advance.

The first boundary is always the hardest. Where no limit has previously existed, the first *no* is experienced by everyone as a rupture rather than an adjustment. It will be interpreted as a change in the man's character, a sign that he has become proud, and, in some cases, as a betrayal.

Boundaries are easier to establish when they are general rather than particular. *I now give each sibling a fixed amount once a month, and I am not able to do more than that* is easier to sustain than a case-by-case refusal, because it applies to everyone equally.

Boundaries require disclosure of capacity. A boundary that is asserted without explanation invites a challenge. A boundary accompanied by a factual statement of capacity — income, obligations, and the arithmetic — is difficult to argue with, because it is not a matter of willingness.

The Method

The method has five steps.

Step One: Establish the total. Before any conversation, produce the arithmetic: total income, total obligations, and the actual allocation across the four bands described in Section 10.1. Nothing proceeds without this figure, and it should be written down.

Step Two: Decide the allocation deliberately. Rather than accepting the accumulated arrangement, set the allocation: what proportion of income goes to the household, to parents, to relatives, to community contributions, and — an item that men omit and which is required — to the man's own health, his retirement, and a reserve. The allocation should be a decision, with reasons, and it should be written.

Step Three: Introduce the boundary as a general arrangement, not a series of refusals. Two forms work well.

- *From this month I am putting family support on a fixed schedule. Here is what I can do for you. I will not be able to do more than this, and I am telling everybody the same thing.*
- *I have had to restructure my finances. I will continue to support X, and I will not be able to continue with Y from March. I am telling you early so you have time to plan.*

Step Four: Attach the boundary to the facts rather than to your feelings. The conversation should contain the arithmetic, stated briefly and without self-justification. Men who explain their boundaries through emotion — *I am tired; I cannot continue; nobody considers me* — find that the conversation becomes a negotiation about their attitude, whereas a conversation about figures is a negotiation about arithmetic.

Step Five: Hold the line, and make a substitution where possible. A boundary accompanied by an alternative is more survivable for everyone. Where a monthly subsidy is reduced, a capacity-building option, an introduction, a specific piece of assistance, or a plan to assist with a business can be offered in its place.

The Conversations, in Order of Difficulty

Men who have made these changes report a consistent sequence, and it is worth setting out because the sequence reduces the cost.

1. **The partner.** Easiest, most important, and the foundation for everything else. The whole position is disclosed, the allocation is agreed, and a joint position is established.
2. **The community obligations.** Usually uncomplicated: the reduction of contributions is accepted, with comment, and the man's standing is essentially unaffected. Most men discover that the cost of the reduction in social terms was considerably lower than they had assumed.
3. **The distant relatives and the informal network.** Manageable with the general-arrangement formula. Some relationships reduce in warmth; in the author's experience, few are lost.
4. **Siblings and the shared obligation towards parents.** Difficult, because the conversation concerns a third party who is not present and who is not choosing.
5. **Parents.** The most difficult conversation in the sequence, and the one most carefully phrased. Two principles apply: never frame the boundary as a reduction in respect; and where the reduction concerns medical costs, involve the siblings before the conversation, so that the parent is presented with a coordinated arrangement rather than a withdrawal.

What Not to Do

Three errors are common and avoidable.

Do not set the first boundary in a crisis. Boundaries introduced at the moment of a demand, when emotion is high and there is no plan, are experienced as a refusal and are frequently reversed.

Do not set boundaries you will not hold. A boundary abandoned under pressure is worse than no boundary, because it teaches the network that the limit is provisional.

Do not withdraw from the community obligation entirely. As Section 10.1 noted, the community is a form of insurance. A man who removes his participation completely removes his access to support in the moment he needs it.

10.5 Shared Financial Planning

The most reliable protection against provider overload is a household that plans its finances together. This section sets out the mechanisms, which are simple and which require almost no financial expertise.

The Monthly Budget Meeting

The single most effective practice is a monthly meeting, of about forty-five minutes, at a fixed time, between the man and his partner, with four agenda items.

1. **The position.** Income received, obligations paid, and the balance. Figures only.
2. **The obligations list.** Every obligation, including those to relatives, with its amount, its duration, and its review date. This is where concealment re-enters if it is permitted to, which is why the list is written rather than remembered.
3. **The decisions.** Any new obligation, any reduction, and any change to the allocation. New obligations are agreed rather than announced.
4. **The next month.** The specific payments, the amounts required, and any event requiring expenditure.

Children of secondary-school age and above can be included in a simplified version of the first and fourth items, which has the secondary benefit of teaching financial literacy in the only context in which it is learned: a household's actual decisions.

Three rules make the meeting work. It is held whether or not there is anything new, because its regularity is what makes difficult disclosures possible. It concerns figures and plans rather than conduct, which keeps it from becoming an accounting of blame. And it concludes with the position written down and kept, so that the household has a record.

The Priority List

A written order of priority for the household, agreed in advance, prevents most of the arguments that occur during a shortfall. A workable order, which households should adapt, runs as follows.

Table 10.1 A priority order for household expenditure. The essential feature is that the order is agreed in advance, in a calm month, so that it does not have to be negotiated during a crisis.

Priority	Category	Rationale
1	Housing: rent or mortgage, and utilities	Loss of housing is the most disruptive single event
2	Food and basic household requirements	Non-negotiable

Priority	Category	Rationale
3	Medical care	Postponement produces larger costs later
4	Education	A commitment, and an investment with returns
5	Secured and legally enforced debts	Where default produces asset loss or proceedings
6	Transport required for income	The means of producing income belongs before discretionary items
7	Family support obligations	Real, and subordinate to the household's survival
8	Community obligations	Social capital, and reducible in a way that most others are not
9	Discretionary expenditure and display	The category that absorbs the shortfall in a managed household

The Written Schedule of Family Support

For every ongoing support obligation, record four items: the recipient, the amount, the duration, and the review date. The document serves three purposes: it establishes the total, which is otherwise invisible; it converts open-ended obligations into arrangements; and it makes the support visible to the man's partner, which is the single change most frequently described by men as having reduced conflict in their marriages.

The Reserve

The purpose of a reserve is not to accumulate wealth; it is to convert a crisis into an inconvenience. Three to six months of essential household expenditure, accumulated in a stable account and not used for any other purpose, changes the consequences of a job loss, a medical episode, or a family emergency entirely. Men who have experienced a serious financial failure describe the building of a reserve as the single change they most wished they had made earlier. Where income is low and irregular, the reserve can begin as a very small monthly set-aside, and the practice matters more than the amount.

The Structure of Accounts

A practical arrangement that reduces conflict and increases clarity, used by many households, is a simple three-way split: a household account for shared, essential expenditure, to which both partners contribute in agreed proportions; a personal account for each adult, which requires no justification; and a reserve account, which requires both parties' agreement for any withdrawal. This structure resolves the most common source of resentment — a partner spending from shared

resources without discussion — without requiring either adult to justify personal expenditure.

Retirement and the Man's Own Position

One item is systematically omitted from household planning, and it is the one that most affects the man's own later life: his own retirement provision and health cover. A man of forty-five supporting nine people frequently has no pension arrangement, no health insurance, and no assets held in his own name. The consequence arrives predictably: men in their sixties who are no longer able to work, who have no provision, and whose children are themselves under pressure. The remedy is simple and unpopular: a fixed monthly allocation to the man's own provision, treated as an obligation of equal standing to the others, from as early as possible. It is also the only item in this chapter that the reader cannot postpone without a consequence that he will personally experience.

10.6 Preventing Provider Burnout

Provider burnout is the condition produced by prolonged provision beyond capacity without recovery, and it is described in Chapter 33 in its general form. Its specific features in the provider role are these: exhaustion that does not resolve with rest; a loss of satisfaction in meeting obligations; a hardening of attitude towards the people being supported; a sense of being trapped; and a growing conviction that no amount of effort will change the situation.

The Cost of the Arrangement to the Man Himself

The practices in this chapter are frequently resisted on the grounds that they serve other people. This final subsection states the position plainly: the arrangement of unlimited provision is as damaging to the man as to anybody else, and in four specific ways.

The loss of the man's own future. Where the household's requirements, the extended family's requirements, and the community's requirements are each met from the same income, the residual is zero, and the residual is what funds the man's own retirement, health provision, and later independence. A man of fifty who has provided for everybody and has no position of his own has not behaved generously; he has behaved imprudently, and the imprudence will be paid for in the third act of his life, when his own capacities are reduced and his obligations, in many cases, are not.

The conversion of relationships into obligations. Where every relationship is conducted through the mechanism of provision, the man's value to others is defined by what he supplies. The consequence is specific and painful: when the supply reduces, the man's relationships reduce, and the man discovers that he has been surrounded by clients rather than relatives. This discovery is frequently

made in illness, in unemployment, or in retirement, which is the worst possible moment to make it.

The erosion of the man's capacity to be cared for. A man who has provided without limit for twenty years has had no practice in receiving. When his own requirement arrives — illness, incapacity, bereavement — he is unable to accept support, and the household has no practice in giving it, because the arrangement has never been reciprocal. The pattern described in Chapter 3, in which men cannot ask, is frequently the product of an arrangement in which they have never been asked.

The loss of the man's own purposes. The final cost is the least visible and the most consequential. A man defined entirely by the provision of support has no answer to the question of what he wants for his own life, and the question tends to arrive in the decade after fifty with considerable force. The practices in this chapter, and the personal definition in Chapter 11, are the two instruments by which the man's own purposes are preserved alongside his obligations.

The Warning Sequence

The sequence by which provider burnout develops is worth setting out explicitly, because it allows early intervention. Chapter 2 gave the general sequence for responsibility without support; the provider-specific version is as follows.

1. **Full engagement.** The man meets all obligations and takes on new ones. He is effective and well regarded.
2. **Silent absorption of shortfall.** The obligations exceed the income, and the difference is met by the man's own rest, medical care, and provision. Nobody knows.
3. **Loss of discretionary capacity.** Holidays, leisure, friendship, and personal expenditure are eliminated. The man attributes this to the economic situation.
4. **Debt accumulation.** Borrowing to meet obligations, followed by borrowing to service borrowing.
5. **Diminished effectiveness at work.** Sleep disturbance, errors, reduced concentration, and the beginning of reputational consequences — the very thing the arrangement was designed to prevent.
6. **Withdrawal and hardening.** Reduced contact with the extended family; reduced patience with dependants; a growing private resentment.
7. **Break point.** An event — an illness, a lost job, an exposure, a collapse in a relationship — that exceeds remaining capacity.

The Protective Practices

Five practices have a good record in preventing burnout for men in this position. They are listed in order of effect.

Establish a total and a limit. Covered above; it is the foundation of everything else. A man who does not know his total cannot know when it is exceeded.

Establish one thing that is never sacrificed. Sleep, medical care, or half a day a week. The item matters less than its status: an inviolable allocation, defended against every claim, which functions as the boundary marker for the whole arrangement. Men who maintain one such item report that it becomes the anchor for the rest.

Convert open-ended obligations into arrangements with ends. Duration and review dates, as described above. The psychological difference between an obligation with an end and an obligation without one is substantial.

Maintain one channel outside the provider role. A friendship, a sport, a group, or an activity in which the man is known for something other than his capacity to pay. Chapter 4 established the reasons this matters, and provider overload makes it more important, not less.

Share the position with one person who is not a dependant. The single strongest protective factor reported by men under prolonged provider strain is the existence of one relationship in which the man is not the provider: not a spouse, not a parent, not a child, and not a relative who receives support. A friend, a peer, a mentor, a professional, or a peer group serves the purpose. If the reader's own list of such relationships is empty, that fact is the most important finding of this chapter, and Appendix J is the place to begin.

10.7 Illustrative Case: The Eldest Son of Seven

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family counselling, financial advisory work, and research on extended-family obligation.

Godwin is fifty-six, a retired secondary-school principal who now runs a small tutorial centre. He is the eldest of seven siblings. He was the first in the family to attend university, and it was understood from his early twenties — understood by everybody, including him — that his position carried responsibilities.

Over thirty years, Godwin's obligations accumulated in a manner nobody ever audited. He paid the school fees of all six of his younger siblings through secondary school, and of four of them through tertiary education. He built a house for his mother after his father's death and maintained it. He paid for the weddings of two sisters and the burial of an uncle. He contributed to the school fees of nine nieces and nephews. He funded medical treatment for his mother over eleven years, including two prolonged hospitalisations. He contributed to the community development association at a level set by his professional position. He built his own house,

educated his four children, and supported his wife's mother for the last seven years of her life.

His income was never sufficient for these obligations, and the gap was met in a consistent order: first from savings, then from a cooperative loan, then from a second loan, then from the sale of a plot of land he had bought for his own retirement, then by delaying his own medical treatment — he had a persistent hypertension problem for which he filled prescriptions irregularly — and finally by continuing to work after retirement rather than resting.

He told nobody. His wife knew that the family needed money and knew that the relatives made requests; she did not know the total, and she did not know about the second loan or the sale of the land. His siblings knew only their own arrangements. His children knew nothing at all.

The crisis arrived when Godwin had a stroke at the age of fifty-five. He recovered substantially, and he was unable to work for seven months. In that period, three facts became visible to the whole family for the first time: the total of the outstanding obligations; the absence of any provision for himself, including a pension of very modest value and no health cover; and the fact that his wife had, for four years, been quietly financing the household's shortfall from her own teaching income without knowing the reason for the shortfall.

The family's response, once the position was known, was not what Godwin had feared. Two of his brothers restructured the support to his mother between them. A sister took over the fees for two of the nieces and nephews. The community association, informed in general terms, reduced his levy without comment. And his eldest son, who had been at university, took a part-time job, which he had not previously been permitted to do because his father considered it a mark of failure that a son of his should need to work while studying.

Godwin's own account of the episode, given two years later, was as follows: *I never decided to carry all of it. I decided, one request at a time, three hundred times, and nobody ever asked me to add it up — not my wife, not my brothers, and not me. The stroke was the first time anybody added it up, and when they did, it took four people eleven days to redistribute what I had been carrying alone for twenty years.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The obligations were individually legitimate and collectively impossible. Every item on Godwin's list would have been defended by any member of the family. The problem was never the reasonableness of any single obligation; it was the absence of a total.

The gap was met in a predictable sequence. Savings, then borrowing, then productive assets, then personal health, then post-retirement work. This sequence is reported consistently by men in this position, and it is worth recording because it identifies the warning points: by the time productive assets are being sold, the arrangement is already unsustainable.

The concealment was perpetuated by consideration. Godwin did not tell his wife because he did not want to worry her. He did not tell his brothers because the conversation would have been awkward. He did not tell his son because it would have diminished him in the boy's eyes. Every one of these reasons was considerate, and their cumulative effect was a man carrying a family's obligations alone until his body intervened.

The redistribution was feasible. The most important finding in the case is the one Godwin had not anticipated: once the position was visible, the obligations were redistributed within eleven days and without the disgrace he had feared. The brothers and the sister had the capacity. They simply had never been asked, and no one had known that the arrangement existed in its actual shape.

The cost that was not recoverable was the man's own provision. The stroke caused permanent changes; the hypertension that had gone untreated contributed to it; the land intended for retirement was gone; and the household's security was permanently reduced. The obligations were redistributed, and the man's own future could not be.

10.8 Practical Exercise: The Dependency Map and the Allocation Plan

This exercise has four parts and takes about two hours. It may be completed alone, and it is considerably more effective when the results are discussed with a partner.

Part One: The Dependency Map

Draw a central circle for yourself, and place a circle for every person or body that depends on you. For each, record four items:

Dependent	Financial	Time	Decisions	Emotional availability
Spouse or partner				
Each child				
Each parent				
Each sibling receiving support				
Other relatives				
Community or religious bodies				
Employees, if any				

For the financial column, enter an actual monthly figure. For the remaining columns, enter hours per week, or a rating from one to five.

Most men who complete this table for the first time find two things: that the financial total is materially higher than they had estimated, and that the time and decision columns add up to more than a working week.

Part Two: The Test of Necessity and Choice

For each obligation, mark one of four letters.

- **N** — Necessary: the obligation protects survival, health, or an irreversible commitment.
- **C** — Chosen: I have decided this deliberately and would defend it as my responsibility.
- **A** — Accumulated: this continues because it began, not because it was chosen.
- **P** — Pressure: this continues because refusing would be socially or emotionally costly, not because the need is real.

The *A* and *P* categories are the available reductions, and the total in those two columns is almost always substantial.

Part Three: The Allocation

Write a deliberate allocation of your income across six categories: household essentials; education and children's requirements; parents; other relatives; community; and your own health, reserve, and retirement. The allocation must total one hundred per cent and must include the sixth category at a non-zero level. Then apply one rule: the allocation takes effect from a named month, and every obligation that exceeds it is reduced, renegotiated, or ended.

Part Four: The Three Conversations

Write the opening three sentences of each of the following conversations, in your own words and in the order given.

1. **With your partner.** Disclose the total, including obligations she does not know about, and propose the allocation. Appendix F provides a structure.
2. **With the relatives whose support will change.** Use the general-arrangement form from Section 10.4. Give the figure, the date it takes effect, and what will not change.
3. **With the siblings, about a shared obligation.** Propose the redistribution: what each sibling will contribute, and how the arrangement will respond to future increases in need.

Write the sentences rather than the intention to have the conversation. Men who write them report that the act of composition removes about half of the difficulty.

10.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it not my duty to support my family? My father did it for his family."

It is a duty, and it is not an unlimited one. The distinction that resolves the apparent conflict is between a defined responsibility and unlimited liability. A man who supports his family within a deliberate allocation is discharging the

duty; a man who carries an unlimited obligation until his health fails is discharging it in a manner that removes his capacity to continue, which serves nobody.

"My brother has a good job but contributes nothing. How do I raise this without destroying the family?"

By raising it as an arrangement rather than as an accusation. *This is what I have been paying. I cannot continue at this level. This is what I propose we each contribute.* The conversation is easier when the man brings figures rather than grievances, and when he proposes rather than protests.

"If I reduce the support, will I not be disgraced in the community?"

Some comment is likely, and the record of men who have made the change is that it is less than expected, and that it is frequently accompanied by respect for having faced the arithmetic. The reduction in community contributions is the least costly item in the whole arrangement: standing, in most communities, depends much more on a man's character and availability than on the size of his contribution in a difficult year.

"My wife says I give too much to my family. What if she is right, and what if she is not?"

The productive way to settle the question is the allocation in Part Three of the exercise: a figure, agreed, with a category for her family as well as yours. Men frequently discover that their partners object not to the support but to their exclusion from the decision, and that a partner who is included is more generous than the man anticipated.

"How do I tell my mother that I cannot continue paying for her treatment?"

Not by reducing care, but by redistributing its cost. Involve the siblings before the conversation, so that the arrangement presented to her is a coordinated plan rather than a withdrawal, and frame it in terms of what will continue rather than what will stop.

"What if my obligations genuinely cannot be reduced?"

Then the priority is to increase capacity rather than to reduce the obligations: an additional income stream, a renegotiation of a rate, a change to the pattern of work, or the disposal of a low-value asset in favour of a productive one. Where neither is possible in the short term, the objective becomes the protection of the essentials — sleep, medical care, and one channel of support — and Chapter 12 addresses the management of work under these conditions.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 10 in brief. The expectations placed on a family provider arrive in four bands: the household's subsistence, investment, and standard; support for parents;

support for siblings, their children, and the wider kin; and community contributions. Each obligation is legitimate, and no one ever adds them up. When they are added up, the total frequently exceeds the man's entire income, and the difference is met by borrowing, by the sale of assets, by the deferral of his own medical care, and by the assumption that he will work until he dies.

Supporting each band of dependants requires different practices. For parents: a plan agreed with the siblings, a separation of predictable from unpredictable costs, and the recognition that time is frequently valued more than money. For a spouse: shared decisions about transfers to relatives, and symmetry between both partners' family obligations. For children: educational commitments structured as far as possible, consistent treatment between children, and presence as a form of provision. For relatives: defined arrangements in place of repeated ad hoc payments, capacity-building in preference to consumption support, and the redistributive principle that other relatives exist.

The emotional burden of being financially indispensable is a man who cannot be ill, cannot rest without guilt, cannot take risks with his position, and cannot be replaced. The consequences are resentment, fear, isolation, and a private sense of unreality; their effects inside the household are absence, irritability at home, the transmission of the burden to the wife, and a model of manhood that children carry forward.

Provider overload presents as virtue, which is what makes it difficult to discuss. The alternative to unlimited liability is not refusal but a defined contribution: a figure, a duration, a plan, and a review. Boundaries are established by producing the total, deciding the allocation deliberately, introducing the boundary as a general arrangement rather than a series of refusals, attaching it to facts rather than feelings, and holding it while offering substitutions where possible. The conversations should begin with the partner and end with the parents.

Shared financial planning is the most reliable protection: a monthly budget meeting with a fixed agenda; a written priority order for expenditure agreed in a calm month; a written schedule of family support obligations with durations and review dates; a reserve of three to six months; a three-account structure that removes the most common source of resentment; and a deliberate allocation to the man's own retirement and health cover, which is the item most frequently omitted and the one he cannot postpone without personal consequences.

Provider burnout develops through a recognisable sequence from full engagement to break point. Its protective practices are the establishment of a total and a limit, the maintenance of one thing that is never sacrificed, the conversion of open-ended obligations into arrangements with ends, the maintenance of one channel outside the provider role, and the existence of at least one relationship in which the man is not the provider. Where that last item is absent, it is the most important finding available to the reader.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the dependency map in your head before writing it down. How many people depend on you financially? What is the total monthly figure, and when did you last calculate it?
2. Which of your obligations are in categories *A* (accumulated) and *P* (pressure)? What would the total saving be if they were reduced?
3. Section 10.3 describes four consequences of indispensability: he cannot be ill, cannot rest, cannot take risks, and cannot be replaced. Which one weighs most heavily on you, and what would reduce it?
4. When did you last have a budget meeting with your partner that concerned figures rather than conduct? What prevented it, and what would make it possible this month?
5. What is your own provision — pension, health cover, reserve — and how does it compare with what you provide to others? What does the comparison suggest?
6. Which of the five protective practices in Section 10.6 do you currently maintain? If none, which one could you establish this month, at the smallest viable scale?
7. Is there one person in your life in whose company you are not the provider? If not, who could become that person, and what is the first step?

Further Reading

- **On extended-family obligation in Africa:** the research literature on extended-family support systems, remittances, and kinship obligation in West Africa and comparable settings, including studies of the pressures placed on the highest-earning member and of the effects of urbanisation and migration on the distribution of obligation.
- **On caregiving and burden:** the established body of research on caregiver burden, including the concepts of role overload, objective versus subjective burden, and the protective factors that reduce burnout — much of which applies directly to men carrying long-term family obligations.
- **On boundaries:** the practical literature on boundary-setting and assertiveness, including scripts and the well-documented finding that boundaries framed as general arrangements are more sustainable than those framed as individual refusals.
- **On household finance:** practical material on family budgeting, the priority ordering of expenditure, emergency funds, and the structure of household accounts. Consumer protection bodies and cooperative societies in Nigeria and elsewhere publish free guidance that is adapted to local conditions.

- **On men's provider role:** the research on how the provider role affects men's identity, health, and family relationships, including studies of the psychological effects of being the sole earner and of the transition from sole provider to shared responsibility.

11 CHAPTER

The Pressure to Become Successful

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the social definition of a successful man, identify its components, and explain how that definition is transmitted and enforced.
2. Analyse the relationship between career ambition and personal identity, including the point at which ambition begins to substitute for identity.
3. Describe the experience of delayed achievement and its psychological consequences, and distinguish between delay that is temporary and delay that requires a change of plan.
4. Recognise the specific effects of unemployment, underemployment, and lost opportunity on men, and identify the support that is appropriate in each case.
5. Assess the cost of constant comparison in his own working life, and apply the practical measures that reduce it.
6. Construct an individual definition of success, expressed in specific and verifiable terms, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

There is a conversation that takes place in almost every extended family, at almost every gathering, and it follows a predictable script. A young man is asked what he is doing now. He answers with his employment, his business, or his studies. The elder responds with a comparison: a cousin who has been called to the bar, a neighbour's son who has a job with an oil company, a nephew who has built a house in the town. The comparison is intended as encouragement, and it is received as a measurement.

Twenty-five years later, the same man is fifty, and the conversation has changed format but not function. He is now the one being described to others, and the description consists of his position, his property, his children's institutions, and his contribution at the last ceremony. He has, by the standards of the conversation, done reasonably well. He is also aware, with a precision that he does not discuss,

that he was overtaken by two men he started with, that he did not become what he was expected to become, and that some of the ambitions he held at twenty-five are now permanently out of reach.

This chapter is about the pressure to become successful, and it proceeds from a distinction that will organise everything else. There are two questions in this territory, and they are frequently confused. The first is: **am I making progress towards something I actually value?** The second is: **am I ahead of the people I am being compared with?** The first is a question about a life. The second is a question about a ranking. Most men, if asked, would say that the first matters more. Most men, under pressure, spend their working lives answering the second.

11.1 Society's Definition of a Successful Man

The definition of success varies in detail between communities, and its structure is remarkably consistent. Five components do most of the work.

Income and its visible signs. A man's income is not usually known, so it is inferred from what can be seen: housing, vehicle, clothing, the school attended by his children, the size of his contributions, and the ease with which he responds to requests for assistance.

Occupation and title. The nature and status of a man's work, together with any formal position he occupies. In many communities the distinction between salaried employment, self-employment, and informal work carries substantial evaluative weight, independently of the income that each produces.

Family formation and its success. Marriage, children, and the visible well-being of the household. A man whose marriage has failed, or whose adult children are not prospering, is frequently assessed as having been unsuccessful regardless of his professional record.

Property. Land, housing, and, frequently, a house in the home area. Property is the most durable and most public of the markers, and its acquisition is frequently the standard by which a working life is judged.

Standing in the community. Positions held, respect shown, the ability to be called upon, and the recognition of the family as one that has produced someone.

Each component is legitimate as a value. Housing, family, useful work, and community standing are goods in themselves. The difficulty is produced by three features of the aggregate definition, and they are worth examining carefully, because each of them causes specific damage.

Feature One: The Definition Is Comparative

Success in this framework is not defined by a standard but by a position. A man is successful if he is ahead of a reference group, and the reference group is not fixed. This produces the consequences set out in Chapter 7: satisfaction is temporary, the standard rises with achievement, and the conclusion is never reached. It also

produces a specific distortion in the assessment of one's own life: a man may have made genuine progress in the terms that matter to him — income sufficient for his household, children educated, health intact, marriage stable — and still assess himself as unsuccessful because the comparison is unfavourable.

Feature Two: The Definition Is Public

Men are assessed by others, and the assessment is conducted in public and recorded in visible form. The consequence is that a man's private evaluation of his own life is constantly contradicted, or confirmed, by other people's commentary: the remark about the car, the question about the house, the observation that a contemporary has been promoted, the unsolicited advice about what he should consider doing next.

The public quality of the assessment has an important implication. A man cannot simply decide to adopt a private definition of success without cost, because the public definition continues to operate on him through the people around him. The practical work, described in Section 11.6, therefore involves both a private standard and a practical strategy for handling the public one.

Feature Three: The Timetable Is Borrowed from a Different Economy

The third feature is the most damaging and the least often discussed. The definition of a successful man was established in economies with predictable career ladders, stable employment, and rising real incomes, and it assumed a life in which a man would be established by his late thirties and secure by his fifties. It is now applied to men living in economies with high youth unemployment, unstable earnings, informal-sector work, currency instability, and career paths that are frequently interrupted rather than progressive.

The consequence is a systematic setting of expectations that many men cannot meet, through no failure of their own. A man of thirty-five who is working hard, supporting his household, and making genuine progress is measured against a timetable calibrated to a different economic world, and he is instructed — by the comparison, by his family, and, most severely, by himself — that he is behind.

> **KEY POINT**
> The pressure to succeed combines five legitimate values — income, work, family, property, and standing — with three destructive properties: a comparative standard, a public assessment, and a timetable borrowed from an economy that no longer exists. The values can be kept. The three properties must be replaced.

11.2 Career Ambition and Personal Identity

Ambition is not a disorder. The desire to build something, to advance, to be of use, and to achieve a standard is honourable, and it is one of the sources of the

considerable achievements of the men this book is written for. The difficulty arises when ambition ceases to be an activity and becomes an identity, and this happens so gradually that most men cannot identify the point of transition.

The Three Relationships of a Man to His Work

It is useful to distinguish three positions, because the interventions differ.

Work as a means. The man works in order to fund a life. His identity is elsewhere: family, faith, community, craft, or interests. He performs well, frequently out of professional obligation, and he leaves the work at the end of the day. This position is increasingly uncommon among men in professional employment, and it remains legitimate and durable.

Work as a vocation. The man is genuinely engaged by the work itself: he finds it interesting, he develops, he takes pride in quality, and he is willing to invest heavily in it. His identity is substantially invested in the work, and this is a stable arrangement as long as the work remains available and as long as the man retains some identity outside it.

Work as an identity. The man's entire sense of himself is contained in his professional role and its position. This position is unstable in three specific ways: it fails when the work is lost; it produces chronic insecurity even when the work succeeds, because the identity requires continuous confirmation; and it produces the erosion described in Chapter 24, in which a man who loses his role loses his sense of who he is.

The transition from the second position to the third is rarely deliberate. It occurs through the ordinary accumulation of years in which the man's competence, recognition, and usefulness are supplied almost exclusively by his work, and in which the other sources of identity — friendships, interests, community participation, and family roles — have been allowed to become secondary or have been abandoned for lack of time.

Society's definition of a successful man	An individual definition that will hold
Comparative: success is measured against the men around him, so the standard moves whenever his position does.	Stated in domains rather than in one: work, household, health, contribution, and conduct.
Public: the evidence must be visible — the house, the vehicle, the title, the school, the office.	Measured against his own previous position, not against a moving comparison group.
Borrowed timetable: the milestones are dated against an economy and a generation that are not his own.	Answered by items the audience cannot see, so it survives the loss of a title.
Single-domain: career position is treated as the whole of the verdict on the man.	Reviewed annually, in writing, against what he actually did.

Figure 11.1 The received definition of success and a definition that can survive a change in the man's position. The right-hand column is built from items that do not disappear when a title does.

The Substitution of Achievement for Identity

A specific mechanism is worth naming, because it is common among men in mid-life. A man who has lost an important external source of identity — a marriage, a father, a community role, a faith practice, a friendship group — frequently substitutes professional achievement for what he has lost, without recognising that this is what he is doing. The substitution is effective in the short term, because achievement supplies structure and self-regard. Its costs are three.

It requires continuous output. Where identity is supplied by achievement, the cessation of achievement is an identity emergency rather than a period of rest. Men in this position cannot take leave without discomfort, and retirement is frequently experienced not as relief but as bereavement.

It is fragile to market conditions. Work-based identity is vulnerable to events entirely outside the man's control: a company restructuring, an economic downturn, an industry change, an illness.

It removes the other sources. The time invested in achievement is taken from the relationships and activities that would supply identity in other circum-

stances, which means a man who has substituted achievement for identity has also destroyed his alternatives.

The Ambition That Cannot Be Satisfied

A further pattern is worth describing because it is so frequently reported by successful men: the ambition that expands at the rate of achievement, so that no level of attainment produces satisfaction. Its features are recognisable. Each goal, once achieved, is immediately replaced by a larger one. Rest feels like falling behind. Competitors are monitored continuously. Achievements are enjoyed for a period measured in days, if at all.

The pattern has a source that is worth understanding: the ambition is not calibrated to a life but to a position. Because the position can always be improved, and because the reference group can always be enlarged, the ambition has no terminus, and it delivers a sustainable supply of dissatisfaction with a variable supply of accomplishment. Chapter 7 set out the machinery. In this chapter, the important point is that the pattern is frequently mistaken for dedication, and that the men who hold it are frequently respected for the very arrangement that is making them miserable.

11.3 Delayed Achievement and Disappointment

Delayed achievement is the condition of the man who is working towards a goal that has not yet arrived, and who has been working towards it for longer than he expected. It is the ordinary condition of a large proportion of men in mid-life, and it is the source of a specific and under-recognised distress.

The Distinctive Character of Delayed Achievement

The experience has four features that distinguish it from failure.

There is nothing to mourn. A man who has failed at a definable task can respond to it: he can analyse, adjust, and set a new objective. A man whose achievement has been delayed has not failed — he is still working, still moving, still within his own account of the plan — and therefore has no event to process. What he has is a chronic discrepancy between where he is and where he expected to be.

The timetable is usually unspoken. Most men cannot say precisely what they expected at thirty, at forty, and at fifty, because the expectation was never formulated. It was absorbed from the comparisons of the environment described in Section 11.1. A man therefore experiences disappointment at missing a deadline he never wrote down.

The evidence is ambiguous. Some of the markers of success are present and some are not: a man may have a stable income and no property; educated children and no reserve; a respected position and no retirement provision. The

ambiguity prevents any clean conclusion, so the man remains permanently uncertain whether he is behind or on schedule, and the uncertainty itself becomes exhausting.

The comparison is continuous. Because the reference group is visible and mobile, a man encounters evidence of other men's achievement at weddings, at funerals, on social media, in the family house, and in the market. Each encounter reactivates the timetable.

The Psychological Consequences

Four consequences follow, and they commonly co-occur.

A chronic sense of being behind. Not an acute distress but a standing background condition, frequently described as a pressure that is always present and never articulated.

Compensatory activity. Working longer, taking on additional engagements, and pursuing accelerated plans. This is the most common response and it is frequently counterproductive: the additional activity increases risk, reduces the quality of decisions, and erodes health and relationships.

Loss of pleasure in the present. Where all satisfaction is deferred to the arrival of the goal, the intervening years are experienced as a waiting room. Men in this position frequently describe a decade of their lives as having been spent entirely in preparation.

Reluctance to celebrate. Because celebration would imply that the position is acceptable, and the position is not yet acceptable.

Temporary Delay and Structural Delay

The practical response depends on a distinction that men frequently do not make.

Temporary delay is a delay produced by a defined and time-limited circumstance: a further qualification being completed, a market that is in a cyclical downturn, a business in its growth phase, a debt being cleared, a care obligation that will end. The appropriate response is to continue, with a defined review point at which the situation will be reassessed if the delay has not resolved.

Structural delay is a delay produced by conditions that will not change on the current path: a ceiling in a profession, a market that has permanently changed, an employment structure that no longer exists, a plan that depends on capital the man cannot obtain, an obligation that has been redefined as permanent. The appropriate response is a change of plan.

The diagnostic question is simple, and men frequently find it uncomfortable to answer: **if nothing changes in my circumstances, and I continue on this path for five more years, will the position be different?** If the honest answer is no, the situation is structural, and continuing is not persistence; it is a strategy of

avoidance. Chapter 24 addresses the transition that follows from accepting such a conclusion, and Chapter 38 addresses the rebuilding.

11.4 Unemployment, Underemployment, and Lost Opportunities

Three specific conditions produce the most severe pressure on men's self-regard, and they require separate treatment because their effects differ.

Unemployment

Unemployment damages men's mental health more severely than it damages women's, on average, in most countries for which data are available, and the effect is strongest in men who were the principal earner of a household. The mechanisms are documented: loss of income; loss of the structure and social contact that employment supplies; loss of the role through which the man's standing in his household and community is constructed; and the pressure of time, which produces rumination rather than rest.

The specific features of unemployment that men report, and that families should expect, are the following.

- **A collapse of structure.** Sleep and waking times drift; days become undifferentiated; the absence of an imposed schedule is experienced as disorientation rather than freedom.
- **Social withdrawal.** Avoidance of gatherings at which the question *what are you doing now?* will be asked, and, frequently, avoidance of former colleagues and of the street on which the former workplace stands.
- **Anger and irritability.** The strain is discharged at home, which is the most damaging feature of the whole condition, and which frequently produces a deterioration in the relationship that is the man's principal support.
- **The job-search decay.** Effort applied to the search declines over months, not through laziness but through the accumulated effect of rejection and the erosion of the belief that the effort will succeed.
- **Health deterioration.** Reduced activity, increased alcohol use, poor diet, and the deferral of medical care. The elevated mortality risk associated with unemployment, which is well documented in the research literature, operates substantially through these routes.

What helps, in the accounts men give, is four things: structure deliberately imposed on the week; the preservation of one or more identities not connected to employment; the separation of the job search into timetabled activity rather than a continuous background condition; and, crucially, at least one person with whom the position can be discussed honestly rather than performed. Chapter 38 addresses the sequence in which these should be established after a job loss.

Underemployment

Underemployment is the condition of working in a position below one's qualifications, experience, or capacity: a graduate working in informal trade, a professional in a role well below his level, a man with a trade who can obtain only casual labour. It is frequently more corrosive to self-regard than unemployment, for three reasons.

The conditions of the role are a daily reminder. Unemployment is a condition; underemployment is a condition experienced inside a workplace, in the form of unsuitable tasks, reduced autonomy, inadequate pay, and the observed position of less-qualified colleagues.

It attracts comment. Men in this position are frequently discussed by relatives and friends, and the discussion includes the assessment that they have not done well, that they have wasted their education, that they should have done something else.

It appears optional. Because the man is employed, his difficulties are frequently not recognised as difficulties. He is not offered the support that an unemployed man would receive, and he is expected to be grateful.

The practical approach to underemployment has three components. First, the work should be recognised as a legitimate achievement rather than a status: it feeds a household, and the fact that it is below his capacity does not make it a failure. Second, a plan for movement should be made explicit — a qualification, a skill, a network, a transition route — with a timetable, because the combination of a household's immediate needs and the demands of the present role tends to eliminate all planning capacity. Third, the domain of identity should be diversified deliberately, since the present role will not supply it.

Lost Opportunities

The third condition is the most private of the three, and it is frequently disclosed only in counselling or late in life: the sense that a specific opportunity was lost, and that the loss determined everything that followed.

The opportunities men name are specific and recurring. The scholarship or admission not taken up. The job not accepted because the family needed him at home. The business not started because the capital was used for a relative's obligation. The move to another city not made. The partnership declined because of a disagreement that now appears trivial. The training not undertaken.

The psychology of lost opportunity has three features. It is comparative: the loss is measured against an imagined alternative life, which is always more successful than any actual one would have been. It is frequently attached to a specific person: a parent, a spouse, or a superior whose requirement caused the opportunity to be declined. And it is often accompanied by a conviction that the

opportunity was the only one, a belief that is rarely accurate and that is maintained by the fact that the alternative path has never been tested.

Three responses are useful. First, the opportunity should be recorded accurately, including the constraints under which the decision was made, since decisions made under constraint are not the same as mistakes. Second, the imagined alternative should be examined, because it is a constructed version of a life that would have contained its own difficulties. Third, and most usefully, the loss should be converted into an assessment of what remains available: opportunities of a different kind, at a different life stage, which the man has been excluding from consideration because he has been measuring them against the one that was lost. Chapter 28 develops this work in full.

11.5 The Hidden Cost of Constant Comparison

Constant comparison is the mechanism by which the definition of success described in Section 11.1 operates on a man's daily experience, and its costs are frequently invisible to the man paying them. Six costs are worth naming.

The loss of intrinsic satisfaction. A man who measures himself against others loses access to the satisfaction that comes from the work itself: solving a difficult problem, developing a skill, doing something well. The work becomes a means of keeping position, and its intrinsic rewards are no longer registered.

The distortion of decisions. Comparison does not merely produce feelings; it produces assessments, and assessments guide decisions. Men have taken on unmanageable debt, expanded businesses beyond their capacity, bought vehicles they could not maintain, and accepted roles for which they were not suited, in each case on the basis of a comparison rather than an analysis.

The erosion of generosity. Comparison converts peers into rivals. A man who is measuring himself against his colleagues and contemporaries cannot celebrate their successes without cost, and this produces a specific and unpleasant change in character that men frequently notice in themselves with alarm: a reluctance to congratulate, an interest in others' difficulties, and a tendency to recount one's own achievements more often than before.

The narrowing of options. Where a man's reference group is defined by a single occupation or a single community, comparison reduces the range of paths he can consider, because any deviation from the group's standard is read as failure. Men in this position frequently decline opportunities that would have suited them, because the opportunities do not compare favourably against the group's definition of advancement.

The exhaustion of the competitive posture. Continuous comparison requires continuous effort, and it produces the state described in Chapters 5 and

12: permanent readiness, degraded sleep, and a low-grade anxiety that the man attributes to work volume rather than to the ranking activity that is generating it.

The transmission to children. A father who measures himself against his contemporaries transmits the same measurement to his children. Children in such households are frequently aware, from a young age, that they are competing on their father's behalf, and they carry the arrangement forward.

The Four Practical Measures

Four measures reduce the cost of comparison without requiring the man to stop noticing others, which is not within voluntary control.

Fix your own reference point. Establish a personal standard, in writing: an income sufficient for defined obligations, a level of saving, a quantity of time at home, a state of health, and a defined contribution. Judging yourself against a standard you have chosen is the single most effective measure, and it is the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Change the reference group deliberately. Men frequently belong to reference groups that were assembled by circumstance — school cohorts, family networks, occupational peers. Deliberately adding a reference group with different priorities (a community organisation, a professional body with a service orientation, a group of men who have made an unusual choice) provides alternative standards and reduces the domination of the existing one. Chapter 27 develops the practical method.

Reduce exposure. This is unglamorous and effective: reducing the social media accounts that present curated achievement, reducing attendance at events whose primary function is display, and reducing the number of occasions on which the question *what are you doing now?* is likely to be asked. The point is not isolation but the removal of unnecessary and continuous exposure to the comparison mechanism.

Convert comparison into information. Where a comparison is genuinely relevant, it can be used rather than suffered. The questions worth extracting are specific and practical: how did he obtain that contract; what qualifications did she pursue; who introduced him to that market; what did the move cost? A comparison converted into information is a research activity, and research is not corrosive.

11.6 Creating an Individual Definition of Success

The final section is the constructive work of the chapter. It consists of constructing a definition of success that is personal, specific, verifiable, and calibrated to the man's actual circumstances — and then using it.

The Requirements of a Workable Definition

A personal definition of success must satisfy five conditions.

It must be specific. *To be successful* has no operational meaning. *To have a home in my own name, to educate all four children through secondary school, to have an income sufficient to meet my household's requirements and my mother's medical costs, and to have three months of reserve* is a definition that can be assessed and acted on.

It must be verifiable. A man must be able to determine, at any point, whether he is meeting it. Definitions that depend on other people's opinions cannot be verified and therefore cannot deliver satisfaction.

It must be yours. The exercise in Section 8.5 of Chapter 2 applies here: each element should be marked as kinship, work, or own. A definition assembled entirely from the expectations of others will be abandoned or resented.

It must be calibrated to capacity. A definition that exceeds what is achievable under the man's circumstances is a sentence rather than a plan. Where a man's definition includes elements he cannot achieve on the present path, the definition should specify the change of path rather than the impossible objective.

It must include what the man is not willing to sacrifice. This is the element most frequently omitted, and it is the one that makes the definition useful. *I will achieve X, and I am not willing to lose my health, my marriage, or my children's regard in order to do it* is a definition that includes a boundary, and the boundary is what prevents the definition from consuming the man's life in the way described in Section 11.2.

The Domains of a Personal Definition

A workable definition covers seven domains, and men who construct one are consistently surprised by how few of the seven they have ever considered deliberately.

Table 11.1 The seven domains of a personal definition of success. A definition that omits the last two domains is not a life; it is a schedule.

Domain	The question to answer
Income and work	What level of income, from what kind of work, is sufficient for the obligations I have chosen to carry?
Housing and assets	What do I need to own, and what am I able to maintain rather than merely to acquire?
Family and marriage	What kind of husband and father do I intend to be, in terms of presence and behaviour rather than provision alone?
Children	What do I want them to be able to do, and to know about me, by the time they are adults?

Domain	The question to answer
Health	What state of health do I need to sustain, and what am I doing that endangers it?
Community and contribution	What contribution do I intend to make beyond my household?
Rest and life	What do I intend to do with the time I have, and what gives me satisfaction independently of achievement?

Using the Definition

A definition of success is only useful if it is applied. Three applications are recommended.

As a standard for decisions. Before accepting a new obligation, a new role, a new debt, or a new commitment, the definition provides the test: does this move me towards my own standard, or towards somebody else's ranking?

As a defence in conversation. A man with a written definition can answer the family's comparison with a statement that is difficult to argue with: *my plan is to do X by the age of Y, and I am on schedule.* Whether or not the interlocutor accepts it, the man is no longer conducting the conversation in the terms of the comparison.

As a measure of progress, reviewed annually. An annual review, on the man's birthday or at a fixed date, comparing position with definition, serves two purposes: it produces evidence of progress, which counters the mechanism described in Section 11.3, and it identifies the deviation, which permits correction before the deviation becomes permanent.

The Comparison That Is Worth Making

Not all comparison is corrosive, and the distinction is worth stating precisely, because men who attempt to abandon comparison altogether usually fail, and they fail for a reason: comparison is the ordinary procedure of any learning process.

What distinguishes the damaging form from the useful one is the object of the comparison. The damaging form compares **positions**: who has more, who has advanced further, who is ahead in the ranking. The useful form compares **methods**: how was that result obtained, what did it require, and what part of the requirement is available to me? The first produces a verdict about the man; the second produces information about the work. The first is conducted at ceremonies, on social platforms, and in family conversations; the second is conducted in a direct conversation, in a professional relationship, or in study.

Three practical consequences follow from the distinction.

First, a man who wishes to reduce the cost of comparison should not attempt to stop noticing other people's positions, which is not within voluntary control.

He should redirect the comparison to the method, which is a learnable act and which converts a corrosive experience into a productive one.

Second, the men who are most useful to consult are not the men who are furthest ahead, whose circumstances may be entirely unlike the man's own, but the men who are one or two steps ahead on a path comparable to his own. The information available from the second group is practical and reproducible; from the first, it is usually a description of an outcome without its conditions.

Third, a man should have at least one comparison that is internal to himself: his own position of three or five years ago, measured in the specific terms of his own definition. This comparison is the only one that is entirely within the man's control, and it is the only one that produces evidence of progress rather than evidence of position. Men who adopt it consistently report a reduction in the sense of being behind that no amount of external achievement had previously produced.

What This Section Is Not Recommending

Two clarifications prevent misunderstanding. The chapter does not recommend the abandonment of ambition. Men who construct personal definitions frequently find that their ambition increases, because it is no longer being consumed in the management of comparison, and because the objectives are now achievable and their achievement is satisfying. Nor does it recommend the rejection of family or community expectations, which are legitimate and frequently valuable sources of standards. It recommends only this: that a man should hold a definition of success that he has examined, that fits his circumstances, and that he would defend — rather than carrying one that was assembled from comparisons and applied without his consent.

11.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Twelve Years Behind

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in career counselling, family practice, and research on unemployment and its psychological effects.

Chidi is forty-three, a graduate of a federal university in a science discipline, and he now runs a small borehole-drilling operation with two employees. He has been married for eleven years and has three children.

At the age of twenty-five, Chidi's expectations were specific and widely shared by his family. He intended to obtain a postgraduate qualification, enter a research institution or an oil-sector company, and be established by his mid-thirties. His family held the same expectation, and it was expressed at every gathering in the standard form of encouragement and comparison.

Four events interrupted the plan, and each was individually reasonable. On completing his national service, he was required at home for two years because his father's health had failed and there was no income in the household other than his. He then obtained a job in a bank, which paid well and required everything, and which made further study impractical. In the fourth year, the bank restructured, and his department was closed. He then used his savings and a loan to start a business, which failed within eighteen months because a major client defaulted on a large contract. After the collapse, he spent three years in informal work — transport, supply, small contracts — before beginning the borehole operation, which has now been stable and profitable for four years.

At forty-three, Chidi supports his household, employs two men, has built a house in his home area with a mortgage from a cooperative society, and has educated his two older children to secondary level. His younger brother, who followed the original plan without interruption, works for an international organisation, and his eldest sister is a lecturer.

The family conversation continues, and Chidi's position in it is settled: he is the one who did not fulfil his potential. The intention of the family is affectionate and its assessment is entirely comparative. At the last funeral, an uncle said, with genuine warmth and in front of a group, *Chidi would have been a director by now if he had stayed in the bank.*

What the family does not know is what the sentence does. For six years, Chidi has carried a settled sense of having failed, built from three elements: the sense of being twelve years behind his own plan; the memory of the failed business, which he has never discussed with anybody; and the continuous comparison with his brother and sister, with whom he is affectionate and whom, in private, he has begun to avoid.

The consequences have been specific. He does not attend the family's development association meetings as regularly as before. He has become unusually sensitive about money in conversations with his wife. He declined an offer to supply equipment to a construction company that would have doubled the size of his operation, because the financing required a guarantee from his brother, and he was unwilling to be in a position where a failure would be known. And he has, for three years, resisted the suggestion that he should train his eldest employee to supervise works so that he can reduce his own hours, on the grounds that the work is not done properly if he is not present.

The turn came through an ordinary conversation with a customer, an older man who had himself restarted twice, and who asked him a question that he had evidently asked himself at some point: *What is your plan from here?* Chidi, who is not given to disclosure, found himself describing the last eighteen years in about four minutes, including the failed business and the brother he avoided. The customer's response was short: *You have spent eighteen years working and you have a business, a house, three children and a wife. Who told you that the only measurement is the one your family keeps?*

> Chidi began, over the following months, to do three things: he wrote down his own standard for the next decade; he attended the association meeting with a contribution he could afford and decided not to comment on it; and he trained his employee to supervise works, which took nine months and resulted, in the following year, in his hours falling by about a fifth. He did not resolve his relationship with his brother, and he does not pretend that he has. What he said, in a conversation two years later, was: *The failed business cost me four years. Comparing myself with my brother has cost me fifteen, and he never asked me to.*

Five features of the case deserve isolation.

The plan was reasonable and the interruptions were not failures. Chidi's original plan was coherent; the interruptions were a father's illness, an employer's restructuring, and a client's default. None of the four events was a consequence of his judgement, and their cumulative effect determined the course of his working life.

The comparative assessment was delivered affectionately and continuously. The uncle's remark was intended as a compliment about Chidi's capacity. The mechanism by which such remarks produce harm is worth noting: the harm comes not from malice but from repetition, from the presence of an audience, and from the fact that the assessment is made in the only terms available to the family.

The costs appeared as opportunities declined, not as failures observed. The declined equipment contract, the untrained employee, the avoided brother, and the three years of resistance to delegating are the real costs of the case, and none of them is visible to the family that produced the assessment.

The intervention was a single question from an outsider. The customer asked about the plan, which is the question that converts a vague sense of being behind into a specific consideration of what is next. The pattern recurs throughout this book, and it is the reason Appendix J and Chapter 27 place such emphasis on maintaining at least one relationship outside the reference group.

The resolution was specific and partial. Chidi wrote a standard, adjusted his participation, and delegated a task. He did not resolve his position in the family, and he did not reconcile fully with his brother. Recovery of this kind is usually partial and practical rather than complete and emotional, and men should expect it to be.

11.8 Practical Exercise: The Personal Definition of Success

This exercise takes between ninety minutes and two hours, and it is best completed in one sitting and then reviewed annually.

Part One: The Inherited Definition

Write out, in about 300 words, the definition of success that you absorbed. Answer specifically:

- What did your family expect you to become by the age of thirty, forty, and fifty?
- What did your community treat as the markers of having done well?
- What did the men you admired in your early twenties have that you were expected to obtain?
- What has been said to you, at gatherings, about how you compare with contemporaries?

Do not evaluate any of this yet. The purpose of the first part is to establish what standard has been operating, in writing, in the man's own account rather than in his general sense of pressure.

Part Two: The Audit

Answer five questions about the inherited definition.

1. **Which elements do I still hold deliberately, and which do I carry without having chosen them?**
2. **Which elements are calibrated to circumstances that no longer exist** — a career ladder, an economy, a family arrangement?
3. **What have I achieved that the inherited definition does not recognise?** This is the most important question in the exercise, and men almost always find that the list is longer than they expected.
4. **What have I sacrificed to meet the inherited definition, and was the sacrifice worth it?**
5. **Which element of it am I still failing to meet, and what is it costing me to keep the element running?**

Part Three: The Personal Definition

Write your own definition across the seven domains in Table 11.1, in specific and verifiable terms, in no more than 400 words. Include three additional elements:

- **The ceiling.** The level at which you would consider yourself to have arrived: a figure, a state, a condition. A definition without a ceiling can never be met.
- **The boundary.** What you are not willing to sacrifice: health, marriage, children's regard, rest, integrity. Write it explicitly.
- **The timeline.** What you intend to have done in three years, and in ten.

Part Four: The Application

Apply the definition to three live decisions in your life — an obligation you are considering accepting, a role or opportunity you are considering pursuing, and

an expenditure or commitment you are maintaining. For each, answer: does this move me towards my own standard, or towards somebody else's ranking?

Part Five: The Annual Review

Set a date, twelve months from today, and write into your calendar what you will review: the seven domains, the boundary, and the timeline. The review is the mechanism by which the definition becomes operational rather than ornamental, and Appendix I provides the extended version of this work, including the values and purpose exercises that accompany it.

11.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it wrong to want more than my father had?"

No, and the ambition is frequently the origin of a family's progress. The distinction is between wanting more than a previous position, which is progress, and wanting more than a contemporary, which is comparison. The first has a ceiling and delivers satisfaction when it is reached; the second does not.

"How do I deal with family members who constantly compare me with others?"

By holding your own standard in the conversation. A single sentence, delivered calmly and repeated as necessary, does most of the work: *My plan is X, and I am on schedule for it.* You will not persuade them, and the objective is not persuasion; it is to prevent the conversation from being conducted exclusively in their terms. Where a specific relative's remarks are continuous and corrosive, reducing exposure to that person is a legitimate decision rather than a family failure.

"I am forty-five and I have not achieved what I planned. Is it too late?"

The answer depends on what the plan was, and the useful exercise is to test the plan's elements individually for feasibility rather than treating the plan as a single verdict. Men frequently discover that one or two elements remain entirely feasible, that one requires a different version of the same objective, and that one is no longer desirable. Chapter 28 addresses the revision of abandoned ambition directly.

"Should I take on more work to catch up?"

Only where the additional work has a defined purpose and an end date, and only where the costs are named in advance. Additional work without a defined purpose is the most common response to the sense of being behind, and it produces the collapse described in Chapter 12 without closing the gap.

"What if my definition of success conflicts with what my family expects of me?"

Then you will have to hold both, and the holding requires two things: a clear statement of your own plan, delivered without apology, and a deliberate decision about which expectations you will continue to meet. This is the same method as

the boundaries described in Chapter 10, applied to status rather than money, and it is exercised in Appendix O.

"I do not know what I want. How do I start?"

Begin with the domains rather than with a life plan. Answer the seven questions in Table 11.1 for the next twelve months only. Men who cannot describe a life plan can almost always describe twelve months, and the annual iterations produce a plan.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 11 in brief. The social definition of a successful man comprises five components — income and its visible signs, occupation and title, family formation, property, and community standing — each of which is legitimate as a value. The definition causes damage because of three properties: it is comparative rather than absolute, so success is a position rather than a standard; it is public, so a man's private assessment is continuously contradicted or confirmed by others' commentary; and its timetable was calibrated to an economy of stable employment and rising incomes that no longer describes the conditions in which most men work.

Ambition becomes destructive when it ceases to be an activity and becomes an identity. Three relationships to work can be distinguished: work as a means, work as a vocation, and work as an identity. The third is unstable in three ways — it fails when the work is lost, it requires continuous confirmation even when the work succeeds, and it erodes the alternative sources of identity that would supply self-regard in other circumstances. The substitution of achievement for identity is common in mid-life and is frequently mistaken for dedication.

Delayed achievement is distinct from failure because there is no event to mourn and no clean conclusion. It produces a chronic sense of being behind, compensatory activity, the loss of pleasure in the present, and a reluctance to celebrate. Its treatment depends on distinguishing temporary delay, produced by time-limited circumstances, from structural delay, produced by conditions that will not change on the current path. The diagnostic question is what the position would look like in five years on the present trajectory.

Unemployment damages men's mental health more severely than women's, through loss of income, structure, role, and social contact, and produces a collapse of routine, withdrawal, irritability at home, decay in the job search, and health deterioration. Underemployment is frequently more corrosive, because the conditions are experienced daily, the man attracts comment, and the difficulty appears optional. Lost opportunities are the most private of the three, are measured against an imagined alternative life, and are frequently attached to a specific person whose requirement caused the opportunity to be declined.

Constant comparison costs men intrinsic satisfaction, the quality of their decisions, generosity towards peers, the range of options they can consider, their health through continuous competitive effort, and the example they transmit to their children. The four effective measures are fixing a personal reference point, changing

the reference group deliberately, reducing exposure to the comparison mechanism, and converting comparison into information.

A personal definition of success must be specific, verifiable, the man's own, calibrated to his actual capacity, and inclusive of what he is not willing to sacrifice. It covers seven domains — income and work, housing and assets, family and marriage, children, health, community and contribution, and rest and life — and it should include a ceiling, a boundary, and a timeline. It becomes useful as a standard for decisions, as a defence in conversation, and as a measure reviewed annually. The chapter recommends neither the abandonment of ambition nor the rejection of family expectation, but the substitution of an examined, personal standard for one assembled from comparisons and applied without consent.

Reflection Questions

1. From Section 11.1, which of the five components of the social definition carries the most weight in your own assessment of yourself? Which of the three destructive properties — comparative, public, or borrowed timetable — has done the most damage in your life?
2. Which of the three relationships to work describes your current position: work as a means, as a vocation, or as an identity? What has changed in the last five years, and what would it take to move one position back?
3. Answer the diagnostic question in Section 11.3: if nothing changes in your circumstances and you continue on the present path for five years, will the position be different? What did you conclude, and what follows from it?
4. If you have experienced unemployment, underemployment, or a serious lost opportunity, which of the reported effects did you experience? Which of them is still affecting you, and what support was available that you did not use?
5. List the five costs of comparison from Section 11.5 and mark those you are currently paying. Which one is most visible to the people around you?
6. Complete Part Two of the exercise: what have you achieved that the inherited definition does not recognise? Read the list aloud before answering. What did you notice?
7. What is your boundary — what are you not willing to sacrifice — and is it compatible with your current working pattern? If not, which of the two will change first?

Further Reading

- **On the social construction of success:** the sociology of status, respectability, and the evaluation of men, including historical and comparative work on how the markers of male success have changed and how they differ between

societies. Work on the post-colonial transformation of status markers in West Africa is directly relevant.

- **On unemployment and mental health:** the extensive research literature on the psychological effects of unemployment, including the well-documented finding that job loss raises depression, anxiety, and mortality risk, and the studies showing that the effects are strongest in men and in those who are the principal earners of a household.
- **On underemployment:** the literature on the psychological effects of working below one's capacity, including research on over-qualification and its effects on job satisfaction, self-esteem, and well-being.
- **On social comparison and career:** the research on social comparison in the workplace, including studies of comparison with peers and its effects on motivation, performance, and satisfaction, and the work on reference group choice.
- **On career transitions:** practical literature on changing career paths at midlife, including structured methods for assessing transferable skills, evaluating a change of path, and planning a transition while meeting existing obligations.
- **On financial independence and lifestyle design:** the practical literature on designing a life with a defined standard, including work on the concept of enough, on reducing obligations, and on the relationship between consumption and satisfaction. Readers may find that this material is frequently written to a different cultural context, and should adapt rather than adopt it.

12 CHAPTER

The Man Who Cannot Afford to Break Down

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the nature of physical and emotional exhaustion in men who work through it, and identify the specific signs that distinguish ordinary tiredness from a condition that requires intervention.
2. Explain the structure of the fear of losing income, and assess the real versus the anticipated consequences of a reduction in earnings in his own circumstances.
3. Analyse the belief that rest is irresponsibility, trace where it comes from, and apply a method for restoring rest without the guilt that currently accompanies it.
4. Identify the specific mechanisms of workplace stress and chronic overwork, including those produced by organisational conditions rather than by the man's own choices.
5. Apply a balancing method that protects health and relationships without requiring a reduction in ambition, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.
6. Design a sustainable working life, including the practical arrangements — hours, boundaries, leave, delegation, and the physical conditions of work — that make it possible.

Introduction

There is a specific type of man whom this chapter addresses, and he is easy to recognise once the pattern is described. He works between fifty-five and eighty hours a week. He travels when required. He has not taken a full week of leave in three years, and when he did take leave, he answered the telephone. He has a persistent condition — hypertension, back pain, gastric trouble, or an untreated dental problem — for which he has an appointment he has rescheduled twice. He sleeps between five and six hours on working nights. He has become short with his children, and he is aware of it and unable to correct it. He drinks more than he

used to. He cannot identify a single thing he enjoys doing that is not connected to work, and when this is pointed out to him, he agrees that it is a problem, and continues.

The phrase that structures this chapter is his own, and it is usually offered in explanation rather than complaint: *I cannot afford to break down.* The sentence is a statement of fact as the man understands it, and it has two parts. The first is financial: the household's obligations require his income, and a period of incapacity would produce consequences he cannot allow. The second is psychological: the man's role, standing, and sense of himself require him to be the person who does not fail, and breakdown is a failure of the person rather than of the body.

Both parts of the sentence deserve careful examination. The financial part is frequently at least partly true, and the psychological part is frequently the more powerful of the two, and the less acknowledged. The purpose of this chapter is to establish three things: what the pattern costs, why it is self-defeating on its own terms, and what can be done about it by a man who is not in a position to reduce his obligations dramatically or to restructure his career.

12.1 Working Through Physical and Emotional Exhaustion

Exhaustion is easily confused with tiredness, and the confusion is expensive. Tiredness is a normal daily fluctuation that responds to sleep, food, and rest. Exhaustion is a state that persists in the presence of adequate sleep and that reduces the man's capacity across every domain at once. The distinction matters because a man who treats exhaustion as tiredness will apply the remedy that does not work and will delay the intervention that does.

The Signs of Exhaustion

Six features indicate that what a man is experiencing is not ordinary tiredness.

Exhaustion that does not respond to rest. A full weekend of sleep is followed by the same depletion on Monday. This is the single most reliable indicator.

Sleep that has become unreliable in structure. Waking at the same hour in the early morning; sleeping but not feeling restored; needing to sleep at unusual hours; or, in some cases, the opposite pattern of disturbing alertness at night and heaviness during the day.

Emotional flatness or heightened reactivity. Either a general reduction in feeling — the numbness described in Chapter 6 — or irritability out of proportion to events. Both indicate depletion of the capacity to regulate emotion.

Physical symptoms with no medical explanation. Tension, headaches, gastric disturbance, chest tightness, palpitations, and recurrent minor illness. Men in this state catch every infection that passes through the office.

Reduced cognitive performance. Forgetfulness, difficulty holding multiple items in mind, and a marked slowdown in decision-making. Men describe this as

a feeling of the mind working through water, and it is frequently the first change noticed by colleagues rather than by the man.

Loss of interest in everything, including things unrelated to work. Hobbies, friendships, sexual interest, family activities, and, in some cases, previously significant religious or community participation.

Why Men Work Through It

Five reasons are consistently reported, and it is worth naming them because a man who understands his reasons can act on them.

The absence of an acceptable alternative. A man who believes that there is no option but to continue will continue. This belief is frequently accurate for the short term and inaccurate for the medium term, since the same man will be incapacitated within a year if the pattern proceeds.

The daily arithmetic of the household. The obligations are specific and dated: fees due, rent due, a loan instalment. Working through exhaustion in April is a rational response to a requirement in April. The problem is that the response recurs every month and there is no moment at which the requirement is complete.

The fear of being replaced. Men in employment, and particularly men in competitive roles, report a specific fear that any reduction in availability or output will be read as a decline in capability, with consequences for the position.

The meaning of the work. For many men, the work is not merely income; it is competence, usefulness, and identity. Stopping is not rest; it is the removal of the source of self-regard.

The prohibition on need. Chapter 2 described the expectation that a man should not require anything. Rest requires the man to require rest, which is an admission he has been trained to avoid.

What Exhaustion Does Over Time

The progression is predictable and well documented. Reduced cognitive capacity produces errors. Errors in a working environment produce further work, or loss, or both. Further work increases exhaustion. Health deteriorates along known routes — cardiovascular risk, immune function, metabolic changes, and psychological conditions. Relationships deteriorate through absence and irritability. And at some point, the system fails: an illness, an accident, a collapse, or a decision made in exhaustion that cannot be reversed.

The central and unpleasant point of this section is that a man who cannot afford to break down is, by the structure of his current arrangements, planning to break down. What he is choosing is the timing, and the timing he is choosing is later — which is to say, at a moment when the consequences will be larger, the household's obligations will be greater, and his capacity to recover will be less.

12.2 The Fear of Losing Income

The fear of losing income is the engine of most of the behaviour described in this chapter, and it deserves to be examined as a specific fear rather than as a general anxiety. The examination has two parts: what would actually happen, and what the man believes would happen. The gap between the two is frequently substantial, and it is the space in which the man's remaining freedom lies.

The Actual Consequences

For a household with a defined set of obligations, a reduction in income has five consequences, and they arrive in a specific order.

Immediate. The obligations that are legally or socially enforced at short intervals — rent, transport, food, school fees at the start of a term, loan instalments — are affected first, and the household's capacity to meet them falls within weeks.

Short-term. The household enters a period of adjustment: expenditure reduction, borrowing, the use of reserves if any exist, and the deferral of non-urgent costs, including medical treatment.

Medium-term. Assets are consumed or sold, credit standing deteriorates, and the standard of living is revised downward. This is the period in which the household's structure changes.

Long-term. The consequences depend on the recovery of income. If income is restored within a period that the household's assets and credit can absorb, the consequence is a period of difficulty followed by restoration. If it is not restored, the household enters a different trajectory, in which the children's education, the couple's security, and the man's health are permanently affected.

The secondary consequences. It is the secondary consequences that the fear of losing income is actually about, and they are not primarily financial: the loss of standing, the questions from relatives, the revision of the family's position in the community, the change in the household's view of the man, and, in some cases, the loss of the marriage.

The Systematic Overestimation

Research and practice both indicate that the anticipated consequences of income loss are systematically overestimated, for four reasons.

The imagining is done at the point of maximum fear. A man contemplating the loss of income normally does so in a state of fear, and fear produces catastrophising — the attaching of total consequences to specific risks, as described in Chapter 8. The imagined outcome is therefore the worst available scenario: the loss of the house, the withdrawal of the children from school, the end of the marriage, and permanent disgrace.

The household is more capable than the man assumes. Families adjust. Expenditure falls, work is taken on by other members, the relatives who are

asked frequently assist, and the school that is approached about fees frequently negotiates. Men who have been through a genuine reduction in income report, with remarkable consistency, that the household's response was materially better than they had feared.

The social consequences are overestimated in the short run and underestimated in the long run. In the short run, the community is less attentive to a man's position than he believes; most people are occupied with their own. In the long run, the consequence of a man's handling of his difficulty — with honesty or with deceit, with effort or with an attempt to conceal — matters considerably more than the difficulty itself.

The fear ignores the alternative. A man who continues working to the point of collapse does not avoid the loss of income; he defers it and increases its probability, and he arranges for it to arrive at a moment when he cannot control its timing and has less capacity to respond.

The Real Question About Income Loss

The discussion above does not establish that the loss of income is harmless. For many households it is a serious event, and this book does not minimise it. What it establishes is that the relevant question is not *how do I avoid any reduction in income* but a set of more specific and answerable questions.

1. **What is the smallest reduction that would make the work sustainable?** Not a change of career, and not a sabbatical. One fewer engagement, one fewer weekend, one fewer additional role, or a reduction of hours from eighty to sixty-five.
2. **How long can the household sustain a reduction of that size?** Here the reserve calculation from Chapter 10 and Appendix D is decisive. A man who knows that he has four months of capacity has a materially different range of options from a man who has none.
3. **What is the earliest point at which the arrangement can be changed?** Not *never*, which is the answer men usually give, but a date: after the fees are paid, at the end of the contract, in the next quarter, when the eldest completes school.
4. **What is the household's position if I become unable to work for three months?** This is the question that converts the fear into a planning exercise, because it produces a specific gap that can be addressed by insurance, by a reserve, by a sibling arrangement, or by a reduction of obligations.

The Preparation That Reduces the Fear

Fear of income loss is reduced more effectively by preparation than by reassurance, and the preparation is concrete. Four items address the majority of the anxiety.

A written statement of the household's essential monthly requirement. The distinction between the household's essential requirement — food, housing, utilities, transport to work, school fees, medical costs, and debt instalments — and its current total expenditure is usually substantial. A man who knows his essential figure has a far more accurate picture of the risk attached to income loss than one who knows only his total spending.

A named duration of the reserve. A man should be able to say: at the present rate of essential expenditure, the household can sustain X months with no income. Most men cannot answer, and the inability is itself a source of the fear, because an unknown quantity of danger is always experienced as larger than a known one. Appendix D provides the calculation and the building plan.

A defined set of response steps. What will be done, in what order, if income stops: which expenditures stop first, which obligations are renegotiated, which relatives and institutions are approached, who else in the household can earn, which assets are available. A man who has written these steps has already made the decisions in a calm state, and will not have to make them in a frightened one.

A reduced sensitivity through diversification. Where a household's income derives entirely from one source, the risk is concentrated and the fear is proportionate. Where a secondary source exists — a partner's earnings, a small side activity, a skill that can be sold, an asset that produces income — the fear is materially reduced, not because the sums are large but because there is an alternative. Chapter 23 addresses the practical construction of a second source.

The Fear of Being Seen to Have Declined

A subset of the fear of losing income concerns not the money but the appearance: the vehicle, the housing, the contributions, and the school attended by the children. Where a man's obligations have been maintained to preserve appearance, he is not merely worried about income; he is worried about exposure. Two observations are useful.

First, exposure is generally survivable. Men who have reduced their standard visibly report that the social consequences were less severe and shorter-lived than anticipated, that the number of people who remarked on it was small, and that the remarks were less damaging than the anticipation. Second, exposure is not avoided by concealment; it is deferred and enlarged, in the manner described throughout Part Three.

12.3 When Rest Feels Like Irresponsibility

Men in this pattern do not, in most cases, fail to rest because they do not want rest. They fail to rest because rest has acquired a moral meaning. The purpose of this section is to describe that meaning, trace it, and set out how a man can recover the capacity to rest.

The Moral Structure of Rest

For many men, rest is not neutral. It carries a verdict. Four elements compose the structure.

Rest as evidence of insufficiency. If the obligations require continuous work, then a man who rests is not meeting them, and the shortfall is his. Rest therefore becomes a demonstration of inadequacy rather than a requirement of the body.

Rest as vulnerability. A man who is resting is not producing, and a man who is not producing is, in his own assessment, replaceable. This element is particularly strong in employment and in competitive business, and it is frequently supported by the actual behaviour of organisations, which reward availability and punish absence.

Rest as betrayal of others. Where a man's work supports a household and an extended network, a day of rest has a cost that is borne by somebody else. Men describe this with precision: *If I rest today, someone's fees will not be paid on Friday.* The reasoning is usually inaccurate in the specific case and accurate as a general description of a structural problem, which is precisely why it is so difficult to argue against.

Rest as the beginning of collapse. The fourth element is the most significant and the least articulated. Men who have been holding a system together by continuous effort frequently fear that if they stop, they will not start again. The fear is not of laziness but of discovering how tired they are. This is a real and important fear, and it deserves to be answered rather than dismissed: the experience of most men who rest after prolonged overwork is that they sleep for an unusual amount of time, feel considerably worse for two or three days, and then recover a level of capacity they had forgotten was available.

Where the Structure Comes From

Three sources account for most of it. The first is direct training: many of the men reading this book were raised in households where idleness was identified with moral failure, and where an adult man who rested during working hours was spoken about in terms of criticism. The second is economic reality: for a man whose income depends on presence and output, resting is a genuine reduction in income, and the association between rest and loss is not a belief but an experience. The third is the male prohibition on need, described in Chapter 2, which converts a physical requirement into a character question.

It is worth noting that the moral structure of rest is not universal. In many societies, and in the earlier lives of many men reading this chapter, rest was structured, expected, and communal: the day of rest, the afternoon pause, the seasonal lull, the evening spent sitting with others. What has changed is not human physi-

ology but the arrangement of work, and the change has been absorbed by men who believe that the loss of rest is their own failing rather than a change in their conditions.

Restoring Rest

Five practical measures have a good record. They are listed in the order in which men usually find them workable.

Schedule rest rather than waiting for it. Unscheduled rest does not occur. Two hours on a fixed evening, half a day on a fixed weekend, and, where possible, one full day a month should be entered into the calendar as commitments of equal standing to any appointment. The scheduling matters more than the amount.

Define rest as maintenance in the language you use. *I am maintaining my capacity to work* is a statement that a man can hold against the prohibition, because it is true and because it is expressed in terms he respects. Chapter 2 introduced the distinction; this is its practical application.

Protect sleep first. Where only one intervention is possible, sleep is the one with the largest effect. A man sleeping five hours who restores seven will recover capacity in every domain more effectively than by any other single measure. Appendix N provides the practical method.

Make one day non-negotiable. A single scheduled item — a weekly football match, a Saturday morning with children, attendance at a religious service, an evening walk with a friend, a fixed dinner with the family — that is not cancelled for work, and that functions as evidence that the boundary exists.

Explain the change before making it, in outcome terms. A man who tells his household and his colleagues what he is doing and why — *I am cutting my Saturday work because I was making mistakes and my doctor is concerned about my blood pressure* — reduces the social cost of the change substantially, and, in the author's experience, the explanation is accepted more readily than the man expects.

When Rest Is Not Enough

A caution is required. Where a man's exhaustion has developed into a depressive episode, an anxiety disorder, a physical condition requiring treatment, or dependence on alcohol or sedatives, rest alone will not correct it, and the delay involved in attempting rest alone is costly. The criteria in Chapters 5 and 6 and in Appendix B should be applied, and professional assessment obtained where they indicate it.

12.4 Workplace Stress and Chronic Overwork

Chronic overwork is frequently treated as a personal choice, and it is frequently produced by conditions the individual man does not control. This section separates the two, because the interventions differ.

The Organisational Conditions

Six conditions account for most chronic overwork among men in employment. A man who examines this list will usually find that his hours are produced by at least four of them.

Understaffing. The work of the establishment is distributed among fewer people than the establishment was designed for. Every reduction in headcount increases the load on those who remain, and the increase is rarely accompanied by a reduction in the volume of work.

Insecure employment. Where employment is casual, contractual, or renewable at short intervals, availability becomes a condition of continued employment. Men in this position accept hours they cannot sustain, because declining is read as unwillingness.

Performance measurement. Where performance is assessed by output, hours, or availability, the rational response is to increase them. Where the measurement is continuous and visible — the dashboard, the ranking, the target — the response continues indefinitely.

The availability expectation. Digital communication has removed the boundary between working and non-working hours. The expectation that a man will respond in the evening, at the weekend, and on leave is now established in many organisations, and it is frequently unwritten and therefore unnegotiable.

The promotion structure. Where advancement depends on visibility and availability, the men who reduce their hours remove themselves from consideration. This is a rational assessment of many organisations, and it means that the reduction of hours carries a career cost that the man must weigh rather than one that he can avoid.

Supervision by absence. Many managers, themselves overloaded, supervise by exception: they intervene when something is late, which means that the overloaded man receives attention only for failure, and receives no attention at all for the arrangement that is producing the failure.

The Personal Conditions

Four personal conditions compound the organisational ones, and these are the ones within the man's control.

Inability to delegate. Described in Chapter 7. A man who requires work to be done to his own standard will perform the work of three people and will therefore be given it.

Acceptance of every request. A man who has never declined a request will be given more requests, because he is the reliable option. The reliability that earns respect also generates the load.

The substitution of work for other parts of life. Work is frequently the least complicated domain: it has defined tasks, measurable outcomes, and clear feedback. A man whose marriage has become difficult, whose children have withdrawn, or whose friendships have thinned may find work the more comfortable place, and will therefore spend more time there. The overwork is not the cause of the difficulty elsewhere; it is frequently the response to it.

Financial commitments requiring continuous high earnings. Described in Chapters 9 and 10. Where the household's standard and the family's obligations are calibrated to peak earnings, every reduction in hours produces an immediate financial consequence.

The Effects on Performance

Chronic overwork is frequently justified by its results, and the justification is partly accurate for short periods and inaccurate for long ones. The research on working hours points to a consistent pattern: output per hour falls as hours rise; error rates increase; and the additional hours produce diminishing and eventually negative returns. In addition, the effects on judgement are the ones that matter most for men in responsible positions: reduced capacity for complex reasoning, increased reliance on quick and familiar responses, reduced tolerance for disagreement, and a reduced capacity to recognise one's own deterioration.

Two specific effects are worth naming because they affect the reader's own decisions about the quantity of work he accepts.

The unrecognised deterioration of judgement. A man in the fourth month of sustained overwork does not experience himself as impaired; he experiences the work as harder and his colleagues as less competent. The assessment is impaired, and the impairment is invisible to the person making it.

Accumulated error. In occupations with high consequences, the research on fatigue shows a marked rise in error rates and in the severity of errors after prolonged hours. This is why the industries with the largest risks — aviation, medicine, heavy transport, and process industries — impose limits on working hours, and it is why men in other fields should impose their own.

The Effects on the Household

The effects of chronic overwork on a man's household are frequently more severe than its effects on his work, and they are systematically under-reported because the household cannot make a complaint in the way that an employer can.

Financial volatility produced by health. The income argument for overwork assumes continuous capacity. Where the overwork produces an illness, an injury, or a hospitalisation, the household's income stops abruptly while its expenditure rises, and the reserve that would have covered the interruption has not been built, because the earnings were absorbed by obligations. The household

that was said to depend on the man's income is therefore most exposed precisely at the moment the income ceases.

The transfer of strain to the people at home. A man operating at his limit arrives home with nothing left for regulation. Irritability, impatience, and silence are the registered effects, and they are directed at the people who are least responsible for the pressure. In the accounts of wives and adult children, this is the most consistently reported feature of a man's overworking years, and it is frequently remembered long after the economic circumstances have improved.

The absence of the father at the years that cannot be repeated. The father's availability matters most in the years of the children's childhood and adolescence, which is precisely the period in which men work hardest. The absence is rarely experienced by the father as a loss at the time, because there is nothing with which to compare it, and it is very frequently experienced as a loss in later life, when the children are adults and the relationship is one of politeness rather than intimacy. Chapter 17 addresses this in detail.

The modelling of a pattern. Children learn from what they observe. A son who sees his father's arrangement as the definition of a man's life will reproduce it, and a daughter who sees it will expect it. This effect is the reason that several men, having completed the capacity audit in the exercise at the end of this chapter, identify their own fathers with more accuracy than they had managed in thirty years.

Practical Measures

Five measures reduce the level of chronic overwork, and they are ordered by the size of the effect.

Establish a ceiling on hours, and measure it. A man who does not know how many hours he works each week cannot reduce them. Two weeks of honest recording usually produces a figure that the man himself does not believe.

Reduce in one category rather than across the board. Choose one: the weekend work, the evening communication, the additional engagements, or the travel. A general intention to reduce produces nothing; the removal of a single category produces a measurable effect and is defensible socially, because it can be explained as a decision rather than a withdrawal.

Delegate one function that is currently yours. Identify a function, not a task: the supervision of a particular process, the management of a particular client, the preparation of a particular report. Delegation of a function transfers the whole of the load associated with it; delegation of tasks transfers only the task.

Manage the availability expectation explicitly. A stated arrangement — *I do not respond after nine; if something is urgent, telephone* — is respected more

often than men expect, and it is considerably more effective than an unstated reduction in responsiveness, which is read as unreliability.

Address the personal conditions. Only the reader can determine whether his overwork is chiefly organisational or personal, and the test is simple: if the organisation offers the arrangement and the man declines it, the condition is personal. The two personal conditions that most commonly maintain overwork are the inability to delegate and the substitution of work for other parts of life, and each has a corresponding section elsewhere in this book.

12.5 Balancing Ambition with Personal Well-Being

The word *balance* is frequently used and rarely defined, and the vagueness allows men to dismiss the whole subject. This section defines it precisely and offers a method.

What Balance Is Not

Balance is not an equal division of hours, which is neither achievable nor desirable. It is not the absence of ambition, and it does not require a man to reduce his commitment or his standards. And it is not a permanent state; there are legitimate seasons of intense work: a business start-up, a professional qualification, a young family's early years, a crisis in the household.

What Balance Is

Balance is the condition in which four things are simultaneously true.

1. **No essential domain is deteriorating.** Health, marriage, relationship with children, income, and obligations are each, at minimum, not worsening.
2. **Every domain receives a minimum allocation.** Not an equal share, but a defined minimum below which the domain is not permitted to fall: an hour a day with children, one evening a week with a partner, seven hours of sleep, three sessions of exercise, one friend contacted each week.
3. **The intensity has an end.** Intense periods are legitimate; permanent intensity is not. Each period of intensity should have a defined end point, after which the arrangement is reviewed.
4. **The arrangement is sustainable by the man himself.** Not by a version of him with more resources, better sleep, and no illness — by him, as he actually is.

The Three Practical Mechanisms

The minimum allocation register. Write the minimum allocation for each domain, and review it weekly. A domain that has fallen below its minimum for two consecutive weeks is treated as a fault requiring correction, in the way that a shortfall in payments would be.

The seasonal structure. Arrange the year so that periods of intensity alternate with periods of recovery. A man who plans four intense months followed by a reduced month will manage it; a man who works at seventy hours every week of the year will not, and the difference is not the total hours but their distribution.

The defined trade. Where a reduction is genuinely impossible, the man should choose deliberately what will be reduced rather than allowing the reduction to be decided by whichever obligation shouts loudest. A defined trade — *I will work these hours for the next two years, and during that period I will not take on any community position, and my health checks will continue* — preserves control and, in the experience of men who use it, reduces the resentment that accompanies an undifferentiated overload.

The Question of Well-Being for Men Who Distrust the Subject

Some men will object at this point, and the objection is legitimate: the language of well-being is frequently promoted by people whose circumstances are easier, and it is frequently used to recommend rest to men who cannot afford it. Three points answer the objection.

First, the material in this chapter is not primarily about comfort; it is about capacity. A man who sleeps six hours, never rests, and has not attended a clinic in four years does not merely feel worse than a man who does; he performs worse, makes more errors, and is more likely to be incapacitated at a moment he cannot predict. The argument is instrumental.

Second, every measure in this chapter is compatible with continued high performance. None of them requires a man to accept a lower standard or to abandon his obligations.

Third, the consequences are borne by other people. A father who collapses from untreated hypertension does not spare his household his illness; he delivers it to them at the worst possible moment, along with the loss of income, the medical costs, and the burden of care. This is the consideration that changes men's behaviour more often than any argument about their own welfare, and Chapter 17 develops it in the context of fatherhood.

12.6 Building a Sustainable Life

The final section sets out what a sustainable working life consists of in practice, and it is deliberately concrete, because the subject attracts generalities.

The Seven Elements

1. A ceiling on hours, established and measured. The figure differs by person and situation; the requirement is that it exists, that it is written, and that actual hours are measured against it monthly. Men who do this report that the measure-

ment itself produces about half of the reduction, because unrecorded hours are invisible even to the man working them.

2. Sleep protected as a component of performance. Seven hours as a working minimum for most adults, with the practical measures in Appendix N. This is the single highest-yield change available, and it is the one most frequently deferred.

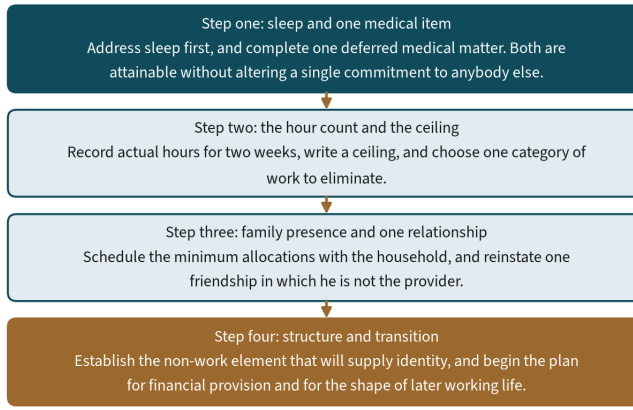
3. One physical practice, maintained. The evidence for the effect of regular physical activity on mood, sleep, cardiovascular risk, and cognitive function is extensive and consistent. Its practical advantages for men are that it is measurable, that it is not a treatment, and that it provides a legitimate reason to be unavailable that no household questions.

4. Medical care attended rather than deferred. A routine check, treatment of chronic conditions, and a dental and eye examination where relevant. Men in this pattern typically have a list of deferred items, and the list should be worked through deliberately, item by item, with dates.

5. One relationship in which the man is not the provider. Described in Chapter 10, and repeated here because overwork eliminates friendships first. A sustainable life includes at least one relationship in which the man is known outside his productive function.

6. A defined minimum for family presence. Not the residual time left after work, which is zero, but a scheduled minimum: an hour a day with children, a fixed weekly engagement with a partner, a monthly activity with each child. Chapter 17 develops the practice.

7. A structure for the transition out of full work. The most neglected element of a sustainable life. A man who has organised his identity around output will find the end of working life disorienting unless the arrangement is planned in advance. This includes financial provision, but the more commonly neglected element is the non-financial one: what the man will do, and who he will be, when the output stops.



A sustainable life is built in sequence rather than announced all at once. Each step is completed before the next is attempted.

Figure 12.1 The sequence in which a sustainable life is actually built, rather than announced. Each step is completed before the next is attempted, and the first requires nothing of anybody else.

The Practical Sequence

The elements above are not achievable simultaneously by a man working eighty hours a week. The sequence that men report as workable has four steps.

Step One: sleep and one medical item. Address sleep first, and complete one deferred medical matter. These two changes are attainable without altering any commitment to anybody else, and they produce a noticeable improvement within a month.

Step Two: the hour count and the ceiling. Record actual hours for two weeks, establish a ceiling, and choose one category to eliminate. This step requires the explanation referenced in Section 12.3.

Step Three: family presence and one relationship. Schedule the minimum allocations, and reinstate one friendship. This step requires the availability arrangement to be stated rather than merely practised.

Step Four: structure and transition. Establish the non-work element that will supply identity — an interest, a community role, a craft, a religious practice, a mentoring commitment — and begin a plan for financial provision and for the shape of later working life.

The Annual Capacity Review

The arrangements described above decay. A ceiling accepted in January is quietly exceeded by June; a scheduled evening is cancelled four weeks in succession and then abandoned; a delegated function is taken back after a single failure. For this

reason the sustainable life requires one maintenance mechanism, and it should be annual, brief, and written.

The review has six items.

1. **Hours.** The average of the last three months, against the ceiling. If the ceiling has been exceeded for three consecutive months, one category of work is removed in the following month, and the removal is a decision rather than an intention.
2. **Sleep.** The average of the last month, against the seven-hour working minimum, together with any change in the pattern — early waking, difficulty falling asleep, unrefreshing sleep.
3. **Health.** The status of every chronic condition, the completion of the appointments identified in the previous year's review, and any new symptom that has been present for more than a month.
4. **Presence.** The hours spent with each child and with a partner, measured rather than estimated, against the minimum allocations. Men are consistently surprised by this figure, in both directions.
5. **Relationships.** The number of non-work relationships maintained during the year, and when each was last contacted. Where the number has fallen below three, the review should identify a specific action rather than a general intention.
6. **Provision and transition.** The reserve position, the retirement provision, and the non-financial plan for the end of full working life. The last of these is the item that every man defers and that determines the quality of the decade after retirement.

The review takes an hour, and it should be scheduled at the same point each year, with the date confirmed in advance. Its value is not the diagnosis, which most men can anticipate, but the interruption of the drift: it converts a set of arrangements that are slowly being abandoned into a set of arrangements that are either being kept or deliberately changed.

The Household Conversation

A sustainable life is not constructed alone, and in most cases it requires the agreement of a household. The conversation has four parts and should be held deliberately rather than in fragments.

1. **The position.** What the current pattern is doing: hours, sleep, health indicators, and the specific symptoms.
2. **The change.** What will be different, in specific terms — which hours, which days, which engagements, which contributions.
3. **The consequence.** What the household will lose, if anything: income, standard, convenience, or a specific arrangement.

4. **The purpose.** What the change is intended to preserve: the man's health, the marriage, the children's experience of him, and the household's income over the next twenty years rather than the next twelve months.

Appendix F provides the structure for this conversation, and Chapter 18 addresses its place within marriage generally.

12.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Booked the Appointment Three Times

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in occupational medicine, family practice, and employment counselling.

Sunday is forty-nine, a transport company's operations manager in Lagos, responsible for a fleet of sixty vehicles and thirty-eight staff. He has been in the role for eleven years. He supports a household of six, his mother, and a nephew's university fees. He earns well by any standard, and his obligations absorb the whole of it.

For four years, Sunday worked between sixty-five and eighty hours a week. The pattern developed during a period when the company lost two contracts and reduced staff, with the result that his department's establishment fell from fifty-one to thirty-eight while the work increased.

Three specific practices maintained the pattern. He personally supervised the dispatch of every vehicle, because a dispatch error costs the company money and his reputation. He answered the telephone at any hour. And he conducted the morning briefing at six o'clock himself, six days a week, because he believed that attendance at the briefing was a test of his commitment.

In the third year, his blood pressure was found to be elevated at a routine insurance examination. He was advised to return for assessment, and he did not. In the fourth year, he began to have episodes of chest tightness on exertion, which he attributed to fatigue. He booked an appointment at a private clinic three times, and rescheduled it three times: the first because a vehicle was involved in an accident, the second because the company's managing director was travelling and Sunday was covering, and the third because his son's school had an event.

His wife, Kemi, became aware that something was wrong through three observations: that he had begun sleeping with the television on, having previously required silence; that he complained of the noise of the children in a manner that was new; and that he had stopped attending the monthly meeting of his church's men's fellowship, where he had been a member for nine years. She raised it twice. He answered, on both occasions, that the year was difficult.

The event that forced the change was not dramatic. In November, during a morning briefing, Sunday lost the thread of what he was saying in the middle of a sentence, in front of fourteen people, and had to ask a colleague to continue. He was, in his own description, terrified. He went, the same day, to a hospital.

The assessment found: severe hypertension requiring immediate treatment; sleep apnoea, which explained a substantial part of the fatigue and which he had never considered because he did not know that snoring, witnessed by Kemi for years, was a clinical sign; and a moderate depressive episode, presenting as irritability and the loss of interest in his fellowship and his family. He was treated for all three: medication for the blood pressure, investigation and treatment for the apnoea, and a course of psychological treatment with an antidepressant.

The organisational changes came after the clinical ones, and their origin is worth recording. Sunday's first step, after his treatment began, was to tell his managing director the position — which he had avoided doing for a year — and the managing director's response was to appoint a deputy operations manager within three weeks, a step that could have been taken at any time in the previous four years and that had never been raised. The morning briefing moved to seven, and Sunday stopped attending it personally on two of the six days. His personal dispatch supervision was transferred, with training, over five months.

Eighteen months later, his blood pressure was controlled, his sleep had improved substantially, and he described the arrangement in the following terms: *I thought the company needed the hours. What it needed was the job. When I was moved out of the way on two mornings a week, nobody noticed, and the figures were the same. What I had been protecting for four years was not the company's performance. It was my own idea that I was the only one who could do it.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The physical condition was present and unexamined for a year. Elevated blood pressure found at an insurance examination, followed by twelve months of deferral and three rescheduled appointments. This is one of the most common and most consequential patterns in men's health, and the delay is the mechanism by which treatable conditions become serious ones.

A treatable sleep disorder was present and unrecognised. Sleep apnoea is common, is frequently unrecognised in men, and produces fatigue, impaired concentration, and cardiovascular risk. It is worth naming in this chapter because it is a physical cause of the exhaustion that men attribute to workload, and it is diagnosed by investigation rather than by effort.

The depression presented in the male register. Irritability about noise, the loss of interest in a longstanding commitment, sleeping with the television on, and the loss of capability in front of colleagues — with no report of sadness at any point.

The organisation's constraint was self-imposed. The most instructive finding in the case is that a deputy was appointed within three weeks of the conversation and that the figures were unchanged after Sunday's personal supervision

was reduced. For four years, the arrangement had been maintained by the man's belief that it could not be changed, rather than by the organisation's requirement.

The change required a disclosure. The appointment, the deputy, and the reduced hours all followed from one conversation with the managing director that Sunday had avoided for a year. The disclosure was not about his feelings; it was about his health, delivered with a proposed arrangement. This is the most effective form of disclosure available to a man in Sunday's position, and it is the method described in Chapter 35.

12.8 Practical Exercise: The Capacity Audit and the Sustainable Week

This exercise takes two hours at the outset and fifteen minutes weekly thereafter. It has five parts.

Part One: The Capacity Audit

Answer the following in writing, with figures rather than impressions.

Item	Your answer
Average hours worked per week over the last three months	
Average hours of sleep per working night	
Days of leave taken in the last twenty-four months, not counting public holidays	
Medical appointments deferred, and for how long	
Chronic conditions currently untreated or under-treated	
Alcohol consumed in an average week	
Days per week with any physical activity of thirty minutes or more	
Hours per week spent with children, excluding travel and television	
Hours per month spent with friends, excluding work contacts	
Days in the last three months in which I felt genuinely rested	

The purpose of the table is to replace an impression with a record. Men who complete it are frequently startled by two or three of the figures, and the startlement is the beginning of the exercise.

Part Two: The Exhaustion Test

From Section 12.1, mark the signs that apply: exhaustion not repaired by rest; disturbed sleep structure; flatness or irritability; unexplained physical symptoms;

reduced cognitive performance; loss of interest in everything. Then apply the criteria from Chapters 5 and 6 and Appendix B, and note whether professional assessment is indicated. If two or more of the criteria for assessment are met, the exercise should pause here and the appointment should be made.

Part Three: The Ceiling

Write your ceiling, in hours per week, and the date on which it takes effect. Then identify the one category of work that will be removed to meet it: weekend work, evening communication, the additional engagements, the travel, or the personal performance of a task that could be delegated.

Part Four: The Minimum Allocations

Write the minimum allocation for each domain, and enter them in your calendar as recurring commitments.

- Sleep: _____ hours on working nights.
- Physical activity: _____ sessions per week.
- Partner: _____ per week, scheduled.
- Each child: _____ per week, scheduled individually.
- Friends: _____ per month.
- Medical: appointments to be made this month — list them, with dates.
- Rest: _____ per week, scheduled.

Part Five: The Weekly Review

Fifteen minutes, the same day each week. Four questions: What were my actual hours? Which allocations were met and which were missed? What caused the misses? What changes next week?

The review is the mechanism that makes the whole exercise operational, and the evidence from behaviour-change practice is clear that the review, rather than the plan, is what produces the result.

12.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I have too much responsibility to reduce my hours. What do I do?"

Reduce the categories that carry no responsibility, and protect the ones that do. ' Responsibilities' is a category that can be audited. Men who complete the audit in Part One frequently find that a substantial portion of their hours is consumed by activity that is either avoidable or delegable, and that the truly non-negotiable core is smaller than they assumed.

"If I slow down, someone else will take my position."

That is a real risk in some organisations and an imagined one in most. The test is the one Sunday's case demonstrates: ask for the arrangement, and observe the response. Where the response is genuinely punitive, the information is important,

because it identifies an employer for whom the man's health is not a consideration — a finding that is better made at forty-nine than at fifty-nine.

"I cannot sleep. What do I do first?"

Establish the cause before attempting remedies. Snoring and witnessed pauses in breathing require investigation for sleep apnoea. Early waking with dread suggests anxiety or depression and warrants assessment. Poor sleep hygiene, alcohol, and caffeine are the most common correctable factors. Appendix N sets out the practical sequence, and Chapter 37 addresses sleep in detail.

"How do I stop feeling guilty about resting?"

By defining the rest as maintenance and by measuring the outcome. Men who schedule rest and then observe their own performance over two months almost always find that the effect on output is neutral or positive. The guilt is not reduced by argument; it is reduced by evidence.

"What if my blood pressure or another condition is already a problem?"

Then the priority order changes, and medical treatment comes before any organisational change, because the risk is immediate rather than cumulative. Appendix B and Chapter 34 provide the framework, and the appointment should be made this week rather than this quarter.

"My father worked like this and lived to eighty."

Some people do. The relevant question is not what is survivable but what is likely, and the evidence on prolonged overwork, untreated hypertension, and untreated sleep problems is consistent. In addition, a comparison with a previous generation should account for a different pattern of work, different diet, and — importantly — the fact that the men who did not survive are not available to be cited.

PART IV

The Battles of Love and Relationships

Heartbreak, rejection, intimacy, and emotional vulnerability: grief that men rarely discuss, loving someone who does not understand your pain, the silent battles of marriage, and the pain of rejection and betrayal.

13 CHAPTER

The Heartbreak Men Rarely Discuss

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the emotional pain that follows the loss of a relationship, and explain why it is frequently experienced more severely by men than the surrounding culture acknowledges.
2. Analyse the reasons men conceal romantic grief, including the specific social and practical costs they anticipate from disclosure.
3. Explain the effect of rejection on self-worth, and distinguish between the pain of losing a person and the injury to self-regard that frequently accompanies it.
4. Describe the psychological effects of betrayal, and identify the distinction between the loss of trust in a person and the loss of the capacity to trust at all.
5. Apply a method for healing that avoids the two destructive responses — retaliation and entrenchment — and that permits recovery without requiring the man to pretend that nothing happened.
6. Assess what is required to love again, including the resolution of unfinished material from the previous relationship, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

A man's marriage ends after fourteen years. Within a week he has arranged his living situation, informed his employer, spoken to a lawyer, and told his closest friend that he is "fine, all things considered." Within a month he has changed his routine, taken on additional work, and begun exercising regularly. Within six months he has been described by four people as having handled it very well.

Two years later he is sitting in a consulting room describing symptoms he did not connect to the separation: an inability to form a new attachment, occasional unexplained anger, a persistent feeling of having been found out, and a reluctance to speak about the marriage at all. Asked what happened at the time, he says that

he simply got on with it. Asked how he felt, he pauses for a long time and then says: *I did not feel anything for about a year. I thought that meant I was coping.*

This chapter is about the emotional pain that follows the end of a relationship — marriage, long partnership, engagement, or a significant attachment that was never formalised — and about the peculiar situation of men who are expected, by everybody including themselves, to be less affected than they are. Its premise is simple. Men form attachments with the same intensity as anybody else; they lose them with the same pain; and they are frequently equipped with fewer means of expressing, receiving support for, or processing that pain, with the result that the grief is delayed, concealed, converted into behaviour, or carried for years without being recognised for what it is.

13.1 Emotional Pain After Relationship Loss

Relationship loss is one of the most stressful events in the life of an adult, and this finding is consistent across countries, measurement methods, and decades. The pain is real, the physical response is measurable, and the duration is frequently longer than the surrounding culture assumes.

What the Pain Consists Of

The grief that follows the end of a relationship has at least six components, and men frequently recognise only one or two of them.

The loss of the person. The daily presence, the conversation, the physical company, the shared history. This is the component that is most readily recognised as grief, and it is the one that people expect.

The loss of the future. The plans, the expectations, the children's milestones, the retirement, the house that was going to be built. This component is frequently more difficult than the first, because it cannot be mourned publicly in the same way; one cannot easily hold a funeral for a life that did not happen.

The loss of the role. A man who was a husband, a provider-dependant pair, or a future father loses an identity as well as a relationship. Where that identity was central, the loss is experienced as a change in himself, as Chapters 11 and 24 describe.

The loss of the household structure. Where children are involved, the loss includes the daily presence of the children, which is frequently the most severe element and which is systematically under-recognised in accounts of separation, particularly for fathers, as Chapter 17 examines.

The loss of standing. Particularly in communities where marriage is a marker of adult status, separation carries an interpretive penalty: assumptions are made, explanations are required, and the man is discussed.

The loss of the assumption of permanence. The most subtle and the most durable component. Where a relationship has ended, the man loses the belief

that a commitment, once made, will hold. This alters his expectations about the future, and it is the component most responsible for the well-documented difficulty that some men have in forming later attachments.

Why the Pain Is Frequently More Severe Than Acknowledged

Four features of male experience make relationship loss particularly difficult.

The relationship may have been the only outlet. Chapter 4 established that many men have no intimate non-romantic relationship. Where this is the case, the loss of a partner is not the loss of one relationship among several; it is the removal of the man's only source of emotional intimacy, which explains the severity that men frequently report and that observers frequently find disproportionate.

The man's role may have been entirely occupied with the relationship's maintenance and not its enjoyment. Men who have defined themselves by provision frequently discover, at the end of a relationship, that the arrangement contained little for them personally, and this produces a particular and disorienting combination of grief and relief that men find difficult to describe.

The support is asymmetric. The literature on separation consistently finds that women receive more support than men at the end of a relationship, because the networks that provide support — friends, family, and confidants — are more frequently maintained by women. A man is frequently left with the practical assistance of colleagues and relatives and with no one to speak to.

The social permission to grieve is narrower. A man who weeps at a parent's funeral is understood. A man who weeps at the end of a marriage is frequently read as weak, as guilty of something, or as a subject of gossip. The result is a grief that must be conducted privately, which is the least effective arrangement available.

The Physical and Behavioural Signs

The pain appears in men in the forms identified throughout this book and deserves listing in this specific context.

Table 13.1 The manifestations of relationship grief in men. Two or three of these are normal and temporary; a persistent majority of them over months warrants professional assessment.

Domain	Typical manifestations after relationship loss
Sleep	Waking early; sleeping in the partner's place or avoiding the bedroom; dreaming of the relationship
Body	Chest tightness; loss of appetite or weight; gastric symptoms; fatigue
Mood	Numbness rather than sadness; irritability; sudden anger at small provocations; shame

Domain	Typical manifestations after relationship loss
Behaviour	Increased work; increased alcohol; sexual activity without attachment; risk-taking; withdrawal from family and social events
Thinking	Idealising the relationship; excessive self-blame; obsessive review of the final period; thoughts of contact
Function	Reduced concentration; errors at work; difficulty making decisions; loss of interest in previously valued activity

The Course and the Duration

Four features of the course of relationship grief are worth stating, because men's expectations about it are frequently wrong in ways that cause them to misjudge their own condition.

The pain is at its sharpest early and its later appearance is intermittent rather than constant. Men who experience a period of relative calm four months after a separation and then a strong recurrence at eight months frequently conclude that they are going backwards. The pattern is ordinary: acute intensity declines, and what remains is a set of specific triggers — an anniversary, a place, a song, a piece of news, a child's question — each of which produces a full-strength episode for a limited period. The episodes become less frequent and less durable. The intervals, not the intensity, are the measure of progress.

The full weight is frequently experienced at a delay. Where a man has practical work to perform — moving house, arranging contact, managing the legal process, informing the family, absorbing the financial consequences — the grief tends to be postponed until the work is complete. Men describe this accurately: *I was fine while there was something to do.* The period immediately after the practical matters conclude is therefore frequently the hardest, and it is the period in which men are least prepared and least supported, because everybody else has concluded that the matter is finished.

Anniversaries and symbolic dates produce predictable recurrences. The date of the wedding, the date of the separation, the birthdays, the family occasions at which the person is absent. Knowing the dates in advance is the practical measure: a man who expects difficulty on the date manages it better than one who is surprised by it.

Recovery is not the absence of feeling. The end state is not indifference. Men who have recovered describe retained affection, retained regret, and, in many cases, a continuing interest in the former partner's wellbeing, without the compulsive monitoring, the self-assessment, and the intrusive replay that characterise

the acute period. The presence of feeling is not evidence that the work has not been done.

> **KEY POINT**
> Relationship loss is not a lesser grief because it involves a living person rather than a death. It is frequently more complicated, because the person remains present in the world, because unfinished business cannot be closed by a funeral, and because the surrounding community may recover faster than the man does.

13.2 Why Men Sometimes Conceal Romantic Grief

Men conceal romantic grief for six reasons, and the reasons are practical rather than emotional. Understanding them matters because each has a different remedy.

The Six Reasons

The audience is unsympathetic. Men report anticipating, accurately, that disclosure will be received in specific ways: the assumption of blame (*what did you do?*), the assumption of culpability (*you should have known*), the immediate advice (*forget her; there are others*), or a practical redirection (*you need to move on*). None of these responses is intended unkindly, and each of them closes the conversation.

The disclosure creates an obligation for the listener. The most common reason men give for silence is that their friends have their own problems. This is frequently true and frequently is not the point: a man who will not mention his own difficulty in order to spare a friend produces two people who are not talking rather than one.

Concealment protects the possibility of reconciliation. Where a man wishes to restore the relationship, public grief is tactically unhelpful, and this is a real consideration for many men in the first months after a separation.

Concealment protects standing with children. A father concerned about being described as bitter, unstable, or unable to manage is frequently silent in front of his children, and this silence often extends to everybody else, since the children hear from relatives.

Grief in men is read as something else. A man who is grieving appears to his colleagues as stressed, his family as withdrawn, his friends as uninterested. His grief is not recognised, so it is not discussed, so he concludes that either it is not happening or it does not matter.

The vocabulary is absent. As Chapter 3 established, men frequently have no way to describe a state of longing, abandonment, or humiliation, and they therefore report its behaviours: work, exercise, sleeping badly, and a general sense of being busy.

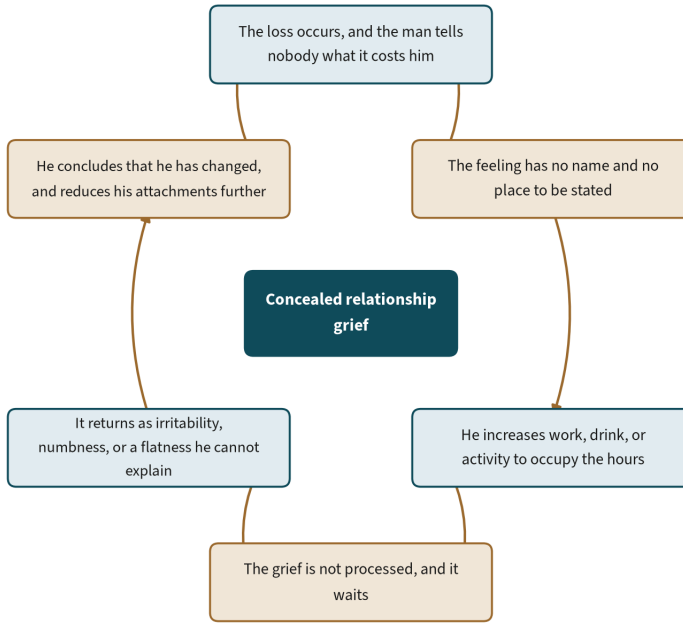


Figure 13.1 Why concealed relationship grief does not resolve. The cycle is maintained by the man's own conclusions about what may be said, and it ends only when the material is stated to somebody who receives it.

The Costs of Concealment

The costs of concealing romantic grief are the costs described throughout Part One, with two additions.

The conversion of grief into behaviour. Where grief cannot be expressed as speech, it becomes behaviour: increased work, or increased alcohol, or sexual activity without attachment, or conspicuous spending, or a hostility that is initially invisible and gradually becomes who the man is. The behaviour frequently continues beyond the point of recovery and becomes a settled pattern, which is one of the reasons that middle-aged men sometimes describe themselves as having become somebody they do not entirely recognise.

The exclusion of the people who would help. Where the man's closest friends and relatives do not know that he is grieving, they cannot adjust their expectations, cannot offer support, and cannot offer corrections to the man's own interpretation of events — which is frequently the most valuable thing available to a man in this position.

13.3 Rejection and Damaged Self-Worth

Rejection in the romantic domain has a distinctive effect on self-regard, and the effect is frequently more damaging than the loss itself. The purpose of this section is to describe the mechanism, because understanding it is what allows a man to reduce it.

The Idea of a Verdict

Rejection is experienced by men as a verdict rather than an event. Where a man is left, refused, ignored, or replaced, the experience is read as an assessment of him: of his worth, attractiveness, competence as a partner, and adequacy as a man. The reading is supported by the terms in which rejection is frequently delivered and discussed. A man is not told that a relationship has not worked; he is frequently told, by implication or explicitly, that he is insufficient in some specific respect — earning, presence, ambition, attractiveness, religious observance, family obligations, or emotional availability.

The results of this reading are specific and are visible in the accounts men give.

The search for the defect. A man in this position conducts an examination of himself, frequently for months, to identify the particular failing that produced the rejection. The examination is conducted with the standard described in Chapter 8: successes discounted, and any identified deficiency treated as conclusive evidence.

A generalisation from one relationship to all. The specific rejection becomes an assessment of the man's capacity for relationship, and it produces a belief that recurs in the accounts of many men after a serious rejection: *this happens to me.* Where the belief is established, later relationships are approached with an expectation of the same outcome, and the expectation produces behaviour — testing, withdrawal, defensiveness, or an anxious accommodation — which contributes to its own fulfilment.

The loss of an assumed partnership. Where a man has built his identity around being part of a couple, or around being a husband and father, the rejection removes the role as well as the relationship, which is the dynamic described in Chapters 11 and 24.

Shame rather than grief. This is the most important effect and the least recognised. Men frequently do not identify the state following a rejection as grief, because grief is what one feels for something that has been lost, and shame is what one feels for having been found insufficient. The two produce different behaviours: grief seeks comfort, while shame seeks concealment. A man who experiences the rejection as shame will therefore do the opposite of what would help him, withdrawing from precisely the people who might provide comfort.

What Reduces the Damage

Five measures reduce the damage to self-worth, and they follow from the mechanism described above.

Separate the decision from the verdict. A partner's decision to end a relationship is a decision about a relationship and about a person's own life, made on the basis of a very large number of factors that include her interests, circumstances, history, family, and future plans. It is not an assessment, and it is not an assessment of the other person's worth. Writing out the factors that were genuinely relevant to the decision, as an observer would list them, is the practical form of this measure.

Establish the actual reasons rather than the imagined ones. Where possible, men benefit from obtaining the actual reasons rather than reconstructing them. This requires a single structured conversation, ideally without recrimination, in which the man listens and does not argue. Men who complete such a conversation report with remarkable consistency that the reasons were more specific, more ordinary, and less damning than the ones they had constructed for themselves.

Reduce the exposure during the acute period. Contact, monitoring of social media, and enquiries through mutual acquaintances prolong the acute phase. A deliberate period of contact reduction — not necessarily permanent, particularly where children require cooperation — is the single most effective measure in the first two months.

Reconstruct the whole relationship rather than the ending. Men in the acute phase idealise what was lost: the relationship is remembered as it was in its best months. A written account of the relationship as it actually was, including its difficulties, is distressing and useful. Men frequently discover, on completing it, that they are grieving less for the relationship than for the version of it that they have constructed since it ended.

Address the underlying beliefs directly. Where the reading is *I am not enough*, the corrective is not reassurance but specificity, in the manner described in Chapter 8: which capacity, in what respect, and according to whom? The general claim does not survive the examination, and the specific claims can be addressed.

13.4 Betrayal and Broken Trust

Betrayal is a distinct experience from rejection, and it requires separate treatment because its effects differ. Rejection involves a decision about the relationship; betrayal involves a violation of the terms on which the relationship was conducted. The distinction matters because the injuries are different: rejection damages self-regard, while betrayal damages the man's model of other people.

The Forms of Betrayal

The forms that men report, in order of frequency, are infidelity; the concealment of a significant matter such as a debt, a previous relationship, a child, or an illness; the diversion of shared resources to another person or to a private purpose; an alliance with a third party against the man — including an alliance with his own relatives; a public humiliation delivered by a partner in company; and abandonment at a moment of the man's greatest need, such as an illness, a financial collapse, or a bereavement.

Not every betrayal ends the relationship. Some are survived, and the work of repair is covered in Chapters 15 and 16.

The Effects

The effects that men describe are consistent and they include the following.

A general collapse of trust. The most consequential effect is not the loss of trust in the specific person; it is the acquisition of a belief that applies to people in general. Men who have been betrayed report a durable change in their assumption about others: an expectation of hidden agendas, a need to verify, and a reduced willingness to be dependent on anybody. This is a serious injury, and it affects the man's future relationships, his work, and his willingness to accept help, as Chapter 35 describes.

Humiliation. Betrayal that becomes known — infidelity, in particular — produces a public element that men describe as worse than the private injury: the knowledge that others knew, that they discussed it, that they pitied him, and, frequently, that some of them participated in concealing it.

A reinterpretation of the past. The betrayed man reviews the entire relationship in the light of the betrayal. Periods of happiness are reconstructed as periods of deception, and this retrospective rewrite is one of the features that distinguishes betrayal from other losses: it damages the memory of the relationship as well as the relationship.

Rage, and the fear of it. The anger produced by betrayal is frequently intense, and men report being frightened by it. This fear is well founded: the risk of harmful behaviour towards the partner, the third party, or himself is elevated in this period, and the appropriate response is to arrange safeguards rather than to rely on self-control alone.

The temptation of revenge. The most common thoughts men report: exposure, retaliation in kind, financial revenge, and legal action pursued for its punitive rather than its practical value.

The Early Period: What to Do and What Not to Do

The first weeks after a betrayal are a period of high risk, and the following guidance is framed accordingly.

What not to do. Do not make decisions that cannot be undone: resign, relocate, dispose of assets, enter a new relationship, or confront the third party in circumstances where any of these could be forced. Do not consume alcohol in the amounts that the situation will suggest. Do not conduct the dispute in public, on social media, or through the children, in any circumstances. And do not assume that the intensity of the initial reaction is a reliable guide to the eventual decision, because it is not: most men who leave after a betrayal do so after weeks, and most of those who stay do so after consideration rather than in the first week.

What to do. First, physical and practical stability: sleep, food, activity, and an arrangement for the immediate household. Second, one confidant: a person who is not a member of the extended family, if possible, so that the man has somebody in whom he can speak freely. Third, professional help: for legal matters where relevant, and for the emotional consequences, which are frequently best addressed by a counsellor rather than by friends. Fourth, a restriction on the number of people who know, in the first weeks, because an announcement cannot be withdrawn and because the man's own judgement is temporarily impaired. Fifth, and importantly, an explicit plan for the period of maximum anger: how the man will leave any situation in which he feels dangerous to himself or others, whom he will telephone, and what he will not do.

Trust After Betrayal

A question men ask, and one that deserves a direct answer, is whether trust can be restored. Three answers apply, depending on the situation.

Where the relationship continues and both parties are committed to repair, trust can be rebuilt, and the process is specific: full disclosure of what occurred, an acceptance of accountability by the person who betrayed, a period in which verification is permitted without objection, the involvement of a counsellor, and time measured in months rather than weeks. Chapter 15 provides the detail. Men should note that this process requires the man to remain in a state of discomfort for a long period, which is the price of continuing, and that it is not a failure to decide that the price is too high.

Where the relationship ends, trust can still be restored, but the object of the restoration is different: it is trust in the man's own judgement and in the general reliability of others. This is achieved through ordinary experience — the accumulation of small, verified interactions with people who prove reliable — and the process is slower than men expect. It is also frequently assisted by the presence of at least one relationship in which trust has been maintained throughout.

Where the betrayal was by a family member or a trusted friend, the same principles apply with an additional element: the continuity of the family or community makes avoidance impossible, and boundaries rather than estrangement

are frequently the practical answer. Chapter 16 and Chapter 26 address this in detail.

13.5 Healing and Learning to Love Again

This section sets out the process of recovery, and it is written with a specific caution: men recover from relationship loss along a recognisable sequence, but the sequence is not a schedule, and a man who attempts to accelerate it by force of will is likely to produce a delay.

The Three Stages

Stage One: Stabilisation. The first weeks to three months. The objectives are physical stability, protection of functioning, and the avoidance of irreversible decisions. Sleep, food, exercise, work, and the ordinary structure of the day should be maintained or re-established. Contact with the former partner should be reduced to what is necessary, and where children are involved, contact should be confined to matters concerning them, in writing, with a fixed format if necessary. Alcohol should be reduced rather than increased, which is contrary to the instinct of the period. One confidant should be identified. Work obligations should be performed at a standard that is defensible, which frequently requires telling a supervisor that something personal is happening, without detail.

Stage Two: Understanding. One to six months, and frequently longer. This is the stage at which the meaning of what happened is processed: the actual reasons, the man's own contribution, the genuine features of him that are worth preserving, and the alterations that follow. It is the stage in which the two destructive hypotheses — *I am insufficient* and *all women are alike* — should be examined and replaced with something specific and accurate. It is also the stage in which most of the practical arrangements are settled and in which the legal and financial matters should be concluded, in the interests of leaving them behind.

Stage Three: Re-engagement. The stage at which interest returns in other people, in activities, and in the possibility of a new relationship. This stage cannot be scheduled. It occurs when the previous stages have been performed and when the man has re-established some structure of life that is his own rather than a reaction to the loss.

The Two Destructive Responses

Two responses are common and both prolong the difficulty.

The first is retaliation in kind. The man enters a period of conspicuous activity designed to demonstrate that he has recovered, to prompt regret, and to establish his own standing. Its features are recognisable: sexual activity pursued for its demonstrative effect rather than its value, conspicuous spending, statements made in public, and social media presentation. The response is understandable,

and it delays recovery for two reasons: it keeps the man's attention on the former partner, and it displaces the work of Stage Two.

The second is entrenchment. The man concludes that relationships are unwise, converts the loss into a general principle, and organises his life around self-sufficiency. This is the more common response among men over forty-five, and it is the more difficult to notice, because it is frequently presented as maturity: the man is focused on work, on his children, on his health, and has no interest in the complications of a relationship. In some cases this is a settled and satisfactory choice. In many it is a defensive arrangement whose cost appears later, in the form of isolation, as described in Chapters 4 and 25.

Learning to Love Again

Three pieces of work are required before a man enters a new relationship in a position to conduct it well.

The completion of unfinished material. Most men carry three items from a previous relationship: a story about what happened, a belief about themselves that resulted from it, and an unresolved grievance. Each should be written out, examined for accuracy, and revised. The test is specific: can the man describe the previous relationship to a new partner in a manner that is fair to everybody involved, that includes his own contribution, and that does not require the new partner to take sides? A man who cannot do this brings the previous relationship into the new one.

The establishment of a life that does not require a partner. The most reliable predictor of a good subsequent relationship, in the accounts men and women give, is that the man had a viable life of his own: work, friendships, interests, health, and structure. A relationship formed out of need is under pressure from the beginning, and a man who has been through a loss is particularly prone to forming one from need.

The examination of the pattern. Where the relationship's end involved something the man did or failed to do — the withdrawal described in Chapter 15, the absence described in Chapter 17, the management described in Chapter 9 — the pattern should be identified and addressed before the new relationship is formed. The contribution is not a matter of blame; it is a matter of identifying the specific behaviour that produced difficulty and confirming that it has changed.

The Re-entry

Three practical points, based on men's accounts of forming relationships after a loss.

Expect the comparison, and do not act on it. A new partner will be compared involuntarily with the previous one, frequently unfavourably, and this is normal in the first months. The comparison should be observed rather than used.

Do not conceal the history, and do not lay it out in detail. The honest and workable position is acknowledgement without elaboration: the relationship ended, here is what happened in one sentence, and here is what I learned. A full history delivered early is a burden; a history concealed is a lie that will be expensive later, as Chapter 35 describes.

Address the practical arrangements before the relationship becomes serious. Obligations to children, support payments, family obligations, and other standing commitments should be disclosed as the relationship becomes serious, and before any formal commitment. This is the material covered in Chapter 9, in a different context, and the same principle applies.

13.6 Illustrative Case: The Widower and the Man Who Was Left

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in counselling practice, bereavement research, and family practice.

Emeka is fifty-six, a secondary school principal, and his wife of twenty-nine years died twenty months ago, after an illness of seven months.

Emeka's response followed the pattern that his community expected. He took three weeks of leave, arranged the funeral, received visitors for eleven days, and returned to work. He spoke at his wife's memorial service with composure, and his composure was repeatedly remarked upon by the family, usually in the form of approval.

What followed was the arrangement he did not discuss with anybody. He retained the household exactly as it was: her clothes, her side of the wardrobe, the arrangement of the kitchen, and the items on the dressing table. He began to sleep on the sofa. He took on additional duties at the school, including Saturday examinations supervision, which he had never done before. He stopped attending the monthly meeting of his professional association. He answered questions about his welfare with the sentence *God knows best*, which was true and also served as a terminator. And he had, for eleven months, a period of what he described as discipline: no alcohol, early rising, daily walking, and an emotional flatness he maintained as an achievement.

Fourteen months after the death, his eldest daughter visited for two weeks and observed the following: that her father did not enter the main bedroom, that he had kept everything in place, that he had not once mentioned her mother by name in her hearing, and that he became distinctly different — quicker, harder, less tolerant — whenever the subject approached. She raised it with him directly on the last evening of her visit, in the terms that adult children use when they have decided to be direct: *Papa, what happened to you has happened. It is not in the wardrobe. You are.*

Emeka's account of what occurred in the following period is instructive. He described an evening, approximately three weeks after his daughter's visit, when he entered the main bedroom for the first time since the death, intending to clear the wardrobe, and found himself unable to do anything other than sit on the bed

for approximately two hours. He said: *I sat there and I understood that I had been organising my life as though she had travelled. I had been living in an arrangement that expected her to come back. I had not permitted myself to know that she was not coming back, because if I knew that, I would have had to feel it, and I did not have the strength to feel it while there were things to do. There were always things to do.*

He began, in the following months, three things, each ordinary. He attended a weekly gathering of widowed men at a social centre in the town, which he had avoided for a year. He began to keep the bedroom as his own, including the removal of the wardrobe contents, a process that took him five evenings. And he began to speak about his wife, at first in the family and then more widely, in ordinary sentences rather than in tributes.

Twenty months after her death, he describes his state as follows: *I am not over it. I do not expect to be over it. I can hold it now without it taking the whole of me. The year when I was strong was the year I lost, and I did not know it.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The composure was read as recovery. The community's approval — reinforced by cultural expectation and by the man's own standard — provided a strong incentive to maintain the appearance of having coped, and the appearance was maintained for fourteen months.

The frozen household was a physical expression of the unfinished grief. Retaining the wardrobe, sleeping on the sofa, and avoiding the bedroom constituted a daily arrangement that presumed the possibility of return. This pattern is common in bereavement and it is not a sign of pathology; it becomes a problem when it is maintained for a prolonged period without the grief being processed.

The overload was a strategy. The additional duties at the school, the Saturday supervision, and the stopped association meeting operated as the same arrangement described in Chapters 5 and 12: the removal of the unstructured time in which grief becomes unavoidable.

The disclosure came through a direct question. The daughter's sentence was short, specific, and did not permit the standard answer, and it enabled the man to reconsider, over weeks, a decision he had made without having recognised it as one.

The three interventions were entirely ordinary. A group of men in the same position, a practical task conducted at home, and the beginning of ordinary speech about the person who died. This is what recovering from serious loss generally looks like: unremarkable, repetitive, and conducted over a long period rather than achieved in a single insight.

Now a second case, deliberately brief, because it produces a different lesson.

Tunde is thirty-eight, a civil engineer, and was left by his fiancée five months before the wedding, by telephone message, with no explanation beyond a statement that she could not continue.

For three months, Tunde behaved in a manner that his friends described as exemplary. He increased his working hours. He organised a trip for six friends, which he paid for. He began a fitness programme with visible results. He attended every family function and answered questions about the wedding with the statement that it was not to be, delivered with a smile.

In the fourth month, an incident occurred at a family gathering. A cousin asked, jokingly and within range of several relatives, whether Tunde had been told the reasons for the cancellation. Tunde rose and left the gathering. He did not return for nine months, and during that period he reduced his contact with his family to telephone calls on important occasions.

What emerged, over two years and in the course of treatment for what he initially described as stress, was a pattern that he had not previously identified. His relationship with his fiancée had been conducted for four years in an arrangement of constant demonstration: he had increased his earnings substantially, taken on a loan to fund the wedding and the housing, adjusted his church membership and family commitments to match her family's expectations, and suppressed three specific disagreements — about the location of the family home, about the number and timing of children, and about the financial assistance he gave to his mother — rather than risk a conflict. He had, in his own description, been managing the relationship as a project. When the project was cancelled, he had no idea who he had been for four years.

Tunde's recovery involved two things that he found difficult and useful: an examination of the four years in which he wrote out the disagreements he had suppressed and what he had actually wanted in each case; and a deliberate practice, in his family and at work, of stating disagreement about small matters, which he had to learn as a technique rather than exercise as an inclination. Two years later, in a relationship that he describes as about sixty per cent as romantic and twice as honest, he reported the sentence that this chapter would identify as its central teaching: *I was not heartbroken because I lost the person. I was broken because I had given up the person I was in order to keep her, and I never told her that I had done it.*

13.7 Practical Exercise: The Relationship Grief Inventory

This exercise takes two sittings of about an hour. It is intended for the man who has lost a relationship and who has not processed it, whether the loss occurred two months or twenty years ago. Men frequently find that the exercise is more useful for losses of long standing than for recent ones.

Part One: The Record

Write out, in about 400 words, the account of what happened, without evaluation. Include the sequence of events, what was said, what you did, and what you were told.

Then answer four questions:

- How long ago did this happen?
- Who have I told about it, in detail, and how many people is that?
- What have I never said aloud about it?
- If this relationship ended again tomorrow, with the same circumstances, what would I do differently?

Part Two: The Losses

List separately what was lost, using the six components from Section 13.1: the person, the future, the role, the household structure, standing, and the assumption of permanence. For each, write one sentence about what it has cost you. Men who complete this part frequently discover that the largest loss is not the first item on the list.

Part Three: The Verdict

Write out the judgement you formed about yourself as a result of the loss, in your own words, as a single sentence. Examples, from men's accounts: *I was not enough. I chose badly. I am not capable of keeping anyone. I am the kind of man women leave.*

Then test the verdict using the method from Chapter 8.

- What is the specific content of the claim, rather than its general form?
- Which parts of it are supported by evidence, and which are inferences?
- What would I say to a friend who described himself in these terms?
- What evidence would be required to disprove the claim, and does that evidence exist?

Part Four: The Contribution

Write out, honestly and specifically, what you did and did not do in the relationship. This is not an exercise in blame, and it should be completed without either self-flagellation or the transfer of all responsibility. The purpose is practical: to identify the behaviours worth changing so that they do not recur in the same form.

The question that organises this part is: what did I do, or fail to do, that a reasonable observer would identify as having contributed to the difficulty?

Part Five: The Unfinished Item

Write the sentence that you have never said to the other person and that you carry. Then decide, deliberately, what to do with it: say it to the person where that is

possible and appropriate, say it to a counsellor or a trusted person, write it and destroy it, or acknowledge that it will remain unsaid and that the cost of carrying it is acceptable.

What is not recommended is to carry it indefinitely without having made the decision.

Part Six: The Current Position

Answer three questions, each with a short written answer.

1. **Where am I in the sequence?** Stabilisation, understanding, or re-engagement — and on what evidence have I placed myself there?
2. **Which of the two destructive responses, retaliation or entrenchment, has been my pattern?** What has it cost me?
3. **What is the next item of work?** One specific thing, with a date. It may be a conversation, an appointment, a written account, a scheduling decision, or the removal of an object. One item rather than a programme.

13.8 Common Questions Men Ask

"It has been three years and I still think about her. Is that abnormal?"

Thinking about somebody after a significant relationship is not abnormal at any duration. What matters is the quality of the thought. Thought that has become settled and factual — *that happened, this is what it was, this is what I learned* — is ordinary memory. Thought that reopens a decision, replays arguments, monitors her life, or activates the same judgement about yourself is unfinished grief, and it is worth treating as such. The inventory above is designed for exactly this case.

"Should I tell my children what happened?"

Where they are adults, yes, in an age-appropriate and non-partisan form: what occurred, in factual terms, without characterising their mother. Where they are children, the guidance in Chapter 17 applies: they should be told what concerns them — where they will live, when they will see each parent — and not the detail of the adult dispute. What should never be done is to use them as messengers, as allies, or as instruments of information.

"How do I know whether to try to reconcile?"

Four questions are decisive: is the person willing to participate in a genuine repair rather than a return to the previous arrangement; is the conduct that caused the separation capable of change, or is it a settled pattern; can you live with the requirement for verification over the coming months; and would you choose the relationship again if it were presented to you today as it actually was, rather than as you remember it? Chapter 15 provides the framework.

"My friend is going through this and has stopped speaking to anybody. What do I do?"

Keep contact without requiring conversation. Practically: a regular call with no agenda, a standing arrangement to eat or walk, and the absence of pressure to discuss anything. Men in this position frequently return to conversation on their own timetable, and the people who are available when they do are the ones who helped. Where there is any indication of self-harm or of serious depression, the guidance in Chapter 6 and Appendix B applies, and professional involvement should be sought.

"I cannot seem to trust anyone now. Will that change?"

It can, and the mechanism is ordinary experience rather than decision. Trust is rebuilt by the accumulation of small interactions in which a person proves reliable, and this requires exposure, which is precisely what the betrayed man avoids. The practical approach is graduated: small commitments to people who have been reliable in the past, extended slowly, and the maintenance of at least one relationship in which trust was never broken. The work is slow and it is possible.

"How long before I should consider another relationship?"

There is no fixed period, and the useful test is the one in Section 13.5: can you describe the previous relationship fairly, without requiring anybody to take sides; do you have a life that does not require a partner; and have you identified and addressed the pattern that contributed to the previous difficulty? Where the answer to all three is yes, the timing is a matter of preference. Where any of them is no, the new relationship is likely to reproduce the previous one.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 13 in brief. Relationship loss is among the most stressful events in adult life, and its pain has six components: the loss of the person, the loss of the anticipated future, the loss of the role the man occupied, the loss of household structure including daily contact with children, the loss of standing in the community, and the loss of the assumption that commitments hold. Men frequently recognise only the first. The severity is often greater than acknowledged for four reasons: the relationship may have been the man's only intimate relationship; his role within it may have been maintenance rather than enjoyment; support after separation is asymmetrically distributed; and the social permission to grieve is narrower for men.

Men conceal romantic grief for six reasons: the anticipated unsympathetic response, the desire not to burden friends, the protection of the possibility of reconciliation, the protection of standing with children, the fact that male grief is read as stress or withdrawal rather than grief, and the absence of vocabulary for longing and humiliation. The costs of concealment are the conversion of grief into behaviour — overwork, alcohol, unattached sexual activity, spending, hostility — and the exclusion of the people who would otherwise offer perspective.

Rejection is experienced as a verdict on worth rather than as an event. Its effects include the search for the defect, generalisation from one relationship to all, the loss

of an assumed partnership, and, most importantly, shame rather than grief — which drives concealment where grief would drive seeking comfort. The damage is reduced by separating the decision from the verdict, obtaining the actual reasons, reducing exposure during the acute period, reconstructing the whole relationship rather than its ending, and testing the underlying belief for specificity.

Betrayal is distinct from rejection: it damages the man's model of other people rather than only his self-regard. Its effects are a general collapse of trust, humiliation, a retrospective reinterpretation of the relationship, intense rage with a genuine risk of harmful behaviour, and the temptation of revenge. The early period requires physical and practical stability, one confidant outside the extended family, professional help, a restriction on the number of people informed, and an explicit plan for moments of maximum anger. Trust can be rebuilt within the relationship through full disclosure, accountability, permitted verification, counselling, and time; where the relationship ends, the object of the repair becomes trust in one's own judgement and in others generally.

Recovery proceeds through stabilisation, understanding, and re-engagement, and the two destructive responses to avoid are retaliation in kind and entrenchment. Learning to love again requires the completion of unfinished material, a life that does not require a partner, and the identification and correction of the pattern that contributed to the previous difficulty. Re-entry should expect involuntary comparison, should acknowledge the history without laying it out in detail, and should disclose practical obligations before the relationship becomes serious.

Reflection Questions

1. From the six components of relationship loss in Section 13.1, which has cost you the most, and which have you never acknowledged as losses at all?
2. What did you do with the pain of the break-up — and where did it go? If it went into work, alcohol, activity, or silence, what has that arrangement cost you since?
3. What verdict did you form about yourself as a result of a rejection, and how specific is it? What would you say to a friend who had formed the same verdict about himself?
4. If you were betrayed, what did the experience do to your general willingness to trust people? Has it changed, and what has changed it?
5. Which of the two destructive responses — retaliation or entrenchment — has been your pattern, and what has it produced in your life over the years since?
6. Complete Part Three of the inventory: write the verdict in one sentence. Then answer the four questions about it in writing, and read the answers aloud.

7. What is your next item of work from Part Six, and what is its date? Write it down and tell one person.

Further Reading

- **On the psychology of romantic loss:** the research literature on the emotional and physiological effects of romantic rejection, including imaging studies showing that social rejection and physical pain involve overlapping neural systems, and the work on the duration and course of recovery after break-up.
- **On grief and bereavement:** the standard literature on grief, including the work on the distinction between normal and complicated grief, the continuing-bonds approach to the loss of a spouse, and the research on widowers' significantly elevated mortality in the period following a spouse's death.
- **On men and help-seeking after separation:** research on men's support networks, on the comparative support available to men and women after marital breakdown, and on the specific vulnerabilities of men living alone after separation.
- **On betrayal and trust:** the psychological literature on infidelity and on the process of rebuilding trust after a violation, including the elements of successful repair and the conditions under which repair fails.
- **On attachment:** the literature on adult attachment styles, including how early patterns influence the formation, maintenance, and ending of adult relationships, and how predictable patterns of relating can be modified through therapy and practice.
- **Practical resources:** structured programmes for separated and divorced men, including recovery programmes built around peer groups; professional counselling for relationship loss and betrayal; and legal advice obtained early, before decisions are made under pressure.

14 CHAPTER

Loving Someone Who Does Not Understand Your Pain

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the situation of the man whose partner does not understand or acknowledge the difficulties he carries, and identify the specific and typical forms that this takes.
2. Explain why disclosure frequently produces an inadequate response, without assuming that the partner's response reflects indifference.
3. Identify the features of the relationship that develop when a man concludes that his partner cannot understand him, and assess whether those features have begun to appear in his own marriage.
4. Apply a structured approach to being understood: what to disclose, when, in what form, and what to do with an inadequate response.
5. Recognise the limits of a relationship's capacity, and distinguish between a partner who is unwilling to understand and a partner who is unable to understand.
6. Decide, using a structured assessment, what to do where understanding cannot be obtained, including the options of external support, renegotiation of the relationship, and, where necessary, ending it.

Introduction

Consider two statements that men make about their marriages, and note how differently they are heard.

The first: *my wife does not understand what I go through.* This statement is heard as a complaint about insufficient appreciation, and it is frequently answered with the observation that the wife also has difficulties, that the man should communicate better, or that he is asking for sympathy he has not earned by disclosing anything.

The second, which is the substance of the first: *I have told the person closest to me what I am carrying, more than once, and the response I received made it clear that the matter would not be discussed again. Since then I have stopped telling her anything that matters. I live with somebody who is my partner in the household and a stranger to my interior life, and I intend to continue doing so for the rest of my life.*

This chapter addresses the second situation, and its tone is deliberately careful, because the subject is one on which both partners are frequently misjudged. The chapter does not assume that the wife is cold, indifferent, or incapable. It does not assume that the man has communicated adequately, because a substantial proportion of men who say they have disclosed have done so once, indirectly, at a bad moment, and in three sentences. It does assume that this is a genuine and common condition, that it hurts, and that the options are more numerous than men generally believe.

The chapter also proceeds from a finding that should be stated at the outset, because it structures everything that follows. In the great majority of the marriages this chapter describes, the wife's difficulty is not a deficiency of love. It is a combination of four things: she has been given insufficient information; the information she was given was delivered in a form that could not be received, such as anger or silence; her own resources are exhausted; and she, too, has concluded that her own difficulties are not understood. The last of these is the most consequential, and it is the one that men in this position most frequently fail to consider.

What This Chapter Is Not Saying

Two clarifications are necessary before the analysis proceeds, because the subject invites two errors in opposite directions.

The first error is to treat the man's complaint as a demand for sympathy. In the accounts given by men, the request is rarely for comfort. It is, in the great majority of cases, for one person in the world to know the actual position. Men in this situation do not generally want to be excused from their obligations; they want to stop maintaining the impression, at home, that their obligations are being carried without cost. The distinction is important because a request for knowledge can be met, while a request for relief from responsibility frequently cannot.

The second error is to treat the wife's inadequate response as the cause. The cause is a sequence of exchanges, and the sequence includes the man's part: the form in which he disclosed, the moment he selected, the fact that he has usually disclosed once rather than consistently, and the fact that he has generally shown no interest in what his wife is carrying. Therefore the entire analysis in this chapter proceeds on the assumption that the arrangement has two authors,

that both of them are acting reasonably on the information available to them, and that the most effective interventions operate on the exchange rather than on either person's character.

To these two clarifications, a third should be added concerning the scope of the chapter. What follows is written for men in marriages and long partnerships that are not abusive, in which both parties are basically willing, and in which the difficulty is a matter of unspoken material rather than a matter of safety. Where a relationship involves violence, coercion, or a threat to the man's safety or the safety of children, the framework in this chapter does not apply and the guidance in Appendix G should be followed instead.

14.1 When Your Partner Does Not Understand

The experience described in this section has recurring features. Men who recognise four or more of them are likely to be in the situation this chapter is written about.

The Ten Features

The first attempts at disclosure were badly received. The man recalls the specific occasion, sometimes years later: what he said, what she said in reply, and what he concluded. The replies he remembers are specific, and they are almost never cruel. They are: *you are the man, this is what you are supposed to do*; *everybody has problems*; *what do you want me to do about it?*; *if I begin to worry about your problems, who will carry mine?*; *I have my own burdens*; or the response of turning the subject to her own difficulties.

The subject has not been raised since. Because the first attempt produced a conclusion, and the man does not attempt a second disclosure of the same type with the same person. This is the central mechanism of the whole condition: silent men are frequently silent because they have an accurate memory of what happened the last time they spoke.

A specific repertoire of behaviour has developed to avoid the subject. The man works later. He answers questions about his state with *I am fine.* He attends to the household's practical matters in a formal and effective manner. He conducts any substantial conversation with his wife about matters of interest but not about himself. Some men describe sleeping in separate rooms, not out of hostility but for the absence of conversation.

Anger is the message when the subject is unavoidable. The anger is produced by the pressure, not by the wife, and it is received as though it were directed at her, which is why the pattern is so damaging to a marriage: the only signal that reaches the partner is the signal that most damages her.

Loneliness is present inside the marriage. This is the defining feature and the most difficult to describe. The man is not alone; he has a partner, a household,

and frequently children. He is also aware that if he were to receive bad news, the first person he would tell is not the person to whom he is married.

An accommodation is reached and maintained. The couple arranges itself in a settled equilibrium: the man manages his difficulties externally or privately, and the wife manages the household and her own difficulties with her own network. The arrangement works, and its costs are that neither partner has a confidant, and that the relationship contains partnership without intimacy.

A separate source of support is developed, or is not. Some men develop one: a close friend, a sibling, a professional, a group. Others do not, which greatly increases the risk described in Chapters 4, 5, and 6.

There is a survivor's interpretation of the wife. Men in this position hold a settled view: that she does not care, that she has never been interested in his interior life, that she married a position rather than a person. Any examination of this interpretation requires the material in Section 14.2, because it is frequently inaccurate and it is difficult to test without a conversation that the man has decided is not worth attempting.

Comparisons occur. With a colleague's marriage, with a brother's, with an imagined ideal. Comparisons of this kind are corrosive and they are almost always based on public information.

The alternative is considered. Men in this position consider, at least occasionally, the possibility of another relationship in which they would be understood. Where the consideration remains a thought, it is usually a symptom of the underlying deprivation; where it becomes a plan, Chapter 16 applies.

Why the First Attempt Failed

It is worth examining the first failed disclosure in detail, because it is the pivot on which the entire condition turns, and because men generally interpret it as evidence about the wife's character rather than as evidence about the exchange.

Consider four recurring forms of the first failed disclosure.

The sudden disclosure. A man who has carried a difficulty for a long time releases it, at night, in a compressed and urgent form, frequently with anger or tears. The partner receives an undigested mass of material, with no warning, at the end of her own long day, in a form that suggests crisis. Her response will be oriented to containing the crisis rather than understanding the man's experience. Men frequently report being told to calm down, or having their account corrected on points of fact, or getting a practical instruction. None of this is a refusal to understand; it is a response to an emergency.

The instrumental disclosure. The man mentions his difficulty as an explanation for a decision or a refusal: he cannot attend the event, he cannot take the additional obligation, he is not able to discuss the matter now. In this form,

the difficulty is presented as an obstacle, and it is answered as an obstacle, with negotiation about the obstacle. The man experiences the negotiation as a refusal to engage with what lies behind it.

The disclosure hedged into insignificance. The man includes a caveat that cancels the disclosure: *it is nothing, I am managing, I only mentioned it.* The partner takes the caveat at its word, which is a rational response to the information received. The man records that she was not interested.

The disclosure with a demand. The man connects the disclosure to an expectation: that she should adjust her behaviour, acknowledge his difficulty, or accept a specific change. The partner hears the demand and responds to it. The man hears the response as the dismissal of the difficulty.

The pattern across all four is the same: the exchange concerned a message, and it is read afterwards as evidence of a character. The correction is not to excuse the wife's response — some responses are genuinely inadequate — but to establish what was communicated, in what form, at what time, and what a different form might produce.

14.2 Why Disclosure Is Hard — For Both of You

This section shifts the focus, deliberately, and examines the wife's position. The shift is not a concession; it is a practical necessity, because a man who holds an accurate model of his partner's situation has a materially better chance of obtaining the understanding he wants.

The Wife's Position

Five features are regularly present.

Her own load. In the households described in this book, the wife frequently carries substantial and continuous responsibilities: household management, children, employment, extended-family obligations, and, in many cases, financial management of a household whose income is unstable. Her capacity to receive additional emotional material at the end of a day is genuinely limited, and this is a matter of capacity rather than love.

Her own undisclosed difficulties. Chapter 22 addresses the recognised fact that women's emotional load is frequently carried invisibly and unevenly. Many wives in these households are themselves carrying material they have never fully disclosed, and some of them have made their own attempt at disclosure that received an inadequate response. Where both partners have concluded invisibly that the other is unavailable, the marriage contains two people who have each decided, separately, not to speak.

The cultural instruction she has received. Many women have been taught, explicitly and from childhood, that a man's difficulties are his to carry, that a wife's role is to manage the household and not to question her husband's inner state,

that a man who complains has been weakened by something, and that a woman who listens to a husband's despair will be required to carry it. These instructions are not the wife's invention and they are frequently held alongside genuine affection and concern.

The fear of what comes next. Where a man discloses that he is struggling, the wife's first concern is frequently practical and well-founded: what happens if he stops working, or becomes ill, or leaves. Her response may therefore be oriented to stability: reassurance, minimisation, and a request to continue. To the man this reads as refusal; to the wife it is management of an unmanageable risk.

Her own history of the man's disclosures. Many wives have been in the position of receiving disclosures that were later used against them — mentioned in arguments, denied, or followed by a decision the wife had not agreed to. A woman whose experience of her husband's disclosures includes subsequent injury will, entirely rationally, respond to the next one with caution.

The Collision

Put the two positions together and the outcome is predictable, and it is worth presenting as a sequence because it explains how a marriage of two willing people arrives at twenty years of silence.

1. The man carries a difficulty, having no vocabulary and no expectation of help.
2. His capacity is reduced, and he becomes irritable, absent, or unavailable, without explanation.
3. The wife observes the change and cannot identify its cause. She infers a cause, frequently the wrong one: work, another woman, dissatisfaction with the household, or contempt for her.
4. The difficulty eventually becomes visible, or is disclosed in one of the four failed forms.
5. The wife responds to what she can see, which is an emergency, a demand, or a change in behaviour.
6. Each partner concludes something about the other: he concludes that she does not want to know; she concludes that he does not trust her, or that he has become somebody she does not know.
7. Each acts on the conclusion in a way that confirms the other's. He stops disclosing; she stops asking, and, in many cases, does more of the household's practical work as compensation, which means she now has less capacity to ask.
8. The equilibrium is established, and it is maintained for years, with both parties believing it was the other's choice.

The eighth step is what makes this chapter necessary. Neither partner has decided to live this way; both have made a series of rational responses to information that was incomplete.

14.3 The Cost of Being Misunderstood

The costs of this arrangement are not abstract, and they fall on four parties.

The Cost to the Man

The loss of the principal support that marriage is supposed to provide. A man who cannot speak to his wife about his interior life is operating without the support that the relationship's structure implies, and he experiences a specific deprivation that he frequently cannot name. It is not the absence of conversation; it is the absence of one person who knows.

A further reduction in the willingness to disclose. Each failed attempt confirms the conclusion, and the conclusion becomes general: the man does not attempt disclosure with anybody. The consequence is the arrangement described in Chapter 4, in which the man has no intimate relationship at all, and the consequences of that arrangement are the material of Part One.

The redirection of the difficulty into behaviour that damages the marriage. Where the difficulty cannot be spoken, it is enacted, and the enactment is directed at home: withdrawal, irritability, alcohol, longer hours, and, in some cases, conduct outside the marriage. It is important to state the attribution clearly: the marriage is damaged not primarily by the man's difficulty but by the arrangement in which the difficulty is unspoken, and the arrangement has two authors.

The progressive reduction of what the man wants from the relationship. Men in long-standing arrangements of this kind report a change in their expectations over time: from wanting to be understood, to wanting to be left alone, to wanting nothing in particular and being surprised when the arrangement becomes intolerable to them at fifty-five. The last stage frequently arrives at a point when the children have left home and the man's work is reducing, and the arrival of the material is then attributed to a crisis of age rather than to the arrangement that produced it.

The development of alternatives that are not chosen deliberately. Where the need for understanding is unmet at home, it is met elsewhere, and the elsewhere is frequently not a counsellor or a friend. Chapter 16 addresses the path from deprivation to infidelity, which is significantly more common among men in this arrangement than among men whose marriages contain an intimate conversation.

The Cost to the Partner

She is dealing with an unexplained change. The wife lives with a man whose mood, availability, and temper have altered without explanation, and she is required to organise her household around an unknown quantity. This is a substantial strain and it is underestimated by men who are experiencing the same change from the inside and who know its cause.

She acquires the belief that the marriage has failed. Where a husband's withdrawal is not explained, the wife's most common inferences are the ones identified above. A woman who believes she has been excluded, replaced, or found inadequate will conduct her marriage on that basis, and she may not mention it for years.

She compensates, which increases her load. In many households, when a man becomes less available, the wife absorbs the difference: additional work, additional management of the children, additional financial arrangement, and additional responsibility for the family's social obligations. Her load increases as her husband's grows, and neither has a way to say so.

Her own difficulties are unattended. A wife whose husband is withdrawn or irritable does not raise her own difficulties with him, because the conditions are wrong. The result is two unattended people in the same house, which is the arrangement that produces the mutual accusation, in later years, that each was unthinking of the other.

The Cost to the Children

The costs described in Chapter 17 apply in full. Children in these households observe a family with no spoken difficulty, and they learn the same repertoire. In particular, they learn that a man in difficulty does not speak about it, that a mother and father manage separately, and that a household's problems are handled in silence. Sons reproduce the pattern with a reliability that the research on intergenerational transmission would predict; daughters frequently select partners who reproduce it.

The Cost to the Man's Capacity

The final cost is practical and is frequently overlooked in accounts of marriage. A man who cannot discuss his difficulties operates with less information, less perspective, and fewer corrections. His wife is the person best placed to identify deterioration — the change in his sleep, the loss of interest, the short temper, the alcohol — because she is the person who knows him well enough to notice a change, and she is also best placed to test his accounts of situations at work, because she knows the history. A man who conceals from his wife therefore loses a source of reality-checking at precisely the moment when his judgement is most

impaired by stress, which is one of the routes by which men in this arrangement make consequential decisions badly.

> **KEY POINT**
> A marriage in which a man's difficulties are unspoken costs both partners, and it is maintained by both. Neither the man's silence nor the wife's inadequate response is the cause; the cause is a sequence of ordinary exchanges in which each party received insufficient information and drew a conclusion.

14.4 How to Be Understood: A Structured Approach

This section sets out a method. It is written for a man who has decided, having read the previous sections, that the arrangement is worth one serious attempt rather than another decade of silence.

The Four Conditions for a Successful Disclosure

Choose the purpose. A disclosure intended to explain a change is received differently from one intended to request help, and both differ from one intended to redistribute responsibility. The purpose must be decided in advance, because a disclosure with mixed purposes is received as a complaint or a demand.

Choose the time. Not at the end of a working day, not in bed, not during a crisis, not in front of children, and not immediately before or after an argument. A scheduled conversation — *I would like to talk about something on Saturday morning when the children are out* — is the most reliable format, because it removes the element of ambush and gives the partner a chance to prepare.

Choose the quantity. One subject. Not the accumulation of twelve years. A man who intends to disclose his financial position should not disclose his financial position, his disappointment about the relationship, and his father's illness in the same conversation. The volume is what produces the emergency response described in Section 14.1.

Choose the form. In the register that the partner can work with. Chapter 3 established the difficulty men have in describing internal states, and this is where it has practical consequences. Three practical devices are available.

- **Use the physical as an opening.** *My blood pressure has been high and the doctor has given me three months to change something.* This is factual, verifiable, and it opens the subject without requiring the man to make an emotional claim.
- **Use the specific event.** *When the contract was cancelled in March, I lost four million naira of expected income, and I have not been able to tell you because I was ashamed.*

- **Use the sequence.** *Here is what happened, here is what I did, here is where I am, and here is what I need.* This structure provides the partner with an account she can follow, and it prevents the most common failure, in which a man presents a conclusion without the material that produced it.

What the man brings to the conversation	What the conversation requires
A conclusion he has carried alone, often for years, and a decision to state it once.	The material stated in sequence, with the conclusion at the end rather than the start.
A request for understanding that has never been made in specific terms.	A specific statement of what he needs: to be heard, to be believed, or to be helped.
A fear that stating the position will be heard as a complaint about her.	A stated distinction between what she did and what he is describing.
The expectation that one conversation will settle a long arrangement.	A second conversation fixed in advance, so that the first one is not asked to carry everything.

Figure 14.1 What a man typically brings to the conversation, and what the conversation actually requires. The most common failure is not the material but the order in which it is delivered.

What to Ask For

An explicit request is more effective than an implicit expectation, and the request should be specific and modest. Among the requests that work:

- *I need you to know this, and I do not need you to solve it tonight.*
- *I need to be able to say when a week has been bad, without it becoming a crisis.*
- *I need one conversation a month in which I say how things actually are.*
- *I need you to come to one appointment with me.*
- *I need you to stop telling your family the things I tell you, and I am telling you that I am asking for that.*

Each of these is concrete, deliverable, and checkable. None of them requires the wife to change her personality or her load.

Handling the Response

Four responses are possible, and each requires a different handling.

A good response. Recognise it and reciprocate. Where the partner responds well, the next step is not to unload everything, but to establish the practice: a regular arrangement in which the material can be raised. Most successful repairs in this domain consist of a small number of conversations held consistently rather than one large one.

A partially adequate response. The most common outcome. The partner is concerned about the substance and responds clumsily about the form: an instruction, a correction of detail, an immediate practical solution, or a comparison with somebody else's situation. This should be accepted rather than scored. The useful reply is a direct request: *I appreciate that. What would help me more is if you simply heard it for now.* Men frequently abandon the whole attempt because the first response was not ideal, and the correction is usually one sentence.

A difficult response. Minimising, blaming, turning the subject to her own difficulties, or an angry response. The appropriate handling has three elements: name what occurred without accusing (*when I told you about the money, you said that I should have known better, and I stopped talking*); hold the position that the disclosure was legitimate (*I am not saying that you have not had difficulties; I am saying that this is mine and it is real*); and propose the repeat (*I would like to try again on Saturday*). Where the response is consistently difficult across several attempts, Section 14.5 applies.

A refusal. The partner declines the conversation, and the refusal may be explicit or expressed through avoidance, absence, or the introduction of a crisis each time the subject approaches. This is a serious finding, and it should be recorded rather than argued. Section 14.6 addresses what follows.

The Reciprocal Obligation

One further element is essential, and its omission is the most common cause of failure in this domain. The man must ask, and must mean it: **what are you carrying that I do not know about?** A marriage contains two interior lives. The disclosure that produces a durable change is usually reciprocal, and the man who approaches his wife with his own difficulty but no interest in hers has requested a service rather than a relationship. Chapter 15 develops the mutual practice, and it is the mechanism by which the arrangements described in this chapter are most reliably changed.

14.5 When Understanding Cannot Be Found in the Relationship

This section addresses the case in which the attempts described in Section 14.4 have been made and the understanding has not been obtained. It begins with a distinction that determines everything that follows.

Unwilling and Unable

Unwilling. The partner is capable of the conversation and declines it. The evidence of unwillingness includes: the capacity to hold comparable conversations about other matters; an active avoidance that appears when the subject approaches; a consistent pattern across years and contexts; and a stated position, sometimes explicit, that the man's interior life is not her concern.

Unable. The partner cannot conduct the conversation, for reasons that are not a refusal: her own mental health condition or trauma history; a load that has genuinely exhausted her capacity; an upbringing and cultural formation that equipped her with no means of receiving such material without interpreting it as a threat; or a personal history in which her own disclosures were received in a manner that makes them impossible for her.

The distinction matters practically. Where the partner is unable, the appropriate response is generally to obtain the understanding elsewhere while maintaining the relationship, and to consider whether anything can improve her capacity — treatment for her own conditions, a reduction in her load, counselling for the couple. Where the partner is unwilling, the appropriate response involves a decision about the marriage itself, and the assessment in Section 14.6 provides the framework.

The distinction is difficult to make from inside. Men are poor judges of their wives' capacity in this specific respect, for two reasons: they have usually attempted disclosure once or twice rather than consistently, and they are usually unaware of the load their wives are carrying, because their wives have also stopped disclosing.

Obtaining Understanding Elsewhere

Where understanding is not available in the marriage, it must be obtained elsewhere, and it must be obtained without deceiving the partner. Four sources are available and each has specific properties.

One confidant. A friend, a sibling, or a colleague. The practical arrangements are the same as those described in Chapter 4: a mutual arrangement, a regular occasion, and a rule of confidentiality. The value is not advice but the presence of one person who knows the actual situation.

A peer group. A group of men in comparable circumstances. The advantage is that it removes the requirement for explanation: men in a group of this kind do

not need to be persuaded that a difficulty is real. Chapter 27 addresses how such groups are found and how they are conducted.

A professional. A counsellor, therapist, or, in some cases, a physician or a religious minister, where the man's own framework includes one. The advantage is capacity and method; the disadvantage, for many men, is cost and the requirement to begin with a stranger. Men should note that a counsellor is generally the most effective option for material that is serious, long-standing, or connected to a condition such as depression, and that the confidant is not a substitute for treatment.

A community or an activity that supplies something other than understanding. Understanding is not the only requirement. Structure, usefulness, competence, and pleasure also matter, and a man whose household supplies none of them may obtain a great deal from an organisation in which he is useful and a practice at which he is competent. Chapter 27 covers this.

The Ethics of External Support

Three rules apply, and they protect both the man and the marriage.

The partner should know that the support exists. Not the content, but the fact: *I have been speaking to somebody about what I am carrying, and I would not be able to tell you who or what about.* This preserves the marriage's honesty without breaching the confidentiality that makes the support effective.

The support must not be a substitute marriage. A relationship with a person of the opposite sex in which the man receives emotional intimacy that his marriage does not provide is, regardless of intent, a relationship that competes with the marriage and that will tend towards the situation described in Chapter 16. This is not a moral judgement about the situation; it is an observation about the mechanism, and it is based on the consistency with which this trajectory is reported.

The support must not be used to accumulate a case. Counsellors and confidants are frequently placed in the position of receiving a man's account of his marriage over years while the marriage itself never hears the material. The result is a file of grievances and no attempt at resolution. The useful test: if a conversation with a confidant would become a conversation with the partner where the partner were willing, the material belongs in the marriage, and the man should ask himself why it has never been delivered there.

14.6 Decision Framework: Staying, Renegotiating, or Leaving

Some men arrive at this point having attempted, repeatedly and reasonably, to obtain understanding, and having found that the relationship will not supply it. This section provides a framework for the decision that follows. It does not presume the answer, and it deliberately sets out all three options.

The Assessment

Answer the following, in writing and honestly. The answers, not the advice of others, should determine the decision.

Part One: The relationship as a whole.

1. What does the relationship supply that matters: children, companionship, practical partnership, financial stability, family connection, reliability, affection, sexual relationship, shared history, care in illness?
2. What does it not supply, and how central is that to my wellbeing?
3. Are there other serious problems, or is the difficulty confined to the man's interior life?

Part Two: The disclosure attempts.

4. How many genuine attempts have I made, and in what form? Were they structured, scheduled, and limited to one subject, or were they sudden, indirect, or made during a crisis?
5. What did I actually ask for, and was it specific and deliverable?
6. Did I ask about her own difficulties, and did I hear them?

Part Three: Capacity.

7. What is her load, and what is she carrying that I know about and have not addressed?
8. Does she have a condition, a history, or a formation that makes this conversation impossible for her?
9. Has her capacity changed over the years, and is it changing now?

Part Four: The alternatives.

10. What would I obtain outside the marriage that I do not obtain inside it, and can it be obtained without damaging the marriage?
11. Would ending the marriage produce the understanding I want, or would it produce a different set of difficulties?
12. What would the consequences be, for each child, for the household, and for the man's own circumstances?

The Three Options

Staying, with an external source of support. This is the most common viable answer and it should not be treated as a failure. A man who maintains his marriage, obtains the support he needs elsewhere, and manages the arrangement with honesty and without substituting the external relationship for the marriage has made a legitimate decision, and many men describe it as satisfactory over a long period. The condition attached to it is the maintenance of honesty about the support's existence, and its risk is the competition described in the previous section.

Renegotiating the relationship. This option involves a deliberate change in the terms: the man states what he requires, states what he will supply in return, and proposes the arrangement — the regular conversation, the counselling, the change in the household's division of labour, the reduction of an external obligation. Renegotiation succeeds more often than men expect where the man's request is specific, where he offers a corresponding change, and where the couple obtains help. Chapter 15 addresses the practice in detail, and couple counselling is generally the most effective route where it is available and affordable.

Leaving. This is a legitimate option in cases where the relationship supplies nothing of significance, where the man's attempts have been genuine and repeated, where the partner is unwilling rather than unable, where the arrangement is harming the children, or where the man's health is being damaged. Leaving should be decided on the basis of the full assessment rather than the immediate feeling, should be prepared before it is announced, and should be conducted, where children are involved, with the guidance in Chapters 13 and 17. The chapter does not recommend leaving, and it does not recommend staying at any cost. It recommends a decision that has been examined.

The Most Common Outcome

The most common outcome, in the experience of practitioners, is not any of the three options in pure form. It is a partial improvement: two or three successful conversations, a modest change in the arrangement, a better division of load, and a continuing gap that both parties have acknowledged. Men who expect a complete transformation are frequently disappointed by this outcome and abandon the whole work as a failure. Men who recognise that a marriage may contain a substantial remaining gap and still be worth maintaining are generally the ones who report an improvement five years later.

14.7 Illustrative Case: Twenty-Two Years in the Same House

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in couple counselling, family practice, and research on marital communication.

Yusuf is fifty-four, a retired customs officer, married to Rukayat for twenty-two years, with four children, the youngest of whom is nineteen.

Yusuf's account, given in a counselling session that he had entered for an unrelated reason, was that his marriage was stable, that his wife was a good woman, that they had not quarrelled seriously in years, and that he had not spoken to her about anything that mattered to him since the year after their marriage.

The origin, which he identified precisely, was an evening twenty years earlier. He had been passed over for a promotion that he had been promised, and the loss had been substantial: a grade, an increase of about a third in his earnings, and, more

importantly, the position he had been working towards for six years. He came home and told his wife. Her response, which he remembered verbatim, was: *Well, you should have followed up with the man when I told you to. Anyway, it is not the end of the world; my sister's husband has been in the same position for nine years.*

Yusuf's conclusion, formed that evening, was that his wife was not a person to whom difficulties could be taken. His behaviour afterwards was entirely rational: he stopped taking them. Over the next twenty years, he handled each difficulty with the institutions involved, with two colleagues, and, at times, with a brother in Kano who died in 2016. He had no conversation with his wife about his work, his health, the household's finances beyond the practical, or his own state, and the marriage was, by his account, harmonious.

Rukayat's account, obtained separately, contained three pieces of information that Yusuf did not have.

First, she recollected the same evening, and she recollected it differently. She had been in the middle of a difficult period: a miscarriage six weeks earlier that she had not told him about in any depth, a conflict with her mother-in-law that was at its height, and the management of four children under eight in a house with no assistance. Her sister's husband, whom she mentioned, had been unemployed for nine years and the family discussed it constantly. Her remark was, in her description, an attempt to reduce his disappointment by placing it in context, and she had not intended that he should stop speaking to her.

Second, she had noticed. She said: *For the first four or five years, I used to ask him. He would say it is nothing, or it is well. After a while I thought, this is the kind of man he is, he does not talk. I thought I had married a quiet man. I did not know that he had decided something about me. I thought it was his character.*

Third, she had her own arrangement of silence, and it had been established earlier than his. She had never told him about the miscarriage in full, because when she began to speak of it he had said that such things happen and that they should be grateful for the children they had. She had, for eleven years, managed a condition for which she was receiving treatment at a private clinic, which he did not know about. And she had, for the previous six years, been managing the household's finances with less money than she had reported, covering the difference from her tailoring work, because she did not want him to feel that the retirement was insufficient.

The intervention, in the session, took an unusual form. The counsellor asked each of them, in the other's presence, to describe the last time they had wanted to say something to the other and had not, and what they had feared. Yusuf described a medical test in the previous year whose result he had waited for alone for eleven days. Rukayat described a request from her sister for assistance that she had refused without consulting him and then concealed. Neither had any difficulty describing the material. The difficulty, in both cases, was the sentence each had formed about the other, twenty years and four years ago respectively, and neither had ever said it aloud.

> The outcome over the following two years was specific and limited. They began a weekly conversation, on Sunday evening, of about an hour's length, and it was not about household logistics, which had filled their conversations previously. Yusuf attended two of Rukayat's clinic appointments. Rukayat ceased the concealment of the household's finances, which required a difficult conversation in which the six-year shortfall was disclosed and, eventually, understood as an act that had been intended protectively and had caused injury. And in the second year, Yusuf told her four things about his years at the customs service that he had never told anybody. His assessment at the end of the process was: *I lost twenty years to one sentence, and she did not say it to me to make me stop. I have been carrying a conclusion about a person who was in the room, and I never tested it. What I have, now, is not a new marriage. It is the same marriage with the door open.*

Six features of this case deserve isolation.

The conclusion was formed from one exchange. A single remark, made under the specific conditions of a bad evening in a difficult period, formed a conclusion that governed twenty years. This is the most common mechanism of the condition described in this chapter, and it is worth stating plainly: men frequently base a twenty-year decision about their marriages on one conversation.

The remark was not intended to close the subject. Rukayat's remark was an attempt at comfort, addressed partly to her own difficulty, and delivered in a form that carried additional meanings for the man. Both parties were operating on incomplete information; neither was acting in bad faith.

The wife had noticed and had formed her own conclusion. Her conclusion — *I thought I had married a quiet man* — is the crucial piece of information, because it demonstrates that she had interpreted his silence as character rather than as a decision about her. Men consistently assume that their withdrawal communicates rejection; it is frequently read as personality, which means the message men intend to convey is not the message received.

Her silence predated his. The miscarriage, the treatment, and the household's financial management were all undisclosed, and the first of them had been closed by an inadequate response from Yusuf. The case is therefore not one of a silent man and an available woman; it is one of two people who had each attempted disclosure and had each been met with a response that ended the practice.

The intervention was a single structured question. The counsellor's question — the last time you wanted to say something and did not, and what did you fear — produced material that neither party had concealed deliberately and that neither had ever been asked for. The format is worth noting: it required no diagnosis, no interpretation, and no emotional performance.

The recovery was partial and practical. A weekly arrangement, two clinic appointments, the correction of a concealment, and four disclosures over two years. The marriage continued to contain a gap, by the man's own account. What changed was that the gap contained a known position rather than an untested conclusion.

14.8 Practical Exercise: The Disclosure Plan and the Two-Chair Conversation

This exercise has four parts. Parts One and Two are completed alone; Part Three is completed with the partner; Part Four is a maintenance arrangement.

Part One: The Conclusion I Formed

Write out, in one sentence, the conclusion you formed about your partner's willingness or capacity to hear you — for example: *she is not interested in anything that is not about the household; she has enough of her own problems; if I tell her, it will become an argument.*

Then answer four questions about it.

- When, precisely, did I form this conclusion, and what happened in that conversation?
- What did she actually say, in her own words, and what did I understand her to mean?
- What have I tested since? If the answer is nothing, say so.
- What would have to happen for me to revise the conclusion?

Part Two: The Record

Write out the material that has gone undisclosed, as a list. Do not write the content; write the subject and its duration: *my work situation, four years; my health, one year; the loan I took, eight months; my father's illness, two years; how I feel about this marriage, nine years.*

The list is usually longer than the man expects, and producing it is frequently the point at which the work becomes urgent.

Part Three: The Structured Conversation

Choose one item from the list. One. Apply the four conditions: purpose, time, quantity, form. Then write four sentences and say them.

1. **The opening.** The factual, present-tense statement of the situation.
2. **The material.** What happened, what you did, where you are. Two minutes, no more.
3. **The request.** One specific and modest thing you are asking for.
4. **The reciprocal question.** Ask what she is carrying that you do not know about, and listen without responding defensively.

Then hold the conversation, at the arranged time, in the arranged place. Record afterwards: what was said, how it was received, what was requested, and what will happen next.

Part Four: The Arrangement

Establish a recurring occasion — weekly, fortnightly, or monthly — for the conversation, at which the following four questions are asked in the same order each time:

- How are you? (asked of the other person first)
- What is the hardest thing about your week?
- Is there anything I have done that has made it worse?
- What do you need from me in the coming week?

Men who adopt an arrangement of this kind report that the structure does most of the work, because it removes the requirement to initiate at a moment of difficulty, which is precisely the moment at which a man in this situation is least able to speak.

14.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I have tried. She is not interested. Is it my fault?"

The attempt and the failure are separate. The relevant questions are how many genuine attempts were made and in what form: a scheduled conversation limited to one subject, with a specific request, is a different attempt from three sentences offered at the end of a bad day. Where genuine attempts have been made repeatedly and the response has been consistently dismissive, the situation is a finding about the relationship rather than a defect in the man, and Section 14.6 applies.

"If I tell her everything, will she use it against me later?"

Some will, and this is a legitimate risk, particularly where previous disclosures have been used in arguments. The mitigation is graduated: begin with material that is factual and verifiable, such as a medical result or a financial position, rather than with material that is interpretive and vulnerable. Where factual material is handled well, proceed; where it is not, the information is valuable and the decision about the marriage is now better informed.

"She says I never talk to her, and she is right. Where do I begin?"

With one subject, at a scheduled time, using the structure in the exercise. Men in this position frequently ask for a general solution when the effective intervention is one conversation. Note also the implication of her complaint: a wife who says that her husband never talks to her has not concluded that he is uninterested in her; she has concluded that he does not trust her. That is a different problem, and it is more tractable.

"Can counselling help if she will not attend?"

Yes. Individual work addresses the man's own contribution, his interpretation of the relationship, and his options. It is less effective than couple work for the relationship itself, and it is frequently the route by which a man obtains sufficient clarity to make a decision or to reopen the conversation. Where a partner declines counselling and the marriage is in difficulty, individual counselling remains worthwhile.

"Am I expecting too much from a marriage?"

The honest answer is that expectations vary and that a man's need for one person who knows his situation is not excessive. It is worth distinguishing three things: understanding, which most marriages can supply in some measure; agreement, which they frequently cannot; and emotional labour, which may need to be obtained externally where the partner's capacity is exhausted. Men frequently confuse the three, and the confusion turns a reasonable request into an unreasonable demand.

"What if she understands, but I still cannot speak?"

Then the difficulty is on the man's side, and it is the subject of Chapters 3, 4, and 35. Men in this position frequently have a partner who has been waiting for years; the obstacle is the vocabulary and the prohibition rather than the relationship. The practical route is the structured conversation in the exercise, conducted with the understanding that the first attempt will be clumsy, and that clumsiness is not disqualifying.

"Should my wife know that I am in counselling?"

Yes, at the level of fact. The content is confidential; the existence of the support is a matter that concerns the marriage. A man who conceals the existence of counselling, particularly where it involves a regular meeting with another person, is creating exactly the ambiguity that damages relationships. The sentence is simple: *I have started speaking to somebody about what I have been carrying, and I will tell you what comes out of it that concerns you.*

Further Reading

- **On marital communication and its effects:** the substantial research literature on communication patterns in marriage, including the observation studies that identify the specific behaviours distinguishing stable from distressed couples, and the findings on withdrawal and the demand-withdraw pattern in which one partner pursues conversation and the other retreats from it.
- **On gender differences in disclosure:** research on the differences in disclosure between men and women, on the socialisation of male emotional inexpressiveness, and on the specific finding that men's emotional disclosure

is frequently inhibited by the anticipated response rather than by the absence of material to disclose.

- **On couple therapy:** the standard literature on the methods of couple therapy, including the behavioural approaches, the emotion-focused approaches, and the evidence on their effectiveness, together with realistic guidance on what couple work can and cannot change.
- **On the effects of marriage on men's health:** the extensive literature on marriage and men's physical and mental health, including the findings on the health advantages of a confiding relationship and the elevated risks associated with isolation within a marriage.
- **On support in later life:** research on social support in mid-life and later life, including the findings on men's reliance on a spouse as their sole confidant and the vulnerabilities this creates when the spouse dies, becomes ill, or is unable to provide support.
- **Practical resources:** couple counselling services, including those offered at subsidised rates through community and institutional providers; structured communication programmes designed for couples; and the material in Appendix H on the couple's conversation and in Chapter 15 on marriage as a mutual arrangement.

15 CHAPTER

The Silent Battles of Marriage

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the hidden struggles that occur inside marriage, and identify those that are specific to men in long-term relationships.
2. Analyse the mechanisms by which a marriage becomes silent, including the role of accumulated grievance, avoidance, and the exchange of small decisions.
3. Identify the causes of marital dissatisfaction and distinguish between the dissatisfaction that can be repaired and that which cannot.
4. Apply a communication framework for serious disagreements, including the rules of engagement that prevent an ordinary conflict from producing permanent damage.
5. Assess the role of responsibility and sacrifice in a marriage, and identify the point at which sacrifice becomes injurious to both parties.
6. Recognise when professional help is required and evaluate the specific options, including counselling, structured programmes, and separation where appropriate.

Introduction

The battles in a marriage are not, for the most part, the battles that are visible. Visible conflicts — the argument about money, the disagreement about a child's school, the dispute about a relative's visit — are the occasions on which an underlying conflict becomes audible. The underlying conflict is usually older, less specific, and rarely named at all. It is a difference about what the marriage is for.

This is why so many men report that they do not understand what the problem is. They address the visible occasions one after another, competently and in good faith, and the marriage becomes no easier. They conclude that their wives are difficult, or that they themselves are inadequate, or that marriage is like this. What they have not identified is that the argument about the school fees was never about the school fees, and that no settlement of the school fees will end it.

The purpose of this chapter is to make the invisible conflict visible, and then to set out what can be done about it. Its approach is deliberately practical. It addresses five subjects: the hidden struggles that men carry inside marriage without disclosing; the mechanism by which a marriage becomes silent; the causes of dissatisfaction and their classification; the practical rules for conducting serious disagreement; and the question of sacrifice — specifically, how to tell the difference between the sacrifice that sustains a marriage and the sacrifice that quietly destroys one of its parties.

One general observation should be made at the outset, and it applies throughout. Most of what damages a marriage is not conflict. It is accumulation. A single disagreement about a mother's visit is a difficulty; the same disagreement occurring in the same unpromising form for eleven years is a structural feature of the relationship. What men and women describe when they finally speak to a counsellor is rarely a recent event; it is an account of a pattern, and the pattern's defining property is that it repeated.

15.1 Silent Struggles Inside Marriage

Seven specific struggles are carried inside marriages without being raised. Each is described below with the signs that indicate its presence.

The Struggle Over Priority

The most common and the least discussed. A man is required to distribute himself between his wife, his children, his parents, his siblings, his work, and, in some cases, his community. He performs the distribution on the basis of obligation, and his wife assesses it on the basis of priority. Where the two assessments differ, the disagreement is rarely about any single instance. It is about the answer to a question that neither party asks: **who comes first?**

The signs: recurrent disputes about time; the wife's references to specific past occasions; the man's sense of being unappreciated despite substantial effort; the presence of a mother-in-law or sibling-in-law in every disagreement; and the wife's statement, delivered in one form or another, that she is not important to him.

The man's position in this struggle is genuinely difficult, because in many cultural settings the requirements are not parallel. Assistance to parents and siblings is frequently a moral obligation whose neglect carries public consequences, while attention to a wife is a private matter whose neglect carries none. A man who manages the public obligation correctly and the private one poorly is behaving rationally in the terms of his environment, and is producing a marriage in which his wife concludes, accurately, that she is not a priority. The resolution is not to abandon the obligations, and it is not to instruct the wife to accept less. It is to make the priority visible and specific, as Section 15.4 describes.

The Struggle With Desire

Men and women frequently differ in the quantity, form, and meaning of sexual desire, and the difference is frequently managed rather than discussed. Its effects, when unmanaged, are recognisable: a prolonged reduction in physical intimacy; approaches that are declined and are then not repeated; resentment that is never expressed; the use of the television or separate bedtimes as an arrangement that avoids the possibility; and, in some marriages, a settled and jointly maintained fiction that the subject is unimportant.

Men rarely raise this subject directly, and there are three reasons: the fear that the request will confirm a pattern of rejection; the belief that raising it will produce compliance without desire, which is a worse outcome than the present one; and the absence of language for discussing the subject that is neither a complaint nor a demand. Chapter 21 addresses the subject specifically, including the marital difficulties that arise from sexual function problems that men conceal rather than treat.

The Struggle Over Money and Standing

Chapter 9 established that men conceal financial hardship. In marriage, a second dimension is added: the assessment of what the household's money should be used for. Four recurring conflicts are identifiable.

Between obligation and provision. Whether available funds should be directed to extended family obligations or retained for the household's own security and standard. This is the single most common financial conflict in the marriages described in this book.

Between the present and the future. Whether the household should consume at the present level, which is frequently demanded by the environment, or save against a future that is not visible.

Between control and participation. Who decides, and how the decision is arrived at. Where one party decides and the other implements, the implementation is frequently accompanied by concealment and the concealment by a slow erosion of trust, in the pattern described in Chapter 9.

Between provision and presence. Where increased income requires absence, the household must choose, and the choice is frequently made by the man alone in the form of additional work, and evaluated by his wife on the basis of the absence rather than the income.

The Struggle With Self-Worth Inside the Home

A specific and painful struggle, reported by men with some frequency: the man is assessed at home by a standard that differs from the one applying at work, and he is frequently found wanting. A man who has a position of respect in his workplace is a man whose household knows his failures, his irritability, his unavailability, and

his difficulty in the specific matters that arise at home. The home is the one setting in which his professional standing is irrelevant.

The consequences are two, and they are mutually reinforcing: the man is more comfortable at work, where his competence is recognised, than at home, where it is not; and he therefore spends more time at work, which confirms the household's assessment. The arrangement is described in Chapter 12 as one of the personal conditions producing overwork, and it is one of the most reliable findings in the accounts of men who describe their marriages as unhappy.

The Struggle With the Man's Own Family

Where a man's family of origin and his wife are in a settled, low-level conflict, the man occupies an impossible position: he is required to adjudicate, he is required not to adjudicate, and every position he takes is read as a betrayal by one party or the other. Chapter 26 addresses the specific dynamics. Within a marriage, the central difficulty is that the man frequently fails to recognise that his wife's complaint is not that his mother is unpleasant; it is that he does not defend her.

The Struggle With Silence

The battle of Chapter 14, occurring inside a marriage that is otherwise functioning. Its presence is indicated by the following sign, which is diagnostic: **the man and his wife converse competently about logistics and rarely about anything else.** Logistics includes the children, the money, the schedule, the relatives, and the household's operational matters, and it is capable of filling many years. Its sufficiency as a subject is a measure of distance rather than of partnership.

The Struggle With a Diminished Sense of the Marriage's Value

The seventh struggle is not with a subject but with a conclusion. Men in long marriages described as stable by their surroundings frequently carry a private assessment that the marriage has become an arrangement: housing, children, an economic partnership, and a division of labour, conducted efficiently and without anything else. The assessment is usually correct in some part and is frequently a description of a stage rather than of a verdict, since marriages do have periods of reduced intensity and these periods are not necessarily permanent. What distinguishes the men who recover from those who do not is, in the accounts available, whether the assessment was ever examined or simply accepted.

15.2 How Silence Takes Over a Marriage

The mechanism is gradual, and it operates through a series of individually rational decisions. It is worth setting out in sequence, because a man who recognises his own marriage in the sequence is generally able to identify the point at which the change can still be reversed.

Stage One: the small decision not raised. A minor dissatisfaction arises. It is not raised, correctly, because the cost of raising it exceeds its importance. This is normal and necessary; no marriage can process every annoyance.

Stage Two: the small decision not raised because of the last time. A second dissatisfaction arises, and it is not raised for a different reason: the last time something similar was raised, the conversation went badly. This is the point of departure, and it is usually invisible at the time.

Stage Three: the accumulation of unraised items. Over months, a set of unraised matters accumulates. Each is individually small. Together they constitute a position: the man's view of the distribution of time, effort, money, and consideration, which his wife does not hold and which he has not described.

Stage Four: the reinterpretation of behaviour. Because the unraised material is unknown to the wife, she interprets her husband's moods, absences, and irritabilities on the basis of the information available to her, which is incomplete. Her interpretations are frequently wrong, and the interpretations she most commonly supplies are the ones that are most damaging to the relationship, because the possibility that is most accessible to a person who is being treated with distance is the possibility of another person.

Stage Five: the withdrawal of reciprocity. Each partner reduces their investment. The wife stops raising some matters, for the reasons in Chapter 14. The man stops attending to some of the household's emotional requirements. Neither decides to stop; both respond to the reduced environment with reduced output, which is the ordinary logic of any exchange.

Stage Six: the establishment of the arrangement. The couple settles into a functional arrangement containing three properties: it is efficient, it is predictable, and it contains no intimacy. The man is comfortable with it, in the sense that it produces no conflict, and he frequently reports, accurately, that his marriage is peaceful.

Stage Seven: the incident that appears to come from nowhere. Some years later, an event occurs — a disclosure, a discovery, a remark made in public, an ultimatum, the appearance of a third party — that appears to be the beginning of the marriage's difficulty. It is not the beginning. It is the point at which an arrangement established at Stage Two becomes audible.

KEY POINT

The silent battle in a marriage is not the absence of conflict. It is the presence of an unexamined arrangement that has been maintained by the daily decision not to raise matters that are individually too small to raise. The remedy is not confrontation. It is a scheduled arrangement that raises the class of matters rather than the individual items.

15.3 Causes of Marital Dissatisfaction

Men frequently describe their marriages as unsatisfying without being able to identify what is missing, and the vagueness prevents action. The classification below is intended to convert a general dissatisfaction into a specific finding. There are eight causes, and they have different remedies.

1. An unequal distribution of load. One partner is carrying materially more of the household's work, financial management, child care, and emotional labour than the other, and the imbalance is not acknowledged. Its remedies are structural: the division of tasks, the reassignment of responsibilities, the reduction of an external obligation. This cause is the most common and the most tractable, and it is the one whose remedy men most often resist, because it requires the reassignment of obligations the man regards as his own.

2. An absence of intimacy. The absence of conversation, physical affection, and one-to-one time. Its remedy is arrangement rather than disposition: scheduled time, a change in routine, and the removal of the conditions that prevent it.

3. A conflict of priorities. The struggle over priority described in Section 15.1. Its remedy is a written and specific allocation, as described in Section 15.4.

4. A specific and unaddressed injury. An infidelity, a humiliation, a financial concealment, a decision made unilaterally, a failure to attend a significant occasion, an intervention by the man's family. Where an injury of this kind has not been addressed and repaired, it operates as a permanent background condition, and no amount of general improvement will affect it. Its remedy is Chapter 13′s material on betrayal and Chapter 16′s on the repair of injury: acknowledgement, accountability, and time.

5. A difference in temperament or expectation that will not change. Some differences are not problems to be solved. They are features of two people, and they include differences in sociability, in orderliness, in religious observance, in ambition, and in the desired level of family involvement. Its remedy is accommodation: an explicit agreement about how the difference will be managed, rather than a continued attempt to convert the other person.

6. An external strain acting on both parties. Financial difficulty, illness, a bereavement, employment insecurity, a difficult child, a burden from the extended family. Its remedy is the joint management of the strain, which requires it to be named as a shared condition rather than experienced as a private problem by each party, which is what most commonly occurs.

7. An untreated condition in either party. Depression, anxiety, post-traumatic stress, alcohol dependence, a hormonal or medical condition, or a chronic pain condition. This cause is the most frequently missed, and it is the one with the largest specific remedy, because treatment frequently improves the marriage more than any relational intervention could. Chapter 36 addresses men's treat-

ment, and men should consider that their wives' conditions fall under the same principle.

8. An incompatibility at the level of the marriage's purpose. The least tractable of the eight. Two people may have fundamentally different expectations of what a marriage is for — companionship versus dynasty, partnership versus hierarchy, an exclusive unit versus a node in a wider family system. Where such a difference exists, the practical objective is not agreement but an explicit and workable arrangement, and where it cannot be reached, the decision framework in Section 14.6 applies.

The practical use of this classification is direct: a man who has identified the cause can identify the remedy, and a man who has identified neither will continue to address occasions.

15.4 A Communication Framework for Serious Marital Disagreements

This section sets out a method that has been assembled from the practice that appears repeatedly in the marital research literature and in clinical practice. It is written for serious disagreements rather than for daily irritations, and it is set out as rules because rules are easier to follow when the temperature rises.

Before the Conversation

Choose one subject. A single matter, stated in one sentence, agreed in advance. Where a man approaches his wife with a list, the exchange will become a scoring of the list.

Set the conditions. A time when both are available and nobody is tired, hungry, or late for something; a place where children cannot hear; a defined duration of about forty-five minutes; and no audience.

Decide the objective. One of three: to inform, to obtain agreement on a specific change, or to understand her position. Deciding the objective in advance is what prevents a conversation from becoming a general assessment of the marriage.

Prepare one specific proposal. Not a complaint but a proposal: what the man will do, what he is asking the other person to do, and the period in which it will be tried. Proposals are the units in which marriages change.

During the Conversation

Begin with the specific situation and the man's own position. *When my mother came for six weeks in July, I did not ask you whether that was workable, and I should have.*

State the finding rather than the accusation. *We have not had an evening together in about four months* rather than *you never want to spend time with me.*

Ask, and listen to the answer, before defending. *What is it like for you?* followed by silence while the answer is given in full.

Do not introduce the past. The rule is strict: the subject is the present arrangement, and previous incidents may be referenced only where a single example is required. Where the past is admitted in quantity, both parties will leave with their positions confirmed and nothing changed.

Do not score. Statements of the form *I do this and you do that* convert the conversation into an assessment, and assessments produce defence rather than agreement.

Allow the silence. The most important of the rules in practice. Where a point has been made, the agreement to stop talking for a minute or two is what allows the other person to consider it. Men who fill the silence with further evidence are the men who describe their conversations as unproductive.

Ending the Conversation

Agree on one thing. Not a general understanding; one specific change, with a date and a person attached. The observed pattern in successful marital change is a large number of small, specific agreements rather than a small number of general ones.

Agree the review. *We will look at this again in a month.* Reviews convert agreements into arrangements and prevent the drift described in Section 15.2.

Close it deliberately. A sentence, a physical gesture, an ordinary activity together. The ending matters because it establishes that the conversation was a matter between two people rather than a verdict on the relationship.

Record it. A note, kept privately, of the agreement and the review date. Men should note the guidance in Chapter 16 about record-keeping and its risks, and confine the record to the specific agreements.

Rules of Engagement for High-Conflict Moments

When the temperature rises, four rules prevent permanent damage. They should be agreed in advance, in a calm period, as rules rather than as accusations.

1. **No character statements.** The subject is behaviour. *You did not tell me* is admissible; *you are a liar* is not.
2. **No audience, and no third party brought in.** Relatives, children, and friends are not participants, and, in particular, the wife's family and the man's family are not to be used as allies. Where an ally is required, the ally should be a counsellor.
3. **A stopping rule.** Either party may end the conversation by stating the fact rather than by leaving the room: *I am not able to continue this well; let us continue on Thursday.* The rule works only if it may be used without penalty and if the continuation actually occurs.

4. **No irreversible acts.** Decisions made in a conflict — about the household, the money, the children, or the marriage — are provisional. Nothing is implemented for a defined period.

15.5 Responsibility, Sacrifice, and the Point of Injury

Sacrifice is intrinsic to marriage. A married man's life contains a large quantity of work performed for the benefit of other people, and this is generally a source of meaning, not of injury. The question this section addresses is the point at which sacrifice becomes damaging — to the marriage and to the man.

Four Kinds of Sacrifice

Sacrifice that is chosen, understood, and reviewed. A man works additional hours for a defined period to clear a debt, and both parties know the period and the reason. This kind of sacrifice is sustainable and it strengthens the marriage, largely because the requirement is shared.

Sacrifice that is chosen but not disclosed. The man carries something the household does not know about: a debt, an obligation to a relative, a health condition, an ambition, a failure. This sacrifice is the material of Chapter 9, and its effect on a marriage is corrosive in a specific way: the man's contribution becomes invisible, and his becoming unappreciated is the direct consequence of his own decision not to be known.

Sacrifice that is imposed and not negotiated. The requirement arises from the environment rather than from the couple's decision: a parent's illness, a sibling's obligation, the community's expectation, the employer's demand. Where this arrangement persists, the couple's shared life is substantially determined by parties outside it, and resistance is expressed indirectly, in the form of the struggles described in Section 15.1.

Sacrifice that has become an identity. The most dangerous of the four. The man defines himself by what he gives up, and the giving becomes continuous, unmeasured, and increasingly resented. Its features: the man's exhaustion; his sense of being unappreciated; his comparison of himself with other men who "do less"; and the tendency of the household to accept the arrangement as permanent. Its specific consequence is described in Chapter 12, and its marital consequence is that the man holds an unspoken ledger, which produces the pattern of sudden, disproportionate anger described below.

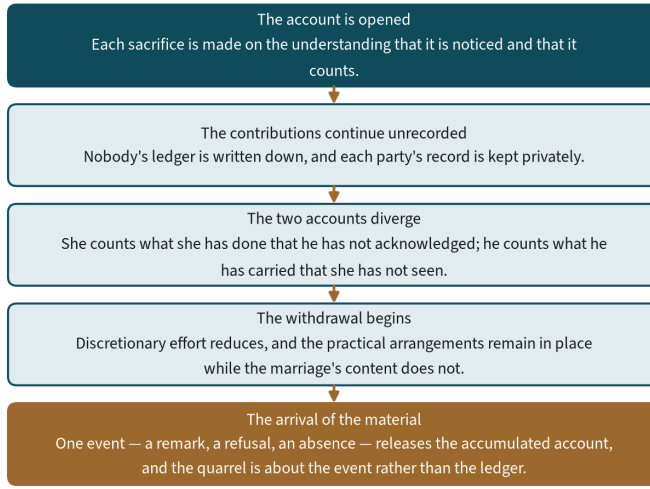
The Unspoken Ledger

This is worth naming separately because it is the most destructive and least understood of the mechanisms in this section. A man who sacrifices without the sacrifice being known, acknowledged, and reviewed begins to accumulate an

internal account: what he has given, what it has cost, and what he has received in return. The account is not disclosed, and it is periodically consulted.

The consequences are recognisable. The man becomes more sensitive to small instances of ingratitude. He becomes disproportionately angry about minor matters, since the response is calibrated to the accumulated balance rather than to the event. And he becomes increasingly isolated, because the material that would correct his account is hidden from the person who holds it.

The remedy is direct and it requires the ledger to be stated: what the man has been carrying, what he has not said about it, and what he would like the arrangement to be. Men consistently report discomfort at the prospect of describing their contributions, on the grounds that a man should not need recognition. The discomfort is worth crossing: the sentence *I have been carrying X for two years and I have not told you, and it is affecting how I behave at home* is the standard and effective form.



The ledger is not a fault in either party. It is what happens when a long arrangement is conducted without either party ever stating its balance.

Figure 15.1 How an unspoken ledger is opened, kept, and finally presented. Neither party is at fault in the opening stages; the account is a product of a long arrangement that was never balanced out loud.

The Test for Injurious Sacrifice

Four questions determine whether a sacrifice has crossed into injury. Where three or more are answered in the affirmative, the arrangement requires attention.

1. **Is it permanent rather than time-limited?** Has a defined period ever been set, and has it been reviewed?

2. **Is it invisible?** Could the man's household state what he has given up in the last two years, in specific terms?
3. **Is it producing resentment?** Does the man find himself keeping account, or reacting to small matters with disproportionate anger?
4. **Is it harming the person making it?** Are there measurable costs: health, sleep, presence, work, sanity, or the capacity to enjoy anything?

Where the answer to question four is affirmative, the guidance in Chapter 12 applies and should be followed before any further relational work is attempted, because a man operating at the point of collapse cannot conduct a difficult marital conversation well.

15.6 When to Seek Help

Men frequently defer marital help for years, and the deferral has a specific cause: the request for help is read, by the man and frequently by his wife, as the beginning of the end. The evidence is more encouraging than the belief. Couples who obtain help early generally do better than couples who obtain it after a decade, and the reason is not mysterious: the accumulation described in Section 15.2 is smaller, and the practice of talking about difficulty has not yet been abandoned.

Indicators That Help Is Required

A single injury of the kind described in item four of Section 15.3 — an infidelity, a financial concealment of significance, a public humiliation, a major unilateral decision. Such injuries do not resolve with time, and the attempt to resolve them without help usually produces the arrangement in which the injury is permanent and unmentionable.

A pattern of the same argument recurring over more than two years. The recurrence is the defining feature: it means that the argument is not about its subject.

Silence of the kind described in Chapter 14, extending beyond a few months. Particularly where the silence is now symmetrical — where neither party raises anything — because symmetrical silence is stable and does not correct itself.

The presence of a condition in either party. Depression, alcohol dependence, anxiety, and trauma conditions affect marriages substantially and directly, and treating the condition frequently improves the marriage more than relational work alone.

Escalation. Increasing frequency, intensifying language, the introduction of children, or the use of relatives as allies.

Any consideration of a third party or of leaving on the part of either spouse. The mention of this subject is frequently treated as a threat and as an ending, and it is more usefully treated as information: it indicates the level of the present difficulty and the urgency of the work.

The involvement of children in the conflict. Where children are being used as messengers, as allies, or as witnesses, the situation requires intervention for their sake independently of the marriage's outcome.

The Options

Couple counselling. The most direct route, and the most effective for communication patterns, mutual understanding, and the negotiation of specific agreements. Its requirements are that both parties attend and that the practitioner is competent and appropriately matched. Its limitations are that it cannot correct a serious individual condition, resolve a fundamental incompatibility, or repair a situation in which one party has already decided to leave.

Individual counselling for the man. Frequently the correct first step, particularly where the man's own state — exhaustion, depression, anger — prevents him from participating in couple work. Its value is that it addresses the man's contribution and his decisions, and it is the route by which a large number of men gain enough clarity either to conduct the conversation properly or to accept the conclusion that the relationship requires a different arrangement.

Individual treatment for the wife's condition. Where the wife is suffering from a treatable condition and is not receiving treatment, this is frequently the single most effective intervention available to the marriage. Raising the subject is difficult and should be done with care, without diagnosis, and with practical support: *I have noticed that you are not sleeping and I am concerned; can I arrange the appointment?*

Structured programmes. Marriage enrichment courses, communication programmes, and group work with other couples. Their advantage is that they present the material as a general practice rather than as a response to failure, which removes the stigma that prevents many couples from obtaining help. Many religious and community organisations offer such programmes, and readers whose framework includes them should note that their effectiveness does not depend on their setting.

Family and community mediation. In settings where extended-family involvement in marital matters is customary, mediation by respected relatives can be effective, particularly for disputes concerning obligations, bride-price matters, and the relationship between the couple and the wider family. Two cautions apply: the mediators should include at least one person acceptable to both parties, and the matters discussed should not include the intimate material whose disclosure in a wide forum is frequently the reason men decline this route.

What Help Requires of the Man

Three requirements are commonly named by men who have obtained help successfully.

Willingness to be examined. The change that marital work requires is frequently on the man's side, and the requirement is not merely to attend. Men who present themselves as participants while treating the sessions as an evaluation of their wives produce no change, and they frequently report that counselling did not work.

Attendance and consistency. Weekly for a defined period, with the specific expectation of about six months for a change of the kind described in this chapter.

Willingness to make one specific change and observe its effect. The evidence from behaviour change applies in relationships as elsewhere: one specific, repeated change produces more than a general intention to be a better husband.

15.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Account

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in couple counselling, family practice, and research on marital conflict.

Adebayo is forty-six, a chartered accountant in Ibadan with a small practice, married to Yemisi for seventeen years, with three children aged fifteen, twelve, and eight.

The case was presented by Adebayo in individual counselling for what he described as anger: for about two years he had been experiencing episodes of intense anger at home in response to small matters. His examples: a question about whether he had eaten; a request to drop a child at a lesson when he was ready to leave; and, on one occasion, his wife's remark that the family had not taken a holiday since the previous year.

The history that emerged was, in outline, a series of entirely ordinary obligations that had accumulated without any of them being disclosed in full. Over seven years, Adebayo had: paid the secondary school fees of his younger brother's two children, after his brother's business failed, which came to approximately a third of his annual income each year for four years; funded the renovation of his mother's house, which he had undertaken under family pressure and which had required a loan he had repaid over three years; provided monthly support to his widowed aunt, at a level established when his income was at its peak and never revised; and absorbed a substantial reduction in his practice's income during a downturn, which he concealed from his wife by reducing his own personal expenditure and increasing his professional borrowing.

None of this had been disclosed. Adebayo's account of why not was consistent and, in his terms, rational: the fees were his brother's children's and could not be refused; his mother's house was a matter of the family's standing, and his wife would have objected on grounds of cost and would have been right to do so; his aunt was a widow; and the practice's difficulties were temporary and he did not want to alarm the household.

Yemisi's experience, which emerged later in a joint session, was of a husband who was increasingly irritable, who had become secretive about his practice, who had refused three family occasions on the grounds of work, and who had responded to a suggestion about a holiday with a remark that she described as contemptuous. Her conclusions, formed over two years and on the basis of the information available to her, were: that her husband no longer wanted to be in the house; that he was possibly involved with somebody else; and that in any case he did not regard her or the children as a priority. She had, in the previous eleven months, reduced her own disclosures to him accordingly.

The intervention had two parts. The first was the disclosure by Adebayo, over two sessions, of the full account: the fees, the renovation, the aunt's support, the practice's finances, and the reason each had been kept separate. The disclosure took him about ninety minutes in total, spread over the two sessions, and it was, in his description, the most difficult thing he had done in twenty years. The second was the removal of the ledger: a written statement, prepared jointly, of the household's obligations — which obligations the household would continue to carry, which would be renegotiated, and which would be concluded and at what date — and a corresponding statement of what would be expected of extended family members, including Adebayo's brother, in future.

Two features of the outcome are worth recording. The first is that Yemisi's response to the disclosure of the school fees was not opposition but anger at the concealment, and her position, once stated, was more generous than Adebayo had assumed: she was willing to continue the fees for one further year to allow the children to complete the level they were in, and then to have the arrangement renegotiated with the brother directly and jointly. The assumption that his wife would have refused, which had governed seven years of concealment, was incorrect, and Adebayo identified this in the session as the most expensive error of the period.

The second is the change in the anger. The episodes diminished substantially within four months, and their disappearance is explained by the mechanism in Section 15.5. The anger had been generated by the ledger — the accumulated, undisclosed account of what Adebayo had given and what he had received — and it had been discharged at the person who held the balance, which was his wife. Once the account was known, its balance could be discussed, and its function as a source of rage ended. Adebayo's summary, eighteen months later, was: *I thought I was protecting the house. What I was actually doing was keeping a private account and sending her the bill.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

Every obligation was legitimate. No element of the arrangement was improper. The fees were for children; the renovation was a family obligation; the widow was a widow; the practice's difficulty was temporary. The damage arose not from the substance of the obligations but from their cumulative, undisclosed character.

The concealment was justified by an assumption about his wife. Adebayo predicted his wife's refusal and acted on the prediction for seven years without testing it. The prediction was wrong, and it is frequently wrong: men consistently overestimate the rigidity of their households' positions on financial obligations and underestimate their objection to being excluded from the decision.

The anger was generated by the ledger. The mechanism in Section 15.5 explains the disproportionate responses: a minor domestic question activated a balance of seven years' standing. Men in this position frequently seek help for anger and are surprised to find that the treatment is a disclosure.

The wife's conclusions were rational on the available information. Irritability, secrecy, the refusal of occasions, and contempt in a single remark are, from outside, entirely consistent with the conclusion she reached. Her withdrawal was not a failure of understanding; it was an accurate response to an incomplete picture.

The remedy was a written joint arrangement. Not an emotional conversation, but a documented statement of obligations with dates attached, which both parties could hold and review. This is the form in which durable marital agreements are made.

15.8 Practical Exercises

Three exercises are set out below. They are ordered by difficulty, and the first should be completed before the second.

Exercise One: The Arrangement Audit

Complete alone, in about forty-five minutes, and in writing.

Part A: The distribution of load. Across two ordinary weeks, record for each of the following: who does it, how many hours it takes, and whether the distribution was ever agreed or has simply evolved.

Area	Who does it	Hours per week	Agreed or evolved?
Household income			
Bill payment and record-keeping			
Food: purchase and preparation			
Children: schooling, appointments, homework, transport			
Cleaning and household maintenance			
Extended-family obligations and communication			
Care of elderly relatives			
Arrangements for visits, ceremonies and travel			

Area	Who does it	Hours per week	Agreed or evolved?
One-to-one time between the couple			

Part B: The unspoken materials. List the matters connected with the marriage that you have never raised or have raised once and abandoned. For each, note whether it is a settled feature of your life or something that is accumulating.

Part C: The ledger. Where you have been keeping an internal account of what you have given, write it out. Be specific and include the dates and the amounts, and include what you believe you have received in return.

Part D: The causes. From the eight causes of dissatisfaction in Section 15.3, mark the two that are most present in your marriage, and write one sentence under each about what the corresponding remedy would require of you.

Exercise Two: The Structured Conversation

This is the exercise in Section 15.4, conducted in full. Choose one subject from Part B of Exercise One, prepare one proposal, arrange the time and place, and hold the conversation. Then complete the record:

- The subject, in one sentence:
- What I said, in my own account:
- What she said, in her own account, as she stated it:
- What was agreed, specifically:
- The review date:
- What I will do differently at the next conversation:

Two notes on the first attempt. It is normal for the first structured conversation to be awkward, and awkwardness is not an indication that the approach is unsuitable. And where the first attempt produces an argument rather than an agreement, the correct response is not abandonment but the application of the stopping rule and the scheduling of the continuation, which is the procedure the framework was designed to protect.

Exercise Three: The Joint Obligation Statement

This exercise is conducted with the partner and takes about two hours. It produces the written arrangement that ended the case in Section 15.7.

Step One. Each party writes out, separately, the complete list of obligations, inside and outside the household: payments, commitments of time, relatives, standing arrangements, debts, and support of any kind.

Step Two. The lists are exchanged and read in full, without comment.

Step Three. Each obligation is classified by joint agreement into one of three groups.

- **Continue:** the obligation stays as it is, and its amount and period are recorded.
- **Renegotiate:** the obligation continues in a reduced form, or in the same form for a defined period, with the change to be requested from the relevant party.
- **Conclude:** the obligation will end, and the date and the method of informing the relevant party are recorded.

Step Four. The statement is written out in one document, in a single page of the agreed items, and both parties keep a copy. It is reviewed at a fixed date, not more than twelve months later.

The purpose of the exercise is not the reduction of the household's obligations, although that is frequently a result. It is the conversion of a set of private arrangements into a shared position, which is what the case in Section 15.7 demonstrates. Where a couple cannot complete the exercise because the obligations are in dispute, the dispute is the finding, and it identifies either the specific matter requiring mediation or the need for professional help.

15.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"We have not had a serious conversation in years. Where do I begin?"

With the smallest possible unit: one subject, one conversation, one agreed change. Men frequently attempt a comprehensive review of the marriage as their first move, and the attempt confirms the conclusion that conversation is impossible. A single subject, a specific proposal, and a defined review date is the correct first step, and its purpose is not to resolve the marriage but to establish the practice.

"Is it possible to fix a marriage after twenty years of this arrangement?"

Improvement is possible and transformation is not usually what occurs. What men report after a year of consistent work is a marriage with a working channel in it: a weekly conversation, a reduction of accumulated grievance, a settlement of the largest unresolved matter, and remaining differences that both parties have acknowledged. On that basis, many men describe their marriages as substantially better, and the standard against which they are judging is not an ideal marriage but the arrangement they had.

"My wife says she wants out. What do I do?"

Take it seriously and do not respond with an attempt to persuade her that she does not mean it. The productive sequence is: obtain an account of what has produced the position, without arguing; decide what you are willing to change and state it specifically; propose counselling, either jointly or individually; and obtain legal advice about your position and your children's, quietly, so that your subsequent decisions are not made in ignorance. Chapter 13 applies where the

marriage ends, and the guidance about conducting the process without damaging the children applies from the first day.

"How do I raise a problem without it becoming a fight?"

By using the framework in Section 15.4, and specifically by following three rules: one subject, a scheduled time, and a proposal rather than a complaint. The rule that men find most effective is the one about beginning with the man's own position, since a statement that is partly against the man's own interest changes the character of the exchange, and it is difficult for the other party to receive it as an attack.

"Should I tell her about the money problems I have kept from her?"

Yes, and it should be done deliberately, with preparation: the full account, in sequence, with the figures, the causes, the steps already taken, and what you are asking for. Chapter 9 and the disclosure plan in Section 9.8 provide the structure. Two cautions: the disclosure should include everything relevant, since a partial disclosure discovered later is more damaging than the original concealment; and it should be delivered at a scheduled time, not during a crisis, and not in a form that requires her to manage your shame as well as the household's finances.

"What if the problem is that I married the wrong person?"

The question is legitimate and it is more useful when made specific. The classification in Section 15.3 allows a man to distinguish a difference in temperament, which can be accommodated; a conflict of priorities, which can be negotiated; an injury, which can be addressed; and an incompatibility at the level of the marriage's purpose, which frequently cannot be resolved. Where the honest finding is the last of these, the decision framework in Section 14.6 applies, and the appropriate next step is individual counselling rather than a decision made alone.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 15 in brief. The battles in a marriage are rarely the visible ones. The visible conflict — about money, a child's school, a relative's visit — is an occasion on which an older and less specific difference becomes audible, and it is usually a difference about what the marriage is for. Most of what damages a marriage is not conflict but accumulation: a pattern that repeats, unexamined, for years.

Seven struggles are carried inside marriages without being raised: the struggle over priority, in which the man distributes himself by obligation and his wife assesses the distribution by priority; the struggle with desire, managed rather than discussed; the struggle over money and standing, with four recurring forms — obligation against provision, present against future, control against participation, and provision against presence; the struggle with self-worth inside the home, where the man's professional standing is irrelevant; the struggle with the man's own family, in which the wife's complaint is usually that she is not defended; the struggle with silence, diagnosed by the fact that the couple converse competently about logistics and rarely

about anything else; and the struggle with the conclusion that the marriage has become an arrangement.

Silence takes over a marriage through seven stages: the small decision not raised; the decision not raised because of the last time; the accumulation of unraised items; the reinterpretation of the man's behaviour on incomplete information; the withdrawal of reciprocity by both parties; the establishment of an efficient, predictable arrangement containing no intimacy; and, years later, the incident that appears to come from nowhere.

Marital dissatisfaction has eight causes with different remedies: unequal distribution of load; absence of intimacy; conflict of priorities; a specific unaddressed injury; a temperamental difference that will not change; an external strain acting on both parties; an untreated condition in either party; and an incompatibility at the level of the marriage's purpose. Naming the cause identifies the remedy; men who name neither continue to address occasions.

Serious disagreement is conducted using four preparations (one subject, set conditions, a decided objective, one specific proposal), six rules during the conversation (begin with your own position, state findings rather than accusations, ask before defending, do not introduce the past, do not score, allow the silence), three endings (agree one thing, agree the review, close deliberately), and four rules of engagement for high-conflict moments (no character statements, no audience, a stopping rule, no irreversible acts).

Sacrifice is intrinsic to marriage and becomes injurious in four forms, of which the most destructive is sacrifice that has become an identity. The unspoken ledger — an internal account of what has been given and not acknowledged — produces disproportionate anger and progressive isolation, and its remedy is to state the account. Four questions test whether a sacrifice has crossed into injury, and an affirmative answer on three or more requires attention.

Help should be sought at defined indicators rather than at the point of collapse: a single significant injury, the same argument recurring for more than two years, symmetrical silence, an untreated condition, escalation, the involvement of children, or any consideration of a third party or of leaving. The available routes are couple counselling, individual counselling, treatment of an individual condition, structured programmes, and family or community mediation, each with its own indications and limits.

Reflection Questions

1. From the seven silent struggles in Section 15.1, which is present in your marriage? Which one have you never named, even to yourself?
2. Where in the seven stages of Section 15.2 is your marriage now? What was the decision you did not raise that started the sequence, if you can identify it?

3. Complete Exercise One, Part A. Was the distribution of load ever agreed, or has it evolved? Which single item would make the most difference if it were reassigned?
4. From the eight causes in Section 15.3, which two are present in your marriage, and what does the corresponding remedy require of you specifically?
5. Have you been keeping an internal account — a ledger of what you have given and not been acknowledged for? Write out the balance, then answer: what would it cost you to state it aloud?
6. Applying the four questions in Section 15.5, has any sacrifice of yours crossed into injury? If three or more answers are affirmative, what will you do this month?
7. Which of the indicators in Section 15.6 applies to your marriage, if any? What is the specific step you will take, and by what date?

Further Reading

- **On the empirical study of marriage:** the major longitudinal research programmes on marriage and its stability, including the observation studies that identify the specific communication behaviours distinguishing marriages that endure from those that end, and the findings on the predictive value of how couples handle disagreement.
- **On the demand-withdraw pattern:** the research on the common pattern in which one partner seeks discussion and the other withdraws, including the findings on its association with marital dissatisfaction and its resolution.
- **On the effects of financial arrangements within marriage:** the literature on money management, concealed expenditure, and financial decision-making within couples, including research indicating that separate and concealed financial arrangements are associated with reduced marital satisfaction.
- **On couples and illness:** the substantial literature on how individual mental and physical health conditions affect marital satisfaction and stability, and how treatment of the individual condition improves the marriage.
- **Practical resources:** couple counselling services, including subsidised and community-based providers; structured marriage enrichment and communication programmes; mediation services for couples; and legal advice, which should be obtained early — before decisions are made — where separation is under consideration, so that the man's position, and his children's, is known rather than assumed.

16 CHAPTER

The Pain of Rejection and Betrayal

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Identify the many forms that rejection takes in a man's life, including those outside the romantic domain, and describe the specific features of each.
2. Explain the psychological mechanisms by which rejection damages a man's self-assessment and behaviour, including the phenomenon of social pain, the rise of rejection sensitivity, and the two opposing responses of withdrawal and aggression.
3. Analyse the anatomy of betrayal, including the distinction between the injury inflicted and the deception that surrounded it, and the effect of the number of people who knew.
4. Describe the pain of being misjudged, falsely accused, or publicly discredited, and the specific problem of restoring a standing that has been taken without a hearing.
5. Apply a structured recovery method covering the acute period, the reconstruction of the account, the restoration of standing, and the role of forgiveness understood as an internal decision rather than a reconciliation.
6. Rebuild the capacity to trust selectively, using the assessment and plan at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

Chapter 13 examined the end of a relationship, and it included the rejection and the betrayal that frequently accompany it. This chapter treats rejection and betrayal as subjects in their own right, because they occur in every other domain of a man's life and because their effects there are less well understood and less discussed.

The two experiences are related and distinct. **Rejection** is a decision by a person or a group that the man is not to be included: not selected, not admitted, not consulted, not invited, not retained. **Betrayal** is a violation of an agreed or assumed trust by a person who was inside it: a friend who uses what he was told, a

partner in business who transfers the assets, a relative who petitions against him, a colleague who takes credit and removes him, an association that spends the money and constructs a story.

Both produce pain that is frequently invisible and that is frequently carried for entire decades. Both are poorly handled by men, for a reason that this chapter will make explicit: the standard male response to rejection is to withdraw, and the standard male response to betrayal is to withdraw and become hard, and both of these responses preserve the injury rather than resolve it.

A note on scale is necessary before proceeding. Rejection and betrayal are not equivalent experiences across their forms, and the reader should not treat them as such. A man who is not invited to a meeting is not in the same position as a man who is falsely accused and cut off from a community of forty years. This chapter distinguishes the incidental, which is ordinary and requires no intervention, from the substantial, which requires work. The distinction is important because men who have been taught to dismiss all such matters as unimportant frequently fail to notice that a substantial injury has been sustained, and because a man who treats every minor rejection as though it were a betrayal will exhaust himself and the people around him.

16.1 The Many Faces of Rejection

The romantic rejection examined in Chapter 13 is the form most discussed. The following are equally consequential and far less often named.

Rejection by Family

Forms: the parent who favours another child and does so visibly over decades; the family that decides collectively on a matter affecting the man without consulting him; the exclusion from a family's decision-making despite his contribution; the withdrawal of a family's recognition in a dispute; the family that receives his assistance and does not record it. In customary settings, where extended-family decisions determine property, marriages, and obligations, exclusion from family decisions is a substantial loss of standing and of practical interest.

The particular feature of familial rejection is that it cannot be repaired by replacement. A friend can be replaced and a community can be joined; a family of origin cannot. A man who is rejected by his family therefore carries a permanent structural feature, which is the reason that familial rejection produces, in men's accounts, a distinguishing and durable grief.

Rejection by Peers and by a Group of Men

Forms: exclusion from a group of colleagues or contemporaries; the loss of a place in a circle through which the man obtained his standing; exclusion from an

association, a cooperative society, a professional body, or a development union; being spoken about in a group and not defended by those present.

The effect on men of exclusion from a group is frequently more severe than the effect of exclusion from an individual relationship, because men's social lives are frequently organised around groups, and because a group's exclusion is public, which is to say that it is known to everybody. The research on ostracism is consistent on this point: exclusion from a group produces measurable pain, a reduction in the sense of belonging, and, in the period immediately following, a reduced capacity for considered reasoning.

Rejection in Work and Profession

Forms: a promotion or appointment given to another, particularly where the man was led to expect it; exclusion from a project, a contract, or a role; dismissal, including dismissal that is treated as routine; a scholarly or professional setback; a business partnership's dissolution with the man's contribution unacknowledged; the refusal of a loan, a grant, or an opportunity for which he was qualified; being passed over repeatedly for a reason that is never provided.

Two features of occupational rejection make it particularly damaging. It is frequently unexplained — the reason is never given, and the absence of a reason invites the man to supply one, which is usually about himself. And it is frequently communicated publicly or semi-publicly: the appointment is announced, the dismissal is known, and other people's reaction to the man's position becomes a continuing source of the injury.

Rejection by One's Own Children

A form that is among the most painful and the least discussed. Forms: estrangement after a separation or divorce; a child's preference for the other parent; the adult child who reduces contact; the child who adopts an accusation made by others; the child who communicates only when something is required. For men whose paternal identity is central — which, on the evidence in Chapter 17, is the majority of men — this is a specific and serious injury, and its management requires the material in Chapters 17 and 24.

Rejection by a Community or a Public

Forms: the destruction of a professional reputation; exclusion from a community after an accusation, a scandal, or a failure; the loss of the standing obtained over decades through a single event; being the subject of a settlement or a story that continues to circulate.

Where a man is rejected by a community, the practical consequences are extensive: social relationships, business opportunities, marriage prospects for his children, and access to informal credit and support all depend on standing.

Self-Rejection

The final form, and the mechanism by which the others become durable. A man who has been rejected repeatedly begins to anticipate rejection, to read neutral events as rejections, and to act on the reading, which is the process described in the next section. The subjective experience is that the world has rejected him; the more accurate description is frequently that the anticipation has begun to do the rejecting, and this is the part of the process over which a man has some influence.

16.2 What Rejection Does to a Man's Mind

Six mechanisms operate, and understanding them is what allows the effects to be recognised and reduced.

Social Pain

Research into the neuroscience of social rejection indicates that exclusion and being evaluated negatively activate regions of the brain also involved in physical pain, and that the experience is not a metaphor. Two practical consequences follow: the pain is genuine and should be treated as such rather than dismissed as an overreaction; and the ordinary methods of managing physical pain — rest, support, time, and the avoidance of further injury during the acute phase — apply.

The Rapid Loss of Belonging, Self-Esteem, Control, and Meaning

A consistent finding in the experimental research on ostracism is that exclusion produces an immediate drop across four dimensions at once: the sense of belonging, self-esteem, the sense of control over one's situation, and the sense of a meaningful existence. This accounts for the severity of the experience: it is not a single injury but a simultaneous reduction across four of the five or six things that a man relies on to feel that his life is working. The same research indicates that the effects attenuate with time and support, and that the most effective intervention in the acute phase is the re-establishment of one or more of the four dimensions by other means: one relationship in which the man belongs, one activity in which he can act effectively, one contribution that is meaningful.

Self-Blame and the Search for the Defect

Men respond to rejection by examining themselves for the cause, and the examination is conducted with the standards described in Chapter 8. The typical content: a specific defect, usually in the man's character or worth; a generalisation from this instance to a pattern; and a discounting of the evidence that contradicts it. This is the mechanism by which an event becomes an identity.

Rejection Sensitivity

Where a man has experienced repeated rejection, he develops a heightened readiness to detect it: ambiguous signals are read as rejection, neutral remarks are scanned for exclusion, and an expectation is established in advance. This produces

two observable patterns, both of which are recognisable to the men themselves once they are named.

Accommodation. Excessive effort to secure inclusion: agreeing with everything, giving to the point of injury, apologising before anything has occurred, and remaining in arrangements that are damaging in order to retain a place.

Anticipatory withdrawal. Leaving before being refused: declining invitations, removing oneself from contention, ending contact, and describing the position as choice rather than as protection.

The Two Opposing Responses

The research on rejection identifies two effects that appear contradictory and are both present, depending on circumstance: the tendency to withdraw, and the tendency to aggression. Withdrawal protects against further injury and increases isolation. Aggression — irritability, hostility, an eagerness for confrontation — restores a sense of control and produces precisely the responses that confirm the man's expectation of exclusion. The two responses alternate in the same man, frequently over the same period, and each produces the outcome the other is designed to prevent.

Rumination

The final mechanism is the most difficult to interrupt and the most responsible for the durability of the injury: the repeated mental review of what occurred, what was said, what should have been said, and what the man should have done. Rumination has two properties that make it particularly adhesive: it feels like problem-solving, which makes it difficult to abandon, and it produces a fresh experience of the injury each time it occurs, which prevents the attenuation that would otherwise take place.

The practical interruption is not the instruction to stop thinking about it, which does not work. It is the two-part method used for the internal critic in Chapter 8: an appointment with the material (a defined period each day in which it may be considered, and no other time), and the conversion of the material into a specific item — one written conclusion, one action, or one question that requires an answer from a person rather than from the mind.

16.3 Betrayal: When Trust Is Broken

Betrayal differs from rejection in its structure, and the difference explains why betrayal is frequently more difficult to recover from.

The Anatomy of a Betrayal

Four elements compose the experience, and the second and third are the ones that cause the greatest and most durable damage.

The act. What was done: the money taken, the confidence disclosed, the relationship conducted, the decision made against the man's interest, the accusation made, the support withdrawn at a moment of need.

The concealment. The act was accompanied by its management: the lie, the omission, the story, the inclusion of others in the silence. This is the element that most distinguishes betrayal from ordinary injury. An opponent who damages a man openly has not betrayed him. A person who damages him and then presents a false account has done something to the man's relationship with reality.

The participation of others. Where other people knew and did not tell him, the injury extends beyond the individual. Men describe this element with particular pain: the discovery that three people knew, that one of them was a relative, that the knowledge continued for months, and that the man was conducting his life on a false account while a group of people watched.

The moment of discovery. A man's experience of betrayal is organised around the moment he learned of it. Its form matters: the accidental discovery that produced everything at once; the gradual accumulation of inconsistencies; the third party's disclosure; the confrontation with the person and their partial admission. Men report that the moment of discovery is as vivid, years later, as the event itself, and that its details are retained permanently. This is why disclosure is frequently experienced as worse than the underlying act, and it is the reason that Chapter 9′s insistence on early, complete disclosure is not merely ethical advice but practical protection of the relationship's future.

The Forms Betrayal Takes in a Man's Life

By a friend. The disclosure of a confidence; the pursuit of the man's partner or the man's opportunity; the taking of a loan or an asset with no intention of returning it; the failure to defend him when a defence was expected; the use of private information in an advantage.

By a relative. The diversion of family property or resources; the obstruction of an inheritance or a business; an accusation made to the family that damages the man's standing; the refusal of assistance after having received it; the pursuit of a relationship that injures the man's household; the alliance against him with his own family's council.

By a business partner or colleague. The transfer of assets or clients; the double contract; the misrepresentation of the man's contribution; the removal of the man from the enterprise he built; the taking of credit; the sabotage of a contract; the falsification of accounts.

By an institution. An employer who undertakes a commitment and abandons it; an association or cooperative that manages the members' funds for private purposes; an organisation that dismisses a long-serving member without process.

By the community or by those who were thought to be supporters. The spreading of a version of events that the man cannot correct; the withdrawal of support at the moment of a man's difficulty, frequently by the very people who received his support; the public judgment of a matter in which the man was not heard.

By a partner. The forms and treatment are in Chapter 13 and Chapter 15, and the material in this section applies with the addition of an ongoing legal and parental dimension.

The Four Injuries

Betrayal produces four distinct injuries, and it is useful to separate them because the treatment differs.

The material injury. What was lost: money, an asset, a position, an opportunity. This injury is addressable, at least in part, by recovery, by legal action, and by rebuilding. Its treatment is practical.

The relational injury. The loss of one relationship and the alteration of others. This is where the number of people who knew becomes significant, and where the man's response determines whether a single relationship is lost or a network is.

The injury to the man's model of reality. The most severe. The injured man's assumptions about other people have been shown to be false, which means his ability to assess who is reliable, who is safe, and who is truthful has been demonstrated to be inadequate. The consequence is a general loss of confidence in his own judgement about people, and the hypervigilance that follows: reading every conversation twice, keeping track of who has been told what, and never fully relying on anybody. Men in this state describe themselves as having become cynical, and they generally present it as maturity.

The injury to the man's account of himself. Betrayal is frequently accompanied by humiliation: others knew, the man was the last to know, and he was managed. The question that recurs is not *how could he do this?* but *how could I not have seen it?* Men are less damaged by other people's conduct than by their own conclusions about their inability to judge character, and this is the injury that the recovery method in Section 16.5 must address directly.

The Two Destructive Responses

The hardening response. The man decides that trust is a mistake, that people are as they are, that he will from now on deal with others only at a distance and with terms written down. The response has genuine protective value in a business context and produces a permanently reduced capacity for closeness. The men who describe this response frequently also report that they cannot be fully known by anybody, including their wives and children, and that the arrangement is lonely.

The exposure response. The man attempts to correct the record publicly and continuously: the court case, the account circulated to the family, the story retold to every new person, and the perpetual preparation of the defence. This response has a specific cost: it organises the man's life around the injury, and the injury therefore occupies the position the man was trying to remove it from. Men who have pursued a wrong for a decade are frequently right about the wrong and unable to describe what else they have done in the period.

16.4 The Pain of Being Misjudged

This section addresses a specific and particularly damaging form: the man who is judged, accused, or discredited without a hearing, and who finds that the judgment has been accepted before he learned of its existence.

The Forms

The false accusation. An allegation, made to a family, a community, an employer, or an institution, of conduct the man did not commit or of conduct presented without its context. Its features: the absence of a hearing; the frequency with which the accusation comes from within the man's close circle; and the speed with which it can acquire an official character through repetition.

The misread conduct. The man's action was not wrong but was read as wrong without enquiry: the financial assistance withheld from a relative because the man had nothing to give; the withdrawal from an arrangement because he was ill; the silence at a funeral because of grief. The misreading is frequently less damaging in its consequences and equally damaging in its effect, because it cannot be corrected without describing matters the man does not wish to describe.

The inherited judgment. A judgment on the man that was formed from the conduct of somebody else: the judgment of his father; the reputation of a family; an accusation made against a deceased relative and carried forward.

The public failure. A business failure, an insolvency, a professional error, a divorce, a scandal, handled or reported in a public form. The man's own handling of the events may have been scrupulous and the community judgment will frequently ignore the distinction, because a judgment is constructed from the outcome.

The judgment of the man's household. The most painful form for many men: the assessment, carried over years, that he has not done enough, that he is not the provider his wife's family expected, that a brother or a neighbour has done better.

The Specific Features of This Injury

The asymmetry. A man cannot correct an allegation that he cannot see. The accusation circulates in the form of the community's attitude rather than in the

form of a statement, and a man who responds to his impression of other people's attitude is generally described as defensive. The practical consequence: the man frequently learns the full content of the allegation years later, and the interval is a period of damage without information.

The impossibility of proof. The structure of many allegations is such that denial does not address them. An allegation of character — that the man is selfish, that he neglects his family, that he is not a serious person — cannot be disproved, because it has not been articulated as a claim.

The duty to respond. Men are frequently obliged to respond publicly, and the responses available — the counter-accusation, the defence of every item, the withdrawal of participation — are each unsatisfactory. The practitioner's experience is that a small number of the available responses are effective, and they are set out in Section 16.5.

The legal and the social dimensions. Where the judgment carries legal consequences — the insolvency, the criminal or civil allegation — the man must obtain legal advice immediately and separate the legal task from the social one, because the methods are different and because misinformation is common: many men believe that a favourable outcome in the legal matter will restore their standing, and frequently it does not, or not without work.

The Cost to the Man's Own Psychology

Misjudgment produces a specific spiral, which is worth setting out because recognising it allows a man to interrupt it.

1. The judgment circulates.
2. The man becomes aware of a change in behaviour toward him and infers the content of the judgment.
3. He attempts correction, and the attempt is read as confirmation.
4. He experiences shame: the judgment is held by people whose regard he needs.
5. He withdraws.
6. His withdrawal is interpreted as a confirmation of the judgment, since a man with nothing to hide would have nothing to avoid.
7. The judgment becomes established, and the man's isolation becomes its evidence.

Step to interrupt is the fifth, and the means of interrupting it is the deliberate maintenance of normal participation, at whatever level of discomfort, together with a small number of authoritative corrections: the man does not defend himself to the community, he states the position once, factually, to the most credible people, and then continues to be present. This is the most effective single measure, and it is also the one that men most reliably fail to take, because withdrawal is what the injury demands.

16.5 Recovering from Rejection and Betrayal

This section sets out the recovery method. It is organised in phases, because the appropriate intervention differs by phase and because men frequently attempt the material of phase three during phase one, which is the reason that many recoveries fail.

Phase One: The Acute Period (the first days and weeks)

The objectives of this phase are protection and stability, not resolution. Six measures apply.

Stabilise the physical arrangements. Sleep, food, activity, and the household's ordinary functioning. Where the injury involves a household matter, arrange the immediate practical position first: where the man will stay, how the children will be managed, whether money needs to be moved, whether a lawyer should be spoken to. Practical action in the acute phase is useful partly because it reduces the sense of helplessness identified in the ostracism research.

Choose five people and tell no others. The practical rule for the acute period: a small number of reliable people, in preference to a general announcement. Identification of the five matters, because the man's judgement is impaired and because the composition of the group determines the quality of the response: at least one person outside the family; at least one person with whom the matter can be discussed practically; and no person who is likely to become an avenue of circulation.

Do not make irreversible decisions. Resignation, sale of assets, relocation, a new relationship, an investment, a break with the family. The intensity of the acute phase is not a reliable guide to the man's eventual conclusion, and decisions made then are frequently regretted, sometimes years later, and sometimes permanently.

Reduce exposure to the source. Where the source is available on a device, the plan should be explicit: the removal of the application, the removal of the contact, the change of route, the change of the meeting. The measure is practical rather than symbolic, and its effect is measurable.

Arrange for the moments of maximum intensity. The two reliable periods are the night and the hours immediately after the discovery of a new piece of information. What helps: a person who can be called, an activity that can be performed at that hour, and, for the night specifically, the avoidance of alcohol, which is the standard method of prolonging the acute phase.

Obtain professional and legal help immediately where indications are present. Any indication of self-harm, any legal dimension, any threat to the man's safety or his children's, and any indication that the man's functioning has collapsed.

Phase Two: The Reconstruction (weeks to months)

Write the account. The single most useful exercise. The account is written in three sections: what happened, in sequence and factually; what I did, including what I now regard as unwise; and what remains unresolved or unclear. Its purposes are to convert scattered rumination into a document, to identify what is genuinely unknown, and to permit the man to separate what he knows from what he has been constructing.

Establish facts separately from narratives. Two columns: what I know to be true, and what has been constructed. Men find, with consistency, that the quantity of established fact is much smaller than the volume of conclusion already drawn, and, relatedly, that a considerable part of the injury is being sustained by material that is inference rather than fact.

Answer the question about the man's own judgement. The material of the fourth injury in Section 16.3. Two things are required. First, an accurate assessment: what were the actual signals, and were they present and observable at the time, or have they become visible only with hindsight? The distinction is decisive, and men are systematically unfair to themselves on this point, because hindsight converts an ordinary and unremarkable relation of trust into a scene of foolishness. Second, a specific and proportionate change of practice: what precisely will be done differently with new relationships — the documentation, the verification, the discussion with a third person, the timetable of trust.

Reduce the generalisation. The conclusion *I cannot trust anybody* should be converted to a workable form: *I will trust in graduated steps, and I will verify what matters.* This is not cynicism; it is practice, and it has the effect of permitting relationships to be formed without ignoring what was learned.

Convert the rumination. An appointment with the material: thirty minutes a day, written, in which the subject may be considered. Outside that period, the material is not to be engaged with; where it intrudes, it is noted for the appointment. This is the same mechanism as the appointment used for the internal critic in Chapter 8, and it works for the same reason.

Phase Three: Restoration (months to years)

Recover what can be recovered. The material injury should be pursued where it is capable of recovery: the legal route, the request, the negotiation, the retraction. Its value is frequently less in the sum recovered than in the removal of the position from the category of things done to the man and not answered.

Restore standing deliberately. Where standing has been damaged, the restoration requires presence, contribution, and time, in that order. The methods that do not work: the general denial, the campaign of correction, and the withdrawal that proves the allegation's consequence. The methods that do: the

continuation of the man's ordinary participation; the statement of his position, once, factually, to those who matter; a visible record of the man's work over the period that follows, since a repair of the reputation is conducted by the ensuing conduct rather than the previous account; and, where the allegation was made formally, the formal answer — which should be given to the competent body rather than circulated.

Address the humiliation. The element that recovery methods most frequently omit. The man was not only injured but exposed, and the exposure is frequently the more painful and the more persistent element, because it is the part he cannot repair alone; it requires that others resume ordinary conduct toward him, which requires that he be present. The specific work: identify the small number of people whose opinion matters, ensure that they know the facts, and then require nothing further of them. That last step is the difficult one, because the aftermath of humiliation produces a strong demand for acknowledgment, and the demand is frequently the obstacle to the restoration.

Decide about forgiveness. Forgiveness, in the sense this book uses, is an internal decision about the man's own carrying of the injury: the decision to stop the account, to cease the internal prosecution, and to release the debt from the position it occupies. It does not require reconciliation, does not require the restoration of trust, and does not require the continuation of a relationship. It is not a moral obligation imposed by anybody, and it is not necessarily available in the period in which the injury is acute. Its practical value is that it ends the arrangement in which the man's life continues to be organised by the other person's conduct, which is the arrangement described in the exposure response. What it does require is that the man has first taken whatever practical steps are available to him, because forgiveness is not a substitute for legal advice, for the recovery of money, or for a boundary.

Decide about the relationship. Four options, each legitimate: continuation on revised terms; a boundary with continued contact, which is the appropriate form in most family and community situations; estrangement, which is appropriate where contact remains damaging and where the relationship's continuation is avoidable; and formal separation. The choice should be made in phase three rather than phase one, and it should be made on the basis of the assessment rather than the intensity of the feeling.

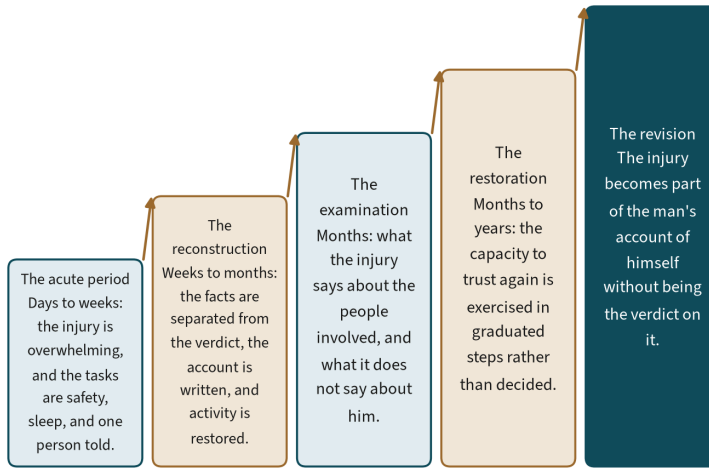


Figure 16.1 The phases of recovery after rejection and betrayal. The phases overlap rather than follow one another strictly, and a return to an earlier phase after a new injury is ordinary.

The Rules of Recovery

Five rules summarise the method.

1. **Phase order matters.** Stability, then reconstruction, then restoration.
2. **Write it.** The material that is written becomes manageable; the material that is carried in thought does not.
3. **Convert every conclusion into a specific item.** A fact, a question, an action, or a decision.
4. **Take the practical steps before the emotional ones.** Legal advice, recovery, boundaries.
5. **Do not construct an identity from the injury.** The most reliable indicator of a recovery that has stalled is a man whose account of himself begins with what was done to him.

16.6 Rebuilding Trust in Yourself and Others

The final substantive section addresses the question that men ask most frequently after a betrayal, and it addresses it as a technical problem rather than a moral one: how is trust rebuilt, in a man who has learned that his trust was misplaced?

Two Distinctions

Trust is not a single quantity. A man who says *I no longer trust anybody* is describing a generalisation that his own behaviour does not fully implement. In practice, men who have been betrayed continue to trust in specific domains —

they trust their driver with the vehicle, the bank with the salary, a colleague with a report — and their difficulty is confined to the domain in which the betrayal occurred and to its closest analogues. Identifying the domain is the first practical step, and it usually reduces the problem from a general condition to a specific one.

Trust is not a decision, it is an accumulation. Men frequently attempt to resolve the matter by deciding to trust again, which fails for the same reason that a decision to trust in the first place would fail: trust is established by experience, in graduated steps, and it is not a setting that can be adjusted by will.

The Graduated Method

The practical method is an escalating sequence of small exposures, conducted deliberately, with a decision point after each.

Step One: identify the domain. In which area did the injury occur — money, confidences, professional cooperation, family loyalty, a relationship? The rebuilding is confined to that domain and does not require the man to alter his conduct in the others.

Step Two: choose low-stakes exposures. Identify people who are appropriate for particular kinds of trust, and begin with items of small value: a small sum, an ordinary confidence, a minor responsibility. Where a person has been reliable in that domain previously, this is the correct place to begin, since the accumulated history is the material from which trust is rebuilt.

Step Three: verify without concealment. Verification is legitimate and should be visible rather than secret. A statement of the form *I am going to ask you to send me the record each month, because of what happened with the previous arrangement* is honest, and it is considerably easier to maintain than covert checking, which produces the man's own dishonesty alongside his injury.

Step Four: record the results as data. A simple written record of the specific exposures and their outcomes, reviewed at intervals. Its function is to correct the mechanism described in Section 16.2, in which any ordinary unavailability is read as evidence and the positive instances are discounted.

Step Five: extend where the results support it, and stop where they do not. The last part is important. Graduated trust does not mean trusting everybody at every level; where the record indicates untrustworthiness in a domain, the correct response is a reduction in exposure, not an increase in vigilance. Men in the aftermath of betrayal frequently continue to deal with the same person, at the same level, and maintain a permanent condition of watchfulness instead. Vigilance is more expensive than a boundary.

The Man's Own Judgement

The fourth injury from Section 16.3 is the injury to the man's confidence in his own judgement. Three measures are specific to it.

Separate the assessment from the outcome. A person who was trusted and proved treacherous does not demonstrate that the assessment was unreasonable; it demonstrates that the person's conduct was concealed, which is the one variable the man cannot observe. The test is the test of information available at the time, and men should apply it honestly: what was observable, and what would a reasonable person in the same position have concluded?

Record the signals that were genuinely present. Not to blame, but to build capacity. The useful output of this measure is a short list of specific features to be more attentive to: the timetable that did not add up, the refusal of documentation, the pattern of other relationships, the treatment of previous partners or associates, the reluctance to be introduced to the person's family.

Introduce one reviewing relationship. A man who has been betrayed should have one person with whom a significant arrangement is discussed before it is entered: a business investment, a loan, a commitment of trust. The purpose is not permission but review, since a second assessment corrects the specific vulnerability — the man's own judgement in a domain where he is interested and therefore partial.

Trust and the Household

Where the man's marriage and children have observed the injury, three measures apply. The man should state what happened at a level appropriate to their age and to their involvement; he should not conduct the recovery as a private operation with the household uninformed, since the household's anxiety, if unexplained, becomes a second injury; and he should avoid the general lesson that bitterness supplies. The most damaging thing a betrayed man can transmit to his sons is the proposition that trust is foolishness. A more accurate and more useful transmission is available: that trust is extended in stages, verified, withdrawn where the evidence requires, and restored where it is earned.

16.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Accused Without a Hearing

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in community affairs, cooperative-society administration, legal practice, and counselling.

Segun is fifty-eight, a retired primary school head teacher, and was for nineteen years the secretary of the development association of his community in Ogun State. He is married with four children, the eldest of whom is a medical doctor in the United Kingdom.

In the fifth year before his retirement, the association undertook the construction of a borehole and a small water project, with a total budget of about eleven million

naira, raised through members' contributions, a grant from the local government, and a donation from a member's business. Segun, as secretary, received the contributions, kept the records, and paid the contractors.

Eighteen months after the project's completion, during a period of dispute over the association's leadership, an allegation appeared in the form of a document circulated to members and submitted to a group of elders: that about 2.4 million naira of the project funds had not been accounted for, and that Segun had been responsible for the receipts.

Three features of what followed determined the case.

First, Segun was not informed before the document circulated. He learned of the allegation from a neighbour who asked him whether it was true, at his gate, on a Saturday morning.

Second, the allegation was framed in a form that could not be answered. The document did not specify a transaction, a date, or a receipt. It stated a total that "could not be accounted for," and requested that Segun respond to the general question, which is precisely the form of allegation described in Section 16.4 as impossible to disprove.

Third, Segun responded in the way that most men respond. He removed himself. He stopped attending the association's meetings, stopped attending the community's functions, and, within two months, stopped attending church services and the weekly market, arranging for his wife to go instead. He described his reasoning as: *What is the point of being there while people look at you? I would rather be absent than be watched.*

Two years were lost. In that period, Segun: applied for and obtained the association's records, twice, and was refused both times on procedural grounds; consulted a lawyer, who advised that the matter had no legal cause of action because no legal proceeding had been initiated against him; lost a rentable property arrangement in the community, which he had intended to develop; and stopped speaking to two members with whom he had been friendly for thirty years. His wife was, in his description, his only confidant, and his withdrawal was interpreted as confirmation: in the words used by two members subsequently, *if the man had nothing to hide, he would have come to the meeting and answered.*

The turn came through his eldest child, who came home for a month in the second year and did three things that Segun described as the reasons for the recovery. She went, with her father, to the association's chairman and obtained the complete file of the project's accounts. She then, with Segun's permission, produced a reconciliation: contributions received, receipted and banked, and the payments made, item by item, against the contractors' invoices and the bank statements. The reconciliation identified the source of the 2.4 million discrepancy: it was the local government grant, which had never been received in full — approximately 2.1 million had been paid in two instalments and 300,000 remained unpaid at the time the accounts were drawn, with the balance still on the donor's ledger — and the project had been com-

pleted at a lower specification in consequence, a decision taken at the association's own meeting, minuted and signed by the chairman.

The third thing she did was the one Segun regarded as decisive, and it involved no document. She told him that his absence was the case against him, and she required him to accompany her to the following general meeting.

Segun attended. He did not make a speech. The chairman, who had by then left the office and been replaced, presented the reconciliation at the meeting, and the matter was recorded as closed. Two of the three principal figures behind the allegation attended the same meeting; one apologised to Segun privately, and one did not.

Segun's account of the recovery, four years after the meeting, identified three changes. He resumed his participation in the association and is currently its treasurer, an office he accepted at the request of the members after a period of refusal. He has not resumed his friendship with the two members who circulated the document, and he described this as a boundary rather than a grievance: *I greet them. I do not work with them and I do not discuss my affairs with them.* And he stated the change in himself in the following terms: *For two years I behaved as though I had been judged. Nobody had judged me. Nobody had even looked at the paper. What I did by staying away was provide the evidence. My daughter made me come back into the room, and in the room it took one meeting.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

Segun learned of the allegation from a neighbour. The absence of a hearing was total: the document circulated, the elders received it, and the man at the centre of it was not informed. This structure — an allegation that acquires standing without the person being heard — is the mechanism of Section 16.4, and it is common in community, family, professional, and employment settings.

The allegation was framed so that it could not be answered. A total without transactions, dates, or documents cannot be refuted by denial, and denial in that form is read as evasion. The only effective answer was the one that eventually worked: a reconciliation of the accounts, item by item, produced from the original records rather than from the man's account.

The withdrawal was the decisive error, and it was entirely rational. Segun's reasoning — that presence meant being watched — is the reasoning that the injury produces, and its consequence was that the association's inference (*if he had nothing to hide he would have come*) became the case's principal evidence. This is the reason the method in Section 16.5 places such emphasis on continuing to be present, and the reason that men find the instruction difficult to accept.

The daughter's intervention was a document and an escort. Two actions: she obtained the records and produced the reconciliation, which supplied the factual answer the allegation had been designed to resist; and she accompanied her father into the room, which supplied the one thing he could not supply alone in

the second year, which was a reason to be present. The pattern recurs throughout this book: practical assistance given by one person, at a specific point, changes a decade-long course.

The boundary was maintained without estrangement. Segun did not resume friendship with the two members who circulated the document, and he did not denounce them, refuse to greet them, or attempt to exclude them from the association. The position — ordinary contact, no cooperation, no discussion of his affairs — is the form of boundary that is sustainable in a community where continued contact is unavoidable, and it is the option identified in Section 16.5 as appropriate in most family and community situations.

16.8 Practical Exercise: The Injury Audit and Recovery Plan

This exercise takes about ninety minutes and is completed in writing. It is intended for a man carrying a rejection or a betrayal of some consequence, whether recent or of long standing.

Part One: The Classified Record

List, briefly, the significant rejections and betrayals you have experienced and not resolved. For each, record four items.

The event	How long ago	Domain	Resolved, carried, or active?

Domains: family, peers or community, work or profession, children, marriage, institutional. Mark each as resolved — meaning concluded, understood, and no longer active in your thinking — carried, or active.

Part Two: The Injury Breakdown

For the single most significant unresolved injury, answer the four questions corresponding to the four injuries in Section 16.3.

1. **Material:** what was lost, in specific and measurable terms?
2. **Relational:** which relationships were lost or altered, and how many people were involved in the knowledge?
3. **Model of reality:** what did this event teach you about how you assess people, and has that assessment changed permanently?
4. **Self-account:** what question about yourself does this injury continue to raise?

Part Three: Phase Assessment

Mark your current phase, with evidence rather than by impression.

- **Acute:** the events are recent; sleep, work, or functioning are disturbed; the material is reviewed involuntarily and frequently.

- **Reconstruction:** the events are understood but not concluded; the material can be discussed without breakdown; the account is still being assembled.
- **Restoration:** the position is clear; the practical steps have been taken or are being taken; the material occupies a defined place rather than the whole.

Where you are in the acute phase, suspend the remainder of the exercise and implement the six measures in Phase One. The rest is done later.

Part Four: The Written Account

Write the account of the injury in three sections and no more than 1,200 words.

- **What happened.** Factual, in sequence, without interpretation.
- **What I did and what I now think of it.** Including conduct you regard as unwise.
- **What is unresolved.** Facts not established, questions without answers, matters requiring a decision.

Part Five: The Facts and the Narrative

Two columns.

What I know to be true	What I have constructed

Then answer: what proportion of my current distress rests on the left hand column, and what proportion on the right?

Part Six: The Recovery Plan

Write specific items with dates in each of the following.

- **Material:** what can be recovered, and by what means? Where legal advice is required, the date by which it will be obtained.
- **Boundary:** with whom, of what kind, stated in one sentence.
- **Presence:** which participation have I withdrawn from, and when will I resume it?
- **Disclosure:** the small number of people who will be told the position, and what they will be told.
- **Verdict:** the conclusion about myself that the injury produced, and the accurate replacement for it.

Part Seven: The Forgiveness Decision

Answer three questions.

1. Am I willing to stop conducting the internal prosecution — the daily review, the rehearsed arguments, the imagined confrontations? If not, what condition would have to be met first?

2. Does the decision to release the account require me to resume the relationship? (The correct answer is that it does not.)
3. What will I do with the time and attention currently occupied by this matter?

16.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I was accused of something I did not do, and people believe it. Should I defend myself publicly?"

State the position once, factually, to the people who matter, and then continue to be present. A campaign of correction sustains the matter in circulation and is read as defensiveness; silence accompanied by withdrawal is read as confirmation, as Segun's case demonstrates. Where the allegation is formal — made to an institution, a professional body, or a legal authority — the answer belongs to that body, in writing, and should not be circulated more widely.

"How long am I supposed to keep greeting somebody who betrayed me?"

The boundary and the greeting are separate matters. Ordinary courtesy can be maintained indefinitely in most community and family settings, at low cost, while cooperation and disclosure are withheld. The practical test is whether the contact is costing you something: where it is, reduce it; where it is a sentence exchanged in the street, it is usually cheaper to sustain than to avoid.

"My own brother did this. How do I continue in the family?"

Three positions are available and each is legitimate: a revised relationship with boundaries and no dependence; ordinary contact without cooperation on the matter in which he failed; and estrangement from that individual while remaining within the family, conducted without explanation to others beyond a single factual statement. What is not workable is a concealed estrangement in which the man continues to appear, contributes, and carries a grievance that nobody knows about — the arrangement described in Section 15.5 as a ledger.

"Is it weakness to admit that this still affects me?"

No, and the reverse is more accurate. The men who continue to be affected and never acknowledge it are the men who organise decades of their conduct around the injury without recognising it. The acknowledgement is the condition of the recovery, and its audience does not have to be large.

"I cannot forgive him. Does that mean I will never recover?"

Forgiveness in the sense used in this chapter is the decision to stop carrying the account, and it is not a prerequisite of every recovery; some men recover fully while maintaining a permanent unwillingness to release the matter, particularly where the conduct was severe and unacknowledged. What is required for recovery is not forgiveness but the completion of the practical steps and the removal of the injury

from the centre of the man's account of himself. Forgiveness, where it occurs, is generally later and easier than men expect once those steps have been taken.

"Should I tell my children what happened?"

At a level appropriate to their age and involvement, and without bitterness. Where the children have observed the effects — the withdrawal, the tension, the absence — an explanation reduces their anxiety and prevents them from supplying a worse one. What should not be transmitted is the general lesson that trust is a mistake; the accurate lesson is the one in Section 16.6, that trust is extended in stages, verified, and adjusted according to the evidence.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 16 in brief. Rejection is a decision that the man is not to be included; betrayal is a violation of trust by a person inside it. Both occur in every domain of a man's life — family, peers, work, children, community — and their effects are less discussed and longer carried than the effects of the romantic forms examined in Chapter 13.

Rejection damages men through six mechanisms: social pain, which is neurologically real and not metaphorical; the simultaneous reduction of belonging, self-esteem, control, and meaning that the ostracism research consistently finds; self-blame and the search for a personal defect; the development of rejection sensitivity, expressed either as accommodation or as anticipatory withdrawal; the two opposing responses of withdrawal and aggression, each producing what the other is designed to prevent; and rumination, which feels like problem-solving and re-inflicts the injury each time it occurs.

Betrayal has four elements — the act, the concealment, the participation of others, and the moment of discovery — and produces four distinct injuries: material, relational, to the man's model of reality, and to his account of himself. Its two destructive responses are hardening, which permanently reduces the capacity for closeness, and exposure, which organises the man's life around the injury.

The pain of being misjudged has its own structure: an allegation that circulates without a hearing, framed so that it cannot be answered, producing shame and then withdrawal, where the withdrawal is read as confirmation. The method that works is presence sustained at whatever level of discomfort, together with a small number of factual corrections delivered once to the people who matter.

Recovery proceeds in three phases. Phase One protects: physical stability, a small number of confidants, no irreversible decisions, reduced exposure, arrangements for the moments of maximum intensity, and professional or legal help where indicated. Phase Two reconstructs: the written account, the separation of facts from constructed narrative, an honest assessment of the man's own judgement, the conversion of a general loss of trust into a graduated practice, and the containment of rumination within a daily appointment. Phase Three restores: recovery of what is recoverable, deliberate restoration of standing through presence, contribution, and

time, the addressing of humiliation, the decision about forgiveness understood as an internal release rather than a reconciliation, and the decision about the relationship. Trust is not a single quantity and not a decision; it is rebuilt in graduated steps within the specific domain where it was damaged, with verification made visible rather than covert, results recorded as data, and extension or limitation decided on the evidence. A man's confidence in his own judgement is restored by separating the assessment from the outcome, recording the signals that were genuinely available, and introducing one reviewing relationship for significant arrangements.

Reflection Questions

1. From the forms of rejection in Section 16.1, which have you experienced — and which have you never named as rejections at all?
2. Which of the six mechanisms in Section 16.2 operates most strongly in you? If it is rejection sensitivity, is your pattern accommodation or anticipatory withdrawal?
3. Apply the four injuries from Section 16.3 to the most significant betrayal in your life. Which has been the most damaging, and which have you never addressed?
4. If you have ever been misjudged or falsely accused, did you withdraw or stay? What did your response produce in the months that followed?
5. Complete Part Five of the exercise. What proportion of your distress rests on established fact, and what proportion on what you have constructed?
6. Which phase — acute, reconstruction, or restoration — describes your position, and what evidence supports the assessment?
7. What boundary have you been unwilling to set, and what is it costing you to leave it unset?

Further Reading

- **On ostracism and social exclusion:** the experimental literature on ostracism, including the research using the ball-tossing paradigm and its replications across cultures, and the consistent finding that exclusion reduces belonging, self-esteem, control, and meaningful existence within minutes.
- **On the neuroscience of social pain:** the research on the overlap between the neural systems involved in physical pain and in social rejection, together with the accompanying debates about the interpretation of those findings.
- **On rejection sensitivity:** the literature on rejection sensitivity as a personality disposition, including its development, its association with depression and relationship difficulty, and the evidence on its modification.
- **On betrayal and trust:** research on trust violation and repair, including the findings on the relative difficulty of repairing competence-based and

integrity-based violations and the conditions under which trust can be reconstructed.

- **On rumination:** the substantial literature on rumination as a maintaining factor in depression and distress, together with the evidence on the specific interventions that reduce it, including structured writing, behavioural activation, and the scheduling of worry.
- **Practical resources:** legal advice obtained early where the injury has a legal dimension; mediation services, which are frequently more effective than litigation for family and community disputes where a continuing relationship is required; and counselling, which is indicated where the injury has produced a depressive or anxiety disorder rather than a maintained grievance.

PART V

The Battles of Family and Fatherhood

The responsibilities men carry within their homes

17 CHAPTER

The Father Who Suffers in Silence

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the weight of paternal responsibility as men actually experience it, and distinguish it from the popular account of fatherhood as authority and provision.
2. Analyse the silent sacrifices that fathers make, including the specific mechanisms by which those sacrifices become invisible to the household and to the man himself.
3. Explain the fear of failing as a father, its origins, and the way it distorts the decisions a man makes about work, presence, and discipline.
4. Identify the processes by which fathers lose the capacity to show emotion, and describe the effects on children of a father who is present but emotionally unavailable.
5. Apply a structured approach to fatherhood that preserves authority and provision while restoring presence, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.
6. Design the legacy a father intends to leave, in terms of knowledge, relationship, and example rather than property alone.

Introduction

A man stands at the door of his house at eleven o'clock at night, takes off his shoes, and enters quietly so as not to wake the children. He has been away for fourteen hours. In the refrigerator there is a plate that his wife left for him. On the table there is a school notice that requires a signature and a payment. In the bedroom the children are asleep, and the youngest one has left a drawing on the bed with the words *for Daddy* written in it.

He eats standing up. He signs the notice. He stands in the doorway of the children's room for a moment, and he does not go in, for the reason that entering would wake them and the morning will be difficult. At half past six the

following morning he leaves for work before they rise. The cycle will repeat for approximately two hundred and forty days of the year.

Ask this man whether he is suffering, and he will tell you no. Ask him what he is sacrificing, and he will tell you that he is not sacrificing anything — he is working. Ask him what his children will remember about him in thirty years, and he will pause, because the question has never been put to him and because he has never permitted himself to consider the answer, since considering it would be an admission that his presence matters and that he does not have it to give.

This chapter is about the father who suffers in silence: the man whose paternal responsibility is the heaviest part of his load, who discharges it as fully as he is able, and who pays for it in a currency he does not count and rarely discusses. The chapter does not argue that fathers should work less, which many cannot; it argues that a man should know the cost of the arrangement he has chosen or accepted, because an arrangement whose costs are known can be adjusted, and an arrangement whose costs are unknown will run for twenty years and then present its bill in the form of children who are polite strangers.

17.1 The Weight of Being a Father

Fatherhood is discussed in public in two registers, and neither of them describes what fathers experience.

The first register is **authority**. The father is described as the head of the household, the one whose word is final, the disciplinarian, the decision-maker. Where men are criticised, it is frequently in these terms: that they are absent, authoritarian, or uninvolved.

The second register is **provision**. The father is described as the breadwinner, assessed by his capacity to fund the household, and evaluated by the visible markers of that funding.

What is missing from both registers is the **responsibility as experienced from the inside**: the continuous awareness of dependence, the sense of being the person on whom consequences land, and the specific fear that has no name in either register, which is the fear of what will happen to the children if the man fails.

The Five Components of the Weight

1. The consciousness of dependence. A man with children carries, permanently, the knowledge that other people's outcomes depend on him. This is not a thought he has occasionally; it is a background condition that shapes every decision. Its practical effect is that risk becomes almost impossible for him: the business opportunity that would require two years of reduced income, the move that would require the family to relocate, the career change that would require further study — each carries an assessment not of the man's own prospects but of the children's, and the assessment operates continuously.

2. The impossibility of the standard. The standard a father carries is not derived from his circumstances; it is derived from his expectations and from the comparison described in Chapter 11. The result, consistently reported by men, is the sense that they are providing substantially and are nevertheless short of what is required.

3. The absence of an equivalent return. A father's work for his children is frequently conducted in an arrangement that supplies him with no feedback. A man can assess his performance at work by output and assessment; at home, the feedback is delivered years later, in the form of who his children have become, and there is no interim appraisal. The absence of feedback is one of the reasons that fathers drift: nothing tells them that a change is required until the change is expensive.

4. The expectation of being the household's shield. A father is the person who absorbs bad news and communicates it in reduced form: the financial difficulty that becomes a scheduling adjustment, the illness that becomes a caution, the job loss that becomes a period of consulting work. The shielding is frequently well-intentioned and it is frequently misjudged, since it produces the household's ignorance of its own position, as Chapter 9 establishes.

5. The fear for the children's world. The fifth component is the most difficult and the least discussed: the father's fear for the world his children will inhabit. Employment conditions, economic instability, and the cost of education figure in it, but its content is broader: the father's knowledge of the world's difficulty and his inability to transmit that knowledge usefully. Men describe this fear with precision: *I know what it takes to survive out there and I cannot teach it to them and I cannot protect them from it.*

The Structure of the Load

The load is distributed across four relationships at once, and this is the feature that distinguishes a father's position from most others.

Table 17.1 The four fronts on which a father's obligation is distributed, and the strain characteristic of each.

Relationship	The father's obligation	The characteristic strain
Children	Provision, protection, guidance, example	Presence — the obligation with the least available time
Partner	Support, custody of the relationship's intimacy, joint management	Attention — the first obligation to be deferred under pressure
His own parents	Respect, care in illness, financial support	Duty — enforced by custom and by his own standards
Extended family and community	Contributions, mediation, representation, reputation	Standing — visible and continuously assessed

The strains are not additive, they are competing. The hours that satisfy the first reduce the second; the money that satisfies the fourth consumes the time that the first requires; the deference that the third requires consumes the decisions that the second needs to be shared. This competition — not the volume of the burden — is what fathers describe when they say that they are stretched: not that they have too much to do, but that each requirement is met at the cost of another.

What Men Do Not Say

Three things about the weight are not said by men, and it is worth naming them explicitly, because each is common and each is treatable.

That the children are the source of the pressure. Men describe their children as the reason for their effort and rarely as a burden. Both statements are true, and the second is frequently unavailable, because the admission seems disloyal. In clinical accounts, the pressure associated with the paternal role is one of the most frequently concealed of all the strains men carry.

That the marriage has been deprioritised deliberately. Where a father has chosen work over attention to his wife, with the justification that the work serves the household, the admission is rarely made to anybody, and the consequences arrive as described in Chapter 15.

That the man does not know his children. Men frequently discover, in the children's adolescence, that they cannot describe their children's interior lives: what they worry about, whom they are close to, what they want, what they fear. The discovery is usually painful and it is usually late.

17.2 The Father's Silent Sacrifices

Every father makes sacrifices, and the sacrifices a father makes are, in the majority of cases, entirely unknown to the people for whom they were made. This is not concealment in the ordinary sense — it is not deception, and it is rarely deliberate. It is the consequence of the way in which paternal sacrifice is structured: it is performed as ordinary duty, it is registered by the household as the normal state of affairs, and it is never converted into a statement.

Figure 17.1 shows the four fronts on which a father's obligation is distributed and the characteristic strain attached to each. The diagram is illustrative and generalised; the distribution differs substantially between households, and the purpose of setting it out is to make the whole arrangement visible rather than to describe any particular family.

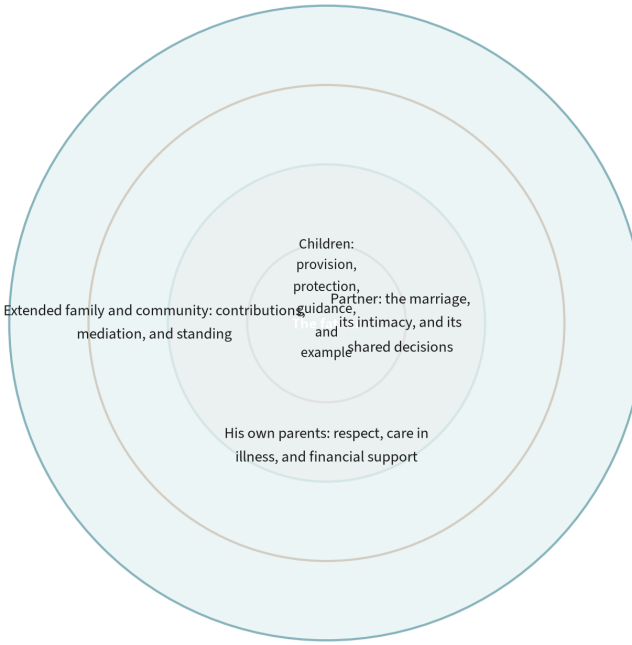


Figure 17.1 The four fronts of a father's obligation. Each front is legitimate on its own terms, and each competes with the others for the same finite hours.

The Six Sacrifices

1. The sacrificial hours. The most visible to the man and the least visible to everybody else. A father's additional work — the overtime, the second job, the weekend contracts, the travel — is performed for the household and is registered by the household as absence. The paradox is exact: the sacrifice of time is made on behalf of the children and is experienced by the children as the withdrawal of the father.

2. The sacrifice of ambition. A substantial number of fathers abandon or postpone particular ambitions — further study, a business, a move, a career change — because the family's security requires stability. The sacrifice is made in a specific decision at a specific time, and it is rarely disclosed, because disclosing it would create an obligation that the man does not want to impose. Men frequently carry such decisions for a lifetime: the degree not taken, the offer not accepted, the city not moved to. Chapter 11 addresses the delayed and abandoned ambition directly.

3. The sacrifice of health. Sleep foregone, meals taken irregularly, medical care deferred, exercise abandoned. The sacrifice is defended on the grounds that there is no time, and the ledger is settled later in the form of conditions that are

expensive to treat and that reduce the father's capacity at precisely the stage when his children need him in a different way.

4. The sacrifice of the man's own interests and friendships. The football, the instrument, the club, the army of friends from before the children. The sacrifice is gradual and it is rarely noticed until the man attempts to recover any of it, at which point he discovers that the friendships have lapsed, the interests have no currency, and his own leisure produces guilt.

5. The sacrifice of emotional availability. The element that the man least recognises as a sacrifice and that his children register most strongly. The suppression described in Chapter 3 is performed, in the paternal context, as a service: the man conceals his fear, his exhaustion, and his disappointment in order to keep the household steady. Its effect on children is the subject of Section 17.4, and it is the sacrifice most likely to be reproduced by the next generation.

6. The sacrifice of the man's own account of himself. The final sacrifice is the least discussed. A father who has given up particular ambitions, particular interests, and particular relationships in the performance of his role may find, at fifty-five, that he can no longer describe who he is apart from his function. Chapter 24 addresses the consequences; the point here is that the sacrifice is made gradually, in individual decisions each of which appears necessary, and that its cumulative effect is not visible until it is established.

Why the Sacrifices Are Invisible

Five mechanisms account for the invisibility, and each is worth knowing because each is reversible.

They are performed as duty rather than announced as gift. A sacrifice that is described is the offering of a gift, and offering a gift creates an obligation in the recipient. Men avoid creating the obligation, and they therefore never mention the sacrifice, which the household accordingly registers as the ordinary state of affairs.

They have no datable end. A sacrifice made for a defined period is visible as a sacrifice. A sacrifice made indefinitely becomes the household's normal condition, and the condition is what the household adapts to, not the sacrifice.

They are invisible in kind. The sacrifice of ambition and health has no visible manifestation, in contrast to the visible manifestation of the money it produces. The household sees the provision; it does not see the offer that was declined.

They are offset by visible rewards. Where the sacrifice produces a vehicle, a house, or a standard of living, the rewards are read as the fruit of the man's choices and the sacrifices are read as the price of what he wanted. The reading is not unreasonable from outside; it is inaccurate, and the inaccuracy is the man's own doing.

The man himself forgets them. The most important mechanism, and the most important reason to write the material down. A man who has made a significant sacrifice and has never described it anywhere, including to himself, will gradually reconstitute his history as a series of ordinary decisions. The cost of this reconstruction is precise: the man loses the ability to state his own position, and therefore the ability to renegotiate it.

The Ledger Problem, in the Paternal Context

Chapter 15 identified the unspoken ledger — the internal account of what a man has given and received — as one of the most destructive mechanisms in a marriage. The paternal version is related and distinct.

Its content is not what the man has given to the household; it is what the man has given up for the children. Its function is protective: it allows the man to justify the arrangement to himself during periods when the arrangement is producing nothing except fatigue. Its risk is that it converts the relationship with the children into an account, and an account held for twenty years produces, in middle age, a specific expectation that the children have not been told about: that they should be grateful, that they should consult him, that they should want what he wanted for them.

The remedy is the same as in Chapter 15 and it requires more courage in this context: the ledger must be stated. The practical form is not a demand for gratitude, which is the form the ledger takes when it is unmanaged. It is a statement of position: *I have done certain things for this family, and I am going to tell you what they were, not because you owe me anything, but because I have never said them aloud and they have been affecting how I behave towards you.*

17.3 Fear of Failing as a Father

The fear of failing as a father is more common, and more consequential, than the fear of failing professionally, and it differs in three respects: it cannot be declined, it is assessed by people who are not in a position to assess it, and its subject is somebody else's life.

The Content of the Fear

Men's accounts make the content specific. A father fears:

- that his children will not be able to compete because of the education he could not fund;
- that his sons will reproduce his limitations and that his daughters will marry men who replicate his failures;
- that his working years were spent on the wrong measure — money rather than presence — and that the error will not be visible until it is permanent;

- that he has transmitted his own fears, his own temper, and his own patterns of silence;
- that a specific event — a separation, a period of unemployment, an illness, a business collapse — has determined his children's outcomes in ways he cannot correct;
- that he will die before his children know the important things about him.

The Effects on Decisions

The fear distorts decisions in five specific ways, and each is common enough to be worth naming.

Overwork justified by the fear. The fear of failing as a provider produces additional work, which produces absence, which produces distance. The man is addressing one component of the role at the cost of another, and the arrangement is not registered as a choice.

Discipline as over-correction. A father who fears that his children will fail may apply a standard of discipline, education, and expectation that exceeds their capacity or their interest, in the belief that the standard is protection. The resulting pattern is documented in family research: high expectation without warmth, which is associated with the poorest outcomes of any combination of the two dimensions.

Conflict with the children's other influences. Where the father's fear concerns a particular outcome — a child's education, a daughter's marriage, a son's choice of career — the fear produces conflict with the child's mother, with the extended family, and with the child, and each conflict is conducted in the belief that the man is protecting the child's interests.

Refusal to seek help. A father who fears failing as a father interprets advice, counselling, or a family conference as an admission of failure. The result is that households with a serious problem — a child's illness, addiction, or difficulty at school — delay intervention for years.

The projection of the man's own unmet ambitions. The last and most common distortion. A father whose educational or professional ambitions were abandoned projects them onto a child, frequently onto the one whose capacities resemble his own. The projection is delivered in the language of the child's interest, and it is experienced by the child as a task on somebody else's behalf, which Chapter 11 addresses from the child's side.

Where the Fear Comes From

The absence of a model. Many men are raising children in conditions very different from the ones in which they were raised, and they have no example of what fatherhood would look like in the new conditions.

The absence of feedback. As described in Section 17.1: the assessment arrives decades late.

The public nature of paternal assessment. A father's performance is assessed by his children's conduct, appearance, schooling, and success, all of which are visible, and by the comparison with other men's children, which is continuous. The mechanism is the same as that of Chapter 11 applied to the next generation.

The man's own childhood. A father who was raised under difficulty protects against its repetition, and frequently in a form that reproduces the other half of it: the father who was never praised produces children who are never praised; the father who was never permitted to speak produces children who are not listened to. The transmission of parental patterns is one of the better documented findings in the developmental literature, and the transmission is not a matter of intention.

The economics. The final source is structural rather than psychological: the cost of education, accommodation, and health care relative to the earnings available to most fathers. A man who cannot fund the education he believes his children require does not experience this as an economic constraint; he experiences it as a paternal failure, and the fear is grounded in fact.

What Reduces the Fear

Three measures are available and all three are practical.

Define what a father is actually responsible for. The fear is sustained by a definition of responsibility that is unlimited. A workable definition has four items: to keep the children safe, to provide the necessities to the extent the man's capacity allows, to be a person whose conduct they may safely imitate, and to remain a person they know. Every other requirement is a preference, a custom, or an ambition, and a father who can distinguish the four responsibilities from the preferences will find the fear substantially reduced.

Measure presence rather than only provision. A man should know the actual number of hours he spends with each child per week, and each child should have a defined, scheduled arrangement with him. Chapter 18 and the exercise at the end of this chapter provide the method, and men consistently report that the measurement, rather than the total hours, is what changes the arrangement.

Obtain the information the fear is substituting for. Ask the children. A father who wishes to know the state of his relationship with his child has the option of asking a direct question, and the answers are frequently more informative and less damning than the fear's content. The question is: *what would you like more of from me, and what would you like less of?* The responses should be received without defence, which is the hard part, and acted on in one item.

17.4 When a Father Cannot Show Emotion

This section addresses the pattern that has the longest consequences and the least deliberation: the father who cannot show feeling, who loves his children entirely, and who is experienced by them as distant, severe, or unknowable.

The mechanism has been described in Chapters 2 and 3: the suppression of emotion is learnt in childhood, maintained by the script, and experienced by the man as ordinary self-control. In the paternal context, the suppression acquires a justification, because a father who conceals his fear or his grief believes he is protecting his children from carrying it.

The Effects on Children

The research and clinical literature on paternal emotional availability identifies six consistent effects. They are stated here as risks rather than as certainties, because the outcome depends on the whole family system and because many men who are emotionally unavailable as fathers are nevertheless deeply loved, respected, and eventually understood by their children.

Uncertainty about the father's regard. A child does not experience a father's love as a fact; the child infers it. Where the inference must be drawn from provision alone, children frequently conclude that they are the subject of an obligation rather than an affection. Children of emotionally unavailable fathers frequently describe, in adulthood, a persistent uncertainty about whether their father liked them, which is distinct from and more corrosive than certainty that he did not.

The reading of silence as disapproval. A child confronted with a father's silence supplies an explanation, and the explanation available to a child is about the child. The result is a pattern described by many adults: a lifelong attempt to secure a father's approval which is never registered as either given or withheld.

The learning of the same repertoire. Children learn the emotional practice of their household. Sons of silent fathers have a measurably higher likelihood of being silent fathers themselves, and daughters of silent fathers frequently select partners whose arrangement reproduces the one they grew up in. The transmission is the strongest argument in this chapter for a father's own work: it is the only effect that extends beyond the man's own life with certainty.

Difficulty with authority and with conflict. Where a father's displeasure was unreadable, children frequently develop either a heightened vigilance for others' displeasure or a neglect of it. Both patterns are visible in adult life: the first in excessive accommodation, the second in the insensitivity that produces avoidable conflict at work and at home.

The difficulty of receiving affection. A child who has not practised receiving a father's affection becomes an adult who is uncomfortable receiving affection,

which produces difficulty in marriage. The pattern is described in Chapter 15 as one of the mechanisms producing a marriage of logistics rather than intimacy.

The consolidation in the father's old age. The most painful of the six. Where the relationship has been conducted in silence for forty years, the father's old age frequently produces a sudden, urgent desire for closeness that the children cannot meet, because the arrangement does not contain the means. Men describe the experience in the same terms: *my father wanted to talk to me when he was seventy and I did not know how, and neither did he.*

What Changes

Five measures change the pattern, and their order matters because the first is the condition of the others.

1. Say one true sentence about the man's own state, in front of the children. Not a lecture about his feelings, and not an account of his difficulties. A single sentence, delivered in an ordinary moment, and repeated at intervals: *I was worried about money this month. I was tired today and I was short with you, and I am sorry.* The purpose of the measure is not to disclose but to demonstrate that words for such things exist in the household.

2. Explain the man's own silences where they have been noticed. Where a child has experienced the father as unavailable — during a specific period, or throughout — the explanation is worthwhile. *When you were small I was working nights for three years and I know I was not there and I am sorry for it.* The statement does not need to be received with forgiveness; the purpose is the removal of the child's self-directed explanation.

3. Establish a recurring, specific activity with each child. Not general time, which does not occur: an activity, weekly or fortnightly, with each child individually, in which the father and child are together without a task. The activity should be chosen to suit the child rather than the father, which is the point of it, and it should be held for a defined period before its value is judged.

4. Receive what the child offers. Children offer contact in the form of their own interests, their own accounts, and their own requests. A father who listens to a description of a child's interest for fifteen minutes, without correcting, improving, or redirecting, produces more effect than a substantial conversation about the child's future. This is the most under-valued measure in the whole of fatherhood, and it is the one most frequently omitted by men who are otherwise attentive parents.

5. Say the direct thing. A sentence, once, and periodically repeated, in the man's own words: *I love you and I am proud of you.* Men frequently resist this sentence on the grounds that their conduct has demonstrated it, which is true and is not a substitute. Children of fathers who never said it describe the absence

regardless of the conduct, and the sentence is worth saying even at the age of sixty-five, when it frequently produces more effect on the father than on the child.

17.5 The Father Who Is Present but Unseen

A distinct pattern deserves separate treatment because it is frequently missed: the father who is present in the household, works locally, attends to the children's logistics, and remains entirely unseen.

The Features

He is a function rather than a person. He drives, pays, repairs, approves, and attends. He is consulted about the practical matters and not about anything else, and he is aware that this is the case.

His interior life is unknown to his household. He has never described a fear, a disappointment, or an ambition to his wife in years, and he has never described one to his children at all. The material of Chapter 14 applies in full.

His authority is procedural. He is obeyed in the matters he manages and ignored in the matters he does not, and he has no standing in the household's emotional domain, which is managed by somebody else.

His relationship with the children is conducted through the mother. Requests, information, and serious matters reach him via his wife, and he learns what his children think from being told, rather than from being told by them.

He is frightened of a conversation. This is the defining feature. The man would like to be known and is unable to initiate the process; the longer the arrangement continues, the more expensive the initiation becomes, since a man of fifty who has never spoken to his children about himself cannot begin without the beginning being remarkable.

The Consequences

The consequences distinguish this pattern from the absent father's, and they are worth stating because they are frequently underestimated.

The children lose the man's history. What he did, what it cost, what he believes, what he regrets, who he was before he was a father. This material is the inheritance that children actually use, and its absence means that the children begin their adult lives with no knowledge of the man who raised them.

The man is left with no reciprocal relationship. In old age, the pattern produces a father who is looked after and not known. The provision continues in reverse: the children provide the visits, the medical arrangements, the financial assistance, and the relationship.

The opportunity of the children's adulthood is lost. Adulthood is the stage at which a father and a child can meet as two adults, which requires that the father be a person rather than a function. Men who establish this relationship

describe it as the most valuable of the whole of fatherhood, and it requires the presence of the father's own interior life, which has to have been made available at some point.

Breaking the Pattern

The practical steps are those in Section 17.4, with two additions specific to this pattern.

Begin with the children individually and with something the man has made. A meal, a journey, a repair, a task. The activity supplies the occasion, and the occasion supplies the permission to speak. Men find that conversation is easiest while doing something with their hands and while not facing the other person, which is a practical observation and not a deficiency.

Answer questions honestly when they are asked. Children ask about their father's past: what he was like, whether he was afraid, what he wanted to do. These questions are the openings the pattern most needs, and the answers that are honest, specific, and slightly unflattering are the ones that produce the relationship. Men should note that a child who asks such a question is not seeking information; the child is seeking the father.

17.6 Building a Father's Legacy of Honesty

The final substantive section addresses what a father leaves, and it proceeds from a finding that men find uncomfortable and then, frequently, useful: the material inheritance is not the part of a father that lasts, and the part that lasts is assembled from ordinary conduct over decades rather than from a plan.

The Three Inheritances

The material inheritance. Property, assets, education funded, position in the community. Its value is real and its transmission is unreliable: it can be divided, lost, disputed, or consumed. The research on inherited wealth indicates that a substantial proportion of it does not persist beyond the second generation, and the disputes it generates frequently damage the family relations it was intended to support, as Chapter 19 discusses.

The competence inheritance. What the man has taught: practical skills, judgement, the ability to handle institutions, financial literacy, the management of a household, the conduct of a negotiation. This inheritance is more durable than the first and it is transmitted by involvement rather than by instruction. A father who takes his son to the market, the bank, the construction site, and the mechanic's yard transmits an inheritance whether or not he names it as such.

The relational inheritance. The pattern the man has established for how people in a family treat one another: whether difficulties are discussed, whether affection is expressed, whether silence is the household's method, whether a man

may be weak in front of those who depend on him. This is the inheritance most likely to survive, and it is the one least likely to be chosen deliberately. Chapter 17's central proposition is that a father should choose it.

The Practical Construction

Five measures build the three inheritances, and the first is the one that most fathers omit.

1. Transmit the history rather than the summary. A father should tell his children what actually happened: the jobs, the failures, the money that was lost, the decision that was made badly, the period of difficulty, the people who helped. Children who know the actual history inherit a usable map; children who know only the summary — *I worked hard and I educated my children* — inherit a standard against which they will measure themselves unfavourably and inaccurately.

2. Teach the competence explicitly. The skills a father holds are frequently so ordinary to him that he does not transmit them. The practical test: what do my children not know how to do that I could teach them in six sessions? Budgeting, negotiation, vehicle maintenance, the management of a rental property, cooking, the interpretation of a payslip, the conduct of a job interview, the handling of a family dispute, first aid, swimming. Six sessions per competence, one competence per year, is a transmission of substantial value.

3. Write the things that are not said in speech. A letter, a document, or a small notebook: what the father believes, what he regrets, what he hopes for each child, what he would do differently, and what he wants them to know about him. The document has a specific property that speech does not: it survives, it can be returned to, and it can be read after the man is no longer available to be asked. Men who write such a document frequently report that the writing changed their conduct as well, because it required them to know what they actually thought.

4. Establish a recurring obligation of contact. A fixed arrangement — a monthly call with each child, an annual journey, a standing meeting — that continues after the children have left the household and continues when the man has nothing practical to discuss. The arrangement matters because the alternative, contact that occurs when there is a reason, produces a relationship that consists of reasons.

5. Say what the children need to hear while it can still be said. Three statements, each of which children report as significant when they have been made and as absent when they have not: that the father is proud of them; that a specific failure does not change his regard; and that he has been affected by them in ways he can describe. The third is the most powerful and the least spoken: a

father who can tell a child what that child has given him has supplied something that no provision can supply.

Correcting the Record

A specific measure is available to a father who recognises that his conduct in a particular period was damaging: the correction. It consists of four elements, and it is best delivered in the form set out here because its structure prevents it from becoming either a defence or a confession.

1. **The conduct, stated factually.** *For three years I was working two jobs and I was not present, and when I was present I was short with you.*
2. **The impact, acknowledged.** *I know that you learned to manage without me, and that you had to be careful about what you said to me.*
3. **The reason, given without excuse.** *I did it because I believed the household would fail otherwise. That does not change what it was like for you.*
4. **What the man will do now.** *I cannot recover the years. What I can do is be available now and not make excuses about it.*

The measure is not a request for forgiveness and it should not be made as one. Its purpose is the removal of the child's self-directed explanation for the father's conduct, which is the specific and frequently unrecognised injury of the father who was present but absent.

17.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Notebooks

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family practice, counselling, and the research literature on fatherhood.

Bashir is sixty-one, a retired nurse who worked for thirty-four years in a general hospital in Kano, married to Hadiza for thirty-five years, with five children aged between twenty-four and thirty-four.

Bashir's account of his own fatherhood, given in the context of a family difficulty concerning his second son, was unusually clear and unusually bleak. He said: *I provided. I was present in the house. I do not think any of them knows me as a person, and I know that because of something that happened at my own father's burial.*

The events that produced the case were as follows.

Bashir's eldest daughter, Aisha, was preparing a family information document — a health history that her own physician had requested — and she asked her father, over the telephone, a series of questions about his parents, his own medical history, and his work. The conversation lasted forty minutes, and Bashir, in his description, found himself unable to answer most of the questions: he did not know his mother's age at her death, he did not know the diagnosis that had killed his father, and he could not recall the years in which he had held two of his own former positions.

The exchange had a further consequence. His daughter asked, in passing, why he had never taken the nurse-training position in Jos that he had mentioned once, and Bashir explained, for the first time to any of his children, that he had declined it in the year of his mother's illness because the family required his presence and because the relocation would have been unaffordable for his father. He had never mentioned the matter to his wife, who was present during the call, and the disclosure required a conversation afterwards in which she asked why he had not spoken of it.

Over the following six months, Bashir did three things, all of which are ordinary and all of which changed the family's arrangement.

First, he began to make notes. He bought two small notebooks. The first held factual material: the family's medical history, the dates, the events, the names, the years of employment, the property transactions, the debts that had been cleared. The second held what he described as the material he had never said: what each of the five children had been like as small children, the specific features of each one he had noticed, what he had feared for each of them, what he thought they should know about him, and, per child, one incident in which his own conduct had been poor and what had produced it. The second notebook took him about eleven months to complete.

Second, he conducted the corrections. He spoke to each of the five children individually, in the form set out in Section 17.6: the conduct, the impact, the reason, and the present arrangement. For three of the five children, the material was minor. For the fourth child — his second son, whose difficulty with his own marriage had prompted Bashir to seek help — the conversation concerned the four years in which Bashir had worked night shift, during which the boy, aged between nine and thirteen, had been managed by his mother and had come to believe that his father preferred his siblings. For the fifth child, the correction concerned a decision Bashir had made about her education, in which he had directed her to nursing against her stated preference for accountancy. She had complied and had become a successful nurse. She described the conversation with her father, twenty-five years later, as the moment at which something she had carried since the age of eighteen was finally released.

Third, and according to Bashir the most useful element, he established a monthly arrangement with each of the five: not a call in which there was news, but a standing call on a fixed day, in which the subject was whatever either of them wished to discuss. Three of his children have maintained the arrangement for four years; two keep it irregularly.

Bashir's summary, at the end of the case, was: *I gave them everything I had and I gave them nothing that was mine. I was the wage, the discipline, and the door that was always open and always empty of a person. The notebooks were the first thing I ever made for them that was actually me.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The disclosure was triggered by an ordinary practical question. The health history, requested by a physician, produced the material. This is a recurring

pattern in men's disclosures: the opening is frequently practical, and the questioner frequently does not know what has been opened.

The abandoned opportunity was unknown to the man's wife of thirty-five years. The declined position in Jos had not been disclosed to anybody, and its disclosure required a subsequent conversation. This is the sacrificial invisibility of Section 17.2 in its purest form: a sacrifice made in a specific year for the man's family of origin, carried for thirty-five years, and never registered by the household it benefited.

The notebook method imposed a structure that men find workable. Factual material and interior material in separate books; per-child entries; one conduct item per child. The structure matters, because the principal obstacle to this work is not unwillingness but the absence of a form in which a man can conduct it.

The corrections were specific and small in content and large in effect. For three of the five children the content was minor; for the daughter directed into nursing it concerned a decision made twenty-five years earlier. The measure's value is not the severity of the conduct; it is the removal of the child's own explanation for it.

The change was in the arrangement, not in the man's character. Bashir did not become a man who discusses his feelings in general. He established five recurring calls and completed two notebooks. The evidence from family practice on this point is consistent, and it is encouraging for men who believe that the change required is a change of personality: what is required is a structure, and structures can be adopted at any age.

17.8 Practical Exercise: The Fatherhood Inventory

This exercise takes about two hours and is completed in writing. It is designed for fathers of any age, including fathers of adult children, and it produces the most value where it is completed honestly in Parts Two and Three.

Part One: The Record

For each child, complete the following without consulting anybody.

Item	Child 1	Child 2	Child 3	Child 4
Age				
Hours I spent with this child last week				
The last thing this child told me that mattered to them				
What this child worries about, to my knowledge				
What this child wants to do, to my knowledge				
The thing I most admire in this child				

Item	Child 1	Child 2	Child 3	Child 4
The last time I said it to them				
What this child would say if asked what I want from them				
What I know about this child that nobody has told me				

Two or three blanks in the last four rows indicate the pattern described in Section 17.5 rather than a deficiency of memory.

Part Two: The Sacrifice Ledger

Write out, in specific terms, what you have given up or deferred on behalf of your children. Include the year and the amount where they exist: the position not taken, the study not undertaken, the business not started, the move not made, the health check deferred, the friendship allowed to lapse, the six years of night shift.

Then answer three questions.

- Have I ever stated any of these aloud, to anybody?
- Which of them did I choose, and which arrived?
- Which of them am I currently expecting something in return for, without having said so?

Part Three: The Fear

Write out your fear of failing as a father in your own words, in no more than 200 words. Then classify each element of it using the four responsibilities in Section 17.3.

- **Keep them safe:** which of my fears concerns this?
- **Provide the necessities to the extent of my capacity:** which?
- **Be a person whose conduct they may safely imitate:** which?
- **Remain a person they know:** which?

Anything that does not fall into one of the four categories is a preference, a custom, or an ambition. Mark it as such. Men consistently find that between a third and a half of the fear's content is in that category, and the marking alone reduces it.

Part Four: The One Change

Choose one item and specify it.

- **The change:** what will be different.
- **The unit:** the activity, the call, the hour, the meeting — stated precisely.
- **The frequency:** weekly, monthly, or annual.
- **The period:** for how long before it will be judged.
- **How the child will know:** what will be said to them, in one sentence.

Write the one sentence that will be said to the child and say it this week. Men who postpone the sentence for more than a month rarely say it.

Part Five: The Notebook

Begin the two records described in Section 17.6.

- **Record One: the facts.** Family medical history, dates, positions held, property, debts cleared, and the events of the man's working life.
- **Record Two: the material never said.** Per child: what they were like, what the father noticed, what he feared for them, what he wishes them to know about him, and one item of his own conduct that requires correction.

Neither record should be shown to anybody until it is complete, and it need not be shown at all. Its function is not the document but the work.

17.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I have worked away for years. Is it too late?"

No, and the measure that matters is not the recovery of the past but the establishment of the present arrangement. A father who begins a monthly call with an adult child at sixty is doing the work at the correct time: the child's need for a father's knowledge and regard does not expire, and the adult relationship is the one that lasts longest.

"My children do not want to talk to me. What do I do?"

Do not require conversation. Establish an occasion and keep it without requirement: the regular call, the shared meal, the journey, the practical assistance offered without conditions. Where there is a specific injury, the correction in Section 17.6 should be delivered, once, without a request for forgiveness, and then the arrangement should be maintained. Withdrawn children frequently re-engage when the requirement of the exchange is removed, and the process takes years rather than months.

"My wife says I am present but not involved. She is right, and I do not know where to begin."

Begin with an activity and a child, individually, weekly, chosen to suit the child. The purpose of the activity is to create the occasion; the conversation follows from the occasion and not the reverse. Men find that the second occasion is easier than the first and that the tenth occasion is entirely ordinary. Where the man has never spoken about himself in the household, the material of Chapters 3 and 14 provides the prerequisite.

"Is it wrong to want recognition for what I have done?"

No. What is unworkable is an undisclosed expectation of recognition, which is the ledger described in Section 17.2. State the position and let the household decide what to do with it. Note that the recognition that fathers most commonly

report as valuable is not gratitude for provision, which children frequently supply in the form of respect that feels formal, but interest in the man himself.

"I am the only one providing for twelve people. Where do I find time for presence?"

The time does not exist and will not be created by reorganisation. It has to be taken from something, and the practical sequence is the one in Chapter 12: the hour count, one category removed, the minimum allocations scheduled. Where the obligations are genuinely non-negotiable for the present year, the correct approach is a defined period: an arrangement stated in advance — *this year I am on the contract and I will be absent; next year the arrangement changes* — which the children can understand, because children manage an explained absence far better than an unexplained presence.

"My father is dying and we have never spoken. Can it be done now?"

Yes, and the form matters. Begin with something practical, which gives both parties a subject: a document, a photograph, a journey, a family matter requiring discussion. Then say the specific things that require saying, in the structure of Section 17.6: what he did for you, what you wish he had done differently, and what you know about him that you value. The conversation does not need to resolve anything; it needs to occur, and men who have had it report that the main effect was on themselves.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 17 in brief. Fatherhood is discussed publicly in two registers — authority and provision — and neither describes what fathers experience from the inside. The weight of paternal responsibility consists of five components: the permanent consciousness of dependence; a standard derived from comparison rather than from capacity; the absence of any interim feedback; the expectation of shielding the household from bad news; and the fear for the world the children will inhabit.

The load is distributed across four fronts — children, partner, the father's own parents, and the extended family and community — and the characteristic strain of each competes with the others for the same finite hours. The competition, rather than the volume, is what men describe when they say they are stretched. Three things about the weight are rarely said: that the children are the source of pressure as well as the reason for effort; that the marriage has been deprioritised deliberately; and that the father does not know his children's interior lives.

Silent sacrifice takes six forms: the sacrificial hours, which the household registers as absence; abandoned ambition, rarely disclosed for fear of imposing an obligation; health; own interests and friendships; emotional availability; and the man's account of himself. The sacrifices are invisible because they are performed as duty, have no end date, leave no visible trace, are offset by visible rewards, and are eventually forgotten by the man himself. The paternal ledger — the internal account of what

has been given up for the children — is protective in function and damaging in effect, converting the relationship into an account the children have never been told about. The fear of failing as a father distorts decisions through overwork, discipline as overcorrection, conflict with the child's other influences, the refusal to seek help, and the projection of the man's own abandoned ambitions. It is reduced by defining what a father is actually responsible for, measuring presence rather than provision, and obtaining the information the fear is substituting for.

A father who cannot show emotion produces six documented effects in his children: uncertainty about his regard, the reading of silence as disapproval, the learning of the same repertoire, difficulty with authority and conflict, discomfort at receiving affection, and the painful consolidation of distance in his old age. The measures that change the pattern are one true sentence about the man's own state, the explanation of his silences, a recurring activity with each child, the reception of what the child offers, and the direct statement of regard.

What a father leaves is of three kinds: material, competence, and relational. The relational inheritance is the most durable and the least likely to be chosen deliberately. It is built by transmitting the actual history, teaching competence explicitly, writing what is not said, establishing a recurring obligation of contact, and saying the three things children need to hear while they can still be said. Where a father's conduct has caused injury, the correction — conduct, impact, reason, and present arrangement — is delivered once, without a request for forgiveness, and its purpose is the removal of the child's self-directed explanation.

Reflection Questions

1. From the five components of the weight in Section 17.1, which is heaviest for you — and which have you never said aloud to anybody?
2. Which of the four fronts in Figure 17.1 is currently being neglected because another is absorbing the hours? What is the cost, in specific terms?
3. Complete Part Two of the exercise. How many of your sacrifices have never been stated to anybody? What are you currently expecting in return for one of them without having said so?
4. What is your fear of failing as a father, in your own words? Applying the four responsibilities, how much of it falls outside them?
5. How many hours did you spend with each child last week, and what is the number you would consider adequate? What is the difference, in hours per month?
6. If you cannot show emotion as your father could not, what is the one sentence about your own state that you could say in front of your children this week?

7. Which of the three statements in Section 17.6 — that you are proud, that a failure does not change your regard, that the child has affected you — have you never said to each child? When will you say it?

Further Reading

- **On father involvement and child outcomes:** the substantial research literature on the association between paternal involvement and children's cognitive, social, and emotional development, including the findings on the specific contribution of fathers' engagement distinct from mothers'.
- **On father absence and presence:** the research distinguishing physical presence from emotional availability, and the findings on the outcomes associated with presence that is not accompanied by engagement.
- **On intergenerational transmission:** the literature on the transmission of parenting patterns across generations, including the findings on the transmission of emotional unavailability and the factors that interrupt it.
- **On fathers' mental health:** the research on paternal depression and anxiety, including the finding that paternal mental health conditions affect children's outcomes independently of maternal health, and the evidence on the underrecognition of these conditions in fathers.
- **On men's grief and bereavement as fathers:** the literature on paternal grief, particularly after the death of a child and after separation, including the finding that fathers' grief is frequently unrecognised and unsupported.
- **Practical resources:** structured fatherhood programmes, many of which are delivered through community organisations, schools, and local government; the material in Appendix L on the father's legacy document; and Chapters 12, 18, and 19 of this book, which address the working life, the marital arrangement, and the father's own history respectively.

18 CHAPTER

The Husband Everyone Expects to Be Strong

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the expectations placed specifically on the husband's role, and identify the sources from which those expectations are received.
2. Explain the psychological pattern of the need to be needed, and assess its benefits and its costs in his own marriage.
3. Identify the experience of feeling unseen within a marriage that is functioning well by every external measure, and describe its typical features.
4. Analyse the cost of continuous responsibility within a marriage, including its effects on decisions, on desire, and on the husband's own health.
5. Apply a structured method for recovering an identity that is not reducible to his role, including interests, relationships, and a personal standard.
6. Construct the arrangements by which emotion becomes permissible inside the marriage, using the plan at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

A man marries, and within a short period he becomes a role. He is the person from whom permission is sought, the person to whom problems are brought, the person whose mood determines the atmosphere of the house, the person who is expected to have an answer, and the person whose own concerns are not brought to anybody. The transition is not the result of anybody's decision, and neither partner can be blamed for it. It is the consequence of a set of expectations that arrive with the marriage, from both sides, and that are implemented by ordinary daily conduct.

This chapter examines what the husband's role does to the man who occupies it, and it deliberately addresses a subject that Chapter 14 and Chapter 15 have already touched from different angles. Chapter 14 concerned the man whose

wife does not understand his difficulties. Chapter 15 concerned the silent arrangements that develop inside a marriage. This chapter concerns the man's own experience of the role itself: the need to be needed, the experience of being unseen by a woman who loves him and knows his habits, the cost of being the household's permanent strong party, and the specific project of recovering a self that is not reducible to function.

The subject attracts two errors, and both should be set aside at the outset.

The first error is to treat the husband's complaint as a demand for gratitude. A man who says that he does not feel seen is not asking his wife to acknowledge his efforts. He is describing the absence of a relationship in which he is a person rather than a supplier, and the difference is the subject of the whole of this chapter.

The second error is to treat the wife as the author of the arrangement. In the great majority of the marriages examined in this book, the wife is implementing a script she was given as thoroughly as the husband was, and she is frequently carrying her own version of the same problem: the experience of being needed for her labour and loved for her usefulness, without being known. The most reliable route out of the arrangement is consequently joint, and it begins, as Chapter 15 established, with one of the two people naming it.

18.1 The Expectations Placed on a Husband

The expectations attached to the husband's role are distinct from those attached to the man's role generally, and they are worth separating because they arrive from four different sources and are frequently in conflict.

The Four Sources

The family of origin. A husband's parents expect the marriage to increase the family's standing, to produce children, to maintain contact, to bring his wife into the family's arrangements, and to leave unchanged his obligations to his parents and siblings. The last of these is the most consequential, and the conflict it produces with the wife is one of the most commonly reported marital difficulties in cultures where extended-family obligations are strong.

The wife's family. Comparable expectations are held in reverse. The wife's family expects a husband to be financially capable, to treat their daughter well, to maintain the household's standard, and to be available to them in the manner customary in their own arrangements.

The community. A husband is expected to maintain a household, to settle disputes, to contribute to community obligations, to be a representative, and to be the person held accountable for the household's conduct.

The wife's own expectations. These are the least often stated and the most reasonably held: that her husband will be a person she can talk to, that he will

know her, that he will share the work and the worry of the household, and that the marriage will be a partnership rather than an arrangement she administers.

The Conflicts

Three specific conflicts are produced by these four sources, and each is a recognisable site of difficulty.

Standing against partnership. The obligations to two extended families and to the community are public, enforced by comment, and honoured in a man's standing. The obligation to know and support his wife is private, enforced by nothing, and honoured by nobody outside the household. A man who satisfies the public obligations and neglects the private one is behaving rationally in the terms of his environment, and he produces a marriage in which his wife concludes that she is not important to him.

Loyalty against loyalty. Where the man's family and his wife are in settled conflict, the man's loyalty is demanded by both and cannot be given to both in the form in which it is demanded.

Provision against presence. The hours required for the first reduce the capacity for the second, and the trade-off is resolved in practice by whichever party complains most audibly, which is generally not the wife.

The Failure Mode Built into the Role

The role's most important feature is rarely discussed: it is defined entirely by its function and contains no clause about the man's own state.

A husband's obligations can be listed: provide, protect, decide, remain calm, be available, be dependable, maintain the household's standing, and manage the external relationships. The list contains no item concerning his own needs, and this absence is not an oversight; it is the role's design. A role defined by function produces, by construction, a person who is evaluated by function and who evaluates himself by function. And a person who evaluates himself by function will, at the first serious failure of function, find himself without other grounds.

Two practical consequences follow and are addressed later in the chapter. The first is that the husband's self-assessment becomes indistinguishable from his performance, which is the mechanism of Chapters 11 and 24. The second is that any expression of need on his part appears, to himself and to his household, as a defect of the role rather than as an ordinary requirement of a person.

> **KEY POINT**
> The husband's role is defined by what it supplies and contains no clause about what it requires. A man who occupies the role exactly as it is defined will be reliable, self-sufficient, and unknown — and he will eventually need something the role has no vocabulary for.

18.2 The Need to Be Needed

There is a psychological pattern in men that is not a disorder, that is frequently praised, and that produces many of the difficulties described in this book: the need to be needed.

What the Pattern Consists Of

A man in this pattern derives his standing from being the one without whom things would not work. Its features are recognisable.

He arranges things so that he is indispensable. He handles the household's financial management, the negotiations, the difficult relatives, the driving, the repairs, the decisions. He does this competently, and he is generally not asked; he assumes the functions because they need to be done and because doing them establishes his position.

He resists being unnecessary. A request for help with one of his functions produces discomfort: the colleague who assists with the accounts, the wife who takes on the school arrangements, the child who answers the telephone call. In each case, the man's response is frequently to reclaim the function rather than to accept the assistance, and his reason, if examined, is that the assistance reduces his position.

He is uncomfortable with being the one who needs. Where he himself requires something, he prefers to obtain it without asking, and where asking is unavoidable, he minimises the request.

He experiences rest as a threat. The arrangement described in Chapter 12. A man who is indispensable cannot rest, both because the work would not be done and because resting would place him in the position of the household's dependent party.

Why It Is Sustained

The pattern is sustained because it works, and it is worth stating its genuine benefits before its costs.

It produces a household that functions. It produces a man who is trusted with real responsibility and whose competence is not in doubt. It produces a marriage that survives economic difficulty, because the man will find a way. And it produces a set of relationships in which the man is genuinely valued, because he is genuinely necessary.

The pattern's costs are hidden in four places, and they are the reason this book treats it as a subject.

The first cost is that being needed is not the same as being loved. The distinction is the central one in this chapter, and it is worth stating exactly. Being needed means that the household's outcomes depend on the man; being loved means that the household's regard for him does not depend on the outcomes.

A man can be indispensable and unloved, and the more he arranges for his indispensability, the less information he has about which of the two he is receiving. This is why the discovery of a wife's affair, or a child's indifference, is frequently so disorienting to a man of this pattern: he had believed his position was secure because it was necessary.

The second cost is the exhaustion of the role. To be needed continuously is to be in continuous use, and the arrangement described in Chapter 12 follows.

The third cost is the suppression of the man's own requirements. A man who is valuable because he needs nothing must not need. The suppression is maintained for decades and its effects are described in Chapters 3 and 6.

The fourth cost is the development of a household that cannot function without him. The pattern's most damaging feature, because it is self-confirming: a man who performs every function for twenty years produces a wife and children who have not practised them, and the arrangement is therefore both his doing and, by the time he wishes to change it, a genuine structural requirement. This is what makes the reduction of the pattern difficult in mid-life, and why the process described in Section 18.5 is conducted steadily over months rather than announced.

18.3 When a Husband Feels Unseen

The experience of being unseen within a functioning marriage is one of the most common reports in the clinical material on men and marriage, and it is one of the least recognisable to the households in which it occurs, because nothing is visibly wrong.

The Distinction Between Being Unseen and Being Neglected

The distinction is the key to this section, and men who are in the situation frequently cannot make it.

Neglect is a matter of attention and effort. A neglectful wife does not listen, does not ask, does not consider the man's needs, and does not maintain the practical administration of the relationship. Neglect is a fault, it is visible, and it is actionable.

Being unseen occurs in the absence of neglect. The wife is attentive to the household and to the man's requirements: she knows his schedule, his preferences, and his obligations, and she manages a substantial part of his practical life. What she does not have is a picture of him — of what he thinks, what he fears, what he wants, and what has happened to him internally. The reason is not indifference; it is that the picture has never been supplied, as Chapter 14 established, and that she has been operating on the version of him that the role presents.

The consequence is a specific and confusing experience: a man who is well looked after and does not feel known. Men describe it with precision: *she can tell*

you what I eat, what I earn, and who my relatives are. She cannot tell you what I am afraid of.

The Signs

Six signs indicate the condition, and they can be assessed without consulting anybody.

The man's answers to a wife's questions are administrative. How was your day, what did they say at the meeting, what time will you be back — each is answered with information rather than with content.

The wife's account of him is a description of his conduct. Asked to describe her husband by somebody else, a wife in this arrangement describes what he does, how he provides, and what he is like to live with. She does not describe what he wants, which she has not been told.

The man has no recent experience of being asked a question about himself by his wife. Not *what did you do* but *how do you feel about it*, *what do you want*, *what worries you*.

Disclosure, where it occurs, is transactional and late. The man explains a difficulty to his wife when he has already decided what to do, or when the consequence has arrived, which is described in Chapter 9 as deferred disclosure.

The man's interior life is supplied by somebody else. A friend, a colleague, a sibling, a counsellor, or, in a proportion of cases, a person outside the marriage. Where this arrangement exists without the wife's knowledge, the conditions for the situation described in Chapter 16 have been established.

The man's own difficulty in answering the question. This is the most important sign and the most diagnostic. Men who are unseen frequently discover, when asked what they want or what they fear, that they cannot answer, because they have not been in the practice of knowing. The absence of a picture is not only the wife's; it is frequently also the man's.

Why the Condition Persists

The man does not know what he would say. He has no vocabulary, no practice, and no precedent. The material of Chapter 3 applies in full, and its practical consequence is that the disclosure has to be constructed before it can be made.

The disclosure appears to risk the marriage's equilibrium. A wife who learns that her husband is unhappy frequently responds with anxiety, with self-examination, or with a crisis. The man's prediction of this response is frequently accurate, and the prediction is the reason he does not attempt the conversation.

The arrangement is comfortable. A marriage of logistics and competent management is comfortable for both parties in some respects. It has no quarrels about the substantial questions, no discussion of the future, and no requirement of either party to face anything uncomfortable. Its cost is invisible until it is high.

The comparison with other households. Where the man's father was silent and the marriages he observes are administered in the same manner, the arrangement appears to be what marriage is. The appearance is not a description of what marriage can be.

The Consequence of Persisting

Four consequences follow from the arrangement's continuation, and the fourth is the one men most frequently report.

The slow conversion of the partnership into an administration. The marriage becomes a well-run institution: children managed, obligations met, occasions observed, and nothing else. Chapter 15 describes the end point.

The increased weight of the man's external relationships. Friendships, work, siblings, and organisations acquire the whole of the man's emotional requirement, and the man's availability to them increases at the expense of the household.

The arrival of the material at an inconvenient point. Men in this arrangement frequently carry the material until the children have finished school, the obligations have reduced, and the working life has begun to slow. At that point the arrangement's absence of intimacy becomes impossible to ignore, because there is no longer a load that explains it. Men at fifty-five describe this as an abrupt discovery, and it is not abrupt; it is the removal of the material that was concealing the arrangement.

The man's conclusion that he is not loved. The fourth consequence, and the most damaging. A man who has been unseen for twenty years does not merely conclude that his wife does not know him; he concludes, with increasing confidence, that she is not interested, that she married a position, and that if he did not provide, she would not care whether he was there. The conclusion is frequently inaccurate and it is almost never tested, and it produces the resignation described in Chapter 14 as the family's settled arrangement.

18.4 The Cost of Continuous Responsibility

The husband's role requires continuous responsibility: for the household's finances, its decisions, its standing, its difficulties, and its crises. This section sets out what continuous responsibility costs, in four domains.

The Cost in Decisions

The quality of decisions made alone. A man who is the household's sole decision-maker decides without review, at speed, under load, and with no independent assessment. The consequences are visible in the material of Part III: the loan taken on the basis of a projection that no second person examined, the

business entered without an assessment of the household's exposure, the property purchased without a title search.

The persistence of decisions that should be revised. A decision made by a man alone is a decision he defends, because revising it is an admission. Where the decision is made jointly, revision is a joint conclusion. The difference is substantial and it is one of the strongest arguments for shared decision-making within a household, which is otherwise debated on grounds of authority rather than of accuracy.

Decision fatigue. The research on self-regulation indicates that the capacity for considered judgement is finite and that it is depleted by sustained requirement. The practical consequence for a husband is specific: decisions of consequence that arrive at the end of a working day, made by a man who has already exercised judgement continuously for ten hours, are systematically worse than the same decisions made in the morning by a rested man. Men in this pattern frequently recognise this and do not correct it, because the structure of the household's day leaves them no alternative.

The avoidance of the large decision. A related and less obvious effect: a man under continuous load defers the substantial decisions — the business, the move, the career change, the medical course — because the continuous load leaves no capacity for them. The deferral is not indecision; it is the absence of the capacity to think at the required scale.

The Cost in Desire and Intimacy

The effect of continuous responsibility on a marriage's physical relationship is frequently discussed in moral terms and it is, more accurately, a matter of physiology and arrangement.

Depletion. Sexual desire is affected by stress, sleep, alcohol, and load. A man at the point of exhaustion frequently has reduced or absent desire, and the reduction is misattributed by both parties: by the man to age, by his wife to rejection.

The conversion of the wife into a function. Where the whole of the household's arrangements are the man's responsibility, the wife's role in his experience becomes one of the arrangements. The transition from partner to administrator is incremental and it is mutually produced, and its sexual consequence is well known.

The use of the relationship as a relief rather than a meeting. Where a man's intimate life is the only place in which he is not performing a function, it acquires a weight that the relationship cannot carry. Men in this position frequently report high desire and low satisfaction, which is a description of a relationship being used to meet a requirement rather than to conduct a relationship.

The concealment of sexual difficulties. The most specific and most treatable element. Erectile difficulty, loss of desire, and premature ejaculation are all considerably more common in men under sustained stress, sleep deprivation, and untreated hypertension or diabetes, and they are concealed rather than treated in a large proportion of cases. Chapter 21 addresses this subject in full, and the practical point here is that a sexual symptom in a man under continuous responsibility is frequently a signal of a physical or psychological condition rather than evidence about the marriage.

The Cost in Health

The health effects of the role are the same as those described in Chapter 12, and they are worth restating in the marital context because their first consequence is frequently a change in the marriage rather than in the man.

The man's irritability, absence, and withdrawal are registered by the household as a change in his regard for them. His reduced capacity for patience is registered as a change in character. His deferral of medical care is registered as indifference to the household's future. And where the health event eventually arrives — the diagnosis, the surgery, the incapacity — the household's arrangements, which depend entirely on the man's functioning, are required to change at short notice and without preparation.

The Cost in the Man's Own Development

The final cost is the least visible and the most difficult to recover. Continuous responsibility consumes the capacity for development: for learning, for change, for the pursuit of interests that are not instrumental, and for the revision of the man's own direction.

The consequence appears, characteristically, in mid-life, in the form described in Section 18.5: a man of fifty who can describe his obligations in full detail and cannot describe a single thing he does for its own sake. It is worth stating plainly that this is a deficit with consequences for the household as well as for the man, since a father or husband who has no interior life cannot supply one to a child or a partner, and the relationship is restricted to the functions he performs.

Figure 18.1 sets out the difference between the two arrangements that a marriage can contain: the marriage administered by a man in his role, and the marriage in which the role is held alongside a person. The diagram is illustrative; the two columns are not alternatives between which a household must choose once, but practices that can be increased over time in either direction.

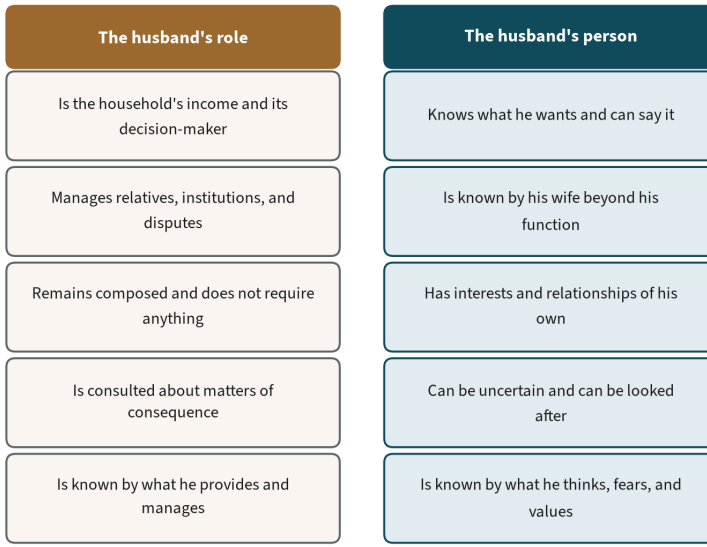


Figure 18.1 The husband's role and the husband's person. The left-hand column describes conduct that is necessary and insufficient; the right-hand column describes what is required for the marriage to contain a relationship rather than an administration.

18.5 Rediscovering Identity Beyond the Role

This section is the practical centre of the chapter. It addresses the specific project that a man in mid-life must conduct if he is to avoid the outcomes described in Chapters 24 and 25: the recovery of a self that is not reducible to function.

The Problem, Stated Precisely

A man of fifty who has occupied the husband's role for twenty years has, in most cases, three components to his identity: his work, his household, and his standing in the community. All three are functions. None of them answers the question *who is this man when he is not performing?* — and the question is asked with increasing force in the decade following fifty, when the work reduces, the children leave, and the household's administration becomes lighter.

The Four Elements of a Recovered Identity

1. An activity that is not instrumental. Something performed because it is interesting or satisfying, and not because it produces income, standing, or benefit to others. The specific nature is not important: football, music, woodwork, fishing, reading, a language, cycling, photography, the study of a subject with no professional application. What matters is that it is the man's own and that it produces nothing for the household. Men frequently resist this element on the grounds that it is self-indulgent, and the resistance is the script described in

Chapter 2. The practical answer: an activity that produces nothing for anybody else is what confirms that the man exists as something other than a provider.

2. At least one relationship in which he is not the provider. Described in Chapter 10 and repeated here. It may be a friend, a sibling, a peer group, or a mentor, and it must be a relationship in which the man is known and not needed.

3. A personal standard. Not a role's requirements but the man's own account of what he intends: work, family, conduct, contribution, and the matters he will not do. Chapter 11's exercise provides the method.

4. Knowledge of his own history. A man who cannot describe what has happened to him — the jobs, the decisions, the losses, the reasons — has an identity composed entirely of the present arrangement. The record described in Section 17.6 serves this purpose, and men report that the writing is itself the work.

The Practical Sequence

Men who recover these elements do so in a sequence, and the sequence starts smaller than most expect.

Step One: recover one activity. Choose one, of no benefit to anybody else, and schedule it weekly for eight weeks without evaluation. The first three or four occasions will feel like a waste; the evaluation should be deferred until the end of the eight weeks.

Step Two: recover one relationship. Contact two people from the period before the household's requirements took all of the man's time. Propose a fixed arrangement, which is described in Chapter 4: a monthly call, a fortnightly walk, a standing meal.

Step Three: transfer one function. The most difficult step and the most consequential. Choose one household function the man performs — the family's medical arrangement, one relative relationship, the school matters, the household's record-keeping, the mediation of family disputes — and transfer it, with training, to the wife, an adult child, or a sibling. The transfer will be resisted in some cases and executed imperfectly, and it should be sustained for six months before evaluation. Chapter 10 provides the method, and the case of Godwin in that chapter illustrates the effect at scale.

Step Four: write the account. The personal standard of Chapter 11 and the record of Section 17.6, completed at whatever pace is available. The output is a document that answers the question of who the man is apart from his functions.

Step Five: disclose one thing. The step that makes the other four real and the one that requires the material of Chapters 14 and 35: one disclosure to the wife, of something that has not been said, in the form described in Section 14.4.

What to Expect

Three expectations should be managed. Recovery is not a transformation of the household; it is the incremental addition of a person to a role, spread over months. The household will resist some of the changes, because a functioning arrangement is valuable to everybody in it, and the resistance is not hostility. And the effect on the man appears before the effect on the marriage: men consistently report that the first changes — the activity, the relationship — produce an improvement in mood and energy within weeks, while the marital effect requires the disclosure in Step Five and takes considerably longer.

18.6 Building a Marriage Where Emotion Is Allowed

The final substantive section sets out the arrangements by which a marriage becomes a relationship in which a man's interior life is permitted, discussed, and known.

The Premise

The premise is that permission is granted by arrangement rather than by affection. Households do not become emotionally open because the parties love each other more; they become open because a structure exists in which difficult material can be raised without the household being destabilised. The structure is the work, and it is more reliable than the intention.

The Six Arrangements

1. The recurring conversation. A scheduled occasion — weekly, fortnightly, or monthly — in which the exchange described in the exercise in Chapter 14 is conducted. Its four questions, in the same order: How are you? What is the hardest thing about your week? Is there anything I have done that has made it worse? What do you need from me in the coming week?

Two design features matter. The first question is asked of the wife first, which prevents the arrangement from becoming the man's channel and confirms that it is reciprocal. And the conversation is scheduled rather than arising, because material of this kind does not emerge spontaneously in a household with children, work, and obligations.

2. A designated hour with nothing to administer. Time together in which there is no task, no logistics, and no children. Men frequently respond that this is impossible, and the practical answer is the one in Chapter 12: the hour has to be taken from something and the decision about what to take it from has to be made. The arrangements that work are specific and unglamorous: a Saturday morning, a Wednesday evening, a monthly day.

3. A rule about third parties. An explicit agreement about what may be shared outside the marriage — with the wife's family, with the man's family, with

friends. Disclosures made inside the marriage and subsequently circulated are the most common cause of a man's decision to close the channel permanently, as Chapter 14 established.

4. A rule about conflict. The rules of engagement in Section 15.4: no character statements, no audience, a stopping rule, no irreversible acts. These should be agreed in a calm period and referred to in the difficult one.

5. A sharing of the load. The division of household functions, including the emotional and administrative labour. This arrangement is the precondition of the others in the majority of households, because a wife who is exhausted cannot conduct the recurring conversation, and the consequence is described in Chapter 22.

6. The man's own support outside the marriage. Described in Chapters 4 and 14: one confidant, one group, or one professional relationship. The purpose of this element is frequently misunderstood — it is not a substitute for the marriage and it is not a channel for complaint. Its function is to prevent the marriage from carrying the whole of the man's requirement, which is the arrangement that fails when the first difficulty between the couple is also the first time the man has needed to speak.

The Six Prohibitions

The arrangements above are frequently defeated by six practices. Naming them is intended to make them avoidable.

Do not use the conversation for scoring. A recurring conversation in which past grievances are submitted as evidence will be discontinued by both parties within a month.

Do not disclose and then withdraw. A man who discloses a matter and then behaves as though the disclosure did not occur, or who becomes unreachable for a period, teaches the household that his disclosures precede difficulty.

Do not require the response to be perfect. The material of Section 14.4 applies. The first responses will be clumsy, and the clumsy response should be corrected in one sentence rather than treated as evidence about the marriage.

Do not make the wife responsible for the man's state. A wife is not the solution to her husband's depression, exhaustion, or grief. She is a participant in the marriage. Where a condition is present, its treatment belongs with a professional, and the wife's role is support and knowledge rather than management.

Do not conduct the arrangements only while they are improving. The arrangements have value at the point at which the marriage is not improving, which is when most of them are abandoned.

Do not treat the disclosure as a single event. A man's disclosure to his wife of what he carries is not the conclusion of the work; it is the opening of a channel

that then has to be used, over years, with respect to matters that are small as well as large.

18.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Loved His Wife and Did Not Know Her

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in couple counselling and in the clinical literature on men and marriage.

Emeka is fifty-four, a senior manager in a logistics firm in Lagos, married to Bisi for twenty-six years, with three children, two of whom are adults and one in secondary school.

Emeka's presenting concern, when he sought counselling, was that he no longer knew why he was married. He was clear that he loved his wife, that the marriage was peaceful, that nothing had occurred, and that he had no intention of leaving. He described the position as follows: *We run the house. We talk about the children, the money, the family, the arrangements. I do not know what she thinks about anything that is not logistics, and, more importantly, I do not know what I think. If she died tomorrow I would be destroyed and I would not be able to tell anybody what we had.*

The history that emerged had the following structure.

Over twenty-six years, Emeka had constructed an arrangement in which he was the household's function: its income, its decisions, its negotiations with two extended families, its medical administration, its representation at community functions, and, for the previous seven years, the manager of his mother's care arrangements. He had performed these functions competently. He had, in addition, carried a private set of matters that his wife did not know about: a correspondence with a former university classmate in which he had, for four years, disclosed more of himself than he had to his wife (the correspondence was not romantic and had never been romantic; it was, in his description, a friendship conducted by message, and he was aware that his wife would find it difficult to understand); a private concern about his middle child's mental state, which he had investigated on his own initiative and about which he had decided not to worry his wife; and a persistent sense of having become a competent administrator of a family rather than a participant in one.

The marital arrangement had three features that Emeka had never named. First, he and his wife had not had a conversation about anything outside the household's administration for eleven years. Second, the household had not contained any criticism of Emeka for the same period: the absence of conflict, which he had regarded as a sign of a good marriage, was, in the counsellor's assessment, a sign that disagreement had become impossible, and, as Bisi later said, she had stopped raising matters because "there was no point in it; he would do what he thought was right in the end". Third, the family's decisions were made entirely by Emeka, who consulted after deciding, a pattern that had been established in the first year of the marriage when the household had negligible income and there was no capacity for deliberation.

The intervention, conducted over about eighteen months, consisted of four elements, and Emeka's account of the order of their effects is instructive.

He began with the transfer of functions — the family's medical arrangements and one set of relative relationships — and he described this as the most difficult step and the most useful. It required teaching Bisi the administrative details, accepting her handling of them differently from his own, and, on two occasions, watching an outcome he would have managed differently.

He then conducted the recurring conversation, initially weekly and later fortnightly. Its first three months were, in his description, awkward and nearly empty, because neither party had practice. By the sixth month the conversation had acquired content and had, on two occasions, produced disagreement, which he noted as a change in the right direction.

He then disclosed the three matters he had been carrying. The correspondence was received badly and required three separate conversations; Bisi's assessment was that the content was not the difficulty but the practice of having spoken to somebody else for four years while not speaking to her, which is the finding of Chapter 14 in a specific form. The concern about the middle child was received with relief: Bisi had reached the same conclusion independently and had also decided not to worry anybody. And the third matter — his sense of having become the administrator of a family — was received as plain information and produced, in his words, the only moment of the whole process at which his wife cried.

He then, at the counsellor's suggestion, wrote the account described in Section 18.5: what had happened in his working life, what he had wanted at various ages, what he regretted, and what he intended for the remaining period.

His summary, at the conclusion of the work, was: *I thought a marriage with no quarrels was a good marriage. What we had was a project with two staff. I am not claiming to have become a romantic. I am claiming that my wife now knows three things about me that she did not know after twenty-six years, and that I have booked a Wednesday evening for twenty years that I had been giving to nothing in particular.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The absence of conflict was the symptom, not the health. Emeka had interpreted the marriage's peacefulness as evidence of success. The counsellor's assessment — that a marriage with no disagreement over eleven years had removed the possibility of disagreement — is a recurring finding in couple work, and it distinguishes the marriage of agreement from the marriage of administration.

The consultation-after-decision pattern was established in the first year. The household's decision structure had been set when there was no income and no capacity for deliberation, and it had never been revised. This is the most common history of the pattern described in Section 18.4: a functional arrangement established early, under constraint, and maintained by inertia.

The undisclosed correspondence was a symptom as much as a fault. The correspondence was not romantic and had not been concealed for its content; it had been concealed because it was the channel through which Emeka was known, and its disclosure would have exposed the fact that such a channel was necessary. This is the mechanism described in Chapter 14 as competition between support and marriage, and it is worth noting that the marriage, rather than the friendship, was the subject that required the intervention.

The child's difficulty had been assessed twice, independently, and not discussed. Both parents had reached the same conclusion and had both decided to protect the other. The arrangement is an exact illustration of Section 18.1: two people performing a protective function for each other and neither in possession of the information available to the other.

The order of the interventions produced most of the effect. The transfer of functions came before the conversation, and the disclosure came after both. Emeka was clear that he could not have conducted the disclosure first, because he had nothing to disclose it into: a marriage in which decisions were made alone had no channel in which a disclosure could be received. This is the practical answer to the question men most frequently ask — *what do I say?* — and it is that the arrangements frequently require attention before the words do.

18.8 Practical Exercise: The Role and the Person

This exercise takes about two hours, and it is completed in two sittings.

Part One: The Functions

List every function you currently perform for your household, including the administrative and the emotional.

Function	How long I have held it	Does anybody else do it?	Would I like to continue holding it?

Include: income, financial management, decisions, negotiations with relatives, medical arrangements, school matters, repairs, driving, discipline, representation at community and family functions, mediation of disputes, care of elderly relatives, and the management of the household's emotional climate.

Then answer three questions.

- How many functions are on the list?
- How many have I ever declined or transferred?
- Which function would be most difficult for me to give up, and what does that difficulty consist of?

Part Two: The Transaction Record

Review the last two weeks of your conversations with your wife and classify each one: **administration** (children, money, schedule, family, household matters), **information** (news, work events, third parties), or **personal** (what either of you thinks, fears, wants, or found difficult).

Category	Approximate proportion of conversation
Administration	
Information	
Personal	

Where the personal proportion is below about one-fifth, the arrangement described in Section 18.3 is present.

Part Three: The Unasked Question

Write the answers to the following, in writing and without consulting anybody. Where an answer is unavailable, write *I do not know*, and note how many times you write it.

- What do I want in the next five years that is mine rather than the household's?
- What am I afraid of?
- What has happened to me in the last ten years that I have never described to anybody?
- What do I enjoy doing that produces nothing for anybody else?
- Who knows me — as distinct from relying on me?

The count of *I do not know* responses is the exercise's most useful output, and it is the reason the exercise is conducted in writing. Men frequently discover that the unavailability of the answers, rather than any difficulty in disclosing them, is what has kept the marriage in its administrative form.

Part Four: The Transfer Plan

Choose one function from Part One, and specify the transfer.

- **The function:**
- **The recipient:**
- **The training period:**
- **What I will stop doing at the end of it:**
- **What I will do if the outcome is managed differently from my own preference:**
- **The date on which the transfer begins:**

Part Five: The Recurring Conversation

Specify the arrangement, in writing, and inform your wife.

- **Frequency and day:**
- **Duration:**
- **The four questions, in order:** How are you? · What is the hardest thing about your week? · Is there anything I have done that has made it worse? · What do you need from me in the coming week?
- **What will not be discussed:** logistics, children's administration, and finances, except where a decision is required.
- **The review date:** six weeks after the first conversation.

Part Six: The Man's Own Position

Complete the five steps in Section 18.5, in the sequence given, over the next six months. Write the dates.

Step	The specific act	The date
One activity, for nobody else		
One relationship recovered		
One function transferred		
The written account begun		
One disclosure made		

18.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"My wife says I do not talk to her, and she is right. But when I try, I have nothing to say."

The absence of content is the finding, not the obstacle. A man in this position has usually spent twenty years not practising, and the material of Chapter 3 applies: begin with the physical and the factual — what the week has done to your sleep, what has worried you about money, what your body is doing — and the material develops from there. The recurring conversation in Part Five supplies the occasion, and the occasion is required before the content can appear.

"If I tell her I do not feel seen, will it not sound like an accusation?"

It will sound like an accusation if it is delivered as one, and it can be delivered otherwise. The form that works is the factual statement about the arrangement rather than the assessment of the wife: *we have not had a conversation about anything that is not the household in about two years, and I want to change that.* This form invites participation; the other form requires a defence.

"I am the one who earns. Should she not be grateful?"

Gratitude and being known are different requirements, and the first does not supply the second. Households do contain real gratitude, and men report that gratitude, where it exists, becomes easier to receive once the man has stopped requiring it as evidence of his own standing. The exchange described in Part Four

of the exercise frequently produces more gratitude than any amount of provision, because it treats the wife as a person rather than as a recipient.

"Is it too late at fifty-six?"

No. The arrangement described in this chapter can be changed at any age, and the sequence is the same. Men who begin at sixty report two particular findings: that the transfer of functions takes longer than expected because the household has been organised around the man's management, and that the effect of being known is experienced more strongly by the man than by his wife, at least initially.

"What if she does not want the conversation?"

Then there is information to work with, and the framework in Section 14.6 applies. It is worth testing the premise first, however: a wife frequently declines an unspecified conversation about the marriage because she does not know what it will produce and because the previous conversations of that kind, if any, have produced conflict. A specific, scheduled, recurring arrangement with defined questions is accepted far more readily than a request to talk.

"What if the problem is not the marriage but me?"

Then the work in Section 18.5 is still the correct work, and the reading of Chapters 6, 21, and 37 is indicated. The distinction between a man's condition and his marriage is important and frequently missed: depression, exhaustion, an untreated condition, and long-standing grief all produce the experience of being unseen in a marriage that is not the source of the problem. The test is whether the man's sense of distance and emptiness persists in circumstances where the household is absent: if it does, the primary subject is the man.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 18 in brief. A man marries and becomes a role: the person from whom permission is sought, to whom problems are brought, whose mood determines the household's atmosphere, and whose own needs are not brought to anybody. The role's expectations arrive from four sources — the family of origin, the wife's family, the community, and the wife herself — and produce three recurring conflicts: standing against partnership, loyalty against loyalty, and provision against presence. The role's decisive feature is that it is defined entirely by its function and contains no clause about the man's own requirements.

The need to be needed is a common pattern with genuine benefits and four hidden costs: being needed is not the same as being loved, and the arrangement reduces the man's information about which of the two he is receiving; the role exhausts the man who occupies it; the man's own requirements are suppressed because a person valuable for needing nothing must not need; and the household becomes structurally unable to function without him, which is his doing and, by mid-life, a genuine requirement.

Being unseen is distinct from being neglected. It occurs in marriages where the wife is attentive, competent, and managing the household well, and where she has never been given a picture of the man. Its signs include administrative answers, a wife's account of the man consisting of his conduct, disclosure that is transactional and late, the man's interior life being supplied by somebody outside the marriage, and the man's own inability to answer questions about what he wants.

Continuous responsibility imposes costs in four domains: in decisions, where the quality is reduced by isolation, persistence, fatigue, and the absence of capacity for substantial choices; in desire and intimacy, through depletion, the conversion of the wife into a function, the over-weighting of the intimate relationship, and the concealment of treatable sexual difficulties; in health, through the mechanisms documented in Chapter 12, whose first consequence is frequently a change in the household's experience of the man rather than in the man; and in development, where the capacity for learning, interest, and revision is consumed.

Recovering an identity beyond the role requires four elements — an activity that is not instrumental, at least one relationship in which the man is not the provider, a personal standard, and knowledge of his own history — and proceeds in five steps: recover one activity, recover one relationship, transfer one function, write the account, and make one disclosure.

A marriage in which emotion is permitted is built by arrangement rather than by affection: six arrangements (the recurring conversation, the designated hour, a rule about third parties, a rule about conflict, a sharing of the load, and the man's own support outside the marriage) and six prohibitions (no scoring, no disclose-and-withdraw, no requirement of a perfect response, no making the wife responsible for the man's state, no conducting the arrangements only while they are improving, and no treating the disclosure as a single event).

Reflection Questions

1. Complete Part One of the exercise. How many functions do you hold, and which would be most difficult to release? What does the difficulty consist of?
2. What proportion of your conversation with your wife is administration, information, and personal? What does the figure tell you?
3. Which of the four costs of continuous responsibility in Section 18.4 is most evident in your life — decisions, intimacy, health, or development?
4. In Part Three, how many times did you write *I do not know*? Which question was the most difficult?
5. Who knows you — as distinct from relying on you? If the answer is one person or none, what is the first step in Chapter 4′s sequence that you will take, and when?
6. Which function will you transfer, to whom, and by what date? What will you do when it is performed differently from your own preference?

7. What is the one disclosure you have been carrying longest, and what has it cost you to carry it? When will you make it, and where?

Further Reading

- **On the provider role and men's wellbeing:** the research literature on the effects of the provider role on men's mental health, including the findings on role strain, the consequences of the loss of the provider role, and the association between provider strain and marital difficulty.
- **On men's experiences within marriage:** qualitative and survey research on husbands' experiences of marriage, including the findings on men's reliance on a spouse for emotional support, the reported difficulties of men in expressing need, and the evidence on men's satisfaction within marriages.
- **On demand-withdraw and silence:** the research on patterns in which one partner raises matters and the other withdraws, including the findings on the dissatisfaction associated with each role and the evidence on interruption.
- **On self-disclosure in marriage:** the literature on the connection between self-disclosure, intimacy, and marital satisfaction, including the findings on the reciprocal nature of disclosure and the effects of concealed material within marriages.
- **On men's mid-life transitions:** the literature on the mid-life transition in men, including the findings on the re-evaluation of identity, the search for meaning outside work, and the outcomes associated with the availability of interests and relationships beyond the household.
- **Practical resources:** couple counselling; men's groups focused on marriage and fatherhood; the material in Appendices H and M; and Chapters 12, 15, and 24 of this book, which address the working life, the marital arrangement, and the loss of self respectively.

19 CHAPTER

The Son Who Became a Man Too Early

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the circumstances in which a boy's childhood ends prematurely, and identify the forms that premature adulthood takes.
2. Analyse the weight of early responsibility, including the specific demands it places on a child and the resources it removes.
3. Explain the pattern in which a child is required to be strong for the family, including the mechanisms by which the requirement is imposed and maintained.
4. Describe the documented long-term effects of parentification and early responsibility in men, and identify them in his own history.
5. Apply a structured method for reclaiming the developmental territory that was lost, including the specific work that can be done in adulthood.
6. Conduct the work of addressing the boy inside the man, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

There is a category of man who is recognisable within a few minutes of conversation, and he is usually the most capable person in the room. He is composed, organised, and reliable. He manages situations that other people find unmanageable. He has a solution for every problem presented to him, and he takes responsibility for outcomes that are not his. He is frequently described as having been *old for his age* since childhood.

Ask him about his childhood, and a different pattern appears. He was the eldest. His father left, died, or worked away. His mother was ill, or overwhelmed, or managing six children on her own. There was no money, and somebody had to work. A sibling required care. A family dispute required representation. A business required running. He was between eleven and seventeen when he took up the position, and he has held it ever since.

This chapter addresses the men who became adults before they were adults, and it proceeds from a finding that surprises many of them: the costs of premature adulthood are not primarily material. The man who became responsible at fourteen frequently achieves a great deal, and his competence is genuine. What he loses is developmental territory that is difficult to obtain later: the experience of being looked after, the practice of play without purpose, the capacity to be uncertain in front of adults, the permission to fail without consequence, and, most importantly, the chance to be a child in a household that contained adults.

The chapter is careful about one thing. Premature responsibility is not a pathology to be deplored; in many households it is a necessity and in many men it produced exactly the competence that the household required. What this chapter argues is narrower and more useful: that the arrangement had costs, that the costs are identifiable in adult life, and that some of them can be addressed.

19.1 When Childhood Ends Too Soon

The Occasions

The transitions that end a childhood are specific and datable, and men in this position frequently remember the exact month.

The death of a parent. The most common occasion. Its effect depends on which parent died, on the age of the child, and on what the household's arrangements permitted. Where the father died, the eldest son frequently acquires the household's representation and frequently the expectation of eventual provision. Where the mother died, the eldest daughter frequently acquires the household's administration, and the eldest son frequently acquires responsibility for the younger children's conduct.

The departure of a parent. Separation, divorce, abandonment, or long-term absence for work. The child acquires the roles vacated, and the acquisition is frequently untroubled by discussion: it is simply that the work is now available and that nobody else is present to do it.

The illness of a parent. Physical illness, disability, or a mental health condition. The child becomes a carer, which is a distinct pattern with its own effects, described in Section 19.4.

Poverty and the requirement of income. The child becomes a worker and a contributor before the end of schooling: trade, apprenticeship, farm work, transport, hawking. This is the most common form globally and the least discussed in psychological writing.

Family conflict and its consequences. A dispute over property, an inheritance conflict, a violent household, a conflict between the extended families. The child becomes a mediator, a messenger, a protector of siblings, or an emissary.

Displacement. Migration, displacement by conflict or disaster, or movement between relatives' households. The child becomes the household's outsider and adapts by becoming useful.

A parent's own immaturity or addiction. The child becomes the parent of the parent: managing the household, the money, and the adult's arrangements.

The Forms Premature Adulthood Takes

What a child acquires in these circumstances falls into five categories, and men usually hold more than one of them.

1. **The provision role.** Earning, contributing, and eventually supporting the household.
2. **The care role.** Feeding, bathing, supervising, and educating younger siblings, and, in many cases, caring for an ill or disabled adult.
3. **The protection role.** Representing the family in disputes, accompanying siblings, dealing with officials, defending the household's position.
4. **The emotional role.** Absorbing the household's distress, comforting the remaining parent, holding the family together, and being the person who does not add to its problems.
5. **The surrogate spouse role.** A specific and frequently unacknowledged form in which a child, usually in adolescence, occupies the emotional or practical position vacated by an absent or incapacitated parent. Its features include the management of the remaining parent's feelings, the assumption of authority within the household, and the loss of the parental relationship's protective quality.

The Distinguishing Feature

The feature that distinguishes premature adulthood from ordinary responsibility is not the quantity of work. Many children work hard and remain children: they are given tasks, they are supervised, they are relieved, they are corrected, and they are allowed to fail at small things.

The distinguishing feature is the **absence of an adult who carries the consequence**. A child who works and whose father remains responsible for the outcome is a working child. A child who works and who is himself responsible for the outcome — for the sibling who went hungry, for the fee that was not paid, for the house that was lost — is an adult in a child's position, and the difference is the whole subject of this chapter.

> **KEY POINT**
> Premature adulthood is defined not by the volume of work a child performed but by whether the child bore the consequence. A childhood ends when a child discovers that nobody is standing behind him.

19.2 The Weight of Early Responsibility

The weight the child carried is not primarily the labour. It is the four things listed below, and each of them is worth examining because each produces a specific adult pattern.

The Continuous Calculation

A child in this position acquires a permanent orientation to risk. The calculation is constant: whether the money will reach, whether the sibling will be collected, whether the parent will manage, whether the situation will hold. The calculation operates in the absence of any capacity to influence most of it, which is the specific combination that produces anxiety: high vigilance coupled with low control.

In adult life the calculation persists and is applied to everything. Men in this pattern describe an inability to be at ease in any situation whose outcome they cannot observe, and a need to monitor: to call, to check, to confirm, to keep track. The pattern is frequently regarded by the man's household as excessive solicitude and by the man as ordinary responsibility.

The Suppression of the Child's Own Requirement

The second element is the most consequential. A child who is responsible for the household's survival does not have the option of the household's attention, and the child learns not to require it.

The learning produces the adult pattern described in Chapters 2, 3, and 4: the man who does not ask, who cannot receive, and who becomes uncomfortable when looked after. The specific link between early responsibility and the male prohibition on need is direct, and it is frequently the reason that an otherwise articulate man cannot say what he wants.

The Premature Assumption of Authority

The third element is the assumption of authority without preparation. A child of fifteen who is required to negotiate with a landlord, to represent the family at a meeting of elders, or to decide a dispute over a relative's property acquires authority without the practice, the experience, and the errors that ordinarily accompany it.

Two adult patterns follow. The first is an unusual competence in the handling of institutions and conflict, which is frequently the reason the man is valuable to his family and his community, and which is genuine. The second is a difficulty with authority over him: men in this pattern frequently find it difficult to work under supervision, to accept a correction from a senior colleague, or to occupy a subordinate position, because their experience of authority is that of having exercised it prematurely and alone.

The Absence of a Person to Whom the Child Could Be a Child

The fourth element is structural, and it is the one that men describe with the most feeling when they identify it. In the household that produced the premature adult, there was nobody to whom the child could be a child. The remaining parent required support rather than supplying it; the siblings required care; the relatives were auditors of the family's performance; and the community assessed the household by its conduct.

The consequence is that a particular capacity was never built: the capacity to be a dependent party in a relationship in which one is safe. Its adult effects are described throughout this book, and, in the specific form, they include the difficulty of marriage to a man in this pattern: his wife may be an excellent partner and will, at some point, find that she cannot reach him, because the relationship's structure does not include a dependent position for him.

What Was Gained

It is important to state what the arrangement produced, because men in this pattern frequently respond to this material as though their childhood were being re-classified as damaged.

The arrangement produced: competence in difficult situations; an unusual capacity for decision under pressure; reliability as a structural feature rather than as an effort; and, frequently, the material condition of the family they were responsible for. Men who became adults at fourteen frequently rescued households, funded siblings' education, and provided their parents with a functioning old age. Those outcomes are real, they are frequently the man's central achievement, and no account of the costs should be permitted to diminish them. The purpose of the analysis in this chapter is to ensure that the costs are known, so that the man can decide what to do about them — not to establish that the arrangement was wrong.

19.3 The Child Who Had to Be Strong for the Family

This section addresses the specific dynamic in which the requirement was not merely practical but emotional: the child who was required to be strong for the family, and who has continued to be the household's strong party ever since.

How the Requirement Is Imposed

The requirement is rarely stated. In the accounts men give, it is imposed in six ways.

By the visible state of the parent. A child who sees a parent weeping, exhausted, or in despair understands the position without being told. The child's conclusion is drawn immediately and permanently: *I must not add to this.*

By comparison with the absent or inadequate adult. *You are the man of the house now.* The sentence is short, its effect is enormous, and men who received it can date it. The instruction is not to be responsible; it is to be the household's adult, which no child can be.

By the allocation of the household's confidence. A child who is told the family's financial position, the details of a parent's illness, the conflict between relatives, or the truth about a father's conduct has been moved into an adult position by the sharing of the material. The movement is a form of trust and it removes the child's childhood at the same time, both effects arriving at once.

By the absence of any response to the child's own difficulty. Where a child's difficulty is not answered — because the parent has no capacity, or because the child's difficulty is unwelcome as an additional requirement — the child concludes that the household has no place for it, and stops presenting it.

By the child's role in the household's reputation. Where a family's standing rests on the child's conduct — his results, his behaviour, his achievements — the child is performing on the family's behalf, and the arrangement is frequently expressed in the family's expectation of him rather than in anything that is said.

By the behaviour of the extended family. Relatives frequently appoint the child to the position by treating him as the household's representative. The appointment is made by question, by expectation, and by the transfer of requests.

The Maintenance of the Arrangement in Adult Life

The arrangement persists for a reason that is worth stating plainly: **it is required, and it is rewarded.** A man who is the household's strong party receives a full return: his competence is valued, his judgement is sought, his provision is depended upon, and his position in his family and community is built on it. To be the strong one is not a burden imposed on an unwilling man; it is a role that supplies some of the most meaningful rewards available to him.

Its costs appear in five places and each is identifiable.

The exclusion of his own difficulty from every relationship. Where a man holds the position of the household's strength, his difficulty is unrepresentable: it would be a change in the arrangement that everybody relies on. Its concealment is therefore not a decision but a structural consequence.

The selection of relationships that reproduce the arrangement. Men in this pattern frequently form relationships with people who require support, and they are frequently described as attracted to needy partners. The description is imprecise and the pattern is real. What is occurring is that the man's available position in a relationship is the supporting one, and a relationship that offers him a different position does not feel like a relationship.

The difficulty of receiving care, in illness especially. Illness and incapacity are the situations in which men in this pattern fare worst, because the arrangement has no procedure for it. The pattern of concealing the diagnosis, deferring treatment, and continuing to work is described in Chapters 12 and 33, and it has its origins in this section.

The household's inability to know him. A household that has been organised around its strong party's competence has no practice of asking him about himself. The point is not the household's fault; it is the consequence of the role's position, and it is the mechanism of Section 18.3 in its purest form.

The delayed arrival of the material. Men in this pattern frequently discover the costs at a specific point: the death of the parent for whom they were responsible, the completion of the last child's education, the end of the obligation — at which point the entire arrangement loses its justification and the absence beneath it becomes visible. The event is frequently a serious depression or a period of unexplained emptiness, and it is frequently misattributed to the bereavement or to ageing.

The Sibling Position

One further element distinguishes this pattern. In most of these households, the man is the eldest, and his position carries a particular weight that is compounded in cultures where the eldest son's responsibilities are formally defined.

The features that men report are consistent. The expectation that the eldest will resolve matters, which continues into adulthood and frequently increases after a parent's death; the assignment of responsibility for younger siblings' conduct regardless of their age; the position of arbiter in disputes between siblings; and the tendency of the family to refer the difficult matters to him, including matters that are properly between other people.

The position also carries a specific exposure: the eldest is the person blamed where the family's arrangements fail, and the blame arrives without a hearing. Chapter 16's material on misjudgment applies, and the reason it lands particularly hard in this case is that the man has been performing a function he did not select since the age of twelve.

19.4 The Long-Term Effects of Parentification

The psychological literature on parentification — the reversal of the parent-child role — identifies a set of outcomes that recur across studies. They are set out below in the order of their frequency in the research and in men's accounts.

The default position of responsibility. The most common and the most obvious. Men in this pattern assume responsibility reflexively, including for matters that are not theirs: a colleague's failure, a friend's debt, an adult sibling's difficulty, a community's problem, an accident witnessed in the street. The reflex

is not a decision and the man is frequently unaware of it. Its costs are in Chapter 10.

Difficulty in identifying and expressing needs. Men in this pattern frequently cannot answer the question of what they want, and the inability is not modesty. The capacity was not developed, because its development requires an environment in which the expression of need produces a response.

Hyper-responsibility combined with anxiety. A specific combination repeatedly observed: the man assumes responsibility for outcomes beyond his control and experiences continuous anxiety about them. The combination is a description of the continuous calculation in Section 19.2, maintained for forty years.

Difficulty in receiving, including in receiving affection. Described above. Its marital effects are significant, and the material in Chapters 14 and 15 applies: a wife who attempts to care for a man who cannot receive care will eventually stop attempting, and the cessation will be experienced by the man as further confirmation of his position.

A tendency towards overwork as a stabiliser. Work supplies a structure in which the man's competence is rewarded and in which his position is clear. Men in this pattern frequently describe work as the only domain in which they know who they are — the observation of Chapter 12 in its most specific form.

Difficulty with play, rest, and unstructured time. The capacity was not developed, and its absence is frequently experienced by the man as a characterological seriousness that he regards as a virtue. In practice it restricts the man's relationships with his children, whose world is conducted in play.

An elevated risk of depression and anxiety in mid-life and later life. The research on parentification identifies elevated rates of both, and the mechanism is generally understood in the terms set out above: the arrangement's collapse when its justification ends, the absence of a developed capacity for self-care, and the accumulated effect of decades of suppression.

Difficulty in the parental relationship itself. Where the parent for whom the man was responsible remains alive, the adult relationship frequently retains its original structure: the man continues to manage, support, and protect, and the parent continues to be managed. Where the parent dies, the man frequently experiences a grief complicated by relief, responsibility, and guilt, and the complication is frequently not nameable by him.

A specific difficulty in relation to the man's own childhood. The final effect, and in some accounts the most difficult: the sense of having missed something that cannot now be obtained. Men describe specific losses — the school years not completed, the sport not played, the friendship groups not joined, the time in which nothing was required — and they describe the difficulty of grieving

for them, because grieving requires acknowledging that something was taken, and the arrangement, in most cases, was nobody's fault. The occasion of the ending is frequently a bereavement or an economic collapse, and neither permits an accusation.

19.5 Reclaiming the Lost Years

The constructive work of this chapter is conducted in two parts: what can be recovered, and what can be grieved. Men frequently attempt the first without the second, and the attempt is unstable, because the grief returns each time the recovery is incomplete.

What Can Be Recovered

1. The experience of being looked after. The capacity to receive is not fixed in childhood, and it can be developed in adulthood, though it requires practice and a deliberate arrangement. The practical method, in the sequence in which men report success:

- **Choose one person and one specific form of care.** Not a general intention to accept help, but a specific arrangement: a meal prepared by somebody else, a journey in which the man is driven, a task performed on his behalf, a payment made for him. The form matters less than the fact that it is somebody else's contribution to his life.
- **State the difficulty.** Men in this pattern find receiving uncomfortable, and the discomfort is best named in advance. *This is difficult for me and I am going to do it anyway* is the sentence that converts the discomfort from an obstacle into a subject.
- **Record the outcome.** After several instances, the man should write what actually happened: what the other person's response was, what the cost was, and whether anything deteriorated. The record is usually decisive, because the anticipated cost of receiving — that it will create an obligation, that it will alter the relationship, that it will be resented — is systematically larger than the actual outcome.

2. The practice of unstructured time. The capacity for leisure is developed by scheduling it, which is a paradox that men in this pattern find workable. One activity per week that produces nothing, held for eight weeks, is the practical measure, and the activity should involve the hands or the body rather than a screen. Men commonly report that the first weeks produce discomfort and that the discomfort diminishes without disappearing entirely, and that the activity produces a specific effect that is worth describing: the restoration of an hour in which the man is not performing a function.

3. The return to abandoned interests. The interests that were discontinued between the ages of twelve and twenty are frequently still available: the sport, the instrument, the drawing, the reading, the making of things. Their return has a value beyond recreation, because they are the man's own in the sense described in Section 18.5: they were chosen by the boy for no reason connected with the household's requirements.

4. The completion of interrupted education or training. Where education was interrupted, its resumption in adulthood is frequently both possible and valuable, and men over forty complete qualifications and training at a considerable rate. The obstacle is not capacity but the arrangement: the time and the cost have to be found, and the justification for spending them on the man himself has to be constructed against a lifelong objection to self-expenditure.

5. The acquisition of the ordinary competences that were never taught. A specific and frequently overlooked item. Men who became responsible early frequently lack competences that were nobody's responsibility to teach: the ability to swim, to drive, to manage a bank account properly, to cook, to negotiate a salary, to handle a formal institution. The list is the man's own to compile, and the addressing of items on it produces a disproportionate improvement in confidence.

6. The practice of failure without consequence. The most valuable and the hardest to arrange. A child who was carrying consequences did not have the option of failing safely, and the adult competence at the man's disposal is frequently built on an over-developed avoidance of error. The measure is to take on one activity in which the man is a beginner and in which the consequences of failure are trivial: a league football match, a class, a public performance, a new business skill, the learning of a language in front of others. The specific and observable effect is a reduction in the fear of attempting unfamiliar things, and men report that this effect extends into more consequential domains.

What Must Be Grieved

The second part of the work is the one men most frequently attempt to skip, and the skipping is the reason the recovery stalls.

The material to be grieved is specific, and it should be established in writing.

The time that was spent working instead of being a child. This is not an abstraction: it is the years, the seasons, the games not played, the friendships not formed, the school years whose detail the man cannot supply because he was not attending to it.

The absence of a person to whom the man could be a child. The most commonly reported and the most difficult item. Men in this pattern frequently

describe the realisation, in middle age, that there was never a moment in their lives at which an adult was reliably managing their situation.

The loss of the parental relationship in its protective form. A parent who required care is not a parent who protects, and the loss is frequently grieved not at the parent's death but decades later, when the man observes another relationship between a man and his father and recognises what was absent.

The version of himself that did not develop. The bookish boy, the athletic one, the sociable one, the one with plans that had no relation to a household's requirements. Men frequently retain a precise memory of who they would have been, and the memory should be written down, because its content is frequently of use — it identifies the interests of Section 19.5 in their original form.

The grief work itself follows the pattern described in Chapter 13: naming the loss in writing, confirming which parts are permanent and which are addressable, and permitting the material to be present without converting it into a grievance against a person who was, in most of these cases, doing what they could with no better options.

The Two Rules

Rule One: recover what is available and do not use the recovery as evidence of what was taken. Men in this pattern frequently experience each new capacity as a demonstration of the loss — football at fifty as a reminder that football was not played at fifteen. The rule is to hold the two apart: the loss is real and permanent, and the recovery is real and worthwhile, and neither reduces the other.

Rule Two: do not require the recovery to be understood by anybody. The wife, the siblings, and the surviving parent frequently do not understand the work, and their incomprehension is frequently expressed as amusement or as a suggestion that the man is behaving childishly. The work is the man's own, and it proceeds better without the requirement of anybody's approval, particularly the approval of the people whose arrangements benefited from the original sacrifice.

Figure 19.1 sets out the sequence by which a childhood ends prematurely and the points at which intervention remains possible. The diagram is illustrative and generalised; the sequence differs between households, and the purpose of setting it out is to identify that the arrangement's effects are not fixed at the moment the childhood ended.

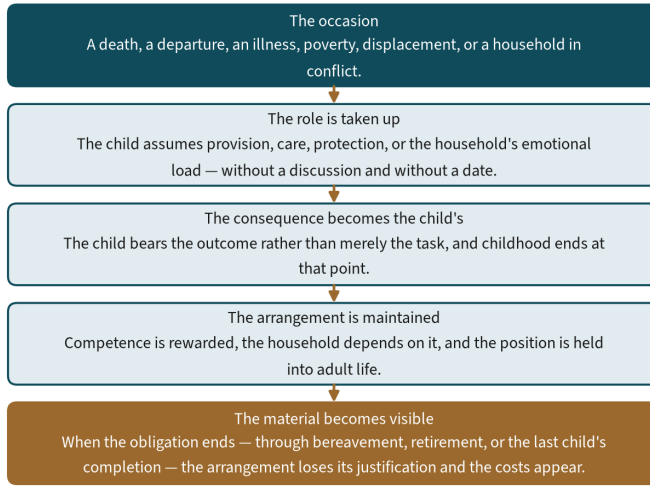


Figure 19.1 How a childhood ends early, and where the arrangement can still be changed. The upper stages concern the imposition of the role; the lower stage identifies the point in adult life at which the material becomes visible and the work becomes possible.

19.6 Healing the Boy Inside the Man

The final substantive section addresses the material that this chapter's title names, and it is written with a specific caution. The phrase *the boy inside the man* is used in popular writing in a way that is frequently unhelpful: it suggests a hidden child requiring rescue, or an unaddressed injury requiring catharsis. What is described in this section is different, more modest, and more useful.

What the Material Actually Is

The material consists of three things, each of which is identifiable and each of which is addressable.

An expectation of the man from himself. The sentences that were formed in the period in question and have operated ever since: *If I do not do it, nobody will. I must not add to the load. I cannot rely on anybody. They are depending on me and I must not fail.* These are not memories; they are current operating instructions, and they are frequently the reason a man in his fifties cannot rest.

An unaddressed requirement. The requirement the boy had and did not present: to be noticed, to be helped, to be allowed to fail, to be looked after, to be told that things would be managed. It persists in adult life in the form of the reception problem in Section 19.5 and in the form of a specific and recurring pattern in marriages: the man who cannot tell his wife what he needs and who is disappointed when she does not supply it.

A version of the self that is not the function. The interests, temperament, and dispositions of the boy, which are frequently still available and which are frequently the material from which the identity work of Chapters 18 and 24 is conducted.

The Four Steps

Step One: name the instructions. Write the sentences that operate in you, in the form in which you say them to yourself. Then test each one for accuracy and current applicability: is the sentence true now, and was it true then? The sentences frequently survive their circumstances by decades: a man of fifty-five operating on an instruction formed at fourteen, in a household that ceased to exist in 1989.

Step Two: revise them into workable forms. The instruction *if I do not do it, nobody will* becomes *if I do not do it, somebody else will do it differently, and that is acceptable*. The instruction *I must not add to the load* becomes *I am permitted to require something of the people who require things of me*. The revision is not an affirmation; it is an accurate statement about the man's present circumstances, and it is written down and referred to, in the form described in Chapter 8.

Step Three: state the requirement. The step that requires the most courage, and the one that produces the most change. The man identifies one requirement he has carried without presenting, and states it to the person from whom it is due: a sibling, a parent, a wife, a relative. The statement should be specific, should not be framed as an accusation, and should not require a response: *I was fourteen when I started carrying the household, and I have continued to carry it, and I am telling you that because nobody has ever been told.* Men report that the statement's effect on themselves is considerably larger than its effect on the listener.

Step Four: give the boy something he did not have. The final step, and the one that makes the others durable. The measures in Section 19.5 constitute the giving: the activity, the interest, the competence, the received care, the safe failure. Men frequently attach a specific plan to this step — the driving lessons, the swimming, the completion of the qualification, the football — and it should be specific, dated, and small enough to complete.

When Professional Support Is Indicated

Two indications are worth stating. Where the material is connected to a specific form of abuse or to a household containing violence or addiction, the work described in this chapter is not a substitute for professional treatment, and Appendix B and Chapter 37's guidance applies. And where the material has produced a depressive condition, an anxiety disorder, or a pattern of alcohol use — all of which occur at elevated rates in men who became responsible early — treatment should precede the reflective work, because a man who is depressed will conduct this exercise as an additional account of his own inadequacy.

19.7 Illustrative Case: The Eldest of Nine

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family practice, counselling, and the research literature on parentification and early caregiving.

Musa is fifty-eight, a retired customs officer, the eldest of nine children, married for thirty-one years with four children of his own.

The events that ended his childhood occurred in 1981, when Musa was fifteen. His father, a produce buyer, died suddenly of a stroke in Kano, leaving a household of eleven — his mother, nine children, and an elderly aunt — with a small house, a plot of farmland in the village, a modest savings account that proved to be considerably smaller than the family had assumed, and a dispute with his father's elder brother over the farmland.

Musa's account of the transition is precise and short: *In September I was in Form Two. In January I was in my father's place on the farmland, learning the trade from a man who had bought from my father for twenty years, and by the following planting season I was responsible for the household. Nobody sat me down. There was nobody to sit me down. My mother was in a state that I did not understand at the time, and my father's brother was making a claim on the land. I understood that I was the only person who could do anything.*

Over the following nine years, Musa: withdrew from secondary school in Form Three and completed his education privately to school certificate level in 1988; supported the household through produce buying, transport, and later a period of employment in a clearing agent's office; reconciled the land dispute in 1991 through the intervention of a community elder, with the loss of a portion of the farmland; funded two brothers' secondary education and one sister's nursing training; and managed his mother's affairs until her death in 2014.

He married in 1994 and joined the customs service in 1996, rising to a senior position before retirement. He has four children, three of whom are graduates. His own description of his adult life is: *I have never had a year in which I was not responsible for somebody. I do not know what that would look like.*

The material that produced the case emerged after his retirement, in the form of a depressive episode that he initially attributed to his mother's death four years earlier and to his loss of structure after retirement. The features he described: a persistent sense of emptiness; the loss of interest in matters he had previously managed; a difficulty in the morning that he described as a reluctance to begin; and one specific and recurrent thought, which he eventually described as: *There is nobody left to be responsible for.*

The assessment identified four elements of the pattern described in this chapter.

First, the instruction set had operated without revision for forty years. Musa's operative sentences, which he wrote during the assessment, were: *If I do not do it, nobody will. I cannot tell them what I am carrying. They will not manage without me.* Each

was true in 1981 and each was, by 2016, either false or negotiable, and none had been examined.

Second, the requirement that had never been presented was specific and datable. Musa had wanted, at seventeen, to continue in secondary school. The decision to leave had been made by him, alone, in a period of two weeks, in the interests of the household, and it had never been discussed with his mother or with anybody else. He had carried the decision for forty-one years.

Third, the position of the family's strong party had been maintained by nine siblings and by his own household. He was the person who resolved disputes, funded emergencies, mediated between siblings, and represented the family. In the five years before his retirement, three of his siblings had brought disputes to him for resolution, all of which he had managed, and none of which he had declined.

Fourth, the capacity for rest and play had never developed. Musa's account of his leisure, at the age of fifty-eight, was that he did not have any: his week was organised by obligations, and his relaxation consisted of watching news programmes, which he described as his one interest.

The intervention ran over two years and consisted of four elements.

The clinical element came first. The depressive episode was treated, which Musa described as the precondition of everything else: *I could not have thought about any of this while I was in that state, and I would have read the whole thing as a further account of my own failure.*

The requirement was then presented. Musa wrote to his mother's surviving brother — his only surviving member of the parental generation — and, later, spoke to four of his siblings, in each case with the same statement: what had happened when he was fifteen, what he had given up, and what it had been like to carry the household without being allowed to be young. The statement was delivered as information rather than as a complaint, and the responses varied: two siblings wept, one recounted that he had never known about the withdrawn school enrolment, and one responded with a comparison to his own difficulties, at which point Musa discontinued the conversation.

The revision of the instruction set was conducted in writing with the counsellor, and its practical effect was specific. Musa, over a period of about a year, transferred: the family's dispute-resolution function, which passed to a younger brother with a professional background in law; the management of his mother's property, which was transferred to a joint arrangement between three siblings; and the arrangement by which he provided for two nephews' fees, which he concluded with a defined date and a statement to the families concerned, both of which were accepted without difficulty.

The fourth element was the recovery of the missing capacities, and it took an unusual form. Musa, at fifty-nine, took up two things: the secondary school education he had not completed, in the form of a part-time programme he enrolled in and completed in eighteen months, and swimming lessons, which he had never had. He described

> the second as the more consequential, on the grounds that he had been unable to swim his whole life and had never told anybody.
> His summary, at the age of sixty, was: *Forty years ago I did the right thing and I have never regretted it and I would do it again. What I did not know was that I was also deciding, at fifteen, that I would never need anything from anybody. That is the part I am now undoing, and it is slow work at this age. The swimming took six months and I would have paid a great deal for it at any point in the last forty years, and it never occurred to me to ask anybody, which is the whole of the problem and the whole of the cure.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The role was acquired without discussion and without a date. The transition is dated by events — September to January — and there was no moment at which an adult said: this is now yours. The absence of any formal transfer is typical, and it is why the position has no terminus: a role acquired without an agreement is not released by one.

The instruction set survived its circumstances by four decades. The sentences formed at fifteen were operating in 2016 on a household that had ceased to exist decades earlier. This is the case's central teaching, and it is the reason Step One of Section 19.6 is conducted in writing: the instructions are invisible until they are written down and dated.

The unaddressed requirement was a school enrolment. Not an abstraction about being loved, but a specific decision at seventeen with a specific cost, carried for forty-one years. The specificity matters: requirements of this kind are presented in a sentence, whereas the general requirement of having been cared for cannot be presented at all.

The depressive episode arrived when the arrangement's justification ended. The thought *there is nobody left to be responsible for* is the mechanism in its exact form, and its arrival after retirement and bereavement is the most commonly reported timing. The clinical treatment preceded the reflective work, in that order, and Musa's own assessment was that the reverse order would have failed.

The recovery was conducted at the level of two concrete items. A part-time qualification and swimming lessons. The material recovered is frequently this specific, and it is worth noting that the man's description of the second item — that he had never told anybody in sixty years that he could not swim — is the entire chapter compressed into one sentence.

19.8 Practical Exercise: The Early Responsibility Audit

This exercise takes about two hours and should be completed in two sittings, with the second sitting at least a day after the first. It is written for men who took up

adult responsibility before the age of eighteen, and also for men whose responsibility arrived later but was not chosen.

Part One: The Record

Answer the following in writing, with dates and specifics.

1. **The occasion.** What ended your childhood? When did it occur? How old were you, and what was the month?
2. **The transfer.** Who, if anybody, told you what your position was? What were the words used, if you remember them?
3. **What you took up.** List the roles you acquired: provision, care of siblings, protection, emotional support of a parent, the household's administration, representation, mediation, work.
4. **What you gave up.** List what you stopped doing: school, sport, friendships, play, particular ambitions, the period of your life in which nothing was required.
5. **Who knew.** Who in your household, your family, or your community was aware of what you were carrying, and who was aware of what it cost?

Part Two: The Instruction Set

Write the sentences you say to yourself about responsibility and need. They are usually in the present tense and they usually sound like facts. Examples from men's accounts: *If I do not do it, nobody will. I cannot rely on anybody. I have to be the strong one. I must not add to the load. It is my duty because I am the eldest. I cannot rest until it is done.*

For each sentence, complete the following.

The sentence	Where and when it was formed	Is it true in my present circumstances?	What would be an accurate revision?

Part Three: The Unpresented Requirement

Identify one requirement you had in that period and never presented. It should be specific: the schooling, the apprenticeship, the time, the assistance, the acknowledgement, the permission to be a child.

Then write the statement described in Section 19.6, Step Three, in four sentences.

- What occurred, factually.
- What it cost, specifically.
- Why you are stating it now.
- What you are and are not asking for.

Then decide to whom it will be stated, and when. It may be stated to a person, or it may be written in a letter that is not sent, or it may be stated to a counsellor. The requirement may be presented in any of those forms; the condition is that it be stated explicitly somewhere outside the man's own mind.

Part Four: The Current Load

Using the transfers in Part One, list every function you currently perform for your family of origin.

Function	For whom	Since when	Who would do it if I stopped?

Then select one function to transfer, with the specification required in Part Four of the exercise in Chapter 18: the function, the recipient, the training period, the date, and what the man will do when it is managed differently from his preference.

Part Five: The Recovery List

Write the specific items that were not obtained in the period in question, and for each, mark it as **recoverable now**, **partially recoverable**, or **permanently lost**.

The item	Status	The specific act, if recoverable

Then take one recoverable item and specify it as an arrangement with a date: the qualification, the lessons, the sport, the interest, the competence, the received care, the safe failure.

Part Six: The Grief

Write, in no more than 300 words, a direct statement of what was lost. Not the circumstances, and not an account of the people involved; the loss itself. Read it once aloud, then put it away for a week and read it again.

The purpose of this part is stated plainly because men in this pattern frequently attempt to skip it: the grief is not optional, and the recovered items in Part Five will not hold their value while the loss remains unacknowledged. The form is not required to be eloquent. It is required to be accurate.

19.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"What I did kept my family alive. Is this chapter telling me it was wrong?"

No. The chapter states explicitly that the arrangement produced real achievements, frequently including the family's survival, and that men in this pattern are usually the most capable people in their households. What the chapter argues is that the arrangement had costs that were never counted, and that a man who wants to know what he is still paying can find out. The recovery work is not a

repudiation of what the man did; it is the completion of it, in the sense that the household's survival was the objective and the man's own life was the collateral.

"My mother is still alive and needs me. How do I reduce anything?"

The transfer, not the withdrawal. The most workable arrangement in these cases is the redistribution of the functions among siblings and relatives, conducted with the parent's knowledge and, where possible, their agreement, and accompanied by a clear statement of what continues. Chapter 10 provides the method and the language. Where the man is the sole surviving support, the reduction should be confined to the functions that are not the parent's direct care, and the sequence in Section 18.5 applies.

"How do I present a requirement from thirty years ago without sounding bitter?"

By delivering it as information rather than as a debt. The statement in Part Three of the exercise has four sentences, and the third of them — why you are stating it now — is the one that prevents the material from being received as an accusation. The accurate reason is generally the same in every case: *because nobody has ever been told, and because it has been affecting how I behave.* A listener who receives that sentence will generally not defend himself, because no defence has been requested.

"I do not remember my childhood. Is that significant?"

It is common in this pattern and it is explained by the mechanism of Section 19.2: a child conducting a continuous calculation does not form the ordinary autobiographical record of the same period, because he was not attending to his own experience. The gap is not evidence of a worse history; it is evidence of an occupied one. Men frequently find that material returns when they begin to write, and the exercise in Part One is designed to permit that.

"My siblings do not see it the way I do and it has caused a quarrel."

Discontinue the account with them. The work of this chapter is not the correction of the family's record and it does not require any agreement. Where a sibling responds with comparison, dispute, or a suggestion that the man is complaining, the correct action is to drop the subject and continue with the transfers and with the recovery list, both of which are entirely within the man's control.

"Is it not self-indulgent to grieve at fifty for a childhood that was lost at fifteen?"

The judgement that this work is self-indulgent is itself an instance of the instruction set in Part Two, and the same analysis applies to it as to any of the other sentences: is the claim true? The practical evidence is that the work produces effects that the man's household notices: a reduction in the sense of emptiness, an improvement in the capacity to receive, and a greater availability in the household's relationships. On those grounds it is not leisure; it is maintenance.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 19 in brief. A childhood ends early when responsibility is transferred to a child before the child is an adult. The occasions are specific — the death or departure of a parent, a parent's illness, poverty requiring income, family conflict, displacement, or a parent's own incapacity — and the roles acquired fall into five categories: provision, care, protection, the household's emotional load, and, in some cases, the surrogate spouse position. The distinguishing feature of premature adulthood is not the volume of work but the bearing of the consequence: a childhood ends when a child discovers that nobody is standing behind him.

The weight the child carried consists of four elements: the continuous calculation of risk, coupled with low control, which becomes a lifelong vigilance; the suppression of the child's own requirements, which produces the adult who cannot ask or receive; the premature assumption of authority, which produces unusual competence and a specific difficulty with authority over the man; and the absence of any person to whom the child could be a child, which leaves a capacity undeveloped rather than damaged.

The requirement to be strong for the family is imposed by the parent's visible state, by direct instruction, by the sharing of the household's confidence, by the absence of any response to the child's own difficulty, by the child's role in the family's reputation, and by the extended family's appointment of the child as the household's representative. The arrangement is maintained in adult life because it is required and rewarded, and its costs appear in the exclusion of the man's own difficulty from every relationship, the selection of relationships that reproduce the arrangement, the particular difficulty of illness and incapacity, the household's inability to know him, and the delayed arrival of the material when the obligation ends.

The documented long-term effects of parentification include the default position of responsibility, difficulty in identifying and expressing needs, hyper-responsibility combined with anxiety, difficulty in receiving, overwork as a stabiliser, discomfort with play and rest, elevated rates of depression and anxiety in mid-life, difficulty in the relationship with the parent for whom the man was responsible, and a specific and unnameable grief for the childhood itself.

Recovery has two parts. What can be recovered: the experience of being looked after, the practice of unstructured time, abandoned interests, interrupted education, ordinary competences never taught, and the practice of failure without consequence. What must be grieved: the time spent working instead of being a child, the absence of a person to whom the man could be a child, the loss of the parental relationship in its protective form, and the version of the self that did not develop.

The work of addressing the boy inside the man consists of naming the operating instructions formed in that period, revising them into accurate statements about the present, stating one requirement that was never presented, and giving the boy something he did not have — the same list, taken as a specific and dated plan. Where the material involves abuse, violence, or addiction, or where a depressive or

anxiety condition is present, professional treatment comes first, because a man who is depressed will conduct this work as a further account of his own inadequacy.

Reflection Questions

1. At what age did your childhood end, and what was the occasion? Who told you, and what were the words, if any?
2. From the five roles in Section 19.1, which did you hold? Which do you still hold?
3. Complete Part Two. Which of your instructions was formed longest ago, and is it still true today?
4. What requirement did you have in that period and never present? What is the statement's third sentence — the reason you would state it now?
5. From the documented effects in Section 19.4, which three are present in your life: the default position of responsibility, difficulty expressing needs, hyper-responsibility with anxiety, difficulty receiving, overwork, discomfort with rest, mid-life depression, difficulty with the surviving parent, or grief for the childhood?
6. Which function do you still perform for your family of origin that somebody else could hold? What is the date on which the transfer begins?
7. From Part Five, which recoverable item will you take up, and by what date? What will you do when somebody tells you it is frivolous?

Further Reading

- **On parentification:** the research literature on parentification and role reversal in families, including the distinction between emotional and instrumental parentification, the conditions under which outcomes are positive, and the findings on the effects of early caregiving on adult wellbeing.
- **On young carers:** the international research on children who provide care, including the findings on the effects of caring on education, health, and social development, and the interventions that reduce the harm.
- **On the eldest child:** research on birth order and its relationship to responsibility, achievement, and the assumption of family roles, together with the specifically cultural literature on the eldest son's position in families where the role is formally defined.
- **On "the man of the house" instruction:** the qualitative literature on the internalisation of adult roles by boys, including studies of boys whose fathers are absent and of the ways in which responsibility is communicated without being discussed.

- **On the effects of childhood adversity:** the literature on adverse childhood experiences and their long-term effects on health and functioning, including the findings on the cumulative effect of adversity and on the factors that improve outcomes.
- **Practical resources:** adult education and second-chance qualification programmes; counselling for men who became responsible early, which is a distinct presenting issue with a specific treatment approach; men's groups with members of comparable history; and the material in Appendix C and Chapter 37 on treatment.

20 CHAPTER

The Pain of Being an Unappreciated Man

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the experience of being taken for granted, and distinguish it from the absence of praise.
2. Analyse the mechanisms by which a man's contribution becomes invisible, including those the man himself operates.
3. Explain the difference between recognition, appreciation, and gratitude, and identify which of the three is actually being sought.
4. Describe the development of bitterness and resentment in men, including its identifiable stages and its effects on the man and his household.
5. Apply a structured method for stating his own value without complaint, demand, or scorekeeping, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.
6. Design the practices by which a household becomes one in which contribution is noticed, using the plan at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

There is a specific complaint that men make rarely, and that when they do make it, is heard badly: *I do everything that is required of me and nobody notices.* It is heard badly for three reasons. It sounds like a demand for praise. It sounds ungrateful, in a man who has more than many. And it sounds as though the man is asking for a service — recognition — that he should not need.

This chapter sets the subject out differently. What the man is describing is not the absence of praise. It is the absence of the ordinary acknowledgement that belongs to a person whose contribution other people depend on, and the experience of it is specific: the man is aware that the household's arrangements would not continue without him, and simultaneously aware that no one in the household has expressed that awareness in any form for years.

The subject has three components that are frequently confused, and separating them is the first work of the chapter. **Recognition** is the household's knowledge

that a contribution exists. **Appreciation** is the household's valuation of it. **Gratitude** is the household's expression of that valuation toward the man. A man may have all three, or any combination, and it is the first that most commonly fails in the households examined here: the contribution is not valued less, it is simply not seen.

The final observation before proceeding is about the stakes. Being taken for granted does not, by itself, end marriages or damage children. What damages households is the second-order effect: the resentment that accumulates in a man who has been unnoticed for a decade, and the behaviours that resentment produces — withdrawal, contempt, the abrupt and disproportionate anger described in Chapter 15, the search for acknowledgement from somebody who will supply it, and, most destructively, the transfer of the arrangement to the next generation, in which the man's children learn to take a father for granted and to expect to be taken for granted themselves.

20.1 The Experience of Being Taken for Granted

The experience has a structure, and men in it describe a consistent set of features.

The Seven Features

1. The work is regular and invisible. The contribution is provided on schedule, in full, and its regularity is why it is not noticed. An unusual contribution attracts attention; a monthly one does not.

2. The contribution has no event attached to it. Married couples acknowledge occasions: anniversaries, births, qualifications, promotions. Sustained provision has no occasion, and it is therefore never marked.

3. The deficits are discussed and the surpluses are not. A household will discuss the month in which the fees were late. It will not discuss the eleven years in which they were not.

4. The man's own affairs are not discussed at all. The household knows what he provides and not what it costs him to provide it. The material of Chapters 9, 12, and 17 applies in full.

5. Other people's contributions are visible and are acknowledged. The relative who assisted once with a hospital bill is thanked repeatedly for years; the man who paid it has not been mentioned. The asymmetry is not maliciousness; it is that the occasional contribution is a change in the arrangement and the man's contribution is the arrangement.

6. Requests are made without acknowledgement of what has already been given. A request for assistance is not unreasonable in itself. What registers with the man is that the request arrives without any reference to the previous ones, which is equivalent to saying that they were not contributions but the ordinary state of affairs.

7. The absence of acknowledgement is not expressible. The man cannot raise it without appearing to request praise, and he therefore does not raise it, and the arrangement continues. This is the mechanism that makes the condition durable, and it is the reason the chapter devotes a section to the way the subject can be stated.

What the Man Is Actually Missing

It is worth being precise, because the imprecision is what makes the complaint unspeakable.

The man is not missing praise. Praise is a general commendation — *you are a good man, you are hardworking* — and it is frequently given and does not address the condition. What he is missing is the household's **knowledge** of what he carries: the specific awareness that the school fees took forty per cent of his income in a month in which he also paid for a funeral; that he declined the travel that would have advanced him; that he has not slept properly since April; that the vehicle is being maintained on credit.

Men describe the need in the same terms across countries and circumstances: not that anybody should thank them, but that somebody should know. The distinction is not sentimental. It is the difference between being a function of a household and being a member of one.

The Man's Own Contribution to the Condition

Three of the mechanisms are operated by the man, and they should be stated before the household is assessed.

He conceals the cost. A man who provides in a manner that conceals what it costs him cannot be acknowledged for the cost, because it is unknown. The concealment is described in Chapter 9, is intended protectively, and produces precisely the invisibility the man then resents.

He declines acknowledgement. Where an acknowledgement is offered, men in this position frequently reduce it: *it is nothing; it is my responsibility; I am only doing what I should.* The reduction is performed to avoid the appearance of seeking credit, and its effect is to remove the acknowledgement from the record.

He does not describe what he wants. The requirements of a household are negotiated in part through complaint and request. A man who never complains and never requests has removed himself from the negotiation, and the absence is registered by the household as an absence of requirements.

> **KEY POINT**
> Recognition, appreciation, and gratitude are three different things. A household may value a man's contribution completely and still not know it, because the

> contribution's cost has never been described. The first practical step in this chapter is not a request for thanks; it is the supply of information that is currently missing.

20.2 Sacrifice That Goes Unnoticed

This section examines the specific form of unnoticed contribution that produces the most bitterness in men: unnoticed sacrifice, as distinct from unnoticed work.

The distinction is as follows. Work is the performance of a required function; a man who works sixty hours a week performs what the household expects. Sacrifice is the giving up of something the household did not require him to give up, in order to meet an obligation the household does require; the abandoned position, the declined opportunity, the abandoned ambition, the friendship let lapse, the health neglected.

Four features make sacrifice uniquely invisible.

It has no output. Work produces a visible result: the fee paid, the food bought, the house built. Sacrifice produces an absence, and absences are not visible. The household sees the household's condition; it cannot see the degree that was not taken.

It is indistinguishable from what the man would have done anyway. A man with a modest income and intermittent work who declined a further qualification may have declined it for any of several reasons; the household's default assumption is that the qualification was not taken because it was not possible, not because it was a sacrifice.

It is rarely announced, for a specific reason. A man who announces a sacrifice creates an obligation in the recipient, and men avoid creating obligations. They therefore perform the sacrifice silently and wait, in a manner that is invisible even to themselves, for the recognition that never arrives because the information never did.

The man himself reconstructs it as an ordinary decision. The mechanism identified in Chapter 17.2: a sacrifice unspoken for fifteen years is eventually remembered as the natural consequence of circumstances, and the man then experiences an unfocused grievance without a subject — *I have done everything and there is nothing to show for it* — which is more difficult to address than a specific complaint.

The Ledger, Again

The unspoken ledger, introduced in Chapter 15 and revisited in Chapter 17, appears in its most damaging form in this chapter. The features are worth restating because they are the reason this material belongs in a book about hidden struggles rather than in a book about manners.

A man who has sacrificed without acknowledgement accumulates an account. The account is not maintained deliberately; it is maintained by the same process that records any unmet obligation. Its effects are recognisable.

- **Selective attention to deficits.** The man registers every instance of ingratitude, every request made without acknowledgement, every arrangement that treats his contribution as the baseline.
- **Disproportionate reactions to small matters.** The response is calibrated to the account rather than to the event, as described in Chapter 15.5.
- **A progressive withdrawal of goodwill.** The man's voluntary contributions reduce: the additional assistance, the readiness, the small generosities. This is the point at which the ledger begins to produce damage that others can see, and it is usually interpreted by the household as a change in the man's character.
- **The construction of a grievance that cannot be raised.** The man's position — *I have given everything and nobody has noticed* — cannot be stated without reclassifying the giving as a request for recognition, and it is therefore carried until it is expressed as contempt, which is the subject of Section 20.4.

20.3 The Difference Between Appreciation and Praise

The distinction introduced in the introduction to this chapter deserves its own section, because men who seek the wrong thing frequently obtain it and remain unsatisfied, and because households that attempt to respond to this chapter's material frequently respond in the wrong currency.

Three Terms

Praise is a general commendation of a person: *you are a good man; you have done well; we are proud of you.* It is pleasant, it is rare in most households, and it addresses the man rather than the contribution.

Appreciation is the valuation of a specific contribution: *the way you handled the matter with my family; the fact that you took the night work during the period when the children were small; what you did about the school fees in that year.* It is specific, it is tied to an action, and it addresses the contribution.

Gratitude is the expression of appreciation toward the man, in whatever form the household uses: words, a gesture, a favour, an arrangement, a public acknowledgement.

What men describe as missing is generally appreciation, and what they frequently receive, where they receive anything, is praise. The distinction explains a frequent and puzzling report: a man who has been praised for years and who continues to feel unrecognised.

Why Appreciation Is Scarce in Households

Four reasons, and only the third involves a fault.

The contribution is the baseline. Households evaluate changes. The arrangement that has been in place for fifteen years is the baseline against which changes are assessed, and its continuation is not an event.

The knowledge is absent. Appreciation requires the household to know what the contribution cost, and the cost is concealed, as Section 20.1 established. A household cannot appreciate a cost it has never been told about.

The cultural script omits it. Most households have no practice of acknowledging a man's contribution. There are practices for acknowledging guests, relatives, and outsiders, and the man's contribution is regarded as the thing itself rather than as a contribution. This is not a fault of any individual; it is a gap in the household's repertoire, and gaps in repertoires are filled by adopting a practice.

The man's own aversion. Where the practice is attempted, men frequently reduce it, as described in Section 20.1, which extinguishes the attempt within two or three instances.

What Appreciation Does

Three effects, all documented in the research on social support and family functioning, and all worth stating because they answer the objection that this material concerns feelings rather than outcomes.

It changes the man's behaviour. A man who knows that a specific contribution has been registered is more willing to repeat it. Men in this pattern frequently describe the mechanism accurately: they will do anything that somebody is aware they are doing, and they find it progressively more difficult to continue doing what nobody notices.

It changes the household's decision-making. A household that knows a man's costs can take them into account: the travel that will cost him two weeks of rest, the additional obligation that will consume the reserve, the request that arrives at a moment of genuine depletion. Households that do not know the costs continue to make requests, and their requests are not excessive in themselves; the household is simply operating without information.

It changes the man's health behaviour. Men report with consistency that medical care, rest, and the reduction of load become easier where somebody in the household knows the position. This is the practical route by which the material of Chapter 12 becomes achievable, and it is why this chapter and Chapter 12 should be read together: the reduction of load requires the disclosure of load, and the disclosure of load is frequently blocked by the man's fear of appearing to request recognition.

20.4 The Bitter Man: How Resentment Grows

The most consequential product of unrecognised contribution is the condition that men recognise in themselves with alarm and that others notice long before: bitterness.

The Stages

Bitterness develops in six stages, and it is worth setting them out because they are recognisable and because the earlier stages are reversible at low cost.

Stage One: the accumulation. Years of competent, unacknowledged contribution. At this stage the man is not bitter and frequently not aware of any problem. His own description is that he is busy.

Stage Two: the recognition of the pattern. A specific event makes the pattern visible: someone else's contribution is thanked in his presence; a request arrives with no reference to what has been given; a family meeting is held and the man's position is not mentioned. The man's conclusion is formed: *it does not matter what I do.*

Stage Three: the withdrawal of discretionary effort. The man continues to meet his obligations, which are, after all, obligations, and ceases the contributions that were not required: the additional generosity, the readiness, the extra mile. The household notices the change, generally without understanding it, and frequently describes the man as having changed or become difficult.

Stage Four: contempt. This stage is the pivot, and it is where the condition becomes self-sustaining. Contempt is not dislike; it is the transfer of the man's grievance to the persons of his household. Its characteristic features: the internal dismissal of the wife and children as people whose acknowledgement would not be worth having; a manner that is dismissive, sarcastic, or condescending in the household and correct in public; and the construction of a private account of the family's unworthiness. Research on marital outcomes identifies contempt as one of the strongest predictors of marital dissolution, and its development here is the direct product of the previous stages.

Stage Five: the alternative audience. The man obtains the recognition elsewhere: a professional achievement, a community position, an organisation in which he is valued, a friendship, or, with some frequency, a person outside the marriage who supplies the appreciation the marriage does not. The last of these is the specific route to the situation described in Chapter 16.

Stage Six: the arrival of the material. At some point the man's obligations reduce or his circumstances change, and the material that was suppressed by the arrangement becomes available. The outcome is described in Chapter 24: a man in his late fifties, still functioning, considerably respected, and unable to describe

a single relationship in which he is valued by the people he has spent thirty years supporting.

The Signs of Bitterness in the Man

Men in Stage Four and beyond present with a recognisable set of statements and behaviours, and naming them is useful because they are frequently experienced by the man as realism.

- The public statement, made in the man's own household, that nobody appreciates anything.
- Enumerating contributions, frequently in arguments, in a manner that is defensible in content and destructive in form.
- Comparisons with other men whose families are described as more appreciative.
- A tendency to refuse requests that would previously have been accepted without comment, delivered with a specific explanation.
- The loss of pleasure in the household's achievements. A child's success is registered privately as an item that the man funded.
- A hardening in the assessment of the wife's character, from *she does not understand* to *she has never wanted to understand*.
- The construction of an audience outside the household in which the man's account of his marriage is conducted and from which the marriage is excluded.

The Cost, and the Case for Early Action

Bitterness is expensive for everybody including the man, and the expense is worth stating precisely because the condition offers an internal justification — *I have earned the right to be like this* — which is difficult to argue with from inside.

The costs are: the man's own experience of his household, which becomes a performance of duty; the loss of the marriage's intimacy, which cannot survive contempt; the children's experience of a father whose regard is conditional on the family's acknowledgement — a form of pressure described in Chapter 17; the loss of the man's own pleasure in the family's achievements; the health consequences of a decade of chronic resentment, which the research on hostility identifies as substantial, particularly for cardiovascular risk; and the loss of the years in which the arrangement could have been corrected.

The case for early action is therefore practical rather than moral: the condition is repairable at Stage One and Stage Two at the cost of one conversation, and it is repairable at Stage Six at the cost of several years of work. The measure that prevents the escalation is the subject of the next section.

20.5 Learning to State Your Own Value

This section provides the method. It is addressed to a man who has decided that the arrangement of unrecognised contribution should be corrected, and it proceeds on the assumption that the man is the party who must initiate, because the household is not aware that anything is absent.

The Four Requirements

1. The purpose must be information, not thanks. The disclosure is not a request for gratitude and should not be framed as one. Its content is the man's position, which the household does not currently hold. Men who conduct the disclosure on this basis report that the conversation is received entirely differently from the exchange they had anticipated, in which the household was required to acknowledge a debt.

2. The material must be specific and dated. Not *I have done a lot for this family* but the specific items: the years, the amounts, the decisions, the things given up. Specificity is what permits the household to know rather than to agree.

3. The delivery must be without accusation. The household has not been malicious; it has been uninformed. A disclosure delivered as an accusation produces a defence, and a defence ends the conversation. The form that works is a statement of the man's position rather than an assessment of the household's conduct, which is the same distinction as in Section 18.3.

4. The follow-up must include a request. A disclosure that supplies information and asks for nothing is informative and produces no change in the arrangement. The request should be specific, modest, and stated last: what the man wants to be different, in terms the household can supply.

The Structure of the Conversation

The conversation has five parts. It should be scheduled, held once with the household's adults rather than with the children, and limited to about forty-five minutes.

Part One: The opening statement of purpose. *I want to tell you something that I have never said and that I am not saying as a complaint. I am saying it because it has been affecting how I behave and because I do not want it to continue affecting it.*

Part Two: The record. The specific contribution, in sequence, with amounts and dates where they exist. The man should prepare this in writing and read it. Reading is not a weakness; it prevents the record from becoming an argument, and it demonstrates that the material has been considered rather than produced in the moment.

Part Three: The cost. What the contribution has required of the man: the hours, the sleep, the health items deferred, the work declined, the obligation car-

ried in secret, the years in which the household's demands and the man's capacity were mismatched. This part is the one most frequently omitted by men, and it is the part the household most needs: the record of the contribution demonstrates the household's dependence, while the cost demonstrates the man's position.

Part Four: The absence of acknowledgement, stated once and factually. *I have never been told that any of it was noticed.* The statement should be delivered without embellishment and should not be repeated in the conversation. Its function is to supply missing information, and one statement supplies it.

Part Five: The request. Two items: what the man wants to be different in the household's conduct, and what he will be changing in his own. The second should be included even where it is unwelcome, because the arrangement will not be corrected by the household alone. Examples of each:

- *I want to be told when something I have done has been useful. It does not have to be often.*
- *I want the family's decisions that concern me to be discussed with me before they are decided.*
- *I want one evening a week in which I am not managing anything.*
- *I am going to stop doing X, and I am going to tell you when I do not have the money, instead of handling it and saying nothing.*

Handling the Responses

Four responses occur, and each has a specific handling.

The response that receives it. The household acknowledges the record and agrees to the request. The corrective here is to note that this is not the only outcome that constitutes success: the objective was the supply of information, and a household that has received it may take some time to act.

The defensive response. The household responds with its own account of contribution — *do you know what I have done?* — which is frequently entirely valid. The handling is to agree with it and continue: *I know, and what you have done is not in question. I am telling you what I have carried, because you do not know it.* Men who respond to the counter-account by withdrawing their own have lost the opportunity, which will not recur for some years.

The response that converts the record into a score. *So I owe you.* The handling is a single sentence and a change of subject: *I am not keeping an account and there is nothing owed. I am telling you so that you know, and I want us to continue from here rather than from there.*

The hostile or dismissive response. This occurs, and where it occurs consistently it is information of the highest value about the household's position. It should be recorded and not argued. Section 14.6's framework then applies to the marriage, and Chapter 10's boundary method applies to the extended family.

The Man's Own Conduct Before and After

Three practices make the conversation's outcome durable.

Stop concealing the cost. From the conversation onward, the man's disclosures of what things cost should be factual and ordinary: *that month the fees took most of the income and I covered the rest from the reserve.* This is the single practice that most reliably prevents the arrangement's recurrence.

Stop reducing acknowledgements. Where an appreciation is offered, accept it, in one sentence: *thank you; it was not easy that year.* The reduction of acknowledgements is a habit and it is extinguished by the man's own practice.

Ask for what is required. A man who does not state his own requirements will be required to meet other people's. The practice is to state one requirement per month in specific terms, and to note that stating a requirement does not create a debt, which is the belief that prevents most men in this pattern from doing it.

20.6 Creating a Family Culture of Recognition

The final substantive section shifts the subject from the man to the household, because the durable correction is a practice rather than a conversation.

The Premise

Households have cultures: established ways in which members speak to each other, register each other's contributions, handle disagreement, and express regard. In most of the households examined in this book, the culture has never been chosen; it has been inherited from the households in which both parties grew up and maintained by the ordinary repetition of conduct.

The principal finding relevant to this chapter is that the culture determines who is noticed. In a household where contributions are noticed, a father's work is registered; in a household where they are not, the same work is the baseline. The difference is not the amount of gratitude in the family's character; it is whether the household has a practice.

The Practices

Six practices establish a culture of recognition. They are listed in ascending order of difficulty.

1. Naming a specific contribution once a week. The practice: each adult in the household names one specific thing another member did that made a difference. It should be specific, it should be delivered in the person's presence, and it should be brief. Men frequently find this practice artificial for two or three weeks and then report that it becomes natural and that its effect on the household is disproportionate to its size.

2. Registering cost as well as outcome. The practice: when a contribution is discussed, its cost is included. *The fees were paid; your father took two extra contracts*

to do it. This practice is the one that addresses the specific deficit of Section 20.1, which is the household's ignorance of the cost.

3. Marking the sustained contribution. The practice: an annual occasion, on a date of the household's own choosing, at which the household reviews its year and names what each member contributed. Households that adopt the practice report two effects: the sustained contribution acquires an event, and disagreements about money and fairness reduce, because the position of each member is visible.

4. Distributing the acknowledging role. The practice: recognition is not only the wife's function and not only the man's. Children should be taught to notice and to name: *what did Papa do this week that made things easier?* This practice addresses the transmission described in the introduction: children who are taught to notice will notice in their own households.

5. Reciprocity in the acknowledgement of the man's own contributions to himself. The practice: the man's contributions to his own maintenance — the medical appointment, the rest, the reduction of an obligation — are treated by the household as contributions rather than as withdrawals. This is the practice that makes the material of Chapters 12 and 18 sustainable, and its absence is the reason that men who adopt healthier arrangements frequently abandon them: the household responds to the change as a loss.

6. The household's account of the past. The practice: the household tells its own story including the difficulty. Children who know that a specific year was hard, and what the parents did in it, inherit a usable account of their family, which is the material of Section 17.6, and, in the specific context of this chapter, a knowledge of what was contributed and by whom.

What Not to Do

Three practices should be avoided, because each is common and each is counterproductive.

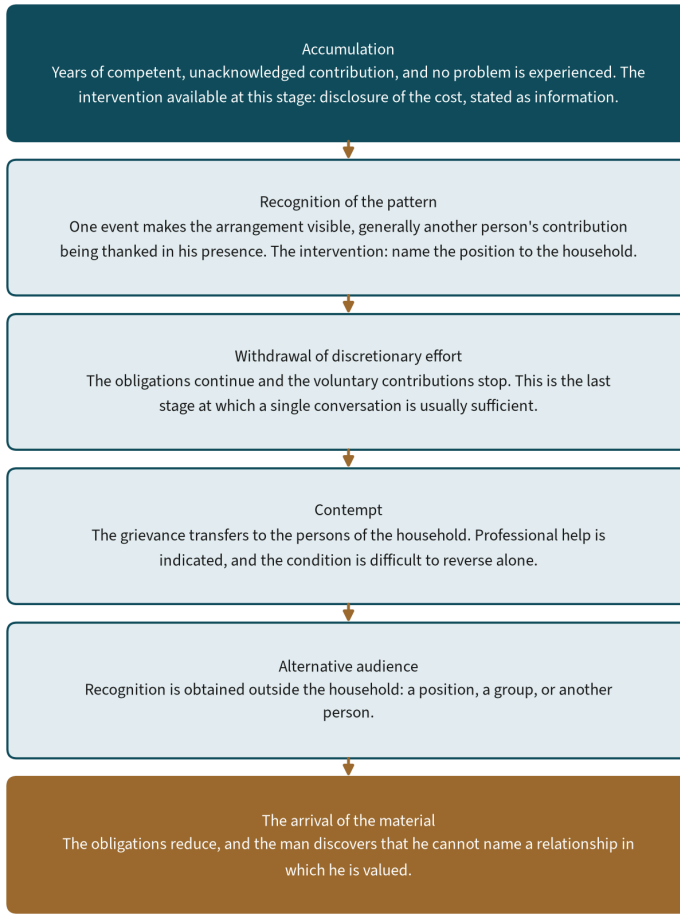
Do not institute a set of formal gratefulness rituals with a recalcitrant household. A practice that is imposed on an unwilling household produces compliance without knowledge and becomes, within weeks, another item of administration.

Do not use the practice as a forum for accounts. Where the weekly practice becomes a mechanism for submitting complaints, the household will discontinue it and the man will conclude that recognition is not wanted, which will confirm the ledger.

Do not require the acknowledgement to be in the form the man prefers. Men frequently want a specific form — spoken words, a particular occasion, a public statement — and reject other forms. Where a household's acknowledge-

ment arrives as a cooked meal, an appreciated visit, or a change in the children's conduct toward the man, it should be received as acknowledgement.

Figure 20.1 sets out the six stages by which unacknowledged contribution becomes bitterness, together with the intervention available at each stage. The diagram is illustrative; the stages are frequently traversed more quickly in some households than others, and the point of identifying a stage is to establish which intervention remains available.



Each stage is described first; the intervention that remains available at that stage follows it.

Figure 20.1 From unacknowledged contribution to bitterness. Each stage is described first, and the intervention that remains available at that stage follows it. The window for the low-cost intervention closes at Stage Three.

20.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Thanked at the Funeral

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family practice, counselling, and the research literature on family functioning and marital contempt.

Obinna is fifty-six, a pharmacist who owns a single retail outlet in a mid-sized city, married to Chidinma for thirty years, with four children between the ages of twenty and twenty-nine.

The case was presented in counselling that Obinna had entered after a specific incident. His elder brother had died in the previous year, and Obinna had, over a period of about nine months, managed the brother's affairs: the hospital arrangements, the funeral, the settlement of the brother's debts, the transfer of a property to the brother's widow and children, and a dispute with a tenant that required the involvement of lawyers. He had paid approximately 2.8 million naira of the expenses himself, which represented most of the reserve that he and Chidinma had accumulated over four years.

At the funeral, three speakers thanked him by name. At the family meeting held a month afterwards to conclude the brother's affairs, the extended family's senior member thanked him again, publicly and at length, in the presence of his wife and two of his children. Obinna described the moment precisely: *I stood there being thanked for my brother by people I see twice a year, while my wife and my children sat in chairs four metres away and said nothing, which they have said for thirty years.*

The history that emerged over the following sessions had five components.

First, Obinna had been the household's sole earner from the third year of the marriage, after Chidinma's employment had ended with a business failure. He had funded: the education of four children to university level; the purchase and later the extension of the family house, which was in his name alone; the medical expenses of Chidinma's parents until both died; a substantial part of his own parents' care; the fees of two nephews; and, over eleven years, a series of unrecovered loans to three friends, one of which had funded the brother's business.

Second, none of the costs had ever been disclosed. Chidinma knew the household's income approximately and did not know: the size of the loans, the extent of the reserve's use, the two occasions on which Obinna had borrowed to meet the household's obligations, or the fact that he had declined an expansion of the pharmacy that he had wanted for a decade because the reserve had been consumed by obligations.

Third, the visible contributions of others were acknowledged and his were not. A sister who had provided food and organised the funeral's catering was thanked repeatedly for years in family conversations. Obinna's 2.8 million was, in the family's account, what was expected of him, and he had not mentioned the sum to anybody, including his wife, at the time.

Fourth, the internal sequence described in Section 20.4 had been completed. Obinna's account identified the stages precisely: the accumulation; the recognition of the pattern at his brother's funeral; the withdrawal of discretionary effort, which he described as his ceasing to offer assistance to his wife's family in a period when he had previously always offered; contempt, which he described in the following terms: *I had reached the point where I did not care what any of them thought of me, and I was correct and courteous in the house and I had nothing for them*; and the alternative audience, which took the form of the community's development association, in which he had become an office-holder and in which, in his own description, he had been valued for the first time in twenty years.

Fifth, the children had observed the sequence. His second daughter, in a conversation that formed part of the case, described her father as follows: *He paid for everything. He was not unkind. He was never pleased with anything, and I have never in my life seen him happy about anything we did. If I got a first-class result he complained about the fees. I learned not to tell him things.*

The intervention consisted of three elements, and Obinna's assessment of their relative value is worth recording because it differs from the sequence in which they were conducted.

The first element was the disclosure, conducted with Chidinma and, separately, with the four children, in the structure of Section 20.5: the record, the cost, the statement that nothing had been noticed, and the request. Its reception varied. Chidinma's response was the defensive counter-account — *do you know what I have carried in this house?* — which was accurate in substance: she had managed the household's administration, the children's education, and the care of three elderly relatives without assistance. Obinna's handling of the counter-account, which the counsellor had prepared him for, was to agree with it and to continue, and this was the single most important action of the whole case. His children's responses ranged from a daughter's tears to a son's question of whether the loans had been repaid.

The second element was conducted with the household's adults and took a different form: a written statement of the household's financial position, historical and current, including the decline of the reserve and the reason. Obinna described this as the measure that produced the most change in the household's conduct, because it gave Chidinma and the adult children a picture of what had been happening for eleven years and removed the assumption that the household's position was comfortable.

The third element was the household's practice: the weekly naming of a specific contribution and, at the review, the inclusion of cost alongside outcome. Obinna described the practice as artificial for the first month and as the reason that the arrangement did not revert, and he identified one specific effect: his daughter's statement — *I learned not to tell him things* — was raised in a household conversation in the fourth month, and the conversation that followed was, in his account, the first of his adult life with his children.

> His summary, two years later, was: *I was thanked by everybody except the people who had received the most. I did not want thanks. I wanted them to know what it had cost, and I had spent thirty years being careful that they should not know.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The contribution was acknowledged outside and not inside the household. The extended family's public thanks, offered at a funeral and at a meeting, contrasted with thirty years of silence at home. This asymmetry is common and it explains why men in this pattern are frequently more valued by their communities than by their households: the community sees the occasional contribution, which is an event; the household sees the sustained contribution, which is the baseline.

The wife's counter-account was entirely valid. Chidinma had carried the household's administration and the care of three elderly relatives, and she had done so without acknowledgement of a different kind. The case's central action was Obinna's agreement with her counter-account, followed by the continuation of his own. A man who treats the counter-account as an evasion will convert the exchange into a competition, and the outcome of a competition of that kind is that both parties withdraw.

The undisclosed financial position was the operative concealment. Not the man's feelings and not the household's conduct, but eleven years of a declining reserve, presented to the household as a stable position. Its disclosure changed the household's behaviour in a manner that no amount of conversation about recognition could have produced, because a household that does not know its position makes requests in good faith that the household's position cannot support.

Contempt had been reached, and its cost was visible in the children. Obinna's account of his own state at Stage Four, and his daughter's description of a father who was never pleased, are the same fact described from two sides. The research on marital contempt and its effects is directly relevant, and the case's most important consequence was not the change in Obinna's marriage but the conversation with his children in the fourth month.

The alternative audience was already established. The community association had been supplying the recognition the household did not, and the case's work therefore included the reduction of that dependence. Men in this pattern frequently hold positions in organisations where they are valued, and the positions are frequently treated as hobbies; in this case, the pattern was identified as a substitute for a relationship, and its role was reduced deliberately.

20.8 Practical Exercise: The Contribution Inventory and the Statement of Position

This exercise has two parts and takes about three hours in total, spread over two sittings.

Part One: The Inventory

Write out, in specific and dated terms, what you have contributed over the last ten years. Use the following table and add rows as required.

The contribution	To whom	The years	The financial value, if any	The cost to me, specifically

Include: income provided and the obligations it met; education funded; medical expenses met; loans made and their recovery; properties purchased or maintained; guarantees given; assistance to extended family; disputes mediated; care provided; work declined and opportunities not taken; health and rest deferred.

The fourth and fifth columns are the ones that matter. Men completing this exercise frequently discover that the financial value of the contribution is larger than they had estimated and that the cost has never been totalled at all.

Part Two: The Silence Audit

For each contribution, mark the level of the household's knowledge.

Contribution	Nobody knows	Somebody knows the fact but not the cost	The household knows the fact and the cost

Then answer three questions.

- What proportion of the contribution falls in the first column?
- Who, specifically, does not know — and why have they not been told?
- Which single item, if known, would most change the household's conduct?

Part Three: The Stage Assessment

From Section 20.4, identify your current stage and the evidence for it.

Stage	Present?	Evidence
One: accumulation		
Two: recognition of the pattern		
Three: withdrawal of discretionary effort		
Four: contempt		
Five: alternative audience		

Stage	Present?	Evidence
Six: arrival of the material		

Where Stage Four or above is present, the disclosure in Section 20.5 should be conducted within the month, and professional support should be considered, because contempt is a condition of the relationship rather than a feeling the man is having, and it is difficult to reverse alone.

Part Four: The Statement of Position

Prepare the five parts of the conversation in writing.

1. **Purpose:** one sentence, stating that the material is information and not a complaint.
2. **The record:** the items from the inventory, in sequence, with the figures.
3. **The cost:** what the contribution has required of you, including the health items, the work declined, and the years of secret management.
4. **The absence:** one factual sentence stating that it has not been noticed.
5. **The request:** what you want to be different in the household's conduct, and what you will be changing in your own.

Then specify: the person or persons, the date, the place, and the duration. Rehearse it once with somebody who is not a member of the household.

Part Five: The Household Practice

Specify two practices from Section 20.6, in writing, with dates on which they begin.

Practice	Who is involved	Frequency	Beginning

Part Six: The Reciprocity Check

Answer the following, honestly, before conducting the statement of position.

- What does each member of my household contribute that I have never acknowledged?
- When did I last name a specific contribution made by my wife, by each child, or by a relative?
- Which of my household's contributions have I registered as their baseline rather than as contributions?

The answers are not a reason to withhold the statement; they are the material of the reciprocal practice that accompanies it. A household in which recognition runs in one direction is a household in which it does not run at all.

20.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it not weak to need to be told that I am appreciated?"

The framing is the obstacle. The requirement being described in this chapter is not for reassurance; it is for the household's knowledge of its own position. A household that does not know what its arrangements cost cannot make informed decisions about them, and the man's concealment of the cost — which is the common alternative — has produced the situation described in Chapters 9 and 10. Stated that way, the statement of position is a management action rather than a request for comfort, and men find it easier to perform in those terms.

"I told her and it turned into a quarrel about what she has done. What now?"

Return to the conversation with the handling in Section 20.5: acknowledge her account in full and without defence, then continue with your own. The two accounts are not in competition, and the fact that hers is valid does not make yours invalid. Where the quarrel repeats across several attempts, the pattern is information about the marriage rather than about the subject, and Section 14.6 applies.

"My children are adults and have their own lives. Is there any point?"

Yes, and the form changes. With adult children the statement of position is generally unnecessary; what is required is the disclosure of the man's position, conducted once, and the establishment of a practice of contact that is not confined to assistance. Adult children who discover, at forty, what their father was carrying at fifty frequently revise their account of him, and the revision is worth the conversation.

"Does this not amount to asking for gratitude, which is precisely what I was taught not to do?"

The distinction is between requiring gratitude and supplying information. Information is supplied; gratitude is not required. Households that have been given the information frequently respond with gratitude, and that response is welcome and is not the purpose. Where no response occurs, the man has lost nothing: he has corrected the household's account of its own position, which is a gain on its own terms and which improves the household's decisions.

"What if the household genuinely does not care?"

Then the finding is important, and it bears on the decisions in Chapters 14 and 15. Men in this position describe a useful test: the household's response to the disclosure, in particular its response to the second and third attempts after any initial defensiveness has passed. A household that does not care can be distinguished from a household that is uninformed, and the distinction determines what the man does next.

"I am not good at speaking. Can I write it?"

Yes, and written form has specific advantages: the record can be read without distortion, the figures can be checked, and the exchange does not depend on the

man's composure. The practice recommended in Section 20.5 is that the record is written and read aloud, and the read-aloud element matters, because a document handed over is a delivery and a document read is a statement.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 20 in brief. Being taken for granted is distinct from the absence of praise. Recognition is the household's knowledge that a contribution exists; appreciation is its valuation; gratitude is its expression. What men most commonly lack is the first, and the experience has seven features: regular and therefore invisible work; no occasion attached to the contribution; discussion of deficits but not of surpluses; no discussion of the man's own affairs; acknowledgement of occasional contributions by others while the sustained contribution goes unmentioned; requests made without reference to what has already been provided; and the impossibility of raising any of it without appearing to request praise.

Three of the mechanisms are operated by the man, and they should be stated before the household is assessed: he conceals the cost, he declines the acknowledgements that are offered, and he does not describe what he wants. Sacrifice is uniquely invisible because it has no output, is indistinguishable from what the man would have done anyway, is rarely announced — since announcing it would create an obligation — and is eventually reconstructed by the man himself as an ordinary decision.

Unrecognised contribution accumulates into a ledger whose effects are selective attention to deficits, disproportionate reactions, the withdrawal of goodwill, and a grievance that cannot be raised. Bitterness develops in six stages: accumulation, recognition of the pattern, withdrawal of discretionary effort, contempt, the alternative audience, and the arrival of the material when the obligations reduce. Contempt is the pivot and the most damaging stage; it is one of the strongest predictors of marital dissolution and it is difficult to reverse alone. The condition is repairable at Stage One or Two with one conversation and at Stage Six only with years of work.

Stating one's own value requires four conditions: the purpose must be information rather than thanks; the material must be specific and dated; the delivery must be without accusation; and the statement must conclude with a specific request. The conversation has five parts — purpose, record, cost, the absence of acknowledgement stated once, and the request — and the expected responses are receipt, defence, conversion into a score, and hostility, each of which has a specific handling. Three practices make the outcome durable: stop concealing the cost, stop reducing acknowledgements, and state requirements as they arise.

A durable correction is a household practice rather than a conversation. Six practices establish a culture of recognition: naming a specific contribution weekly; registering cost alongside outcome; marking the sustained contribution annually; distributing the acknowledging role to children; treating the man's own maintenance as a contribution rather than a withdrawal; and telling the household's story including its difficulty. Three practices should be avoided: formal rituals imposed on an unwilling

household, using the practice as a forum for accounts, and requiring acknowledgement to arrive in a preferred form.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete Part Two. What proportion of your contribution does nobody know about? Which single item, if known, would most change your household's conduct?
2. When did you last reduce or deflect an acknowledgement that was offered to you? What did you say, and what did it cost the record?
3. Which contribution of your own have you registered as somebody else's baseline — and which contribution of somebody else's have you done the same to?
4. From the six stages in Section 20.4, where are you? If you are at Stage Four, what has contempt cost you in the last two years?
5. What is your alternative audience, and how much of your requirement does it satisfy? What would it look like if that audience were the only one that knew you?
6. Write the five parts of the statement of position in Part Four, and answer: what single sentence of it is most difficult to say aloud? Say that sentence to one person this week.
7. Which two household practices will you establish, with whom, and beginning on what date? What will you do if the household receives them with indifference?

Further Reading

- **On social exchange within families:** the research on equity and reciprocity in intimate relationships, including the findings on the association between perceived inequity, satisfaction, and stability, and the evidence on the effects of unrecognised contribution on relationship outcomes.
- **On housework, invisible labour, and its distribution:** the literature on the distribution of unpaid work within households, including the findings on the visibility of different forms of labour and the perceived fairness of the distribution.
- **On contempt and marital outcomes:** the observation research identifying contempt as a predictor of relationship dissolution, together with the experimental literature on the effects of contemptuous communication on the person receiving it.

- **On hostility and health:** the research associating chronic hostility and anger with cardiovascular risk and other health outcomes, including the findings on resentment as a distinct and measurable construct.
- **On appreciation and prosocial behaviour:** the literature on gratitude and the expression of appreciation as influences on behaviour within families, including experimental findings on the effects of expressions of appreciation on relationship maintenance.
- **Practical resources:** structured communication and marriage enrichment programmes, which generally include an explicit practice of expressing appreciation; the material in Appendices H and I; and Chapters 15 and 17, which address the marital arrangement and the paternal role in their respective forms.

PART VI

The Private Battles of Identity and Self-Worth

The conflicts between who a man is and who he is expected to become

21 CHAPTER

The Man in the Mirror

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the image a man presents to the world, identify how it is constructed and maintained, and assess its cost in his own life.
2. Analyse the gap between the presented image and the man's private account of himself, and explain why the gap widens over time.
3. Explain the structure of private shame and the fear of exposure, including the specific behaviours that shame produces in men.
4. Describe the obstacles that prevent men from accepting themselves, and distinguish acceptance from resignation and from lowering standards.
5. Apply a structured method for facing the truth about himself without self-destruction, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.
6. Construct a specific and dated plan for becoming the man he intends to be, rather than the man the image requires.

Introduction

A man stands in front of a mirror at the end of a working day. There is nothing unusual in the scene: he is tired, he is unshaven, he is dressed in the clothes he wore to the office. But look at what he is doing. He is not examining his appearance. He is conducting an assessment, and the assessment is familiar to him.

It runs as follows. He notes that he is fifty-one, that he is carrying weight around the middle, that the shirt he is wearing was bought when he earned less and cared more. He notes that the man who looks back at him does not correspond to the account he gives to others: the man who is managing, who knows what he is doing, whose household is in order, whose judgement is sound. He notes one specific item — a decision made badly, an obligation unmet, a thing done that nobody knows about, a failure that he has not disclosed. And he concludes the assessment in the usual manner, which is not with a plan but with a sentence: *this is not who I was supposed to be.*

This chapter is about the man in the mirror: the private assessment that men conduct, the gap between the account they present and the account they hold, the shame that lives in that gap, and the question of what can be done about it.

Its premise is that the gap is normal and its size is not. Every adult presents a version of themselves; the difference between a functioning life and an intolerable one is not the existence of the gap but whether the man can acknowledge it, whether anything in his life permits him to be seen as he actually is, and whether the gap is closing or widening. For a great many men, the gap widens for thirty years, and the widening is not detected until the assessment at the mirror produces something more serious than discomfort.

The chapter proceeds in six sections. Sections 21.1 and 21.2 examine the image and the gap. Section 21.3 examines shame and the fear of exposure, which is the mechanism that prevents the gap from being closed. Section 21.4 examines the obstacles to self-acceptance. Sections 21.5 and 21.6 set out the work: facing the truth without destroying oneself, and constructing a plan for becoming the man one intends to be.

21.1 The Image a Man Presents to the World

The image a man presents is not a lie and it is not a mask in the ordinary sense of a disguise. It is a selection, made continuously and mostly without deliberation, of the material that can be safely shown. It is assembled from four components.

The Four Components

1. The record of accomplishments. The position held, the property acquired, the children educated, the contributions made, the crisis managed. This material is factual, it is legitimately the man's, and it constitutes the greater part of the image.

2. The competence in the present. The appearance of knowing what to do: the confident answer, the decision delivered without visible hesitation, the handling of a matter without appearing to find it difficult. This component is performed continuously and its performance is frequently confused by others, and sometimes by the man, with the underlying state.

3. The absence of need. The image contains no requirements. The man who presents it does not ask for help, does not appear uncertain, does not require reassurance, and does not disclose what he is carrying. The absence is not produced by deceit; it is produced by the prohibition described in Chapter 2, which operates even where a man is willing to speak.

4. The management of appearance. The visible markers: the clothing, the vehicle, the household's presentation, the children's institutions, the contributions made in public. This component is the most easily mistaken for vanity, and it is more often a form of accuracy as the man understands it: the markers are the

language in which his position is legible to his community, and their maintenance is frequently a requirement of the position rather than a preference of the man.

How the Image Is Maintained

The maintenance consumes a substantial quantity of a man's daily effort, and the effort is invisible because it is continuous.

By selective disclosure. The man reports the items that fit and omits the items that do not. The operation is performed in every conversation: at work, at family gatherings, at community functions, and, in the more advanced cases, at home.

By the management of information about the household. The children's difficulties, the marriage's conditions, the financial position, the state of the man's health. Each is disclosed in the form that the image can absorb.

By the avoidance of situations in which the gap would be visible. Men in this pattern decline invitations to occasions where the household's position would be examined, avoid the company of those who know an earlier version of them, and reduce contact with the relatives who are aware of the material that the image excludes.

By the replenishment of the image. The maintenance of an image requires material. Where the position does not move, the image weakens, and the man responds by acquiring: the vehicle, the obligation performed conspicuously, the contribution made larger than the budget permits. Chapter 9′s account of the maintained standard in financial terms is the same mechanism applied to the whole of a man's presentation.

By the conversion of the image into a standard. The most consequential form of maintenance, and the one that produces this chapter's subject. A man who presents the image for long enough begins to measure himself against it, and the measurement is conducted without mercy, because the image was constructed for public consumption and cannot be satisfied in private.

What the Image Costs

Four costs, all of them documented in men's accounts.

The exhaustion of maintenance. The continuous effort of presenting a version of the self requires energy that is not available for anything else, and men in this pattern describe a permanent low-grade fatigue that is distinct from overwork: the fatigue of being always legible, always composed, and always available.

The exclusion of support. The image contains no need, and a man who presents no need receives no support. The mechanism is described in Chapter 2.4 and its consequences are described throughout Part I.

The escalation of the requirement. The image is comparative and public, as Chapter 11 established, and its standard rises as the reference group does. A man

who obtained his position through the performance of the image will find that the performance's requirement increases without his consent.

The impossibility of intimacy within it. A person can only be known to the extent that they are visible. A man whose presentation is a selection cannot be known by anybody who has only the presentation to work with, and the closest relationships are therefore conducted in a permanent partial visibility that both parties experience as a limitation they cannot name.

21.2 The Gap Between the Image and the Man

The gap is the difference between what a man shows and what he holds. It is worth defining precisely, because most men experience the gap as a general dissatisfaction and cannot identify its content, which prevents them from doing anything about it.

The Contents of the Gap

A man's private account contains material that falls into six categories. The gap is the distance between what he shows and what is in these categories.

1. Failures that are not disclosed. The business that failed, the examination that was not passed, the job that was lost, the debt that was defaulted, the decision that was made badly, the child who has not prospered as expected.

2. Conduct that the man regrets. Not only the large items — an infidelity, a concealment, a moment of cruelty, a betrayal of somebody's confidence, an act in a period of desperation — but the ordinary and persistent items: the years of absence, the anger directed at the wrong people, the promise not kept, the relative neglected, the parent whose calls were not answered.

3. States the man is in. The fear, the exhaustion, the depression, the grief, the loneliness, the sense of having become someone he does not recognise. Chapter 3′s material and Chapter 6′s apply in full.

4. Facts about the man's household. The state of the marriage, the children's difficulties, the financial position, one member's conduct, the family's position in the community.

5. Doubts about the man's own competence. The private assessment that the position is held by luck, that the work is not understood, that exposure is a matter of time. This category is universal among men in positions of responsibility and it is described in detail in Chapter 8.

6. The man's estimate of himself. The conclusion at the bottom of the assessment: that he is not as good as people believe, that he has not done what he should have done, that he is a fraud, that the man others respect does not exist.

Why the Gap Widens

The gap widens through five mechanisms, and each is worth naming because each admits a different intervention.

Time. Every year adds material to the private account and, in most cases, adds no material to the public presentation, which was fixed at a particular standard and is maintained rather than revised.

The accumulation of unspoken items. Each undisclosed item makes the next disclosure more expensive, because the disclosure of a new matter would expose the existence of the previous ones. The mechanism is the same as in Chapter 9′s account of deferred disclosure and in Chapter 15′s account of the unspoken ledger.

The increase of responsibility. A man's obligations grow as his household and his position develop, and the image's requirements grow with them, while his capacity to meet them is reduced by age, health, and the accumulated cost of maintenance.

The absence of any corrective relationship. Where nothing exists that can reflect the man's actual state — no confidant, no group, no professional relationship, no wife who knows — the private account is never corrected, and errors in it are never revised. Men whose self-assessment is most damaging are frequently those with the fewest relationships in which it might be tested.

The comparison with an imagined standard. The gap is measured not against the man's actual capacities and circumstances but against the version of himself that the image promised. Since the promise was always calibrated higher than the man's conditions allowed, the gap widens automatically.

The Gap in Three Populations

The gap appears in a specific form in three groups of men, and identifying them is useful because each is frequently assumed to be free of the condition.

The successful man. The man whose position is publicly respected and whose private account records the failures, the compromises, and the concealments that produced it. His characteristic fear is exposure, and his characteristic statement is that people would think differently of him if they knew.

The man who has done nothing conspicuous. The man of ordinary means whose private account contains the sense of having not become what he should have become. His characteristic fear is assessment by the people who knew him young, and his characteristic statement is a comparison between himself and a contemporary.

The man who has carried out of duty something that has damaged him. The man whose private account contains the material of Chapters 9, 17, and 19: the household supported at the cost of the man's health, the ambition abandoned,

the childhood spent working. His characteristic fear is that the account will be converted into an accusation, and his characteristic statement, made rarely, is that he does not know who he is apart from what he has carried.

The Consequence of the Widening

Three consequences follow. The first is **the progressive reduction of what the man permits to be known**, described in Chapter 14, which eventually removes the possibility of being known at all. The second is **the escalation of behaviour that defends the image**, including the material in Chapter 9 and the patterns in Chapter 23. The third is **the arrival of an event that makes the gap unavoidable**: a collapse, a diagnosis, a separation, a loss of employment, a child's crisis — at which point the man's presentation and his position become visibly different, and the response is frequently severe, because the man has no practice in being seen.

> **KEY POINT**
> The gap between the presented image and the man's private account is universal. Its size is not. What determines the size is not the quantity of the man's failures but whether anything in his life permits him to be known as he actually is — and whether the gap is being measured against his circumstances or against a standard the image invented.

21.3 Private Shame and the Fear of Exposure

Shame is the subject that organises the second half of this chapter, and it requires a definition because it is frequently confused with guilt.

Guilt and Shame

Guilt concerns an act: what I did was wrong, and the remedy is repair, restitution, or amendment. Guilt is specific, and it is addressed by action.

Shame concerns the self: what I am is inadequate, and there is no remedy by action, because the object of the judgement is the person rather than the conduct. Shame is general, and its characteristic response is concealment.

The distinction is practically decisive. A man who feels guilt about an undisclosed failure can be moved to disclosure by the argument that the disclosure will end the guilt. A man who feels shame cannot be moved by that argument, because the disclosure will expose the person, and exposure is precisely what shame requires him to avoid. This is why exhortations to openness fail with men whose difficulty is shame: the advice addresses guilt and the condition is shame.

The Features of Shame in Men

Six features are consistently reported.

1. The conviction of being different. The man believes that his difficulty is not shared: that other men manage, that his failures are of a kind that others do not have, that the disclosure would place him outside the group. The conviction is almost always factually false — the research on male secrecy consistently finds that the material men conceal most thoroughly is material that nearly all of them hold — and its falsity does not reduce its force, because the man's access to evidence has been closed by the concealment itself.

2. The belief in exposure as catastrophe. The man's assessment of the consequences of being known is total: that the household would reject him, that the community would withdraw, that his position would end. The assessment is rarely tested and is almost always overstated, as Chapters 12 and 16 both establish.

3. The performance of the correct version. Not the ordinary maintenance of an image but the active projection of a particular man: the generous one, the competent one, the settled one, the devout or the principled one. The performance consumes energy and produces a specific and characteristic distance: the man's relationships are pleasant and shallow, and he is frequently described by others as a fine person who is difficult to know.

4. Anger at the prospect of exposure. The most visible feature to others, and the one that most damages households. Where a matter approaches the material in the account, the man turns the subject, attacks the messenger, or withdraws. Chapters 2.3 and 14 describe the mechanism; the point here is that the anger is the response of shame rather than of guilt, and that it is often the man's most visible signal that shame is present.

5. Contempt for those who are seen. A specific and revealing feature: the man who is ashamed frequently expresses contempt for people who disclose, who fail publicly, or who require help. The contempt is a defence, and its recognition by the man himself is frequently the point at which the material becomes visible to him.

6. The impossibility of receiving. A man in shame cannot receive anything, because receiving requires an acknowledgement of need, and the acknowledgement confirms the material. The feature is described in Chapters 19 and 20 in other contexts, and it appears here as the principal obstacle to the recovery of the man's relationships.

What Shame Produces

Five behaviours are produced, and they include the material of the earlier parts of this book.

Concealment. The defining behaviour, described throughout.

Compensation. Over-achievement, conspicuous generosity, the assumption of obligations, and the constant demonstration described in Chapter 2.3. Com-

pensation is not hypocrisy; it is an attempt to be worth what the man does not believe he is.

Avoidance. Of the relationships, occasions, and subjects in which exposure is possible.

Attack. Anger at the person, frequently a wife, who has come closest to the material. The pattern produces the phenomenon frequently reported by counsellors: the wife's account of the marriage contains material that the husband denies, and her account is correct.

Collapse into conduct. Alcohol, sexual conduct, risk, spending, work — the material of Chapter 23. Where shame cannot be reduced by disclosure or by compensation, it is anaesthetised.

The Route Out of Shame

Shame is reduced by one mechanism, and it is universal across clinical approaches: **exposure to a safe person, in graduated doses, with the outcome recorded.** The mechanism is not catharsis; it is evidence. Shame claims that the man's material cannot be known and that its disclosure would end his standing. The evidence that this claim is false is produced by disclosing a small item to a safe person and observing that nothing occurred.

The practical sequence, in the order given in the exercise at the end of this chapter:

1. **Select one item of low weight.** Not the central matter: a failure, an ordinary regret, a condition, a period of difficulty.
2. **Select one person and check the safety.** The criteria: has the person kept confidences in the past, and does the person have no stake in the material?
3. **Disclose in structured form.** The four sentences: what occurred, what it has cost, why you are saying it, and what you are asking for — which may be nothing.
4. **Record the outcome in writing.** What the person said, what happened to the relationship, and what happened to the man's assessment of the item after the disclosure.
5. **Graduate.** Where the outcome matches the report, select a heavier item. Where the outcome is worse than reported, analyse what occurred — it is frequently a matter of the person chosen rather than of the disclosure — and repeat with a different person before concluding that the material is unshareable.

The sequence is the treatment. Its value depends on its being graduated, written down, and repeated; and the men who complete it report a specific and characteristic outcome: not that the shame ends, but that its claim about the consequences

of being known is demonstrated to be false, which reduces its force by a large margin.

21.4 The Struggle to Accept Who You Are

Self-acceptance is a subject that attracts two errors and this section disposes of both before setting out what the work actually consists of.

What Self-Acceptance Is Not

It is not resignation. Resignation says that the material is unacceptable and unchangeable, and it produces inertia. Acceptance is compatible with a plan; it is the precondition of one, because a man cannot change what he will not examine.

It is not the lowering of standards. Standards concern conduct and outcomes; acceptance concerns the man's relationship to his own history. A man may accept what he has done and hold a high standard for what he does next, and the combination is the ordinary condition of an adult.

It is not a feeling. Men frequently report that they cannot accept themselves because they do not feel acceptance. Acceptance is a position rather than a feeling: it consists of holding the facts about oneself without either concealing them or being destroyed by them, and it is frequently experienced as a lack of drama rather than as warmth.

The Six Obstacles

Each obstacle below is common in men, and each is addressable.

1. The over-developed standard. A man whose standard for himself is global, personal, and permanent, as described in Chapter 8, cannot accept anything, because the standard is not satisfiable. The route is not the reduction of the standard but the conversion of it into specific and achievable items.

2. The comparison mechanism. Acceptance requires a man to hold his own account, and comparison requires him to hold a position relative to others. The two cannot be operated simultaneously. Chapter 11's work on a personal reference point is the intervention.

3. The rejection of what the man actually is. Where the man's own character, temperament, capacities, or interests do not match the script he was given, he frequently treats his material as a defect. The test in Chapter 2 is relevant: which elements of the script does the man hold deliberately, and which does he hold because they were applied to him?

4. The confusion of acceptance with giving up. Men frequently resist acceptance because they believe that the discomfort is the mechanism of their performance. The belief is not unfounded: many men have achieved what they have by the reliable operation of a hard standard. What they have not established, and what the research on motivation indicates, is that the discomfort is necessary

for the standard to operate. Men who replace self-directed hostility with a specific and maintainable standard consistently report an improvement in output alongside the improvement in mood.

5. The absence of any experience of being known. A man cannot accept himself against nothing. Acceptance is a relational act as well as an internal one, and men in this pattern characteristically discover that the work becomes possible only after somebody has been given an accurate account. This is the connection between this chapter and Chapters 4 and 14.

6. The shame described in Section 21.3. The final obstacle and the largest. Its route out is the graduated disclosure described above.

What Acceptance Actually Requires

Four items, in the order in which men generally find them attainable.

An accurate inventory. A written statement of what the man is and what he has done: the capacities, the failures, the periods, the conduct, the circumstances. Its purpose is the replacement of a vague and unfavourable impression with a specific record. In the author's observation, this exercise produces the single most reliable change in men whose difficulty is a general sense of inadequacy, because the specific record is almost always more defensible than the general impression.

A distinction between what is his and what arrived. A substantial proportion of what men hold with shame concerns circumstances, other people's conduct, and the economic and familial conditions of their lives. The distinction should be made explicitly: which items on the inventory are my conduct, and which are what happened to me?

A distinction between what can be changed and what is concluded. The inventory should be divided into three parts: what is an open matter, what is amendable at a cost the man is willing to pay, and what is concluded. Concluded matters are not thereby approved; they are closed, which means that they no longer occupy the position of an open item.

One accurate account given to one person. The measure that converts the inventory from a private document into a fact about the man's life. Its purpose is not permission and not absolution; it is the demonstration that the material can be held by somebody else.

Where Acceptance Is Not Possible

One caution is necessary. Where a man's difficulty is a depressive condition, the attempt to accept himself will be conducted in a state that makes acceptance feel like exposure, and the work should follow treatment rather than precede it, as Chapter 6 established. Where the man's inventory contains serious conduct — violence, serious harm to another person, abuse — the work requires professional support, and the guidance in Appendix C is the correct point of entry.

21.5 Facing the Truth Without Self-Destruction

The risk in this chapter's material is a specific one: that a man who examines his private account, without the structure described here, will conduct the examination as the internal critic conducts it, and will reach the conclusion that the account confirms what he feared. Men who complete the work well do so with four protections in place.

The Four Protections

1. The examination is conducted in writing, not in thought. Thinking about one's own failures is the activity described in Chapter 8 as rumination: it is general, repeated, and it produces no output. Writing produces an inventory, which is specific, finite, and available for classification. The difference between the two is the difference between the whole of this section's method and the process that men have already attempted unsuccessfully.

2. The account is classified before it is assessed. The three-way classification in Section 21.4 — open, amendable, concluded — and the two-way distinction between the man's conduct and what arrived. These are mechanical operations, they take about an hour, and they prevent the material from being held as a single undifferentiated mass, which is what makes it crushing.

3. The examination is bounded and time-limited. Two sittings, of about ninety minutes each, with a defined end. The material is examined in a defined period and then closed for a week. The bound is not a refusal to face the truth; it is the condition under which facing it produces work rather than despair.

4. The examination concludes with specific items. Every part of the inventory must produce one of three outputs: a fact that requires no action, an item with a specific action and a date, or a matter that requires professional assistance. An inventory that concludes without items has produced a verdict rather than a plan, and verdicts are the product of the critic.

The Method

Sitting One: The record.

Four columns, completed without evaluation.

What is in my private account	Whose conduct is this?	Open, amendable, or concluded?	What does it require?

The third column is completed after the first, never during it. Men who attempt to classify while recording will spend the sitting producing conclusions rather than records.

Between sittings. Do nothing with the material except keep the document. This interval is deliberate: it allows the material's emotional weight to settle, and

men frequently find that a large proportion of it is less significant than it appeared while it was being written.

Sitting Two: The plan.

For each row marked *open* or *amendable*, specify the action and the date. The actions fall into a small number of kinds: a disclosure, a repair, a payment, an apology, an appointment, a change of practice, a conversation, a decision. For rows marked *concluded*, write the single sentence that closes them: *that is what occurred; it is finished; I am not required to revisit it.*

The Three Practices After the Examination

1. The re-reading. Read the inventory at two months, six months, and one year. Its value is specific: the re-reading demonstrates the movement of the *open* items into *concluded*, which is the evidence that the account is a changing document rather than a permanent verdict. Men frequently report that the second reading, not the first, produced the change.

2. The counter-record. A second document, kept alongside, of the man's genuine capacities, contributions, and conduct of which he is not ashamed. This is not an exercise in affirmation; it is a correction of the inventory's natural bias, which is that a man records failures and does not record the ordinary and substantial good that he has done and continues to do. The counter-record should be specific and it should include the material that other people would identify if asked.

3. The disclosure of one item. The item selected in the graduated process of Section 21.3, conducted within the six months following the examination. Men who complete the inventory and disclose nothing frequently report that the material has been reorganised without being reduced.

The Signals That Professional Assistance Is Required

Three signals should be treated as conclusive. Where the inventory's content is connected to abuse, violence, or a traumatic event, the material requires professional treatment rather than reflective work. Where the examination produces a sustained deterioration in mood, sleep, or functioning across more than two weeks, the conditions in Chapters 5 and 6 apply and assessment should be sought. And where the man cannot conduct the examination at all — where the reading of his own account produces a state from which he cannot recover without consequence — the work is not the obstacle and the assistance is required first.

21.6 Becoming the Man You Want to Be

The final substantive section converts the preceding material into a construction: not the reduction of a gap but the building of a person.

The Problem With the Image as a Goal

A man who attempts to become the man his image promised will fail, for a structural reason: the image was assembled for public legibility and it contains other people's requirements. Its standard is comparative, its timetable is borrowed, and its criteria are the six requirements described in Chapter 2. A man pursuing it will be conducted for a lifetime by an assessment he did not write.

The alternative is not the abandonment of ambition. It is the substitution of a self-authored specification, which is the work described in Chapter 11, conducted here with respect to the man's person rather than his position.

The Specification

The specification has five parts and is written in one sitting of about two hours.

Part One: What I will not do. The negative specification, which is the most useful part and the one most frequently omitted. A list of the conduct the man will not undertake, in specific terms: the ways he will not treat his household, the matters on which he will not compromise, the conduct in his work he will not undertake, the arrangements he will not conceal. The negative specification has the advantage of being entirely within the man's control, which distinguishes it from any objective that depends on circumstance.

Part Two: The capacities I intend to hold. Not achievements but capacities: the ability to describe his own state; the ability to obtain assistance; the ability to remain in a relationship in which he is known; the ability to keep himself functioning over a decade. The four unrecognised capacities from Table 2.1 form the core, and additions should be specific to the man's life.

Part Three: The relationships I intend to have, and what I will do in them. Specific: the arrangement with each child, the arrangement with a partner, the number of friendships he will maintain and their form, the participation in the family of origin, the contribution to a community. Stated as arrangements rather than as wishes.

Part Four: The work and the provision. What the man intends to do for income, at what intensity, for how long, and with what limits. This part should state the ceiling and the boundary from Chapter 11, and it should state the transition: what the man intends to be doing in the decade after full working life.

Part Five: The record I intend to leave. The material of Section 17.6, applied to the man's whole life: what he intends to be known for, by whom, and in what form. Writing this part has a specific effect that men report with surprise: it makes the previous four parts easier to write, because it establishes the standard against which the arrangements are being chosen.

The Three Practices That Convert the Specification Into a Man

1. The daily sentence. One sentence, written at the end of each day, on how the day was conducted with respect to one element of the specification. Not a diary and not an assessment; one sentence. The practice operates in the manner of the measurements elsewhere in this book: it makes the specification visible daily, and its effect is disproportionate to its size.

2. The monthly review. Thirty minutes, on a fixed date, against four questions: which part of the specification did I keep; which did I fail; what caused the failure; what is the one change for the coming month? The review converts the specification from a document into an arrangement.

3. The annual account. Two hours, once a year, in which the man writes an account of the year as he would wish somebody who knew him to be able to give it. The account is not for publication and it is not an assessment. Its function is the one identified throughout Part VII and Part XI of this book: a man who writes down what his year contained is in a position to notice what it did not contain.

The Relationship Between the Specification and the Household

Two observations are important.

First, the specification should be known by at least one person, and preferably by the man's household. A specification held privately is a plan; a specification known by the household is an arrangement, and the difference in outcome is substantial, as the case below demonstrates.

Second, the specification will conflict with other people's expectations in at least one respect. The conflict should be expected and should not be treated as evidence of error. A man who has written a specification that requires no change in his arrangements has written a description rather than a specification.

Figure 21.1 sets out the two directions in which the gap between the image and the man can move, together with the practices that govern each. The diagram is illustrative; the two columns are not opposites in a single decision, but slopes that a man's ordinary conduct determines over decades.

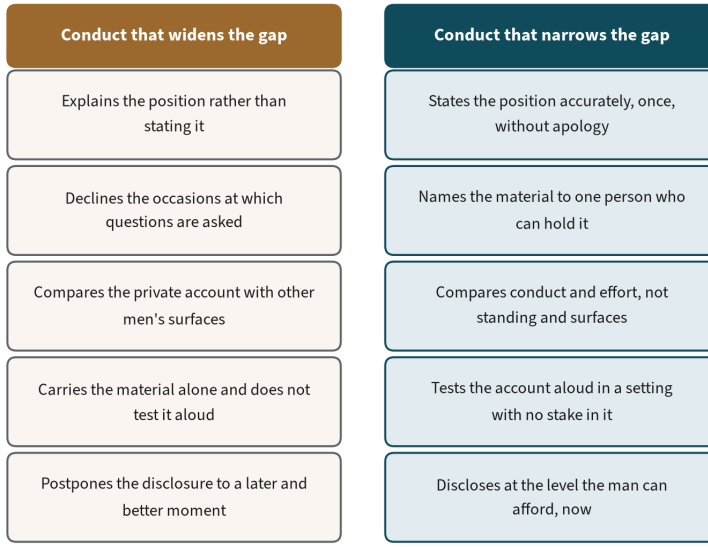


Figure 21.1 Two slopes. Conduct that widens the gap between the presented image and the private account, and conduct that narrows it. The practices in the right-hand column are those set out in Sections 21.3 to 21.6.

21.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Two Men

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in counselling practice and in the literature on shame and male identity.

Kunle is forty-eight, a senior lecturer at a polytechnic, married to Folake for nineteen years, with three children.

The case was presented in counselling for insomnia and a general loss of interest, and the material that emerged concerned a discrepancy that had been maintained for twenty-two years.

Kunle's public position was as follows: he held a doctorate, a senior lectureship, a position on two professional committees, and the respect of his department; he had supervised eleven postgraduate students; he was his extended family's principal representative; and he was known as a calm, principled, and highly competent man. His household was well regarded and his three children attended good schools.

Kunle's private account contained four items, none of which had been shared with anybody.

First, his doctorate had been obtained at a private institution of modest standing, at a period when his first choice had been unaffordable; his thesis had been supervised at a distance and had been completed with limited support. He had, at the time, described the situation to colleagues in terms that omitted the institution's standing, and the omission had never been corrected. Over twenty years, the omission had

been maintained through a series of small avoidances: a reference to "my university" rather than its name; an unwillingness to discuss the periods of study; a decline of two invitations to speak at events where the question would arise.

Second, he had, in his first year of teaching, obtained a position for which another candidate was better qualified. The appointment had been determined by a family connection, and Kunle had not been told about the connection until after the appointment. He had accepted the position, had performed well in it, had applied for nothing further through connections, and had regarded his own career since then as an attempt at restitution.

Third, his second child, aged sixteen, had a health condition — a diagnosis of epilepsy made three years earlier — which the household had managed carefully and which Kunle had not disclosed to his extended family, his department, or any friend. The concealment had required a continuing series of arrangements: the child had been withdrawn from a swimming programme, his absences had been explained in other terms, and the household had declined two invitations that would have required the disclosure of the diagnosis.

Fourth, Kunle had lost interest in his subject. He had entered the discipline with enthusiasm at twenty-two and had, over two decades, become an administrator of a subject rather than a student of it. He had published nothing in four years, and he described his lecturing as competent and empty. He had not told his wife, and he had presented the loss of interest as workload.

The insomnia and the loss of interest were assessed as a depressive episode, which was treated. The four items were then worked through in the manner described in Sections 21.3 and 21.5.

The doctorate was addressed first, and it produced the case's most instructive finding. Kunle disclosed the matter to a colleague of fifteen years' standing, in the structure of Section 21.3, and the colleague's response was that he had known the institution for years, that it had never occurred to him to regard it as significant, and that two other members of the department had completed their postgraduate work at institutions of comparable or lower standing. The disclosure took about four minutes. Kunle recorded, in his own words, that what he had carried for twenty-two years was *a fact that four thousand words of other people's biographies also contain and that nobody but me had ever cared about*.

The position obtained through a family connection was disclosed to his wife, who had not known, and was resolved by a specific decision: Kunle placed his name on a professional register of available assessors, in which appointments were made by open procedure, and has since taken two such appointments.

The child's diagnosis was disclosed to the extended family and, in the form appropriate to the child's interest, to the department. Its effects were entirely practical: two relatives with medical knowledge were identified, the swimming concern was resolved through a supervised arrangement, and Kunle reported that the item had occupied a position in his account that its actual weight did not support.

The loss of interest was the last item and the most consequential. Its resolution required two things: an admission to Folake, which was received with the observation that she had known for about three years, and a change in the arrangement of his work. Kunle reduced his administrative commitments by one role, negotiated a reduction of his teaching load, and took on a research collaboration with a colleague in another institution with the specific requirement that he write rather than administer.

His summary, two years later, was: *I was two men. The one in the department was competent, principled, and didn't care about any of it, and the one at home was ashamed of four things, three of them invisible to anybody but me. The four things took about a year to work through, and the largest of them was not the doctorate or the appointment. It was that I had stopped being interested in anything and had decided that this was what a man of my age is.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

Three of the four items were invisible to everybody, and their weight was maintained entirely by the man. The doctorate, the appointment, and the loss of interest had no external consequence. What gave them their force was the belief in exposure: that the disclosure would end the man's standing. The disclosure's outcome — a colleague's four-minute response — is the mechanism of Section 21.3 demonstrated in a single exchange.

The concealments required continuing arrangements. The avoidances, the withdrawals, the declined invitations, and the terms used to refer to the institution. This is the maintenance cost described in Section 21.1, and it is the reason that concealed material is expensive even when it is never discovered.

The child's diagnosis was being carried as shame rather than as care. Kunle's management of his son's condition was competent, and it was conducted inside a framework of concealment that belonged to the man's account rather than to the child's welfare. The case is included because this pattern is common: a household's legitimate privacy about a child's condition frequently merges into the man's private account of his own inadequacy.

The wife had known about the loss of interest for three years. The most frequently reported finding in cases of this kind: the material that the man believes is concealed is frequently visible to the people who live with him, and what is concealed is the man's acknowledgement of it. Chapter 14′s material on the partner who cannot be told is the corresponding subject.

The final item required an arrangement rather than a disclosure. The loss of interest was resolved by reducing an administrative role, negotiating a teaching load, and entering a collaboration. This is the pattern in Section 21.6: the specification produces arrangements, and the arrangements produce the man.

21.8 Practical Exercise: The Inventory, the Acceptance, and the Specification

This exercise has three stages and is completed over about four weeks. Stage One takes two sittings; Stage Two takes one; Stage Three takes one.

Stage One: The Inventory

Sitting A: The record. Complete the table without evaluating anything.

What is in my private account	Whose conduct is it, or what circumstance?	Open, amendable, or concluded?	What it requires

Include the six categories from Section 21.2: failures not disclosed; conduct regretted; states you are in; facts about your household; doubts about your competence; and your own estimate of yourself.

Sitting B: The plan. For each open or amendable row, specify the action and the date. For each concluded row, write the closing sentence. Then answer three questions.

- How many rows are concluded, and how many have been carried as open when they are in fact finished?
- How many rows concern my conduct, and how many concern what happened to me?
- Which single row, if resolved, would reduce the account's weight most substantially?

Stage Two: The Graduated Disclosure

Select one item, chosen by this rule: it should be genuine, it should not be the heaviest item, and it should be one you have never told anybody.

- **The item:**
- **The person, and the evidence of safety:**
- **The setting and the date:**

Then write and deliver the four sentences.

1. What occurred.
2. What it has cost me.
3. Why I am saying it now.
4. What I am asking for — which may be nothing.

Afterwards, record six items: what the person said; what they did not say; whether the relationship changed; what happened to the item's weight; whether the predicted consequence occurred; and what you conclude about the next disclosure.

Stage Three: The Specification

Write the five parts from Section 21.6, in one sitting, without consulting anybody.

1. **What I will not do.** At least five specific items.
2. **The capacities I intend to hold.** The four from Table 2.1, plus any specific to your life.
3. **The relationships I intend to have, and what I will do in them.** Stated as arrangements with frequencies.
4. **The work and the provision.** Intensity, ceiling, boundary, and the transition after full working life.
5. **The record I intend to leave.** What I intend to be known for, by whom, in what form.

Then complete the three practices:

Practice	Frequency	When it will occur
The daily sentence	Daily	
The monthly review	Monthly, on a fixed date	
The annual account	Annually	

And answer the final question: **who will be told about this specification, and by what date?** A specification known by nobody is a plan; a specification known by one person is an arrangement.

21.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it not simply dishonest to present a version of myself that is not the whole truth?"

Selection is not deception. Every person is known in part, and the ordinary management of what is disclosed is what makes social life possible. The distinction this chapter draws is between selection and concealment: selection is the omission of material that does not need to be discussed, and concealment is the omission of material whose discussion is necessary for the man to be known by the persons who require it. The test is simple: would the person most concerned be harmed by discovering that the material had been known to me for years and withheld from them?

"What if the disclosure damages my position?"

Sometimes it does, and the risk should be assessed rather than assumed. The distinctions worth making: disclosure of the material that concerns a man's competence in his work carries real occupational risk; disclosure of the material that concerns his history, his household, and his states carries considerably less, and it is the material that does the most damage when concealed. The structured

conversation in Chapter 35 provides a method for assessing the audience, the content, and the timing.

"I have carried this for decades. What is the point of disclosing it now?"

Two answers, one of which is decisive. The first is that concealed material continues to operate: it produces the avoidance, the anger, and the maintenance cost described in Section 21.1, and those effects do not reduce with time. The second is that the disclosure's effect on the man frequently exceeds its effect on anybody else, as Section 21.7's first item illustrates: the material is frequently lighter than it has been made to feel, and the man is the party who has been carrying the weight rather than the party who has been threatened by it.

"How do I know whether an item belongs in the private account or is simply my personality?"

By the test of concealment: an item that the man would alter his conduct to avoid disclosing is in the account; a matter that he simply does not discuss, and would discuss without difficulty if it arose, is not. The second test is the test of weight: material in the Account is weight-bearing, and the man will find that it occupies his attention disproportionately to its actual significance.

"My wife says I present a version of myself to her as well. Is that normal?"

It is the most common form, and it produces the arrangements described in Chapter 14. The relevant question is not whether the presentation exists but whether anything in the marriage permits the man to be known outside it. Where the answer is no, the practices in Chapters 14 and 18 and the graduated disclosure above are the route, and the first disclosure is the hardest.

"I am not a bad man. Why do I feel like a fraud?"

Because the estimate of oneself described in Category 6 of Section 21.2 is rarely derived from conduct; it is derived from the comparison between the private account and the presented image, and it will therefore be unfavourable regardless of the man's actual conduct. The remedy is the counter-record in Section 21.5 and the inventory itself, whose most consistent effect is that the record is considerably better than the impression.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 21 in brief. The image a man presents is a selection rather than a lie, assembled from four components: the record of accomplishments, the competence in the present, the absence of need, and the management of appearance. It is maintained by selective disclosure, by managing information about the household, by avoiding situations in which the gap would be visible, by acquiring the material to replenish it, and — most consequentially — by converting the image into a standard against which the man measures himself. Its costs are the exhaustion of maintenance,

the exclusion of support, the escalation of the requirement, and the impossibility of intimacy within it.

The gap between the image and the man's private account contains failures not disclosed, conduct regretted, states he is in, facts about his household, doubts about his competence, and his own estimate of himself. It widens through time, the accumulation of unspoken items, the increase of responsibility, the absence of any corrective relationship, and the comparison with a standard that the image invented. It appears in specific forms in the successful man, the man of ordinary means, and the man who has carried out of duty something that has damaged him, and it produces the progressive reduction of what the man permits to be known.

Shame is distinct from guilt: guilt concerns an act and is addressed by repair, while shame concerns the self and produces concealment. Its features in men are the conviction of being different, the belief in exposure as catastrophe, the performance of the correct version, anger at the prospect of exposure, contempt for those who are seen, and the impossibility of receiving. It is reduced by one mechanism: graduated exposure to a safe person, with the outcome recorded, because the mechanism is evidence rather than catharsis.

Self-acceptance is not resignation, not the lowering of standards, and not a feeling. Six obstacles stand in its way: the over-developed standard, the comparison mechanism, the rejection of what the man actually is, the confusion of acceptance with giving up, the absence of any experience of being known, and shame. It requires an accurate inventory, a distinction between the man's conduct and what arrived, a distinction between open, amendable, and concluded matters, and one accurate account given to one person.

Facing the truth without self-destruction requires four protections: the examination is conducted in writing rather than in thought; the account is classified before it is assessed; the examination is bounded and time-limited; and it concludes with specific items rather than a verdict. The three practices that follow are the re-reading at intervals, the counter-record of genuine capacities and contributions, and the disclosure of one item within six months.

Becoming the man one intends requires a self-authored specification in five parts — what I will not do, the capacities I intend to hold, the relationships I intend to have, the work and provision with its ceiling and boundary, and the record I intend to leave — converted into a man by three practices: the daily sentence, the monthly review, and the annual account. The specification should be known by at least one person, and it will conflict with somebody's expectation, which is evidence that it is a specification rather than a description.

Reflection Questions

1. From the four components of the presented image in Section 21.1, which do you maintain at the highest cost? What does the maintenance consist of, in hours and in money?

2. Complete Stage One, Sitting A. How many rows are concluded but carried as open? How many concern your conduct and how many concern what arrived?
3. What is your Category 6 estimate of yourself — the conclusion at the bottom of the assessment — and when was it formed? Is it derived from your conduct or from the distance between your account and your image?
4. Which of the six features of shame in Section 21.3 do you recognise: the conviction of being different, the belief in exposure as catastrophe, the performance, the anger at the prospect of exposure, the contempt for those who are seen, or the impossibility of receiving?
5. Select the item for the graduated disclosure and write it down. What is the predicted consequence, in your own words, and what evidence supports the prediction?
6. Write Part One of the specification — what you will not do. Read it and answer: how many items on the list have you done in the last twelve months?
7. Who will be told about the specification, and by what date? What will you do if their response is indifference?

Further Reading

- **On shame and its distinction from guilt:** the psychological literature on shame and guilt as distinct affects, including the extensive research associating shame-proneness with concealment, withdrawal, and poorer mental health outcomes, and the evidence that guilt, by contrast, tends to motivate repair.
- **On self-concealment:** the literature on the concealment of personal information, including the consistent finding that concealment is associated with increased distress, reduced social support, and greater physiological stress responses.
- **On self-compassion:** the research on self-compassion and its correlates, including the findings on its association with lower anxiety and depression and with behaviour change rather than with complacency.
- **On identity and the self-concept:** the literature on identity development in adulthood, including the work on possible selves and on the role of self-authored standards in motivation and wellbeing.
- **On impression management:** the sociological and psychological research on self-presentation, including the findings on the costs of continuous impression management and the conditions under which it becomes damaging.
- **Practical resources:** counselling and psychotherapy, particularly approaches addressing shame and self-criticism; structured programmes on

identity and purpose for men in mid-life; and the material in Appendices I and O, together with Chapters 8, 11, and 35 of this book.

22 CHAPTER

The Battle Against Personal Weaknesses

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Name the personal weaknesses that men most commonly struggle against, and describe the features that make each of them difficult to change.
2. Describe the hidden cost of private shame, including its effects on honesty, relationships, and decision-making.
3. Explain why willpower alone fails to produce durable change, and identify the mechanisms by which behaviour actually changes.
4. Identify his own patterns and triggers, distinguishing between the situations that produce the behaviour and the reasons he gives for it.
5. Apply a practical programme of change, including environment, substitution, measurement, and relapse handling.
6. Establish accountability and honest self-examination without exposing himself to destructive disclosure, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.

Introduction

There is a category of struggle that men carry that is not described by any of the subjects in the earlier parts of this book. It is not the burden of the provider role, or depression, or marital silence, or grief. It is the specific and private matter of character: the things a man does that he does not want to do, the things he fails to do that he wants to do, and the habits that have survived his repeated attempts to break them.

The form of this struggle is distinctive, and it has four features that make it more difficult than it appears from outside.

It is **private**. The man's failure is known to him, and, in most cases, imperfectly acknowledged. Where a man's weakness is known to others, the knowledge is frequently partial: the household is aware of the drinking but not of the gambling; the wife is aware of the temper but not of the reason for it.

It is **repetitive**. A weakness is not a single event; it is a pattern that has recurred through many attempts at change, and its recurrence is the reason the man has concluded that it cannot be altered.

It is **attached to self-respect**. The specific character of shame is the subject of Section 22.2. It is sufficient to note here that a man's weakness is the single thing he is least able to discuss and most likely to be assessed on by himself.

And it is **frequently concealed from precisely the people who could help**, because disclosure of the material risks the standing that the man believes is the only resource he has.

This chapter proceeds on a premise that many men find uncomfortable at first and useful afterwards: a weakness is not a verdict on a man's worth, it is a behaviour with a function, and it can be changed by arrangement rather than by willpower. The arrangement consists of the situations in which the behaviour occurs, the substitute that performs the same function, the measurement that makes the pattern visible, and the accountability that removes the isolation. None of these is a matter of resolve, and all of them are within the man's control.

22.1 Naming the Weakness: What Men Struggle With

Men's struggles are more uniform than they appear, because the material is rarely discussed. The following eight categories account for the substantial majority of what men describe when the subject is raised in a setting where disclosure is safe.

1. Anger and the temper. The most commonly reported weakness, and the most damaging to households. Its features: a threshold that is reached too quickly; a disproportionate response calibrated to accumulated strain rather than to the event; a tendency to discharge the response at the people with the least power in the man's life, which is generally his household; and, after the event, a specific form of shame in which the man's regret concerns the household's experience of him rather than the matter that began the incident.

2. Alcohol. Considered in Chapter 23, and mentioned here because the man's own account of it typically begins as a matter of weakness rather than of dependence: *I drink more than I should and I have tried to stop three times.*

3. Sexual conduct. The category that is least discussed and most frequently held against the man. Its forms: the compulsive pursuit of sexual material or encounters; conduct conducted outside a committed relationship; and, in a specific and painful variant, the man's involvement in a practice that he regards as inconsistent with his own values. The material in this category is concealed with the greatest care, and the concealment is the principal obstacle to its treatment.

4. Gambling and betting. Its prevalence in men is substantial, its amplification by mobile technology is significant, and its concealment is almost total. The specific feature of gambling as a weakness is its association with shame and with

the belief in a single large recovery, which is the mechanism by which the losses accumulate.

5. Lying and concealment. A weakness that is frequently reported in men who consider themselves honest, and which concerns the ordinary untruths by which they manage their households: the concealment of expenditure, of the financial position, of an obligation, of a contact, of an absence. Chapter 9 addresses the financial form; the general form is listed here because men frequently experience it as their principal failing.

6. Procrastination and sloth. The most commonly named item. Its features: the deferral of matters that are within the man's capacity, the use of activity as a substitute for the matter deferred, an increase in the deferral's cost with time, and the man's own explanation of laziness, which is generally inaccurate: the deferral is frequently produced by the fear described in Chapter 7, by the absence of a structure in which the task can be done, or by the condition described in Category 8 below.

7. Pride and contempt. The disposition that is least commonly named and most commonly described by others. Its features: the requirement to be right; the difficulty of conceding; the use of status in dealings with those who have less; the readiness to assess others. Men frequently identify it only when somebody who knows them well states it directly, and the identification is frequently followed by a period of significant progress.

8. The behaviours that are symptoms of an untreated condition. The man who is unable to do anything, who has withdrawn from his interests, who drinks heavily in the evening, or whose temper has changed over a defined period may be presenting the symptoms of a depressive or anxiety condition, a sleep disorder, a chronic pain condition, or a hormonal condition. The specific test: has the behaviour changed during the last two years, and was it preceded by a change in mood, sleep, or energy? Where the answer is yes, the condition is the primary subject, and Chapter 6 and Appendix B apply.

Three Principles for Naming

Name one, not a catalogue. A man who sets out to correct everything at once will correct nothing. The evidence on behaviour change is consistent on this point, and the practical rule is one weakness at a time, for a defined period, with the others recorded for later.

Name it in the form of a behaviour. Not *I am angry* but the specific conduct; not *I am dishonest* but the specific untruths and the situations in which they occur. The general form cannot be changed because it has no behaviour attached to it.

Name the smallest version that is the problem. The temper expressed as shouting at the children at the end of a working week is a changeable target; the temper as a general statement of character is not. Where the man's own preference is the general statement, the correct response is to treat the general statement as a description of the target area and the specific behaviour as the objective.

22.2 The Hidden Cost of Private Shame

The second section examines what the private carrying of a weakness costs, and it is deliberately placed before the material on change, because the shame is the mechanism that prevents change and because its costs extend well beyond the weakness itself.

The Six Costs

1. The distortion of the man's account of himself. A single concealed matter acquires a weight in the self-assessment that is disproportionate to its actual content. Chapter 21's account of the private account applies in its most concentrated form: a man who has concealed one pattern for twenty years will frequently report that it has become the principal fact about him, and the assessment is made in isolation, without correction, and without comparison.

2. The loss of the relationship's truth. Where a wife does not know a matter of substance about her husband, the marriage is conducted in a partial reality. The specific consequences are described in Chapter 9: the wife's inferences, formed from the available information, will be wrong and will be unfavourable, and the man's behaviour — the withdrawal, the irritability, the absences — will be explained in the only terms available to her. This is the cost that men most consistently underestimate.

3. The energy of concealment. Every undisclosed matter requires maintenance: the explanations, the timing, the tracking of what was said to whom, the avoidance of situations in which the matter could emerge. The cost is continuous and it is drawn from the same account as the man's capacity for work, judgement, and relationship.

4. The escalation of the behaviour. The relationship between shame and repetition is well established in the clinical literature, and its mechanism is direct: the behaviour produces shame, shame produces distress, and the behaviour is the means by which the distress is managed. A man who drinks to manage his distress about his drinking is the plainest illustration, and the pattern is identical in gambling, sexual conduct, and anger.

5. The prevention of help. Shame prevents disclosure, and disclosure is the route to treatment. Men whose conditions are the most treatable — alcohol dependence, gambling disorder, compulsive sexual behaviour, mood disorders — are frequently the men who arrive latest, and the delay is frequently measured in

years or decades, with the result that conditions which respond to early intervention have become entrenched.

6. The transmission to the household. A household in which a matter is concealed produces a set of secondary effects: the children learn that some matters are not discussed; the wife develops a vigilance that is frequently read by the man as nagging; and the family's arrangements are adapted around a matter that nobody has named. The case in Section 22.7 illustrates the effect precisely: the children's most common statement, in adulthood, is that they knew something was wrong and never learned what.

22.3 Why Willpower Alone Fails

The most important practical fact about personal weaknesses is that the method men apply to them — resolve — is the method with the worst record. Understanding why is not an academic exercise; it is the reason the alternative methods work.

The Mechanism of a Habit

Four components operate together, and each is a point of intervention.

The cue. A specific situation that initiates the behaviour: a time of day, a place, a person, a state of feeling, an activity that precedes it. The cue is frequently invisible to the man because it has been established for years and because the behaviour begins before he has registered the decision.

The routine. The behaviour itself, performed with varying degrees of awareness.

The reward. What the behaviour supplies: relief, stimulation, company, oblivion, a sense of competence, or the discharge of tension. This is the component that keeps the behaviour in place, and it is the one that men most frequently do not identify, because they assess the behaviour by its cost rather than by its function.

The repetition. The behaviour's establishment owes more to the number of repetitions than to the strength of any single urge. A weakness performed four hundred times over six years is not a disposition; it is a path that has been worn into the ground.

Why Resolve Fails at the Four Points

Resolve fails because it operates against the cue rather than on it. A man who decides, in the morning, not to repeat the behaviour that occurs at eleven o'clock at night has made a decision at a moment when the cue is absent. By the time the cue arrives, the decision is a memory and the situation is present. The method that works reverses this: the cue is changed in advance, when the man has capacity, rather than resisted at the moment when he does not.

Resolve fails because it does not address the reward. A man who removes a behaviour without supplying what the behaviour provided has removed his own method of managing a state, and he will reinstate the behaviour in order to restore the method. This is the reason that the instruction to stop is frequently complied with for two or three weeks and then abandoned.

Resolve fails because it is finite and it is being spent on everything. The research on self-regulation is consistent on this point: the capacity for active resistance is a limited resource that is depleted by the ordinary requirements of a working day. A weakness that must be actively resisted at six o'clock in the evening is being resisted by a man whose capacity has been spent since eight in the morning. Chapter 12's material on decision fatigue is the same finding applied elsewhere.

Resolve fails because it is stated in the form that produces the most shame. *I will not do this again* is an absolute, and each failure is therefore a complete failure, which produces the shame described in Section 22.2, which produces the behaviour.

What Replaces Resolve

Four mechanisms, and they operate together. They are set out in Section 22.5 and their logic is summarised here.

The cue is altered in advance. The behaviour's trigger is removed, changed, or interrupted before the situation in which it occurs. This is done at a time of the day when the man has capacity.

The reward is supplied by something else. A substitute is arranged that performs the same function, chosen to fit the function rather than to be virtuous.

The behaviour is measured rather than resisted. A record of occurrences, in place of a prohibition, converts the matter from a question of character into a question of data, which is a change in register that men find substantially easier to sustain.

The isolation is ended by one person. Accountability removes the private context in which the behaviour occurs, and it provides the correction to the man's account of himself that shame prevents.

Figure 22.1 sets out the cycle that maintains a weakness, in which each element produces the next. The diagram is illustrative and generalised; the purpose of setting it out is to identify the two points at which the cycle can be interrupted, neither of which is the moment of the behaviour itself.

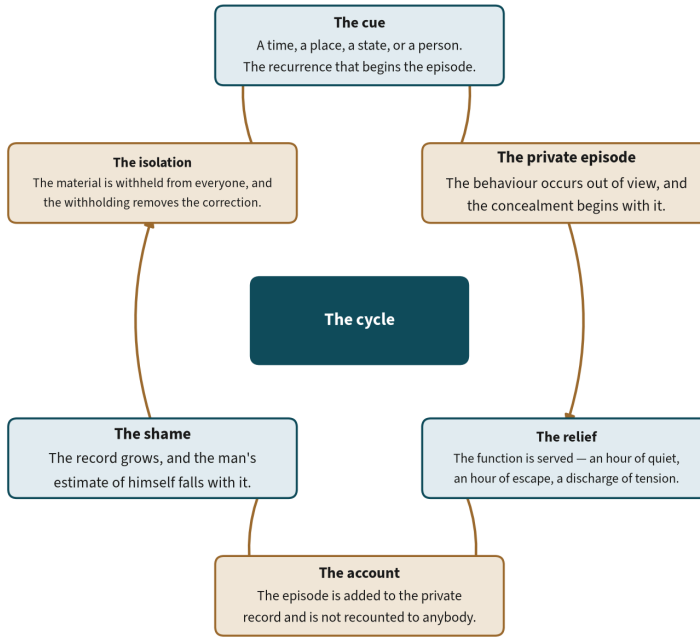


Figure 22.1 The maintenance cycle of a concealed weakness. The cycle is interrupted at the level of the cue and at the level of the isolation; attempts to interrupt it at the level of the behaviour itself have the weakest record.

22.4 Understanding Your Patterns and Triggers

The work of this section is diagnostic and it should be conducted in writing. Its purpose is to convert a general struggle into a specific pattern, because only specific patterns can be changed.

The Trigger Map

For the weakness selected in Section 22.1, complete the following over two to four weeks, recording each occurrence at the time rather than reconstructing it later.

Date and time	Where I was	Who was present	What I was feeling immediately before	What I had done in the previous hour	What I expected the behaviour to do

Four patterns emerge from this record with considerable reliability.

The timetable. Most weaknesses occur at defined times. The man who believes his anger is unpredictable will frequently find that it occurs in the two

hours after work, on the days when the household's demands arrive before he has had a period of transition.

The state. Hunger, exhaustion, pain, anxiety, shame, boredom, and loneliness are the states most frequently preceding the behaviour. This finding is important because it means that a substantial proportion of the occurrences can be addressed by changes in sleep, food, and the structuring of the day, which are simpler interventions than the man expects.

The company and the place. The specific individuals and environments associated with the behaviour. The identification frequently produces an uncomfortable finding about a friendship or an arrangement.

The expectation. What the man expected the behaviour to produce. This is the field that identifies the function, and men who complete it report with consistency that the function is not the one they would have named: the drinking that was expected to produce relaxation was being used to produce sleep; the anger that was expected to discharge tension was being used to produce a sense of control; the gambling that was expected to produce money was being used to produce excitement in a period of numbness.

The Function Test

Write the sentence: *I do this in order to* ____. Then test it against four questions.

1. **Does the behaviour actually produce the stated outcome?** Frequently not, or not beyond the first thirty minutes.
2. **What would produce the same outcome without the cost?** The answer to this question is the substitute, and it should be specific.
3. **What would happen if the state the behaviour manages had no management at all?** This question is uncomfortable and it is the one that identifies what the man believes he cannot survive.
4. **Who else's behaviour participates in the pattern?** Frequently another person's conduct is required for the man's weakness to operate: the person who supplies the alcohol, the colleague who invites the bet, the relative whose conduct produces the anger. The pattern is frequently not the man's alone.

The History

A further diagnostic step, and it is frequently the one that produces the most useful material: identify the period in which the weakness began. Men report, with consistency, that the behaviour has a start date and that the date is attached to a situation.

The situations named most frequently are: a period of financial difficulty; a job or a role the man could not refuse and could not perform; a loss — a bereavement, a separation, a business failure; a period of illness; a marriage's deterioration; and a period in which the man was required to carry something he had never disclosed.

In a substantial proportion of cases, the weakness is a method of managing a situation that has never been addressed, and its treatment is therefore the treatment of the situation.

The practical implication is direct: a weakness that began in a specific period is frequently not addressable without addressing that period's material. Men who attempt to remove the behaviour while leaving the situation untouched report the pattern described in Section 23.6 — recovery that does not hold — and the case in Section 22.7 illustrates it.

22.5 Practical Strategies for Change

This section sets out the methods, in the sequence in which they should be applied. The order matters: the environmental measures come before the behavioural ones, and the behavioural measures before the psychological ones, because each stage makes the next possible.

Stage One: The Environment

Remove the cue from the environment. The substance from the house; the application from the phone; the route that passes the betting shop changed; the television removed from the bedroom; the specific room avoided at the specific hour. The measure is mechanical, it is decided once, and it operates continuously thereafter. Its effectiveness is disproportionate to its apparent simplicity, and men who attempt the behavioural work without it frequently report that the environmental change alone produced a substantial reduction.

Introduce friction. The behavioural work of the last decade has established a reliable principle: the effort required to perform the behaviour predicts the rate of the behaviour. Every step added between the cue and the act — the distance, the lock, the requirement to ask, the requirement to go somewhere, the delay of thirty minutes — reduces its frequency.

Alter the situation that surrounds the cue. Where the behaviour occurs at a specific hour, the hour should be occupied. Where it occurs in a specific company, the occasion should be restructured rather than the friendship ended. Where it occurs after an argument, the argument's handling is the intervention.

Recruit the household where the household is affected. Not as supervisors, which produces resentment, but as participants in the arrangement: the removal of alcohol from the house, the change of an evening routine, the substitution of a shared activity. Chapter 18's material on arrangements applies.

Stage Two: The Substitute

Identify the function from the trigger map. Rest, sleep, company, relief from anxiety, the discharge of anger, excitement, competence.

Choose the substitute to fit the function, not the virtue. The most frequent error in this work is the selection of a substitute on grounds of healthfulness: the man who substitutes running for late-night screen use has chosen an activity that performs a different function, and it will not hold. The substitute should be tested against the function identified in Section 22.4, and it should be available at the hour and in the place in which the behaviour occurred.

Arrange the substitute in advance. The decision must be made before the cue arrives, which is the whole of the difference between a substitute and an intention. The form that works is a scheduled arrangement rather than an available option: the gym appointment, the standing call, the specific task, the fixed activity with another person.

Accept the substitute's imperfection. Men frequently abandon a substitute because it does not produce the relief the weakness produced. The standard is comparison with the alternative, which is the weakness and its consequences, rather than comparison with the weakness's reward.

Stage Three: The Behavioural Method

Measure rather than prohibit. The record in Section 22.4 continues. Its effects are three: it produces the data on which the plan is based; it interrupts the automaticity of the behaviour, because recording requires awareness; and it converts the matter from a moral question into a practical one, which is the change of register that men report as the most important element of the whole process.

Reduce the target rather than eliminating it, where reduction is the objective. A defined reduction — from daily to three days, from four units to two — with a review point, is more durable than an absolute prohibition, and its failures are smaller and recoverable. Where the behaviour is a dependence, the elimination is the objective and the route is Chapter 23's.

Set the review at a defined interval. Two weeks for the first review, then monthly. The review's four questions are those used elsewhere in this book: what occurred, what the pattern shows, what caused the failures, and what changes in the arrangement for the coming period.

Plan for the relapse. The situations in which the behaviour is most likely to recur, identified in advance, with a specific arrangement for each. This is the same danger-point method as in Section 23.6, applied to a weakness rather than a dependence, and its purpose is to prevent the single episode from terminating the work.

Stage Four: The Psychological Work

Address the belief. A weakness that has persisted for years is frequently supported by a belief: that the behaviour is required for sleep, for social acceptability, for the discharge of tension, for the management of an unbearable state.

The belief should be written out and tested against the record. In a substantial proportion of cases the belief is contradicted by the man's own data, and the contradiction is more persuasive than any argument supplied by somebody else.

Address the situation that produced the weakness. As Section 22.4 establishes: the period, the loss, the role, the undisclosed material. Where the weakness began in a specific period, its treatment includes that period's business, and the relevant material is in Chapters 11, 13, and 19.

Address the shame. The material in Chapter 21's graduated disclosure applies. The specific finding that men report in this context is worth repeating: the disclosure of a weakness to one safe person reduces its hold substantially, and the reduction is not a matter of comfort but of evidence, since the disclosure demonstrates that the material can be known without the catastrophe the man has predicted.

Stage Five: What to Do When It Fails

Four rules govern the handling of a failure, and they are the material that determines whether the work continues.

Analyse, do not sentence. The questions are: what was the cue, what was the state, what was the arrangement, and what failed? Not: what does this say about me?

Shorten the interval between the failure and the resumption. The critical variable in every account of behaviour change. A man who resumes within a day has lost a day; a man who resumes after a month has lost a month and has also had a month in which to conclude that the work is futile.

Change one element of the arrangement. The lesson of a failure is generally information about the environment or the substitute. The change should be specific: a different substitute, a different hour, a different arrangement with the person involved.

Report the failure to the accountable person. Described in Section 22.6. The report is the mechanism by which the failure does not become the material of shame, and the men who maintain change for years are overwhelmingly those who have somebody to whom the failures are reported.

22.6 Accountability and Honest Self-Examination

The final substantive section addresses the arrangement that makes the others durable, and it begins with a finding that men find counterintuitive: the private management of a personal weakness is the arrangement with the poorest record, and confidentiality is not the same as secrecy.

The Distinction Between Confidentiality and Secrecy

Confidentiality is a property of an arrangement in which a small number of specified people know the situation and do not disclose it. It is the arrangement of professional practice, it is what enables men to obtain treatment, and it is compatible with accountability.

Secrecy is an arrangement in which nobody knows. It produces the costs described in Section 22.2 and it is the arrangement in which the behaviour is not measured, not discussed, and not corrected.

The whole of this section concerns the conversion of secrecy into confidentiality.

The Accountable Person

The selection. One person, at least, and the criteria are specific: they should have no stake in the material that would compromise their judgement; they should have a record of keeping confidences; they should be able to state an assessment to the man's face; and they should be willing to hold the arrangement over time rather than to hear the matter once.

The categories available. A professional — counsellor, psychologist, physician, or a religious adviser where the man's framework includes one — whose function is confidential by definition and who requires no prior relationship. A peer — a friend, a sibling, or a member of a group of men in comparable positions. A group, which for many men is the most effective arrangement because the position is symmetrical: everyone present has a weakness, and the man's material is not unusual.

What the arrangement consists of. Not the disclosure of every occurrence, which is neither necessary nor sustainable. The arrangement is: the man reports at a defined interval, states whether the plan is being followed, states the failures, and receives an assessment. The interval matters more than its frequency; a monthly report that occurs is worth more than a weekly arrangement that lapses.

The Four Practices of Honest Self-Examination

1. The record. The written measurement described in Section 22.4, maintained continuously. Men report that the record's principal value appears after several months, when it demonstrates a change or the absence of one, and that it is the only reliable protection against the man's own account of himself, which is systematically either too favourable or too harsh.

2. The defined review. Monthly, with the four questions, and annually, against the specification described in Section 21.6. The review converts the work into an arrangement with a schedule rather than an intention with an indefinite term.

3. The assessment from somebody else. The practice of asking, at intervals, for an assessment from a person who knows the man: how has he been in the last month, what has changed, and what has the person noticed. This practice supplies the correction that the man's own account cannot supply, and it is the practice most frequently omitted.

4. The stated standard. The written statement of what the man intends, which is the specification from Section 21.6. Its function in this context is to distinguish between the standard and the shame: the standard is specific and is met or not met on particular days, while the shame is general and is met or not met in the man's assessment of himself.

The Four Prohibitions

Do not conduct the arrangement with somebody who has a stake in concealing the weakness. The colleague who shares the behaviour, the relative who would be shamed by the disclosure, the person whose own conduct the weakness protects.

Do not use the arrangement as absolution. The arrangement's function is measurement and assessment, not relief. Men who report the behaviour and feel relieved without changing the arrangement are reported in the literature on behaviour change as a recognisable pattern, and their reports become a substitute for the work rather than a part of it.

Do not disclose in a form that subjects the man to a general assessment. The arrangement concerns the specific behaviour, and its scope should be defined. The temptation to convert it into a general conversation about the man's life should be resisted, at least in the early period, because general conversations are what produced the shame in the first place.

Do not abandon the arrangement at the point of improvement. The most common failure of this section's method, and it occurs at about six to nine months, at the point at which the man's confidence is highest and the arrangement appears unnecessary. The behaviour's return follows within a year in a substantial proportion of cases in which the arrangement was discontinued.

22.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Two People After Six

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in counselling practice, family practice, and the research literature on anger and behaviour change.

Idris is forty-four, a regional sales manager for a pharmaceutical distributor, married to Zainab for sixteen years, with three children aged between seven and fourteen.

The case was presented by Idris's wife, through a family counselling service, with the following account: for approximately eight years, Idris had been a different person in the two hours after he returned from work. In that period he was irritable, quick to shout, intolerant of noise, and, on about four occasions each year, would shout at one of the children in a manner that left the child distressed for days. After about nine o'clock in the evening, the behaviour would change: he would become quiet, apologetic, and, in Zainab's description, unreachable.

Idris's own account, obtained separately, had three parts.

First, he did not accept that he had a problem with anger. He described himself as a man with a short temper after a long day, which he regarded as ordinary and which he stated was shared by most men in his position. He noted, with some accuracy, that he had never been violent and that his anger was expressed in words.

Second, he had attempted to change the behaviour four times. Each attempt had taken the same form: a decision, made after an incident, that he would not shout at the children again; a period of between one and three weeks during which the decision held; and a return to the previous pattern, generally after a day of particular difficulty at work. Each return was followed by a period of increased shame, during which he did not discuss the matter at all.

Third, and after about four sessions, the material that gave the case its form emerged. Idris's working day had a specific structure that he had never described to anybody: he spent the final three hours of each day, between four and seven in the evening, in his vehicle, driving between two towns to deliver stock and collect payments, and it was in that period that the pressure of the day accumulated — the shortfalls, the customers who did not pay, the targets he had not met, and the knowledge that his income depended on figures that he had never once, in eight years, met at the level expected of him. He arrived at his house, in his description, "with about three hours of accumulated things that I had nowhere to put." The house was noisy, the children were present, and the first request of the evening frequently produced the shout.

The assessment and the plan had the following components.

The function was identified in the third session: the anger was the discharge of an accumulated state, and the state was not the day's events but the man's assessment of himself against a target he had never met. The shout was, in his own account once he had described it, *the one moment of the day when I am the one deciding something*.

The trigger map was completed over four weeks and produced three findings that Idris had not anticipated. The shouts occurred, without exception, in the first ninety minutes after his arrival. They occurred on the days when he had received a payment shortfall, which was the majority of days. They did not occur on the days when he stopped at the second town, where a colleague kept an office, and spent twenty minutes there — a practice he had begun years earlier and had abandoned.

The plan was constructed along the five stages and consisted of the following measures.

Environment. A stop of twenty minutes was reinstated at the second town, at the colleague's office, on every working day. Idris described this measure as the single

most effective element and as the one he had resisted, on the grounds that it delayed his arrival at home. The counter-argument, which was decisive, was that the twenty minutes produced an arrival that his household could live with.

Substitute. For the first ninety minutes after arrival, a fixed arrangement: Idris would change, would spend fifteen minutes alone, and would then take the children's bathtime, which was the loudest and most demanding period of the evening and which he had previously spent in another room attempting to be undisturbed. The change placed him, deliberately, in the situation he had been avoiding, but at a point after the transition.

Measurement. A daily record of the state on arrival, from one to ten, and of any incident. The record produced the case's most instructive finding within five weeks: the state on arrival correlated much more strongly with whether he had stopped at the second town than with the day's actual figures.

Psychological work. The material about the target was addressed directly, and it required about four months. Idris's position, which he had never stated to anybody including his wife, was that he had been recruited into a role requiring a level of sales performance that he did not have and could not obtain, and that he had spent eight years concealing this from his employer and from his household. The plan included a specific step: a conversation with his employer about a change of role, which he conducted in the fifth month and which resulted in a move to a technical support position at a lower level of variable pay.

Accountability. A monthly arrangement with a male counsellor and, at Idris's own initiative, an arrangement with his brother-in-law, whom he described as the only person in the family who would tell him the truth. The brother-in-law's function was specific: Idris telephoned him on the days when an incident had occurred, without exception, and reported it.

The outcome at eighteen months was: no shouts at the children in about fourteen months, with one incident in month four; a change of role with a reduction of about nine per cent in income and, in Idris's description, the removal of the daily basis of his self-assessment; and a change in the household's arrangement of the evening, which Zainab described as the period in which she stopped managing the children's behaviour around her husband's state.

Idris's summary was: *I did not have a temper. I had a nine-to-seven situation that I could not tell anybody about, and a house that I arrived at with nowhere to put it. Four attempts to decide that I would not shout produced three weeks each. What worked was a twenty-minute stop and telling my wife what the last eight years had actually been.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The man's own account was accurate in its content and wrong in its conclusion. Idris was correct that he had never been violent and correct that his anger was expressed in words. His conclusion — that this constituted an ordinary temper — was the obstacle, and it is the most common obstacle in this material:

the man assesses the behaviour against a threshold that he sets, and the threshold is generally set below his own conduct.

The four attempts followed the same mechanism as Section 22.3. A decision made in the aftermath of an incident; a period of abstinence; a return; an increase in shame; and no change in the arrangement. The pattern is set out in the chapter as the reason resolve fails, and the case illustrates it without embellishment.

The measurement produced the finding that the man could not have reached by reflection. The correlation between the twenty-minute stop and the state on arrival was established from Idris's own record, and the finding is the kind that reflection systematically misses. This is the reason Section 22.5 places measurement at the centre of the method.

The weakness was sustained by an undisclosed situation. Eight years of concealed performance shortfall. The case belongs in this chapter as an example of the rule in Section 22.4: a weakness that began in a specific situation is frequently not addressable without addressing the situation, and the arrangement changes — the twenty-minute stop and the change of role — did more of the work than the psychological material.

Accountability was supplied by a person with the right properties. The brother-in-law was selected for a specific reason — that he would state an assessment to the man's face — and the arrangement's function was narrow: the report of an incident, on the day it occurred. The narrow scope is the reason the arrangement survived, and it is the practical form of Section 22.6's fourth prohibition.

22.8 Practical Exercise: The Weakness Audit and the Change Plan

This exercise takes about three hours in total, across four weeks, and it is conducted in writing. Its sequence is deliberate: the audit precedes the plan, and the plan precedes the accountability arrangement.

Part One: The Audit (Week One)

Write the weakness you intend to address. One item only. Then complete the following.

Question	My answer
In what situations does it occur?	
What time of day, and in whose company?	
What state am I in immediately before it?	
What do I expect it to do for me?	

Question	My answer
What does it actually do?	
Who else is affected, and how?	
What have I tried before, and what happened?	
When did it begin, and what was happening in my life at that time?	

The last two rows are the ones that determine the plan, and they are the ones most frequently left blank on a first attempt.

Part Two: The Trigger Record (Weeks Two and Three)

Complete the trigger map in Section 22.4 for every occurrence, at the time of occurrence. At the end of the period, answer four questions.

- What is the timetable of the behaviour?
- Which states precede it most frequently?
- What is the function, stated in one sentence beginning *I do this in order to*?
- What single element of the pattern is most within my control?

Part Three: The Change Plan (Week Four)

Specify each measure, and use the stages in the order given.

Stage One — Environment.

What I will remove, change, or add friction to	By what date

Stage Two — Substitute.

The function it serves	The substitute	When and where it will occur

Stage Three — Behavioural method.

The target (reduction or elimination, stated in numbers)	The measurement method	The first review date

Stage Four — Psychological work.

- The belief that supports the behaviour, and what my record shows about it:
- The situation in which the behaviour began, and what it requires:
- The person to whom the weakness will be disclosed, in the graduated form of Chapter 21:

Stage Five — Failure handling.

The situation in which a recurrence is most likely	What I will do instead	Within what period I will resume the plan

Part Four: The Accountability Arrangement

- **The person, and the evidence that they will state an assessment to my face:**
- **What will be reported, in specific terms:**
- **The interval and the form of the report:**
- **What I will do if the arrangement lapses:**

Part Five: The Prohibitions

Write, in your own words, the four prohibitions from Section 22.6 as they apply to your situation. In particular: which person from whom you would naturally seek support should not be given this material, and why?

22.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it not simply a matter of discipline? Other men manage."

Other men are managing considerably less well than the appearance suggests, and the appearance is the reason the belief persists. The specific finding that men report on entering a group or a professional arrangement for the first time is that the material they believed was unique to them is held by most of the men present. Discipline is a component of the work and it is not the whole of it, as Section 22.3 establishes, and the men who change are those who add the arrangement to the intention.

"My weakness is anger. Is that not just my personality?"

Temperament is real and the behaviour at a given moment is not the temperament itself. The distinction is testable, and the test is in Part One: is the behaviour concentrated in specific situations and states? Where the answer is yes, the behaviour is a response pattern rather than a disposition, and response patterns are changeable. Where the behaviour occurs continuously and across every setting, the assessment is different, and a professional opinion is worth obtaining.

"I have tried many times. Why would this be different?"

Because the method differs at the four points identified in Section 22.3: the cue is altered rather than resisted, the function is supplied rather than removed, the behaviour is measured rather than prohibited, and the isolation is ended. If the previous attempts consisted of decisions made after an incident and held by resolve, then none of these four elements was present, and the comparison is not between the same method applied twice.

"Can I do this without telling my wife?"

For material of the kind in Chapter 23, the disclosure question is set out there and depends on the severity. For an ordinary weakness, the answer depends on the effect on the household. Where the behaviour affects the household — the anger, the expenditure, the drinking, the absences — the concealment is a second problem, and the household's participation in the arrangement is frequently decisive. Where the behaviour is private and affects nobody else, the disclosure is a matter of the man's judgment and the accountability arrangement can be conducted with a professional or a peer.

"What if the person I tell uses it against me?"

Then the material is information about that person, and it should be recorded rather than regretted. Two practices reduce the risk: choosing the person on the criteria in Section 22.6, and disclosing in the specific form rather than as a general confession about the man's character.

"How long does this take?"

The observable pattern is that the environment and the substitute produce a measurable change within two to six weeks; that the measurement and the accountability arrangement are required indefinitely; and that the psychological work — the belief, the situation, the shame — takes between six months and two years, in the cases in which it concludes at all. Men should plan on the arrangement's being permanent and the work's being finite, which is the reverse of the usual expectation.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 22 in brief. A personal weakness is a repeated behaviour that the man believes is against his own interest, that he has attempted to change and has not changed, and for which he bears some responsibility. Four categories are habitually merged under the term and require different treatment: character weaknesses, which are supported by the man's own judgement in the moment; habits, which are the most changeable because their mechanism is known; conditions, which require treatment; and circumstances with behavioural results, where the arrangement rather than the behaviour is the subject.

The weaknesses men most commonly hold against themselves are anger, alcohol, sexual conduct, gambling, lying and concealment, procrastination, pride and contempt, and the behaviours that are symptoms of an untreated condition. Three principles govern the naming: name one weakness rather than a catalogue, name the behaviour rather than the character, and address the smallest version that is the problem. The word *weakness* carries its weight for four reasons: it is read as evidence about the person, it contradicts the script's requirement of control, its cost frequently falls on other people, and it is old — which produces the conclusion that it is permanent.

Private shame has six costs: the distortion of the man's account of himself; the loss of the relationship's truth; the energy of concealment; the escalation of the behaviour, since the behaviour manages the distress the behaviour produces; the prevention of help; and the transmission of the pattern to the household.

Willpower fails at four points: it operates against the cue rather than on it; it removes the behaviour without supplying what the behaviour provided; it draws on a capacity that has been spent by the end of a working day; and it is stated in the form that produces the greatest shame. The replacement methods are the alteration of the cue in advance, the substitute that fits the function, measurement rather than prohibition, and accountability that ends the isolation.

Understanding one's own patterns requires a trigger record kept at the time of occurrence, which reliably identifies the timetable, the states, the company and place, and the function the behaviour serves; a function test that asks what the behaviour actually produces and what would produce the same outcome without its cost; and a history that locates the period in which the weakness began, which is frequently the situation that requires attention.

The change programme proceeds in five stages: the environment, the substitute, the behavioural method of measurement and defined review, the psychological work on the belief, the situation, and the shame, and the handling of failure through analysis rather than sentencing, rapid resumption, a change to one element of the arrangement, and a report to the accountable person. Accountability requires the conversion of secrecy into confidentiality: one person at minimum, selected for their independence, their record of discretion, their willingness to state an assessment, and their availability over time; a defined interval of reporting; and four prohibitions concerning unsuitable confidants, the use of disclosure as absolution, the conversion of the arrangement into a general assessment, and the abandonment of the arrangement at the point of improvement.

Reflection Questions

1. Name the single weakness you will address. What have your previous attempts consisted of, and which of the four mechanisms in Section 22.3 were absent from them?
2. What does the weakness do for you — stated in one sentence beginning *I do this in order to*? Does it actually produce that outcome?
3. When did the behaviour begin, and what was happening in your life at that time? What has never been addressed from that period?
4. From the six costs of shame in Section 22.2, which are you paying now — the distorted account of yourself, the loss of the relationship's truth, the energy of concealment, the escalation, the prevention of help, or the transmission to your household?

5. On the trigger record, what is the timetable of your behaviour? What state precedes it most often, and which single environmental change would interrupt the sequence?
6. Who is your accountable person, and does the person meet the four criteria in Section 22.6? Who is the person you should not tell, and why?
7. Write your failure plan: the situation in which a recurrence is most likely, what you will do instead, and within what period you will resume the plan.

Further Reading

- **On habit and behaviour change:** the research literature on habit formation and change, including the findings on cue-based automaticity, the role of context and friction, and the evidence on the relative weakness of intention as a predictor of behaviour.
- **On self-regulation:** the literature on self-control as a limited and context-dependent capacity, including the findings on ego depletion and the substantial evidence that environmental change outperforms resistance.
- **On anger and its management:** the research on anger and aggression in men, including the findings on the physiological and cognitive mechanisms of anger episodes, and the evidence on structured anger-management programmes.
- **On procrastination:** the psychological literature on procrastination, including the consistent finding that it is associated with aversive task appraisal and emotional avoidance rather than with time management, and the evidence on the interventions that reduce it.
- **On accountability and disclosure:** the research on the effects of disclosure on distress, including the findings on expressive writing, and the literature on accountability and goal attainment.
- **Practical resources:** counselling for specific behaviours; structured anger-management and habit-change programmes; men's groups with an agreed rule of honesty; and the material in Chapters 21, 23, and 35 of this book.

23 CHAPTER

The Secret Struggle With Addiction

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Define addiction in behavioural and physiological terms, and distinguish between dependence, harmful use, and habits that are not addictive.
2. Identify the substances and behaviours to which men most commonly become addicted, and recognise the specific features of each.
3. Explain why addiction is concealed, and describe the progression from private use to private dependence.
4. Describe the effects of addiction on the man, his household, his work, and his finances, including the effects that are not visible from outside.
5. Evaluate the routes into treatment, including self-help, professional treatment, medical assistance, and residential programmes, and identify the appropriate route for a given situation.
6. Apply a structured method for assessing his own use, and use the exercise at the end of this chapter to construct a plan.

Introduction

The subject of this chapter is the most thoroughly concealed of all the struggles in this book, and the concealment is the reason it is included in a book about men who fight their battles alone. A man with a drinking problem, a gambling problem, a dependence on a substance, or a compulsive behavioural pattern is frequently the last person in his household to acknowledge it, and the concealment is maintained by a set of mechanisms that are entirely rational from the inside: the fear of losing the standing on which everything depends, the fear of the household's reaction, the belief that the matter can be managed without assistance, and the specific and powerful belief that disclosure would make the problem permanent by making it official.

This chapter is written with two audiences in mind, and it addresses them differently.

The first audience is the man who is concerned about his own use. What is offered to him is a set of specific assessments, an explanation of the progression by which ordinary use becomes dependence, an account of the treatment routes with an honest description of what each involves, and the practical guidance for the period between the recognition and the treatment, which is frequently the most dangerous period of the entire process.

The second audience is the man who is not the person with the condition: the man whose brother, son, colleague, or friend is using heavily, whose wife has a dependence, or who occupies a responsible position — a manager, a head of a family, a professional — in which the situation has to be handled. For him, what is offered is a set of principles for intervention, an explanation of the effects that other people's intervention reliably produces, and the guidance on the boundaries that a person living with or managing an addicted man must establish.

Two general points should be stated at the outset, because they determine everything else in this chapter.

Addiction is a condition, not a failure of character. This is now established in the clinical and research literature with respect to both substances and behaviours. It has a physiological component, a psychological component, and a social component; it responds to treatment; and it is associated with relapse in a substantial proportion of cases, in the same manner as diabetes and hypertension, whose management is also imperfect and whose relapse is also not treated as proof that the patient is a bad person.

Disclosure is the pivot. Almost every route out of an addiction runs through a conversation that the man has not been able to hold. The reason is described in the sections that follow: the condition is sustained by isolation, and isolation is maintained by shame. The chapter's practical objective is therefore specific: to make that conversation possible and to identify where it should be directed.

23.1 Understanding Addiction

The word is used loosely in ordinary conversation to describe any strong enthusiasm or any habit, and the looseness makes the subject harder to think about. A precise set of terms is therefore necessary.

The Three Levels

Harmful use. Use that produces damage to health, relationships, work, or finances, without the features of dependence. The person retains control of the quantity and the frequency, and the damage is the reason the pattern is a problem. The appropriate response is a reduction in use, obtained by the methods described in the previous chapter.

Dependence. A specific clinical pattern with a defined set of features. Its core elements are: a compulsion to use; difficulty in controlling the quantity or

duration; a physical withdrawal state when use stops; tolerance, where increasing quantities are required; the neglect of other interests and obligations; and continued use despite clear evidence of harm. Dependence is a condition, and its management is a clinical matter.

Addiction in the behavioural sense. The same pattern applied to behaviour rather than to a substance: gambling, sexual conduct, gaming, internet use, shopping, work. The clinical literature on behavioural addictions has developed substantially, and the pattern for gambling in particular is established as a condition with mechanisms closely comparable to those of substance dependence.

The Mechanism, in Ordinary Language

Four features of the mechanism are worth setting out, because men frequently reject treatment on the grounds that they should be able to manage the matter themselves, and the rejection is based on a misunderstanding of what is happening.

The reward pathway is being directly engaged. Substances and certain behaviours produce their effects through the brain's reward system, and repeated engagement produces a change in the system itself: the same quantity produces less effect, and the system's baseline state changes so that ordinary activity produces less pleasure and the substance or behaviour becomes the principal source of it.

Tolerance and withdrawal create their own logic. Once dependence has developed, the substance is required not to produce pleasure but to restore a tolerable state. The man is no longer using in order to feel good; he is using in order to feel normal, and the distinction is frequently the first thing that a man recognises when the pattern is explained to him.

The triggers are learned. The situations associated with use — the time of day, the place, the company, the emotional state, the argument — acquire the capacity to produce the urge by themselves. This is why the environment and the situation are part of the treatment rather than incidental to it.

The self-management is impaired. A central feature of dependence is that the capacity to govern one's own use is precisely what the condition damages. This is the reason that the instruction to exercise self-control, which is the standard response of families and employers, fails at the point where it is most needed: the capacity has been affected by the condition the instruction is intended to correct.

What Addiction Is Not

It is not a moral failure, and describing it as one does not help. The moral account has a specific and measurable cost: it produces concealment, and concealment is the principal reason that men do not obtain treatment.

It is not a permanent identity. A man who has been dependent is not defined by it, and the increasing social acceptance of treatment has made the disclosure of recovery substantially less costly than the fear suggests.

It is not, in most cases, immediate. The progression from ordinary use to dependence occurs over a period whose median length is measured in years rather than months, through a sequence of stages: use for a purpose, use in a pattern, use with increasing frequency, use with consequences, use with concealment, and use as a requirement. This matters practically because it means that the earlier stages are identifiable, and because the man who recognises his own position in the sequence at stage three faces a much cheaper intervention than the man who reaches stage six.

The Sequence

Figure 23.1 sets out the progression from use to dependence, with the point at which the pattern becomes visible to the man and the point at which treatment has the best prospect of success. The diagram is illustrative and generalised; the progression differs between substances and individuals, and its purpose is to identify that the stages are recognisable.

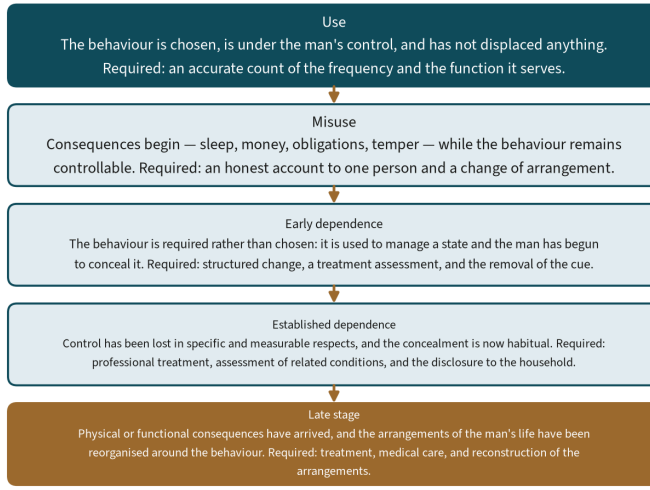


Figure 23.1 The progression from use to dependence. The left-hand column describes the stage; the right-hand column identifies what is required at that point. The window in which a change of pattern is achievable without treatment closes earlier than most men assume.

23.2 The Forms Addiction Takes in Men

The forms are numerous and the men affected are not a distinguishable type. The following account sets out the principal forms, with the features that matter practically.

Alcohol

The most common dependence among men in most countries, and the one with the widest range of presentation. Its features are worth stating because the popular image of the dependent drinker — the man who is intoxicated daily and visibly — does not correspond to the majority of cases among men in professional and family life.

The patterns that men most frequently describe: drinking daily at a level that is not visible to others and that has increased over years; drinking concentrated in the evenings and increasing with stress; drinking in secret — before an event, at home alone, in the vehicle; drinking with the specific purpose of managing sleep, anxiety, or mood; and the pattern in which the man's drinking is entirely under control in public and entirely uncontrolled in private.

The features that indicate dependence rather than heavy use: drinking in the morning or during working hours; the experience of withdrawal symptoms — tremor, sweating, anxiety, sleeplessness — when drinking is interrupted; drinking to relieve those symptoms; unsuccessful attempts to reduce; and drinking in the presence of clear consequences, including medical advice, a spouse's ultimatum, or a professional warning.

The medical caution is important: alcohol withdrawal in a dependent man can be dangerous, and sudden cessation without medical support is unsafe in cases of heavy long-term use. Assessment should precede the attempt.

Gambling and Betting

The pattern among men has changed substantially with the availability of mobile betting, and its features now include the man whose gambling occurs entirely within a device, in the house, in the presence of his family, without any of the visible markers of the traditional gambling situation.

Its characteristic progression: occasional betting; betting with the intention of covering other losses; concealment of the amounts; borrowing; the sale of assets or the use of funds held for another purpose; and, at the final stage, the attempt at a single large recovery, which consolidates rather than repairs the position. The financial consequences are frequently the largest of any addiction, because the mechanism permits losses that are orders of magnitude beyond the man's income.

The signs are described in Chapter 9 as financial: the concealed obligation, the separate account, the deferred disclosure, and, characteristically, a man who is unusually knowledgeable about money and unusually secretive about his own.

Substances Other Than Alcohol

The forms vary by region and circumstance, and their practical features are consistent: a rapid progression from occasional use to dependence; a high association with a specific social environment; and a strong association with concealment, because the substance use is illegal as well as harmful in most jurisdictions. The treatment routes are comparable to those for alcohol, with the addition of medical management where dependence is established.

Sexual Conduct

The form that men disclose last, and, in the author's experience, the form that produces the most severe shame. It includes: the compulsive use of sexual material, which typically escalates in quantity and in the extremity of content over years; pursuit of encounters outside the man's committed relationship; and use of commercial sexual services. The features that indicate a condition rather than a matter of choice: the compulsion to use at specific times or in specific emotional states; use that continues against the man's stated intentions and values; the escalation of content or risk; and the specific pattern of use followed by shame, followed by renewed use to manage the shame.

The clinical literature treats compulsive sexual behaviour as a behavioural addiction with mechanisms comparable to gambling, and the evidence on treatment is developing. What is established is that the disclosure of the pattern to a professional produces an improvement in a substantial proportion of cases, and that concealment maintains the pattern.

Gaming, Internet Use, and Screens

The form most commonly dismissed by the man himself and by his household. Its practical features: hours of use that displace sleep, work, and family relationships; use as the principal means of managing negative feeling; irritability when prevented from use; and a specific pattern of concealment that is simpler than that of the other forms but equally effective, because the device is in the man's hand.

The clinical literature on gaming disorder has developed in recent years, and men should note that the same principles apply: use with consequences, failed attempts to reduce, concealment, and the escalation of quantity over time.

Work

The form that is never classified as an addiction at all, and that produces many of this book's subjects. Its features: work as the principal means of managing anxiety, mood, and relationship difficulty; the inability to reduce work without distress; the displacement of sleep, family, and health; and, characteristically, the approval of the man's environment, which is the reason it is not identified. Chapter 12 addresses the pattern from the perspective of overwork and this chapter names it as a behavioural pattern with the same structure as the others.

Other Behaviours

Shopping and expenditure; eating; risk-taking in driving and in financial speculation; and, in a form that is increasingly recognised, the pursuit of anger and conflict. In each case the structure is the same: a behaviour engaged in to manage a state, escalating over time, producing consequences, and concealed.

Two Features Common to All Forms

The concealment escalates faster than the behaviour. The man's commitment to concealment increases with the behaviour's seriousness, and the concealment is frequently the more damaging of the two.

The purpose is managing a state. The substance or behaviour is always doing something. Identifying what it does — providing relief from anxiety, sleep, company, oblivion, a sense of competence, or a temporary removal of self-assessment — is the first step of treatment, and men who identify it report that they experience a reduction in the behaviour's hold, because the behaviour has stopped being a characteristic of their character and become a method with a purpose.

23.3 Why Addiction Is Concealed

Six reasons, each of which is practical and each of which the man has considered.

The standing. A man's position — in his household, his work, his community — is constructed from his reliability. The disclosure of dependence is assessed by the man as a threat to the whole of it, and the assessment is not unreasonable in every case. What the assessment omits is that the behaviour is frequently already known in its consequences if not its extent, and that the concealment's cost is being paid in the interim.

The fear of the household's reaction. Men anticipate, and frequently correctly, that disclosure will produce a crisis: the wife's ultimatum, the children's knowledge, the family's involvement. The anticipation is one of the strongest forces maintaining concealment, and it is the reason that treatment frequently begins with the man and a professional rather than with the household.

The belief in self-management. The belief that the matter can be handled without assistance, which is the script described in Chapter 2 operating in its most damaging form. Men frequently attempt multiple private resolutions before any treatment is sought, and each failure reduces the man's belief in his own capacity and increases the concealment.

The specific fear of formal entry. The belief that treatment makes the matter permanent by making it official: that the employer will learn, that the record will exist, that the household's account of the man will be fixed at this point. The belief is inaccurate in most jurisdictions and circumstances, and its accuracy varies by profession — which is a matter to be established with specific advice rather than assumed.

The shame. Described in Chapters 21 and 22. Its specific dynamic in addiction is the strongest of the reasons: the shame produces distress, the distress is managed by the behaviour, and the behaviour produces the shame.

The absence of a person to tell. A man who has no confidant has no route to disclosure. The material of Chapter 4 is a precondition of this chapter's material, and the practical implication is direct: the first intervention for a man with a concealed dependence is frequently the establishment of one confidential relationship, not with the household but with a professional or a person outside the man's immediate circle.

23.4 What Addiction Costs

The costs of dependence are extensive, and they are set out here in four categories because each requires different attention in the recovery.

The Cost to the Man

Health. The direct effects of the substance or behaviour; the indirect effects of sleep loss, poor nutrition, and neglect of existing conditions; the elevated rate of accidents and injuries; and the specific effects on the liver, cardiovascular system, and nervous system in the case of alcohol, which is the most common case among the men this book addresses.

Mental health. The condition and the mental health condition are related in both directions. Depression and anxiety are more common among men with dependence, dependence produces and maintains both, and the two are frequently treated as one. The practical implication is that both should be assessed, because treating one and not the other is one of the common causes of relapse.

Capacity. The reduction in judgement, memory, and reliability is frequently noticed first by colleagues. Men with concealed dependence frequently work longer to compensate, which accelerates the condition.

Self-regard. The specific injury described throughout this chapter: the man's own account of himself is organised around a matter he cannot discuss.

Time and money. The direct expenditure, which is frequently larger than the man admits even to himself, and the ancillary costs: the absences, the losses, the payments, the interest.

The Cost to the Household

The atmosphere of the house. The most consistently reported effect by the families of men with dependence: the household is organised around the man's condition. The children learn to read the man's state; the wife manages the arrangements to avoid the trigger; the household's plans are made conditional on the man's capacity to participate.

The financial consequences. The direct expenditure, the losses, the debts, and the diversion of household funds, as described in Chapter 9. Where gambling is the form, the losses can be catastrophic, and their recovery takes years.

The relational consequences. The deterioration of the marriage; the wife's assumption of the household's management; the children's formation of their own patterns; and the specific development described in the marital literature, in which the unaffected partner becomes the household's manager of the condition and the man becomes its subject.

The physical risk. Where the condition involves a substance, the risk to the household is not only financial and relational. The safety considerations in Appendix G and the guidance in the safety sections of this book apply where a household contains violence or the threat of it, which is more likely in the presence of alcohol.

The Cost to the Man's Position

Employment consequences; professional consequences, including licensing matters where the profession regulates conduct; the loss of reputation; and, in the specific case where the condition becomes known to the community, the loss of standing described in Chapter 16. Men should note that the position is rarely as irreversible as the fear suggests, and that the pattern for the men who lose the most is concealment maintained until the condition declares itself on its own terms — the incident, the dismissal, the offence — at which point the man has no control over the disclosure's form.

The Cost That Is Frequently Overlooked: The Cost of Concealment

The final category is the one this chapter exists to name. Concealment has its own costs, and they are frequently larger than the costs of the condition.

The delay. Every year of concealment is a year in which the condition progresses and in which the treatment has a lower prospect of success. This is the single most consequential cost.

The household's wrong conclusions. Where the behaviour is known in its effects but not in its cause, the household constructs an explanation, and the explanation is generally about the man's character or about its own inadequacy. The children of fathers with concealed dependence frequently carry an account of themselves as having been the reason their father withdrew.

The compulsion to compensate. The man works longer, provides more, and performs reliability to demonstrate that nothing is wrong. The compensation produces exhaustion, and it produces the material of Chapters 12 and 20.

The loss of the years in which the man could have been known. The most general cost, and the one that men in recovery most frequently describe as irrecoverable.

23.5 The Routes to Recovery

This section sets out the routes, with an honest account of what each involves. It is deliberately specific, because the vagueness of the advice offered to men on this subject is a substantial part of the problem.

Route One: Assessment

The first step in every case, and not an optional preliminary. An assessment establishes: whether dependence is present, which determines the treatment; whether a co-occurring condition — depression, anxiety, a sleep disorder, a physical condition — is present, which is the case in a large proportion of men with dependence; whether withdrawal carries medical risk, which determines the safety of the initial period; and what the appropriate level of treatment is.

Where assessment is obtained: a physician, a psychiatrist, a clinic specialising in substance use, a hospital emergency department where the situation is acute, or a confidential telephone service offered by health authorities in many jurisdictions. The specific content of the discussion can be limited to the material the man is willing to disclose; the assessment does not require the household's involvement at this stage.

Route Two: Professional Treatment

Outpatient treatment. The most common form for men in employment and family life: regular sessions with a counsellor, a psychologist, or a physician, frequently weekly, sometimes with group participation. Its advantages are confidentiality and compatibility with work. Its requirement is a genuine reduction in use alongside the treatment, which should be established at the outset with the practitioner.

Medication. Where indicated, for withdrawal management, for the reduction of craving, and for co-occurring conditions. The evidence on medication for alcohol dependence is substantial, and the specific point for men is that the medication is not a substitute for the psychological work and the psychological work is frequently insufficient without medication.

Residential treatment. Where outpatient treatment is insufficient, where the environment cannot be altered, where the condition is severe, or where the household's safety requires separation. Its advantage is the removal of triggers and the provision of a structured environment. Its costs are the time, the expense, the disclosure, and the return to an unchanged environment at the end.

Group programmes and peer support. The structured group programmes, including the long-established twelve-step approach and its variants, and the professional group programmes. Their specific advantage is the presence of other men with the same condition, which produces the evidence against the shame described in Chapter 21 more rapidly than any other route. Men who are reluc-

tant to attend a group frequently describe the experience afterwards as the point at which the condition lost its uniqueness.

Route Three: What the Man Can Do Himself

Three measures that a man can take without treatment, and that are appropriate in cases of harmful use rather than dependence.

The record. Two weeks of honest recording: the quantity, the time, the situation, the state before and after. The record is the most reliable instrument available, and most men who complete it find that their use is higher than their estimate.

The environment. The removal of the substance or the trigger from the house; the removal of the application; the change of route; the change of company. The environmental change is not a permanent solution and it produces a substantial reduction, which establishes the man's position.

The substitute. A specific activity at the time and in the place in which the use occurred: exercise, a meeting, a call with a person, a task. The substitute must serve the same function — rest, company, relief, sleep — and it must be arranged in advance rather than decided at the moment of the urge.

Route Four: The Conversation With the Household

The subject that brings most men to this chapter's page last, and the one that determines the durability of the recovery.

The conversation should not be conducted first, and it should not be conducted alone. The order that practitioners generally recommend: assessment, treatment begun, the household informed with the support of the practitioner, and the household's arrangements adjusted with professional input. The conversation's content should be: what the condition is, what has been occurring, what treatment is in place, what the household's role is, and what the man needs — which is frequently specific and modest, such as the removal of alcohol from the house or the management of a trigger.

The household's reaction is not controllable and should not be predicted. Men who have conducted the conversation with professional support report a range of responses: relief, anger, a period of crisis followed by support, and, in a minority of cases, a decision that the marriage cannot continue. The last outcome is a genuine possibility, and its probability is considerably higher where the disclosure is made after an incident than where it is made before one.

23.6 Relapse, and the Long Work

The subject of relapse is treated separately because the popular account of addiction misrepresents it and because the misrepresentation causes men to abandon the work after a single episode.

Relapse Is Expected

Relapse is a common feature of recovery from dependence, in the same manner that the adjustment of treatment is a common feature of the management of diabetes and hypertension. The evidence on treatment outcomes indicates that a substantial proportion of people who achieve recovery do so after one or more episodes of return to use, and that the factors associated with a good long-term outcome include the speed of return to treatment rather than the absence of any return.

The practical consequence is a rule that men should establish in advance: **a return to use is information about the plan, not a verdict on the man.** The alternative understanding, which is the common one, is that the episode demonstrates that the condition is untreatable and the man is beyond help, and that understanding produces the pattern in which a single episode ends a two-year recovery.

The Danger Points

The research on relapse identifies a set of situations in which risk is elevated, and knowing them in advance is the principal preventive measure.

- **Negative emotional states:** the argument, the financial loss, the humiliation, the bereavement.
- **Positive emotional states:** the celebration, the promotion, the wedding, the business success.
- **Interpersonal conflict:** a specific quarrel, a family dispute, a marital crisis.
- **Social pressure:** the specific person, the occasion, the environment associated with use.
- **Physical states:** pain, exhaustion, hunger, illness, the effect of medication.
- **The early period after a significant period of abstinence**, including at the point where the man's confidence is highest.

Men should write the specific danger points for their own condition, and a plan for each: what will be done, whom will be called, and what will be avoided.

The Handling of an Episode

Five steps, and their order matters.

Stop the episode at its shortest. The most consequential variable. The difference between one evening and a three-month return is almost always attributable to the interpretation the man places on the first evening, not to the severity of the condition.

Tell the person who knows. The disclosure to the practitioner, the group, or the one confidant should occur within days, and it is a feature of the recovery rather than a failure of it.

Review the plan, not the man. What was the situation, what was the trigger, and what will be different in the arrangements? The review should be conducted in the form the man uses elsewhere in this book: specific items with dates.

Do not make it the central fact about the recovery. The danger of a review conducted in the register of shame is that the episode acquires a position in the man's account that it does not occupy in the plan.

Return to the treatment arrangement without delay. Where the treatment had concluded, it should be resumed; where it continues, the frequency should be increased for a period.

The Long Work

Recovery in the durable sense is not an event but an arrangement that is maintained. Four elements are consistently present in the accounts of men who have maintained recovery for years.

A permanent disclosure to at least one person. Not a public announcement, which is a matter of the man's judgment, but the presence of at least one person who knows the condition and who remains in contact. Its function is to prevent the isolation that maintains the condition.

A continuing practice. A group, a meeting, a professional relationship at reduced frequency, a routine of record-keeping. Its function is maintenance, and its duration is indefinite.

A revised arrangement of life. The environment, the company, the hours, the work, and, in a significant proportion of cases, the household's arrangements. Recovery that leaves the arrangement which produced the use untouched has a lower prospect of durability, and the changes in Chapters 12 and 18 are frequently part of the same work.

A purpose that is not the recovery itself. A specific observation from the accounts of men in long-term recovery: the men who maintain it are those for whom something has taken the place the substance or the behaviour occupied — a relationship, a work, a contribution, an activity. A recovery defined only by the absence of the behaviour is fragile, because absence is not a life.

23.7 When It Is Someone Else

This section addresses the reader who is not the person with the condition: the man whose son, brother, wife, colleague, or friend is dependent, or who occupies a position in which he must manage the situation. It sets out what helps and, more importantly, what does not.

What Does Not Help

The repeated request. Asking a dependent man to stop, repeatedly and in the same form, produces no change and consumes the relationship's remaining

capacity. The evidence on the effectiveness of unaided requests is not encouraging, and the requests frequently postpone treatment by reinforcing the man's belief in his own capacity to manage.

The rescue that removes the consequences. Paying the debts, covering the absences, repairing the damage, and concealing the effects from the household and the employer. This is the most common action taken by families, and it is the one most consistently associated with the continuation of the condition. Its removal — the decision that the man will bear the consequences of his use — is the action that most frequently produces a decision to seek treatment.

The moral lecture. The effect is described in Section 23.2: shame increases, and shame maintains the behaviour.

The threat that is not carried out. An ultimatum stated and not implemented teaches the man that the threats are not to be taken seriously, which removes the one instrument available to the household.

The secrecy maintained on the man's behalf. Where a father conceals his son's condition, or a wife conceals her husband's, the condition's progression is assisted by the very person most concerned about it.

The declaration that the person must want help. The claim that treatment is impossible until the person is ready is not supported by the evidence. Coerced or strongly pressured entry into treatment, whether by an employer, a court, or a family, produces outcomes broadly comparable to voluntary entry, and the practical implication is that pressure applied with a specific and available treatment option is worthwhile.

What Helps

The assessment. The most useful single action available to a family member is obtaining a professional assessment and ensuring the man attends it. The offer should be specific: the appointment made, the date given, the journey arranged, and the reduction of every practical obstacle.

The described consequence. The household states what will change if the situation continues, in specific and implementable terms, and implements it. Not a threat about an unmanageable outcome; a stated arrangement. Examples: the money will be separated; the household will not carry the debts; the children will be removed from the situation; the man will leave the house until the situation is addressed.

The boundary. The arrangements in Chapter 10's method, applied to the condition: what the household will and will not do, stated in advance and held. The purpose is not punishment and not leverage; it is the household's survival, which is required for the household to be in a position to support a recovery.

The offer that is specific and repeated. The offer of help should be specific — the assessment, the clinic, the journey, the cost, the practitioner's name — and it should be repeated at intervals, in the same form, without a lecture. Repeated specific offers are among the more effective interventions available to families, and their effect is frequently delayed by months.

The household's own support. The family members of a dependent man need support of their own: a counsellor, a group for families, a professional relationship. The pattern of the family's own health deteriorating while it manages the man's condition is one of the most consistent findings in the literature on families and addiction.

The safety plan, where it is required. Where the household contains the possibility of violence, threats, or the endangerment of children, the safety material in Appendix G takes precedence over everything in this section, and it should be implemented before any other work is attempted. The incidence and severity of domestic violence are both substantially elevated in the presence of alcohol, and the household's safety is not negotiable in the interests of the man's treatment.

23.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Never Drank at Home

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in addiction treatment, family practice, and the occupational literature on concealed dependence.

Femi is forty-nine, a branch manager in a commercial bank, married to Nkechi for twenty-one years, with three children aged between fourteen and twenty.

The case emerged through an occupational referral. Femi had been observed by two colleagues over a period of about eight months: arriving late three or four times each month; a change in his handwriting and in the accuracy of his figures; a period of four days in March during which he was reported to be unwell; and, in June, a customer complaint concerning a call in which Femi's speech had been slurred. He was referred to the bank's medical service, which referred him for assessment.

Femi's account, given at assessment, was that he did not have a drinking problem because he never drank at home. The pattern he described, once he had begun, was the following.

He drank on the way home from work, in the vehicle, from a bottle kept in the boot, between the office and the house, on approximately four days each week for about six years. He drank at the bar attached to a hotel near his office, in the early evening, on two or three days a week, with the intention of a single drink and, in his description, "one or two more than that." He drank at the weekends, at a club, from Friday until Sunday, at levels he described as social. He never drank in the morning, he never drank in the house, and he had never been intoxicated in front of his wife

or children, which he regarded, at the time of the assessment, as the evidence that no problem existed.

Four features of the history emerged subsequently.

First, the pattern had developed from a specific and datable event: a role change six years earlier, in which Femi had been moved from an operations position in which he had been highly competent to a branch management position requiring sales performance, at which he had no experience and which he had disliked from the first month.

Second, the consumption had increased gradually, and the increase was in quantity rather than in frequency for the first four years and in both thereafter. He had attempted to stop entirely three times, for periods of between eleven days and six weeks, and each attempt had ended in a period of heavier use than before.

Third, his sleep had deteriorated seriously over about two years: he was waking at approximately 3 a.m. and lying awake, and he had begun to require a drink at that hour on some nights. This symptom, which he had not mentioned to his physician at an insurance examination eight months earlier, was the clearest clinical indicator of dependence.

Fourth, the concealment had produced a set of secondary arrangements that had become substantial in their own right: a second fuel budget to account for the extra journeys; the scheduling of his arrival at home after the children had gone to bed; the removal of a telephone call log that he had worried about; and, most significantly, a persistent refusal of two family holidays on the grounds of work, because he could not maintain the pattern away from home.

The assessment identified alcohol dependence at a moderate level with an associated depressive episode, which had been present for about two years and which he had described to himself as being tired of the job.

The treatment was as follows.

The initial period required a medically supervised withdrawal, because of the quantity and duration of use, and this was conducted over five days with medication. Femi described this period as the most significant element of the whole process: *I had not known that I was physically dependent. I thought I had a habit. When I understood that I could not stop safely without a doctor, I understood what the last six years had actually been.*

The withdrawal was followed by a course of medication and weekly psychological treatment, both continuing over about eighteen months, and by attendance at a structured group programme, which Femi joined reluctantly in the fourth month and continued for two years.

The disclosure to Nkechi was conducted in the eighth week, with the practitioner present, and it produced, in Femi's description, the response he had least expected: she had known something was wrong for at least four years, had concluded that he was having an affair or had decided that he did not want the family, and had spent the period attempting to manage an unnamed situation. The disclosure required,

in the following months, a second conversation that Femi had not anticipated: the account of what the concealment had done to her.

The arrangement changes were substantial and they were not limited to the drinking. Femi took a reduction in grade and a transfer back to an operations position in the second year, with a salary reduction of about twelve per cent, and described the decision as the one that consolidated the recovery: *The job was the reason for the drinking and everybody knew it except me. I have never been good at selling and I spent six years being bad at it and drinking about it.*

Three years after the assessment, Femi was abstinent, his depressive episode had resolved, and he described the position as follows: *I never drank at home. That was my evidence and it was the whole of my lie. What I learned in the first month was that the important question was never where I drank. It was why, and where I was going at six o'clock in the evening.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The concealment was structured around a plausible indicator. *I never drink at home* was the man's evidence for the absence of a problem, and its plausibility was the reason that neither his household nor he had identified the condition for six years. The case is included because this pattern — dependence maintained entirely away from the household, or in a form the household cannot interpret — is common among men in employment.

The pattern had a datable origin. A role change that the man disliked and could not refuse, followed by a gradual increase in use. This is the ordinary history of dependence in men: not a pathology that arrives, but a method of management that develops from a specific situation and becomes independent of it.

The physical dependence was the pivot. The withdrawal requirement was the first fact that contradicted the man's own account, and his statement — that the understanding of physical dependence changed his understanding of the previous six years — is the reason that Section 23.5 places assessment first in every case.

The wife had constructed a different explanation. As in Section 23.4, the household's conclusions in the presence of unexplained behaviour are generally about the man's regard for the family. The second conversation, conducted months later, concerned the effect of the concealment rather than the drinking, and the case is included because this second conversation is frequently omitted from the recovery work and is frequently the substance of the marital repair.

The recovery required an arrangement change. The transfer and the reduction in grade were not incidental to the treatment; in Femi's account they were its mechanism. This is the pattern in Section 23.6 — that recovery which leaves

the arrangements untouched has a lower prospect of durability — illustrated at the level of a man's working life.

23.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"How do I know whether I have a problem or I simply enjoy drinking?"

Four questions are decisive. Have I attempted to reduce or stop and failed? Has my use increased over the last two years? Has anything important been affected — health, marriage, work, money, judgement? And do I experience any symptom when I stop — sleeplessness, tremor, anxiety, sweating? Three affirmative answers indicate a situation that requires assessment. The questions are answered accurately only after a period of honest recording, which is the reason Section 23.5 places the record first.

"Will my employer find out?"

This depends on the jurisdiction and the profession, and the accurate answer is obtained from a practitioner or a confidential advisory service rather than assumed. Two general points are relevant: treatment obtained through a health service is generally confidential, and the situation is materially better addressed before an incident than after one. The man who is considering treatment should ask the specific question of the specific practitioner: what is disclosed, to whom, and under what conditions.

"Can I manage this myself?"

Where the pattern is harmful use rather than dependence, the measures in Route Three are appropriate and frequently sufficient. Where dependence is present, the evidence indicates that self-management is rarely sufficient and that the attempts consume years that the condition uses to progress. The assessment in Route One determines which situation applies.

"My wife says she will leave if it continues. Is that fair?"

It is a legitimate position for a household to hold, and it is frequently stated at a point that the household has reached after years rather than in a first response. The relevant questions for the man are whether the statement is specific, whether it is implemented, and whether he has obtained treatment. The research on family pressure indicates that a stated and implemented consequence, accompanied by the availability of treatment, is among the more effective interventions available.

"What if I return to use after a year?"

Then the plan resumes and the return is treated as information, as described in Section 23.6. The single most useful action is to inform the practitioner or the group within days, because the isolation that follows a return is the mechanism by which a single episode becomes a return to dependence.

"My son is using. What do I do?"

The material in Section 23.7 applies in order: assessment, the specific and repeated offer of help, the removal of the rescues, the stated and implemented consequence, the household's own support, and the safety arrangements where required. The specific addition for a father is the preservation of the relationship, which is the resource that is most frequently consumed by the attempt to manage the condition; and the material in Chapter 17 on being a person the child can approach applies in full.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 23 in brief. Addiction is distinguished from harmful use and from habits by the presence of compulsion, impaired control, withdrawal, tolerance, the neglect of obligations, and continued use despite harm. It is a condition with physiological, psychological, and social components; it responds to treatment; and it is sustained by concealment, which is therefore the principal target of intervention.

Men's principal forms are alcohol, gambling and betting, other substances, sexual conduct, gaming and screen use, work, and other behaviours including expenditure and risk-taking. Every form shares two features: the concealment escalates faster than the behaviour, and the behaviour always serves a purpose — the management of a state — which is why the behaviour persists and why identifying its function is the first step of treatment.

Concealment is maintained by six forces: standing, the anticipated household reaction, the belief in self-management, the fear of formal entry into treatment, shame, and the absence of any person to confide in. Its costs frequently exceed the costs of the condition itself, principally through delay, the household's wrong conclusions, the compulsion to compensate, and the loss of the years in which the man could have been known.

The routes to recovery are assessment; professional treatment including outpatient work, medication, residential treatment, and group programmes; the measures a man can take himself, comprising honest recording, environmental change, and substitution; and, finally and not first, the conversation with the household, conducted with professional support and after treatment has begun. Relapse is a common feature of recovery rather than a verdict on the man, and the variables that determine the outcome are the speed of return to treatment and the maintenance of a continuing arrangement.

Where the person with the condition is somebody else, the actions that help are a professional assessment, a stated and implemented consequence, a boundary defined in advance, a specific and repeated offer of help, and support for the household itself. The actions that do not help are the repeated request, the rescue that removes the consequences, the moral lecture, the threat that is not carried out, the secrecy maintained on the man's behalf, and the claim that nothing can be done until the person wants help. Where violence or the endangerment of children is present, the safety material in Appendix G takes precedence over everything else.

Reflection Questions

1. Applying the four questions in Section 23.9, do you have a situation that requires assessment? What have you not recorded honestly, and when will you?
2. From the forms in Section 23.2, which applies to you — and what is the function the behaviour serves? What state is it managing?
3. Which of the six forces maintaining concealment in Section 23.3 operates most strongly in your case, and who is the one person to whom the disclosure could be made?
4. What has the concealment cost you in the last three years, in money, health, sleep, and relationships? Write the figures.
5. If you are the person with the condition, what is your danger-point plan: the three situations in which the risk is highest, and what will be done in each?
6. If somebody in your household or family is affected, which of the unhelpful actions in Section 23.7 are you currently performing — the repeated request, the rescue, the lecture, the unimplemented threat, or the maintained secrecy?
7. What is the arrangement in your life that the behaviour is serving — the job, the marriage, the hours, the environment — and what change would be required for the recovery to hold?

Further Reading

- **On the nature of dependence:** the standard clinical literature on substance use disorders, including the diagnostic criteria for harmful use and dependence and the evidence on the physiological mechanisms of reward, tolerance, and withdrawal.
- **On alcohol and health:** the substantial research literature on the health effects of alcohol, including the current evidence on the relationship between consumption and mortality, and the findings on the medical management of withdrawal.
- **On gambling:** the research on gambling disorder, including its mechanisms, its recent amplification through mobile and online betting, and the evidence on treatment.
- **On treatment:** the literature on the effectiveness of the different treatment modalities, including outpatient, residential, medication-assisted, and peer-support approaches, and the findings on what determines their outcomes.
- **On relapse:** the research on relapse and its prevention, including the identification of high-risk situations and the evidence that the speed of return to treatment predicts the long-term outcome.

- **On families:** the literature on the effects of addiction on households, including the guidance for family members on the actions that help and those that do not, and the material on the support that family members require themselves.
- **Practical resources:** national and regional confidential telephone advisory services; addiction treatment services, including those attached to general hospitals and those provided privately; peer-support groups for the man and separate groups for family members; and the safety material in Appendix G.

24 CHAPTER

When a Man Loses Himself

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the process by which a man's identity becomes attached to his roles, and explain why the attachment is invisible until the roles change.
2. Identify the specific events in which a man's roles disappear, and describe the loss that follows each.
3. Recognise the features of the period in which a man does not know who he is, and distinguish it from depression, grief, and ordinary transition.
4. Analyse the search for meaning outside achievement, and assess the resources available to him.
5. Apply a structured method for reconstructing a self after a rupture, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.
6. Construct a purpose for the second half of life that is not reducible to occupation, income, or standing.

Introduction

There is a specific kind of collapse that occurs in men who have done nothing wrong. A man works for thirty-two years, provides for his household, holds a position, is known in his community, and retires on a Friday. On the following Monday he has no function, no schedule, no audience, and no answer to the question of what he is. Within a few months his wife observes that he has become silent, that he follows her around the house, that he has begun to drink in the afternoon, and that he is angry about matters that did not previously concern him. His children observe that he telephones them with no subject. His physician records a rise in blood pressure and a loss of weight. And the man himself, if he is asked how he is, will say that he is adjusting, because he has no vocabulary for what has occurred and because the event that occurred — retirement — is not understood by anybody as a loss.

This chapter addresses that collapse and its many equivalents. Its subject is the loss of the self, and its thesis is specific: men's identities are frequently constructed almost entirely from their roles, and a role is not a self. A man may occupy, simultaneously, the roles of provider, husband, father, professional, community officer, and family representative; each role supplies structure, purpose, standing, and a definition of what to do next; and the ordinary experience of a man's adult life is of these roles reinforcing one another. When they are removed — by retirement, redundancy, the children's departure, separation, bereavement, illness, or a business failure — there is nothing underneath, and the collapse is experienced not as the loss of a job or a relationship but as the loss of the person.

Two clarifications are necessary before the analysis proceeds.

The first is that this is not a failure of imagination in the men concerned. A man who has spent thirty years working sixteen hours a day and supporting eleven people has not had the time to build a self that exists independently of those obligations, and his community has not supplied him with any account of what a man is apart from his function. The collapse is a structural product of the arrangement described throughout Part II of this book, and its treatment is therefore the reconstruction of something that was never built, not the recovery of something that was lost.

The second is that the collapse is frequently misattributed. A man in this condition presents with symptoms — insomnia, irritability, loss of appetite, withdrawal, loss of interest, a persistent sense of emptiness — and he is assessed as depressed, which he frequently is, and treating the depression alone leaves the condition intact, because the depression was the surface of a structural absence. The chapters on treatment in Part X apply, and this chapter supplies the material that the treatment will require.

24.1 The Loss of Identity in Mid-Life

Identity, in the sense used in this chapter, is the answer to three questions: what am I, what am I for, and who knows me? A man's answers to the three questions are assembled from his roles, and the assembly is invisible to him because it is never examined while the roles continue.

How Identity Is Assembled

A man's identity is built from five materials, in the following order of the weight most men give them.

Occupation. The work the man does, and the position within it. Its contribution to identity is enormous and frequently underestimated by men who are in work. It supplies structure, purpose, competence, an audience, a social position, and the answer to the question *what do you do?* which is the first question asked of a man at any gathering.

Provision. The man's capacity to support his household and his extended family. It supplies the tangible evidence of his usefulness and the reason for his effort, and it is the material of Parts III and V of this book.

Relationships in the roles. Father, husband, son, brother, uncle, head of a family. Each supplies a definition of what is required and a position in the family's structure.

Standing. The man's position in his community, his association, his profession: the respect, the position held, the recognition, the capacity to be called upon.

Interests, capacities, and relationships outside the roles. This material is the smallest for most men in the pattern this chapter addresses, and it is the material on which the reconstruction depends.

The Characteristic Structure

Four features of the assembly are worth stating because they determine the collapse.

The materials are all function-based. Occupation, provision, and the role-relationships are all definitions of what a man does rather than of what he is. Chapter 18's account of the husband's role and Chapter 17's account of the father's role are examples of the same structure.

The materials are mutually dependent. A man's occupation supplies the provision, and the provision is what makes him a valid father and husband in his own and his family's account. The materials therefore fail together, and a partial failure — a loss of income, for example — is experienced as the failure of the whole.

The materials produce a busy life. The arrangement described in Chapters 10 and 12 supplies structure to every hour of a man's day, and the structure prevents the questions from arising. This is the mechanism by which the examination is postponed: a man who is occupied cannot ask what he is.

There is no material outside the roles. For most men in this pattern, there is no activity, relationship, or interest that is genuinely the man's own and not attached to a function. The absence is invisible until the roles end, at which point the man discovers that he has no arrangement for the hours and no account of himself.

The Point of the Chapter

The purpose of this analysis is not to recommend that men detach themselves from their roles, which is neither possible nor desirable, and not to suggest that a role-based identity is a defect. A man who is a good father because his identity requires it is performing a good that would otherwise not be performed. The purpose is to establish the practical point: **a man should hold one material of identity that does not depend on the roles continuing.** One activity, one relationship, one capacity, one contribution, one thing he is that is not a function.

The chapters that follow describe the construction, and the case in Section 24.7 describes what happens without it.

24.2 When the Roles Disappear

The events that remove a man's roles are specific and datable, and each has a distinct signature. They are set out below with the material that is lost in each case, because the treatment depends on identifying what has actually gone.

Retirement

What is removed. The occupation, the position, the daily structure, the audience, the professional relationships, the income, and the answer to the question *what do you do?* For a man whose identity is assembled from his roles, retirement removes four of the five materials at once.

The characteristic progression. The first two to six weeks are frequently described as a holiday and are managed well. Then the structure's absence produces a specific effect: the day has no shape, and the man's time is not claimed by anybody. Between the second and the sixth month, the symptoms appear: insomnia, irritability, the sense of being in the way, and, in a substantial proportion of cases, the use of alcohol in the afternoon. The condition deepens over the following year, and it is frequently described by the household as the man's growing difficult rather than as a loss.

The specific feature. Retirement removes the roles without removing the man's capacity to occupy them. The man is still fully capable of work and is not required to do it, which produces the arrangement described by men in retirement as the worst element: the sense of being unnecessary while still competent.

Redundancy and the Loss of a Business

What is removed. The occupation, the income, the position, the professional relationships, and, in many cases, the man's public standing and his own account of his competence.

The characteristic progression. Unlike retirement, which is scheduled, redundancy is a rupture: it removes the roles without preparation and it carries a judgement. The man's response is initially active — applications, contacts, plans — and then, frequently, collapses after six to nine months if the search has not succeeded. The condition that follows is described in Chapters 11 and 38.

The specific feature. The loss carries a verdict. Retirement removes a role; redundancy removes a role and supplies an assessment of the man's value. The second element is the reason the loss is frequently concealed, and the concealment is described in Chapter 9.

The Children's Departure

What is removed. The father's daily function: the supervision, the provision of the immediate practical requirements, the presence, the structure of the household, and the position of the person on whom the household's arrangements depend.

The characteristic progression. The departure is gradual and it is generally accompanied by the man's satisfaction at the child's success, which prevents the loss from being recognised. The effects appear between six months and three years later, frequently at a point at which the man is asked to describe his life and discovers that he has nothing to describe except work.

The specific feature. The loss is ungrievable in public, because the child's departure is an achievement and any expression of difficulty is read as a failure to support it. The father therefore carries the material privately, and the household interprets his irritability or increased work as a reaction to something else.

Separation and Divorce

What is removed. The husband role, the household structure, the daily presence of the children, the position in the extended family, and, in many cases, a substantial part of the man's social network, which was maintained through the marriage.

The characteristic progression. The material of Chapter 13 applies. The specific identity element is that separation removes both the role and the standing, and, in customary settings, supplies an interpretation. Men frequently respond by the consolidation of the one role that remains — the occupation — with the consequences described in Chapter 12.

The specific feature. The man's position in the extended family frequently changes without any discussion, and the change is not reversed when the marriage is. Men should note that the role's removal is frequently more durable than the marriage's interruption.

Bereavement

What is removed. The husband or father role, the identity as the person who is responsible for a particular individual, the household's structure, and, in many cases, the man's only confidant.

The characteristic progression. Described in Chapter 13′s case and in Chapter 25: initial containment and activity, followed by a period of collapse that arrives when the practical work concludes, and then a long period of restructuring that is not linear.

The specific feature. The research on widowers identifies this group as at elevated risk across every measured outcome, including mortality in the first year. The reason is partly the loss of the relationship and substantially the loss of the

roles: the man has lost the person for whom he was responsible, the household he managed, and the person to whom he spoke.

Illness, Injury, and Incapacity

What is removed. The capacity to provide, to protect, to perform, and to occupy the physical role. The identity materials are removed not by circumstances but by the man's body.

The characteristic progression. The medical condition, the treatment, the period of incapacity, the revision of the man's expectations, and the reconstruction of an arrangement that the condition permits. The psychological material is described in Chapter 33, and the specific identity element is that the loss is not attributable to anybody and therefore cannot be resented, which produces a particular form of difficulty: the man has no object for his anger.

The specific feature. The body becomes the visible evidence of the loss, and men frequently describe the specific moment at which they understood that they would not recover what they had, which is the beginning of the reconstruction.

Migration and Displacement

What is removed. The standing accumulated in a community over decades, the position in the family's structure, the professional identity, the network, and the language in which the man was competent.

The specific feature. The loss is frequently invisible to the receiving community, which sees a man with a job and a household. The identity material that was built over thirty years is not transferable, and the reconstruction of standing in a new setting takes years and is frequently not undertaken, because the man's account of himself is still located in the place he left.

The Common Structure

Four features recur in every case, and each is a point of intervention.

The loss is dated. The man can identify the day, which is useful, because the reconstruction can be dated from it.

The roles disappear faster than the man's capacity to occupy them. The man remains fully capable, which is the source of the specific frustration described under retirement.

The loss is not socially recognised as a loss. Retirement is congratulated, children's departure is celebrated, recovery from illness is expected. The absence of recognition prevents the grief, and ungrieved loss produces the condition described in the following section.

The man's own explanation is generally about something else. He attributes his state to boredom, to age, to his wife, to the state of the country. The accurate attribution — I have lost the material of which I was constructed

— is generally not available to him, and the whole purpose of this chapter is to supply it.

24.3 The Empty Season: When a Man Does Not Know Who He Is

This section describes the condition itself, and it is written so that a man in it can recognise what is occurring, because the condition's principal feature is that it presents without a name.

The Features

1. The absence of purpose in the day. The man wakes without an obligation and experiences the absence not as freedom but as a weight. The hours are not merely empty; they are undifferentiated, and men describe a specific effect: the day passes without any memory of it.

2. A muted or absent pleasure. The capacity for enjoyment is not merely reduced; it is frequently absent, and the man is unable to identify anything he would like to do. This feature is shared with depression, and its presence requires the assessment described in Section 24.4.

3. A specific form of loneliness. Not the absence of company — the man is frequently surrounded by his household — but the absence of a position. The condition is frequently described in exactly these terms: *I am in the house and nobody needs me to do anything, and I do not know what to do with myself.*

4. Irritability about small matters. The response is calibrated to the material described in Chapter 15: an account of what the man has done, held privately, and a household that appears not to recognise it.

5. An increase in the behaviours that manage states. Alcohol, screen use, gambling, spending, sleep. Chapter 23's material applies, and the empty season is one of the most common periods in which a behavioural pattern is established.

6. Withdrawal from the relationships that remain. The most consequential feature. The man declines invitations, reduces contacts, and avoids the gatherings at which the question of what he is doing will be asked.

7. A persistent sense of having been left behind or overtaken. Comparative, and supplied by the environment: the colleagues who have progressed, the contemporaries who have been appointed, the former subordinates who are now senior. Chapter 11's material applies in the specific form produced by a loss of position.

8. A diffuse anger with no object. Described under illness above, and present in most forms of the condition: the man is angry and cannot identify the party at fault, because the loss was produced by time, by the economy, by a decision he made, or by his own body.

The Distinctions That Matter

Four distinctions determine the treatment, and each requires a specific assessment.

From depression. Depression is a condition with a defined set of criteria, it is treatable, and it requires assessment. The distinction's practical importance is that depression must be treated before the reconstruction work will hold; Chapter 6 and Appendix B provide the criteria, and where they are met, assessment precedes the material in Sections 24.5 and 24.6. The two conditions co-occur frequently, and the presence of the second does not exclude the first.

From grief. Where the loss is a bereavement or a separation, the material of Chapter 13 applies, and the reconstruction work proceeds after the acute period rather than during it. Where the loss is a role rather than a person, the grief is frequently unrecognised, and one of the practical interventions is to name it as a loss and permit the grief: the retirement, the lost position, the departed household.

From ordinary transition. Every change of role requires a period of adjustment, and the period's normal length is a matter of months. The indicator that the condition is more than an adjustment is the absence of any reconstruction after twelve months, together with the presence of withdrawal, increased alcohol use, and the loss of the capacity for enjoyment.

From a physical condition. The symptoms of the empty season overlap substantially with those of hypothyroidism, anaemia, sleep apnoea, testosterone deficiency, and the effects of medication. A man over forty-five presenting with loss of energy, loss of interest, and disturbed sleep should obtain a medical assessment, and the assessment should be conducted before the material in this chapter is worked on. This is not a formality; a substantial proportion of men presenting with the condition described here have a treatable physical component.

The Two Errors Men Make in This Period

The first error is the attempt to recover the lost role. The man applies for the same kind of position, returns to the same working pattern, or attempts to restore the role in a similar form. The attempt is not unreasonable and it frequently succeeds in part. Where it fails repeatedly, the man is left in a worse position, because each attempt has been conducted against the reconstruction, and because the failure supplies further evidence for the assessment he is making of himself.

The second error is the attempt to fill the time. Travel, projects, the assumption of obligations, the management of relatives' affairs, the acquisition of qualifications with no purpose. The activity is real and it does not address the condition, because the condition is not the absence of activity; it is the absence of an account of what the man is. Men describe the outcome precisely: *I was busy for two years and I was exactly where I started.*

The productive direction is neither the recovery of the role nor the filling of the time, and is set out in the sections that follow.

24.4 The Search for Meaning Outside Achievement

The material in this section addresses what the reconstruction requires, and it is deliberately practical, because the subject of meaning attracts writing that is either abstract or sentimental and neither is useful to a man in the empty season.

What Is Actually Required

The reconstruction requires that the man possess three things that do not depend on his roles continuing. Each is a specific item rather than a disposition.

1. One activity that is his own. An activity performed for its own sake, of no value to anybody else, in which the man's competence or interest is a matter of his own assessment. Its function is to supply a structure that the man has chosen, and to provide the daily evidence that he is a person with preferences rather than a function. The nature of the activity is not important. What matters is that it is not attached to a role.

2. One relationship in which he is known and not needed. The material of Chapters 4, 10, and 18. Its function is to supply the answer to the third question — who knows me — in a form that does not depend on the roles.

3. One contribution that is not an obligation. A contribution the man elects: teaching, mentoring, a practical skill given to a group, a role in an organisation that is chosen rather than inherited or assumed. Its function is to supply purpose in a form the man controls, and the specific property that distinguishes it from an obligation is that the man may conclude it.

Why Achievement Cannot Supply It

The essential distinction of this chapter is between achievement and meaning, and it is worth stating precisely because it explains why successful men are as susceptible to the condition as unsuccessful ones.

Achievement is comparative; meaning is not. A man's achievement is assessed against a standard or a position, and it therefore requires a reference group and a continuing supply. Meaning requires no comparison, which is why a man who teaches a single person to read has obtained something that a man who has exceeded his targets has not.

Achievement terminates; meaning does not. Each achievement concludes, and its conclusion returns the man to the position he occupied before it. The arrangement results in the permanent requirement to achieve again, described in Chapters 7 and 11. Meaning is sustained by the activity itself rather than by its conclusion.

Achievement is external; meaning is internal. The reward for achievement is supplied by other people, and its supply is therefore not within the man's control. The reward for meaning — that the activity is worth doing, that the contribution is useful, that the relationship is real — is available regardless of anybody's assessment.

Achievement requires capacity; meaning does not. The final distinction, and the one that matters most after fifty-five: a man's capacity to achieve reduces with age, illness, and the economy's conditions, and a life composed of achievement is therefore a diminishing resource. Meaning is available to a man in a wheelchair and to a man whose business has failed.

The Available Materials

For the man who has built nothing outside his roles, the materials available are specific and they are more numerous than he expects. The following list is drawn from the accounts of men who completed the reconstruction, and each entry is a category rather than a suggestion.

- **Skill transmission.** What the man knows that others need: a trade, a professional competence, a practical skill, an administrative ability, language, driving, accounting, negotiation.
- **Organisations that require competent people.** Community associations, cooperative societies, professional bodies, schools, sports clubs, health services, disaster responses. Men with administrative competence are in demand in all of them, and the roles are frequently available on the man's own terms.
- **Interests that were abandoned.** The instrument, the sport, the reading, the making of things, the collecting. The material of Section 19.5 applies.
- **The relationships that were neglected.** Former colleagues, school friends, siblings, relatives with whom contact was reduced for lack of time.
- **A practice.** Something performed regularly, of no consequence, which establishes the shape of the day: walking, exercise, the study of a subject, the maintenance of something.
- **The household's arrangements.** The transfer of functions described in Chapter 18 and the assumption of specific household work. This is the material most frequently overlooked and the most immediately available, and it is also the material most likely to produce a conflict, because the household has arranged itself without the man's participation and the man's assumption of functions disrupts it.

Figure 24.1 sets out the sequence by which a role-based identity fails when the roles are removed, and the point at which the reconstruction can begin. The diagram is illustrative; the sequence varies in length between men and between the

kinds of loss, and its purpose is to identify that the period between the loss and the reconstruction is not a defect of the man.

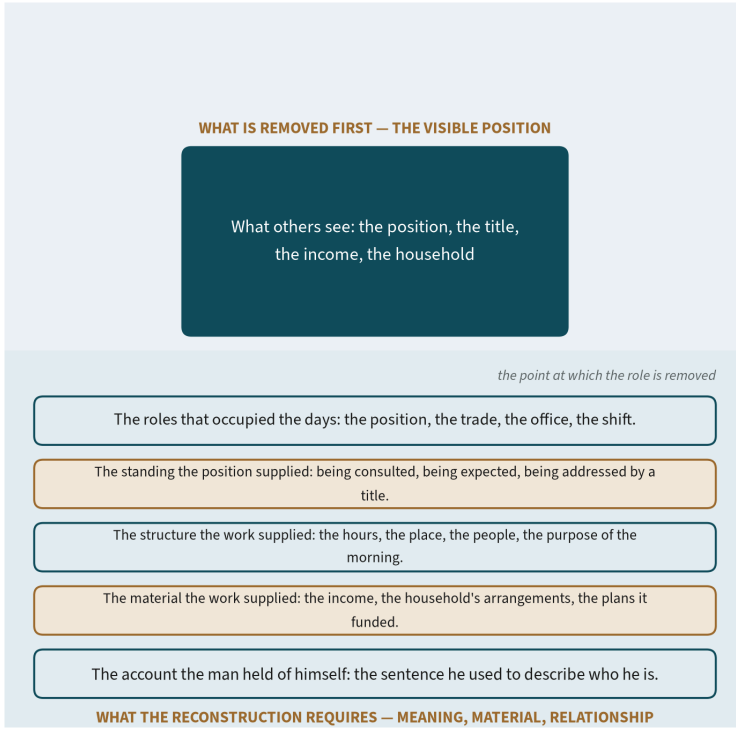


Figure 24.1 The sequence of identity loss and reconstruction. The upper stages describe what is removed and what follows; the lower stage identifies the three materials the reconstruction requires.

24.5 Reconstructing a Self After Rupture

The reconstruction is conducted in six stages. The order matters, and men who attempt the later stages without the earlier ones report that the activity is undertaken without conviction and is abandoned within months.

Stage One: The Assessment

The medical assessment. Before anything else. The conditions listed in Section 24.3 — thyroid function, anaemia, sleep apnoea, testosterone deficiency, the effects of medication, and depressive illness — should be assessed by a physician. The assessment is not a formality and it should not be deferred, because a substantial proportion of men in this condition have a treatable component and because the reconstruction will not hold on top of an untreated condition.

The functional assessment. A written record of the man's actual day for two weeks: the hours, the activities, the contacts, the states. Its value is specific: men in the empty season describe their days inaccurately, and the record frequently shows that a substantial proportion of the time is occupied by activity of no value that has not been chosen, which is a finding that produces action.

The role inventory. A written table of every role the man holds, with three columns: the role, what it supplies, and whether it depends on the roles that have been lost. The output identifies exactly what is missing and what remains.

Stage Two: The Grief

The losses must be grieved, and the work is the same as in Chapter 13: the written account of what was lost, the identification of what is permanent and what is addressable, and the permission for the material to be present. Men in this condition frequently resist the stage on the grounds that the loss was voluntary or favourable — a retirement, a child's success, a business sold — and the resistance is the reason the material remains.

The practical form for this stage is a letter written to the lost role or to the period, in which the man states what it gave him, what he gave it, what it cost him, and what he would have done differently. The letter is not sent. The exercise is used widely in loss and transition work, and men report that its effect is disproportionate to its apparent simplicity.

Stage Three: The Materials

The man identifies the materials from Section 24.4 that are available to him, and selects one activity, one relationship, and one contribution. The selection should be made on the following criteria.

- **Available now.** Not requiring resources, permission, or a change of circumstances.
- **Within the man's existing competence or his willingness to begin as a beginner.**
- **Not attached to the roles that were lost.** The activity of the retired accountant should not be an accounting practice; the activity of the man whose children have left should not be the management of their affairs from a distance.
- **Sufficiently small to begin this month.** The scale is the most common reason that the reconstruction fails: the man selects a project of the size of his former occupations.

Stage Four: The Arrangement

Each material is converted into an arrangement with a schedule, a place, and, where relevant, other people. The properties required are those established else-

where in this book: a fixed time, a fixed place, a defined unit of activity, and a review point.

The specific caution for this stage is that the arrangement must be the man's rather than the household's. A retired man who fills his days with the household's requirements has exchanged one role for another of the same type, and the reconstruction requires at least one arrangement in which the man is acting on his own account.

Stage Five: The Structure of the Day

The man builds a daily structure that is his own, from the base up. The structure should include three elements, and their order in the day reflects the evidence on mood and functioning.

1. **A fixed waking time and a morning activity.** The evidence on the effect of morning light exposure, physical activity, and consistent waking time on mood and sleep is substantial, and the morning is the period in which the structure is most easily established.
2. **One scheduled activity with a purpose.** The contribution, the skill, the work, whether paid or not.
3. **One scheduled activity that is the man's own.** The interest, the practice, the relationship. The remaining time is left unplanned, which is the element that men find most difficult and which becomes manageable after the three elements are established.

Stage Six: The Re-Entry Into Relationship

The final stage, and the one that determines whether the reconstruction holds. The man's withdrawal during the empty season has damaged his relationships, and the repair requires that he resume participation in the settings from which he withdrew: the family gatherings, the community's occasions, the association's meetings, the friendships that were allowed to lapse.

The practical form is the material of Chapter 4 and Chapter 27: three relationships re-established, each with a specific arrangement rather than a general intention. The specific finding for men in this condition is that the re-entry is frequently welcomed more than the man expects, because his withdrawal was read as his preference rather than as a symptom, and because the people who knew him before the rupture are frequently the only people who can reflect the parts of him that the roles did not supply.

24.6 Finding Purpose in the Second Half of Life

The final substantive section addresses purpose, and it does so without the vocabulary that men distrust. Purpose, in the sense used here, is not an elevated concept;

it is the answer to the question of what the man's remaining time is for, expressed in a form that produces a decision.

The Four Requirements

1. It must be specific. *To be useful* is not a purpose. *To teach the bookkeeping element of the association's certificate course, on Tuesdays, for two years* is a purpose, and its specificity is what allows it to be conducted.

2. It must be the man's. Chapter 11's test applies: is this mine, or is it the expectation of my family, my community, my former profession, or my children? Purposes that are assembled from other people's expectations survive until the first difficulty and then dissolve.

3. It must be capable of being concluded. A purpose that cannot be completed is an obligation. The capacity to conclude is what distinguishes a purpose from a role, and it is the property that makes the second half of life manageable: the man is able to take on substantial work because he retains the capacity to put it down.

4. It must be compatible with the man's actual condition. A purpose requiring physical capacity that the man does not have will produce a further account of his own inadequacy. The purpose should be calibrated to what the man can do at the present time, with the expectation that the calibration changes.

The Four Domains

A workable purpose for the second half of life is generally composed from four domains, and a man should hold at least two of them.

The relational. The arrangements with the household and the people who matter: the specification in Section 21.6, the obligations of contact in Section 17.6, the friendships of Chapter 4. The distinguishing property of this domain is that its value is not measurable and its effects are cumulative.

The contributive. What the man does for a group, a place, an institution, or a person outside his household, on terms he has set. Its function is the supply of usefulness without a role, and its scale should be deliberately modest.

The developmental. What the man intends to learn, make, or understand. Its function is the supply of the future: a man with a subject he is pursuing has an answer to the question of what comes next that does not depend on his capacity to engage the world economically.

The receptive. What the man accepts: care, company, assistance, treatment, and rest. This domain is the one this book has placed at the centre of the whole of its argument, and in this context it is the domain that protects the reconstruction, because a man who cannot receive will rebuild an identity of the same type and will fail at the next rupture.

The Practical Instruction

Three specific measures, for the man who is starting from the position described in Section 24.3.

Write the purpose in one sentence, in the form of an arrangement. The date, the unit, the frequency, the review point. A purpose that cannot be written in this form is a wish.

Report it to one person who is not a member of the household. The disclosure performs the same function as the accountability arrangement in Chapter 22: it converts the purpose from a private intention into a fact, and it supplies the correction that a man's own assessment cannot provide.

Establish the review, and expect that the purpose will change. The review's questions: is this still mine; is it producing anything; what would I change; and what would I take on if I concluded this? The expectation that the purpose will change over a decade is what distinguishes this work from the roles that preceded it, and it is the reason the work is manageable after sixty.

What to Expect

The final expectation to manage is the timing. The reconstruction does not produce the state the man had before the loss; men report, with consistency, that the second half of life is a different arrangement rather than a restoration. What they describe, when the work has been done, is not a return to a previous condition but three specific elements: a day with a shape, a small number of people who know them, and an answer to the question of what the present period is for. That answer is the whole of the objective, and it is available to a man of seventy with a failing body as readily as to a man of fifty with a failed business.

24.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Retired on a Friday

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in occupational health, geriatric and family practice, and the research literature on retirement and identity.

Alhaji Ganiyu is sixty-three, a retired assistant director in a federal ministry, married to Rukayat for thirty-six years, with five children, all of whom are adults and four of whom live outside Nigeria.

Ganiyu retired in March, on his sixty-third birthday, having served for thirty-seven years. He had planned for the retirement for four years: the house was complete, a property in the town had been built for rental income, the pension arrangements were in order, and two of the children were settled. He described his plan for the retirement, in the assessment, as follows: *I had done everything properly. There was nothing left to arrange.*

The condition emerged over the following fourteen months and was described by Rukayat, who requested the assessment, in the following terms: he had stopped leaving the house except for Friday prayers and the market; he had begun to drink at about four in the afternoon, which he had never done during his working life; he had become angry about small household matters and had, on two occasions, raised his voice at his grandson; he had stopped attending the meetings of the professional association of which he had been a member for thirty years and had, in November, declined a position in the community's development association; and he had begun to telephone his children abroad at intervals of a few days with no subject.

The assessment identified three components.

First, a depressive episode of moderate severity, which had been present for about nine months. It had presented in the male register: irritability, alcohol use in the afternoon, sleep disturbance, weight loss, and, in his own account, a persistent sense that there was nothing to get up for.

Second, a physical component: assessment identified hypertension, which had been untreated since a routine examination two years earlier, and a testosterone deficiency, which was confirmed on two separate measurements and which his physician regarded as contributing substantially to the loss of energy and drive.

Third, and the component that required the work of this chapter, a structural absence: a role inventory, completed in writing, established that of eleven roles Ganiyu had held at the age of sixty, nine had been removed by the retirement, and the two that remained — husband and grandfather — had been conducted entirely within a household that had been organised for thirty years around his absence during working hours.

The further history had a specific feature that Ganiyu had never described. During the four years of planning his retirement, he had not planned for the retirement's content. He had planned for its finances, its housing, and its obligations, and he had described his intention for the time itself, whenever asked, as *resting* and *taking things easy* — phrases that he had repeated so often that he had not examined them. He said, in the assessment: *I planned everything except the part where I am still alive at eight in the morning.*

The work extended over about two years, and its components were as follows.

The medical component came first: treatment for hypertension, treatment for the testosterone deficiency, treatment for the depressive episode, and the reduction of alcohol use, which did not require a withdrawal programme and which was addressed with the methods of Chapter 22.

The grief work came second, and it took the form of a written account of the working life: thirty-seven years of it, in sequence, including the positions, the colleagues, the disputes, the two appointments he had not obtained, and the period of eight years in which he had been posted to a state in which he had been unhappy. Ganiyu described this task as the most substantial element of the whole period, and he wrote approximately forty pages by hand.

The materials were identified in the fourth month and were, in his own account, entirely unpredicted. He identified a competence he had never regarded as a competence: he had spent seventeen years, in two of his postings, negotiating with state-level officials on budget matters, and he had become, in that period, unusually good at it. He identified an interest he had abandoned at the age of twenty-eight: the repair and maintenance of mechanical equipment, which he had learnt from his father and had stopped when his career became demanding. And he identified a relationship that had lapsed: a former colleague, with whom he had worked for twelve years and with whom he had not spoken since his colleague's own retirement four years earlier.

The arrangements were established as follows. Ganiyu undertook to provide three sessions of advice each month, without payment, to the small business association of a neighbouring town, whose members were negotiating collectively with suppliers. He established a workshop in a room at the back of the house, in which he repaired and maintained small equipment, initially for his household and later for a small number of paying customers, and which he describes as the single most consequential element of the whole reconstruction: *I had forgotten that I am a person who can make a thing work with his hands. It was the first thing in fourteen months that had nothing to do with who I used to be.* And he re-established contact with his former colleague, with a fixed arrangement to meet on the first Saturday of each month to discuss machinery, which both men described as a friendship rather than an appointment.

Two years and four months after the retirement, the position was as follows: the depressive episode had resolved; the hypertension was controlled; the alcohol use had returned to occasional; and Ganiyu's own description of the arrangement was: *I have four things in the week. On Tuesday I go to the association. On Thursday the workshop is open. On the first Saturday I see Aliyu. Every morning I walk for forty minutes and I do not sit down when I come back. That is all. It took me fourteen months and a doctor and forty pages of writing to find out that the answer was that small, and I had been telling everybody for four years that I would be resting.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The retirement had been planned in every respect except its content. The financial, housing, and family arrangements were complete. The man's own description — that he had planned everything except the part where he is still alive at eight in the morning — is the chapter's central statement, and it identifies the specific gap that produces the condition in men who are otherwise well organised.

Three conditions were present simultaneously and required separate treatment. The depressive episode, the untreated hypertension, and the testosterone deficiency each contributed to the presentation, and the case is included because the assessment of men in this condition is frequently conducted as though it were solely psychological. The medical assessment came first in the sequence, and its placement is deliberate.

Nine of eleven roles were removed at once. The role inventory is the instrument that made the situation legible, and its output is the reason the work was directed at materials rather than at activity in general: the man's initial attempts at *keeping busy* had failed for the reason given in Section 24.3.

The materials were not the ones the man would have predicted. A negotiation competence of seventeen years' standing, a repair workshop abandoned at twenty-eight, and a lapsed friendship. The identification of the materials from a written history rather than from reflection is the case's most transferable feature, and the workshop — an activity of no relation to the man's former profession, in which he was a beginner — produced the largest effect.

The arrangement was small and specific. Four items in a week, each scheduled. This is the pattern in the accounts of men who reconstruct successfully, and it stands against the expectation that the second half of life requires a project of substantial scale, which is the expectation that most frequently produces a period of activity without conviction followed by a return to the empty season.

24.8 Practical Exercise: The Role Inventory and the Reconstruction Plan

This exercise takes about three hours across four weeks. It is written for a man who has experienced a loss of role, whether recently or years ago, and for a man who wishes to establish the protection before a loss occurs.

Part One: The Role Inventory

The role	What it supplies	Does it depend on a role I have lost, or may lose?

Include every role: occupation, income, the household's decision-making, father, husband, son, brother, head of the family, community position, association membership, professional identity, mediator, and any other function you hold.

Then answer four questions.

- How many of the roles are function-based?
- What proportion of your identity is supplied by roles that could be removed by circumstances beyond your control?
- Which role would produce the largest loss, and what would remain?
- Which material in your life exists independently of every role on the list?

The fourth question is the diagnostic one, and for most men in this pattern the answer is very small. The finding is the purpose of the exercise.

Part Two: The Functional Record

For two weeks, record the day in half-hour blocks: the activity, the purpose, and the state. Then answer:

- What proportion of the day is occupied by activity that I have chosen?
- What proportion is occupied by activity that has no purpose and has not been chosen (screen use, errands without requirement, the management of other people's affairs)?
- At what hour is the state at its worst, and what is happening at that hour?
- How many contacts did I have with people who know me, in the two weeks?

Part Three: The Medical Check

List the assessments to be booked, and their dates. The list should include: a general physical assessment with blood pressure, blood glucose, and thyroid function; a discussion of the symptoms in Section 24.3; a review of medication; and, where indicated, an assessment of sleep and of testosterone.

The assessment	The practice or facility	The date booked

Part Four: The Letter to the Lost Role

Write a letter, of no fewer than 800 words, to the role, institution, or period that has ended. Include: what it gave you; what you gave it; what it cost you; what you would have done differently; and what you are taking from it. Do not send it.

Part Five: The Materials

Material	Available now?	Within my competence?	Not attached to the lost roles?	Begins this month?
The activity that is mine				
The relationship in which I am known				
The contribution I elect				

Part Six: The Arrangement

For each of the three materials, specify the arrangement in the form required: the unit, the frequency, the place, the people, and the review point.

	Unit	Frequency	Place	Review date
Activity				
Relationship				
Contribution				

Part Seven: The Purpose Sentence

Write the purpose of the present period in one sentence, in the form of an arrangement. Then answer:

- Is it specific?
- Is it mine, or is it assembled from somebody's expectations?
- Could I conclude it, and what would happen if I did?
- Is it compatible with my present condition?
- Who will I report it to, and by what date?

24.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I retired and I am fine. Does this apply to me?"

Apply the diagnostic question from Part One: which material in your life exists independently of a role? If the answer includes an activity, a relationship, or a contribution that is yours and not attached to a function, the protection is present and the chapter is a description of what you already have. If the answer is empty, the condition has not yet appeared and the arrangements in this chapter are the prevention.

"Is this not simply depression, and should I not just take the treatment?"

The two frequently co-occur, and the treatment is required where the criteria in Chapter 6 are met. The treatment alone leaves the structural absence, and the accounts of men who have taken treatment without the reconstruction are consistent: the mood improves and the emptiness remains. The medical assessment, the treatment, and the reconstruction proceed together, in that order.

"I am sixty-eight. Is it not too late to build something new?"

The case in Section 24.7 began at sixty-three and the materials included a workshop and a monthly friendship. Men in their seventies establish arrangements of this kind, and the specific obstacle at that age is not capacity but the belief that the work is for younger men. The scale of the arrangement is what makes it possible: four items in a week, of a size that requires no permission and no capital.

"My wife has her own routine and I am in the way."

This is the most common domestic form of the condition, and its resolution requires two things. The man should establish arrangements that take him out of the house, which is the subject of this chapter, and the household's routine should be discussed explicitly, which is the material of Chapter 18. The specific practical measure that men report as effective is the transfer of one household function to the man in a form that the household wants transferred, rather than the assumption of functions that the household has been managing without him.

"I lost my business and everything with it. Where do I start?"

With the medical assessment and the functional record, because the condition after a business failure is frequently accompanied by a depressive episode and by a physical component that has gone unaddressed. Then with the grief work, which is required here in full, since the loss is a person-sized loss: the business was the man's construction and its failure is frequently carried as a verdict. The material in Chapters 16, 22, and 38 applies alongside this chapter.

"What if I do not want a purpose? What if I want to rest?"

Then that is the arrangement, and it should be made specific: what rest consists of, where, for how long, and with what structure. The condition described in this chapter is not produced by rest; it is produced by the absence of an account of what the man is. A man who has chosen rest, knows what it consists of, and has a structure around it is not in the empty season, and the distinction is generally visible within a fortnight.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 24 in brief. A man's identity is assembled from five materials, in order of the weight most men give them: occupation, provision, the relationships within the roles, standing, and — as the smallest material for most men in this pattern — interests, capacities, and relationships outside the roles. The materials are all function-based, they are mutually dependent, they produce a life in which every hour is occupied, and for most men there is nothing outside them. The practical point is not that men should detach from their roles but that they should hold at least one material of identity that does not depend on the roles continuing.

The events that remove a man's roles are retirement, redundancy or the loss of a business, the children's departure, separation and divorce, bereavement, illness or injury, and migration or displacement. Each has a distinct signature: retirement removes the roles while leaving the capacity to occupy them; redundancy removes the role and supplies a verdict; the children's departure is ungrievable in public; separation removes the role and the standing; bereavement removes the person and the structure at once; illness removes the materials through the body and leaves no object for the anger; migration removes standing that is not transferable. Four features recur: the loss is dated; the roles disappear faster than the man's capacity; the loss is not socially recognised; and the man's own explanation is about something else.

The empty season presents without a name: the undifferentiated day, muted or absent pleasure, a loneliness that is the absence of a position rather than of company, irritability calibrated to a private account, an increase in state-managing behaviours, withdrawal, the sense of having been overtaken, and a diffuse anger with no object. The distinctions that matter are from depression, from grief, from ordinary transition, and from a physical condition — and the medical assessment should precede the reconstruction work in every case. Men make two characteristic errors in this period: the attempt to recover the lost role, and the attempt to fill the time.

Meaning cannot be supplied by achievement, for four reasons: achievement is comparative and meaning is not; achievement terminates and meaning does not; achievement is externally rewarded and meaning is not; and achievement requires capacity that reduces with age. The materials available for the reconstruction are skill transmission, organisations that require competent people, abandoned interests, neglected relationships, a practice, and the household's own arrangements.

The reconstruction proceeds in six stages: assessment, including the medical and functional assessments and the role inventory; grief, conducted in written form; the materials, selected for availability, competence, independence from the lost roles, and small scale; the arrangement, with a schedule, a place, and, where relevant, other people; the structure of the day, built from a fixed waking time, one purposeful activity, and one activity that is the man's own; and re-entry into relationship, in which three relationships are re-established with specific arrangements.

Purpose in the second half of life must be specific, the man's own, capable of being concluded, and compatible with his actual condition. It is generally composed from four domains — relational, contributive, developmental, and receptive — of which a man should hold at least two. It is converted into practice by writing it as an arrangement, reporting it to one person outside the household, and establishing a review, with the expectation that the purpose will change over a decade. What the work produces is not a restoration of the previous condition but a day with a shape, a small number of people who know the man, and an answer to the question of what the present period is for.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the role inventory. What proportion of your identity is supplied by roles that circumstances could remove? What single material exists independently of all of them?
2. Which of the events in Section 24.2 has occurred in your life, and what precisely was removed? What did you tell yourself at the time, and how much of it was accurate?
3. Which features of the empty season in Section 24.3 apply to you — the undifferentiated day, the absent pleasure, the loneliness of position, the irritability, the state-managing behaviours, the withdrawal, the sense of having been overtaken, or the diffuse anger?
4. Have you obtained a medical assessment covering the conditions in Section 24.3? If not, what is the date on which it will be booked?
5. Write the letter to the lost role, or the lost period. What did it give you, and what did it cost you? What are you taking from it?
6. From Section 24.4, which three materials are available to you now, and which have you dismissed as too small to matter?

7. Write the purpose sentence. Who will you report it to, by what date, and what will you do when the first arrangement lapses?

Further Reading

- **On retirement and identity:** the research literature on the transition to retirement, including the consistent findings that occupation is central to men's identity and that retirement is associated with a specific risk of depression, particularly where the transition is abrupt and where the man's identity is entirely occupational.
- **On role loss and wellbeing:** the sociological and psychological literature on role loss, role strain, and the effects of the removal of significant roles on mental health, including the research on the loss of the provider role in men.
- **On meaning and purpose in later life:** the literature on meaning in life and its correlates, including the substantial evidence associating a sense of purpose with reduced mortality and with better cognitive and functional outcomes in later life.
- **On the transition to the second half of life:** the practical and academic literature on midlife and later-life transition, including structured approaches to the reconstruction of identity after a major loss.
- **On loneliness and re-engagement in later life:** the material in Chapter 25 and Appendix M, together with the research on the re-establishment of social connection after a role loss and the specific findings on men's difficulty in doing so.
- **Practical resources:** occupational health and retirement preparation programmes; counselling for life transitions; men's groups with members in comparable transitions; community and professional organisations that require competent volunteers; and the material in Appendices I and M.

PART VII

The Battles Men Face in Society

Public expectations, private wounds, and the struggle for dignity

25 CHAPTER

The World That Judges a Man by His Results

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the social practice of measuring a man by his results, and identify the specific mechanisms through which the measurement is applied.
2. Analyse the price of being publicly assessed as a failure, including its effects on standing, opportunity, and self-regard.
3. Explain what occurs when a society has no place for a man's version of success, and identify the particular difficulties of unemployment, informal work, disability, and interrupted careers.
4. Define dignity in a context that values achievement, and distinguish it from recognition and from status.
5. Apply a structured method for choosing his own measure of worth without denying the reality of his circumstances, using the exercise at the end of this chapter.
6. Construct a way of living that does not require the approval of the judging audience.

Introduction

There is a question that every man is asked, at every gathering, by almost every person he meets for the first time: *What do you do?* The question is not an inquiry about a man's occupation. It is an evaluation's first instrument, and the answer determines how the conversation proceeds: the seat offered, the interest taken, the respect extended, and the estimate formed.

This chapter is about a world in which that question is the principal means of assessment, and in which the answer is received as a verdict. It is not about an imagined society; it is a description of the arrangements in which most of the men who read this book conduct their lives. In these arrangements, a man's worth in public is a function of his results: what he has built, what he earns, what his

children achieve, what he contributes, and how his position compares with the positions of the men against whom he is measured.

The chapter's purpose is to describe the machinery accurately, because a man who understands it can work with it, and to address three specific situations that the machinery handles badly.

The first is the man whose results are publicly inadequate: the man who has not built, who does not earn, whose children have not prospered, and whose position is visibly below his contemporaries'.

The second is the man whose version of success the society has no place for: the man in informal work in an economy that recognises salaried employment; the man whose competence is in a trade for which there is no market; the man with a disability in an environment built entirely for the able-bodied; the man who chose a path that his community does not recognise as success.

The third is the man whose results are adequate and who has discovered that they do not produce what he was promised. His position is understood least of all, because the machinery asserts that results produce satisfaction, and he is the evidence that it does not.

The chapter proceeds from a position that should be stated at the outset. The measurement of men by their results is not a conspiracy and it is not solely oppressive. It is a system of evaluation that a society requires in order to allocate standing, opportunity, credit, marriageability, and trust, and it has supplied, over generations, a powerful incentive for men to build and provide. The difficulty is that the system is applied to every part of a man's worth, that it produces permanent categories of failure, and that it offers no procedure by which a man judged inadequate can be restored to his own account of himself. The work of this chapter is the construction of that procedure.

25.1 Measuring a Man by What He Produces

The measurement of men by their results is older than any particular economy and it is maintained by six mechanisms, each of which is worth describing because each is a point at which a man can establish his position.

The Six Mechanisms

1. The question and its answer. *What do you do?* The question is the primary instrument, and its power is that an answer is required immediately, in public, and without qualification. Men who are not working, whose work is informal, or whose work carries no recognised title report a specific and recurring difficulty in answering, and the difficulty is compounded by the fact that a delayed answer is itself read as an answer.

2. The visible markers. The housing, the vehicle, the children's institutions, the clothing, the contributions. These supply evidence whether or not a question is asked, and they are read by an environment that is practised at reading them.

3. The comparisons conducted by others. Men are compared by relatives, neighbours, colleagues, and their own families, frequently in their presence and frequently in the form of congratulation of somebody else. Chapter 11's material applies; the mechanism belongs here as well because the comparison is not merely a personal pressure but a public practice.

4. The institutional records. A man's results are recorded by institutions: the employer's file, the credit reference, the tax record, the educational certificates, the property register. These records determine what is available to him next, and their effect is that an assessment made in one period governs the man's options in another. Men who have had a business fail, a period of unemployment, or a bad credit record describe this effect precisely: the record is a verdict, and it is administered by institutions rather than by opinion.

5. Language. The vocabulary available for men is largely evaluative. A man is described as serious, solid, or successful; or as unserious, useless, or a failure. There is little language available for a man who is competent, generous, and productive in forms the society does not recognise.

6. The informal consequences. The consequences that fall outside the institutions: the invitations not extended, the introductions not made, the marriage proposals not entertained for a man's daughters, the membership not offered, the loan not advanced by a cooperative, the opportunity not mentioned. These consequences are rarely experienced as decisions, because they are not decisions; they are the ordinary operation of a system of standing.

Why the Measurement Is Applied to Everything

A man's results determine more than his position in the economy. Three extensions are characteristic and each is damaging.

The measurement extends to his household. A man's children's conduct, education, and appearance are read as results, and the reading places the household's outcomes in the man's account. The material of Chapter 17 applies: the fear of failing as a father is substantially a fear of this assessment.

It extends to his character. Results are read as evidence about the man's qualities: a man who has not succeeded is frequently assumed to lack seriousness, intelligence, or effort, and the assumption survives the knowledge of his circumstances. Men who have lost positions in a general economic contraction report the assumption precisely: the reduction is understood as personal, because the environment has no other scale.

It extends to his family's history. A man's results are read as the outcome of his parents' investment and of his community's support. The reading produces a specific and heavy form of pressure in families where several members' hopes have been placed on one young man, which is the material of Chapter 19 in its adult form.

The Countervailing Observation

One observation should be recorded, because it is true and because it moderates the analysis. The system of measurement is applied with substantial variation by setting, and the variation is important for practical purposes.

In stable communities of long duration, the measurement is tempered by knowledge. A community that has known a man for thirty years evaluates his conduct in relations where his results are not known: his treatment of his parents, his reliability, his conduct in a dispute, his behaviour when he had nothing. Men report that the assessment of a long-standing community is frequently more accurate and more generous than the assessment of a new environment.

In large cities and professional settings, the measurement is applied more sharply, because standing is determined by information that can be established quickly, which is generally results.

In families, the measurement is applied by the members who have least information about the man's actual position, and it is generally the relatives he sees twice a year.

The practical implication is that a man's assessment by others is not a single verdict but a set of verdicts of differing quality, and that a man who is judged to have failed is frequently being judged by the least informed of the available audiences.

> **KEY POINT**
> A man is measured by his results, and the measurement is not merely psychological: it determines what institutions extend to him, what opportunities reach him, and what his family records about him. Understanding the machinery precisely is the first step, because a man who has identified the mechanism can distinguish between the assessment that is consequential and the assessment that is merely audible.

25.2 The Price of Being Seen as a Failure

The experience of being publicly assessed as a failure has features that distinguish it from private inadequacy, and they are worth setting out, because men in this position frequently cannot name what has occurred to them.

The Nine Features

1. The verdict is general. The failure of one undertaking — a business, a marriage, a career — is read as an assessment of the man. Men describe the transition precisely: *I lost the business and became a man who had lost a business, and then I became a man who cannot do anything.*

2. The verdict is permanent until it is contradicted by results. Because the assessment is based on results, it cannot be altered by conduct, by explanation, or by time. Only a result alters it, which imposes the requirement described in Section 25.4.

3. The verdict is administered socially. It appears in the manner of others, which is the material of Chapter 16.4: the man becomes aware of a change in treatment without being told its cause, and the change is frequently more damaging than an explicit judgement.

4. The man's own account is composed with the audience in mind. The most consequential feature. A man who has been judged a failure constructs his account of himself to answer the judgement, and the account is therefore organised by the audience. Its content is defensive, its standard is the audience's, and its effect is that the man lives inside an assessment he did not make.

5. The withdrawal. As Chapter 16 establishes, the man withdraws from the settings in which the verdict circulates, which is read as a confirmation of it.

6. The reduction of the man's own conduct. A specific and frequently unnoticed effect: a man judged a failure reduces his ambitions, declines opportunities he would have attempted, and adjusts his household's expectations downward, in order to avoid a further verdict. The reduction is rational given the assessment and its cumulative effect over a decade is substantial.

7. The transfer to the household. The household experiences the verdict: the wife's treatment by her circle, the children's position among their peers, the family's standing in the community. This is frequently the element the man finds most difficult, because it is the element he cannot conceal and because it produces guilt in addition to the social injury, and because the household's response — which may be support, or may be pressure, or may be reproach — becomes part of the man's circumstances.

8. The absence of any procedure for restoration. This is the structural defect that the chapter addresses. A man judged by his results has no means of appeal: no forum, no procedure, no record to correct, and no mechanism by which the judgement can be replaced, except the production of results, which is not always possible.

9. The interioration. The final feature, and the one that determines whether the condition becomes permanent. The verdict, having been applied externally for a sufficient period, becomes the man's own assessment of himself. This is the

mechanism by which a public judgement becomes a private identity, and it is the point at which the material in Chapters 8 and 21 becomes necessary.

The Groups Most Affected

Four groups carry the verdict in specific forms.

The man whose business has failed. His failure is public, it is recorded, it is discussed, and, in customary settings, it is frequently accompanied by a moral interpretation concerning the man's conduct. The recovery material is in Chapter 38, and the specific burden is that the failure is treated as a completed verdict at the moment it occurs, whereas businesses ordinarily fail and recover, and the same trajectory in a man's career is treated as normal.

The man who is unemployed or underemployed for a sustained period. The verdict is applied immediately and it compounds: employers prefer the employed, lenders prefer the settled, and families' assessments sharpen as the period extends. Chapter 11.4 addresses the condition; the societal element is that a man in this position is being assessed for something he cannot correct by the means available to him.

The man whose results are adequate in a form that his community does not recognise. The man in informal trade with a substantial income; the technician whose competence exceeds his credentials; the man whose work is of high quality and low status. His difficulty is that his results are real and are not receivable as results, and that he is required to explain himself continuously.

The man with a disability or a chronic condition. The verdict is applied to his capacity, and it is applied by institutions and by individuals who have not assessed it. The material is in Chapter 33, and the societal element is the reduction of the man's scope to a single fact about him.

25.3 When Society Has No Place for Your Version of Success

This section addresses the specific situation in which a man's competence and effort are substantial and the environment's available categories do not recognise them. It is a distinct problem from personal failure, and it requires a distinct treatment, because the standard advice — work harder, produce results — does not apply to a mismatch between a man's capacities and the categories available.

The Four Mismatches

1. The structural mismatch. The economy does not contain the work for which the man has prepared, or contains less of it than the number of men prepared for it. The graduate in an economy with a graduate surplus; the professional in a sector that has contracted; the tradesman in a market that has been displaced by imports.

The treatment. The man requires an accurate account of the market rather than a personal diagnosis, and the two available routes: the identification of a related competence that the market does contain, and the construction of a livelihood from more than one source. Chapter 39 provides the practical method. The specific requirement is that the man's assessment of himself be separated from the market's assessment of his qualifications, which is the work of Section 25.5.

2. The credential mismatch. The man's competence exceeds his formal qualifications, and the environment requires the qualification rather than the competence. This is the most common mismatch in the countries where this book will be read, and it produces a characteristic experience: the man who is technically superior to the certified practitioner and who is invisible to every institution.

The treatment. The correction of the credential where it is obtainable, and it is frequently more obtainable than men assume: professional bodies, examinations, professional registration routes, and adult education. Where it is not obtainable, the construction of arrangements in which competence is demonstrated rather than certified: direct client relationships, referral networks, and the accumulation of a public record of completed work. Men in this position report that the referral network is the principal route, and its construction is described in Chapter 27.

3. The recognition mismatch. The man's work is of high quality and low status: the artisan, the technician, the driver, the security officer, the man whose contribution is essential and whose standing is derived from a category that society treats as inferior. His competence is not in doubt and is not counted.

The treatment. Two things. First, the man's own measure, which is the central subject of this chapter, and the specific finding that a man who knows the quality of his own work is substantially protected from the social assessment of its category. Second, the conversion of the work into a record and a relationship: the customers who return because the work is good, the reputation built in a specific market, the mentorship of younger men. Men in trades report that the standing available within their own professional community is frequently more substantive than the standing available in the general society.

4. The path mismatch. The man has chosen a path that his community does not recognise as success: the artist, the musician, the researcher in a subject without commercial application, the teacher in a family of businessmen, the man who has taken a position of lower income and greater value, the man who has chosen caring work. His results, judged by the community's scale, are inadequate; judged by his own, they are not.

The treatment. The clear statement of the man's own standard, the acceptance that a section of his family will not recognise it, and the deliberate maintenance of at least one reference group in which the work is understood.

The material is in Chapters 11 and 27, and the case in Section 25.7 illustrates the pattern.

What the Mismatches Have in Common

Three features are shared.

The man's effort is not the variable. The advice to work harder assumes a market that rewards effort, and in each of the four mismatches the market does not. The consequence of receiving the advice is that the man concludes that his effort is deficient, which is inaccurate and which produces the loss of the one resource he actually has.

The record is the decisive practical instrument. In all four mismatches, the man's protection is a record: of work completed, skills demonstrated, clients satisfied, students taught, and results produced in a form the market recognises. The record is constructed by the man, it is at his disposal, and it is the raw material of both the livelihood and the self-assessment.

A reference group is required. The man's own standard will not survive an environment that applies a different one continuously. The group may be small: three men in comparable positions, a professional association, a group of practitioners, a monthly meeting. Its function is to supply recognition from people who can judge the work, which is the form of recognition that the man actually requires, and which the general society cannot supply because it cannot assess what it has not understood.

25.4 Dignity in a World That Values Achievement

Dignity is the chapter's central concept, and it requires a careful definition, because it is used loosely and because two of its common meanings are obstacles.

What Dignity Is Not

It is not recognition. Recognition is the acknowledgement of a man by others, and it is valuable and external. Dignity does not depend upon it, which is precisely why it is useful to a man whose recognition has been withdrawn.

It is not resignation. Resignation accepts an assessment and stops acting. Dignity is compatible with a full effort, and it is the position from which effort becomes sustainable: a man who has dignity can attempt and fail without losing his standing in his own account, which is the condition of persistence described in Chapter 8.

It is not the denial of the circumstances. A man's circumstances are what they are, and dignity is not produced by describing an inadequate position as adequate. The distinction is between the assessment of the man and the assessment of his position: the first is what dignity concerns, and the second should be described accurately.

It is not the maintenance of pride. Pride defends the position; dignity concerns the man. The distinction is visible in behaviour: a man defending a position will conceal, exaggerate, decline the conversation, and manage the impression, whereas a man holding dignity will state his position accurately, including its inadequacy, without its being converted into a verdict about him.

The Definition

Dignity is **the position a man holds toward himself when his conduct is consistent with his own standards and his circumstances are described accurately.**

Three elements of the definition matter.

It is about conduct rather than outcome. A man's circumstances are substantially determined by factors outside him; his conduct is frequently the portion he controls. A man who has discharged his obligations, kept his commitments, treated people properly, and made his effort in full holds dignity regardless of the results, and he holds it accurately, not as a comfort.

It requires an accurate description of the circumstances. Dignity cannot be built on a false account. A man who describes an inescapable position as a temporary difficulty has not preserved his dignity; he has deferred the work, and the deferral is the mechanism described in Chapter 9.

It is held in a position toward himself. Not a statement to others and not a feeling. The practical form is a written statement of the man's standard, of his conduct against it, and of his circumstances as they actually are, which is the exercise at the end of this chapter. The statement's function is to make the man's account of himself independent of the audience that judges results.

The Four Practices of Dignity

1. Speak the circumstances accurately, once, without elaboration. A man who is unemployed, who has lost a business, or who is in work of low standing should be able to state his position in one sentence without apology. The practice's function is the removal of the man's dependence on the audience's interpretation: an accurate statement cannot be corrected, and it removes the material from the register of concealment.

2. Refuse the verdict while accepting the assessment. The distinction is precise. *The business failed, and the market has no work for my qualifications* is an assessment, and it is accepted. *I am a failure* is a verdict, and it is refused. Men should note that the refusal is not a matter of declarations but of description: the man states what occurred, states what it means practically, and does not accept the generalisation.

3. Keep conduct within the standard. This is the element that produces dignity, and it is the reason that the practice works. A man who maintains his

conduct — obligations discharged, commitments kept, work performed properly, household treated well — has evidence, and the evidence is not susceptible to the audience's opinion. In the accounts of men who have maintained dignity through serious reversals, this is the practice they most consistently identify.

4. Hold one relationship in which the man is not assessed. A wife, a friend, a sibling, or a professional relationship in which the man's position is known and in which his worth is not conditional on results. Chapter 4′s material applies; the specific function here is that the relationship supplies the correction to the audience's verdict.

25.5 Choosing Your Own Measure of Worth

The practical work of this chapter is the construction of a measure of worth that the man has chosen, that is available to him, and that does not require the audience's approval. The measure does not replace the world's assessment, which continues; it supplies a second assessment, held by the man, from which he acts.

The Conditions

Four conditions must be met, and a measure failing any of them will not hold.

It must be verdict-free. The measure must not depend on outcomes the man does not control. A measure that requires the business to succeed is the audience's measure in the man's own handwriting.

It must be available now. The measure must be operable in the man's present circumstances, including the inadequate ones. *I will be a man who does not lie, who discharges what he owes to the extent of his capacity, who keeps himself present to his children, and who does not waste the day* is available to a man with no income.

It must be specific enough to be checkable. A man must be able to determine at the end of a day whether he has met it. The test used elsewhere in this book applies: if it cannot be answered with evidence, it is not a measure but a sentiment.

It must be the man's. Chapter 2′s three-way test — kinship, work, own — applies to each element. A measure assembled from the community's requirements is the audience's verdict with different vocabulary.

The Four Domains of a Personal Measure

Conduct and integrity. What the man will and will not do, stated specifically. The negative specification of Section 21.6 is the most durable form, because it is entirely within the man's control.

Effort. What the man intends to attempt, stated in units: the applications submitted, the hours worked, the training completed, the work performed properly. Effort is the domain in which the man has power, and it is the domain that the results-based measure ignores.

Obligation. What the man owes and to whom, discharged to the extent of his capacity, with the shortfall disclosed rather than concealed. This is the domain described in Parts III and V, and its importance here is that it supplies a standard the man can meet in conditions of scarcity: a man who cannot pay may still be a man who has told the truth about it and has paid what he could.

Conduct toward his household. The measure in Section 17.3: the four responsibilities of a father, and the specific attention items from Section 18.6. Its function is to hold the part of the man's worth which no market assesses.

The Translation of Results into Effort

A specific technique, and the one men report as most useful. For each outcome in the man's circumstances, identify the corresponding effort and enter the effort into the measure.

The outcome	The effort within my control	Is it in my measure?
The income I did not obtain	The applications I submitted, the meetings attended, the skills developed	
The promotion I did not receive	The quality of the work I performed, the competence I developed	
The business that failed	Whether the effort was made in full, whether the accounting was honest, whether the failure was contained	
My children's outcomes	My presence, my example, my conduct toward them	
My standing in the community	My conduct in public, my contribution at the level available to me	

The technique's function is not to console the man. It is to restore a domain in which his effort counts, because the results-based measure has removed it, and because a man without a domain in which his effort counts stops making effort, which is the reduction described in Section 25.2.

The Question of Ambition

One clarification: choosing a personal measure does not require the abandonment of ambition. Men who construct a personal measure report, with consistency, that their ambition becomes more sustainable and frequently larger, for the reason given in Chapter 7: ambition that is pursued without a verdict attached to each outcome can be sustained through failure, whereas ambition attached to a verdict is abandoned at the first verdict.

25.6 Living Without Needing Approval

The final substantive section addresses the practical arrangements by which a man conducts his life without requiring the approval of the judging audience. The objective is not indifference to other people, which is neither possible nor desirable; it is the reduction of the audience's authority over the man's decisions and his account of himself.

The Four Arrangements

1. The smaller audience. A deliberate reduction of the number of people whose opinion is treated as authoritative. The practical form: identify by name the people whose assessment has genuine standing, on the criteria of knowledge, honesty, and concern, and treat the assessments from outside that group as information rather than as verdicts. The group is generally small, and men report that its identification alone produces a substantial change.

2. The reduced exposure. The unglamorous measure described in Chapter 11.5: the reduction of the ceremonies at which position is displayed, the reduction of the comparisons conducted by relatives, the reduction of the social media accounts through which other men's results are presented continuously. The measure's purpose is to reduce the frequency of the verdict's delivery, which is a matter of exposure rather than of attitude.

3. The stated standard. The man's measure, written and referred to. Chapter 11's exercise and Section 25.5 supply it, and its function in this context is to supply a second opinion at the moment the audience's judgement arrives.

4. The relationship in which the man is not assessed. Described in Sections 25.4 and 4.4. One relationship, at minimum, in which the man's position is known and his regard is not conditional on results. In the accounts of men who have maintained their footing through public failure, this is consistently identified as the decisive resource.

The Three Prohibitions

Do not argue with the audience. The verdict is not produced by an argument and cannot be corrected by one. A man who defends his position against a relative at a family gathering has accepted the audience's authority and is conducting his case in its court. The practice is to state the position once, accurately, and to allow the verdict to stand unchallenged by the man's conduct over the following years. This is the material of Chapter 16.5, and its record in men's accounts is better than the argument's.

Do not require the household to defend you. A man who requires his wife and children to uphold his position in the community's conversations has transferred the audience's authority into his own household, which produces the arrangements described in Chapter 17.

Do not construct a counter-audience in which the man is over-valued. The opposite error, and a common one among men who have been judged: the deliberate construction of a circle in which the man's account is accepted entirely and in which the failure is attributed to others. The arrangement is comfortable and it is the mechanism by which men spend decades in the exposure response described in Chapter 16.3, conducting an unending case in a court that has already decided in their favour.

What the Work Produces

Men who complete the work in this chapter describe four outcomes, and their consistency is worth recording because the outcomes are modest and the modesty is the point.

They report a reduction in the amount of their day consumed by the assessment of their position. They report an increase in the effort applied, for the reason given in Section 25.5. They report an improvement in their relationships with their households, because a man who is not defending his position at home is available to the people in it. And they report that their relationships with the extended family and the community improve, because an accurate and unapologetic statement of a man's position is substantially easier for others to work with than concealment, which is the finding of Chapters 9 and 20 in another register.

Figure 25.1 sets out the machinery by which the results-based assessment operates on a man, together with the points at which the arrangements in Sections 25.4 and 25.6 interrupt it. The diagram is illustrative and generalised; the machinery operates with different intensity in different settings, and the interruptions listed are those with the most consistent record in men's accounts.

How the assessment arrives	Where it can be interrupted
The question and the immediate answer it requires	State the position accurately, once, without apology
The visible markers, read without a question being asked	Reduce the ceremonies at which position is displayed
The comparisons conducted by others in the man's presence	Reduce exposure to continuous comparison
The institutional records that decide his next options	Obtain the record: applications, work completed, obligations met
The evaluative vocabulary available for men	Apply your own measure, written and specific
The invitations, introductions, and opportunities not extended	Build the smaller audience and one relationship without assessment

Figure 25.1 How a results-based assessment reaches a man, and where it can be interrupted. The left-hand column describes the sequence; the right-hand column identifies the interruption available at each stage.

25.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Written Off

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in vocational counselling, family practice, and community affairs.

Emeka is fifty-two, a refrigeration and air-conditioning technician, married to Ifeoma for twenty-four years, with four children between the ages of thirteen and twenty-two.

Eleven years ago, Emeka was employed as a maintenance supervisor for a company that operated a chain of supermarkets. In the third year of that employment, the company was taken over, the maintenance function was outsourced, and Emeka was made redundant as part of a group of about sixty staff. He was forty-one, he had a school certificate and an apprenticeship, and he had no formal professional qualification.

Two events in the following period determined the course of the case.

The first concerned his efforts. Over the following two years, Emeka submitted approximately 190 applications, obtained four interviews, and received no offer. He worked in the interval as an air-conditioning installation contractor on a per-job basis, which produced an income of about half his former salary and which

fluctuated substantially. He also completed two short technical courses, neither of which altered the position.

The second concerned the response of his environment, which he described precisely. At his father's funeral, in the second year after the redundancy, a relative observed, in the presence of the family, that Emeka was *the one who used to be with the big company*. In the fourth year, a relative who had previously sought his advice on property matters began to consult his younger brother instead. In the fifth year, the family's contribution to a development levy was reduced to a level set by the association without reference to him, which he subsequently learned had been described as an allowance for his circumstances. In the eighth year, a proposal concerning the family land was discussed and concluded without his being consulted.

Emeka's own account of this period identified three elements. He had, over about four years, stopped attending the association's monthly meetings, which he described as *not wanting to sit in the room where they have decided what I am*. He had reduced the household's expenditure and had withdrawn two of his children from a school that the household could no longer fund, which he regarded as the only failure about which he was certain. And he had, by the sixth year, formed the conclusion that he was *finished*, which he defined in the assessment as follows: *I meant that I had stopped expecting anything to change. I did my jobs. I did not plan.*

Two interventions, which came at approximately the same period and from different directions, produced the change.

The first came through a technical channel. In the seventh year after the redundancy, a large installation project in the city required a site supervisor with experience of commercial refrigeration, and the contractor, who had worked with Emeka fifteen years earlier, approached him. Emeka supervised the project for nine months at a day rate that was approximately two and a half times his contracting income. The project led to two further engagements, and by the second year he was supervising approximately four projects annually, with two apprentices working under him.

The second came through a professional association. On the recommendation of the same contractor, Emeka joined a national body for refrigeration technicians, which required an examination for membership and which provided, in addition to the credential, a network of practitioners in the trade. He sat the examination in the second year and passed. His account of the association's effect was specific: *In that room I am not the man who lost his job. I am the one who has done more cold-room installations than most of them, and they know it because they have been on those sites. Nobody in that room has ever asked me what company I work for.*

The reconstruction that resulted had four components, each of which he identified separately.

The record. Emeka compiled, on the association's advice, a written record of eleven years of completed work: the installations, the sites, the clients, the fault diagnoses, and the two apprentices trained. He described this as the single most significant action of the whole period, and its effect was specific: *I had eleven years in which I*

worked every week and I had come to believe that I had not done anything. I wrote down 340 jobs. I had never counted them.

The measure. With the record as the basis, he wrote out his own standard, which consisted of five items: every installation commissioned properly or not paid for; no work concealed from a client; the apprentices taught properly; the household's obligations met to the extent possible and any shortfall disclosed rather than hidden; and no participation in any arrangement that misrepresents what he had done. He described the standard as the reason the position with his family changed, because he could state his position in a sentence without apology.

The re-entry. In the third year, Emeka resumed attending the association's meetings of his community's development association. He described his reasoning as follows: *I decided that I would attend whether or not they had decided what I am.* At the meeting of the fifth year, a proposal concerning the family land was raised, and Emeka stated his position on it and was heard. He was subsequently appointed to the association's works committee, and, in the seventh year, was its chairman.

The disclosure to the household. The final element, and the one Emeka described as the most difficult. He explained to Ifeoma and to the two children who had been withdrawn from school the position of the intervening years: the 190 applications, the conclusion that he was finished, and the reason he had become silent in the house. He described the outcome as follows: *The children did not know that I had applied for anything. They thought I had stopped trying. My daughter told me, at that meeting, that she had believed I did not care about her school, and she had been carrying that for eleven years.*

Emeka's summary, at the end of the case, was: *I lost a job at forty-one and I was written off, and I am not claiming that the writing off was my imagination. What I did not know was that I had agreed with it. For six years I carried their verdict and I did not count the 340 jobs. The record and the room full of technicians were worth more than every application I ever submitted.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The verdict was administered socially, in specific events that could be dated. The remark at the funeral, the transfer of the consulting relationship, the reduced levy, the unconsulted discussion of the land. None of these was an act of cruelty and their cumulative effect was to relocate the man in the community's structure. This is the machinery of Sections 25.1 and 25.2 operating in its ordinary form, and the case is included because the mechanism is frequently invisible to the man's household and to the man himself.

The man's interioration of the verdict was the decisive event. Emeka's conclusion that he was finished was formed in his own assessment, and it produced the withdrawal, the reduction of his ambitions, and the silence in his household. The case's central teaching is the finding of Section 25.2, that a public

judgement becomes a private identity when it is held without challenge, and the period between the verdict and the interioration was in this case about four years.

The record was the instrument. Three hundred and forty jobs, written down for the first time in eleven years. The instrument's function is described in Section 25.3: it converts a man's unrecorded effort into evidence, and the evidence is not subject to the audience's opinion. Men in comparable situations frequently describe the counting as the moment at which the position became visible to them, and the case is included for that reason.

The recognition came from people who could assess the work. The professional association's members knew the installations, the sites, and the quality of the work, and their assessment was therefore substantive rather than social. This is the reference group of Section 25.3 in operation, and the case illustrates its specific value: recognition from a competent audience is different in kind from recognition from a general one, and it is frequently available to men to whom the general audience has closed.

The disclosure to the household corrected eleven years of misattribution. The daughter's statement — that she had believed her father did not care about her school — is the cost of the concealment described in Chapters 9 and 17, and the case is included because this misattribution is systematic: in the absence of information, a man's withdrawal is interpreted by his children as a statement about them.

25.8 Practical Exercise: The Judgement Audit and the Personal Measure

This exercise takes about two and a half hours, spread over three sittings.

Part One: The Audit of Judgements (Sitting One)

Write out the judgements that have been applied to you and that you have accepted. Be specific and, where possible, record the event, the person, and the date.

The judgement	Who applied it	On what basis	Have I accepted it?

Sources to consider: family comments at gatherings; the treatment you receive from relatives and neighbours; the institutional records (employment, credit, qualifications); the reduced consultations and invitations; anything said to you directly.

Then answer four questions.

- How many of the judgements on the list are based on results rather than on conduct?

- Which of them did I accept without noticing that I had accepted it?
- What have I stopped doing, applying for, or attempting, since accepting them?
- Which single judgement has done the most damage, and what is the evidence for it?

Part Two: The Record (Sitting Two)

Compile the record described in Section 25.3. Write out, with as much specificity as you can:

- the work completed in the last five years, in units (installations, jobs, projects, client engagements, services rendered, students taught, cases handled, customers served);
- the skills demonstrated, including those for which you have no certificate;
- the people who have depended on your work and who would confirm its quality;
- the obligations discharged: what you paid, supported, funded, repaired, and maintained.

Then answer: how many of these had I ever counted before? What proportion of my effort has been recorded anywhere?

Part Three: The Personal Measure (Sitting Three)

Write your measure in the four domains. Each item must be specific and checkable, and none may depend on an outcome you do not control.

Conduct and integrity. What I will not do:

Effort. What I will attempt, stated in units and per week:

Obligation. What I owe, and what I will do where I cannot meet it:

Conduct in my household. The specific items of presence and treatment:

Then apply the four conditions from Section 25.5: is it verdict-free, available now, checkable, and mine?

Part Four: The Audience

Name the people whose assessment carries authority.

Name	Why their judgement has standing	Whether they know my actual position

Then answer: who, on the list of people whose judgement I have been treating as authoritative, does not meet the criteria — and what would change if their assessment were treated as information rather than as a verdict?

Part Five: The Arrangements

Specify the four arrangements from Section 25.6 with dates.

The arrangement	The specific act	The date
The smaller audience		
The reduced exposure		
The stated standard		
The relationship in which I am not assessed		

Part Six: The Statement

Write the one-sentence accurate statement of your position, without apology and without elaboration. Examples of the form: *I lost the business in 2019 and I have worked as a technician since; I am supporting four children and I am two years behind on the fees.* Then rehearse saying it aloud, once, to somebody who is likely to ask. The purpose is the removal of the man's dependence on the audience's interpretation, which requires that the position be statable.

25.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it not simply an excuse to say that the world judges by results?"

The observation is a description, not an excuse, and the chapter is explicit that a man's circumstances should be described accurately and that effort should be made in full. What the observation establishes is that the world's assessment is not the whole of a man's worth, and that a man who has accepted it as the whole will stop making effort, which is the opposite of the effect intended by the people applying it.

"I have lost everything. Everyone in my community knows. What do I say?"

The statement in Part Six of the exercise, delivered once, accurately, and without apology. The record of men in this situation is consistent: the audience's interest in the failure lasts considerably less long than the man's fear of it, and the man's subsequent conduct is what the community actually assesses, because a community of long duration evaluates conduct in practice rather than results in the abstract.

"My family treats me as the unsuccessful one. How do I change their view?"

By not requiring the change. The practical sequence is the one in Section 25.6: state the position once, continue to attend and contribute at the level available to you, and allow the conduct to accumulate. Men report that the change in the family's assessment arrives, where it arrives, in the form of a specific occasion — an appointment, a consultation, a role on a committee — rather than in the form of a retraction.

"Is it dishonest to hold a personal measure that lets me feel adequate when I am not?"

Only if the measure describes the circumstances inaccurately, which Section 25.4 prohibits. The measure concerns the man's conduct and effort, over which he has control, and the accuracy of the measure is what makes it honest: a man whose obligations are unmet should record the shortfall in the measure, disclose it, and record what he did about it. What the measure refuses is the extension of the circumstances into a verdict about the person, which is not honesty but a generalisation.

"What if I genuinely have not made the effort?"

Then the measure requires it, and the honest assessment is the beginning of the correction rather than an account of the man's character. Men frequently discover, on completing Part Two of the exercise, that the effort has been made and that the environment has been inefficient; they also discover, in a minority of cases, that the effort has not been made, which is the more useful finding and which the measure addresses directly.

"Does this chapter apply to men who have succeeded?"

Yes, and frequently more urgently. The man whose results are adequate has the same audience and has usually invested more completely in the assessment it applies, which is why the loss of position in mid-life is as damaging to him as it is to the man who never obtained it. The material of Chapter 24 applies, and the measure in Section 25.5 is the protection against its collapse.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 25 in brief. A man is measured by his results, and the measurement is applied through six mechanisms: the question *what do you do?* and the immediate answer it requires; the visible markers; the comparisons conducted by others in his presence; the institutional records that determine his future options; the evaluative vocabulary available for men; and the informal consequences, comprising invitations, introductions, memberships, and opportunities that never arrive. The measurement extends to the man's household, to his character, and to his family's history, and it is applied most sharply in settings where standing is determined by information available quickly, and most accurately in communities of long duration that assess conduct rather than results.

Being publicly assessed as a failure has nine features: the verdict is general, permanent until contradicted by results, socially administered, and answered by an account composed with the audience in mind; it produces withdrawal; it reduces the man's own conduct and ambition; it transfers to his household; it has no procedure for restoration; and, in its decisive form, it is interiorated and becomes the man's own assessment of himself.

Society has no place for four specific versions of success: the structural mismatch, where the economy does not contain the work for which the man is prepared; the credential mismatch, where competence exceeds certification; the recognition mis-

match, where work of high quality attracts low status; and the path mismatch, where the man's chosen measure is not the community's. All four share three features: the man's effort is not the variable, the record is the decisive practical instrument, and a reference group of people who can assess the work is required.

Dignity is defined as the position a man holds toward himself when his conduct is consistent with his own standards and his circumstances are described accurately. It is not recognition, resignation, the denial of circumstances, or the maintenance of pride. Its practices are to state the circumstances accurately once without elaboration, to refuse the verdict while accepting the assessment, to keep conduct within the standard, and to hold one relationship in which the man is not assessed.

A personal measure must be verdict-free, available now, checkable, and the man's own. It is constructed in four domains — conduct and integrity, effort, obligation, and conduct toward his household — and it is supported by the technique of translating outcomes into efforts. Living without requiring approval involves four arrangements: the smaller audience identified by name, the reduced exposure to the delivery of the verdict, the stated standard, and the relationship in which the man is not assessed. It involves three prohibitions: do not argue with the audience, do not require the household to defend you, and do not construct a counter-audience in which the man is over-valued.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete Part One. Which judgement have you accepted without noticing that you had accepted it, and what have you stopped attempting since?
2. What is the record of your work over the last five years, in units? How many of those units had you ever counted before?
3. From the four mismatches in Section 25.3, which applies to you — structural, credential, recognition, or path? What does the corresponding treatment require, specifically?
4. Write your one-sentence statement of position, without apology. What is the sentence you would most dislike saying aloud, and why?
5. Which of the four practices of dignity in Section 25.4 do you currently operate, and which is absent? What would change in your week if all four were present?
6. Name the people whose assessments you treat as authoritative. Which of them does not meet the criteria of knowledge, honesty, and concern — and what would change if their assessment were treated as information?
7. Which of the three prohibitions in Section 25.6 are you currently violating: arguing with the audience, requiring the household to defend you, or maintaining a counter-audience? What has it cost you?

Further Reading

- **On social evaluation and status:** the sociological literature on status, respect, and the evaluation of persons, including the work on how societies allocate standing and the consequences of low status for health and behaviour.
- **On the provider role and social standing in men:** research on the association between men's employment status and their social position, including the findings on the effects of unemployment on men's standing within households and communities.
- **On unemployment and mental health:** the substantial literature on the psychological effects of unemployment, including the consistent finding that the effects are stronger in men and stronger where the man is the principal earner of a household.
- **On dignity:** the philosophical and psychological literature on dignity and self-respect, including the accounts of dignity as a standing that does not depend on the recognition of others, and the distinction between self-respect and self-esteem.
- **On informal work and the mismatch between competence and credentials:** the literature on informal employment, on skills recognition, and on the labour market consequences of the absence of formal certification, including the evidence on the value of competency-based assessment.
- **Practical resources:** adult education and professional certification routes; business and technical support services for small enterprises and trades; men's groups and professional associations in occupational communities; and the material in Appendices I and J.

26 CHAPTER

The Betrayal of Friends and Brothers

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the friendships men build in adult life, identify what they rely on, and assess the strength of his own arrangements.
2. Explain what occurs when a friend breaks faith, and identify the specific features that distinguish betrayal by a friend from other losses.
3. Analyse the betrayals that occur between brothers and within families, including their causes, their forms, and their consequences for the family system.
4. Describe the anatomy of a betrayed friendship, including the stages through which it passes and the point at which repair remains possible.
5. Draw lessons from a betrayal without converting them into a general suspicion of other men.
6. Apply a method for discerning friendship, and use the exercise at the end of this chapter to audit and rebuild his own arrangements.

Introduction

A man's friendships occupy a position in his life that is difficult to describe to anybody who does not hold them. They are not discussed in the way that marriage and fatherhood are discussed, and they are frequently not named as important even by the men who rely on them. Yet the evidence is consistent: men with close friendships report better mental health, recover faster from losses, live longer, and describe their lives in terms that the men without them do not use. And the loss of a friendship, by betrayal, by drift, or by death, produces a grief that men frequently cannot identify as grief, because the vocabulary available for it is used for other relationships.

This chapter addresses the specific form of the loss described in its title: the betrayal of friends and brothers.

The subject is distinct from the material in Chapter 16, which examined rejection and betrayal generally, and it is distinct from the material in Chapter 27,

which addresses the condition of having nobody to call. This chapter concerns the middle case: a man who had friendships, who relied on them in specific and unexamined ways, and who discovered that one of them would not hold.

Its approach has three commitments, and they should be stated at the outset.

The first is that betrayal by a friend or a brother is a real loss and should be treated as one. The material is frequently dismissed — by the man, by his household, and by the wider culture — with the observation that friendships end and that a man should not be sentimental about them. The dismissal prevents the grief and the analysis, with the results described in Chapter 24.

The second is that the betrayal is frequently the product of an arrangement that both parties maintained, and not of a single person's wickedness. Men's friendships are frequently built on an unstated set of assumptions about what each party will provide, defend, and keep silent about, and those assumptions are tested only in the circumstances described in the following sections. Many betrayals are the failure of an arrangement that was never agreed.

The third is that the chapter's objective is the reconstruction of the man's capacity to rely on other men, and not the establishment of a general suspicion. A man who concludes from a betrayal that men cannot be relied upon has accepted a proposition that is both false and expensive, and he will conduct the remainder of his life on it, as Section 26.5 describes.

26.1 The Friendships Men Build and What They Rely On

Male friendship has an architecture that differs from female friendship in ways that are documented and that determine what a betrayal costs. Before examining the betrayal, the architecture must be described, because the betrayal is generally a failure at one of its load-bearing points.

The Four Functions

Men's friendships supply four functions, and a man's arrangements may supply some and not others.

1. Company and activity. The football, the club, the drinking group, the market, the two men who repair vehicles together on Saturdays. This function is the most common, and it is the one that men most readily recognise as friendship.

2. Practical assistance. The contacts, the introductions, the small loans, the help with a vehicle, the place to stay, the intervention in a bureaucratic matter. This function is transactional and it is essential, and it is the one men most frequently rely upon while denying that they rely upon it.

3. Standing and membership. The group that recognises a man, that has known him for years, that supplies his position in a social world that is not his household or his workplace. This function is the subject of Chapter 27′s material on groups.

4. Disclosure. The function that men most frequently lack, and the one this book has repeatedly identified: one or more men with whom the man's actual position is known, and to whom he may speak about matters that are not practical. The absence of this function is the central finding of Part I, and its presence is the strongest single predictor of men's resilience to the losses described in this book.

The Unstated Terms

Every friendship operates on terms, and men's friendships operate on terms that are frequently never stated. Six are common, and the betrayal described later in this chapter is generally the failure of one of them.

Confidence. What is said between the men remains between them. This term is universal and it is the term most frequently broken.

Non-predation. Neither man will pursue the other's wife, business, position, or opportunity. The term is unspoken and it is absolute, and its breach is the betrayal that men rank most severely.

Reciprocity of effort. The arrangement is understood to be roughly balanced over time, without accounting. Its breach produces the resentment described in Chapter 20 in a friendship rather than a household.

Defence in absence. The man defends the other when he is not present, and does not join in the assessment of him.

Assistance at the moment of crisis. The term that is tested least frequently and that carries the greatest weight when it is tested. It operates in one direction at a time and it is generally assumed rather than agreed.

Silence about the man's failures. The term that keeps a man's difficulty out of the community's conversation. Its breach is the mechanism of the public verdict described in Chapter 25.

What Men Rely On Without Knowing It

Three features of the reliance are worth naming because each explains the severity of a betrayal.

Men place a large weight on a small number of relationships. The research on men's social networks consistently finds that men maintain fewer close relationships than women and that their networks are more dependent on specific individuals, particularly the spouse and one or two male friends. The concentration means that a single betrayal removes a large proportion of a man's support, and men frequently discover the size of what they relied on only after losing it.

The reliance is practical as well as emotional. A man's friend is frequently the person who supplies the intervention in a difficulty, the reference for a position, the funding for a shortfall, the assessment of a business decision. The

loss of a friend is therefore also the loss of the man's access to a set of the practical capacities of his network.

The reliance is unexamined. Men do not audit their friendships, discuss their terms, or test their assumptions. The absence of examination is what makes the betrayal so disorienting: the man's model of the relationship contained a term that the other party's model did not, and the discovery of the divergence is frequently more damaging than the act itself.

> **KEY POINT**
> Male friendship supplies company, practical assistance, standing, and — least often — disclosure, and it operates on unstated terms concerning confidence, non-predation, reciprocity, defence in absence, assistance in crisis, and silence about failure. The severity of a betrayal is determined not by the act alone but by which term was relied upon without ever being agreed.

26.2 When a Friend Breaks Faith

This section sets out the forms that betrayal by a friend takes, and, for each, the specific loss that follows. The forms are arranged in the order of their frequency in men's accounts, not of their severity.

The Disclosure of a Confidence

The act. Material that a man gave to a friend in confidence is disclosed: to the group, to the community, to the man's family, or to the man's wife.

The specific loss. The man's safety in the relationship, and — in a proportion of cases that is larger than most men expect — the man's standing, where the disclosed material was the kind described in Chapter 21's private account. The severity of the loss is determined by the content rather than by the act: the disclosure of an ordinary difficulty is a breach, and the disclosure of a shameful matter is an exposure.

The distinctive feature. The damage is frequently invisible. The man cannot identify who knows, and his conduct changes accordingly: he avoids the group, he becomes guarded with the friend, and he is unable to state what occurred. The pattern is the material of Section 16.4.

The Pursuit of the Man's Interest

The act. The friend pursues the man's opportunity, position, client, contract, or — in the most severe form — his wife or partner.

The specific loss. The object lost, together with the man's model of his own judgement, as described in Chapter 16. The case in Section 26.7 illustrates the form.

The distinctive feature. The act is frequently deniable. The friend presents the pursuit as coincidence, as an opportunity that arose independently, or as a matter in which the man's claim was never established. The denial leaves the man in the position of appearing to accuse without proof, which is the reason this betrayal frequently ends the friendship silently rather than visibly.

The Failure of Assistance in Crisis

The act. The man is in difficulty — a bereavement, a financial collapse, an illness, a legal matter, a divorce — and the friend who was relied upon does not appear: no call, no presence, no assistance, and, frequently, an avoidance that becomes visible over the following weeks.

The specific loss. The material assistance that did not arrive, and, more significantly, the man's position: he has been left visibly alone in the moment in which the presence of a friend was the term he most relied upon.

The distinctive feature. This form of betrayal frequently involves no decision. It is produced by the friend's own incapacity, fear, or absorption, and it is frequently accompanied by a subsequent guilt that prevents the friend from re-establishing contact, which produces a permanent loss from an act of omission. The material for the man is the finding described in Chapter 4: the reliance was unexamined, and it was never tested before the crisis, which is why the failure arrived at the worst possible moment.

The Financial Betrayal

The act. A loan not repaid; a business partnership in which the funds are diverted; a joint arrangement in which the friend's portion is not contributed; a guarantee called upon; a property arrangement in which the friend takes more than the agreement provided.

The specific loss. The money, together with — and this is the element that men most consistently report as the larger loss — the position of having been taken advantage of by somebody who was trusted in the one domain in which trust was assumed to be unnecessary.

The distinctive feature. This betrayal is frequently preceded by a period in which the man made accommodations: the delayed repayment accepted without comment, the reduced contribution overlooked, the accounting not requested. The accommodations were performed in the name of the friendship and they are the mechanism by which the loss accumulates. The material in Chapter 20 on the unspoken ledger applies: the man's account of what he has not raised is frequently the substance of what he is eventually betrayed out of.

The Failure of Defence in Absence

The act. The man is being assessed, criticised, or accused in a setting in which the friend is present, and the friend does not defend him: says nothing, joins the assessment, or supplies the details that make the assessment effective.

The specific loss. The man's standing, which is the material of Chapters 16 and 25, together with the discovery that a term he had assumed was universal was not held by the other party.

The distinctive feature. The act is not a betrayal in the man's own assessment at the moment it occurs, because he is not present. The information arrives later, from a third party, and it arrives accompanied by the requirement to decide what to do with it, which men frequently resolve by not confronting the friend and by reducing the relationship silently.

The Accumulated Betrayal

The act. No single act; a long pattern in which the friend takes and does not give, is present for his own requirements and absent for the man's, maintains the friendship on terms that suit him, and uses the man's resources — the vehicle, the contacts, the household's hospitality, the man's willingness — as an available supply.

The specific loss. The years, the resources, and the man's own account of the relationship, which is revealed to have been, from the other side, an arrangement of convenience.

The distinctive feature. This form produces a specific and particularly difficult injury because the man cannot identify a betrayal at all. He can identify a pattern of small events, each individually dismissing, and his conclusion — that the friendship was not what he believed it to be — cannot be stated as an accusation. It is the form most frequently reported in mid-life, and the form that most frequently produces the general conclusion described in Section 26.5.

26.3 The Brothers of Adulthood: Family Loyalty and Its Failures

The betrayals that occur between brothers — and between siblings generally, where men are concerned — have a distinct structure, and they are frequently the most damaging of the losses described in this chapter, for three reasons: the relationship is permanent, the community's judgement is applied to it, and the material in question is frequently the family's property, its standing, and its history.

The Five Forms

1. The dispute over inheritance or family property. The most common form globally, and the most destructive to families. Its typical features: an intestate

estate or an estate whose distribution was never formalised; a brother who takes possession of a property, a plot, or a business; the use of a position of trust — the executor, the eldest, the brother who lives closest, the brother who holds the documents — to acquire an advantage; the circulation of a competing account within the family; and a dispute that lasts years and that is frequently concluded without any settlement at all.

The specific loss for the man is threefold: the material; the relationship with the brother; and, most significantly, the family's structure, since the dispute frequently divides subsequent generations, who inherit the enmity without having participated in the cause.

2. The refusal of assistance at a moment of obligation. A brother who does not contribute to a parent's care, a funeral, a sibling's medical costs, or a family obligation, while retaining the standing that the family's arrangements confer. The material is the whole of Chapter 20 in a family setting: the man who carries the obligation while the brother who does not appears at the ceremony.

3. The alliance against the man. A brother who supports an account of the man that is being circulated in the family; who supplies family information to an adversary in a dispute; who takes the side of a relative against the man in the expectation of an advantage; or who participates in the exclusion described in Section 16.4.

4. The pursuit of the man's interest. As in friendship, and frequently in a form that is not available to a friend: the brother who takes a position in a family business without the man's knowledge, who obtains a property that the man had been negotiating for, who makes an approach to the man's wife's family, or who succeeds to a relationship within the family that the man had relied upon.

5. The disclosure of the man's history. The brother holds a set of information that nobody else holds: the family's arrangements, the man's childhood, his early failures, and frequently his confidences. Its disclosure to the family, to the wife's family, or to the community is a betrayal of a different weight from the friend's, because the material is deeper and the audience more consequential.

The Specific Difficulties of a Fraternal Betrayal

The relationship cannot be ended by the man's decision. A friend can be left; a brother is present at every family occasion, in every family decision, and in the family's records. The man's options are limited to the forms described in Chapter 16.5 — revised terms, a boundary with contact, and estrangement within a family he continues to belong to.

The community does not recognise the injury. Family disputes are frequently treated as ordinary, and the man who loses a case of family property is frequently advised to accept the position for the sake of peace. The advice is

frequently correct in its practical consequence and it removes the man's permission to grieve.

The man is frequently required to be the party who concedes. Where the man is the elder, the more capable, or the more solvent, the family's expectation is that he will absorb the cost, and the expectation is frequently applied by the very relatives who have assessed the dispute.

The material is frequently never resolved. Unlike the friendship, which ends, a family dispute can continue for decades, conducted in the family's occasions and in the conduct of the next generation. The practical work of this section is therefore not the resolution of the dispute but the arrangement by which the man continues to function inside an unresolved situation.

The Practical Handling

Establish the facts and the documents. The single most useful action, and the one most frequently omitted. Where a family matter is in dispute, the man should obtain: the will or the applicable customary position, the title documents, the bank records, the correspondence, and a written account of the family's decisions with dates. The records convert the dispute from a contest of accounts into a matter of fact, and they are frequently the instrument by which an allocation is corrected, as the case in Section 16.7 illustrates.

Bring the matter to a body rather than to the family's conversations. The available bodies: the family's own council, if it has a procedure; the customary authority, where applicable; a mediation service; the relevant government agency for property and title matters; and the courts, where the material justifies it. The practical finding from men's accounts is that a matter taken to a competent body, even where the outcome is partial, is substantially less damaging than the same matter conducted indefinitely in the family's conversations.

State the position once and then continue to appear. The pattern established in Chapter 16.5. The man's most effective response to a fraternal betrayal is presence: he continues to attend, to contribute at the level available to him, and to treat the brother with ordinary courtesy. The conduct is what alters the family's assessment, and it does so over years rather than months.

Decide the boundary explicitly. The available positions, in ascending order: ordinary contact with no cooperation on the disputed matter; ordinary contact with no dependence on the brother in any matter; the reduction of contact to the family's obligatory occasions; and estrangement. The choice should be made in writing, should be based on the assessment rather than on the man's immediate state, and should be reviewed annually.

Protect the next generation. The most consequential measure, and the one that determines whether the dispute outlives the participants. The rule: the

man does not transmit his account of the brother to the children, and he does not use them as messengers or allies. Where the children observe the dispute, the explanation should be factual and brief: this is a disagreement about property between adults, and it does not change anything about your relationship with your cousins.

26.4 The Anatomy of a Betrayed Friendship

This section describes the course of a betrayed friendship, because the men who navigate it well do so by identifying the stage they are in and taking the appropriate action at each.

The Six Stages

Stage One: The act. The disclosure, the pursuit, the failure of assistance, the financial loss. The man's immediate response is frequently disbelief, which is a defence: the material is inconsistent with the model of the relationship he held.

Stage Two: The discovery's management. The man decides, generally within days, what to do with the information. The options are the confrontation, the silent reduction of the relationship, or the attempt to continue as though the act had not occurred. The last of these is the most common and it is the most expensive, because it maintains the relationship while transferring the man's trust investment into a private account of resentment — the ledger described in Chapters 15, 17, and 20.

Stage Three: The confrontation, where it occurs. Two forms. The direct account — what the man knows, what it has cost him, and what he intends — which is effective and difficult; and the indirect account, comprising the general remark, the pointed observation, and the withdrawal, which is ineffective and produces a period of mutual manoeuvring. Men should note that the direct form does not require the friend's agreement; it requires the man to have stated the position, which is the same standard as in Chapters 20 and 25.

Stage Four: The assessment of the relationship. The stage most frequently omitted, and the one that determines the outcome. The questions: which term of the relationship was relied upon and was not held; was the failure a decision or an incapacity; is the conduct capable of change; is the relationship worth the revised terms; and what would the man require in order to continue? The questions are answered in writing, and the answers determine whether the outcome is repair, revision, or conclusion.

Stage Five: The outcome. Three possibilities. **Repair**, where the friend has acknowledged the act and the terms have been restated — a legitimate outcome, and the one that requires the most work from both parties. **Revision**, where the relationship continues on reduced terms: the friendship without the confidences, the association without the financial arrangements, the group without

the reliance. **Conclusion**, where the relationship ends, either formally or by the ordinary lapse that follows a deliberate reduction of contact.

Stage Six: The consolidation. The stage in which the man's understanding of the event is fixed, and the stage at which the lessons are drawn. Section 26.5 addresses it directly, because the outcome of this stage determines whether the man's capacity to trust other men is preserved or reduced.

26.5 What Betrayal Taught You: Lessons Without Bitterness

The final substantive section is the one that determines the man's arrangements for the remainder of his life. Its subject is the conversion of the experience into usable knowledge, without the conversion of the man into somebody who cannot rely on anybody.

The Wrong Lesson and the Right One

The wrong lesson is the general proposition: *men cannot be relied upon; I am better off alone; I will not give anybody that position again.* The proposition is false — the same men who betray also assist, and the evidence for reliability is available in the man's own history — and its cost is exact: it removes the arrangements that the research associates most strongly with men's resilience, and it produces the condition described in Chapter 27.

The right lesson is specific and technical, and it consists of four findings.

1. Which term I relied upon without agreeing it. The man's contribution to the outcome, stated without self-blame: he assumed a term that the other party did not hold. The finding converts the event from a general statement about trust into a matter of procedure.

2. What the evidence was, and when it was available. The man identifies the signals that were present before the act — the previous breach, the pattern in the friend's other relationships, the reluctance to be accountable, the accommodation that the man had made and not raised — and the time at which they became visible. The finding supplies the man's capacity to read such signals in future, and it should be conducted without the hindsight bias described in Chapter 16.5.

3. What the arrangement should have included. The practical correction: the documentation of a financial arrangement, the disclosure of the material to one other person, the test of a small reliance before a large one, the stated term. The finding is the substance of Section 26.6.

4. What remains true about men. The man should conduct this finding deliberately, because the previous three findings leave it open. The material: the men who have kept faith, the assistance that has arrived without being asked for, the relationships that have held through difficulty. Men who complete this finding

report that the list is longer than they expected, and that its construction is the mechanism by which the general conclusion is avoided.

The Three Rules of Revised Reliance

Rule One: grade the reliance to the demonstrated record. A man's trust should be extended in proportion to what the other person has demonstrated, in the domain in question, over time. The rule is not cynicism; it is the ordinary practice of every professional arrangement and it is applied in ordinary relationships more often than men acknowledge. Its application requires the man to ask, before a substantial reliance, what the person has demonstrated in that specific domain.

Rule Two: state the terms of any material arrangement. Where the friendship involves money, business, property, a position, or a confidence of consequence, the terms should be stated and, where the material justifies it, written. The rule is frequently resisted on the grounds that stating terms implies distrust; the evidence from men who have adopted it is that the statement of terms is the mechanism by which friendships survive material arrangements, and that the arrangements conducted without terms are the ones that end.

Rule Three: maintain more than one confidant, and more than one source of assistance. The concentration described in Section 26.1 is the structural vulnerability. The rule: a minimum of two men with whom the man's actual position is known, and a practical network of more than one person for each kind of assistance the man requires. The rule's function is to remove the single point of failure, and its adoption is the single most effective protection against the severity of the losses described in this chapter.

The Question of Forgiveness, in the Friendship Context

The material in Section 16.5 applies, with two specifications.

Forgiveness does not require the resumption of the reliance. A man may release the account and continue the relationship on reduced terms, and this is the most common outcome among men who have handled the situation well. The reduction is not a failure of forgiveness; it is the accurate consequence of the other person's demonstrated record.

The forgiveness, where it occurs, is frequently delayed and frequently arrives without the man's noticing. Men describe the process in the same terms across cases: the material occupies the mind continuously for a period measured in months; its incidence reduces; a year or two later the man encounters the friend at an occasion and finds that the account has closed without a decision having been taken. The description is worth recording because it indicates that the outcome requires the practical steps rather than a decision about the past.

26.6 Choosing Better Men: Discerning Friendship

The final section converts the chapter into an instrument: the construction of a set of friendships that will hold, and the selection of the men to build them with.

The Discerning Criteria

Six criteria, drawn from the accounts of men whose friendships have held over decades. They are properties rather than characteristics, which is to say that they can be observed rather than inferred.

1. How the man speaks about people who are not present. The most reliable single indicator. A man who speaks of his wife, his colleagues, and his friends with contempt in their absence will do so about any man in the group, including the reader. The criterion is applied to the man rather than to the conversation, and its predictive record in men's accounts is high.

2. How the man behaves when he has an advantage. Whether he takes the opportunity, shares it, or mentions it. The conduct in small advantages predicts the conduct in large ones, and the criterion can be observed by the man in a relationship of some months' duration.

3. The treatment of people who can do nothing for him. The staff, the subordinate, the relative with no resources. This is the criterion most frequently identified by men who have been betrayed, in retrospect, and it is the one that is most easily observed from the beginning of a friendship.

4. The handling of a small confidence. Whether the man keeps an ordinary piece of information that was given to him without consequence. The test is available early, it is inexpensive, and its result is informative. The grading principle of Section 26.5 — extend the reliance in proportion to the record — requires exactly this kind of test before a substantial reliance.

5. Whether the terms can be discussed. A man who can discuss the terms of an arrangement — the repayment, the contribution, the boundaries, the expectations — without discomfort is a man with whom material arrangements are possible. A man who becomes uncomfortable at the discussion of terms will not be reliable in the arrangement, and the discomfort is frequently the signal that the man treats the friendship as a licence.

6. Behaviour in a difficulty of the man's own. The criterion that carries the greatest weight and that is tested least often, because it is the one that requires the friend to have an opportunity. Its observation is therefore frequently a consequence of the crisis rather than the preparation for it, which is the reason that Section 26.5's Rule Three — more than one confidant — is the practical protection.

The Construction

Four measures for building the arrangements, and the specific form matters.

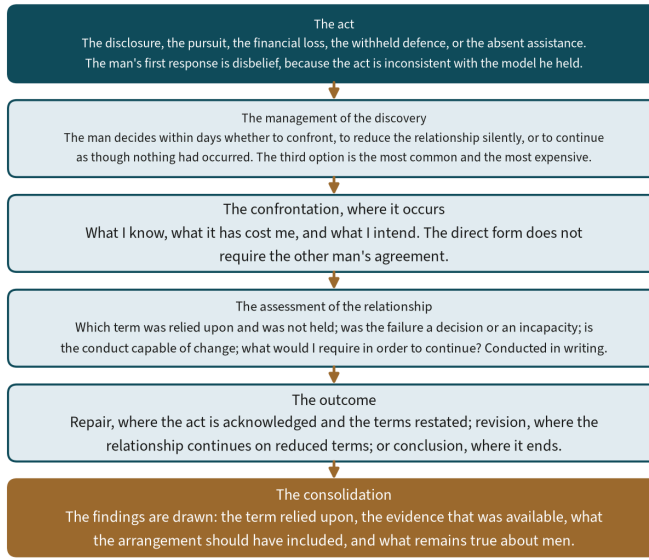
Reinstate one relationship from before the man's obligations consumed his time. Chapter 4's method: two men contacted, one arrangement proposed, a fixed form. Men report that the reinstatement is frequently easier than expected, because the lapse was mutual and because men are generally pleased to be contacted.

Add one group. A group of men with an agreed rule of honesty: a discussion group, a professional association, a group of fathers, a men's group meeting for a defined purpose. The group's function is to supply the membership and disclosure functions at once, and it removes the concentration that Section 26.1 identified.

Test the terms in one relationship. Choose one friendship and state a term explicitly: the arrangement for the money, the boundary concerning the household, the requirement of confidence. The exercise is uncomfortable and its result is informative, and men generally report that the response was better than anticipated.

Establish one arrangement that will hold after a crisis. The practical test of any friendship is whether it contains an arrangement that would operate in a difficulty. Men should identify, for each of their principal friendships, what the friend would actually do if the man were hospitalised for three months, and whether the answer has ever been discussed. Where the answer is unexamined in every relationship, the vulnerability described in Section 26.2's third form remains unaddressed.

Figure 26.1 sets out the anatomy of a betrayed friendship as a sequence, with the intervention available at each stage. The diagram is illustrative and generalised; the sequence differs between cases, and the purpose of setting it out is to identify that the outcome is determined at Stage Four, where the assessment of the relationship is made, rather than at the act itself.



The outcome is determined at the stage of assessment, not at the act. Men who omit that stage move directly from the act to a general conclusion about trust.

Figure 26.1 The anatomy of a betrayed friendship. The left-hand column describes the stages; the right-hand column identifies the available intervention at each. The outcome is determined by the assessment conducted at Stage Four, not by the act.

26.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Men and the Contract

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in business practice, mediation, and counselling.

Segun and Bayo are cousins and business partners, aged forty-nine and forty-seven, who operated a building-materials supply business for eleven years in a state capital.

The business began in Segun's house in 2009, with Segun contributing the initial capital from a gratuity and Bayo contributing the relationships, being the son-in-law of a man who had traded in materials for thirty years. Their arrangement was verbal: Segun held the capital, managed the accounts, and controlled the bank mandate; Bayo managed the customers, the suppliers, and the relationships; the profits were shared equally; and neither drew a salary.

The business grew from a single shop to three shops and a yard, and by 2016 it was supplying three construction companies under annual arrangements. Its turnover at that point was approximately fourteen times the initial capital.

The events that produced the case occupied about two years and consisted of a sequence of four matters.

The first matter was the introduction of Bayo's younger brother, Tunde, as a staff member in 2014: a salaried position managing the yard, with no ownership. Segun agreed to the appointment without a discussion of its implications.

The second matter was a contract with a construction company introduced by Bayo in 2016, requiring the business to extend credit of a sum equal to about half the business's capital for a period of four months. Segun agreed, on Bayo's assurance of the customer's reliability, and the necessary funds were obtained by Segun's personal guarantee at a bank.

The third matter was the customer's default, at the end of 2016, on approximately two-thirds of the credit extended. Segun's personal guarantee was called upon in the first quarter of 2017, and he met it from the sale of a plot of land.

The fourth matter was the discovery, in the second quarter of 2017, that Bayo had, over the previous two years, established a parallel supply arrangement in his own name with two of the business's customers, using the business's supplier relationships, at a volume of approximately a fifth of the business's turnover. The arrangement had accommodated the credit extension of 2016 by directing the business's cash to the parallel supply at the point when the customer's payments were delayed.

Segun's account of the discovery has three parts that are typical of the cases in this section.

First, he did not confront Bayo directly. He reduced his involvement over the following four months, attended the business less frequently, and ceased to raise the matters that required discussion. In his description: *I did not want the family to know, and I did not have it written anywhere, so I would have been the one accusing my cousin of something I could not prove.*

Second, he conducted the matter privately, drawing up his own records of the business, the bank payments, and the customer's default, and, at the same time, constructing a larger private account: the introduction of Tunde, which he now regarded as the beginning of the diversion; the nineteen years of relationship; the land that had been sold; and his own conclusion that he had been *the one who supplied the money and the premises while Bayo did the business*.

Third, the family became involved, and not by Segun's decision. In the third quarter of 2017, Bayo's parallel arrangement became known within the family through a supplier, and Segun's position was characterised in the family's discussion as one of two partners in a failed arrangement rather than as the party who had lost his land to Bayo's contract.

The intervention, which occurred through a mediation service after Segun's wife insisted on seeking professional advice, consisted of four elements.

The mediator required, as a first step, the production of the business's records: the bank statements, the contracts, the customer accounts, and the correspondence. The records established the four matters set out above with precision, and Segun's own account of the effect is instructive: *The day we put the papers on the table, I stopped*

being a man with a grievance. There were eleven pages and the papers said what had happened.

The second element was the disclosure to the family, conducted jointly by Segun and Bayo before the family's council, with the records presented. The established facts were: the parallel arrangement, the diversion of cash, the personal guarantee that Segun had met from the sale of his plot, and the written valuation of Bayo's parallel turnover. The council's finding, which the mediator had anticipated, was not a moral one: the parallel arrangement had used the business's supplier relationships, and the value was quantifiable.

The third element was the settlement, which consisted of: the transfer of Bayo's interest in the two new shops to Segun; the cessation of the parallel arrangement and the transfer of the two customers to the business; the repayment by Bayo of a sum equivalent to two-thirds of the land's value, in instalments over twenty-four months; the confirmation of the salaries and roles of Tunde; and the writing of a partnership agreement containing the terms that had never existed, including the treatment of related-party transactions, the requirement of joint authorisation above a defined value, the accounts procedure, and the exit provisions.

The fourth element concerned the family rather than the business, and it was the element that Segun identified as the most difficult. The family's council required, as part of the settlement, a stated position: that the dispute was concluded, that neither party would circulate it further, that the children of both households would not be involved, and that both men would attend the family's occasions. Segun described his acceptance of that element as the most difficult decision of his life and described its effect, three years later, as the reason his children still knew their cousins.

Segun's summary, three years after the settlement, was: *I lost a friend and I did not lose a cousin, and I am not sure which of those sentences I mean. The lesson I took was not that men cannot be trusted. It was that I had run a business for eleven years on an agreement that existed only in my own head, and that I had called that friendship. The papers would have protected both of us.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The agreement existed only in the men's understanding, and each man's understanding differed. Eleven years of business on a verbal arrangement with no terms concerning related-party transactions, joint authorisation, accounts, or exit. This is the failure of arrangements described in Section 26.5′s Rule Two, and the case is included because the form is extremely common: the materially successful partnership conducted without terms, whose dissolution is attributed to the other party's character rather than to the absence of an agreement.

The man accommodated rather than raising the matter, and the accommodation accumulated. The appointment of Tunde, the credit extension accepted on assurance, the delayed payments, and the reduced contributions were each accepted in the name of the relationship. The material of Chapters 15 and

20 applies: the undisclosed account was the substance of what he eventually lost, and the man's own conduct contributed to the arrangement that made the loss possible.

The records converted the matter from an accusation into a case. This is the finding of Sections 16.7 and 26.3 reproduced: eleven pages of statement and contract, after which the man's position was established and no longer dependent on his account of it. The men who settle family and partnership disputes most effectively are overwhelmingly those who obtain the documents.

The family's council produced a conclusion that a court would not have produced. Bayo was found to have used the business's relationships and was required to compensate; Segun received the shops and the customers; the partnership was provided with written terms; and the family was required to conclude the matter and to protect the next generation. The case is included as an illustration of the power of a competent family or community body in matters where the parties must continue to live in relationship, which courts handle poorly and which this kind of body handles well.

The outcome was a settlement that preserved both the material position and the family structure, and the man's grief was not thereby resolved. Segun's final statement is deliberately included: the arrangement was concluded, the family held, and the friendship was lost. Both outcomes were present at once, and the case is included because the expectation that a settlement produces a resolution of the emotional material is inaccurate and produces a further disappointment.

26.8 Practical Exercise: The Friendship Audit and the Rebuilding Plan

This exercise takes about two hours, in three sittings, and it is conducted in writing.

Part One: The Audit of Arrangements (Sitting One)

List your friendships of more than three years' standing, and assess each against the four functions from Section 26.1.

The friend	Company and activity	Practical assistance	Standing and membership	Disclosure

Then answer five questions.

- How many friendships supply the disclosure function? (The number is frequently zero or one, and the finding is the exercise's purpose.)

- For each friendship, which of the six unstated terms do I rely upon: confidence, non-predation, reciprocity of effort, defence in absence, assistance in crisis, silence about my failures?
- Which of those terms has ever been discussed with the friend?
- If I were hospitalised for three months, what would each of these men actually do — and how do I know?
- What proportion of my support is supplied by one person?

Part Two: The Betrayal Analysis (Sitting Two)

For the most significant betrayal by a friend or a brother in your life, complete the following.

- **The act, stated factually.** What occurred, when, and what it cost.
- **Which term** of the relationship was relied upon and not held.
- **The evidence that was available, and when.** What signals were present before the act? At what point did they become visible?
- **What the arrangement should have included.** The document, the statement of terms, the test, the disclosure to a third person.
- **What remains true about men.** List, specifically, the men who have kept faith, the assistance that arrived unrequested, and the relationships that have held. The list must be written, and it must be specific; the exercise is not complete without it.

Then complete the four findings from Section 26.5 in your own words, and write the wrong lesson down explicitly — *men cannot be relied upon; I am better off alone* — so that it can be examined rather than operated.

Part Three: The Rebuilding Plan (Sitting Three)

The reinstatement. One relationship from before your obligations consumed your time.

The man	The arrangement I will propose	The date

The group. One group of men with an agreed rule of honesty, or one professional association in which you are a member rather than a name on a list.

The group	How to join, or when I last attended	The date

The test of terms. One friendship in which you will state a term explicitly.

- The friend:
- The term:
- What I will say, in one sentence:

- The date:

The crisis arrangement. For one friendship, discuss and agree what would actually occur if you were incapacitated for three months. Record what was agreed.

Part Four: The Discerning Criteria

Apply the six criteria from Section 26.6 to two men you are considering admitting to a closer position in your arrangements. Record the evidence for each, not the impression.

Criterion	Man A	Man B
How he speaks about people who are absent		
His behaviour when he has an advantage		
His treatment of people who can do nothing for him		
His handling of a small confidence		
Whether terms can be discussed with him		
His behaviour in a difficulty of his own		

26.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it not weakness to be affected by the loss of a friend?"

The loss of a friendship is a loss of the same kind as the losses in Chapter 13, and its effects on men's health and functioning are documented. What is missing is the social permission to treat it as such, and the absence of permission is a defect of the environment rather than of the man. The exercise in Part Two is designed to permit the acknowledgement, which is the condition of the work.

"I have known him for thirty years. How do I reduce the relationship without a war?"

By reducing the reliance rather than the relationship, which is the option that men most frequently overlook. The friendship can continue — the meetings, the occasions, the ordinary contact — while the confidences, the financial arrangements, the business involvement, and the dependence are removed. The reduction requires no announcement, and men report that the arrangement is sustainable for years, provided that the man does not simultaneously continue to extend the reliance.

"Should I confront him?"

Where the material is significant and the relationship matters, yes, and in the direct form from Stage Three: what I know, what it has cost me, and what I intend. The confrontation does not require his agreement and should not seek it. Where the material is a confidence breached or a defence withheld, the direct conversation is difficult and the alternative — silence plus withdrawal — produces the resentful ledger described in Section 26.4.

"The dispute is with my brother, and it is over our father's property. Where do I begin?"

With the documents, as the case in Section 26.7 illustrates: the will or the customary position, the title, the records, and a written account of the family's decisions. Then with the appropriate body rather than with the family's conversations. Then with the decision about the relationship, made in writing and reviewed annually. And throughout, with the protection of the next generation, which is the measure that determines whether the matter outlives you.

"I have been betrayed twice by different men. Is the problem me?"

Possibly, in the specific and useful sense that the selection is the man's own: the criteria in Section 26.6 are applied at the point of the decision, and a man who has twice extended a substantial reliance without a test of the small ones has not applied them. The finding is not a verdict on the man's character; it is an instruction about procedure, and the procedure — graded reliance, stated terms, more than one confidant — is available immediately.

"How long does this take?"

The practical work in this chapter is conducted over months: the audit in a fortnight, the disclosure or confrontation within the first month, the rebuilding plan over six months. The emotional material follows the practical work and requires one to three years, and the men who report the outcome consistently describe it in the terms given in Section 26.5: the incidence reduces, the man encounters the friend at an occasion, and the account has closed without his noticing.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 26 in brief. Male friendship supplies four functions — company and activity, practical assistance, standing and membership, and disclosure — and it operates on six unstated terms: confidence, non-predation, reciprocity of effort, defence in absence, assistance in crisis, and silence about the man's failures. Men place a large weight on a small number of relationships, the reliance is practical as well as emotional, and it is entirely unexamined, which is why a betrayal is frequently the discovery that the two parties held different terms rather than the discovery of a wicked act.

Betrayal by a friend takes six forms: the disclosure of a confidence, which damages the man's safety and frequently his standing and is invisible in its effects; the pursuit of the man's interest, which is deniable and which damages the man's model of his own judgement; the failure of assistance in crisis, which frequently involves no decision and is produced by the friend's own incapacity and subsequent guilt; the financial betrayal, which is preceded by accommodations the man performed in the name of the friendship; the failure of defence in absence, which arrives through a third party and is resolved by silent reduction; and the accumulated betrayal, which

cannot be stated as an accusation and which produces the general conclusion about trust.

Fraternal betrayal has five forms — the dispute over inheritance or property, the refusal of assistance at a point of obligation, the alliance against the man, the pursuit of his interest, and the disclosure of his history — and four specific difficulties: the relationship cannot be ended by the man's decision, the community does not recognise the injury, the man is frequently required to be the party who concedes, and the matter is frequently never resolved. Its handling is the establishment of the facts and the documents, the bringing of the matter to a body rather than to the family's conversations, the statement of the position once followed by continued presence, an explicit boundary reviewed annually, and the protection of the next generation.

A betrayed friendship passes through six stages: the act; the management of the discovery, in which the most common and most expensive option is to continue as though nothing had occurred; the confrontation, which should take the direct form and which does not require the other party's agreement; the assessment of the relationship, which is the stage that determines the outcome and is most frequently omitted; the outcome, which is repair, revision, or conclusion; and the consolidation, in which the man's understanding is fixed and the lessons are drawn.

The wrong lesson is that men cannot be relied upon; its cost is the removal of the arrangements that most protect men's resilience, and it produces the condition described in Chapter 27. The right lesson consists of four findings: the term that was relied upon without being agreed, the evidence that was available and when, what the arrangement should have included, and what remains true about men. Revised reliance operates on three rules: grade the reliance to the demonstrated record, state the terms of any material arrangement, and maintain more than one confidant and more than one source of assistance. Discerning friendship applies six observable criteria, and the construction of durable arrangements involves reinstating one relationship, adding one group, testing the terms in one friendship, and establishing one arrangement that would operate in a crisis.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete Part One. How many of your friendships supply the disclosure function, and how much of your support is supplied by one person?
2. For your closest friendships, which of the six unstated terms do you rely upon — and which has ever been discussed?
3. What was the term your most significant betrayal failed to hold, and what was your own contribution to the arrangement that made it possible?
4. Write down the wrong lesson explicitly. Where has it operated in your decisions in the last two years?
5. Complete the fourth finding: what remains true about men? Write the specific list, with names and events.

6. Which of the three rules of revised reliance do you currently violate — grading the reliance, stating the terms, or maintaining more than one confidant?
7. Which relationship will you reinstate, which group will you join, and which term will you state — and what are the three dates?

Further Reading

- **On men's friendships:** the research literature on male friendship, including the findings on the smaller number and lower intimacy of men's friendships compared with women's, and the evidence on the functions that male friendships serve.
- **On social support and mortality:** the substantial literature associating social connection with mortality and health outcomes, including the consistent finding that men with fewer close relationships face elevated risks.
- **On trust and its violation:** the literature on trust within dyadic relationships, including the findings on the difficulty of repairing integrity-based violations, and the research on how trust is built by graduated reciprocal exchange.
- **On sibling and family conflict:** the research on sibling relationships in adulthood, including the findings on conflict over inheritance and family property, the effects on family structure and on subsequent generations, and the evidence on mediation and on family councils.
- **On mediation:** the practical literature on mediation in family, community, and business disputes, including the evidence on its effectiveness where the parties must maintain a continuing relationship, and the material on the form of mediated settlements.
- **Practical resources:** mediation services for family and commercial disputes; legal advice on property, succession, and partnership matters, obtained early; men's groups with an agreed rule of honesty; and the material in Appendices J and O.

27 CHAPTER

The Man with Nobody to Call

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Recognise the forms that isolation takes in men's lives, including the forms that are concealed by activity, position, and marriage.
2. Identify the processes by which men arrive at a position in which nobody can be called, and trace their own course through them.
3. Explain the documented consequences of isolation for men's health, behaviour, and judgement, including the mechanism by which isolation damages decision-making.
4. Analyse the internal barriers that prevent a man from reaching out, and distinguish between the barriers that reflect the environment and those that reflect his own arrangements.
5. Apply a staged method for building a support network from a position of having none, including the first step, which is the one that stops most men.
6. Use the exercise at the end of this chapter to identify the person he would call, and to establish the arrangement.

Introduction

This chapter is about the position the book has been approaching since its first page, and the one that men describe to practitioners in almost identical terms: *There is nobody I can call.*

The sentence is not an account of loneliness in the ordinary sense. Men in this position frequently have wives, children, colleagues, employees, and acquaintances; they attend occasions; they are known in their communities and their names are on lists. The sentence describes a specific absence: there is no person to whom the man may deliver the material described in Parts I to VI of this book — the failure, the fear, the shame, the accumulated account, the conclusion he has reached about himself — without a permanent cost.

The absence is not a private matter. Its consequences are substantially documented. Men with few close relationships have higher mortality, worse recovery from illness, higher rates of depression, and higher rates of suicide; the effect is comparable in magnitude to well-known risks that receive far more public attention. Isolation also damages judgement, which is documented and less well known: a man who has nobody with whom to think a matter through makes decisions from a single perspective, and the decisions made in isolation are characterised by exactly the features this book has repeatedly described: the large irreversible commitment, the concealment, the adjustment that is never revisited, and the conclusion formed in the absence of challenge.

The chapter's approach has four commitments.

The first is to describe the positions accurately, including the concealments. A large proportion of men who have nobody to call do not know that they have nobody to call, because the fact is concealed by the activity of their lives. The description in Section 27.1 therefore distinguishes the forms.

The second is to take the internal barriers seriously, without treating them as the whole problem. Men who cannot reach out generally have reasons, and the reasons frequently concern concrete harm: what will be said, who will learn, what it will cost at work, what his wife will conclude, what his children will see. These are addressed directly rather than dismissed.

The third is to supply a practical construction. The chapter does not ask a man who has nobody to call to obtain support by an act of will; it supplies a sequence, with an entry point, and it is designed for a man who is unwilling or unable to talk about himself at the present time and who is not persuaded that talking would help.

The fourth is the book's central proposition in its final form: a man can carry the responsibilities described in Parts II to VI without being required to carry them alone, and the requirement to carry them alone is not a law of nature but an arrangement, and arrangements can be altered.

27.1 The Forms Isolation Takes in Men's Lives

Isolation is not a single condition. Six forms are common among men, and each has a different cause, a different outward appearance, and a different route out.

Form One: The Man Who Was Never Asked

The first form, and the most straightforward. The man grew up in circumstances in which no adult attended to his difficulties: the household was occupied, the father was absent or harsh, the mother was managing an environment of scarcity, and the difficulties of childhood were managed privately. He acquired no experience of being attended to, and he therefore has no expectation of it.

Appearance: composed, self-reliant, frequently competent, and unable to identify anything missing. He will tell an interviewer that he is fine and that he does not need to discuss anything.

Route: the earliest and smallest available arrangement, and the requirement that the first attempt be described as experimental rather than as the man's actual position. Section 27.5′s staged method is designed for this form.

Form Two: The Man Whose Arrangements Were Removed

The man had arrangements, and they were removed: by bereavement, by divorce or separation, by migration, by retirement, by redundancy, by the departure of the children, by illness, or by the ending of a friendship. This is the form the first section of the chapter has most in common with Chapter 24′s material: the man's network was substantially carried by one or two relationships, and circumstance removed them.

Appearance: frequently active and capable, and frequently unaware of the size of what was lost, because the arrangement was never counted. The discovery frequently occurs at a specific moment: the day of a diagnosis, a difficulty with a child, an emergency at night, when the man reaches for the telephone and finds that there is nobody to call.

Route: the reconstruction of arrangements, and the specific finding in Chapter 24′s material: the identity-based material must be addressed first, because the man is frequently too reduced by the loss to initiate arrangements.

Form Three: The Man Who Cannot Ask

The man has arrangements and uses none of them. He has friends, brothers, colleagues, and a wife; he knows that they would respond; and the requirement that he ask is one he cannot meet. The form is extremely common and it is the one whose failure rate is highest at the point of the first act.

Appearance: excellent networks, no utilisation, decline of the arrangements over time as the network becomes convinced that the man does not value them.

Route: the removal of the requirement that the first act be an act of asking. Section 27.5′s entry points are constructed for this form: an offer of assistance to somebody else, a practical request, an attendance. The form's route is described at greater length in Chapter 35.

Form Four: The Man Whose Isolation Is Arranged

A form that receives insufficient attention. The man's relationships are constrained by structure rather than by circumstance: the job that moves him every three years; the position from which friendships with subordinates are impossible; the marriage in which the man's own relationships have been the object of the wife's objection; the relocation to a new city; the care arrangement that occupies every hour; the shift pattern that removes the evenings. The man's isolation is a

consequence of good conduct in other roles, and he frequently does not identify it as a problem until the cost becomes visible.

Appearance: frequently a man of high performance and substantial responsibility, who attributes the absence of friendships to having no time, which is accurate.

Route: the deliberate construction of arrangements as a structural requirement rather than as a consequence. The specific finding from men's accounts: the arrangements must be scheduled, as any other requirement of the position is scheduled, and the man's excellent organisational capacities are applied to a task they are not ordinarily applied to.

Form Five: The Man Who Is Surrounded

The most concealed form. The man is in constant contact with people: family, staff, customers, congregants, patients, colleagues, and, in a substantial number of cases, an entire household that depends on him. He is spoken to all day. And the material of his own life has no recipient, because every available person is either dependent upon him, subordinate to him, the object of his responsibility, or an audience before which the material would cost him something.

Appearance: busy, connected, respected, exhausted, and frequently the last person in the room in whom anybody would suspect isolation.

Route: the identification of one person outside the man's responsibility, and this form's principal practical obstacle: the requirement that the person not be a dependent, a subordinate, or a member of the man's own household. Practitioners recommend, for this form, an arrangement that is explicit — a supervisory or peer relationship with a defined purpose — because the man's material requires a setting in which the discussion of it is the task rather than an act of disclosure.

Form Six: The Man Who Chose It

A minority position that must be distinguished, because it is frequently not a problem. Some men's isolation is deliberate and functioning: they have a small number of relationships, they are content, and their arrangements supply what they require. The distinguishing test is not the size of the network but its sufficiency, and the test is this: whether there is at least one person to whom the man could deliver the material in the event of a serious difficulty, and whether he would do so.

Where the answer to both is yes, the form is not a defect and should not be treated as one. Where the answer to the second is no, the man's arrangement will not hold under load, and the material in Chapter 35 applies.

KEY POINT

Isolation among men takes at least six forms, and only one of them looks like isolation. The man who was never asked, the man whose arrangements were removed, the man who cannot ask, the man whose isolation is arranged by his other obligations, the man who is surrounded by people who depend on him, and the man who chose it. The route out differs by form, and the first useful step is the identification of which form is operating.

27.2 How a Man Ends Up with Nobody to Call

The positions described in Section 27.1 are generally not chosen. They are produced by processes, and the processes are describable, which matters because a man who can identify the process operating in his life can interrupt it.

The Seven Processes

1. The narrowing produced by responsibility. The ordinary and most widespread process. A man's obligations expand: the job, the marriage, the children, the extended family, the community, the additional income, the second position. Each additional obligation consumes the time available for relationships, and the arrangements that are consumed first are those with no claimant. A man's friendships have no claimant; they will not send a reminder, incur a charge, or appear at the door. They are therefore the first item to be dropped and the last to be restored, and the process operates silently for two decades.

2. The migration and relocation process. Each move removes the arrangements that were in place and requires them to be rebuilt. Men frequently do not rebuild, for the reason given in the previous process and for a second reason: the arrangements at the destination require an introduction that the man does not have and a period of availability that his obligations do not allow. Men who have moved three times in a career frequently have substantial relationships in three cities and no functioning arrangements in the one where they live.

3. The status-change process. A change in a man's position removes relationships in a specific way: the promotion that makes friendships with former colleagues awkward; the loss of a position that removes the men with whom the man's days were spent; the wealth that changes the terms of relationships in a community where he grew up; the poverty that makes the man withdraw. In each case, the arrangement was carried by the shared circumstances and does not survive their change.

4. The grief and loss process. Bereavement, divorce, and the loss of a parent or a friend remove the men's principal arrangements. The specific feature in men's accounts is that this process is frequently accompanied by a second mechanism: the man's own withdrawal during the period of the loss, which converts the

temporary absence of arrangements into a permanent condition. The withdrawal is the material of Chapter 13, and the process is the reason that the material of that chapter addresses the network directly.

5. The household process. A man's arrangements are frequently carried, substantially, by his wife. She maintains the friendships with other couples, the family obligations, the community relationships, and the occasions at which the man's own relationships are sustained. Where the marriage ends, or where the wife dies, the arrangements are discovered to have been hers. This process is the most under-recognised in the material on men's isolation and it accounts for a substantial proportion of the isolation experienced by widowed and divorced men.

6. The concealment process. A man who has concealed material from his network over a period — the failure, the addiction, the loss of the position, the condition — discovers that the concealment removes the relationships themselves. He avoids the settings in which he would be asked, declines the occasions, and by the time the concealment is no longer necessary the arrangements have been dissolved. The process is the material of Chapters 9 and 16 combined, and it is the most insidious of the seven, because its operation is invisible to the man: he believes that he is protecting his position and he is dismantling it.

7. The conclusion process. The final process, and the one that operates after the others. A man who has been betrayed, dismissed, or disappointed arrives at a conclusion about other men — the wrong lesson described in Section 26.5 — and ceases to extend arrangements. The process then eliminates the participants rather than the relationships, and the man's isolation becomes a decision, which is why it is the most difficult process to reverse.

The Three Accelerants

Three factors accelerate any of the seven processes, and they are worth identifying separately.

Alcohol. The most significant. Alcohol supplies the function of company and disclosure in a form that requires no arrangement, and it therefore removes the requirement to build one. Men who drink in the evening with the group at the bar frequently have no other arrangements, and the finding from treatment practice is consistent: when the drinking is addressed, the absence of any relationship capable of receiving the man's actual position becomes visible, and its construction becomes a required part of the work.

Overwork. The respectable accelerant. Work supplies activity, purpose, standing, and the appearance of connection, and it consumes exactly the hours in which arrangements are made. A man can be in the presence of thirty people for sixty hours a week and have no arrangement at all.

Screens and the substitute arrangements. The digital forms supply a partial version of each of the four functions from Section 26.1 — the group chat supplies membership, the forum supplies company, and, in a minority of cases, genuineness. The substitute is generally real as far as it goes, and its specific effect is that it removes the pressure to construct arrangements where the material itself could be delivered. The finding is not that digital connection is worthless; it is that the man who has replaced face-to-face arrangements entirely with digital ones has removed the function that survives a crisis.

27.3 What Isolation Does to a Man

The consequences of isolation are documented, and this section sets them out because the material is the strongest available argument against the assumption that a man's isolation is a private preference that costs him nothing.

Health and Longevity

The research literature on social connection and mortality consistently finds that men with few social relationships face substantially elevated mortality risk, after accounting for other factors. The association is comparable in strength to well-established risk factors that receive far greater public attention, and the effect is larger in men than in women in most of the studies that report it.

Two mechanisms are documented.

Physiological. Social connection is associated with measurable differences in cardiovascular function, immune response, and stress hormone regulation. Isolated men carry higher physiological load, and the load is chronic.

Behavioural. Isolated men receive fewer prompts to attend to their health, present later with conditions, are less likely to be accompanied to appointments, receive less assistance with adherence to treatment and medication, and are more likely to continue a course of conduct that others would have interrupted. Men in treatment consistently identify this factor: somebody noticed.

Mental Health

The findings are consistent and strong: social isolation is associated with elevated rates of depression, anxiety, and suicide. Men are already at substantially higher risk of suicide than women despite lower reported rates of depression and of treatment seeking, and isolation is among the most consistently identified factors in the analysis of that gap. The mechanism described in this book applies directly: a man with nobody to call holds the material in private, and the material compounds in the manner described in Chapters 8, 9, and 21.

The Damage to Judgement

The least known consequence and, for the purposes of this book, the most important, because it explains why isolation damages men in the domain in which they most value their competence.

A man who has nobody with whom to think a matter through makes decisions from a single perspective, and the decisions have recognisable characteristics. The documented finding from the decision literature is that isolation produces risk-seeking in some domains and excessive caution in others, that it reduces the capacity for effective perspective-taking, and that it substantially increases the weight given to whatever framing the man has adopted.

Its practical forms in men's lives are the four described in this book's chapters.

The **large irreversible commitment** made without a second opinion: the guarantee signed for the friend, the business entered without documentation, the property purchased on an inside understanding, the investment made in a scheme that a colleague would have questioned in a single conversation.

The **concealment** continued beyond the point at which disclosure would have been affordable: the debt allowed to compound through the year in which it could have been declared, the condition allowed to develop through the period in which its management might have been simple.

The **adjustment** made in private and never revisited: the household expenditure reduced in a manner that the man's wife would have questioned, the retirement plan altered without any discussion, the decision to decline a position that a friend would have tested in ten minutes.

The **conclusion** formed without challenge: the conclusion that he is finished, that the betrayal proves what men are, that the business cannot be rescued, that his marriage is over. Men who have reached conclusions of this kind in isolation and who have then said them aloud in the presence of one person consistently report the same experience: the sentence, once spoken to somebody who takes it seriously, changes in the man's own hearing. The change is not produced by advice, and it is frequently not produced by disagreement. It is produced by the impression the sentence makes when it has to be stated to another person, and this is the smallest and most reliable benefit of the arrangement this chapter is asking men to build.

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

A composite account, constructed from patterns reported in practice. A man of fifty-three, a bank branch manager, described the two months in which he made the decision that altered his household's circumstances for a decade. His employer had offered him a position in another city at a cost in income and in his children's schooling, and the decision was required within three weeks.

> He described the three weeks in these terms: *I thought about it every night from eleven until two. I had all the numbers. I made a sheet. I decided to decline, and I declined it, and I told my wife after I had answered.*
> His account of the outcome, which he gave eight years later, was that the position had been the last opportunity of its kind, that the household's circumstances had never recovered from his remaining in a declining role, and that his wife learned of the offer a week after he had refused it.
> When asked what he would have done differently, he did not say that he would have accepted the position. He said: *I would have said it out loud to somebody who had nothing to gain. I have never been able to explain why I did not, and I have thought about it for eight years. There was nobody I could say it to. My wife would have had an interest in the answer. My colleagues were the office. My brother would have told my mother. I did not want to discuss it with my father because I did not want to tell him that I had an offer and might not take it. So I thought about it from eleven until two, for three weeks, and I decided.*

The account's significance for this chapter is not the decision, which may or may not have been the correct one on the facts. It is the description of the deliberation: three weeks of solitary nightly reasoning with a single framing, no perspective available, and the decision delivered as a completed fact. This is what isolation does to a man's judgement, and it is the reason that the arrangements in Section 27.5 are described in this book as a requirement of competence rather than as a matter of comfort.

27.4 What Stops a Man from Reaching Out

The barriers must be treated accurately, because a man who is told that he should reach out has generally already considered the question and has reasons. This section sets out the barriers in the order of their frequency in men's accounts, with the practical answer to each.

The Eight Barriers

1. *There is nothing to say.* Frequently accurate and frequently the expression of a specific inability: the man's difficulty does not take the form of a narrative he has practised. A difficulty that occupies the man continuously may have no sentences attached to it, which is why the man interprets his state as nothing to say rather than as difficulty in finding the words.

The answer: the opening does not have to concern the man's state. It may concern a shared activity, a practical matter, or a request for help with something else. The state is frequently delivered later, after the arrangement exists, and it arrives more easily in the middle of an activity than at the beginning of a conversation.

2. *It will be used against me.* The barrier with the most basis in the man's own history, and the one Chapter 26′s material addresses. It is frequently correct in its judgement of specific people and incorrect as a general rule.

The answer: the graded reliance of Section 26.5. The material is delivered in proportion to what the recipient has demonstrated, and the first delivery should be small. If the man requires a recipient with an obligation that is governed by rules rather than by goodwill, the professional route exists and is described in Section 27.5.

3. *It will cost me at work or in my position.* A real consideration in specific professional environments: the regulated profession, the senior position, the small community, the employer with a record on health matters.

The answer: the confidential professional route, and the separation of the professional identity from the personal difficulty. A general practitioner, an employee assistance programme where it exists, a private practitioner paid out of pocket, a practitioner in a neighbouring city, and, for the specific professions and conditions where it is required, the licensed route with its confidentiality obligations. The practical finding is that the men who bear the greatest risk from disclosure are the ones who most benefit from an arrangement whose confidentiality is a professional obligation rather than a favour.

4. *I will be a burden.* The barrier that men report most frequently in the framing of other people's interests, and the one that is most consistently unfounded in practice. The evidence from the people who are asked is clear: they do not experience the request in the terms the man anticipates.

The answer: the recognition that the other person's experience of being asked is generally positive, which the men who have reached out consistently report as their own finding. In addition: the request should be specific and bounded, and it should, where possible, be reciprocal. Men manage their concern about burdening others very effectively when the arrangement includes something that the man supplies in return.

5. *He has his own problems.* The barrier that reflects the man's accurate assessment of his friends' circumstances. Because men's networks are small, the man's two available contacts are frequently carrying their own substantial loads.

The answer: the reciprocal arrangement, and the finding that the two-way channel sustains the contact considerably better than the one-way. Men in groups with an agreed rule of honesty report this consistently: the arrangement holds because each man has something to bring as well as something to obtain.

6. *It will change how my household sees me.* The barrier with the most substantial basis, and the one that concerns the man's authority in his own home. The concern is that a man who discloses difficulty in the household's range will be repositioned within it.

The answer: this barrier governs the material delivered to the household and does not govern the material delivered to a person outside it. The requirement of Chapter 35′s material applies: a man may hold the household as one thing and one or two arrangements outside it as another. Where the material is an addiction, an addiction to a substance, or a behaviour with consequences for the household, the disclosure to the household becomes a requirement of the treatment, for the reason Chapter 23 sets out.

7. *I do not know who to call.* A practical barrier rather than a psychological one, and a very common one, particularly in Forms Three, Four, Five, and Six of Section 27.1.

The answer: Section 27.5. Where no name exists, the professional route is the entry point, and the entry point for a man who will not talk is the general practitioner's consultation, which requires only a physical complaint.

8. *It will not help.* The last barrier, and the one that frequently conceals the others. Its form is a prediction: *nothing changes; talking about it changes nothing; I know what I would be told; I have tried before.* The prediction is generally constructed from one or two experiences and it is applied generally.

The answer: the standard is not resolution but alteration, and the alteration is documented. The specific finding from men who have used the arrangements: the situation frequently does not change, and the man's capacity to carry it does. The finding is modest and it is entirely reliable, and it is the reason the arrangements in this chapter are described as functional rather than therapeutic.

The Barrier Behind the Barriers

Four barriers in the list — the second, the third, the fourth, and the sixth — are variations on one proposition: that the material, once delivered to another person, becomes a fact in the world and will have consequences. This is true, and it is the reason the graded approach in Section 27.5 matters: the arrangements are built by degrees, with each delivery small enough to be survived, and the man's confidence in the arrangement is built from the outcomes of the earlier deliveries rather than from an argument.

27.5 Building a Network from Nothing

This section sets out a staged method for a man who has no arrangement at present and who requires one. The stages are arranged so that each is available on the basis of the previous stage, and the first stage requires nothing of the man that he cannot supply on the day he reads it.

Stage One: The Identification of One Person

The identification is conducted in writing, and it uses four criteria. The person must be **available** — that is, reachable and still present in the man's life; **not**

dependent on the man, not subordinate to him, and not in his household; **not part of the material's audience** — not the relative who would circulate it, not the colleague in the same office; and **in possession of a record** of some reliability in his conduct.

The candidate list is generated by finding the answer to a single question: *who, over my adult life, has ever asked me a question that was not about my position or my usefulness?* The list is generally short. Where it is empty, Stage One's alternative is the professional route described at Stage Four.

Stage Two: The Contact Without the Material

The second stage requires the man to contact the person without delivering any material. The purpose is the restoration of the contact and the establishment of the arrangement; the material is not required and should be withheld.

The forms, in ascending order of difficulty. First, a message; not a letter and not a long message, but an ordinary contact with a reason: a greeting and a real question about the other person. Second, a telephone call of three to five minutes with a stated reason for ending it, which removes the requirement of an extended conversation. Third, a meeting for a practical purpose — to collect, to deliver, to attend something, to assist — which is the form men find easiest because the purpose supplies the structure.

The men who attempt Stage Two report, consistently, that the contact is received more positively than expected. This is the finding the chapter asks readers to accept provisionally until it is confirmed by the man's own experience.

Stage Three: The Reciprocal Arrangement

The third stage converts the contact into an arrangement, and the form is the offer of something rather than the request for it. The purpose is to establish a channel in which the man is a supplier as well as a recipient, which is the form that men's arrangements actually take when they hold.

The forms: an offer of specific practical assistance; a share of something real — the market information, a contact, a demand, a supplier, an opportunity; an arrangement for a recurring activity. The last of these is the most durable: the Saturday arrangement, the monthly meeting, the standing task. Men's friendships are carried by recurring arrangements far more than by conversation, and the recurring arrangement is the structure in which conversation eventually occurs without being sought.

Stage Four: The Delivery of Material

The fourth stage is the delivery of a small item of the man's actual material, and its purpose is not resolution. Its purpose is to establish that the channel will hold.

The rules for the first delivery. Keep it **small**: an ordinary difficulty, a concrete difficulty, or a difficulty that is already past. Keep it **specific**: not the man's general

state, but one event with dates and facts. Keep it **non-catastrophic**: the item should not require the recipient to take action, reconsider the man's character, or bear a burden. And keep the **principle**: the delivery establishes the channel and permits the full material to be delivered later, in the manner Chapter 4.6 describes — in the middle of an activity, without announcement, as an ordinary fact.

Where the first delivery goes badly, the man should recall that the outcome is information about that particular person, which is the finding of Section 26.5, and not a verdict on the arrangement generally.

Stage Five: The Professional Route

The professional route is an arrangement in the technical sense: a defined time, a defined fee or service, a specified confidentiality, and a purpose that the man does not have to construct. It has three advantages over the personal arrangement and one disadvantage.

The **advantages.** It is available today; it requires no existing relationship; its confidentiality is governed by an obligation rather than by a favour; it imposes no reciprocity; the man is not required to manage another person's concern; and the material can be delivered in full at the first meeting without any of the four barriers of Section 27.4 applying.

The **disadvantage.** It is not the arrangement that will be available at two in the morning, and the research on men's support consistently finds that professional relationships do not supply the functions that personal arrangements supply. The professional route is therefore the **entry point** and not the destination: it makes the delivery of the material possible today, and it supplies the platform from which the personal arrangements in Stages Two to Four are built. This sequence — professional first, personal arrangements built over the following months — is the route that men who have nobody to call most frequently take, and it should be stated plainly in the chapter.

Where to begin, for a man who will not talk: the general practitioner's appointment, which requires a physical complaint and supplies an opening. The practitioner's three questions — sleep, appetite, and how long this has been going on — are part of routine assessment, and the man who answers them honestly has already delivered material.

Stage Six: The Group

The final stage, and the one that supplies the arrangements that survive the loss of any individual person. A group of men with an agreed rule of honesty: a men's group, a professional association, a group with a defined purpose, a discussion group, a group of fathers. The group supplies the three functions that a single relationship cannot supply: membership and standing, the availability of more

than one man, and the correction of the man's own account by people whose positions differ from his.

The group's practical form matters, and the guidance from men's group practice is consistent: a defined purpose, a small number (five to nine), a fixed time, a rule of confidentiality, and a rule against advice-giving for the first twenty minutes of any man's material.

Figure 27.1 sets out the six stages of the construction, with the requirement of each and the specific obstacle at each stage. The diagram is generalised; the purpose of setting it out is to establish a route that begins with an action available to any man on the day he reads this chapter.

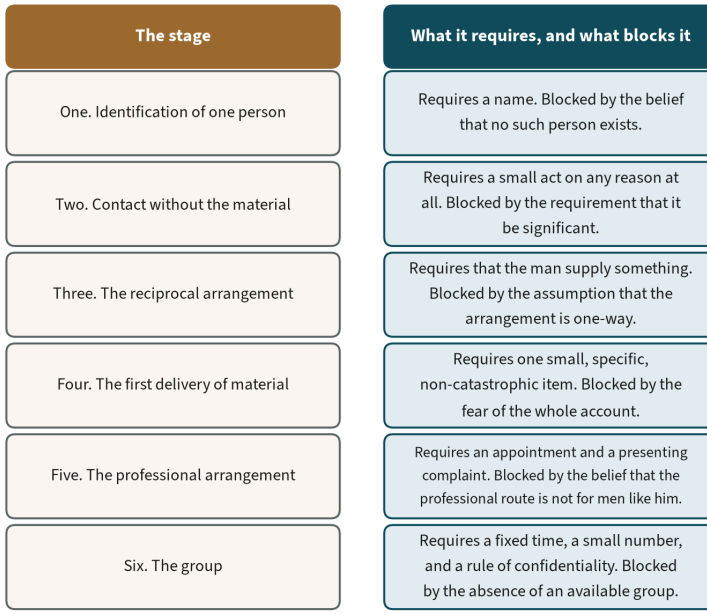


Figure 27.1 Building a support network from nothing. The left column gives the six stages in order; the right column identifies the requirement and the characteristic obstacle at each. Stage One requires only that one person be identified, and Stage Four is the first stage at which any material is delivered.

27.6 Illustrative Case: The Widower Who Had Nobody to Call

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in bereavement services, primary care, and men's group practice.

Musa is sixty-one, a retired vehicle mechanic, widowed for four years, with three adult children in three different cities.

Musa and his wife, Hauwa, married in 1988 and lived in the same town for thirty-four years. He operated a workshop with two apprentices; she was a teacher and, in the description her family gave, the person who knew everybody.

The pattern of the marriage was, in Musa's own account, this: *She had the house, the family, and the visits. I had the workshop and the boys. When there was a wedding or a naming, she told me where to go and what to wear. When somebody died, she told me what the family was doing. I did not have her friends and she did not have the workshop.*

Hauwa died in 2022 after a short illness. Musa's account of the following two years, which he gave in a primary care consultation and later in a men's group, had five stages.

The first was activity. For approximately seven months, Musa managed the funeral, the family's arrangements, and the estate, and he described this period as *full*: *Everybody was calling, the house was full, and I was the one who knew what to do.*

The second was the emptying. From about eight months, the calls reduced, the house became quiet, and the two apprentices left, one for a salaried position and one to start a business in another state. Musa's business had already been declining, and he retired formally in the following year. His account: *I sat in the parlour and I listened to the whole compound. By that time there was nothing to repair in the house and no reason to go out.*

The third was the discovery. Musa was unwell in the second year — a period of fever and severe headaches which he attributed to malaria and which did not resolve. His account of the discovery: *I was going to the hospital for three days and I had nobody to take me. My daughter in Abuja offered to come. I told her not to come. My son in Lagos sent money. I sat in the taxi on the third day and I asked myself who I would call if they told me it was serious. I went through everybody. I could not find anybody. I was very surprised. I had thought I was a man with a large family.*

The fourth was the concealment of the discovery. Musa told nobody about it, and described the following six months as the worst period of his life: *I did not want my children to think their father was a man who had nobody. They would have worried, and then they would have arranged things, and I would have been the old man they were arranging.* His sleep deteriorated, his appetite reduced, and he described a period in which he stopped leaving the house except for the market.

The fifth was the intervention, which occurred through his doctor. In the second consultation regarding his sleep, the general practitioner asked the four questions that constitute routine assessment in this area: whether he was eating, whether he was sleeping, how long the sleep had been affected, and whether he had anybody he spoke to. Musa's account of the fourth question: *He asked me if I had somebody I talked to. I told him I was fine. He wrote on the paper and he said, well, the question is on my form, and you have answered it, and he did not look at me while he said it. I sat there for a while and then I told him, and I am not sure why. I said, there is nobody to call. That was the sentence.*

The arrangements that followed consisted of four elements, and they were constructed in a deliberate order.

The first element was a defined professional arrangement: monthly consultations for a period of six months with a practitioner seen through the hospital, with the sleep addressed as a presenting problem. Musa's account: *The first month I did not say anything about the marriage. I talked about the sleeping. It was easier to go for the sleeping.*

The second element was the reinstatement of one friendship from before the marriage consumed his time: a man with whom he had worked in the same workshop in the 1990s and to whom he had not spoken in eleven years. The reinstatement was conducted by the man himself, on the practitioner's instruction, and Musa described it in these terms: *I called him about a spare part. I did not have a spare part to ask about; I looked up the name of a part and I called him. He talked for forty minutes and asked when I was coming. I said I would come in two weeks. I went. We sat in his shop.*

The third element was a men's group of seven men of similar age which met fortnightly, which Musa joined through a community association in the third month. The group operated the arrangement used by men's groups generally: a rule that nothing said leaves the room, no advice for the first twenty minutes of any man's material, and no requirement for any man to speak about himself.

The fourth element was the disclosure to his children, conducted individually, over about four months. Musa's account, which is the part of the case most worth recording: *I told each of them the same thing. I told them that their mother had done all the family's visiting, that I had discovered in the hospital that there was nobody for me to call, and that I had been ashamed about it, and that I had not wanted them to see it. My daughter cried for about an hour. My son in Lagos was quiet and then he said that he had the same problem, and he was forty-two years old. I did not know that.* Musa's summary, two years after the consultation, was: *I did not need to be helped; I needed to be reached, and I did not know how to be reached, and the doctor asked me a question off a form. I would like men to know the thing that I did not know for two years: the sentence I was afraid to say — there is nobody to call — was the answer to the question that took me out of the house. It did not shame me to say it. It was the only sentence I have said in my life that changed the thing it described.*

Six features of this case deserve isolation.

The isolation was produced by the household process. Musa's arrangements with the family, the community, and the occasions were carried by his wife, and he described this precisely: *She had the house and the family. I had the workshop.* This is Process Five from Section 27.2, and the case is included because the finding is common and rarely anticipated: the arrangements that men lose when a spouse dies or a marriage ends are frequently not their own, and their absence is discovered at the point of need.

The discovery arrived through a practical emergency. The hospital, the taxi, and the sentence: *who would I call?* This is the pattern identified in Section 27.1′s second form, and it is included because men frequently describe the moment precisely and describe it as the first occasion at which they counted their arrangements.

The case moved through Forms Three and Four of Section 27.1 in sequence. Musa first could not ask — his position was Form Three, the man with arrangements who cannot use them, since his children were available and he declined their help. And his arrangements had been structured by his responsibilities, which is Form Four. The sequence, in which one form conceals the next, is common.

The entry point was a form rather than a confidence. The general practitioner's four questions on a printed form, asked without eye contact, supplied the opening that the man could not construct. The case's practical teaching is the value of an arrangement in which the delivery of the material is routine rather than an act of disclosure: the man is asked, and answering a question is a different act from volunteering a statement. This is why Stage Five of Section 27.5 is placed as the entry point, and why it is described as an entry point rather than a destination.

The arrangements were built in an ascending order of difficulty. The sleeping first, the marriage later; the friend contacted about a spare part; the group joined in the third month; the children told in the fourth month. The man's own account of the sequence — *the first month I did not say anything about the marriage; it was easier to go for the sleeping* — is the graded method of Section 27.5 in practice, and the case is included because men are frequently instructed to begin with the largest item, which produces the outcome the man fears.

The disclosure to the children produced a finding the man had not anticipated. His son, aged forty-two, had the same position. This outcome is reported with striking consistency by men who disclose to their adult children, and it is included because it indicates the reach of the material in this chapter: the condition is transmitted, it is transmitted in silence, and a single disclosure frequently reveals that it is held by both parties and by neither man's arrangement.

27.7 Practical Exercise: The Person You Would Call

This exercise takes about ninety minutes. It is conducted in writing and it has five parts.

Part One: The Count

Answer the following questions with names or with the word *nobody*.

- If I were taken to hospital tonight, whom would I call? (Name:)
- If I lost my position this month, whom would I tell first? (Name:)

- If my marriage reached a serious difficulty, whom would I speak to about it? (Name:)
- If I were afraid of something I have not told anybody, whom would I say it to? (Name:)
- Whom do I currently ask for advice on a decision involving money? (Name:)
- Behind all of these: who knows my actual position? (Name:)

Then complete: the number of *nobody* answers on the list is **.** That number is the finding of the exercise.

Part Two: The Form of My Isolation

From the six forms in Section 27.1, identify the form operating in your life, and record the evidence.

- **The form:**
- **The evidence:**
- **How long it has been operating:**

Then, from the seven processes in Section 27.2, identify the process that produced it: responsibility, migration, status change, grief and loss, the household process, concealment, or the conclusion. Where more than one applies, list them in order of weight.

Part Three: The Barrier I Hold

From the eight barriers in Section 27.4, identify the barrier that operates in your case, and state it in your own words, in the form in which your own mind states it.

- **The barrier, in my own words:**
- **What it protects me from:**
- **What it costs me:**

Part Four: Stage One

Complete the identification from Stage One of Section 27.5.

The person	Available?	Not dependent?	Outside the material's audience?	The evidence of a record

Then answer the question that generates the list: who, over my adult life, has ever asked me a question that was not about my position or my usefulness?

And record the fallback: if the list is empty, the professional entry point I will use, and the date of the appointment.

Part Five: The Arrangement

Specify the arrangement in the form of the six stages, with dates.

The stage	The specific act	The date
One: identification		
Two: contact without the material		
Three: the reciprocal arrangement		
Four: the first delivery of material		
Five: the professional arrangement		
Six: the group		

The first date should be within seven days of the completion of this exercise, and Stage Two's act should be small enough that you can perform it in one sitting.

27.8 Common Questions Men Ask

"I have a wife and children. Surely that is not nobody to call."

The household is a genuine arrangement and it is one of the most important in any man's life. The question the chapter addresses is different, and it concerns the specific function described in Section 27.3: an arrangement outside the household in which the material can be delivered. The reasons are practical and they are not a criticism of the marriage. A man's wife is an interested party to most of the material — the money, the household's decisions, the marriage itself — and she cannot supply the second perspective, since she has her own position. A man's children are frequently the subject matter, which places the material outside their range. And the household can be lost, by bereavement, by separation, or by a period in which the marriage is in difficulty, and the arrangements that were carried by it are then discovered to be absent. Men in these circumstances report the finding described in Section 27.1's second form, and the recommendation is not that the wife is insufficient but that one arrangement outside the household is required.

"I do not want to burden my friend. He has enough of his own."

The concern is legitimate and it is addressed by the reciprocal form in Stage Three of Section 27.5: an arrangement in which the man is a supplier as well as a recipient. Men's arrangements hold when both parties bring something to them, and the specific finding from men who have built such arrangements is that the reciprocal form, once established, is stable for years. The concern also rests on a prediction about the friend's response which is worth testing with a small delivery rather than assuming.

"What if I make the call and it is awkward?"

It will, occasionally, be awkward, and awkwardness is not an indication of failure. The first contact after eleven years, as the case in Section 27.6 illustrates, frequently opens with a practical matter and lasts forty minutes. Where a contact is poorly received, the outcome is information about that particular person. The

standard for evaluating the attempt is not the quality of the conversation but whether the arrangement now exists and whether a second contact is possible.

"Is there any point in this if the situation is not going to change?"

The situation frequently does not change, and the standard is not resolution. The documented effect of the arrangement is on the man's capacity to carry the situation, on his judgement, and on his physical and mental health, as Section 27.3 sets out. The man whose circumstances cannot be altered is exactly the man who most requires the capacity, which is the finding on which Part IV's material rests.

"I have tried therapy and it did not help."

The professional route's variability should be acknowledged: the outcome depends on the match, the practitioner's approach, and the material. Where an arrangement has failed, the relevant distinctions are whether the practitioner was appropriate to the material, whether the arrangement was of sufficient length, and whether the man was able to deliver the material or only the presenting complaint. The professional route is an entry point, not a single appointment, and the men who report substantial benefit generally describe a first several months in which little occurred.

"I am the man other men call. What am I supposed to do?"

The position described as Form Five in Section 27.1, and it is the most common among men in positions of responsibility. The requirement does not change: one arrangement outside the man's responsibility, with a defined purpose, and preferably a peer relationship or a professional one. Men in this position frequently describe the greatest difficulty in the world, since they have no experience of being a recipient and their entire professional life is organised around supplying. The finding from practice is that the professional arrangement, where the purpose is defined and the confidentiality is absolute, is the route that such men will actually use.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 27 in brief. Isolation among men takes six forms: the man who was never asked, whose childhood supplied no experience of being attended to; the man whose arrangements were removed by bereavement, divorce, migration, retirement, or loss; the man with arrangements who cannot ask; the man whose isolation is arranged by the structure of his other obligations; the man who is surrounded by people who depend on him and has no recipient for his own material; and the man who chose it, whose arrangement is not a defect where it can hold under load.

The positions are produced by seven processes: the narrowing produced by responsibility, migration and relocation, status change, grief and loss, the household process in which the man's arrangements were carried by his wife, the concealment process in which the man's avoidance dissolves the arrangements themselves, and the conclu-

sion process in which the man ceases to extend arrangements after being betrayed. Alcohol, overwork, and substitute arrangements accelerate every one of them.

The consequences are documented. Isolated men face substantially elevated mortality risk, with physiological and behavioural mechanisms identified; elevated rates of depression, anxiety, and suicide; and a specific and under-recognised damage to judgement, whose practical forms in men's lives are the large irreversible commitment made without a second opinion, the concealment continued beyond the point at which disclosure was affordable, the adjustment made in private and never revisited, and the conclusion formed without challenge.

Eight barriers stop men from reaching out: there is nothing to say; it will be used against me; it will cost me at work; I will be a burden; he has his own problems; it will change how my household sees me; I do not know who to call; and it will not help. Four of them are variations on a single proposition — that the material, once delivered, becomes a fact in the world with consequences — and the graded method addresses them all, since the arrangements are built by degrees, each delivery small enough to be survived.

A network is built in six stages. Stage One requires the identification of one person, on the criteria of availability, non-dependence, position outside the material's audience, and a record of reliability, generated by asking who has ever asked a question that was not about the man's position or usefulness. Stage Two requires contact without the material. Stage Three establishes a reciprocal arrangement, in which the recurring arrangement is the most durable form. Stage Four delivers a first small item of material, whose purpose is to establish that the channel will hold. Stage Five is the professional route, which is the entry point for a man who will not talk and which requires nothing of the man that he cannot supply today. Stage Six is the group, which supplies what no single relationship can: membership, more than one man, and the correction of the man's own account.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete Part One of the exercise. How many *nobody* answers are there, and what is the sentence you would most dislike writing in Part Four?
2. Which of the six forms in Section 27.1 describes your position, and which of the seven processes in Section 27.2 produced it?
3. Which of the four documented forms of damaged judgement in Section 27.3 have occurred in your life: the large commitment without a second opinion, the concealment continued too long, the private adjustment never revisited, or the conclusion formed without challenge?
4. State your barrier in your own words — the sentence your own mind uses. What is it protecting you from, and what does it cost you?
5. Complete the table in Part Four. If the list is empty, what is the professional entry point, and what is the date of the appointment?

6. Which of the six stages in Section 27.5 is the one you cannot currently perform, and what is the smallest version of that act that is available to you this week?
7. What are the three dates in Part Five, and what will you do if the first attempt is poorly received?

Further Reading

- **On social isolation and mortality:** the research literature on social connection, social isolation, and mortality, including the systematic reviews and meta-analyses that established the association and estimated its magnitude.
- **On isolation and men:** the literature on men's social networks, including the findings on the smaller size of men's networks, men's reliance on a spouse for their social connection, and the elevated risks faced by separated and widowed men.
- **On loneliness and health:** the research on loneliness as distinct from objective isolation, including the physiological and psychological findings, and the material on the specific effects of loneliness in men.
- **On men's help-seeking:** the literature on men's reluctance to seek help, including the findings on the specific barriers men report, the role of professional identity and self-reliance, and the interventions that have been shown to increase help-seeking among men.
- **On decision-making in isolation:** the research on group and dyadic decision-making, including the findings on the effects of the absence of a second perspective, the value of thinking a matter through aloud, and the phenomenon of the statement that changes in the speaker's hearing when it is delivered to another person.
- **Practical resources:** general practice and primary care, where the routine assessment questions supply an entry point; employee assistance programmes and occupational health services; men's groups operating with agreed rules of confidentiality; peer support services for men in specific occupational groups; and the material in Appendices J and Q.

PART VIII

The Battles of Loss, Regret, and Broken Dreams

Confronting painful experiences that cannot simply be forgotten

28 CHAPTER

The Dreams That Died Quietly

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Identify the categories of dream that men carry, and distinguish between a dream, a plan, and an obligation.
2. Explain the seven processes by which a dream ends without a decision, without a funeral, and without anybody being informed.
3. Name the particular form of grief that belongs to a dream that died quietly, and explain why it is frequently not recognised as grief by the man or by his household.
4. Assess the cost of holding a dead dream open, and the different cost of closing it.
5. Apply a structured reckoning to the life that was built in place of the dream, without dismissing either the loss or the achievement.
6. Use the exercise at the end of the chapter to decide, for each dream, whether it is live, closed, or genuinely pending — and to act accordingly.

Introduction

Almost every man carries the record of at least one thing he intended to become and did not become. It may be the education that was interrupted, the business that was never started, the country he meant to leave for, the work he meant to do, the house, the journey, the craft, the role, or the life he described to himself at nineteen and quietly stopped describing at thirty-five.

This chapter concerns those dreams, and specifically the ones that died quietly: the ones that were not abandoned in a decision and were not ended by an event that anybody observed. They were set down. They were postponed with a date that was never fixed. They were overtaken by obligations that were real, by money that was not available, by a father's requirement, by a wife's fear, by a failure, by a child's needs, by the slow accumulation of months in which the dream was not advanced.

The chapter is written on four commitments.

The first is that this is a loss, and that it should be named as one. Men are frequently told that dreams are for the young, that a man should be practical, and that a man who still speaks of the thing he meant to do is indulging himself. The instruction is applied by men to themselves more harshly than by anybody else, and its effect is that the loss is carried without being named. An unnamed loss behaves as an unnamed loss always behaves: it is present continuously, it is not processed, and it is available to be triggered by the smallest event — a former classmate's announcement, a child's decision, a song, a road.

The second is that the dream must be distinguished from the fantasy. A proportion of what men carry is not a dream but an image: a picture of a life with no plan attached, frequently adopted from a culture's account of success, and its loss is not a loss at all, because it was never held as a possibility. The distinction is developed in Section 28.2, and it matters because men frequently expend considerable effort grieving an image while neglecting a real dream.

The third is that the reckoning must include the life that was actually built. The chapter will not treat the man's obligations as the enemy of his life. In the material on men's dreams there is a strong cultural tendency to treat every abandonment as a tragedy produced by duty, and it is false to the accounts men give, in which the household, the children, the trade, and the position are frequently things they would not surrender. The work of this chapter is an accurate accounting of both, which is what Section 28.6 constructs.

The fourth is the practical objective. A dream that is kept open is expensive: it occupies the mental space of a live possibility while offering none of the activity of one, and it supplies a continuous standard against which the man's actual life is measured and found deficient. This is the mechanism described in Chapter 7, and it is the reason that a dream must eventually be classified — as live, as closed, or as genuinely pending — and acted upon in the appropriate manner. Closing a dream is a loss and it is also a relief, and the two are not in conflict.

28.1 The Dreams a Man Carries

Before the processes are described, the dreams themselves must be sorted, and the sorting matters because different kinds of dream require different handling.

The Eight Categories

1. The vocational dream. The man intended to do work of a particular kind: the medicine, the law, the engineering, the teaching, the research, the music, the writing, the design, the sport. This category is the most frequently reported and the one with the clearest structure, since a vocation has observable requirements — a qualification, an entry, a period of training — and its abandonment can usually be dated.

2. The educational dream. The degree, the certificate, the professional qualification, the second degree, the course that was to be taken *after this busy period*. This category overlaps with the first and is heavier in the man's account when the education was the mechanism of the vocation, because the loss of the one is the loss of the other.

3. The entrepreneurial dream. The business, the shop, the company, the practice, the farm, the workshop, the truck, the brand. This category has a characteristic feature: it is frequently not closed but repeatedly deferred, and the deferral is organised around a condition — *when I have saved, when the children finish, when the market improves, when I have a partner I can trust*. Chapter 26's material on trust is frequently connected.

4. The migratory dream. The country, the city, the life elsewhere. The visa that was applied for and refused, the application that was never submitted, the opportunity that was declined because of a parent's illness, the plan that was silently abandoned when a child's schooling was established. This category is frequently accompanied by a comparison with the men who went, which supplies the continuous measure described in Chapter 11.

5. The creative dream. The book, the album, the art, the film, the business of a particular aesthetic kind. This dream has the property of being permanently available — the man can begin at any time — which makes its deferral easy and its abandonment invisible. The category is the one in which men most frequently report a specific and painful discovery late in life: that the material they intended to produce still exists only as an intention.

6. The family and legacy dream. The family that was going to be different from the one the man grew up in; the marriage of a particular kind; the number of children; the house in which the children would be raised; the name he would leave. Its abandonment is quiet because the reality is gradual and because the man's own conduct participates in every stage of it, which makes the loss hard to state without self-accusation. The material of Chapters 17 and 19 is connected.

7. The place and life dream. The house, the land, the village, the life in a particular setting. Its abandonment is frequently financial and frequently permanent, and it is the category in which the man's plan is most frequently carried by a single object — the plot, the title, the building — which means the loss has a date and a location and is therefore, in an unhelpful way, continuously visible.

8. The bodily dream. The sporting achievement, the physical capacity, the standard the man held for himself as an athlete, a soldier, a dancer, a physically capable man. This dream dies quietly with age and injury, and it is the category least often recognised as a loss, which is why the material in Chapter 32 is required.

The Three Distinctions

Three distinctions separate a dream from the other things men carry, and each is worth applying to the list the reader has just generated.

A dream has a plan. Not necessarily a schedule, but a set of steps the man could name. *I intended to study medicine* has a plan: sit the examination, obtain the entry, complete the training. *I intended to be a wealthy man* does not, and it is an image rather than a dream. The distinction matters because images do not die quietly — they die by being looked at — and their abandonment does not warrant the work described in this chapter.

A dream belongs to the man. Chapter 2's three-way test applies: is this dream mine, or is it my family's, my community's, or my father's? A substantial proportion of what men carry is a dream that was installed by somebody else and never examined. Its abandonment is frequently not a loss but a release, and the case in Section 28.7 illustrates the pattern. The work of this chapter should not be applied to a dream the man never held.

A dream has been held against the man's own judgement. A dream the man actually carried has a specific signature: the man can describe the moment he decided it, the person he told, the step he attempted, and the point at which he stopped. Where a man cannot supply those four items, the item is either an image, an obligation, or a regret acquired from somebody else's account. The four items are also the raw material of the exercise at the end of the chapter.

The Two Categories of What Remains

Once the dreams have been sorted, they fall into two groups and the grouping determines the work.

The dead dream. The dream that cannot be resumed in its original form. The age limit, the qualification route, the market, the injury, the migration window, the person who would have done it with him. Its handling is described in Sections 28.3 to 28.5: the acknowledgement of the loss, the grief conducted without an audience, and the closing.

The pending dream. The dream that is genuinely available: the course that can still be taken, the qualification that has no age barrier, the business that could be started at any point, the book, the land, the trade, the way of life. Its handling is different and it is not primarily emotional: the man must either take a first step within a defined period or reclassify the dream as closed. The most damaging of all the positions described in this chapter is that of the pending dream that receives no first step and no closing, which is where the majority of the men who carry dreams appear to be. This is the position the chapter's exercise addresses directly.

KEY POINT

Dreams fall into eight categories — vocational, educational, entrepreneurial, migratory, creative, family and legacy, place and life, and bodily — and must be distinguished from images, from obligations, and from dreams that were never the man's own. A real dream has a plan, belongs to the man, and can be described at the moment it was decided, the person it was told to, the step that was attempted, and the point at which it stopped. Once sorted, dreams are either dead or pending, and the two require entirely different work.

28.2 What Kills a Dream Quietly

A dream rarely ends in a decision. It ends through one or more of seven processes, and the processes are worth setting out because men who can identify the process operating in their case are frequently, for the first time, able to describe the loss accurately.

The Seven Processes

1. The substitution of duty for the dream. The most common process by far, and the one that deserves the most careful treatment because it is also, frequently, the correct decision. The man's obligations arrive — the household, the parent's illness, the sibling's fees, the child's schooling, the family's expectations — and the dream is set down in favour of the obligation. The process has no hostile agent: the man chooses the obligation himself, repeatedly, in small decisions, and each decision is defensible. What makes the process quiet is that no single moment can be identified as the abandonment, and what makes it painful is that the man who chose his obligations with full competence does not feel entitled to grieve something he set down deliberately.

The specific finding from men's accounts is that the majority of such decisions were correct in their own terms and are not regretted in their own terms. *I would make the same decision again* is the most common sentence in the material. The loss is nonetheless real: the man regrets the dream and would repeat the decision, and both are true, and the chapter's work is to allow both to be held at once.

2. The narrowing produced by money. The dream survived on the assumption of a surplus that never arrived. The margin above the household's requirements remained thin for a decade, and the amount the dream required — the fees, the capital, the passage, the equipment, the unpaid year — remained just out of reach each year. The process is not poverty in the absolute sense and it is not prosperity: it is the condition of a man whose income covers his obligations and not his plans, maintained over the whole of the period in which the plan was possible.

The specific feature is that the process produces a particular kind of bitterness when it is accompanied by visible prosperity elsewhere: the man does not resent those with more than he has, he resents the absence of a margin, which is a different and more corrosive position.

3. The failure that ended the route. The attempt was made and it failed: the examination not passed, the business lost, the application refused, the audition unsuccessful, the injury sustained. This process is the most visible of the seven and it is frequently not the one that killed the dream, because a failed attempt ordinarily produces a second attempt. What kills the dream in this case is generally the interpretation the man attaches to the failure, which is the material of Chapters 9, 21, and 25 combined: the failure becomes a verdict about the man, and the second attempt becomes inconceivable.

The specific finding from men's accounts: in a substantial proportion of cases the man was capable of a second attempt, had one avenue open, and had the information required, and did not attempt again because the first failure had been converted into a conclusion about himself.

4. The requirement of another person. The dream was set down at the request, insistence, or fear of somebody else: the father who required the man to enter the family business or the profession, the wife who would not agree to the move or the risk, the mother who was frightened of a particular path, the family that would not accept the marriage that was part of the plan.

The specific feature is the difficulty of stating the loss without indicting the person, which is why the process is frequently not described at all. Men's accounts handle it in three ways, and the chapter notes them because each has a cost: the man blames the other person and carries the resentment described in Chapter 15; the man blames himself for having yielded; or the man says nothing, which is the most common and which leaves the loss unstated for decades.

5. The slow erosion. No obstacle, no opposition, no failure: the dream was simply not advanced. The hours were occupied by legitimate matters, the months passed, the man's skill or preparedness declined, and at a certain point the item that remained was no longer a plan but a memory of one. This process is the quietest of the seven and it is the one that produces the most shame when it is finally examined, because there is no event to which the loss can be attributed and no other party to whom any part of it can be assigned.

The finding from men's accounts: this process is very frequently accompanied by a parallel erosion in other domains, and the man's examination of it is frequently the point at which the wider material of Chapter 24 becomes visible.

6. The decision made on somebody else's timetable. The dream was pursued under a schedule imposed by circumstances: the age limit, the closing date, the requirement of the employer, the expectations of a community concerning

when a man should be married, established, or settled. The pressure is not malicious and it is effective: the man commits to a path because the timetable requires a commitment, and the dream is set aside because it required time the timetable did not allow.

The specific feature is the man's own sense, in later years, that he made a decision he did not actually make — that he was moved by a schedule and that the schedule belonged to other people.

7. The loss of the person with whom the dream was shared. The dream was a shared plan: with a friend, a brother, a wife, a mentor, a father, a business partner. Its death is a bereavement as well as a loss of plan, and it is the process that most cleanly belongs to the material of Chapter 13. Men who lose a shared dream in this way describe a specific refusal, over years, to close it: *it would be a betrayal to let it go.* The chapter addresses the position directly in Section 28.4.

What the Seven Processes Have in Common

Four features, and they explain why this class of loss behaves as it does.

None of them produces an event. There is no funeral, no letter, no final conversation, and no date on which a man could say *that was the day I stopped*. The absence of an event means the loss is not registered by the man's household, by his community, or by the man himself, and it is therefore never acknowledged, which the research on loss identifies as the principal factor that turns a loss into a prolonged one.

Each involves a decision the man would make again. This is the distinguishing feature of the class and the reason the ordinary language of loss does not fit it. The man is not the victim of a reversal; he is the author of a sequence of decisions that were, in the terms available to him, correct. The consequence is a specific kind of stuck grief that has no villain and to which the man does not feel entitled.

Each is compatible with a functioning life. The dream dies while the man's other arrangements continue, which is why the loss is not visible and why the man's household is frequently surprised by its significance when it is finally mentioned.

Each produces a comparison that operates continuously. The man's account of what happened to the dream always includes the alternative: the man who went, the colleague who completed the training, the cousin who started the business, the version of himself who would be somewhere else. The comparison is applied automatically and it operates as the deficiency measure described in Chapter 7.

28.3 The Ache of a Dream Nobody Knows About

The distinguishing feature of the loss described in this chapter is that there is no audience for it. This section sets out what follows, because the consequences are practical and because they explain the form the grief takes.

Nobody Was Informed, and Therefore Nobody Can Offer Anything

The ordinary arrangements by which a loss is processed require that the loss be known. A bereavement is announced, attended, and spoken about; a financial collapse is described to the people who are affected by it; an illness is disclosed to the household. In every case the acknowledgement by others performs four functions: it establishes that something has happened, it permits the man to speak of it, it supplies the company of people who know, and it marks a transition.

For a dream that died quietly, none of these operate. Nobody knows, so the man cannot speak of it without first explaining that there was something to speak of; and the explanation itself invites the response described below. There is no company, because the people who know the man do not know the dream — frequently including his wife, which is the most consequential and the most common form of the absence. And there is no transition, because there was no event.

The Five Responses the Man Anticipates

Men who consider disclosing a dead dream anticipate five responses, and the anticipation is accurate in a substantial number of cases.

The practical response. *You can still do it.* Delivered with goodwill, it treats the disclosure as an invitation to solve a problem, and it is frequently the most difficult response of the five, because it requires the man to explain why the plan is no longer available — the age, the money, the route that has closed — which is a description of defeat. The response is also inaccurate in the important respect: the man is not reporting a plan he has failed to make; he is reporting a loss.

The minimising response. *There are people with worse problems* or *you have a good job and four children; be content*. The response is common, it is frequently accompanied by an accurate assessment of the man's circumstances, and it removes his permission to grieve by comparing his loss to a larger one.

The accusation. *You should have done it when you had the chance* or *you always had an excuse*. This response is less common than the man fears and it is the one he most expects, which is a measure of how much of the accounting has already been conducted in his own mind.

The retrospective verdict. *So it was a waste, then* — the response that converts a life's decision into a failure, which is the material of Chapter 25 applied to the man's private record.

The silence. The response that is most common of all: the hearer says something brief, moves to another subject, and does not return to it, because he does not know how the material should be handled. The man reads the silence as a confirmation that the material should not have been raised, and it is generally this response that prevents a second attempt.

Why the Man Does Not Grieve It

Four reasons, and they are worth setting out because they must be answered before the work of Sections 28.4 and 28.5 can proceed.

Because there is no dead body, no loss to be recovered, and no event to be described. The ordinary grief processes are triggered by events; the process in this case has no trigger, and men are not generally equipped to grieve a thing that simply stopped being possible.

Because he chose it. The man's own participation in the loss is the principal obstacle. A man who set the dream down in favour of his children's schooling does not feel entitled to describe the outcome as a loss, because to do so implies that the alternative would have been better, which would have required him to have chosen differently, which he would not.

Because he is supposed to be over it. The cultural instruction described in the introduction is applied internally with force. The man's own position is generally this: *I decided this at thirty-one and I am fifty-two; a man of fifty-two who still speaks of a medical career he did not begin is not being honest about his age.* The instruction suppresses the material without resolving it, and the material remains available to every comparison described below.

Because the loss is not the loss of a thing but the loss of a version of himself. The most important of the four reasons. The dream was not an object the man possessed; it was a description of who he was going to be. Its death is therefore an identity loss, and the material of Chapter 24 applies directly: the man must reconstruct an account of himself that includes what he became and that does not require him to pretend that the other account was never held.

The Two Comparisons That Operate Continuously

Two comparisons supply the persistent occupation that men describe in connection with this material, and both are available at any moment.

The comparison with the men who went. The former classmate, the colleague, the cousin, the man from the same street who took the path. The comparison operates through whatever evidence is available — the professional listing, the announcement, the return visit, the social media account, the school reunion — and it is the mechanism described in Chapters 11 and 25. Its specific feature in this material is that the comparison is not with a stranger's general position but with a specific alternative to the man's own life, which makes it considerably more

painful and considerably less accurate, since the man compares his actual life, in its whole and visible detail, with an account of another life that is composed of its public successes.

The comparison with the version of himself who took the path. The stronger of the two, and the one that operates without any external evidence. The man imagines the life he would have had: the position, the income, the household, the respect, the children raised elsewhere, the parents cared for differently. The imagined version is constructed entirely from the dream's advantages and contains none of its costs, and it is therefore a comparison between a real life and an ideal one, which cannot be won. The material of Chapter 24 on the ideal standard applies, and this comparison is the specific reason that a dead dream occupies the mental space of a live one.

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

A composite account, constructed from patterns reported in counselling and in men's group practice.

A man of fifty-six, a school teacher who had taught for thirty-two years, described during a men's group meeting the dream that had occupied him since the age of twenty-two.

I was going to be a lawyer. I had the papers, I had the entry, and I had the fees for the first year. My father fell ill in the year I was to go, and the fees became the hospital's fees. When he recovered — he recovered fully, he lived another twenty-one years — I was twenty-four, and by then I had taken the teaching job, and my younger two were in secondary school, and there was nobody else to pay for them. I never decided not to be a lawyer. There was no day. I just did not register for the second year, and then the years had gone.

The thing nobody knows is that I have been a lawyer in my own head for thirty-four years. When a case is in the news, I decide it. When I hear an argument, I think about how I would have put it. I have written judgements in my head during lessons. I have never told my wife any of this. She believes that I am a man who wanted to be a teacher. She asks me sometimes why I am quiet in the evening, and I say I am tired, and I am tired.

What I could not say in this room until tonight is that I chose it. I chose my father's recovery and I chose my brothers' schooling and I would choose them again, tomorrow. So what am I grieving? I am grieving a man I invented, who I have carried for thirty-four years and who I have kept alive in my own head, and who was never going to exist, because the man who did all those things — the one I have been imagining — he would have had to be a man who let his father die and his brothers leave school. I have been envying a man who is not worth being.

The account is included because it supplies the chapter's central mechanism in the man's own words. The imagined alternative is not the life that would have

followed from the dream; it is the dream's benefits without its costs. The imagined self is a man who took the path and did not pay for it. And the resolution the man discovered is one of the two the chapter develops in Sections 28.5 and 28.6: the dream is closed by an accurate reconstruction of what the dream would actually have required, which is not a consolation but a correction of the record.

28.4 Grief for Something That Never Existed

This section sets out what is required in order to conduct a grief that has no object, and what the man should expect from it.

The Naming

The first requirement is that the loss be named as a loss, and named in a form the man can accept. Four formulations are used in practice, and men report that at least one of them is workable.

The formulation of loss. *I lost the thing I intended to do, and I have never had anywhere to put that.* This is the most straightforward and it is the one men most frequently resist, because the word *lost* suggests that something was taken. Section 28.2's point — that the man's own decisions were correct — does not conflict with the naming: a thing can be lost by a correct decision as well as by a wrong one.

The formulation of mourning. *I am mourning a life I did not live.* This formulation is more accurate for men whose dream involved a specific alternative existence — the country, the profession, the version of the household — and it has the advantage of placing the object of the grief correctly: the man is mourning a life, which is a real loss, and not a possession.

The formulation of the closed door. *That route closed at a particular point in the past, and I have been behaving as though it were still open.* This formulation is the most practical and it is the one that most frequently leads directly into the work of Section 28.5.

The formulation of the debt. *I owe that intention a proper ending, and I have never given it one.* This formulation is useful for men whose difficulty is that the matter feels unfinished rather than painful. It converts the work into an obligation, which men manage well.

The Grief Conducted Without an Audience

The loss has no public process, so the man must construct a private one. The following four elements constitute the form used in practice, and they are adapted directly from the material in Chapter 13 on burial and remembrance.

1. The account, written. The dream, in writing: what it was, when it was decided, what was attempted, and what stopped. The document should contain the four items from Section 28.1 and should be written in the past tense, which

is the detail that begins the closing. Men report that the writing is frequently the first occasion on which the dream has been described accurately, and that the description is itself the greater part of the work.

2. The accounting of the reasons. Written separately: why the dream was set down, whether the decision was correct, whether it would be repeated, and what would have been required to do otherwise. The section should include the actual cost of the alternative — the costs that the imagined life did not include — for the reason given at the end of Section 28.3. This is the element that converts the man's envy of the imaginary man into an accurate assessment.

3. The witness. One person who is informed that the dream existed and that it is being closed. The requirement is not that the person should comfort the man; it is that somebody should know. Men in men's groups report consistently that the single act of telling one person is the step that alters the position, and the mechanism is the one described in Chapter 27.3: the account, delivered to another person, is changed in the man's own hearing.

4. The marker. A physical or dated act that marks the ending: a written page filed in a particular place, a small object retained or given away, an entry in a journal, a visit to the place associated with the dream, an hour set aside with a date and a decision. The marker's function is the transition that the ordinary arrangements would have supplied, and men report that it works despite its arbitrary nature. Its form matters less than its having a date.

What the Man Should Expect

Six outcomes, described consistently by men who have conducted the work, and their ordinariness is the point.

The incidence of the material reduces. It does not disappear, and the reduction is generally gradual over several months.

The comparison with the men who went reduces, because the accounting of the alternative's costs has made the imagined life less attractive and because the man's own account of the dream's ending is now accurate.

The comparison with the imagined self reduces similarly, and this is the largest change men report.

The dream is available to be discussed. Men report that after the work, the dream can be mentioned in conversation without the accompanying private event, which is the practical measure of the closing.

The grief recurs on specific occasions — a milestone, a child's graduation, a funeral, a former colleague's obituary, a particular piece of music — with reduced intensity each time. The recurrence is not a failure of the work; it is the ordinary pattern described in Chapter 13.

The life that was built becomes available for the accounting described in Section 28.6, which the man has generally been unable to conduct while the dream remained open.

Two Special Cases

The shared dream. Where the dream belonged to the man and another person and the other person has died, the work has an additional requirement: the man must grieve the person as well as the plan, and he must permit himself to close the plan without regarding the closure as a betrayal. The formulation used in bereavement practice is worth recording: the dream is not kept alive by the man's refusal to close it; the dream is kept alive by the man's conducting what it stood for. This matter is treated at greater length in Chapter 30's material.

The dream that belongs to the next generation. Where the man's dream is available to his children, a specific and delicate situation arises, and the chapter notes it because practice reports that it is frequently mishandled. A father who communicates to a son the value of the thing he himself did not do has transferred the material, and the receipt of it by the son produces exactly the pattern described in Chapter 19: a young man carrying an obligation that was not his own. The distinction to be maintained is between an example and an assignment. The example is *this is what I valued and what it looked like*; the assignment is *you will do what I did not*. The first supplies a model; the second supplies a debt.

28.5 When the Dream Dies Late

A substantial proportion of the dreams in this material die late: not in the years of the obligations, but at the point at which the obligations end, when the man finally has the time, the margin, and the freedom — and discovers that the dream is no longer available, or that he is no longer the man who held it.

The Trigger

The trigger is generally one of five events, and each has the same structure: it removes the constraint that had justified the deferral.

Retirement or redundancy. The time has arrived and the money is different from the plan.

The last child's completion. The fees have ended, the household has reduced, and the man's account of why the dream was set down no longer applies.

The death of the parent whose requirement had governed the decision. The constraint is removed by a bereavement, which produces a compound event: the grief and the discovery that the reason for the decision has gone.

The medical event. An illness or an injury that establishes a horizon, and that converts a postponed dream into a closed one without a decision.

The encounter. A former colleague, a reunion, an obituary, a returned acquaintance: an event that presents the alternative life in a form the man cannot avoid.

The Specific Errors of a Late-Dying Dream

The man attempts to resume it in its original form. He registers for a course he cannot possibly complete, initiates a business with no assessment of the market, migrates to a place he has not visited in thirty years, or commits to the discipline required at twenty at an age at which the body will not cooperate. The attempt frequently ends in a second failure, which is then added to the first as evidence.

The man treats the discovery as a verdict. The finding that the original form of the dream is closed is converted into an assessment of the whole life, which is the material of Chapter 24 and which is the reason the two chapters are adjacent.

The man closes it in anger. The dream is abandoned with a resentful act: the papers destroyed, the correspondence discarded, the subject forbidden in the household. Practice reports that this form of closing does not work, because the material is not closed but hidden, and it returns on the same triggers.

The man transfers it to somebody else. The pattern described at the end of Section 28.4: the dream is delivered to a son or a nephew as an assignment, and the man's material is then carried by a younger man who was not consulted.

The Correct Handling of a Late-Dying Dream

Establish what remains available. The first practical step, and it is not a matter of attitude but of information: what of the dream's content is still possible in a modified form, and what is genuinely closed? The distinction between the two is frequently larger than the man assumes, and it is the work of the exercise at the end of the chapter. The man who intended to be a lawyer may not be able to practise; he may be able to study the subject, to teach it, to advise within a defined scope, to represent in a permitted forum, or to qualify in a related capacity. The man who intended to live elsewhere may be able to spend a defined period there annually. The man who intended to write may still write, and the fact that the book would have been better at thirty is not an argument against writing it at sixty.

Distinguish the content from the form. The most useful single distinction in this material. The dream's content is what the man was after: the practice of law, the life in another country, the craft, the land, the work with his hands, the position of responsibility, the recognition. Its form is the way he intended to obtain it at twenty-two. Frequently the content remains available through a different form, and the man's inability to see this is generally because the dream in his head is stored as the form: the examination, the visa, the building, the title.

Set the deadline and the first step. For a dream established as available, the man sets one first step and a date within thirty days, and the step must be small: the enquiry, the application, the visit, the enrolment, the conversation, the purchase of the material. Men report consistently that the first step taken is worth more to the position than any amount of further deliberation, for the reason given in Chapter 7.

Close what is closed, properly. The work of Section 28.4, conducted with the four elements: the account, the accounting, the witness, and the marker. The man who has decided that a dream is closed should conduct the closing rather than allowing the dream to stand open indefinitely. The most useful sentence available to men in this position is the one from the case in Section 28.3: the object of the envy was not the dream but an imaginary man who took the path and did not pay for it.

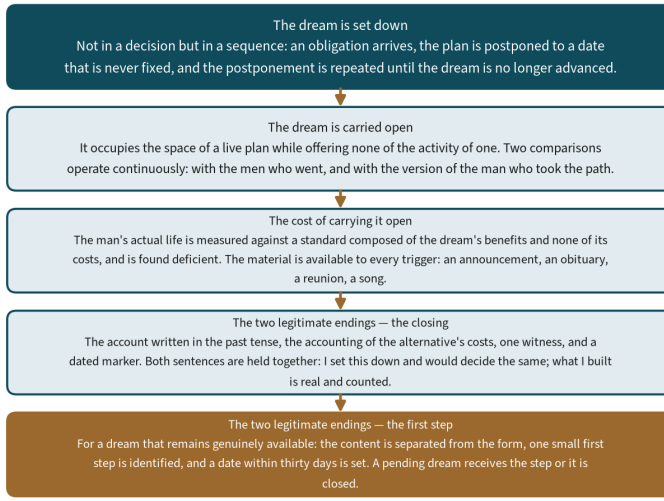


Figure 28.1 The life of a dream: how a dream is set down without a decision, what it costs while it remains open, and the two legitimate endings. The dead dream is closed through the accounting work of Section 28.4; the pending dream is advanced by a first step within thirty days or reclassified as closed.

28.6 The Life You Built Instead

The final piece of the work, and the one that determines whether the closing of a dream leaves the man with a grief alone or with an accurate account of his life, is the reckoning with what was built in the dream's place.

Why the Reckoning Is Difficult

Four reasons, and they must be handled rather than argued away.

The comparison is conducted in the man's own mind, and it is rigged. The imagined life contains the dream's benefits and none of its costs; the actual life contains every cost, visible in detail, and its benefits are spread across decades in the ordinary form of a functioning household, which the man does not count because he has lived inside it. The reckoning corrects the comparison and it cannot be conducted by encouragement; it must be conducted by enumeration.

The man's household does not know there is anything to count. The people for whose sake the dream was set down generally do not know that the setting down occurred. A wife who learns at fifty that her husband carries an unchosen alternative will frequently respond with guilt, which is the last thing the man requires and which is why the disclosure requires the framing described in Section 28.4: the man is describing a loss and is not asking for an account of the decision to be reopened.

The reckoning is frequently greeted as complacency. Men report a resistance to the idea that their actual life constitutes an achievement, because the culture's instruction is that a man should not console himself and that the counting of ordinary goods is a form of settling. The instruction should be identified as what it is: a requirement that the man carry the loss without counting anything, which produces the condition described in Chapter 7.

The reckoning must not be conducted as a substitution. The final and most important reason. The life that was built does not replace the dream. The chapter is not proposing that the man should conclude that everything worked out for the best, which would be false and which the man will not believe. The accurate position is the one stated in Section 28.2 and repeated here: the man lost something real, and the life he built in its place contains things he would not surrender. Both are true, and the work is to hold both.

What to Count

The enumeration is specific, and the following six domains supply it. The exercise at the end of the chapter structures the counting; the domains are listed here so that the reader knows what the work involves.

1. The people who exist because of the decision. The children who were raised, schooled, and kept; the siblings whose education was completed; the parent whose care was provided; the younger relatives who were supported; and, in a proportion of cases, the men and women who were trained, employed, or mentored in the man's trade. The counting is conducted by name, and it is the domain that men most consistently report as decisive.

2. The capability that was accumulated. The skill, the trade, the professional competence, the reputation, the knowledge of a market, the understanding of a craft. The dream was not the only thing the man built; the decades produced a body of capability that frequently exceeds what the man credits, since he has never seen it described.

3. The obligations discharged. What was paid, maintained, funded, repaired, and kept afloat: the fees, the rent, the medical costs, the family's contributions, the repairs, the support that was extended without being recorded. This domain is addressed at length in Chapter 20 and it is conducted from the record rather than from memory.

4. The standing in the community. Not the rank but the position: the man who is consulted, the man whose word is taken, the man who can be relied upon to appear. The domain is frequently invisible to men who hold it, because standing acquired over decades is not accompanied by a description of itself.

5. The competence of the man in the present. What he can now do that he could not do at twenty-two: the judgement, the calibration of risk, the ability to manage people, the tolerance of difficulty, the knowledge of himself. This domain is the one in which the comparison with the imagined self is most decisively corrected, since the imagined self is the man at twenty-two with the dream intact and none of the man's present capacities.

6. The life that was lived in the interval. The marriages, friendships, places, events, meals, journeys, and occasions of which the dream would have contained none. Men frequently report, on completing this domain, that the contributions and events they have counted occurred in the years in which the dream would have been pursued, and that a substantial portion of them would not have existed otherwise. This is not a consolation; it is a fact about the actual composition of the life.

The Two Sentences

The reckoning is completed with two sentences, and both must be written, in the man's own words, and both must be present.

Sentence one: *I set down this. It cost me this. I would make the same decision again.*

Sentence two: *What I built instead is this, and I count it.*

A man who holds only the first sentence is the man described in Chapter 24, whose account of himself consists of the role he lost. A man who holds only the second is treating his own grief as a defect, which is the position of a substantial number of the men in the case material of this chapter, who have assumed that a contented man could not carry an unwished-for alternative. Both sentences are required, and the practice is to read them together in the same document.

The Position on Regrets of This Kind

Two clarifications, which the chapter states because they are frequently raised.

A closed dream is not a regret in the sense of Chapter 29. A regret concerns a decision the man believes was wrong. A closed dream concerns a decision the man believes was right and whose cost he is acknowledging. The distinction matters because regret and grief require different treatment: Chapter 29's work addresses the decision, and this chapter's work addresses the loss. Men who treat a dead dream as a regret expend years on a question — *was it right?* — to which their own answer has been known all along.

The dream may be closed and the ambition may remain. The closing concerns the specific form the man intended at a specific age. It does not require the man to abandon ambition, and the men who conduct this work frequently report the opposite: with the occupied mental space freed and the imagined self retired, they undertake something, small or large, that they had not attempted for years. The finding is worth recording in the chapter's own terms: a dream that has been properly closed leaves the man with the capacity to choose what to build with the years remaining, whereas a dream that stands open indefinitely consumes that capacity in an unproductive comparison.

28.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Papers

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in vocational counselling, mid-life review practice, and men's group discussion.

Nathaniel is fifty-nine, a retired Customs officer of twenty-nine years' service, married to Grace for thirty-one years, with two adult children.

Nathaniel's dream was agriculture. He had grown up on a family plot of about four hectares in a rural area, and at the age of nineteen, in his second year of a diploma in agricultural science, he had a plan that he could describe in detail thirty-nine years later: a poultry unit, a fish pond, and a mixed orchard on the family land, with the produce supplied to two markets in the state capital.

The plan ended in his third year, in a sequence he described precisely: his father's death, the family's dispute over the land, and the requirement that he obtain salaried employment to support his mother and his two younger sisters. He sat the examination for the customs service at twenty-four, was appointed at twenty-five, and worked in three cities in twenty-nine years.

The material he carried consisted of four items.

The papers. Nathaniel retained, from the age of nineteen, the handwritten plan, the drawing of the layout for the poultry unit, a notebook of prices and feed calculations, and a file of correspondence concerning a small grant he had enquired about in 1988. The file was kept in a folder in his box of documents and he looked at it, by his own account, *perhaps twice a year, generally in December*.

The land. The family plot had been resolved in favour of his uncle's branch of the family in the dispute, and about one and a half of the four hectares had passed to Nathaniel in the eventual settlement in 1996. He had never done anything with it and had, at one point in his forties, been approached by another man about selling it and had refused.

The alternative life. Nathaniel described a specific and detailed account of the life he would have had, including the income, the house he would have built on the plot, the position of his children, and — a detail he mentioned twice — the respect he would have received in his community as a man who had built something.

The concealment. Nathaniel had never told his wife the substance of the plan or the existence of the folder. His account of the concealment: *She knows the land is there. I told her once that I was going to farm it when I retired, and she said that it would be good to have something to do. She has never seen the drawings. I did not want her to know that I had planned all of this before I met her and that I gave it up.*

The position was discovered during the year before his retirement. Nathaniel had begun, from about the age of fifty-four, to make visits to the plot of an average of twice a year, and in the fifth year he spent a Saturday clearing a portion of it by hand. His account: *I stood in that place and I understood what I was doing. I was sixty years old and I was clearing land with a cutlass because I had decided in my head at twenty-five that I would come back and farm it, and I had forty hectares in my mind and one and a half hectares in front of me, and I did not want to do it. I did not want to keep chickens at sixty. I did not want to sell fish. I wanted the life I would have had if I had done it when I was thirty, and I had made a plan for a man I have never been.*

The work Nathaniel conducted over the following fourteen months had four elements, and he identified each separately.

The accounting of the alternative. With the help of a counsellor at his workplace's welfare office, Nathaniel wrote out what the farming life would actually have required and contained. The exercise, conducted on the version of the imagined life he had carried for thirty-nine years, produced a document of four pages with the following items: the failure rate of the small poultry and fish operations he had observed in the same area; the losses sustained by a former classmate who had farmed and whom he had envied in the 1990s; the years of the family support he would not have been able to provide, including his youngest sister's education, which had produced a nurse whose income had, subsequently, funded the household during his own mother's illness; and the fact, which he recorded himself, that his children had grown up in three cities and had received a schooling that no rural plot would have supplied.

He described the effect of that document in the following terms: *I had never asked what the farm would have failed at. I had only asked what I had lost. My sister, the nurse, paid for my mother's treatment for four years. I wrote that down and I sat with it and I stopped wanting my other life.*

The disclosure. Nathaniel told his wife Grace about the plan, the folder, the imagined life, and the visit to the plot. He described the conversation at length and

identified its most important feature as the framing: *I told her first that I was not blaming anybody and that I would choose the same things again, and I said it before I told her anything else.* Grace's response, which he described as the reason the conversation went the way it did, was: *she said she had always known there was something in that box that I looked at, and that she had never touched the box.*

The marker. Nathaniel selected four items from the folder — the plan, the drawing, the notebook, and the 1988 correspondence — and placed them, with a written account of two pages entitled *What I did instead*, in a new file. He then took his son and his daughter separately to the plot, showed them the land, and told each of them the plan and the accounting. His account: *I wanted them to have the papers with the story attached, so that they would know what it was instead of finding a drawing of a poultry house in my box and wondering whether their father had been a disappointed man.*

The step. In the second year after the retirement, Nathaniel rented the plot to a cooperative of three young men on a two-year arrangement with an option to renew, and he visited the site, by his own account, *about once every three months, to look and to advise, and I enjoy it, and that is all it is.*

Nathaniel's summary, three years after retirement, was: *For thirty-nine years I carried a plan for a man who never existed. He had my land and he did not have my children, my sister's nursing certificate, my mother's last four years, or the three cities my daughters know. I kept his drawings in a box and I looked at them in December. The day I wrote down what he would have failed at was the day I stopped carrying him. The land is not wasted. The other two and a half hectares are still in the family's hands and I have stopped thinking about them.*

Six features of this case deserve isolation.

The dream was stored in physical form, and the storage maintained it. A folder in a box, consulted twice a year. This detail is extremely common in men's accounts and it is the mechanism by which a dead dream remains available: the object is the dream's container, and its presence in the man's documents gives the dream a location in his actual life. The marker in Section 28.4 addresses this directly by giving the object a new context rather than by requiring its destruction.

The imagined life was detailed and included standing. The house, the income, the children's positions, and the respect of a community. The detail is characteristic and it is the reason the imaginary life is so difficult to compete with: it has been furnished over four decades and every item in it was chosen by the man.

The concealment was from the wife, and the reason was the prehistory of the marriage. *I did not want her to know that I had planned all of this before I met her and that I gave it up.* This is the specific form the concealment takes in this material and it is included because it is frequently misunderstood by the man's household when the disclosure eventually occurs: the withholding is not

a judgement on the marriage, it is the man's refusal to present his wife with an alternative life in which she does not appear.

The grounding happened in a physical place and produced the truth about what remained. The man standing on one and a half hectares with a cutlass, having held forty hectares in his mind. This is the practical counterpart of the exercise at the end of this chapter: the dream must be brought into contact with the actual circumstances in order to be assessed, and the assessment is generally less terrible than the man's imagination and entirely different from it.

The accounting was conducted on the alternative's failures, and it worked. Four pages concerning the failure rate, the classmate's losses, the sister's nursing certificate, and the children's schooling. This is the element the chapter emphasizes most strongly and it is included despite its apparent ordinariness. The imaginary life is constructed from advantages only; the correction is not encouragement but information about what that life would have contained, and the information is generally available within the man's own knowledge.

The closing transferred the material into the family's record rather than into silence. The file entitled *What I did instead*, the visits with the two children, and the disclosure to the wife. The outcome is the one Section 28.6 describes: the dream is closed, the life that was built is counted, and the man's children inherit an accurate account of their father instead of a box of unexplained drawings.

28.8 Practical Exercise: Closing a Dream, Advancing a Dream

This exercise takes about two and a half hours, over three sittings, and it is conducted in writing.

Part One: The Inventory (Sitting One)

List the dreams you have carried. For each, record the following.

The dream	Category (28.1)	When decided	Who was told	What was attempted	Where it stopped

Then apply the three distinctions from Section 28.1 to each item on the list.

- **Is there a plan?** (If not, it is an image and should be removed from the list.)
- **Is it mine?** (Apply the kinship, work, and own test from Chapter 2.)
- **Can I describe the moment I decided it, who I told, what I attempted, and where I stopped?** (If not, the item is an image, an obligation, or somebody else's account.)

Part Two: The Classification (Sitting Two)

Classify each remaining dream as **dead**, **pending**, or **genuinely closed**.

The dream	Dead / pending	The reason	What remains available in modified form?

For each **dead** dream, complete the four elements of Section 28.4.

- **The account.** What it was, when it was decided, what was attempted, and what stopped it. Written in the past tense.
- **The accounting of the reasons.** Why it was set down; whether the decision was correct; whether it would be repeated; what the alternative would have cost — with the specific costs the imagined life does not contain.
- **The witness.** The one person I will tell, and the date.
- **The marker.** The dated act that closes it, and the date.

For each **pending** dream, complete the following.

- **The content** (what I was actually after):
- **The form** (how I intended to obtain it at that time):
- **The available form now:**
- **The first step, small enough to take in a week:**
- **The date:**

The rule for a pending dream is stated plainly: it receives a first step within thirty days or it is reclassified as dead and closed. A pending dream that receives neither is the most expensive position in this chapter.

Part Three: The Reckoning (Sitting Three)

Count the life that was built, in the six domains of Section 28.6.

1. The people who exist because of the decision. By name.

2. The capability accumulated. What I can do now that I could not do at the age I set the dream down.

3. The obligations discharged. What was paid, maintained, funded, and kept afloat — taken from records, not from memory.

4. The standing in the community. Where I am consulted, relied upon, or expected.

5. The competence of the man in the present. What I now possess that the imagined man at twenty-two did not.

6. The life lived in the interval. The occasions, places, friendships, marriages, and events that the imagined life would not have contained.

Then write the two sentences of Section 28.6, in your own words, in a single document.

Sentence one:

Sentence two:

28.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is it not a waste of a man's time to grieve a plan he abandoned twenty years ago?"

The material is being carried whether or not it is addressed, and its carrying has costs: the continuous comparison described in Section 28.3, the deficiency by which the man's actual life is measured, and the availability of the material to be triggered by an obituary or a reunion. The work in the exercise takes about three sittings, and men report that the reduction in the incidence of the material is out of proportion to the effort. The investment is therefore not the grieving of an old plan; it is the removal of an open item that has been occupying the man's attention for a period measured in decades.

"Everyone has dreams that did not work out. Why should mine be treated as a loss?"

Because they are losses, and the universality of a loss does not reduce it. The universality does, however, explain why nobody offers the man anything for it, and that is precisely the reason the chapter asks him to construct the four elements himself. Furthermore, the position is not uniform: the men who carry a dead dream without any process are the ones who are occupied by it at fifty-five, whereas the men who have, in whatever form, acknowledged the loss and conducted a reckoning are generally able to describe it without the accompanying event.

"My wife and children would feel blamed if I said that I gave something up for them."

The framing requirement addresses this directly, and it is the element of the method that most frequently fails when it is conducted without preparation. The man must establish, before he describes the loss, that the decision was correct, that he would repeat it, and that he is not asking for it to be reopened. The case in Section 28.7 illustrates the order: the disclaimer first, the account second. Where the man is unable to state the disclaimer sincerely, the disclosure should not be made; the work of Sections 28.4 and 28.6 can be conducted with a witness outside the household.

"What if the dream is still possible and I simply have not done it?"

Then it is pending, and the requirement is the first step within thirty days. The chapter's position on this category is deliberately strict, because this is the position that produces the largest and most prolonged damage: a live dream that is not advanced. Men in this position frequently report that they have been *meaning to* begin for a decade, and the report is generally accompanied by the whole of the material in Chapter 24. The choice is between the step and the closing; both are legitimate; the prolongation is not.

"I have tried to let it go and it comes back."

Which is the expected pattern, and the reason the chapter prescribes a process rather than an attitude. The material returns on triggers, and it will continue to return so long as it has not been described, accounted for, witnessed, and marked. The measures in Section 28.4 are the ones that alter the pattern in men's own reports; the resolution to stop thinking about a matter is not among them.

"My dream was blocked by my family. Am I supposed to say that I was prevented?"

No, and the chapter's material on the fourth process in Section 28.2 is written for this position. The facts may be stated accurately and the requirement remains the same: the accounting of what the alternative would have cost, since the alternative in this case carried not only the dream but the rupture with the people who opposed it, and that rupture has a price that the imagined life does not include. Where the man's reading of the events is that he was prevented, the useful work is the separation of the two questions: what happened, and what the man chooses to hold about it now. The first is a matter for the record; the second is a matter for the reckoning in Section 28.6.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 28 in brief. Dreams fall into eight categories — vocational, educational, entrepreneurial, migratory, creative, family and legacy, place and life, and bodily — and must be distinguished from images, from obligations, and from dreams the man never held. A real dream has a plan, belongs to the man, and can be described at the moment it was decided, the person it was told to, the step that was attempted, and the point at which it stopped. Once sorted, dreams are either dead or pending, and the two require different work.

Seven processes kill a dream quietly: the substitution of duty for the dream, in which the man repeatedly chooses his obligations and would choose them again; the narrowing produced by money, in which the income covers obligations and never plans; the failure that ended the route, whose effect is produced not by the failure but by the verdict the man attaches to it; the requirement of another person, which cannot be stated without indicting somebody; the slow erosion, in which the dream is simply not advanced and there is no event to attribute; the decision made on somebody else's timetable; and the loss of the person with whom the dream was shared. All four features of the class follow: none produces an event, each involves a decision the man would repeat, each is compatible with a functioning life, and each produces a comparison that operates continuously.

The ache of such a dream is that nobody was informed, and therefore none of the ordinary functions of acknowledgement is available. The man anticipates five responses — the practical solution, the minimisation, the accusation, the retrospective verdict, and the silence — and the silence is the most common and the most discouraging. The man does not grieve the dream for four reasons: there is no event, he chose it, he is supposed to be over it, and the loss is not of a thing but of a version

of himself. Two comparisons operate continuously: with the men who went, and with the version of himself who took the path. The second is the stronger and it is rigged, since the imagined life is composed of the dream's benefits and none of its costs.

The grief is conducted without an audience through four elements: the account written in the past tense, the accounting of the reasons including the alternative's costs, the witness, and the marker. A dream that dies late — on retirement, on the last child's completion, on a bereavement, on a medical event, or on an encounter — produces four characteristic errors: attempting to resume the original form, treating the discovery as a verdict about the whole life, closing it in anger, and transferring it to a son as an assignment. Its correct handling is to establish what remains available, to distinguish the dream's content from its form, to set a deadline and a first step, and to close what is genuinely closed.

The final work is the reckoning with the life that was built instead, counted in six domains: the people who exist because of the decision, the capability accumulated, the obligations discharged, the standing in the community, the competence of the man in the present, and the life lived in the interval. It is completed with two sentences that must both be present: the man set down this and would decide the same again, and what he built instead is real and counted. A closed dream is not a regret — a regret concerns a decision believed wrong, a closed dream concerns a decision believed right whose cost is being acknowledged — and the closing does not end ambition. It frees the capacity that the open dream was consuming.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the inventory in Part One. How many of the items on your list are dreams, and how many are images, obligations, or somebody else's account?
2. Which of the seven processes in Section 28.2 ended the dream you carry most heavily? What does the process explain about why the loss has never been named?
3. Of the five anticipated responses in Section 28.3, which one have you actually received, and which one have you been avoiding by not speaking?
4. Write the accounting of the alternative's costs, as Section 28.4 requires. What did the imagined life not contain?
5. Which of your dreams is pending, and what is the first step you can take in the next seven days? If you will not take it, what is the date on which it will be closed?
6. Complete the six domains in Part Three. Which domain produced the largest correction to your account of your life?
7. Write both sentences from Section 28.6. Which of the two have you been holding without the other, and what has that cost you?

Further Reading

- **On mid-life review and the sense of time remaining:** the research on mid-life psychosocial development, including the evidence on generativity, the re-evaluation that commonly occurs in the fifth and sixth decades, and the findings on how the perception of remaining time alters motivation and priorities.
- **On disenfranchised grief:** the literature on losses that are not socially recognised or publicly mourned, including the findings on ambiguous loss, the effects of the absence of social acknowledgement, and the practices that have been developed for conducting such grief.
- **On possible selves and counterfactual thinking:** the research on possible selves and on counterfactual reasoning, including the findings on the effects of comparing an actual life with the imagined alternatives to it, and the conditions under which counterfactual thinking is useful rather than corrosive.
- **On the achievement of goals and their abandonment:** the literature on goal disengagement and re-engagement, including the evidence that the capacity to abandon an unattainable goal and to identify a substitute is associated with better wellbeing than persistence in the unattainable goal.
- **On retirement and identity:** the research on retirement adjustment and identity, including the findings on the mid-life and retirement transitions, the losses that accompany the ending of an occupation, and the factors that predict a better adjustment.
- **Practical resources:** vocational and career guidance services, including those for adults; adult education and part-time qualification routes; men's groups and discussion groups in which the material can be witnessed; financial and retirement planning services; and the material in Appendices I, K, and N.

29 CHAPTER

Living With Regrets Nobody Knows About

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Distinguish regret from remorse, and explain why the distinction determines the correct treatment of each.
2. Identify the categories of regret that men carry privately, and assess which of them are repairable, partially repairable, or irreparable.
3. Explain the mechanisms by which an undisclosed regret continues to operate: rumination, the counterfactual loop, and the private standard that others do not know is in force.
4. Recognise the difference between regret that supplies a correction and regret that has become a punishment, and apply the criteria that separate them.
5. Construct a repair where repair is possible, in the form required by the material — acknowledgement, restitution, and the statement of what will be different.
6. Conduct the work required for an irreparable matter, including the position on self-punishment, the limits of what a man may legitimately require of himself, and the redirection of the material into conduct.

Introduction

There is a category of material that men carry privately in a form the previous chapters have not fully addressed. It is not a failure of provision, not a loss, and not a concealed weakness. It is a record of a specific past act or omission for which the man holds himself responsible and which he regards as something he should not have done.

This chapter concerns those regrets, and specifically the ones nobody knows about.

The distinction in the chapter's title matters. Almost every man's regrets include items that are known: the household knows about the business that failed, the family knows about the years of absence, the wife knows about the money that

was lost. Those regrets are conducted in company, in whatever form the company provides, and their material is addressed in Parts III to VI. The regrets nobody knows about are a different class, because they have no audience and therefore no correction.

They are frequently not large events. In men's accounts they are unremarkable acts that occurred in a moment of pressure, tiredness, fear, or convenience and that the man has never described to anybody: the thing said in anger that a man's wife has been told about but nobody else has; the decision made at a critical moment in a way that failed a child, a brother, a friend, or a colleague; the money that was not repaid, the visit that was not made, the letter that was not sent, the chance that was not taken on somebody's behalf, the person who was not stood up for when standing up for him was possible; the dishonesty that was never discovered; the act of cowardice in a situation in which a young man believed he would have performed better; the treatment of somebody who could not answer back.

Three observations structure the chapter.

The first is that regret and remorse must be distinguished, and the distinction is not a matter of vocabulary. Regret concerns an outcome that a man wishes had been different. Remorse concerns conduct that the man judges to have been wrong, and it carries an obligation: something is owed. Men frequently treat one as the other, and both errors have costs. A man who treats an error of judgement, a decision that turned out badly, or an available choice he made under conditions he could not control as though it were a moral failure will carry an obligation that cannot be discharged, since nothing was owed. A man who treats a genuine wrong as an unfortunate outcome will never conduct the repair, and the material will remain in the form described in Section 29.3.

The second is that the correct response to a regret is determined by whether the matter can be repaired and not by how the man feels about it. This is the reason the chapter devotes a substantial section to the classification of regrets, and it is the practical core of the material: repairable matters are repaired, and irreparable matters are conducted in a manner that the chapter specifies precisely, because the alternatives — indefinite rumination or an artificial, cheap absolution — both fail.

The third is that a man is not required to be at peace. The chapter does not propose that the work will remove the material or that a properly conducted reckoning leaves nothing behind. Some regrets do not close. What the work supplies is that the material ceases to operate as a private punishment and is converted into conduct: a matter that is carried with accuracy, that contributes to what the man does, and that no longer consumes the attention it consumed before.

29.1 The Regrets Men Carry

The material in this chapter is stable across men's accounts, and it clusters. Nine categories cover the great majority of what men report when they are finally able to describe it.

The Nine Categories

1. The decision that failed somebody. The man made a choice that had a consequence for another person: he declined the guarantee, refused the loan, opposed the marriage, advised against the treatment, chose one child's schooling over another's, decided not to move, decided not to return. This category is the most common, and its characteristic feature is that the man's decision may have been defensible in itself and is nonetheless connected to a harm that he now sees in the light of everything that followed.

2. The failure to act. The refusal or omission at a moment that required action: the man did not intervene, did not speak, did not attend, did not sign, did not report, did not go back. This category carries the heaviest weight in men's accounts and it is frequently the smallest act on the list: a telephone call not made, a statement not put, a person not stood up for, a matter left to somebody else. Men describe a specific and durable form: *the moment lasted thirty seconds and I have carried it for twenty-five years.*

3. The words said. The statement made in anger, contempt, exhaustion, or drink to a wife, a child, a parent, a subordinate, a friend. The material is generally known in part, since the circumstances are frequently known, and the actual content is not: the specific words, the setting, and what the man's face did when he said them.

4. The words not said. The acknowledgement never made, the apology never delivered, the appreciation never expressed, the last conversation that did not occur. Its weight is generally discovered late, and this category is the one most frequently reported in the years following a bereavement.

5. The person not attended to. The parent who was cared for competently and not known; the wife who was provided for and not regarded; the child whose years passed in the man's preoccupation; the friend whose deterioration was noticed and not addressed. This category is the substance of Chapters 17 and 18 and it is present in the material of the chapter with a specific addition: what the man regrets is not the absence of provision but the absence of attention at a time when attention was available.

6. The money. The debt not repaid, the man who was held to an obligation that the debtor could have softened, the partner who was not properly compensated, the family member whose share was not defended, the person who was treated unfairly in an arrangement the man controlled. This category is repairable

considerably more often than men believe, which is the reason Section 29.5 treats it at length.

7. The failure to protect. The specific and severe category: the man did not protect somebody to whom he owed protection. A child from the conduct of another adult; a sibling from a violent parent; a wife from his own household's treatment of her; a younger colleague from an injustice that the man's position could have prevented; a subordinate from a supervisor; a family from a debt that his own conduct incurred. Men carry this material the longest of any category, and it is the one for which the material in Section 29.6 is most frequently required.

8. The compromise. The man's own conduct in a system that required something of him: the false declaration to support a family, the payment to a policeman, the accounts that were prepared falsely, the colleague whose contribution was taken, the examination that was not honestly passed, the work that was signed off when the standard was not met. The category is frequently accompanied by the man's own rationalisation, and the rationalisation is generally accurate as far as necessity goes and does not resolve the material.

9. The particular act never described to anybody. The category the chapter exists for. An act the man has never disclosed in any form: an episode of dishonesty, an act of cowardice, a betrayal of somebody who trusted him, an abandonment, an involvement in somebody's harm, a cruelty in youth, an act he regards as being completely out of character and which therefore cannot be reconciled with the account he holds of himself. Its purpose is not the induction of shame; it is the accurate recognition that this class of material is the one that produces the condition described in Sections 29.2 and 29.3, and that the work of the chapter must be capable of handling it.

The Distinction That Organises the List

Once the material has been listed, each item falls into one of three classes, and the class determines the work.

Class One: the error. The decision that turned out badly and that was not wrong in itself. The man made a competent judgement on the information available and the outcome was adverse. Class One items require a specific form of work and it is the opposite of what the man generally applies to them: the establishment of the facts as they stood at the time, without the benefit of the outcome, which is the hindsight correction described in Chapter 16.5. Nothing is owed, and the material is to be closed by accurate assessment rather than by repair.

Class Two: the wrong. The conduct that was wrong when it was done, on the information available at the time. The man knew what he was doing, or could have known, and did it. Class Two items carry an obligation, and the obligation is dischargeable to the extent that repair is possible.

Class Three: the tragedy. The situation in which the man's conduct was defensible, the outcome was severe, and the man's responsibility is real but partial: the decision distributed among circumstances, other people's conduct, and the man's own contribution. Class Three is the most common and the most difficult, because it requires the man to hold a real degree of responsibility without either denying it — which is what the culture's response supplies — or inflating it into full authorship of an outcome he did not control.

> **KEY POINT**
> Men's private regrets cluster in nine categories, and their treatment is determined not by how heavily the man carries them but by their class: the error, in which the decision was competent and the outcome was bad; the wrong, in which the conduct was wrong at the time and an obligation is owed; and the tragedy, in which the man's responsibility is real and partial. Class One is closed by accurate assessment, Class Two by repair, and Class Three by the difficult work of holding real but partial responsibility.

29.2 Why the Regrets Nobody Knows About Are the Heaviest

The private class of regret operates differently from the disclosed class, and the difference is not a matter of severity. Men report that a disclosed regret of a large event is carried more easily than an undisclosed regret of a small one, and the reasons are structural.

The Five Mechanisms

1. There is no correction available. The chapter has returned to this mechanism repeatedly because it is the mechanism of the whole book. A disclosed regret is corrected by the version of events that somebody else holds, and the correction frequently alters the material: what the man remembers as contempt is recalled by his wife as exhaustion; what he remembers as a decision made in thirty seconds was in fact made over months. An undisclosed regret receives no correction, so the man's account of it is the only account, and it has been constructed, over years, in private, from the least favourable available materials.

2. The material is protected from the disclosure that would alter it. The reason the material is held privately is generally that its disclosure would cost the man something, and the cost is frequently accurate: the disclosure of the act, the words, or the omission would change how a specific person sees him. The material is therefore secure in its place, which means it is never revised.

3. The material is carried without the ordinary permission to be affected. A disclosed difficulty is met by others with acknowledgement, and the acknowledgement supplies the man's permission to be troubled. The private material receives none, so the man holds it in a form in which he cannot raise

it, cannot indicate that he is occupied, and cannot receive company — while the material operates continuously. The pattern is the one described in Chapter 27.3: the man is surrounded by people and has no recipient for the item that most occupies his attention.

4. The private standard is not known to anybody. This mechanism is subtle and important. The man holds a standard of conduct which he has violated, and the standard is his own. His wife, his family, and his community do not know the standard was in force, so they cannot assess the size of the violation. The consequence is that the material has no external scale at all: the man measures it against his own account, which is at once the most demanding scale available and the least calibrated, since nobody has ever said that the matter was smaller than he thinks.

5. The material is available to be triggered without warning and without explanation. The man encounters the situation, the person, the place, or the circumstance of the original event, and the material returns. Because nobody knows, nobody can make sense of the man's response, and the man must manage it in public without the ordinary arrangements that a known difficulty supplies. Men describe this pattern precisely: the sudden flatness at an occasion, the withdrawal from a conversation, the unnecessary harshness in an unrelated matter.

The Reason Men Keep Them

Four reasons, and each is accurate in its terms.

The first is the cost of disclosure. The material concerns something the man did, and its disclosure exposes him to judgement rather than to sympathy. There is no available construction of the disclosure as a misfortune.

The second is the harm to the people who now know. A man who discloses a wrong committed against a dead parent, a departed wife, or a person who is now absent creates a new burden for the living.

The third is the position it would place others in. A disclosure frequently implicates other people: the relative who encouraged the man, the friend who participated, the family that benefited. The material is frequently held in order to protect those people.

The fourth is the man's determination to carry it. A distinct and important reason, and one that men state openly when they are finally able to describe the position: the man has decided that the matter should not be set down. *I deserve to carry it* is the sentence, and it is occasionally correct in its reasoning and almost always damaging in its consequence, and Section 29.6 addresses it directly.

29.3 The Anatomy of Regret

Regret has a structure, and the structure is important because the man's difficulty is generally not the original event but the process the event has been operating since.

The Five Components

1. The event. What occurred, with its date, its setting, and its participants. The event is fixed and small, and men are frequently surprised, when they describe it for the first time, by how short the account is. This is because the event has been compressed and expanded alternately in the man's mind over a period of years.

2. The counterfactual. The alternative the man constructs: what would have happened if he had acted differently. The counterfactual is the single most important component of the material, and it is generally unfounded. The man's construction has three characteristic properties: it is certain — *if I had gone back, he would have recovered*; it is complete — the alternative is imagined through to a good outcome, with none of the intermediate complications; and it is favourable to the man's self-accusation, since the alternative always displays him as effective and the actual event displays him as he was. The research on counterfactual thinking identifies a consistent finding that is useful here: the ease of constructing an alternative is not evidence that the alternative was available.

3. The verdict. The conclusion the man has drawn about himself: that he is a coward, that he is not the man he believed he was, that he failed the one test that mattered. The verdict is the component that converts an event into an identity, and it is the material of Chapters 21 and 24.

4. The debt. The position that something is owed, and that it has not been paid. The debt may be owed to a person, to an outcome, or, in the private class, to nobody the man can identify, which is what makes it durable: a debt to an unnamed creditor is carried indefinitely, because there is no transaction that could settle it.

5. The management. The practices the man has developed to keep the material out of view: the avoidance of the place, the person, or the subject; the compensating conduct described in Section 29.4; the drinking at particular hours; the busyness; the silence at particular moments. The management is the largest component in terms of the man's daily life, and it is the one that most frequently produces the effects the man attributes to the original event.

The Two Operating Modes

Regret operates in two modes, and the distinction determines everything in Sections 29.4 to 29.6.

The corrective mode. The material is available, has been examined, and supplies information the man acts upon. It functions as a standard: it is not revisited

continuously, it does not produce the verdict, and it is engaged when a comparable situation arises. Men describe this mode accurately: *I do not dwell on it. It is part of what I know about myself, and it makes me careful in the specific way that it should.*

The punitive mode. The material operates as a standing sentence. It is revisited without being examined, the counterfactual is replayed without being corrected, the verdict is sustained, and no conduct is altered by the material because the function of the operation is not correction but sentence. Men describe this mode in terms that are consistent across cases: the material arrives at particular times — the early hours, the long drive, the specific date, the anniversary, the month — and it produces a specific sensation of exposure, lowness, and, in a substantial proportion of cases, the belief that the man's ordinary contentment is illegitimate.

The Five Markers of the Punitive Mode

The following five markers distinguish the punitive mode, and each is a practical criterion that the reader can apply.

1. The material is replayed without alteration. The account the man rehearses is identical to the account he rehearsed a decade ago. New information has never entered it and the counterfactual has never been tested.

2. No conduct has been altered by it. The material is not producing any change in how the man acts; it is producing only an alteration in how he feels. This is the most useful criterion of the five, and it is the one that decides the treatment.

3. The material is held privately and its disclosure is refused. The punitive mode protects its material: the man declines the disclosure even where the disclosure is affordable, on the grounds that the matter should not be raised, which for a punitive-mode item is generally a statement about the sentence rather than about the audience.

4. The man's ordinary goods are treated as illegitimate. The household, the position, the children's progress, and the man's own satisfaction are treated as though they were obtained fraudulently or are not entirely his to enjoy. This marker is the one that produces the pattern described in Chapter 7 and it is the reason the material in this chapter and in Chapter 24 are adjacent.

5. The material escalates in response to low mood, alcohol, or anniversary. The escalation is the marker: a corrective item is stable across states, and a punitive item is amplified by states, which indicates that the material is operating as an instrument of self-sanction rather than as a source of information.

The Figure of the Two Modes

The mechanism is set out in Figure 29.1, which distinguishes the two modes and, for each, identifies the specific intervention required. The diagram is conceptual

and generalised; the two modes are not fixed states, and men move between them, frequently in the space of a single evening.

The corrective mode	The punitive mode
The material is examined once and then held as information.	The material is replayed without alteration, frequently for decades.
It supplies a standard the man acts upon in comparable situations.	It alters no conduct; its only product is the man's private condition.
It is stable across states: low mood, drink, and anniversaries do not alter it.	It escalates with low mood, drink, and anniversaries.
The man's ordinary goods are not affected by it.	The man's ordinary goods are treated as illegitimate or unearned.
Its conduct is visible: the man intervenes, attends, speaks, repays.	Its conduct is avoidance: the place, the person, and the subject are declined.

Figure 29.1 The two modes in which a regret operates. The corrective mode supplies a standard the man acts upon; the punitive mode sustains a sentence and alters no conduct. The right-hand column gives the intervention required in each mode, and the marker that distinguishes them is stated at the foot.

29.4 The Uses and the Abuses of Regret

Regret is not a defect of character and it serves a documented function. It also has a documented capacity to do harm, and the chapter requires the man to distinguish the two in his own material.

The Uses

1. Correction. The material supplies the specific information required for the man to behave differently in comparable circumstances: the moment at which he should have spoken, the warning he should have noticed, the commitment he should have documented, the person he should have asked, the conduct he should avoid in drink. Men report that this function works when the material has been examined once and stored in this form rather than replayed.

2. Prevention. The generalised form: the man who has failed a person through cowardice becomes a man who intervenes in comparable situations, frequently at cost, for the remainder of his life. This is the function described in Section 29.6: the material converted into conduct. It is the most useful outcome available and it is the one the chapter pursues for irreparable matters.

3. The calibration of a man's standard. A man without regret has no evidence that his standard is operative. The regret is a demonstration that the man's values are real to him, and men in the corrective mode describe the material with a specific quality: they wish it had not occurred, and they recognise that it is evidence of what they hold.

4. The grounds of a man's treatment of others. Men who have failed somebody are frequently, subsequently, the men who stand with those who are failing: they visit the hospital, they attend the funeral, they make the call. This function's record in practice is strong, and it is included because the men who carry the heaviest material are frequently, in their conduct, the most reliable.

The Abuses

1. Rumination. The replay without examination described in Section 29.3. The literature on rumination identifies its central feature accurately: the process feels like work while doing none, and it consumes the attention that the corresponding corrective function would require in a fraction of the time. A man who has replayed an event four hundred times has not examined it once.

2. Self-punishment. The maintenance of the sentence, and its specific feature is that it consumes the man's capacity without supplying anything to the person harmed. Section 29.6 addresses it at length, and the central proposition is worth stating here: an unrepaid debt to the person harmed is not discharged by the man's suffering, and where a man's suffering is the only payment being made, the ledger has been redirected rather than settled.

3. Compensation in the wrong direction. A distinct pattern with substantial costs, described in more detail in Section 29.7: the man who failed his younger brother becomes the over-attentive father of a son; the man who was absent from a dying parent's bedside becomes the man who will not permit his children to leave; the man who did not speak up becomes a man who speaks with disproportionate force. The compensations are real efforts and they are directed at people who were not the injured parties, which means the original debt remains and a new set of arrangements is imposed on people who did not require them.

4. The denial of the man's present standing. The practice of conducting the man's life in the shadow of the material, described in Chapter 7: the position declined, the pursuit abandoned, the attention that the man regards himself as

not entitled to. The abuse is frequently presented as humility and its mechanism is a refusal of the man's actual standing, which does not benefit anybody.

5. The avoidance of the specific place or person. The management described in Section 29.3 as the fifth component: the man does not attend the village, does not visit the person, does not speak to the relative, does not open the letter. The avoidance is expensive in a specific way: it removes exactly the arrangements through which the matter might be repaired or, where it cannot be repaired, acknowledged.

29.5 Repairing What Can Be Repaired

The classification in Section 29.1 determines the work, and Class Two — the wrong — is the class in which an obligation exists and a repair may be possible. This section sets out the repair in the form required by the material.

The Four Repairable Forms

1. The obligation to a person who is available. The debt, the damage, the unfair arrangement, the wound that was inflicted on somebody the man still sees. This is the most common repairable form and the most frequently deferred. The repair has three parts, set out below.

2. The obligation to a household. The man's conduct has damaged a household arrangement: the money was taken from a purpose it was committed to, the affair created an arrangement of concealment, the violence produced a household that manages the man rather than living with him. The repair in these cases is generally longer, involves conduct rather than a statement, and is frequently conducted in the presence of an arrangement outside the household — a counsellor, a mediator, a professional arrangement — because the household's own resources have been spent. Chapters 18 and 22 to 23 provide the material.

3. The obligation to a person who is dead. The repair is to the available relation: to the surviving spouse, the children, the estate, the record. Men report the specific finding that the repair of a matter with a dead person through the living relative is not a substitute and does relieve the position, for the reason given in Section 29.6: the material is converted into conduct that reaches somebody.

4. The obligation with no identifiable creditor. The category of the private wrong: the man was involved in something that harmed people he cannot name, at a time and in a system he cannot now repair. In this case the repair takes the redirection form of Section 29.6, and the requirement is that the redirection correspond in some stated way to the original harm rather than being a general charitable gesture.

The Three Parts of a Repair

Part One: The acknowledgement. The man states what he did, to the person concerned, without qualification, without the explanation that converts it into a defence, and without requesting anything.

The rules for the acknowledgement are specific, and their violation is the most common reason a repair fails:

Do not explain. Explanation, even when accurate, converts the acknowledgement into a case. Where the circumstances genuinely mitigate the matter, they should be offered after the acknowledgement and only if the other person asks.

Do not defend. The phrases that begin *but you also* or *if you had* terminate the repair and restart the original dispute.

Do not request anything. Not forgiveness, not confirmation that the matter is closed, not an acknowledgement that the man has acted well. The request converts the acknowledgement into a transaction in which the injured person is required to supply something, which is the reverse of the repair.

Do not use the past tense to distribute the responsibility. *Mistakes were made* and *things happened* are forms of non-acknowledgement. The man's own act is the subject of the sentence.

Accept that the response may be adverse. The acknowledgement may produce anger, refusal, silence, or an account of the matter that the man does not recognise. The man's position should be that he has supplied the acknowledgement and that the response is not his to manage or to correct.

Part Two: The restitution. The material element, where one exists: the repayment, the compensation, the property returned, the correction of the record, the arrangement restored, the obligation performed. Restitution is the part of the repair that men omit and it is the part that the injured party most frequently requires, since the acknowledgement without restitution is a statement and the restitution without the acknowledgement is a payment.

Where the material sum is large relative to the man's capacity, the restitution is conducted in the form used in debt settlement and it is worth setting out: the full accounting of what is owed, presented to the person and stated without concealment; the offer of what can be paid; the schedule with dates; and the performance of the schedule without requiring further contact. The findings from practice are consistent: a partial restitution performed with accuracy is worth substantially more to both parties than an indefinite intention to repay in full.

Part Three: The statement of what will be different. The specific commitment about the man's future conduct, stated to the person concerned where that is appropriate and written in the record where it is not. The statement must be specific and checkable, following the standard used elsewhere in this book: not *I will be a better father*, but *I will attend every school event, and I will not be absent*

from the house on Sundays. The third part's function is to convert the repair from a transaction about the past into an arrangement about the future, which is what the injured party most frequently requires.

What the Repair Does Not Require

The injured party's forgiveness. The repair is conducted for the man's obligation, and the response is a separate matter. The research and the practice both indicate that the absence of forgiveness does not leave the repair incomplete: a wrong acknowledged and made good is a repaired wrong whether or not the relationship is restored, and the man's position afterward is that of a man who has discharged his obligation rather than a man who has been pardoned.

The restoration of the relationship. The relationship may continue, in a changed form, or not at all. The man should consider that the restoration is a separate request and that it should not be attached to the acknowledgement.

The repetition of the disclosure. Having stated the matter once, the man does not return to it, and does not require the injured party to discuss it again. Where the man requires a recipient for the material beyond the injured party, the recipient is the witness described in Section 29.6.

The Common Failure

The most common failure of a repair is a repair that is too small and too late and that is conducted for the man's relief rather than for the obligation. Its signs are recognisable: the acknowledgement is delivered as a means of obtaining reassurance; the man's performance of the restitution is incomplete; the statement of what will be different is general; and the man's subsequent account makes clear that he has settled the matter in his own mind while continuing to behave in the conduct that caused it. Men should apply a simple test before beginning: if I could not tell anybody that I had done this, would I still do it? A repair that requires an audience is not a repair.

29.6 What Cannot Be Repaired

This section addresses the class of material for which no repair is available: the person is dead, the harm is permanent, the act is past and the person may never know, or the harm was distributed across people and years in a way that no acknowledgement can address.

The Available Positions

Four positions exist, and the man is generally operating one of them whether or not he has chosen it.

1. The indefinite sentence. The material is carried as a standing penalty. Its costs: it alters no conduct, it consumes the man's attention, it renders his ordinary goods illegitimate, and it does nothing for the person harmed, who, being dead

or absent, is not the beneficiary of the suffering. This is the default position, and it is where most men with an irreparable matter are.

2. The forgetting that does not occur. The attempt to put the material away: the place avoided, the subject closed, the paperwork destroyed, the years passed in the practice described in Chapter 9. Its characteristic failure is that the material is not put away but relocated, and it returns in the forms described in Section 29.3 with the addition of the man's anxiety about the material itself.

3. The cheap absolution. The matter is dismissed in the man's own account by a general proposition: *everybody makes mistakes; it was another time; I was young; nobody is perfect; I have done more good than harm.* The position is cheap in a precise sense: it is obtained without cost, and it is unstable, because the man does not believe it and must maintain it against his own knowledge. Its practical form in the material is well documented: the man who asserts his absolution most firmly is frequently the man who is most occupied by the matter.

4. The carrying with accuracy. The position the chapter recommends, and it should be described precisely, because it is not comfortable and it is not a resolution. It consists of five elements.

The Five Elements of Carrying With Accuracy

Element One: The account, stated once and completely. In writing, in the man's own hand, with the event, the man's own conduct, the harm caused, and the man's assessment of what he did. There is no requirement to be fair to himself in this document and there is a requirement to be accurate: the account should distinguish what the man did from what he could not control, which is the work of Class Three in Section 29.1.

Element Two: The witness. One person who receives the account, in the form described in the repair: the statement of the act, without explanation, without defence, and without a request. The witness is generally not a member of the family and not somebody who would be harmed by the knowledge. Where the material is severe, the witness should be a professional.

The function of the witness requires some explanation, because it is the element men most frequently refuse. The man has been the sole holder of the material, and he has held it as an account that exists only in his own mind. Delivered to a person who receives it without either judgement or absolution, the account becomes a fact in the world, held by two people, and this changes the man's relation to it in the specific manner described in Chapter 27.3: the account, delivered aloud, alters in the man's own hearing. Men who have conducted this element consistently report that the material is thereafter present in a different form: present, acknowledged, and not requiring management.

Element Three: The stated position on self-punishment. Written by the man, and it addresses the fourth reason from Section 29.2 directly. Its content is the man's own answer to the question of what his suffering has achieved. The following points are the ones used in practice, and the man should adopt only those he can state honestly in his own words.

The material's cost is not discharged by the man's suffering. If the suffering were a payment, the account would need a recipient, and there is none: the person harmed is not assisted by the man's early hours or by the occasions he declines.

The suffering is not the same thing as the matter. The man's punishment is a private arrangement that he maintains; the matter is the harm he caused. The two are related and they are distinct, and one does not reduce the other.

The further cost that self-punishment imposes is paid by people who did not cause the harm. The household that lives with a man who is unavailable at particular moments, the children who receive a reduced version of their father, the work that is not attempted — the ledger of the man's self-punishment is charged to people who had no part in the original event.

The energy is the remaining resource. A man's attention and capacity are finite, and the same capacity that is consumed by the punitive mode is the capacity that would be required for the repair of what can still be repaired, or for the conduct described in Element Four.

Element Four: The redirection into conduct. The material is converted into conduct that corresponds to the harm. This element is the one that men report as the most effective and it is the one the chapter asks the reader to construct with care.

The correspondence should be stated, so that it is not a general benevolence: a man whose regret concerns a young man he failed becomes a man who intervenes with young men; a man whose regret concerns a parent he did not attend to becomes a man who visits the old; a man whose regret concerns a family he left in difficulty becomes a man whose obligations are discharged with accuracy and without publicising; a man whose regret concerns the silence he kept becomes a man who speaks at the moment when speaking is possible.

The rule of the correspondence is that the conduct must be of the same kind as the harm and must be performed without the requirement that it be observed. Conduct that is performed in the man's visible account — the public charitable act in respect of a private matter — is generally a substitute for the work rather than the work, and men who have conducted this element well report that it is almost entirely unobserved.

Element Five: The dated reckoning. The material is conducted once more on a stated date, annually or at the interval the man chooses, and the reckoning is a review rather than a rehearsal: what has the conduct of the past year been; has

the statement of what will be different held; is there any part of the matter that has become available for repair? The element's function is to establish that the material has been conducted, and its practical benefit in men's accounts is that the remaining fifty-one weeks are relieved of the material: it has a place, it holds a date, and it is not required to arrive unannounced.

What This Work Does Not Promise

The chapter records the limits plainly. The material does not disappear. Men who have conducted the work describe the regret as present but not occupying: it is available, it is an accurate part of the man's knowledge of himself, and it no longer arrives as a sentence. Men describe a specific change in its occasion: it is engaged when they do the corresponding conduct, and not otherwise. Two men may conduct the same work and one may find that the material arises several times a year and another that it arises twice; both positions are within the range the chapter describes, and neither is a failure.

The chapter's final position on the irreparable is stated in the form used in the practice literature and it is worth recording in its own right: a man is not required to be at peace with a matter that is not at peace. He is required to carry it accurately, to make good what can still be made good, to convert the remainder into conduct, and to refuse the arrangement in which his own suffering is treated as payment for a harm that does not benefit from it.

29.7 The Prohibition on Transferring the Debt

Before the case material, the chapter addresses one practice directly, because it is common, it is well-intentioned, and it damages people who were not involved.

The Pattern

A man carries an obligation he cannot discharge — to a dead parent, an estranged sibling, a person he failed, a family he left — and he converts it into an obligation imposed on somebody else. The forms are recognisable.

The father who was absent for his eldest son's childhood becomes the man who cannot permit his youngest daughter to leave the house.

The man who did not attend his father's funeral becomes the man who insists on the family's attendance at every obligation, enforced with disproportionate force.

The man who failed to protect a younger brother becomes a man who monitors his own sons' friendships, schools, and whereabouts so closely that the boys' accounts of childhood are dominated by surveillance.

The man whose own education was interrupted becomes a man who requires a particular course of study from a child who has a different capacity and a different wish.

The man whose honesty failed in a specific matter becomes a man who insists on a rigidity of procedure in his household which produces, in the case material, children who conceal ordinary matters in order to avoid the man's response.

Why It Occurs

The mechanism is straightforward and the chapter states it without accusation. The man's obligation is real, his capacity to discharge it is absent, and his attention is consequently organised around the material permanently. When a person becomes available who resembles the injured party, the man's obligation attaches to that person, and the attachment feels like the discharge of it. The man is frequently aware of the intensity of his attention and frequently unaware of its origin.

Why It Fails

It does not discharge the obligation. The debt belongs to a specific person or event, and the recipient of the transfer was not the injured party. The material's operation is unchanged, which is why the pattern tends to intensify over the years.

It imposes a debt that was not the child's. The mechanism is exactly the one described in Chapter 19: a young person carrying an obligation that was not his own, which produces either compliance and resentment, or refusal and the man's response to the refusal, which is experienced by the child as a judgement on his character rather than on his conduct.

It produces concealment in the household. Where the transferred obligation is enforced with intensity, the household's response is concealment rather than honesty, which is the arrangement described in Chapters 18 and 22, and which has the effect of removing the man's access to the very information through which his attention could be appropriately directed.

It removes the possibility of the man's own repair. The conversion of the material into the management of another person is a practice that consumes his attention without conducting any part of the work described in Section 29.6.

The Correction

The correction is specific and it consists of three acts.

Identify the transfer. The man writes out the obligation and, separately, the intensity of his attention to the person in his household, and states the connection in his own hand. Men report that the statement is generally sufficient to reveal the pattern: the intensity, once described, is recognised by the man as disproportionate.

State the obligation to its actual object. Where the injured party is available, this is the repair of Section 29.5. Where the injured party is dead or absent, the man states the obligation in writing, in the form of a letter that is not sent, or of a page in a private record, and he states what he owes and to whom.

Establish the household on the arrangement it actually requires. The specific forms of attention and requirement that the man's household and children actually require are the ones set out in Parts III and V, and they are generally different from the transferred obligation in two respects: they are smaller, and they are about the people concerned rather than about the man's material.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in counselling, mediation, and men's group practice. The material is a case of irreparable regret.

Damian is forty-eight, a civil engineer, married to Ngozi for twenty years, with three children. He was born in a village about three hours from the city in which he works, and he is the second of five children.

The matter at the centre of Damian's case occurred when he was twenty-three. His eldest brother, Peter, who was twenty-eight, had been responsible for the family's small transport business, one lorry and a car, and had, in the year of the events, been diagnosed with a heart condition and warned to reduce his work. The family required an additional driver and Peter asked Damian to take over the business's second vehicle for a period.

Damian had received an offer of employment in the city that year and he accepted it. He describes the conversation: *He asked me in the yard. I told him I had the job in the city and that I would be going in two weeks. He was quiet. He said it was fine. I did not tell him that I had not applied for the job yet and could have taken the lorry. I could have told him I would drive for six months and then go. I did not want to delay my own thing by six months and I did not want to say that out loud.*

Peter continued with both vehicles for eight months, and during that period his condition worsened and a further cardiac episode occurred. A replacement driver was found eventually, the business was not sustained, and Peter died at thirty-nine, eleven years later, of a heart attack.

Damian's account of the material contains the elements of Section 29.3 in their punitive form: the counterfactual (*if I had driven that lorry, the business would have held, he would not have worked, he would be alive*); the verdict (*I was a man who chose his own thing over his brother and I have known that about myself for twenty-five years*); the debt with no creditor he can reach (Peter died eleven years later, and Damian has no way of establishing what the intervening years would have contained); and the management, which consisted of four practices: he did not return to the village except for obligations, he did not discuss Peter in the household, he did not accept a management position offered to him at thirty-eight which would have required relocation, and he drank heavily at the period of the year in which the conversation in the yard had occurred.

The transfer described in Section 29.7 was also present and Damian was unaware of it until it was named: his second son, aged nineteen, wanted to study in another state, and Damian had refused to discuss it for two years, on grounds that were described

in the household as *he is too young*, and which Damian was, in his own words, *unable to explain to my wife without raising my voice*. The son's account of the position, which emerged in a family consultation, was: *My father will not let me go anywhere. He says it is about my studies. I have known for four years that it is about my uncle.*

The work Damian conducted occupied about five months and consisted of four elements.

The account. Written over three sittings: what occurred, what he was offered, what he refused, what he did not say, and what he actually controlled at twenty-three. The document distinguished, on the counsellor's instruction, three columns: the things I did; the things I could have done; and the things about which I decided nothing.

The witness. Damian gave the account in full to a counsellor and subsequently, at his own decision, to his sister, the eldest surviving sibling, in a conversation that lasted four hours. His account of the sister's response: *She said that she had known that Peter had asked me, and that she had never thought about it since, and that the family's view was that Peter's heart was the family's problem and not mine. She said it three times because I did not believe her the first two times.*

The stated position on self-punishment. Damian wrote a page in which he answered the question of what his suffering had achieved over twenty-five years. Three items in the page are worth recording. First, that Peter was not assisted by it. Second, that the position he had declined at thirty-eight had cost him an income that his household required. Third, that his son had been refused a course of study for two years because of a conversation held in a village yard when the son was not born.

The redirection. The form Damian chose came from the fact of the case: his son's position. He gave the permission, assisted with the enrolment, and took on, over the following three years, the mentorship of two young men in his workplace who were supporting their families and studying part-time. He describes this as *the lorry I did not drive, in a different shape*, and states that the correspondence is deliberate and that he does not discuss it with the young men.

The outcome Damian reported two years after the work was described in the following terms: *I have not stopped knowing what I did. I said no to my brother because I did not want to lose six months and I could not say that out loud, and he was dead eleven years later and I have no way of knowing whether it made any difference. What I stopped doing was paying for it every year with my own life. The reckoning is on the anniversary; my wife knows about the anniversary; my son is in another state and I am helping him, and I intervened for two young men at the office who do not know why I help them. There is nothing else I can do and I have done all of it.*

Four features of this case deserve isolation.

The material was an omission of thirty seconds in a yard. The man's own description of the case, and the reason it is included: the chapter's material is frequently of this size, and the man's sense of disproportion — *I have carried this for twenty-five years and it lasted half a minute* — is itself a component of the punitive mode and not a reason to consider the matter small.

The counterfactual was unfounded and the man could not test it. Peter died eleven years later of a heart condition, and the imagined alternative — that six months of driving would have altered the outcome a decade later — cannot be established. The case illustrates the finding from the counterfactual literature: ease of construction is not evidence, and men who construct the alternative with the greatest certainty are frequently constructing it on the least information.

The punitive mode was signalled by the escalation and the transfer. The drinking at the period of the year of the conversation, the declined position, and the two-year refusal of a son's plan. These are the markers of Section 29.3 and the transfer of Section 29.7, and the case is included because its most consequential feature was not the twenty-five-year rumination but the harm that the rumination was producing in the man's own household — a debt charged to a young man who was not involved.

The work did not remove the material; it altered what it produced. Damian's account two years later retains the knowledge, the regret, and the absence of any possibility of knowing the counterfactual. What has changed is its operation: it has a date, it is known to his wife, it has been described to one witness, it has been converted into conduct of a corresponding kind, and it is no longer charged to a child. This is precisely the position described at the end of Section 29.6 and it is the most that the chapter claims.

29.8 Practical Exercise: The Regret Inventory and the Plan

This exercise takes about three hours, over three sittings, and it is conducted entirely in writing. The material it concerns is private; the documents should be kept where the man keeps his private records, and the exercise does not require that any of them be shown to anybody except where a step of the plan specifies it.

Part One: The Inventory (Sitting One)

List the regrets you carry. The list should include the items you have never described to anybody, which is the purpose of the exercise. Five columns.

The matter	Date	Who was affected	What I did or did not do	Does anybody know?

Then, for the item you carry most heavily, apply the components of Section 29.3.

- **The event, described in no more than five sentences.** (Keep the description short; the length of the man's account is generally an indication that the event and the rumination have been confused.)
- **The counterfactual.** What I believe would have happened otherwise. Then, under it: **the evidence for that belief** — what do I actually know, and what am I constructing?

- **The verdict.** The conclusion I have drawn about myself.
- **The debt.** What I believe is owed, and to whom.
- **The management.** What I do to keep the matter out of view: the place, the person, the subject, the hour, the drinking, the busyness, the silence.

Part Two: The Classification and the Mode (Sitting Two)

Classification. For each item on the inventory, assign the class from Section 29.1.

Item	Class One (error)	Class Two (wrong)	Class Three (tragedy)	My reason

For each Class One item, record the facts as they stood at the time, without the benefit of the outcome, and state whether the decision was competent on the information available. For each Class Three item, divide the outcome into three parts: what I did, what was done by others, and what was circumstance. The three parts are written separately and in different columns.

Mode. For each item, apply the five markers of Section 29.3 and record which are present: the material is replayed without alteration; no conduct has been altered by it; the disclosure is refused; ordinary goods are treated as illegitimate; and the material escalates with mood, drink, or anniversary.

Then answer: **which of my items are operating in the punitive mode?** The marker that decides the matter is the second: if no conduct of yours has been altered by the material, it is functioning as a sentence and not as a correction.

Part Three: The Plan (Sitting Three)

Section A: Repairable matters (Class Two). For each, complete the three parts.

The person	The acknowledgement (what I did, without explanation)	The restitution (the sum, the act, the schedule)	What will be different (specific and checkable)	The date

Apply the four rules of the acknowledgement before proceeding: no explanation, no defence, no request, no distribution of responsibility. Apply the test at the end of Section 29.5: if I could not tell anybody that I had done this, would I still do it?

Section B: Irreparable matters. For each, complete the five elements.

1. **The account.** Written once, completely, with the event, my conduct, the harm, and an accurate assessment of what I controlled. (Where useful, use the three columns from Part Two.)
2. **The witness.** The person I will tell, and the date. (Where the material is severe, record the professional arrangement.)

3. **The stated position on self-punishment.** In my own words: what has my suffering achieved; who has paid for it; what is the relationship between my suffering and the harm I caused.
4. **The redirection into conduct.** The harm I caused, and the conduct of the same kind that I will perform without requiring it to be observed.
5. **The dated reckoning.** The date on which I will review it, and what the review will consist of: the conduct of the past year, whether the commitments held, and whether any part of the matter has become available for repair.

Section C: The transfers. For each person in my household with respect to whom my attention is disproportionate or my requirements are unusually firm, state the obligation I am carrying and the person to whom it actually belongs. Then write the correction: what the household member actually requires of me, stated in the forms of Parts III and V of this book.

29.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Everyone carries something. Why should I dismantle a burden that keeps me careful?"

Because the chapter proposes no dismantling of the material; it proposes the removal of the punitive mode, which does not keep the man careful. The corrective mode is what keeps a man careful, and it operates with the material present, examined, and available. The punitive mode supplies nothing: by the second marker in Section 29.3, it has altered no conduct, and by the third element in Section 29.6, its cost is charged to people who had no part in the original matter.

"The person I wronged is dead. Is it dishonest to be relieved by writing a page nobody will read?"

The page is a step and not the work. The work of an irreparable matter consists of the accurate account, the witness, the stated position on self-punishment, the redirection into conduct, and the dated reckoning; the page is the first element. The relief men report after these steps is not a claim that the matter is settled but the ending of the arrangement in which the man's private suffering stands in the place of reparation.

"I will not tell anybody. What then?"

Then the witness does not occur, and the material remains held by one person. The chapter's position is that this is a legitimate choice with a known cost, and the cost is the correction described in Section 29.2's first mechanism: the man's account remains the only account, unconverted, and unexamined by anybody. Where the refusal is based on the fear of judgement, the professional arrangement is the appropriate route, since the recipient's obligation of confidentiality removes the exposure and the recipient is trained for the material. Where

the refusal remains, the remaining four elements are still available and are still worth conducting.

"My regret concerns something done to me, not by me."

Then the material belongs, initially, to Chapter 13 and to Chapter 16. It is worth noting, however, that a substantial proportion of the items men list under this heading contain a second element, which is a regret at the man's own conduct in the matter: that he did not resist, that he did not report, that he did not leave, that he did not tell. Where such an element is present, the material should be divided: the harm done to the man is addressed in its own chapter, and the regret concerning his own conduct is addressed here, with the Class Three treatment if the man's responsibility was real and partial.

"How long does the work take?"

The written work takes three sittings. The repair of a Class Two matter takes as long as the restitution takes, and in the case of a material sum this is frequently a period measured in years. For an irreparable matter, men report a change in the material's operation within two to six months of conducting the five elements, and they report the dated reckoning continuing indefinitely. The chapter's position should be recorded accurately: the material is not intended to close, and the work is not offered as a means of obtaining peace.

"Is this not simply a way of letting myself off?"

Only if the work is conducted without the restitution, without the acknowledgement, and without the redirection. The chapter's arrangement is deliberately constructed so that the lenient path is unavailable: the man is required to state what he did to the person he wronged, to make good the material part of it, to write down what his suffering has and has not achieved, and to perform conduct of the same kind as the harm for the remainder of his life. Every element of the arrangement imposes cost. What is refused is the additional and uneconomical cost of an indefinite private sentence that benefits nobody, and the reader should test the distinction by asking which of the two arrangements the person he wronged would actually require.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 29 in brief. Regret must be distinguished from remorse. Regret concerns an outcome the man wishes had been different; remorse concerns conduct he judges to have been wrong and carries an obligation. Men's private regrets cluster in nine categories: the decision that failed somebody, the failure to act, the words said, the words not said, the person not attended to, the money, the failure to protect, the compromise, and the particular act never described. Each item is an error (a competent decision with an adverse outcome), a wrong (conduct that was wrong at the time, with an obligation attached), or a tragedy (real but partial responsibility).

Private regrets are heavier than disclosed ones for five structural reasons: there is no correction available, the material is protected from the disclosure that would revise it, the man has no permission to be affected, the standard he has violated is unknown to anybody else and therefore uncalibrated, and the material is triggered without warning and without explanation. Regret has five components — the event, the counterfactual, the verdict, the debt, and the management — and it operates in two modes. In the corrective mode it is examined once and supplies a standard the man acts upon. In the punitive mode it is replayed without alteration, alters no conduct, is held privately, renders the man's ordinary goods illegitimate, and escalates with mood, drink, or anniversary. The marker that decides which mode is operating is whether the material has altered any conduct. The functions of regret are correction, prevention, the calibration of the man's standard, and the grounds of his treatment of others; its abuses are rumination, self-punishment, compensation in the wrong direction, the denial of the man's present standing, and avoidance.

Repairable matters are conducted in three parts: the acknowledgement, stated without explanation, defence, request, or distribution of responsibility; the restitution, where a material element exists, with a full accounting and a performance schedule; and the statement of what will be different, specific and checkable. The injury is not required to forgive and the relationship is not required to continue. Irreparable matters are conducted by five elements: the account stated once in writing, the witness, the stated position on self-punishment, the redirection into conduct of the same kind as the harm, and the dated reckoning. The obligation of a regret may not be transferred to somebody who was not involved, and the practice of doing so — the over-managed child, the enforced obligation, the rigidity of procedure — charges the man's debt to people who had no part in the original matter. The work does not promise peace. It promises that the material will be carried accurately, will be converted into conduct, and will no longer be charged to the man's household.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the inventory. How many items on your list has anybody ever been told about, and what does that number tell you about the maintenance described in Section 29.3?
2. For your heaviest item, write the counterfactual and then, separately, the evidence for it. What do you actually know, and what have you been constructing?
3. Apply the five markers of the punitive mode. Which apply, and what has the material produced in conduct over the last ten years?
4. Which of the five abuses in Section 29.4 are present in your material: rumination, self-punishment, compensation in the wrong direction, the denial of your present standing, or avoidance of a specific place or person?

5. For each Class Two item, write the acknowledgement without explanation, defence, or request. What is the restitution, and what is the first date on the schedule?
6. For each irreparable item, write the elements. What is the specific conduct of the same kind as the harm, and how will you perform it without requiring it to be observed?
7. Where has an obligation been transferred to somebody in your household — a child who is monitored, a plan that is refused, a rigidity that has no explanation? Write the obligation's actual object and the correction the household member actually requires.

Further Reading

- **On regret:** the psychological literature on regret, including the distinction between regret and remorse, the research on the most frequently reported regrets across the lifespan, and the findings on the difference between regret that motivates action and regret that produces rumination.
- **On counterfactual thinking:** the research on counterfactual reasoning, including the findings on the ease with which alternatives are constructed, the influence of the ease of construction on the certainty that the alternative was available, and the conditions under which counterfactual thought improves rather than impairs subsequent performance.
- **On rumination and self-criticism:** the literature on rumination and on self-criticism, including the evidence on rumination as a maintaining factor in depression and anxiety, and the findings on the difference between reflection and rumination.
- **On apology and repair:** the research on apology and on restorative practice, including the findings on the components of an effective apology, the role of restitution and of committed future conduct, and the evidence on when apology produces repair and when it fails.
- **On moral injury:** the literature on moral injury, including work on the experience of having transgressed one's own values, the distinction between moral injury and fear-based traumatic responses, and the treatment approaches that address the experience of transgression directly.
- **Practical resources:** counselling and psychological services for the conduct of the witness element and for material of this kind; mediation and restorative services where a repair involves other people; services for credit and debt where the regret is material; men's groups in which an account of this kind can be received; and the material in Appendices K, L, and R.

30 CHAPTER

Grieving Without an Audience

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Identify the losses for which men are given no public occasion of mourning, and explain the specific difficulty of a grief that has no witness.
2. Describe the ways in which men's grieving differs from the accounts that dominate the culture, and assess whether his own grieving is a deficiency or a different form.
3. Recognise the ways grief presents in men when it is not expressed as sorrow, including irritability, work, drink, risk-taking, somatic symptoms, and the delayed arrival of the material.
4. Conduct the work of mourning in the form available to him, including the elements that supply the transition that a public occasion would otherwise supply.
5. Recognise when a grief has become a condition requiring treatment, and distinguish between the course of ordinary grief and the patterns that require clinical attention.
6. Apply the exercise at the end of the chapter to a specific loss, and construct the arrangements that give the material a place.

Introduction

The material of this chapter is the loss that has no occasion.

In the ordinary arrangement of societies, a death and a loss are managed by an occasion: the announcement, the gathering, the attendance, the words spoken, the period observed, the return of the community to ordinary life with the mourner in a recognised position. The occasion performs the four functions from Chapter 28.3: it establishes that something has happened, it permits the mourner to speak of it, it supplies the company of those who know, and it marks the transition.

This chapter concerns the losses for which no occasion is provided, and the men who are carrying them.

There are two categories, and they are distinct.

The first is the loss that the surrounding society does not recognise as a loss at all. The man's friend of thirty years has died and his own household offers him three days of consideration; he is expected to return to work and to be steady. The man's former wife has died, and while her family mourns, his position is ambiguous. The man's colleague, the man with whom he spent eleven hours a day for eight years, has died, and his absence is a practical matter rather than a bereavement. The man has lost a child before birth. His mentor has died. The man from his unit or his training has died. In each case, the loss is real and the mourning is not authorised.

The second is the loss that the man cannot afford to have witnessed. The death of a person who is not supposed to be mourned by him; the death of somebody whose connection to the man would damage him or his household; the loss of a person the man was not permitted to love; the death of the man's own child by a manner that the community would treat as a judgement; the death of a companion in circumstances that must be concealed; and, in the material reported from treatment services, the losses of men whose lives contain a chapter, a period, or a relationship that no member of their present household knows about.

The chapter proceeds on four commitments.

The first is that these are losses and that their status is a defect of the arrangement rather than of the man. The evidence is consistent: a grief without a witness behaves differently from a grief with one, and the difference is not that the man is stronger or weaker but that the ordinary mechanisms of acknowledgement are absent.

The second is that men's grieving has its own form and should be treated as legitimate. The dominant cultural account of mourning describes a process of expression, tears, and the sharing of feeling, and men's actual grieving frequently takes a different course: activity, problem-solving, the management of the practical, thinking about the person in private, and the maintenance of a composed exterior. The research describes these as different styles rather than as adequate and inadequate mourning, and this book takes the same position. The practical consequence is that the work of this chapter is not the instruction of men to mourn in somebody else's form; it is the construction of arrangements in which their own form can operate.

The third is that grief that has no place does not stay still. It presents in other forms, and the forms are recognisable: the irritability, the collapse of patience, the work that expands, the drinking, the risk, the physical symptoms, the sudden flatness, the anniversary, and the delayed arrival of the whole material years later. Section 30.3 sets these out, and the recognition is frequently the point at which

a man who has never described himself as grieving identifies what has been operating.

The fourth is that the chapter does not promise closure. Grief is not an illness with an endpoint and the losses in this chapter are not concluded. The objective is that the material has a place in the man's life, that it is connected to the person who was lost, and that it is not discharged into his household, his work, or his own body.

30.1 The Grief Men Are Not Given

The distinction in this chapter is between a loss that is acknowledged and a loss that is not. The following nine categories cover the great majority of the material men report, and they share the feature that no occasion is provided.

The Nine Categories

1. The death of the man's own friend. A man's friend dies and the man's household provides him with a period measured in days. The wife of the deceased is a widow and is recognised as such; the man's own position is invisible, and it is not recognised by anybody, including, frequently, the man. The loss is frequently discovered late and it is frequently severe, for the reason given in Chapter 26.1: the friend occupied a large share of a small network.

2. The death of the man's colleague or work companion. The person with whom the man spent more waking hours than with his household. The employer supplies a day of leave and a condolence; the man's mornings are rearranged; the loss is treated as a staffing matter. The specific difficulty is that the relationship was frequently intimate in its content — the private conversations of a working life — and it was not of a kind that supplies a mourning position.

3. The bereavement of a marriage that ended. The former wife, the former husband of a relative, the children's other parent. Where the marriage ended in conflict, the man's position at the death is ambiguous, and he may be unwelcome at the funeral; where it ended amicably, he is present and has no recognised standing. The grief is compounded by the man's own history with the person and by the presence of children whose loss is recognised while his is not.

4. The loss of a child before birth or in infancy. A category with a distinct structure. The loss occurs early in a pregnancy; the man's household and community do not know about the pregnancy, or know and offer no occasion; the mother is attended to because she bore the physical event; the man's own loss is not provided with a position at all. Men describe the specific finding that the material arrives years later and that it has never been spoken of, including between the parents.

5. The death of a mentor. The person who taught the man the trade, the profession, the craft, or the standard. The loss of a mentor is a loss of a position

and a part of the man's history: the man who knew the beginnings, the person to whom the man's early failures and early hopes were known, and, frequently, the person who supplied the standing described in Chapter 27.3.

6. The loss of a companion from the man's cohort. The classmate, the training group, the unit, the team, the group of men with whom the man came up. Each death removes one of the people who held the same history, which is what makes this class progressively heavier: at the tenth death, the man is the last holder of a particular period of his own life.

7. The loss that occurred remotely. The parent who died in another country, the sibling who died during a period of estrangement, the family member whose funeral the man could not afford to attend, the relative whose burial had already occurred when the man was informed. The absence of the man's own attendance is frequently a second loss and, in men's accounts, it is frequently the more durable of the two.

8. The person who disappeared, or whose death was never confirmed. A child, a sibling, a friend who left and was not heard of; a body never recovered; a death in a place where the man cannot obtain information. The loss has no event, which removes every mechanism by which mourning is conducted, and the men who carry it describe a specific and indefinite occupancy that may extend for decades.

9. The death of the man's animal, home, land, or country. The category that the culture most readily dismisses. The dog that the man kept for a decade and with whom he spent more hours than with most people; the house in which the man's entire adult life occurred and whose loss was a taking or a forced sale; the land that was divided or confiscated; the country that was left. Each of these is a loss to which the man had attached a substantial proportion of his daily life, and the absence of any recognition reinforces the man's own conclusion that the material is not legitimate.

The Four Features They Share

The loss is real. The absence of an occasion is not evidence about the loss. The categories in this chapter are the ones with the strongest documented associations with prolonged grief, because the absence of acknowledgement is the single most consistently identified factor in the persistence of grief.

The man is expected to continue immediately. Work provides a few days, the household provides a period of irregularity, and the community provides a condolence. Then a specific requirement is imposed: the man's competence is required, which the man himself accepts. There is no assignment of a mourning period, and a man who attempted to claim one would be imposing upon his household's arrangements, which is the transaction men generally refuse.

The loss is frequently not the man's to display. Where the man has children, or a position, or a household that has just lost somebody, his own grief is subordinate to theirs. This is a real responsibility and it is coherent: he is the one who carries the household through the event. Its cost is that he is the person to whom nobody attends, at the moment of his own loss, which is the form of male isolation described in Chapter 27.3 in its most acute version.

The material is unshared between the man and his own household. The most consequential of the four features. The man's own household, at the loss, has its own grief and its own arrangements, and the man's specific loss — the friend, the colleague, the child before birth, the mentor — is not shared by the people with whom he lives. It therefore has no place in the household's account of the period, and the man carries it while conducting the household's own mourning. The pattern is common and it is invisible: the man who has organised the funeral of his father with complete competence and who is carrying, privately, the death of a friend who died in the same month.

> **KEY POINT**
> Men carry losses for which no occasion is provided: the friend, the colleague, the bereavement of a marriage that ended, the child lost before birth, the mentor, the companion from the man's cohort, the loss that occurred remotely, the person whose death was never confirmed, and the animal, home, land, or country. The absence of acknowledgement is the factor most strongly associated with prolonged grief, and the man's own competence is generally required by his household at the moment of his own loss, which removes the only period in which the loss could have been attended to.

30.2 How Men Grieve, and Why It Looks Like Nothing

The cultural account of grief is dominated by one pattern: the expression of feeling, tears, the sharing of the material, and a progressive return to ordinary life. Men's grieving frequently does not look like this, and the difference has been studied. This section sets out what the research describes, because the assessment of a man's own process depends on it.

The Two Styles

The grief literature distinguishes, in broad terms, between two patterns, and reports that both are common and that neither is a deficiency.

The intuitive style. Grief is experienced and expressed as feeling. The mourner's attention is on the internal state, the material is shared with others, and the process runs substantially through expression and through the company of other mourners. This is the pattern the culture describes and that most people assume is universal.

The instrumental style. Grief is experienced and managed substantially through thinking and doing. The mourner's attention is on the practical, the mastery of tasks, the arrangement of affairs, and the thinking through of the loss, and the expression of feeling is limited and frequently private. The pattern is more common in men, in the men who report it the process is real and the loss is felt, and the observable signs of mourning are frequently absent.

The research reports that the two styles are not exclusive, that many people combine them, and that the widespread belief in a single correct pattern has two consequences: it produces the expectation that a man who is not visibly mourning is not affected, and it produces the man's own conclusion that something is wrong with him when he does not experience the material in the prescribed form.

The Five Legitimate Forms of a Man's Mourning

1. Activity as mourning. The man's process runs through the practical: the arrangements, the estate, the household, the support of the family, the completion of what the deceased required. Men describe this accurately: *I did not sit down and cry. I did the things that had to be done, and I was thinking about him the whole time.* The activity is not an avoidance of grief; in the instrumental pattern, it is the medium of it.

2. Solitary thinking as mourning. The man's engagement with the material occurs privately and in thought: on a long drive, in a period of work that requires no conversation, in the early hours, at a place associated with the deceased. This is a real engagement with the loss and its absence of witnesses is what makes it invisible to the household, which then concludes that the man is unaffected.

3. Physical forms. The work, the walk, the drive, the manual labour, the training. Men report, with strong consistency, that physical activity is where the material moves: the period in which the loss is engaged coincides with exertion, and the necessity is real. This form has a documented basis and it is more effective in men than the verbal forms that are generally prescribed.

4. The private conversation with the deceased. The man who speaks to the person, in the car, at the graveside, over a photograph, on a particular date. Men report this form frequently and generally with embarrassment, and it is worth recording that the practice is generally treated in the grief literature as a normal and functional engagement with a continuing bond rather than as a failure of acceptance.

5. The maintenance of the bond. Men describe maintaining the connection deliberately: the object retained, the anniversary observed, the photograph in the workroom, the ritual of the visit, the habit of the person continued. The grief literature describes this as a continuing bond and notes that its maintenance is

common and is not associated with worse outcomes; the cultural instruction that a man should *let go* is, in the research, not well supported.

The Two Errors of Interpretation

The man's error. The man reads his own non-expression as evidence that he is not affected, or as evidence that he is deficient in feeling. The error is made at the beginning of the process and it determines the rest of it: a man who concludes that nothing is occurring does not construct any of the arrangements described in Section 30.4, and the material then operates through the forms described in the following section.

The household's error. The household reads the man's competence as a statement. The finding from the family practice literature is consistent: the man's composed conduct at the funeral is read by the household as evidence that the loss has not affected him, that his attention is available, and that he is the appropriate person to manage the others. The result is the arrangement described at the end of Section 30.1: the man conducts the household's mourning and has no arrangement for his own.

The One Requirement

Both styles require a place in which the material is engaged. The difference between the intuitive and the instrumental style is the form of that engagement, and not its existence. The instrumental mourner's requirement is frequently not a conversation about the loss but the availability of a setting in which to think and to do: the drive with nobody present, the visit, the work performed for the deceased, the object handled, the account written. The chapter's practical work therefore concerns the setting rather than the disclosure, and this is the reason that men who reject the idea of talking about a loss frequently conduct the work of this chapter successfully.

30.3 What Grief Does Behind the Silence

A grief with no audience does not remain still. It presents in forms that are recognisable, and the following nine are the ones most consistently reported by men and by the practitioners who see them.

The Nine Presentations

1. Irritability and the collapse of tolerance. The most common presentation in men. The man who has always been steady becomes short with his household, intolerant of ordinary friction, and disproportionately severe about small matters. The household experiences a change in the man's temper and attributes it to work, age, or ill health, and the man himself generally attributes it to the same things.

2. The expansion of work. The man's hours extend, the man takes on additional work, the man occupies the evenings. The mechanism is legitimate in

the man's account — *there is a lot to do* — and its function is the reduction of the unstructured time in which the material arrives. Men in this presentation are frequently described as coping well.

3. The drinking, and the other numbing. The alcohol, the gambling, the sexual conduct, the screens, the substances. A distinct and well-documented relationship exists between bereavement and substance use in men, and the mechanism is the one described in Chapters 22 and 23: the behaviour supplies the function of relief and removes the requirement to construct any other arrangement. The presentation is important because it is frequently the first thing the practitioner sees and the last thing the man connects to the loss.

4. The risk-taking. The driving, the investment, the business decision, the drink-driving, the confrontation, the affair. A specific association between bereavement and risk behaviour in men is described in the literature, and its mechanism includes both the numbing described above and a direct quality that men describe in their own accounts: *I did not care what happened to me for about a year.*

5. The somatic presentation. The chest, the head, the stomach, the back, the sleep. Men present to practitioners with physical complaints and the loss is not mentioned, and the finding from primary care is consistent: a substantial proportion of the presentations that follow a bereavement in men are physical. The material's own channels — sleep, appetite, energy, tension, and the immune response described in Chapter 27.3 — are the body's.

6. The flatness. The absence of interest, the absence of pleasure, the absence of appetite for the things the man ordinarily enjoys. Distinguished from depression by its association with the loss and by its usual course, and difficult for the man to interpret because its symptom is the absence of something rather than the presence of pain.

7. The anniversary and the date. The material that arrives annually, or at a particular month, or at the time of a particular event, frequently with an intensity that surprises the man and permits no explanation. Men describe the specific association precisely: a period of low mood that recurs at the same time each year, whose connection to a loss is not drawn until it is pointed out.

8. The delayed arrival. The material that arrives months or years later, generally triggered by an unrelated event: a smell, a piece of music, a road, an item of clothing, a stranger who resembles the deceased, a second loss. Men describe the arrival with particular force and with a specific disbelief: *it happened four years later, and I had thought I was past it.* The finding from the literature is that delay is common, that the man's competence at the time of the loss is frequently the reason for it, and that the arrival, when it comes, is not evidence of failure.

9. The grief that is discharged into the household. The material that is expressed as conduct toward the people available: the man's severity with a child, his sustained coldness toward his wife, his obsessive management of a matter that resembles the loss. Section 29.7′s material on the transfer of the debt applies, and the effect is that people who had no part in the loss receive its cost.

The Four Signs That the Material Is Unattended

These signs are not symptoms of illness but indicators that the material has no place, and each is useful to the man in identifying whether the work of Section 30.4 is required.

1. The subject cannot be mentioned. The man's name, the place, the matter, or the person cannot be raised in the man's presence without a change in the room. Where a man has to manage a subject, the material has no place.

2. The material has not been described to anybody. Where the account of the loss has never been stated in full to one person, the man's version has never been revised, and the version carried in private is generally more severe than the account that would survive delivery.

3. The loss has no date and no place in the man's calendar. No anniversary, no visit, no object, no ritual. Where a loss of significance has no mark in the man's year, the material is not placed but stored.

4. The man's conduct toward a specific person or in a specific setting is different in a way he cannot explain. The avoidance of a village, a family, a colleague's wife, a particular month, a particular conversation. Section 29.3′s fifth component applies: the material has a management, and the management is the evidence of the material.

30.4 The Unattended Funeral

This section addresses the specific and common situation in which the man was not present at the loss and the ordinary mechanisms of mourning were therefore impossible.

The Forms of Absence

The funeral that was not attended. Distance, cost, work, estrangement, a visa, a conflict with the family, an illness, a miscommunication, or a decision made in the disorder of the period. The specific and durable nature of the material is described consistently by men: not *he died* but *I did not go*. The pattern's mechanism is that the man's attendance would have supplied the four functions from the introduction, and its absence left the loss unmarked in his own conduct.

The funeral that occurred before the man knew. The death in another country or another state, the family that did not inform him, the burial conducted within the required period, the notification that arrived after the fact. The man's

position is that a completed event has to be mourned from a distance and after the fact, and the ordinary sequence of the arrangements — the visits, the condolences, the presence — cannot be reconstructed.

The death that was never confirmed. The missing relative, the person lost in a disaster, the man whose body was never found. The grief has no event and no conclusion, and men who carry it describe a state that the literature correctly identifies as ambiguous loss: the material cannot be closed because the fact to which it would attach has never been established. Section 30.5′s material on the household's arrangements applies at its strongest here: the family may spend decades in a position that no occasion can resolve.

The death in custody, in detention, or in a place where the body was not released. A category with a specific difficulty: the mourning is inseparable from a dispute about the circumstances, and the family's attention is substantially occupied by the question of the cause, which delays the mourning and sometimes prevents it.

The restrictions that prevented attendance. The periods in which gatherings, travel, and funerals were restricted, and the men whose parents or siblings died during them. Men in this category describe a form of material that they identify individually and that the surrounding arrangements did not recognise at the time.

The Reconstruction of the Mechanism

Where the ordinary mechanisms did not operate, they must be constructed, and the following five elements constitute the form.

1. The place. A location that the man associates with the deceased: the grave, the family house, a place they went, a place the man chooses. The element's function is the physical anchor that the funeral would have supplied, and its specific value for the instrumental grieve is that it is a place at which to be rather than a conversation to be held.

2. The visit. A specified period at the place, conducted with a defined purpose: to say what the man would have said, to speak to the person, to perform a task the person would have valued, to be present. Men report that a defined visit, done properly once or repeated annually, is a real arrangement and that it works.

3. The account. The loss, the man's own position, and what the man would have said, in writing. Where the man is unwilling to write in the form of feeling, the account can take the form of a record: what the person was, what the man owes him, what the man intends to do in relation to the loss. The document's form matters less than that the account is made.

4. The witness or the assembly. Where the man can supply a person who knew the deceased, a conversation with that person is the closest available mecha-

nism to the absent funeral: the shared account, the shared memory, the exchange of what each knew, and the acknowledgement of the loss by somebody for whom the loss is also real. Where such a person is unavailable, a men's group or a professional arrangement supplies the function partially.

5. The obligation discharged. The matter that the man would have performed had he been present: the support to the household, the maintenance of the grave, the assistance to the children, the completion of a matter the deceased had begun, the payment of a sum. This element is the one to which men respond most strongly, and its function is the discharge of the position that the absence created.

The Position Where Nothing Can Be Reconstructed

Where none of the five elements is available — the man does not know where the grave is, the family will not receive him, the person's history cannot be established, the circumstances remain disputed — the work reduces to the internal elements and the chapter states them plainly: the account, the stated position on what the man owes, the maintenance of the person's memory in the man's own conduct, and the dated reckoning. Men carrying these cases report what the material of Chapter 29 reports: the loss is present and it is not expressed in the man's household, his work, or his body, and it has a place in the man's own arrangements.

30.5 When the Loss Cannot Be Spoken Of

The chapter's most difficult category is the loss that cannot be acknowledged, because the acknowledgement would cost the man something that he cannot afford to lose. The following five forms are reported consistently, and each is presented here for the purpose of recognition rather than for the purpose of judgement.

The Five Forms

1. The death whose manner the community treats as a judgement. The death by suicide, by overdose, by an illness that carries stigma, by violence in circumstances that reflect badly on the family, or by an event that the community reads as the consequence of the household's conduct. The man's own position is compounded: he has lost somebody and he is required, simultaneously, to manage the community's interpretation of the death, which consumes the attention that the mourning would require. Men in this position describe the household's management of the facts as the first priority in the period after the death, and the grief is deferred indefinitely.

2. The relationship that the man's household does not know existed. The loss of a person with whom the man's connection cannot be disclosed: a relationship from before his marriage, a child for whom he was never acknowledged, a companion in a matter that would damage him, a person whose connection to

the man would damage the man's family. The loss is real and the mourning is impossible in every arrangement available to him, which produces the position described in Section 29.2 in its most complete form: the material is held privately, protected from correction, and carried without permission.

3. The loss connected to the man's own conduct. The person whose death followed a matter in which the man was involved: the man killed in a collision in which the man was driving, the death during an arrangement the man proposed, the death of somebody the man introduced to a risk. This form combines the material of this chapter with the material of Chapter 29, and the two must be worked together: the mourning concerns the person, and the remorse concerns the man's own conduct, and neither is discharged by the other.

4. The loss the man is not permitted to mourn. In some circumstances the man's mourning itself would be an admission: the father who is not permitted to display grief for a child the family regards as having disgraced it; the man whose grief for a former partner would be read by his household, his children, or his present wife as an act of disloyalty; the man whose loss concerns a person his own community regards as an opponent or an offender. Men in this position frequently describe their own house as a place in which the material cannot be present.

5. The loss of a person with whom the man's history is a secret. A category described by men in treatment for addiction, in prison settings, and in the material of veterans' services: the loss of a companion from a period of the man's life that is unknown to his household, so that the mourning would require a disclosure that the man has never made. The person is real, the loss is real, and the absence of any recipient is total, because the only people who knew the relationship are the people in the concealed period, with whom the man has no contact.

What the Man Requires in This Category

Four requirements, and they should be stated as requirements rather than as suggestions, because the category has no self-managing form.

1. One recipient whose obligation is confidentiality. The requirement is structural: the man requires at least one recipient who is not part of the audience that the material must be protected from. A professional arrangement — a counsellor, a general practitioner, a psychologist, an employee assistance service — satisfies the requirement exactly, since the confidentiality is governed by an obligation and the practitioner's judgement of the material is not the judgement of the community. Where the material concerns the man's own conduct as well, the arrangement is a clinical one, for the reasons given in Chapter 29.6.

2. A place of the man's own. A location, an hour, a drive, a room, a time on a stated day: somewhere the material can be engaged in forms that are not the household's. The requirement is not decorative. Men in this category consistently report that the presence of the material is continuous and that it requires a place rather than an occasion, and the construction of a private place is frequently the element that makes the material bearable.

3. The material conducted with reference to the person and not to the secret. The most important of the four, and the one that distinguishes the work of this chapter from the work of Chapter 22. Where the material concerns a relationship the man cannot disclose, the work must retain the person as its subject: what the person was, what the man owed him, what he means in the man's account of himself. The material conducted with reference to the secret becomes a second concealment, and men in this position describe a specific and painful result: the person's memory becomes an inventory of the man's circumstances rather than a memory of the person.

4. A decision about the secret that is separated from the decision about the loss. The two questions must be answered separately: whether the matter will ever be disclosed to the household, and what the man will do about the loss now. Men in this category frequently conflate the two and conclude that the loss cannot be addressed until the disclosure is settled, which postpones the work indefinitely. The chapter's position is that the two decisions are separate, that the second can proceed without the first, and that a decision taken in either direction on the first question is legitimate provided it has been taken deliberately rather than by default.

30.6 The Arrangements That Give Grief a Place

This section consolidates the practical work: the arrangements that supply, for a grief without an occasion, what the occasion would have supplied.

The Six Arrangements

1. The date. A date in the man's calendar associated with the person: the anniversary of the death, the person's birthday, the date of a shared event. Its function is to gather the material into a place in the year rather than allowing it to be distributed across the whole of it. The arrangement is the one the chapter recommends most strongly, and men who adopt it report a specific benefit: the material arrives on the date, is attended to, and does not arrive continuously.

2. The place. The grave, the town, the house, the workshop, the spot. Where the place does not exist, the substitute — a photograph in a particular position, an object on a shelf, a route driven annually, a tree, a page in a record. The place supplies the anchor that the physical arrangements of a funeral would have supplied.

3. The account. The written record of the person and of the loss: what he was, what the man owes him, what the man's own position is, and what will be maintained. The document is the man's own and it need not be seen by anybody unless he chooses to show it.

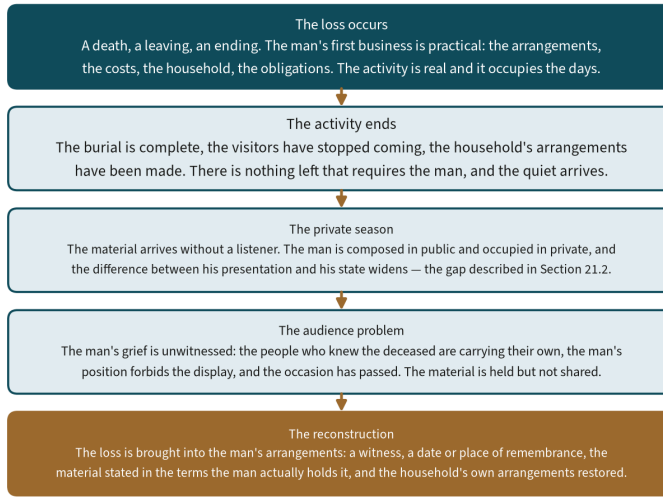
4. The recipient. One person with whom the loss can be discussed, on the man's own terms. Where a person who knew the deceased is available, that person is preferable, for the reason given in Section 30.4: the shared account and the acknowledgement of a loss that is also somebody else's. Where no such person exists, the arrangement is professional, and the men who have used this route report that the specific benefit of the professional arrangement is that the man's own account of the loss can be stated without the requirement to protect the listener's feelings.

5. The conduct in the person's name. The obligation or the practice the man maintains in relation to the loss: the support of the deceased's household, the training of a young man as the deceased had trained the man, the annual contribution, the maintenance of the grave, the completion of the deceased's matter, the correspondence with the deceased's children. Chapter 29.6′s material on redirection applies, and its value here is that it moves the material into conduct rather than leaving it in the man's private state.

6. The household's arrangement. The final and most frequently omitted element: the man's own household is entitled to know that he is carrying a loss, in the form that the loss permits. The disclosure does not require the content; it may consist of the fact. *The man who died was my friend for thirty years and I am not all right about it* is a sentence that men report as changing the arrangements in the household immediately, because it supplies the household with the explanation for the change in the man's temper, availability, and quietness that they had been attributing to something else.

What These Arrangements Require of the Man

Two things only: that the arrangements have dates and that they are his. The first requirement comes from the material on transition in Chapter 24: a matter acquires a place when it has a time and a location. The second is the requirement that the arrangements not be constructed from a template — the place, the form, and the conduct must correspond to the man and to the person, and an arrangement that has been adopted from a general prescription will not be maintained.



The private season is not a failure of strength. It is a normal season made longer by the absence of an audience.

Figure 30.1 Grieving without an audience: the course from the loss to the reconstruction. The upper stages describe what follows a loss that has no occasion; the final stage identifies the five elements that supply what the occasion would otherwise have supplied.

Two Clarifications

This is not a programme for closure. The arrangements do not end the grief and they are not intended to. Their function is that the material has a place, that it is connected to the person, and that it is not distributed into the man's temper, his household, his work, his body, or his drinking.

The arrangements are conducted in the man's own form. A man who cannot speak of the loss at the graveside can stand there. A man who cannot describe the person to a listener can write the page and leave it in the file. A man who cannot attend a support arrangement can maintain the deceased's obligation, and the conduct is a form of mourning. The chapter's position is stated plainly: the work is the man's engagement with the material in whatever form he can sustain, and the forms supplied in this chapter are not a prescription but a list from which the man selects what he will actually do.

30.7 When Grief Becomes a Condition

The chapter must supply the distinction between the course of grief and the point at which a grief requires treatment, because the material in this chapter is the material most likely to go unattended and because men in this position frequently attribute a treatable condition to the loss itself.

What Ordinary Grief Does

The literature describes a course that includes the following, all of which are ordinary and none of which indicates illness: the material's intensity varies and frequently increases at certain points; it arrives in waves; sleep is disturbed; appetite changes; the man's concentration is reduced; he is irritable, flat, or restless in periods; he experiences the physical symptoms associated with distress; and the material is engaged by reminders. The course generally eases over months, with recurrence at anniversaries and milestones, and this pattern continues, in a reduced form, indefinitely.

The Six Patterns That Require Assessment

1. The material does not vary at all. Constant intensity with no waves, no relief, and no capacity for the man to be engaged by anything else, sustained without change, is the pattern that most frequently indicates a condition requiring treatment.

2. The duration exceeds the ordinary course without any reduction. Where the man's functioning has been substantially impaired for a period of a year or more after the loss, with no reduction in intensity, an assessment should be obtained.

3. The functioning has collapsed. The man cannot work, cannot discharge his obligations, cannot maintain the ordinary arrangements of his life. This is the clearest practical indicator, and it should be assessed without delay.

4. The material has become a condition of the man's whole account of himself. The loss has become the organising fact of the man's existence, and every matter is interpreted through it. This pattern is the one associated in the literature with the risk of a prolonged and impairing course.

5. The self-destructive conduct has begun and is continuing. The drinking, the driving, the risk, the prolonged absence from the household, the suicidal thinking. The specific and urgent point: men in later life have the highest suicide rate of any group, and the loss in this chapter — the friend, the wife from whom the man was separated, the colleague, the person from the concealed period — is frequently the triggering event. A man with an active wish to die should seek help immediately and should regard the urge as a clinical emergency rather than as an insight.

6. The material is presenting in the body. Persistent physical symptoms that have not been evaluated, insomnia over an extended period, the cessation of eating, sustained exhaustion. The presentation is common in men and it is frequently the channel through which the man can be brought into an assessment.

The Distinctions to Be Obtained

There are four, and they are diagnostic questions rather than matters for the man to conclude on his own.

Whether the man's condition is grief or depression. The two overlap substantially and differ in important respects: grief's material is oriented toward the loss and arrives in waves; depression's is general and persistent, with the loss frequently secondary. The distinction matters because the treatment differs.

Whether the loss has prolonged the grief beyond its ordinary course. The category of prolonged or complicated grief is recognised, is associated with substantial impairment, and responds to specific treatment. Men who have carried a loss for years without the possibility of acknowledgement are exactly the group in which it is most likely to occur and least likely to be assessed.

Whether there is an associated condition requiring treatment. Alcohol dependence, anxiety, a physical condition, or a condition that predates the loss and has been unmasked by it.

Whether the loss is connected to a matter requiring its own treatment. The material of Chapters 22, 23, and 29: an addiction, a remorse, or an injury that the loss has activated.

The Practical Guidance for Men

The following four points are stated plainly, because the material in this chapter is the material about which men most frequently decide not to act.

An assessment is not a diagnosis. A consultation establishes what is present and what is required, and a substantial proportion of men who obtain an assessment are told that their material is within the ordinary range of grief and that what they require are the arrangements in Section 30.6.

The presenting complaint can be something else. A man who will not discuss the loss can present the sleep, the chest, the drinking, or the exhaustion. Primary care is organised to accept exactly these presentations, and the assessment questions used in routine practice — sleep, appetite, how long, and whether the man has somebody he speaks to — supply the route into the material, as the case in Chapter 27.6 illustrates.

The arrangements in Section 30.6 do not require the assessment and should be conducted either way. The date, the place, the account, the recipient, the conduct, and the disclosure to the household are worth constructing in every case, including where treatment is also required.

The man's household should be informed at the level of the fact. Where the material is being treated or where an assessment has been sought, the household's arrangements are substantially improved by knowing that something is being carried and attended to, even where the content is not disclosed. The case

for this position is in Section 30.6 and it is a matter of accuracy: the household's alternative explanation for the man's state is generally worse than the truth.

30.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Conducted Both Funerals

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in bereavement services, primary care, and family practice.

Sunday is fifty-one, a regional manager for a distribution company, married to Beatrice for twenty-three years, with two children aged nineteen and fifteen.

In a period of five weeks in 2019, two people died. Sunday's father died at the age of seventy-eight after a period of illness. Twenty-three days later, in the same month, Sunday's closest friend, Mark, died at forty-nine of a stroke, in a hotel in a city where he had been working.

Sunday's account of the five weeks and the two years that followed supplies the case. The father's death was managed with complete competence and it supplied the man's whole position in the household. Sunday arranged the hospital's formalities, the family's notifications, the funeral's arrangements, the burial, the reception, the accounts, and the subsequent attention to his mother's circumstances. His description: *I was the eldest son. I did the whole thing, and I did it well. Everyone said so. My mother still says so.*

Mark's death was managed in six hours. Sunday was informed by telephone on a Tuesday morning, and he attended the funeral in another state on the Thursday: a four-hour journey each way, a night in a hotel, and a return to work on the Friday. His description: *Nobody knew Mark in my family. He was my friend for twenty-two years. My wife met him twice, at functions. I told my office that I was attending a funeral and I told my house that a friend had died. My son asked me if I was all right and I said I was fine, and I went to work on the Friday because the week's report was due.*

The household's arrangement of the period is worth recording exactly. The family's attention was on the father's death. The mother required support. The relatives required the arrangements' details. Sunday's own position was that he had lost his friend, and nobody in the household had known Mark, and Sunday described the discovery of what that arrangement produced: *There was no day on which anybody was thinking about Mark except me. He was in my head and nowhere else in the world. It sounds like a thing a man would exaggerate. It is not. My father was being mourned in four houses. Mark was being mourned in one head, and I was taking the children to school.*

The first year was silent. Sunday described himself as busy and functional, with three items he identified later: his temper, his sleep, and his Saturdays. His temper, which his wife raised twice in that year, was short with his son and with his staff, which he attributed to the position's demands; his sleep was five hours, with the early waking that he described as *the hour in which I would think about everything at once*; and

the Saturdays, which he had spent with Mark for eleven years — the workshop, the vehicle, the market — became unsettled, and he filled them with work and with an additional weekend engagement at the company.

The material arrived in the second year, triggered by a vehicle. Sunday was at a market and approached a man selling spare parts of the kind Mark had used, and he described the event precisely: *I stopped in front of the stall and I could not speak. I stood there for about a minute. The man thought something was wrong with me. I walked away and I sat in the car for twenty minutes and I cried properly for the first time, in a car park in the middle of the day, and I have not told anybody about the car park.*

The following six months produced three of the presentations in Section 30.3: the drinking, which had increased from occasional to four or five evenings a week; the presentation to his general practitioner with chest pain and palpitations, which was investigated and found to be without a cardiac cause; and the discharge into the household, which took the form of Sunday's sustained severity toward his son about arrangements and money, which he acknowledged in the case account as *not about my son*.

The work Sunday conducted, beginning in the third year, had five elements and he identified the order as important.

The consultation. Sunday attended a counselling arrangement through the hospital where the chest had been investigated. He identified the point of entry accurately: *I went about the chest. In the second appointment the counsellor asked me whether anybody close to me had died in the previous two years, and I said my father, and she waited, and I told her about Mark. She asked me why I had mentioned my father first. I said because he died first. She asked me how many days apart. I said twenty-three. She asked me how many people came to my father's funeral and how many came to Mark's. I did not answer her for a long time.*

The account. Over three sittings, Sunday wrote the record of Mark: what he was, the twenty-two years, the Saturdays, the eleven years of the workshop arrangement, what Sunday owed him, and what he had done in the three years since the death. The document included one item that he identified as the centre of the whole matter: *Mark had asked me, eight months before he died, to go with him to his hometown to see his mother, and I had said I would go in the following month, and in the following month the company's audit was held and I did not go, and I never met his mother and I did not go to the house after the funeral.*

The visit. In the fourth month of the work, Sunday travelled to Mark's hometown, met Mark's mother, and told her what Mark had been to him, and remained for two days. He described it as the most difficult and most useful act of the whole process: *I told her I had been going to come with Mark eight months before he died and that I did not come. She said he had told her and that she had been waiting to meet me. She is eighty-four. I now go twice a year and I take her provisions and I sit with her and she tells me what he was like as a boy. There is nobody else in the world who does that*

for me. My own father has four houses in which he is remembered. Mark has one old woman and me.

The date. Sunday established the date of Mark's death in the household's calendar. He told Beatrice about Mark, the twenty-two years, the funeral that he had attended and returned from in three days, and the car park. The instruction he followed was that from Section 30.6: the disclosure does not require the content, and Sunday's form was: *Mark was my best friend for twenty-two years and I did not mourn him because there was no room for it in that month, and I have been carrying it since and it has been coming out in my temper and in my Saturdays. I am not all right about it and I am going to give it a day.* Beatrice's response, which he recorded: *she said she had known that something had been happening for two years and that she had thought it was a woman.*

The conduct. Sunday established two practices in Mark's name: the annual contribution to the education of two of Mark's grandchildren, arranged with Mark's daughter, and the maintenance of the workshop arrangement with Mark's nephew, which Sunday continued for the following four years as an arrangement rather than as a favour.

Sunday's summary, four years after the second death, was: *I organised my father's funeral for about two hundred people and I have been thanked for it by nearly all of them. I buried my friend in three days and nobody in my house knew his name. For two years I thought I was tired. The counsellor asked me how many days apart they died and I understood everything at once. There is no arrangement for a man whose friend dies. There is one now in my house.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The contrast between the two losses was total, and it was structural rather than emotional. Two hundred mourners and one memorial service; nothing and nobody. This is the material of Section 30.1 in its clearest form, and the case is included because the difference is not a measure of the man's feeling but of the audience available to it: the father's death had arrangements and the friend's death did not.

The man's competence at the first loss supplied the mechanism that delayed the second. The competence was real, was required, and was acknowledged. It also occupied precisely the weeks in which he could have mourned Mark, and it supplied the household's account of the period in which his own loss did not appear. The case is included because the pattern is extremely common and is not a failure: the man did what the situation required and the material was left without arrangements.

The material arrived in the body and in the temper. The chest pain and the palpitations were investigated and found not to have a cardiac cause; the severity toward the son was acknowledged in the man's own account as unrelated

to the son. These are the third and ninth presentations of Section 30.3 and the fourth and sixth from Section 30.2′s perspective, and the case is included because the presentation is what brings such men into contact with a service, if anything does.

The entry point was a question on a form. The counsellor's question about a death in the previous two years, asked in a consultation about a chest symptom. The case is included because it demonstrates the point made in Chapter 27.6 and repeated in Section 30.7: the man's route into the material is generally through a presentation he is willing to make, and the arrangement's requirement is that the presenting complaint be accepted.

The reconstruction was external and specific. A visit to a mother in a hometown, two grandchildren's education, an arrangement with a nephew, a date in the year. The case is included because the reconstruction was not the expression of feeling, which the man found difficult, but the construction of arrangements through which the material had somewhere to go, and because its effect is described accurately in the man's own words: *there is no arrangement for a man whose friend dies; there is one now in my house.*

30.9 Practical Exercise: Giving a Loss a Place

This exercise takes about two hours, in three sittings, and it concerns one loss: the one the reader selected when reading Section 30.1.

Part One: The Identification (Sitting One)

Answer the following.

- **The person or matter lost:**
- **The date:**
- **Who else knows about this loss:**
- **Who in my household knows that it affected me:**
- **The category from Section 30.1:**
- **Has the loss ever been described in full to one person?** (Yes/No. If no, the account in Part Three is the step.)

Then apply the four signs of unattended material from Section 30.3.

- Can the subject be mentioned in my presence without managing the room?
- Has the account ever been given to anybody?
- Does the loss have a date and a place in my calendar?
- Is my conduct different in a specific setting or toward a specific person in a way I cannot explain?

Then apply the nine presentations and record which are present in your case: irritability, expanded work, drinking or other numbing, risk-taking, somatic symptoms, flatness, the anniversary, delayed arrival, discharge into the household.

Part Two: The Form of My Grieving (Sitting Two)

From Section 30.2, record which of the five legitimate forms of a man's mourning are available to you: activity, solitary thinking, physical forms, the private conversation, and the maintenance of the bond.

Then answer: **which of the forms in Section 30.6 will I actually use?** The chapter's position is that the arrangements must be selected rather than prescribed, and the test is not which of them is appropriate but which of them the man will maintain.

Part Three: The Arrangements (Sitting Three)

The arrangement	The specific form	The date or the interval
The date		
The place		
The account (written)		
The recipient (who, and what I will say)		
The conduct in the person's name		
The disclosure of the fact to my household		

For the disclosure of the fact: write the sentence you will use, in the form given in Section 30.6 — the fact, and the man's own position — without content that you do not wish to supply.

For the account: write the page. The following four items constitute the minimum: what the person was; what the man owes him; what the man's own position is; and what will be maintained.

For the assessment question (Section 30.7): record which of the six patterns requiring assessment are present, if any, and, if any are present, the date of the appointment.

30.10 Common Questions Men Ask

"I did not cry. Does that mean I am not grieving?"

No. The pattern in which grief is experienced and managed through thinking and doing rather than through expression is common, is more frequently reported by men, and is a style rather than a deficiency. The relevant question is not whether the man has cried but whether the material has a place in his arrangements: whether it has a date, a location, an account, a recipient, and a form of conduct. Where those are absent and the presentations in Section 30.3 are present, the material is unattended regardless of how the man has appeared to himself or to others.

"The funeral was three years ago. Am I not too late?"

The absence of an occasion at the time is the reason the arrangements in Section 30.6 exist, and they can be constructed at any point. Men who conduct this work years after the loss report two findings consistently: the material is still available, and the delay has not reduced what the arrangements can do. The one qualification concerns the sixth pattern in Section 30.7: where the man's functioning has been substantially impaired for a long period, an assessment should accompany the arrangements rather than being deferred until they have been attempted.

"My wife would be hurt if I said that the loss of a friend affected me like this."

The disclosure recommended in Section 30.6 is the fact rather than the content, and it is directed at the household's arrangements rather than at the household's feelings. The form offered — *this person died and I am not all right about it* — is a statement about the man's state, and it does not compare the loss with the household's own. The men who have conducted it report, with consistency, that the household's response was relief rather than injury, because the household had been working with an inaccurate explanation of the man's temper, quietness, and unavailability for a period of months or years.

"I cannot visit the grave or the house. The family's arrangements make it impossible."

Then the place is the man's own: a location he associates with the person, a route, a photograph in a particular position, a workshop, an object. Section 30.4′s position applies here as it does with an unattended funeral: the mechanisms that did not operate must be constructed, and the construction can be entirely the man's.

"The person I lost is somebody I cannot talk about in my house."

Section 30.5 applies. The requirement is one recipient whose confidentiality is an obligation rather than a favour, a private place, the material conducted with reference to the person rather than to the secret, and the separation of the decision about the disclosure from the decision about the loss. The last of the four is the most important and the most frequently conflated: the mourning can proceed whether or not the household is ever informed.

"How do I know whether I need help?"

Apply the six patterns in Section 30.7. Where the material has not varied at all, has produced no reduction over a year or more, has impaired your functioning, has become the organising fact of your account of yourself, or is being discharged into drinking, risk-taking, or any thought of ending your life, obtain an assessment. The fifth item is the most urgent and the one about which men in this material most frequently delay: persistent thinking about death or about

the man's own ending is a clinical emergency and should be treated as one, with immediate professional contact rather than with private deliberation.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 30 in brief. Some losses are never provided with an occasion of mourning, and the absence of acknowledgement is the factor most consistently associated with prolonged grief. Nine categories of such loss are reported by men: the death of the man's own friend, the colleague or work companion, the bereavement of a marriage that ended, the child lost before birth, the mentor, the companion from the man's cohort, the loss that occurred remotely, the person whose death was never confirmed, and the animal, home, land, or country. They share four features: the loss is real, the man is expected to continue immediately, the loss is frequently not his to display, and it is unshared between the man and his own household.

Men's grieving differs from the dominant cultural account. The grief literature distinguishes an intuitive style, in which grief is expressed as feeling and shared, from an instrumental style, in which it is managed through thinking and doing; both are common, neither is a deficiency, and the second is more frequently reported by men. Its five legitimate forms are activity, solitary thinking, physical forms, the private conversation with the deceased, and the maintenance of the bond. The two errors of interpretation belong to the man, who concludes from his own non-expression that nothing is occurring, and to the household, which reads his competence as a statement and then assigns him the management of everybody's mourning.

Grief that has no place presents in other forms: irritability, the expansion of work, drinking and other numbing, risk-taking, somatic complaints, flatness, the anniversary, the delayed arrival, and the discharge of the material into the household. Four signs indicate that the material is unattended: the subject cannot be mentioned, the account has never been delivered to anybody, the loss has no place in the man's calendar, and his conduct differs in a setting he cannot explain.

An unattended funeral — whether the funeral was not attended, had already occurred, has never been confirmed, or was prevented by restriction — requires the reconstruction of the mechanisms the occasion would have supplied: a place, a visit, the written account, a witness or an assembly, and the discharge of the obligation the absence created.

Where the loss cannot be spoken of, the requirements are structural: one recipient whose confidentiality is an obligation, a private place, the material conducted with reference to the person rather than to the secret, and the separation of the decision about disclosure from the decision about the loss. The arrangements that give grief a place are six: the date, the place, the account, the recipient, the conduct in the person's name, and the disclosure of the fact to the man's household. The work does not promise closure; it promises that the material is connected to the person and is not discharged into the man's temper, household, work, body, or drinking. Where the material does not vary, does not reduce, impairs functioning, organises the man's

whole account of himself, or is being discharged into drink, risk, or thoughts of dying, an assessment should be obtained, and the last of these is an emergency.

Reflection Questions

1. Which loss from Section 30.1 did you select, and who in your household knows that it affected you? What has been the household's explanation for the changes in your temper, availability, or quietness?
2. Which of the nine presentations in Section 30.3 are present in your case, and which of them has anybody else noticed?
3. Which of the five legitimate forms of a man's mourning are available to you at present, and which of the six arrangements in Section 30.6 will you actually maintain?
4. If there was a funeral you did not attend, what were the circumstances, and which of the five elements of the reconstruction in Section 30.4 can you construct?
5. Does this loss belong to the category in Section 30.5 — a loss that cannot be spoken of? If so, who is the recipient whose confidentiality is an obligation, and what is the private place?
6. Write the sentence for the disclosure of the fact to your household, and write the page — the four items of the account.
7. Apply the six patterns in Section 30.7. Is an assessment required, and on what date will you obtain it?

Further Reading

- **On disenfranchised grief:** the literature on grief that is not socially recognised, including the findings on which losses are disenfranchised and why, the effects of the absence of acknowledgement on the course of grief, and the practices developed for conducting such grief.
- **On men's grief styles:** the research on instrumental and intuitive grieving patterns, including the findings on the greater frequency of the instrumental style among men, the evidence that the style is not associated with worse outcomes, and the critique of the assumption of a single correct form of mourning.
- **On prolonged and complicated grief:** the literature on prolonged grief disorder, including the diagnostic criteria, the distinction between prolonged grief and depression, the risk factors, and the treatments that have established effectiveness.
- **On continuing bonds:** the research on continuing bonds with the deceased, including the findings that the maintenance of a relationship with

the deceased is common and is not associated with worse adjustment, and the critique of the prescription to let go.

- **On bereavement and substance use, and bereavement and risk:** the literature on the associations between bereavement and alcohol use, substance use, and risk-taking behaviour, including the findings on the elevated risks faced by bereaved men and the implications for assessment.
- **Practical resources:** bereavement counselling and bereavement services, including services for specific categories of loss; peer support for the bereaved, including groups for men; general practice and psychological services for assessment; and the material in Appendices K, Q, and R.

PART IX

The Battles of Leadership, Power, and Responsibility

The hidden pressures of carrying other people's expectations

31 CHAPTER

The Loneliness of Leadership

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the three structural effects that a position of authority has on a man's relationships, and distinguish them from personal failings.
2. Explain why the isolation of leadership is produced by the position rather than by the man's temperament, and identify the arrangements that the position makes impossible.
3. Name the four burdens that a leader carries and that are not visible in his performance, and assess which of them he is currently carrying alone.
4. Recognise the presentations of a leader who has nothing left, including the signs that his condition is affecting the people he is responsible for.
5. Construct the arrangements that allow a man to hold authority without the position consuming his relationships, his judgement, and his household.
6. Recognise the specific risk of transferring a leadership arrangement into a household, and apply the correction described in Section 31.6.

Introduction

Every arrangement of authority separates the man who holds it from the people subject to it. This is not a defect of particular men or particular institutions. It is a structural consequence of the position, and it operates in the same way in a company, a government department, a school, a hospital, a farm, a workshop, a household, a cooperative, and an association.

The man who holds authority is the person whose decisions determine what happens to other people; the person to whom information is brought after it has been selected; the person whose reactions are read by everybody in the room; the person who cannot be told the ordinary things that colleagues tell one another; and, in a substantial proportion of cases, the person who is the last to learn what the people around him already know.

This chapter concerns the cost of that arrangement, which is not usually described as a cost at all. Authority is treated as an achievement and a privilege, and the man who holds it is not expected to require anything. He is expected to be composed, to be available, to decide, to absorb the anxiety of others, and to carry whatever he is carrying without its appearing in his conduct or his performance.

The chapter's approach has four commitments.

The first is to describe the isolation as a property of the position. Men who find themselves without a peer frequently assume that the fault is theirs: that they have become arrogant, that they have failed to make friends, that they do not know how to relate to people any more. The description in Section 31.1 and Section 31.2 makes the structural element explicit, and the distinction matters because a structural problem requires a structural arrangement rather than a personal correction.

The second is that leadership imposes obligations that are real and that the chapter is not arguing against. A man who holds authority has responsibilities to the people he leads, and those responsibilities include the management of his own state. This is the reason the chapter is placed where it is. A leader whose judgement is degraded by isolation makes worse decisions, and the costs of those decisions are borne by people who had no part in them.

The third is that the material is specifically male in its form, and not in its difficulty. Men in positions of authority are frequently the men least likely to have the arrangements described in Chapter 27, and the position compounds the ordinary barriers with a further set: the disclosure would be a risk to the position, the arrangements that exist are frequently subordinate, and the man's own model of the role excludes the requirement.

The fourth is that the work is practicable. The arrangements in Section 31.5 are specific, they are used by leaders in every sector, and they do not require the man to behave in a way that conflicts with his position. A man can lead and be known; the two are not alternatives, and the arrangements exist precisely to make them compatible.

31.1 What a Position of Authority Does to Relationships

The first section describes the mechanism. Three structural effects operate in every setting, and each has consequences that the man experiences as personal.

Effect One: The Boundary of Rank

Authority establishes a difference between the man and the people he leads, and the difference is not a matter of personal attitude. It operates through six channels.

The consequence of the man's words. What the man says in a meeting, in a corridor, or in jest is received as a statement of direction, preference, or assessment. A remark that a colleague would treat as an opinion is received as a position; a

suggestion is received as an instruction; an irritation is received as a warning. Men describe the discovery of this channel in almost identical terms: the moment they understood that they could no longer speak in the way they used to.

The consequence of the man's mood. A leader's mood propagates. His flatness in the morning is read as a problem, his silence as disapproval, his fatigue as an assessment of somebody's work. The leaders who understand this frequently adopt a deliberate constancy — composed, level, and unrevealing — and the constancy is a genuine requirement of the position. Its cost is that the man's actual state no longer appears anywhere.

The consequence of intimacy. Friendship with a subordinate is genuinely difficult, and the difficulty is not the leader's fastidiousness: it imposes on the subordinate a position in which he must manage both the relationship and the reporting line, and it imposes on the man's other subordinates the suspicion of favouritism, which the leader's own conduct cannot remove. The result is that the man's friendships are progressively confined to other people of comparable authority, and those people are generally his competitors or his equivalents in other organisations.

The consequence of dependence. The people around the man need things from him: approval, resources, a decision, a defence, a position, a word. The need is legitimate and it makes the relationship one-directional. Men describe this as the specific and slowly realised feature of the position: *I could not remember the last conversation I had had in which the other person did not want something from me.*

The consequence of the man's own requirement. The man in the position is aware of all of the above, and he manages it, which requires constant attention. The management is part of the work, and it consumes the capacity that would otherwise be available for the ordinary conduct of relationships.

The consequence of the man's history. A man in a position of authority has generally acquired it by a period in which he was assessed, evaluated, promoted over others, and required to demonstrate performance. Some of the people around him were passed over, and the history remains in the arrangement whether or not anybody mentions it.

Effect Two: The Information Asymmetry

The man in the position receives information in a form that has been processed before it reaches him, and the processing is universal.

What he is told is selected. The subordinate reports what he judges to be relevant, what reflects well on him, what he has already addressed, and what he believes the man wishes to hear. The selection is generally not dishonest; it is the ordinary conduct of an intelligent person reporting upward.

What he is not told is frequently the material. The problem that has not been solved, the colleague who is struggling, the client who is dissatisfied, the mood in the team, the matter that will become a crisis in three months. Men describe the position accurately: *I am the last person in the building to know.*

The man's own questions determine what arrives. The organisation supplies what the man asks about, and the questions he asks are shaped by his own model of the work. A leader who is oriented to financial performance will be told about financial performance and not about morale; a leader who is oriented to output will be told about output and not about the fatigue behind it. The arrangement is self-reinforcing, and the leaders with the most accurate information are generally those who ask a wider set of questions deliberately.

The man's own state is not reported to him by anybody. The most consequential asymmetry. Nobody tells a leader that he has become short, that his attention is elsewhere, that he looks exhausted, that he has been less clear than usual, that his conduct at the last meeting was unusual. The information is available to everybody in the organisation and is withheld from the person it concerns, because the subordinate who reports it takes a risk and the peer who reports it incurs a cost.

Effect Three: The Position as the Container of Other People's Anxiety

The third effect is the one that men report most heavily and describe least precisely, and it concerns the emotional function of the position.

In every group, the leader is the person to whom the group's uncertainty is brought. When the market moves, when the budget is cut, when a client leaves, when the future is unclear, the group's anxiety is delivered upward: to the man who is expected to know, to decide, and to hold. The function is performed whatever the man's state. A leader who is uncertain simply receives the anxiety and holds it, which produces the specific and well-documented condition that practitioners describe in leadership work.

The man's own anxiety is not delivered anywhere. It is added to the load rather than distributed, and the arrangements that would ordinarily receive it — the peer group, the supervisor, the spouse, the friend — are each affected by the position. His spouse requires his stability at home as much as the organisation does; his supervisor, where he has one, requires his performance; and his peers, as Effect One described, are generally his competitors.

KEY POINT

A position of authority has three structural effects on a man's relationships: the boundary of rank, through which his words, moods, intimacies, and needs acquire a weight determined by the hierarchy rather than by the relationship; the information

asymmetry, through which he receives selected information and is not informed of the matter that most concerns him — his own state; and the position as the container of other people's anxiety, into which the group's uncertainty is delivered and from which nothing of the man's own is returned. None of the three is a personal failing, and all three require an arrangement rather than an adjustment of character.

31.2 The Isolation of the Position

The previous section described the mechanism. This section describes the positions in which it produces the specific condition this chapter concerns: a man who is surrounded by people and has no peer, no confidant, and no arrangement in which he is not the leader.

The Five Forms

1. The man with nobody above him. The proprietor, the founder, the chief executive, the commander, the bishop, the head of a household in which no adult has standing. He has no supervisor, so nobody has the authority to require an account of him, to question his judgement, or to tell him that he is wrong. The form's characteristic consequence is that the man's judgement is unbounded: there is no correction available, and the material of Chapter 27.3 on the damage isolation does to decision-making applies in its most complete form.

2. The man whose nearest peer is his competitor. The two people who hold equivalent positions in the same market, sector, or family. They can talk to one another, they generally do not, and the matters that most require discussion are the matters they cannot discuss.

3. The man promoted from the group. The man who was one of the team, who was promoted over his friends, and who must now lead them. He has lost the peer group and acquired a subordinate one. His friendships from before the promotion are not gone in name and they have changed in substance, and men describe a specific loneliness in this position that people outside it do not anticipate.

4. The man in the small setting. The leader of the small enterprise, the school principal, the officer of the association, the head of the department in a small town, the man who runs the family business. His position does not supply a leadership network, a professional community, or a peer group, and the handful of other leaders in his setting are frequently people with whom he has an interest in common: customers, contracts, political positions, or family matters.

5. The man whose position is not recognised as leadership. The man who leads by default rather than by appointment: the eldest brother, the man who holds the family's finances, the man who is consulted because he is the one who is competent, the man in the household who has become its decision-maker

without a title. The position carries all three structural effects and none of its compensations, and this form is largely invisible, including to the man himself, who would not describe his position as leadership.

The Four Things the Position Makes Impossible

It makes complaint impossible in the ordinary direction. The man cannot put his difficulty to the people he leads; the position forbids it, and where he attempts it the consequence is a loss of the confidence that the group requires in order to function. The prohibition is not a cultural prejudice; it is a functional requirement of the arrangement, and its consequence for the man is that a whole category of material has no audience.

It makes uncertainty visible. The man who expresses doubt about a decision that he has made is read as having changed his mind, and the organisation will begin to implement two directions at once. The man is therefore required to hold his uncertainties internally, which is exactly the material that requires a recipient.

It makes friendship reciprocal with difficulty. A relationship of equals requires two people who can supply one another. In the man's relationships with subordinates the material flows one way; with peers it flows through competition; with superiors it flows through performance. The man who has a genuine reciprocal friendship from before his position, or from outside his field, is the exception rather than the rule, and men who have one consistently identify it as the arrangement that has held.

It makes the man's own state unavailable to him. The fourth and most important impossibility. The man in the position does not receive the information about himself that everybody else receives, and he is generally the person about whom the least is known by the people closest to him in his working life. The condition this produces is described in the literature on leadership as a specific form of isolation, and its principal consequence in men's accounts is the loss of calibration: the man has no means of knowing whether his mood, his conduct, his workload, or his judgement has altered, and he therefore discovers the alteration only at the point at which it produces a consequence he cannot ignore.

31.3 The Weight Nobody Sees

The second section of the chapter concerns the load itself. Leaders' burdens are described in organisational terms — the targets, the budget, the staffing, the strategy — and the following four are generally not among them, because they are not recorded anywhere and because the man would not describe them.

The Four Burdens

1. The decision burden. The number of decisions, and the fact that each of them is final.

A man in a position of authority makes a large number of decisions daily, of which a substantial proportion cannot be referred upward, deferred to a meeting, or made by consensus. The material on decision fatigue is relevant and its findings are consistent: the quality of decisions declines over a day of unbroken decision-making, and the effect is strong enough that practitioners in several fields have constructed routines to protect judgement at the hours in which it matters.

The burden's specific form for a man in authority is the number of people affected by each decision. A decision about a supplier affects the supplier's staff; a decision about a position affects a household; a decision about a procedure affects the people who must perform it. Men describe the arithmetic precisely: *I counted, one year, that my decisions had affected about six hundred people directly and their families indirectly, and after I counted it I could not sleep.*

Leaders also carry the decisions that were made wrongly, which never leave the record. The man knows which of his decisions were mistaken, which people were harmed by them, which of them are still producing effects, and there is no arrangement in which this material is processed. It accumulates.

2. The example burden. The requirement to be what the position requires, continuously.

The man in authority is a standard. His attendance, his punctuality, his conduct, his honesty, his treatment of people, his work rate, and his reaction to difficulty are all read, by everybody, as the standard of the organisation. The requirement is real and it does not have off hours: the man's conduct at a function, in a car park, in a period of his own difficulty, and in his household is part of the organisation's standard, and the men who lead well describe the requirement as continuous and as the burden they most frequently resent.

The cost is that the man's own conduct is never free — including, frequently, in his own household, which is the subject of Section 31.6.

3. The morale burden. The requirement to hold the state of the group while holding his own.

The leader is the person who holds the group's morale, and the holding is performed in specific ways: the level tone at the difficult meeting, the explanation when the news is bad, the availability in the period of a crisis, the presence at the occasion nobody wants to attend, the decision to absorb an anxiety rather than distribute it. Men describe this burden as the one that produces the most fatigue and the one that is least acknowledged, because its successful performance is invisible: a group that is steady because the man held it steady gives the man no credit, having never seen the alternative.

4. The boundary burden. The requirement to decide what the position will be allowed to consume.

The man's hours, his attention, his household's arrangements, his health, his friendships, and his own interests are all available to the position, which will take as much of them as the man permits. Nobody else in the arrangement has an incentive to set the limit: the organisation's requirements are genuine and expanding, the subordinates are not responsible for the man's household, and the man's own household is generally reluctant to make demands on him because his position is understood to be demanding. The boundary is therefore the man's own obligation, and the material on men's overwork in Chapter 18 applies directly here, with one addition: a man in authority who does not set the boundary frequently presents the absence of a boundary as a virtue, and the presentation is received as such.

The Fifth Burden, and the Reason It Is Listed Separately

The burden of carrying other people's personal material.

This burden is not in the ordinary description of leadership and it is very commonly carried. The men in a leader's organisation bring him their material: the employee whose marriage is failing, the colleague whose child is ill, the subordinate who is drinking, the young man who is being mistreated by his supervisor, the member who has a debt, the relative of a member who has died. The man is brought these matters because he is the person with the standing to do something about them, and he does what he can, and the material does not leave him.

In the material reported in leadership work, the accumulation of this burden is among the most frequently described sources of the man's condition, and it is the category he is least likely to mention, because the others' difficulties are real and his own position appears privileged. The point should be stated plainly: a leader who receives the confidences of forty people is carrying forty pieces of material, and there is no arrangement, in most organisations, in which his own is received.

The Two Effects of Carrying the Weight Alone

The degradation of judgement. The material from Chapter 27.3 applies in its full form to men in authority, and the finding should be considered by the reader in the specific terms of his own responsibilities: a decision made by an isolated man is made from one perspective; a decision made by an exhausted and uncalibrated man is made with degraded judgement; and the consequences of such decisions are borne by the people the man is responsible for. The arrangement described in Section 31.5 is therefore not a benefit to the man alone. It is a component of the man's responsibilities.

The accumulation of the material in the household and the body. The material that has no arrangement at work does not disappear. It presents at home as severity, absence, and unreachability; in the body as sleep disturbance, blood pressure, chest symptoms, and exhaustion; and in the man's conduct as the

drinking, the risk-taking, and the shortening temper described in Section 30.3. Men in authority are frequently the men whose households absorb the cost of the position, and the man learns of it, if he learns of it, from a spouse, a child, or a medical practitioner.

31.4 When the Leader Has Nothing Left

The presentations of a man in authority who has reached the end of his capacity are recognisable and are frequently misread — by the man as a temporary period, by the organisation as a performance matter, and by the household as a change in temperament.

The Nine Presentations

1. Exhaustion that sleep does not correct. The man sleeps and wakes unrefreshed, the pattern is sustained over months, and the ordinary remedies — a weekend, a holiday, the reduction of hours — produce less relief than expected and less each time.

2. Decision avoidance. The presentation characteristic of this group: the man who has always decided begins to postpone, to form committees, to require more information, to defer to others, or, in the most striking form, to cancel meetings at which decisions would be required. Men describe the experience precisely: *I could not make one more decision, so I moved the meeting.*

3. The collapse of tolerance for other people's material. The man who has spent his career receiving other people's difficulties begins to find them unbearable: the complaints, the requests, the confidences, the problems he is brought. He becomes short with the people who need him, which is not consistent with his history and which he frequently recognises afterwards with severe self-judgement.

4. Cynicism. The man's account of the work, the people, or the organisation becomes contemptuous, and the contempt is expressed in private. The presentation is documented in the literature on occupational burnout as one of the core components, and its specific danger for men in authority is that the man's private account of the people he leads affects his decisions about them before it appears in his conduct.

5. The loss of the position's meaning. The work continues, the performance is maintained, and the man no longer knows why he is doing it. He frequently describes the position in the terms of Chapter 24: the role has become his whole account of himself and the account has lost its content.

6. The performance of performance. A specific and deceptive presentation: the man's professional functioning remains intact while the interior of the work has emptied. Colleagues notice nothing, the results continue, and the man describes performing the role rather than holding it. Men in this state are frequently at their most admired.

7. The body. The blood pressure, the chest, the stomach, the headaches, the insomnia, the weight, the alcohol. This category is frequently the channel through which the man is eventually brought into an assessment, and it should be treated as information rather than as an unrelated matter.

8. The conduct at home. The severity, the withdrawal into the study or the phone, the inability to be present, the flatness at occasions, the short temper with the people he loves, the household's management of his mood. Households in this situation generally describe the man's condition accurately to a third party long before the man describes it himself.

9. The unreachable conclusion. The specific and most serious presentation: the man has concluded, privately, that he cannot continue — in the role, in the marriage, in his life. The conclusion is generally reached in the same isolation as everything else, it is frequently not communicated, and it is sometimes acted upon. Men in authority are a group with a documented elevated risk, and the chapter states the position directly: a man who has reached the conclusion that his situation is unendurable and that nothing can be altered should treat the matter as requiring professional assessment immediately, and should not rely on his own capacity to manage it privately, because that capacity is the facility that the condition has degraded.

The Two Errors

The man's error. The presentations are interpreted as temporary, as related to a particular quarter, as the consequence of a difficult individual, as a matter of fitness, or as an indication that the man requires a holiday. The interpretation delays the response for a period that is frequently measured in years, and the delay is what allows an ordinary condition to become a serious one.

The organisation's error. The matter is read as a performance matter, and performance matters are managed with the measures available to the organisation: targets, monitoring, additional support on the immediate tasks, and, in the end, an exit. The man's conduct is then interpreted as evidence about his capacity rather than about his condition, and the corrective arrangement — the arrangement in Section 31.5 — is the one measure that is not among the available options.

31.5 Leading Without Losing Yourself

The arrangements that allow a man to hold authority without the position consuming his judgement, his relationships, and his household are six, and they are specifically adapted to the three structural effects of Section 31.1.

Arrangement One: The Peer Arrangement

What it is. A standing arrangement with one or more people who hold comparable authority and are not in the man's reporting line and not in competition

with him for the same things: a group of chief executives in a sector, a principals' group, a group of heads of department from different institutions, a professional association's senior section, a business owners' group, a small standing group of three to six men in similar positions.

What it supplies. The only available form of disclosure that is not compromised by the position. The members are neither the man's subordinates nor his competitors for the specific matters he requires discussion of, and the arrangement's function is exactly the one described in Chapter 27.5 Stage Six: more than one man, membership, and the correction of the man's account by people whose positions differ from his.

The rules that make it work. A fixed time; a small number; a rule of confidentiality; a rule that nobody reports anybody's material outside the group; and a rule against advice-giving for the first period of any man's material. The rules are not a formality. Groups of this kind fail when they become occasions for presentations or for the exchange of positions, and they succeed when they are occasions at which the man can say the sentence he has a reason not to say anywhere else.

The obstacle. Men in authority frequently decline the arrangement on the grounds that they cannot disclose: *anything I say will be known.* The concern is legitimate and it is answered by the rules above and by the requirement of a group whose members are outside the man's own market. Where a group cannot be formed, the arrangement is supplied by a professional relationship, which is Arrangement Two.

Arrangement Two: The Arrangement Outside the Line

What it is. A supervision, mentoring, counselling, coaching, or medical arrangement with a defined purpose, a defined fee or service, and a confidentiality obligation. What distinguishes it from the peer arrangement is the professional obligation and the absence of any relationship outside the arrangement.

The three functions. To supply a recipient for the man's own material; to supply the calibration the position removes, since the practitioner will tell the man what nobody in his organisation will; and to supply a setting in which the man is not the leader, which is its own distinct function and which is addressed in Arrangement Five.

The frequency. Monthly or fortnightly for a period of no less than six months. A single arrangement of three sessions is not a test of the arrangement, and the men who report the greatest benefit describe a first period of two to three months in which the sessions appeared to be of limited use.

The obstacle. The man's belief that the arrangement implies incapacity. Where the arrangement is a regular feature of the man's professional community,

the difficulty disappears, and where it is not, the framing that men report as workable is functional: the arrangement is a component of the man's responsibilities, since his judgement is a resource that the people he leads depend upon.

Arrangement Three: The Questions That Retrieve the Information

What it is. A deliberate practice for addressing the information asymmetry of Section 31.1, and its form is a set of questions the man asks as a routine rather than as an exception.

The material that the organisation will not report upward is specific, and the questions that retrieve it are correspondingly specific:

- What is the matter that nobody has raised with me this month?
- What has changed in the mood of this group, and who noticed it first?
- Which of the people in my area is carrying something that is affecting their work?
- What is the thing that would be obvious to me if I were not the leader here?
- What have I done in the last month that was unhelpful, and who saw it?

The practice requires two conditions to work. It must be asked of somebody who can answer honestly — generally a small number of people the man has identified as willing to report accurately — and the man must not defend himself against the answers. Men who operate the practice describe the first period as uncomfortable and describe the information obtained as the most useful available to them.

Arrangement Four: The Boundary as a Written Arrangement

What it is. The man's own specification, in writing, of what the position may consume: the hours, the days, the travel, the availability at weekends, the household arrangements that will not be moved, and the conditions under which the specification will be revised.

The specific requirement. The specification must be written, must have dates, and must be given to somebody who will notice. The material on men's overwork in Chapter 18 applies; the addition here is that a man in authority has no natural constraint and must therefore supply one deliberately. Men who have constructed the specification report that its function is not the reduction of the work but the availability of a position from which to make the trade-offs: with a written boundary, a request for the man's household time is a decision with a stated cost rather than an automatic concession.

Arrangement Five: The Place Where He Is Not the Leader

What it is. One setting in which the man has no authority, is not consulted, is not responsible, and is not performing: a men's group, a sports club, a class, a choir, a workshop, a volunteer role in which he is a participant, a friend's household in which he is a guest, a place of worship where he is one of the attendees.

The function. The setting supplies the man's own experience of not being in charge, which is the condition of his rest. Men in authority describe the specific quality of this setting accurately: it is where the man's shoulders come down. Its other function is calibration: the man who has been addressed as the person who knows for twenty years has no information about what he is like in the ordinary position, and the setting supplies it.

The obstacle. The man's own conduct. Men in authority frequently convert every new setting into a leadership position within a period of months, because leading is what they are competent at and because the setting's members frequently ask them to. The arrangement requires the man's deliberate refusal of office in that setting, which he should extend to the small things: no chairing, no organising, no being the person who handles the money.

Arrangement Six: The Household Arrangement

What it is. The man's spouse and children know his actual position at the level of the fact: that he is under load, that he is carrying something specific, that his short temper is not about them, that he has an arrangement in which it is being addressed, and what the household requires of him.

The case for it. The household is generally the party that absorbs the cost of an unsupported leader, as Section 31.3 establishes, and the household's arrangements would be substantially altered by accurate information. The specific material on this arrangement is in Chapters 17 and 18.

The form. The disclosure of the fact rather than the content: what the load is, what the man is doing about it, and what he requires. The men who conduct it report the household's response as relief rather than as additional burden, and the finding is consistent enough to be stated as a general proposition.

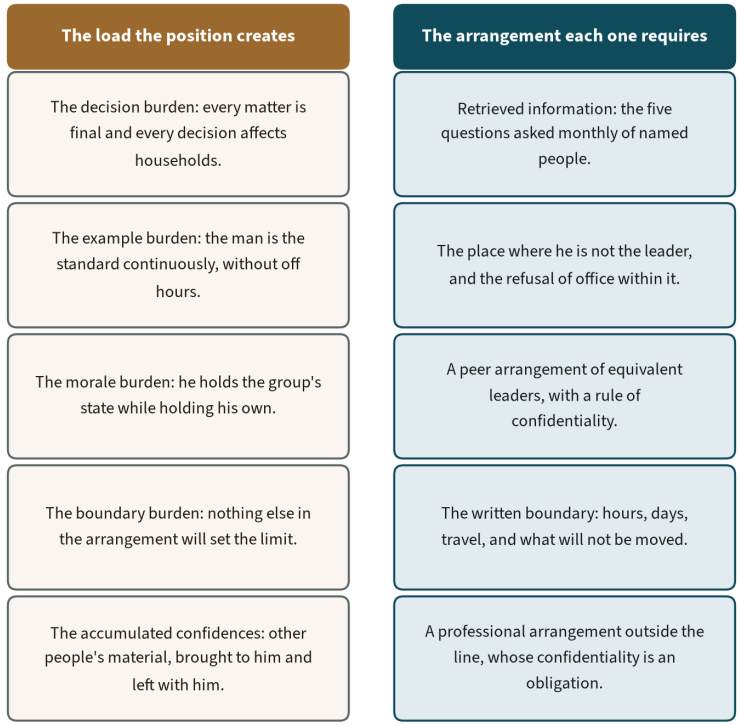


Figure 31.1 The leader's load and the six arrangements that carry it. The upper part of the diagram sets out the four burdens that are not visible in the man's performance, together with the fifth — other people's personal material. The lower part identifies the six arrangements, and the structural effect from Section 31.1 that each is constructed to counter.

31.6 Leading a Household as Though It Were an Organisation

The chapter's final substantive section concerns the specific error most frequently reported by the households of men in authority, and it requires a section of its own because its effects are produced inside the man's own home.

The Transfer

A man who leads an organisation for eleven hours a day returns to a household and applies the same arrangements. The transfer typically takes four forms.

The reporting line. The household is arranged as a structure with the man at the top: decisions are brought to him, information is selected on the way up, and the household's members are positioned in relation to his approval, his assessment, and his availability. The arrangement is frequently not the man's own construction; it is the household's response to his position, and it becomes the household's shape over years.

The information asymmetry. The household's members select what they report, in exactly the way the organisation does, and for the same reason. The man therefore does not know the household's actual position, while believing that he does, which is the arrangement described in Chapter 18 and which produces the man's own late discovery of matters his household has been managing for years.

The emotional discharge. The household becomes the place in which the material accumulated in the day is released, because it is the only place where the man is not required to hold it. The release frequently takes the form of shortness with the people who are most available and least likely to impose a consequence: a spouse, a child, a domestic employee.

The standard. The man's example burden, carried all day, is continued at home: the household's conduct is required to meet the standard of the man's organisation, and small domestic arrangements are managed with the oversight appropriate to a workplace.

The Consequences

The household's arrangements are managed rather than lived. The spouse manages the man's mood, the children manage their disclosures, and the household's occasions are conducted with the man's requirements as the organising principle. This is the household described in Chapter 18, and its feature is that it functions well and none of the people in it are known to the man.

The man's authority becomes unconditional. In an organisation, the man's authority is bounded by the law, by his own supervisor, by procedures, and by the fact that people can leave. In a household, and particularly where the man is the provider, the authority is frequently unbounded, and the report from family practice is that this is where the pattern's most serious consequences occur. The arrangements of an organisation are designed to contain authority; a household has no such design. Any man who applies authority in his household without a container should regard his own conduct as the principal risk in the arrangement, and should obtain the arrangements of Section 31.5 in the household's terms.

The man is not known in the one place where he is most himself. The final and most reported consequence. The man arrives home and is not a participant: he is the person whose arrival changes the room. Men describe the discovery of this position precisely and frequently late: *I realised that my children talk differently when I am not there, and that I have never heard the conversation they have when I am not there.*

The Correction

Three measures, and their order matters.

Separate the positions in the man's own account. In writing: what the man's authority at work consists of, and what it entitles him to at home. The

two lists are different, and the writing frequently establishes the difference for the first time.

Renegotiate the household's arrangements in the household's terms. The material of Chapters 18 and 20 applies, and the specific measures are those chapters': the household's meetings at which information is exchanged rather than reported; the removal of the man from the approval position in matters that the household can decide; the deliberate practice of being told about the household's actual position; the spouse's own arrangements, resources, and standing; and the children's disclosures received without assessment.

Conduct the fifth and sixth arrangements, and supply the man's own position to the household. The household's difficulty is not the man's authority in itself; it is the man's authority without the man. Where the household knows what the man is carrying, knows that he has an arrangement in which it is addressed, and knows what he requires of it — the forms described in Arrangements Five and Six — the household's response is substantially altered, and its members' conduct toward the man becomes the conduct of people with information.

31.7 Illustrative Case: The Principal Who Held Everything

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in leadership practice, occupational health, and family practice.

Olusegun is fifty-four, the principal of a secondary school of about nine hundred students, in the position for eleven years, married to Funmi for twenty-nine years, with three children, the youngest of whom is twenty.

The school's position at the beginning of the case was substantial and it was well known in the state: results rising over eight years, a building programme, a staff of sixty-four, and a reputation that made the school an attractive posting for teachers and a difficult one for a principal.

Olusegun's account of the load, given in an occupational health consultation and subsequently in a structured review, had four components.

The decisions. He described his average day as containing between thirty and fifty matters requiring a decision, of which about a quarter affected individuals directly: a teacher's request, a parent's complaint, a student's discipline, an allocation, a purchase, a staff matter. His account: *The one I could not forget was a boy I expelled in my fourth year. He did not finish. I do not know what happened to him. I expelled him for a reason that was correct and I have not stopped thinking about him in eleven years.*

The example. He described the requirement of being the school's standard, and identified the cost precisely: *I have not been seen in this town in a bad temper or in an untidy shirt in eleven years. Not once. I cannot remember what it is like to have a morning in which I am not being read.*

The morale. The staff's anxieties, the parents' expectations, the government's requirements, the students' material. His account of the emotional function of the position: *Everybody in the school brings their problem to my office. When the money is late, the staff come and I must explain it and I must be calm about it. Nobody brings me anything to be calm about. I am the office where the calm is deposited.*

The material. Olusegun's accumulated confidences were substantial and he listed them in the review: the teacher whose husband had left; the two teachers in a long-running dispute; the boy who was being abused at home and whose case had been managed over two years; the bursar's error that Olusegun had covered from the school's contingency; a member of the governing board who had asked him to do something improper and had made the request three times; the death of a student in his fifth year and the family's anger; and the continuing financial difficulty of two members of his staff. His account: *I keep them all in my head. I have never told anybody, and I could not tell my wife, because half of them involve people she knows.*

The position by the eleventh year, in the account of both Olusegun and his wife, contained six of the nine presentations from Section 31.4: sleep that did not restore him; the postponement of decisions, including the deferral of a staff appointment for nine months; the intolerance of other people's material, expressed in February of that year by his telling a teacher with a domestic difficulty that he should *take it up with the welfare committee*, which was not his manner; a private cynicism about the staff and the parents which he expressed in his own words as *sometimes I look at the assembly and I do not care about any of them*; the loss of the position's meaning, described as *I have built this place and I do not know why I am still doing it*; and the conduct at home, which Funmi described in the following terms: *He was not shouting. He was gone. He would come in, greet, eat, sit with the phone, sleep. If the children had anything to tell him, they told me. If I asked him anything about the school he said it was fine.*

Two matters made the position visible. The first was a medical episode: Olusegun was taken to a clinic with chest pain and a raised blood pressure during a week of the school's examinations, was investigated, and was told after three days that the cardiac findings were normal and that the blood pressure was likely to be responsive to his circumstances.

The second was Funmi's decision, taken without warning, to move temporarily to her sister's house with a written statement of her reasons. Her statement, which Olusegun produced in the review and which occupied two pages, had the following central passage: *You became the school eleven years ago. You are not the manager of the school; you are the school. There is no part of you that is separate from it and there is no part of you at home, and I am not able to live with an institution. You are carrying that place and you will not put any of it down, and I have watched you do it for eleven years and I am tired. I am not leaving you. I am leaving the school's husband.*

The work Olusegun conducted over the following eighteen months had six elements and he identified each separately.

The professional arrangement. From the clinic's recommendation, Olusegun engaged a counselling arrangement with a defined purpose. He described the first three months as unproductive and the fourth month as the point at which the arrangement changed: *She asked me, in the fourth month, what I had decided about the boy I expelled. I had not mentioned him for ten weeks. I began to cry, which I had not done since I was a boy, and I talked about him for the whole hour. In eleven years, I had never said his name to anybody.*

The peer arrangement. Olusegun joined a regional association of school principals and, on the recommendation of a colleague, a small group of five principals from different schools which met monthly. He described the group in the terms of Arrangement One: *We do not talk about the results. The first hour is arrangements and the second hour is what is actually happening. I have heard four men in that group describe what I have been hiding and none of them is a weak man. The first meeting I attended I said nothing for an hour and a half.*

The retrieved information. Olusegun established the practice from Arrangement Three, asking five specific people — two members of staff, the vice-principal in charge of administration, the bursar, and the chair of the staff welfare committee — the questions from Section 31.5 monthly. He described the outcome: *The second month, the welfare chairman told me that a teacher I had trusted was upsetting the younger staff. I did not know. I had not known for two years. The practice is the most useful thing I have introduced for myself in eleven years.*

The boundary. A written specification of the position's requirements, constructed with Funmi over two sittings, containing the hours, the days, a rule that the school's matters would not be conducted after 7 p.m. and a rule that Saturday would be the household's except in an emergency. He described the first six months of its operation as the hardest part of the whole process, because *the school objected in the way an institution objects: everything was urgent.*

The place where he was not the principal. Olusegun joined a football group of men of his age in the town, an arrangement that had nothing to do with the school, and where he was a participant and not a decision-maker. He refused a request to be its chairman in the second year. His account: *For two hours on a Sunday I am one of the men who cannot play well enough and nobody brings me a problem. It took me a year to enjoy it. I enjoy it now.*

The household. Over the fourth to seventh months, Olusegun conducted the household arrangement with Funmi and, separately, with the two children who were at home. The content was the fact rather than the material: the load, the accumulated confidences, the expelled boy, the chest episode, the arrangement he had entered, what the group was, what the boundary contained, and what he required of the household. Funmi's response is recorded because it identifies the arrangement's function: *He spent four hours telling me things I had not known in twenty-nine years and the thing I noticed was that he was answering a question I had asked for eleven years, which was whether there was anything in there. There was. There was a great*

deal. He had just not given it to anybody, and I had been guessing at what it was, and my guess was worse than what it was.
Olusegun described the position in the fourth year after the episode in the following terms: *I am still the principal and the school is still hard. I said to the group in the second year that I had been carrying eleven years of other people's material and my own and I had never once said the words out loud, and four of the five men said the same thing. I have a group, a counsellor, a boundary on the paper on the wall of my office, a Sunday where I am not the principal, and a wife who now knows the reason I am quiet in the evening. I have not become different. I have become known, in three places.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The load was invisible in performance. Eleven years of rising results, a building programme, and a staff of sixty-four, with the man's own state deteriorating behind them. This is the presentation described in Section 31.4 as the performance of performance, and the case is included because the men in this position are frequently the last in their organisations to be identified as being at risk, since the evidence available to everybody else is the results.

The accumulated material was the specific burden, and it had no arrangement. The expelled boy, the abuse case, the bursar's error, the board member's request, the staff's difficulties. The case is included because the phenomenon is, in the experience of practitioners, among the most under-recognised sources of load in leadership work: the man accumulates confidences because they are brought to him, and there is no arrangement in which his own position concerning them can be held.

The spouse's statement identified the mechanism precisely. *You are the school. There is no part of you that is separate from it and there is no part of you at home.* This is the identity collapse of Chapter 24 combined with the boundary failure of Section 31.3, and the case is included because the household's account is frequently the most accurate description of the man's position available anywhere, and it is frequently ignored until the household takes a measure.

The arrangements were multiple, and no single one of them worked alone. The professional arrangement supplied the disclosure; the peer group supplied the correction and the recognition that the condition was general; the retrieved information supplied the calibration; the boundary supplied the structure; the Sunday supplied the rest; and the household arrangement supplied the man's position to the people living with him. The case is included because men frequently attempt one of the six and conclude that the arrangements do not work, and because the six are designed as a set.

The fifth element is the one men refuse. The place where the man is not the leader, and the refusal of office within it. The case records the man's own difficulty

with the arrangement — a year before he enjoyed it, and a refused chairmanship — and it is included for that reason: the element that appears the most trivial in the list is the one that supplies the man's own experience of being off duty, and it is the one leaders most frequently convert into another position.

31.8 Practical Exercise: The Load Audit and the Six Arrangements

This exercise takes about three hours, over three sittings.

Part One: The Load Audit (Sitting One)

Section A: The four burdens. For each, record what you are currently carrying, in specific terms.

The burden	What it consists of in my position	What I am carrying alone
The decisions		
The example		
The morale		
The boundary		
Other people's material		

Section B: The accumulated confidences. List, without names where the material is confidential, the matters other people have brought to you in the last three years that you are still carrying: the difficulties of subordinates, the disputes, the errors you have covered, the requests you have declined, the cases you have managed, the losses you have witnessed. Count them.

Section C: The decisions you have not put down. List the decisions you have made in your position that produced harm, or that you are not certain were right, and that you have never described to anybody.

Section D: The information audit. From Section 31.1's second effect, answer the following.

- Who tells me the matter that nobody has raised with me?
- What have I learned in the last year about my own conduct or state from somebody else?
- Who would tell me if I had become short, distant, or difficult? Has anybody ever?
- What is the matter that would be obvious to me if I were not the leader here?

Part Two: The Presentations (Sitting Two)

Apply the nine presentations from Section 31.4 and record which are present, with the evidence.

Presentation	Present?	The evidence
Exhaustion that sleep does not correct		
Decision avoidance		
Intolerance of other people's material		
Cynicism		
Loss of the position's meaning		
Performance of performance		
The body (sleep, blood pressure, chest, stomach, alcohol)		
Conduct at home		
A conclusion that I cannot continue		

Where the ninth item is present, or where the body items indicate an untreated condition, record the date of the appointment in Part Three and treat it as the first arrangement.

Part Three: The Six Arrangements (Sitting Three)

The arrangement	The specific form	The date
One: the peer arrangement		
Two: the arrangement outside the line		
Three: the questions, asked monthly of named people		
Four: the written boundary		
Five: the place where I am not the leader		
Six: the household arrangement		

For Arrangement Three: write the five questions from Section 31.5 and the names of two people to whom you will ask them, monthly, for six months.

For Arrangement Four: write the boundary specification itself: the hours, the days, the travel, the availability, the household arrangements that will not be moved, and the conditions under which it will be revised. Give a copy to one person who will notice.

For Arrangement Five: name the setting, and record the offices and responsibilities you will refuse within it.

For Arrangement Six: write the disclosure of the fact, in the form given in Section 31.5, and record the person to whom you will make it.

Part Four: The Household

Answer the following, and where any answer is affirmative, conduct the correction in Section 31.6.

- Are decisions in my household brought to me for approval that the household could decide?

- Do the members of my household select what they tell me?
- Do I release the day's material at home, and toward whom?
- Do I know the household's actual position, including its financial position, its difficulties, and what each member is carrying?
- What does my household do differently when I am not in the house?

31.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is this not simply the price of the position? Everybody who leads is alone."

The isolation is general and the price is not fixed. The arrangements in Section 31.5 are used by leaders in every sector, and the men who use them report specific differences in their judgement, their health, and their households. The proposition that leadership requires total isolation is a description of the current arrangement rather than a law, and its practical consequence is the degradation of the judgement of the person responsible for the outcomes of everybody in the organisation.

"I cannot tell anybody anything. Anything I say will get out."

The concern is legitimate in a small market or a small town, and it is the reason that Arrangements One and Two are constructed as they are: a peer group whose members are outside the man's own market, with a rule of confidentiality; and a professional arrangement whose confidentiality is an obligation rather than a favour. Where the man can obtain neither, the question to be answered is what the alternative costs: the Chapter 27.3 material on judgement applies, and the man's decision-making is being conducted without correction.

"I do not have time for a group and a counsellor and a boundary."

The arrangements take less time than the man's current position consumes in managing the consequences of his condition: the deferred decisions, the meetings cancelled, the episodes of illness, the household's crisis, the matter that was not raised with him for two years. The case material is consistent on the arithmetic: the arrangements consume a few hours a month and the condition consumes the man's evenings, his health, and frequently a year of his work.

"My household does not need to know about my work."

The household does not require the content. The arrangement in Section 31.5 is the disclosure of the fact: the load, what the man is doing about it, and what he requires. The specific finding from men who have conducted it is that the household's alternative explanation for the man's state is generally worse than the truth, and that the disclosure alters their conduct toward him in the direction he requires.

"I have been leading for twenty years and I am not in difficulty."

Then the arrangements that apply are the ones that keep it that way: the peer group, the retrieved information, the boundary specification, the place where the

man is not the leader, and the household arrangement. The specific value for a man who is not in difficulty is the calibration in Arrangement Three: the information about his own conduct that nobody in his organisation will supply. Men who have operated the practice over years report that it is the measure that has prevented the position from altering them without their noticing.

"I think I am at the end of it. What do I do first?"

Apply Section 31.4's ninth presentation and treat it as an emergency: obtain a professional assessment now, and do not conduct the matter privately. Then, in the order in which the case material reports them as most useful: the professional arrangement, since it is the earliest available; the household arrangement, since the household is already affected; the boundary, since the position will not reduce itself; and the peer arrangement, which requires more time to construct. The chapter's position on the ninth presentation should be recorded plainly: the conclusion that a man cannot continue, held in isolation by a man whose judgement has been degraded by that same isolation, is the most dangerous configuration in this book, and it requires contact with a professional rather than further private deliberation.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 31 in brief. Every arrangement of authority separates the man who holds it from the people subject to it, and three structural effects operate: the boundary of rank, through which his words, moods, intimacies, dependence, self-management, and history acquire a weight determined by the hierarchy; the information asymmetry, through which he receives selected information, is not told the matter that most concerns him, and is not informed of his own state by anybody; and the position as the container of other people's anxiety, in which the group's uncertainty is deposited and none of the man's own material is returned anywhere.

The isolation takes five forms: the man with nobody above him, whose judgement is therefore unbounded; the man whose nearest peer is his competitor; the man promoted from the group; the man in the small setting without a professional community; and the man whose position is not recognised as leadership at all. The position makes four things impossible: complaint in the ordinary direction, the visible expression of uncertainty, reciprocal friendship, and the man's own state being available to him.

The load consists of five burdens, of which the first four are the decision burden, the example burden, the morale burden, and the boundary burden, and the fifth — carried by many leaders and rarely named — is the accumulation of other people's personal material, brought to the man because he has the standing to act and left with him because there is no arrangement in which his own position concerning it can be held. Carrying the load alone has two consequences: the degradation of judgement, which affects the people the man is responsible for, and the accumulation of the material in his household and his body.

The presentations of a leader who has nothing left are exhaustion that sleep does not correct, decision avoidance, intolerance of other people's material, cynicism, the loss of the position's meaning, the performance of performance, the body, the conduct at home, and a privately reached conclusion that he cannot continue. The final item is the most serious configuration in this book and requires professional assessment rather than private deliberation.

Six arrangements allow a man to hold authority without being consumed by it: the peer arrangement of equivalent leaders with a rule of confidentiality; the professional arrangement outside the reporting line; the five questions asked monthly of named people to retrieve the information the organisation withholds; the boundary written, dated, and given to somebody who will notice; the place where the man is not the leader and refuses office; and the household arrangement, in which the man's spouse and children know the fact of the load, what he is doing about it, and what he requires. Finally, a leadership arrangement must not be transferred into a household: the reporting line, the asymmetry, the emotional discharge, and the standard all produce a household that functions and whose members are not known to the man, and the correction is the separation of the two positions, the renegotiation of the household in its own terms, and the supply of the man's own position to the people who live with him.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the confidences list in Part One, Section B. How many matters are you holding that were brought to you by other people, and who holds your own?
2. From Section 31.1's second effect: what have you learned in the last year about your own conduct from somebody else, and who would tell you if you had altered in a way that mattered?
3. Which of the nine presentations in Section 31.4 are present in your case? Which has your household noticed, and what have they concluded about it?
4. Which of the five forms of isolation in Section 31.2 describes your position, and what does it make impossible in your arrangements?
5. Construct the five questions from Arrangement Three and name two people you will ask them. What do you expect the first month's answers to contain?
6. Write the boundary specification. Which item in it is currently being violated, and by whom?
7. Answer the five questions in Part Four about your household. What does your household do differently when you are not in the house?

Further Reading

- **On leadership and isolation:** the literature on the loneliness of leadership, including the findings on the structural sources of leader isolation, the effects

of isolation on leader judgement and wellbeing, and the practices that leaders use to obtain candid feedback.

- **On decision fatigue:** the research on decision fatigue and on the depletion of judgement across a working day, including the findings on the conditions under which judgement is preserved and the practical routines that have been developed in professions where the consequences of poor decisions are severe.
- **On executive and leadership coaching, mentoring, and supervision:** the practice literature on the arrangements available to men in positions of authority, including the evidence on their use, the conditions under which they are effective, and the confidentiality obligations that govern them.
- **On leader wellbeing and burnout:** the research on burnout in leaders and in managers, including the findings on the association between leadership responsibility and psychological strain, the evidence on exhaustion, cynicism, and the loss of meaning as its components, and the risk factors that predict more serious outcomes.
- **On family business and on the household of the leader:** the literature on family dynamics in which one member holds the principal authority, including the findings on how leadership conduct transfers into household arrangements and its effects on spouses and on children.
- **Practical resources:** peer groups and professional associations for leaders; executive coaching, mentoring, and counselling services with defined confidentiality; occupational health services; family and relationship counselling; and the material in Appendices I, J, N, and O.

32 CHAPTER

The Man Who Must Always Have Answers

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the requirement to have answers, identify its sources, and explain why it is imposed on men more heavily than on others.
2. Explain the four costs of the requirement, including its effects on the man's learning, his judgement, and the people who depend on him.
3. Identify the knowledge trap: the position in which a man's standing rests on his being the one who knows, and the specific difficulty of asking for help from inside it.
4. Distinguish the four kinds of question a man is asked, and assess which of them he actually has the authority and information to answer.
5. Apply the protocol for saying *I do not know* in a form that preserves the position and improves the outcome.
6. Use questioning as a competence rather than as a defect, and apply the exercise at the end of the chapter to identify where the requirement is currently costing him and his organisation.

Introduction

There is a sentence that men in positions of responsibility learn early and generally without noticing: *You are the one who is supposed to know.*

It arrives with the position, with fatherhood, with the role of the eldest, with the trade, with the household's finances, with the title, with the uniform, and with the age at which a man becomes the person others consult. From that point onward, a specific requirement attaches to him: whatever the matter is — the money, the decision, the illness, the marriage, the child, the document, the machine, the discipline, the direction — he is expected to have an answer, and his own uncertainty is not among the responses the role permits.

This chapter concerns that requirement: its cost to the man, its cost to the people who depend on him, and its correction.

The requirement is not imaginary and it is not imposed by hostile people. It is a functional requirement of a position: a group that cannot obtain decisions does not function, and men are frequently the people in the group who have been assigned the deciding. The chapter's position is not that men should cease to be competent, cease to decide, or abandon the authority their positions require. It is that the requirement, in its absolute form, degrades four things: the man's learning, his judgement, the accuracy of the information available to him, and the confidence of the people around him — and that all four improve when the requirement is corrected into a specific and workable practice.

The chapter's approach has four commitments.

The first is that the difficulty is produced by the requirement rather than by the man's vanity. Men who cannot say *I do not know* are frequently not arrogant; they are operating the arrangement they were given, and they have accurate information about its terms. A man who says *I do not know* in a setting that requires answers from him frequently observes a change in how he is regarded, and the observation is generally correct. The problem requires a method rather than a resolution to be more humble.

The second is that the requirement's cost is borne principally by other people. The man who bluffs an answer to a technical question puts his organisation at risk; the man who will not ask the doctor a question affects his household's decisions; the man who cannot say *I was wrong about this* keeps a failing arrangement running; the man who must answer every question from his children supplies them with information he does not have. The chapter's material on judgement in Chapter 27.3 applies with an additional feature: the isolated man's decisions affect people who had no part in his isolation.

The third is that the correction is technical and can be stated in a form the man can use. Sections 32.5 and 32.6 supply the protocol and the practice: the three-part reply to a question the man cannot answer, and the use of questions as a competence rather than as a confession of ignorance. The protocol is deliberate and it is used by professionals in every field where the man's credibility and the outcome both matter.

The fourth is that the choice is not between knowing everything and knowing nothing. The absolute requirement and its opposite — the man who refers every matter upward, who will not commit, who says *I do not know* as a means of avoiding responsibility — are both failures, and the material is written to establish the position between them: a man who knows what he knows, says so plainly, says plainly what he does not know, and then does the work of finding out.

32.1 Where the Requirement Comes From

The requirement has six sources, and they reinforce one another. Identifying the ones operating in the reader's case is the first practical step, because the correction differs by source.

Source One: The Position

A position of authority requires decisions, and decisions are answers. The group's functioning depends on a person who will bring a matter to a conclusion, and the person assigned that function is the man and, in the case of a group of any size, the handful of people who occupy the positions. The requirement follows from the function and it is not a matter of culture: a group in which everybody defers the decision indefinitely will not function, which is why the man who has been given the function is under a genuine obligation to supply answers in the domain of his authority.

Source Two: The Cultural Instruction About Men

The instruction is delivered in specific forms: that a man should not ask for directions; that a man should know how to do the thing; that a man who asks is not the man for the position; that a husband should be the one who knows the way; that a father should have the answer for his children. The instruction is documented in research on men's help-seeking, where it appears among the principal barriers: the belief that seeking help is a sign of inadequacy, the fear of being seen not to know, and the anticipation of a loss of standing.

The instruction's effect is not the elimination of the man's questions but their suppression. Men ask them elsewhere, anonymously, privately, of a search engine, of a stranger, of a practitioner who has an obligation of confidence. The information obtained privately is frequently accurate and it is not shared with the people who needed it, which is the practical cost.

Source Three: The Household

A man's own household imposes the requirement in a specific form, and its instrument is the man's assumption about what his household needs from him. Men report, with high consistency, the belief that their spouse and children require certainty from them: that a father who says *I do not know how we will manage this* is abandoning his household, that a husband who admits fear is transferring the fear, and that the man's function is to hold the household's picture of the future steady.

The belief is partly accurate and it is generally applied too broadly. The material in Parts III and V establishes the distinction: the household requires the man's competence in the domains in which he has power, and it requires his honesty in the domains in which he does not. A household informed of the actual position

makes better arrangements than a household holding an account the man has constructed, which is the finding of Chapters 18 and 20 in a different register.

Source Four: The Previous Generation

The requirement is frequently inherited. The father who never explained, who never admitted ignorance, who never discussed a matter he did not control, who answered a question with a fact rather than with an account. The son of such a man frequently reproduces the form, because it is what he knows, and he reproduces it with the same consequences: the household's information is organised around what the man can supply.

Source Five: The Man's Own Account of Himself

The requirement is, in many men, an identity arrangement rather than a role requirement: the man's account of himself includes being the one who knows, and the arrangement is carried because the alternative is a change in the account. The material of Chapter 24 applies. The specific markers: the man who is unable to say in a meeting that he does not know; the man who is unable to ask a practitioner to explain; the man who is uncomfortable when his household manages a matter without him; and the man who experiences the disclosure of an error as a loss of standing rather than as information.

Source Six: The Rewards

The requirement is reinforced by its outcomes. Men who supply answers promptly are promoted, chosen, deferred to, and trusted, and the reinforcement is real. The difficulty is that the reinforcement attaches to the answer rather than to its accuracy, which means that in a domain where the man's knowledge has an edge, the arrangement is rewarded, and in the domain where it does not, the arrangement is still rewarded. The pattern is documented in the research on overconfidence in expert settings: the man's rapid answer is read as competence by people who cannot assess it.

KEY POINT

The requirement to have answers has six sources: the position's functional need for decisions; the cultural instruction that a man should know; the household's requirement as the man understands it; the inherited form from a father who never said *I do not know*; the man's own account of himself; and the rewards that attend a prompt answer irrespective of its accuracy. The suppression of the man's questions does not remove them; it relocates them to settings with an obligation of confidence and removes the information from the people who required it.

32.2 What the Requirement Costs

The four costs are documented and they fall on four different parties, which is why the requirement is frequently described as a strength by the man's environment.

Cost One: The Bluff

The direct cost, and the most consequential. The man who has the answer requirement and lacks the information supplies an answer, and the answer is composed of the material available to him. Its forms.

The confidently wrong answer. The man gives a specified figure, a route, a period, a name, a mechanism, or a legal position, and the information is not correct. Men in every sector describe having done it: the operating rule given to a young operator, the tax position stated to a client, the consequence explained to a patient's family, the timing given to a household, the diagnosis offered to a subordinate, the measurement stated on a building site.

The answer that is concealed by its delivery. The man's tone, certainty, and brevity carry the answer, and the hearer therefore cannot assess it. The mechanism is documented: the man's status in the setting determines the credence given to his statement, which is the reason the confident answer is the most dangerous form of the error.

The answer that ends the enquiry. The most costly form, and the one that is the least visible: the man's answer prevents the question from being asked of somebody who knows. Several men or a whole group then proceed on the basis of a statement that was supplied in order to close a matter rather than to inform it.

Cost Two: The Arrested Learning

The requirement prevents the man's own development, and the mechanism is structural.

A man who cannot say *I do not know* cannot ask a question in public, so the matters he does not understand are not addressed in the settings in which they arise. He learns them, where he learns them, privately, after the event, and the learning is frequently too late to be of use. Over years, the arrangement produces a specific profile in men: wide practical competence in the domains in which the man has experience, and a substantial gap in the domains in which he does not, which persists for decades though it would have closed within months if the questions had been asked.

The pattern is documented in the research on men's help-seeking and it is described by men with a specific regret: *I spent eleven years pretending to understand the accounts before I asked somebody to explain the difference between two of the lines.*

Cost Three: The Distorted Information

The requirement alters what arrives to the man, and the alteration is produced by his own conduct.

A man who must always have answers must also always be correct, and the second requirement is what changes the information. Subordinates learn what happens to a bearer of bad news; colleagues learn which matters can be raised; households learn which difficulties can be described. The organisation's information is thereby shaped by the man's intolerance, and the man is the last person to learn of the distortion because nobody informs him of it — the same asymmetry described in Chapter 31.1.

The specific consequence, and the reason this cost is the most expensive for the man's organisation: the man's position is at its most vulnerable in the domain of his own errors. Nobody raises the matter with him, the matter develops, and the correction arrives late or not at all.

Cost Four: The Withdrawal of the People Around Him

The most consequential cost for the man's household and his closest relationships.

A man who cannot be uncertain is a man whose household cannot deliver uncertainty to him, and the material is therefore redirected. The spouse manages alone and says nothing; the children select their disclosures; the subordinate makes the decision without telling him; the friend does not bring his own trouble. The pattern produces the arrangement described in Chapters 17, 18, and 27: a man surrounded by people who no longer bring him anything, and who believes that nothing is being carried by anybody.

The specific and most frequently reported version in men's accounts is the man's late discovery of a matter his household had been managing for years: the debt, the illness, the child's difficulty, the marriage's condition, the relative's conduct. In each case the household's purpose was to protect him from the requirement, and the protection was accurate: the requirement was genuine, and the alternative the household saw was the man's distress, his anger, or a burden added to his load.

The four costs belong to the man and to the parties around him: the bluff falls on the people who act on his answer; the arrested learning falls on the man; the distorted information falls on the man's judgement and on the organisation; and the withdrawal falls on his household. This distribution is the strongest available argument for the correction, and it is the reason the chapter's material is not framed as a matter of the man's personal growth.

32.3 The Knowledge Trap

There is a specific position that carries the requirement to its maximum and that is experienced by men in every walk of life: the man whose standing rests on his knowledge.

The Forms

The self-taught expert. The man who acquired his competence without formal instruction: the mechanic, the builder, the technician, the trader, the farmer, the driver, the administrator, the small-business owner. His standing in his field is entirely his knowledge and his results, and there is no credential to fall back on. The form's specific difficulty is that his authority is personal: nobody assigned it to him, and there is no document that establishes him as the person who knows. His standing is therefore vulnerable in a way that a certified professional's is not, and he manages the vulnerability by never being seen not to know.

The professional whose expertise is narrow and whose authority is broad. The specialist whose formal competence is in one domain and whose position requires him to speak in several. The doctor asked about the law, the engineer asked about the contract, the accountant asked about the strategy, the teacher asked about the child's health, the officer asked about the market. The man answers in the adjacent domain, because the question has been addressed to him and because the alternative is a referral.

The man whose marginal knowledge is being tested. The man among men, in the group, the meeting, the argument: the man who must be able to state the figure, the name, the date, the outcome, the record. Its specific form in men's settings is the competitiveness of the exchange, which recruits the requirement even in men who are not otherwise subject to it: the man who can answer quickly acquires standing in the conversation, and the man who says he does not know loses a point.

The man whose history is his knowledge. The man who has the record of the family, the community, the institution, and the trade: the one who knows what happened, who was involved, what was agreed. This form is common in the man's later years and it carries the same trap in its most complete version, because the man is the sole holder of material that others require and because his standing in the present is frequently his knowledge of the past.

The man who has been the answer's supplier to a person who has died. The specific and reported form in which a man's father, wife, or brother was the person who knew, and the man now occupies the position and must supply what he does not have. Men in this form describe a specific and prolonged difficulty: *he was the one who knew all of this and now people ask me.*

The Trap's Mechanism

The trap has five components, and they compound.

1. The man is identified with his knowledge. His standing in the setting, his income, his household's position, and his own account of himself are all substantially composed of what he knows. A question he cannot answer is not merely an unanswered question; it is a reduction in the man's standing, and the reduction is visible to everyone in the room. The fact that this is somewhat true is what gives the trap its force.

2. The setting reinforces the avoidance. Every time the man answers, the group's behaviour confirms that he is the one who knows, and every time he declines to answer, an unspoken uncertainty is registered. The arrangement is a stable equilibrium: the more the man answers, the more he is asked, and the less anybody asks anybody else.

3. The questions are addressed to the wrong person. Because the man is known as the one who knows, all questions of any kind come to him, including the questions belonging to other people's domains. The man therefore answers, or refers, or deflects. The correct response — that the question be addressed to the person whose competence it concerns — requires the man to admit that there is such a person and that he is not it.

4. The information required to check the man does not exist. The man's answers are frequently not verifiable in his setting: the others do not know enough to check him. The verification comes, where it comes, from the consequence, which arrives later and at a cost that is generally paid by somebody else.

5. The man's own supply of knowledge degrades while his standing requires that it not. The most durable component. A self-taught expert's competence decays with the technology, the market, the regulation, and the practice. The decay is universal and it is normally addressed by asking questions and by learning, which the trap forbids. The man's position therefore deteriorates in the domain on which his standing depends, and the deterioration is invisible to everybody, including frequently to himself, until a consequence arrives.

The Way Out

Four measures, and the fourth is the one that changes the term of the arrangement.

Move the standing from what the man knows to what the man does. The man's account of himself — and his environment's account of him — should rest on his conduct, his obligations, his results, and his reliability rather than on his information. The measure is the one described in Chapter 25.5: the personal measure in the domains of conduct, effort, obligation, and household conduct. A man whose standing is his conduct can be asked a question he cannot answer

without any change in his position, and the arrangement was in evidence in the case material of Chapter 25.

Establish one practice in which the man is demonstrably learning. The trade's new methods, the qualification, the professional association's technical sessions, the course, the reading, the tool, the machine, the software. The practice's function is to place the man in the position of a learner regularly and publicly enough that the position is normal, which converts the occasional admission of ignorance from an event into a habit.

State the domain of your competence. The measure that most effectively ends the trap, and it is a sentence: *that is outside what I do; the person who knows is X*. The sentence's use requires the man to possess an answer of a different kind, which is the referral, and the professionals who operate best in the material are the ones who refer fluently.

Supply the correction yourself before somebody else does. The man who finds an error of his own announced, in his own account, in the setting in which it matters, acquires the position of a man whose information can be trusted. The measure is the practical form of the recovery described in Chapter 25.6, and men who have adopted it describe a specific result: the organisation begins to bring the man's errors to him, which is the arrangement that prevents the most expensive failures.

32.4 When the Answer Is Not Yours to Give

A large proportion of the questions a man receives in a position of authority are not questions that his authority equips him to answer, and the failure to distinguish the classes is what produces the bluff. This section supplies the classification.

The Four Kinds of Question

1. The question within your authority and your information. The decision that only the man can make, with the information available to him. His answer is required and it is his to give. The requirement is legitimate, and the element the man should retain from this chapter is the discipline of saying what he is deciding on: *This is a decision I am taking on what I know, and here is what I am not certain of.*

2. The question within your authority and outside your information. The decision that the man must take, and that requires information he does not have. His answer is required and its content is not: the correct response is the enquiry, the assessment, or the referral, with the decision timetable stated. *I will decide this by Friday, and I cannot decide it until I know X.* The form is described in Section 32.5.

3. The question outside your authority. The matter belonging to somebody else's function: the technical question belonging to the engineer, the

medical question belonging to the practitioner, the legal question belonging to the lawyer, the financial matter belonging to the accountant, the discipline matter belonging to the institution's procedure, the domestic matter belonging to a spouse. The answer required is the referral, and the referral should be specific: the name, the institution, or the procedure, and not a general instruction to seek advice.

4. The question that is not actually a question. The most common of the four in a man's household and in his working life. The person is not requesting information; the person is requesting presence, acknowledgement, attention, an ally, or an account of the man's position. The questions in this class include the household's *what are we going to do about your son*, the subordinate's *who is going to support me in this*, the friend's *what do you think of what he has done*, and the wife's *is this how the next ten years are going to be*. The man's instinct is to supply information, which is not what is being requested, and the household's experience of the exchange is that the man answered a question that was not asked.

The correct response is the one in Part V of this book: the acknowledgement first, the orientation second, the help third. *That is a hard thing to be carrying. Let me hear how it is from your side.*

The Distinctions to Apply Before Answering

Three, and they should be applied in the moment rather than afterwards.

Is this my domain? The fastest question in the classification and the one that catches most of the avoidable bluffs.

Is the information required available to me, or is it available to somebody else? If the answer is the latter, the correct response is the referral, and the referral is a complete answer to the question of what the man can do.

Is the person asking for information, or for something else? If the latter, the answer required is presence rather than content, and supplying information in its place is the reason the man is experienced by his own household as unreachable.

32.5 Saying "I Do Not Know" Without Losing the Room

The correction of the requirement is a protocol, and the protocol has three parts. Its function is not the man's relief; it is the accuracy of the information on which the group, the household, and the man himself will act.

The Three-Part Reply

Part One: what you know. The man states accurately and without amplification what he knows about the matter: the facts, the previous results, the comparable case, the part of the question that is within his domain. The part's function is to establish that the man is competent and engaged, and it is the part that the other two depend upon.

Part Two: what you do not know. The man states the boundary clearly and without apology: *I do not know that.* The sentence should be delivered in the same register as Part One — without a change in tone, without an explanation, without a compensating display of competence in an adjacent matter. The register is the whole of the technique: an apology or a nervous explanation signals that something has occurred, whereas a boundary stated plainly signals that the man has supplied an accurate account.

Part Three: what happens next. The man states who will know, how the matter will be established, and when the answer will arrive: *X knows that; I will ask him this morning. I will have the answer by tomorrow and I will bring it to you.* The part is what preserves the man's position completely, because the position's requirement is not the information itself. It is the assurance that the matter is in hand.

The Protocol in Practice

The protocol's four applications, with the form of the reply.

In a meeting, to a technical question outside the man's domain. *What I know is that the previous contract was priced at X and that the cost has moved. What I do not know is what the current rate for the component is — that is the procurement officer's assessment. I will have it before the next meeting and it will be in the paper.*

In the household, to a question about a matter the man cannot resolve. *I do not know how the fees will be paid in the second term. What I know is that we can cover the first and that I have applied to the cooperative and I will know their position by the end of the month. If they decline, these are the three options and we will decide them together.*

In the man's own domain, on a matter that requires information he lacks. *I am going to decide this by Friday, and I cannot decide it until I know what the supplier's position is. I will not decide it on an estimate, because the last estimate cost us four months.*

To a question the man has been asked for years and has answered incorrectly. *I have been telling you something about that which I now know is wrong. Here is the correction.* The form is the one in Section 32.3′s fourth measure, and it is the single most effective act available to a man whose standing depends on his knowledge.

The Five Obstacles to the Protocol

1. The fear that the question will be read as the man's failure. Answered by the protocol itself: the third part supplies the assurance that the position requires. The men who operate the protocol report the finding consistently: the group's confidence in the man is not reduced and is frequently increased, since the man has demonstrated that his answers can be relied upon. **2. The man's own history**

of never having said it. Men describe the first occasion as the most difficult and describe subsequent occasions as ordinary. The pattern is worth stating: the first *I do not know* in a setting where the man has always known is an event; the twentieth is a habit. **3. The setting in which the man has been making claims.** Where the man has, for years, been the source of answers in a domain he does not command, the correction requires an act of exposure. The act should be conducted deliberately, once, with the correction stated plainly, and the men who have done it report that the exposure is considerably smaller than the dread of it and considerably shorter. **4. The status competition of men's settings.** Where the question is part of an exchange in which the man is competing for standing, the protocol's use requires the man to decline the exchange rather than to lose it. The available form is the one that ends the exchange without a concession: *I do not know that one. What I know is X.* **5. The absence of an alternative in the man's own domain.** Where the man is the only person in his setting with any relevant competence — the sole trader, the lone professional in a small town, the last surviving practitioner of a trade — the protocol's third part has no referent. The correction is then the arrangement rather than the protocol: a peer elsewhere, a professional association, a technical service, an arrangement for a second opinion. Section 27.5′s material on the construction of arrangements applies, and the finding is the same: the man's position requires the arrangement, and the arrangement is constructible.

The Signal the Protocol Sends

The material on this point is consistent in professional practice, and the chapter states it because it corrects the man's central assumption.

The protocol does not read as weakness in a competent man. It reads as accuracy, and accuracy is the attribute that the people around the man actually need from him. The settings in which *I do not know* is read as weakness are the settings in which nothing was known and nobody established anything: the informal competition of men's talk, the exchange among strangers, the environment in which the man's standing is nothing but his display. In the settings that matter to the man's household, his organisation, and his professional standing, the reverse operates: the man whose answers are bounded is trusted in a way that the man whose answers are universal is not.

32.6 Questions as a Competence

The correction's second half, and the part that converts the arrangement from a concession into a skill.

The Five Questions

The following five questions are the ones with the strongest record in leadership practice and in professional settings, and each is a question a man in authority can ask without any reduction in his position because the question demonstrates that he is assessing rather than being assessed.

1. What am I missing? Addressed to a named person who sees the matter from another position. It is the highest-yield question available to a man in authority: the information asymmetry of Section 31.1 means that the man is systematically uninformed, and this question is the instrument that retrieves what the arrangement withholds.

2. Who disagrees, and what is their case? Asked before a decision rather than after it. The question converts disagreement from a threat into an assigned function and, in the practice's own terms, it is the measure that most reliably prevents the decision that nobody had the standing to oppose.

3. What would have to be true for this to fail? The question of the leader who is assessing a plan he has decided to pursue, and its function is to place the failure analysis in the room before the plan rather than after.

4. What is the part of this that nobody has raised? The question for the matter with an unusual absence of objection, and it is the most useful single instrument available against the group's tacit decisions.

5. What have I done in the last month that I should know about? Asked of a small number of people who have indicated that they will answer. The question is uncomfortable, it is the most consequential of the five, and the men who have practised it report that it is the measure that has kept their conduct calibrated.

The Practice

Frequency and setting. The five questions monthly, in a fixed setting: a meeting with two or three people, a supervision arrangement, a walk, a call. The practice requires regularity rather than intensity.

The conditions. Two, and they are the conditions of the Chapter 31.5 third arrangement: the question must be asked of people who can answer honestly, and the man must not defend himself against the answer. The man's first response to an unfavourable answer should be an acknowledgement and a follow-up question, and the practice's whole value depends on it: a man who asks *what am I missing* and then argues with the reply has taught his organisation that the question is a formality.

The record. The answers, written, with dates. The record supplies the man with the calibration described in Section 31.1, and it supplies him, at the end of

a year, with an account of his own conduct that he would not have obtained by any other means.

The Difference Between Asking and Abdicating

Two clarifications, because the material can be misread.

The man who asks has not ceased to decide. The questions are the input to a decision that remains the man's. The distinction is between a decision made with the group's information and a decision delegated to the group, and the members of a group are generally able to distinguish the two accurately.

The man who asks has not become uncertain. The questions operate on the man's account of the matter and not on his confidence in himself. The men with the strongest record in this practice describe their confidence as unaltered: what changed was the accuracy of the information and the number of matters that arrived before they became problems.

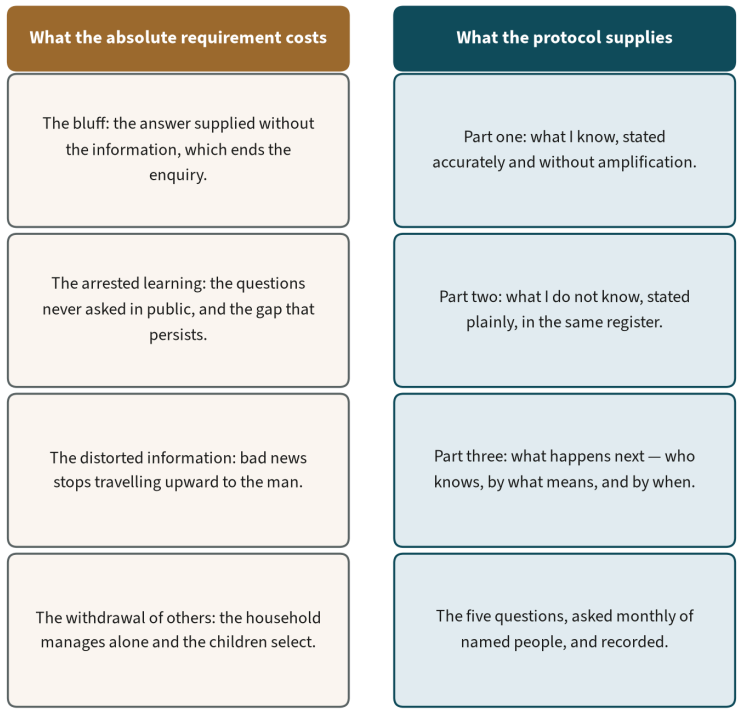


Figure 32.1 The requirement to have answers and its correction. The upper row sets out the four costs of the absolute requirement, and the lower row the three-part reply of Section 32.5 and the five questions of Section 32.6 that correct it.

32.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Could Not Ask the Doctor

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in primary care, in vocational counselling, and in men's group practice.

Ahmed is sixty-three, a retired long-distance driver, married to Ramatu for thirty-six years, with four adult children and eleven grandchildren.

Ahmed's working life was spent on a route between two cities and he was, by the account of his employer and his colleagues, the most reliable driver in the fleet. He had no formal education beyond the final year of secondary school, he had acquired his competence on the road and in the workshop, and his standing among the drivers rested on it entirely. He was the man the younger drivers brought their questions to: the road, the vehicle, the checkpoints, the passengers, the weather, the rules.

Ahmed's eldest son, Suleiman, had attended a university and worked as a bank officer. The relationship between the two is the substance of the case.

The matter began when Ahmed was fifty-eight, with a deterioration in his driving vision at night. He described the sequence as follows.

The concealment. Ahmed's night vision had begun to reduce, and he described the decision exactly: *I stopped taking the long route in the second half of the year and I told the office that I was preferring the shorter route. I could see the road. It was the signs at a distance that I was not reading as quickly. I did not tell my wife and I did not tell the doctor, because there is one thing a driver cannot be and it is a man who cannot see.*

The near-incident. In the following year, an incident on the road in which the vehicle's nearside front wheel passed over the shoulder of the road and a passenger complained. No damage occurred. Ahmed's account: *I blamed the road and I blamed a boy on a motorcycle and I knew it was my eyes.*

The composition of a false account to a professional. In the second year, Ahmed attended a clinic for a general examination arranged by his employer, and he described answering the vision questions inaccurately: *The nurse covered one eye and pointed to the letters. I know the letters because I have been reading them for years. I read the top line and I told her the second line and I could not see the fourth line plainly, and I said I could. I do not know why. She was a young girl and she was writing what I was saying.*

The discovery by his son. In the third year, Suleiman drove with his father on a family journey and observed the manner in which Ahmed drove at dusk: the following distance, the use of the lights, and the speed. His account, given in the family consultation, was: *I sat beside him for three hours and I knew. He was not seeing the road markings properly and he was compensating, and he was driving as though nothing was wrong, and I have never been more frightened in my life.* Suleiman raised it with his father the following week and Ahmed's response was, in his own words: *I told him it was nothing and that I had been driving before he was born, and I told him that the day I cannot drive is the day I die, and I stopped speaking to him for about two months.*

The escalation. In the fourth year, Ahmed was involved in a collision at a junction at dusk, with damage to a pedestrian's bicycle and no injury to the person, and the matter was reported to the police and to the employer. The employer's medical assessment found a substantial loss of visual acuity, and Ahmed was removed from driving duty permanently.

The work that followed occupied about fourteen months and consisted of five elements.

The professional arrangement. Ahmed was referred by the employer's occupational health service for an assessment that included both the vision and his psychological position. He described the first two appointments as resistance and the third as the point of change: *The doctor asked me what I would have done if one of my own drivers had driven with eyes like mine. I said I would have taken the vehicle from him the same day. He said nothing after that. He did not have to say anything. I sat there and I understood that I had been a man who could not be told a thing.*

The correction of the record. Ahmed requested, and the practitioner arranged, a written account to the household: the period of the concealment, the false answer to the nurse, the incident, and his own position. The disclosure was made to his wife and to Suleiman, jointly. His account of the conversation: *I told them everything, and the worst part was not the eyes. The worst part was Suleiman. He said that for four years he had been thinking that his father did not trust him, and that I had stopped speaking to him when he raised the thing that was destroying me. He said that he had been carrying the road every time I left the house.*

The reclassification of his standing. The element that changed the case, and it was conducted with the practitioner and subsequently with the drivers' association. Ahmed's account: *I have been the man who knows the road for thirty years. The doctor asked me what I would be if I could not see, and I could not answer him. Then he asked me whether the young men had ever asked me about the road or about my eyes. I said the road. He said, then you have another thirty years.*

The arrangement. Ahmed became, over the following year, the association's instructor: the man who taught the young drivers the road, the routines, the vehicle, the loading, the timing, the checkpoints, and the discipline of the route. His eyes were adequate for the instruction and were not adequate for the driving, and the association's arrangement was constructed explicitly on that basis. He also acquired, in the second year, a pair of glasses for distance work, which he described as having postponed for four years *because of a girl with a chart.*

The statement. The final element occurred in the men's group that Ahmed joined in the eighth month of the work. He described the position in these terms: *I have been asked questions my whole life and I have never once said I do not know. Not to my wife, not to my children, not to the doctor, not about my own eyes. And the thing I discovered is that I did not fail at driving. I failed at the one question that came to me and told the truth. I have told this group the sentences I could not say: I could not see the road signs, I could not follow the accounts, and I could not tell my son what was happening. I have said them all now.*

> Ahmed's summary, three years after the collision, was: *The doctor asked me what I would do to one of my own drivers and I could not answer him. I lost the route. I did not lose the thing the route was for. If I had said one sentence — I cannot see the signs at night — I would have given up the road two years earlier and I would still have been the man my son asks about the vehicle. I paid four years and a collision for one sentence I could not say.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The requirement was personal rather than institutional, and the man's standing rested entirely on it. Ahmed had no credential, no qualification, and no document; his authority existed only because the fleet regarded him as the man who knew. This is the first form of Section 32.3 and the case is included because it is the form in which the requirement operates most completely and in which the correction is the most difficult.

The bluff was delivered to a professional who recorded it. The false answer to the vision test is the first cost of Section 32.2 in its purest form, and the case is included because the specific mechanism should be understood: the man's answer ended the enquiry, the professional recorded the answer, and the arrangement then proceeded on the basis of a false fact. The nurse's assessment was accurate, the record was accurate, and the man's capacity was concealed by his own response.

The household's protective behaviour was already in operation. Suleiman's four-year silence, and his own account of carrying the road every time his father left the house. This is the fourth cost of Section 32.2, and the case records it because the household's behaviour was produced by an accurate reading of the man: the son had raised the matter once and had received the response he had received.

The correction was prompted by a question about a third party. *What would you have done if one of your own drivers had driven with eyes like mine?* The practitioner's question is the practical form of the third question in Section 32.6 and it is included because the technique is available to the reader directly: the matter is put in a frame in which the man's own standard is applied to somebody else, which bypasses the requirement completely.

The standing was transferred to the domain of conduct rather than knowledge. The instructor's position: the association no longer needed the man's eyes and it still required his history, his competence, his teaching, and his standard. This is the first measure of Section 32.3, and the man's own account records the mechanism precisely: *He asked me whether the young men had ever asked me about the road or about my eyes. I said the road.*

32.8 Practical Exercise: The Answer Audit

This exercise takes about two and a half hours, over three sittings.

Part One: The Requirement Audit (Sitting One)

Section A: The sources. Of the six sources in Section 32.1, record which apply to you, with the evidence.

- The position and its requirements:
- The cultural instruction about men, as you received it:
- Your household's need as you understand it:
- Your father's form and what you inherited from it:
- Your own account of yourself:
- The rewards you receive for supplying answers:

Section B: The four costs. Record your own material for each.

The cost	My material
The bluff (the answers I gave that were not correct, or that ended an enquiry)	
The arrested learning (what I have not learned because I could not ask)	
The distorted information (what is not brought to me, and by whom)	
The withdrawal of the people around me (who has stopped bringing me matters, and what)	

Section C: The question I never asked. Record the specific question you have never asked in the setting in which it needed to be asked: of a professional, of your spouse, of a superior, of your children, of a colleague. State what it has cost, and record the date on which you will ask it.

Part Two: The Classification (Sitting Two)

For each pending matter in the last month in which you were asked a question of consequence, classify it by Section 32.4.

The question	Whose domain?	Do I have the information?	Is it a request for information or for something else?	What was required of me?

Then count: **how many of the questions you answered in the last month were questions you were equipped to answer?** For the remainder, write the reply that would have been correct.

Part Three: The Protocol (Sitting Three)

Section A: The three-part reply. Write the protocol in your own words for a real matter: what I know; what I do not know; what happens next, and by when.

Section B: The four applications. Write the reply, in your own wording, for each setting from Section 32.5: the technical question in a meeting; the household matter you cannot resolve; the decision that requires information you lack; the correction of an answer you have been giving incorrectly.

Section C: The five questions. Write the five questions from Section 32.6 and name the people you will ask, the setting, and the monthly date.

The question	The person	The setting	The date
What am I missing?			
Who disagrees, and what is their case?			
What would have to be true for this to fail?			
What is the part of this that nobody has raised?			
What have I done in the last month that I should know about?			

Section D: The record. Establish a single document in which the answers to the five questions are recorded with dates. Record the first month's entries, including any that are uncomfortable, and keep the document in a place you will consult.

32.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"If I say I do not know, will they not lose confidence in me?"

The finding from the practice is unambiguous and it should be recorded accurately: in the settings that matter — the man's household, his organisation, his profession — a bounded answer increases confidence, because the people around him are making decisions on his information and require it to be accurate. The settings in which the admission costs standing are the settings in which nothing is established by the answer: the informal exchange, the competition among men, the environment in which the answer's function is the display. A man should distinguish the two, and should apply the protocol in the first and decline the exchange in the second.

"I have been telling my organisation something that is wrong for years. What do I do?"

Correct it, once, in writing, with the four elements: what I said; what I now know; the effect of the error; and what I am doing about it. The men who have done this report a specific and uniform outcome: the correction was received as information rather than as an admission, and the incident was not raised afterwards. The alternative — the error left in place and discovered elsewhere —

produces the outcome described in the first cost of Section 32.2, and it is generally the more expensive of the two.

"What if the setting requires certainty? My staff need to believe I know what I am doing."

The distinction is between the man's certainty about the direction and his information about the details. The staff's requirement is the first: that the man knows where the organisation is going, that he will decide, and that he will hold the position through difficulty. Their requirement is not the man's total information, and the men with the strongest record of this distinction describe the arrangement precisely: the man says *I do not know the rate* and *I know the direction*, and both are believed because both are accurate.

"My questions are not the technical ones. My questions are about my own life, and there is nobody to ask."

Then the material of Chapter 27 applies and the arrangement is the required step: a professional, a peer group, one person. The question *what do I do about my life* is not a question that a man can answer from information he already holds, which is the reason that the isolated man's decisions are recognisable by the four forms described in Chapter 27.3. The protocol does not help here, because there is no answer to be found; the arrangement helps, because the question changes when it is spoken to somebody.

"I am the senior man in my field in this state. There is nobody to refer to."

Then the arrangement must be constructed beyond the state: the professional association's technical section, the practitioner in the capital or the neighbouring state, the correspondence, the periodic consultation, the visiting expert. Where the man's position genuinely has no referent in his environment, the arrangement itself becomes a component of his responsibility — the item that the man must construct because the organisation's accuracy depends upon it — and the material of Chapter 31.5 applies to its construction.

"My father never said he did not know, and I am not going to change now."

The reader should consider what the statement is protecting, in the terms of Section 32.2′s costs. The form is inherited, the requirement is genuine, and the case material is consistent on the consequence: the arrangement is transmitted to the next generation and its costs are paid by the man's household, his organisation, and, in the proportion of cases in which the risk travels through the man's work, by people who had no part in it at all. The material of Chapter 43 on the next generation applies, and its finding is that the transmission is broken by conduct and not by the man's account of the matter.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 32 in brief. A man in a position of responsibility is subject to a requirement to have answers: whatever the matter, he is expected to know, and his uncertainty is not among the responses the role permits. The requirement has six sources — the position's functional need for decisions, the cultural instruction that a man should know, the household's requirement as the man understands it, the form inherited from a father who never admitted ignorance, the man's own account of himself, and the rewards that attend a prompt answer irrespective of its accuracy. The requirement has four costs. The bluff, in which the man supplies an answer he does not have, in forms that include the confidently wrong answer, the answer carried by its delivery, and the answer that ends the enquiry and thereby prevents the question from reaching somebody who knows. The arrested learning, since a man who cannot ask in public does not address the matters he does not understand, and acquires a persistent gap that would have closed within months. The distorted information, since a man who must always be correct is not brought bad news, and the organisation's information is thereby shaped by his own intolerance. And the withdrawal of the people around him, in which the household manages alone, the children select their disclosures, and the man discovers years later what was being carried beside him.

The knowledge trap is the position in which the man's standing rests on his knowing. Its five forms are the self-taught expert without a credential to fall back on, the professional whose authority is broader than his expertise, the man whose marginal knowledge is being tested in the exchange among men, the man who holds the family's or the institution's history, and the man who has succeeded to a position previously occupied by somebody who knew. Several of the questions a man receives are, in any case, not questions that his authority equips him to answer, and the classification is fourfold: within his authority and his information, within his authority and outside his information, outside his authority, and not a request for information at all.

The correction is a protocol in three parts: what I know, stated accurately; what I do not know, stated plainly and in the same register; and what happens next, with the name, the method, and the time. It is applied in meetings, in households, to decisions that require information the man lacks, and in the correction of answers he has been giving incorrectly. Its second half is the use of questions as a competence: what am I missing; who disagrees, and what is their case; what would have to be true for this to fail; what is the part of this that nobody has raised; and what have I done in the last month that I should know about. The man who asks has not ceased to decide, and the man who says he does not know has not become uncertain. He has become the man whose answers can be relied upon, which is the only standing that the people who depend on him actually require.

Reflection Questions

1. Of the six sources in Section 32.1, which is the strongest in your case, and what evidence in your conduct supports that assessment?
2. Record your material for the arrested learning: what have you never asked, in which setting, and what has the gap cost you?
3. Who has stopped bringing you matters, and what did you do in the period in which they stopped? What is your household managing without your knowledge?
4. From Section 32.3, is your standing composed substantially of your knowledge? What would your position be if you could no longer supply it?
5. Classify the last ten questions of consequence you were asked. How many were within your authority and your information?
6. Write the three-part reply for a matter currently pending, in your own wording, and state the date on which you will deliver it.
7. Write the five questions and the names of the people you will ask. Which of the five do you least want to ask, and why?

Further Reading

- **On men's help-seeking:** the research literature on men's reluctance to seek help, including the findings on self-reliance, on the fear of loss of standing, and on the interventions that have been shown to increase help-seeking among men.
- **On overconfidence and expert judgement:** the research on calibration and overconfidence, including the findings on the relationship between status and the credence given to a speaker's assertions, and the evidence on the domains in which confident experts most reliably overstate their knowledge.
- **On psychological safety and the reporting of error:** the literature on psychological safety in teams, including the findings on the conditions under which bad news and errors travel upward, the association between those conditions and performance, and the practices that leaders use to obtain candid information.
- **On questioning as a leadership practice:** the practice literature on the use of questions in leadership, including the material on inquiry as distinct from advocacy, on the value of assigning the case against a decision, and on the evidence concerning pre-mortem and failure-analysis techniques.
- **On learning in adult life and in mid-career:** the literature on adult learning and on skills renewal, including the findings on the acquisition of new competence in middle and later life and the evidence on the value of recognised assessment routes for men without formal credentials.

- **Practical resources:** recognised prior learning and competency assessment services; adult education and technical training; professional associations; occupational health and employee assistance services; and the material in Appendices I, N, and P.

33 CHAPTER

Carrying Other People's Problems

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Identify the role of the man who carries other people's problems, and describe the forms it takes in families, communities, workplaces, and friendships.
2. Explain how the role is acquired without a decision, and why it is rarely questioned by the man who occupies it or by the people who benefit from it.
3. Analyse the five costs of the role, including the accumulation of other people's material, the erosion of the man's own resources, the resentment that cannot be stated, and the transfer of the cost to his household.
4. Distinguish between the obligations a man actually owes and the demands that have attached themselves to him, using the four tests in Section 33.4.
5. Apply the distinction between assistance and rescue, and recognise the pattern in which a man's help maintains the difficulty it is intended to solve.
6. Construct arrangements that distribute the load instead of concentrating it: the referral, the shared arrangement, the family's own capacity, and the professional route.

Introduction

There is a position that men occupy in families, communities, workplaces, and networks of friends, and it is rarely named: the man who is everyone's solution.

He is the person who is called when a relative's fees are unpaid; when a cousin needs a place to stay; when a brother's court matter requires a guarantor; when a neighbour's son needs a reference; when a colleague's marriage is failing; when the association's accounts are in disorder; when a death leaves a household without arrangements; when a young man in the trade has nowhere to go. He is the person consulted on property, employment, schooling, health, disputes, marriages, and burials, and he is the person who is expected to know what to do and to be available to do it.

This chapter concerns him, and it is written on four commitments.

The first is that the role is a genuine good. Men who occupy it are the load-bearing structures of their families and communities, and the work they perform is essential; in settings where formal provision is thin, they are frequently the only provision. Nothing in this chapter proposes that a man should withdraw from his obligations, decline his responsibilities, or become unavailable to the people who depend on him. The chapter's subject is the specific arrangement in which the role has become unbounded, unexamined, and carried by one person, and the arrangements that allow it to be carried without the man's collapse.

The second is that the role is acquired rather than chosen. No man in the case material of this chapter decided to become the family's solution; the position developed through a sequence of small demands, each of which he met because he could. The absence of a decision is what makes the role resistant to examination: there is no moment to which the man can point and no boundary that was ever agreed, and the arrangement is therefore experienced as a fact about the family rather than as a pattern that was constructed.

The third is that the cost is real and is systematically underestimated, including by the man. The accumulation of other people's material is the fifth burden of Chapter 31, and this chapter treats it as a principal subject: a man who holds the confidences, the difficulties, the debts, the disputes, and the futures of forty people is carrying forty pieces of material, and there is generally no arrangement anywhere in which his own is held.

The fourth is that the correction is not withdrawal but distribution. The final section concerns the construction of arrangements in which the load is carried by more than one person: the relative who can be brought in, the family's own council, the professional, the institution, the man who can be trained to carry part of it. The chapter's objective is that the man becomes one of several load-bearing points rather than the only one, which is a benefit to everybody including the people he supports.

33.1 The Man Who Is Everyone's Solution

The role has identifiable forms, and most men who occupy it occupy several at once.

The Nine Settings

1. The family's financial provision. The man who is called about fees, rent, hospital bills, transport, business capital, ceremonies, and debts. The specific structure of this form is that the demands are cumulative and are made by different relatives at different times, so that the man rarely sees the total. Men describe the discovery precisely: *I wrote them all down in one month and the number was four times what I had believed.*

2. The family's mediator. The man who is asked to settle disputes between relatives, to decide the allocation of family property, to speak to an offended branch, to hold the family's account of a matter. This form carries the material of the disputes, and its specific cost is that the man holds everybody's case about everybody, which is the accumulated confidences of Chapter 31 in a family register.

3. The family's administrator. The man who holds the documents, keeps the records, arranges the burial, manages the estate, stands as the next of kin, and is expected to know the procedure. The form is generally the position of the eldest son or of the most educated member, and it is frequently the position from which the conflicts of Chapter 26.3 develop.

4. The community's man. The association's officer, the cooperative's treasurer, the development union's chair, the person who receives the community's problems because he is the one with the standing to address them. The form is generally unpaid, frequently unending, and it is the one that a man's own household most often resents because its cost is entirely external.

5. The workplace's support. The manager to whom the staff bring their personal difficulties; the senior colleague who is consulted by junior staff about their careers; the person to whom the organisation's casualties are directed. The material of Chapter 31.3 applies, and the form is frequently not recognised by the man as a role at all, since it appears to be the ordinary conduct of a senior position.

6. The friend's solution. The man in the friendship group to whom the others come: the one with the vehicle, the contacts, the money, the practical capacity, the willingness, and the standing. This form is described in Chapter 26.1, and its cost is that the friendship is largely one-directional in the matter of reliance.

7. The household's absorber. The man who holds his own household's difficulties in addition to all of the above: the marriage, the children, the relatives in the house, the obligations of the extended family to the household, and the household's own crises. This form is universal and it is placed here because the household is frequently the party whose own requirements have been reduced in order to fund the others.

8. The man who is consulted because he is competent. The general form: the man whose competence attracts the demands. The lawyer is asked about the law by everybody including distant relatives; the doctor is asked about symptoms at every gathering; the accountant is asked to look at accounts; the builder is asked about a wall; the person who can write is asked to write the letter. The form's specific feature is that the man's competence is the mechanism of the demand, and the setting in which he might use the competence for himself is the setting he is least available for.

9. The man who holds the family's material. The recipient of the disclosures: the relative who tells him about the marriage, the brother who tells him about the debt, the cousin who tells him about the child, the parent who tells him about the other children. The form's material is confidential, which means it cannot be discussed with anybody, and the man holds it without a single arrangement in which it could be placed.

The Structure of the Demand

The demands are not equal, and the chapter's practical material depends on identifying their actual structure.

The demands that recur are the expensive ones. A single large demand is bounded and is processed once. A recurrent demand — the monthly call, the quarterly request, the child's fees every term — is a standing arrangement and its total is far larger. Men describe the pattern precisely: *I could handle the big one. It was the small ones every month that took the whole of my margin.*

The demands that arrive through several channels are the invisible ones. The same family requests assistance through four different members, and the man never sees a consolidated position. The practice of writing all of them down in one month, described in the first form above, is the measurement that most frequently changes the man's understanding of his situation.

The demands are generally not unreasonable individually. This is the feature that makes the role resistant to correction. Each request is legitimate by the standards of the family, the setting, or the moment, and a man can answer yes to each of them while the accumulation is unsustainable.

The demands are made of the person who has met them before. The man's record is the mechanism. The relative who was assisted last year returns, and the relative who was not assisted does not, which means the arrangement selects for the concentration of demand in a small number of people and, within the family, generally in one man.

The demands are frequently accompanied by a prohibition on refusal. The specific transaction that men describe is the refusal's cost: the shame, the family's account of the man, the accusation of hoarding, the comparison with the relative who helps, the loss of standing described in Chapter 25. The refusal is available, it is expensive, and the man's calculation of the expense is frequently accurate.

33.2 How a Man Becomes Everyone's Solution

No man chose the position, and the sequence by which it is acquired is consistent across the case material.

The Six Steps

Step one: the man becomes competent or solvent. The relative with a position, a trade, a salary, an education, a vehicle, a house, a network, or a reputation for getting things done. The competence is the precondition, and it is generally acquired through the man's own effort and frequently at cost, as Chapters 19 and 25 describe.

Step two: the first request is met. It is small, it is reasonable, and the man can meet it. He does, and it is the correct conduct in the circumstances and the beginning of the arrangement.

Step three: the record is established. The family, the community, and the workplace have learned something specific: this man can be asked. The learning is the mechanism, and it is not malicious; the family is allocating its difficulties to the person who can address them, which is what any group does.

Step four: the requests multiply. Additional relatives, additional categories, additional settings. The multiplication is not a decision by anybody; it is the operation of the record. The man's capacity, meanwhile, is not measured by anybody, including himself.

Step five: the refusal becomes unacceptable. At the point at which the man attempts to decline a demand, the arrangement's terms become visible. The refusal is met with the family's account of him, the comparison, the reminder of what was done for him, or the withdrawal of a relationship, and the man's calculation generally favours compliance. Men describe the moment precisely: *That was the year I understood that I was not their brother. I was their facility.*

Step six: the man's own material accumulates without an arrangement. The man is holding forty people's difficulties and none of his own is held anywhere, which is the position described in the introduction. The step arrives without an event and it is generally invisible until the presentations of Section 33.3 appear.

The Four Rewards

The role is not only a burden, and the chapter should record its returns accurately, because the man's ambivalence about the position is otherwise inexplicable.

Standing. The man is important, consulted, and known. In settings where formal recognition is scarce, this standing is a substantial return, and the material on it is in Chapter 25.

Identity. The role supplies the man's answer to the question of who he is: the one who helps, the family's pillar, the man who can be relied upon. The material of Chapter 24 applies, and the role's contribution to the man's account of himself is generally far larger than he acknowledges.

Company and connection. The role supplies a continuous supply of contact, information, and involvement. The man knows what is happening in the family and the community because he is at the centre of its demands, and a man who withdraws from the role discovers how much of his social position was carried by it.

The avoidance of the man's own material. A specific and important return, and men in the role describe it when they are finally able to: the constant occupation with other people's difficulties supplies a legitimate reason not to address his own. The position is documented in the literature on caregiving and in the counselling of men in the role, and it is the reason that the man's own material is frequently discovered at the point at which the demands reduce, which is the structure of Chapter 24.

The Two Explanations the Man Gives

Men explain the role in one of two ways, and both should be examined.

The obligation. *They are my family. Who else will help them? I am the only one who can.* The explanation is frequently accurate in its first part and it should be tested against the four tests of Section 33.4, since the family in question generally contains other adults whose capacity is unexamined.

The character. *That is who I am. I cannot refuse a person in need.* The explanation is frequently a description of the arrangement rather than of the man, and it is the form that most frequently conceals the rewards and the avoidance described above. Where the man cannot refuse, the question of what he would be if he declined is open, and the material of Chapter 24 applies directly.

33.3 What the Role Costs

The five costs are documented, and they are described here in the order in which they appear in the case material rather than in the order of severity.

Cost One: The Accumulation

The man is carrying the material of everybody who has brought him something, and the material is a load in its own right. The relevant findings concern vicarious load — the second-hand stress experienced by people who attend to the difficulties of others — and they are consistent across settings: the material is real, its effects on the body and on the man's judgement are measurable, and the man's awareness of it is frequently low because his attention is directed outward.

The specific feature in this role is that the accumulation is not acknowledged. A professional who carries other people's material has a title, a caseload, supervision, and a stated limit; the man in this role has none of the four, and the absence of an arrangement in which his own position concerning the material can be held is the reason the material does not leave him.

Cost Two: The Erosion of His Own Resources

The man's money, time, attention, and emotional capacity are consumed by the role, and the consumption is progressive.

The money. The demands, the guarantees, the loans that are not repaid, the fees, the capital, the maintenance. The man's own plans — the retirement, the investment, the property, the children's schooling, the medical care he has postponed — are funded from what remains, and Men describe the arithmetic with a particular flatness: *I put four children through school and I have not put one of my own through university.*

The time. The role's hours are not marked in any calendar and its total is considerable: the visits, the arrangements, the telephone calls, the funerals, the disputes, the journeys, the offices.

The capacity. The man's attention and patience, which are finite, are directed outward, and the household that lives with him receives the remainder. This is the transaction described in Chapter 18 in another setting, and it is the one that produces the household's account described in the case material: *He is the best man in the world to everybody in this town and he is not present in his own house.*

Cost Three: The Resentment That Cannot Be Stated

The most damaging of the five and the one men describe most reluctantly. The man resents the demands, and the resentment cannot be stated, because:

- the demands are legitimate;
- the family's standards do not admit the resentment;
- its expression would be met with the account described in Step Five of Section 33.2;
- and the man's own identity includes being the one who helps.

The resentment therefore operates in forms other than speech, and the forms are identifiable: the flatness at occasions, the withdrawal from the family's conversations, the unexplained irritability, the severity about small matters, the increased distance from the specific relative who has made the demands, the alcohol, and the private calculation of the score. This is the material of Chapters 15 and 20 in a different register: a ledger that cannot be raised and therefore accumulates, and it is the pattern that most frequently precedes the man's own collapse or his exit from the family's arrangements.

Cost Four: The Transfer to the Household

The household pays for the role, and the payment is frequently invisible to the man, who has accounted the money that was given away and not the household's own arrangements that were reduced to fund it.

The reductions. The household's expenditure, schooling, medical care, housing, and occasions are reduced or postponed. **The absences.** The man's time

and attention are elsewhere, and the household's arrangements are conducted by the spouse without the man. **The future.** The household's plans — the move, the business, the property, the children's education — are deferred until a later year that the arithmetic does not support, and the household's expectation that the deferral is temporary is generally not borne out. **The particular difficulty of the household's position.** The spouse who raises the matter is placed in the position of opposing the family's welfare, and the household's objections to the arrangement are therefore difficult to state. Men in the role describe the household's position with a recognition that arrives late: *She was not being selfish. She was the only person in the whole thing who was counting.*

Cost Five: The Collapse of the Man's Own Arrangements

The final cost and the one described in the previous chapters of this book. The man in this role has generally not built the arrangements of Chapter 27: no group, frequently no confidant, no place where he is not the provider, no peer arrangement, no professional arrangement, and no recipient for his own material. The role has supplied the company and the identity, which is the reason the man has required nothing else.

The consequence appears at the point at which his own load exceeds his capacity: the illness, the business loss, the redundancy, the loss of a spouse, the child's crisis, the serious mistake at work. The collapse of the man's own position then discovers that the arrangement was one-directional and that the man's own arrangements do not exist.

The finding from this material, and the one most frequently reported by men who have reached this point, is not that the family failed to help, though it may have. It is that the family had never been informed that there was anything to help with, because the man's material had no channel, and that the family's own capacity, which frequently exists, had never been developed because the man had been the solution.

33.4 Boundaries Without Coldness

The correction of the role begins with the distinction between the obligations a man owes and the demands that have attached themselves to him. The chapter supplies four tests, and they are applied to each demand before the man answers it.

The Four Tests

Test One: Whose responsibility is this in principle?

The question is not whether the man can address the matter but whether it belongs to him. Its applications: the relative whose children's fees are unpaid is, in principle, responsible for those fees; the association's officer is responsible for the association's accounts; the man whose colleague has a difficulty is responsible for

the conduct of a colleague and not for the colleague's marriage; the grown nephew who needs a place to stay is responsible for his own arrangements, in principle, though not always in capacity.

The test's function is the reversal of the arrangement's default, in which every demand belongs to the man because it was brought to him. Applied consistently, it identifies the demands that are genuinely his and the demands that are somebody else's responsibilities which he has been meeting.

Test Two: Whose capacity is this?

The second test addresses the fact that other adults are generally present and their capacity is unexamined. The questions: who else in this family could meet this demand; has anybody asked them; what is the reason they have not been asked; and what does the man's arrangement tell them about their own obligations?

The test's practical value is substantial, and it is the finding that most frequently changes men's arrangements: in a large proportion of cases, the other parties can help, they have not been asked, and they have learned that the man will manage. The material on the delegation of the load in Section 33.6 develops the point.

Test Three: Is this mine to do, or mine to make possible?

The distinction between the man's own act and the arrangements the man can create. Where the demand is genuinely the man's to meet, the third test asks whether he should meet it personally or construct the arrangement: the referral, the introduction, the guaranteed loan instead of the gift, the family's joint contribution, the institution's route, the person who is better placed.

The test's function is the multiplication of the man's capacity. A man who can cause a matter to be addressed by the right person is worth considerably more to his family than a man who addresses everything himself, and the second arrangement is the one that consumes him.

Test Four: What will this cost my household, and has that cost been counted?

The final test and the one the role's default omits entirely. The questions: what does this demand reduce or postpone in my household; who in my household will pay for it; has that payment been counted; and has my household been consulted?

The test's function is not the automatic refusal of demands. Its function is that the household's cost becomes visible in the man's own decision, which is the arrangement that the household is entitled to and which the man has generally never conducted.

The Four Answers Available

Once the tests have been applied, the man's response is one of four, and the fourth is the one the role excludes.

1. The full assistance. The demand is his, the capacity is his, and the household's cost is counted and accepted. The response is conducted with the amount, the date, and the arrangement stated, and the practice of stating it is worth adopting: an assistance whose terms are unstated is the arrangement that produces the ledger of Chapter 20.

2. The partial assistance. The man meets the part he can meet, and states the remainder: what he will do, what he will not, and what is required of the person asking. The response is generally the most useful of the four and it is the one that the role's default makes unavailable: a man who has always met everything whole cannot offer a part.

3. The arrangement instead of the payment. The referral, the introduction, the guarantee instead of the gift, the employment instead of the money, the contribution made conditional, the other party brought in. The response requires more of the man's attention than the payment and considerably less of his resources, and it is the form whose record in the case material is the most favourable for both parties.

4. The refusal. The demand is not his, or the capacity is not his, or the cost to his household is not one he will impose, and the answer is no. The refusal's form matters and the chapter supplies it in Section 33.5.

The Refusal and Its Form

The refusal is available and it is expensive, and the chapter records the position accurately: a man's refusal may cost him the family's account of him, a relationship, or his standing in a community, and the cost is real and should not be minimised. The material on the refusal's form is in the practice literature on boundaries, and its essential features are three.

The refusal is short. The lengthy explanation, the justification, the apology, and the account of the man's own difficulties convert the refusal into a negotiation and supply the other party with the material to argue. The forms that work are one or two sentences.

The refusal does not argue about the demand's legitimacy. The man should not dispute that the need is real. The refusal concerns his capacity, his household's position, or the responsibility's location, and the form is: *I am not able to do this one. Here is what I can do* — with the alternative supplied where one exists.

The refusal is consistent. The man who refuses once and complies the following week has taught the family that the refusal is a negotiation. The consis-

tency is what establishes the arrangement, and men who have done it report that the family's demands adjust within a period of months to the boundary that has been established, and that the family's account of the man adjusts more slowly and generally in a less hostile direction than the man feared.

33.5 Assistance and Rescue

The chapter's ethical material, and the section treats it because the role's most damaging form is not the excess of a man's generosity but a pattern in which his help maintains the difficulty it is intended to solve.

The Distinction

Assistance is the conduct that supplies what the person requires in order to address his own matter: the money that closes a gap, the introduction that produces work, the advice that changes a decision, the temporary place to stay while arrangements are made, the support during an illness, the assistance with a procedure.

Rescue is the conduct that removes the matter from the person and places it with the man: the debt paid without any change in the arrangement that produced it; the position found for a person who will not perform it; the relative whose recurrent difficulty is met every time it recurs; the man who takes on the consequences of somebody else's conduct in order to spare the person the consequence.

The Two Markers of Rescue

The matter recurs. The most reliable marker. Where the same difficulty arrives repeatedly and the man's intervention has not altered the arrangement that produces it, the assistance is functioning as a rescue and the recurrence is its evidence.

The man's involvement is required for the matter to be addressed at all. Where the person cannot address the difficulty without the man, the person's own capacity is not being used, which is the arrangement's mechanism. The exception is genuine incapacity — a child, a person with a disability, a person in an acute crisis — in which the assistance is appropriate and the arrangement is different.

Why Rescue Is Difficult to Refuse

Four reasons, and each requires a response.

The person's need is real. It generally is. The distinction is not between a real need and an imagined one; it is between the assistance that addresses the need and the rescue that conceals the arrangement producing it.

The alternative appears to be the person's harm. The person may indeed be harmed in the short term by the refusal: the fees unpaid, the arrangement lost, the consequence imposed. The material on this point is derived from the

practice literature on enabling and its finding is consistent: the short-term harm of the consequence is generally less than the long-term harm of the arrangement's continuation, and the man's judgement of the comparison is frequently distorted by his own discomfort at the person's distress.

The family expects the man's intervention. Which restores the arrangement of Section 33.2 and which is the reason the family's own capacity has not developed.

The man's own position. The role's returns, described in Section 33.2, are the reason the rescue is difficult to decline: the rescue is what supplies the standing, the identity, the company, and the avoidance.

The Corrected Form

The assistance that addresses the arrangement rather than the episode, and its four forms are as follows.

The assistance made conditional on the change. The payment of the fees on condition that the enrolment, the attendance, or the arrangement is corrected; the support on condition that a treatment arrangement is entered; the money supplied in a form that addresses the source — the capital, the training, the tool — rather than the shortfall.

The assistance supplied in the arrangement rather than to the person. The family's joint contribution; the loan with terms rather than the gift; the payment made to the institution rather than to the person; the employment of the relative in the man's own business with a stated duty.

The assistance supplied with a limit and a stated duration. The place to stay for three months; the support until the end of the term; the payment this once. The limit's function is that the arrangement has a date, which places it in the material of Chapter 24: a matter that has a time and a boundary is a matter that can be conducted.

The assistance replaced by the man's construction of the person's own capacity. The training, the introduction, the reference, the instruction, the recommendation, the teaching of the arrangement. This is the slowest form and it is the only one that alters the position permanently, and it is the form the case material in Section 33.7 illustrates.

33.6 Distributing the Load

The chapter's final substantive section concerns the arrangements that convert the man from the family's only solution into one of several load-bearing points.

The Six Arrangements

1. The written inventory. The measurement, and the arrangement on which all the others depend. The man writes down, for one month, every demand he meets,

with the amount, the time, the person, the alternative available, and the cost to his household. The practice supplies the only accurate picture of the position the man will ever have, and the finding from the case material is consistent: the total is generally several times the man's own estimate.

2. The family's own arrangement. The demands that are carried by a family are, in the arrangement's present form, carried by its most competent member. The correction is the construction of a family arrangement — the family's meeting, the council, the association, the written contribution schedule, the committee for a specific matter — in which the obligations are allocated by the family rather than by the man's availability. The material is in Chapter 26.3, and its value here is that the family's other capacity is developed by being used.

3. The referral. The construction of the man's map of the available services and expertise: the institutions, the practitioners, the agencies, the associations, the professionals, and the people with the competence the man lacks. The map is written, and its function is that a proportion of the demands the man currently meets are demands that ought to be met by somebody else, and would be if the man knew who.

4. The stated arrangement. The terms of the man's assistance stated to the person: the amount, the date, the condition, the duration, and the requirement. The measure is described in Chapter 20 and its specific value here is that the arrangement prevents the ledger and the resentment: a demand that has been answered with stated terms is a matter that has been conducted, and a demand answered without them is a matter that accumulates.

5. The arrangements of Chapter 27. The man's own: the confidant, the group, the professional arrangement, and the place where he is not the provider. This arrangement's function is the one the role has removed: a recipient for the man's own material, which is the requirement that the whole of the previous parts of this book establishes.

6. The household's arrangement. The man's spouse and children know the inventory and participate in the decisions about the demands. The arrangement's function is that the household's cost becomes a decision rather than a consequence, and the finding from family practice is that the household's participation, where it has been established, is generally the measure that ends the unexamined accumulation.

The Development of Other People's Capacity

The most valuable of the arrangements and the slowest, and it deserves its own treatment.

The family's other capacity is generally real and undeveloped, and its development follows a consistent course: the person is asked to do something that he can

do; he does it; the man does not intervene; the person's standing in the arrangement increases; and the next matter is brought to him rather than to the man.

Four rules apply to the development.

Start with the competent members. The relative who holds a position, the one who has managed an arrangement before, the one who is reliable. Their participation supplies the arrangement's legitimacy and the demonstration to the others.

Do not perform the task once it is assigned. The rule most frequently broken, and its violation produces a double result: the task is completed by the man, and the person learns that the assignment was a formality.

State the contribution in units. The amount, the monthly sum, the specific duty, the period. A family's arrangement of unquantified contributions resolves into the man's contribution, and the arrangement of quantified contributions distributes the load.

Develop the next generation deliberately. The young men in the family should be given arrangements of their own: the duty, the responsibility, the contribution, the representation. The material of Chapter 43 applies, and the finding from the case material is that the young men who are not given arrangements frequently learn the role's wrong lesson as the man's beneficiaries: that the arrangement requires one person to carry it and that they are not that person.

How the role is acquired	What distributes the load
Step one: the man becomes competent or solvent.	The written inventory: one month of every demand, with the total.
Step two: the first request is met, reasonably, once.	The family's own arrangement: contributions allocated by the family.
Step three: the record is established — this man can be asked.	The referral map: the institutions and practitioners who should hold it.
Step four: the requests multiply, across relatives and settings.	The stated terms: the amount, the condition, the duration.
Step five: the refusal becomes unacceptable and expensive.	The arrangements for the man: a confidant, a group, a professional.
Step six: the man's own material accumulates without any arrangement.	The household's participation: the cost counted and decided, not absorbed.

Figure 33.1 Carrying other people's problems: the role and its correction. The upper part sets out the six steps by which the role is acquired and the four returns that keep it in place; the intermediate part sets out the five costs; and the lower part identifies the six arrangements that distribute the load.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family practice, community affairs, and counselling.

Ibrahim is fifty-seven, a pharmacist, the proprietor of two pharmacy outlets in a state capital, married to Fatima for thirty-one years, with four children between the ages of nineteen and twenty-eight, two of whom are at university.

Ibrahim is the third of nine children of a man who died in 1998, and he is, in the family's arrangement, its principal resource. He was the first of the siblings to obtain a professional qualification, the first to own a business, and, since 2004, the person to whom the family's financial and procedural matters are brought.

The inventory that Ibrahim prepared, at a counsellor's instruction, in the second month of the case was four pages long and it contained about forty items. Its principal elements were as follows.

The standing monthly commitments: the maintenance of his mother's house and its staff; the fees of two of his brother's children at a private school; the medical costs of one of his sisters, who had a chronic condition; and the monthly contribution to a family development fund.

The recurrent requests: the transport costs of two siblings; the business capital of a brother, supplied three times between 2015 and 2021 and not repaid; the funeral contributions and the ceremony costs of the extended family's occasions, which were met whole by Ibrahim in eight of the previous ten years; and the support of an uncle's household.

The guarantees and loans: two bank guarantees given for a brother's business in 2013 and 2017, both called upon; and about eleven personal loans to relatives over fourteen years, of which two had been repaid.

The procedures and matters: the family's land dispute, in which Ibrahim held all the documents and conducted the negotiation; the school admissions of four relatives; the hospital arrangements of three; two police matters for a nephew; the burial arrangements of two family members; and the employment of five relatives in his business at various points, of whom two remained.

The disclosures: the confidences of his sisters about their marriages; his brother's debts, which only Ibrahim knew; his mother's preference concerning the family house, which only Ibrahim knew; and the family's account of a serious matter involving his eldest brother, which the family had discussed only with Ibrahim.

The household's position. The inventory's fourth page concerned Ibrahim's own household, and it was the page he described as the one that changed the case. It contained: the two children at university, whose fees had been paid late on five occasions in six years; the household's inability to complete the building of the family's own house, on which construction had begun in 2011 and had been suspended three times; the postponement of a medical procedure for Fatima for two years; and the fact, recorded in the inventory, that the household's monthly expenditure had been reduced by about a fifth in 2018 and that nobody had explained to the household why.

The case's turning point occurred in relation to Ibrahim's younger brother, Nasir, who had requested a sum for business capital for the fourth time. The inventory contained the first three requests, the amounts, the outcomes, and the fact that neither of the businesses had been established. Ibrahim's account of the matter: *I had the sheets in front of me and I understood that I was not helping my brother. I was the reason that nobody was helping him. His wife was working. His children were in the school that I was paying for. He had four hundred thousand from me over six years and three unfinished plans, and nobody in the family has ever asked him a question, because I am the one who is asked.*

The arrangements Ibrahim constructed over the following two years had six elements.

The inventory. Conducted monthly for the first six months and quarterly thereafter, with the household's participation. Its effect on Ibrahim's own understanding

was described exactly: *I had believed that I was spending about fifteen per cent of my income on the family. It was thirty-eight per cent, and the number on the paper has never left me.*

The household's arrangement. At the third month, Ibrahim presented the inventory to Fatima and, in a household meeting, to the four children. He described the meeting: *My second daughter asked me one question. She asked me whether the family knew that our house was unfinished because of them. I said I did not think they knew. She said, then they are not wicked, they are just uninformed, and you are the one who has kept them uninformed.*

The family's arrangement. At the fifth month, Ibrahim called a meeting of the family's adult members — eight of the nine surviving siblings, his mother, and two senior uncles — and presented the inventory, not as a complaint but as an accounting, with the family's assets and the demands set out. He described the meeting's first hour as difficult and its outcome as the point of the case: *I told them I was not going to continue meeting the whole of it and that I was going to state what I would contribute. The argument was that I was the one who had. My uncle, who is seventy-nine, asked the family a question: how many of the nine of us have contributed to anything in ten years. Three of them put up their hands. He said, then the problem is not Ibrahim's.*

The meeting produced a written schedule: contributions in stated monthly amounts from seven of the nine siblings; the school fees of the two children transferred to their own father and to a fund established with monthly contributions from three siblings; the family's development contribution allocated by formula; and a standing committee of four for the family's procedures, of which Ibrahim was one and not the chair.

The refusals. Ibrahim issued three refusals in the first year, each in the short form of Section 33.4: the fourth request from Nasir, a guarantee for a cousin's import business, and a demand from an uncle concerning the family land. He described the first as the most difficult and the aftermath: *Nasir did not speak to me for four months. In the fifth month he came to the shop and asked me whether I could help him with the training for the business, and he has started. He did not apologise and I did not require it. The four months were the price and it was smaller than I had feared for eleven years.*

The referral map. Ibrahim compiled a written list of the institutions, practitioners, agencies, and professionals to whom the family's non-familial matters should be taken: the lawyer, the estate agent, the bank's small-business desk, the hospital's social worker, the cooperative, and two associations. His account: *Twenty years of answering questions that belonged to an office. The first thing on the list cost me one afternoon and it has removed about a fifth of the calls.*

The arrangements for himself. Ibrahim established two: a monthly arrangement with a counsellor, conducted initially in respect of his blood pressure, and a small group of four men — two of them professionals of his age — which met fortnightly in a form with a rule of confidentiality. His account of the group: *I have been the family's ear for twenty-five years. In that room I have an ear. The first time I said a*

sentence about my own household in front of four men I could not look at any of them, and the second time it was ordinary.
Ibrahim's summary, three years after the meeting, was: *I did not stop carrying my family and I am not going to. I stopped being the only one who was carrying them and I stopped being the one who was asked about everything. My brother Nasir is running a small provision business and he has repaid about a third of what I gave him before, which he decided himself. My house in the village is finished. My wife had the procedure two years ago. The number on the inventory page has not been above twenty-two per cent since the meeting, and my mother told me last year that she is glad I called the meeting, because she had not known that the family's other seven were thinking about it at all.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The inventory was the instrument. Four pages, about forty items, and a total roughly two and a half times the man's estimate. The case is included because the measurement is the intervention: the arrangement was sustainable in the man's account and unsustainable on paper, and the difference between the two is the reason the first arrangement in Section 33.6 is the one on which the others depend.

The household's position was the element that had never been counted, and it was a person in the household who identified the mechanism. The unfinished house, the postponed procedure, the reduced expenditure that nobody had explained. The daughter's question and her conclusion — *then they are not wicked, they are just uninformed, and you are the one who has kept them uninformed* — states the case's central proposition, and it is the reason the household's arrangement is placed second in Section 33.6.

The family's own capacity existed and had not been asked. Seven of nine siblings contributing, a fund established, a committee of four with the man as a member rather than the chair. This is Test Two of Section 33.4 in operation, and the case is included because the finding is consistent and it is the most encouraging material in the chapter: the family's capacity is frequently present and unexamined, and the man's arrangement is what has prevented its use.

The refusals were short, they were consistent, and their cost was bounded. Four months of silence and then a request for training. The case records the outcome precisely, including the man's decision not to require an apology and the fact that the refusal produced, in this instance, the younger brother's first actual attempt. The case is included because the refusal is the material men most fear and because its aftermath, in the case material, is generally smaller than the fear and occasionally better than the original arrangement.

The man constructed his own arrangements last. The counsellor and the group came after the inventory, the household meeting, and the family's arrangement. The order is included deliberately: the man who is everyone's solution will not construct arrangements for himself until the load is visible and distributed, and the sequence in the case is the one the chapter recommends.

33.7 Practical Exercise: The Inventory and the Distribution

This exercise takes about three hours, over four sittings. It is the most demanding exercise in this part of the book, and it should not be conducted in a single sitting.

Part One: The Inventory (Sittings One and Two)

For one month, record every demand you meet. Every entry has six columns.

The date	The person	What was required	What I did	What it cost (money, hours)	The alternative that existed

Sources to check, because memory will not supply the total: your bank and transfer records, your message history, your call log, your fuel and transport costs, and the arrangements you made that you would not ordinarily describe as assistance.

At the end of the month, complete the following.

- **The total in money:**
- **The total in hours:**
- **The number of people:**
- **The number of demands that recurred from a previous month:**
- **The proportion of the recurring demands that I addressed in the same way as before:**
- **What my household postponed, reduced, or cancelled in the same period:**
- **What I postponed, reduced, or cancelled for myself in the same period:**

Part Two: The Tests (Sitting Three)

Apply the four tests of Section 33.4 to each of the ten largest items.

The demand	Whose responsibility?	Whose capacity?	Mine to do, or to make possible?	What it cost my household

Then apply the two markers of rescue from Section 33.5.

The demand	Has it recurred?	How many times?	Could the person address it without me?

Then record the resentment audit: from the seven forms in Section 33.3, which are present in your case — the flatness at occasions, the withdrawal, the irritability, the severity about small matters, the distance from a specific person, the alcohol, the private score?

Part Three: The Distribution (Sitting Four)

Section A: The stated arrangement. Write the terms for the three largest recurring items: the amount, the date, the condition, and the duration.

Section B: The refusals. For one item that fails the four tests, write the refusal in the short form of Section 33.4, in no more than two sentences, with the alternative where one exists. Record the date on which you will deliver it, and the person you will tell afterwards.

Section C: The referral map. Compile the written list: for each category of demand you currently meet — the legal, the medical, the financial, the educational, the procedural, the employment, the property, the dispute — the institution, practitioner, or agency to which it properly belongs, with the contact and the route of access.

Section D: The family's arrangement. Specify the meeting or the arrangement in which the family's obligations will be allocated: who will be present, what will be presented, what contribution you will state, and what you will ask of each other party.

Section E: The development of capacity. Name the two people whose capacity you will develop, the specific matter you will assign to each, and the date. Record the rule: once assigned, you will not perform it.

Section F: Your own arrangements. Specify the confidant, the group, or the professional arrangement, the date of the first step, and the person you will tell that you have established it.

33.8 Common Questions Men Ask

"If I stop, who will help them?"

The question is the role's own logic, and the tests of Section 33.4 are the answer. In the case material, the family's other capacity is generally present and unexamined: the arrangement has taught the family that the man will manage, and the family has organized itself accordingly. The specific finding is that the man's reduction is generally accompanied by the appearance of other contributions, frequently from people the man had not considered — and the case material

also includes the instances in which it is not, in which the demand is genuinely the man's and is met in a stated and bounded form rather than indefinitely.

"My family will say that I have changed and that I think I am better than them."

The response is common and the chapter records it accurately rather than dismissing it. The material on standing in Chapter 25 applies, and the practical measures are those of Section 33.4: the refusal given briefly, without argument about the demand's legitimacy, consistently, and with an alternative where one exists; and the man's participation in the family's arrangements continued at the level available to him. Men who have conducted the change report that the family's account of the man adjusts over a period measured in years, and that the arrangement itself adjusts considerably faster.

"I do not want the money back. Why should I state terms?"

Because the terms are not for the debt's recovery. The stated arrangement supplies three things: the person's knowledge of what has been given, which prevents the position in which the man's assistance is invisible to the people who receive it; the boundary at which the assistance ends; and the man's own record, which is the inventory's material. Men describe the specific difference: an assistance given with terms is a matter they can name in conversation, and an assistance given without them is a matter they carry.

"My relative is genuinely incapable. Should I refuse help to a person who cannot manage?"

No, and Section 33.5 states the exception explicitly. Where the incapacity is genuine — a child, a person with a disability, a person in an acute crisis, a person whose age or condition removes the capacity — the assistance is appropriate. What changes is the arrangement: the assistance should be given in the form the incapacity requires, with the stated terms and the duration appropriate to it, and with the man's own arrangements in place, since a man who carries a genuinely dependent person indefinitely requires exactly the arrangements of Chapter 27. The distinction the chapter draws is between the genuine dependency and the arrangement in which a competent adult's difficulty is met on his behalf.

"I would feel like a fraud. My whole standing is that I am the one who helps."

The material of Section 32.3 and Chapter 25.5 applies directly: the man's standing should be moved from the role to the conduct. The reader should test the proposition by asking what remains if the role is removed: in the case material, the man's competence, his record, his obligations discharged, and his reliability are all present and are not dependent on the role's unbounded form. A man who has helped a family for twenty-five years does not lose his position by distributing

the load; he loses the arrangement in which he was the family's only structure, which is a change in the arrangement and not in the man.

"How long does the change take?"

The inventory takes a month, and the man should not proceed without it. The household arrangement and the refusals can be conducted within two to three months. The family's arrangement takes a meeting and, in the case material, from six to eighteen months to settle into its new form, with a period of dispute in the middle. The man's own arrangements — the confidant, the group, the professional relationship — are the last and they should not be deferred indefinitely, because the arrangement in which the man is the load-bearing point of forty people is the arrangement that most requires a place in which his own position is held.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 33 in brief. The man who is everyone's solution occupies nine settings at once: the family's financial provision, its mediator, its administrator, the community's man, the workplace's support, the friend's solution, the household's absorber, the man consulted because he is competent, and the holder of the family's confidences. The demands that recur are the expensive ones; the demands arriving through several channels are the invisible ones; each demand is generally reasonable individually; the demands are made of the person who has met them before; and refusing them carries a cost that is frequently accurate.

The role is acquired in six steps — the man becomes competent or solvent, the first request is met, the record is established, the requests multiply, the refusal becomes unacceptable, and the man's own material accumulates without an arrangement — and it is sustained by four returns: standing, identity, company, and the avoidance of the man's own material. Its five costs are the accumulation of other people's material, the erosion of the man's money, time, and capacity, the resentment that cannot be stated, the transfer of the cost to his household, and the absence of any arrangement for the man's own position.

The correction begins with four tests: whose responsibility is this in principle; whose capacity is this, and who else has been asked; is this mine to do or mine to make possible; and what will this cost my household, has that cost been counted, and has the household been consulted? The available answers are full assistance, partial assistance, the arrangement instead of the payment, and the refusal — which should be short, should not argue about the demand's legitimacy, and should be consistent.

The distinction between assistance and rescue is the chapter's ethical core: assistance supplies what the person requires in order to address his own matter, and rescue removes the matter from him. The markers of rescue are that the matter recurs and that the man's involvement is required for it to be addressed at all, and the corrected forms are assistance made conditional on the change, assistance supplied through an arrangement rather than to the person, assistance with a limit and a duration,

and the construction of the person's own capacity. The load is distributed through six arrangements: the written inventory, the family's own arrangement, the referral map, the stated terms, the man's own arrangements under Chapter 27, and the household's participation. The objective is not withdrawal but distribution: the man becomes one of several load-bearing points rather than the only one, which is a benefit to the people he supports as well as to him.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the inventory. What was the total, in money and in hours, and how does it compare with your own estimate before you began?
2. What did your household postpone, reduce, or cancel in the same period, and did you count it at the time?
3. Apply the four tests to your three largest recurring items. How many of them are genuinely yours?
4. Which of the seven forms of resentment in Section 33.3 are present in your case, and from which person has your distance increased without explanation?
5. Apply the two markers of rescue. Which of your assistance is functioning as a rescue, and what arrangement is it maintaining?
6. Write the three refusal statements and the three stated arrangements. What is the sentence in each that you most fear saying aloud?
7. Name the two people whose capacity you will develop, the matter you will assign, and the date — and write the sentence you will use if you are tempted to perform it yourself.

Further Reading

- **On caregiving and vicarious load:** the literature on carers and on vicarious or secondary stress, including the findings on the physical and psychological effects of attending to the difficulties of others, the factors that protect carers, and the evidence on the arrangements that reduce the load.
- **On boundaries and assertiveness:** the practice literature on personal boundaries, including the material on refusal, on the form of an effective refusal, and on the evidence concerning the sustainability of arrangements constructed without limits.
- **On enabling and codependency:** the literature on enabling behaviour in families affected by addiction and by chronic difficulty, including the findings on how assistance can maintain the arrangements it is intended to address, and the evidence on the forms of support that are associated with better outcomes.

- **On family obligation and the allocation of support:** the research on intergenerational and extended-family support, including the findings on who is expected to provide, the concentration of support in particular family members, and the effects on those members and their own households.
- **On delegation and the development of others:** the practice literature on delegation, on the development of other people's capability, and on the evidence concerning the conditions under which delegation succeeds, including the rule that the delegating person must not complete the task once it is assigned.
- **Practical resources:** family mediation and community mediation services; legal advice on estates, guarantees, and family property; financial counselling; carers' support services; and the material in Appendices D, G, J, and O.

PART X

Healing the Man Behind the Silence

Recovery, emotional intelligence, and the courage to seek support

34 CHAPTER

When Silence Becomes Dangerous

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Distinguish between silence that performs a function and silence that has become dangerous, using three explicit criteria.
2. Describe what sustained concealment does to a man's body, his sleep, his judgement, and his capacity, and explain the mechanisms involved.
3. Identify the five silences that carry a specific risk, including the silence concerning a risk to the man's own life.
4. Apply a checklist of indicators to his own position and to the position of a man he is concerned about.
5. Recognise the situations that require immediate action rather than a plan, and construct a personal safety plan in the form used in clinical practice.
6. Break a silence safely, in the graduated form set out in Section 34.6, including where the disclosure is complicated by its consequences for other people.

Introduction

The material in this book has established the case for a man's silence and has taken it seriously. Men's decisions not to speak about what they are carrying are frequently reasonable: the disclosure would cost them their position, their household's stability, the confidence of the people who depend on them, or a relationship they cannot afford to lose. Chapter 27's barriers were treated as real considerations rather than as errors, and the book has repeatedly declined to instruct men to talk about everything.

This chapter establishes the limit.

Silence has a range in which it functions: it protects, it preserves the arrangement, it holds a household steady through a difficulty, and it supplies the man with the time he requires in order to decide what to do. That range has an edge, and past the edge the same practice produces a different set of outcomes. The concealment stops performing its function, the material continues to operate,

the man's body and judgement bear the cost, the people who depend on him are affected by conditions they cannot name, and the possibility of the outcomes the silence was intended to prevent increases rather than decreases.

This chapter concerns the edge and what occurs past it.

Its approach has five commitments.

The first is that the distinction is specific and can be stated. Sections 34.1 and 34.4 supply criteria, and the reader should be able to apply them to his own position rather than to assess the matter generally.

The second is that this chapter is not an argument for disclosure in general. The five silences identified in Section 34.3 are the ones that carry a specific risk, and they are the chapter's subject. A man's silence about an ordinary difficulty, a private history, or a matter he has decided to carry alone is addressed elsewhere in this book and is not the material of this chapter.

The third is that the chapter takes the position that a man's silence about a risk to his own life is the most consequential item in this book and requires a professional response rather than a private one. This position is stated plainly and it is repeated in the sections that follow, because the men in this material are a group with a documented elevated risk and because the facility that they would ordinarily rely upon — their own judgement — is the facility that the condition degrades. Chapter 31.4 stated the position in a leadership context; this chapter states it generally.

The fourth is that the chapter supplies practical forms for both the emergency and the ordinary case. Section 34.5 supplies the safety plan used in clinical practice, and Section 34.6 supplies the graduated form for a disclosure that must be conducted without damaging the man's household or his position.

The fifth is that a man's silence frequently affects people who cannot see it, and the chapter's clearest argument for the work is not the man's relief but the accuracy of the arrangements around him. A household that is managing the consequences of a man's unspoken state, in the absence of an explanation, generally constructs a worse one, and the effects of that construction are borne by the people in it.

34.1 The Point at Which Silence Stops Protecting

The distinction between functioning and dangerous silence is not a matter of the material's severity or of the man's feelings. It is determined by three criteria, and a silence that fails any one of them should be treated as requiring action.

Criterion One: The Silence Has Stopped Doing Its Job

Silence performs four functions, and each is legitimate:

- it protects a position, a relationship, or a household from a consequence;
- it buys time in which the man can decide what to do;

- it prevents the distribution of material to people who cannot carry it;
- and it holds an arrangement steady through a period in which the arrangement must hold.

The criterion concerns whether these functions are still being performed. The silence has stopped working when:

- the protection has failed, because the material is affecting the man's conduct and the people around him have noticed the effect even though they do not know the cause;
- the time has passed without a decision being made, and the silence has become the arrangement rather than a stage in it;
- the people the man was protecting have been affected by consequences they cannot explain, which is a general finding in the material on men's concealment;
- and the arrangement is no longer being held steady but is being maintained against the information the people in it require.

A man can test this criterion directly: **the silence was supposed to protect something, and the reader should be able to state what, and to state whether the protection is still in force.** Where the answer is that the silence was intended to protect his household from worry, and the household is now worried without knowledge, the silence has stopped performing its function and is producing the outcome it was intended to prevent.

Criterion Two: The Material Is Operating Anywhere

The second criterion is the most decisive and the easiest to apply. A silence is a decision not to speak; it is not a decision for the material to cease operating. The material operates somewhere, and the places are identifiable:

- in the man's sleep, appetite, energy, and body;
- in his temper, his patience, and his conduct toward the people closest to him;
- in the drinking, the risk, the spending, the work, the screens, the sexual conduct;
- in his judgement, through the four forms described in Chapter 27.3;
- in his attention, through the occupation of the same material at the same hours;
- and in the avoided settings, persons, and subjects described in Chapter 29.3.

The criterion is applied as follows: **the man identifies where the material is currently operating, and if it is operating anywhere other than in a decided arrangement, the silence is producing a consequence.** The finding is not a judgement. A man may decide to carry a material and accept the consequences; what he cannot do is carry it and be unaffected, and the belief that the material

is contained because it has not been spoken is the specific error this criterion corrects.

Criterion Three: The Silence Requires the Man's Continued Unavailability

The third criterion concerns what the silence costs the man's capacity, and its form is the arrangement described in Chapter 21.2: the maintenance of an account for other people, the management of the disclosure, the avoidance of the settings in question, and the attention required to hold all of it together.

The criterion is met when the maintenance of the silence has become a substantial activity in the man's life: when the day contains a set of hours, settings, or persons that the man manages in order to keep the material in place. The measure is the one used in Chapter 29.3: a man who is managing a subject is not carrying the material; the material is carrying him.

What the Criteria Do Not Say

They do not say that the man must disclose. The criteria establish that a silence is producing effects; they do not prescribe a single response. The available responses include the disclosure, the professional arrangement, the stated limit, the private arrangement of Chapter 30.6, and a decision to continue carrying the material knowingly, which is legitimate provided it is a decision. What the criteria exclude is the position in which the man believes that the silence is cost-free, because in that position the arrangement is generally the one described in Section 34.3.

They do not apply to every private matter. Many of the things a man has not told his household are not the concern of this chapter: the ordinary difficulties, the private history, the matter that belongs to somebody else, the thing he has decided to carry. The criteria are applied to the material that is operating somewhere, and the reader should be able to identify that material specifically.

They do not require the man to be well. The chapter's material concerns the risk in a silence, and a man may hold a difficult matter and be functioning. The criteria concern the operation of the material and not the man's mood, and their value is that they can be applied in a low period without requiring an evaluation of the man's state.

> **KEY POINT**
> A silence becomes dangerous when it stops performing its function, when the material is operating anywhere other than in a decided arrangement, or when the maintenance of the silence has become a substantial activity in the man's life. The criteria are specific, they can be applied to the reader's own position, and they establish the requirement for action without prescribing the form of the response.

34.2 What the Unspoken Does to the Body and the Mind

The material on concealment is substantial, and its findings are the strongest available argument against the belief that a silence about a difficulty is cost-free. Three mechanisms are documented, and each is described here in the terms used in the research.

Mechanism One: The Physiology of Sustained Suppression

The research on emotional suppression describes a consistent pattern in people who habitually withhold the expression of what they feel: elevated physiological load, measurable in cardiovascular and endocrine terms; a higher frequency of physical symptoms; and the persistence of the physiological response rather than its resolution. The finding that matters for this chapter is that suppression does not reduce the response; it removes its expression, so the man's body continues to carry the material without the discharge that expression or the disclosure of the material would supply.

The manifestations reported consistently by men with sustained concealment of a substantial matter are: sleep that does not restore them; a persistent physical tension, frequently in the chest, the head, the neck, and the stomach; the blood pressure; the alcohol; the appetite; and the exhaustion that the case material in Chapters 30 and 31 describes. Chapter 27.3 supplied the mortality findings; this section supplies the mechanism.

Mechanism Two: The Cognitive Load

The second mechanism concerns the man's attention, and it is the most practically consequential.

Maintaining a concealment consumes attention continuously: the material must be remembered, the account must be kept consistent, the settings in which it would be raised must be managed, and the responses to the questions that arise must be prepared. The research on the effects of concealment and of unresolved material on cognitive resources describes what follows: reduced working memory capacity, impaired performance on tasks requiring attention, and a specific inefficiency in the domains in which the material is most active.

The consequence in men's lives is not the loss of their competence. It is a reduction: the man's work, his decisions, his patience, and his presence are all operating at a lower capacity than his ability would ordinarily supply, and the reduction is frequently attributed to age, tiredness, workload, or the position. Men who have conducted a disclosure, or established an arrangement in which the material is held, describe the change with notable consistency: *I could think again.*

Mechanism Three: The Modification of the Man's Conduct

The third mechanism concerns the material's effects on the man's behaviour, and it is the one that most frequently brings the man into contact with a service: in the end, through a consequence.

The patterns are documented in the material on men's concealment and are described in this book throughout:

The avoidance. The settings, persons, and subjects that the man manages in order to keep the material out of view, together with the arrangements he declines and the places he no longer goes.

The compensating conduct. The drinking, the work, the risk, the sexual conduct, the spending, the screens: each supplying a function of relief, escape, or numbing in place of the arrangement that the material requires.

The reduced conduct. The matter of Chapter 25.2: the positions not applied for, the decisions deferred, the relationships not maintained, the ambition adjusted downward, since the material occupies the space and the man's available capacity is reduced.

The severity at home. The material of Chapters 17 and 18: the man whose household receives the consequences of a state they cannot explain and whose behaviour is read as being about them.

The judgement. The four forms of Chapter 27.3: the irreversible commitment made without a second opinion, the concealment continued beyond the point at which disclosure was affordable, the adjustment made in private and never revisited, and the conclusion formed without challenge.

The Specific Finding on Timing

The research supports a finding that men in the case material report repeatedly in their own words, and it is the practical case for addressing the material early rather than late.

The cost of a disclosure rises with delay, and it rises in three specific ways.

The material grows. An undeclared debt accumulates interest, penalties, and the additional arrangements the man constructs to manage it; an untreated condition progresses; an unrepaired wrong accumulates consequences; a household's misconstruction of the man's conduct becomes established as its account of him.

The account becomes difficult to deliver. A matter concealed for a period carries a second component: the reason for the concealment. The man must explain not only the material but the years, which is the arrangement described in Chapter 21.3 and which is considerably more difficult to conduct than the original disclosure.

The audience's response becomes harder to manage. The household that has been managed for years has its own account of the period, and the disclosure

must be received against it. Men describe this precisely: *I could have told her in the first year. In the fifth year I had to tell her that everything she had believed for four years was not what was happening.*

The finding is the practical conclusion of the section: the earlier the making of an arrangement — the disclosure, the professional relationship, the stated limit — the lower the cost of every part of it, and the delay is the variable that the man controls.

34.3 The Five Dangerous Silences

Five categories of silence carry a specific risk, and each requires a different response. They are the chapter's practical subject.

Silence One: The Silence About a Risk to the Man's Own Life

The most urgent category by a substantial margin, and the one the chapter addresses first and most directly.

The material. Thoughts that the man would be better off absent; the wish not to wake up; the sense that others would manage better without him; the specific plan; the rehearsal; the note that has been written and not left; the giving away of things; the arrangement of affairs; the purchase; the drive; the risk taken with the man's own life on the road or in the water or by the medication. The material is frequently not expressed as the wish to die, which is the reason men in this category are missed: the man's own account is frequently of tiredness, of being unable to see a way through, of a weight, of not being able to continue, or of a specific and unshakeable conviction that his family would be better without him.

The specific risk. Chapter 27.3 supplied the research on isolation and suicide; Chapters 30.7 and 31.4 supplied the elevated risk in specific groups of men. The relevant and urgent point is that men's suicide rates are substantially higher than women's while their reported depression and help-seeking rates are lower, which means that a substantial proportion of the material in this category is never presented to any service and is held, if it is held anywhere, by the man.

The requirement. The silence in this category must not be maintained, and the requirement is professional contact rather than a plan. The position is stated plainly because it is the position of the research and of clinical practice: a man who is carrying thoughts of ending his own life, or who has formed the conclusion that his household would be better without him, requires an assessment by a professional — a general practitioner, a mental health service, a crisis line, an emergency department — and requires it before anything else in this book is conducted. Section 34.5 supplies the plan and the routes.

What the man should know. The material in this category responds to treatment. The belief that the state is a permanent assessment of the man's situation, rather than a condition that has altered the man's perception of his situation, is a

symptom of the condition and not a fact about the man's life. This is the single most important sentence in the chapter, and it should be read as a statement about the evidence and not as encouragement.

Silence Two: The Silence About an Addiction

The material. The drinking, the substances, the gambling, the sexual conduct, the screens, the spending, and the use of any behaviour as the principal means of managing the man's state. The material of Chapter 23 applies in full, including the secrecy that the behaviour requires and the household's experience of a man whose conduct has altered with no explanation.

The specific risk. The progression described in Chapter 23.1, and the recurrence of the emergencies listed in Section 34.5. This category also carries a specific feature: the silence is frequently the behaviour's mechanism, and the man's management of the concealment is what maintains the arrangement.

The requirement. The professional assessment, the disclosure to the household in the form Chapter 23 specifies, and the arrangements described in that chapter. Where the man is in acute risk — withdrawal, overdose, the drink-driving, the violence, the inability to stop — the requirement is immediate medical attention.

Silence Three: The Silence About Violence and About Harm

The material. Two directions, and both require treatment.

The man's own violence: toward a spouse, a partner, a child, or anybody else; the conduct he has concealed; the incident he has minimised; the pattern he has not named. The specific risk is the escalation and the household's position, and the requirement is professional intervention, with the safety of the people in the household as the first consideration.

The violence done to the man: the abuse he experienced as a child; the assault; the conduct of a relative; the treatment he has received in a household, an institution, or a period of his life. The silence in this category is frequently of decades, and its feature is that the material is held with the man's own account of why it was his fault or why it did not matter. The material of Chapters 21 and 30 applies, and the professional arrangement is generally required, because the disclosure to a household carries a specific risk of the man's household being drawn into the original arrangement.

The requirement. In both directions, professional contact with a service that has the competence for the material: a domestic violence service, a child protection service, a sexual assault service, a counselling service with the relevant experience, or, where a person is at present risk, the emergency route.

Silence Four: The Silence About a Medical Condition

The material. The man's diagnosis that he has not told his household; the symptoms he has not had investigated; the treatment he has discontinued; the medication he has not taken; the condition he regards as inconsistent with his position.

The specific risk. Chapter 32.7's case is the illustration, and the mechanism is the one described in Section 32.2: the man's answer requirement prevents the question, and the condition progresses in the interval. The category's other specific risk is the men's mortality data, which consistently show that men present later with conditions that are treatable earlier.

The requirement. The medical route first, and then the disclosure of the fact to the household, in the form of Section 34.6. The position on the household's entitlement is settled in this chapter and in Chapters 18 and 20: the household cannot make its arrangements while it is uninformed, and the withholding is frequently presented as protection while it functions as an assumption about the household's capacity.

Silence Five: The Silence About a Financial Collapse

The material. The debt that the household does not know about; the business that is failing; the guarantee that has been called; the obligation that cannot be met; the arrangement the man has been managing without disclosure.

The specific risk. The material of Chapters 20 and 25. The collapse, when it arrives, is frequently larger than it would have been had it been disclosed earlier, because the man's private management of the position generally involves additional obligations, higher-cost borrowing, and arrangements constructed to conceal. The household's discovery, when it occurs, is the arrangement described in Chapter 20.5: the loss of the position, together with the loss of the household's trust in the man's account of the household's affairs.

The requirement. The disclosure of the position in the form of Section 34.6, with the accounting, the arithmetic, and the options; and the professional route for the specific categories: debt counselling, insolvency advice, legal advice on guarantees, financial counselling, and, where the material involves a guarantee or a business partnership, appropriate legal advice obtained before further commitments are made.

34.4 The Signs That Silence Has Become Dangerous

The following checklist is for the reader's own position and for his assessment of a man he is concerned about. It is not a diagnostic instrument; it is a list of indicators that practitioners use to prompt a fuller assessment, and any single item from the first group is sufficient to warrant an assessment.

The Indicators in the Man Himself

Group One — requiring immediate action: - Thoughts that others would be better off if the man were not present. - The wish not to wake up, or a wish to be absent. - Any plan, rehearsal, or preparation relating to the man's own death. - Risk-taking with the man's life: the road, the water, the medication, the confrontation. - The giving away of possessions or the settling of affairs without a stated reason.

Group Two — requiring prompt assessment: - Sleep that has not restored the man for a period of months. - The withdrawal from arrangements the man previously maintained. - The escalation of drinking, gambling, spending, screens, or risk. - The collapse of the man's patience with people he is ordinarily patient with. - The conclusion that his situation is unendurable and that nothing can be altered. - The avoidance of a specific person, place, or subject that the man is unable to explain. - A physical presentation that a practitioner has investigated and found no cause for. - The man's own statement that he cannot continue. - The cessation of the man's interest in matters that previously occupied him.

Group Three — the man's own material: - The material is operating somewhere other than in a decided arrangement. - The maintenance of the silence has become an activity in the man's life. - The silence is no longer protecting what it was intended to protect. - The man has not stated the silence's purpose in any form, including to himself.

The Indicators in the Man's Household and Setting

What the household sees: - A change in the man's temper, availability, or presence with no explanation. - The man's management of a subject, or a room that changes when a matter is raised. - The household's construction of an account of the man's state that it does not test. - The administration of the man by the household: the children's selections, the spouse's arrangements, the occasions organised around him.

What the organisation sees: - The man's withdrawal from settings he previously maintained. - The performance of performance: the work maintained while the man's engagement has emptied. - The deferral of decisions that the man previously took promptly. - The team's management of the man: the matters not raised, the subject avoided, the meeting deferred.

What the practitioner sees: - The presentation of a physical complaint with the material unmentioned. - The consumption data: alcohol, sleep, appetite, weight, work hours. - The enquiry's own answers: the man who declines every question about the state and answers all the questions about the details.

The three criteria and three mechanisms	Where the requirement changes
Criterion one: the silence no longer protects what it was meant to protect.	Where the material is operating in the man's body or judgement, an arrangement is required.
Criterion two: the material is operating somewhere — body, temper, attention, avoidance.	Where the household is affected by consequences it cannot explain, the fact must be supplied.
Criterion three: maintaining the silence has become an activity in the man's life.	Where the cost is rising with delay, the rate of increase is set by the delay itself.
Mechanism one: suppression removes expression and leaves the physiological load.	Five dangerous silences: a risk to life, an addiction, violence, a medical condition, a financial collapse.
Mechanism two: concealment consumes attention and reduces working capacity.	The first of these requires today's professional assessment, not a plan.
Mechanism three: conduct alters — avoidance, compensating behaviour, severity at home.	The others require the four decisions and the four-part statement.

Figure 34.1 When silence becomes dangerous: the criteria, the mechanisms, and the points at which the requirement changes. The left-hand column gives the three criteria of Section 34.1; the centre describes the three mechanisms by which unspoken material operates; the right-hand column identifies the point at which the requirement becomes professional rather than personal.

34.5 The Emergency: The Safety Plan

This section concerns the situation in which the material has reached the point of risk to the man's own life, and it is written in the form used in clinical practice rather than in the form of the rest of the book. The reader who recognises his own position in Group One of Section 34.4 should treat this section as the chapter's first instruction and should act on it before continuing.

The First Instruction

If you are thinking about ending your own life, or if you have formed the view that the people around you would be better off without you, the matter requires a professional assessment today, and it should not be managed privately.

Three routes, and any of them is sufficient.

The crisis line or the emergency number. Every state operates one or more, and the specific numbers for the reader's country are in Appendix Q of this book. A crisis line is staffed by people trained for exactly this conversation, it is confidential, it can be used by a man who does not want to explain himself to anybody he knows, and it can arrange the next step.

The emergency department of a general hospital. Attendance, at any hour, with the words the man is able to use: *I have been thinking about ending my life.* The sentence is sufficient. No further explanation is required at that point, and the practitioner's next step is the assessment.

A general practitioner or a mental health practitioner, urgently. Where the man has an existing relationship, this is the fastest route to the assessment. Where the man cannot obtain an appointment promptly and the risk is present, the emergency route should be used instead and the appointment should not be waited for.

The Obstacles and Their Answers

Four obstacles stop men in this category from acting, and each has an answer that is drawn from the material of the clinical practice on men and risk.

"I do not want to be a burden, and I do not want to be seen like this." The concern is real and the specific finding is worth stating: the practitioners who receive men in this position do not regard them as burdens, and the professional route exists precisely because the material may need to be held by somebody who is not the man's household. The confidentiality obligations of the professional arrangement are the mechanism.

"Nothing will change." This belief is characteristic of the condition and not of the situation, and it is the symptom that most reliably distinguishes a treatable state from a settled assessment. A man whose perception has been altered by a condition cannot evaluate his own position from inside it; the evaluation must be conducted externally, which is the reason the assessment rather than private deliberation is required.

"I have a position to protect." Then the professional route is the one that protects it. The confidentiality of medical and psychological consultation is a legal and professional obligation rather than a favour, and the men in the case material who hold substantial positions are generally able to obtain an assessment without it becoming known.

"I am needed, and admitting this means I am failing my household." The household requires the man alive and functioning rather than the man's concealment. This is not a rhetorical claim; the bereavement material on families after a man's death is unambiguous, and the chapters on men's families in this book supply its content.

The Safety Plan

The following plan is the form used in clinical practice, and a man in or near the risk category should write it out and keep it where he can find it — in his wallet, on his telephone, or in a document he will see. It is written for the man and it is also written to be handed to somebody who is trying to help him.

Step 1: The warning signs. What the man's own pattern is when the risk is rising. Examples from the practice material: the early waking; the flatness on a particular day; the withdrawal from a person; the belief that the household would be better off; the desire to drive a particular route fast; the feeling of being trapped; the period after a specific loss; the weekend; the month of a specific anniversary. The list is specific to the man, and it should be honest.

Step 2: The internal measures. The things the man can do on his own that reliably reduce the state, even partially, and that he has used before. The practice material includes: physical exertion to the point of exhaustion; a specific route walked; cold water on the face and hands; the reduction of the immediate setting; sleep; eating; the company of a specific person; a task requiring concentration; the postponement of any decision; the reduction of the means of harm in his own environment.

Step 3: The people. The names and numbers of the people the man will contact. At least two, and the plan should state the sentence he will use: *I am not in a good state and I need to be with somebody.* Where the man has nobody, the plan names the professional and the crisis line, and the man should treat the absence of a person as the reason to use the second.

Step 4: The places and the settings. The settings that must be avoided when the risk is rising: the location the man has considered, the routes, the vehicle, the alcohol, the firearm or the medication, the person, the argument. The plan's requirement is specific and it is the same requirement as the one on means safety described in Step 5.

Step 5: The means. The plan states what will be done about the means of harm: the medication returned to the clinic or handed to somebody; the firearm stored elsewhere; the keys, the alcohol, and the vehicle managed; the specific location avoided; the arrangement established with a person who will hold the items. This step is the one with the strongest evidence in suicide prevention, and it is the step men most frequently omit.

Step 6: The professionals. The name, the arrangement, and the number: the general practitioner, the practitioner the man is seeing, the crisis line, the emergency department. The plan states that the professional route is used when Steps 2 and 3 have not reduced the state, and that it is used immediately when the risk is rising.

Step 7: The reasons. Written in the man's own hand and in his own terms, and specific: the people, the obligations, the things that would be lost, the account of what his absence would do. The step draws directly on the material of this book: the man's duties to his household in Part V, the people who depend on him in Part IX, the conduct he has discharged, and the life he has built as Chapter 28.6 counts it. The step's function is that it is the man's own statement, written in the state in which he was able to reason, and it is available to him in the state in which he is not.

The Plan for Somebody Else

Where the reader is concerned about another man, the plan is used as follows.

Ask directly. The evidence is consistent on this point and it is worth stating in full: asking a man whether he is thinking about ending his life does not increase the risk, and the direct question is the single most useful act available to a person who is concerned. The question should be plain: *Are you thinking about ending your life?* The man's answer is frequently the first disclosure he has made.

Do not leave him alone with the material. Stay with him; help him make the first contact; where the risk is immediate, do not leave him to travel alone and do not leave him with the means of harm.

Help him make the call rather than advising him to make one. The mechanism is the arrangement rather than the advice, as Chapter 27.5 established: the man who cannot construct the first step will frequently take it if somebody is present while he does.

Do not keep the confidence. Where the man has told you he intends to harm himself, the professional obligation of a friend is that the arrangement is contacted. The instruction should be stated plainly: the confidence is not a confidence where the man's life is at risk.

34.6 Breaking a Silence Safely

The remainder of the chapter concerns the ordinary case: a silence that has met the criteria of Section 34.1, that is not a present risk to life, and that must be opened in a form that does not produce a worse arrangement than the silence.

The Principle

The disclosure is an arrangement rather than an act. Its purpose is that the material be held by more than one person and that the arrangements around it be constructed with the information that they require. The form therefore follows the principle established in Chapter 27.5: the disclosure is graduated, it is proportionate to the recipient's demonstrated record, and its first instance is small.

The Four Decisions

Before the disclosure, four decisions should be made in writing, because they determine the form.

Decision One: What is the purpose of the disclosure?

The possible purposes, and the man should select one: to supply the household with the information its arrangements require; to obtain an arrangement in which the material is held; to bring a specific matter into the open so that it can be addressed; to correct an account that the recipient currently holds; or to establish a boundary that the man cannot establish without the disclosure. The purpose determines what is delivered.

Decision Two: Who is the recipient, and how much can this person hold?

The recipient's capacity must be assessed. The categories: the household member who is entitled to the information because their arrangements depend upon it; the person who can hold the material without being damaged by it; the person who cannot hold it, and to whom the delivery would transfer the load — the elderly parent, the child, the person in their own crisis, the person whose position would require them to act on it. The second and third categories are distinguished by a single test: whether the recipient will be required to carry the material indefinitely, or whether they can place it.

Decision Three: What is the smallest true version?

The disclosure can be delivered at the level the man can afford, and the levels are: the fact of the material without its content (*there is a matter I have been carrying and I need you to know that it exists*); the fact with the outline; the fact with the content; and the full account, including the history of the concealment. The man should select the level and should be able to state it in one sentence. The second and third levels are legitimate and are the levels most frequently used; the requirement is that the delivery be accurate, since a partial account that misleads is a new concealment.

Decision Four: What do I require?

The disclosure should state what the man requires of the recipient, since the household's practical response depends on it. The forms: nothing, other than the recipient's knowledge; the recipient's participation in a specific arrangement; the recipient's silence on the matter outside the household; the recipient's assistance with a specific step.

The Six Obstacles and Their Handling

The recipient's distress. The household's response to a disclosure may be substantial: the tears, the anger, the fear, the sense of betrayal where the man's conduct has been concealed, the question of why the man did not speak earlier.

The man's handling: allow the response, do not manage it, do not defend the delay at the first instance, and state the position's own terms — what the material is, what he is doing about it, and what he requires.

The recipient's response to the delay. The specific and most common difficulty in a disclosure that follows a period of silence. The recipient's question concerns the years rather than the material. The handling: acknowledge the delay as a fact and give its reason briefly, without the explanation that converts it into a defence, and connect the delay to the disclosure: *I did not say it because I did not want to be the man who had done it, and I am saying it now because you cannot make the arrangements you need to make without knowing.*

The recipient's own material. The recipient's difficulty, which the disclosure may activate. The handling: recognize it, place it, and do not allow the man's disclosure to be replaced by the recipient's account of their own position. The professional arrangement is the appropriate route where the recipient is in difficulty of their own.

The consequences in the household. A disclosure may alter the household's arrangements: the expenditure, the schooling, the plan, the marriage, the responsibilities. The handling: the disclosure should be accompanied by the man's account of what is altered and what is not, and by the specific arrangements that follow. Men who have conducted a financial disclosure, the most common of this category, describe the finding consistently: the household's response was oriented to the plan rather than to the loss, provided a plan was supplied.

The consequences in the man's position. Where the material concerns work, the regulated profession, the position of trust, or the community, the disclosure carries a risk that is frequently accurate. The handling: the assessment of the risk should be conducted before the disclosure, with professional advice where the material is regulated; the professional route should be used where the exposure can be reduced by it; and the disclosure to the household should be separated from the disclosure to the employer or the institution, where the two are capable of separation.

The consequences for other people. The disclosure of the man's material may implicate others: a relative who participated, a friend who assisted, a person whose conduct is part of the material, a party to a dispute, a child. The handling: the man's disclosure should not deliver another person's material, and where the material is inseparable, the professional route should be established before the household's disclosure. The man should state his own position and should not distribute the accounts of those who have not consented.

The Form of the Statement

The practice material gives a consistent form for the disclosure, and its four parts are as follows.

Part one: the statement of the material. One or two sentences, plain, without elaboration and without the account's full history.

Part two: the reason for the silence, stated without defence. *I did not say it because I was afraid of how you would look at me.* One sentence, no justification.

Part three: what has been happening as a result. The consequences that the recipient has already observed and attributed to something else: the temper, the withdrawal, the drinking, the quietness, the sleep. This part matters because it corrects the recipient's existing account of the man's conduct, and it is frequently the part that alters the household's arrangements most substantially.

Part four: what happens next. What the man is doing about the material, what he requires, what will be different, and what will not change. The part should be specific and, where possible, should have dates.

The Subject the Man Cannot Yet Deliver

Where the man cannot deliver the material — the disclosure's content is genuinely unavailable to him, or the recipient is the person the material concerns — the chapter's position is that the professional arrangement is the required step and that the household's entitlement is limited to the fact. The form: *There is a matter I am carrying, it is being addressed with a professional, and it affects me in these specific ways.* The form is legitimate, it is accurate, and it supplies the household with what it actually requires.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in primary care, in occupational health, and in men's counselling.

Tunde is forty-six, a middle-ranking officer in a state agency, married to Bola for eighteen years, with three children aged sixteen, thirteen, and nine.

The material Tunde was carrying concerned a financial position, and it began with a guarantee.

In 2019, Tunde's younger brother approached him about a business: a supply arrangement requiring working capital, for which a bank required a guarantee. Tunde gave the guarantee in the sum of about eleven months of his salary. The business operated for fourteen months and then failed. The guarantee was called in 2021, and Tunde met the sum in instalments over the following three years, using a facility from a cooperative, an advance from his employer's credit scheme, and, in the third year, the proceeds of the sale of a plot of family land that had been intended for the household's house.

The household's knowledge of the position was, at the time of the case, as follows: Bola knew of the guarantee, because Tunde had told her at the outset; she did not

know that it had been called, that the instalments were being met, that the cooperative facility existed, that the credit scheme's advance was outstanding, or that the plot had been sold. The household's plan for the house had been deferred twice and Bola had been told that the delay was the agency's arrears of salary. The two eldest children attended a school at which the fees had been paid late four times in six years, on explanations that described a banking delay.

The presentations that brought the case into a service, in the third year, were four: the sleep, which had reduced to five hours with early waking; the presentation to a general practitioner with what was recorded as chest pain and palpitations, investigated with normal findings; the shortness with the children about money, in which Tunde had refused a school trip and later found himself unable to explain the refusal without raising his voice; and Bola's own statement, made in the second year, that *if there is a problem, the problem is that you have become a different man in the house.*

Tunde's own position at the point of the consultation was described by him exactly: *I had three things in my head. I could not tell her that the land is gone. The land was for the house. Her mother sold her own jewellery for the first plan in 2013 and I have not been able to look at her since the sale. And I had believed that I could recover the whole of it before anybody noticed, and at the point of the chest pain I understood the arithmetic. I have been paying the instalments out of this month's salary every month for three years. There is nothing coming.*

The work, conducted over about eight months, had five elements.

The professional arrangement. From the general practitioner, Tunde was referred for an assessment and then for counselling. He described the first six weeks as devoted almost entirely to arithmetic: *The counsellor made me write every obligation down. I had been keeping them in my head, which is why I could not sleep. On paper there were seven obligations and a total, and the total was three times what I had been able to think about at once. The page did not make it worse. It made it possible to look at.*

The accounting. With a debt counselling arrangement obtained in the second month, the position was consolidated: the obligations, the interest, the arrears, the income, and the options. The arrangement reduced the total by a third through the negotiation of one facility and the restructuring of another, and it established a schedule with dates.

The disclosure. Tunde made the disclosure to Bola over a period of two sittings, in the four-part form of this section, and, in the second sitting, with the accounting document present. His account of the first sitting: *I said the material in two sentences, I said why I had not said it in one, and then I said that the fees had been late four times and that the delay in the house was not arrears of salary. She was quiet for about a minute. Then she asked me for the numbers. I was prepared for something else. She asked me for the numbers and I did not have them, because I had not brought the page.*

The household's arrangements. In the third month, Tunde and Bola conducted the household meeting with the three children, at which the position was stated in the terms of Section 34.6′s Part Four: what had happened, what the household's position was, what would change, and what would not. Tunde described the meeting:

The sixteen-year-old asked me whether he was leaving the school. I said no, and I was able to say it because I had the schedule. He asked me how much was owed and I told him, and after that he stopped asking me for the things he had been asking for, which I had not understood was connected.

The arrangements for himself. Tunde joined a men's group in the fourth month and continued the counselling arrangement for a further year. He described one element of it as the most important: *I had been the one who covered. My brother, my brother-in-law, two colleagues — I had given guarantees for four people in eleven years, and I had not counted them until the group asked me to count. The group was the first place in my life where I said that I was afraid and where somebody was not relying on me for something. The man next to me had done the same thing with his own brother and had lost a house. We have both stopped giving guarantees. There is nobody else in my life who would have told me that sentence without blaming me.*

Tunde's summary, three years after the disclosure, was: *I am still paying and the schedule has about two years remaining. The house has not been built and we have a revised plan that the whole household knows. My brother has not repaid anything and Bola knows that as well, and I am not required to defend him in my own house any more, which was the part I had not expected. What I had believed was that the money was the weight. The weight was the arithmetic I was holding alone in the dark, at five in the morning, for three years, with no page.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The silence was maintained by the man's management of the arithmetic. The seven obligations held in the head rather than on a page, and the total, which the man could not consider at once. This is the cognitive load of Section 34.2 in its practical form, and the case records the counsellor's intervention accurately: the page did not make the position worse; it made the position available to be looked at, which is the mechanism by which a position can be addressed.

The household had constructed its own account and the account was worse than the material. The arrears of salary, the banking delay, the different man in the house. The case is included because this is the most consistently reported consequence of a man's financial concealment: the household supplies an explanation, the explanation is inaccurate, and the arrangements are made on the basis of it.

The disclosure was conducted in the four-part form and the recipient's response was to the plan rather than to the loss. Bola's request for the numbers. The case is included because the outcome is general and because it corrects the man's central prediction about the disclosure: what the household required was the information with which to make its arrangements, and the man's assumption that the household's response would be directed at him was inaccurate.

The household meeting with the children was conducted with the plan. What would change and what would not, with the schedule present. The case records the son's question and the change in his requests, and the finding is worth noting: the household's members adjust their own conduct to the position once it is stated, and the adjustment is generally constructive.

The man's own position was diagnosed through the guarantees and the group. Four guarantees in eleven years, uncounted, and the man's own account of the group's function: the first place where he had said he was afraid and where nobody was relying on him for anything. This is the arrangement of Chapter 27.5 in operation, and the case is included because the material of the chapter is a silence and the correction is an arrangement rather than a disclosure: the disclosure supplied the household with the information, and the group supplied the man with a place in which the material was held.

34.7 Practical Exercise: The Assessment, the Safety Plan, and the Disclosure Plan

This exercise has three parts. Part One should be completed now; Part Two should be completed and kept where the reader will find it; Part Three concerns the ordinary case.

Part One: The Assessment (Forty Minutes)

Section A: The criteria. Apply the three criteria from Section 34.1.

The criterion	My position	The evidence
The silence has stopped doing its job. What was it protecting, and is the protection still in force?		
The material is operating somewhere. Where is it operating — the body, the temper, the drinking, the risk, the attention, the avoidances?		
The silence requires my continued unavailability. What am I managing, avoiding, or holding in order to keep it in place?		

Section B: The category. Which of the five dangerous silences of Section 34.3 applies to you, if any? Record the category and the date on which it began.

Section C: The indicators. Apply the checklist from Section 34.4. Record every item that is present.

- **From Group One (requiring immediate action):**
- **From Group Two (requiring prompt assessment):**
- **From Group Three (the material's operation):**

Where any item from Group One is present, stop this exercise and conduct Section 34.5. The exercise is resumed only after the professional contact has been made.

Part Two: The Safety Plan (Thirty Minutes, Written and Kept)

Write the plan in your own hand, or type it and keep it where you will see it. It should be one page and it should be specific. The seven steps:

1. **My warning signs.** What my pattern is when the risk is rising. (Be specific: the hour, the belief, the impulse, the place, the date, the person.)
2. **My internal measures.** What has worked before, and for how long.
3. **My people.** Two names and numbers, and the sentence I will use: *I am not in a good state and I need to be with somebody.*
4. **My places to avoid.** The location, the route, the setting, the argument, the person.
5. **My means.** What will be done about the medication, the firearm, the keys, the alcohol, the vehicle, the location — and who will hold each.
6. **My professionals.** The general practitioner, the practitioner, the crisis line, the emergency department, with numbers.
7. **My reasons.** Written in your own terms and specific: the people, the obligations, the account of what your absence would do. This step should be written when you are able to reason, and kept for the times when you are not.

Then record the date on which you will give a copy — to your spouse, a friend, a practitioner — and do it. A plan that nobody else holds is a plan that cannot be used.

Part Three: The Disclosure Plan (One Hour, Two Sittings)

Section A: The four decisions.

The decision	My answer
The purpose of the disclosure	
The recipient, and what this person can hold	
The smallest true version	
What I require	

Section B: The statement. Write the four parts.

- **Part one — the material, in two sentences:**
- **Part two — the reason for the silence, in one sentence, without defence:**

- **Part three — what has been happening as a result (the consequences the recipient has already seen and attributed elsewhere):**
- **Part four — what happens next, with dates:**

Section C: The obstacles. From the six in Section 34.6, record which apply in your case and the specific handling for each.

Section D: The date. Record the date, the place, and the person you will tell afterwards. The date should be within fourteen days.

Section E: Where the disclosure cannot be made. Record the professional arrangement instead: the practitioner, the route, the date of the first appointment, and the sentence you will use with your household, in the form given at the end of Section 34.6.

34.8 Common Questions Men Ask

"My silence protects my household. Why would I remove that protection?"

Because in a large proportion of cases the protection has stopped operating and the household is being affected without the information it requires. The test is Section 34.1's first criterion: state what the silence protects, and state whether the protection is still in force. Where the household has noticed the man's temper, withdrawal, drinking, or absence and has constructed an account of it, the silence is no longer protecting anything and the household is making its arrangements on an incorrect basis.

"I cannot tell my wife. She will not survive this."

The assessment of another person's capacity is frequently inaccurate, and the case material on this judgement is consistent: households that are believed to be unable to hold a position are frequently the parties who address it most competently once they have the information. The professional route exists where the man's assessment is correct, and the household's entitlement to the fact — what is being carried and what it changes — is separate from the household's receipt of the content.

"If I disclose at work, I will lose the position."

The risk is frequently real, and the handling differs by category. Where the material is a regulated matter — a professional registration, a security clearance, a driving licence, a position with a specific health requirement — the professional advice should be obtained before the disclosure, and the routes are frequently narrower than the man assumes. Where the material is not regulated, the disclosure to the employer is generally not required, and the disclosure to the household and to a professional arrangement should be conducted independently of it.

"I have been carrying it for thirty years. Is there any point?"

The evidence and the case material are consistent: men conduct their first disclosure of material of this age and report the change in its operation. The specific

finding concerns the debt's interest rather than its principal: the matter itself does not change with the delay, and what has accumulated is the arrangement around it — the account held in private, the consequences carried by the household, the man's own management. The professional arrangement is generally required for material of this duration, since a thirty-year silence is not ordinarily opened in a single conversation with a household.

"I told one person and nothing changed."

Then the arrangement was not completed. The disclosure performs one function, which is that the material is known; the remaining functions require the arrangements of Chapter 27.5 — the professional relationship, the group, the household's arrangements, and the specific repairs where a repair is available. The disclosure is the first step and it is not the work.

"What if the person I told uses it against me?"

The outcome should be recorded as information about that person, in the form of Chapter 26.5, and the next arrangement should be constructed with a recipient whose confidentiality is an obligation rather than a favour. The professional route is the general answer to this concern, and the case material is unambiguous on its value: the man whose material is held by a practitioner under an obligation of confidence has the arrangement that does not depend on anybody's goodwill.

"I am worried about a man I know. What should I do?"

Read Section 34.5′s material for somebody else and follow it: ask directly; do not leave him alone with the material; help him make the contact rather than advising him to make one; and do not keep the confidence where his life is at risk. Then read Chapter 26′s material and remain present over the following months, since the arrangement's continuation is the part that most frequently fails.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 34 in brief. Silence has a range in which it functions, and past the edge of that range it produces the outcomes it was intended to prevent. Three criteria establish the edge: the silence has stopped performing its function, so that the protection it was supposed to supply is no longer in force; the material is operating somewhere other than in a decided arrangement, and the man can identify where; and the maintenance of the silence has become a substantial activity in the man's life, so that the material is carrying him rather than the reverse.

Unspoken material operates through three documented mechanisms. Sustained suppression does not reduce the physiological response; it removes its expression, and the body continues to carry the load. The maintenance of a concealment consumes attention continuously, producing a measurable reduction in the man's working memory, performance, and patience. And the material alters the man's conduct through avoidance, compensating behaviour, reduced ambition, severity at

home, and the four forms of damaged judgement. The cost of addressing the material rises with delay, in three specific ways: the material grows, the account becomes more difficult to deliver because it now includes the reason for the silence, and the audience's established account of the period must be corrected.

Five silences carry a specific risk: the silence about a risk to the man's own life, which is the most urgent and requires a professional assessment rather than private deliberation, since the belief that nothing can change is a symptom of the condition rather than a fact about the man's circumstances; the silence about an addiction; the silence about violence, in both directions; the silence about a medical condition; and the silence about a financial collapse.

A checklist of indicators is supplied for the man himself, for his household, for his organisation, and for the practitioner, and any indicator from the first group warrants immediate action. For that group, the chapter supplies the routes — the crisis line, the emergency department, the urgent practitioner — the answers to the four obstacles that stop men from using them, the seven-step safety plan, and the guidance for somebody who is concerned about another man: ask directly, do not leave him alone with the material, help him make the contact, and do not keep the confidence where his life is at risk.

For the ordinary case, the disclosure is an arrangement rather than an act, and it is conducted through four decisions — its purpose, its recipient and the recipient's capacity, the smallest true version, and what the man requires — with the six obstacles identified and handled, and with a statement in four parts: the material in one or two sentences, the reason for the silence stated without defence, the consequences the recipient has already observed and attributed elsewhere, and what happens next. Where the man cannot deliver the content, the professional arrangement is the required step and the household's entitlement is to the fact.

Reflection Questions

1. Apply the three criteria of Section 34.1. Which of them is satisfied in your case, and what is the evidence?
2. Record where your material is currently operating: the body, the sleep, the temper, the drinking, the risk, the attention, or the avoided settings. What has it produced in the last two years?
3. Which of the five dangerous silences applies to you? What is the date on which it began, and what is its cost so far in money, health, and relationships?
4. Complete the safety plan. Write Step 7 now, in your own terms, and record the person who will hold a copy.
5. Write the four parts of the disclosure statement for your material. Which part is the one you cannot yet say, and what does that indicate about the recipient or the content?

6. Complete the four decisions. What is the smallest true version of the material, and what is the one sentence in which you will state it?
7. Where a household member has constructed an account of your conduct — the arrears, the banking delay, the work pressure — what is their account, and what would change in it if they were told the material?

Further Reading

- **On emotional suppression:** the research on expressive suppression and on the effects of withholding the expression of feeling, including the findings on physiological load, on the persistence of the response, and on the social and cognitive consequences of habitual suppression.
- **On concealment and cognitive load:** the literature on secrecy and concealment, including the findings on the effects of holding concealed material on attention and working memory, and the evidence that disclosure reduces the load.
- **On men's suicide risk:** the epidemiological and clinical literature on suicide in men, including the findings on methods, on the lower rate of help-seeking and of reported depression among men, on the role of isolation and loss, and on the interventions that are associated with reduced risk.
- **On means safety and safety planning:** the evidence base for safety planning and for means restriction in suicide prevention, including the findings on which measures are associated with reduced risk and the recommended content of a safety plan.
- **On disclosure and stigma:** the research on disclosure of stigmatised conditions, including the findings on the benefits and the risks of disclosure, the factors that determine the outcome, and the evidence on the outcomes of disclosure in the workplace.
- **Practical resources:** crisis lines and emergency services; general practice and mental health services; domestic violence, child protection, and sexual assault services; addiction and gambling treatment services; debt counselling and insolvency advice; and the material in Appendices Q, M, D, and R.

35 CHAPTER

The Courage to Ask for Help

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the specific barriers that prevent men from asking for help, and distinguish between the barriers that reflect a real cost and the barriers that reflect an anticipated one.
2. Assess the actual costs of asking, in the four categories men report, and compare them with the costs the man has already been paying without asking.
3. Identify the map of available help, including the forms men actually use, and match his own need to the appropriate source.
4. Apply the four-part form of a request, and use the practice forms for asking a friend, a professional, an employer, a household member, and a man in a position to assist.
5. Ask for what he actually requires rather than for what he believes is available, and recognise the pattern of the reduced request that is refused in the form in which it was made.
6. Receive another man's request in the form that keeps the channel open, using the four rules for the man who is asked.

Introduction

This chapter concerns the act that the whole of this book has been approaching: a man's asking for help.

The preceding chapters have established why the act is difficult. Men's arrangements are built on provision and competence; the requirement to have answers is imposed by positions and reinforced by reward; the role of everyone's solution is acquired rather than chosen; the instruction that a man should manage unaided is delivered by the culture, by the household, and by the man's own account of himself; and the material that most requires an arrangement is frequently the material that is most costly to disclose. Every one of those arrangements is real, and none of them is a prejudice that can be corrected by instruction.

The chapter's approach has five commitments.

The first is that a man's reluctance to ask is not irrational and is not primarily a matter of pride. It rests on an assessment of costs that is frequently accurate and that the chapter does not dismiss: the standing that a man loses in some settings when he asks, the dependence he establishes, the obligation he incurs, the exposure of a material he has decided to carry. The chapter's argument is not that these costs are imaginary. It is that they have been assessed incompletely, and that the assessment has omitted the other side of the ledger: the costs the man is already paying by not asking, which are generally larger and are generally invisible because they are paid in instalments.

The second is that help is available in more forms than men recognise, and that the form the man rejects is frequently not the form he needs. The man who will not attend a therapy appointment may use a general practitioner's consultation, a trade association, a lawyer, a debt counselling service, a peer group, a professional supervisor, an apprenticeship, a cooperative, or a single conversation with a man who has been through the same difficulty. Section 35.3 supplies the map, and its purpose is that the reader should be able to match the need to the source rather than concluding from his refusal of one form that no form exists.

The third is that asking is a technique. The chapter supplies the four-part form and the practice scripts, and their purpose is that the act ceases to be an all-or-nothing declaration of the man's inadequacy and becomes a specific, bounded request that most recipients can answer. The finding from practice is consistent: the request that fails is generally vague, unlimited, apologetic, or framed as an announcement of the man's collapse; the request that succeeds is specific, bounded, and made in the language of a task.

The fourth is that the man's first request is generally not the one he believes he is making, and that this is not a failure. The first contact is frequently about a presenting complaint, a practical matter, or somebody else's difficulty, and the material arrives later. The staged material of Chapter 27.5 applies, and the chapter supplies the forms that allow the first step to be made before the man is able to name what he needs.

The fifth is that the chapter's material concerns both directions. Section 35.6 supplies the four rules for the man who is asked, since a man who asks and is badly received will not ask again, and since the men who read this book are frequently the men that other men bring their requests to.

35.1 Why Asking Is Difficult for Men

The research on men's help-seeking identifies consistent barriers, and the following nine cover the great majority of the material men report. They are arranged in the order in which men describe them, and each is stated in the man's own terms.

The Nine Barriers

1. The meaning of asking. The first and most powerful. For a large proportion of men, the act of asking is not a request; it is an admission. The man's understanding of the exchange is that he is stating that he cannot manage, which is a statement about his standing as a man, a provider, a father, or a professional. The barrier's force is that it is not a prediction about the recipient's response but a conclusion about the act's meaning, and it therefore applies regardless of who is asked.

The correction that applies: the distinction between the man's whole capacity and the specific matter. A man does not fail to manage because he requires a competence he does not possess in a domain in which it does not reside. The distinction is examined in Section 35.2.

2. The anticipated loss of standing. The prediction that the recipient, or the setting, will regard the man differently afterwards. Men report the prediction in specific terms: the colleague who will regard him as unreliable, the wife who will regard him as reduced, the family which will use it, the employer who will note it, the professional who will record it.

The correction that applies: the evidence on the actual outcomes of disclosure, which is more favourable than the prediction, and the distinction between the settings in which the cost is real and the settings in which it is anticipated. The distinction is supplied in Section 35.2 and represents the chapter's principal practical material.

3. The requirement to have answers. The material of Chapter 32 in the form it takes in the act of asking: a man who is supposed to know does not ask a question in the setting in which he is supposed to know. The barrier is specific to the man's domain, and it is the strongest barrier reported by men in professional and technical occupations.

The correction that applies: the professional and peer arrangements of Chapter 31.5, which relocate the asking to settings in which the man is not required to know.

4. The obligations of the position. Men in positions of responsibility report that the act of asking is unavailable to them because the people who could help are the people they are responsible for. The barrier is accurate in the short term, and it is the reason that the arrangements of Chapter 31.5 are constructed outside the reporting line.

The correction that applies: the construction of the arrangement rather than the choice of a recipient from among the man's dependents.

5. The absence of any experience of being helped. The man who was never attended to as a child has no model of the exchange, and he therefore cannot imagine its form. The barrier is the first form of isolation in Chapter 27.1, and its

feature is that the man does not experience it as a barrier at all: he reports that he has never needed help rather than that he cannot ask for it.

The correction that applies: the staged method of Chapter 27.5, and the deliberate adoption of the smallest available form of the exchange.

6. The debt of gratitude and the reciprocity problem. The man's assessment that accepting assistance establishes an obligation he may not be able to discharge, and that the relationship will be permanently altered by the imbalance. The barrier is frequently the strongest one in the material on family assistance, where the man has seen relatives made permanently subordinate by the assistance they received.

The correction that applies: the reciprocal arrangement of Chapter 27.5′s third stage, the stated terms of Chapter 33.4, and the professional route, in which the exchange is a service rather than a favour.

7. The fear of what will be found. A specific and frequently reported barrier: the man's reluctance concerns not the act of asking but its outcome. The assessment will produce a diagnosis, the accounts will be examined, the position will be worse than the man has admitted to himself, and the arrangement entered into will require changes he does not wish to make.

The correction that applies: the information that the position is almost always better known than the man believes it to be, and that the assessment's function is to establish what is required rather than to deliver a verdict. Section 34.2′s material on the rising cost of delay applies: the material's total is larger, not smaller, at the point at which the man finally addresses it.

8. The specific barrier of the man who has asked before. The man whose earlier request was refused, dismissed, forgotten, or used against him, and who has concluded from the outcome that asking does not work. The barrier is also the reason that the Staged material of Chapter 27.5 requires more than one attempt: the outcomes of requests vary by recipient, and the first outcome is information about that recipient rather than about asking.

The correction that applies: the principle of Chapter 26.5′s revised reliance, applied to the asking itself: the reliance should be graded to the demonstrated record of the recipient, and the first request should be one the man can afford to have refused.

9. The instruction that a man should not need help. The barrier is delivered in childhood by households, by schools, by men's groups, by the culture of the trade, and by the man's own account. It is stated in the form of a rule rather than a prediction, and rules are resistant to evidence.

The correction that applies: the recognition that the instruction is a description of a role that was designed for particular circumstances — the man who must function in conditions where his failure is dangerous for other people — and that

it has been applied beyond its useful range. The material on which the chapter relies is the arithmetic of Section 35.2: the instruction's costs are large, they are paid by the man's household, and there is no arrangement that requires them.

The Common Structure

The nine barriers share a structure, and it is worth stating because it determines the correction.

Each concerns **the man's whole standing** rather than the specific matter; each is anticipated rather than experienced; each is therefore available to be tested; and each suppresses the request entirely rather than altering its form.

The consequence is that men who cannot make the whole request make no request. The chapter's method is the opposite: it supplies a form of request that is specific, bounded, and made in the language of a task, and its purpose is that the man is able to test the barriers with an act small enough to survive the outcome.

35.2 What Asking Actually Costs

The section treats the four costs honestly. Two of them are real and require an arrangement; two are anticipated and are generally inaccurate.

Cost One: Standing — Real in Specific Settings, Anticipated in Most

Where the cost is real. The settings in which a man's asking is recorded against him are identifiable: the competitive environment in which the man's position depends on his apparent command; the informal setting among men in which the exchange is a competition; the regulated setting in which the disclosure of certain material is a reportable matter with a defined consequence; the small community in which the material will become general; the family arrangement in which the man's assistance has been the family's structure, and in which his request alters the arrangement described in Chapter 33.

Where the cost is anticipated and does not occur. The findings from the research and from practice are consistent and should be stated plainly: the household, the friend, the general practitioner, the professional, the employer who is not in a competitive setting, and the men's group do not regard the man as reduced by his request. The specific finding is that the recipient's experience of being asked is generally positive and is frequently the occasion of a relief of their own: the man who asks a friend for help generally discovers that the friend had been aware that something was wrong and had not known how to raise it.

The distinction's practical use. The man should identify the setting before the request and select the recipient accordingly. Where the setting is one of the categories in the first paragraph, the request should be routed through the professional or the arrangement rather than made directly; where the setting is any of the others, the anticipated cost is generally inaccurate.

Cost Two: Dependence — Real, and Managed by the Arrangement

The cost. The man who asks establishes a dependence, and its two forms are different. The assistance that is required once is a transaction; the assistance that is required regularly is a dependence, and its terms matter. The men in the case material who most fear the second form are frequently the men who have provided it to others and who know what a repayment arrangement looks like from the provider's side.

The management. Four arrangements reduce the cost to the level the man can carry. The **professional arrangement**, in which the exchange is a service with defined terms and no ongoing obligation. The **reciprocal arrangement**, in which the man brings something to the relationship, as Chapter 27.5′s third stage specifies. The **stated terms**, in which the assistance is given with a limit and a duration, as Chapter 33.4 supplies. And the **group arrangement**, in which the assistance circulates among several men rather than running in one direction between two.

The finding that corrects the man's assessment. The dependence that men fear is generally less permanent than the attachment that the alternative produces. A man who has received assistance and discharged the terms of it has a relationship; a man who has concealed a matter, declined the assistance, and carried it alone has an arrangement that his household is participating in without knowledge.

Cost Three: Obligation — Real, and Frequently Smaller Than the Man Assumes

The cost. Assistance creates an obligation: the assistor has a claim, the man has an account, and the account may be raised. Men report this cost precisely, and it is frequently the strongest of the four in the family setting, where the assistance is remembered and quoted for decades.

The management. The professional route removes the obligation entirely. The stated terms convert it into a defined transaction. The reciprocal arrangement balances it. Where an obligation is genuinely incurred, the mode of its discharge should be established at the time of the assistance and not left to the assistor's account, which is the arrangement described in Chapter 33.4 and which is worth conducting even at the cost of some awkwardness.

The finding that corrects the man's assessment. The obligation that men fear in the family setting is frequently the obligation they have already created in the other direction. The man who has assisted eleven relatives, guaranteed four loans, and funded two households has already established a set of obligations; the request for assistance that he declines to make is the request that would balance an account that is, in most cases, heavily in his favour.

Cost Four: Exposure — Real, and the Actual Subject of the Chapter

The cost. The material of the previous chapters: the disclosure of the difficulty, the failure, the addiction, the debt, the condition, the wrong, or the state. The exposure is real and it is the cost that distinguishes the request for practical assistance from the request for help with the material of this book.

The management. The graduated form of Chapter 34.6 and the staged method of Chapter 27.5: the smallest true version, supplied to a recipient selected for capacity and record, with the professional route available where the confidentiality must be an obligation rather than a favour. The disclosure's cost rises with delay, as Chapter 34.2 established, and the arrangement reduces the exposure to the level the man can afford at the time.

The finding that corrects the man's assessment. The exposure of a difficulty is generally smaller than the exposure of its consequences. A man who discloses a financial position in the first month is exposed to a conversation; a man who discloses it in the third year is exposed to the arrears, the household's reduced arrangements, and the account the household has constructed in the interval. The same comparison holds for the medical condition, the addiction, and the difficulty at work.

The Ledger the Man Has Not Counted

The chapter's central practical argument is the comparison, and it should be written rather than reasoned.

The costs of asking: the standing in the settings where it is real; the dependence, managed by the arrangement; the obligation, discharged by terms; and the exposure, controlled by the graduated form and by the choice of recipient.

The costs of not asking, over the same period: the material's accumulation and the interest it accrues; the household's reduced arrangements and its misattributed account of the man; the man's own condition, including the presentations of Chapters 30.3, 31.4, and 34.2; the reduced conduct of Chapter 25.2: the positions not taken, the decisions deferred, the capacity not used; the arrangements not maintained; and the risk categories of Chapter 34.3, whose totals the chapter has already supplied.

The comparison is the chapter's argument, and the finding from practice is that it is decisive: the men who conduct it discover that they have been paying the larger sum in instalments and that the sum was invisible because it was not denominated in a single transaction.

35.3 The Map of Available Help

Men frequently conclude that help is unavailable because the form they considered is one they will not use. The following map is arranged by the kind of need

rather than by the kind of service, and its purpose is the matching of the need to the source.

The Five Sources

1. The person. One man, a household member, a friend, a relative, a colleague, a mentor. What this source supplies: presence, the arrangement in which the material is held, the practical assistance, and the correction that the isolated man does not have. What it does not supply: competence in the specific technical matter, confidentiality governed by an obligation, and an arrangement that is available when the person is unavailable.

2. The professional. The general practitioner, the psychologist or counsellor, the psychiatrist, the lawyer, the accountant, the financial counsellor, the debt adviser, the occupational health service, the employee assistance programme, the mediator, the social worker. What this source supplies: competence in the specific matter, the confidentiality obligation, the defined terms, the absence of an ongoing obligation, and the availability. What it does not supply: the two-in-the-morning company, the presence at the hospital, and the ongoing relationship that a man's arrangements require — which is the reason the professional route is an entry point rather than a destination.

3. The institution. The hospital, the bank's small-business or restructuring desk, the government agency, the cooperative, the credit union, the housing authority, the school, the training provider, the regulatory body, the union. What this source supplies: scale, legality, procedure, and the routes that the man cannot construct as an individual — the restructuring, the assessment, the recognition of prior learning, the instalment arrangement, the grant, the examination.

4. The peer group. The professional association, the trade association, the men's group, the group of people in the same situation — the bereaved men, the men who have lost businesses, the men in recovery, the men in comparable positions, the fathers' group. What this source supplies: the recognition that the condition is general, the correction of the man's account, the absence of cost, and the recognition of the man's competence by people who can assess it, which is the material of Chapter 25.3.

5. The arrangement. The measures the man constructs rather than sources he approaches: the written boundary of Chapter 31.5, the inventory of Chapter 33.6, the stated terms of Chapter 33.4, the safety plan of Chapter 34.5, the measures for means safety, the arrangements for the household, the written measure of Chapter 25.5. The category is included because a substantial proportion of what men require is not a service but a structure.

The Matching

The need	The source
I am carrying material and it has no recipient.	The person, the professional, the peer group.
I have a specific technical matter — a legal, financial, medical, or property question.	The professional, the institution.
My position requires me to be the man who knows and I cannot ask my own people.	The professional outside the line, the peer group of equivalent position.
I cannot pay for the assistance.	The institution, the cooperative, the public service, the group.
I need to know whether my state is a condition requiring treatment.	The general practitioner, the mental health service.
I need the arrangement rather than the advice.	The institution, the professional relationship, the group with a fixed time.
I need to be known by people who know my work.	The professional or trade association.
I need somebody to be present at a specific event or period.	The person, the group.
I need to stop and I cannot stop on my own.	The treatment service, the medical route, the group in recovery.

The Finding on the Form Men Actually Use

The chapter records a finding from practice that corrects a common instruction: men's first contact is frequently not with the form prescribed for their difficulty. Men enter the arrangements of this book through the general practitioner's physical presentation, the lawyer's consultation about a document, the debt adviser's appointment concerning a notice, the trade association's technical enquiry, the mediation service's enquiry about a family dispute, and the men's group brought by a friend. The route matters less than the establishment of the arrangement, and the chapter's instruction is therefore: **use the route that is available, and allow the material to arrive later.** The case material in Chapters 27.6 and 32.7 illustrates the mechanism, and Section 35.4 supplies the forms.

35.4 How to Ask

Asking is a technique, and this section supplies the form.

The Four Parts of a Request

Part one: the specific thing. The request concerns a task, not a condition. *I need an hour of your time to look at these accounts* is a request; *I am not coping* is an announcement, and it generally produces either anxiety or advice rather than the assistance. The man should be able to state what he is asking for in a single sentence, in the language of a task.

Part two: the reason, in one sentence. The reason supplies the recipient with the context required to respond and does not require the man's full history. *I am in a position with the business that I do not understand and I have been managing it on my own.* The sentence is true, it is brief, and it does not require the material.

Part three: the scale and the limit. The request should be bounded: the time, the amount, the number of occasions, the period. *An hour on Saturday; a sum I will repay over six months; four sessions; one meeting.* The part's function is that the recipient can assess what is being asked and can agree to it, which is the arrangement that most requests lack.

Part four: what the man will do. The man's own part in the arrangement, stated: the information he will bring, the steps he will take, the schedule of the repayment, the decision he will make, the point at which he will report back. The part converts the request from a dependence into an arrangement, and it is the part that men most frequently omit because it appears to weaken the request. In practice it is the part that most reliably produces agreement.

The Five Practice Forms

Asking a friend. *I need to talk to somebody about something that has been happening with me for about a year. I do not need you to solve it. I need an hour, and I need you not to repeat it. Saturday morning or any evening.*

The form's features: the material is named only as a category; the limit is stated; the requirement is stated specifically and it is small; and the setting is a recurring arrangement rather than an occasion.

Asking a professional. *I need an appointment about a matter that has been going on for some time and that I have not dealt with. I am not sure how to describe it in a line on a form.*

The form's features: the presentation is the appointment itself rather than the material; the sentence states that the material exists; and no diagnosis, history, or justification is required at that point. Where the man cannot make even this statement, the physical presentation is the available route, as Chapter 34.5 establishes.

Asking an employer or an institution. *I need to request X: the arrangement, the change of duties, the instalment plan, the leave, the assessment, the training. Here is the position in writing, here is what I am proposing, and here is what I will commit to.*

The form's features: the request is made in writing, with the position and the proposal; the employer is not asked to manage the man's state; the arrangement proposed is specific; and the request is made before the man's performance has been affected where that is possible.

Asking a household member. The four parts become the four sections of Chapter 34.6: the material, the reason for the silence, the effects already visible, and what happens next. The specific addition here is the request itself, which should be stated explicitly rather than left to be inferred: *I need you to know this, and I need to ask you for X.* The household's most frequent complaint about a man's disclosure is not the material but the absence of a request: the man has supplied the burden and left the household with nothing to do with it.

Asking a man in a position to assist. *I am asking you for one specific thing. Here is the position. Here is what I am doing about it. Here is what I will do with what you provide.* The form's features: the request is explicit that it is a request rather than an account of the man's troubles; the position is supplied, which is what a person with the capacity to assist actually requires; and the man's own part is stated, which is the arrangement that protects the relationship, as Chapter 26.5's rules establish.

The Five Errors

1. The vague request. *Can you help me?* The recipient cannot assess it, and the common outcome is a general expression of support and the absence of assistance.

2. The unbounded request. The request for assistance *whenever you can* or the account of a difficulty with no stated requirement. The form's outcome is the deferral of the matter and the recipient's discomfort.

3. The request that is an announcement. The statement of the man's position with no requirement attached. The outcome is that the recipient must construct a response, which explains the frequency of the two responses men report: advice and reassurance, neither of which is assistance.

4. The apologetic request. The request that begins with the man's account of why he should not be asking. The form supplies the recipient with the man's own assessment of the request's illegitimacy, and it is frequently the mechanism by which the recipient declines.

5. The request delivered at the worst possible moment. The material delivered in a crisis, in a public setting, or to a person who is themselves in difficulty. The form's outcome is generally the arrangement described in Chapter 34.3's first category, in which the man's disclosure is received by somebody who cannot hold it, and the man concludes that asking does not work.

The Timing

Two findings from practice, and they are worth recording.

The first step should be a request the man can afford to have refused. The graded form of Chapter 26.5 applied to the asking: the small request, the available recipient, the arrangement the man can survive. The finding is that the

small request generally succeeds, which supplies the evidence that changes the man's assessment of the larger ones.

The material should be delivered in an activity rather than at an appointment. The material of Chapter 4.6 in the asking context: the drive, the walk, the workshop, the errand. The setting's function is that the man is not required to hold the recipient's eye for the duration of the material, which is the specific difficulty that the case material in Chapters 26 and 30 identifies.

35.5 Asking for What You Need

The chapter's final substantive section concerns the accuracy of the request, since a large proportion of the refusals men experience concern requests that were not what the man required.

The Reduced Request

The most common form of the inaccurate request, and its mechanism is the wish to minimise the request's cost. The man requires money and asks for advice; he requires an arrangement and asks for information; he requires the household's participation and asks for tolerance; he requires treatment and says that he is tired.

The form's outcome is that the request is refused in the form in which it was made. The recipient answers the question that was asked, the man receives an answer that does not address the position, and the man's conclusion — that asking does not work — is drawn from a request that was not the one he needed to make.

The correction. The man should write what he actually requires and then, opposite it, what he is intending to say, and should identify the difference. The practice's finding is that the difference is frequently large and that the reduction was made in order to protect the recipient, to preserve the man's position, or to keep the request within a range the man could imagine being answered.

The Inflated Request

The opposite error, and it is common in men who ask once: the request is made at the level of the man's whole position rather than the specific matter. *I need help with my life* is a request that cannot be answered; *I need four sessions with a practitioner and one person who will sit with me on Sundays* can be.

The correction. The decomposition: the whole position, divided into the specific matters, with an identifiable source and an identified requirement for each. The practice is the same as the inventory of Chapter 33.6: the written list, the item-by-item matching, and the arrangement for each item.

The Request That Transfers the Load

The third form: the request delivers the man's material to a recipient who is required to carry it indefinitely. The recipient is the elderly parent, the child, the

person in their own crisis, the subordinate, the person whose position requires them to act on the material.

The correction. The assessment of the recipient's capacity before the request, in the form of Chapter 34.6′s second decision and with the same test: whether the recipient will be required to carry the material indefinitely, or whether they can place it. Where the recipient cannot place it, the professional or the group is the correct source, and the request to the household is limited to the fact.

The Request Made Before the Man Can State It

The fourth form, and it is the most common in the material: the man knows that something is wrong and cannot yet state what it is. The available requests, in ascending order: the practical request (the appointment, the assistance with a specific task, the arrangement); the request for company (the standing arrangement, the activity); the request for an assessment (*I do not know what the matter is; I need somebody to establish it*); and the request for the arrangement (the group, the professional relationship, the supervision).

The chapter's instruction is that all four are legitimate and that the third is frequently the most useful: a man who can state only *I do not know what is wrong* has made a complete request to a general practitioner and a sufficient request to a peer arrangement.

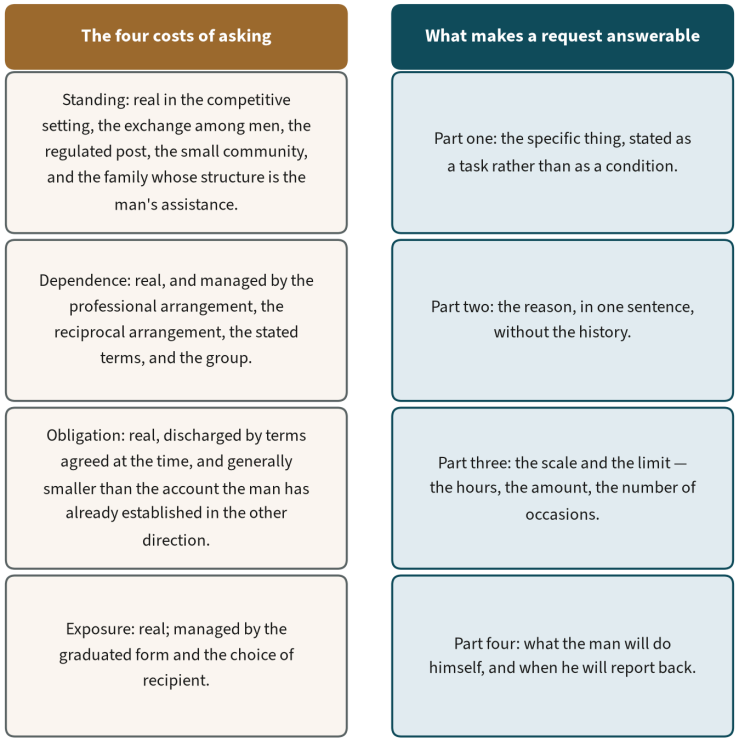


Figure 35.1 Asking for help: the four costs of the request, the five sources available, and the four parts of an effective request. The lower band sets out the form that converts a request from an announcement of the man's position into a bounded arrangement a recipient can answer.

35.6 When You Are Asked

The chapter's final section concerns the other direction, and it is included for a practical reason: the men who read this book are frequently the men who are asked, and a request that is badly received is the mechanism by which men stop asking.

The Four Rules

1. Receive it in the form it was delivered. The man will frequently make a request that is not the request he needs, as Section 35.5 establishes. The recipient's task is to take what was delivered and to find what is beneath it: the question that is not the question, the complaint that is a request, the practical matter that is standing in for a material. The instrument is the follow-up question: *is it the accounts, or is it something else as well?*

2. Do not supply advice as the first response. The strongest finding in the practice material on men's disclosure: the man who is given advice receives the message that his position has a solution he had not thought of, which is generally inaccurate and which forecloses the delivery of the material. The correct first response is the acknowledgement and the request for more: *tell me what it is like from your side.*

3. State what you can give, and state it as an offer rather than as a limitation. The form: the specific thing the recipient can provide, with the time or the limit, and the alternative where the recipient cannot supply what was asked. The form's function is that the man's request is answered rather than deflected, and it establishes the arrangement that can actually be maintained.

4. Keep the arrangement rather than the occasion. The finding that most reliably determines whether the man will ask again: the recipient's contact over the following weeks. The single conversation, however well conducted, is generally insufficient; the arrangement — the calls, the meetings, the practical presence, the reporting back — is what the man's position requires.

The Two Prohibitions

Do not disclose the material. The man's request is a confidence, and its disclosure terminates the arrangement and frequently produces the consequences the man's barriers predicted. The exceptions are the categories of Chapter 34.3, and the position there is stated plainly: a confidence does not hold where a life is at risk or where the material concerns violence or the safety of a person who cannot protect himself.

Do not require the man to be grateful. The requirement, frequently imposed in the form of a general expectation, converts the arrangement into a favour and establishes the obligation of Section 35.2 in the relationship. The man who is received without the requirement of gratitude will return.

35.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Asked the Wrong Question for Six Years

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in primary care, vocational counselling, and debt advice practice.

Godwin is fifty, a self-employed builder with a small contracting business, married to Ekaette for twenty-four years, with two children aged twenty-one and seventeen.

The material began in 2018 with a contract: a supply and installation project for a private development of eleven houses, for which Godwin had committed his own capital, taken a facility from a microfinance bank, and given a guarantee. The

agreement was verbal in its variations and was never documented in its full form. The developer's funding was disrupted in 2019, the work was suspended with about 60 per cent completed, and payments stopped.

Godwin's position at that point was: an outstanding facility of about eight months' income; a sum owed to two suppliers; eight staff and seven artisans to whom wages for about ten weeks were due; and a claim against the developer which he had concluded, incorrectly, had no documentation.

The six years that followed are the substance of the case, and Godwin described them in the terms of this chapter.

Year one: the reduced request. Godwin approached two relatives and a colleague. In each case the request was for advice: *an opinion on what I should do about the developer.* He received, in each case, an opinion. His description: *I asked three men for advice. Two of them told me that the developer was a criminal and that I should take him to court. One told me that I should let it go. None of them knew that I had a facility and that my people had not been paid for ten weeks. I did not tell them what I needed, and then I concluded that asking does not help.*

Years one to four: the management. Godwin paid the artisan wages from his household's reserves, then from a second facility at a higher rate, then from a rotation of payments in which the two suppliers and the facility were each deferred in turn. The business continued at about half its prior volume, taking small work to cover the week. He did not reduce the household's expenditure. His household's account of the period, as recorded by Ekaette in the family consultation, was: *He was working. He was working more than before, in the evenings and on Saturdays. I believed that the contracts were slow. I did not know that there was a facility until the third year, and I did not know about the guarantee at all until the fifth year.* The household's arrangements in the period were: the elder child's fees paid late twice; the household's car sold in year three with an explanation concerning a mechanical fault; and the family's annual obligation to Ekaette's mother reduced.

Year four: the presenting complaint. Godwin attended a general practitioner with insomnia, weight loss, and a raised blood pressure, and was treated for the blood pressure. He did not mention the business. His description of the consultation: *He asked me whether I was worried about anything and I said the business is slow, and he wrote the tablets and said to come back in a month. I told him the truth about everything except the number.*

Year five: the questions asked of the wrong people. Godwin approached a lawyer about the developer, who advised that a claim was possible and requested the documents, which Godwin did not produce, being embarrassed by the agreement's informality. He approached a second relative for a loan, requesting the sum in the form of an investment in the business, and was declined. He approached his employer of an earlier period for work. He described the pattern: *I have asked nine people for something in six years. I have asked a lawyer to fight my case. I have asked a relation to invest. I have asked my doctor for tablets. I have not asked one person to look at the whole of it and tell me what to do.*

Year six: the arrangement. The position came into a service through the microfinance bank's restructuring officer, after the third deferral, who required a full financial statement of the business and the household. Godwin described the preparation of that statement as the turning point: *It took four days and it was the first time in six years that everything was on one page. When I saw it, I began to understand what I had been doing. I had been carrying eleven different things and answering each one separately, and the whole of it was about twice what I had been able to think about. I did not need advice about the developer. I needed somebody to look at the whole of it.* The arrangements constructed over the following fourteen months had five elements.

The professional arrangement. A debt counselling service, obtained through the bank's restructuring officer, which conducted the consolidated accounting and negotiated with the facility. The negotiation rescheduled the outstanding sum over thirty months and reduced the interest.

The legal arrangement. A lawyer was engaged on the developer's claim with the documents that Godwin reconstructed — the correspondence, the delivery notes, the site records, the payment history — and the claim was settled in the second year for about a third of the sum, which was applied to the suppliers.

The household disclosure. Godwin conducted the disclosure to Ekaette in year six, in the four-part form: the material, the reason for the silence, the effects the household had already seen — the late fees, the car, the reduced obligation to her mother — and what happened next, with the schedule present. He described the conversation: *She was angry about the car, not about the money. She had believed that I had been cheated on a vehicle repair and she said that if I had told her at the time, we would have kept the car and delayed the school fees and it would have been the same amount. I had not thought about it that way, because I had been making each decision separately.*

The household's arrangements. In the third month, Godwin and Ekaette conducted the household meeting with the two children, in which the business's position, the schedule, and the schooling plan were stated. The elder child, who had been told in the period that the fees' delay was a bank matter, learned the actual position six years after the first delay. The account he gave at the meeting is recorded because it is the material of Chapter 34.6′s third part: *I have known for four years that something was happening, because he stopped asking me about the business. I did not know what it was and I had decided it was the school fees, and I had planned to leave the university after this year. I will not leave now.*

The arrangements for himself. Godwin joined a trade association in the second year and established a small group with three other contractors which met monthly. He described one element as decisive: *The other three have each been where I was. One of them lost a business in the same way in 2016 and he told me the thing I most needed to know, which was that the partnership agreement is a page and that I had been building for twenty-two years on handshakes. I now take the page to every client. The second thing he told me was that I should have gone to the bank in the second month*

> *of the suspension rather than in the fifth year, because the restructuring is available to a man who comes early and it is not available to a man who comes late. That is a sentence I could not have got from anybody in my family.*
> Godwin's summary, at the end of the case, was: *I asked nine people for something in six years and I did not ask anybody for the right thing. I asked for advice because advice is what I could ask for without saying the number. I have been asked every week by somebody in the trade whether I have the facility, and I have told them the truth since the second year. What I did not know was that the question I could not ask — help me look at the whole of it — was the only one that mattered, and that the man who could answer it was sitting in the association's meeting every month.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The requests were made and were not the requests the man required. Nine approaches in six years, all of them in forms that could be answered without the position. This is Section 35.5′s reduced request in its most complete form, and the case is included because the pattern is extremely common among men and because it produces the false conclusion that asking does not work.

The material was held in eleven separate pieces with no consolidated account. The facility, the two suppliers, the wages, the claim, the household's reserves — each addressed in turn, with the whole invisible. The case records the intervention accurately: the statement took four days and it was the first occasion on which the total had been visible. This is the inventory of Chapter 33.6 in a business context, and the same principle as Chapter 34.7′s arithmetic page: the position cannot be addressed until it is on one page.

The household's explanation of the period was constructed from six years of partial information, and it included a plan the man did not know about. The car's mechanical fault, the fees' banking delay, the son's decision to leave the university. The case is included because the finding is the chapter's strongest practical argument against the concealment: the household's account of the period was assembled from the man's incomplete explanations, and it had produced arrangements — the son's plan, the household's expenditure — that the man was not aware of and that were made on an incorrect basis.

The presentation to the practitioner did not include the position. The doctor's question about worry and the man's answer about the business being slow. The case is included because the material on routine assessment in primary care is consistent with this finding, and because the presentation route is the one available to men who cannot construct the disclosure: the question is asked on a form, and the man answers as far as he can, and the arrangement is established from the point at which he answers further.

The arrangement that changed the position was a peer arrangement in the man's own trade. The three contractors, monthly, of whom one had been in the same position and supplied the two sentences the man most required: that the agreement is a page, and that the restructuring is available early and not late. The case is included because the peer arrangement is the source that men most frequently overlook and the one whose material is the most directly usable: the recognition and the technical knowledge are supplied by people who have done the work, which is Chapter 25.3's reference group in a form available to any man who joins his association.

35.8 Practical Exercise: The Ledger and the Request

This exercise takes about two hours, over three sittings.

Part One: The Ledger (Sitting One)

Write the two columns. The comparison is the chapter's argument, and it should be conducted in figures where figures exist.

The costs of asking, in my case:

The cost	What I fear it would be	Where it would actually fall
Standing		
Dependence		
Obligation		
Exposure		

The costs I have already paid by not asking:

The cost	What it has been, in the last two to five years
Money (the interest, the penalties, the higher-cost borrowing, the deferred arrangements)	
Health (sleep, the physical symptoms, the drinking, the weight, the blood pressure)	
The household (what was reduced, postponed, or misattributed)	
My own conduct (positions not taken, decisions deferred, capacity unused)	
The arrangements (which relationships, groups, and services do not exist for me)	

Then answer: **which column is larger, and by how much?**

Part Two: The Need and the Source (Sitting Two)

Section A: The decomposition. List what you currently require, in specific items, and match each to the source from Section 35.3.

What I require	The source (person, professional, institution, group, arrangement)	The specific form

Section B: The request I have been making. For each item, record what you have actually been asking for, and how it differs from what you require. Identify whether it is a reduced request, an inflated request, a request that transfers the load, or a request made before you could state the matter.

Section C: The barriers. From the nine barriers in Section 35.1, record the three strongest in your case, and, for each, the correction from that section and whether you accept it.

Part Three: The Requests (Sitting Three)

Section A: The four parts. Write the four parts of the request for your most important item.

- **Part one — the specific thing:**
- **Part two — the reason, in one sentence:**
- **Part three — the scale and the limit:**
- **Part four — what I will do:**

Section B: The script. Write the request in full, in the setting in which you will make it, in your own words. Then read it aloud once, and record what changed in the reading.

Section C: The dates. Record three requests with dates, in ascending order of difficulty, and the person or source for each.

The request	The source	The date
The smallest, which I can afford to have refused		
The professional appointment		
The household or the material		

Section D: The receiving. Read Section 35.6 and record the two requests, made to you in the last year, that you received badly. What did you do, and what would the four rules have produced instead?

35.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I have always managed. Why would I begin asking now?"

Because the material has established what the management has cost, and because the reader is now able to count it. The exercise's finding is consistent: the men who conduct the ledger discover that the management has been paid for in money, health, household arrangements, and deferred capacity, and that the total is substantially larger than the cost of the request they have declined to make. The chapter does not propose that the man cease to manage; it proposes that he manage with information he does not currently have.

"Asking a professional means that this is on a record. What about my position?"

The confidentiality obligations of medical and psychological practice are legal and professional requirements rather than favours, and in most settings the record is not accessible to an employer. Where the man's position is subject to specific requirements — the regulated profession, the licence, the security requirement — the correct step is advice on the requirement before the disclosure rather than the avoidance of the consultation, since the requirement frequently applies to the condition rather than to the consultation, and the man who obtains advice discovers that his position is generally narrower than he feared.

"I asked my wife and she was angry. That is why men do not ask."

The recipient's anger at a disclosure that follows a period of concealment is a common and comprehensible response, and it is generally directed at the delay rather than the material, as the case material in Chapter 34.6 establishes. The handling is the four-part form, including the acknowledgement of the delay as a fact without defence, and the supply of the arrangements that follow. The chapter's position is that a single poorly received disclosure is information about the form of the disclosure and frequently about its timing, and not a verdict on the act.

"I am afraid that if I start, I will not be able to stop."

A specific concern, and the material's answer is that the arrangement is not a release of the man's responsibilities but a structure around them. The relevant finding is from the men in the case material who have established the arrangements: their work, their households, and their standing were not altered in the direction they feared. What altered was the amount of their attention consumed by the unshared material and the number of matters that had become crises.

"What if I ask and there is nothing available?"

Then the request will have produced information: the source that is unavailable, the route that is closed, the waiting period, the cost. The chapter's material on the map is designed so that the man has more than one source per need, and the practice's finding is that men who ask find a route rather than a wall in the substantial majority of cases. Where the wall is genuine, the arrangement of Sec-

tion 35.3′s fifth source is the remaining option: the man constructs the structure, which is what Chapters 31, 33, 34, and 25 have already supplied.

"How do I ask when I am the man other men come to?"

The material of Chapter 33 applies: the man who is everyone's solution is the man least likely to ask and the man most likely to require the arrangements. The practical answer is the one the case material records: the peer group and the professional arrangement outside the man's own line, established before the requirement rather than after it, and the single request made to a person who is not dependent on him. The finding is that the first request is the most difficult and the least consequential, and that the men who make it describe it in retrospect as ordinary.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 35 in brief. Men's reluctance to ask rests on an assessment of costs that is frequently accurate and that has been conducted incompletely. Nine barriers are identified: the meaning of the act as an admission, the anticipated loss of standing, the requirement to have answers, the obligations of the man's position, the absence of any experience of being helped, the debt of gratitude and the reciprocity problem, the fear of what will be found, the earlier refusal that the man has generalised, and the instruction that a man should not need help.

The four costs of asking are assessed honestly. Standing is real in specific settings — the competitive environment, the informal exchange among men, the regulated setting with a reporting requirement, the small community, and the family arrangement in which the man's assistance has been its structure — and is anticipated and generally inaccurate in the household, the friendship, the professional consultation, the non-competitive employer, and the group. Dependence is real and is managed by the professional arrangement, the reciprocal arrangement, the stated terms, and the group. Obligation is real, is discharged by terms agreed at the time, and is frequently smaller than the account the man has already established in the other direction. Exposure is real and is the actual subject of the chapter; it is managed by the graduated form, the choice of recipient, and the professional route, and the finding that corrects the man's assessment is that the exposure of a difficulty is generally smaller than the exposure of its consequences.

Help is available in five sources: the person, the professional, the institution, the peer group, and the arrangement the man constructs himself. Men's first contact is frequently not with the form prescribed for their difficulty, and the instruction is therefore to use the route that is available and to allow the material to arrive later. Asking is a technique with four parts — the specific thing, the reason in one sentence, the scale and the limit, and what the man will himself do — and five practice forms, for a friend, a professional, an employer or institution, a household member, and a man in a position to assist. Its five errors are the vague request, the unbounded

request, the announcement, the apologetic request, and the request delivered at the worst possible moment.

The accuracy of the request determines the outcome: the reduced request is refused in the form in which it is made, the inflated request cannot be answered, the request that transfers the load imposes on a recipient who cannot place it, and the request made before the man can state the matter is legitimate in all four of its available forms. Where the reader is the man who is asked, four rules apply — receive the request in the form delivered and look beneath it, do not supply advice as the first response, state what you can give as an offer, and keep the arrangement rather than the occasion — together with two prohibitions: do not disclose the material, and do not require the man to be grateful.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the ledger in Part One. Which column is larger, and by how much, in money and in years?
2. From the nine barriers, which three are strongest in your case? For each, does the correction in Section 35.1 apply to your circumstances?
3. Complete the decomposition in Part Two, Section A. Which item has no source, and what does that indicate?
4. Identify your reduced request: what have you been asking for, and what do you actually require? Write both sentences.
5. Write the four parts and the script for your most important request. What changed when you read it aloud?
6. Record the three requests and their dates. What is the smallest request you can afford to have refused, and who will receive it?
7. Read Section 35.6. Which request made to you in the last year did you receive badly, and what would each of the four rules have changed?

Further Reading

- **On men's help-seeking:** the research literature on men's reluctance to seek help, including the findings on self-reliance, on the specific barriers men report, on the role of traditional masculine norms, and on the interventions that have been shown to increase help-seeking.
- **On the outcomes of disclosure:** the research on the disclosure of difficulties and of stigmatised conditions, including the findings on the outcomes for the discloser, the conditions under which disclosure is beneficial, and the evidence on the gap between anticipated and actual consequences.
- **On the effectiveness of help:** the literature on the outcomes of counselling, psychological treatment, and practical advice services, including the findings

on what is effective for whom, on the role of the working relationship, and on the evidence concerning early intervention.

- **On social support and assistance:** the research on received support and on its effects, including the findings on the conditions under which support is beneficial, the evidence concerning the receipt of support and self-esteem, and the material on the reciprocal arrangements that sustain support over time.
- **Practical resources:** crisis lines and emergency services; general practice and mental health services; employee assistance and occupational health services; debt counselling and financial advice; legal advice and mediation; trade and professional associations; men's groups and peer support arrangements; and the material in Appendices J and Q.

36 CHAPTER

Healing the Wounded Man

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Define healing in the terms used in this book, and distinguish it from the four things it is commonly mistaken for.
2. Conduct an inventory of the wounds he carries, in the categories that research and practice identify, and identify those that are still operating.
3. Explain the four conditions that the evidence identifies as necessary for recovery, and assess which of them he has and which are absent.
4. Describe the sequence of the work — stabilisation, the account, mourning, repair, and reconnection — and the reason the sequence matters.
5. Recognise the conditions for which professional treatment is required, and describe what the available treatments consist of, in plain terms.
6. Apply the exercise at the end of the chapter to construct the arrangements for his own recovery, with dates.

Introduction

The material in the preceding chapters has identified the wounds and the positions. This chapter concerns their repair, and its first task is a definition, because the word is used loosely and because four of its common meanings are obstacles rather than aids.

Healing, in this book, means that a wound has been given an arrangement in which it is held, and that its operation in the man's life has been reduced. It does not mean that the wound has been removed, that its consequences have been reversed, or that the man has ceased to carry it. It means that the wound no longer determines his conduct, his relationships, his judgement, and his household's arrangements in the manner described in the preceding parts of this book, and that the man has a place to put it.

The consequences of this definition are worth setting out at the beginning.

It is achievable. Men who find the word *healing* difficult because it appears to promise a condition they do not believe in should note that the definition concerns operation and not removal. The standard is not the absence of the wound; it is the reduction of what the wound does.

It is measurable. The operation of a wound can be observed: in the man's sleep, temper, drinking, avoidance, judgement, and conduct toward the people closest to him. A reduction is therefore not a matter of the man's opinion, and the exercise at the end of the chapter supplies the measures.

It requires arrangements rather than resolve. The book's central mechanism applies in full: a wound that has no arrangement operates somewhere, and the four conditions of Section 36.4 are the available arrangements rather than a description of an attitude.

It takes years and it begins in weeks. The two statements are both true and are not in conflict. The work has an identifiable sequence whose first steps can be taken within a week; the material's full conduct occupies a period measured in years, and the men who have conducted it describe the change in decade terms: not the year in which the material stopped, but the years in which its operation reduced.

The chapter's approach has four commitments.

The first is that the material must be approached in the sequence the evidence supplies. The chapters of this book have been arranged to that end: the practical arrangements of Part IV, the household material of Part V, the identity material of Part VI, the social material of Part VII, the loss material of Part VIII, the load material of Part IX, and the safety material of the preceding chapter. A man who attempts the mourning of a loss before the safety of his position is established will frequently surface the material and then withdraw from it, which produces the second concealment described in Chapter 9.

The second is that the process is conducted in the man's own form. Chapter 30.2 established the legitimate forms of a man's grieving; the same finding applies here. The conditions of Section 36.4 can be met through arrangements as various as the written account, the physical work, the group of men, the professional relationship, the trade association, the mentorship of a younger man, the arrangements of the household, and the conduct described in Chapter 29.6.

The third is that the reader should be told plainly what requires a professional. Section 36.6 supplies the conditions and the treatments, and the chapter takes the position that a man's refusal of professional treatment for a condition that requires it is not a form of strength but an arrangement with a known cost, borne principally by the people who depend on him.

The fourth is that recovery is not a private achievement. The evidence on recovery is consistent on this point and the case material in this book is consistent

with it: the men who recover are overwhelmingly the men who had arrangements — one person, one group, one professional, one household that knew the position, one thing to build. A man's recovery is frequently the work of several people, and the chapter's practical task is the construction of the arrangements rather than the improvement of the man's solitary resolve.

36.1 The Wounds Men Carry

This section is an inventory, and its purpose is that the reader can identify what is still operating before selecting the work. The categories are drawn from the research and the practice literature and are presented in plain terms.

The Ten Categories

1. The wounds of childhood. The absence of attention; the harsh or unpredictable parent; the parent who was present and unwell; the violence in the household; the sexual or physical abuse; the humiliation; the poverty that required the man to work from an early age; the parentification described in Chapter 19; the separation or the death of a parent; the household's treatment of one child as the problem. The category's feature is that its effects are frequently invisible to the man because the household's arrangements were normal to him.

2. The wounds of violence. The man as the victim of violence in adulthood: the assault, the robbery, the armed attack, the police or institutional violence, the violence in a conflict, the violence in a marriage or by a partner, the violence at work. The category carries the injury's physical consequences and the material described in the research on traumatic exposure: the intrusion of the event, the avoidance of the setting, the hypervigilance, the alteration of the man's assessment of his safety and his world.

3. The wounds of humiliation. The specific category in the research on men and shame: the public degradation; the failure in front of the men whose regard mattered; the position lost; the man's body, speech, or status mocked at a formative age; the family's arrangement that made him the object; the treatment at an institution. Its feature is that it operates through the man's conduct in the setting rather than through his memory of the event, and its consequences are those of Chapters 8 and 21.

4. The wounds of betrayal. The material of Chapter 26: the confidences used, the trusts broken, the abandonments, the parent who left, the partner's conduct, the colleague's betrayal, the institution's conduct toward a man who had served it. The category's specific feature is the alteration of the man's general model of other people, which is the reason the correction requires evidence rather than argument.

5. The wounds of loss. The deaths and separations of Chapter 30 and the losses of Chapter 28. The category includes the losses whose acknowledgement was not available, which are the ones the chapter's work most frequently concerns.

6. The wounds of failure. The business lost, the position removed, the examination failed, the man's own conduct that produced a consequence for his household or for others. This category overlaps with the material of Chapters 25 and 29 and its feature is the man's own participation, which is what makes it resistant to the form of healing that requires the man to be a victim of circumstance.

7. The wounds of the position. The material of Part IX: the decisions that harmed people, the material of forty people received and never placed, the man's own conduct while carrying a load he could not support — the severity, the drinking, the neglect of his household. The category is identified in leadership practice and occupational health and its feature is that the man's responsibility is real and the arrangement is absent.

8. The wounds of the household. The man's own conduct as a husband and father: the years of absence, the severity, the marriage that failed, the child who is estranged, the disclosures the household made and the man did not receive. This category is the material of Parts III and V, and its inclusion here is deliberate: a man's own conduct is a wound he carries, and the work on it is Chapter 29's.

9. The wounds of the body. The injury, the disability, the chronic condition, the illness, the loss of the man's physical capacity, the material of Chapter 32.7 in its wider form. The category carries the man's relation to his own body and to the position his body supplied, and its treatment is described in Chapter 32.3's first measure.

10. The wound of the man's whole account of himself. The specific category that the book has identified repeatedly: the conclusion the man has formed about himself. It may be the material of Chapter 8's core belief, Chapter 21's private account, Chapter 24's lost identity, or Chapter 25's accepted verdict. Its feature is that it operates as the frame through which all the other categories are interpreted, and its work is the reconstruction described in Chapters 24 and 25.

What the Inventory Produces

Four outputs, and each is required before the work of Section 36.4 can be conducted.

The identification of what is still operating. A wound that is not operating requires no work; a wound that is operating must be identified. Its markers are the ones used throughout this book: the sleep, the temper, the avoidance, the drinking, the attention, the specific subject that cannot be raised, the specific setting that is declined, the man's own account of his conduct toward his household.

The identification of the categories, which determines the work. The categories are not interchangeable. Betrayal requires the material of Chapter 26.5. Loss requires Chapter 30's arrangements. Failure requires Chapter 25's measure and the moral material of Chapter 29. Violence and traumatic exposure require the professional route of Section 36.6. Humiliation requires the reconstruction of the man's account of himself, which is Chapter 21's work.

The identification of the sequence. Where several categories are present, the work is ordered: the safety and stability first, then the material that is most available, then the material that requires support. The ordering matters and its principle is supplied in Section 36.4.

The identification of what requires a professional. The categories of Section 36.6 — traumatic exposure, depression that has not lifted, the material connected to substances, the material of Chapter 34.3's first category — should be referred to the professional route at this point rather than after the man has attempted the private work. The finding from practice is consistent: the man who attempts the traumatic material without support generally surfaces it and then withdraws, which produces the position described in Chapter 9 and frequently the conclusion that the work does not help.

> **KEY POINT**
> The wounds men carry fall into ten categories: childhood, violence, humiliation, betrayal, loss, failure, the position, the household, the body, and the man's whole account of himself. The inventory's function is to identify what is still operating, which categories determine the work, the sequence in which the work proceeds, and what requires a professional. A wound that is not operating does not require work, and a man should not conduct an inventory of his history in order to produce a conclusion about himself.

36.2 What Healing Is Not

Seven misconceptions operate in men's material on this subject, and each prevents the work by setting a standard that cannot be met.

The Seven Misconceptions

1. Healing is forgetting. A man who believes this will measure his progress by the material's absence, and the material's recurrence — which is the ordinary course of memory — will be read as failure. The accurate position: the material remains and its operation reduces. Chapter 30.2's finding on continuing bonds applies: the goal is not the removal of the connection but its integration into the man's arrangements.

2. Time heals. The statement is partly true and it is dangerous in the form in which it is used, because the man's conclusion is that no work is required. The

accurate position: time assists when the wound has an arrangement and assists considerably less when it has none, which is the finding on prolonged grief in Chapter 30.7 and on the persistence of the material in Chapter 29.3. A wound with no arrangement frequently becomes more established with time, because the arrangements around it — the household's account of the man, the compensations, the avoidance, the identity — acquire their own structure.

3. Healing means becoming a different kind of man. The instruction that a man's recovery requires him to become expressive, soft, available, or verbal in a form that is not his. The accurate position: the forms of the work are varied, as Chapter 30.2 established, and the objective is the man's arrangements and the reduction of the wound's operation. A man who is not a talker can conduct this work through the written account, the physical form, the group with a defined purpose, and the conduct of Chapters 29 and 30.

4. Healing requires forgiveness. The material on forgiveness in Chapters 16, 26, and 29 applies. The accurate position: the release of the account and the repair of the man's own obligations are the man's work; the injured party's forgiveness and the resumption of the relationship are separate matters; and a man may conduct the whole of his recovery with the wrong unrepaired in the other party's hands.

5. The single breakthrough. The expectation that the material will be resolved by one conversation, one appointment, one disclosure, one insight. The expectation is a product of the culture's accounts of recovery, and its operation in practice is that the man conducts the first step, finds that the material remains, and concludes that the work failed. The accurate position: the work proceeds in stages with relapses, as Section 36.5 sets out, and the change is measured over years rather than occasions.

6. The permanent reduction of the man's capacity. The belief that healing requires the man to accept a reduced version of himself: less decisive, less capable, less ambitious, permanently marked. The accurate position is the opposite in the case material: the men who conduct the work report an increase in capacity, because the attention that was occupied and the judgement that was degraded are returned, and because the arrangements of Chapters 31, 33, and 35 make the man more effective rather than less.

7. The requirement to be grateful for what the wound taught. The instruction that a man should find the benefit in what was done to him. The instruction is applied by well-intentioned people, and its operation is that the man's own account of the harm is not permitted. The accurate position: some consequences of a hard experience are real — the competence, the caution, the capacity to endure — and the man is not required to regard the harm as beneficial in order to retain them.

The Effect of the Misconceptions

The seven share a common mechanism: each sets a standard that the work cannot meet and therefore converts the man's ordinary course into evidence of failure. The man who expects forgetting reads the material's return as a setback; the man who expects a breakthrough reads the absence of resolution as a failed treatment; the man who expects a reduced self declines to begin, because the price appears to be his capacity.

The chapter's practical instruction is therefore that the reader should select a measure that the work can actually produce, and the following five are the ones used in the practice material.

The measures:

- a reduction in the frequency with which the material arrives unbidden;
- the availability of a person who knows the material;
- the absence of the material's operation in the observed places — the sleep, the temper, the drinking, the avoidance;
- the man's ability to describe the material without managing the room;
- the reduction of the material's cost to the man's household.

Each of the five is observable, none requires the wound's removal, and all five are within reach of the arrangements in Section 36.4.

36.3 The Four Conditions of Recovery

The research and the practice literature identify four conditions that are consistent across the settings in which recovery occurs, and the chapter presents them as arrangements rather than as attitudes.

Condition One: Safety and Stability

What it is. The material must be addressed from a position that can hold it. The condition has four components: the man's physical safety, which concerns violence, the immediate risk, and the settings in which he is not safe; his basic stability, which concerns sleep, food, shelter, medical care, and the material of Chapter 34.5; the absence of the immediate emergencies of Chapters 22, 23, and 34 — an active addiction, a financial collapse in progress, a risk to life; and the availability of at least one arrangement that can hold what the man will surface.

Why it comes first. The evidence on recovery is consistent: the material should not be surfaced before there is somewhere for it to go. The mechanism is practical: a man who opens the material without an arrangement will experience the material's full intensity, will have no place to put it, and will do what any person does in that position — close it again, generally more tightly, which produces the position described in Chapter 9 and which frequently produces the conclusion that the work is dangerous.

What it means for the reader. Chapters 18 to 23 are conducted first where the man's position includes an active addition, a financial emergency, a risk to life, a marriage in acute crisis, or a recent bereavement. This is the sequencing principle of the whole book, and it is the reason the book's structure places the material as it does.

Condition Two: The Account

What it is. The material must be described, in a form that the man can produce, and the description must be available to at least one recipient beyond the man. The forms: the written account of Chapters 29.6 and 30.6; the spoken account to a witness or a professional; the account conducted in a group; the account rendered as the record of Chapter 25.3; the account constructed with the assistance of the professional in the structured forms used in treatment.

Why it matters. The research on the operation of memory for difficult material identifies the mechanism: an event that has not been described in language is frequently held in the form of sensory fragments, physiological responses, and generalised associations, and its representation in language is what allows it to be situated in the man's past and distinguished from his present. This is the reason that a man's material arrives as a physical state, a mood that appears without a cause, a specific fear, or an image, and the reason its description in words changes its operation.

The specific note for men. The account does not require the man's feeling to be narrated. The description of what occurred, in sequence, with the facts, is the operative element. Men who believe that they cannot describe the material because they cannot describe their feelings about it should note that the feeling is not the required content.

Condition Three: Mourning and the Conduct of What Was Lost

What it is. The material has a cost, and the cost requires acknowledgement. The forms are those of Chapter 30.6 and Chapter 13: the acknowledgement of what was lost, the marking of the loss, the conduct of the grief in the man's own form, and the incorporation of the loss into the man's account of his life.

Why it matters. The material on loss and on the adaptation to irreversible circumstances is consistent: the reduction in the wound's operation is associated with the man's acknowledgement of the loss's actual size, and the failure to acknowledge it is associated with the prolongation of the material and with the compensations described in Chapter 29.7. The man who has not mourned the loss may not conduct anything else, because the material remains invested in the maintenance of an account in which the loss has not been counted.

The conduct of losses that were not acknowledged. The categories of Chapter 30.1 are the chapter's most frequent material: the loss with no occasion,

the shared dream that ended, the child lost before birth, the friend whose death nobody in the man's household knew about. Each requires the four elements of Chapter 30.4: the place, the visit, the account, and the witness.

Condition Four: Reconnection and the Construction of the Life

What it is. The work's final condition, and the one that determines whether the material becomes a place in the man's life or a project in its own right. Its components: the man's re-engagement with the arrangements of an ordinary life — work, household, relationships, the community, the future — in a form that includes the material rather than requiring it to be resolved first; the construction of the arrangements of Chapter 27; the undertaking of the measures of Chapters 24, 25, and 28; and the deliberate conduct of what the man has identified as owed.

Why it matters. The finding from the practice literature and from the case material is consistent: recovery is not completed in the material but in the man's reconnection. The men whose recovery holds are the men who, at some point in the process, took up something — the arrangement, the responsibility, the work, the mentorship, the measure — that required them and that was not the material. This is the reason that the material of Chapter 28.6, Chapter 29.6′s element four, and Chapter 33.6′s arrangements are the substance of recovery rather than an appendix to it.

The four conditions are set out in Figure 36.1, with the chapters that supply the arrangements for each and the markers by which the reader can assess whether a condition is in place.

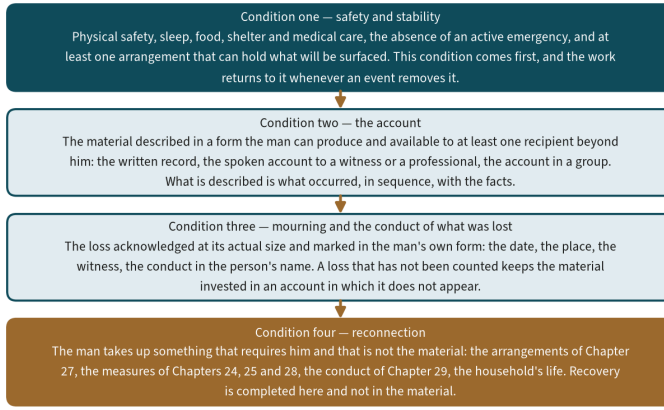


Figure 36.1 The four conditions of recovery, their sequence, and the arrangements that supply each. The diagram is conceptual; the conditions are not achieved once and held, and a man may need to return to the first column after an event that removes his stability.

36.4 The Sequence and the Work

The work has a sequence, and the sequence is supplied by the four conditions of the previous section. This section describes the stages, the durations, and the relapses.

The Five Stages

Stage One: The stabilisation. Duration: weeks to months. What is conducted: the material of Chapter 34′s assessment and safety plan where it applies; the immediate practical emergencies, including the financial, the medical, and the addiction-related; the sleep; the arrangements of Chapter 27.5, at least to the level of one recipient and one professional or group; the household's arrangements where the man's conduct is affecting it. The stage's marker: the man can state where his material goes and can name the person or the arrangement.

Stage Two: The account. Duration: months. What is conducted: the account in its written and spoken forms; the witness; the inventory of Chapter 36.1; the identification of the categories and the sequence; and, where the material requires it, the professional arrangement's structured work. The stage's marker: the man has described the material in full to one recipient and has a written version that he has produced himself.

Stage Three: The mourning and the repair. Duration: months to years. What is conducted: the mourning arrangements of Chapter 30.6 for each loss identified; the repairs of Chapter 29.5 for each wrong the man has identified as his own; the work of Chapters 26 and 33 where the material concerns relationships and obligations; and the correction of the record, which is frequently the most consequential element — the correction of the household's account of the man, the correction of the man's own account of himself, and the supply of the information that the arranged consequences require.

Stage Four: The reconstruction. Duration: years. What is conducted: the identity work of Chapter 24 where a role has been lost; the measure of Chapter 25.5 where the man's account of his worth rests on results; the measures of Chapter 28.6 for the dreams that were set down; the arrangements of Chapters 31, 33, and 35 for the load and the asking; and the construction of what the man will do with the years remaining.

Stage Five: The reconnection and the maintenance. Duration: continuous. What is conducted: the arrangements maintained rather than completed — the professional relationship where it continues, the group, the peer arrangement, the household's meeting, the dates of Chapter 30.6, the measures of Chapter 25.5, and the review described in Chapter 29.6′s element five. The stage's marker: the arrangements exist without the man's having to construct them again after each difficulty.

The Three Findings About the Sequence

The stages are conducted in parallel as well as in sequence. A man stabilises while he writes; he mourns while he reconstructs; the repairs continue after the reconnection. The sequence is a principle of priority rather than a timetable.

The sequence is frequently reversed by circumstance, and this is not a failure. The bereavement, the redundancy, the illness, the collapse of a business, or the loss of a relationship removes the man's stability and returns him to Stage One, and the return is normal. The finding from practice is that the return is shorter each time, because the arrangements have been constructed once and can be reoccupied.

The work is not conducted alone. Every stage requires at least one person beyond the man, and the arrangements are the mechanism. The chapter repeats the point because it is the finding that the case material supports most strongly: the men who conduct the work with the arrangements recover; the men who attempt it alone surface the material and return to the concealment.

The Relapses

The word is used deliberately, and its meaning should be distinguished from the sense in which it is used in Chapter 23.

The material's return. The account has been constructed, the arrangements exist, and the material returns — at an anniversary, at a milestone, in response to a trigger, in a low period. The return is the ordinary course of the material and not evidence of failure. The handling: the arrangements are reoccupied, the material is described to the recipient, the date of Chapter 30.6 is observed, and the man continues with the conduct of the following day.

The withdrawal from the arrangements. The man stops attending, stops writing, stops calling, and the material resumes its operation. The handling: the arrangements are treated as requirements rather than as responses to the man's state, which is the reason the practice material prescribes the fixed time. The finding is that the fixed time is the element that saves the arrangement during the periods in which the man does not wish to attend.

The resumption of the compensating conduct. The drinking, the work, the risk, the spending, the screens. Chapter 22′s material applies; the finding specific to this chapter is that the resumption should be treated as information about the man's state rather than as a moral failure, and that it frequently indicates that the sequence has moved too fast or that a stage has been attempted without the support that it requires.

The Duration

The chapter supplies the answer plainly because men's expectations on the subject are the cause of a substantial proportion of the abandoned work.

The first change — the reduction in the material's unbidden arrival, the availability of a recipient, the improvement in the sleep — is generally reported within three to six months of the arrangements' establishment. The substantial change — the alteration of the man's conduct toward his household, the reduction of the material's operation in the observed places, the change in the man's account of himself — is generally reported at one to three years. The man's own account of the whole, offered in retrospect, is generally in decades: *I was twenty years carrying it and it took about four years to put it down.*

The men who abandon the work do so overwhelmingly in the first six months, before the first change has appeared, and their reason is generally the absence of the change they expected. The chapter's instruction on this point is therefore the most useful sentence it contains: **the first measure of progress is the existence of the arrangements and not the state of the man.** A man who has established the recipient, the professional, the group, the written account, and the household's arrangements has conducted the work's first two stages regardless of how he feels on the day.

36.5 When Professional Treatment Is Required

The chapter states the conditions and the treatments in plain terms, and it takes the position recorded in the introduction: where a condition requires treatment, the man's refusal of treatment is an arrangement with a known cost, borne principally by the people who depend on him.

The Six Conditions

1. Traumatic exposure with continuing symptoms. The intrusion of an event — the images, the nightmares, the physical responses, the flashbacks; the avoidance of the settings associated with it; the hypervigilance, the startle response, the disturbed sleep, the irritability. Where these have persisted beyond about a month and are affecting the man's functioning, the assessment is required, and the treatment for the specific condition is established and effective.

2. Depression that has not lifted. The persistent lowering of mood, the loss of interest, the alteration of sleep and appetite, the fatigue, the difficulty in concentration, the sense of worthlessness, and the material of Chapter 34.3′s first category. The assessment is required where the pattern has persisted for weeks, where it is impairing the man's functioning, or where the man's own conclusion is that nothing can be altered.

3. Anxiety, panic, and the physical presentations. The panic attacks, the persistent worry, the physical symptoms that have been investigated without a physical cause, the avoidance that has reduced the man's life. The conditions are treatable and the treatments are structured and brief in many cases.

4. Substance and behavioural dependence. The material of Chapters 22 and 23, and particularly where the man's own attempts have produced the pattern of Chapter 23.6: the reduction followed by the return. The treatment is established, and the finding from practice is that the man's own attempts are frequently the reason the material's severity is underestimated — a dependence that has required several attempts at control is generally a dependence that requires treatment.

5. The consequences of severe or prolonged adversity in childhood. The material of category one in Section 36.1: the persistent difficulty in relationships, the man's account of himself, the difficulty in regulating states, the pattern of the man's own conduct that he does not understand. The treatment is available in the forms developed for this material, and the finding is that the conditions are treatable and are frequently untreated because men do not present.

6. The material of Chapter 34.3′s first category, at any point. The risk to the man's own life requires immediate assessment, and the chapter repeats the instruction of Chapter 34.5 without qualification.

What the Treatments Consist Of

The following descriptions are supplied in plain terms, and the reader should note that the specific treatment is a matter for the practitioner's assessment.

The talking treatments with the strongest evidence base. Cognitive behavioural therapy, which examines the relation between the man's interpretations of events and his state, and which is structured, time-limited, and oriented to specific difficulties. Trauma-focused treatments, which address the traumatic material directly by established procedures that allow the material to be described and situated without its being relived at full intensity, and which are the treatments of choice where traumatic exposure is the principal matter. Interpersonal treatments, which address the man's difficulties in his relationships and in his conduct of the roles described in Parts III to V of this book. The treatments for substance dependence, which combine the behavioural work of Chapter 22 with assessment of the related conditions and with the supports of Chapter 23.

Medication. For specific conditions — the moderate and severe depressions, the anxiety conditions, and others — the practitioner may recommend medication alongside or before the talking treatment. The relevant findings for the reader: the medication is a treatment of the condition and not a substitute for the arrangements; the effect is generally apparent in weeks rather than days; the man should not discontinue it on his own; and the practitioner's monitoring is a component of the treatment.

The setting. Treatment is delivered through the general practitioner, a hospital or clinic's mental health service, a private practitioner, an employee assistance

programme, a specialist service for a specific matter — the addiction, the trauma, the bereavement — or a service for a specific group. Appendix Q of this book supplies the routes by category, and the general practitioner is the entry point where the man is uncertain.

The Two Notes for Men

The conditions are ordinary and the treatments are effective. The material that requires treatment is neither a consequence of the man's character nor a permanent state. The research on outcomes is consistent: the conditions are common, they respond to treatment, and the earlier the treatment the better the outcome.

The barriers men report are the barriers the arrangements are designed to address. The concern about the record, the position, the standing, and the disclosure is addressed by the confidentiality obligations of professional practice, by the routes that can be taken outside the man's setting, and by the practical material of Chapters 31 to 35. A man is not required to choose between his position and his treatment, and the finding from practice is that the choice appears artificial once the arrangements have been examined.

36.6 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Still There

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in mental health services, occupational health, and family practice.

Chukwuemeka, called Emeka, is forty-nine, a security supervisor at a large market complex, married to Nkechi for twenty-one years, with three children aged twenty, seventeen, and eleven.

The material at the centre of the case occurred in 2005, when Emeka was thirty, and it consisted of an armed robbery at a filling station in which he had been working as an attendant.

Emeka's account of the incident, given in the professional arrangement, was as follows: four men arrived at about nine in the evening, one remained at the entrance, and two entered the office. Emeka was on the forecourt and was struck on the head with the butt of a weapon and left on the ground. His colleague, a man named Uche, aged twenty-three, who was in the office, was shot and died at the scene. Emeka was hospitalised for three days for the head injury, attended the funeral, was interviewed by the police, gave evidence at a trial two years later, and returned to work at a different filling station within a month.

His description of the period that followed: *I did not sleep in a bed for two years. I slept sitting up with the light on. I told my family that it was the injury. My mother told me to pray about it, and I stopped mentioning it, because I did not want to be a man who was crying about something that was finished. Uche's mother came to the*

house three times in the first year and after that she stopped, and I have seen her in the market twice in nineteen years and I have walked the other way both times.

The material's pattern over nineteen years, in Emeka's own account and in the record of the service that eventually saw him, was as follows.

The sleep. The disturbed sleep, which persisted with variation for the whole period, with periods of relief. The man described the specific finding: *I could not sleep in the dark for the first three years, and for the next fifteen I could not sleep on the side of the bed nearer the door.*

The hypervigilance. The man's conduct at his work, which was in security and which meant that the pattern was organised into his professional life. He was, in his own words, *the best man the company ever had at the gate*: he knew the vehicles, the routines, the small details, and he was unable to relax during any period of duty. His account: *I have been watching doors for nineteen years. The company thinks it is the personality. I have never been able to sit with my back to an entrance, and I have not been in that filling station's road since 2010.*

The avoidance. The filling station's road, the two encounters with Uche's mother, the subject of the incident, the subject of Uche, and the funeral arrangements of colleagues, which the man avoided for years with explanations about the shift.

The anger at home. The specific pattern in the household, recounted by Nkechi in a family consultation: the man's sudden and disproportionate rages, triggered by the children's coming in late, by a door left open, by a noise in the compound at night. Her account: *He would be calm and in the next minute he would be shouting about the gate. The children learned to come in before six. He was never like that before we married and I have never understood it and I do not ask him anything about that time any more.*

The alcohol. The man's drinking, which began as a means of sleeping and which had, by the tenth year, become a nightly pattern of about four to six units, with the increase in the years of the trials and the anniversary.

The presentation. Emeka was referred by the employer's occupational health service at forty-nine after two matters: a period of four months of reduced sleep and increased alcohol following the death of a colleague in a road accident, and an episode at the market's gate in which the man had intervened in a confrontation between traders, had been struck, and had experienced a period afterwards of several hours in which he could not remember where he was and believed he was at the filling station. The second matter was the one that produced the referral, and Emeka's own description of it was: *I was twenty-nine years old in my own head. I was on the ground and I could hear the shot and I could not get up.*

The treatment, conducted over fourteen months, had five elements.

The assessment and the diagnosis. The assessment identified the symptoms of long-standing traumatic exposure, together with a moderate depressive episode and a harmful pattern of alcohol use. The practitioner's description, recorded with permission and used in the case with details altered, was: *A man who has been at the scene of a killing for nineteen years, who has organised his entire professional conduct*

around predicting the repeat, who has never described what happened to a single person, and who has been treating the alarm as a feature of his personality.

The stabilisation. The first two months were directed to the sleep, the alcohol, and the safety arrangements of the working setting, together with the establishment of the treatment relationship itself. Emeka described the period: *I was expecting that he would want to talk about the night and the first two months were entirely about the sleeping and the drinking and my shift. In the ninth week I told him that I had not said anything about the night and he said, we are not there yet, and I understood that somebody was holding the thing.*

The trauma-focused treatment. The work on the incident was conducted over about four months in a structured form, with the man describing the event and its elements in a sequence, in the session, at a pace set by him, together with the work on the man's interpretations of his own conduct. Emeka described the element of the work that mattered most: *The man asked me, in about the fourth month, what I believed I should have done at the gate in nine seconds with a head injury and two men armed, and I told him that I should have reached Uche, and he asked me to describe how that would have been done. I could not describe it. I sat there and I could not describe it, and then he asked me whether anybody else at the filling station had reached the office. I said no. He asked me whether Uche had been in the office with the door closed. I said yes. She was inside and the door was closed and I could not have been inside in the time. I had never once said that sentence in nineteen years because I had never let anybody ask me the question.*

The alcohol work. Conducted in parallel with the structured work of Chapter 22: the removal of the cue, the substitution, and the arrangements. The man's sleep improved as the work progressed and the drinking reduced to occasional use by the eighth month.

The repairs and the conduct. The elements that the man identified as the ones that altered his life, and they were conducted in the ninth to the fourteenth months. He gave his account to Nkechi in full, in a conversation that occupied an evening, with the four parts of Chapter 34.6: *She said the thing I did not expect. She said, so it is not the children. She had been carrying nineteen years of believing that I had become a man who was angry with his family, and the explanation had been in front of her the whole time.* He then visited Uche's mother, in the eleventh month, with his account and with an arrangement: a monthly contribution and a visit. His description: *She said she had waited for me. She said she had not understood why I had stopped coming and that she had thought that I had blamed her son for the night, and I told her what had actually happened and that I had blamed myself and that I had not been able to sit in her house. I go every month now. She is seventy-four.*

Emeka's summary, at the end of the treatment, was: *I was thirty years old on that forecourt and for nineteen years I was still there. I could not have done it without the man in the room asking me what I had been certain about. I was certain that I could have reached her. I have said the sentence about the closed door and the nine seconds out loud and I know what happened now. I sleep in the dark and I sleep on the side near*

> *the door. I go to Uche's mother's house. My children come in at night and I do not shout about the gate. My wife knows what it is. I am forty-nine years old and I have been a guard for twenty years and I am still careful, and I am careful for the right reason now, which is the job and not the night.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The material had been carried for nineteen years without a single disclosure. The man had attended the funeral, given evidence at a trial, returned to work, married, raised three children, and never described the event to anybody. The case is included because the material in this category is frequently held for decades and because the man's own conduct — the functioning, the competence, the household — supplies no indication that a disclosure is required.

The symptoms had been organised into the man's professional life. The hypervigilance, the watchfulness, the inability to sit with his back to an entrance, and the exceptional performance in a security role. The case is included because this is the specific mechanism described in the research on traumatic exposure in men: the symptoms are frequently functional in the man's occupation and are therefore rewarded rather than identified.

The household had constructed an account and the account was wrong in the man's own conduct. *He was never like that before we married and I have never understood it and I do not ask him anything about that time any more*, and the discovery that the household's explanation was that the man had become angry with his family. This is the material of Chapter 34.6′s third part in its most consequential form, and the case is included because the correction of the household's account was, in the man's own order of significance, the most important element of the treatment.

The premise at the centre of the material was a belief about the man's own conduct, and it was never tested. *I could have reached her.* The case is included because this is the finding that the structured work on trauma and the work of Chapter 29 both identify: the material's persistence is frequently maintained not by the event but by a conclusion the man has drawn about his own conduct and has never been required to describe. The practitioner's questions — how would it have been done, who else reached the office, was the door closed — are ordinary questions about a conclusion that had been held for nineteen years without examination.

The recovery was conducted with the arrangements and not by the man alone. The treatment relationship, the practitioner's work, the alcohol treatment, the household's disclosure, and the repair with the bereaved mother. The case is included as the chapter's clearest illustration of the sequence and the conditions:

the stability first, the account second, the mourning and the repair third, and the reconnection — the monthly visit, the household's arrangements, the sleep on the side near the door — as the last and continuing element.

36.7 Practical Exercise: The Inventory, the Conditions, and the Plan

This exercise takes about three hours, over four sittings, and it is the longest in this part of the book. Sections A and B should be conducted before the plan, and the plan should not be conducted alone if the material surfaced in the inventory is substantial.

Part One: The Inventory (Sitting One)

For each of the ten categories in Section 36.1, record what applies, with the date, and — the operative question — **whether it is still operating**, judged by the markers used in this book: the sleep, the temper, the drinking, the avoidance, the attention, the specific subject that cannot be raised, the specific setting that is declined, and the man's own conduct toward his household.

Category	What applies	Date	Still operating?	The evidence
Childhood				
Violence				
Humiliation				
Betrayal				
Loss				
Failure				
The position				
The household (my own conduct)				
The body				
My account of myself				

Then answer four questions.

- Which single category is operating most strongly, and where is it operating? (Be specific: the hour, the setting, the person, the conduct.)
- Which of the categories belongs to the professional route of Section 36.5?
- What has the operation cost in the last three years — in money, health, the household, and my own conduct?
- What have I done about it, and what has that produced?

Part Two: The Conditions (Sitting Two)

The condition	In place?	The evidence	What is absent
Safety and stability			
The account			
Mourning and the conduct of what was lost			
Reconnection and the construction of the life			

From the components of Condition One, record specifically: my physical safety; my sleep, food, and medical care; the presence of any active emergency from Chapters 22, 23, or 34; and the availability of at least one arrangement that can hold what I will surface.

Do not proceed to the plan if Condition One is absent. The plan's first items are the arrangements that supply it.

Part Three: The Misconceptions (Sitting Two, Continued)

From the seven misconceptions in Section 36.2, record which you hold, in your own words — the sentence your own mind uses. Then select from the five measures the ones you will use to judge the work.

- **My measure one:**
- **My measure two:**
- **My measure three:**

Part Four: The Plan (Sittings Three and Four)

Section A: The stage I am in. From the five stages of Section 36.4, record the stage and the evidence.

Section B: The arrangements. Specify each with a date.

The arrangement	The specific form	The date
The recipient (the one person who will know)		
The professional arrangement (if required by Section 36.5)		
The group		
The written account		
The mourning arrangements (Chapter 30.6)		
The repairs (Chapter 29.5)		
The household's arrangements		
The conduct (Chapter 29.6's element four)		

Section C: The sequence. Record what will be conducted first, second, and third, and the reason — the sequence principle of Section 36.4.

Section D: The maintenance. Record the fixed times: the professional arrangement's interval, the group's date, the mourning date of Chapter 30.6, the family meeting, and the review. The fixed time is the element that survives the periods in which you do not wish to attend.

Section E: The relapse plan. Write the three relapses of Section 36.4 in your own terms and the handling for each: the material's return, my withdrawal from the arrangements, and the resumption of the compensating conduct.

36.8 Common Questions Men Ask

"I have managed for thirty years. Why would I open this now?"

Because the material is operating whether or not it is opened, and because the marks of that operation are generally available to the reader in his own conduct: the sleep, the temper, the avoidance, the drinking, and — the element men report most heavily on examination — the household's arrangements, which have been constructed around a state that the household cannot explain. The case material in this chapter and in Chapter 34 records the outcome of the work in men of this age and older, and the finding is consistent: the material is addressable, the arrangements are constructible, and the household's position changes.

"What if the treatment makes it worse?"

The concern is legitimate and the evidence addresses it: the treatments with the strongest record for traumatic material are conducted in a structured sequence in which the material is prepared for before it is addressed, and the preparation is the reason the treatment is effective. The risk that the material will worsen is associated with surfacing it without the arrangements, which is the reason the chapter places the stabilisation first and the reason it directs the traumatic material to a professional rather than to private work.

"I do not want to talk about my childhood."

Then the material of the childhood may be conducted in a form other than the narrative: the written account, the work with a professional who sets the pace, the structured treatments that address the man's present difficulties and his patterns rather than the childhood's narrative, and the arrangements of Chapter 33 where the material concerns obligations. The chapter's position is that the man's own account does not have to be delivered to anybody, but that the material's operation must have an arrangement.

"My household has been living with this for years. Can I say anything now?"

The material of Chapter 34.6 applies directly, including the four-part form and the handling of the recipient's response to the delay. The finding from the case material is that the household's account of the period is generally inaccurate and generally worse than the material, and that the disclosure is frequently received as

an explanation the household has been waiting for. The man should also expect the household's own position to require its own arrangements, which is the material of Chapter 36's Condition Four.

"Is my material serious enough for treatment?"

The question is answered by Section 36.5's six conditions rather than by any comparison of the man's material with somebody else's. Where any of the six applies, the assessment is required; where the man is uncertain, the general practitioner is the route; and where the man's material is less severe than he had assumed, the assessment will have established that and supplied the arrangements that are appropriate.

"How long does recovery take?"

The first change in three to six months; the substantial change in one to three years; the man's own account of the whole, in retrospect, in decade terms. The finding that matters for the reader is the one at the end of Section 36.4: the first measure of progress is the existence of the arrangements rather than the state of the man, and a man who has established the recipient, the professional, the group, the account, and the household's arrangements has conducted the work's first stages regardless of how he feels in the month in which he reads this chapter.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 36 in brief. Healing means that a wound has been given an arrangement in which it is held and that its operation in the man's life has been reduced. It does not mean that the wound is removed. The consequences of the definition are that the standard is achievable, that it is measurable in the man's sleep, temper, drinking, avoidance, judgement, and conduct toward his household, that it requires arrangements rather than resolve, and that it takes years while beginning within weeks.

The wounds men carry fall into ten categories: childhood, violence, humiliation, betrayal, loss, failure, the position, the household, the body, and the man's whole account of himself. The inventory's function is to identify what is still operating, which categories determine the work, the sequence in which the work proceeds, and what requires a professional. Seven misconceptions obstruct the work — that healing is forgetting, that time heals, that it requires a different kind of man, that it requires forgiveness, that a single breakthrough will supply it, that it requires the permanent reduction of the man's capacity, and that the man must be grateful for what the wound taught — and each sets a standard the work cannot meet. Five measures are supplied instead, in place of those standards.

Four conditions are necessary, and they are arrangements rather than attitudes: safety and stability, which comes first because material should not be surfaced without somewhere for it to go; the account, which must be described in a form the man can produce and available to at least one recipient, and in which the description of what occurred rather than of the man's feelings is the operative element; mourning

and the conduct of what was lost, without which the material remains invested in an account in which the loss has not been counted; and reconnection, in which the man takes up something that requires him and that is not the material. The work proceeds in five stages — stabilisation, the account, mourning and repair, reconstruction, and reconnection and maintenance — and the stages are conducted in parallel as well as in sequence. The sequence is frequently reversed by circumstance, and the return to the first stage is normal and becomes shorter each time.

Professional treatment is required for six conditions: traumatic exposure with continuing symptoms, depression that has not lifted, anxiety and panic and the physical presentations, substance and behavioural dependence, the consequences of severe or prolonged adversity in childhood, and any material from the first category of Chapter 34.3, at any point. The treatments consist of structured talking treatments with an established evidence base, the specific trauma-focused treatments, medication where the practitioner recommends it, and the specialist services available for specific matters; and the chapter records, as its final note, that the conditions are ordinary, that they respond to treatment, and that the barriers men report are the barriers the arrangements of this part of the book are designed to address.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the inventory. Which category is operating most strongly, and where exactly is it operating — the hour, the setting, the person, the conduct?
2. Which of the seven misconceptions do you hold, in your own words? What standard have you been measuring yourself against?
3. Which of the four conditions of recovery is absent in your case, and what is the first arrangement that would supply it?
4. Where in your history is a conclusion about your own conduct that nobody has ever asked you to describe? Who could ask you the question, and what would the question be?
5. What is the household's account of your state, and what does it contain that is inaccurate? Which of the four parts of Chapter 34.6's statement would correct it?
6. Complete the plan in Part Four, with dates. Which arrangement is the one you are least willing to construct, and what does that indicate?
7. Write the three relapses in your own terms and the handling for each. What will you do on the day you do not wish to attend?

Further Reading

- **On recovery from trauma:** the research and practice literature on traumatic exposure and its treatment, including the findings on the symptoms of post-traumatic stress in men, the evidence on the treatments with the

strongest record, and the material on the sequence in which treatment is conducted.

- **On recovery from adverse childhood experiences:** the research on the long-term effects of adversity in childhood, including the findings on the conditions that follow, the evidence on treatment in adulthood, and the material on the factors that predict better outcomes.
- **On the process of recovery generally:** the literature on the process of change and of recovery in mental health, including the findings on the role of social connection, meaningful activity, and the person's own account, and the evidence on the stages and the durations of change.
- **On treatments and outcomes:** the evidence base for cognitive behavioural therapy, for trauma-focused treatments, for interpersonal treatments, and for medication in the conditions identified in Section 36.5, including the findings on effectiveness, on the working relationship, and on the factors that predict response.
- **Practical resources:** general practice and mental health services; specialist services for trauma, bereavement, addiction, and family matters; employee assistance and occupational health services; crisis lines; men's groups; and the material in Appendices B, C, K, M, Q, and R.

37 CHAPTER

Learning to Rest Without Feeling Guilty

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe why rest is difficult for men, and identify the four sources of the prohibition he carries.
2. Define rest accurately, distinguish it from sleep and from the absence of work, and identify the categories of recovery that his own position requires.
3. Recognise the presentations of a man who has not rested for years, and the relationship between sustained overwork and the conditions described in this book.
4. Analyse the guilt he experiences when he rests, in the terms of the rule that produces it, and state the counter-argument in a form he can use.
5. Construct rest as an arrangement: scheduled, of the required kind, protected, and maintained through the household's and the organisation's responses.
6. Apply the exercise at the end of the chapter to determine what his own position actually requires, and to establish the arrangement with dates.

Introduction

A man who can work continuously without difficulty and who cannot stop is not demonstrating a strength. He is describing a condition, and the condition has costs that are documented, that are borne principally by his household, his body, and the people who depend on his judgement, and that are corrected by an arrangement rather than by an attitude.

This chapter concerns rest. Its subject is the specific difficulty that a large proportion of men experience with it — the inability to stop without a reason, the guilt that arrives when the work is set down, the rest that is not rest because the telephone is on the table, and the years of continuous activity that the man describes to himself and to others as dedication.

The chapter's approach has four commitments.

The first is that the difficulty is not laziness's opposite and it is not a virtue. The chapter does not treat continuous work as a defect of character; it treats it as an arrangement that most men acquire for good reasons, that is rewarded by their environments, and that has costs which the man generally does not count. The chapter's practical purpose is the accounting.

The second is that the guilt is produced by a rule rather than by a feeling. The man's guilt at resting is the operation of a specific proposition — that his worth is his output, or that he is only secure while he is producing — and the proposition is amenable to examination. Section 37.4 states the rule and Section 37.5 supplies the counter-argument, which is drawn from evidence rather than from encouragement.

The third is that rest is a component of the man's responsibilities rather than a reward for discharging them. This is the reframing on which the chapter turns, and it is not a rhetorical device: Chapter 31 established that a leader's judgement is the resource on which the people he is responsible for depend, and the research on the effects of sustained work without recovery establishes the mechanism by which that resource is degraded. A man who cannot rest is a man whose capacity, judgement, and conduct toward his household will deteriorate, and the deterioration will be observed by others before it is observed by him.

The fourth is that rest must be constructed in the man's own form and stated in his own terms. The material on men's forms of recovery in Chapter 30.2 applies: the rest that a man will maintain is generally structured, purposeful, physical, or accompanied by an activity, and the instruction that he should lie down and do nothing is generally the instruction he will not follow. The arrangements in Section 37.6 are constructed accordingly, and their requirement is that the rest be scheduled and protected rather than earned.

37.1 Why Rest Is Difficult for Men

The difficulty has four sources, and they reinforce one another. Each is described here in the terms men use.

Source One: The Man's Account of Himself

For a large proportion of men, the answer to the question of who they are is composed substantially of what they do and provide. Chapter 24's material applies: the identity assembled from the roles, and the account held in the form of the sentence used to describe himself — the position, the trade, the provision, the responsibility.

The consequence for rest is direct: setting the work down is not experienced as a pause in the man's activity. It is experienced as a pause in his standing. The man's uneasy sense when he is not working is not laziness; it is the interruption of the arrangement through which he knows who he is. The finding from the practice

material is that this source is the strongest of the four in men above fifty and in men whose positions carry weight, and that it is the source that remains after the others have been addressed.

Source Two: The Measure of Worth by Output

The second source is the rule rather than the identity: **a man is worth what he produces, and the accounting is periodic.** The rule is delivered by the environment and adopted by the man, and it is examined in Section 37.4. Its operation on rest is that rest is unaccounted time, and unaccounted time is registered as a loss.

The rule has a specific feature that men describe precisely: it applies to the current period rather than to the accumulated record. A man who has worked for thirty years and provides for eleven people does not, when he rests on a Saturday, register the thirty years; he registers the day. The arrangement is the one described in Chapter 25.5: the results-based measure, applied at short intervals, in which the man's standing must be re-established continuously.

Source Three: The Household's Requirement as the Man Understands It

The third source is the man's model of what his household requires, and it is frequently more demanding than anything the household has stated. The man's position is that his household's security depends on his continuing, that his availability is one of the things he supplies, and that his stopping would be a visible reduction in that supply.

The model is partly accurate: a household's arrangements do depend substantially on the man's provision, and the men in the case material who cannot rest are frequently the men whose households require what they provide. What is inaccurate is the conclusion drawn from it — that the requirement is continuous and that any pause is a risk. Section 37.3 supplies the evidence on the alternative's cost, and Section 37.5 supplies the reframing.

Source Four: The Environment's Reinforcement

The fourth source, and the one that is genuinely external. The environment rewards continuous work in specific and observable ways: the promotion, the selection, the standing, the deference, the invitations, the requests, the competition among men, and the specific approval that the culture extends to the man who is always working. It penalises rest in subtler and equally observable ways: the man who declines the additional engagement, who leaves at the stated hour, who is unavailable at the weekend, who takes the leave, is recorded in the organisation's informal account before it is recorded in any formal one.

The source's practical consequence is that the man's decision about rest is a decision against a considerable gradient, and that its correction requires an arrangement rather than a preference. The men who rest successfully in the case

material are not the men who decided to; they are the men who constructed a specification — the boundary of Chapter 31.5 — and who held it against the environment's pressure, generally with the support of one person who noticed.

The Two Forms of the Prohibition

The four sources produce two distinct prohibitions, and the distinction matters because the corrections differ.

The prohibition on stopping. The man cannot set the work down: the extended hours, the weekend, the leave not taken, the retirement deferred, the telephone maintained through the holiday, the work conducted at the family occasion. Its correction is the arrangement of Section 37.6, and specifically the specified boundary with dates.

The prohibition on being restored. The second form, and the one men report less frequently because it is less visible: the man stops and is not restored. The rest is filled with the administration of the position — the calls, the messages, the planning, the reading, the worry, the household's tasks accepted as demands. The man's report of the position is precise: *I have not worked less in ten years; I have worked in different places.* Its correction is the definition of Section 37.2 and the selection of the specific categories of recovery that the man's position requires.

37.2 What Rest Actually Is

The chapter defines the term, because the definition determines the arrangement.

The Definition

Rest is the conduct that restores the man's capacity. It is not the absence of work, and it is not sleep.

The distinction has three parts.

Rest is not the absence of work. A day in which the man does not work and in which his attention remains on the position — the calls, the worry, the planning, the telephone — is not a day of rest; it is a day of work conducted in another location, which is the second prohibition of Section 37.1.

Rest is not sleep. Sleep is one route to restoration and it is the most important single route; the man's position after a week of insufficient sleep cannot be corrected by an afternoon, and the material on sleep and judgement is unambiguous. But rest includes the restoration that sleep does not supply: the physical, the sensory, the mental, and the social categories below.

Rest is defined by its effect rather than by its form. The measure is not what the man did but what it produced: the man's capacity, his judgement, his mood, his patience, and his household's experience of him. The measure is checkable and it is applied in the exercise at the end of the chapter.

The Six Categories of Recovery

The research and the practice literature on recovery from work identify categories that are distinct, and the man's requirement frequently spans more than one. The categories are set out with their characteristic forms.

1. Physical recovery. The sleep, the exercise, the food, and the restoration of a body that has been used. The category is the one with the most documented effect on mood, cognition, and stress physiology, and the men in the case material who adopt a single measure generally adopt this one, frequently in the form of the walk, the run, the cycle, or the gym.

2. Mental recovery. The disengagement of the attention from the work's material: the task that occupies the whole of the man's attention with something else, the engrossing pursuit, the practical work with the hands, the game, the reading, the learning. The category's mechanism is documented: the attention cannot be disengaged by instruction, and it is disengaged by the substitution of an absorbing activity.

3. Sensory recovery. The reduction of the input: the quiet, the dark, the absence of the screen's light and the noise of the day, the silence, the natural setting. The category is the one that men most frequently overlook, and its neglect is associated in the case material with the form of exhaustion that the man describes as *I cannot hear myself think*.

4. Social recovery. The company that requires nothing of the man: the friend without the purpose, the group without the agenda, the household's ordinary evening, the conversation without the outcome. The category is distinguished from the work's company and from the household's administrative meetings, and the material of Chapters 26 and 27 applies to its construction.

5. Creative recovery. The making, building, writing, drawing, playing, gardening, cooking, repairing, and craft. The category's specific value for the men in the case material is that it supplies the engagement that mental recovery requires while producing a result, which addresses the measure problem of Section 37.1′s second source directly.

6. Purposeful recovery. The conduct of the man's own choice that is neither work nor obligation: the interest, the pursuit, the involvement with a group or a cause, the arrangement in which the man is not the provider. The category overlaps with the fifth arrangement of Chapter 31.5 and its function for men is that it supplies the recognition and the engagement that the position supplies in a form the man has chosen.

The Four Distinctions

Rest is not a reward. The arrangement in which rest is earned by production is the arrangement of Section 37.1′s second source and it produces the pattern in

which the man rests only when he has collapsed or when the measure is satisfied, which is never. The chapter's position is that rest is a component of the man's obligations: the people who depend on his judgement require it to be maintained.

Rest is not uniform. Different men require different categories, and the same man requires different categories in different periods. The man's own position is the criterion, and the exercise supplies it: what restores the man's capacity is identified by the effect, and the man should record which category produced which change.

Rest is mostly small. The research on recovery identifies short frequent episodes as effective, and the practice material records that men generally seek restoration in the annual holiday and neglect the daily and weekly measures. The specific finding is that a fortnight's leave taken in the absence of any daily recovery produces less restoration than the same fortnight taken with the daily measures in place.

Rest is mostly unimpressive. The categories are unremarkable: the sleep, the walk, the quiet, the friend, the afternoon's practical work, the Sunday, the evening without the telephone. The chapter notes this because the men in the case material describe their own measures as trivial, and because the effect of the ordinary measure is generally out of proportion to its appearance.

37.3 What the Absence of Rest Produces

The material on sustained work without recovery is substantial, and the following findings are the ones the reader can apply to his own position.

The Research Findings

1. Performance declines, and the decline is not noticed by the person affected. The research on sustained work without recovery, in settings where the consequences are measurable, reports a consistent finding: performance, vigilance, and judgement degrade over extended periods of continuous work, and the affected person's assessment of their own performance degrades more slowly than the performance itself. The finding is important because the man's evidence for the adequacy of his capacity is his own assessment, which is the measure most affected.

2. Recovery has a threshold. The recovery of performance and of physiological state requires a period that is not reducible to a shorter substitute: many of the effects of sustained work are corrected by sleep and by the categories of Section 37.2, and they are not corrected by a brief break, a weekend, or the man's intention. The finding is consistent with men's own reports: the holiday that produced no restoration, the weekend that left them in the same state, the Sunday evening in which nothing had changed.

3. Sleep is a specific intervention. The research on sleep restriction and performance is among the most consistent in this field: the restriction of sleep degrades vigilance, mood, judgement, emotional regulation, and physical health; the effects accumulate over successive nights; and the affected person's rating of their own performance is substantially better than their measured performance. For the reader, the finding means that a chronic reduction in sleep is not a lifestyle preference; it is a condition with a measurable cost, and it should be treated as a matter for the general practitioner where it has persisted.

4. Sustained work without recovery is associated with the presentations described throughout this book. The research on burnout and on prolonged occupational strain reports associations with depression, anxiety, sleep disturbance, cardiovascular outcomes, alcohol use, and the degradation of relationships. The presentations in Section 37.4 are the ones reported in this book's own case material in Chapters 30, 31, and 34, and the finding is that they are frequently attributed to the position, the age, or the man's temperament rather than to the absence of recovery.

The Presentations in the Man

The following are reported consistently by men in the case material and by the practitioners who see them, and they are arranged in the order in which they develop.

Stage one: the reduction of the man's margins. The man's patience, tolerance, availability, and interest reduce, and the reduction is generally attributed to the workload's temporary intensity. The specific sign is the man's conduct in the minor matters: the traffic, the noise, the staff, the household's ordinary friction.

Stage two: the loss of the man's restoration. The categories of Section 37.2 cease to be available or cease to work: the sleep reduces in quality; the exercise stops; the interests are set down; the social arrangements are cancelled with reasons; the quiet is replaced by the screen. The man's account is that he has no time, which is accurate, and the account's consequence is that the measures that would restore his capacity are the ones removed to make room for the work that requires it.

Stage three: the presentation in the body and the mind. The sleep, the blood pressure, the chest, the stomach, the headaches, the weight, the alcohol; the flatness, the anxiety, the reduced concentration, the exhaustion that sleep does not correct. The presentation that most frequently brings the man into contact with a service, and the one that is most frequently treated as a separate matter from the work that produced it.

Stage four: the cynicism and the loss of meaning. The man's account of the work, the people, and the organisation becomes contemptuous; the position's

purpose is no longer available to him; and the work continues. This is the presentation described in Chapter 31.4 as the core of the burnout pattern, and its feature is that the man's performance is generally maintained.

Stage five: the collapse or the emergency. The illness, the medical event, the collapse at the desk, the household's crisis, the accident, the conclusion of Chapter 34.3′s first category. The stage is frequently the point at which the man first rests, and the finding men report is the one that gives the chapter its title: *the first proper rest I had in nine years was three weeks in the hospital.*

The Presentation in the Household

The cost that the chapter treats as decisive, because it is the one the man does not count.

The household's reduced arrangements. The occasions not attended, the conversations not held, the arrangements conducted by the spouse without the man, the children's events missed, the contributions reduced. The household's account is generally more accurate than the man's: the members of a household observe the man's state without the man's explanation of it, and their arrangements adapt to what they see.

The man's conduct toward the household. The specific and most frequently reported consequence: the man with no margins is short with the people who are available, and the people who are available are the people who cannot impose a consequence. Men in the case material describe the discovery of this arrangement late: *I was the most patient man in the office and I was shouting at my own children about their shoes.*

The household's management of the man. The children's selections, the spouse's timing, the occasions organised around the man's state, the subject not raised. This is the arrangement described in Chapters 18 and 31.6, and it is the chapter's principal argument for the accounting: the household's arrangements are constructed around the absence of the man's restoration, and its members pay for the work in a currency that does not appear in the organisation's accounts.

The transfer of the man's condition to the household. The material of Chapters 29.7 and 30.3: the man's state discharged into the people available, and the household's members carrying the consequences of a condition whose cause is elsewhere and which they cannot alter.

37.4 The Guilt of Resting

The section takes the guilt seriously and analyses it, because the analysis is what produces the counter-argument.

The Rule

The guilt of resting is produced by a proposition, and the proposition is generally available to the man in the following forms.

The worth form. *I am worth what I produce, and a day of rest is a day of zero.*

The security form. *My position exists because I am producing. If I stop producing, the position is at risk, and everything that depends on the position is at risk with it.*

The desert form. *I have not earned it.* The form's mechanism is the arrangement in which rest is the reward for a completed quantity of work, and its feature is that the quantity is never completed, because the position's requirements expand to fill the available capacity.

The comparison form. *Other men are working.* The form is supplied by the environment's evidence: the colleague's hours, the competitor's activity, the man who is always available, the men who are succeeding.

The inheritance form. *My father did not rest.* The form is delivered in the man's own history and is generally accompanied by an accurate description of the father's conduct: the man in the case material who cannot rest is frequently the son of a man who did not, and the rule is transmitted without its costs ever having been stated.

The Mechanism

The rule operates as follows.

The man's environment rewards output and penalises its absence, as Section 37.1 established. The man generalises the arrangement into a proposition about himself. The proposition is applied continuously, and the accounting period is short, generally the day. Rest therefore appears as an unaccounted period in which the man's standing is not being maintained, and the man experiences the expected consequence of standing being reduced. The guilt is not a feeling about rest; it is the sensation of the rule's operation.

The mechanism explains three of the chapter's most frequently reported findings: the guilt is frequently strongest in the first hours of rest and reduces over a longer period, because the rule's application is periodic; the guilt is frequently relieved by productive activity during a rest period, which is the arrangement in which men perform restoration's activities as tasks; and the guilt is generally experienced as evidence that the man's rest is wrong, which is the rule's operation interpreted as information.

The Seven Statements Men Make

The guilt is generally presented in one of seven statements, and each requires the counter-argument stated in Section 37.5.

1. *I cannot afford to rest.*

2. *If I stop, everything I have built will be at risk.*
3. *There is nobody else to do it.*
4. *I will rest when the work is finished.*
5. *This is what the position requires.*
6. *My father worked every day of his life and did not complain.*
7. *The work is the only thing I am good at.*

The statements are not irrational. Each is accurate in its own terms, and the counter-argument in the following section is drawn from the evidence rather than from an assertion to the contrary.

37.5 The Argument Against the Guilt

The counter-argument is supplied in seven parts, in the order of the statements in Section 37.4. Each is available to the reader as a position rather than as reassurance, and each is drawn from the material of the preceding chapters.

1. *I cannot afford to rest.*

The statement concerns money and time, and it should be examined in figures: the actual cost of the daily and weekly measures, which is generally small, against the cost of the presentations in Section 37.3, which is generally substantial and is paid in the man's income, his health care, his household's arrangements, and his organisation's results. The specific comparison available to men in the case material: the days of work lost in a year of reduced capacity, the medical costs, and the matters that became crises because nobody had the margins to address them, against the hours that the measures would have required. The finding is consistent and it is that the man who states that he cannot afford to rest has not counted the alternative.

2. *If I stop, everything I have built will be at risk.*

The statement is examined in three parts. First, the work that is actually at risk from the man's rest is the work that requires his physical presence, which is a minority of what men in the case material are carrying; the majority is the administration of the position, which survives an afternoon. Second, the man's reduced judgement, reduced conduct, and reduced capacity are already risk factors for everything he has built, and they are risk factors that grow. Third, the arrangement is not the absence of work but its bound: nothing in this chapter proposes that the man set the position down; it proposes that he conduct it from a position of maintained capacity, which is the arrangement of Chapter 31.5′s boundary specification.

3. *There is nobody else to do it.*

The statement is frequently accurate and its consequence is not the continuation of the arrangement but its correction. The findings of Chapter 33 apply: the

load's concentration is a structural vulnerability of the man, the family, and the organisation alike, and the development of other people's capacity is the measure that addresses the statement rather than the man's continuous labour. The specific and decisive point: an arrangement that depends on one man's continuous presence is an arrangement that will fail when that man is ill, and the man's rest is the first and smallest test of the structure's resilience.

4. *I will rest when the work is finished.*

The statement is examined in the terms of Chapter 33.6′s first arrangement and of the case material on retirement. The condition is never satisfied: the position's requirements expand to the capacity available, and the arrangement in which rest follows the work's completion produces the pattern of the man's whole working life and the presentation, in retirement, of the material of Chapter 24. The reconstruction of the statement is the most useful thing the chapter supplies: **the work is not going to be finished; the man's capacity must therefore be maintained while the work continues.**

5. *This is what the position requires.*

The statement is accurate about the position and incomplete about its requirements. The position requires the man's judgement, his availability, his decision, his conduct, and his reliability; none of those requirements is met by a man whose sleep is reduced, whose patience has gone, whose judgement is degrading, and whose household is being managed around his state. The statement should be completed: *this is what the position requires of my capacity, and my capacity requires maintenance.* This is the reframing of the chapter's third commitment, and it is the argument that the men in the case material report as decisive, because it converts the measure from an indulgence into an obligation.

6. *My father worked every day of his life and did not complain.*

The statement is examined in three parts. First, the father's arrangement is generally accurate in the description and incomplete in the accounting, and the reader should consider what the father's state was: the man's own memory of his father's temper, his silence, his absences, his availability, his health, and his death. Second, the father's circumstances were frequently different, and the reader should test whether they were: the number of hours, the physical nature of the work, the imposition of his own position's requirements, the difference in the demands that arrive through a telephone. Third, and most importantly, the statement is a description of what the father did and not a statement of what the reader owes him: the material of Chapter 32.1′s fourth source applies, and the chapter's position is that the appropriate response to a father's years of unrelieved work is not its reproduction but the acknowledgment of what it cost him.

7. The work is the only thing I am good at.

The statement is the identity source of Section 37.1 in its most complete form, and it is addressed in full by the material of Chapters 24 and 25: the measure of worth, the reconstruction of the account of himself, the arrangements of Chapter 27, and the categories of Section 37.2's last four. The specific finding for this statement is the one that the men in the case material report: the man who can do nothing but work is generally a man who has not conducted anything else for a substantial period, and the capacity for the other things is not absent but undeveloped. The test is available and it is small: one pursuit, one group, one arrangement that requires the man and is not the position.

The Presentation of the Argument

The seven parts are supplied as a written position, and the practice material records that the argument works in the written form rather than in argument with the guilty feeling.

The method: the man writes the seven statements as he experiences them, in his own words, and writes the response to each beneath it. The responses are then available at the moment the guilt arises, which is the reason the written form is prescribed.

The specific application for the man who does not accept the argument at all: the exercise should begin with the accounting rather than with the argument. A man who cannot accept that rest is legitimate can generally accept that the presentations of Section 37.3 have costs and that his household requires his capacity. The argument can be conducted through the material of the household, and the finding is that the position, once adopted for the household's sake, becomes the man's own.

37.6 Building Rest Into the Arrangement

The practical section. Its requirement is that rest be constructed rather than requested, and the arrangement has six components.

1. The Sleep Specification

What it is. The man's specification of the hours, the arrangement, and the conditions: the time of going to bed and of rising, the room's conditions, the reduction of the screens in the period before sleep, the removal of the work material from the room, the alcohol, the caffeine, and the treatment of any disturbance of which the man is aware.

Why it is first. Sleep is the single largest component of restoration, and its correction is generally the largest available improvement. The research on the effects of an insufficient sleep period on judgement, mood, and health is the strongest evidence in this chapter.

The form. Written, with times, and given to the household, since the household's arrangements are frequently involved. Where the sleep has been disturbed for months, or where the disturbance includes early waking with the material of Chapter 34.4, the general practitioner is the route.

2. The Daily Measure

What it is. One measure conducted daily, of the categories in Section 37.2, of a duration the man will actually maintain. The practice material's recommendation is physical recovery in the first instance, because its effect is the largest and its form is the easiest for men to maintain: the walk, the exercise, the cycle, the swim, conducted at a fixed time.

The form. Fixed rather than discretionary, and stated as part of the position's requirements. The finding on the arrangement is the same as Chapter 30.6′s: the fixed time is what survives the periods in which the man does not wish to conduct it.

3. The Weekly Specification

What it is. The specification of the man's non-working period: the day or the part of it, the period's protection, and the conditions. The forms vary — the Sunday, the Saturday, the Friday evening, the two evenings in the week — and the requirement is that the specification be written, that it be given to the household and, where relevant, to the organisation, and that the man's availability during the period be defined.

The specific difficulty. The telephone. The chapter records the finding plainly: the man who is physically away from the work and available by telephone has not rested, and the weekly specification's practical content is generally the telephone's arrangement: the hours, the alternatives, the person who holds the position in the period, and the exceptions.

4. The Annual Specification

What it is. The leave, taken, in blocks of a length the research supports, and taken with the arrangements in place: the person who holds the position, the telephone's arrangement, the man's own measures, and the household.

The finding men report. The leave taken in the absence of daily and weekly measures produces little restoration, and the leave taken with them produces considerably more. The specific instruction is the one from Section 37.2: the holiday is the least effective of the measures when it stands alone.

5. The Boundary and the Position's Specification

What it is. The written boundary of Chapter 31.5′s fourth arrangement, and the material on the household's arrangements in Chapters 18 and 31.6: the hours, the days, the availability, the travel, the household arrangements that will not be moved, and the conditions under which the specification is revised.

Why it is required. The environment will not set the man's rest; the position's requirements will expand; the household is generally reluctant to make demands on a man whose position is understood to be demanding. The boundary is the man's own obligation and its absence is his own decision.

6. The Stated Arrangement With the Household

What it is. The man's statement to his household, in the form used elsewhere in this book: what he is going to do, why, what it changes, what it does not change, and what he requires. The specific content for this chapter: the measures, the times, the telephone's arrangement, and the request that the household support the arrangement rather than respond to it.

Why it is required. Two findings from the case material. First, the household frequently responds to a man's rest with the requirements that his availability had previously supplied, since the household's arrangements have been constructed around his presence whenever he was present. The statement is what allows the household to plan. Second, the household's support is one of the strongest determinants of whether the arrangement holds: the man who is reminded of the arrangement by somebody else maintains it considerably more reliably than the man who relies on his own intention.

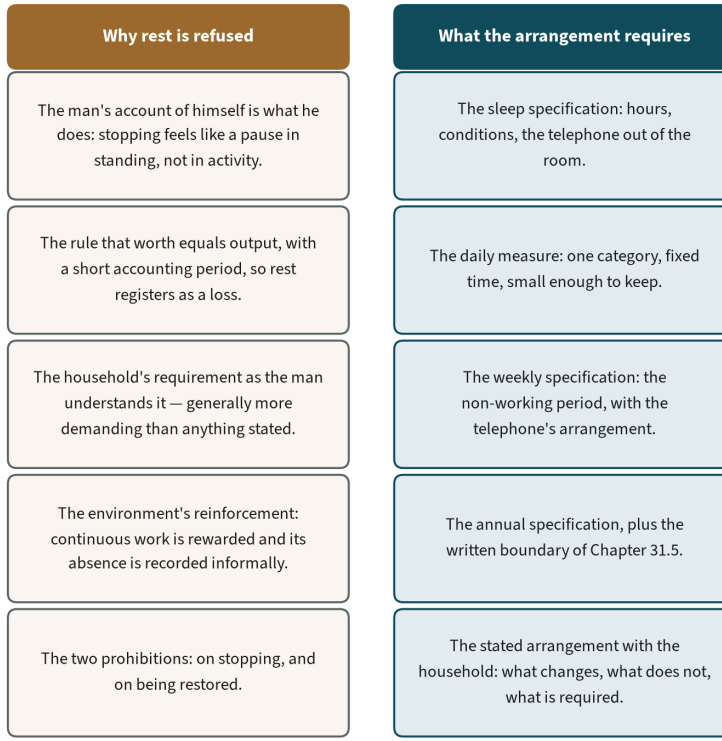


Figure 37.1 Learning to rest: the four sources of the prohibition, the six categories of recovery, and the six components of the arrangement. The diagram is conceptual; the categories overlap, and a man's requirement generally spans more than one.

37.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Worked Every Day for Nine Years

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in occupational health, primary care, and family practice.

Bashir is fifty-two, a doctor in private general practice in a state capital, married to Halima for twenty-six years, with four children between the ages of fifteen and twenty-four.

Bashir's practice had grown from a single consulting room in 2008 to a three-doctor clinic with a laboratory and a small inpatient facility. His working pattern, which he described as having developed without a decision, was as follows: consultations from 8 a.m. to 8 p.m. on six days, the clinic's administration on Sunday mornings, telephone availability at all hours, and — the element he identified as the significant one — the assumption among his patients that he would attend personally to any

matter of difficulty, including deliveries, emergencies, and the hospital admissions of families who had attended the clinic for years.

His account of the nine years: *I did not decide to work every day. There is a difference between deciding something and not stopping. In the first year I was building the practice. In the third year I had four staff and I was still there at ten in the evening because the patients asked for me and I could not send them to somebody else. In the ninth year my wife said to me that she had counted and that I had not been in the house for a full day since 2017, and I checked and she was right.*

The presentations by the ninth year were six, and they were the ones recorded in Section 37.3: the sleep, which was five to six hours with the telephone beside the bed; the blood pressure, for which he had been taking medication for four years and which was not controlled; the weight; the alcohol, which had become a nightly pattern of three to four units; the flatness, described by him as *I have not been interested in anything except the clinic for about three years*; and the conduct at home, described by Halima in the family consultation: *He is not a harsh man. He is a wall. He answers questions. He does not have a conversation. My daughter asked him in December about her university choices and he answered in three sentences and he was looking at his phone and she did not ask him anything again.*

Two matters brought the case into a service. The first was a medical one: Bashir attended a hospital's emergency department with chest pain at the age of fifty-two, was investigated, and was found to have no cardiac event. The consultant's own account, recorded with permission in the case: *He came in at two in the morning from the clinic, he had a raised blood pressure and a normal cardiac workup, and he told me he had last taken a full day away from his practice in 2017. He was sitting in the department at two in the morning planning to be at work by eight. I asked him what would happen to his patients if he died in the next month and he did not answer me.*

The second matter was Halima's decision, taken with the eldest two children, to present Bashir with a written statement signed by the four children and by her, which he produced in the case. Its central passage: *You are the best doctor in this area and you are not in this house. We are not asking you to close the clinic. We are asking you to be in this family for the years that are left, and you are fifty-two years old and you have not yet been present at a meal that lasted an hour.*

The arrangements Bashir constructed over the following fourteen months had six components and he identified the sequence as the reason they held.

The medical and the boundary. From the hospital's referral, Bashir engaged a physician and a counselling arrangement for the blood pressure, the alcohol, and his own position. The first decision, taken in the second month, was the clinic's specification: two additional doctors engaged over the following year, a defined consultation period ending at 6 p.m., a rota for out-of-hours cover, and a rule that the telephone beyond the rota went to the practice's nurse.

His account of the first three months: *I had believed that the patients would leave. About forty left and about two hundred stayed and the practice's income was down by*

eleven per cent in the first year. And in the fourth month I slept for seven hours for the first time since 2016 and I understood what I had been trading.

The sleep. The sleep specification, written: the telephone removed from the bedroom, the hours, the alcohol reduced to occasional use, the caffeine, and the treatment of the blood pressure. He described the sleep as the change with the largest effect: *The first three weeks were the strangest. I had been working for nine years with a battery at about thirty per cent and I did not know it, because it had been thirty per cent for so long that I thought that was the level.*

The daily measure. Bashir took up walking, at 6.30 in the morning, for about forty minutes. He identified the measure's function as not primarily physical: *It is the only forty minutes in the day in which nobody requires anything from me and I am not available. I have not missed a morning in fourteen months, including the days I did not want to. The first morning I went out and I did not know where to walk, because I had not been anywhere in my own neighbourhood except the clinic and the house in nine years.*

The weekly and the annual specifications. Saturday was made a non-working day, with the clinic's rota and the nurse's telephone, and a fortnight's leave was taken with the family in the following year. Bashir described the household's response in the first weeks of the Saturday arrangement: *They did not know what to do with me. My youngest asked me whether I was sick. My wife had been organising the house for nine years around my absence and she had a routine and I was in it. It took about six weeks before the house was normal on a Saturday and about three months before the Saturday was ordinary to me.*

The stated arrangement with the household. Bashir conducted the household meeting in the third month, in the form of Section 37.6′s sixth component, including the four children. He described the meeting: *I told them what the clinic was, what I had been doing for nine years, what the specification was, and what the Saturday was. My second son, who is twenty-one, asked me whether I was doing it for them or for myself. I said that I was doing it because I had been told by a consultant at two in the morning that I might not have a choice in the matter if I did not, and because I wanted to be in the house for the years that are left. He said, then you should say that sentence at the start of the meeting rather than the end.*

The position's arrangements. Bashir established two: a group of five medical practitioners which met monthly, and a period on the association's continuing education committee, which he described as *the first thing I have done in nine years that was not my clinic.* He described the group's function: *I have been the doctor for two thousand people and I have not had a doctor. In that group I am one of five men with the same practice and the same problems, and I have said things in that room that I have never said to anybody.*

Bashir's summary, fourteen months after the emergency department, was: *I went to the hospital at two in the morning with a normal heart and a blood pressure that I had not controlled for four years, and a consultant asked me what would happen to my patients if I died in the next month and I could not answer him. I could not answer*

> *him because I had not been able to think about it, and the reason I had not been able to think about it was that I had been working for nine years without a day. The practice lost eleven per cent of its income and the patients who left were the ones who wanted a doctor available at two in the morning, and what I have instead is two additional doctors, two hundred patients who stayed, a Saturday, a morning walk at half past six, and a wife who speaks to me at the table. My daughter asked me about the university in April and we talked for an hour and a half. That is the whole of the accounting.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The pattern developed without a decision, and the man's own account identified the mechanism precisely. *I did not decide to work every day. There is a difference between deciding something and not stopping.* This is Section 37.1′s second form — the prohibition on stopping — and the case is included because the absence of a decision is what makes the arrangement resistant to correction: there is no moment at which the man can identify having chosen.

The man's capacity had operated at a reduced level for long enough that the reduced level was his normal. *A battery at about thirty per cent, and it had been thirty per cent for so long that I thought that was the level.* This is the research finding of Section 37.3 — that the affected person's assessment of their own capacity is the measure most affected — expressed in the man's own terms, and the case is included because it is the finding that most frequently changes the reader's understanding of his own position.

The household had constructed its arrangements around the man's absence, and his presence initially disrupted them. The house's routine, the youngest child's question about whether he was sick, the six weeks before the house was normal on a Saturday. The case is included because men anticipate that their rest will be welcomed and are unprepared for the household's response when their availability changes the arrangements that the household has built in its absence.

The presentation was a medical one, and the practitioner's question was the entry point. The chest pain, the uncontrolled blood pressure, the two-in-the-morning attendance, and the consultant's question about what would happen to the patients. The case is repeated from Chapter 32.7 and Chapter 35.7 because the mechanism is the same and because it is the most frequently available route for men in this position: the physical presentation is the form in which the man arrives, and the question about a third party is the form in which the position becomes visible to him.

The arrangements were six and they were established in sequence. The medical and the clinic's specification first, because the position's requirements had to change before the man's hours could; the sleep second, because it produced

the largest and the earliest change; the daily and the weekly measures next; the household's arrangement at the third month, with the meeting's form including the man's own reason rather than the household's request; and the position's arrangements last. The sequence is the one recommended in Section 37.6, and the man's own account of it — the Saturday ordinary after three months, the walk unmissed in fourteen — is the practical evidence that the arrangement is maintainable.

37.8 Practical Exercise: The Recovery Audit and the Specification

This exercise takes about two and a half hours, over three sittings.

Part One: The Recovery Audit (Sitting One)

Section A: The current position. Record the last full day on which you did not work, the last full day on which you were not reachable, your average hours of sleep in the last month, and the last week's leave taken.

Section B: The categories. For each of the six categories of Section 37.2, record what you currently have, and whether it is producing restoration.

Category	What I have	Does it restore my capacity?
Physical		
Mental		
Sensory		
Social		
Creative		
Purposeful		

Section C: The presentations. Apply Section 37.3's five stages and the household's presentation, and record which are present with the evidence.

The presentation	Present?	The evidence
The reduction of my margins		
The loss of my restoration		
The body and the mind		
The cynicism and the loss of meaning		
The collapse or the emergency		
The household's position		

Section D: The household's account. Ask one member of your household — separately, and without defending yourself — the following four questions, and record the answers verbatim.

- What does the house do differently when I am not here?
- What have I missed in the last two years that you did not tell me about?
- When was the last time I was present for an hour with nothing else?
- What would change if I were present on Saturday?

Part Two: The Guilt (Sitting Two)

Section A: The statements. Write the seven statements of Section 37.4 as you experience them, in your own words, and beneath each write the response from Section 37.5 in your own words. Where a statement does not apply, record that.

Section B: The rule. Write the rule in your own terms: the form of the proposition about your worth, your security, your desert, the comparison, or the inheritance that produces the guilt. Then record the evidence for it and the evidence against it.

Section C: The inheritance. Write what your father's working pattern was, what it produced for him, and what its costs were — including the costs visible to you as a child. Then write the sentence that separates the description from the obligation: this is what he did, and this is what I owe him.

Part Three: The Specification (Sitting Three)

The component	The specific form	The time or the date	The person who will notice
The sleep specification			
The daily measure			
The weekly specification (including the telephone)			
The annual specification			
The boundary (Chapter 31.5)			
The stated arrangement with the household			

Section A: Write the weekly specification in full, including the telephone's arrangement: who holds the position, what the exceptions are, and what the household is to do in an emergency. Then give a copy to one member of the household and, where relevant, to one person at work.

Section B: Write the stated arrangement with the household — what I am going to do, why, what it changes, what it does not change, and what I require — and conduct it within fourteen days.

Section C: Record the measure by which you will judge whether the specification is working. Use the definition of Section 37.2: the effect on your capacity, your mood, your patience, and your household's experience of you — recorded at thirty days, ninety days, and one year.

37.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I am building something. When it is established, I will rest."

The condition is not going to be satisfied, and the case material in this chapter and in Chapter 24 is consistent on the point: the position's requirements expand to the capacity available, and the man's construction is generally complete by the time he is considering the question. The available measure is therefore the specification rather than the condition, and the case material's finding is that the men who adopted it while building did not lose the building; they lost the eleven per cent of income that came from the patients who required a doctor at two in the morning.

"My household needs what I earn. Rest reduces the earnings."

The statement is examined in Section 37.5's first part, and the accounting is generally decisive. The specific finding for men in this position: the earnings lost to the man's reduced capacity, the medical costs, the days not worked, the crises produced by the absence of margins, and the household's own losses — the arrangements not made, the opportunities not taken, the man's absence at the years that will not return — are generally larger than the earnings at issue, and they are paid by the household in a currency that does not appear in the accounts.

"I rest. I watch television every evening."

The screen's use is examined against the definition: the effect on the man's capacity. The material's finding, which men report consistently when they examine it: the screen frequently supplies the cessation of work without supplying any of the six categories, and the man's state after two hours of it is frequently the state he began with, with the addition of the night's sleep reduced. The substitute is not a failure and it is not rest; the chapter's position is that it should be identified as what it is, and that one category of Section 37.2 should be added to the week in place of some of it.

"My father rested even less and he lived to eighty-five."

The observation is entirely possible and it is not evidence about the reader. The material on individual variation in the effects of sustained work is the same as in any other field: some men sustain arrangements that damage others, and the reader's own position is established by his own presentations in Part One of the exercise and not by comparison. The specific finding from the case material is that the men who offer the observation are generally the men with three or four of the presentations of Section 37.3.

"I cannot take the leave. The position cannot be left."

Then the position is a structure with a single point of failure, which is the material of Chapter 33 and which is a risk that the man's employer or organisation owns whether or not it has acknowledged it. The practical measures are the ones in Section 37.6: the rota, the additional capacity, the specified hours, and the arrangement for the telephone. Where the man genuinely cannot leave and the position's capacity cannot be constructed, the matter should be treated as information about the position rather than about the man, and the available response is the reduction of the position's scope — which is a decision, and which is generally available and generally deferred.

"I feel guilty, and I still do not rest. What now?"

Then the exercise should be conducted in the order of Section 37.5's final part: the accounting first rather than the argument. The man who cannot accept that rest is legitimate for its own sake can generally examine what the absence of it has cost, and can adopt the arrangement for his household's sake. The finding is that the position, once adopted, becomes the man's own, and that the guilt reduces with the arrangement rather than before it: the guilt is not the obstacle that must be removed before the arrangement is constructed, and the arrangement is frequently what removes the guilt.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 37 in brief. Rest is difficult for men for four reasons: the man's account of himself is composed substantially of what he does and provides, so that stopping is experienced as a pause in his standing rather than in his activity; the rule that a man is worth what he produces, with a short accounting period, so that rest registers as unaccounted time; the man's model of what his household requires, which is generally more demanding than anything the household has stated; and the environment's reinforcement, since continuous work is rewarded and its absence is recorded in the organisation's informal account before any formal one. The four sources produce two prohibitions: on stopping, and on being restored.

Rest is the conduct that restores the man's capacity. It is not the absence of work, and it is not sleep, and it is defined by its effect rather than its form. Six categories of recovery are identified — physical, mental, sensory, social, creative, and purposeful — and four distinctions apply: rest is not a reward, is not uniform, is mostly small, and is mostly unimpressive in appearance.

The absence of rest produces a documented decline that the person affected notices last: performance and judgement degrade while the man's own assessment degrades more slowly; recovery requires a period that cannot be reduced to a shorter substitute; sleep restriction has measurable costs across vigilance, mood, judgement, and health; and sustained work without recovery is associated with the presentations described throughout this book. Those presentations develop in stages: the reduction

of the man's margins, the loss of his restoration, the body and the mind, cynicism and the loss of meaning, and the collapse or the emergency — while the household pays in reduced arrangements, in the man's conduct toward its members, in its management of his state, and in the transfer of his condition to the people who are available.

The guilt of resting is produced by a rule, available in five forms — worth, security, desert, comparison, and inheritance — and it operates by applying a short accounting period to a proposition about the man's standing. Seven statements are supplied with their counter-arguments, and the decisive reframing is that the position's requirements are met by the man's judgement, availability, and conduct, none of which is served by a man whose capacity is depleting: the measure is a component of his obligations rather than an indulgence. The arrangement has six components — the sleep specification, the daily measure, the weekly specification including the telephone, the annual specification, the boundary, and the stated arrangement with the household — and the first measure of progress is the existence of the arrangement rather than the man's state on the day it is constructed.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the recovery audit. What is the last full day you did not work, what is your average sleep, and which of the six categories are absent?
2. Which of the five stages of Section 37.3 is your position? Which presentation has your household noticed, and what has it done about it?
3. Complete the four questions put to a member of your household. What did the answers contain that you did not expect?
4. Write the rule in your own terms. What is the accounting period you apply to yourself, and what evidence would you require from another man before accepting it about him?
5. Which of the seven statements is strongest in your case, and which part of the counter-argument in Section 37.5 do you accept?
6. Write the weekly specification in full, including the telephone's arrangement, and name the person who will hold the copy.
7. What did your father's working pattern cost him, what did it produce, and what do you owe him? Write the two sentences separately.

Further Reading

- **On sleep and performance:** the research literature on sleep restriction and its effects on vigilance, mood, judgement, and health, including the findings on the accumulation of effects across successive nights and the evidence on the difference between measured and self-assessed performance.

- **On recovery from work and on occupational burnout:** the literature on recovery from work, including the findings on the categories of recovery, on the value of short frequent episodes as against extended breaks, and on the associations between sustained work without recovery and the outcomes described in this chapter.
- **On overwork and health:** the research on long working hours and health outcomes, including the findings on cardiovascular outcomes, on mental health, and on the relationship between hours and productivity.
- **On leisure and wellbeing:** the research on leisure and on the forms of activity associated with restoration, including the findings on physical activity, on engaging pursuits, and on the social and creative forms.
- **Practical resources:** general practice and occupational health services for sleep, blood pressure, and the presentations of Section 37.3; employee assistance programmes; leave and flexible-working arrangements; and the material in Appendices C, N, and P.

PART XI

Rebuilding a Man’s Life

Restoring purpose, confidence, relationships, and direction

38 CHAPTER

Rebuilding After Everything Falls Apart

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe what a total collapse consists of, distinguish it from a partial loss, and identify the specific features that make it difficult to address.
2. Conduct the four tasks of the first period — safety, information, the triage of obligations, and one ally — and identify the actions that constitute each.
3. Recognise the seven errors that men make in the first period and the consequences of each, and identify which he is at present inclined toward.
4. Conduct a full reckoning: the accounting of assets, liabilities, obligations, capacities, and relationships, together with the identification of what remains intact.
5. Apply the staged reconstruction, in the order supplied, and state what belongs to each stage and what must not be attempted until the earlier stages are complete.
6. Conduct the reconstruction with his household, using the disclosure and planning forms of this book, and recognise the household's own losses as a separate matter requiring its own arrangements.

Introduction

A man's difficulties in the earlier parts of this book were partial: a position lost, a business failing, a marriage in difficulty, a debt concealed, a material carried and unshared. This chapter concerns the position in which the losses arrive together and the man's entire structure is affected at once: the business has failed and the debts are not payable, the employment has ended and the household's income has stopped, the marriage has ended or is in the process of ending, the property is gone or at risk, the standing in the community has been affected, the health has been affected, and the relationships through which the man would ordinarily be supported are the relationships that the collapse has reached.

The chapter is written on five commitments.

The first is that the position is survivable and that the material's central proposition applies to it in its strongest form. Men rebuild after total collapse, and the accounts of how they do it are consistent; the chapter supplies them as a sequence rather than as encouragement, and its order is drawn from the practice material on financial collapse, insolvency, bereavement, redundancy, and family crisis.

The second is that the first period has its own requirements, and that the failure to meet them is what converts a collapse from a period of years into a decade. The four tasks of Section 38.2 are small, they are specific, and they can be conducted by a man in the state the collapse produces — which is the reason they are prescribed in that form.

The third is that the errors of the first period are predictable, that men make them for comprehensible reasons, and that the errors are expensive. Section 38.3 sets them out because the reader's own inclination, at the point at which the collapse occurs, will be toward one or more of them, and because the material's function is to place the inclination in front of him before he acts on it.

The fourth is that the reconstruction is staged, and that the staging is not a matter of temperament but of arithmetic. A man rebuilding after a collapse whose income is not yet restored will not settle his obligations; a man whose obligations are unaddressed will not rebuild his standing; a man whose standing is not rebuilt will not rebuild his largest opportunities. The order is mechanical and it can be stated, which is what Section 38.5 does.

The fifth is that the household is the party through which the reconstruction is conducted and not the party to be protected from it. The material in Chapters 34 and 35 applies in full: the household's arrangements depend on the man's position, the household will construct an account in the absence of information, and the household's own losses require their own arrangements.

38.1 What "Everything Falls Apart" Means

The phrase is used loosely, and it must be defined, because the definition determines the work.

The Definition

A total collapse is a loss of the man's standing arrangements in two or more domains at once, in a manner that has removed the structure through which he would ordinarily address any one of them.

The definition has four components, and each should be tested against the reader's position.

The loss is in more than one domain. The domains are: the income and the work; the property and the assets; the household and the marriage; the standing in the community and the profession; the health and the body; and the support the man relies upon. A single loss, however severe, is addressed through the

arrangements in the other domains. Two or more losses remove the arrangements through which each would be met.

The structure has been removed. The man who has lost a business but retains his employment, his household, and his relationships has a structure. The man who has lost his business and, through it, his income, his household's security, his standing in the community, and his relationships with the people who were connected to the business, has lost the structure itself.

The man's account of his position has been affected. The definition includes the identity material of Chapter 24: the man's answer to the question of who he is is frequently composed substantially of the arrangements that have failed, and the collapse therefore removes his account of himself along with his position.

The position requires its own method. Partial difficulties are addressed with the material of the preceding chapters; a collapse requires the sequence in this chapter, because the ordinary methods assume arrangements the collapse has removed.

The Six Forms

1. The business collapse. The enterprise fails, the debts remain, the personal guarantees are called, the household's security is affected, and the standing in the community is altered. Frequently accompanied by the loss of the relationships that were connected to the business and by the man's own sense of having taken his household's security into a venture.

2. The employment collapse. The redundancy, the dismissal, the contract's ending, the position's removal, particularly where it has occurred in a period of general contraction, where the man's age is a factor, or where the position carried the household's arrangements and the man's own standing.

3. The household collapse. The separation or divorce, particularly where it combines with a financial loss, the loss of the house, and the loss of daily contact with the children. This form carries the highest reported load in the material and it combines the losses of Parts III and V with the practical material of this chapter.

4. The health collapse. The illness, injury, or condition that removes the man's capacity to work, his physical arrangements, and, through both, his household's position. Its specific feature is that the instrument through which the collapse would ordinarily be addressed — the man's own capacity — is the thing affected.

5. The legal or positional collapse. The loss of the licence, the registration, the position of trust, the reputation, or the liberty. Its specific feature is the alteration of the man's public account: what was known about him is replaced

by something else, and the community's assessment, described in Chapter 25, becomes the principal practical obstacle.

6. The compound collapse. Two or more of the above arriving together or in sequence, which is the most common form in the case material: the business failure followed by the separation; the redundancy followed by the illness; the bereavement followed by the financial discovery. The compound form is the one for which this chapter is principally written.

The Five Features That Make It Difficult

The instruments are gone. The man's income, network, standing, and household stability were the means by which he addressed difficulties, and they are the matters that the collapse has affected.

The obligations continue. The debts, the maintenance, the household's requirements, the obligations of Part IX, and the expectations of the community do not pause while the man rebuilds. The finding is the reason the first period's tasks are supplied as they are: they are directed at the obligations that must be contained rather than at the collapse as a whole.

The man's judgement is affected. The material of Chapter 27.3 applies in its strongest form: the collapse produces the isolated decision-making that the collapse itself requires the man not to conduct. The finding from the practice material is consistent: the men who make the largest errors in the collapse's first period are the men who conducted it alone.

The audience. The standing material of Chapter 25 applies, and in the collapse's case the audience is frequently real: this is the setting in which men are written off, and the practice material records that the community's assessment of the man is frequently formed in the first months and revised slowly.

The shame. The material of Chapters 8 and 21 applies: the collapse of the arrangement that supplied the man's standing produces the private account described in Chapter 21.2, and the account is generally harsher than the facts.

The Question of Timing

One finding from the practice material should be stated at the outset because it determines the chapter's urgency.

The collapse's first period — from the event to about three months after — determines the shape of the following years in a manner that is out of proportion to its length. The obligations that are triaged, the assets that are protected, the income that is restored, the ally who is engaged, the household that is informed, and the errors avoided in that period govern the reconstruction's starting position. The men in the case material who rebuilt efficiently describe the same finding: *the whole thing turned on about six weeks.*

38.2 The First Period: The Four Tasks

The first period runs from the collapse to about three months after. It has four tasks, and each is small enough to be conducted in the state the collapse produces.

Task One: Safety

What it covers. The man's physical safety and his household's; the immediate risk of any material from Chapter 34.3, including the risk to the man's own life; the shelter, food, and medical care of the household; and the containment of any active danger, including violence, the risk of self-harm, the risk to a spouse or a child, and the risk to a person the man's obligations concern.

Why it is first. Because nothing else can be conducted from a position of active danger, and because the risk categories of Chapter 34.3 are elevated in exactly the circumstances of this chapter. The chapter states the position plainly: a man who is in a collapse and who has any thought of ending his own life should treat the safety plan of Chapter 34.5 as the first task of this period, and the professional contact as the first action.

The specific actions. The accommodation for the following month, which is a matter of the next thirty days and not the next year; the food and the household's immediate requirements; the medical care, including the man's own; the assessment of any person at risk, with the appropriate professional route; and the safety plan in written form.

Task Two: Information

What it covers. The man must establish what has actually occurred, in figures and in facts, before he acts on any of it. The specific content: the assets and their status; the liabilities, in full, including the guarantees, the personal obligations, and the sums owed to family and friends; the income that remains and what is required; the obligations with legal consequences, including the maintenance, the tax, the rates, and the contractual exposures; the position of any joint parties; and the deadlines.

Why it is second. Because the material of this book's preceding chapters is consistent on the point: the man's account of his position and the position itself are generally different, and the difference is generally in the direction of the position's being worse than the man's picture and the man's options being better. The practice material records the same finding in the collapse setting: the man's mental account is generally incomplete in both directions, and the written statement is generally the occasion on which he discovers the assets he had forgotten and the obligation he had minimised.

The specific actions. The written statement, in the form supplied in Section 38.4; the institution's records, obtained where they are obtainable; the professional appointment, being the lawyer, the debt adviser, the insolvency

practitioner, or the financial counsellor, of which at least one should be arranged in this period; and the stopping of all new commitments until the statement is complete.

The rule for this task. No decision of consequence is taken before the statement exists. The rule is the same as the one in Chapters 27.3 and 34.2, and its purpose is the same: the decision that is taken from an incomplete account is generally the decision that produces the next collapse.

Task Three: The Triage of the Obligations

What it covers. The obligations are sorted into three categories, and the sorting is a matter of consequence rather than of preference.

Category A: the obligations that are legally or physically unavoidable. The maintenance, the tax, the court orders, the rates, the obligations secured against property that must be protected, the household's basic requirements, and any obligation whose failure would produce a consequence the man cannot survive, including the loss of liberty, the loss of shelter, or the loss of a professional capacity.

Category B: the obligations that can be deferred, negotiated, or restructured. The unsecured debts, the trade accounts, the facilities, the obligations to parties who can be negotiated with, the arrangements with a period that can be extended.

Category C: the obligations that are moral rather than legal. The sums owed to family and friends, the commitments that were offered without terms, the arrangements of Chapter 33 that the man was carrying. This category must be identified and it must not be addressed before Category A.

Why it is third. Because the man's inclination in the first period is generally to pay the obligations that carry the most shame, which are frequently Category C, while the obligations that carry the legal consequence — Category A — are deferred. The practice material records the consequence precisely: the man who pays his sister and defers the tax has produced a second and larger problem, and the material of Chapter 33′s inventory applies in its most consequential form.

The specific actions. The written list of every obligation, with its category, its deadline, its consequence, and the person or institution to whom it is owed; the negotiation of every Category B obligation by a stated date; the professional assistance for the negotiations; and the standing rule for Category C, which is that it is addressed after Category A and with the disclosure of the arrangement, in the form of Chapter 34.6.

Task Four: One Ally

What it covers. One person who knows the whole position and who is available for the period.

Why it is fourth, and why it is a task. Because the material of Chapters 27 and 35 identifies this as the specific requirement in a collapse, and because the man's inclination is the opposite: to conceal the position until it is resolved, which in the case material produces the twelve-month period of solitary management described in Chapters 34 and 35. The ally's function is not to solve anything. It is the function supplied in Chapter 27.5: a recipient for the material and the correction of the man's own account.

The specific actions. The identification of the person, on the criteria of availability, capacity, and record; the delivery of the position in the honest form, including the parts that are the man's own failure; the arrangement's form, being the times, the means, and the extent; and, where no person exists, the professional route established as the ally of the period.

The additional element for a collapsed man. The ally should be told what the man is not to do, as well as what he is to do: the decision the man is inclined to take too quickly, the asset he is inclined to sell, the borrowing he is inclined to take, the confrontation he is inclined to have, and the amount he is inclined to drink. The practice material records this as the arrangement's most useful feature: the man's error in the first period is generally known to him in advance, and the ally is the mechanism by which it is interrupted.

> **KEY POINT**
> The first period of a collapse runs about three months and it has four tasks: safety, which covers the man's life and his household's; information, which supplies the written statement of the position on which every later decision depends; the triage of the obligations into the legally unavoidable, the negotiable, and the moral; and one ally who knows the whole position and who is told what the man is not to do. The rule for the period is that no decision of consequence is taken before the written statement exists.

38.3 The Seven Errors of the First Period

The errors are described in the order of their cost in the practice material, and the reader should identify the ones toward which his own inclination runs, because the inclination is generally present before the situation that would act on it.

Error One: The Concealment

The error. The man manages the collapse without informing the household, the ally, or the professionals, on the basis that he will resolve it and disclose it afterwards.

The cost. The mechanism of Chapters 34 and 35 in its most expensive setting: the household's arrangements are made on an incorrect account; the obligations that could have been negotiated are not; the assets that could have been protected

are lost; the man's judgement operates without correction for the period in which the largest decisions are taken; and the disclosure, when it arrives, carries the additional material of the period of concealment and the household's loss of trust in the man's account of the household's affairs.

The finding. The men in the case material who concealed describe the outcome in uniform terms: *everything I did in that period that I did alone was wrong, and everything I did after I told her was better than what I had done before.*

Error Two: The Panic Borrowing

The error. The man borrows to meet the immediate obligations: the high-cost facility, the informal lender, the sale-and-leaseback, the additional guarantee, the arrangement with terms that cannot be assessed in the state the man is in.

The cost. The obligation's size and cost, together with the asset or guarantee committed, and, most consequentially, the loss of the man's capacity to negotiate: the man who has taken the high-cost facility has removed his ability to negotiate the original obligation, because the negotiation requires the resources he has just committed.

The finding. The practice material's instruction is unambiguous: no new borrowing is taken in the first period, with the exception of the borrowing required to meet Category A, and that borrowing only where its terms have been assessed by the professional route.

Error Three: The Rapid Sale of the Assets

The error. The man sells what can be sold in order to meet the obligations: the property, the vehicle, the equipment, the raw materials, the household's assets, the land.

The cost. The price obtained, which in a forced sale is generally well below the asset's value, together with the removal of the resources through which the reconstruction would be conducted. The specific case material finding: the man who sells the tools to pay the debt has removed the mechanism of his own income, which is the measure that determines whether the following years contain a reconstruction.

The finding. No asset is sold in the first period except where the professional route has advised it, where the asset's retention produces a risk that cannot be contained, or where the sale is required to meet Category A. The general rule is the one stated in Section 38.4: the assets' identification is a task of the reckoning, and their disposition belongs to the reconstruction's later stages.

Error Four: The Isolated Major Decision

The error. The man takes the decision of consequence — the migration, the career change, the relocation, the marriage's ending, the business's dissolution, the property's disposition — in the first period and alone.

The cost. The material of Chapter 27.3 in its most consequential form, and the specific finding from the practice material: the decisions taken in the first period under the collapse's pressure are, in the men's retrospective assessments, the decisions they most regret. The reason is structural: the man's judgement is degraded by the state, the information is incomplete, the time pressure is generally less than it appears, and the alternatives are unexamined.

The finding. The decision is deferred until the statement exists, the professional has been consulted, the ally knows the position, and the household has been informed. The one exception is the decision required to meet Category A or to address an active risk.

Error Five: The Revenge and the Litigation Impulse

The error. The man pursues the party he holds responsible: the partner, the debtor, the employer, the client, the institution, the relative. The forms include the litigation commenced in the first period, the public confrontation, the report and the complaint, and the correspondence.

The cost. The money, the period, and — the largest element — the man's attention, which is the resource the reconstruction requires and which the dispute consumes for years. The chapter's material on the claim is in Chapter 26.3 and the case in Chapter 26.7: the claim should be assessed on the documents, pursued where it is economic and where its conduct does not remove the resources required for the reconstruction, and placed in the professional's hands rather than in the man's.

The finding. The claim is assessed in the first period and not pursued by the man personally. Where the claim is economic, it is conducted professionally and in parallel with the reconstruction; where it is not, it is recorded and set aside, which the man should do explicitly rather than passively, since the alternative is the years of attention that the case material records.

Error Six: The Drinking and the Numbing

The error. The alcohol, the gambling, the risk, the spending, the screens, and the behaviour described in Chapters 22 and 23, taken up as the means of managing the state the collapse produces.

The cost. The material of those chapters, together with the specific feature of the collapse setting: the numbing is generally accompanied by the man's reduced capacity to conduct the four tasks of Section 38.2, which is the period in which the reconstruction's conditions are established.

The finding. The reader's own report of his state in the collapse period should be treated as information, and the material of Chapter 34.4′s checklist should be applied. Where the pattern is established, the professional route of Chapters 23.5

and 36.5 applies, and it is not deferred until the position is resolved, because the position's resolution requires the capacity.

Error Seven: The Attempt to Restore the Position Immediately

The error. The man attempts to reconstitute his former position in the first period: the new business begun with the remaining capital, the position sought at the same level, the arrangement entered to demonstrate that nothing has occurred, the lifestyle maintained at the previous standard.

The cost. The remaining capital, which is the reconstruction's principal resource, together with the second failure and the additional material it supplies. The specific finding: the man's position is generally not restoreable in its previous form, and the attempt consumes the period and the resources that the reconstruction requires. The material is the practical form of Chapter 28.5′s discussion of the dream's form and content: what the man requires is the content — the income, the standing, the capacity to provide — and the form in which he obtained it previously is generally gone.

The finding. The reconstruction begins at the level the position now permits: the income that is available, the work that can be obtained, the arrangements that can be maintained. The practice material records the men's own accounts consistently: the reduction to the lower starting point was the measure that made the reconstruction possible, and its avoidance is the reason that some men's collapses last for a decade.

38.4 The Reckoning: The Full Statement of the Position

The reckoning is the written statement of everything the man has and owes, and it is the instrument on which the reconstruction's every stage depends. It is conducted over one to three sittings, and it should be conducted with the professional where the position includes legal or debt consequences.

The Six Sections

Section One: The assets. Everything the man owns or has an interest in: the property, the vehicles, the equipment, the tools, the stock, the materials, the accounts, the investments, the policies, the land, the interests in any business or family property, the debts owed to him, and the items of value in his household. Each entry with its estimated value, its status — owned, encumbered, jointly held, in dispute — and its identification.

The instruction. This section is frequently the one in which the man discovers that his position is better than his picture of it: the interest in the family property, the policy, the vehicle's actual value, the debt owed to him that he had written off, the tools.

Section Two: The liabilities. Everything the man owes, in full: the facilities, the trade accounts, the credit arrangements, the guarantees — including contingent guarantees for other parties, which men most frequently omit — the tax, the rates, the maintenance, the sums owed to family and friends, and the obligations of any business in which the man is a partner or a director, in each case with the amount, the holder, the terms, the security, and the deadline.

The instruction. The section should be complete before any decision is taken. The practice material's finding is that the section's completion is generally the point at which the position becomes manageable, because the man's mental account is generally a small number of the obligations and the total is frequently less alarming than the man's fear of it.

Section Three: The income and the requirements. The income that remains, by source and by period; the household's requirements, separated into the fixed and the variable; the obligations of Category A from Section 38.2; and the gap between them. The section supplies the figure that determines the reconstruction's pace.

Section Four: The capacities. What the man can do: the trade, the professional qualification, the skill, the experience, the reputation, the network, the languages, the physical capacity, and the time available. The section is the one the man most frequently omits, and the practice material identifies its omission as the reason that men who are in a financial collapse conclude that they have nothing, while their actual position contains a complete set of capacities that the reconstruction will use.

The instruction. The capacities should be written in the form of what they can produce, since the reconstruction's first stages concern income: the work the man can do, the services he can supply, the market that exists, and the routes to it. This is the material of Chapter 25.3′s record, and its preparation is the first element of the reconstruction's second stage.

Section Five: The obligations of standing. The man's obligations of Part IX: the relatives, the community, the family's arrangements, the association, the church or mosque's obligations, the commitments that he was carrying. This section is written separately and it is not addressed until the reconstruction's later stages, because addressing it in the first period is the mechanism of Chapter 33′s collapse. The section's function is that the obligations are identified rather than denied, and that the man has a written account of what he is deferring, which he can state to the persons concerned in the form that Section 38.2′s Task Three supplies.

Section Six: What remains intact. The section the chapter requires and the one the man does not write unless instructed: the list of what the collapse has

not taken. Its categories are specific and the reader should complete each with the actual material.

The health, where it is intact. The body, the capacity, the sleep, the ability to work physically, the medical position.

The capacities. Section Four, restated in the form of what they are worth.

The relationships that the collapse has not reached. The household, where the collapse has not taken it; the spouse and the children; the friends who have remained; the relatives who have not required anything; the professional network; the men with whom the man's history is shared.

The standing that survives. The man's reputation in the settings where his conduct is known, which is the material of Chapter 25.1′s countervailing observation: the communities of long duration assess conduct rather than results, and a man's conduct is generally not what has failed.

The years. The time available for the reconstruction, which is generally longer than the man believes and which is the resource he has not counted.

The experience. The knowledge of the position, the market, the people, and the failures, which is the material of the record in Chapter 25.3 and which a man who has not been through a collapse does not possess.

The Two Sentences the Section Requires

The reckoning is completed with two written statements, and both are required.

The first: the accurate description of the position. One page, in figures and facts, without either minimisation or catastrophe: what is owed, what is held, what remains, what has been lost, and what the position now is. The statement is the man's own and it is the document he will use with the professional, the household, and the institutions.

The second: the account of the failure. The man's own account, in writing, of what occurred and of his own part in it: the decision, the judgement, the omission, the quality of the arrangement, and the measure of what was outside his control. The material is Chapter 29.1′s classification conducted on the collapse: the error, the wrong, and the tragedy, each stated separately. The statement's function is the one Chapter 38.9 of the case material supplies: the man who has written the account of his own part in the failure is able to act on the position without the account's being applied to him continuously by himself.

38.5 The Staged Reconstruction

The reconstruction has six stages, and the order is mechanical. The reader should establish the stage he is in and should not attempt a later stage's work before the earlier stages' conditions are met.

Stage One: The Stabilisation of the Position

Duration: about three to six months. **The work:** the four tasks of Section 38.2; the statement of Section 38.4; the negotiations of Category B; the arrangements of Category A; the household's disclosure and planning; and the man's safety, sleep, and health.

The stage's condition: the man knows the position in figures, the household knows it, the ally knows it, the professional arrangements exist, and no new obligations have been entered.

Stage Two: The Restoration of Income

Duration: about six to eighteen months. **The work:** the man's income, in the immediate form available: the work he can obtain, the trade's services, the employment at the level the position permits, the small contracts, the temporary arrangement, the second or third source as Chapter 25.3′s material establishes. The stage's content is Chapter 35′s asking applied to work, and Chapter 25.3′s record applied to the man's capacities.

The finding that governs the stage: the first income is generally smaller than the man's previous position and larger than his fear of it, and the stage's function is not the restoration of the man's former standard but the establishment of the flow on which every later stage depends.

The prohibition: no capital-consuming venture, no attempt to restore the former position's form, no borrowing for the reconstruction, until the income flow is established.

Stage Three: The Settlement of the Obligations

Duration: one to five years. **The work:** the Category B negotiations concluded and conducted; the Category A obligations maintained without default; and, where the position requires it, the formal processes — the insolvency, the arrangement with creditors, the consolidation, the renegotiation, the legal process — conducted through the professional route.

The stage's condition: the obligations have a schedule, the schedule is being met, and the Category C obligations have been addressed with the disclosure and the arrangement of Chapter 34.6.

The finding: the settlement is frequently the stage at which the man's position begins to alter in the community's account, because a schedule that is being met is evidence, and the material of Chapter 25.4′s third practice — the conduct within the standard — is the mechanism.

Stage Four: The Restoration of Standing

Duration: two to five years. **The work:** the man's conduct in the settings where his standing is assessed: the obligations kept, the arrangements met, the work performed properly, the community's contributions made at the level available,

the attendance maintained where it was previously declined, and the statement of the position delivered once and accurately, in the form of Chapter 25.8′s Part Six.

The finding: the restoration of standing is not obtained by the demonstration that the collapse was not the man's fault; it is obtained by years of the conduct within the standard. The material of Chapter 25.6′s three prohibitions applies in full, and the prohibition on arguing with the audience is the one that matters most in the collapse setting.

Stage Five: The Restoration of the Relationships and the Household

Duration: continuous. **The work:** the material of Parts III, V, and VII conducted with the position's new circumstances: the household's arrangements reconstructed at the level available; the corrections of the household's account of the period; the friendships retained and, in the case material's consistent finding, the friendships resumed after a long interval; the obligations of Part IX addressed within the terms of the new position; and the arrangements of Chapters 26 and 27 restored rather than abandoned.

The stage's condition: the man is known by his household and by at least one person outside it, and the accounts of the collapse period have been corrected rather than left to the household's construction.

Stage Six: The New Construction

Duration: years. **The work:** the man's own reconstruction, conducted on the material of Parts VI and X: the identity, which is the material of Chapter 24; the measure, which is Chapter 25.5; the dreams, which are Chapter 28′s; the rest, which is Chapter 37′s; the arrangements, which are Chapters 31 and 33′s; and the account of the years, which will be the material of Chapter 44.

The stage's finding: the men in the case material who have rebuilt describe this stage in specific terms: the reconstructed position is not the former position, and it is frequently experienced as better in ways that the man could not have described in advance. The elements most frequently identified are the accuracy of the man's account of himself, the household's knowledge of him, the arrangements that did not exist before, and the reduction of the audience's authority.

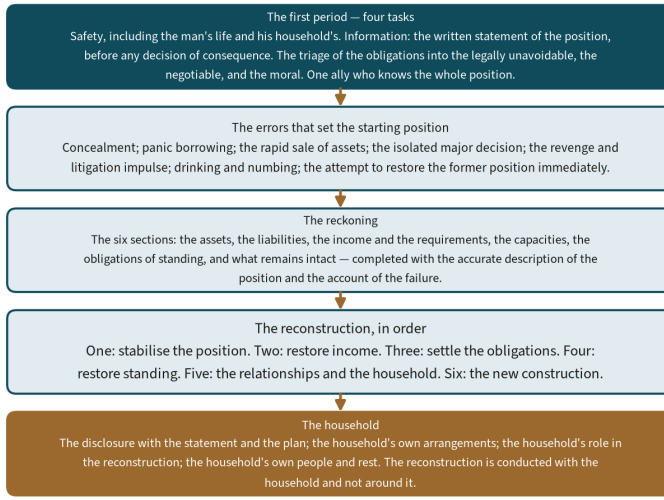


Figure 38.1 Rebuilding after everything falls apart: the four tasks of the first period, the seven errors that determine the reconstruction's starting position, and the six stages of the reconstruction in their order. The diagram is conceptual; the durations are indicative and vary with the position.

38.6 Rebuilding With the Household

The household is the party through which the reconstruction is conducted, and this section supplies the arrangements.

The Household's Position

The findings from the practice material, and the reader should apply them to his own household.

The household generally knows that something has occurred. The reduced expenditure, the man's state, the telephone calls, the visitors, the changes in the household's arrangements, and the man's conduct are all observed. The household's account of what has occurred is constructed from these observations, and it is frequently inaccurate and frequently worse than the position.

The household has its own losses. The financial security, the plans, the house, the standing, the schooling, the occasions, the relationships with the extended family, and the future the household was arranging. The losses are the household's own and they require their own arrangements; the man who addresses the financial position and does not recognise the household's material will find that the reconstruction does not hold.

The household's members have their own conduct in the period. The spouse who manages, the children who select their disclosures, the household's

own arrangements and their costs, and, in the case material, the household member who has been carrying the position for longer than the man has known.

The household's trust is a separate matter from the household's finances. The material of Chapter 20.5: the discovery of the concealment produces the loss of the household's trust in the man's account of the household's affairs, and its restoration is not produced by the financial position's improvement. The restoration is conducted by the arrangements of this section and by the man's conduct over a period of years.

The Four Arrangements

Arrangement One: The disclosure. The four-part form of Chapter 34.6, conducted with the household, with the statement of Section 38.4 present: the position in figures and facts; the man's own part in it, without defence; the consequences that the household has already observed and attributed elsewhere; and what happens next, with the stages and the dates.

The instruction. The disclosure should be conducted before the reconstruction's decisions are taken, since the household's arrangements depend on the position. The practice material's finding is consistent: the household's response is oriented to the plan, and the disclosure without the plan produces the household's anxiety, while the disclosure with the plan generally produces the household's participation.

Arrangement Two: The household's own arrangements. The household's requirements, at the level the position now permits; the changes, stated specifically; the members' own losses acknowledged; and the arrangements the household requires, established with the household's participation rather than supplied by the man. The material of Chapters 18.6 and 20.6 applies, at the level the position allows.

Arrangement Three: The household's role in the reconstruction. The specific contributions the household can make: the spouse's own income or capacity where it exists, the children's arrangements, the reductions that the household decides rather than those the man imposes, the household's own network, and the household's participation in the negotiations and the institutions' processes where that is appropriate. The practice material records the finding plainly: the men who conducted the reconstruction with the household's participation rebuilt faster, and the households reported the position as more manageable, than the men who conducted it as a private project.

Arrangement Four: The household's own people. The spouse's and the children's own arrangements: their confidants, their professionals where required, their groups, and their rest. The material of Chapters 27 and 37 applies to the household members as it does to the man, and the specific finding is that

the household's members are frequently carrying more than the man knows, and that their arrangements are the reconstruction's support rather than its addition.

The Two Errors

The error of the protective concealment. The man withholds the position from the household in order to protect it, on the basis that he will disclose it when the position has improved. The cost is the material of Chapters 34 and 35 in this setting: the household's arrangements are constructed on an incorrect account, its losses accumulate without explanation, and the disclosure's cost increases with the delay.

The error of the reconstruction conducted as a private project. The man informs the household of the position and conducts the reconstruction alone, treating the household as the party to be protected from the process. The cost is the household's exclusion from the arrangements that concern it and the household's own losses unaddressed, which is the arrangement most frequently reported in the case material of the men whose reconstructions did not hold.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in insolvency practice, family practice, and counselling.

Yakubu is fifty-four, a mechanical engineer, married to Zainab for twenty-seven years, with three children aged twenty-four, twenty, and sixteen. Yakubu's position in 2020 was the result of eleven years of construction: a fabrication and engineering services company with about forty staff, a workshop on a site he had developed, a house in a suburb on which a mortgage remained, and a position in the state's engineering community that he described as *a name that people called on*. The collapse occurred over eighteen months. The principal client, a state agency, suspended three contracts in 2019 with about eleven months of certified work unpaid. Yakubu met the company's obligations — the wages, the suppliers, the site's rent — from the company's facilities and from the household's reserves and, in the second year, from a facility secured against the house. In 2020 the agency's payments stopped altogether; the company's facilities were called; the house was under threat; the workshop was lost; the staff were reduced from forty to six; and, in the same year, Zainab's brother, whose guarantee of one facility had been given on Yakubu's request, was affected, which produced the family's involvement.

Yakubu's first period, which he described in the case in the terms of this chapter, contained five of the seven errors.

The concealment. Yakubu did not inform Zainab of the position for about ten months. His account: *She knew the contracts were suspended. She did not know that I had used the house and that her brother had signed. I believed I would get the money in the following quarter and that nobody would ever need to know.*

The panic borrowing. A facility at a substantially higher rate in the fourth month, taken from an informal lender, described by Yakubu as *the worst decision of my life*

and I knew it when I signed it, and I signed it because I could not face the wages on Friday.

The isolated major decision. Yakubu accepted a payment arrangement with the agency that included a substantial reduction in the certified sums, negotiated alone over four months, and which he later identified as the error that reduced the creditors' recovery and his own position.

The drinking. His alcohol use increased from occasional to a nightly pattern of four to five units, described by him as *the only hour of the day in which I was not in that building.*

The attempt to restore the position immediately. In the eleventh month, Yakubu bid for and obtained a contract with a different agency, funded by a further facility, and the contract's margin was consumed by the facility's cost.

The two matters that produced the change were, first, the other lender's demand and the seizure of the workshop, which occurred in the twelfth month, and, second, Zainab's discovery of the position, which occurred when the bank's letter arrived at the house and she opened it. Her account, recorded in the family consultation: *I opened the letter and it was for the house. I read it three times. I was not shocked about the money. I was shocked that he had been carrying it alone, and that my brother's name was in it, and that I had been planning the school fees in my head for ten months.*

The reconstruction, conducted over about four years, had six stages, and Yakubu identified the stage order as the reason it worked.

Stage one: the stabilisation. Conducted with an insolvency practitioner engaged in the second month after the discovery, on the recommendation of a friend in the association, and with the household's disclosure conducted in the same month, in the four-part form, with the practitioner's statement in hand. The negotiations with the facilities, the other lender, and the suppliers were conducted by the practitioner. The position established at the end of the stage: the total in figures, the categories of the obligations, the protection of the house through a rearrangement with the mortgage holder, the arrangement with the other lender, and the removal of the workshop from the position.

Stage two: the income. Yakubu obtained employment as a maintenance engineer at about half his former income in the fourth month, and Zainab, who had trained as a teacher before the marriage, resumed teaching on a part-time arrangement in the sixth month. Yakubu described the stage: *I had been the proprietor of a company with forty staff and I went to work for another man as a supervisor at fifty-one. For the first three months I could not say the word. And the money came in on the twenty-eighth of every month and the household's position changed in the first month of it.*

Stage three: the settlement. The formal arrangement with the creditors was concluded in the second year, with a schedule of payments over four years. Yakubu's account of the stage: *I had avoided the practitioner for eleven months because I believed that the arrangement was the end of me. The arrangement is the thing that has kept the house and the name. I have paid on the twenty-fifth of every month for thirty-one*

months and I have not missed one, and I have a letter from the practitioner after each year.

Stage four: the standing. Conducted over the following three years: the association's meetings resumed and attended, the professional registration maintained, the community's contributions made at the reduced level, the explanations given once where they were required, and no argument conducted with the audience. Yakubu described the period: *There were about nine months in which I did not go to the association, because I did not want to answer. Then a man I had not seen in two years called me for advice on a pump and I went to his site and I gave him the advice, and I have gone every month since. Nobody has asked me about the company. Two men have asked me about the practitioner.*

Stage five: the relationships and the household. The involved elements were the brother-in-law's guarantee, which Yakubu repaid in instalments over three years with the family's arrangement recorded in writing at the disclosure, and the household's own losses, which were addressed at a household meeting in the sixth month at which the family's circumstances were stated: the withdrawal of the youngest child from the private school at the end of that year, the eldest child's contribution, and the house's position. Yakubu described the meeting: *My eldest son said that he had known for a year and that he had been paying the household's electricity from his own salary without telling me. My wife said that she had been teaching for four months and had not told me because she did not want me to know that she had needed to. We had three people carrying the same thing in one house, each one hiding it to protect the others, and the meeting was the first hour in about two years in which everybody said what was actually happening.*

Stage six: the new construction. In the fourth year, Yakubu established two arrangements: a monthly supervision arrangement with a practitioner, from the alcohol and the position, and a small partnership with two former employees for the workshop's services on a reduced scale, conducted with written terms after the association's advice. His account: *The company is not coming back and I do not want it back in that form. I have three pages of terms with the two men and the terms were my own condition, after eleven years of doing everything on a handshake and a name. And what I have that I did not have in 2019 is a wife who knows the accounts, a son who tells me what he is paying, a group of men who have each been where I went, and a practitioner who has the whole of it. I would not have traded the company for those four things in 2019 and I would not trade them back for it now.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

Five of the seven errors were present, and the man's own account identified each precisely. The concealment, the panic borrowing, the isolated decision, the drinking, and the attempt to restore the position immediately. The case is included because the errors are registered by the man himself in retrospect, which is the reason Section 38.3 is written for the reader in the first period rather than for his judgment afterwards.

The collapse removed the instruments through which it would have been addressed. The company, the workshop, the house's security, the agency's relationship, the reserves, and — through the brother-in-law's guarantee — the family's standing. This is the definition of Section 38.1 in practice, and the case is included because the sequence of losses is the reason a partial method does not address a total collapse.

The household was carrying the position and concealing its own conduct. The wife's teaching, the son's electricity payments, and the man's concealment. The case records the household meeting's finding in the man's own words: three people carrying the same thing in one house, each hiding it to protect the others. This is the material of Chapter 34.6′s mechanism in its strongest form, and the case is included because the arrangement's function is to end exactly this arrangement.

The stages were conducted in order, and the man identified the reason. The practitioner and the statement first, then the income — including the employment at half the former income — then the settlement schedule, then the standing, then the relationships, then the new construction. The case is included because the order is the chapter's principal instruction, and because the man's account supplies its mechanism: the settlement is what kept the house and the name, and the income flow was the condition of the settlement.

The reconstruction was not the restoration of the former position. The company was not reconstituted; the position at fifty-four is smaller, differently arranged, and, in the man's own accounting, preferable: the terms in writing, the household that knows the accounts, the group, and the practitioner. This is the material of Section 38.5′s sixth stage, and it is the finding that most frequently distinguishes the men whose reconstructions hold from the men whose collapses continue.

38.7 Practical Exercise: The Statement and the Reconstruction Plan

This exercise is conducted over several sittings and, where the position includes legal or debt consequences, with a professional. It has four parts.

Part One: The First Period Audit (Sitting One)

Section A: The four tasks.

The task	What it requires in my position	What I have done	The date
Safety (including the safety plan where any item of Chapter			

The task	What it requires in my position	What I have done	The date
34.4's first group applies)			
Information (the written statement)			
The triage of the obligations			
One ally			

Section B: The errors. From the seven in Section 38.3, record which you have committed and which you are currently inclined toward. For each inclination, record the ally who knows it and the sentence you have asked them to use with you.

Section C: The safety question. Apply the checklist of Chapter 34.4 in full. Where any item from the first group is present, conduct Chapter 34.5 before continuing.

Part Two: The Statement (Sittings Two and Three)

Complete the six sections of Section 38.4.

Section one: the assets.

The asset	Estimated value	Owned / encumbered / joint / disputed	The identification

Section two: the liabilities.

The obligation	The amount	The holder	The terms	The security	The deadline

Section three: the income and the requirements. The income by source; the household's fixed and variable requirements; the Category A obligations; and the monthly gap or surplus.

Section four: the capacities. What I can do and what it can produce, in the form of the work, the service, the market, and the route.

Section five: the obligations of standing. The list, written, with what I am deferring and for how long.

Section six: what remains intact. Complete each category with the actual material: the health; the capacities; the relationships the collapse has not reached; the standing that survives; the years; the experience.

Then write the two sentences.

The accurate description of the position. One page, in figures and facts.

The account of the failure. My own part, classified: the error, the wrong, and the tragedy, each stated separately and without the other two mixed into it.

Part Three: The Triage (Sitting Four)

The obligation	Category A / B / C	The deadline	The consequence of failure	The action and the date

The rule for the period: no new obligations; no asset disposed of without the professional route; no decision of consequence before the statement exists; the Category C obligations disclosed and scheduled in the form of Chapter 34.6 and not paid first.

Part Four: The Reconstruction Plan (Sittings Five and Six)

The stage	What it consists of in my position	The condition that ends it	The date
One: the stabilisation of the position			
Two: the restoration of income			
Three: the settlement of the obligations			
Four: the restoration of standing			
Five: the relationships and the household			
Six: the new construction			

The household's arrangements. Write the four arrangements of Section 38.6: the disclosure with the statement; the household's own arrangements at the level the position permits; the household's role in the reconstruction; and the household's own people and rest.

38.8 Common Questions Men Ask

"I have not told my wife. Is there any way to avoid that?"

The chapter's position is that the household's arrangements depend on the position, and that the household is constructing an account of the period in any case from the reduced expenditure, the man's state, and the changes it observes. The delay's cost is the material of Chapter 34.2: the account becomes more

difficult to deliver, the household's arrangements are made on an incorrect basis, and the trust's restoration is a separate matter that requires the years. The men in the case material who delivered the disclosure with the statement and the plan report the household's response as oriented to the plan, and the response to the delay as directed at the concealment rather than at the position.

"I cannot face the professionals. The bank, the practitioner, the creditors."

The professional route is established to conduct exactly this work, and its function is that the man is not required to conduct the negotiations personally. The practice material records the finding consistently: the practitioner's engagement is generally followed within weeks by a reduction in the position's size and in the man's own state, and the element men most frequently identify as decisive is that the position became a matter of figures held by somebody who was not ashamed of it.

"If I take the employment at half of my former income, everyone will see that I have failed."

The audience will see what the man's conduct over the following years supplies. The material of Chapter 25.6′s three prohibitions applies, and the case material is consistent: the men who took the reduced position and rebuilt describe the period of the reduced position as the point at which the recovery began, and the men who refused it describe the years of the attempt to restore the former form.

"My family expects me to continue the contributions. I cannot."

The material of Chapters 33.4 and 38.4′s fifth section applies: the obligations are listed, the disclosure is made once with the arrangement, and the reduction is stated in specific terms. The case material records the finding plainly: the family's capacity is generally present and unexamined, and the collapse is frequently the occasion on which the family's contributions appear. Where they do not, the man has conducted the disclosure accurately and the obligation is a matter of the family's record rather than of his concealment.

"How long does the reconstruction take?"

The stages' indicative durations are supplied in Section 38.5: the stabilisation in three to six months, the income in six to eighteen, the settlement in one to five years, the standing in two to five, and the relationships and the new construction continuously. The men in the case material describe the whole in terms of four to seven years for the practical position and longer for the standing. The reader should note the finding of Section 38.1: the first three months govern the starting position, and that is the period in which the chapter's instruction is the most valuable.

"What if the position is genuinely irrecoverable — the health, the capacity, the age?"

Then the material of Chapters 24, 28, and 36 applies in its full form, and the reconstruction is conducted on the capacities that remain rather than on the capacities that were lost. The practice material records the finding in the cases of men whose capacity was removed by injury or illness: the reconstruction is constructed on a reduced position, on the man's remaining capacities, and on the arrangements of Parts VI and X, and the men's own accounts describe the outcome in the terms of Chapter 38.5′s sixth stage. The chapter's instruction on the point is that the recounting of the capacities in Section 38.4′s fourth section is not a formality, and that a man who has concluded that he has nothing should have the section reviewed by the ally and the professional before accepting his own assessment.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 38 in brief. A total collapse is a loss of the man's standing arrangements in two or more domains at once, in a manner that has removed the structure through which he would ordinarily address any one of them. Its forms are the business collapse, the employment collapse, the household collapse, the health collapse, the legal or positional collapse, and the compound collapse. Its five features are that the instruments are gone, the obligations continue, the man's judgement is affected, the audience is real, and the shame is present — and its first three months govern the shape of the following years.

The first period has four tasks: safety, covering the man's life and his household's, with the safety plan of Chapter 34.5 where any item of the first group applies; information, the written statement of the position, with no decision of consequence taken before it exists; the triage of the obligations into the legally unavoidable, the negotiable, and the moral, with the moral obligations disclosed and scheduled rather than paid first; and one ally who knows the whole position and who is also told what the man is not to do. Seven errors must be avoided: concealment, panic borrowing, the rapid sale of assets, the isolated major decision, the revenge and litigation impulse, drinking and numbing, and the attempt to restore the former position immediately.

The reckoning is the written statement in six sections — the assets, the liabilities, the income and the requirements, the capacities, the obligations of standing, and what remains intact — completed with two sentences: the accurate description of the position, and the man's own account of the failure classified into the error, the wrong, and the tragedy. The reconstruction proceeds in six stages in a fixed order: the stabilisation of the position, the restoration of income, the settlement of the obligations, the restoration of standing, the restoration of the relationships and the household, and the new construction. The order is mechanical rather than tempera-

mental, and its mechanism is arithmetic: the settlement requires the income, the standing requires the settlement, and the largest opportunities require the standing. The reconstruction is conducted with the household and not around it. The household generally knows that something has occurred; it has its own losses; its members have their own conduct in the period and are frequently carrying more than the man knows; and the household's trust in the man's account of its affairs is a separate matter requiring its own restoration. The four arrangements are the disclosure with the statement and the plan, the household's own arrangements at the level the position permits, the household's role in the reconstruction, and the household's own people and rest. The two errors are the protective concealment and the reconstruction conducted as a private project. The reconstructed position is not the former position, and the men who have rebuilt describe its advantages in terms that they could not have described in advance: the accuracy of their account of themselves, their household's knowledge of them, the arrangements that did not exist before, and the reduction of the audience's authority over them.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the first-period audit. Which of the four tasks have you conducted, and which of the seven errors are you currently inclined toward?
2. Complete the statement's six sections. What did section one contain that you had forgotten, and what did section four contain that you had not counted?
3. Write the account of the failure in its three classes. Where have you been applying the wrong or the tragedy to a matter that was an error, or the reverse?
4. Complete the triage. Which Category C obligation have you been paying before Category A, and what has it cost?
5. Name the ally and record the sentence you have asked them to use with you. What is the decision you are inclined to take too quickly, and does the ally know it?
6. Write the household's four arrangements. What are the household's own losses, and what arrangements do its members require?
7. Which stage are you in, and what is the condition that must be met before the next stage's work is attempted?

Further Reading

- **On insolvency and debt:** the practice literature on personal and business insolvency, on arrangements with creditors, and on debt advice, including the findings on which routes produce better outcomes and on the consequences of early as against late engagement with creditors.

- **On business failure:** the research on business failure and on the personal consequences for proprietors, including the findings on the financial and psychological effects, on the recovery of the proprietor's subsequent income, and on the factors that predict a better outcome.
- **On redundancy and unemployment:** the literature on job loss, including the findings on the effects on health and on the household, the evidence on the value of early re-employment even at reduced income, and the material on the reconfiguration of identity after a position is lost.
- **On rebuilding after disaster and adversity:** the research on recovery after major adversity, including the findings on the factors associated with recovery, on the role of the man's account of the event, on social support, and on the evidence concerning the reconstruction of identity.
- **Practical resources:** insolvency practitioners, debt advisers, and credit counselling; legal advice on guarantees, contract, and family property; employment services; family and relationship counselling; men's groups; and the material in Appendices D, P, and R.

39 CHAPTER

Becoming Emotionally Strong Without Becoming Emotionally Cold

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the false choice between strength and warmth, and explain why men are offered it.
2. Trace the process by which a man becomes emotionally cold, and identify the point in the process at which he currently stands.
3. Analyse the five costs of coldness, including its effects on his marriage, his children, his own perception, and his judgement.
4. Define emotional strength in the terms used in this book, and distinguish it from stoicism, bluntness, and aggression.
5. Apply the six practices that build and maintain it, in the man's own form.
6. Treat warmth as a discipline of conduct rather than as a feeling to be waited for, and construct the arrangements that maintain it.

Introduction

A man who has been injured in the arrangements described in the earlier parts of this book arrives at a specific position, and it is a rational position. He has learned that the expression of what he feels is met with a cost, that the disclosure of his material is met with consequences, that his softness is used against him, and that the reliable conduct available to him is the composed exterior. He therefore constructs it, and his competence increases as the warmth decreases.

The construction produces two outcomes, and the culture has named only one of them. The first is a man who is steady, reliable, unshakeable, and available in a crisis. The second, which arrives with the first and which is generally discovered late, is a man who cannot be reached by the people who live with him, who cannot be moved by what would ordinarily move him, and who has lost the perception of his own state because he has spent years refusing to register it.

This chapter concerns the point at which strength becomes coldness and how a man acquires the first without the second.

The chapter's approach has five commitments.

The first is that the difficulty is genuine. Men are offered a false choice by their environments: the man who feels is treated as unreliable, and the man who does not feel is treated as strong. The chapter does not treat the men who took the second position as fools; they took it for reasons, and their reasons were frequently accurate. The purpose of the chapter is to establish that the choice is false and that the position between the two extremes is not a compromise but a third thing with its own competence.

The second is that coldness is a process and not a trait. Men are not cold by nature; they are cold by arrangement, and the arrangement can be described. Section 39.2 traces it, and the reader should be able to identify the point at which his own process stands, because the practices in Section 39.5 differ by stage.

The third is that the costs of coldness are borne by others and are visible to them. The chapter's material on the wife who lives with a man who is present and unreachable, on the children who learn to select their disclosures, and on the household that organises itself around the man's state is the strongest available evidence, and the reader should apply it to his own household during the reading rather than afterwards.

The fourth is that emotional strength is definable, is composed of competences, and is learnable. Section 39.4 supplies the definition and the four competences, and Section 39.5 the practices. The claim is not that the work is easy for men; it is that the work is describable in the terms this book has used throughout — an arrangement, a practice, a set of specific acts — rather than as a temperamental change.

The fifth is that warmth is a discipline. This is the chapter's practical centre, and it is the finding that men report as the most useful: warmth is not a feeling that arrives and is therefore not something to be waited for. It is a set of specific acts — the attention, the appreciation, the touch, the remembering, the presence — and the acts are available to a man in any state. The men who conducted them report that the feeling follows the conduct, which is the reverse of the arrangement they had assumed.

39.1 The False Choice

The choice offered to men is stated in many forms, and its structure is the same: **the man may be strong or he may be warm, and the two are alternatives.**

The Eight Forms of the Offer

1. *A man who cries in front of his wife will not be respected in his own house.*
2. *You cannot carry that position and be soft about it.*

3. *Feelings are for women; men deal with facts.*
4. *If you let them see that it affects you, they will use it.*
5. *A strong man does not complain.*
6. *Do not bring your work home and do not take your feelings to work.*
7. *He is too emotional for this role.*
8. *He has become a different man since the loss — he used to be dependable.*

The offers are delivered by the man's environment, generally with goodwill; they are frequently supported by the man's own experience; and they are supported by the consequences described in the previous chapters of this book, in which the disclosure of material did carry costs and in which the composed exterior did preserve the man's position.

The Three Errors of the Offer

The first error: it treats the choice as a matter of degree rather than of kind. The offer assumes that strength and warmth lie at the two ends of a single scale, and that a man's movement toward one is his movement away from the other. The position is inaccurate, and the research on emotional competence identifies the pattern that the offer obscures: the capacity to register, to regulate, and to express states appropriately, and the capacity to act reliably under pressure, are separate competences. They are associated with each other in most people, and the man who loses one does not thereby acquire the other; he loses both, and the strength he has constructed is a specific and narrow competence — the management of his own conduct under pressure — purchased at the cost of the others.

The second error: it treats the composed exterior as strength rather than as an arrangement. The composed exterior is a technique. It performs the function of protecting the man's position and his standing, and it is genuinely effective for that purpose. The offer converts the technique into an identity: what was a conduct in a setting becomes a description of the man, and the arrangement is then maintained in settings in which it has no function — including the marriage, the household, the friendship, and the man's own account of himself.

The third error: it omits the costs. The offer is stated as a trade of warmth for strength, and the trade's actual terms are different. What is surrendered is the capacity to register states, in himself and in other people; the capacity to regulate; the capacity to be known; the capacity to perceive what is happening in the settings where he is responsible; and, in the case material, the capacity to know what he wants. The position is not a trade of a small good for a large one. It is a trade of a large good for the appearance of one.

The Evidence for the Position Between the Two

The chapter establishes the position with three findings, and each is available to the reader in the material of this book.

The research on men's emotional competence and its outcomes. The literature on emotional awareness and regulation reports consistent associations with mental health, relationship satisfaction, occupational effectiveness, and physical health, and the associations are in the direction of the higher competence producing better outcomes in each. The competence is not opposed to strength; the men with the highest measured capacity for reliability under pressure are not the men with the lowest emotional awareness.

The material on men's relationships. The findings in Chapters 26 and 27 establish that the disclosure function is the strongest single predictor of men's resilience, and that the men who lack it are the men who cannot be reached. The composed exterior does not produce the arrangements that protect men; it removes them.

The case material of this book. The men described in these chapters who are functioning well in their households are, in the accounts of their own families, men who are both reliable and known. The reader who considers his own household will find the same finding in his own material: what the household requires of him is not warmth instead of strength and not strength instead of warmth, but his presence as a person in the arrangements he is conducting.

The Third Position

The chapter's subject is a third position, and it is not the midpoint of the scale. Its description, in the terms the case material supports:

A man who can register what he feels, who can regulate it, who can state it in the settings in which stating it is useful, who can hold it privately where holding it is required, and who is fully available to the people who are entitled to him — while acting reliably, making decisions, and carrying what he carries.

The position is unremarkable, it is held by a substantial proportion of men, and its components can be described and practised. The chapter's task is their description.

> **KEY POINT**
> Men are offered a false choice: that a man may be strong or he may be warm. The offer treats the two as ends of a single scale, converts a technique of conduct into an identity, and omits the costs of the trade. The position between the two is a third thing rather than a compromise, and it is composed of competences that can be described: registering what one feels, regulating it, stating it where stating it is useful,

> holding it where holding it is required, and remaining fully available to the people who are entitled to one — while continuing to act, decide, and carry.

39.2 How a Man Becomes Cold

The process is consistent across the case material, and it has six stages. The reader should locate his own position before conducting Section 39.5′s practices, because the practices that apply at the third stage are not the practices that apply at the sixth.

The Six Stages

Stage one: the man's states are met with a consequence. The childhood in which the expression of fear, grief, or need was met with ridicule, punishment, or the parent's inability to hold it; a household in which the man's father was cold; an environment in which boys who showed distress were treated as weak. The stage's finding is the man's first lesson: the expression of a state produces a worse outcome than its concealment.

Stage two: the man acquires the technique. He learns to present the composed exterior: at school, at the training, in the trade, in the household, in the profession. The technique is effective and it is rewarded, and the stage's finding is that the man's competence increases and his standing improves. The reader should note that this stage is the one at which the arrangement is deliberate and effective, and that the process's problem is not the technique but its extension.

Stage three: the technique is extended to the settings in which it has no function. The marriage, the friendship, the household, the man's own relationship with himself. The extension generally occurs without a decision: the man's conduct in the settings that require the technique is the conduct he has, and no occasion arises at which he is required to distinguish. The stage's marker is the man's own report in later years: *I could not switch it off. I did not know that it was on.*

Stage four: the man stops registering the states. This is the point at which the process becomes self-maintaining, and it is the stage the chapter's practices primarily address. The man who has not expressed a state for years ceases to identify it accurately: he reports tiredness instead of grief, irritation instead of fear, busyness instead of avoidance, and *nothing* instead of a state that he cannot name. The finding is documented in the research on the effects of the suppression of emotional experience, and men describe the stage in the material's own terms: *I did not know what I was feeling. I knew what I had to do.*

Stage five: the man's states are discharged elsewhere. The material of Chapters 29 to 34: the temper at home, the drinking, the risk, the work, the silence, the severity about small matters, the withdrawal. The stage's specific

feature is that the man's states have not been removed; they have been given a different outlet, and the outlet is generally the household, because the household is the setting in which the technique is not required and in which the consequence is the cheapest.

Stage six: the man becomes the exterior. The final stage, and the one described in Chapters 24 and 37: the account of himself is the position, the technique, the function, and the provision. Nothing remains outside it; the interests, the play, the softness, and the connections have been set down, and the man's own state is available to him only in the negative — the flatness, the exhaustion, and the specific conclusion about his life that arrives in the early hours.

The Four Mechanisms

The process is driven by four mechanisms, and each should be identified separately.

The immediate relief of the numbing. The suppression of a state produces the removal of the state's discomfort, and the removal is immediate. The mechanism is the strongest of the four and it is the same mechanism as Chapter 22′s: the arrangement is reinforced by the relief it supplies in the moment, and the arrangement's costs are paid later and in other currencies. The research on numbing identifies its central finding: **the numbing does not select.** The man who arranges not to feel the grief, the shame, or the fear arranges also not to feel the satisfaction, the tenderness, the pleasure, and the connection, since the arrangement operates on the man's capacity to register states and not on a list of them.

The environment's reinforcement. The composed exterior is rewarded in the settings in which it is required, as Section 39.1 established, and the reward is consistent. The mechanism's specific feature is that the environment cannot see the extension of the technique into the household, and so it cannot correct it.

The absence of an occasion. The fourth stage proceeds without a decision, because a man is not ordinarily required to distinguish between the settings in which the technique is required and the settings in which it is not. The absence of the occasion is the reason that a man's coldness is frequently discovered in a specific event: the wife's statement, the child's withdrawal, the bereavement that the man cannot respond to, or his own conclusion in the early hours.

The example of the man's own father. The inherited form: the son of a cold man becomes a cold man, generally with the same absence of a decision and frequently with a greater determination to provide what the father provided. The mechanism is the material of Chapter 32.1′s fourth source, and the reader should identify it explicitly, because the finding from the case material is that the pattern's

interruption requires it to be named as the father's pattern rather than accepted as the man's nature.

39.3 What Coldness Costs

The costs are five, and the first three are borne by other people, which is the reason the chapter presents them first.

Cost One: The Marriage or the Partnership

The material is consistent across the case material of this book and the research on marriage.

The spouse's position. She lives with a man who is present, reliable, and unreachable. The household's practical arrangements are conducted; the marriage's own content is absent. The specific description, reported by spouses in the family practice material, is that the marriage becomes administrative: the man is consulted about the matters of consequence and is not available for the matters that constitute the relationship.

The specific forms. The conversations that end within a minute because the man has answered; the man's attention which is present but not engaged; the absence of the man's own material, so that the wife carries hers without reciprocity; the absence of his interest in hers; the physical dimension, which reduces without a decision; and the wife's own conclusion, which the case material records in a consistent form: *I am not unhappy about the money or the house. I am alone in the house.*

The outcome. The research on marital satisfaction reports the association that the case material illustrates: the man's emotional availability is among the strongest predictors of the wife's satisfaction and of the marriage's stability. The specific finding for this chapter is that the marriages that end in the case material of men who are not unfaithful, not violent, and not financially inadequate most frequently end on this ground, and that the men describe the ending as incomprehensible to them.

The finding the chapter states plainly. A man's provision does not substitute for his presence, and a man's reliability does not substitute for his being known. The wife who has everything the man supplies and does not have the man is the position that the case material reports most frequently among the marriages of men who are functioning well by every external measure.

Cost Two: The Children

The material of Parts III and V applies, and its specific form for a cold father is as follows.

The children select. The children learn what can be brought to the man and what cannot, and the selection becomes the household's arrangement. The

finding: the children of a cold father describe the same childhood in later years, and the description is generally that he was a good man and that they did not know him.

The sons learn the pattern. The specific and most consequential mechanism: the son of a cold man acquires the man's technique as the model of strength and reproduces it. The finding from the case material is that this is the most frequently reported transmission in this book: the man's father was cold, the man is cold, and the man's son, in his own account, is beginning to be. The chapter's instruction is that the pattern's interruption requires the man's own conduct and not his instruction: the son learns from what the man does with the material of his own life.

The daughters learn something else. The material on the daughters of unexpressive fathers is reported consistently: the daughter's pattern of relationship with men, her own assessment of what she can expect, and the specific difficulty reported in the material where the daughter is required to interpret a man's silence as ordinary conduct. The finding is included because men report the discovery of it at their daughters' marriages and frequently with significant effect.

The grandchildren. The pattern's continuation is the material of Chapter 43, and the chapter's instruction is that the interruption is conducted at the man's own level: the grandchildren's knowledge of their grandfather is determined by the man's children's account of him, which is determined by what the man did in their childhoods.

Cost Three: The People He Leads and the People Who Depend on Him

The material of Part IX applies, with a specific addition: the cold man's organisation does not bring him the information.

The consequence for the information. The material of Chapter 31.1′s second effect is magnified: the staff of a cold leader do not report the difficulties, the morale, the errors, or the man's own conduct. The organisation's information is therefore shaped by the man's temperature, and the man's decisions are made on a selected account.

The consequence for the people. The subordinates, the staff, the household's members, and the community's people are conducted by a man who is reliable and unmoved. The specific finding from occupational practice: the men who work for a cold leader describe the absence of anything to be loyal to, and the finding is not that they resent the man's severity; it is that there is nothing to be loyal to.

The consequence for the man's own development. The material of Chapter 32.2: the cold man's learning is arrested, because the asking requires an exposure the man has arranged not to conduct.

Cost Four: The Man's Own Perception

The cost that is borne by the man and that he reports last, because it is the one he has arranged not to notice.

The loss of the capacity to register states. Section 39.2′s fourth stage. The man cannot identify his own position accurately: he reports tiredness, busyness, and *nothing*; the states that would supply him with the information about his situation are not available to him. The specific consequence for the reader's own position is that his assessment of himself is the least reliable evidence in this chapter, and that the exercise at the end of it should be conducted with the household's material and not only with his own.

The loss of the capacity to be moved. The man's response to what would ordinarily move a person — the child's achievement, the death of a friend, the beauty, the music, the occasion — is reduced or absent. Men report the finding precisely and generally late: *I was at his graduation and I knew that I should feel something and I did not, and I stood there and I clapped.*

The loss of the aliveness. The final form: the life's content. The interests, the play, the pleasure, the anticipation, the curiosity, the desire, and the satisfaction are reduced, and the man's account of his own life is that it is a set of requirements that are being discharged. The material is the case material of Chapter 37.3′s fourth and fifth stages and of Chapter 24′s empty season.

Cost Five: The Loss of Judgement and of the Means of Knowing What He Wants

The fifth cost, and the one that most frequently affects the man's actual decisions.

The mechanism. The material of Chapter 27.3′s isolation applies in an additional form: the man who cannot register his own states cannot use them as information. His preferences, his resistances, his satisfactions, and his unease are the means by which a person knows what to do with his life; a man who has arranged not to feel them decides from an incomplete account, and the decisions he makes are visible to others — the position he takes because he cannot feel his own objection, the marriage he remains in because he cannot register that he has left it years earlier, the business he pursues because he cannot feel the drag of it.

The specific application. The chapter's material on men's requests for advice applies: the man who reports that he does not know what he wants generally has a position and cannot read it. The finding from the case material is that the capacity returns with the work: the men who conduct the practices of Section 39.5 report that their preferences return, generally first in the physical and practical domains and then in the larger matters.

39.4 What Emotional Strength Actually Is

The definition and the competences. The chapter supplies them in operational terms, because the word *strength* has been used to license conduct that is not strength.

The Definition

Emotional strength is the capacity to register one's own states and other people's accurately, to regulate them, to state them where stating them is useful, to hold them where holding them is required, and to act well in the settings for which one is responsible — with all of it available at once.

Three elements of the definition matter.

It is a capacity, and capacities are practised. The definition supplies competences rather than a state of character, and competences are developed by repetition. This is the reason Section 39.5 supplies practices.

It includes holding. The definition does not require the man to express everything he feels in every setting. It requires accurate registration and appropriate conduct: the man who holds his fear through a briefing and states it to his wife that evening has conducted both parts of the competence.

It requires action. The definition's last element is the one that distinguishes the chapter's position from the opposite error — the man who is expressive and ineffective. The competence is not feeling; it is feeling plus conducting correctly in the position for which the man is responsible.

The Four Competences

Competence One: Registration. The capacity to identify what is present in the man and in the setting: the state, its intensity, its trigger, and its likely effect on his conduct. The practice is Section 39.5's first, and its instrument is language: the man who can name the state has it available; the man who has only *nothing*, *fine*, and *tired* does not.

The specific difficulty for men. The vocabulary. Men in the case material report that they lack words for states that they can nonetheless identify when supplied with a list. The practice therefore employs a list, and the men report that the access to the list is the element that makes the competence learnable: fear, anger, grief, shame, guilt, humiliation, longing, tenderness, satisfaction, pride, weariness, anxiety, disappointment, contempt, envy, gratitude.

Competence Two: Regulation. The capacity to hold a state without either suppressing it or being conducted by it: the breath, the physical channel, the phrase used in the practice material, the pause before the response, and the arrangements of Chapters 22 and 37. The competence's marker is the man's conduct: the state present, the man's response appropriate, and the man's recall of the state intact afterwards.

The specific note. Regulation is not suppression. The distinction in practice: suppression removes the state's availability and produces the costs of Section 39.3; regulation keeps the state's availability and removes the automaticity of the response.

Competence Three: Expression. The capacity to state the material in the settings where stating it is useful, at the level appropriate to the setting, in the man's own form. The forms are those of Chapters 4.6, 27.5, and 34.6: the small delivery, the specific statement, the four-part disclosure, the unit of conduct. The competence's marker: the man has at least one setting in which his states are stated and are received.

Competence Four: Endurance. The capacity to carry the material that has not been resolved, through a period, without either the suppression that removes it or the discharge that dumps it on somebody else. The competence's substance is the material of Chapters 8, 13, and 29.6: the carrying with accuracy, the stated position on self-punishment, the arranged place for the material, and the conduct that corresponds to it.

The finding for the reader. The four competences are ordered and cumulative in practice: registration is the condition of the others, and the case material records consistently that men who attempt expression without registration produce either the discharge or the performance of feeling, and neither is the competence the chapter describes.

39.5 The Six Practices

The practices are set out in the order in which they are conducted, and each is specific. Their purpose is the four competences of the previous section, and their form is adjusted for men: each is brief, each is conducted on a fixed occasion, and none of them requires the man to speak about his feelings in a conversation he has not chosen.

Practice One: The Daily Registration

What it is. Once each day, at a fixed time, the man writes one sentence: what was present in him during the day, named from the list in Section 39.4, together with the occasion that produced it. The practice takes two minutes.

Why it works. The competence's instrument is language, and the practice supplies the language without requiring a conversation. Men report the finding consistently: in the first weeks the sentence is *tired* and *nothing*, and by the fourth to sixth week the man is identifying states that he had not previously registered, generally beginning with irritation and anxiety and proceeding to the material of Chapters 28 to 30.

The specified form. The sentence should contain the state's name, the occasion, and the intensity from one to five. The intensity scale is not an assessment of the man's state; it is the beginning of his ability to read it.

The difficulty. The practice's first weeks are unproductive, and the man's conclusion is generally that he does not have states. The finding from the case material is that the practice should be continued for at least six weeks before it is assessed, and that the assessment's measure is whether the man's vocabulary has increased and not whether his states have altered.

Practice Two: The Physical Channel

What it is. A physical arrangement conducted regularly, in which the man's states are given their physical expression: the exercise, the run, the weights, the walk, the manual work, the labour, the drive, the swim.

Why it works. Two mechanisms are documented. The physiological: exertion discharges the physiological component of the stress response, which is the component that suppression leaves in the body, as Chapter 34.2 established. And the practical: the physical arrangement supplies the man with a setting in which his states are present without the requirement that they be discussed, which is the form that men in the case material maintain most reliably.

The specified form. The arrangement should be regular rather than occasional, and it should be of an intensity at which the man's attention is occupied by the physical matter. The finding: the walk in which the mind continues on the position is not the practice; the exertion that occupies the man's attention is.

Practice Three: The Deliberate Non-Numbing

What it is. One occasion each week in which the man declines the numbing and allows the state to be present: the evening without the drink, the drive without the radio, the hour without the screen, the period in which the man sits with what is present.

Why it works. The competence of registration requires occasions on which states are permitted, and the numbing supplies the opposite in every hour. The practice's purpose is not the man's discomfort; it is the identification of what is actually present, which the practice material reports is generally less severe than the man's fear of it and considerably more informative.

The specified form. The occasion should be bounded — an hour, one evening, a stated period — and the man should record what was present, using Practice One's form. The finding: the first two or three occasions are the most difficult, and the material that arrives is frequently the material of Chapters 29 and 30.

The safety note. Where the material that arrives includes any item from Chapter 34.4′s first group, the safety plan of Chapter 34.5 is conducted, and the

practice is conducted with the professional arrangement in place. The chapter states the position without qualification: the presence of the material is not to be conducted alone when the material is of that kind.

Practice Four: The Repair After Rupture

What it is. The specific, brief, and conducted form of the repair after the man's state has escaped into his conduct: the harsh remark, the disproportionate response, the silence through an evening, the withdrawal.

Why it works. The competence's most consequential application for men, and the one that determines the household's experience. The mechanism: the man's temperature is conducted where it is felt, and the household accumulates the material; the repair conducts the account and thereby prevents the household's construction of it, which is the material of Chapters 17 and 34.6.

The specified form, in four parts and stated within the day where possible: what I did;' what it was actually about; the correction, where one is required; and what the household should understand about it. The men in the case material describe its effect in consistent terms: *I started saying, that was not about you, it was about the office, and the household changed within a month.*

The finding for men who cannot name the state. The practice's third part is the one that matters, and it is available to the man who cannot yet name what was present: *I do not know what it was. It was not about you and I am sorry.* The statement is accurate, it is sufficient, and the case material records its effect on the household's arrangements.

Practice Five: The Arrangement in Which He Is Known

What it is. At least one setting in which the man's states are stated and received: the wife, the friend, the group, the professional, the brother. The material of Chapters 4, 26, 27, and 35 applies, and the chapter's requirement is that the setting exists, since the competence cannot be maintained in a vacuum.

Why it works. The competence is practised in a setting and not in private. The finding from the case material is the one that Chapter 35 established: the man's states become available to him in proportion to their availability to one other person.

The specified form. The arrangements of Chapter 27.5, at the level the man can maintain: the one person, the group, the professional arrangement, the standing occasion. The practice's measure is the competence's fourth element, endurance, which is the capacity to carry the material through a period, and the capacity requires the setting as the material of Chapters 29.6 and 30.6 requires it.

Practice Six: Warmth as a Discipline

What it is. The deliberate conduct of the specific acts that constitute warmth, conducted whether or not the man feels them, at a stated frequency. The acts are supplied in Section 39.6.

Why it works. The chapter's practical centre, and the reason it is placed last: a man who cannot yet register or name his states can conduct warmth as a discipline, and the case material records consistently that the feeling arrives with the conduct. The mechanism is the one the whole of this book has established: the arrangement precedes the state, and the man's conduct in the arrangement supplies the state rather than the reverse.

The specified form. A written list of specific acts, with the frequency at which each is conducted, and, where the man wishes, a statement to his wife and children that he is conducting it. The statement's form in the case material: *I have been present in this house without being in it, and I am going to do specific things rather than promise to change.* The finding from the case material is that the statement and the acts together altered the household's arrangements within months.

39.6 Warmth as a Discipline

The acts. The following register is the one used in the case material and in the practice literature on marriage and fatherhood, and the reader should select from it rather than adopting all of it.

The Twelve Acts

1. The greeting. Conducted on arrival, with the man's attention as well as his presence: the man stops, looks, and speaks. The act's specific finding: the household's experience of the man's arrival is determined in the first thirty seconds.

2. The question about the day, asked and then waited for. The act requires that the man not fill the pause, and the finding from the case material is that this is the single act that most alters a household's arrangements.

3. The appreciation that is specific. Not *thank you for everything*, but the specific statement: *the way you managed that matter with the school was better than I would have done it.* The specific form of the appreciation is the element that makes it received.

4. The appreciation that is spoken rather than assumed. Men report that their appreciation exists and is not spoken, on the basis that it is known. The finding from the spouses in the case material: the appreciation that is not spoken is not received, and the household's account of the man as unappreciative is constructed in the absence of the statement.

5. The touch that is not an approach. The hand, the arm, the shoulder, the brief and ordinary contact. The act's finding: the men who reduced their physical

contact to the sexual dimension report, on conducting it, that the household's temperature alters within weeks.

6. The presence at the occasions that matter to the other person. The school event, the relative's occasion, the friend's funeral, the thing the child is doing. The act's finding: the occasions that matter to the household's members are frequently not the ones the man had identified, and the household should be asked.

7. The remembering. The birthday, the anniversary, the date the man's wife mentioned the matter she was worried about, the child's examination. The act requires an instrument — the written list, the calendar, the note in the telephone — and the finding is that the instrument is not a diminishment of the act but its mechanism.

8. The protection of the other person's time. The act of taking the household's arrangements off somebody: the evening with the children, the errand, the period in which the man holds the household so that a member may rest. The material of Chapter 37 applies to the household's members as to the man.

9. The apology that is not qualified. The material of Chapter 29.5′s rules. The act's finding: the qualified apology is not received and the household's account is not corrected.

10. The play. The act that men most frequently set down and that the household's members most frequently identify as its absence: the game, the joke, the foolishness, the laughter, the nonsense. The finding from the case material is that the sons and daughters of the men in this chapter describe the play's absence before they describe anything else.

11. The statement of the man's own position. The specific act of telling the household what is present in him: the difficulty, the fatigue, the worry, the satisfaction, the pride. The material of Chapters 34.6 and 39.5′s Practice Four applies, and the act's function is that the man becomes a person in the household rather than its provision.

12. The question about the other person's actual material. Not *how are you* but the question that requires an answer: *how has the matter with your mother been this week*; *what is the thing you are not telling me about the school*. The finding from the case material: the household's members will answer this question and will not answer the general one.

The Two Rules

Rule One: The acts are conducted at a stated frequency, and they are not conditional on the man's state. The rule is the chapter's practical centre and its reason is the one that governs the whole of this book: the arrangement

precedes the state. The men who conducted the acts in their worst periods report the finding consistently: the act was available when nothing else was, and the household's arrangements altered while the man's state remained difficult.

Rule Two: The acts are stated to the household, once, in the man's own words. The statement's form is supplied in Practice Six, and its function is that the household should know what is being conducted, since the household's members otherwise interpret the man's changed conduct as a temporary matter or as a tactic.

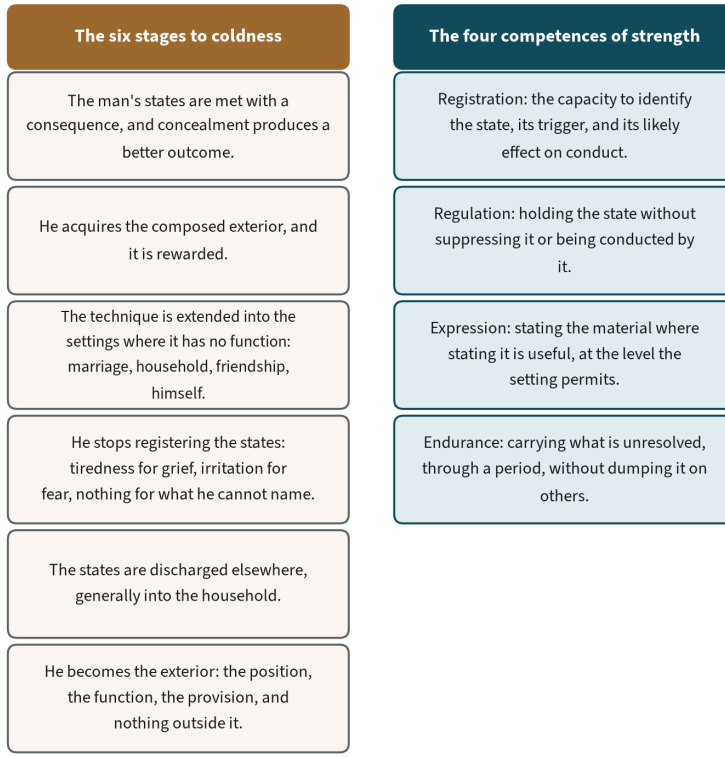


Figure 39.1 Emotional strength without coldness: the six stages by which a man becomes cold, the four competences of emotional strength, and the arrangement in which the competences are practised. The lower band is the register of warmth as a discipline.

39.7 Illustrative Case: The Man They All Respected

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in family practice, marriage counselling, and counselling of men.

Alhaji Musa, called by his title, is sixty-one, a retired deputy director of a state ministry, married to Hadiza for thirty-four years, with five adult children and two grandchildren.

The man's standing in his community, in his profession, and in his family was uniform across every account obtained in the case, including the accounts of his children. He was, in the words used by three separate parties and recorded in the case, *a straight man* and *a man of his word*: he had served thirty-four years without a stain, he had built the family house, he had educated five children, he had carried his siblings' obligations, and he had been the person the community brought its disputes to.

The material at the centre of the case was described by his wife, Hadiza, in the family consultation, in the following terms: *I have been married to the most respected man in this area for thirty-four years and I have been alone in the house for thirty of them. He has never raised his voice. He has never been late with anything. He has never once asked me how I was. When my mother died, in 2009, he arranged everything, and he sat in the front and he did not put his arm around me, and in the evening he asked me about the accounts of the burial, and I went into my room and I put my hand over my mouth and cried so that nobody would hear it in the house, and I have never told him that. There is nothing wrong with my husband. My husband is not there.*

The accounts of the five children, obtained separately, were consistent and each contained a specific detail.

The eldest son, aged thirty-three, an engineer: *I have never in my life had a conversation with my father of more than four minutes. I can tell you the principles. I could recite his principles in my sleep. I do not know one thing that he is afraid of, except that I know, because I was twenty-nine and my business was in trouble, and he gave me the money and he said nothing about it ever again. I have not been able to say to him that I was frightened in that year. He was not interested in that. He was interested in the money.*

The second child, a daughter aged thirty, a pharmacist: *My father has never touched me. I do not mean that anything happened. I mean that in thirty years he has never put his hand on my head. When I got my registration, he said, you have done well. I have that sentence. I have counted the sentences.*

The third child, a son aged twenty-seven who had left the country: *I moved to another continent and I called him and I told him and he said, that is good, do not forget where you come from, and the call was four minutes. When I told my mother she asked me how I was feeling about leaving and she cried on the telephone. I do not call my father. There is nothing to say. I love him and there is nothing to say.*

The fourth child, a son aged twenty-four, described as the closest to the man: *He is my best teacher and I am his project, and I do not know how to be with him when I am not doing something he can approve of. In January I lost my job and I did not tell him. I told my mother. My mother said, tell him. I have not told him. I would rather tell him that I am dead than that I am not working.*

The fifth child, a daughter aged twenty-one: *My father is a good man and I do not know him and I have stopped expecting to.*

The position was discovered through a specific event in the man's sixty-first year. Hadiza, after a period of four months in which the man had retired and had organised his days with the same discipline, told him in the household's parlour that she intended to visit her sister for a period of about six weeks, and gave him a written statement, which he produced in the case. Its central passage: *You have retired and you are now in this house all day and I have to tell you something that I should have said thirty years ago. I am not able to be in this house with you all day. You are not a bad husband. You have never asked me one question about myself and I do not think that you know anything about me, and I have a sister and I am going to her house.*

The work, conducted over about two years, began with the man's attendance at a general practitioner for a sleep difficulty and proceeded through counselling, and had five elements.

The registration. The counsellor gave the man the list of states and the daily sentence practice. His account of the first six weeks: *I wrote nothing for eleven days. I could not find a word. The counsellor asked me what I had felt in the meeting that day and I told her that I had felt that I needed to write something. She said that is not a feeling. I sat there for four minutes and I said, I felt that I was going to be told off, and she wrote it and said, that is fear, and I said, no. And she said, what is it. And I said, that is fear, and I was sixty-one years old and I had not said that sentence in my life.*

The account. The material of Chapter 29.6's first element, conducted over three months, in writing, of the man's own account of his life: his father, who had been a railway clerk and who had died at fifty-eight, whose conduct Musa described in the case document as *he never said one word to me in my life except instructions*, and the man's own sentence, recorded in the document: *I became the man my father was, and I did it deliberately, because I decided at fourteen that I would be a man whose word was his bond, and I did not know that the bond had no person behind it.*

The repairs. Musa conducted the disclosure to Hadiza in the fourth month, over two sittings, in the four-part form, and it contained the material most frequently reported in cases of this kind: the man's own statement that he had not known that she had been alone; that he had provided what he had understood to be the requirement; and that he had not asked her a question in thirty-four years because he had not had any such question in his own household and had not known they existed. Hadiza returned from her sister's house in the fifth month. Her account, given a year later: *He asked me how I was on the first evening. I told him that he had never asked me in thirty-four years and that I did not know how to answer him. He said that I should take my time. He asked me again on the following evening, and on the third evening I told him about my mother and I spoke for about two hours and he did not move.*

The repairs with the children. Conducted individually over about ten months, and the man's description of the sequence is the element most worth recording: *I began with the fourth. He had told me that he had lost the position and he had not*

told me, and my daughter had told me that. I went to him and I said four sentences. I said that I had heard, that I was sorry, that I was not disappointed, and that I did not know how to say anything else. He cried, and I sat there, and then I put my hand on his shoulder and I have never done that to any of my children. He said, in about ten minutes, that he had been afraid of telling me for seven months. I have a son who was afraid of me for seven months and he was in the same town.

The warmth as a discipline. The final element, and the man's own selection within it: the greeting, the specific appreciation, the question about the day with the pause, the touch, and the play. He described the practice's difficulty and its outcome: *The counsellor told me to write the five things and do them whether I felt them and I told her that was dishonest. She said, you have been doing things you did not feel for thirty-four years, except you were doing the wrong ones. In the first month I asked my wife about her day eleven times and every time I wanted to leave the room. In the fourth month I was sitting with her in the evening and I realised that I was enjoying it, and I said the sentence out loud, and she laughed at me for about a minute.*

Musa's summary, two years after the parlour conversation, was: *I was known in this town as a man of his word and I am not giving that up. I have added one thing. I have grandchildren and one of them is three and she runs to me when I come in and I sit on the floor with her, and my eldest son watched me doing that and he said the sentence that I have not forgotten: that his children would run to him. I have been a wall for thirty-four years and I have been told by my own daughter that she has counted my sentences. I cannot recover those years. I can be a person in the years that are left, and I am, and my son is watching me do it.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The man's standing was authentic and the coldness was not a failure of character. By every external measure — his service, his provision, his conduct, the community's assessment — Musa had discharged his obligations completely, and the case is included because the men in this position are the ones least likely to be identified and least likely to be presented with the material. The household's accounts were uniform in their respect for him and uniform in their description of his absence.

The material was a specific inheritance, identified by the man himself. His father, who spoke only instructions, and his own decision at fourteen. This is the fourth mechanism of Section 39.2 and the case is included because the reader's own pattern is generally traceable in the same way, and because the naming of it as the father's pattern is what makes it available to be altered.

The coldness was maintained in the absence of any awareness of the household's experience. The man did not know that his wife had been alone, that his daughter had counted his sentences, that his son had been afraid for seven months of a job loss. The case records the mechanism of Section 39.3′s third cost

in its household form: the household's members conduct the selection described in Chapters 17 and 18, and the man's account of his family's life is therefore constructed from what was brought to him.

The registration was the first competence and it was the hardest. Eleven days without a word, the counsellor's refusal of *I felt that I needed to write something*, and the identification of fear at sixty-one. The case is included because the finding is reported by men in this material consistently: the first competence is the gate, and the vocabulary is the instrument, and the reader who concludes that he does not have states is at the stage the practice's first weeks supply.

The warmth was conducted as a discipline and the feeling followed. The five acts conducted in the first month with the man wishing to leave the room, and the fourth month in which he identified enjoyment and stated it aloud. This is the chapter's central practical claim — that the arrangement precedes the state — and the case's final element is the one that makes it: the son watching the man sit on the floor with the grandchild and stating that his own children would run to him.

39.8 Practical Exercise: The Temperature Audit and the Two Arrangements

This exercise has three parts and takes about three hours.

Part One: The Audit (Sitting One)

Section A: The offer. From the eight forms in Section 39.1, record the ones you received and the person who delivered each. Then record the one you adopted, in your own words, as a statement about yourself.

Section B: The process. From the six stages of Section 39.2, record the stage you are in, with the evidence:

The stage	Am I in it?	The evidence
My states were met with a consequence		
I acquired the technique		
The technique was extended into the settings where it has no function		
I stopped registering the states		
My states are discharged elsewhere — where?		
I have become the exterior		

Section C: The competences. Rate your own position in each of the four competences from Section 39.4, and record the evidence from your last month's conduct.

Section D: The household's material. Ask the questions below of one household member, separately and without defending yourself, and record the answers verbatim.

- When, in the last month, did I ask you a question about yourself and wait for the answer?
- What have you decided not to tell me in the last year?
- When did I last thank you for something specific?
- When did we last do something together that was not a requirement?
- What do you think I am afraid of?

Section E: The costs. From Section 39.3, record the evidence in your own material for each cost: the marriage or the partnership; the children; the people you lead or who depend on you; your own perception; and your own capacity to know what you want.

Part Two: The Practices (Sitting Two)

The practice	The specific form I will use	The time or the frequency	The person who will notice
One: the daily registration			
Two: the physical channel			
Three: the deliberate non-numbing			
Four: the repair after rupture			
Five: the arrangement in which I am known			
Six: warmth as a discipline			

For Practice One: write the state list from Section 39.4 into the notebook or the telephone you will use, and record the first seven daily sentences now.

For Practice Four: write the four parts of the repair, in your own words, and record the sentence you will use when you cannot name what was present.

For Practice Five: name the setting and record the date of the first occasion.

Part Three: The Register (Sitting Three)

Select from the twelve acts of Section 39.6. The instruction is to select five rather than twelve, and to state the frequency of each.

The act	Whom it concerns	The frequency	The date of the first

Then write the statement to the household, in the form given in Practice Six, and record the date on which you will deliver it. The statement should contain: what you have been, what you are going to conduct, the five acts with their frequency, and what you require.

The interview. After one month, ask the same household member the five questions from Part One, Section D, and record the answers. The comparison between the two sets of answers is the measure of the work, and it is the only measure in this chapter that does not depend on the man's own assessment of himself.

39.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"If I start feeling everything, how will I carry the position?"

The concern is the strongest barrier reported by men in this material and it is addressed by the definition in Section 39.4: the competence includes regulation and holding, and the position's requirements are met by the man who registers a state, holds it, and acts. The finding from the case material is the reverse of the man's prediction: the men who conducted the work report that their capacity to carry the position increased, because the states that had been operating outside their awareness — the mounting pressure, the accumulating resentment, the unregistered exhaustion — became available to be managed rather than discharged into their households.

"My father was like this and his father before him. It is in the family."

The pattern is transmitted and it is not a nature. The mechanism is the fourth of Section 39.2, and its correction is the one the case in Section 39.7 illustrates: the naming of it as the father's pattern, the man's own account of the decision at which he adopted it, and the practices. The specific finding for readers who hold this position: the transmission is interrupted by conduct, and the man's children learn the pattern's interruption from his conduct rather than from his instruction.

"I do not want to become soft. My household needs me to be the strong one."

The chapter's definition supplies the answer: strength is the capacity to register, regulate, hold, and act, and the man who registers his grief and acts correctly in his position is stronger in the terms that matter than the man who cannot register

it. The household's requirement is the man who can be relied upon and who is present, and the material of Section 39.3 establishes that the household pays a specific price for the version of strength that omits the presence.

"I am not built for this. I am not a talker."

The practices are constructed for readers who are not talkers: the daily sentence, which is written and takes two minutes; the physical channel; the bounded occasion; the brief repair; the one setting; and the register of acts. The chapter's finding is that men who describe themselves as unable to talk conduct the practices successfully, and that the written forms are generally the route by which the spoken forms become available.

"My wife has been living with this for thirty years. Is there anything left to say?"

The case in Section 39.7 supplies the finding: the disclosure conducted in the fourth month altered the household's arrangements, and the man's wife returned from her sister's house. The specific instruction is Chapter 39.7′s fourth element — the disclosure in the four-part form, with the man's own account of what he had not known rather than a defence of what he had done — and the finding from the case material is that the household's response is generally available even after a long period, because the household has been waiting for the account rather than for the correction of the past.

"What if I do the acts and the feeling never arrives?"

Then the acts will have altered the household's arrangements, which is the first objective. The finding from the case material is that the feeling arrives in the majority of cases and that it arrives with a delay measured in months, and that the men who conduct the acts without the feeling report a specific and unanticipated outcome: the household's conduct toward them changes on the basis of the acts, and the household's warmth is itself the material that returns the feeling.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 39 in brief. Men are offered a false choice: that a man may be strong or he may be warm. The offer treats the two as ends of one scale, converts a technique of conduct into an identity, and omits the trade's costs. The evidence is that the two are separate competences, that the composed exterior is a technique rather than an identity, and that the position between the extremes is a third thing rather than a compromise: a man who can register what he feels, regulate it, state it where stating it is useful, hold it where holding it is required, and remain fully available to the people entitled to him — while acting, deciding, and carrying.

A man becomes cold in six stages: his states were met with a consequence; he acquired the technique; the technique was extended into the settings where it has no function; he stopped registering the states; the states are discharged elsewhere,

generally into the household; and he becomes the exterior. The mechanisms are the immediate relief of the numbing, which does not select among states and therefore removes the satisfaction and the tenderness along with the pain; the environment's reinforcement; the absence of any occasion at which the technique is reconsidered; and the example of the man's own father.

The costs are five: the marriage, which becomes administrative and in which the spouse lives with a man who is present and unreachable; the children, who select what they bring to him and who describe him in later years as a good man they did not know, with the sons reproducing the pattern; the people he leads, whose information and loyalty are altered by his temperature; his own perception, including the loss of the capacity to be moved and of the capacity to know what he wants; and his judgement, which operates without the information his states would supply.

Emotional strength is defined, in operational terms, as a set of four competences: registration, regulation, expression, and endurance. Six practices build them: the daily registration in one written sentence; the physical channel; the deliberate non-numbing; the repair after rupture, stated within the day; the arrangement in which the man is known; and warmth as a discipline. Warmth is the chapter's practical centre and it is a conduct rather than a feeling: twelve acts are supplied — the greeting, the question and the pause, the specific appreciation, the spoken appreciation, the touch that is not an approach, the presence at what matters to the other person, the remembering, the protection of another's time, the unqualified apology, the play, the statement of the man's own position, and the question that requires an answer — and two rules govern them: the acts are conducted at a stated frequency and are not conditional on the man's state, and they are stated once to the household in the man's own words. The arrangement precedes the state; the feeling follows the conduct.

Reflection Questions

1. Which form of the offer did you adopt, and what is the sentence about yourself that you took from it?
2. Which stage of Section 39.2 are you in, and where are your states currently discharged?
3. Complete the household's four questions and record the answers. What did you learn that you had not known?
4. Which of the five costs is most visible in your material, and what is the evidence?
5. Complete the four competences for your own case. Which is the one that is absent, and what does its absence produce in your marriage, your children, and your decisions?
6. Write the five acts and their frequencies, and deliver the statement to your household.

7. Consider a man you know whose father was cold and who is now cold himself. What would the interruption of the pattern require of him, and what would it require of you?

Further Reading

- **On emotional awareness and regulation:** the research literature on emotional awareness, on the identification and naming of states, and on the effects of the suppression of emotional experience, including the findings on the consequences of suppression for perception, memory, relationships, and health.
- **On men and emotional expression:** the research on men's emotional socialisation and its effects, including the findings on the consequences of restricted emotional expression, on the patterns of men's relationships, and on the evidence concerning change in adult life.
- **On marriage and the man's emotional availability:** the research on marital satisfaction and stability, including the findings on the association between the husband's emotional availability and the wife's satisfaction, on the patterns of interaction that predict marital outcomes, and on the evidence concerning change in established marriages.
- **On fatherhood and children's outcomes:** the literature on fathers' involvement and its associations with children's outcomes, including the findings on the effects of the father's availability and warmth, on the transmission of patterns between generations, and on the evidence concerning the interruption of those patterns.
- **Practical resources:** marriage and relationship counselling; individual counselling and psychological services; men's groups; parenting programmes; and the material in Appendices E, F, G, and J.

40 CHAPTER

The Man Who Finally Chooses Himself

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Define what choosing oneself means in this book, and distinguish it from the versions that damage other people.
2. Describe the process by which a man's own life is deferred indefinitely, and identify the point at which his own deferral stands.
3. Analyse the four losses the deferral produces, including the loss of the capacity to know what he wants.
4. Apply the four permissions that men require, and test each against his own account of himself.
5. Conduct the audit of the second half of life: the list of what he will keep, what he will set down, and what he will take up, together with the conversations each requires.
6. Make the specific choices that a man's own life requires, using the criteria in Section 40.7, and conduct them without requiring the agreement of everybody affected.

Introduction

This chapter's title can be misread, and the misreading must be addressed at the outset because it is the reason that many men reject the material before examining it.

Choosing oneself, in this book, does not mean the abandonment of the people a man is responsible for. It does not mean the affair, the departure, the spending, the pursuit of the man's pleasure at his household's expense, or the reconstruction of his life on his own terms while the obligations of Parts III to V are left standing. The material of this book has been written against that pattern throughout: Chapter 33 established the obligations a man actually owes, Chapter 20 established the unspoken ledger, Chapter 26 established what a man owes the people who have relied on him, and Chapter 29 established the repairs.

What the chapter means is the opposite of that pattern, and it is the position the reader arrives at when the material of this book has been conducted.

Choosing oneself means that the man's own life is one of the items the man is responsible for, that it is placed on the ledger with the other items, and that it is not the last item to be funded.

Three findings from the case material establish why the chapter is placed here and why it is required.

The men in this book have been choosing everything except themselves, and they have done it competently. The obligations of Parts III to V, the work, the family, the community, the load of Chapter 33, and the dreams of Chapter 28 have been conducted in an arrangement in which the man's own life is what remains after the other items are funded — and the arithmetic, as the case material records, does not leave a remainder. The consequence is the position described in Chapters 24, 37, and 39: the man arrives at fifty-five, sixty, or sixty-five, and reports that he does not know what he wants, that he has no arrangements of his own, and that the years that remain are not identified as his.

The deferral is produced by a rule rather than by the man's circumstances. The rule is the one examined in Chapters 25 and 37: that worth is measured by what a man provides and that the man's own requirements are, by comparison, illegitimate. The rule is the reason that a man's own life is deferrable indefinitely, and it is the material of Section 40.2.

The choice is available and it is not the abandonment of anything. The audit in Section 40.5 has three lists rather than one, and the first is what the man will keep. In the case material of this chapter, the men who conducted the audit found that the majority of their obligations survived it, that a substantial minority were released with an arrangement rather than a rupture, and that a small number — generally two or three items — were the items that had consumed the man's own life without being either owed or wanted.

The chapter's approach has four further commitments.

The permission is internal. Section 40.4 is written as four permissions, and the finding from the case material is that the permissions are not available from the environment: the household generally requires the man's continuation in the arrangement, the family requires his assistance, the organisation requires his availability, and the culture requires the provision. The permission is granted in the man's own account, and the chapter supplies the argument by which it is granted.

The choice must be conducted in the arrangement rather than announced. The men whose changes held negotiated them: the timing, the disclosure, the arrangement, and the periods of transition. The men whose changes failed announced them and required the household's agreement, which is the

pattern in which the change is met with the household's resistance and the man's own resentful withdrawal.

Some people will resist, and the resistance is frequently legitimate. The chapter records this finding honestly: the household that has been arranged around the man's provision has its own interest, and a member of the extended family whose obligation the man has been carrying has a real stake. The arrangement should be constructed with those interests stated rather than with the claim that the man deserves his own life, which is true and not an argument in a negotiation.

The choice is conducted in the years that remain. The chapter's practical orientation is the second half of the man's life: what he will do with it, whom he will be for, what he will keep, and what he will finally undertake. The material of Chapter 28′s sixth section and Chapter 36′s fourth condition supplies the substance, and the chapter's task is the man's decision that the years are his.

40.1 What Choosing Yourself Does and Does Not Mean

The section supplies the boundary, and it is the most important material in the chapter because it determines whether the reader can conduct the work or is required to reject it.

What It Does Not Mean

It does not mean the abandonment of the people the man is responsible for. The obligations of Parts III to V are the man's, and the audit of Section 40.5 is conducted on them rather than around them. A man's children's requirements, his household's arrangements, the obligations he has undertaken, and the repairs owed under Chapter 29 are not items that the chapter proposes to release.

It does not mean the man's pleasure as a criterion. The chapter's test is not whether an arrangement pleases the man. It is whether the arrangement is his: whether he has chosen it, whether it is owed, and whether it is the item he would fund if he were conducting the accounting rather than being conducted by it. The distinction matters: a man may choose a demanding obligation and be choosing himself in doing it, provided the choice is his.

It does not mean the ending of a marriage for a better one. The research and the case material on this point are unambiguous, and the chapter states the finding: the man who reconstructs his life around a new relationship while the circumstances that produced his unhappiness are unaddressed generally reproduces them. The specific choices of Section 40.7 include the marriage, and the criteria for it are supplied there and not here.

It does not mean the announcement that he is now putting himself first. The version of the chapter's material that men most frequently report as damaging to their households: the man's statement that he has decided to live for

himself, delivered without an arrangement, which the household experiences as the withdrawal of the man who was providing for it.

It does not mean the abandonment of the arrangements of this book. The measure of Chapter 25.5, the arrangements of Chapter 27, the rest of Chapter 37, and the discipline of Chapter 39 are the man's own life being conducted; the chapter is not a substitute for them but their application to the question of what the remaining years are for.

What It Does Mean

The man's own life is an item on the ledger. It has a cost, a budget, and a claim, and it is placed with the other items rather than after them. Its content: the health, the rest, the arrangements of Chapter 27, the work the man has chosen rather than the work that arrived, the relationships he has chosen rather than the ones that were assigned, the time, and the conduct he regards as his own.

The man's own requirements are legitimate. They are not a reward for the discharge of the obligations; they are items with their own claim. The finding that establishes this in the case material is the one from Chapter 37.5: the man's capacity, judgement, and conduct are the resources through which the obligations are discharged, and the neglect of his own life degrades the resources on which everything else depends.

The man's obligations are audited rather than assumed. The audit's mechanism is the material of Chapter 33.4′s four tests, applied to every item the man is carrying: whose responsibility it is in principle, whose capacity it is, whether it is his to do or to make possible, and what it costs the people he is responsible for. The audit's output is three lists rather than one, and the case material's finding is that the second list — what the man will set down — is generally smaller than he expects and the third — what he will take up — is the one that has been empty for years.

The man's own preference is information that he is required to have. The finding of Chapter 39.3′s fifth cost: the man who cannot register his own states cannot use them as information about his life. The chapter's preliminary condition is therefore the work of Chapter 39.5, and the reader who reports that he does not know what he wants should conduct the registration practice before conducting the audit, since the audit requires the material that the practice supplies.

The choice is conducted in the years that remain and not in the years that were lost. The material of Chapter 28.5 applies in full: what is available now, in the actual circumstances, with the actual capacities and the actual obligations. The chapter's finding is that men who conduct the audit discover that the

available items are more numerous than the losses they have been counting, and that the losses' significance reduces when the available items are taken up.

The Test of the Two Versions

The chapter supplies a test by which the reader can establish whether the work he is conducting is the version this book describes or the version that damages people.

The test: what does the household's position look like at the end of the work?

In the version described in this book, the household's arrangements are known to the household; the obligations owed are conducted; the repairs owed are made or arranged; the man's capacities are maintained; and the man is present in the household in a form the household can describe. In the damaging version, the household is informed of the man's decision; the obligations are reduced without arrangement; the repairs are not conducted; and the household's arrangements are conducted without the man.

The test's second element: **the man's own account of the work, offered to the household.** Where the account is *I have decided to put myself first*, the version is the damaging one. Where the account is *I have been the last item on my own list for thirty years and I am going to be an item on it, and here is what I am keeping, what I am setting down, and what I am taking up*, the version is this book's.

> **KEY POINT**
> Choosing oneself does not mean the abandonment of the people a man is responsible for, the man's pleasure as a criterion, the ending of a marriage for a better one, or the announcement that he is now putting himself first. It means that the man's own life is an item on the ledger with the other items, that his requirements are legitimate rather than a reward, that the obligations are audited rather than assumed, that his preference is information he is required to have, and that the choice is conducted in the years that remain. The test of which version is operating is what the household's position looks like at the end of the work.

40.2 The Man Who Never Chose

The deferral is a process, and its stages are consistent. The reader should locate his own position and, more usefully, identify the specific rule or occasion on which his own deferral is anchored.

The Seven Stages

Stage one: the man's requirements are subordinated early. The childhood in which the man's own wants were not attended to, or were attended to only after the household's other requirements were met; the eldest son's position; the

household of scarcity in which any requirement was a luxury. The stage's lesson is the rule of Section 40.1's rule: the man's requirements are legitimate but deferred.

Stage two: the man's first obligations are accepted. The family's fees, the sibling's school, the parent's assistance, the household's requirements after a death. The stage's finding is the first competence: the man's provision is effective, and its effect on other people is visible.

Stage three: the arrangement is established and rewarded. The man is the one who provides; the family's account of him is composed of it; the man's standing in the community, as Chapter 25 described, is produced by it. The stage's finding is that the arrangement is now an identity and not only a conduct.

Stage four: the deferral acquires a date. The man's own requirements are deferred to a specific condition: when the children finish school; when the house is built; when the business is established; when the position is obtained; when the debts are cleared; when the parents are cared for. The stage's finding is that the condition is generally met, and the deferral is replaced by another condition, which the case material records in almost every instance: *I said I would do it when the last one finished school, and she finished in 2019, and I did not notice that I had stopped saying it.*

Stage five: the man's own requirements are no longer formulated. The most consequential stage and the least visible. The man stops producing the items: the things he intended, the work he wanted, the place, the pursuit, the rest, the relationships of his own choosing. The stage's marker is in the man's language: the requests, the wants, and the preferences disappear from the man's account of himself.

Stage six: the man's own material is not counted. The man's health, sleep, friendships, finances, and time are not among the items he audits or reports to anybody. The stage's finding, from the case material: the man who can give a complete account of his household's position and a partial account of his own, whose own arrangements are unknown to him in figures.

Stage seven: the discovery. The condition met; the retirement; the bankruptcy; the loss; the illness; the wife's statement; the bereavement; the child's departure; the daughter's wedding. The stage's material is that of Chapters 24, 28, and 30, and its presentation is generally the one that brings the man into the arrangements of this part of the book.

The Five Anchors

The deferral is anchored to a rule or an occasion, and the reader should identify his own, because the anchor is what the arrangement must address.

The worth anchor. *I am what I provide.* The anchor is the one examined in Chapter 25.5 and its correction is the personal measure.

The duty anchor. *I am the one who was given the position and the obligation.* Its correction is the audit of Section 40.5, conducted with the four tests of Chapter 33.4.

The fear anchor. *If I stop, everything will collapse.* Its correction is Chapter 37.5′s second part and the arithmetic of the collapse.

The permission anchor. *I have not earned it.* Its correction is the four permissions of Section 40.4.

The identity anchor. *I do not know who I would be.* Its correction is Chapters 24 and 28, and its conduct is the audit's third list.

The Two Findings the Case Material Supplies

The deferral is generally invisible to the man. This is the reason the chapter's audit is a written exercise: the arrangement is conducted competently, the man's account of it is that he has been fulfilling his obligations, and the specific question of what his own life consists of has never been asked. The finding from the case material: the men who conduct the exercise discover the deferral's size within an hour.

The deferral is generally incorrect in its accounting. The men who conduct the audit find that a substantial proportion of what they have been carrying is neither owed nor wanted: the obligation that was accepted because nobody else would, the arrangement maintained because it was the arrangement, the position held because it had been obtained, the relationship conducted because the man could not raise the matter. The finding is the reason the audit's first list — what he will keep — is generally larger than the man's fear and the second — what he will set down — is generally larger than he had considered.

40.3 The Cost of Never Choosing

Four losses. The first two are external and the last two are borne by the man.

Loss One: The Lives He Was For

The material. The men in this book who have deferred their own lives have generally conducted the obligations of Parts III to V competently, and the case material records the finding that the people they were for were frequently not required to conduct the relationship with them.

The specific forms. The children who describe the father as a good man they did not know, as Chapter 39 established; the wife who has lived with the provision and not the man; the friends who were maintained as arrangements; the family that received the assistance and not the man; the household whose members selected what they brought to him.

The finding from the case material, and it is the hardest in this chapter. The men who discover the deferral's size at the end frequently report that the

obligations were discharged and the relationships were not constructed: that they were, to their children, the position and the money and the instruction; that the accounts in Section 39.7 are reproducible in their own households; and that the years of provision did not produce the material they had believed the provision would produce.

The corrective. The material of Chapter 39.5′s sixth practice and Chapter 29.6′s fourth element: the repairs, the practices, and the audits. The finding is that the repairs are generally available, that the household waits for the account rather than the correction of the past, and that the years remaining are sufficient for the work — which is the second half of the chapter's material in Sections 40.5 to 40.7.

Loss Two: What Was Not Built

The material. The work a man intended, the business, the qualification, the book, the school, the land, the trade, the practice, the craft, the thing he was going to do. Chapter 28′s material applies in full, and its accounting is the one this section conducts.

The two findings. First, that a proportion of the deferred items are still available: the men in the case material who took up an item at fifty-eight or sixty-two and produced it. Second, that a proportion are not: the qualification whose requirements have altered, the route that has closed, the partnership that has died, the years whose accumulation was the item itself.

The instruction. The audit of Section 40.5′s third list is conducted on what is available. The chapter's finding is that the available items are generally more numerous than the man's account of them, and that the accounting is properly conducted with the ally and with the professional rather than alone — the material of Chapter 30.4′s rule that the man should not audit his own position without an instrument he has not written.

Loss Three: The Capacity to Know What He Wants

The material. The fifth cost of Chapter 39.3, in its most consequential form, and the loss that makes the chapter's own exercise difficult for the reader who has deferred longest.

The specific presentation. The man reports that he does not know what he wants; that he has no preference; that he would not know what to do with the time; that the question is unanswerable. The case material records the presentation in the man's own words: *The doctor asked me what I enjoy and I sat there for a minute and I said, I do not know. I have never been asked that. I do not think I have ever asked myself that.*

The mechanism. The capacity to identify preference is a competence, and it is developed by its exercise and reduced by its disuse. A man who has not exercised

it for thirty years has the position of a man who has not used a limb: the capacity's apparatus is intact and the man's access to it is not.

The corrective, and it is specific. The capacity returns with the practice and it returns in a sequence: first the physical and practical preferences (what he wants to eat, where he wants to sit, when he wants to sleep); then the matters of conduct (what he is willing to do and to refuse); then the larger matters (the work, the place, the relationships, the years). The finding from the case material is that the sequence takes months rather than weeks and that it should be recorded rather than assessed, which is the reason the exercise of Section 40.8 includes the preference register.

Loss Four: The Man's Own Account of His Life

The material. The final loss and the one the chapter's reflection questions address directly: the man's own account of the years.

The presentation. The man's account of his life is composed of the obligations: the children educated, the house built, the position held, the family carried, the debts cleared. The account is accurate and it is not the man's own. The specific finding from the case material: the men who report the position describe the account as somebody else's, and the material of Chapter 24′s empty season is its presentation.

The mechanism and the corrective. The mechanism is the identity anchor of Section 40.2: the man's account of himself is the provision, and the provision is not the man. The corrective is the audit and the choices: an account of a life requires the man's own items, and the items are constructed by the conduct and not by the accounting. The chapter's instruction is therefore that the audit is the beginning and the choices are the work.

40.4 The Four Permissions

Men in the case material report that the barrier to the chapter's work is not the arrangement but the permission: the man does not believe that he is entitled to conduct it. The section supplies the four permissions and the arguments that establish them.

Permission One: The Permission to Have a Life

The statement. *My life is a thing in itself and not the residue of my obligations.*

The argument, in four parts.

Part one: the man's life is the instrument through which every obligation is discharged. Chapter 37.5′s argument in its broadest form: the health, the judgement, the capacity, the relationships, and the years are the resources; the discharged obligation is the product; and a man who consumes the instruments to produce the products is a man who is consuming his own capacity. The case

material contains the demonstration: the men whose health failed under the load of Chapters 33 and 37 discharged fewer obligations in the following ten years than the men who maintained their capacities.

Part two: the man's life has its own term. The years are finite, the deferral's condition may never be met, and the death of Chapter 28′s material arrives in the case material of men in this book at ages between forty-four and seventy-one. The argument is not an appeal to urgency; it is the statement of the position, and the reader's own experience of the deaths in his cohort supplies its evidence.

Part three: the account of the man's life is required. The reflection questions at the end of every chapter of this book, the material of Chapter 24.4, the letter of Chapter 28.5, and the man's own position when his years end. The argument is the material of Chapter 44 in its preliminary form: a man's conduct is a life, and the life is either conducted with the man's participation or without it.

Part four: the people he is for require him as a person. The material of Chapter 39.3′s first and second costs, in the household's own words: the wife who has everything the man supplies and does not have the man; the son who would rather report his death than his unemployment. The argument's form for the reader: the obligations' principal beneficiaries are the people in the household, and the household's accounts, taken separately, are the evidence of what it requires.

Permission Two: The Permission to Not Be Everybody's Solution

The statement. *I am not the solution to every problem in my family, my community, and my organisation, and my pretending otherwise has cost the people who should have had to solve their own.*

The argument. The material of Chapters 33.4 and 33.6: the man's assistance that prevents another person's capacity; the household's material that is consumed by the extended family's requirements; the man's over-availability that produces the organisation's dependence; and the specific finding from the case material that the men who conducted the reduction found that the receiving parties' capacity appeared. The argument's household form: the man's wife and children have a claim on the arrangement that the man's other obligations have been consuming.

Permission Three: The Permission to Be a Beginner and to Be Bad at It

The statement. *I may take up something I am not competent in, in public, at this age, and be seen doing it.*

The argument. The material of Chapters 24.5 and 28.6: the self-measure that makes a man's own pursuits unavailable to him; the competence that has been the man's protection and the reason that he has not been a beginner since his twenties; and the case material's finding that the men who conducted a new

pursuit reported the incompetence as the element that produced its effect. The argument's mechanism: a man's own life consists of the items he has chosen, and an item chosen at forty-eight is an item at which he is not competent, which is the price of the item and not its disqualification.

Permission Four: The Permission to Ask for What He Wants

The statement. *I may state what I want, in the ordinary matters and in the large ones, and the statement is legitimate whether or not it is granted.*

The argument. The material of Chapters 30, 35, and 39.4′s third competence: the man's requests, at the level of the practice material in Chapter 35.4, conducted in the four-part form; the finding that men's first contact with the material's sources follows a prolonged silence; and the specific finding of the case material for this chapter: the men who stated what they wanted to their households reported that the household's response was generally available, and that the household's own arrangements had frequently been waiting for the man's statement in order to be constructed.

The permission's distinction. Stating what he wants is not the same as requiring that it be granted. The chapter's rule: the statement is the man's responsibility and the answer is not.

40.5 The Audit of the Second Half

The exercise is conducted in one page of three lists, and its purpose is to establish what the man's remaining years consist of him doing. The form is supplied in Section 40.8; the section here supplies the four questions that classify each item.

Question One: Is It Owed?

The four tests of Chapter 33.4, applied to the item:

Whose responsibility is it in principle? The item's owner. **Whose capacity is it?** Whether the man is the party able to conduct it. **Is it mine to do, or mine to make possible?** The distinction that produces the audit's largest revision. **What does it cost the people I am responsible for?** The household's material, counted.

The classification. Where the item is owed, it goes on the first list with its arrangement. Where it is not owed and the man is merely capable, it goes on the second list, with the arrangement by which the other party's capacity is to be constructed.

Question Two: Do I Want It?

The question of the man's own position, and the one the reader may be unable to answer. The instruction from Section 40.3′s third loss: the answer is recorded as it arrives, without assessment, and where the answer is *I do not know*, the item

is marked and returned to in the following month after the preference register has been conducted.

The distinction the chapter requires. There is a class of items that the man does not want and that are owed: the children's requirements, the household's arrangements, the repairs of Chapter 29, the obligations given. **The chapter's position on this class is not that it should be released; it is that it should be named accurately.** A man who knows that he is conducting an obligation he does not want is in a different position from the man who has arranged not to notice, because the first man can arrange his own life around it and the second is conducting it as the whole of his life.

Question Three: Would I Take It Up Now?

The test of the item's actual claim, and the one that resolves the majority of the audit's difficult cases. The specification: **if the item arrived today, in my actual position, with my actual capacities and obligations, would I take it up?**

The instances. The position held because it was obtained; the relationship conducted because it was begun; the arrangement maintained because it was the arrangement; the community's office accepted in a year the man cannot now identify. The test's function: it supplies the classification for the items that are not owed and not wanted and that have been conducted through inertia, which the case material records as the largest class in most audits.

The caution stated. The test should not be applied to the items of Parts III to V without the four tests of Question One. A man's children's requirements would not be taken up if they arrived today in the sense that no man would choose them; the item is owed, and the test does not apply to it.

Question Four: What Would Its Ending Require?

The question that governs the second list, since the item's release is generally an arrangement and not a cessation. The material of Chapters 33.6 and 35.4: the disclosure, the arrangement, the period of transition, the other party's capacity, and the man's own conduct through the period.

The three forms of release.

The closure. The item ends, and it ends by agreement or by the man's statement. The forms: the community's office, the arrangement, the membership, the irrelevant obligation.

The transfer. The item is handed over: to a sibling, a colleague, a subordinate, another member of the family. The form's requirement: the transfer is arranged with notice and with the transferee's capacity addressed, which is the material of Chapter 33.6′s second part.

The reduction. The item is continued at a level the man's own life can fund. The form is the most frequent of the three in the case material, and the material of Chapter 40.6 supplies the household presentation by which it is conducted.

The Four Categories of the Second List

The audit's second list — what the man will set down — contains four categories, and the reader should record his own items in each.

Category one: the obligations that were never his. Accepted because nobody else would, because it was offered, because the man was competent, or because the other party's capacity was never tested.

Category two: the positions held for the standing. The office, the title, the committee, the association's responsibility, the arrangement conducted for the community's account of him. The material of Chapters 25.6 and 30.5 applies, and the specific finding is that the standing produced by a position of this kind is generally less than the man's estimate.

Category three: the arrangements maintained through inertia. The relationship, the membership, the commitment, the property, the arrangement whose continuation has not been examined. The class recorded by Question Three.

Category four: the man's own conduct that consumes his resources without producing anything. The specific and least examined class: the hours of the position that have grown, the habit, the arrangement of the day that consumes the evening, the screen, the drink of Chapter 22, the competition, the anger of Chapter 34. The class is included in the audit because its items are the ones that are released without negotiation and that supply the largest recoverable amount of time in most audits.

The Third List

What the man will take up. The list that has been empty, and the one the chapter exists for.

The four categories.

The unfinished item that is still available. The qualification, the practice, the trade, the piece of land, the business, the study, the craft.

The item that was never begun. The thing the man intended and did not start. The case material's finding: the class is generally populated and its items are generally small and specific rather than large and general.

The relationship the man will construct rather than maintain. The specific person, and the specific arrangement, in the form of Chapter 27.5.

The conduct that is the man's own. The place, the pursuit, the hours, the rest of Chapter 37, the health of Chapter 23, the practice of Chapter 39.5.

The requirement for the third list. Each item must be specific, dated, and arranged, and it must be recorded in a form that states what the first step is. The finding from the case material: the men whose third list contained items without a first step did not take them up, and the men whose lists contained a first step with a date generally did.

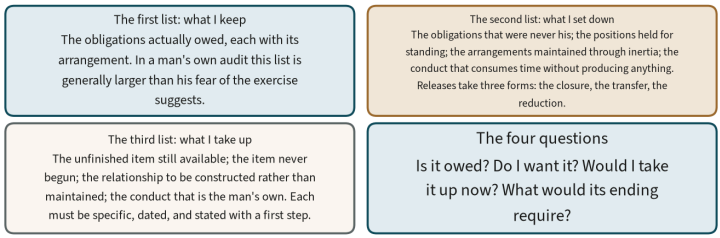


Figure 40.1 The audit of the second half of life: the three lists and the four questions that classify each item.

40.6 Conducting the Choice

The mechanics. The section supplies the four matters that determine whether the chapter's work is conducted or abandoned.

Matter One: The Household

The position. The household has its own arrangements, its own expectations, and frequently its own account of what the man's remaining years will consist of. Its members' responses to the man's choices are legitimate, since the household's position may be affected by them.

The arrangement. The four arrangements of Chapter 38.6, applied to this material: the disclosure, in the four-part form, of the man's position — what he has been, what he has found, what he intends, and what he requires; the household's own arrangements, at the level the man's choices permit; the household's role in the choice, which is generally substantial; and the household's own people and rest.

The sequence. The disclosure precedes the conduct. The finding from the case material: the men who conducted the changes and informed the household afterwards met the household's resistance and, in a substantial minority of cases, the household's arrangement of its own life in the departure of one of its members; the men who conducted the disclosure first met the household's participation.

The household's statement. The form recorded in the practice material, and the reader should use it: *This is my position. This is what I have found about my own life in the last month. This is what I intend to keep, what I intend to set*

down, and what I intend to take up. I am telling you before I conduct it because our arrangements concern you, and I require your account of what it does to you.

Matter Two: The People Who Will Resist

The position, stated plainly. The chapter's material will be resisted by some parties, and their resistance is frequently legitimate: the household member whose arrangements depend on the man's availability; the family member whose obligation the man has carried; the organisation that requires his availability; the person whose position in the arrangement is produced by the man's continuation. The resistance is not evidence that the work is wrong and it is evidence that the work has consequences.

The arrangement. Three instructions. **First: the distinction between the two kinds of resistance.** The party who is affected has a claim on the arrangement; the party who objects that the man has no business conducting his own life has an argument, and the argument is not owed an answer. **Second: the arrangement before the conduct.** The commitment is reduced, transferred, or ended with notice, with the period stated, and with the party's capacity addressed where the man has been carrying it. **Third: the resistance is endured.** The material of Chapters 26.6 and 32.5: the man's tolerance of another party's account of him, recorded and not argued, with the conduct unaltered.

The two prohibitions. The man does not conduct the change as an argument with the resisting party, which is the form in which the work becomes a quarrel about the man's rights. And the man does not require the resisting party's agreement before conducting the change, since the requirement is the arrangement in which nothing is ever altered.

Matter Three: The Timing

The findings. The case material supplies three. **First: the change is conducted in a period of transition and not in a crisis.** The men who conducted the audit during a collapse, a bereavement, or a health event found the audit's items distorted, and the audit's conduct is generally better at a distance of some months from the event. **Second: the changes are distributed.** The men who conducted all of the changes in one quarter met the household's and the family's combined resistance and, in the case material, frequently abandoned the whole of the work; the men who conducted one or two items at a time over a year or two conducted the majority of the audit. **Third: the third list is conducted first.** The finding is the chapter's principal sequencing rule: a man who takes up an item from the third list before he sets down the items of the second list has established the claim of his own life, and the reduction of the obligations is thereafter conducted as a rearrangement rather than as a withdrawal.

Matter Four: The Instruments the Man Requires

The ally. The material of Section 38.2′s fourth task: one person who has the whole of the man's position, and who is told what the man is not to do, including the two prohibitions of Matter Two.

The professional route. Where the audit includes the marriage, the man's employment, the property, the finances, or the household's arrangements, the professional is engaged: the legal, the financial, the clinical, or the relationship. The material of Chapters 30.4 and 40.3′s second loss.

The written record. The three lists, the dates, the first steps, and the household's statement. The finding: the men who recorded the audit in writing conducted substantially more of it than the men who conducted it in their thinking, which is a difference reported consistently enough in the practice material to be the section's principal instruction.

The review. The audit is reviewed at three months, at six months, and at a year, with the ally where possible. The review's questions: what has been conducted, what has not, what the resistance has been, and what the third list now contains.

40.7 The Choices

The specific decisions. The section supplies the seven choices the audit generally produces, with the criteria for each. The reader should apply the criteria to his own position and should not adopt the conclusions of the case material.

Choice One: The Work

The question. Whether to continue in the work, to alter it, or to leave it, and on what terms.

The criteria. The requirement: the income the household requires, stated in figures, and the route's minimum. **The cost:** the hours, the travel, the health, the household's position, and the man's state, recorded in the form of Chapter 33.4′s fourth test. **The alternative:** stated as an actual arrangement rather than as a possibility, with its income, its requirements, and the period of transition. **The age and the qualification:** the route's availability at the man's actual position. **The man's own material:** what he wants, from the preference register, recorded even where the answer is *I do not know*.

The finding from the case material. The most frequent outcome is not the ending of the work but its conduct on altered terms: the reduction of the hours, the refusal of the promotion, the transfer, the ending of the additional engagement, the negotiation of the arrangement. The second most frequent is the establishment of the second income, generally the item of the third list, conducted while the first income is maintained. The outright ending is the least frequent outcome and is generally conducted with the alternative in place and with the household's arrangements stated.

The prohibition. The man does not end the income on the basis of the audit alone, in a period of transition, without the alternative's arrangement and without the professional advice where the household's position is affected. The material of Chapter 38.3′s errors applies in this material in full.

Choice Two: The Household's Arrangements and the Extended Family

The question. What the man will continue to carry, at what level, and for whom.

The criteria. The four tests of Chapter 33.4; the household's own requirements, which take precedence over the extended family's in the case material and in the chapter's position; the other parties' capacity, required to be tested; the arrangement by which the commitment is reduced or transferred; and the disclosure of Section 40.6′s Matter One.

The finding. The most frequent outcome is a substantial reduction conducted over a period of one to two years, with two or three items transferred and one or two ended, and with the household's requirements funded before the others. The specific finding for readers whose position is the load of Chapter 33: the reduction is generally met with the extended family's resistance in the first year and with its accommodation in the second, and the receiving parties' capacity appears.

Choice Three: The Marriage, or the Partnership

The question. Whether the marriage is to be conducted as it is, altered, or ended.

The criteria, and the chapter states them in full because this choice is the one most frequently mishandled.

First: the position of the man's own conduct. Chapter 39′s material applied to the man's own case: where the marriage's state is produced by the man's absence, coldness, or unavailability and not by the relationship's material, the choice is the conduct of Chapter 39.5′s practices and not the marriage's ending. The case material is emphatic on the point, and Section 39.7′s case is its illustration.

Second: the repairs owed. The material of Chapter 29.6: the man's own account, the disclosure, the apologies, and the altered conduct over a period. The chapter's rule: the choice is not made until the repairs have been conducted.

Third: the relationship's material. Where the disclosure, the repairs, the altered conduct, and the arrangements of Chapter 27 have been conducted over a period of a year and the position is unaltered, the relationship's material is the matter, and the professional route is engaged: the couple's counselling, and separately the legal advice where the choice is considered.

Fourth: the household's members. The children's position, their ages, and the arrangements that the choice requires. The material of Chapters 18 and 20 applies in full, and the chapter's finding is the one the research supplies: the

household's outcome is determined less by the marriage's continuation than by the conflict's conduct and by the man's continued presence as a father.

The prohibition. The man does not leave the marriage on the basis of the audit, of a new relationship, or of the report that his life is unfulfilled. The case material records the outcome of that version consistently, and it is the material of Section 40.1′s third prohibition.

Choice Four: The Children

The question. What the man's remaining periods with his children consist of.

The criteria. The children's ages and their position; the material of Chapters 18, 20, and 39; the repairs owed, conducted in the individual form of Chapter 29.6′s fourth element; the practices of Chapter 39.6; and the specific matter of what the man will be for each of them, which the case material records as the question that most alters men's conduct in this domain.

The finding. The most frequent outcome is not a change in the man's provision, which is generally established, but the construction of the relationship's content: the individual time, the specific question, the participation in what matters to the child, and the conduct of the repairs where the man has been absent. The finding from the case material's own reporting: the children's response is generally available, and the man's delay is generally explained by the difficulty of the first conversation rather than by the child's position.

Choice Five: The Man's Own Arrangements

The question. What the man's own life consists of, in its practical and arranged form.

The criteria. The third list of Section 40.5; the material of Chapter 27.4′s five sources and Chapter 27.5′s arrangements; the rest of Chapter 37; the health of Chapter 23; the physical channel of Chapter 39.5; and the arrangements' cost, in time and money, which the man's own ledger is required to fund.

The finding. The most frequent outcome in the case material: three or four arrangements, of which at least one is physical, at least one is a relationship in which the man is known, and at least one is an item from the third list. The men's own reports identify the finding that makes the section's material effective: the arrangements were established before the man felt that he had time for them, and the time appeared once they existed.

Choice Six: The Standing

The question. What the man's remaining years are for in the account of the community, the profession, and his own household.

The criteria. The material of Chapter 25.6 — the audience's authority, the personal measure, the recognition's actual value — conducted as a decision rather than as an analysis; and the material of Part XII's contribution question, which is

the substance of the chapter's own conclusion: what the man will be for beyond his own household.

The finding. The most frequent outcome is the identification of one or two domains in which the man's contribution is conducted and the release of the remainder, which is the material of Section 40.5′s Category Two. The men's own accounts describe the outcome in the terms of Chapter 25.6′s third prohibition: the audience's authority reduced, and the man's actual contribution increased.

Choice Seven: The Years

The question. The chapter's final choice, and the one that the audit's third list addresses: what the man's remaining years consist of, stated in the terms of what he will have produced and whom he will have been for.

The criteria. The material of Chapter 28.6′s sixth section and of the reflection questions of Chapter 44: the years' actual number at the man's own table; the items of the third list; the relationships; the work; the contribution; and the rest.

The form of the choice. The chapter's instruction is that the choice be written in the form used by the men in the case material: one page, in the man's own hand, dated, containing the three lists, the specific choices, the first steps, and the sentence that states what the years are for. The page is kept, reviewed at the intervals of Section 40.6′s Matter Four, and shown to the ally and to the household.

40.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Chose Late

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in counselling of men, family practice, and career counselling.

Joseph is fifty-eight, a quantity surveyor, who conducted his practice as a sole practitioner from the age of thirty-one, married to Ngozi for thirty-one years, with four children aged twenty-nine, twenty-seven, twenty-three, and nineteen.

Joseph's practice was established, competent, and satisfactory in its income. His position in the case is the one this chapter describes: at fifty-eight, he was carrying a domestic load that consisted of his household, two widowed sisters, a nephew's fees, a cousin's rent, a building project he had begun in 2011, and nine years of a professional association's secretaryship that he described as *the thing that eats my Saturdays*. His savings were adequate. His health was described by his doctor as *satisfactory with two warnings*. His account of why he had come to the consultation, given in the first sitting and recorded in the case document, was: *I have everything and I am not interested in any of it. I do not know what I want. My wife says I have not been myself for two years and I cannot argue with her because I do not know what myself is.*

The audit, which took three sittings, produced the following.

The first list — what he would keep. The household's requirements; two of the four children's remaining obligations; the building project, which he revised to a smaller and completable form; one of the two sisters' maintenance, reduced and dated; his own practice, at two-thirds of its hours, with the introduction of an assistant; the marriage, identified as the item he would take up and not the item he would leave.

The second list — what he would set down. The association's secretaryship, which he described as *nine years and I have never once been asked whether I still wanted it*; the cousin's rent, which he had been paying since 2015 and which he described as *nobody has ever discussed it with me*; the second sister's maintenance, transferred to his son and his brother with a period and an arrangement; three investment arrangements he had entered on advice and had never examined; the involvement in two community committees; his Fridays' additional engagement; and the habit he described as *the two hours in the evenings that I could not account for*.

The third list — what he would take up. A six-month course in a technical subject he had intended since 2004 and had never begun; a weekly walk with his wife, arranged on a fixed day; a repair of the relationship with his second son, with whom he had been in a dispute since 2021 over a matter he described in the audit as *my own fault and I have never said so*; and one arrangement of his own, which he described in the audit as unchanged from its first form: *to read for two hours on a Sunday afternoon and not apologise for it.*

The conduct, over about eighteen months, is the case's material.

The third list was conducted first. Joseph enrolled in the course in the second month and attended on Tuesday evenings. His account of the first weeks: *I walked into a room with nine people and I was the oldest by about twenty years and the lecturer asked me what I did and I said I was a quantity surveyor and he said, so why are you here. I said, because I have wanted to do this since 2004 and I am fifty-eight. He said, welcome. I sat down and I had a feeling and I could not name it and I wrote it in my notebook on the bus and the word was pleased.*

The disclosure to the household was conducted in the fourth month, in the four-part form, with the audit's three lists in hand and the paper on the table. Ngozi's account, recorded in the case document: *He read it out and I knew most of it before he said it. What I did not know was the course and the Sunday. He said, I am not asking you to agree, and I am asking you to tell me what it does to you, and I told him that the Tuesdays were not a problem and the Sunday was not a problem and that I had been afraid that he was going to say something else.*

The association's secretaryship was ended in the fifth month, with a letter, with notice, with a nominated successor, and with the arrangement for the handover period. Joseph's account: *I wrote the letter four times. I had the speech ready for the chairman, with everything I had done for nine years. He said, we have been waiting for you to say it for two years, we did not want to ask. I have written to the association once*

since and I have not attended since June and nobody has said anything to me except the man who took over, who calls me about once a month and whom I am glad to help.

The cousin's rent was ended with three months' notice and an arrangement, and Joseph's account of the conversation is the finding the chapter wishes to record: *He said that he had been afraid that I would stop, for four years. He said that he had asked his employer for a rise in 2022 and had not got it, and that he had not asked again because of this. I said four sentences and I did not argue with him about the past, and I gave him the three months. In the second month after the notice he told me he had obtained the increase in his allowance. I have contributed nothing to him since December of last year.*

The son's repair was conducted in the seventh month. Joseph's account: *I telephoned him and I said four sentences. I said that I had been wrong about the matter in 2021, that I did not have a reason, that it was not his fault, and that I wanted to see him. He was quiet for about fifteen seconds and then he said, I was waiting for you to say that, and I have seen him eleven times since and he brought his daughter at Christmas and she sat on my lap.*

The review at eighteen months, conducted in the case and recorded in the document, contained the following items. The course was completed, with the certificate kept in a folder that Joseph described as *the most expensive thing I own and I did not need the certificate*. The Tuesday evening and the Sunday afternoon continued. The walk with Ngozi continued, and Joseph described its effect in the household's own terms: *She told me in the eighth month that the forty minutes on Saturday was the first time in twenty years that we have talked about something that was not a decision.* The practice continued at the reduced hours with the assistant, and its income was reduced by about a fifth and its hours by about a third. The nephew's fees continued and the second sister's maintenance continued at the transferred arrangement. Two of the three investment arrangements were closed. His health's two warnings were addressed and one was resolved. His own sentence, recorded at the review: *I was the item that was never on the list, and I put it on the list, and I did it in the year I turned fifty-eight. I have four children and I want them to know that I did something that nobody asked me to do, and that I sat in a room as the worst student in it, and that I have a Sunday.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The deferral's stages were all present, and the anchor was the duty anchor. Joseph's obligations were accepted over three decades, each for a reason that was valid at the time, and his own life was deferred to a condition that was met in about 2019 and replaced by another. The case is included because the reader's own audit will generally find the same structure: not one decision, but thirty years of competent deferrals.

The audit was small and the third list was the smallest item on the page. The course, the walk, the repair, and the Sunday. The case is included because the

chapter's material is frequently read as a proposal for a large reconstruction, and the case material's finding is the reverse: the third list's items are generally small, specific, and available, and their effect on the man's position is disproportionate to their size.

The third list was conducted first, and it established the others. The course in the second month, before the association's letter, the cousin's notice, and the son's telephone call. This is Section 40.6′s Matter Three and the case is included because the sequencing rule is the chapter's most useful mechanical instruction: the man who has taken something up conducts the reductions as a rearrangement of his life rather than as the surrender of it.

The second list was conducted with the arrangement and not with an argument. The letter with notice and a successor; the cousin with three months and a statement; the association with the handover. The case's material records the receiving parties' responses, and they are the finding of Chapter 33.6 in its clearest form: the chairman who had been waiting for two years, the cousin who had been afraid for four, and the increase that appeared in the cousin's allowance within months of the notice.

The repairs were conducted as a separate and specific work. The second son, the four sentences, and the eleven visits since. The case is included because the chapter's material is not only about the man's own life: the audit's first list contains the relationship he would take up, and the repairs owed under Chapter 29 are conducted as part of it. The finding that the case supplies — *I was waiting for you to say that* — is the one reported by the parties on the receiving end of this material across the case material of this book.

40.9 Practical Exercise: The Page and the Year

The exercise is conducted over four sittings and produces one page in the man's own hand.

Sitting One: The Position

Section A: The assets of the second half. Record, as figures, what the man has that the years can be constructed on: the income and its requirements; the savings and the period they would cover; the house; the health and the two warnings; the capacities and the qualifications; the relationships he has; the standing he holds; and the years, counted at his own table from his actual age.

Section B: The obligations currently carried. Every item, in the form of Chapter 33.4′s budget: the person, the arrangement, the cost in money and time per month, and the period it has been conducted.

Section C: The preference register. For two weeks, record each preference as it arrives, without assessment: what he wanted to eat, where he wanted to sit,

what he wanted to refuse, what he did not want to attend, what he wanted to say. The register is required material for Sitting Two.

Sitting Two: The Audit

Complete the four questions of Section 40.5 for every item in Section B, and record the item's classification.

The item	Is it owed? (four tests)	Do I want it?	Would I take it up now?	What would its ending require?	List

Then write the three lists.

The first list: what I keep. With the arrangement for each, stated specifically.

The second list: what I set down. With the form of the release — the closure, the transfer, or the reduction — the date, the notice, and the arrangement.

The third list: what I take up. Four items at most, each specific, each dated, and each with a first step written as an act rather than as an intention.

Sitting Three: The Household and the Instruments

Section A: The household statement. Write it in the four-part form of Section 40.6′s Matter One, in no more than one page: the position, what I have found, what I intend to keep, set down, and take up, and what I require of the household's account of what it does to them.

Section B: The resistance. For each item on the second list, record the party, their interest, the arrangement, the notice, and the sentence the man will use. Record also the two prohibitions: no argument with the resisting party, and no requirement of their agreement.

Section C: The professional route. Record which of the choices — the work, the household's arrangements, the marriage, the children — requires legal, financial, clinical, or relationship advice, and record the appointment's date.

Section D: The ally. Name the ally, record what the ally is told, and record what the man is not to do.

Sitting Four: The Page and the Year

Write one page, in the man's own hand, dated, containing:

1. The accurate statement of his position, in four sentences.
2. The three lists.
3. The seven choices of Section 40.7, with his decision on each, stated in one sentence each.
4. The first step of the third list, with its date.
5. The sentence that states what the years are for.

Then fix the reviews: three months, six months, and a year, with the dates written, with the ally present where possible.

40.10 Common Questions Men Ask

"Is this not selfish?"

The distinction of Section 40.1 governs, and the test is supplied there: what the household's position looks like at the end of the work. The obligations owed are conducted; the repairs are made; the arrangements are disclosed; the household's account is sought. The specific finding from the case material is the one that answers the question: the men who conducted the audit were better able to discharge their obligations over the following decade than the men who did not, and their households report the position as improved. The chapter's position is that the account of the man's own life as selfish is the rule of Section 40.2′s worth anchor in the man's own voice, and that the rule has been examined in Chapters 25 and 37.

"I do not know what I want. The exercise does not work for me."

This is the presentation of Section 40.3′s third loss, and it is expected. The sequence is supplied: the preference register first, in the physical and practical matters, for at least two weeks; then the registration practice of Chapter 39.5; then the questions, recorded as they arrive and returned to in the following month. The finding from the case material is that the capacity returns, that it returns before the larger questions can be answered, and that the register should not be abandoned on the basis of the first week's result.

"My wife will not agree to this."

The chapter's position requires the household's account and not the household's agreement. The disclosure in the four-part form; the household's material sought in specific terms; the arrangements conducted with notice and with the household's position addressed; and the resistance endured. The case material records two findings: the household's specific objection is frequently to one or two items rather than to the audit, and the household's objection to the man's own arrangements is generally addressed by the man's conduct in the household's arrangements, which is the material of Chapters 39.5 and 38.6.

"I have obligations I cannot set down. The children, the parents, the debts."

The chapter does not propose their release. The first list exists for this material, and the instruction is that the owed obligations be named accurately and arranged rather than conducted as the whole of the man's life. The audit's effect for the men in this position is generally not the release of an obligation but three changes: the release of the items that were not owed, the arrangement of the items that were, and the addition of the third list. The case material records the finding that

the third list's addition is what alters the position, and that the reduction of the obligations frequently follows it.

"I am fifty-eight. Is it not too late?"

The case of Section 40.8 is included for this question, and its man was fifty-eight with a course he had intended for twenty-one years. The chapter's material on the point: the third list's items are generally available at fifty-eight and at sixty-two and are generally small; the years' number, counted at the man's own table, is generally more than his account of it; and the finding from the case material is that the men who conducted the work at sixty report the same outcome as the men who conducted it at forty-eight. What is not available is the previous decades, which is the material of Section 40.3′s second loss and of Chapter 28′s accounting — and the accounting's purpose, as that chapter established, is not the man's punishment but the accurate statement of what is left.

"What if my household's position is altered by my choices and a member of it suffers?"

Then the choice is being conducted correctly, because every choice of consequence alters somebody's position, and a choice that alters nobody's is not a choice. The chapter's requirement is that the alteration be known, stated, and arranged: the disclosure, the notice, the period of transition, and the party's capacity addressed. The specific finding from the case material for readers who hold this question: the household member whose position is altered by the man's neglect of his own life is the member who has been receiving a man who is not there, and the alteration produced by the audit is frequently the first change in that member's position that either party can describe.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 40 in brief. Choosing oneself does not mean the abandonment of the people a man is responsible for, the man's pleasure as a criterion, the ending of a marriage for a better one, or the announcement that he is putting himself first. It means that the man's own life is an item on the ledger with the other items, that his requirements are legitimate rather than a reward, that the obligations are audited rather than assumed, that his preference is information he is required to have, and that the choice is conducted in the years that remain. The test of which version is operating is what the household's position looks like at the end of the work.

A man's deferral is a process in seven stages — his requirements subordinated early, his first obligations accepted, the arrangement established and rewarded, the deferral given a date, his own requirements no longer formulated, his own material not counted, and the discovery — and it is anchored to one of five rules: worth, duty, fear, permission, or identity. The costs are four: the lives he was for, in which the obligations were discharged and the relationships were not constructed; what was not built; the capacity to know what he wants, which returns in a sequence when

it is exercised; and his own account of his life, which has been composed of other people's items.

Four permissions are required, and they are granted by argument rather than by the environment: the permission to have a life; the permission not to be everybody's solution; the permission to be a beginner and to be bad at it in public at this age; and the permission to ask for what he wants, with the distinction that the statement is his responsibility and the answer is not.

The audit is one page of three lists, classified by four questions: whether the item is owed, whether he wants it, whether he would take it up now, and what its ending would require. The second list's releases take three forms — the closure, the transfer, and the reduction — and the third list's items must be specific, dated, and stated with a first step. The choice is then conducted in four matters: the household, with the disclosure and its account required and not its agreement; the people who will resist, whose resistance is frequently legitimate and is endured rather than argued; the timing, in which the third list is conducted first and the changes are distributed; and the instruments, which are the ally, the professional route, the written record, and the reviews at three months, six months, and a year.

The seven choices are the work, the household's arrangements and the extended family, the marriage, the children, the man's own arrangements, the standing, and the years — and the product of the work is one page, in the man's own hand, dated, containing the three lists, the seven decisions, the first step, and the sentence that states what the years are for.

Reflection Questions

1. What has your own life been deferred to, and what is the condition? Has it been met, and was it replaced?
2. Which of the five anchors of Section 40.2 holds your deferral in place, and what is the sentence in your own words?
3. Complete the audit's second list. How many of the items are actually owed, and what would the release of the remainder require?
4. Which of the four permissions are you withholding, and what is the argument you use?
5. Write the third list. Which item has been there longest, and what is its first step?
6. Consider the last five years. Which of your obligations were conducted as arrangements and which consumed the years? What would the audit have altered in 2021?
7. Write the sentence that states what your remaining years are for, and read it to the ally.

Further Reading

- **On the second half of life:** the research and practice literature on midlife and later-life development, including the findings on the reconfiguration of purpose and identity in the second half of life, on the evidence concerning the pursuit of long-deferred aims, and on the patterns of satisfaction reported in later life.
- **On goal pursuit and the deferral of personal aims:** the research on personal goals, including the findings on the effects of unattained goals, on the conditions under which long-deferred aims are taken up, on the value of specific and dated intentions, and on the role of social support in their conduct.
- **On caregiving burden and the reduction of obligations:** the literature on caregiving and on the burden of family obligation, including the findings on the effects of over-commitment on health and household relationships, and the evidence on the outcomes of reducing or transferring commitments.
- **On preference and self-knowledge:** the research on the identification of preference and on self-knowledge, including the findings on the effects of chronic self-neglect on the capacity to identify one's own states and preferences, and on the methods by which the capacity is recovered.
- **Practical resources:** career and financial counselling; individual counselling and psychological services; couple's counselling; legal advice on property and family arrangements; and the material in Appendices D, G, H, and P.

PART XII

Beyond the Battle

From silent survival to purposeful living

41 CHAPTER

Redefining What It Means to Be a Man

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the definition of manhood he inherited, and identify its sources, its functions, and its clauses.
2. Analyse the five clauses of the inherited definition and state what each actually requires.
3. Explain how the definition operates as a rule rather than as a description, and how it is enforced without anybody enforcing it.
4. Apply the eight tests by which a clause of the definition is examined, and classify his own clauses.
5. Construct a working definition of manhood in the form used in this book: a statement of conduct rather than of status, with its obligations, its permissions, and its prohibitions named.
6. Conduct the substitution exercise, in which the inherited clauses are replaced by specific conduct in the reader's actual circumstances.

Introduction

This chapter is the first of the book's final part, and it addresses the subject that the previous forty chapters have been circling: the definition of manhood that the reader holds, and the question of whether he chose it.

The chapters to this point have established the difficulties and the arrangements. The battles of silence, the wounding, the losses, the load, the provision, the friendships that do not reach the material, the emotional arrangements, and the reconstructions. The present chapter addresses the rule that has been behind them, because the case material of this book has recorded one finding consistently and it is the finding on which the final part is constructed: **the difficulties are maintained by a definition of manhood that the men in this book did not write and have not examined.**

The definition is not a superstition and it is not an invention of the men who hold it. It is a set of instructions that were transmitted by parties who had the man's interests at heart — his father, his mother, his household, his school, his training, his trade, his profession, his community, his friends, and his culture — and it produced outcomes in the conditions for which it was written. It instructed men to be reliable, to provide, to endure, to protect, to be composed under pressure, to keep their word, and to carry what they are given. Those instructions built the households, the trades, the institutions, and the settlements that the man's generation inherited.

The chapter's position is not that the definition is false. It is that the definition is **incomplete, that its incompleteness has been concealed by its authority, and that the specific omissions are the material of this book.**

The definition gives a man an instruction about what to do with his fear, his grief, his shame, his exhaustion, and his own requirements, and the instruction in each case is a form of silence or suppression. Chapter 34 measured the cost of the first, Chapter 37 the cost of the second, and Chapter 39 the cost of the third. The chapter now addresses the source.

Its approach has five commitments.

The first is that the reader is not to be treated as a victim of the definition. Men hold their definitions for reasons that were valid and that remain partly valid; the definition has, in the case material of this book, saved men's lives, their households, and their positions. The chapter's examination is conducted with respect for what the definition has done, and the reader who approaches it expecting an indictment of his father's generation will not find one here.

The second is that the definition is analysable. It is not a mood or a tradition; it is a set of clauses, and clauses can be stated, examined, and revised. Sections 41.1 to 41.3 supply the analysis, and the reader should be able to write his own definition's clauses before he examines them.

The third is that the definition is enforced socially but held personally. The audience of Chapter 25 is the mechanism, and the definition's enforcement does not require an enforcer: the man conducts the examination of his own conduct against the definition, and his compliance is voluntary, which is the reason its revision is possible at the level of the individual man.

The fourth is that the replacement is constructed rather than adopted. The chapter supplies eight tests, a working definition, and a substitution exercise, and the reader's product is his own statement in his own words. The case material is consistent on the point: the men who adopted another man's formulation reproduced their original difficulty in a new vocabulary, and the men who constructed their own altered their conduct.

The fifth is that the work is conducted in the second half of the man's life and it changes what he leaves. The material of Chapter 43 is the substance of the chapter's closing sections: a man's definition is transmitted to his sons, his daughters, the young men in his trade, his household, and the men who work for him, and its revision is the mechanism by which a generation's inheritance is altered without a lecture being delivered to anybody.

41.1 The Definition He Inherited

The section establishes the material. The reader's task in this section is not to evaluate the definition but to write it down.

The Sources

The definition a man holds is assembled from eight sources, and the reader should identify what each of his own supplied.

Source one: the man's father, or the man who occupied that position. The most powerful source, and the one that supplies the conduct rather than the words. The case material is consistent: men can recite their fathers' statements about manhood in the abstract, and their actual conduct is modelled on what their fathers did with pressure, money, grief, conflict, work, and the household. The specific material: what the father did with his own distress; whether he asked for anything; how he treated the mother; what he did when he was wrong; whether he was present.

Source two: the man's mother, and the household's women. The instructions: what a man provides; what a man is forgiven for; what a man is not permitted to be; what a man must protect. The specific material from the case reports: the mother's account of the father's character, and the sentence that accompanies a boy's distress — *do not cry, you are a man*, which the case material records as the single most frequently reported instruction of childhood in this book.

Source three: the school, the training, the trade, and the profession. The instructions of the setting: the tolerance of the difficulty, the prohibition on the complaint, the value of the competence, the marking of the softness, the rituals by which a boy was admitted into the category of men. The finding from the case material: the sources that carried the sharpest punishment for deviation were generally the institutions of the man's adolescence.

Source four: the man's peer group, in the period of the definition's hardening. Generally between fourteen and twenty-five, and the material: the terms used of the man who expressed or asked; the conduct that was rewarded; the men who were the group's models. The case material records that the majority of the men in this book can still reproduce the specific words.

Source five: the arrangements of the man's household of origin. Whether there was enough money; whether the man was the eldest son; whether a parent died, left, or was ill; whether the household held its difficulties privately. The source's material is the arithmetic of the period rather than the instruction, and its finding is the one recorded in Chapter 33.1: the man who was the eldest son of a household of scarcity generally holds the definition with the intensity of the arrangement that produced it.

Source six: the culture's presentation of men. The songs, the stories, the films, the proverbs, the religious instruction of the man's childhood, the public figures, the sporting material, the advertisement, and the community's accounts of its notable men. The source's material is not the man's obedience to these items but their ubiquity, and their effect is the establishment of the definition as the ordinary shape of things, so that a man's examination of it is conducted against a background in which the alternative appears deviant.

Source seven: the man's own experience. The most underrated source, and the one the case material records as decisive for many men. A man's definition is composed substantially of what happened to him and the conclusions he drew: the disclosure that was used against him; the expression that was met with ridicule; the relationship in which his softness was received and then exploited; the year in which the money was short and he was the one who was told; the occasion on which he asked for help and it did not arrive. The source's material is included because the chapter's central difficulty is located here: **the definition is partly a set of conclusions drawn from the man's own evidence, and its examination therefore requires that the evidence be re-examined rather than dismissed.**

Source eight: the man's own conduct and its consequences. The source that maintains the definition in the present. The man's position, his standing, his reliability, his household's reliance, and the rewards of the definition as he has experienced them. The finding: the definition is supported by the man's actual success, and the examination is not conducted against a tradition but against the man's own achievements.

The Eleven Statements

The following statements are the ones most frequently recorded in the case material as the man's own account of his definition, and the reader should mark the ones he holds.

1. *A man provides for his family.*
2. *A man does not show weakness.*
3. *A man does not cry.*
4. *A man protects the people he is responsible for.*

5. *A man does not complain, and he does not explain himself.*
6. *A man keeps his word.*
7. *A man does not ask for help.*
8. *A man controls his household.*
9. *A man is measured by what he achieves and what he owns.*
10. *A man handles his problems himself.*
11. *A man does not talk about his feelings.*

The reader's instruction: **write the statements you hold, in your own words, and do not soften them.** The exercise's value depends on the accuracy of the material, and the case material records the finding that men write softened versions when they expect to be judged by them.

The Five Classifications

Each statement the reader holds falls into one of five classifications, and the classification determines whether the clause survives the examination.

Class one: the obligation. The clause requires the man to do something for another person: to provide, to protect, to keep his word, to be present. The classification's material is the material of Chapters 3 to 6 and of Parts III to V, and its clauses are generally maintained through the examination with their content made specific.

Class two: the prohibition on a state. The clause requires the man not to feel or not to show a specified experience: not to fear, not to grieve, not to be uncertain, not to be tired. The classification's material is the difficulty at the centre of this book, and its clauses are the ones that the examination corrects, since a man cannot undertake not to feel.

Class three: the prohibition on an act. The clause requires the man not to conduct a specified act: not to ask, not to state, not to request assistance, not to be seen in the act of any of them. The classification's clauses are the ones Chapters 35 and 39 address, and their examination is conducted by distinguishing the act from its setting.

Class four: the description of a status. The clause asserts a position rather than a conduct: what a man is, what a man deserves, what a man is owed, what a man is entitled to determine. The classification's clauses are the ones that produce the material of Chapters 20, 26, and 40, and their examination is the chapter's principal work.

Class five: the inheritance without a function. The clause is held because it was transmitted and not because it produces anything the man can state. The classification's clauses are the ones that the examination releases, and the case material records the finding that the reader will generally identify two or three of them within an hour of writing the list. The frequently reported examples: a

rule about a specific food, a rule about a specific task, a rule about the acceptable form of a man's clothing, a rule about the conduct a man permits his wife, a rule about the arrangement of the household's money that the man cannot connect to a purpose.

KEY POINT

A man's definition of manhood is assembled from eight sources — his father's conduct, his mother's and the household's instruction, the institutions of his adolescence, his peer group, his household of origin's arrangements, his culture's presentation, his own experience, and his own conduct and its rewards. The definitions are held as statements, and each is an obligation, a prohibition on a state, a prohibition on an act, a description of a status, or an inheritance without a function. The classification determines whether a clause survives the examination: a man cannot undertake not to feel, but he can examine what he has instructed himself not to do and what he has assumed he is owed.

41.2 The Five Clauses and What They Actually Require

The section examines the five clauses most frequently reported in the case material and states what each actually requires — not what it is said to require, but what its holders' conduct shows it to require.

Clause One: The Provision

The common form. *A man provides for his family. A man is the one who makes sure that the household has what it needs.*

What it actually requires, in the case material. In the overwhelming majority of the men described in this book, the clause requires that the man be **the primary or the sole source of provision, that he be the party to whom the household's shortfall is a personal failure, and that the provision's burden be borne silently, with no statement of its size, no request for reduction, and no disclosure of its effects.**

The distinction the examination requires. The clause's obligation is authentic. The household requires the provision, and a man's provision is a real good. What the clause adds to the obligation, and what is not in the clause's plain words, is the following four elements: **the exclusivity** — that the provision must come from him; **the silence** — that its burden may not be stated; **the personalization** — that a shortfall is a failing of his person rather than a change in the position; and **the anonymity** — that the act of providing is the whole of his relation to the household, so that his presence, his attention, and his person are not items the clause's holder considers himself to be providing.

The consequence. The material of Chapters 33 and 37: a load that cannot be stated, a burden that cannot be reduced, and a man whose value is computed at the point of his exhaustion.

The revision the examination produces. The obligation is maintained with its content made specific and its elements removed: the provision is the man's responsibility **with** the household's participation where the household has capacity; its size is stated as information and not as complaint; the shortfall is a change in the position rather than a verdict on the man; and the man's presence in the household is among the items he provides, as Chapters 18 and 39 established.

Clause Two: The Composure

The common form. *A man does not show weakness. A man stays composed. A man does not let them see it.*

What it actually requires. The clause requires the man to conceal the evidence of his states from specified parties, at specified moments. The specification is generally: from his household always; from his wife in most matters; from his children in all; from his colleagues and staff in all; from his friends in the matters that concern him; and from himself, which is the clause's most consequential extension.

The distinction. The clause's obligation has a defensible content, and it is the material of Chapter 39.4′s definition: **the regulation of one's states and their appropriate conduct in the setting.** The man who governs his conduct under pressure, who holds his fear through a briefing and states it afterwards, who does not discharge his anger into his household — that man is conducting a competence, and the clause names it.

What the clause adds. The clause's added content is the extension of the concealment to the settings in which no requirement exists for it, and its conversion into a rule about the man's own access to his states. The mechanism is Chapter 39.2′s third stage: the technique is extended until it operates without a decision, and the man's registration of his own material is reduced to the point at which he cannot supply an account of his state to anyone, including himself.

The consequence. The material of Chapters 39.3 and 39.4: the man who is composed and unreachable; the household that constructs his absence; the information he does not receive; and the judgements he makes from an incomplete account of himself.

The revision. The regulation is maintained and the concealment is specified: the man states what is present in him to the parties entitled to it, on the occasions of his choosing, in the forms of Chapters 4.6, 27.5, 34.6, and 39.5′s Practice Four.

Clause Three: The Self-Sufficiency

The common form. *A man handles his own problems. A man does not ask for help. A man does not complain.*

What it actually requires. The clause requires that the man's difficulties be identified, managed, and resolved without the participation of another person, and that the man's need be invisible to the parties who might respond to it.

The distinction. The clause's obligation is the material of Chapters 31 and 35: the man's competence, his assumption of responsibility, and his conduct of the matters in his position. The clause's defect is not that it requires the man to be capable; it is that it requires the capability to be **conducted alone**, and it thereby removes the instruments on which capability depends. The research on help-seeking records the finding: the men who do not ask receive information about which they are wrong, carry positions longer than is necessary, and are treated later in the conditions that require early treatment.

The consequence. The material of Chapters 31.5 and 35.2: the delays, the undiagnosed conditions, the unnegotiated positions, the exhaustion, and the specific outcomes recorded in the men's health data.

The revision. The clause's obligation is maintained — the man handles his own problems — with the sentence added: **and he uses every instrument available, including other people's knowledge, because an instrument used alone is not a virtue.** The material of Chapter 35.4's five forms supplies the acts.

Clause Four: The Control

The common form. *A man controls his household. A man is the head of the family. A man's word is the decision.*

What it actually requires. In the case material, the clause as held requires that the man's determination prevail in the matters of consequence, that his household's arrangements be conducted by him or by his direction, that his judgement not be publicly contradicted, and that the household's difficulties be referred to him for resolution.

The distinction, and this clause requires the most careful examination in the chapter. The obligation of responsibility is authentic: the man is accountable for the household's position, and the material of Parts III to V establishes that a man's conduct of the household's affairs is real work with real consequences. **What the clause adds is the conversion of accountability into authority.** Accountability is a relation to consequences: the man answers for the household's position. Authority is a relation to persons: the man's determination governs the household's members. The two are not the same thing, and their confusion produces the specific material of this book: the man who is accountable and who therefore believes he must decide; the household that is required to receive the

arrangement rather than participate in it; the wife who manages the household and is not consulted about its conduct; the children who are conducted.

The consequence. The case material records four consequences. **First: the household's information is reduced**, because a member who is conducted does not report, which is the material of Chapter 31.1′s second effect in its household form. **Second: the man's load is increased**, because the arrangement in which every decision refers to him is the arrangement of Chapter 33.2′s second effect. **Third: the household's capacity is not developed**, which is the finding most frequently reported by the household members themselves: *I stopped deciding anything, because there was no point.* **Fourth: the man's equality as a party is lost**, which is the finding of Chapters 18.6, 20.6, and 26.5: the household's substantive arrangements — the marriage's content, the children's confidence, the disclosure function — require a different relation between the parties than the one the clause's control element supplies.

The revision. The accountability is maintained, and its conduct is specified: the man answers for the household's position; the household's members participate in the arrangements that concern them; the decisions are distributed according to the matters and the competences; the man states his determination as a position rather than as an order; and the household's members' capacity is developed rather than protected from requirement. The material of the four arrangements in Chapters 38.6 and 40.6 supplies the form.

Clause Five: The Achievement and the Status

The common form. *A man is measured by what he achieves and what he owns. A man does not stop. A man makes his mark.*

What it actually requires. The clause requires that the man's value be computed from his position, his income, his property, his title, his reputation, and his standing in the community; that the computation be continuous; and that any reduction in the position be a reduction in the man.

The distinction. The obligation of meaningful work is authentic and the material of Parts VI and VII: the work is real, its products are real, and a man's satisfaction in what he has built is a legitimate good. **What the clause adds is the identification of the man with the position**, which is Chapter 25.5′s material in its clause form. The consequence: the man who is not his position cannot be reduced by the position's reduction, and the man who is his position has no remainder.

The consequence. Three outcomes are recorded in the case material. **The first is the perpetual insufficiency:** because the computation is continuous and comparative, the position is always short of the available comparison, and the man's satisfaction is always deferred to the next item. **The second is the**

exposure to the collapse: the material of Chapter 38, in which the man's identity is destroyed with his position and in which the reconstruction is therefore not a reconstruction. **The third is the release at the end:** the material of Chapter 40.3′s fourth loss, in which the man discovers that his own account of his life is composed of the position's items and contains nothing of his own.

The revision. The work and the achievement are maintained, and the computation is altered: the man's measure is his whole conduct, as Chapter 25.5 established — the conduct in his household, his obligations, his work, his conduct with the people who cannot benefit him, and his own life — and his position is an item among them rather than the whole of them. The specific form: the man's statement of his value contains items that the audience cannot see.

The Three Additional Clauses

The case material records three further clauses that appear frequently enough to require their own treatment.

The clause of the comparison. *A man must be at least the equal of the men around him.* Its actual requirement: the man's conduct is conducted in relation to a comparison group, and the choice is made by the comparison's demands rather than the man's material. Its consequence: the house that is larger than required, the vehicle, the occasion, the schooling, the gifts, the borrowing, and the arrangements of Chapter 38.3′s second error.

The clause of the endurance. *A man continues. A man does not stop. A man carries it.* Its actual requirement: the man's continuation regardless of the position's actual arithmetic, and its consequence is the material of Chapters 33, 37, and 36: the man who continues until the position produces his collapse. Its revision is Chapter 37′s material in its clause form: the continuation is maintained for the obligations that warrant it, and the arithmetic is conducted.

The clause of the invulnerability to feeling. *A man does not become attached to that extent; a man does not let it affect him.* Its actual requirement: the reduction of the man's attachment to his household, his children, his friends, and his work to a level at which the losses do not reach him. Its consequence is the material of Chapter 39.3: the man who is not moved by his own household's life, and whose account of his losses is that nothing has happened to him.

The Comparison of the Five Clauses

The clause	Its authentic obligation	What it adds	The chapter's revision
Provision	The household has what it requires	Exclusivity, silence, personalisation, anonymity	Maintain the provision; state the size; let the household

The clause	Its authentic obligation	What it adds	The chapter's revision
			participate; include your presence
Composure	Regulation and appropriate conduct	The extension of concealment into every setting and into the man's own access	Maintain the regulation; specify the settings in which the material is stated
Self-sufficiency	Capability and responsibility	The requirement that the capability be conducted alone	Handle your problems, using every instrument, including other people's knowledge
Control	Accountability for the household	The conversion of accountability into authority over persons	Answer for the position; distribute the decisions; develop the household's capacity
Achievement	Meaningful work and real products	The identification of the man with the position	Measure the whole conduct, including the items the audience cannot see

41.3 How the Definition Is Enforced Without an Enforcer

The section supplies the mechanism, and it is the material that makes the chapter's work possible: a definition that is enforced by an institution is altered by altering the institution, and a definition that is enforced by the man himself is altered by the man.

Mechanism One: The Internal Examination

The mechanism. The man conducts a continuous examination of his own conduct against the definition's clauses and records his compliance. The case material supplies its forms: the man who reports that he has not cried since 1996 and states the year as an item of his own conduct's record; the man who describes a night's sleep as *a weakness*; the man who recites the number of years he has not taken a day of leave, as in the case of Chapter 37.7.

The finding. The examination's principal feature is that the man does not agree with the definition; he **is** the definition in his own account of himself. The material of Chapter 39.2′s sixth stage: the man has become the exterior, and the interior's examination is conducted by the exterior's rules.

Mechanism Two: The Audience's Monitoring

The mechanism. The audience of Chapter 25.2: the wife's household, the extended family, the community, the colleagues, the staff, the neighbours, and the men of the man's cohort, all of whom hold the definition and who record

the man's position against it. The mechanism's forms: the remark about another man's conduct; the account of a man who *let his wife decide*; the observation that a man *has changed* since the difficulty; the question about what the man is building.

The finding. The audience's authority is imposed by the man and not by the audience, which is the material of Chapter 25.6′s third prohibition. The audience's remark produces the man's response because the man assents to the audience's standing as a judge, which is the mechanism on which the definition's enforcement depends.

Mechanism Three: The Consequence That Was Real

The mechanism. The man's own experience, as Source Seven established: the occasions on which the definition's violation produced an actual cost. The disclosure that was used against him; the expression that was met with ridicule; the assistance that was not given; the financial disclosure that altered his household's regard; the request that was refused; the departure that occurred when he became less available.

The finding. The definition's enforcement is strongest at this mechanism and its examination must be conducted here, because the man's evidence is real and the chapter's instruction is not that the evidence should be disregarded. The instruction is that the evidence should be re-examined in the form the chapter supplies in Section 41.4′s eighth test: the specific form of the reasoning by which a man constructs a general rule from a specific event, which is generally a single event, frequently an event of his adolescence, and almost never the whole of the available evidence.

Mechanism Four: The Substitution of the Man's Own Record

The mechanism. The man's account of his own worth, conducted without the definition's assistance. The material of the internal ledger in Chapter 33.5 and of the measure in Chapter 25.5: the man's own record of what he has carried, what it cost him, and what it produced, held in his own accounting.

The finding. The mechanism's presence is the chapter's objective and it is the reason the exercise in Section 41.9 requires the construction of the man's own statement. The case material's finding: **a man who has constructed his own record cannot be reduced by the audience's accounting, because he has an accounting.** The audience's remarks continue; the man's assent to them does not.

The Two Instruments of the Examination

The section closes with the two instruments that the chapter's remaining sections provide, and the reader should hold them together.

The first instrument: the eight tests. Section 41.4′s tests by which a clause is examined. Their function is analytical: they establish what the clause requires, whether it is possible, what it produces, and what it omits.

The second instrument: the substitution. Section 41.6′s exercise, in which each clause is replaced by specific conduct in the reader's actual circumstances. Its function is constructive: a definition is not altered by its analysis. The case material is unambiguous on the point — a man may state the clause's defect accurately and conduct it in the following week — and the substitution is what replaces the statement with conduct.

41.4 The Eight Tests

Each of the reader's clauses is examined with the following eight tests, in the order given, and the clause's classification is recorded at the end. The reader should conduct the tests in writing and should conduct them on his own clauses and not on the examples supplied here.

Test One: What Does It Require, in Acts?

The test. State the clause's requirement as a list of specific acts, conducted in specific circumstances.

Why it is first. The clause's authority depends substantially on its abstraction. *A man does not show weakness* is a statement about a category; its actual content is a list of acts — the tears held, the sentence not stated, the face arranged, the question not asked, the appearance of the medical symptom omitted, the day's exhaustion not mentioned, the fear not named. The test converts the category into the list, and the case material records the finding that readers are frequently surprised by the length of the list and by the number of items within it that produce nothing.

The reader's record. The clause, the acts, and, for each act, the setting and the person concerned.

Test Two: Is It Possible?

The test. Whether a human being can comply. The clauses that require the absence of a state — not to feel fear, not to grieve, not to be tired, not to be uncertain, not to be moved — are impossible, and the man's compliance with them is produced by concealment rather than by the state's absence. The finding is the material of Chapter 39.2′s fourth stage: the impossible clause is held, the state continues, and the man's access to it is removed, which is the clause's cost rather than its achievement.

The reader's record. For each clause, whether it is possible, and, where it is not, what the man has actually been conducting in its name.

Test Three: Whom Does It Serve?

The test. The clause's beneficiary: the man, his household, his organisation, his community, or the audience. The question should be asked in the direct form.

The common findings. The provision clause generally serves the household and would serve it better if its silence and exclusivity elements were removed, since the household's material is the reduction of the risk rather than the maintenance of the arrangement. The composure clause generally serves the audience and costs the man, which is the material of Chapter 25.6. The self-sufficiency clause generally serves the audience's regard and costs the man's health, which is the material of Chapters 31.3 and 35.2. The control clause generally serves the man's position and costs the household's capacity, which is the finding of Section 41.2′s fourth clause. The achievement clause serves the audience in part and the man in part, and the test's function is to establish the proportions.

The reader's record. The beneficiary of each clause and, where the beneficiary is the audience, the name of the specific audience.

Test Four: What Does It Cost, and Who Pays?

The test. The clause's cost, in figures and in material: the money, the hours, the health, the relationships, the opportunities, and the man's own account of his life. And the party who pays.

The method. The reader should conduct the test with the material of his own record: the year's hours, the medical position, the household's accounts of him from Section 39.8′s questionnaire, the items of Chapter 40.5′s second list, and the material of the losses in Parts VI and VII. The case material records the finding that the test is the one at which the reader's examination acquires its force, because the costs are the man's own and not the chapter's.

The reader's record. For each clause, the cost items and the party who pays.

Test Five: What Does It Omit?

The test. The clause's silence: what the definition does not contain, and what the man therefore has no instruction about.

The seven omissions of the inherited definition, as recorded in the case material.

1. **What a man is to do with his grief.** The clause requires the man not to display it and supplies no instruction beyond the concealment.
2. **What a man is to do with his fear.** The same, with the addition that the fear's object is frequently the household's position.
3. **What a man is to do when his load exceeds his capacity.** The clauses require the provision and the endurance and supply no instruction about the limit.
4. **What a man owes himself.** The definition's obligations are addressed to the household, the family, the community, and the position, and the man is the instrument of them rather than a party to them. The material of Chapter 40.

5. **What a man is to do when the position collapses.** The definition is written for the position's conduct and the material of Chapter 38 is its omission.
6. **What a man is to do when he is wrong.** The clauses supply the correction of others and not the man's own; the material of Chapter 29.
7. **What a man is to do with his tenderness.** The definition's clauses address the man's protection of his household and not his affection for it; the material of Chapter 39.6′s register.

The reader's record. The omissions he identifies in his own definition and the specific circumstances of his own life that fall into them.

Test Six: Where Did It Come From?

The test. The clause's source, from the eight in Section 41.1, and the occasion of its acquisition where the man can identify it.

The finding. The test's function is not to disqualify the clause but to establish its provenance, which is the material of Section 41.3′s third mechanism. The clauses that came from the man's own experience of a specific event are the ones that require the re-examination, and the reader's record should state the event and its date.

The reader's record. The source and the occasion for each clause, with the event recorded where the clause is held on the basis of the man's own evidence.

Test Seven: What Would It Require of Me If I Applied It to Myself as I Apply It to Others?

The test. The consistency test, and the one that produces the largest revision in most readers.

The method. Apply the clause to the reader's son, his daughter, his wife, his brother, his friend, and his subordinate, and then to himself.

The findings recorded in the case material. *A man does not ask for help* applied to a son who is failing at something → *I would tell him to ask*. *A man does not complain* applied to a daughter in a marriage that is making her ill → *I would tell her to speak*. *A man handles his own problems* applied to a friend whose position is the man's → *I would tell him he is a fool to carry it alone*. *A man does not show weakness* applied to the man's own father in the last years of his life → *I wanted him to tell me*. The test's finding is the reason it is included: **the reader generally holds a version of the definition for other people that is different from the version he holds for himself, and the version he holds for other people is the one he can state in his own voice.**

The reader's record. The clause, the version applied to the named others, and the difference.

Test Eight: What Is the Evidence, and Is It Sufficient?

The test. The clause's evidence, and the reasoning from it.

The method. For each clause held on the basis of the man's own experience, record the occasion, the parties, the outcome, and the conclusions the man drew. Then record the occasions to the contrary: the disclosure that was received well; the expression that was met with support; the assistance that was given; the request that was granted; the departure that occurred for reasons other than the man's softness; the year in which the man stated his position and the position was the better for it.

The finding, and the chapter states it as the examination's principal mechanical instruction. The clauses that men hold on the basis of their own experience are **very frequently held on the basis of one or two occasions, generally in adolescence, and generally of a type that the reader has never retested in the forty years since.** The specific form of the reasoning: a single event at fifteen (the disclosure to a friend that was laughed at; the tears in front of a father that were punished; the request that was refused) is converted into a rule about all parties, all settings, and all ages, and the rule is then maintained by the man's own compliance, which prevents the collection of any further evidence.

The reader's record. The evidence, its date, its sufficiency, and the specific retest the reader will conduct — one disclosure to one party, at one occasion, with the result recorded. The retest is the chapter's principal practical instruction and the material of Section 41.6′s substitution.

The Classification

After the eight tests, each clause is classified.

The classification's four outcomes.

Outcome one: maintain. The clause's obligation is authentic, its content is stated, and the additions identified by the tests are removed. The classification applies to the majority of the clauses that follow.

Outcome two: revise. The clause's obligation is authentic and its form requires alteration: the wording, the setting, the beneficiary, the acts. The material of Section 41.6.

Outcome three: replace. The clause's content is a prohibition on a state or an act that the man requires replaced by a specific conduct. The replacement is constructed in Section 41.6 and not adopted from a list.

Outcome four: release. The clause is an inheritance without a function, and the reader identifies no party it serves, no cost it is worth, and no occasion on which he would require it of anybody. The case material records the finding that the released clauses are generally the ones the man laughs at, which is not a defect in the examination but its evidence.

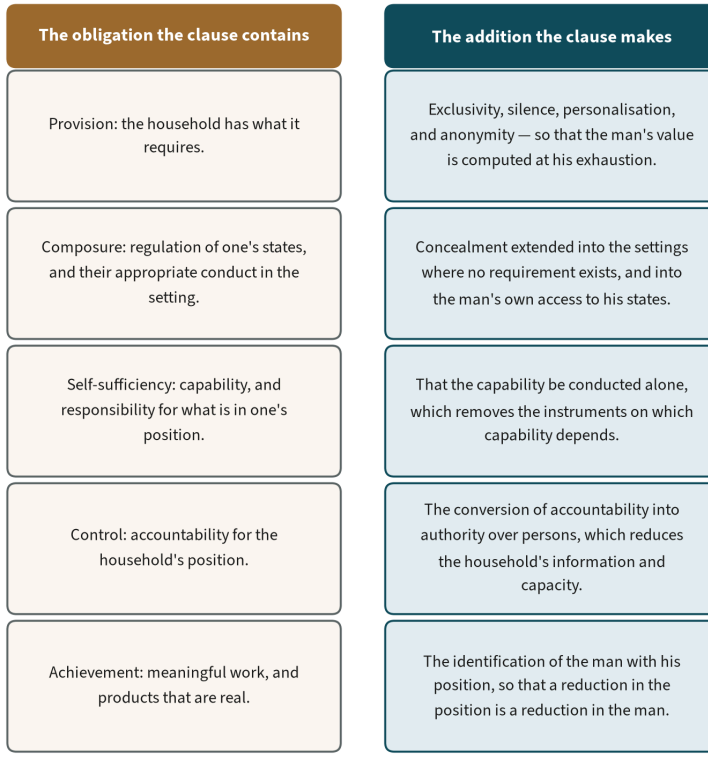


Figure 41.1 The five clauses of the inherited definition: the authentic obligation each contains, and the addition each makes. The revision maintains the obligation and removes the addition.

41.5 The Working Definition

The section supplies the form of the man's own definition, and the reader constructs his from it in Section 41.9. The chapter's form has four parts, and it is supplied because the case material recorded the finding that readers who were given no form produced statements that were either abstract or self-justifying.

Part One: The Obligations

The form. *A man is responsible for the following, and I state their content in acts.*

The material of Parts III to V, stated as the reader's actual obligations: his children, his household, his marriage or partnership, his work, his debts, his parents where they require it, the obligations he has undertaken, and the repairs he owes.

The requirement. Each obligation is stated with its content in specific acts, its size, and its period. The reader's instruction: **the obligations are stated accurately and not aspirationally.** The case material records that men who stated

their obligations aspirationally wrote definitions they could not conduct, which is the material of Chapter 33.2 in its definitional form.

Part Two: The Permissions

The form. *A man may do the following, and it is not a departure from his obligations but a condition of conducting them.*

The material of Chapter 40.4′s four permissions, in the reader's own words, together with the permissions that his own tests require: the permission to state his states, to ask, to reduce a load, to be bad at a new thing, to rest, to be wrong, to be moved, and to have a life.

The requirement. Each permission is stated as an act rather than as a licence: not *I may rest*, but *I may take the Saturday and state the arrangement in advance.*

Part Three: The Prohibitions

The form. *A man does not do the following, and these are the acts and not the states.*

The requirement. The prohibitions are stated as acts, which is the examination's principal achievement: not *I do not show weakness*, but *I do not discharge my anger into my household, I do not conceal a position that concerns my wife, I do not require the household's agreement before stating my own position, and I do not continue a load past the point at which I have stated its size.*

The finding. The reader's prohibitions will contain the material of Chapters 19, 20, 22, 26, and 29: the violence, the contempt, the discharge, the concealment, the infidelity that is the expression of everything unstated, the failure to repair.

Part Four: The Measure

The form. *A man's worth, and mine, is his whole conduct: his obligations and their conduct; his household and his presence in it; his work and its products; his conduct with the people who can do nothing for him; the repairs he has made; and his own life, which is an item and not a residue.*

The material of Chapter 25.5, in the reader's own statement.

The requirement. The measure is stated with at least three items that the audience cannot see, which is the test of whether the measure has been constructed or recited.

41.6 The Substitution

The analysis of a definition does not alter it, and the substitution is the section that supplies the construction. Its method is the replacement of each clause by specific conduct, conducted in the reader's actual circumstances, at the level of the act.

The Four Steps of the Substitution

Step one: the clause is stated. In the man's own words, as he holds it, without softening.

Step two: the acts are listed. The specific acts the clause currently requires of him, in his actual circumstances.

Step three: the acts are tested. For each act: what it produces, whom it serves, and what it costs. The criterion for retention: the act produces a good that the man can state, in his own voice, without the definition's assistance. The criterion for release: the act produces nothing but compliance.

Step four: the replacement act is written. Specific, dated, conducted in the man's circumstances, and stated in the form of a first step.

The Twelve Substitutions

The following substitutions are the ones most frequently recorded in the case material. The reader should construct his own and should use these as the patterns of the form rather than as the content.

1. **From** ***I do not discuss the position with my wife*** **to** ***I state the position's size on the first Sunday of each month, in figures, and I ask what it requires of her arrangements.***

2. **From** ***I do not ask for help*** **to** ***I have four named parties I telephone before I hold a difficulty for more than a month, and their names are written.***

3. **From** ***I do not show that it is affecting me*** **to** ***I state what is present in me to my wife within the day, in four sentences, and I do not require her to resolve it.***

4. **From** ***I do not cry*** **to** ***I permit the tears when they arrive, and I do not apologise for them.***

5. **From** ***I do not complain*** **to** ***I state the load's size as information, without the complaint and without the concealment.***

6. **From** ***I handle my own problems*** **to** ***I conduct the position and I use every instrument, including the professional and the man who has been where I am.***

7. **From** ***I control my household*** **to** ***I answer for the household's position, I distribute the decisions, and I state my determination as a position rather than as an order.***

8. **From** ***a man's word is the decision*** **to** ***my word is my undertaking, and my household's members are parties to the arrangements that concern them.***

9. **From** ***I do not take a day off*** **to** ***I keep the period of rest, and if there is one who cannot rest it is on the strength of my rest.***

10. **From** ***I am measured by what I own and what I have achieved*** **to** ***I am measured by my whole conduct, and I can state three items in that measure which the audience cannot see.***

11. From *I do not become attached to that extent* to *I am attached, I say so, and the attachment is what I am for in this house.*

12. From *I must be the equal of the men around me* to *I conduct my household's position at the level of my own obligations, and the comparison is not among my criteria.*

The Three Requirements of the Substitution

Requirement one: each replacement is in acts and in the present circumstances. Not *I will be more open*, but the party, the occasion, the sentence, and the frequency. The case material is consistent: the substitutions that were conducted were stated as acts and the substitutions that were abandoned were stated as intentions.

Requirement two: the first step is conducted within the week. The finding from the case material: the man who conducts one substitution within a week of the exercise conducts the majority of the remainder, and the man who completes the exercise without conducting one does not return to it.

Requirement three: the substitution is stated to one person. The material of Chapters 35, 39.5′s Practice Five, and 40.6′s Matter One. The reading of the man's statement to the ally or to the household is the mechanism by which the definition is altered in the man's actual arrangements rather than in his notebook.

The Three Difficulties

Difficulty one: the substitution reads as a betrayal of the man's father. The difficulty is reported by men more frequently than any other in this material, and the chapter's instruction is specific: **the reader is not replacing his father; he is completing him.** The case material's formulation, recorded from a reader in a group setting: *My father gave me the rules for the conditions he was in, and he did not have the information that I have, and I am not judging him. I am adding the part he could not have known about, and I am doing it for his grandsons.* The instruction's second element: the man's own addition is the more useful because his father's conduct is not available to be altered and the man's conduct is.

Difficulty two: the substitution feels like a description of a different man. The difficulty of the man whose definition is not a set of clauses but a constitution. The instruction is the substitution's size: the reader replaces two or three clauses rather than the whole, and the case material records that a man who conducts two substitutions has altered his definition's effect on his household within a year.

Difficulty three: the household does not believe the change. The material of Chapter 39.6′s second rule and Chapter 40.6′s Matter Two: the change is conducted rather than announced; the household's doubt is endured rather than argued with; and the conduct is continued for the period in which the household

is calibrating its response, which the case material records as generally between six and eighteen months.

41.7 Illustrative Case: The Two Definitions in One Man

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in men's counselling, occupational practice, and family practice.

Ibrahim is forty-seven, a police officer of the rank of chief superintendent, married to Halima for twenty-two years, with three children aged twenty, seventeen, and eleven.

Ibrahim's position in the case is the one this chapter describes in its most explicit form, because his professional definition and his household's requirements were stated to him in writing and in conduct, and the case records both.

The professional definition, as he described it in the first sitting: *In my service the rule is simple. You do not show fear and you do not show favour and you do not show that a thing has touched you. I have been in the service for twenty-four years and I have never once said to a colleague that something was difficult for me, and I have never once been asked. The rank is the thing. When I put on the uniform I am the rank, and the rank does not have a private position.*

The household's material, as described by Halima in a separate interview: *He is a good man. He has never touched me in anger. He provides. He is respected everywhere. And for twenty-two years he has come into this house and he has been the rank. He answers me the way he answers a constable. He asks me questions when he wants a decision. When my father died in 2018 he arranged the burial and he stood at the gate greeting the people for three days and in the evening of the third day he asked me whether the accounts were complete. I said yes and I went inside and I sat in the bathroom for one hour. I have never told him that either.*

The material of the case that produced the man's attendance was a specific event in his twenty-fourth year of service. He was required, as the senior officer present at the scene of a fatal road collision, to identify the body of a young man and to inform the family. The young man was nineteen years old, and the man's own son was seventeen at the time. The event, in his own account: *I did everything correctly. I made the identification. I went to the house. I told the father in four sentences, the way I have been trained, and I stood there while he fell down, and I held his arm and I said the two sentences I always say, and I came back to the station and I wrote my report and I went home and I ate my food and I went to sleep at ten. And I woke at twenty past two in the morning and I could not move my arms. I lay there for about an hour and I thought, I have been doing this for twenty-four years and I have never felt any of it, and it is not that I am strong, it is that I have not been in the room. And I thought about my son, and I began to shake, and I could not stop it, and I got out of the bed and I stood in the bathroom and I did not know what to do and I did not wake my wife because I did not know how to tell her that I was frightened.*

The work, conducted over about two years, had four elements.

The first element: the definition written down. Ibrahim wrote eleven statements, and the ones he identified as his own, in his own words, were: *a man is the rank; a man does not show that a thing has touched him; a man handles it alone; a man's household is conducted by him; a man does not explain himself twice; and a man is the one who stands at the gate.*

The second element: the eight tests. The tests' findings, in his own account, were three. **The first** was Test Two, the possibility: *The counsellor said, can a man arrange not to be touched by a dead boy. I said that a man can arrange not to show it. She said, and you have arranged that, and the touching is still happening, and it is happening in your bathroom at half past two. I have never forgotten that sentence.* **The second** was Test Five, the omissions, in which he identified two: *There is nothing in my rules about what happens after, and nothing at all about my own house. It is all about the station.* **The third** was Test Eight, the evidence, and it concerned his own father. His father had been a soldier and had died when Ibrahim was twenty-six, and the material was: *I never had one conversation with my father that was not about my career or the family. And when he was dying, in the hospital, I sat with him for six days and I wanted him to say one thing to me about himself, anything, and he told me about the arrangements for his burial and the house in Kaduna. I have been angry about that for twenty-two years and I have been doing it to my own children.*

The third element: the household's material. Ibrahim conducted the disclosure to Halima in the fourth month, in the four-part form, and the passages he supplied included the bathroom conversation: *I told her about the three days of her father's burial and about what I had asked her, and she began to cry, and I sat there and after some time I put my hand on her shoulder, which I have not done in about ten years, and I said the sentence that the counsellor had told me to say if I could not find my own, which was that I was sorry and that I did not know how to do this. And she said something that I will not forget. She said, Ibrahim, I have been waiting for you to be bad at something for twenty-two years. You have never once been bad at anything.*

The fourth element: the substitutions. He selected three, and his own formulations, recorded from his written statement, were the following. **One:** *From, I am the rank in this house, to, I put the rank at the gate.* He described the conduct: *I decided to take off the tunic at the door. I am not making a joke. I would enter the house and I would stand in the small corridor at the back and I would take off the uniform and I would put on the cloth and I would come into the house and I would speak in my ordinary voice, and I did it for about four months before it was not a performance. My youngest noticed before anybody. He said, Baba, you are talking like a person.* **Two:** *From, I do not explain myself twice, to, I tell them what I am thinking and I let them disagree.* The conduct: *I began to say what I was thinking at the table. I said, the thing about this matter is that I do not know what to do. My wife stopped eating. My daughter said, Baba, you do not know what to do? I said, no, and she said, that has never happened in this house. And then they began to tell me things. My second one told me in that week about a matter at the school that she had been carrying for four months and had not told me because I would have gone to the school and settled it and*

she did not want it settled, she wanted to be heard. I listened for about forty minutes. I have never listened for forty minutes in that house. **Three:** *From, a man is the one who stands at the gate, to, a man is the one who can be found inside the house.* The conduct: *I delegated the gate. I mean this literally. At my niece's wedding in the following year I stood at the gate for one hour and then I went inside and I sat with my family and I ate the food. My brother-in-law asked me who was at the gate and I said, my brother is at the gate, and he looked at me for a moment and then he laughed.*

The review, conducted at eighteen months and recorded in the case document, contained three items. **First:** the rank and the household were being conducted separately, and Ibrahim's own description of the change was: *The service has not changed and I have not changed my work. I have my rank. What has changed is that there is one room in this town in which I am not the rank, and I go to that room every evening, and I am fifty years old and I have just found out that I like my wife's company and that my daughter tells jokes.* **Second:** his sleep, which had been the presenting difficulty: *I sleep. I do not know why. I have not done anything about the sleep. The counsellor says it is because there is nowhere left in the day in which nothing is happening.* **Third:** the material of his own father, which he described as follows: *I went to the grave in December with a bottle of water and I poured it on the ground and I said, Baba, I have added something to what you gave me, and I have given it to your grandchildren, and you were doing what you knew. That was all I said and I stood there for about ten minutes and then I drove home and my son was in the compound and he said, Baba, where have you been, and I told him.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The two definitions were explicit and both were written down. The professional definition was stated in the man's own words, and the household's requirement was stated by his wife. The case is included because the reader's own two definitions are generally as distinct as Ibrahim's and as rarely examined together: the definition a man conducts at work, where it functions, and the definition he conducts in his household, where its extension is not required.

The wakefulness at twenty past two was the moment of the examination. The event was a decade of the man's professional experience compressed into one night, and the case records the mechanism of the chapter's fifth omission: the definition supplies no instruction about what happens after. The case is included because the material of this book's examination is generally located at a single occasion of this kind, and because the man's own description — *it is not that I am strong, it is that I have not been in the room* — is the chapter's central finding in the reader's own voice.

The tests produced the material rather than the counsellor. Tests Two, Five, and Eight supplied the possibility's finding, the omissions, and the father's conversation in the hospital. The case is included because the chapter's instru-

ment is analytical and its results are the reader's own, and because the man's own evidence about his father — carried for twenty-two years and reproduced in his own household — is the third mechanism of Section 41.3 in its clearest available form.

The substitutions were specific, physical, and conducted. The tunic on the corridor hook, the statement at the table that he did not know what to do, and the hour at his niece's wedding inside rather than at the gate. The case is included because the substitutions' forms are the chapter's practical instruction: a definition is altered by conduct that is small, repeated, and visible, and the man's own report — *I did it for about four months before it was not a performance* — records the period honestly.

The household's response was immediate and it contained the material the man had not had. The wife's sentence about being bad at something, and the daughter's matter at the school carried for four months. The case is included because it records the finding of Chapters 31.1 and 34.6 in the household's setting: the man's definition has been reducing the information available to him, and the reduction's removal produces the material within a week.

41.8 Warmth, Strength, and the Man His Household Needs

The chapter's material has one further subject, and it is supplied here because the reader who has conducted the analysis of his definition will arrive at it.

The question. If the definition is revised, what is left? The case material records the question in the reader's own form: *You have taken away the rules. What am I now?*

The answer, in five statements.

First: the obligations are unchanged. The reader's obligations to his children, his household, his marriage, his work, his debts, and the people who rely on him are the material of Parts III to V and they are not reduced by the chapter. The definition's revision removes the clauses that conceal the position, silence the load, isolate the man, convert accountability into authority, and identify him with his position. It does not remove a single obligation.

Second: the competences are unchanged and they are increased. The reliability, the judgement, the composure under pressure, the capacity to carry, the provision, the protection, the keeping of the man's word, and the conduct in the position. These are the man's competences and the chapter's revisions increase them, because the man's states become information, his instruments become available, and his household becomes a party rather than a protected object.

Third: the man becomes available, and that is the largest single alteration. The material of Chapter 39.3′s first two costs, and the household's accounts in the cases of this book: what the household requires is not the man's

softness in place of his strength and not his strength in place of his presence, but his presence as a person in the arrangements he is conducting.

Fourth: the man's own life is added rather than substituted. The material of Chapter 40: the man's own life is an item on his ledger. The definition's revision does not require him to choose himself instead of his household; it requires that he be on the list.

Fifth: the transmission alters, and it alters without a lecture. The material of Chapter 43: a man's sons, daughters, and the young men in his trade learn the definition from his conduct with his own material, his own fear, his own failures, and his own household. A man who conducts the chapter's revisions transmits a definition with the omissions filled, and the case material records the finding that the transmission is not conducted by instruction because it does not need to be.

The chapter's closing statement to the reader. The definition he inherited was written by people who were conducting their lives in conditions that were harder than his and with information that was smaller than his, and it produced the man he is and the household he has kept. Its revision is not ingratitude, and it is not the abandonment of the category: it is the completion of an unfinished document by the party who has the material that the authors did not have — which is the man himself, in his own household, with his own evidence, in his own years.

41.9 Practical Exercise: The Definition and the Substitution

The exercise is conducted over three sittings and produces a one-page statement in the reader's own hand.

Sitting One: The Material

Section A: The statements. Write the statements you hold, in your own words, without softening. Consult the eleven in Section 41.1 as a prompt and do not adopt them where they are not yours.

Section B: The sources. For each statement, record its source from the eight in Section 41.1, and the occasion or the age where you can identify it.

Section C: The classification. Classify each statement: the obligation, the prohibition on a state, the prohibition on an act, the description of a status, or the inheritance without a function.

Section D: The definition at work and the definition at home. Write the two definitions separately, as Ibrahim's case establishes: the statements you conduct in your work or your public position, and the statements you conduct in your household. Record the differences.

Sitting Two: The Tests

Conduct the eight tests of Section 41.4 on the three clauses you have classified as the prohibition on a state, the prohibition on an act, and the description of a status, and record the results.

The clause	The acts it requires	Is it possible?	Whom does it serve?	What does it cost, and who pays?	What does it omit?	Its source	Applied to others, what would it require?	The evidence, and is it sufficient?	The outcome

The record of the evidence. For each clause held on the basis of your own experience, write the occasion, the date, the parties, and the conclusions you drew. Then write the three occasions that ran the other way, and record where you have not tested the clause since.

The retest. Select one clause and design one retest: one disclosure to one party, at one stated occasion, with the result recorded in writing afterwards, and record the date.

Sitting Three: The Statement and the Substitution

Section A: The statement. Write your own definition in the four parts of Section 41.5, in no more than one page.

1. **The obligations.** Your actual obligations, each with its content in acts, its size, and its period.
2. **The permissions.** In your own words, each stated as an act.
3. **The prohibitions.** As acts and not as states.
4. **The measure.** Your measure, with at least three items the audience cannot see.

Section B: The substitution. For each clause you classified as revise, replace, or release, write the substitution in the four steps of Section 41.6: the clause, the acts it currently requires, the test of each act, and the replacement act with its first step and its date.

Section C: The statement to the household. Write it in the form of Chapters 39.5′s Practice Six and 40.6′s Matter One: what you have held, what you have found, what you are conducting, and what you require of the household's account. Record the date on which you will read it.

Section D: The review. Fix the review at three months and at a year, and record the two questions: which substitutions have been conducted, and which have not.

41.10 Common Questions Men Ask

"If I let go of these rules, what will hold my household together?"

The obligations of Parts III to V are not among the rules the chapter proposes to release, and the review in Section 41.4's classification supplies the boundary: the clauses classified as maintain are the ones the household's position depends on, and the clauses classified as revise, replace, or release are the ones that conceal the position, silence the load, isolate the man, convert accountability into authority, or identify him with his position. The finding from the case material is that the households of the men who conducted the revision describe the household as more secure and not less, and the mechanism is supplied by their own accounts: the household knows the position, the household participates in the arrangements, and the man is present in a form it can describe.

"I was raised this way and I turned out well. Why should I change it?"

The chapter's material does not require the reader to regard his raising as a failure. The case material's finding, and the one the chapter states plainly in Section 41.8, is that the definition's authors conducted their lives with less information than the reader now has, and that the definition's omissions are the material of this book's forty preceding chapters. The specific question the chapter puts to the reader is not whether he turned out well but the one in Section 41.4's eighth test: **what is the evidence for each clause, and where has it been tested?** The men in the case material who retained the majority of their definition retained it with the tests conducted and with the clauses stated in acts, and their own accounts record the difference between the definition they were given and the definition they now hold.

"My wife is used to me as I am. Will this not disturb the household?"

The alteration of a man's conduct alters the household's arrangements, and the case material records the disturbance honestly. The instructions that govern it are Section 41.6's three requirements and Chapter 40.6's Matter One: the substitutions are conducted rather than announced; the first step is conducted within the week; the statement is made to the ally and to the household; and the household's doubt is endured for the period it takes to calibrate, which the case material records as generally between six and eighteen months. The specific finding of Ibrahim's case — the wife's sentence about waiting twenty-two years for him to be bad at something — is recorded because it is reported in similar forms across the case material.

"My father is still alive and he holds these rules. Do I owe him a conversation?"

The reader owes his father the account and not the argument. The material of Chapters 29.6 and 30.6 applies: the man's own account of what his father gave him, stated once, with the addition stated as the man's own act and not as a

correction of his father. The case material records two findings: the conversation is generally received better than the man's fear predicted, and the conversation's purpose is not the father's alteration, which is not available, but the man's own statement of the account, which is the material of Chapter 36′s fourth condition and Chapter 44′s material.

"I do not want to be an example for my sons. That is pressure."

The transmission is not conducted by the man's intention to be an example; it is conducted by his conduct, which the man's sons are already observing. The material of Chapter 43 establishes the mechanism and its direction: the sons learn the man's conduct with his own difficulty, his own fear, his own request for assistance, and his own repairs. The reader who does not wish to be an example has not thereby avoided being one; the specific choice available to him is what the example consists of.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 41 in brief. A man's definition of manhood is assembled from eight sources — his father's conduct, his mother's and household's instruction, the institutions of his adolescence, his peer group, his household of origin's arrangements, his culture's presentation of men, his own experience, and his own conduct and its rewards — and the last of these maintains it in the present. The definitions are held as statements, and each is an obligation, a prohibition on a state, a prohibition on an act, a description of a status, or an inheritance without a function.

The five principal clauses are the provision, the composure, the self-sufficiency, the control, and the achievement. Each contains an authentic obligation and an addition: the provision's additions are exclusivity, silence, personalisation, and anonymity; the composure's addition is the extension of concealment into the settings where no requirement exists and into the man's own access to his states; the self-sufficiency's addition is that capability be conducted alone; the control's addition is the conversion of accountability for the household into authority over its members; and the achievement's addition is the identification of the man with his position. The revisions maintain the obligations and remove the additions.

The definition is enforced without an enforcer, by four mechanisms: the man's internal examination of his own conduct, the audience's monitoring, the real consequences of his own past disclosures, and — where it exists — his own substitute record. Eight tests examine each clause: what it requires in acts; whether it is possible; whom it serves; what it costs and who pays; what it omits; where it came from; what it would require if applied to others; and what the evidence is. The tests' most consequential finding is that the clauses held on the basis of a man's own experience are very frequently held on one or two occasions, generally in adolescence, and have never been retested.

The working definition has four parts: the obligations, stated accurately and in acts; the permissions, stated as acts; the prohibitions, stated as acts and not as states; and

the measure, which is the man's whole conduct and contains at least three items the audience cannot see. The substitution replaces each revised clause with specific conduct in the reader's actual circumstances, with its first step conducted within the week and its statement read to the ally or the household. The analysis of a definition does not alter it; the substitution does.

Reflection Questions

1. Write your definition's statements, in your own words, without softening. How many are prohibitions on a state?
2. Which single clause has cost you the most, and what is the evidence from your own household?
3. Complete the eighth test on the clause you hold most firmly. What was the occasion, how old were you, and how many times has it been tested since?
4. Which of the seven omissions of the inherited definition is present in your life, and what has it produced?
5. Write the version of your definition that you would give your son or your daughter. How does it differ from the version you conduct?
6. Write your measure with three items the audience cannot see.
7. Which substitution will you conduct this week, and to whom will you read the statement?

Further Reading

- **On masculinity and its construction:** the research literature on the construction of masculinity and its socialisation, including the findings on masculine norms, on the restrictive-emotion dimension of those norms, and on the consequences of conformity to them for men's health, relationships, and help-seeking.
- **On norms and behaviour change:** the research on social norms and on behaviour change, including the findings on the internalisation of norms, on the conditions under which norms are revised, and on the role of conduct as against argument in changing what a person holds.
- **On men's emotional socialisation:** the literature on boys' and men's emotional development, including the findings on the messages men receive in childhood and adolescence, on the specific content of the prohibitions, and on the evidence concerning adult change.
- **On fatherhood and the transmission of patterns:** the research on intergenerational transmission, including the findings on the transmission of fathers' emotional styles and on the evidence concerning the interruption of transmitted patterns.

- **Practical resources:** men's groups and discussion groups, including the material in Appendix S; individual counselling and psychological services; marriage and relationship counselling; and the worksheets in Appendices H, I, and O.

42 CHAPTER

Building a Life That Does Not Depend on Pretending

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Define what pretending means in this book, and distinguish it from privacy, from discretion, and from the ordinary management of a man's account of himself.
2. Identify the six domains in which pretences are conducted, and locate his own in each.
3. Analyse the five costs of a life that depends on pretending, including the cost that is paid before anything is discovered.
4. Describe the four mechanisms by which a pretence is maintained, and the seven signs that it is failing.
5. Construct the supports of a life that does not depend on pretending, in the six domains.
6. Conduct the dismantling in the order that the practice material supports: the controlled disclosure, the reduction, the negotiation, and the reconstruction at the true level.

Introduction

The previous chapter examined the definition of manhood a man holds. This chapter examines the life he has built on it — and specifically the part of that life whose continuation depends on other people continuing to believe something that is not true.

The position is common enough that it must be stated precisely at the outset, because its boundary is not obvious and the reader's first response is generally to deny that the material applies to him.

A man's privacy is not a pretence. A man is entitled to conduct his own affairs without reporting them; the material of Chapters 18.6 and 20.6 established the distinction between the household's right to know and the man's general right

to conduct his own matters. A man's discretion about his income, his savings, his dealings, his past, and his own interior is not the subject of this chapter.

A man's ordinary presentation is not a pretence. A man who is composed at a meeting when he is exhausted, who conducts a negotiation while his household's position is unsettled, who does not state his grief at a professional occasion, or who presents a confidence he does not wholly feel is conducting the ordinary management of his own conduct. This is the material of Chapter 39.4′s definition and it is a competence.

A pretence, in this chapter's sense, is a state of affairs in which the man's position can continue only for as long as specified parties do not learn specified facts. The man's income, his debts, his employment, his competence, his marriage, his health, his household's arrangements, or his professional position is represented to be something other than what it is, and the representation's continuation is a **requirement** of his position rather than a choice about its presentation.

The distinction has a mechanical test, and it is the one the chapter supplies at the outset because it determines whether the reader can conduct the work: **a man is conducting a pretence where he is arranging his conduct so that a particular party does not learn a particular fact, and where his arrangements would require alteration if that party learned it.**

The chapter's concern is not the lie's morality. It is the structure: a life that requires specific parties to remain uninformed has a shape, and the shape has five costs. The cost that the case material establishes first, and the one that men report as the most significant, is the cost paid before anything is discovered: the constant vigilance that the position requires, the anticipation, the arrangements made to avoid the meeting of parties, the accounts not seen, the questions not answered, the telephone calls taken outside the room, and the specific exhaustion of a man who is conducting two accounts at once.

The chapter's approach has five commitments.

The first is that the material is not a moral lecture. The men in the case material did not build their positions out of vanity. They built them in the ordinary conduct of the obligations of Parts III to V: the school fees that had to be paid, the household that could not be told, the standing that was the instrument of the business, the occasion that could not be declined, the money that was borrowed to cover, and the covering that then required further borrowing.

The second is that the outcome is not the exposure and its shame; it is the restoration of the man's position at its true level. Section 42.5′s material is constructive, and the case material's finding is consistent: the man's position, conducted at its true level, is generally more secure, cheaper to conduct, and more productive than the performance it replaced. The specific finding: **the perfor-**

mance has costs that the true level does not have — the interest, the avoided arrangements, the occasions that must be conducted, the parties who must not meet, the hours of vigilance, and the deals made on false accounts whose terms the man cannot enforce.

The third is that the disclosure is cheaper than the exposure. The central mechanical finding of the chapter, and the one that supplies its urgency: a controlled disclosure, conducted by the man, at his own timing, in the order he chooses, with the arrangements he has prepared, costs the man a fraction of what an uncontrolled exposure costs. The case material records the difference consistently: the men whose positions collapsed in a discovery lost their standing, their relationships, and frequently their households; the men who conducted the disclosure lost the performance, which was the thing that had to end in either case, and retained their households' participation.

The fourth is that the dismantling is conducted in an order. The seven errors of Chapter 38.3 apply directly here, and the most consequential of them for this material is the attempt to restore the position immediately, generally by a further borrowing, which is the mechanism by which the pretence escalates into a collapse.

The fifth is that the man's purpose is the substance and not the conduct of the work. The chapter is placed in Part XII because its subject is the construction of a life; the reader's product is not the removal of a set of pretences but the establishment of arrangements that do not require them, and Section 42.5′s six supports are supplied as the constructive material.

42.1 The Six Domains

The section supplies the material. The reader's task is to record, for each domain, the fact that would have to be known and the parties who must not learn it.

Domain One: The Money

The common form. The man's income and his obligations are represented to be different from what they are. The household's expenditure is conducted at a level the man's income does not support; the position is maintained by borrowing, by facilities, by instalments, by the household's relatives' assistance, by an inheritance, or by the sale of assets; and the accounts are held by the man alone.

The specific acts. The statement of a salary higher than the actual; the concealed facility; the second facility; the instalment arrangements whose total is not stated; the school fees funded by a borrowing the household believes is the man's income; the contributions to the extended family funded by a shortfall in the household; the vehicle whose instalments are unknown; the occasion conducted at a level that requires a borrowing; the account held in a form the wife is not shown.

The parties who must not learn. Generally the wife, the children, the extended family, and the community. The finding from the case material: the man's account of *why* is almost always the same, and it is the material of Chapters 25 and 41 — *because I could not be seen to be unable* — and the specific form the case material records most frequently is a sentence about the man's father, his cohort, or his wife's family.

The measure. The gap between the household's expenditure and the man's actual income, recorded monthly; and the total of the concealed obligations, recorded as a figure. The reader who cannot state either of these figures is in the position this domain describes.

Domain Two: The Work and the Competence

The common form. The man's position, his income's source, or his competence is represented to be other than what it is. The business that has ceased to trade; the contract that was not renewed; the practice that lost its principal client; the employment that ended in the previous quarter; the competence the man does not hold and represents that he does; the qualification that is expected and was not obtained; the project that is not proceeding; the promotion that is not available.

The specific acts. The man who leaves the house at the usual hour and conducts the day without employment; the business whose closure is known to the man and not to the household; the man who accepts work beyond his competence because the disclosure of the limit was unavailable to him; the project's reports conducted from the man's own accounts; the arrangements with the creditors conducted in secret.

The parties who must not learn. The household, the extended family, the professional body, the client, the community. The finding: the work domain's pretence is the one with the shortest duration, because the income's reduction becomes visible in the household's arrangements within months, and the case material records the specific and painful period of the man who leaves at the usual hour and returns at the usual hour with nothing accomplished.

The measure. The answer to the question *what would my household learn if it read my bank statements and my post for the last three months?*

Domain Three: The Marriage

The common form. The marriage is represented to be other than what it is: to the extended family, the community, the household's children, the man's colleagues, and frequently to the man himself.

The specific acts. The performance of the marriage at the occasions; the joint attendance; the photographs; the account of the marriage given to the relatives; the separate arrangements conducted under one address; the man's own report

to his friends that his marriage is satisfactory; the silence about the years of the arrangement described in Chapter 39.3′s first cost.

The parties who must not learn. The extended family, the community, frequently the children, and — the specific and most consequential form — the man himself. The finding from the case material: this domain contains the pretence that is maintained for the longest period and the one whose disclosure the man most resists, and the material of Chapters 39 and 40.7′s third choice is its substance.

The measure. The answer to the question *if the person closest to me were asked tomorrow to describe our marriage in four sentences, what would they say, and how far is it from what I would say?*

Domain Four: The Household

The common form. The household's position is represented to be other than what it is: the provision that is actually conducted by the wife's labour, the school fees funded by a relative, the house that is not owned, the arrangement that is not on the terms represented, the household's difficulties concealed from the extended family or the community.

The specific acts. The man who accepts the credit for a provision that was substantially his wife's; the household conducted on the wife's income while the man's account of the household is that he is the provider; the assets that are not owned; the accommodation that is represented as owned; the man's arrangements with the extended family that are conducted at the household's expense without the household's knowledge.

The measure. The answer to the question *what does my household's position actually consist of, and who is actually conducting it?* The finding recorded in the case material: men in this domain generally list the household's material accurately when asked directly and have never stated it to the household, and the pretence is one of attribution rather than of fact.

Domain Five: The Health and the Body

The common form. The man's health is represented to be other than what it is: the symptom that has not been investigated, the condition that has been diagnosed and not disclosed, the medication that is taken privately, the functioning that is supported by alcohol, by stimulants, by caffeine, or by an effort that is no longer sustainable.

The specific acts. The appointment not made; the result not collected; the diagnosis not stated to the household; the medication in the vehicle; the drinking whose measure is known to the man and not the household; the sleep that the man accounts for as ordinary; the injury not reported; the fatigue attributed to work.

The parties who must not learn. The household, the employer, the professional body, the colleagues, the insurer. The finding: this domain's pretence has the most serious consequences in the case material of this book, since the condition that is concealed is the condition that is not treated, and the material of Chapters 23, 31, and 36 supplies the outcomes.

The measure. The answers to three questions: what have I not had investigated; what do I know about my health that my household does not know; and what am I using to function that I have not disclosed?

Domain Six: The Standing and the Position

The common form. The man's position in his community, his profession, his household's extended family, his place of worship, his association, or his trade is represented to be other than what it is: the titles, the offices, the membership of the arrangements, the contributions at the occasions, the assistance extended to the extended family, the fees paid to the associations, the position in the community's accounts.

The specific acts. The contribution to the extended family's occasions that requires a borrowing; the office accepted and not conducted; the title held without the substance; the contributions to the community whose level is sustained by the man's borrowing; the vehicle, the clothing, the house, and the occasions maintained at a level produced by the audience rather than by the man's obligations.

The measure. The answer to the question *what am I paying for, in this domain, that produces nothing except the audience's account of me?* The finding from the case material, and the material of Chapters 25.6 and 40.5′s Category Two: the amount is generally substantial, its release is generally the largest single recovery in a man's audit, and its release is the one he resists most.

The Two-Column Form

The reader's record for each domain:

The domain	The fact	The parties who must not learn it	What I do to prevent their learning it	What it costs me to do so
The money				
The work				
The marriage				
The household				
The health				
The standing				

KEY POINT

A pretence, in this chapter's sense, is a state of affairs in which the man's position can continue only for as long as specified parties do not learn specified facts. Privacy is not a pretence, and the ordinary management of a man's presentation is not a pretence; the test is whether the man is arranging his conduct so that a particular party does not learn a particular fact, and whether his arrangements would require alteration if that party learned it. The six domains are the money, the work and the competence, the marriage, the household, the health, and the standing.

42.2 The Five Costs

The costs are five, and the first is paid before anything is discovered. The reader should apply each to his own record and should note that the first is the one the case material records as the most significant.

Cost One: The Vigilance

The material. A life that requires specified parties to remain uninformed requires an active arrangement to keep them so, and the arrangement is conducted continuously.

The specific forms. The telephone calls taken outside the room; the correspondence collected before it is seen; the message deleted; the account's password; the two parties kept apart; the meeting declined; the visit avoided; the question answered without the answer's subject; the figures in the head that must be consistent with the figures previously stated; the story that must be maintained with each party separately and consistently; the household's routines observed in order to know what has been seen.

The finding. The vigilance is **the man's most significant ongoing cost**, and it is unpaid in no currency the man can see, which is the reason it is undercounted. Its material: the attention that is not available for the man's work; the sleep that is reduced by the night-time accounting; the anticipatory dread of the discovery, which is the condition Chapter 30.2 described; the man's own withdrawal from ordinary occasions, because ordinary occasions are the settings in which the pretence may be punctured; and the specific exhaustion that the case material records in the man's own words: *I was not tired from the work. I was tired from the managing.*

The particular mechanism. The vigilance's cost increases with the pretence's age, because the number of parties who must be kept apart increases, the number of accounts that must be consistent increases, and the number of small items that must be remembered increases. The finding: the man who has maintained a pretence for five years is conducting more arrangement to maintain it than he is conducting to conduct his position.

Cost Two: The Escalation

The material. A pretence requires the covering of its own evidence, and the covering generally produces further borrowing, further statement, or further arrangements that must themselves be concealed. This is the mechanism of Chapter 38.3′s second error extended over time.

The specific forms. The facility taken to cover the instalments; the second facility taken to cover the first; the new contract taken to fund the current obligations; the borrowing to conduct the occasion that maintains the standing; the promotion sought not for the income or the work but for the account of the position; the compounding of the story as the facts diverge further.

The finding. The escalation is the mechanism by which a pretence becomes a collapse, and the case material records the specific progression in figures: a shortfall of a manageable size in the first year, a shortfall that is a multiple of it in the third, and a position that cannot be covered in the fifth. The finding is worth stating in the reader's own terms: **the pretence does not hold the position; it delays the discovery of the position's size, and it increases the size while it delays.**

Cost Three: The Reduction of the Man's Relationships

The material. A pretence cannot be conducted in the presence of the parties who would puncture it, and the arrangement's consequence is that the man's relationships reduce.

The specific forms. The wife, who is the first party from whom the money, the work, the health, and frequently the marriage itself must be concealed; the friend whose questions are searching; the household's members whose arrangements touch the concealed domain; the colleague who knows the work's position; the relative who would need to be told the truth about the extended family's arrangements. The finding: the man's relationships reduce to those parties before whom the pretence can be maintained, and those parties are generally the ones who require nothing of him.

The particular consequence. The disclosure function of Chapter 27 is removed, which is the finding of the case material: the man conducting a pretence is the man with no one who knows the whole of his position, and the material of Chapters 27, 31, and 35 supplies the outcomes — the delays, the isolation, the unnegotiated positions, and the conditions that are treated late.

Cost Four: The Reduction of the Man's Own Judgement

The material. A man conducting two accounts cannot use either accurately. The specific forms: the decisions taken on the basis of the position he has represented rather than the position he has; the orders accepted on a false income; the occasions conducted at a level that requires a further borrowing; the risk accepted because the shortfall could not be stated; the negotiation conducted without the

household's material; the route chosen because the alternative would require the disclosure.

The finding. The judgement's reduction is structural rather than psychological: the man's decisions are taken in the world he has described, and the world he has described is not the world he is in. The case material records the outcome with the specific and consistent form: **the man's decisions were correct for the position he had told people he was in, and wrong for the position he was actually in.** The material of Chapter 38.4's reckoning — the written statement in figures — is the chapter's corrective.

Cost Five: The Discovery, and Its Disproportion

The material. The final cost, and the one the man has been arranging to prevent, which is precisely the reason it is disproportionately severe when it arrives.

The specific forms of the discovery. The bank letter opened by the wife, as in Chapter 38.6's case; the creditor at the door; the facility called; the business's closure known through a third party; the diagnosis discovered; the account's balance seen; the relationship discovered; the community's remark; the relative's enquiry; the employer's notice.

The finding, and it is the chapter's central mechanical statement. The discovery's cost is not the loss. The loss is the position's actual size, which existed before the discovery and which the man would have had to address in either case. **The discovery's additional cost is the loss of the parties' trust in the man's account of himself, and the specific finding from the case material is that the parties' response to the loss is generally competent and their response to the concealment is not.** The wife who says that she was not shocked about the money and was shocked that he had been carrying it alone, in Chapter 38.6's case, is not an unusual respondent; she is the ordinary one.

The specific disproportion. The case material records four findings. **First:** the discovery arrives at the moment of the parties' least preparation, which is the moment at which the man has exhausted the options and can no longer construct an arrangement. **Second:** the discovery removes the man's ability to state the position in his own order, so the parties construct it from fragments and generally construct the worst version. **Third:** the discovery's timing is frequently connected to a third party — the creditor, the bank, the employer, the relative — which produces the specific humiliation of being disclosed by an outsider rather than by the man. **Fourth:** the discovery destroys the man's authority over his own account of himself, which is the material of Chapter 25.6 and the reason the standing is the domain that recovers most slowly.

The comparison the chapter requires the reader to conduct. The disclosure, at the man's own timing, with the statement and the plan: the parties are

informed; the arrangements are constructed with their participation; the man retains the account of himself; the position is addressed at its actual size; and the trust's restoration is a separate matter that requires its own period. The exposure, at the discovery: the parties are informed by circumstance; the arrangements are constructed in the parties' reaction; the man's account is composed of what the fragments suggest; the position is generally larger than it needed to be; and the trust's restoration is required to begin from the position of having been deceived. The chapter's statement: **the two outcomes contain the same facts and the second contains them in the form that costs the most.**

42.3 How the Pretence Is Maintained

The four mechanisms, and the section is placed here because a man's pretence is generally conducted by these four instruments and each can be identified in his own conduct.

Mechanism One: The Script

The material. The pretence requires a consistent account, and the man composes it. The fact stated in the same form to each party; the figure stated consistently; the answer to the recurrent question prepared; the account of the business, the employment, the project, or the marriage rehearsed; the details that are added in order to be convincing and that must then be remembered.

The specific features. The script is generally short, and it contains a small number of load-bearing items: a figure, a date, a client, a project, a plan, a state of affairs. The case material records the finding that the script's load-bearing items are the ones that eventually fail, and that the man's own memory of them degrades: *I had told three people three versions of the same figure and I could not remember which one I had told my wife.*

The identification. The reader should write the recurrent questions and the answers he has prepared: the income, the position, the business, the project, the marriage, the health, the household's arrangements.

Mechanism Two: The Avoidance of the Meeting Points

The material. A pretence survives by keeping its parties apart. The specific forms: the correspondence collected; the call taken outside the room; the two relatives not invited at once; the colleague not brought to the house; the account statement not opened; the appointment not made; the occasion not attended; the question not asked; the domain's specific meeting point avoided — the household budget meeting, the clinic, the professional body's register, the association's meeting, the extended family's gathering.

The particular finding. The avoidance is the mechanism that produces the vigilance cost of Section 42.2, and its specific feature is escalation, because the

number of meeting points increases with the pretence's age. The finding from the case material: the man's own record of the meeting points he has been avoiding is the most useful single instrument of the chapter's exercise, because the list is generally longer than he expects and each item is an arrangement he is conducting.

Mechanism Three: The Borrowing Against the Future

The material. The pretence is financed, and it is financed from the future: the facility, the instalment, the arrangement with a supplier, the family's assistance, the sale of an asset, the deferred maintenance, the unpaid contribution, the borrowing from a friend, the second employment conducted in the hours that were the household's, the contract accepted at a loss, the asset pledged.

The specific feature. The mechanism defers the position's discovery and increases the position's size, which is Cost Two of Section 42.2. Its most consequential form in the case material is the facility secured against the household's principal asset, which converts a financial difficulty into the household's loss of the house, and its second most consequential form is the guarantee: the man's own guarantee given to another party, and the man's request that a relative or a friend guarantee his facility, which is the mechanism that draws parties into the man's position and that Chapter 38.6′s case records in the person of the brother-in-law.

The identification. The reader should record every arrangement entered in the previous twenty-four months that deferred a position, and the party who is exposed by it.

Mechanism Four: The Maintenance of the Appearance

The material. The appearance is the pretence's instrument — the standing, the vehicle, the house, the schooling, the occasions, the contributions, the clothing, the office, the gifts, the hospitality — and it is maintained because it is the account from which the man's income, credit, and standing are derived.

The specific feature. The mechanism has an economic logic that the case material records as the pretence's most effective justification: the appearance produces the credit and the business, and the credit and the business produce the income, and the man therefore presents the argument — which is frequently true — that the appearance is his instrument rather than his vanity. The finding the chapter supplies in response: **the appearance is a legitimate instrument up to the point at which its maintenance requires the concealment of the position.** Chapter 25.6′s three prohibitions apply, and the specific case material finding is that businesses and practices conducted from a reasonably presented and accurately understood position outperform those conducted from an appearance whose maintenance consumes the position.

The identification. The reader should record: the items of appearance, their annual cost, and the specific items whose maintenance requires a fact to be concealed.

The Four Mechanisms in the Man's Own Record

The mechanism	My material	What it costs per month, in time or money	The item that would end it
The script			
The meeting points avoided			
The borrowings against the future			
The maintained appearance			

42.4 The Seven Signs That It Is Failing

A pretence fails before it is discovered. The following signs are the ones the case material records, and the reader should note that the signs are the man's own and that he has generally been treating them as ordinary difficulties.

Sign One: The Man Cannot State His Position in Figures

The sign that is present in every case in the material and that the man reports as the moment at which he knew. The specific form: the man is asked an ordinary question — what the household's monthly requirement is, what he owes, what the income is, what the school fees come to, what he has in the account — and he cannot answer without constructing it.

The instruction. This sign alone should conduct Section 42.6′s first step, and it is the reason Chapter 38′s statement is the chapter's first instrument.

Sign Two: The Explaining Has Become Routine

The man finds himself explaining, in the ordinary course of the week, matters that require no explanation: the late arrival, the call, the visitor, the absence, the appointment, the amount, the delay, the arrangement. The finding: the explaining is the script's maintenance, and its routine presence is the sign.

Sign Three: The Man Is Avoiding a Named Party

The specific party whose questions he will not face: the wife's account, the colleague, the relative, the accountant, the professional, the creditor, the man who would ask the right question. The finding: the party's name is generally known to the man and he has been arranging the avoidance for a period measured in years.

Sign Four: The Arrangements Are Conducted in the Gaps

The letters opened in the vehicle; the calls taken outside; the account's statement kept elsewhere; the appointment conducted in the working day; the arrangements conducted at hours when the household is not present; the specific arrangement of the man's day around the pretence's requirements. The finding: the man's timetable contains the pretence, and the reader should draw it.

Sign Five: The Man Has Withdrawn from the Occasions

The family's gathering, the association's meeting, the community's occasion, the school event, the marriage's social arrangements, the friend's visit. The withdrawal is conducted on the ground of work, of fatigue, of the position's demands, and its actual mechanism is the avoidance of the setting in which the pretence may be punctured.

Sign Six: The Sleep, the Drinking, or the Temper Has Altered

The material of Chapters 22, 23, and 34. The finding from the case material: a pretence's cost is borne by the sleep first, then by the drinking or the eating, and then by the man's temper in the household, and the sequence is generally reported in that order.

Sign Seven: The Man Has Begun to Think About the Discovery

The sign that the position is failing rather than merely inconvenient: the man's own arrangements of the discovery — what he would say, whom he would tell first, what he would do, where he would go. The finding: the man's rehearsals of the discovery are frequent, and their presence in his thinking is the clearest available sign of the position's state. The case material records the specific form: the man who has conducted the discovery in his thinking for a year and who has not conducted it in fact.

> **KEY POINT**
> A pretence is maintained by four mechanisms: the script, the avoidance of the meeting points at which the parties would compare accounts, the borrowing against the future, and the maintenance of the appearance from which the man's income and standing are derived. It fails before it is discovered, and the seven signs are that the man cannot state his position in figures; his explaining has become routine; he is avoiding a named party; his arrangements are conducted in the gaps of the day; he has withdrawn from the occasions; his sleep, drinking, or temper has altered; and he has begun to rehearse the discovery in his own thinking.

42.5 The Six Supports

The chapter turns to its constructive material. A life that does not depend on pretending is not a life of full disclosure to everybody, and the section establishes what it is: **six supports, each of which removes a specific pretence's necessity.**

Support One: A Position Stated in Figures, to the Man Himself

The material. The written statement of Chapter 38.4, in its six sections, held current. The income, the obligations, the assets, the household's requirements, the capacities, and the standing's obligations, recorded as figures.

The mechanism. The support removes the necessity of the script, because a man who knows his position in figures is not required to compose his answers to the questions about it. The case material's finding: the man's ability to state his position in figures is the chapter's single most useful instrument, and its absence is the sign of Section 42.4′s first item.

The frequency. The statement is conducted monthly, and it takes under an hour once its form is established.

Support Two: One Person Who Knows the Whole

The material. The disclosure function of Chapter 27.4, in the form the case material establishes as the minimum: one person who has the entire account of the man's position, including the material that is concealed from every other party, and including the material he is ashamed of.

The mechanism. The support removes the necessity of the isolation and the possibility of an unbroken concealment, because a man who has stated the whole of his position to one party cannot be conducting a full pretence. The finding: the party should be selected for the capacity to hold the material rather than for convenience, and the material of Chapter 27.4′s five sources and Chapter 35.4′s four parts applies.

The specification. The person's name should be written, the arrangement's frequency stated, and the material's subject matter stated: the position, the money, the work, the health, the marriage, and the decisions the man is inclined to take too quickly. The material of Chapter 38.2′s fourth task applies in full.

Support Three: The Household's Arrangements Stated to the Household

The material. The four arrangements of Chapter 38.6 and Chapter 40.6′s Matter One: the disclosure, the household's own arrangements, the household's role, and the household's own people and rest.

The mechanism. The support removes the money, work, household, and marriage domains' pretences at the household level, which is the level at which the case material records the greatest cost. The specific finding: the household that knows the position is a household that participates in its management, and its

members' arrangements are constructed on the actual position, which is the only form in which the arrangements can hold.

The specification. The monthly statement of the position, in figures, at a stated occasion; the household's requirements stated and its reductions conducted as arrangements rather than as impositions; and the household's account of what the position requires of each member sought rather than supplied.

Support Four: The Reserve

The material. The material of Chapter 23.4′s financial arrangements and Appendix D: the reserve that stands between the man's position and the collapse. The case material's specification: an amount equal to the household's fixed requirements for a stated period, held in a form that the man can access within days.

The mechanism. The support removes the trigger of the escalation, which is the specific mechanism of Section 42.2′s second cost. The finding is mechanical and it is the chapter's most concrete: **the man with a reserve does not take the facility, and the man without one does.** The case material records the finding in the men's own accounts: the borrowing that began the collapse was taken because the wages, the fees, or the instalment fell due in a week in which no reserve existed.

The specification. The reserve's amount stated as a figure; the period it covers stated; the form it is held in stated; and the rule for its use stated: the reserve is used for the fixed requirements and is not available for the occasions, the appearance, the instalments, or the contributions.

Support Five: The Man's Own Capacity and Its Documentation

The material. The material of Chapters 23.4, 24.5, and 40.5′s capacities: the qualification, the competence, the registration, the practice, the trade, the record, the network, and the second source of income. And its documentation, which is the support's mechanical requirement: the certificate, the registration, the written record of the man's work, the references, the portfolio, the account of what he has done.

The mechanism. The support removes the work domain's pretence by removing its necessity. The man whose position is a single employment, a single client, a single contract, or a single competence that is represented rather than held is in the position in which a change in the position requires a concealment. The man with a documented second capacity has an alternative that can be stated, which is the finding: **the ability to state a true alternative removes the need to conceal a false position.**

The specification. The second capacity named; the documentation's state recorded; the frequency with which it is maintained stated; and the income it could produce at the man's actual position estimated in figures.

Support Six: The Standing That Does Not Require Performance

The material. The material of Chapters 25.6 and 41.2′s fifth clause: the standing that is produced by the man's actual conduct rather than by his presentation, and the reduction of the domain that is conducted for the audience.

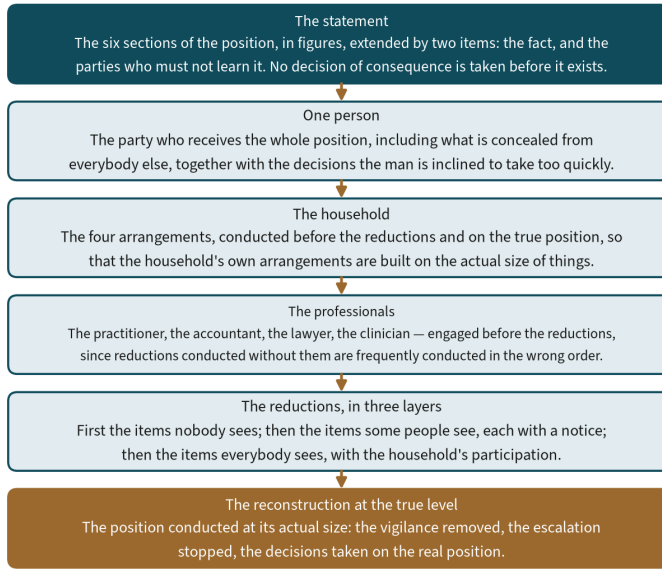
The mechanism. The support removes the standing and appearance domains' pretences, which are the ones whose maintenance consumes the man's income. The finding from the case material: the standing produced by the man's actual competence, reliability, and conduct survives the disclosure of his position, and the standing produced by his presentation does not. The specific finding: the men who conducted a controlled disclosure generally retained their professional standing, and the men who were exposed lost it, and the difference is the mechanism's demonstration.

The specification. The domains in which the man's standing is actual, recorded with evidence; the domains in which it is presented, recorded with their annual cost; the reductions, with the form of Chapter 33.6′s three releases; and the man's own measure, from Chapter 41.5′s fourth part, stated with items the audience cannot see.

The Supports in Combination

The finding the section closes with, and it is the one the case material supports most strongly: **the six supports are cumulative and their order is not arbitrary.**

The position in figures is conducted first, because it is the instrument of the other five. The person who knows the whole is conducted second, because the man's conduct of the statement requires the arrangement in which it is held. The household's arrangements are conducted third, since the household's participation is what the remaining supports require. The reserve is conducted fourth, because it is what prevents the escalation while the position is being addressed. The documented capacity is conducted fifth, since it is the ground on which the man's alternatives are constructed. The standing is conducted last, because the man's authority to reduce the standing's domain is generally produced by the other five.



Each step produces the condition the next requires. The position conducted at its true level is generally more productive than the false one.

Figure 42.1 The six steps of the dismantling, in the order the practice material supports.

42.6 The Dismantling

The chapter's practical section. A pretence is not removed by a decision; it is dismantled in a sequence, and the sequence is the one the practice material supports. The section supplies the five steps, their order, and the errors that interrupt them.

The Order and Its Reason

The order is: **the statement; the one person; the household; the professionals; the reductions; the reconstruction at the true level.**

The order's reason is mechanical, and it is the same reason as Chapter 38.5′s: each step produces the condition the next requires. The statement produces the man's own knowledge of his position, without which he cannot state it to anybody. The one person produces the arrangement in which the statement can be delivered and revised. The household's disclosure produces the parties whose participation the reductions require. The professionals produce the arrangements with the creditors, the employers, the lawyers, the accountants, and the clinicians. The reductions produce the position at its true level. The reconstruction produces the life that does not require the pretence.

The errors that interrupt the sequence are the seven of Chapter 38.3, and the three most frequently recorded in this material are the attempt to conduct the household's disclosure before the statement exists, the attempt to conduct the

reductions before the professionals have been engaged, and the attempt to reconstruct the position at a new level through a further appearance.

Step One: The Statement

The conduct. Chapter 38.4′s six sections, in figures, completed in writing. The reader should note the specific instruction from Chapter 38.2: no decision of consequence is taken before the statement exists, and the statement takes days rather than weeks.

The specific additions for this chapter. The statement's sections are extended by the two columns of Section 42.1: the fact, and the parties who must not learn it. And by the four mechanisms of Section 42.3, with their monthly cost recorded. The extension's purpose is that the statement should record not only the position but the position's concealment, which is the item the reader is dismantling.

Step Two: The One Person

The conduct. The selection of the party and the delivery of the statement to them, in the four-part form of Chapter 34.6′s disclosure: the position; the man's own part in it; what has been concealed and from whom; and what he intends to conduct.

The specific finding. The case material records the finding that this step is the one at which the man's position alters, and that the alteration is frequently visible to him rather than to the party: *I said it out loud to one man and I slept for seven hours, and I had not slept for seven hours in a year.*

The instruction. The party is selected for the capacity rather than the convenience; the statement is read rather than recited; and the man's request of the party is stated specifically: the holding of the material, the asking of the question at a stated interval, and the naming of the decisions the man is inclined to take too quickly.

Step Three: The Household

The conduct. The four arrangements of Chapter 38.6, in the order supplied there, with the statement in hand.

The specific finding for this chapter. The household's disclosure is the step the case material records as the one the man most fears and the one that most frequently produces the position's recovery. The specific finding: the household's response is generally to the arrangement rather than to the fact, and the fact that the household most frequently identifies as the difficulty is not the size of the position but its concealment's duration.

The instruction. The disclosure is conducted before the reductions, so that the household's arrangements are constructed on the true position rather than on the reductions' consequences.

Step Four: The Professionals

The conduct. The engagement of the routes required by the statement: the insolvency or debt practitioner, the accountant, the lawyer for the guarantees, the contract, the property, and the family arrangements, the clinician for the concealed health matter, the marriage or relationship route where the marriage's domain is concerned, and the employment or career advice.

The specific finding. The professionals' engagement is the step at which the position's size generally reduces, and the mechanism is the one supplied in Chapter 38.8: the position becomes a matter of figures held by a party who is not ashamed of it, and the arrangements available to a professional are generally not available to the man conducting the same negotiations privately.

The instruction. The professional is engaged before the reductions, and the reason is the one the case material records: the reductions conducted without the professionals are frequently conducted in the wrong order — the appearance, the occasion, and the contributions maintained while the Category A obligations are unpaid — which is the triage error of Chapter 38.3 and Chapter 38.4's third section.

Step Five: The Reductions, in Three Layers

The conduct. The reductions are conducted in layers, from the least visible to the most, and the reason is the one the case material records: the man's available authority for the reductions is produced by the earlier layers' effectiveness.

The first layer: the items nobody sees. The subscriptions, the memberships, the arrangements conducted from inertia, the second vehicle, the additional engagement's hours, the hospitality, the unnecessary travel, the consumption of Chapter 40.5's Category Four. The finding: this layer generally produces a reduction of between five and fifteen per cent of the household's requirements, and it is conducted without any disclosure to any party outside the household.

The second layer: the items some people see. The occasions' scale, the contributions' level, the community's arrangement, the association's office, the extended family's arrangement, the school's arrangements, the vehicle's replacement. Each is conducted with a disclosure to the specific party concerned, and Chapter 40.6's Matter Two supplies the form: the notice, the arrangement, the party's capacity, and the resistance endured rather than argued with.

The third layer: the items everybody sees. The house, the address, the employment, the business's form, the school, the marriage's public arrangements, the position. Each is conducted with the household's participation and with the professional route, and each is conducted last, because the man's authority to conduct it and the family's capacity to absorb it are produced by the earlier layers.

Step Six: The Reconstruction at the True Level

The conduct. The material of Chapter 38.5′s stages and Chapter 40′s audit, conducted at the position's actual level rather than at the represented level.

The specific finding, and the section closes with it. The case material records the finding consistently: **the position conducted at its true level is generally more productive than the position conducted behind the pretence.** The mechanism's components are four. **The first:** the vigilance's cost is removed, and its material — the attention, the sleep, the hours, the decisions — returns to the man's actual work. **The second:** the escalation's cost is removed, and the interest, the instalments, and the arrangements' margins stop consuming the income. **The third:** the decisions are taken on the actual position, and the case material records the improvement in their quality as the finding that the men reported as the most unexpected: *I began to make decisions that worked, because I had stopped making them for a position I was pretending to be in.* **The fourth:** the man's relationships are restored to their actual parties, and the disclosure function of Chapter 27 is available, with the consequences of Chapters 31 and 35.

42.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Was Doing Well

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Composite case. Constructed for teaching purposes from patterns reported in insolvency practice, family practice, and counselling of men.

Emeka is thirty-nine, a builder and contractor, married to Grace for fourteen years, with two children aged eleven and seven.

Emeka's position in the case is the chapter's central example, because his standing in the community, in the church's building committee, in the association, and among the extended family was produced by his conduct of business, and his business was conducted on an appearance that his position could not fund.

The record at the beginning of the case. Emeka's company had a reasonable turnover. His household's position was maintained at the level of a successful contractor: a house on a modest mortgage, two vehicles, the children at a private school, the extended family's contributions, the occasion's hospitality, a quantity of machinery acquired on instalments, and a reputation that Emeka described as *the kind of name that gets the job without a long conversation*.

The position beneath it, recorded by Emeka in the first sitting. One principal client accounted for about sixty per cent of the turnover; the client's payments were running ninety days late and had been running later for two years; the company's facilities were at their limit and one was secured against the house; a second facility had been taken eleven months before the case and had been used to pay the wages of the previous quarter; the machinery's instalments were in arrears of two periods; the children's school fees for the current term had been paid from a friend's loan; and the extended family's contributions for the last year had been met from the

second facility. His own statement of the position: *I am about two hundred and forty thousand in arrears, and about a hundred and ten of it is concealed from my wife, and if the client pays in the next four weeks, none of it exists.*

The six domains, recorded in the case. The money: the concealed facilities, the school fees, the extended family's contributions, and the machinery's arrears. The work: the client's position was concealed from the household and the company's position was represented to the association; the second facility had been taken without a written agreement, on a verbal understanding with a lender Emeka described as *a man I have known for twelve years*. The marriage: conducted at the level of the appearance, with Grace's own business's income — she had a small catering business — being used, in fact, to conduct the household's monthly expenditure, a fact Emeka had never stated. The household: the school's arrangements represented as affordable and the house's position unstated. The health: the sleep, the drinking of between three and six units of beer nightly, and a blood-pressure reading of 158 over 104 recorded at a pharmacy in an odd moment and not acted on. The standing: the building committee's contributions, the association's dues, the extended family's occasions, the household's hospitality, and the vehicle.

The signs, applied to Emeka's account. All seven were present. He could not state his position in figures without constructing it; the explaining had become routine; he was avoiding his wife's brother, who had lent him the school fees and had asked him twice about the repayment; his arrangements were conducted in the gaps of the day; he had withdrawn from the association's meetings and two occasions; his sleep had reduced and his temper had altered; and he had rehearsed the discovery for about a year. His account of the last item: *I used to lie in the bed and decide what I would say to her if the bank called, and I had one version in which I had already told her that morning, and it was the only way I could sleep.*

The material that produced the change was, in the case, three items in ten days. The client's finance department informed the company that the certification for the previous quarter would be delayed a further period of two months and that the matter was with a new officer. The lender who held the verbal facility telephoned on the same day about the interest. And Grace's discovery, on the following Sunday, was not of the money: she had taken the vehicle to the market and the school had telephoned Emeka's number twice, and she had answered the second call from the passenger seat and had learned from the school's assistant that the fees were outstanding, and she then asked Emeka a direct question about the household's accounts, and he told her a partial version, and she said the sentence he recorded in the case: *Emeka, I have been carrying this house for four years. I know exactly what is happening. I do not know why you think I do not.*

The work, conducted over about twenty months, followed the order of Section 42.6.

The statement. Conducted over four days, and its effect in Emeka's account: *I put everything on two sheets in figures. I had known most of it. What I had not known was the total, which was two hundred and forty-one thousand and some. I wrote the two sentences the book says to write, and the second one, about my own part, took me about*

an hour. What I wrote was that I had borrowed eleven times in two years and had never once written down the total, and that I had done it because I was afraid of being seen to be a man whose business was failing, and that I had been right about the fear and wrong about the price.

The one person. A quantity surveyor eleven years older than Emeka, who had contracted in the same city for twenty-six years, whom Emeka had known for eight and had never disclosed anything to. The material: the two sheets, read out, in the surveyor's office, on a Wednesday evening. The surveyor's response, recorded in the case: *He read the two sheets and then he was quiet for about a minute and he said, you have described my own 2009. He told me for about forty minutes what had happened to him: the client who did not pay, the building society, the house he lost, the year in which he drove a taxi, and the two people who helped him. He said, I am going to tell you three things and you will not like the first. The first is that your client is not going to pay you for six months and possibly not at all, and you already know that and you have known it since November. The second is that your wife is stronger than you are and you have been insulting her for four years. The third is that you are going to have to reduce your life and that when you have done it you will be a better builder and you will not miss one thing that you are going to lose.*

The household. The disclosure to Grace was conducted in the following week over two sittings with the two sheets and the surveyor's notes. Grace's account, recorded separately: *I knew the shape of it. I did not know the amount or the second facility. What I want to record is what I said to him, which I had been holding for a long time: that we had been conducting this house on my business's money for four years while he was calling himself the provider, and that I had let him do it because I could see what it cost him, and that this was my part in it. And when I said that, he sat down on the floor of the parlour, which I have never seen him do in fourteen years.*

The professionals. A debt and insolvency adviser was engaged in the third week, on the surveyor's recommendation. The adviser conducted the arrangements with the two facilities, negotiated the machinery's instalment schedule, and advised on the house. A lawyer reviewed the guarantee and the verbal facility. The client's position was pursued through a formal demand and, in the ninth month, through the association's arbitration route, and it settled at about seventy per cent of the certified work with payment over eight months. And Emeka attended his doctor in the fourth week, was commenced on treatment for hypertension, and was referred for counselling on the alcohol use, which he described as follows: *The doctor asked me how much I was drinking and I told him the truth for the first time in my life and I said, about a bottle a night, and he wrote it down and said, right, and I sat there and nothing happened. I have been carrying that for eleven years and nothing happened.*

The reductions, in layers. The first layer, conducted in the first month, contained the association's dues, two subscriptions, the second vehicle, the hospitality, and the machinery that was not in use, which was sold. The finding: the layer produced about eleven per cent of the household's requirement and no disclosure outside the household. The second layer, conducted over the following four months, contained

the school fees, which were renegotiated to a termly arrangement with the school's bursar and which were conducted at the same school after a conversation Emeka described as *the hardest fifteen minutes of the year*; the extended family's contributions, which were reduced with a stated arrangement and a three-month notice; and the building committee's position, which Emeka resigned. The third layer, conducted in the sixth month after the reductions' other layers and with the adviser's arrangement, contained the house, which was sold and the position moved to a smaller rented accommodation for a period of two years; the main vehicle, which was sold and replaced with one of about a third of the value; and the arrangement with the lender, which was settled at a figure over eleven months.

The reconstruction. Conducted over about two years and described by Emeka at the review in three items. **The first:** the work. The company's turnover reduced by about forty per cent and its position became profitable in the second year, and its composition altered: the principal client's share reduced from sixty to about twenty-five per cent and eight smaller clients were added. Emeka's account: *I had been chasing one big job for nine years. When it went, I had to go and find eight small ones, and I now know that the eight were the business and the one was the risk. I did not know that in 2019 and no one could have told me. I had to lose it to learn it.* **The second:** the household. The position at the true level, conducted with Grace's business as a stated and joint arrangement rather than as a concealed support, and the arrangement recorded: *We have one account for the house and one for the work and we do the figures on the last Sunday of the month, and it takes about twenty-five minutes, and in the first month of it I could not do it and I sat there with my hands shaking and Grace did the adding. In the eleventh month I did the adding and she was watching me and she said, you are enjoying this. It is twenty-five minutes and it is the thing I look forward to in the month.* **The third:** the health. The blood pressure controlled, the alcohol stopped for the first eight months and thereafter occasional, and the sleep restored. His account: *I have not had a drink at home in about a year and a half and I did not make a decision about it. The doctor told me in the fourth month that the pressure was down and I noticed that I had stopped needing it, and I think the reason is that there was nothing left to carry at the end of the day.*

The finding the case records as its own conclusion. Emeka, at the review: *Two years ago I was a man who had a name and no money and one big client and a wife who was carrying my house while I was being the provider. Today I am a man who has two vehicles fewer, one house fewer, one client fewer, one title fewer, and one flask of my own blood pressure tablets on the table and one wife who knows every figure in my business, and I do the accounts with her on the last Sunday of the month. I would not go back. And I want to record one more thing: my son, who is eleven, watched me sell the vehicle and he asked me why, and I told him the truth in four sentences, and I have been told by a man who knows the family that he is now telling his friends at school that his father is a builder who does not lie about money. I did not teach him that. I lost it in front of him and he learned it.*

Five features of this case deserve isolation.

The position was successful according to every external measure. Emeka had a name, work, a house, vehicles, the children in school, and standing in his community and his association, and the case is included because the chapter's material is not addressed to men in visible difficulty. The specific finding: his position's collapse was not produced by a failure of competence but by the mechanism of Section 42.2′s second cost, and his competence was in fact the reason the pretence was sustained for so long.

The pretence was financed by the wife's concealed labour. Grace had been conducting the household's monthly expenditure from her business's income for four years, and Emeka had never stated it. This is the fourth domain of Section 42.1 in its most frequent form, and the case is included because the finding is reported across the case material of this book: the man's account of himself as the provider is frequently maintained by a party who is not told that she is the provider.

The seven signs were all present and each was treatable as an ordinary difficulty. The sleep, the temper, the withdrawal, the explaining, and the rehearsed discovery. The case is included because it records the reader's own likely position: the signs of Section 42.4 are present in the man's material for a period measured in years, and they are accounted for as the ordinary conditions of a man's life.

The disclosure to the one person and the household altered the position before an arrangement was constructed. The surveyor's three statements, including the statement about Grace, and Grace's account of her own part. The case is included because the finding is the chapter's central claim about the mechanism: the position's facts were unchanged at the disclosure and the man's conduct of them was altered immediately, and the case material records the same finding in every domain of this book.

The position at the true level was smaller and better. Fewer clients, fewer vehicles, one house fewer, one title fewer, and a business that was profitable rather than a business whose appearance consumed it. The case's conclusion, in the man's own voice, is the chapter's closing statement, and its final item — the son who learned from the loss — is the material of Chapter 43 in its preliminary form.

42.8 Practical Exercise: The Two Columns and the Six Supports

The exercise is conducted over four sittings and produces a statement, a schedule, and a plan.

Sitting One: The Two Columns

Complete the two-column record of Section 42.1 for all six domains.

The domain	The fact	The parties who must not learn it	What I do to prevent their learning it	What it costs me per month, in money and in hours
The money				
The work				
The marriage				
The household				
The health				
The standing				

Then total the fourth column. The figure and the hours are the price of the arrangement, and they are the chapter's first instrument with the reader.

Sitting Two: The Mechanisms and the Signs

Section A: The four mechanisms.

The mechanism	My material	Its monthly cost	The item that would end it
The script			
The meeting points avoided			
The borrowings against the future			
The maintained appearance			

Section B: The seven signs. Mark each sign present or absent, with the evidence and the date at which it began.

The sign	Present?	The evidence	Since when
I cannot state my position in figures			
The explaining has become routine			
I am avoiding a named party — who?			
My arrangements are conducted in the gaps of the day			
I have withdrawn from the occasions			
My sleep, drinking, or temper has altered			
I have rehearsed the discovery			

Section C: The statement. Conduct Chapter 38.4's six sections, in figures, extended by the two columns above. Write the two required sentences.

Sitting Three: The Six Supports

For each support, record its current state, the specific gap, and the first act with its date.

The support	Its current state	The gap	The first act and its date
A position stated in figures, monthly			
One person who knows the whole			
The household's arrangements stated to the household			
The reserve			
The documented capacity			
The standing that does not require performance			

For the household support: write the disclosure in the four-part form, and record the occasion.

For the reserve: record the household's fixed monthly requirement, the months of cover held, the target, and the rule for the reserve's use.

Sitting Four: The Dismantling Plan

The step	What it consists of in my position	The date	The party or the professional concerned
One: the statement			
Two: the one person			
Three: the household			
Four: the professionals			
Five: the reductions — layer one			
Five: the reductions — layer two			
Five: the reductions — layer three			
Six: the reconstruction at the true level			

The layer lists. Record every item in the three layers, with its cost and the party concerned.

The two prohibitions of Section 42.6′s fourth step and Chapter 38.3′s errors, written in the reader's own words: no new obligations during the dismantling, and no decision of consequence before the statement exists.

The review. Fix it at one month, three months, and a year, and record the two questions: which steps have been conducted, and what remains concealed from whom.

42.9 Common Questions Men Ask

"I am not lying. I simply have not told anybody. Is that not different?"

The chapter's test resolves the question and not the man's description of it. The test: is the position's continuation dependent on specified parties not learning specified facts, and would the man's arrangements require alteration if they learned them? Where the answer is yes, the position is the one Section 42.1 describes, whatever the man calls it, and the costs of Section 42.2 are being paid. Where the man's position would not require alteration, the material is privacy and the chapter does not apply to it. The case material records the finding that the men who described their position as *simply not having told anybody* answered the test's two questions in the affirmative.

"If I tell my wife, she will leave."

The prediction is recorded in the case material frequently and the outcome is recorded less frequently as the man feared it. The findings: the party's response is generally to the arrangement rather than to the fact; the party's response to the concealment is frequently the more severe of the two; and the party's own position is frequently more capable than the man had assumed, which is the material of Chapter 42.7′s case in Grace's account. The reader who holds this question should put it to the professional route and to the one person of Section 42.5′s second support before acting on his own prediction, which is the material of Chapter 30.4′s rule.

"I cannot reduce the school fees. The children's education is not negotiable."

The instruction is not that every item of the third layer is released. The instruction is that the reductions are conducted in layers, from the least visible to the most, and that the third layer's items are conducted last, with the household's participation and the professional route, after the first two layers have produced what they can. The case material records the school's arrangements being renegotiated rather than abandoned in a substantial proportion of cases, as in Chapter 42.7, and records the finding that the concealment of the fees was a greater difficulty for the household than the fee's level.

"My business runs on credit and reputation. If I disclose my position, I lose the work."

The concern is legitimate and it is the one the chapter addresses in Section 42.3′s fourth mechanism. The distinction the chapter supplies: the position's accurate statement to the professional, the household, and the one person is not the position's publication to the market. The case material records the finding that the men who conducted the disclosure with the arrangement and the advisers generally retained their professional standing and their credit, because the disclosure was conducted with a plan, and that the men who were exposed lost both. The reader's instruction: the disclosure's parties are selected, and the selection is a professional question.

"What if I have already been exposed? The position is known."

Then the chapter's later steps apply without the earlier ones, and the material of Chapter 38.5′s stages is the sequence: the stabilisation, the income, the settlement, the standing, the relationships, and the new construction. The specific finding for this position, from the case material: the man whose exposure has occurred has lost the account of himself and has not lost the position's facts, which are the same facts that would have been addressed in a disclosure; his work is therefore the restoration of his account, which is conducted by the accurate statement, the repairs of Chapter 29, and the conduct over a period of years, and which the material of Chapter 38.5′s fourth stage describes.

"I have been doing this for twenty years. Is the position still recoverable?"

The material of Chapter 38.5′s indicative durations applies, and its finding for a long-maintained pretence is the one the case material records: the reductions available to a man whose position has been conducted on an appearance for twenty years are generally larger than he expects, because the appearance's cost is cumulative; the arrangements with the creditors are available at any stage; and the household's participation is generally available, as Chapter 42.7′s case records, since the household has been participating in the position already and without being told.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Chapter 42 in brief. Privacy is not a pretence and the ordinary management of a man's presentation is not a pretence. A pretence, in this chapter's sense, is a state of affairs in which the man's position can continue only for as long as specified parties do not learn specified facts; the test is whether he is arranging his conduct so that a particular party does not learn a particular fact, and whether his arrangements would require alteration if that party learned it. The six domains are the money, the work and the competence, the marriage, the household, the health, and the standing.

The costs are five: the vigilance, which is paid before anything is discovered and which increases with the pretence's age; the escalation, in which the pretence's covering produces further borrowing and increases the position's size while delaying its discovery; the reduction of the man's relationships to the parties before whom the pretence can be maintained, which removes the disclosure function; the reduction of his judgement, since his decisions are correct for the position he has described and wrong for the position he is in; and the discovery, whose additional cost beyond the loss is the loss of the parties' trust in the man's account of himself. The comparison the chapter requires: the disclosure and the exposure contain the same facts, and the exposure contains them in the form that costs the most.

The four mechanisms are the script, the avoidance of the meeting points, the borrowing against the future, and the maintenance of the appearance. The seven signs that the position is failing are that the man cannot state his position in figures; his explaining has become routine; he is avoiding a named party; his arrangements are conducted in the gaps of the day; he has withdrawn from the occasions; his sleep, drinking, or temper has altered; and he has begun to rehearse the discovery.

The six supports of a life that does not depend on pretending are: a position stated in figures, monthly, to the man himself; one person who knows the whole; the household's arrangements stated to the household; the reserve; the documented capacity; and the standing that does not require performance. They are cumulative and their order is not arbitrary. The dismantling proceeds in six steps and its order is mechanical: the statement; the one person; the household; the professionals; the reductions in three layers, from the items nobody sees to the items everybody sees; and the reconstruction at the true level. The position conducted at its true level is generally more productive than the position conducted behind the pretence, because the vigilance's cost is removed, the escalation stops, the decisions are taken on the actual position, and the man's relationships return to their actual parties.

Reflection Questions

1. Complete the two columns for all six domains. What is the total cost in the fourth column, and how much of it had you counted before this exercise?
2. Which of the seven signs is present in your own record, and since when?
3. What is the largest figure you have never stated to the person closest to you?
4. Which party are you avoiding, and what is the question you expect them to ask?
5. Which of the six supports is absent from your position, and what would its establishment require in the next month?
6. Consider the last decision of consequence you took. Was it correct for the position you were in, or for the position you had described?
7. Which layer of reductions will you conduct within the next three months, and which professional will you engage before you conduct them?

Further Reading

- **On deception and its costs:** the research literature on deception, concealment, and self-presentation, including the findings on the cognitive and attentional costs of maintaining concealment, on the effects of concealment on relationships and health, and on the evidence concerning disclosure and its outcomes.
- **On financial stress and household debt:** the research and practice literature on household debt and financial stress, including the findings on the effects of unmanageable debt on health and relationships, on patterns of concealment within households, and on the outcomes of early engagement with debt advice.
- **On disclosure and its timing:** the literature on self-disclosure and on the disclosure of adverse information, including the findings on the effects of voluntary as against involuntary disclosure, on the role of the recipient's response, and on the conditions under which disclosure improves outcomes.
- **On business and reputation:** the practice literature on business failure, credit, and reputation, including the findings on the relationship between accurate representation and long-term commercial performance, and on the outcomes of reputation-management strategies conducted through misrepresentation.
- **Practical resources:** insolvency and debt practitioners; accountants; legal advice on guarantees, credit, and family property; financial counselling; clinical advice on alcohol use, sleep, and hypertension; and the material in Appendices D, M, and P.

43 CHAPTER

Teaching the Next Generation of Men to Speak

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the four channels through which boys acquire their conduct in the presence of emotion, and identify each channel in his own history and in his household.
2. Explain what is actually transmitted when a boy learns silence, distinguishing the expression that is withheld from the lesson that is taught by the withholding.
3. Analyse the specific contribution of parents, teachers, coaches, artisans, and mentors, and the reason the influence of a single adult is frequently decisive.
4. Identify the harmful propositions contained in common statements about manhood, and challenge them without lecturing, shaming, or abandoning the standard the boy requires.
5. Teach the six competences of emotional coping to a boy of a stated age, using the four-stage method of demonstration, rehearsal, feedback, and application.
6. Design the conditions under which a boy will ask for help: the permission, the named person, the routine, the confidentiality, and the follow-through.
7. Conduct an emotional curriculum within a household, a school, a workshop, an association, or a community, and state its measures.

Introduction

Every chapter of this book has described a man conducting a position largely alone. This chapter turns to the point at which that position was formed. It is placed at the end of the book's argument for a reason that is not sentimental. The patterns described in Parts I to XI are not produced afresh in each generation. They are transmitted, and the transmission has a mechanism, a curriculum, a set of instructors, and an examination that is conducted continuously and without notice.

The chapter's subject is therefore not children in the ordinary sense. It is the reproduction of a man's silence, and the possibility of interrupting that reproduction at the point where it is cheapest to interrupt: in the years before the pattern has become a man's character, his marriage, his health, and his household's arrangements.

The chapter begins from a finding that the case material of this book records with unusual consistency. Men who describe themselves as unable to speak about what they carry do not generally report having decided, at some point, to become silent. They report having learned it. The learning was not conducted in a single conversation. It was conducted in thousands of small transactions, most of which nobody in the household remembers: the boy's report of an injury and the adult's instruction to stop crying; the boy's account of a humiliation at school and the adult's advice to hit back; the boy's question about his father's absence and the adult's answer that the father is working; the boy's tears at a funeral and the instruction to be a man; the boy's fear before an examination and the assurance that fear is for women; the boy's disclosure of a failure and the silence that followed it.

None of these transactions was intended to produce a man who cannot speak. Most of them were intended to produce a man who can endure. The distinction between the intention and the effect is the chapter's central concern, because it explains why the pattern survives the good will of the people who transmit it. **The men and women who teach a boy to be silent are, in the great majority of cases, trying to protect him.** They are preparing him for a world they believe to be hard, and they are using the preparation they received. The preparation works in the sense that it produces endurance. It fails in the sense that it also produces the specific incapacity this book has described: the inability to state a position, to name a state, to ask for an instrument, or to accept a party's participation before the position has collapsed.

The chapter's approach has five commitments, and the reader should hold them because each one corrects a common error in the material.

The first is that the chapter is not an indictment of parents. The material of the book's earlier chapters establishes the position of the fathers and mothers who transmitted the pattern: they were conducting households under economic pressure, often with their own unaddressed losses, frequently without a model of any other method, and generally with the sincere belief that the preparation they were giving was the kindest thing available. The chapter's interest is in the mechanism, not in the allocation of blame. A reader who finishes this chapter resentful of his father has misunderstood it, and has also lost the opportunity the chapter supplies, because the pattern is interrupted by the man who can describe what happened to him without either excusing it or being destroyed by it.

The second is that the chapter is not a programme for making boys emotional in the sense that word is used dismissively. Nothing in the chapter proposes that a boy should be encouraged to express every state at every moment, to abandon standards, to treat his own discomfort as the central fact of every room, or to conduct his interior life as a public performance. The material of Chapter 39.4′s four competences is the standard: the boy is taught to know what he feels, to regulate it, to state it to a party who has a right to know, and to conduct himself appropriately in the setting. This is a discipline, and it is a harder discipline than silence, which is why boys frequently prefer silence when it is available.

The third is that the teaching is conducted by conduct rather than by instruction. The research literature on the acquisition of emotional conduct is consistent on this point, and the case material of this book confirms it: a boy learns what is done with a feeling by observing what the adults around him do with theirs, and he learns it more reliably than he learns anything they say. A father who instructs his son to speak about his difficulties while conducting his own position in complete concealment is teaching the son the second lesson and not the first. The chapter therefore treats the adult's own practice as the curriculum's first component, and it treats the adult's repair after failure as the second.

The fourth is that the teaching has an age structure, and the structure is not optional. A method that is appropriate for a boy of seven is inappropriate for a young man of seventeen, and the reverse. The chapter supplies the age structure in Section 43.4, and it supplies it as a working guide rather than as a set of rules, because the reader's boy is a particular boy and the material of the book's earlier chapters establishes how much variation exists in the timing of a young man's development.

The fifth is that the chapter's unit is not the individual boy but the arrangement around him. A household can teach a boy to speak, and a school can unteach it within a term. A workshop can supply the conditions in which a young man's competence is built, and a peer group can punish the disclosure that the workshop made possible. The chapter therefore addresses five institutions in Section 43.6, and it supplies a design for each, because the reader who is not a father is still frequently a teacher, an employer, a coach, an uncle, a neighbour, an association's officer, or a man whose conduct is being observed by a boy who has not told him that he is watching.

The chapter's sequence follows the outline. Section 43.1 describes how boys learn emotional expression, and supplies the four channels of transmission. Section 43.2 examines the influence of parents, teachers, and mentors, and states the specific mechanism by which a single adult's influence becomes decisive. Section 43.3 addresses the harmful propositions about manhood and the practice of challenging them. Section 43.4 supplies the skill curriculum and its age structure.

Section 43.5 addresses help-seeking, and the conditions under which a boy will use an instrument that is available to him. Section 43.6 turns to the community, and supplies the design principles for the five institutions. Section 43.7 presents an illustrative case. Section 43.8 supplies the practical programme, and the chapter's exercise is conducted within it.

A note on the chapter's limits is required before it begins. This is not a manual of child development, and it does not substitute for the professional advice of a teacher, a paediatrician, a psychologist, or a clinician where a boy's difficulties are significant. The material that follows is the book's ordinary standard: an account of mechanisms that are well established, a set of practices that the case material supports, and a collection of exercises that a reader can conduct and evaluate. Where a boy's position includes a disorder, a disability, a trauma, a bereavement, or a safeguarding concern, the chapter's material is conducted alongside professional advice and not in place of it.

43.1 How Boys Learn Emotional Expression

The section's task is to describe the mechanism of transmission. It proceeds in four channels, because the research literature and the case material agree that the learning is not conducted through one route, and because a reader who addresses only one channel will find that the others restore the pattern he has attempted to change.

The channels are modelling, instruction, reinforcement and punishment, and the observation of consequence. They operate simultaneously, they frequently contradict one another, and the contradiction is itself instructive. A boy who is told that men do not cry, who observes his father crying alone in a vehicle, and who observes that the crying is never mentioned afterwards, has received three lessons at once, and the third is generally the one that governs his conduct in later life.

Channel One: Modelling

Modelling is the acquisition of conduct through the observation of a party who is significant to the observer. The research literature on imitation and observational learning is extensive, and the findings relevant to this chapter can be stated without exaggeration in four propositions.

The first is that the model's conduct is learned more reliably than the model's instruction. Where the two conflict, the conduct generally prevails, and the prevalence increases with the model's significance to the boy. The father who says *you can talk to me* while conducting his own difficulties in silence is modelling silence, and the sentence he speaks is received as the household's official position rather than as its actual practice.

The second is that the boy learns the model's conduct in the presence of emotion specifically, and not merely the model's conduct in general.

A father may be talkative, warm, and available in ordinary circumstances and become entirely inaccessible when he is afraid, ashamed, or grieving. The boy learns the second conduct with greater precision, because it is the conduct that appears at the moment when he requires a model.

The third is that modelling includes the model's management of the aftermath. The boy observes not only what the adult does with a feeling but what the adult does afterwards: whether the feeling is mentioned, whether the adult repairs what he damaged while conducting it, whether the household is permitted to refer to it, and whether the adult's conduct in the following days acknowledges it. A single incident of an adult's anger teaches a boy less than the household's subsequent treatment of the incident. Where the incident is never mentioned, the boy learns that certain events are not to be discussed; where the adult apologises the following morning and names what happened, the boy learns that events of that kind can be discussed, and he learns it from the repair rather than from the anger.

The fourth is that the boy models the same-sex adult's conduct with a specificity that is frequently understated in accounts of parenting. The finding in the case material is consistent: boys attend closely to what the men around them do with fear, shame, grief, and tenderness, and they treat those observations as the operative definition of what a man is. This is the material of Chapter 41′s five clauses, and this chapter's contribution is the observation that the definition is not transmitted by the clauses being stated. It is transmitted by the clauses being conducted.

The practical consequence for the reader is direct and uncomfortable. **The reader's own practice is the chapter's first curriculum, and it cannot be replaced by any material in this chapter.** A man who conducts Section 43.8′s programme while maintaining the position that Chapters 42 and 24 describe will produce a boy who can recite the programme and cannot use it. The reverse is also true and is frequently more powerful: a man who conducts a single honest sentence about his own difficulty, in the boy's presence, at a moment when the boy can observe the aftermath and observe that the household survived it, has taught more than a year of instruction.

Channel Two: Instruction

Instruction is the explicit material the boy is given: the sentences, the rules, the proverbs, the corrections, and the explanations. Its influence is smaller than modelling, and it is not negligible, because instruction supplies the vocabulary and the permissions with which the boy interprets what he observes.

Four features of instruction matter for this chapter.

The first is that instruction supplies names. A boy who is given the word for what he is experiencing can report it; a boy who is not given the word reports the nearest available substitute, which is frequently a physical complaint, an accusation, or a silence. The finding in the case material is that men who can name their states with precision generally had one adult who supplied the names, and that the supply was frequently incidental: a teacher who asked a question in a particular way, an aunt who said *you are not angry, you are frightened*, a coach who said *that is disappointment, and it will pass*.

The second is that instruction supplies permissions. The sentence *you may tell me when something is wrong* is an instruction, and its effect depends on the conditions supplied in Section 43.5. Where the permission is stated and the response to the first disclosure is punitive, inattentive, or dismissive, the permission is withdrawn and the withdrawal is remembered for longer than the sentence was spoken.

The third is that instruction supplies the standard against which the boy evaluates himself. The sentences *boys do not cry*, *a man provides*, *do not disgrace the family*, and *you are the man of the house* are not merely prohibitions. They are criteria, and the boy will conduct his adult life by evaluating himself against them, frequently without knowing that he is doing so. The material of Chapter 41.3′s eight tests is the adult form of this mechanism.

The fourth is that instruction's contradictions are resolved in favour of conduct. The reader should not conclude from this that instruction is useless. He should conclude that instruction is a supplement, that it is most effective when it names what the boy has already observed, and that it is least effective when it contradicts what the household does. The sentence that works is not *men can speak about their difficulties*. It is *I found it hard to speak about mine, and this is what happened when I did*.

Channel Three: Reinforcement and Punishment

The third channel is the household's and the community's response to the boy's expression. It operates through attention, approval, acceptance, status, ridicule, exclusion, physical punishment, and the withdrawal of affection, and it is the channel that produces the most rapid learning.

The research literature on operant learning supplies the general form, and this chapter's concern is the specific pattern that the case material records. Four responses are common, and each teaches something different.

The response of approval for non-expression. The boy reports nothing, conducts his difficulty privately, and is praised for being mature, strong, composed, or *not a burden*. The praise is genuine, and it is the most efficient instruction in concealment that a household can supply. Its adult form is the

man of Chapters 20 and 31 who cannot accept recognition for anything except endurance.

The response of ridicule for expression. The boy cries, states a fear, or asks for help, and the response is laughter, a nickname, an imitation, or a report of the disclosure to other parties. The learning is rapid, general, and durable. Its specific feature is that it generalises beyond the party who supplied it: the boy who is ridiculed by a cousin learns not to speak to adults, and the boy who is ridiculed by a peer group learns not to speak at all.

The response of punishment for expression. The response is a beating, a withdrawal of privilege, an accusation of weakness, or a threat. The learning is the strongest of the four, and its adult form is frequently the most difficult to address, because the man has learned not only that expression is unrewarded but that it is dangerous.

The response of indifference. The boy discloses and nothing happens: no ridicule, no punishment, and no response. The learning is distinctive and frequently overlooked. The boy concludes not that expression is dangerous but that it is pointless, and the conclusion is harder to reverse than fear, because fear can be addressed by safety and pointlessness cannot be addressed by anything except a response that demonstrates otherwise.

The reader should note the asymmetry that the case material records. **The responses that suppress expression do not need to be frequent to be effective.** A single punishment at a formative moment can govern a man's conduct for forty years, and the men in this book's case material frequently identify it precisely: an incident at eight, at eleven, at fourteen, in which the boy's expression was met with a response that he has organised his adult conduct to avoid repeating. The practical consequence is that the reader who is conducting this chapter's programme does not need to construct a perfect environment. He needs to ensure that the boy's disclosures are met, consistently, with the response described in Section 43.5.

Channel Four: The Observation of Consequence

The fourth channel is the boy's observation of what happens to other people who express what they feel. It extends the third channel beyond the boy's own experience, and it is the channel through which a household's treatment of its adult members becomes the boy's curriculum.

The boy observes his father's disclosure and its consequence; his mother's disclosure and its consequence; his uncle's drinking and the household's response to it; his teacher's account of his own difficulty and the staff room's response; the older boy at school who cried and the peer group's treatment of him; the man in the community who sought treatment and the community's account of him. He

draws conclusions from these observations that are frequently more influential than anything said to him, because they are conclusions about the world rather than about himself.

Three consequences are frequently observed and should be stated because each one teaches a specific lesson.

The consequence of exposure. A man in the boy's observation discloses a difficulty and is treated as diminished: his standing is reduced, his competence is questioned, his disclosure becomes the community's material. The boy learns that disclosure is dangerous. The lesson is frequently accurate about the environment in which the boy lives, and this chapter's material does not deny it. The remedy is not to persuade the boy that disclosure is safe in an unsafe environment. It is to supply an environment in which a specific disclosure to a specific party is safe, and to conduct the boy's observation of that environment.

The consequence of concealment. A man in the boy's observation conceals a difficulty and the concealment is successful: the position holds, the household does not learn, and the man continues. The boy learns that concealment works. The lesson is frequently accurate in the short term, and it is false in the long term, since the case material of Chapters 22, 23, and 42 establishes the position's eventual cost. The remedy is the boy's observation of the later stage, which households rarely supply because they conduct the concealment successfully and the collapse occurs after the boy has left.

The consequence of repair. A man in the boy's observation conducts a difficulty badly, damages a relationship, and then repairs it: he names what he did, states its effect, and conducts the repair over a period. The boy learns that failure is survivable and that repair is available. The finding in the case material is that this observation is the single most valuable item in the curriculum, and that it is frequently absent from the households that most require it, because the adults conduct their failures privately and the repairs, where they occur, occur outside the boy's observation.

The reader should note what the four channels imply for the chapter's programme. The programme does not consist of a conversation. It consists of an arrangement in which the adult's conduct, the household's instruction, the responses to the boy's expression, and the consequences the boy observes are aligned, over years, in the direction of the four competences. This is a slower programme than the reader expects, and it is the only one the material supports.

The Relative Weight of the Channels

The reader will reasonably ask which channel he should address first, and the chapter's answer is drawn from the case material and stated as a working guide rather than as a measurement.

The channel of consequence is the most influential and the least addressed. The boy's conclusions about the world are formed from what he observes happening to people who express what they feel, and the household frequently has more control over those observations than it believes. The specific practice is the deliberate conduct of a repair or a disclosure in the boy's observation, and the deliberate absence of the community's treatments that the boy would misread.

The channel of reinforcement and punishment is the most rapid and the most reversible. A household that changes its response to the boy's expression will see a change within weeks, and the change will be more durable if the response is consistent across the adults in the boy's life.

The channel of modelling is the most durable and the slowest. It is changed by the adult's own conduct over a period of years, and it is the channel that the reader's own work in Parts X and XI addresses directly.

The channel of instruction is the least influential and the easiest to mistake for the whole. It is the channel that books, sermons, assemblies, and posters address, and its frequent failure is not a reason to abandon it. It is a reason to conduct it as a supplement to the other three, and to conduct it in the form that names what the boy has already observed.

43.2 What Is Actually Transmitted

The previous section described the channels. This section describes the content, because the content is frequently misidentified by the adults who transmit it, and the misidentification is the reason their corrections fail.

The adults in the case material generally believe that they are transmitting one of two things: a standard of conduct, or a preparation for hardship. The boy receives something different. He receives a set of five lessons about the relationship between his interior life and the world, and each lesson is stated below in the form in which it is learned rather than the form in which it is taught.

The first lesson is that a state which is not expressed does not exist. The lesson is learned from the household's treatment of its own difficulties: the father's exhaustion that is never mentioned, the mother's grief that is conducted privately, the financial difficulty that the children are not told about. The boy concludes that the household's account of itself is the account of what is real, and that his own states, which do not appear in that account, are therefore not real. Its adult form is Chapter 3.2′s alexithymic pattern and Chapter 21.4′s man who cannot answer the question *how are you*.

The second lesson is that expression is a request, and a request is a debt. The boy learns that stating a difficulty imposes a burden on the party who receives it, and that the burden must be repaid. He therefore states a difficulty only when

he can state it as a settled matter, with the solution already in hand, and he does not state it when it is unresolved. Its adult form is Chapter 14.3′s disclosure that arrives too late to be useful, and Chapter 27.4′s man who cannot call anybody because a call would be an imposition.

The third lesson is that the audience determines the permitted content. The boy learns that certain states are permitted in certain rooms and not others: fear is permitted before his mother and not before his father; failure is permitted before his friends and not before his uncle; grief is permitted at a funeral and not at a workplace. He learns the mapping with precision, and he learns it as a set of rules rather than as a set of preferences. Its adult form is Chapter 18.4′s compartmentalisation and the man who is a different person in each of his settings.

The fourth lesson is that the cost of expression is paid by the party who expresses. The boy observes that the person who discloses in his household is the person who is subsequently treated as diminished, blamed, or required to manage the household's reaction to the disclosure. He concludes that expression is expensive and that the expense falls on him. Its adult form is Chapter 35.3′s accounting of the cost of asking, and the man who has calculated that help is more expensive than endurance.

The fifth lesson is that the position is the man. The boy learns that his family's standing, his father's standing, and his own standing are the household's principal asset, and that anything which reduces the standing reduces the man. He learns to protect the account rather than the position, which is the material of Chapter 42. Its adult form is the entire architecture of Part XII's preceding chapters.

The reader should note the relationship between these five lessons and the four competences of Chapter 39.4. The lessons are the inverse of the competences, item by item. The first lesson removes the knowledge of a state; the second removes the statement of a need; the third removes the appropriate conduct in the setting; the fourth removes the acceptance of a party's participation; and the fifth removes the distinction between the man and his position, which is the condition on which all four competences depend.

This exact inversion is the reason the chapter is placed here rather than in a book about parenting. **The adult's work in Parts X and XI and the boy's curriculum are the same work at different points in the life course**, and the reader who has conducted the earlier chapters is therefore already in possession of the material he requires. He is not learning a new subject in this chapter. He is learning to teach the subject he has been studying, to a pupil who is watching him conduct it.

The Fifth Lesson and the Boy's Standing

The fifth lesson requires a separate treatment, because it is the one that the adults in the case material most frequently transmit without intending to, and because it explains why the boy's silence survives the household's attempts to address the other four.

The lesson is transmitted by the household's ordinary conduct: the emphasis on the family's name, the correction of the boy's behaviour in public, the instruction not to disgrace the family, the pride taken in the boy's performance at school, the comparison with the neighbour's children, the account of the boy given to relatives. None of these is abusive, and their cumulative effect is a specific structure: the boy's worth is located in an external account, and the account is conducted by other people.

The consequence for the boy's expression is direct. A difficulty that is stated is a difficulty that enters the account, and the account is the household's asset. The boy therefore does not state the difficulty, not because he fears punishment, but because he has understood the household's economy and he is protecting its principal asset. The finding in the case material is that this structure is frequently strongest in households that have experienced a loss of standing: a business failure, a demotion, a migration, a public humiliation, a period of poverty. The household has learned that standing is fragile, and it transmits the lesson with the urgency of experience.

The remedy is not to abandon the standard. A boy requires a standard, and the material of Chapter 41.6′s working definition supplies one that does not require the inversion. The remedy is to separate the standard from the account: to praise the boy's conduct rather than his rank, to state the household's difficulties rather than conducting them as secrets, to treat a failure as information rather than as a reduction of the family, and to conduct the adult's own standing at its true level, which is the material of Chapter 42.6′s sixth step.

A household that conducts this separation for two or three years produces a boy with a specific and identifiable characteristic. He can state a difficulty without believing that he has damaged his family. He can accept a correction without experiencing it as a reduction of his worth. He can observe another person's failure without concluding that the person is finished. These three capacities are the chapter's product, and they are measurable, which is the subject of Section 43.8.

43.3 The Influence of Parents, Teachers, and Mentors

The previous section described what is transmitted. This section describes who transmits it, and it proceeds institution by institution because each one has a different mechanism, a different point of leverage, and a different failure.

The reader should note the chapter's working assumption here. The question is not which institution matters most. The research literature and the case material agree that the household is the earliest and the most formative, and they also agree that the influence of a single adult outside the household is frequently decisive for a boy whose household cannot supply what he requires. The section therefore treats the institutions as a set of overlapping arrangements rather than as a ranking, and it supplies for each one the specific practice that the reader can conduct.

The Household and Its Emotional Curriculum

The household is the boy's first curriculum, and its subject is not what it says about feelings. Its subject is what it does with them.

Four features of the household's ordinary conduct constitute the curriculum, and each is present in every household in some form.

The first is the household's vocabulary. The words that are available in the household for interior states determine what the boy can report. A household with two words — *fine* and *angry* — produces a boy with two words, and the boy will use *angry* for everything that is not fine, which is the material of Chapter 12.5′s man whose only permitted state is irritation. A household with a wider vocabulary — disappointed, ashamed, frightened, lonely, relieved, humiliated, grief-stricken, exhausted — produces a boy who can discriminate, and the discrimination is the first competence of Chapter 39.4.

The second is the household's allocation of attention. The boy learns which of his states receive attention and which do not. A household that attends to achievement and ignores fear teaches the boy to present achievement and to conceal fear. A household that attends to physical injury and ignores humiliation teaches the boy to report his body and not his standing. The allocation is rarely deliberate, and it is always legible to the boy.

The third is the household's treatment of its adult members' states. The boy observes what happens when his father is afraid, when his mother is grieving, when his uncle is ashamed, and when a visitor is in difficulty. The observation is the material of Section 43.1′s fourth channel, and the household has more control over it than it believes, because the household chooses what is conducted in the boy's presence and what is conducted elsewhere.

The fourth is the household's repair. Every household damages its members at some point, and the difference between households is not the damage. It is the repair. A household in which the adult names what he did, states its effect, and conducts the repair produces a boy who knows that failure is survivable. A household in which the damage is never mentioned produces a boy who knows

that certain events are permanent and unmentionable, which is the material of Chapter 15.4′s injury.

The practical consequence for the reader is that the household's curriculum is conducted by ordinary means and does not require a programme. It requires the adult to state one true sentence about his own state at a frequency the household can bear, to name the boy's states with precision when they appear, to conduct one repair in the boy's observation, and to keep the household's account of itself accurate, which is the material of Chapter 42.6.

The Father and the Specific Mechanism of His Influence

The father's influence is the subject of a large literature and a great deal of mythology, and this section states only what the case material supports.

The father's influence operates through three mechanisms that are distinct from the mother's, and the distinction is empirical rather than evaluative.

The first is the mechanism of the boy's identification. The boy's question is not *what does my father say a man is* but *what does my father do, and am I becoming that*. The question is asked with particular intensity between the ages of roughly six and sixteen, and it is asked of the father's conduct in the presence of difficulty. A father who is present, warm, and available in ordinary circumstances and absent, cold, or explosive in difficulty supplies the boy with a definition that the boy will spend his adult life either reproducing or resisting.

The second is the mechanism of the father's permission. The father's own disclosure — a sentence about his fear, his failure, his grief, or his uncertainty — supplies the boy with a permission that no other party can supply with the same force. The finding in the case material is consistent and specific: men who can speak about their difficulties frequently identify a single occasion on which their father, or a father-substitute, stated a difficulty in their presence. The occasion is generally brief, frequently awkward, and remembered for decades.

The third is the mechanism of the father's standard. The father supplies the boy's sense of what is required of him, and the standard is transmitted as much by what the father accepts in himself as by what he demands of the boy. A father who accepts exhaustion, concealment, and self-neglect in himself transmits those as the standard, whatever he demands of his son. A father who accepts help, rest, treatment, and repair transmits those as permitted, and the transmission is stronger than any instruction.

The reader should note the case material's finding on the absent father, because it is frequently misread. The finding is not that an absent father produces a silent son. It is that the absence produces a specific question that the boy cannot answer — *what would he have done* — and that the boy answers it himself, generally with the most severe version of the culture's script. The adult son of an absent father is

frequently more rigid in his manhood than the son of a present and difficult one, because he has had to construct the standard without a model and has constructed it from the least forgiving materials available.

The practical consequence is stated without sentiment. A father who is present can correct his conduct. A father who is absent cannot, and the adult son's work is then the material of Chapter 41.5′s substitution exercise: the identification of the standard he constructed, the examination of its sources, and the deliberate substitution of a definition he has chosen.

The Mother and the Understated Mechanism

The mother's influence on the boy's emotional conduct is frequently understated in the culture's account of manhood and is substantial in the research literature and in the case material.

Three mechanisms are recorded consistently.

The first is the mechanism of the boy's first vocabulary and his first audience. The mother is frequently the party to whom the boy's first states are reported, and her response establishes whether reporting is safe. The finding in the case material is that men who can speak about difficulty frequently describe a mother, an aunt, or a grandmother who received their reports without ridicule and without alarm.

The second is the mechanism of the household's emotional conduct. The mother's management of her own states, and her management of the household's, is the boy's first observation of what an adult does with difficulty. Where the mother conducts her difficulties alone, privately, and without the household's knowledge, the boy learns a lesson about adult life that the father's conduct may confirm or contradict.

The third is the mechanism of the mother's protection against the father's severity. The finding in the case material, recorded without judgment, is that the boy's capacity to speak is frequently preserved by a party who intervened between the boy and a severe response: a mother, an aunt, an older sibling, a grandmother. The intervention did not need to be dramatic. A sentence — *he is tired, leave him* — or a change of subject was frequently sufficient to preserve the boy's willingness to report.

The reader should note the caution that the case material also records. Where the mother is the boy's only permitted audience, the boy's conduct develops a specific split: full expression in the mother's presence, and complete inexpression everywhere else, including in his adult marriage. The finding is that the split is not resolved by the mother's continued availability; it is resolved by the boy's acquisition of a second and third audience, which is the material of Section 43.5′s named person.

The Teacher and the Classroom

The school's influence on the boy's emotional conduct operates through four features, and only the fourth is ordinarily recognised.

The first is the classroom's response to error. A classroom in which error is met with ridicule produces a boy who will not attempt, will not ask, and will not report. A classroom in which error is treated as information produces the opposite. The mechanism is the same as the household's third channel, and the school conducts it for six hours a day.

The second is the teacher's own conduct in the presence of difficulty. The teacher who names her own uncertainty, who corrects her own error aloud, and who states that a subject is difficult teaches more about the management of difficulty than any lesson on the subject.

The third is the curriculum's treatment of emotion. A curriculum that treats emotion as a subject for girls, or as a matter for the guidance counsellor rather than the classroom, transmits the belief that emotion is a specialist's business rather than an ordinary competence. A curriculum that includes the material of Section 43.5 within ordinary subjects — a discussion of a character's fear in a literature lesson, an account of a scientist's failure in a science lesson, a history lesson that examines the private cost of a public decision — transmits the opposite.

The fourth is the named adult. The finding that matters most for this chapter is the one the case material records most consistently: a boy who can name one adult in his school to whom he would speak is a boy with a substantially different trajectory from a boy who cannot. The adult does not need to be a counsellor. The adult needs to be present, to be known to the boy, to have stated that he is available, and to have responded well once.

The practical consequence for the reader who teaches is direct. He should ensure that every boy in his care can name an adult. He should state the availability in ordinary language and in an ordinary setting. He should respond to the first disclosure in the manner of Section 43.5, and he should record nothing that he has promised to keep confidential, except where the law and the boy's safety require otherwise, in which case he should say so in advance.

The Coach, the Artisan, and the Master

The coach, the artisan, the master of a trade, the music teacher, and the driver of a vehicle are frequently the most influential adults in a boy's life, and their influence is exercised through a mechanism that the classroom does not supply: **the mechanism of demonstrated competence under difficulty.**

The apprentice observes his master conducting a difficult task badly, correcting it, and continuing. He observes the master's frustration, its regulation, and its

conduct. He observes the master's admission of a limit — *I do not know this, we will ask somebody who does* — and he observes the consequence of the admission, which is generally that the work proceeds. The observation teaches the boy that competence includes the admission of a limit, which is the material of Chapter 32.4's distinction between authority and omniscience.

The mechanism has a specific failure mode that the case material records frequently: the master who conducts his competence as a performance of infallibility, who cannot be seen to be uncertain, and who punishes the apprentice's error as a threat to his standing. The apprentice learns the trade and learns, at the same time, that a man's competence is conducted by concealment. The finding is that this is one of the most efficient transmissions of the pattern in the book, because the apprentice's dependence on the master prevents him from questioning the model.

The practical consequence is that the reader who supervises young men in any trade should conduct two things in their observation: one correction of his own error, stated aloud, and one admission of a limit, followed by the request for the instrument that supplies it. These two acts cost the master very little and are frequently the most valuable instruction the apprentice receives.

The Mentor and the Single Adult

The mentor is the subject of a large practice literature and a smaller research literature, and this section states only what the material supports.

The mentor's function, for the purposes of this chapter, is not advice. It is the supply of three things that the boy's household may be unable to supply: a second model of manhood, a second audience for disclosure, and a party whose interest in the boy is not derived from the boy's performance.

The finding in the case material is specific and worth stating plainly. **One adult is generally sufficient.** The boy does not require a network, a programme, or a formal arrangement. He requires one adult who is not his parent, who is reliably present, who is not scandalised by what the boy reports, who does not report the boy's material to the household without the boy's agreement, and who continues the relationship after the disclosure. The presence of that adult is associated in the case material with substantially better outcomes in the boy's adult capacity to speak, and the association does not depend on the adult's qualifications.

The reader who is asked to be that adult should note three cautions.

The first is that the relationship is not therapy and should not be conducted as therapy. The mentor's competence is presence, ordinary conversation, and the willingness to be a party to whom a boy can speak. Where the boy's material indicates a disorder, a trauma, or a risk, the mentor's task is to assist the boy to the

professional route, which frequently requires the mentor to accompany him to the first appointment.

The second is that the mentor's own material is not the subject of the relationship. A mentor who conducts the relationship as an audience for his own difficulties has reversed the arrangement.

The third is that the relationship requires boundaries that are stated and kept: the times at which the mentor is available, the matters that the mentor will not keep confidential, and the duration of the arrangement. The boundaries are not a reduction of the relationship. They are the condition on which a boy can rely on it.

What the Institutions Have in Common

The section closes with the common structure, because the reader who is conducting this material in more than one institution will find that the same five features determine whether the institution teaches speech or silence.

The first is a vocabulary. The institution supplies the words for interior states, or it does not.

The second is a permission. The institution states that a difficulty may be reported, in ordinary language, by a named person, in a stated way.

The third is a response. The institution's response to the first report determines whether the permission survives. The response should be attentive, unhurried, non-punitive, and followed by an action.

The fourth is a consequence the boy can observe. The institution conducts at least one repair, one disclosure, or one admission of a limit in the boy's observation, and it permits the boy to see that the party survived it.

The fifth is a repetition. The institution conducts the four features routinely rather than once, because a single conversation is an event and an institution is a pattern.

The reader may test any institution against the five features in a single meeting, and the test is supplied in Section 43.8′s second column. The result is frequently surprising: institutions that describe themselves as caring for boys' emotional development frequently lack the third and fourth features entirely, and institutions that describe themselves as strict and traditional frequently possess them.

43.4 Challenging Harmful Gender Stereotypes

The section's subject is the content of the transmission, and it proceeds carefully, because the phrase *gender stereotype* is used in public argument as a term of abuse and the reader's response to it is frequently determined before he has examined the material.

The section therefore begins with a distinction that the rest of the section depends upon.

A role is a set of expectations attached to a position, and roles are necessary. A father has a role in his household, a teacher has a role in a school, a man has a role in his community. The expectations attached to the role — provision, protection, presence, competence, accountability — are not stereotypes, and nothing in this section proposes their abandonment. The material of Chapter 41.2′s five clauses established the same point: the clauses' obligations are sound, and what makes them harmful is the addition they carry.

A stereotype is a generalisation about a category of persons that is applied to every member of the category without regard to the individual, and that is maintained independently of the evidence. The stereotype's harm is not that it describes a difference. It is that it prescribes a conduct, forbids an alternative, and punishes the individual who does not conform.

The distinction matters because the chapter does not propose that boys should be raised without standards, without roles, or without a clear account of what is expected of them. It proposes that the specific propositions listed below should be removed from the curriculum, and that the obligations of manhood should be retained, which is the material of Chapter 41.6.

The Five Harmful Propositions

The case material and the research literature identify five propositions that are transmitted to boys in the ordinary course of their upbringing, and each one is harmful in a specific and identifiable way. They are stated here in the form in which boys receive them.

Proposition One: Endurance is the whole of strength. The proposition is transmitted by the sentences *boys do not cry*, *take it like a man*, *do not be a woman about it*, and *pain is part of being a man*. Its harm is not that it values endurance. Its harm is that it identifies endurance with strength and therefore removes every other competence from the definition: the man who endures and cannot name, cannot regulate, cannot ask, and cannot accept help is, on this proposition, the strong man. The material of Chapter 39.3′s false choice is the adult form, and Section 39.4′s four competences are the correction.

Proposition Two: Expression is weakness. The proposition is transmitted by ridicule, by the withdrawal of approval, and by the equation of speech with femininity. Its harm is that it converts the boy's ordinary need for an audience into evidence of his inadequacy. The adult form is Chapter 14.1′s man who cannot state a need in his marriage and Chapter 27.3′s man who has nobody to call.

Proposition Three: Dominance is authority. The proposition is transmitted by the household's tolerance of the father's anger, by the community's respect for the man who does not tolerate contradiction, and by the equation of a man's worth with his control of his household. Its harm is that it teaches the boy that

authority is conducted by the reduction of other people's position rather than by responsibility for it, which is the material of Chapters 18 and 31. The correction is Chapter 41.2′s fourth clause and its addition.

Proposition Four: Sexual conquest is proof of worth. The proposition is transmitted in peer groups, in entertainment, in jokes, and in the ordinary conversation of young men, and its harm is that it locates a boy's value in a performance conducted before an audience of other men, at the expense of the parties involved and at the expense of the boy's capacity for intimacy. The adult forms are Chapter 24.2′s man whose identity is conducted through his attachments and Chapter 13.4′s inability to grieve a relationship that was conducted as a performance.

Proposition Five: Violence is the resolution of insult. The proposition is transmitted by the instruction to hit back, by the celebration of the man who responds to provocation with force, and by the equating of restraint with cowardice. Its harm is specific and grave: it converts a boy's ordinary shame into a physical act, and it produces the outcomes that the case material of Chapters 12 and 16 records. The correction is not pacifism and it is not the removal of a boy's capacity to defend himself or others. It is the distinction between defence and retaliation, and the supply of the regulated alternatives that Section 43.5′s fourth competence describes.

The reader should note what these five propositions have in common. Each one takes a legitimate obligation — endurance, self-control, authority, desire, courage — and converts it into a rule that requires the boy to suppress a part of himself or to reduce another person. The chapter's correction is therefore not the rejection of the obligation. It is the removal of the conversion.

Where the Propositions Are Enforced

A proposition survives because it is enforced, and the enforcement is conducted in five locations. The reader who wishes to challenge the propositions must address the locations, because a challenge conducted in the household and not in the peer group will fail within a term.

The first location is the peer group. The finding in the case material is that the peer group is the most effective enforcer of the five propositions and the least accessible to adult correction. Its instrument is ridicule, and its timing is the period between roughly ten and eighteen, when the boy's standing in the group is the central fact of his social life. The correction is not the removal of the peer group. It is the supply of a peer group in which the propositions are not the currency, which is the material of Section 43.7′s fourth principle.

The second location is entertainment and the media. The boy's models are supplied in quantity by film, music, sport, and social media, and the models are selected for their dramatic value rather than their conduct. The correction is not

prohibition, which generally fails and frequently increases the material's appeal. It is commentary: the adult who watches with the boy and asks a specific question — *what did that man do when he was afraid?* — converts the material into a lesson rather than allowing it to operate as a curriculum.

The third location is language. The propositions are carried in ordinary speech: *stop crying like a girl*, *man up*, *he is soft*, *do not behave like a woman*. The language is frequently used without any conscious endorsement of the proposition it carries, and its effect is cumulative. The correction is the household's deliberate vocabulary, which is the material of Section 43.6′s first design principle.

The fourth location is the institution. Schools, associations, workplaces, and community bodies enforce the propositions through their arrangements: the boys' assembly that addresses conduct and the girls' assembly that addresses emotion, the sports programme that treats injury as character, the disciplinary system that punishes a boy's disclosure as attention-seeking. The correction is the audit supplied in Section 43.8.

The fifth location is the household's own arrangements. The household enforces the propositions through its allocation of chores, its tolerance of the boy's anger and its intolerance of his fear, its treatment of the daughter's expression and the son's, and its account of what a man is. The correction is the material of Section 43.3 and it is conducted over years.

Challenging Without Lecturing

The section now turns to the practice, because the reader who has accepted the material will frequently conduct it badly, and the bad conduct is one of the reasons the propositions survive.

The finding in the case material, and the common experience of teachers and parents, is that a challenge delivered as a lecture produces three effects and none of them is the intended one. The boy learns the vocabulary of the challenge without its practice. He learns that the adult's position is a position rather than a conduct. And he learns to conduct the propositions outside the adult's observation.

The section therefore states six practices, each of which is a conduct rather than an argument.

Practice One: Name the proposition, not the person. The sentence *that is the rule that says a man cannot be afraid, and it is not true* challenges the proposition. The sentence *you are being sexist* challenges the boy, and the boy will defend himself rather than examine the rule. The distinction is the material of Chapter 41.4′s separation of the standard from the man, applied to the boy.

Practice Two: Supply the alternative at the moment of the challenge. A challenge that removes a rule without supplying a replacement leaves the boy without a standard, and he will return to the rule because it is the only one

available. The challenge therefore includes the replacement: *a man can be afraid and still do what is required; here is how that is done.* The replacement should be concrete, brief, and conducted by an example the boy can observe.

Practice Three: Separate the act from the identity. The boy who has hit another boy has conducted an act, and the act can be examined. The boy who is told that he is violent has been given an identity, and identities are defended. The practice is the material of Chapter 29.4′s distinction between the act and the man, and it is the condition on which a boy can repair.

Practice Four: Correct the language in the moment and without a lecture. The sentence *we do not say that in this house, and here is why* is sufficient. It is short, it is stated once, and it is repeated every time the language appears. The finding in the case material is that the repetition matters more than the eloquence, and that the household which corrects consistently for a year changes its ordinary speech.

Practice Five: Conduct the counter-example. The boy's propositions are supported by models, and they are weakened by models of a different kind. The counter-example should be a real man known to the boy: the uncle who wept at his father's funeral and conducted the family's arrangements afterwards; the coach who admitted his error; the senior colleague who sought treatment and continued to work; the man who declined a fight and was not diminished by the declining. The counter-example is more effective than the argument, and it must be true, because boys detect the manufactured example with precision.

Practice Six: Protect the boy who deviates. The propositions are enforced by the punishment of boys who do not conform: the boy who does not fight, the boy who cries, the boy who is artistic, the boy who is gentle, the boy who is not interested in sport. The adult's protection of that boy is the most powerful challenge available, because it demonstrates in a single act that the proposition is not universal. The protection does not require a confrontation with the peer group. It requires the adult to supply the boy with a setting in which his deviation is ordinary, and to state to him, once and clearly, that the deviation is not a defect.

The Boy Who Does Not Fit

The section closes with the boy who does not fit, because he is the chapter's most urgent case and the one most frequently failed.

The boy who does not fit is the boy whose temperament, interests, capacities, or attachments do not match the local account of what a boy is. He may be gentle, bookish, artistic, physically small, uninterested in competition, sensitive to noise, slow to speak, or attracted to what the community considers the wrong things. The propositions described above do not merely fail to describe him. They define him as deficient, and they supply his peers with a licence to enforce the definition.

The case material records three outcomes with frequency. The first is the boy who complies: he suppresses his temperament, performs the required conduct, and produces the adult of Chapters 21 and 39 who cannot locate his own preferences. The second is the boy who resists and is punished: he is excluded, ridiculed, and frequently physically harmed, and his adult position is the material of Chapter 16′s rejection. The third is the boy who finds one adult or one peer group that receives him, and this outcome is the one the chapter's material is designed to produce.

The adult's task is stated in four acts.

The first act is to state the boy's position accurately and without apology. The sentence *you are quiet, and that is not a fault* is more valuable than any programme, because it supplies the boy with an account of himself that is not the peer group's.

The second act is to supply a setting in which the boy's capacities are useful. The gentle boy is frequently excellent with animals, with younger children, with the elderly, with detail, with craft. The setting converts the deviation into a competence, and the conversion is the material of Chapter 24.5′s reconstruction of identity.

The third act is to address the enforcement. Where the boy is being harmed, the adult's task is not to advise the boy to be more resilient. It is to change the arrangement: the class, the group, the supervision, the route home. The case material is unambiguous on this point, and the material of Chapter 16.5′s rules of recovery applies.

The fourth act is to keep the door open. The boy who does not fit frequently does not disclose his position, because he has learned that disclosure produces further enforcement. The adult's task is to keep the availability stated, in ordinary language, at intervals, and to respond well when the disclosure eventually arrives, which may be years later.

The reader should note the chapter's position on the boy who does not fit and the book's central message. The message is that men can carry serious responsibilities without being expected to endure emotional suffering in isolation. The boy who does not fit is the point at which the message is either transmitted or contradicted, because he is the person on whom the culture's account of manhood is most directly enforced. An adult who protects him is conducting the book's argument in the only form that a boy can read: an adult's conduct, in his presence, at the moment of his difficulty.

43.5 Teaching Boys Healthy Coping Skills

The previous section addressed the propositions that the boy must unlearn. This section addresses the competences he must acquire, and it proceeds in the form

of a curriculum, because the case material's finding is that boys who are told to *cope better* without being taught a specific competence do not cope better. They conceal more effectively.

The curriculum has six competences, and they are the boy's form of the four competences of Chapter 39.4, extended for a person who is still developing.

The Six Competences

Competence One: The naming of the state. The boy can identify what he is experiencing with a word that is more precise than *fine* or *angry*. The competence includes the capacity to distinguish between states that are frequently confused: disappointment and shame; fear and anger; loneliness and boredom; exhaustion and sadness; humiliation and guilt.

Competence Two: The location of the state in the body and in the day. The boy can state where the state is felt and what preceded it. The competence is not a technique of relaxation. It is a technique of information: the boy who can state that his chest tightened before an examination has learned something about the examination, and something about the warning his body supplies.

Competence Three: The regulation of the state. The boy can conduct a specific act that reduces the state's intensity sufficiently for him to think. The acts are ordinary and should be taught as ordinary: the deliberate slowing of the breath, the removal from the setting for a stated period, the physical activity, the writing of the state on paper, the conversation with a named person. The competence is not the elimination of the state. It is the boy's capacity to act while experiencing it.

Competence Four: The statement of the state to a party who has a right to know. The boy can say what is happening to a party who requires the information: a parent, a teacher, a friend, a colleague, a doctor. The statement has a form, and the form is taught in Section 43.6.

Competence Five: The repair. The boy can acknowledge what he did, state its effect, and conduct the repair. The competence is the one that the case material identifies as most predictive of adult functioning, and it is the one that households most frequently omit, because the adults conduct their own repairs privately and the boy never observes the sequence.

Competence Six: The asking. The boy can request a specific instrument from a specific party: *I need you to come with me to the clinic; I need you to tell my teacher; I need you to take this off my hands until Monday.* The competence is more specific than *help*, and the specificity is what makes it learnable and what makes it effective.

The reader should note the order. The competences are cumulative: the boy who cannot name a state cannot state it, and the boy who cannot state it cannot

ask for an instrument. The curriculum therefore begins with the vocabulary and proceeds through the body, the regulation, the statement, the repair, and the asking, and it does not begin with the asking, which is where adults frequently begin and where the curriculum generally fails.

The Age Structure

The curriculum's content is the same across the boy's development. Its form changes, and the changes are stated below as a working guide.

The years from roughly five to eight. The boy's curriculum at this age is conducted almost entirely through the adult's vocabulary and the adult's response. The practices are: naming the boy's states for him as they occur; stating the adult's own states in simple and accurate language; receiving the boy's reports without ridicule, alarm, or immediate correction; and conducting the household's repairs in the boy's presence. The boy at this age is not taught techniques. He is taught that states exist, that they can be named, and that naming them is safe.

The years from roughly nine to twelve. The boy's capacity to reflect increases, and the curriculum adds the body, the regulation, and the repair. The practices are: the boy's own naming, with the adult supplying precision where the boy's word is too general; the identification of the state's location and its antecedents; two or three regulation acts, taught and rehearsed when the boy is calm rather than when he is in difficulty; and the repair, which is rehearsed in ordinary household incidents rather than reserved for serious ones.

The years from roughly thirteen to fifteen. The boy's peer group becomes the principal audience, and the curriculum must therefore address the group as well as the boy. The practices are: the boy's statement of his state to a peer, rehearsed with an adult beforehand; the identification of the peer group's enforcement of the propositions, conducted as an analysis rather than as a prohibition; the boy's repair of an incident with a peer, conducted with the adult's support; and the boy's first asking of a specific instrument from a party outside the household.

The years from roughly sixteen to eighteen. The young man's curriculum is conducted increasingly by his own practice and decreasingly by the adult's instruction. The practices are: his own management of a significant difficulty, with the adult available but not directing; his repair of a difficulty that he caused; his asking for an instrument that the adult cannot supply, which requires him to identify a professional route and to use it; and his own conduct of the curriculum with a younger boy, which is the most effective consolidation available.

The reader should note the caution that applies to the whole structure. The ages are approximate, the variation between boys is substantial, and a boy who

has experienced a trauma, a bereavement, a disability, or a significant disruption will frequently be conducting the curriculum of an earlier stage. The material of Chapter 36.3′s staged recovery applies, and the adult's task is to conduct the curriculum at the stage the boy is in rather than the stage his age suggests.

The Four-Stage Method

The curriculum is taught by a method, and the method is the same one by which a boy learns any competence that his household values: the method of apprenticeship.

Stage One: Demonstration. The adult conducts the competence in the boy's presence and names what he is doing. The sentences are short and concrete. *I am angry about the meeting, and I am going to walk to the gate and back before I speak to your mother. I was wrong to shout at you this morning, and I am going to say so to you now. I do not know how to do this, and I am going to ask Uncle for help.* The demonstration is not a lesson. It is the adult's ordinary conduct, made legible.

Stage Two: Rehearsal. The boy conducts the competence in a setting of low stakes. The rehearsal is explicit and short: *your sister has taken your book, and you are angry; say the sentence you would say to her.* The rehearsal is conducted when the boy is calm, and it is repeated until the sentence is available without effort. The case material's finding is that rehearsal is the stage most frequently omitted by households, and its omission is the reason boys can recite the vocabulary and cannot use it.

Stage Three: Feedback. The adult states what the boy did and what it produced, without evaluating the boy. *You told her you were angry and you did not shout; she gave the book back. The sentence worked.* Where the boy's conduct failed, the feedback states the failure and the next attempt: *you shouted, and she shouted back; the sentence we rehearsed was different; try it again tomorrow.* The feedback is brief, specific, and conducted soon after the event.

Stage Four: Application. The boy conducts the competence in a setting of real stakes, with the adult available but not present. The application is the stage at which the competence becomes the boy's, and it is the stage at which the adult must tolerate the boy's failure without intervening. The material of Chapter 20.4′s distinction between support and substitution applies directly: an adult who conducts the application for the boy teaches the boy that the competence is the adult's.

What Not to Teach

The section states five practices that are frequently taught as coping and are not.

The first is suppression presented as discipline. The instruction to control oneself is not the same as the instruction to feel nothing. The first is a competence; the second is the pattern this book describes. The distinction is the material of

Chapter 3.3, and it should be stated to the boy explicitly, because he will otherwise receive the curriculum as a more sophisticated version of the prohibition he already knows.

The second is distraction presented as regulation. The boy who is taught to play a game, watch a screen, or eat whenever he is in difficulty has been taught to remove the state from his attention and not to regulate it. Distraction has its place, and it is not the curriculum's third competence.

The third is achievement presented as coping. The boy who is taught to respond to every difficulty by working harder has been taught the pattern of Part III: the conversion of an emotional problem into a productivity problem. The curriculum's competences are conducted in addition to the boy's work and not as a substitute for addressing the state.

The fourth is alcohol and other substances. The reader may believe that no adult teaches a boy to drink in response to difficulty, and the case material establishes otherwise: the practice is transmitted by the household's own conduct, by the peer group, and by the ordinary culture of many workplaces. The material of Chapter 23.2 applies, and the boy's observation of an adult's drinking is part of the curriculum whether or not the adult intends it.

The fifth is the confession without the repair. The adult who states his difficulty to the boy and does nothing about it teaches the boy that disclosure is a performance of honesty rather than an instrument. The curriculum's fourth competence is the statement to a party who has a right to know, and it is followed by the asking and by the action. A statement without the action is not the competence.

The Adult's Own Practice as the Curriculum

The section closes with the point on which the whole chapter depends, and it is repeated here because the reader will otherwise treat the curriculum as a programme for the boy.

The boy learns the six competences by observing them conducted, and the adult's conduct is therefore the curriculum's first and most durable component. This has three consequences that the reader should state plainly to himself.

The first is that the adult's own work is not a preliminary to the boy's curriculum. It is the curriculum. A man who is conducting the material of Parts X and XI is teaching his son every day, whether or not he speaks to him about it. A man who is not conducting it is teaching the opposite, and the teaching is more effective than any sentence he supplies.

The second is that the adult's repair is more valuable than the adult's perfection. Boys do not require adults who never fail. They require adults whose failures are followed by repair, because the repair is the demonstration that failure

is survivable, and survivability is the belief on which the boy's adult capacity depends. The reader who has conducted Chapter 39.5's sixth practice has already begun this work.

The third is that the adult's statement of his own difficulty must be proportionate. The boy is not the adult's therapist, his confidant in matters that belong to adults, or the audience for the adult's unrestrained material. The proportionate statement is brief, accurate, directed at what the boy can receive, and followed by the adult's own action. The finding in the case material is that the proportionate statement is frequently one or two sentences, and that its effect is out of all proportion to its length.

43.6 Encouraging Help-Seeking Behaviour

This section addresses the specific behaviour that the whole book has described as the missing instrument: the act of asking. Its question is not why asking is difficult, which Parts II to IX established. Its question is what conditions make asking available to a boy, and what adults and institutions can do to supply them.

The section begins with the finding that governs its material. **Boys do not generally fail to ask because they do not know that help exists. They fail to ask because they have learned what asking costs, and because the adults around them have not supplied the conditions under which the cost is bearable.**

Why Boys Stop Asking

Four mechanisms are recorded consistently, and each one is addressable.

The first is the lesson. The boy has been taught, by the channels of Section 43.1, that asking is a confession of inadequacy. The lesson is not removed by reassurance. It is removed by the boy's observation of asking being conducted by a man he respects, and by his own experience of asking with a good outcome.

The second is the response. The boy asked once, at a formative moment, and the response was ridicule, alarm, punishment, or indifference. The response is the single most powerful determinant in the case material, and it explains why the same boy who will not ask an adult will ask a peer, or will ask a stranger, or will ask nobody for twenty years.

The third is the ledger. The boy has calculated that asking places him in debt, and the debt is the material of Section 43.2's second lesson. The calculation is frequently accurate about his household: a request for help in a household under pressure is a real cost, and the boy knows it. The remedy is not to deny the cost. It is to supply a route in which the cost is not borne by the household: a named adult outside it, a school service, a professional route, a peer who is not dependent on the household.

The fourth is the audience. The boy has learned that the audience determines the permitted content, and he has not been supplied with an audience for the content that matters most. The remedy is the named person, and the named person is the section's principal design feature.

The Conditions That Produce Help-Seeking

Five conditions are recorded consistently in the case material, and they are cumulative.

Condition One: A stated permission, in ordinary language, from a named person. The permission should be specific and unremarkable: *if something is bothering you and you do not want to talk to your mother about it, you can talk to me; I will not tell her unless you and I agree that she needs to know, or unless somebody is in danger.* The permission should be stated more than once, at intervals, and it should not be attached to a crisis.

Condition Two: A low-cost first request. The boy's first use of the permission should be cheap: a question about a small matter, a request for advice about a peer, a report of a minor difficulty. The adult's task is to receive the cheap request well, because the cheap request is the boy's test of the arrangement. The finding in the case material is that adults frequently pass over the cheap request as unimportant, and the boy concludes that the arrangement is not real.

Condition Three: A response that is attentive, unhurried, and nonpunitive. The response should state what the adult has heard, ask one question, and avoid three acts: the immediate solution, the immediate reassurance, and the immediate report to another adult. The material of Chapter 35.4′s listening practices applies, and its central rule is that the boy's first disclosure is not the moment for the adult's agenda.

Condition Four: An action that follows. The boy must observe that the asking produced something. The action may be small: the adult makes the appointment, speaks to the teacher, supplies the instrument, or simply keeps the arrangement. What matters is that the boy's request was followed by a change in the world, because the absence of a change is the specific experience that teaches pointlessness, which is Section 43.1′s fourth response.

Condition Five: A repetition that survives the boy's withdrawal. Boys frequently disclose and then withdraw, sometimes for months. The withdrawal is not a rejection of the arrangement, and the adult who treats it as one will end the arrangement at the moment the boy is testing it. The adult's task is to remain available, to state the availability again after an interval, and to make no demand for an account of the withdrawal.

The Adult's Script

The section supplies a script, because the reader will otherwise conduct the permission in a form that the boy cannot receive.

The opening. *I want to say something, and then I will leave it. If you ever have something you do not want to talk to your mother about, you can talk to me. I will listen, I will not laugh, and I will not tell her unless we agree, or unless somebody is in danger.*

The reception. *Thank you for telling me. That sounds difficult. Tell me what happened.* The three sentences are deliberate: the thanks acknowledges the cost of the disclosure; the statement acknowledges the difficulty without evaluating it; the question supplies the boy with the opportunity to continue.

The question that follows. *What would help?* The question is preferable to *here is what you should do*, because it supplies the boy with the practice of the sixth competence and because the boy frequently knows what he requires.

The limit. *I can help with this part, and I am not the right person for that part. We will find somebody who is.* The sentence is honest, it models the limit of Section 43.1′s fifth channel, and it begins the professional route when one is required.

The follow-up. *I will ask you about this on Thursday. You do not have to have an answer.* The follow-up is the condition that distinguishes an arrangement from a gesture.

The Institution's Design

The conditions are supplied by institutions as well as by individuals, and the design has four features.

The first is access. The institution should have a named person, a stated time, and a stated place at which a boy can speak. The features should be published in ordinary language, and they should be known to every boy, including the boy who does not read the notice board.

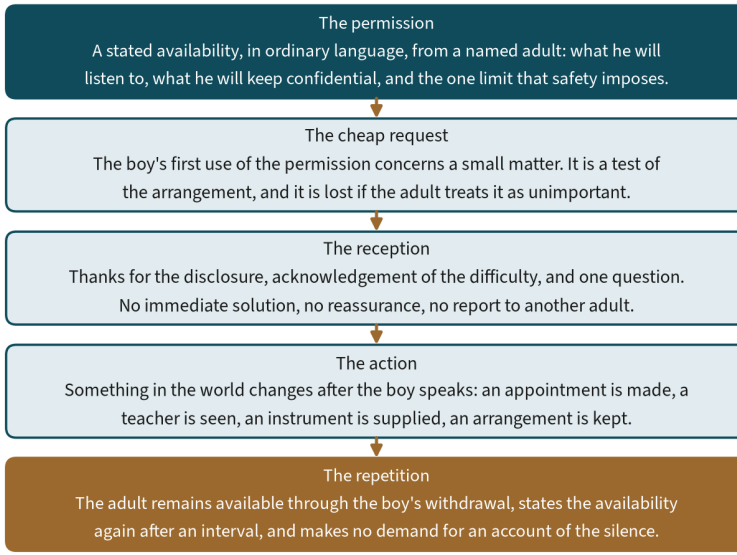
The second is confidentiality. The institution should state what will be kept confidential and what will not, in advance, and it should keep the statement. The finding in the case material is that boys frequently do not disclose because they cannot predict what will be reported, and that the prediction is more important than the promise.

The third is competence. The named person should be trained, supervised, and supported. An untrained adult with good intentions is frequently placed in a position where a boy's disclosure exceeds his capacity, and the outcome is frequently worse than no disclosure, because the boy's experience of the arrangement is the adult's alarm.

The fourth is the follow-through. The institution should record what it did after a disclosure, review it, and adjust the arrangement. The feature is the one

that distinguishes a service from a policy, and it is the one that the case material finds most frequently absent.

The section's material is summarised in Figure 43.1, which states the conditions and the process as a single sequence.



The sequence fails at the point where any condition is omitted. The most frequent failures are the cheap request dismissed as trivial and the action that never follows.

{width:88%}

43.7 Creating Emotionally Supportive Communities

The previous section supplied the individual and institutional conditions for help-seeking. This section turns to the community, because the individual boy is never conducting his development in isolation, and because the community determines whether the conditions that a household establishes survive the boy's adolescence.

The section's subject is therefore not a campaign, an awareness day, or a slogan. It is the design of the ordinary arrangements through which a community conducts its business, and the specific question of whether those arrangements permit a boy to speak.

The section proceeds in three parts: the five institutions that constitute a community's emotional curriculum; the six design principles that the case material supports; and an illustrative account of a community that conducted the design.

The Five Institutions

Institution One: The Household. The household is the first institution and the one with the greatest influence, and its design is the material of Section 43.3. Its specific features are the vocabulary, the allocation of attention, the treatment of the adults' states, and the repair.

Institution Two: The School. The school is the institution through which a boy's peer group is most frequently constituted, and it therefore has the greatest influence on the enforcement of the propositions described in Section 43.4. Its design features are the classroom's response to error, the presence of a named adult, the curriculum's treatment of emotion, and the school's response to a disclosure.

Institution Three: The Workplace, the Workshop, and the Trade. For the young man of sixteen and above, the workplace conducts a curriculum that the household and the school no longer control. Its design features are the supervisor's conduct in the presence of difficulty, the workplace's response to error, the availability of the professional route, and the ordinary conversation of the trade, which is frequently the most powerful enforcement of the propositions in a young man's life.

Institution Four: The Association and the Community Body. The association — the trade association, the cooperative, the residents' body, the alumni group, the sports club, the social club — conducts a curriculum through its meetings, its ceremonies, its language, and its account of its members. Its design features are the language of its proceedings, the conduct of its officers, the response to a member's difficulty, and the arrangements it supplies at the moments of loss that the case material of Part VIII describes.

Institution Five: The Peer Group. The peer group is not an institution in the formal sense, and it is the most powerful of the five for the boy between roughly twelve and twenty. Its design is conducted indirectly, through the settings in which it forms and the adults who supervise those settings, and its features are the currency of its standing, the treatment of a member's disclosure, and the presence of at least one member who conducts a different standard.

The reader should note that these five institutions overlap and that a boy's conduct is determined by the combination. A household that establishes the conditions of Section 43.6 and a peer group that punishes their use will produce a boy who speaks at home and nowhere else, and the adult form of that position is the material of Chapter 18.4′s compartmentalisation. The community's task is therefore not the improvement of one institution. It is the alignment of the five, and the alignment is conducted over years.

The Six Design Principles

The case material and the practice literature support six principles, and each one is stated with the specific arrangement that conducts it.

Principle One: The permission is stated in the community's own language. A community's language is the medium through which its permissions are transmitted, and a permission stated in the language of a campaign will frequently be received as external. The principle's conduct is the community's own vocabulary, used by its own officers, in its own settings: the phrase in the local language that a father uses to his son, the proverb that the association's chairman cites at the meeting, the sentence that the coach uses at the end of training. The finding in the case material is that the community's own language is more effective than any imported formulation, and that it is frequently available already, since most communities possess a vocabulary for endurance and a smaller but existing vocabulary for shared difficulty.

Principle Two: A named person is available in each institution. The principle is the community form of Section 43.6′s first condition. Every institution should have a person who is known, available, and trained, and the person should be named in ordinary communication rather than in a policy document. The finding in the case material is that the named person is the single most effective element in a community's arrangement, and that it costs less than any other element.

Principle Three: The arrangements are routine rather than occasional. A community that conducts a programme once a year conducts an event. A community that conducts its arrangements weekly conducts a culture. The principle's conduct is the routine: the ten minutes at the start of the association's meeting at which members report; the weekly conversation at the workshop; the termly assembly at the school; the monthly household conversation described in Section 43.8.

Principle Four: The community supplies settings in which boys form peer groups of a different kind. The principle addresses the enforcement described in Section 43.4. The settings are ordinary: the team, the club, the choir, the workshop's apprentice group, the reading group, the volunteering arrangement. The design requirement is that the setting should have an adult who conducts the standard, a currency of standing that is not dominance, and at least one occasion on which members speak about difficulty. The finding in the case material is that the setting's effect is substantial and that it is frequently produced by a single adult's conduct over a single season.

Principle Five: The community's leaders conduct the material in public. The principle is the community form of the modelling channel, and it is the one that communities most frequently omit. The leader's disclosure should be

proportionate, should be followed by action, and should be conducted in the leader's ordinary setting. The finding in the case material is that a single proportionate disclosure by a respected man — a chairman, a coach, a head teacher, a senior colleague — changes the community's permission more than a year of programming, and that the disclosure's effect depends on its being followed by the leader's visible action.

Principle Six: The community's arrangements survive the individual who established them. The principle is the one that determines whether the work endures. The arrangements should be written into the institution's ordinary practice, attached to a role rather than a person, reviewed annually, and supplied with the resources they require. The finding in the case material is that community programmes frequently end when their founder leaves, and that the arrangements which survive are the ones that were built into the institution's routine before the founder's departure.

The Community's Specific Difficulties

The section states four difficulties that the case material records, because the reader who attempts this work will meet them and will otherwise interpret them as failure.

The first difficulty is the fear of imported agendas. Communities frequently receive emotional programmes as an external criticism of their culture, and the reception is frequently accurate, since many programmes are designed elsewhere and conducted in a language that the community does not use. The remedy is Principle One: the work should be conducted in the community's own terms, by the community's own people, and should be presented as the recovery of something the community already possesses rather than as the importation of something it lacks.

The second difficulty is the exposure of the first person who speaks. The first man who discloses in a community bears a cost that the later members do not, and the cost is frequently the material of Chapter 26′s betrayal. The remedy is the protection of the first person: the leader's explicit support, the community's stated norms, and the absence of any arrangement that makes the disclosure the community's material. The finding in the case material is that communities which fail to protect the first person do not produce a second.

The third difficulty is the substitution of the programme for the arrangement. A community that has conducted a workshop frequently believes that it has conducted the work, and the belief is the most common failure in the practice literature. The remedy is Principle Three and Principle Six: the routine and the institution, rather than the event.

The fourth difficulty is the professional boundary. A community arrangement is not a clinical service, and the case material records harm where untrained members conducted material that exceeded their competence. The remedy is the professional route: a stated referral arrangement, a trained named person, and the community's explicit acknowledgement of its limits. The material of Chapter 35.6 and Appendix Q applies.

An Illustrative Account: The Association That Changed Its Meetings

The section closes with an account that is composite and illustrative, constructed from the case material and presented as an example rather than as a report of a particular body.

A trade association in a mid-sized town had, for eleven years, conducted its monthly meeting in the same form: the chairman's opening, the reading of the minutes, the financial report, the old business, the new business, and the closing. Its membership was approximately ninety, most of them men between thirty-five and sixty, and its ordinary conversation concerned contracts, prices, and the conduct of competitors.

In the year of the account, two of its members died within four months. The first died suddenly; the second, according to the account that circulated afterwards, had been unwell for a year and had told nobody. At the meeting that followed, the chairman departed from the agenda and spoke for four minutes. He stated that he had known the second member for twenty years, that he had not known he was unwell, and that he had been asking himself what in the association's arrangements had made it easier for a man to conduct a year of illness alone than to mention it at a meeting. He did not answer the question. He proposed one change: that the meeting should begin with ten minutes in which any member could report on any matter, personal or professional, with the assurance that nothing reported would be minuted.

The change was adopted, and its first three months were difficult. In the first month, nobody spoke. In the second, a member reported a difficulty with a bank facility, and the association's ordinary business resumed. In the third, a member stated that his wife had been unwell for six months and that he had not known how to say so. The association's response was not therapeutic and it was specific: two members who had experience of the hospital's arrangements spoke to him afterwards; the association's welfare officer made an appointment with him; and the ten minutes continued.

At the end of the year, the association's account of the change was recorded in the case material in three statements by its members. The first: *nothing has changed in the business, and the meetings are longer.* The second: *I know three things about my colleagues that I did not know, and I am less alone in this town.*

The third, from the chairman: *the ten minutes cost us nothing, and it is the only part of the meeting that anybody remembers.*

The account is presented because it illustrates the section's principles in their ordinary form. The permission was stated in the community's language. The named person existed already, in the welfare officer, and was used. The arrangement was routine rather than occasional. The leader conducted a proportionate disclosure and followed it with an action. The arrangement was attached to the meeting rather than to the chairman. And the community's limits were acknowledged, since the association referred its member to a professional and did not attempt to conduct his position itself.

The reader should note what the account does not contain. It contains no campaign, no slogan, no external programme, and no claim that the association had solved the problem. It contains a change in an agenda and a decision by a chairman. The case material's finding is that this is the ordinary form of the work, and that the extraordinary forms — the national programme, the awareness campaign, the public figure's testimony — are effective in proportion to the number of ordinary forms that accompany them.

43.8 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Learned to Speak in Front of His Son

The case is composite and illustrative. It is constructed from the case material of this book and is presented as an example of the chapter's material rather than as a report of a particular person.

The Presenting Event

Segun Alabi was forty-six years old and had been the production manager of a food-processing plant for nine years. He was married to Funke, a pharmacist, and he had two children: Damilare, thirteen, and Moyosore, nine.

The event that began the case was a telephone call from Damilare's form teacher. The teacher's account was specific. Damilare had stopped answering questions in class. His written work was unchanged and his marks had not fallen, which was the reason the school had not called earlier. He had withdrawn from the football team without stating a reason. He had been found, twice, sitting in the corridor during the break rather than in the yard. The teacher's question was whether anything had happened at home.

Segun's first response was the one the reader will recognise. He conducted a review of the household's recent months and found nothing: no bereavement, no financial difficulty, no illness, no dispute. He then conducted a review of Damilare's conduct and found a set of small changes that he had observed and had not registered: the boy had stopped asking to be taken to his cousin's house; he had

begun going to bed early and sleeping badly; he had stopped reporting anything about school; and he had begun answering every question with the word *fine*.

The last observation produced the case's first difficulty, because Segun recognised the word. It was his own.

The Household's History

Segun's father had been a quantity surveyor in a state ministry. In the year Segun was fifteen, his father had been implicated in a procurement irregularity that he had not committed, and had been suspended. The household had conducted the period in complete silence. Segun's father had left the house at the usual hour each morning and returned at the usual hour each evening, and he had not told his wife or his children what had happened. Segun had learned the facts eighteen months later, from a cousin.

His father had been reinstated, and had died six years afterwards of a stroke at the age of fifty-eight. At the funeral, the household's account of him was that he had been a strong man who had carried a great deal and had never complained. Segun had repeated the account for twenty years. In the week of the teacher's call, he found himself unable to repeat it without hearing the sentence differently: *he never complained, and nobody knew what he was carrying, and he died at fifty-eight.*

Segun's own conduct had reproduced the pattern with a precision that he had not examined. He had concealed a period of unemployment at thirty-two. He had concealed a hypertension diagnosis at forty-one for eight months. He had conducted the household's finances alone, on the principle that Funke should not be burdened. He had not told his wife about the suspension he had received at forty-four following a dispute with a supplier, and he had conducted the resulting reduction in his standing at the plant without stating it at home.

His account of these concealments, given later, was the one this book has recorded in Chapters 42 and 41: *I did not want to add to what they were carrying.* The account was sincere, and the case's finding is that it was also the mechanism by which his son had learned that a difficulty is a thing a man conducts alone.

The First Attempts and Their Failure

Segun's first attempt followed the pattern that Section 43.4′s practices describe. He told Damilare that he could talk to him about anything. He asked, at intervals, whether anything was wrong. He received the word *fine* on each occasion, and he interpreted the word as evidence that nothing was wrong.

The second attempt was an interrogation. He asked Damilare, on a Saturday morning, what had happened at school. The boy stated that nothing had happened. Segun stated that the teacher had called. The boy stated that the teacher was mistaken. Segun's response was an increase in volume, and the exchange

ended with the boy leaving the room and Segun conducting a two-hour review of his son's ingratitude.

The third attempt was conducted by Funke, who spoke to Damilare for forty minutes and reported that he had said very little and had cried once and had asked her not to tell his father. The report produced the case's second difficulty, which was Segun's shame: his son had identified him as the party from whom the material had to be concealed.

The finding that the case records at this point is important and should be stated plainly. **Segun's three attempts were not failures of technique. They were the household's curriculum operating exactly as it had been transmitted.** The household's permission had been stated in words and contradicted by the father's conduct for thirteen years, and the boy had learned the conduct. No sentence that Segun could speak in a Saturday morning conversation was going to outweigh thirteen years of demonstration.

The Turning Point

The turning point was not a conversation with Damilare. It was an event at the plant.

In the sixth month of the case, Segun approved a production change that resulted in a batch of approximately four hundred thousand naira of product being condemned. The error was his. He conducted the following two weeks in the pattern of Chapter 42: he prepared an account that attributed the loss to a supplier's specification, he delayed the report, and he conducted the plant's morning meetings with the vigilance that the position required.

On the fourteenth day, he stated the position to his production supervisor, in full, with the figure and with his own responsibility. The supervisor's response was not the response Segun had predicted. He stated that the loss was recoverable, that the specification would be changed, and that he was relieved to have the accurate position. He then asked Segun a question that Segun had not anticipated: *why did you wait two weeks?*

Segun's answer, given in the supervisor's office, was the case's turning point. He said: *because I did not know how to say that I had got it wrong without it meaning that I was finished.*

He went home that evening and conducted the same statement in his household. He stated the error, the figure, and his responsibility, in the presence of Funke and both children. He stated that he had concealed it for two weeks and that he had been afraid. He stated that he had been wrong to conceal it, and he stated what he had done to correct it.

The statement took four minutes. The case's record of the household's response is specific. Funke asked two questions about the correction and then

stated that she was glad he had told her. Moyosore, who was nine, asked whether they would have to leave the house, and was told that they would not. Damilare said nothing during the statement and, at the end, asked whether his father had been afraid of losing his job. Segun said yes. The boy nodded and left the room.

The case's finding is that the four minutes did more than the three preceding months of attempts. The finding is consistent with Section 43.1′s first channel: the boy had observed his father conduct a difficulty, state it, repair it, and survive it, and the observation was the curriculum.

The Programme

Segun conducted a programme over the following nine months. It is described here in the form in which the case material records it, because the reader will find it more useful than a set of principles.

The first component was the household's ten minutes. The household began a practice of ten minutes on Sunday evening, after the evening meal, in which each member stated one thing about the week that had been difficult and one thing that had been good. The rule was that no member's statement was to be commented on, advised on, or reported outside the household. The practice was conducted for nine months, and it was missed on four occasions.

The second component was the vocabulary. Segun and Funke conducted a deliberate change in the household's language. The word *fine* was replaced, where it was inaccurate, with a more precise word, and the parents conducted the replacement in their own statements first. The household's working list, written on a card in the kitchen, contained eleven words: tired, worried, ashamed, disappointed, angry, frightened, lonely, relieved, embarrassed, overwhelmed, and sad.

The third component was the father's own practice. Segun conducted three statements of his own difficulty in the nine months, each of them brief and proportionate. The first was the statement of the plant's error. The second was a statement, in the fifth month, that he had been to the clinic and that his blood pressure was being treated. The third was a statement, in the eighth month, that he had been afraid that Damilare's withdrawal was his own fault. The third statement was the one that the case material records as the most significant, because it supplied the boy with the sentence he had not been able to supply for himself: *my father thinks it might be his fault, and he has said so.*

The fourth component was the named person. Segun identified a party outside the household to whom Damilare could speak: a family friend, Mr. Nwachukwu, a widower of sixty-one who repaired radios in a shop near the school and who had known Segun since his own apprenticeship. The arrangement was stated to Damilare in the language of Section 43.6′s script, and Damilare used it in the fourth month. The case material does not record what was said

in the shop, and it records that the boy returned from the shop on four further occasions.

The fifth component was the school. Segun met the form teacher and the school's guidance counsellor, stated the position accurately, and asked for two things: that Damilare should be given a named adult in the school, and that the school should not conduct any arrangement that identified him to his peers as a case. The school supplied both. The teacher's report in the seventh month recorded that Damilare had begun answering questions again, and that his answers were shorter than before and accurate.

The sixth component was the setting. Segun enrolled Damilare in a Saturday workshop at the plant, where he spent three hours each week with the maintenance team under a supervisor named Mr. Bello. The choice was deliberate. The workshop supplied the boy with a setting in which competence was demonstrated, error was corrected, and a limit could be admitted, and it supplied him with three young men between eighteen and twenty-two whose ordinary conversation was less governed by the propositions of Section 43.4 than his school's peer group. The case material records that Damilare's first statement of a difficulty to his father, in the seventh month, concerned a mistake he had made at the workshop and had been afraid to report. Segun's response was the one he had rehearsed: *thank you for telling me; what would help?*

The Outcome and Its Measure

The case's outcome is stated with the restraint that the material requires. Damilare did not become a boy who spoke about everything. He became a boy who could state a difficulty to two parties, and who had begun to distinguish between the states that he had previously conducted as *fine*.

The case material records four measures.

The first is the household's own count: in the nine months, Damilare made eleven statements of difficulty to his parents, of which four concerned school, three concerned the workshop, two concerned a peer, and two concerned his own states without an external cause. The count before the programme was zero.

The second is the school's report: attendance at the football team resumed in the eighth month, and the teacher's report recorded that the boy had begun to ask questions in class.

The third is the boy's own statement, recorded at the end of the nine months: *I used to think that if I said something, it would make it worse for everybody. Now I say it and it is usually not as bad as I thought.*

The fourth is the father's measure, which the case material treats as the most significant. Segun recorded, at the end of the nine months, that he had conducted three disclosures of his own that he would not have conducted before the case;

that he had begun treatment for his blood pressure; that Funke had become a party to the household's accounts; and that he had begun to conduct the plant's morning meeting differently, in a specific and observable respect: he had begun to state his own errors at the meeting rather than conducting them privately.

The case's finding is that the father's change was the programme's principal component, and that the components which the reader will find most attractive — the vocabulary card, the Sunday ten minutes, the workshop — were effective because they were conducted by a man whose own conduct had changed. The finding is the chapter's central claim in its case form.

The Relapse

The case material records a relapse in the fourteenth month, and it is included because a case that records only the improvement is not useful to the reader.

In the fourteenth month, Segun's plant conducted a restructuring, and his position was changed. He conducted the change in the pattern of Chapter 42 for eleven days: he stated nothing at home, he conducted the household's arrangements from the previous position, and he slept badly. On the twelfth day, Funke asked him what was wrong, and he stated that nothing was wrong.

Damilare, who was then fourteen, stated at the Sunday ten minutes that his father had been *doing the thing he said he used to do*. The statement was made without accusation, in the household's ordinary form, and it produced the case's most important exchange. Segun stated that the boy was right, that he had been conducting the change alone, and that he had been afraid. The household then conducted the change as a household: Funke stated the household's expenditure, Segun stated the new income, and the three of them conducted a set of reductions over the following month.

The case's finding on the relapse is stated as the chapter's closing claim about transmission. **The boy had learned the curriculum well enough to identify its interruption in his father, and the household had learned it well enough to conduct the interruption as a household rather than as a failure.** The pattern was not abolished. It was made visible, and the visibility was the change.

43.9 The Programme

The section supplies the programme in a form that the reader can conduct, in three settings: the household, the school or workshop, and the community. It is deliberately small, because Section 43.7′s finding is that the ordinary arrangement is more effective than the extraordinary one.

The Household Programme

Element	Conduct	Frequency	Measure
The ten minutes	Each member states one difficulty and one good thing; no advice, no reporting	Weekly	Whether it was conducted; the number of members who spoke
The vocabulary	The household's card of state words, used by the adults first	Daily	The number of precise words used in a week; the reduction of *fine*
The adult's statement	One proportionate statement of the adult's own difficulty, followed by action	Monthly	The statement made; the action taken
The repair	The adult's acknowledgement of a specific act, its effect, and the repair	As required	The repair completed; the boy's observation of it
The named person	One adult outside the household, stated and available	Stated quarterly	Whether the boy can name the person; whether he has used the arrangement
The rehearsal	One competence rehearsed in low stakes	Weekly	The competence conducted without prompting
The application	One competence conducted in real stakes, with the adult available	Monthly	The boy's report of what happened

The School and Workshop Programme

The institutional programme has five elements, and each one is attached to a role rather than to a person.

The first is the named adult. Every boy should be able to name an adult in the institution. The role is stated in the institution's ordinary communication, the adult is trained, and the arrangement is reviewed each term.

The second is the classroom's response to error. The institution should state and conduct a standard: error is information, it is corrected, and it is not punished by ridicule. The standard is conducted by the teachers' own practice, and it is measured by the boys' willingness to attempt.

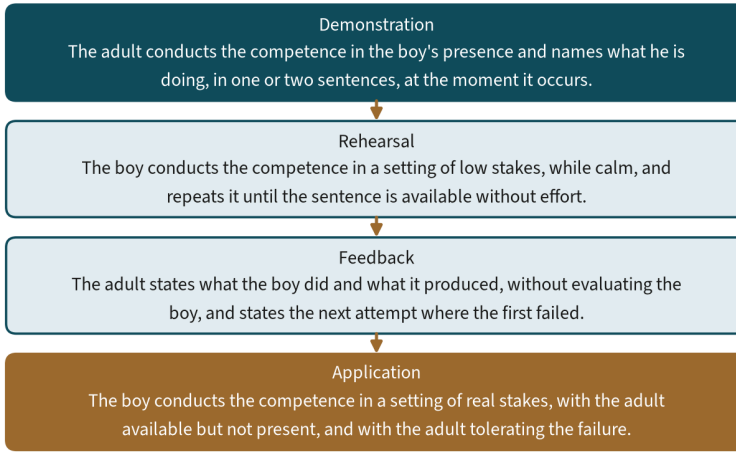
The third is the curriculum's ordinary inclusion of difficulty. Each subject supplies one occasion per term on which the private cost of a public matter is examined: the scientist's failure, the character's fear, the statesman's grief, the engineer's correction. The occasion is not a lesson on emotions. It is a lesson in the subject that includes the material.

The fourth is the setting. The institution should supply at least one setting in which a boy's capacities are useful and his standing is not conducted by dominance: the workshop, the team, the choir, the committee, the repair group.

The fifth is the disclosure's conduct. The institution should have a stated process for a disclosure: the named person, the confidentiality statement, the professional route, the follow-through, and the review. The process should be tested once a year with a scenario, in the way that a fire procedure is tested.

The Four-Stage Method

The teaching method is summarised in Figure 43.2. The figure states the four stages and the failure that each stage prevents.



The method is an apprenticeship, not a lesson. Omission of rehearsal produces a boy who can recite the vocabulary; omission of application produces a boy who can use it only in the adult's presence.

{width:86%}

The Community Programme

The community programme is the six principles of Section 43.7 attached to the five institutions, and it is conducted in the following order.

The first step is the audit. The reader should establish which of the five institutions in his community already possess the five features of Section 43.3's closing material: a vocabulary, a permission, a response, an observed consequence, and a repetition. The audit is conducted by asking five questions of each institution, and it takes an afternoon.

The second step is the named person. The cheapest and most effective intervention in any institution is the appointment of a trained, known, available person. The reader should establish whether such a person exists and, where he does not, propose the role at the institution's next ordinary meeting.

The third step is the leader's disclosure. The reader should identify one respected person in the institution who is willing to conduct a proportionate

disclosure followed by an action. The disclosure need not be dramatic and should not be conducted as a testimony.

The fourth step is the routine. The institution should adopt one recurring arrangement: ten minutes at the meeting, a termly assembly, a weekly conversation at the workshop. The arrangement should be attached to the agenda rather than to a person.

The fifth step is the review. The institution should review the arrangement annually, record what it did after a disclosure, and adjust. The review is the feature that distinguishes the arrangement from a gesture.

The Measures

The programme's measures are stated because the reader will otherwise evaluate it by his impression, and the case material's finding is that impressions are unreliable in this material.

Measure One: The boy's vocabulary. The number of precise state words the boy uses without prompting, recorded over a week.

Measure Two: The boy's statements. The number of statements of difficulty the boy makes to a party who has a right to know, recorded over a month, together with the party and the response.

Measure Three: The boy's askings. The number of specific requests for an instrument, recorded over a month.

Measure Four: The boy's repairs. The number of occasions on which the boy acknowledges an act, states its effect, and conducts a repair.

Measure Five: The adult's own conduct. The number of the adult's own statements, repairs, and askings conducted in the boy's observation, recorded over a month. The measure is the programme's leading indicator, and the case material's finding is that the other four follow it.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE

Exercise 43: The Curriculum Audit and the Thirty-Day Conduct Plan

The exercise has four parts. It should be conducted in writing, and it should be conducted over two sittings rather than one.

Part One: The boys in your observation. List every boy and young man between the ages of five and twenty-two whose conduct you can observe: sons, nephews, students, apprentices, neighbours, members of your association, younger colleagues. For each, record four items: his age; the adult he would go to if he were in difficulty, if you know it; the last occasion on which you observed him state a difficulty; and the channel of Section 43.1 through which you have most influence on him. Where you cannot complete an item, record the fact that you cannot.

Part Two: The audit of one institution. Choose one institution in which you have standing: your household, your school, your workshop, your association, your

team. Answer the five questions of Section 43.3′s closing material, with evidence rather than impression. (1) What vocabulary does the institution supply? (2) What permission does it state, in whose name, and in what words? (3) What was the response to the last disclosure, and what did it teach? (4) What consequence can a boy observe in the institution: a repair, a disclosure, an admission of a limit? (5) Where is the repetition, and how often does it occur? Record a score of zero to five, and record the weakest feature.

Part Three: The adult's own audit. Record, for the last thirty days: the number of occasions on which you stated a difficulty to a party who had a right to know; the number of occasions on which you conducted a repair; the number of occasions on which you asked for a specific instrument; the number of occasions on which you admitted a limit in a boy's observation; and the number of occasions on which you said *fine* when it was inaccurate. The counts are the curriculum your boys are receiving.

Part Four: The thirty-day plan. Write four commitments, each with a date, a party, and a measure. (1) The statement: one proportionate statement of your own difficulty, in the presence of a named boy, followed by an action. (2) The permission: the statement of availability to one boy, in the language of Section 43.6′s script, with the confidentiality statement. (3) The rehearsal: one competence rehearsed with a boy in low stakes, at a stated time. (4) The institution: one proposal to one institution, at its next ordinary meeting, for a named person or a recurring arrangement. At the end of thirty days, record what was conducted, what was not, and what the boy did in response. Bring the record to the next thirty days.

43.10 Questions Readers Ask

The questions below are the ones the case material records most frequently, together with the answers that the chapter's material supports.

"I did not receive this from my father. Am I able to teach it?"

The question is the most common in the case material and the answer is yes, with one condition. The condition is that the reader conducts the material on himself first, because the teaching is conducted by observation and a man cannot demonstrate a competence he has not begun to acquire. The sequence is not *learn it and then teach it*. It is *begin it and teach it while beginning*, which is the more honest arrangement and, according to the case material, the more effective one, since the boy observes an adult acquiring a competence rather than an adult possessing one.

The reader should note a specific finding. Men who did not receive the curriculum from their fathers frequently teach it better than men who did, for a reason the case material records: they are aware of what they are doing, they do not assume the material is obvious, and their own work is visible. The finding does not depend on the reader's history. It depends on his conduct in the present.

"My son is already fifteen and has learned the pattern. Is it too late?"

It is late, and the material does not pretend otherwise. The propositions of Section 43.4 are most efficiently removed before adolescence, and a boy of fifteen has conducted them for a decade.

The material's finding is that the change remains available, and that its mechanism is different at fifteen from what it is at five. At fifteen, the boy's principal audience is his peer group, and the household's instruction has less influence than the boy's observation of a man he respects. The specific practices at this age are: the father's own visible conduct, conducted without commentary; one adult outside the household who is not the father and who is not a formal authority; the setting in which the boy's competence is real; and the repair, which at fifteen is frequently the single act that changes the relationship. The case material records substantial changes in boys of sixteen and seventeen, and it records that the changes followed the father's own disclosure more reliably than any conversation the father constructed.

"My wife says I am too soft with him. Am I?"

The question contains the assumption that the curriculum of this chapter is a reduction of standards. The assumption is incorrect, and the reader should examine the specific concern rather than the label.

The material's position is that the curriculum is more demanding than silence, not less. It requires the boy to name what he feels, to regulate it, to state it to a party who has a right to know, to repair what he damages, and to ask for what he requires. Each of these is a discipline, and each is harder than the alternative. The boy who is permitted to express everything without regulation has not been taught the curriculum; he has been taught a different failure.

The specific distinction to put to the concern is this: **the curriculum does not remove the boy's obligations. It supplies him with the instruments for conducting them.** If the concern is that the boy is being excused from work, from responsibility, or from respect for others, the concern is legitimate and the material agrees with it. If the concern is that the boy is being permitted to have feelings, the concern is answered by Section 43.5′s third competence, which is the discipline of conducting a state rather than being governed by it.

"I am not his father. Is it my place?"

It is your place if you are one of the adults in his observation, and Section 43.2′s material establishes that a single adult outside the household is frequently decisive. The limits are specific and should be kept: you are not the boy's parent, you do not conduct the household's decisions, you do not report the boy's material to his parents without his agreement except where safety requires it, and you do not conduct the relationship as therapy.

The practice is the one Section 43.2 describes: a stated availability, in ordinary language; a reliable presence; a response that is not scandalised; and a relationship that continues after the disclosure. The case material's finding is that the party who supplies this is frequently an uncle, a teacher, a coach, an artisan, a neighbour, or a colleague of the boy's father, and that the party's formal qualifications are irrelevant to the effect.

"He told me something serious. What do I do now?"

The first act is to receive it well, which is Section 43.6′s reception: thanks, acknowledgement, and a question. The second act is to establish what the boy requires: *what would help?* The third is to state your limits honestly, and to identify the professional route where the material exceeds them.

The material of Chapters 35 and 36 and Appendix Q applies. Four situations require an immediate professional route rather than a household arrangement: any indication of risk to the boy's life; any indication of abuse or harm by an adult; any indication of a disorder that is affecting the boy's functioning; and any disclosure that exceeds your competence. In these situations the boy should be told, in advance and in plain language, what you will do and why, and the arrangement should be conducted with him rather than to him.

The finding that matters for the reader's confidence is this: **the boy's disclosure is not made fragile by your honesty about your limits. It is made fragile by your pretence that you have none.** The adult who says *I do not know how to help with this part, and I know who does, and I will go with you* has conducted the fifth competence in the boy's observation.

"What if the school or the community punishes him for speaking?"

Then the arrangement must be conducted where it is safe, and the enforcement must be addressed separately. The material of Section 43.4′s third location and Section 43.7′s fourth difficulty applies. The boy should not be advised to disclose in a setting that will punish him, because the advice would be a repetition of the pattern the chapter describes: an adult recommending a course of conduct whose cost the adult does not bear.

The specific practices are: identify one safe party and one safe setting; conduct the disclosure there; protect the boy's material from the institution until the institution's response is known; and address the institution's enforcement through the ordinary means available to you, which are frequently slow and occasionally effective.

"I am a teacher with a hundred and twenty boys. What can one adult do?"

Three things, and the case material's finding is that they are not small.

The first is to be the named adult for the boys who choose you, which requires only that you state the availability and respond well once.

The second is to conduct the classroom's standard: error is information, it is corrected, and it is not punished by ridicule. The standard is conducted by your own practice, and it is measured by the boys' willingness to attempt.

The third is to conduct one repair, one disclosure, or one admission of a limit in the boys' observation each term. The acts are brief and their effect is disproportionate, because they supply the boys with the counter-example that Section 43.4′s fifth practice requires.

"Our community considers this a Western import. How do I answer that?"

The answer is not a defence of the material's origin. It is a demonstration that the community already possesses the material, which Section 43.7′s first principle requires.

The specific answer has three parts. The first is that the community's own traditions contain arrangements for shared difficulty: the gathering after a death, the delegation that visits a bereaved household, the elder who is sent to speak with a man who has lost his position, the association that contributes at a member's occasion. The second is that the material of this chapter is an account of how those arrangements work and why they are effective, stated in the language of the present. The third is that the community's own vocabulary is more effective than any imported formulation, and that the work should be conducted in that vocabulary by the community's own people.

The finding in the case material is that communities which conduct the work in their own terms produce arrangements that endure, and that communities which import a programme produce an event that ends. The distinction is the section's practical answer to the objection.

"What if I conduct all of this and my son still does not speak to me?"

Then the material has been conducted and the outcome is not yours to determine. The case material records three findings for this position.

The first is that the curriculum's effect is frequently delayed. Boys who received a father's disclosure at thirteen have reported its effect at twenty-five, and the father in the interval frequently believed that nothing had been transmitted.

The second is that the curriculum's effect is frequently conducted through the boy's later relationships rather than through the relationship with the father. The boy who learned that a difficulty can be stated may state it first to a wife, a friend, or a colleague, and the father may never observe the result.

The third is that the father's own conduct remains the correct conduct independently of its reception. The material of Chapter 40′s permissions applies here in its household form: the father's work is his own, and its value is not computed by the boy's response. A man who conducts the curriculum in order to produce

a grateful son has made the curriculum into a transaction, and the boy will detect the transaction with precision.

43.11 Chapter Summary

Chapter 43 in brief. The patterns of this book are transmitted rather than invented, and the transmission has four channels: modelling, instruction, reinforcement and punishment, and the observation of consequence. The channel of consequence is the most influential and the least addressed; the channel of reinforcement is the most rapid and the most reversible; the channel of modelling is the most durable and the slowest; and the channel of instruction is the least influential and the easiest to mistake for the whole. Where instruction contradicts conduct, conduct prevails, and the boy learns the contradiction itself.

What is transmitted is not the adult's intention but five lessons: that an unexpressed state does not exist; that expression is a request and a request is a debt; that the audience determines the permitted content; that the cost of expression is paid by the person who expresses; and that the position is the man. The five lessons are the exact inverse of the four competences of Chapter 39.4, which is why the adult's work in Parts X and XI and the boy's curriculum are the same work at different points in the life course.

The institutions that transmit are the household, the school, the workplace, the association, and the peer group, and they share five features: a vocabulary, a permission, a response, an observed consequence, and a repetition. A single adult outside the household is frequently decisive, and the finding is specific: one adult is generally sufficient, provided that he is reliably present, is not scandalised by what the boy reports, keeps the boy's confidence, and continues the relationship after the disclosure.

The five harmful propositions are that endurance is the whole of strength, that expression is weakness, that dominance is authority, that sexual conquest is proof of worth, and that violence is the resolution of insult. Each converts a legitimate obligation into a rule that requires the boy to suppress a part of himself or to reduce another person. They are enforced in the peer group, in entertainment, in language, in the institutions, and in the household's own arrangements. The practice of challenge has six forms: name the proposition rather than the person; supply the alternative at the moment of the challenge; separate the act from the identity; correct the language in the moment and without a lecture; conduct the counter-example; and protect the boy who deviates.

The six competences are the naming of the state, the location of the state in the body and the day, the regulation of the state, the statement of the state to a party who has a right to know, the repair, and the asking for a specific instrument. They are cumulative, and the curriculum begins with the vocabulary rather than with

the asking. They are taught by the four-stage method of demonstration, rehearsal, feedback, and application, and the method fails most frequently at rehearsal and at application. The adult's own practice is the curriculum's first and most durable component, and the adult's repair is more valuable than the adult's perfection.

Help-seeking is produced by five conditions: a stated permission from a named person, in ordinary language; a low-cost first request received well; a response that is attentive, unhurried, and non-punitive; an action that follows; and a repetition that survives the boy's withdrawal. The conditions are supplied by individuals and by institutions, and the institution's design has four features: access, confidentiality, competence, and follow-through.

The community's work is conducted through six principles: the permission stated in the community's own language; a named person in each institution; arrangements that are routine rather than occasional; settings in which boys form peer groups of a different kind; leaders who conduct the material in public; and arrangements that survive the individual who established them. The work's measures are the boy's vocabulary, his statements, his askings, his repairs, and the adult's own conduct, which is the leading indicator.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The chapter's central claim. A man's silence is not a private inheritance. It is a curriculum, conducted by identifiable institutions, through identifiable channels, over identifiable years, and it can be replaced by a different curriculum conducted by the same institutions. The replacement does not require a programme, a campaign, or a qualification. It requires an adult whose conduct is legible, a vocabulary, a permission, a response, an observed repair, and a repetition. The reader who supplies these to one boy has interrupted the transmission for that boy and, through him, for the household he will conduct.

Reflection Questions

1. Which of the four channels was strongest in your own upbringing, and what specifically did it teach you?
2. What did you learn about the cost of expression, and from which incident?
3. Which of the five lessons of Section 43.2 is still governing your adult conduct, and where does it appear?
4. Who was the single adult, if there was one, to whom you could speak as a boy? What did that adult do that made the arrangement possible?
5. Which of the five harmful propositions do you still enforce, without intending to, in your household or your workplace?
6. Which of the six competences are you least able to conduct in front of a boy, and what does that inability transmit?

7. Complete Part Three of the exercise. What does your conduct over the last thirty days tell a boy about what a man does with difficulty?
8. Which boy in your observation is receiving no curriculum at all, and what is the smallest arrangement you could supply within the next month?
9. What will you do when the boy discloses something that exceeds your competence? Write the sentence you will use before you need it.
10. In five years, what do you want the boys who observed you to be able to say about what a man does with what he carries?

Further Reading

- **On the development of emotional competence:** the research literature on emotional socialisation in childhood and adolescence, including the findings on the role of parental modelling and response, on the development of emotion vocabulary and regulation, and on the longitudinal associations between early emotional competence and adult functioning.
- **On observational learning and modelling:** the established literature on imitation, modelling, and vicarious learning, including the findings on the conditions under which a model's conduct prevails over a model's instruction, and on the effects of observing the consequences of others' conduct.
- **On help-seeking:** the research literature on help-seeking behaviour, including the findings on the barriers to help-seeking among men and boys, on the role of confidentiality and of the first response, and on the design of services that young men use.
- **On gender stereotypes and their enforcement:** the research literature on gender socialisation, stereotype threat, and the enforcement of masculine norms in peer groups, schools, and workplaces, together with the practice literature on programmes that have produced measurable change in boys' attitudes and conduct.
- **On mentoring and youth development:** the research and practice literature on mentoring relationships, including the findings on the characteristics of effective mentors, on the role of a single non-parental adult, and on the risks of poorly designed mentoring arrangements.
- **On school-based and community-based prevention:** the practice literature on whole-school approaches to emotional health, on the design of named-person arrangements, and on the evaluation of community programmes in low- and middle-income settings.
- **Practical resources:** school guidance services; clinical child and adolescent psychology; teacher training and continuing professional development; apprentice and vocational training programmes; and the material in Appendices B, E, G, and S.

44 CHAPTER

The Battles That Make a Man Wiser

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Distinguish between the cost of adversity and the value that can be extracted from it, and state why the two are not the same ledger.
2. Identify the five myths that glorify suffering, and explain the specific harm each one does to a man who is in difficulty.
3. Conduct a structured review of a mistake or a setback, including the attribution of what is his and what is not.
4. Apply the four tests of proportion, and describe the six markers of emotional maturity that the material supports.
5. Convert personal experience into constructive action in three domains, without converting the suffering into his identity.
6. State the five functions of a mentor and the four practices that a mentor must not conduct.
7. Identify the anatomy of bitterness in his own record, and state the exit from it.
8. Construct a personal wisdom account: what a specific difficulty cost, what it taught, and what it has been used for.

Introduction

The previous chapter addressed the transmission of silence to the next generation. This chapter addresses the material that the reader may, with care, transmit instead: the wisdom that a man accumulates by surviving what he has survived.

The chapter's title contains a claim that requires immediate qualification, because the claim is one of the most frequently misused propositions in the literature of manhood and one of the most damaging to the men who believe it. The claim is that battles make a man wiser. The qualification is that **they do not do so automatically, and they frequently do the opposite.**

The case material of this book establishes the qualification with sufficient consistency to state it as a rule. Two men may survive the same event — a business

failure, a betrayal, a bereavement, a period of unemployment, a humiliation in public — and produce opposite outcomes. The first becomes more accurate about the world, more capable in difficulty, more generous with other men who are in it, and more stable in his own estimate of himself. The second becomes more rigid, more suspicious, more isolated, and more convinced that the world is arranged against him. The difference between them is not the severity of what happened. It is what was done with it afterwards, and that is a craft, not a gift.

The chapter's subject is therefore the craft. It proceeds from a distinction that governs everything else in it and that the reader should hold from the first page: **the cost of an event and the value extracted from it are two different ledgers, and neither cancels the other.**

The cost ledger records what the event took: the money, the years, the health, the relationship, the standing, the opportunities, the version of the man's life that would have existed had the event not occurred. The cost is real, it is frequently large, and it is not reduced by anything the man learns afterwards. The case material's finding on this point is important, because the literature of resilience frequently obscures it: **a man who is told that his suffering was worth it because of what he learned has been told something false about the people he lost, the years he spent, and the damage that was done to him.** The value ledger does not repay the cost ledger. It is a separate account, and its entries are available whether or not the cost was deserved, whether or not it was fair, and whether or not anybody acknowledged it.

The value ledger records what the event supplied: information about the world, information about the man himself, the collapse of a false assumption, the discovery of a capacity, the identification of a party who can be relied on and a party who cannot, the reduction of a fear that had been larger than the event, and the acquisition of a competence that no other route would have supplied. These entries are real, they are frequently substantial, and they are not automatic. They are produced by work, and the work is the chapter's subject.

The chapter's approach has five commitments.

The first is that the chapter does not glorify suffering. The distinction between this chapter and the large literature that does glorify it is stated at the outset. The glorification of suffering takes three forms, and all three are addressed in Section 44.1: the claim that difficulty is necessary for character, which is false as a general proposition and cruel as a consolation; the claim that a man should seek difficulty, which is the confusion of a craft with a discipline; and the claim that a man who has suffered is entitled to a status that others lack, which produces the bitterness that Section 44.6 examines. The chapter's position is the inverse of all three: difficulty is common, frequently undeserved, frequently damaging, and

occasionally instructive; the instruction is worth extracting; and the extraction is not a justification of the damage.

The second is that the chapter's unit is the review, not the event. A man cannot choose most of what happens to him. He can choose, to a substantial degree, what he does in the weeks and years afterwards, and the case material's finding is that the choice is exercised through a small number of repeatable practices: the structured review, the attribution, the test of proportion, the conversion of experience into use, and the conduct of the material with another man. These practices are supplied in Sections 44.2 to 44.5, and each one is small enough to conduct in an evening.

The third is that the chapter is written for the man who is still in the difficulty as well as the man who has left it. A great deal of the material on adversity is written retrospectively and is useless to a man who is in the middle of the event. The chapter therefore states where each practice becomes available: the review is available in part from the first week, the attribution from the first month, the proportion test at any time, the conversion after the position has stabilised, and the mentoring after a period that the case material puts at not less than two years.

The fourth is that the chapter's standard of wisdom is practical rather than mystical. The word wisdom is used in this chapter in a specific and testable sense: **wisdom is the capacity to act well in circumstances that are uncertain, unwelcome, and not fully within one's control, on the basis of what one has learned from previous such circumstances.** It is not serenity, it is not detachment, and it is not the absence of distress. It is a competence, it is measurable in a man's conduct, and it is acquired in the way that other competences are acquired.

The fifth is that the chapter's outcome is not a better story about the past. The case material records a specific failure that the reader should avoid: the man who converts his history into a narrative that he tells at occasions, that improves with each retelling, and that leaves his present conduct unchanged. The narrative is not the product. The product is the alteration of what the man does, and Section 44.4 supplies the test for distinguishing the two.

The chapter's sequence follows the outline. Section 44.1 examines adversity and the myths that surround it. Section 44.2 supplies the review of mistakes and setbacks. Section 44.3 addresses perspective and emotional maturity. Section 44.4 addresses the conversion of experience into action. Section 44.5 addresses mentoring. Section 44.6 addresses the choice between growth and bitterness. Section 44.7 presents an illustrative case. Section 44.8 supplies the programme and the exercise.

44.1 Understanding Adversity Without Glorifying Suffering

The section begins with an account of what adversity actually supplies, because the account determines whether the rest of the chapter is conducted honestly.

What Adversity Supplies

Five entries are recorded consistently in the case material, and each one is stated with the condition under which it appears.

Entry One: Accurate information about the world. A man's ordinary arrangements rest on assumptions that are frequently untested: that his income will continue, that his health will hold, that a particular party can be relied on, that a particular institution will behave as it is supposed to, that his competence is sufficient for the demands he will meet. Difficulty tests these assumptions, and the test produces information that ordinary life does not supply. The information is frequently unwelcome and it is frequently accurate.

The condition under which this entry appears: the man must be willing to revise his account. The case material records that men who conduct a difficulty while defending their previous assumptions extract very little from it, since the event's information is treated as an anomaly rather than as evidence. The man who emerges from a business failure believing that the failure was entirely the fault of a customer, a bank, or a competitor has learned nothing about his own exposure, and the same exposure will produce the same failure.

Entry Two: Accurate information about himself. Difficulty supplies a measurement of the man's own capacities that ordinary circumstances do not supply: what he does under pressure, what he does when he is afraid, what he does when he is humiliated, what he does when nobody is watching, how long he can sustain an effort, and where his limit actually lies. The measurement is frequently different from the man's self-estimate in both directions: men discover capacities they did not know they had, and limits they had denied.

The condition: the man must be willing to record the measurement rather than to defend his self-estimate. The practice is supplied in Section 44.2.

Entry Three: The identification of his actual parties. Difficulty conducts a test of the man's relationships, and the results are frequently surprising in both directions. The party he expected to be present is absent; the party he had not counted is present; the colleague who was reliable in ordinary business is absent in difficulty; the acquaintance who had no obligation conducts himself well. The information is among the most valuable the event supplies, and it is the information that men most frequently waste, because the disappointment of the absent party occupies their attention and the presence of the unexpected party is not registered.

The condition: the man must record the parties rather than conducting the disappointment. The practice is supplied in Section 44.8's first table.

Entry Four: The reduction of a fear that was larger than the event. A man frequently carries a fear of an event that has not occurred: the fear of failure, of dismissal, of humiliation, of poverty, of being left. When the event occurs, the fear is frequently replaced by the event's actual demands, and the actual demands are frequently more manageable than the fear was. The finding in the case material is consistent and it is stated carefully: this entry does not make the event desirable, and it does frequently reduce the territory that the fear had occupied.

The condition: the man must distinguish between the event and the fear. A man who conducts the event as confirmation of the fear learns the opposite lesson.

Entry Five: A competence that no other route would have supplied. Certain competences are acquired only in difficulty: the capacity to conduct a negotiation from a position of weakness; the capacity to state a loss to a household; the capacity to work while grieving; the capacity to be corrected in public without collapse; the capacity to conduct a household on a reduced income; the capacity to ask for help. These competences are not taught in ordinary circumstances, because ordinary circumstances do not require them.

The condition: the man must conduct the competence deliberately rather than merely surviving the circumstance. The distinction is the chapter's central mechanical point and it is developed in Section 44.4.

What Adversity Does Not Supply

The section now states what adversity does not supply, because the myths that surround it consist almost entirely of attributing these things to it.

Adversity does not supply meaning. An event has no meaning in itself, and the meaning a man assigns to it is a construction. The construction is necessary and it is not automatic: a man who assigns the meaning *I am finished* will conduct himself accordingly, and a man who assigns the meaning *this has cost me a great deal and I am still here* will conduct himself differently. The construction is the material of Section 44.3, and the case material's finding is that the construction is frequently made in the first weeks and is rarely revised afterwards. It is therefore worth making deliberately.

Adversity does not supply permission. A man who has suffered frequently believes that the suffering entitles him to something: an exemption from ordinary obligations, a licence to conduct himself badly, a claim on other people's patience, or a status that others lack. The belief is common, it is understandable, and it is destructive, because it converts the man's difficulty into a permanent claim and the claim into the bitterness of Section 44.6. The material's position is that a man

who has suffered is entitled to support, treatment, time, and accommodation, and is not entitled to reduce the position of other people.

Adversity does not supply wisdom. This is the chapter's central correction. Wisdom is not a substance that difficulty deposits in a man. It is a set of practices that a man conducts on the material his difficulty supplied, and a man who does not conduct the practices emerges from the same difficulty with the same information and no more capacity than he had before. The case material records this with precision: men who have survived severe events and conducted no review are frequently less capable in the following decade than men who have survived moderate events and conducted the review carefully.

Adversity does not supply community. A man in difficulty frequently discovers that the community's support is real and that it is time-limited. The support that arrives in the first month is frequently absent by the sixth. The absence is not necessarily a betrayal; it is the ordinary limit of the arrangements that communities maintain. The finding is that the man who mistakes the first month's support for a permanent arrangement is frequently bitter by the sixth, which is the material of Section 44.6′s third mechanism.

Adversity does not supply virtue. A man who has suffered is not thereby more honest, more generous, more humble, or more kind. He is a man who has suffered, and his conduct afterwards is determined by what he does with the material. The case material records men who emerged from severe difficulty more generous and men who emerged more cruel, and their severity of suffering did not distinguish them.

The Five Myths

The section now examines the five myths directly, because the reader will have encountered them and will have internalised at least one.

Myth One: What does not kill you makes you stronger. The statement is a compression of a proposition that is partly true and is frequently false. Its truth is that some capacities are acquired in difficulty. Its falsity is that severe events frequently leave lasting damage that no subsequent learning repairs: an injury, a bereavement, a period of malnutrition, a trauma, a criminal record, a destroyed reputation, a child's lost education. The man who believes the myth will frequently decline treatment, because treatment implies that the damage is real rather than formative, and the case material records this mechanism in the delay described in Chapter 35.2.

The correction: **what does not kill you frequently weakens you, and it may also teach you something.** Both clauses are true, and the man who holds both is in a position to seek treatment and to conduct the review.

Myth Two: A man needs a hard life to become a man. The statement is a prescription rather than a description, and it is one of the five propositions of Chapter 43.4 in a more respectable form. Its harm is specific: it converts the accidents of a man's history into a requirement, and it therefore justifies the withholding of support from boys and young men on the grounds that the withholding is formative. The case material records the mechanism frequently: the father who declines to assist his son on the grounds that he was not assisted, and who describes the refusal as preparation.

The correction: **a man needs a standard, an example, a party, and an instrument. Difficulty supplies the instrument only when nothing else does, and it frequently supplies damage along with it.**

Myth Three: Suffering is where the real man is revealed. The statement is the aesthetic form of the myth, and it is the one that literature and film supply most frequently. Its harm is that it assigns a positive value to the man's collapse and thereby removes the incentive to prevent it. The finding in the case material is that the statement is frequently held by men who are conducting a position that is damaging them, and that it functions as the permission described in Chapter 12.4.

The correction: **a man's conduct under difficulty is informative. It is not a justification for the difficulty, and it is not the only thing about him that is worth knowing.**

Myth Four: Time heals. Time does not heal. Time passes, and what the man does in the time determines the outcome. The case material records men who conducted no review for twenty years and whose difficulty was as present in the twentieth year as in the first, and men who conducted the review in the second year and whose difficulty had become material rather than governing by the fifth.

The correction: **time supplies distance, and distance is useful. It is a condition, not an instrument.**

Myth Five: A wise man does not need help. The statement is the myth that this book was written against. Its harm is the harm of the whole first half of the book, and its correction is the material of Chapter 35: the man who asks is conducting a competence, the competence is learnable, and its absence is a disability rather than a virtue.

The Rule of the Two Ledgers

The section closes with the rule that governs the chapter, stated in the form in which the reader can use it.

Rule One: Never use the value ledger to cancel the cost ledger. The sentence *it was worth it because I learned something* is permitted only where the man is the party who paid. It is not permitted as a consolation offered to another man, and it is never permitted in respect of a cost paid by somebody else.

Rule Two: Never use the cost ledger to cancel the value ledger. The fact that an event was unjust, undeserved, and damaging does not mean that nothing was learned. The man who refuses the value because the cost was unjust is conducting a comprehensible act and is depriving himself of the only return available.

Rule Three: Record both ledgers, separately, in writing. The practice is the first item of Section 44.8, and its purpose is to prevent the two accounts from contaminating each other. The case material's finding is that men who record both are more accurate about the event, more effective in the following years, and less prone to the bitterness of Section 44.6 than men who record one.

Rule Four: The value ledger's entries must be evidenced. An entry is not *I learned to be grateful*. It is *I learned that my brother-in-law will lend money and will not mention it, which I did not know in 2019, and which I have used twice.* The requirement of evidence is the distinction between the ledger and the narrative, and it is the condition on which the entries can be used.

Figure 44.1 states the distinction between what an adverse event supplies and what it does not, since the confusion between the two columns is the mechanism by which the myths are maintained.

What the event supplies	What the event does not supply
Accurate information about the world: the untested assumption, disclosed.	Meaning. The meaning is assigned, and the assignment is frequently made in the first weeks and never revised.
Accurate information about the man: his conduct under pressure, and his actual limit.	Permission. Support and time are owed; a licence to reduce other people is not.
The identification of his actual parties — who arrived, and who did not.	Wisdom. This is the chapter's central correction: wisdom is a set of practices, not a deposit.
The reduction of a fear that had been larger than the event.	Community. Support arrives in the first month and is frequently absent by the sixth.
A competence that ordinary circumstances would not have required.	Virtue. Men emerge from severe difficulty more generous and more cruel.

{width:90%}

44.2 Learning from Mistakes and Setbacks

The previous section described what difficulty supplies. This section supplies the instrument by which the supplies are extracted: a structured review.

The section's subject is deliberately narrower than the previous one. A setback is frequently not the man's fault; a mistake is. The review of a mistake requires the man to distinguish between the two, and the distinction is the section's first difficulty because men frequently conduct it in one direction only. The man who blames himself for everything conducts a review that produces shame and no information. The man who blames himself for nothing conducts a review that produces no information and no change. The section supplies a method for holding both facts at once.

The Five Questions

The review consists of five questions, conducted in order, in writing, within a stated period of the event. The period matters: the case material finds that a review conducted in the first three days is frequently governed by the event's emotion, and a review conducted after the third month is frequently governed by the man's revised account. The period that works is between roughly the second week and the eighth week, and the early period is used for the records that the review will need.

Question One: What happened, in sequence, without interpretation? The first question produces a chronology: the decisions, the dates, the parties, the information available at each point, and the actions taken. The chronology must be conducted without adjectives, without the man's evaluation of himself, and without the account he has prepared for other people.

The question's purpose is the separation of the event from the story, and the case material records its value precisely. Men who conduct the chronology frequently discover that the event they have been reviewing is not the event that occurred: the failure they have attributed to a single decision was a sequence of six, of which the first was taken eighteen months earlier; the betrayal they have attributed to a party's character was a process in which the man's own arrangements supplied the opportunity; the loss they have attributed to the market was a consequence of a commitment made before the market moved.

Question Two: What did I decide, and on what information? The second question isolates the man's own contribution, and it requires the distinction between a decision that was wrong on the information available and a decision that was wrong in retrospect. The distinction is the material of Chapter 29.3's difference between an error of judgement and a fault, and it is the condition on which the review produces information rather than shame.

The specific form of the question is: *at the moment I decided, what did I know, what did I not know, and what did I assume?* The answer frequently establishes that the decision was reasonable on the information and that the information was insufficient, which is a matter of the man's information arrangements rather than his character. Or it establishes that the man knew enough and decided against the information, which is a matter of his conduct, and which the next question addresses.

Question Three: What did the decision cost, and to whom? The third question records the cost, in figures where the cost is financial and in specific terms where it is not. The question is asked without the mitigation that the man will wish to supply, because the mitigation is the subject of the fourth question and the two are frequently confused.

The question's purpose is the prevention of the vague account. *It cost me a lot* is not a record. *It cost eleven months, four hundred and twenty thousand naira, the contract with the second client, and my wife's confidence in my judgement about money* is a record, and it is a record the man can use.

Question Four: What in my arrangements made this possible? The fourth question is the one that produces the section's most valuable material, and it is the one that men most frequently avoid. It does not ask what the man did wrong. It asks what in his arrangements, his habits, his information, his incentives, or his household's structure made the event possible.

The answers are frequently structural rather than personal: the man had no written record of his commitments; he was the only party who held the accounts; he had no party who could tell him that the plan was unsound; he had an arrangement in which a single customer supplied sixty per cent of his income; he had a habit of agreeing to requests in the moment and reviewing them afterwards. Each answer is a design fault, and a design fault is correctable in a way that a character fault is not.

Question Five: What will be different in the next twelve months? The fifth question converts the review into an alteration. Its form is specific: one change to the man's arrangements, with a date and a measure. The change should be small enough to conduct and structural enough to matter.

The case material's finding on this question is that men frequently produce a list of five intentions and conduct none, and that a single structural change, conducted, is worth more than the list. The examples are ordinary: the written record of commitments, reviewed on the first of each month; the second customer, secured before the next contract; the party who is authorised to disagree with the man's plans; the rule that no request is answered in the moment.

The Four Errors of Review

The section now states the four errors that men make in conducting the review, because each one is common and each one is identifiable.

Error One: The review as a court. The man conducts the review in order to establish his own guilt, and the review therefore produces a verdict rather than information. The error's signature is the review's language: the man's account consists of adjectives about himself — careless, stupid, weak, greedy — rather than descriptions of decisions and arrangements. The correction is the chronology, which cannot be conducted in adjectives, and the structural question, which cannot be answered by a verdict.

Error Two: The review as an exoneration. The man conducts the review in order to establish that the event was not his fault, and the review therefore excludes the decisions that were his. The error's signature is the review's cast: the account consists entirely of other parties' conduct, and the man's own decisions appear only as responses to provocation. The correction is the second question, which requires the man to state what he decided, and the fourth, which requires him to state what in his arrangements made the event possible regardless of who was at fault.

Error Three: The review as an avoidance. The man conducts the review formally and produces a document that contains no material: a set of general lessons — *I will be more careful*, *I will trust fewer people*, *I will not take risks* — that are not changes to arrangements and cannot be measured. The error's signature is the absence of any answer to the fifth question with a date in it. The correction is the fifth question's specific form.

Error Four: The review as a rumination. The man conducts the review repeatedly, without a fifth question, and each repetition produces the same material and a stronger emotion. The error's signature is the review's recurrence: the man has conducted the same review forty times in eighteen months and has not altered an arrangement. The correction is the rule that the review is conducted once, written, dated, and filed, and that subsequent attention to the event is conducted as an application of the fifth question rather than as a repetition of the first four.

The Attribution

The section's second instrument is the attribution, and it is conducted separately from the review because it answers a different question. The review asks what happened and what the man will change. The attribution asks how much of the event belongs to the man and how much belongs to other parties, to circumstance, and to chance.

The attribution's form is a division of the event's components, stated as percentages where the man finds percentages useful and as a list where he does

not. A business failure may be divided as follows: forty per cent the man's decision to accept a single large customer; twenty per cent the customer's own difficulty, which was not knowable; twenty per cent the bank's decision to withdraw a facility, which was within the bank's discretion and not within the man's; ten per cent the currency's movement, which was neither; and ten per cent the man's failure to conduct a written record, which made the first component invisible until it was too late.

The purpose of the attribution is not precision. No man can compute these percentages accurately, and the case material does not propose that he should. The purpose is the correction of the two errors that the review is prone to: the total attribution of the event to the man, which produces shame and paralysis, and the total attribution to other parties, which produces no change.

The attribution has three rules.

Rule One: The attribution is stated in conduct rather than in character. *I failed to keep a record* is a conduct. *I am disorganised* is a character. The first can be altered and the second cannot, and the second is a verdict in the language of a description.

Rule Two: The attribution includes what the man could not have known. The inclusion is not an excuse. It is an accuracy requirement, and its absence produces the man who blames himself for a currency movement or for a customer's concealed insolvency.

Rule Three: The attribution's other-party components are recorded for information and not for action. The man's task is not to establish other parties' fault, which is frequently impossible and rarely useful. It is to record what he now knows about those parties and to alter his arrangements accordingly. The alteration is the fifth question of the review, and the case material's finding is that men who conduct the attribution frequently make the same alteration as men who conduct the review alone: they reduce their exposure to the party whose conduct they have now measured.

The Setback That Was Not a Mistake

The section closes with the case that the review does not fit, because it is common and because the material's honesty requires it.

A setback is frequently not a mistake. A man may be dismissed in a restructuring that had nothing to do with his performance; may lose a contract because a relation of the client's director was given the work; may be injured in an accident caused by another driver; may be defrauded by a party who had been recommended by a friend; may lose a household member to an illness that no arrangement could have prevented.

The review's questions remain useful in these cases, and their application is different.

The first question is conducted, because the chronology is always useful. The second question is frequently answered by *I decided correctly on the information available*, which is the correct answer and should be recorded, because the man will need it later when his account of the event has begun to blame him. The third question is conducted in full, because the cost is real regardless of fault. The fourth question is conducted in the modified form: *what in my arrangements made me vulnerable to this, and what would reduce the vulnerability?* — which is a question about exposure rather than about fault, and which produces the changes that a man can make in a world where other parties behave badly. The fifth question is conducted as usual.

The finding that the section records is this: **men who conduct the review on events that were not their fault frequently make the most valuable changes, because the review discloses an exposure that they had never examined.** The man who was dismissed in a restructuring discovers that his entire professional network consisted of the colleagues in his own department; the man who was defrauded discovers that he had no procedure for verifying a recommendation; the man whose contract was lost to a director's relation discovers that his commercial arrangements depended on a relationship rather than on a contract. None of these discoveries is a fault, and each is a design fault, and each is correctable.

44.3 Developing Perspective and Emotional Maturity

The previous section supplied the instrument for extracting information from an event. This section addresses the capacities that determine whether the information is used well, and it proceeds by describing what perspective and maturity actually consist of rather than by exhorting the reader to acquire them.

The section's first proposition is that both are competences rather than attributes. A man is not born with perspective and does not acquire it by ageing. The case material records men of sixty with no perspective and men of thirty with a great deal, and the distinction between them is the set of practices described below.

The Four Tests of Proportion

Perspective, in this chapter's sense, is the capacity to locate an event in its actual size. The capacity is exercised through four tests, and each one is a question that the man asks of the event.

Test One: The test of time. The question is: *where will this be in five years?* The test is not a reassurance, and it is not always answered favourably: some events are still present in five years, and the man who assumes otherwise is conducting a denial. The test's purpose is accuracy, and its most frequent result is a reclassification. The event that has occupied the man's entire attention for six weeks is

frequently classified, on the test, as a matter that will be resolved within a year and will be a paragraph in his account of his life. The event that the man has treated as minor is occasionally classified as the thing that will determine his next decade, and the reclassification is the more valuable of the two.

Test Two: The test of the audience. The question is: *whose estimate of this event am I currently holding?* The test addresses the mechanism of Chapter 25.3, in which a man's estimate of his own position is conducted by an imagined audience. A man who is humiliated by a professional failure frequently discovers, on the test, that the humiliation is being conducted before an audience of four people whose opinion he does not actually value, and that the parties whose opinion he does value have not altered their estimate at all.

Test Three: The test of the alternative. The question is: *what would I have had to do differently, and would I have done it?* The test addresses the counterfactual that governs much of the rumination described in Section 44.2′s fourth error. The answer is frequently that the alternative required information the man did not have, or a decision he was not capable of making at the time, or a cost he would not have accepted. The test's result is the conversion of the counterfactual from a reproach into a description.

Test Four: The test of the whole. The question is: *what else is in my life at this moment?* The test is the simplest and it is the one that men in difficulty most frequently fail. A man in a financial crisis conducts his attention as though the crisis were the whole of his position, and on the test he discovers that he has a marriage that is intact, three children who are well, a competence that the market still requires, and a body that is functioning. The discovery is not a denial of the crisis. It is the restoration of the crisis to its actual proportion within a life, and the restoration is the condition on which the man can conduct the crisis without conducting it as the end of everything.

The four tests are conducted in writing, and their result is recorded. The case material's finding is that the written form is essential, because the tests conducted in the man's head are conducted by the same faculty that produced the disproportion.

The Six Markers of Emotional Maturity

The section now states the markers, because the reader will otherwise evaluate his maturity by his age, his composure, or his capacity to endure, and none of the three is a marker.

Marker One: The capacity to state a state without either dramatising it or denying it. The mature man can say that he is afraid, ashamed, or grieved, in ordinary language, to a party who has a right to know, without the statement becoming a performance or a concealment. The marker is the adult form of

Chapter 39.4′s four competences, and it is measured by the statement's accuracy rather than its frequency.

Marker Two: The capacity to be corrected without collapse. The mature man can receive information that he was wrong, consider it, and alter his conduct, without either accepting every criticism in order to avoid conflict or rejecting every criticism in order to protect his standing. The marker is the one that the case material associates most strongly with professional effectiveness, and it is the marker that the propositions of Chapter 43.4 most directly attack.

Marker Three: The capacity to hold two true things at once. The mature man can hold that his difficulty was unjust and that he is responsible for what he does with it; that he was wrong and that his accuser was also wrong; that his father did his best and that the harm was real; that his marriage is worth continuing and that it is currently unsatisfactory. The capacity is the one that the myths of Section 44.1 most frequently remove, since each myth offers a single account.

Marker Four: The capacity to delay the account. The mature man can conduct a difficulty for a period without requiring an immediate explanation, a verdict, or a resolution, and without the delay becoming avoidance. The marker is the adult form of Chapter 39.4′s third competence, and its absence produces the man who must resolve every uncertainty within the hour.

Marker Five: The capacity to act without certainty. The mature man can take a decision on incomplete information, state the uncertainty, and revise the decision when the information changes. The marker is the material of Chapter 32.4′s distinction between authority and omniscience, and it is the capacity that leadership requires and that the fear of failure most directly removes.

Marker Six: The capacity to be generous from a position of loss. The mature man can extend something to another party while he is himself in difficulty: attention, assistance, patience, or recognition. The marker is the one that the case material identifies as the clearest evidence that a difficulty has been converted rather than merely survived, and it is the marker that Section 44.4′s conversion produces.

What Maturity Is Not

The section states four things that are frequently mistaken for maturity and are not.

The first is composure. A man who presents an unaltered surface in every circumstance has not necessarily acquired maturity. He may have acquired the concealment described in Chapter 42. The distinction is the marker of statement: the mature man can state a state, and the composed man's surface is maintained by not stating it.

The second is endurance. A man who has carried a great deal for a long time has demonstrated a capacity, and the capacity is not the same as maturity. The case material records men who endured for thirty years and whose understanding of their own position was no more accurate at sixty than at thirty.

The third is detachment. A man who has ceased to be affected by events has frequently ceased to be affected because he has withdrawn from the arrangements that would affect him, which is the material of Chapter 24.3's withdrawal. Maturity is not the absence of response. It is the appropriate response.

The fourth is seniority. Age and position supply experience, and experience supplies material. The material becomes wisdom only through the practices of this chapter, and the case material records men of high position whose conduct in difficulty was less mature than that of men half their age.

The section closes with the relationship between the two subjects. Perspective is the capacity to locate an event correctly. Maturity is the capacity to conduct oneself well in the event's actual size. The first is an estimate and the second is a conduct, and the case material's finding is that men frequently acquire the first without the second: they can state that the failure was not the end of everything, and they continue to conduct themselves as though it were.

44.4 Turning Personal Experience into Constructive Action

The chapter now reaches its mechanical centre. The previous sections supplied the material and the capacities. This section supplies the conversion, and its argument is stated at the outset because everything in it depends on the statement.

Experience becomes competence only when it is used. The proposition is simple and its consequences are not. A man may possess thirty years of difficulty and no competence, and a man may possess four years of difficulty and a great deal, and the difference between them is the number of occasions on which the material was applied to a decision, an arrangement, a relationship, or another person's difficulty.

The section's subject is the application, and it proceeds in three domains, because the case material finds that the man who applies his material in only one domain constructs an unstable arrangement.

The First Domain: His Own Life

The first domain is the man's own conduct and arrangements, and it is the domain that must be conducted first, for the reason stated in Chapter 43.4: a man cannot transmit what he has not applied.

The application in this domain has four forms.

Form One: The alteration of an arrangement. The review of Section 44.2 produces design faults, and the design faults are corrected by alterations. The man who discovered that he had no written record of his commitments establishes

one. The man who discovered that a single customer supplied sixty per cent of his income secures a second. The man who discovered that he had no party authorised to disagree with his plans appoints one. The alteration is small, dated, and measurable, and the case material's finding is that the man who conducts one alteration per review, twice a year, will have conducted twenty alterations in a decade and will be a substantially different man.

Form Two: The correction of a standing pattern. The review frequently identifies a pattern rather than an event: the man agrees to requests in the moment and regrets them afterwards; the man accepts work beyond his capacity and conceals the shortfall; the man conducts his finances alone; the man does not state a difficulty until it is a crisis. The pattern is corrected by the material of Parts X and XI, and the correction is conducted over a period rather than in a resolution.

Form Three: The revision of the man's account of himself. The material of Chapter 41.5′s substitution exercise is the instrument. The man's account of himself after a difficulty frequently contains a clause that the difficulty installed: *I am not good with money; I cannot judge people; I am not the kind of man who can lead.* The clause is examined against the material the review produced, and it is replaced where the material does not support it. The finding is that the clause is frequently supported by one event and contradicted by the man's subsequent record, and that the examination is worth conducting because the clause governs decisions that the man does not attribute to it.

Form Four: The conduct of the man's health. The case material records that a significant proportion of the men who conduct this chapter's material discover, in the review, that the difficulty's cost included a health cost that was not addressed: the blood pressure that was not measured, the sleep that did not recover, the drinking that increased, the weight that changed, the back that was not examined. The application in this form is the appointment, the treatment, and the alteration of the conditions that produced the cost. The material of Chapters 23, 34, and 36 applies, and the case material's finding is that this form is the one most frequently deferred and the one with the greatest effect on the man's next two decades.

The Second Domain: His Household

The second domain is the man's household, and the application here is the material of Chapters 17 to 20 and 43 in their constructive form.

The household application has three forms.

The first is the transmission of the lesson without the transmission of the damage. A man who has learned, at considerable cost, that a difficulty conducted alone becomes larger has a specific asset for his household: he can state the lesson and conduct it. The conduct is the material of Chapter 43.6′s conditions,

and the case material's finding is that the man's own history is frequently the most effective material he possesses, provided that it is stated proportionately and used for the household's benefit rather than for his own account.

The second is the alteration of the household's arrangements. The review frequently identifies a household design fault: the household's expenditure that was never stated; the arrangement in which the man's position was the household's only source; the silence about a member's difficulty; the allocation of the household's labour that had not been examined since the children were small. The alteration is conducted with the household's participation, which is the material of Chapter 42.6′s third step.

The third is the conduct of the man's own difficulty in the household's observation. The application is Chapter 43′s first channel in its household form: the man conducts a difficulty, states it, repairs what he damages, and survives it, in front of the people who will otherwise learn that difficulties are not conducted in front of anybody.

The Third Domain: Other Men

The third domain is the man's conduct toward other men who are in difficulty, and the section's treatment of it is placed here rather than in Section 44.5 because its principle belongs to the conversion and not to the mentoring relationship.

The principle is stated as a rule. **A man's experience is available to another man only in the form in which it can be used.** The rule has two applications.

The first application is the distinction between the account and the instrument. A man who has survived a business failure can supply another man with an account of the failure: what happened, how it felt, what he learned. The account is frequently valuable, and it is not the same as the instrument. The instrument is the specific practice that the first man acquired: the written record, the second customer, the party authorised to disagree, the call to the bank before the third month. The case material's finding is that men in difficulty ask for the account and require the instrument, and that the man who supplies only the account is frequently experienced as inspiring and unhelpful.

The second application is the distinction between the testimony and the warning. A man's experience may be offered as a testimony — *I went through this, and I am still here* — which supplies hope, or as a warning — *this is what I did not see, and here is how to see it* — which supplies information. Both are useful and the second is scarcer. The case material records that men in the first weeks of a difficulty require the testimony and men in the middle months require the warning, and that a man who supplies the warning to a man in the first weeks is frequently heard as a reproach.

The Failure Mode: Suffering as Identity

The section now addresses the failure that the conversion is prone to, because it is common and because it is frequently invisible to the man conducting it.

The failure is the conversion of the suffering into an identity. The man's difficulty becomes the thing about him that is most interesting, most valuable, and most frequently presented. It appears in his account of himself at occasions, in his professional materials, in his conversation with new acquaintances, and in his household's account of him. It supplies a standing that his present conduct does not supply, and it therefore becomes something he has an interest in maintaining.

The case material records five signs of the failure, and the reader should examine his own record against them.

The first sign is that the account does not change. The man's account of the difficulty in the tenth year is identical to his account in the second: the same details, the same emphasis, the same conclusion. A converted experience develops: the man's understanding of what happened alters as he applies it, and the alteration is evidence that the material is being used. An account that has not altered in eight years is frequently an account that is being performed rather than used.

The second sign is that the difficulty is presented before the man's present competence. The man introduces himself through the difficulty, and the parties who know him principally through it do not know what he does, what he has built, or what he is capable of.

The third sign is that the man's present difficulties are referred to the past one. The sentence *this is like the time I lost the business* is used to explain every subsequent setback, and the explanation removes the present event's specific information. The mechanism is the material of Chapter 29.5′s pattern of recurrence.

The fourth sign is that the man resists the resolution of the difficulty's consequences. Where the difficulty's consequences are capable of resolution — the debt that could be settled, the qualification that could be obtained, the relationship that could be repaired, the treatment that could be undertaken — the man does not conduct the resolution, and the case material's finding is that the non-conduct preserves the account. The sign is subtle and it is the most important: **a man whose difficulty has become his identity has an interest in the difficulty's continuance.**

The fifth sign is that the man's account requires other parties' guilt. The account is maintained by the wrong that was done to him, and the resolution of the wrong would require the account's revision. The mechanism is the material of Section 44.6′s second mechanism, and its outcome is bitterness.

The correction is not the erasure of the experience. It is the subordination of the experience to the man's present conduct: the account is shortened, the

instrument is stated in its place, the present competence is presented before the past difficulty, and the consequences that can be resolved are resolved. The finding in the case material is that men who conduct the correction frequently report a specific and unexpected result: the experience becomes more useful to other men, because a short account with an instrument in it is more usable than a long account with a meaning in it.

The Test of the Conversion

The section closes with the test by which the reader may evaluate whether his own experience has been converted.

The test has four questions, and each one is answered by evidence rather than by impression.

The first question is: what do I do differently because of this? The answer should be a list of arrangements, decisions, or practices that did not exist before the event. Where the answer is a change of attitude, the conversion has not begun.

The second question is: what can I now do that I could not do before? The answer should be a competence: the negotiation from weakness, the statement of a loss, the conduct of a household on a reduced income, the correction received in public, the asking for an instrument.

The third question is: who has used it? The answer should be a party other than the man: a household member, a colleague, a younger man, a member of his association. Where the answer is nobody, the material has been extracted and has not been transmitted, and the finding is that transmission is frequently the stage at which the man's own understanding becomes precise.

The fourth question is: what does it still cost me, and what am I doing about that cost? The question is the chapter's honesty requirement. The conversion does not remove the cost, and the man who claims that it has is conducting the myth of Section 44.1. The answer should be an honest statement of the remaining cost and an honest statement of the treatment, the accommodation, or the arrangement that addresses it.

44.5 Mentoring Others Through Difficult Transitions

The previous section established that experience is available to another man in the form in which it can be used. This section describes the relationship in which the use is conducted.

The section's first proposition is a caution. **Mentoring is not a licence to conduct another man's life**, and the case material records more harm from well-intentioned mentorship than from its absence. The harm has a specific form: a man in difficulty is supplied with the mentor's account, the mentor's solutions, and the mentor's timetable, and the man's own position is not examined at all.

The relationship then becomes an arrangement in which the man performs the mentor's advice, and its failure is attributed by both parties to the man.

The section therefore proceeds by describing the mentor's functions, the mentor's limits, and the practices that the mentor must not conduct.

The Five Functions

The mentor's functions are five, and they are supplied in the order below.

Function One: Presence. The mentor is reliably available, at stated times, without requiring the man to justify the contact. The function is the material of Chapter 43.6′s first condition in its adult form, and the case material's finding is that presence is the function that men in difficulty value most and that mentors most frequently underestimate, because presence produces no visible result.

The practice is ordinary: a call on the same day each week, a meeting on the first Saturday of the month, a message at an interval. The practice's value is its reliability rather than its content, and the case material records men who were sustained through a year by a weekly call whose content they cannot remember.

Function Two: Information. The mentor supplies what he knows: the practice that worked in a similar position, the professional who can be approached, the institution's actual procedure, the arrangement that the man has not considered, and the warning that the mentor's own experience supplies. The function is the instrument described in Section 44.4′s third domain, and it is supplied on request rather than in advance.

Function Three: Accompaniment. The mentor goes with the man to the appointment, the institution, the meeting, or the conversation that the man cannot conduct alone. The function is the material of Chapter 35.5′s third support, and the case material's finding is that accompaniment is frequently the specific act that converts an intention into a conducted step. The mentor's role at the appointment is to be present and not to speak, unless the man asks him to.

Function Four: The limit. The mentor states honestly what he can and cannot supply, and identifies the professional route for what exceeds his competence. The function is the material of Chapter 43.6′s fourth condition, and its conduct is the sentence that the case material records as the most valuable in the whole relationship: *I do not know how to help with this part, and I know who does, and I will go with you.*

Function Five: Continuity. The mentor remains in the relationship after the transitions and after the failures, including the man's withdrawal, his relapse, and his refusal of the mentor's advice. The function is the one that distinguishes mentorship from consultation, and the case material's finding is that continuity is the function that produces the relationship's effect.

The Four Practices the Mentor Must Not Conduct

The section states four practices that mentors frequently conduct and must not.

Practice One: The prescription. The mentor states what the man should do, in specific terms, without the man's request. The practice has three effects: the man's own judgement is not exercised; the mentor's advice is frequently wrong because the mentor's position is not the man's; and the man's failure of the advice becomes the mentor's failure or the man's fault. The correction is the question: *what are you considering?* The question supplies the man's own judgement and leaves the mentor free to supply information.

Practice Two: The comparison. The mentor states what he did in a similar position and implies the comparison. The implication is frequently unintended and is always heard, and its effect is to convert the relationship into an examination that the man is failing. The correction is the statement of the mentor's experience as information rather than as a standard: *this is what I did, and it may not fit your position.*

Practice Three: The rescue. The mentor conducts the man's problem for him: makes the call, pays the debt, speaks to the employer, supplies the solution. The practice produces a specific and damaging outcome, which is the material of Chapter 20.4′s substitution: the man learns that the mentor's capacity is the operative capacity, and his own is not exercised. The correction is accompaniment: the mentor goes with the man rather than instead of him.

Practice Four: The testimony. The mentor conducts his own difficulty as the subject of the relationship, and the man becomes the audience. The practice is frequently a response to the mentor's own unresolved material, and its effect is the reversal of the relationship's direction. The correction is the discipline stated in Chapter 43.2: the mentor's own material is disclosed proportionately, in service of the man's position, and never as the relationship's subject.

The Conditions of the Relationship

The section states five conditions that the case material finds in effective mentoring relationships.

Condition One: The relationship is bounded in time and in scope. The mentor states when he is available, how often, for what matters, and for how long. The boundaries protect the man from an arrangement that ends without notice and protect the mentor from an arrangement that exceeds his capacity.

Condition Two: The relationship is confidential, with stated limits. The mentor states what he will keep confidential and what he will report, in advance, in the form supplied in Chapter 43.6′s script. The statement should include the limits that safety imposes and the mentor's own supervision arrangements.

Condition Three: The relationship has an object that is not the relationship. The effective arrangement is conducted around a task: the rebuilding plan, the professional qualification, the business's reconstruction, the marriage's repair, the return to work. The object supplies the relationship with a measure and prevents it from becoming an arrangement in which the two men meet in order to discuss the man's difficulty indefinitely.

Condition Four: The mentor has his own support. The mentor who conducts another man's difficulty without a party of his own is conducting an exposure that the case material records as harmful to both. The mentor's support may be a peer, a supervisor, a professional, or a group of men conducting similar work, and its absence is the most frequent cause of the mentor's own collapse.

Condition Five: The relationship can end well. The effective arrangement has a stated ending, or a stated review at which the ending is considered, and the ending is conducted with an acknowledgement of what was done. The finding is that men frequently continue arrangements past their usefulness out of loyalty, and that the arrangement's continuation in these conditions prevents the man's independence.

The Transition and Its Stages

The section closes with the specific transitions for which men most frequently require a mentor, and with the mentor's role at each stage. The stages are the material of Chapter 38.5 in its mentoring form.

The first transition is the loss of a position. The man has lost his employment, his business, or his professional standing. The mentor's functions at this stage are presence, information about the immediate arrangements, and accompaniment to the institutions. The specific caution is the man's timetable: the case material records men who required a period of two to six weeks before they could conduct a plan, and mentors who imposed a plan in the first week and lost the relationship.

The second transition is the end of a marriage or a significant relationship. The mentor's functions are presence, information about the legal and financial arrangements, and accompaniment to the professional route. The specific caution is the mentor's own account of marriage, which is frequently supplied as advice and is frequently unhelpful.

The third transition is a bereavement. The mentor's functions are presence, the practical arrangements, and continuity through the second year, which the material of Chapter 30.4 identifies as the period in which the community's support has ended and the man's difficulty has not.

The fourth transition is the diagnosis of an illness or a disability. The mentor's functions are information, accompaniment to the appointments, and

the conduct of the man's household arrangements. The specific caution is the mentor's optimism, which is frequently experienced as a refusal to acknowledge the position.

The fifth transition is the return from a period of treatment, imprisonment, or withdrawal. The mentor's functions are presence, the reconstruction of the man's ordinary arrangements, and the introduction of the man to parties who do not know his history. The specific caution is the community's account, which the mentor can influence and cannot control, and which the material of Chapter 25.5 addresses.

In each of the five transitions the mentor's task is the same in structure: presence, information, accompaniment, the limit, and continuity. The content changes and the structure does not, and the case material's finding is that mentors who hold the structure are effective in transitions they have never experienced, which is the reason the structure matters more than the mentor's history.

44.6 Choosing Growth over Bitterness

The chapter's final substantive section addresses the alternative that the case material finds in men who have conducted the material badly: bitterness. Its treatment is placed last because bitterness is not a failure of the earlier sections in general. It is the specific outcome of a particular set of mechanisms, and those mechanisms can be identified, described, and interrupted.

The section begins with a definition, because the word is used loosely and its looseness prevents the reader from examining his own record.

Bitterness, in this chapter's sense, is a settled account of the world in which the man's injuries are the central fact, the parties who caused them are permanently in debt to him, and the future is pre-emptively discredited on the evidence of the past. The definition has three components, and each one is required. The injuries must be real — the case material does not apply the word to a man who is complaining about ordinary difficulty, and the misapplication of the word to such a man is a common cruelty. The account must be settled, which is to say that it is not being examined. And the future must be pre-emptively discredited, which is the component that distinguishes bitterness from grief, from anger, and from the ordinary resentment that a man conducts for a season and then leaves.

The Anatomy

Bitterness has five components, and the case material records them in a consistent order.

Component One: The injury. Something was done to the man, or something happened to him, that was genuinely unjust, genuinely damaging, or genuinely undeserved. The first component is the material of Section 44.1's cost

ledger, and the reader should note that the chapter does not treat the injury as the man's invention. The finding is that bitterness occurs most frequently in men whose injuries were real, and that the men whose injuries were imagined are generally conducting something else.

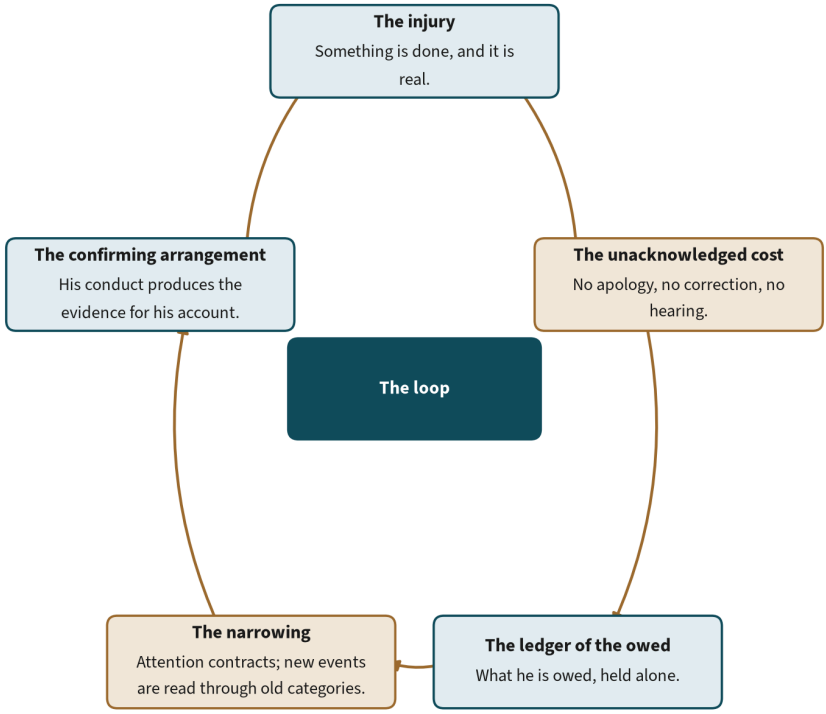
Component Two: The unacknowledged cost. The injury's cost was not acknowledged by the parties who caused it, by the institutions that should have addressed it, or by the community that observed it. The component is the one that the case material identifies as the most frequent cause of the bitterness's persistence, and its mechanism is specific: an unacknowledged cost remains an open account, and an open account requires attention.

Component Three: The ledger of the owed. The man constructs a ledger of what he is owed: the apology, the compensation, the recognition, the position, the years. The ledger is not irrational. It is a claim, and the claim is frequently valid. Its difficulty is that it is held by the man alone, it cannot be enforced, and every day in which it is not settled increases its amount.

Component Four: The narrowing. The man's attention narrows to the injury and to the parties who caused it. His reading, his conversation, his professional judgement, and his account of new events are conducted through the injury's categories. New parties are assessed by their resemblance to the parties who caused the injury, and new events are interpreted as repetitions of the original. The component is the material of Chapter 29.5′s recurrence, and its effect is the loss of information: the man's capacity to perceive his present position accurately is reduced by the instrument he is using to perceive it.

Component Five: The confirming arrangement. The man's conduct produces the evidence that confirms his account. He is suspicious, and parties withdraw; he is contemptuous of the institutions, and they exclude him; he tests new relationships for betrayal, and they fail the test; he declines opportunities because they come from the wrong quarter, and his position does not improve. The component is the most consequential, because it converts the account into a self-fulfilling arrangement, and it is the mechanism that the case material records as the point at which bitterness becomes a system rather than a mood.

Figure 44.2 states the loop, and the reader should note its structure: every element of the loop is a response to the previous element, and the loop can be interrupted at any point.



{width:84%}

Why Bitterness Is Not a Moral Failure

The section states this explicitly, because the reader who recognises himself in the anatomy will frequently respond with shame, and shame is not the instrument that the material requires.

Bitterness is not a moral failure, for three reasons that the case material supports.

The first reason is that the injury was real. The man did not construct the injury in order to have an account. He was injured, and the account is his response to the injury rather than its cause. The reading of bitterness as a character defect is therefore a second injury, and the case material records its effect: men who are told that they are bitter rather than injured frequently withdraw from the parties who might have helped them.

The second reason is that the ledger is a rational response to an unacknowledged cost. A man who has been damaged and has received no acknowledgement has no instrument by which to close the account. The ledger is his attempt to keep the claim open in the absence of any institution that will hear it, and it is frequently the only form of justice available to him.

The third reason is that the man has frequently conducted the alternatives and found them closed. He reported the injury and was not believed; he sought the institution and was refused; he conducted a legal or professional process and did not obtain the outcome; he attempted a reconciliation and was rebuffed. The bitter account is therefore frequently the last of a series rather than the first, and the case material's finding is that the series should be examined before the account is addressed.

The section's position is nevertheless that bitterness is a position that costs the man more than it costs the parties who caused it, and that its cost is paid in the currency described in Component Four and Five: the reduction of his capacity, his relationships, and his future. The material's task is therefore not to establish that the man is wrong. It is to establish that the account's maintenance is being conducted at his expense, and that the expense is optional.

The Exit

The exit from bitterness has five steps, and they are stated in the order in which the case material finds them effective.

Step One: The injury is stated accurately and in full. The statement is written, it is specific, and it includes the cost. The man states what was done, by whom, when, and what it cost him: the money, the years, the health, the relationship, the standing. The statement is not conducted for publication and it is not conducted for the parties who caused the injury. It is conducted for the man, and the case material's finding is that the written statement frequently produces a specific and unexpected result: the injury's size is either confirmed or reduced, and in both cases the man's attention is released from the task of keeping it in mind.

Step Two: The claim is separated from the account. The man distinguishes between what he is owed and what he will do if it is not paid. The distinction is the exit's mechanical centre, and it is stated as a rule: **the man's future is not a hostage to the acknowledgement he has not received.** The rule does not abandon the claim. It places the claim in one account and the man's conduct in another, and it permits the man to conduct his life while the claim remains open.

The case material records two practical forms of the rule. The first is the legal or institutional route: where a claim can be pursued, it is pursued, with a professional, and its progress is conducted as a matter rather than as the man's identity.

The second is the abandonment of the claim where it cannot be pursued: the man states in writing that he will receive no acknowledgement, that the absence is a fact about the other party, and that he will not conduct his future as a demand for it. The second form is frequently experienced as a loss and is frequently the step that produces the release.

Step Three: The ledger is closed by an act the man controls. The ledger of the owed requires an act that only the other party can conduct, which is the reason it remains open. The exit requires an act that the man can conduct himself, and the case material records several forms: the formal complaint that is lodged and then released; the letter that is written and not sent; the compensation that is sought through an institution and accepted at its outcome; the forgiveness that is conducted privately and without the other party's knowledge; the decision to conduct the injury as information rather than as a claim.

The reader should note the position of forgiveness in this material. It is included as one form among several, it is conducted for the man's benefit rather than the other party's, and it is not required. The finding in the case material is that men who conduct the release in whatever form suits them are substantially better off than men who wait for an acknowledgement that does not come, and that the form is less important than the conduct.

Step Four: The narrowing is reversed by deliberate breadth. The man's attention is restored to the fields that the injury had occupied, and the means is deliberate rather than passive. The practices are ordinary: a new competence, undertaken for its own sake; a setting in which the man is useful to parties who do not know his history; a body of work that produces something visible; a relationship that is conducted without the injury's categories; and a reading or study that supplies the man with material outside his own account. The finding is that the reversal is produced by the new material rather than by the decision, and that the decision is required in order to begin.

Step Five: The confirming arrangement is interrupted by a deliberate exception. The man's conduct produces the evidence that confirms his account, and the interruption is conducted by a specific exception: one party who is given the benefit of the doubt, one institution that is approached without the previous expectation, one opportunity that is accepted from the quarter the man distrusts, one test that is not administered. The exception is small, it is stated in advance as an experiment, and its result is recorded. The case material's finding is that a single favourable exception does not overturn the account and that a series of three or four, recorded, frequently does.

The Distinction Between Bitterness and Grief

The section closes with the distinction, because the two are frequently confused by the man himself and by the parties around him.

Grief is the response to a loss. It is conducted over time, it is frequently severe, it comes in waves, and it does not narrow the man's capacity to perceive his present position. A grieving man may be uninterested in his future for a period and he does not generally construct a ledger of what he is owed.

Bitterness is the response to an injury that has not been acknowledged. It is conducted over years, it is steady rather than wave-like, and it narrows the man's perception to the injury's categories.

The distinction matters because the treatments are different. Grief requires time, acknowledgement, the conduct of the loss, and the material of Chapter 30: it is not resolved by an act of will, and a man who attempts to conduct it as a decision will fail. Bitterness requires the five steps above, and a man who waits for it to resolve with time will generally find that it has not.

The case material also records that the two frequently coexist. A man may be grieving a loss and conducting a bitter account of the injury that caused it: the death of a household member in circumstances that involved another party's negligence; the end of a marriage that involved a betrayal; the loss of a position that involved an injustice. The material's instruction in these cases is that the grief is conducted first, with the material of Part VIII, and the bitterness is conducted afterwards, because the bitter account is frequently performing a function that the grief has not yet been permitted to perform.

44.7 Illustrative Case: The Man Who Kept the Account

The case is composite and illustrative. It is constructed from the case material of this book and is presented as an example rather than as a report of a particular person.

The Injury

Emmanuel Otu was fifty-one years old and had spent twenty-two years in the accounts department of a state-owned transport corporation. In the year of the injury, a new chief executive was appointed, and within eight months the corporation's procurement records for a three-year period were referred to an anti-corruption body. Emmanuel had signed the payment vouchers for the period, as had his immediate superior, a man named Okon, who was two grades above him and who had approved the contracts that the inquiry concerned.

The inquiry's finding, issued fourteen months later, was that the contracts had been awarded to a company connected to the chief executive's brother-in-law and that the payments had been made on documentation that did not support them. Emmanuel was not found to have benefited. He was found to have signed

the vouchers without adequate verification, and he was dismissed. Okon was dismissed and prosecuted; the chief executive resigned; the brother-in-law was not charged.

Emmanuel was fifty-two at the time of the dismissal. He had eleven years of pension contributions, a wife named Grace who taught at a primary school, four children of whom two were in university, and a house that was three years from being paid for.

The First Year

Emmanuel conducted the first year in the pattern that Chapter 38 describes, with one difference that the case material treats as significant. He did not stabilise. He conducted a legal challenge to the dismissal, which he pursued for two years and lost; he conducted a series of approaches to former colleagues, of whom two responded and neither offered work; he conducted a period of five months in which he left the house each morning and returned in the evening without employment, which his wife did not learn about until the sixth month.

His account of the dismissal, given to his family and to his former colleagues, was specific and accurate: he had signed the vouchers, the verification had been the responsibility of a department that had not conducted it, he had raised the matter twice in writing, and his letters had been ignored. The account was true. The case material records that it was corroborated by two documents that Emmanuel produced at the inquiry.

The case's finding at the end of the first year is that Emmanuel had sustained a real injury and had conducted it with a degree of accuracy that most men do not achieve. His difficulty was not the account's truth. It was what he did with it over the following nine years.

The Nine Years

Emmanuel did not return to employment at his former level. He conducted a series of small engagements: bookkeeping for two schools, a period as the treasurer of a cooperative, a part-time arrangement with an audit firm that lasted fourteen months. The income was approximately a third of his former salary, and the household conducted a substantial reduction in its arrangements, which Grace managed with a competence that the case material records as one of the factors that made the household's survival possible.

The bitterness was not immediate. In the third year, Emmanuel's account was still specific and still accompanied by an activity: he was pursuing the legal challenge, he was writing to the professional body, he was assisting two former colleagues who had been dismissed in the same inquiry. The case material records the third year as the period in which the conversion was still available.

The change occurred in the fifth year, and it had three identifiable components, which the case material treats as the case's central material.

The first component was the exhaustion of the routes. The legal challenge was dismissed at the end of the fourth year, and the professional body declined to review the dismissal at the beginning of the fifth. Emmanuel's response, recorded in his own account, was the sentence *there is nobody left to tell.* The sentence is the material of Component Two of the anatomy, and its effect was the beginning of the ledger's closure — not through acknowledgement, which did not arrive, but through the absence of any further party to whom the claim could be addressed.

The second component was the narrowing. In the fifth and sixth years, Emmanuel's attention contracted to the dismissal. He read the inquiry's report repeatedly. He conducted a correspondence with two former colleagues that consisted entirely of the case's material. He declined two engagements, one because the client had been connected to the corporation and one for reasons he could not state. He began to assess new acquaintances by their resemblance to the chief executive, and he stated to Grace, in the sixth year, that he had concluded that *people in positions always protect each other*.

The third component was the confirming arrangement. By the eighth year, Emmanuel's conduct was producing the evidence that confirmed his account. He had withdrawn from the cooperative, whose officers he had begun to suspect of the irregularities he had been dismissed for failing to detect. He had declined a position as the treasurer of a community association, on the grounds that the association's accounts would not bear examination, which was true and was not the reason he declined. He had ceased to attend the occasions at which he would meet his former colleagues, and his account of the absence was that they had abandoned him. The case material records that two of them had attempted to maintain the relationship and had been rebuffed.

The Measure

The case's finding on the nine years is stated in the household's own record, which the case material obtained from Grace's account.

The financial measure. The household's income in the ninth year was approximately forty per cent of its income in the year before the dismissal, and its expenditure had been reduced accordingly. The house had been retained. Two of the four children had completed university. The third had deferred for two years. The measure is not the case's principal finding, and it establishes that the household survived materially.

The professional measure. Emmanuel had not practiced at his former level and had not obtained a comparable position. Two engagements in nine years had

been conducted at a level below his competence, and both had ended in the man's withdrawal rather than in dismissal.

The health measure. Emmanuel had been diagnosed with hypertension in the seventh year and had not sought treatment until the ninth, when he was admitted for four days following an episode that the case material records without clinical detail. The measure is the one that the case material treats as the bitterness's most concrete cost.

The relational measure. Emmanuel's relationship with Grace had survived and had narrowed. Her account, recorded in the ninth year, was: *he does not talk about anything else. He is not cruel. He is not present either.*

The measure that the case material treats as the principal one. Emmanuel's own account, recorded in the ninth year, was that he had been *waiting for eleven years for somebody to say that they had been wrong about me.* The sentence is the ledger of the owed in its clearest form, and the case material's finding is that it is the sentence that the exit's second step addresses.

The Interruption

The interruption was not a decision. It was a letter.

In the tenth year, the anti-corruption body published a review of its earlier cases, and the review contained a paragraph that stated that a number of officers in the corporation had been dismissed for failures of verification that had been the responsibility of a department whose own procedures had subsequently been found deficient. The paragraph did not name Emmanuel. It did not constitute an acknowledgement, and it did not alter his position.

Emmanuel read the paragraph and, in the case material's account, conducted an act that he had not conducted in eleven years. He wrote to the review's author, stated his case in two pages, and asked for a correction to the record that named him. The correction was issued four months later. It stated that his dismissal had been reviewed and that the finding against him had been set aside.

The finding did not restore his position, his pension, or his eleven years. The case material records that Emmanuel's response to the correction was not elation. It was a period of two weeks in which he slept, and then a sentence to Grace that the material treats as the case's turning point: *I have been keeping an account with a bank that was never open.*

The Exit

Emmanuel conducted four of the five steps over the following two years, and the case material records them in the order in which they occurred.

He conducted the statement. He wrote the account of the injury in full, in eleven pages, and he did not show it to anybody for eight months. When he

eventually showed it to Grace, her account was that it was *shorter than what he had been saying for years, and more accurate.*

He separated the claim from his future. The correction had been issued; the pension was not restored, and he pursued it for a period through the pension authority without success. In the second year, he stated in writing that he would not receive the pension, that the absence was a fact about the authority, and that he would not conduct his remaining years as a demand for it. The statement is the material of the exit's second step, and the case material records it as the point at which the man's attention began to move.

He interrupted the narrowing. He accepted a position as the treasurer of the community association that he had declined three years earlier. He conducted it for four years, and the case material records that the association's accounts were, in fact, in order.

He interrupted the confirming arrangement. He contacted the two former colleagues who had attempted to maintain the relationship and stated, in specific terms, that he had withdrawn and that the withdrawal had been his. One of the two responded within a week. The other did not respond, and the case material records that Emmanuel's response to the silence was, in his own words, *one account closed and one not, and I am not going to wait for the second.*

He did not conduct the fifth step in full. The case material records that Emmanuel continued to distrust institutions and that he stated the distrust openly and specifically rather than conducting it as a general account of the world. The distinction is the one the case material treats as the case's most useful finding: **the exit does not produce a man who trusts. It produces a man whose distrust is specific, stated, and does not govern his conduct toward parties who have not earned it.**

The Finding

The case's finding is stated in three parts.

The first part is that the injury was real and the bitterness was not a moral failure. Emmanuel's account was accurate, his legal challenge was reasonable, and his dismissal was, on the review's own finding, unjustified. The case material does not treat his nine years as a defect of character, and the reader who recognises his own position in the case should note the point.

The second part is that the cost of the bitterness was paid by the man and by his household, and not by the parties who caused the injury. The chief executive had resigned and had continued his career elsewhere. The brother-in-law had not been charged. The corporation had been restructured. The nine years were conducted in the man's own house, at his own expense, and the expense was measured in income, health, and presence.

The third part is that the exit was available at every point and was conducted by small acts. The correction was not the exit; it was the occasion. The exit was conducted by a letter, a written statement, a decision about a pension, an accepted position, two telephone calls, and a sentence to his wife. The case material's finding is that this is the ordinary form of the work, and that the extraordinary form — the reconciliation, the public acknowledgement, the restored position — is neither available nor necessary.

44.8 The Programme

The section supplies the chapter's material in a form that the reader can conduct. Its four instruments are the two ledgers, the review, the wisdom account, and the mentoring arrangement. Each is small, each is conducted in writing, and each is repeated rather than completed.

Instrument One: The Two Ledgers

The instrument is a table with two columns, conducted for one significant event and repeated annually.

The cost ledger	The value ledger
What the event took, stated specifically: the money, the years, the health, the relationship, the standing, the opportunity.	What the event supplied, stated with evidence: the information, the capacity, the party identified, the assumption that collapsed.
Who paid each item, and whether the payment was theirs to make.	What was done with each item, and what it produced.
What remains, and what would address it: treatment, accommodation, legal route, arrangement.	What has not yet been used, and what use would require.

The instrument's rules are the four of Section 44.1's closing material. The ledgers are recorded separately; neither cancels the other; every entry in the value ledger is evidenced; and the remaining costs are accompanied by an action.

Instrument Two: The Review

The review is conducted on one event, within the second to eighth week where possible, and it is written.

Question One: The chronology. What happened, in sequence, without adjectives: the dates, the decisions, the parties, the information available at each point.

Question Two: The decisions. What did I decide, and on what information? For each decision, record what I knew, what I did not know, and what I assumed.

Question Three: The cost. What did it cost, in figures where the cost is financial and in specific terms where it is not, and to whom?

Question Four: The design faults. What in my arrangements, habits, information, incentives, or household's structure made this possible? Record at least two, and record them as design faults rather than as character faults.

Question Five: The alteration. What will be different in the next twelve months? Record one structural change, with a date and a measure. Where the event was not a mistake, record the change in the form *what would reduce my exposure to this*, rather than in the form of a fault.

The review is conducted once, dated, and filed. Subsequent attention to the event is conducted as an application of the fifth question.

Instrument Three: The Wisdom Account

The wisdom account is the chapter's central instrument, and it is conducted in four parts.

Part One: The event, in eight sentences. The account is limited deliberately. The case material's finding is that the limit forces the selection of the material that matters and removes the performance from the account.

Part Two: What it cost, and what remains. The cost ledger's summary, with the remaining cost and the action that addresses it.

Part Three: What it taught, stated as instruments. Five entries, each in the form: *I learned that [specific thing], and I have used it to [specific act].* Where an entry cannot be completed with a use, it is recorded as *learned and not yet used*, and the reader should note the entries in this category, because they are the chapter's most valuable unfinished work.

Part Four: Who has used it. The parties to whom the man has supplied the account or the instrument, and what they did with it. Where the answer is nobody, the reader should conduct Section 44.4′s third domain within the following quarter.

Instrument Four: The Mentoring Arrangement

The arrangement is stated in one page and contains six items.

Item One: The party. Who the man is mentoring, and how the arrangement arose.

Item Two: The functions. Which of the five functions of Section 44.5 he is supplying: presence, information, accompaniment, the limit, continuity. The reader should record the functions he is not supplying, since the case material's finding is that mentors frequently supply information and omit presence.

Item Three: The boundaries. The times, the frequency, the scope, the stated limits of confidentiality, and the review date.

Item Four: The object. What the arrangement is conducted around: the rebuilding plan, the qualification, the business's reconstruction, the marriage's repair, the return to work.

Item Five: The mentor's own support. Who the mentor speaks to about the arrangement, and when.

Item Six: The prohibition. The four practices of Section 44.5 that the mentor will not conduct, stated explicitly, because the case material's finding is that they are conducted by men with the best intentions and without any awareness that they are conducting them.

The Four Tests

The programme's measures are the four tests of Section 44.4's closing material, and they are recorded annually.

The first is what the man does differently: a list of arrangements, decisions, or practices that did not exist before the event.

The second is what he can now do: a list of competences that the difficulty supplied.

The third is who has used it: the parties to whom the material has been transmitted and what they did with it.

The fourth is what it still costs and what is being done about that cost: an honest statement of the remaining cost and the treatment, accommodation, or arrangement that addresses it.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE

Exercise 44: The Wisdom Account and the Bitterness Audit

The exercise has four parts, and it should be conducted across two sittings of not less than one hour each. It requires paper, and it should not be conducted on a screen.

Part One: The two ledgers. Choose one event from your life that was significant, that was difficult, and that is at least two years past. Conduct the two-ledger table of Instrument One. Record the cost in specific terms, including the parties who paid it and whether the payment was theirs to make. Record the value in specific terms, with evidence, and record what has been used and what has not. Where an entry in the value ledger cannot be evidenced, strike it out and record the fact that you cannot evidence it.

Part Two: The review. Conduct the five questions of Instrument Two on the same event, in writing. Where the event was not a mistake, conduct the fourth question in the exposure form. Record the single alteration, with a date and a measure, and record the date on which you will review whether it was conducted.

Part Three: The bitterness audit. Examine your own record against the five components of Section 44.6's anatomy, with evidence. (1) What was the injury, and was it real? (2) Whose acknowledgement are you waiting for, and for how long? (3) What is on your ledger of the owed, and what is its total? (4) Which fields has your attention narrowed to, and what have you ceased to perceive? (5) What evidence has your own conduct produced that confirms your account, and who has been tested and failed? Record the component that is strongest in your record. Then state, in

writing, the second step of the exit: what you are owed, and what you will do if it is not paid.

Part Four: The mentoring arrangement. Conduct Instrument Four for one young man or one man in difficulty whom you are already in a position to assist. Where no such party exists, conduct the instrument for the party you would be willing to assist, and state the arrangement to him within the following month. Record the functions you are supplying and the functions you are not, and record the prohibition of the four practices in your own words.

At the end of the two sittings, record three sentences: the cost that is still being paid, the instrument that the event supplied, and the party who will receive it.

44.9 Questions Readers Ask

"My difficulty was not a mistake. Somebody did this to me. Does this chapter apply?"

It applies, and the section that applies is the one on bitterness rather than the one on mistakes. The chapter's material does not require the man to have caused his difficulty, and the case of Section 44.7 is a case in which the injury was real and the dismissal was subsequently set aside.

The specific application for the reader whose difficulty was caused by another party is the following. The review's first, third, and fifth questions are conducted in full. The second and fourth are conducted in the modified forms supplied in Section 44.2′s closing material: the second as a record of what was decided on the information available, which is frequently *I decided correctly*, and the fourth as a question about exposure rather than fault. The bitterness audit is conducted in full, because the anatomy of Section 44.6 applies most directly to injuries that were caused by other parties.

"I do not want to be told that my suffering was worth it. Is that what this chapter is saying?"

No, and the distinction is stated at the chapter's beginning. The cost ledger and the value ledger are separate accounts, and neither cancels the other. The chapter's position is that the cost was real, that it was frequently unjust, and that it is not repaid by anything the man learned. The value ledger is a separate account, it is available whether or not the cost was deserved, and its extraction is worth conducting because the alternative is to pay the cost and receive nothing.

The reader who is told by another party that his suffering was worth it should note that the statement is frequently made in order to close a conversation that the speaker finds difficult. The statement is not the chapter's position, and the man is entitled to say so.

"I have conducted the review and I found nothing. What does that mean?"

It means one of three things, and the reader should establish which.

The first is that the review was conducted too early, in the first days of the event, when the chronology is not yet complete and the emotion governs the material. The correction is to conduct it again in the second month.

The second is that the review was conducted as a verdict or as an exoneration, in the forms of Section 44.2's four errors. The signature is the presence of adjectives about the man or about other parties, and the absence of any description of a decision or an arrangement. The correction is to conduct the chronology as a list of dates and decisions, without evaluation, and to answer the fourth question with a design fault.

The third is that the event was genuinely one to which the man contributed nothing and from which he can extract nothing except the exposure information. This is a real category, it is smaller than most men believe, and where it applies the review's output is the exposure question and the alteration that reduces the exposure.

"How do I know whether I am grieving or bitter?"

The distinction is supplied in Section 44.6's closing material, and it is stated here in its practical form. Grief comes in waves, and the man's account of his present position remains accurate between them. Bitterness is steady, and the man's account of his present position is organised by the injury's categories.

The three questions that distinguish them are: does the difficulty arrive in waves, or is it present continuously? Does my account of the injury remain fixed, or does it alter as I learn more? Am I waiting for a party to acknowledge something, and has the waiting organised my conduct?

Where the answers indicate grief, the material of Chapter 30 applies, and the man should not attempt to conduct the grief as a decision. Where the answers indicate bitterness, the exit of Section 44.6 applies.

"I have mentored three young men and all three have withdrawn. What am I doing wrong?"

The pattern is common and it is frequently not a fault. The case material records three causes, and the reader should examine his own record against each.

The first cause is the mentor's timetable. A young man frequently requires a period before he can conduct a plan, and a mentor who supplies the plan in the first week is experienced as a demand. The correction is presence without agenda for the first month.

The second cause is the prescription. A young man who is told what to do and who cannot do it will frequently withdraw rather than report the failure. The correction is the question, which leaves the judgement with the young man and the information with the mentor.

The third cause is the arrangement's object. A relationship that exists in order to discuss the young man's difficulty has no other content, and it exhausts itself. The correction is the object of Section 44.5′s third condition: the arrangement is conducted around a task, and the task supplies the relationship with ordinary material.

Where none of the three applies, the reader should consider the fourth possibility, which the case material records and which is not the mentor's fault: the young man's withdrawal is frequently a stage, and a proportion of young men return after a period of months or years. The mentor's task is to remain available without requiring the return.

"Is it possible to become wiser without suffering?"

Yes, and the proposition is not a paradox. A man acquires the material of this chapter through difficulty of some kind, and not every difficulty is severe. The ordinary difficulties of work, marriage, parenthood, and professional failure supply a great deal of material to a man who conducts the review. The case material records men who conducted the material on moderate difficulties and acquired substantial competence, and men who survived severe difficulties and acquired none.

The finding is that the variable is not the difficulty's size. It is the review's conduct, the attribution's accuracy, the conversion's application, and the mentoring's transmission. A man who conducts these on the ordinary difficulties of a professional life will acquire more than a man who survives a catastrophe and conducts none of them.

"What if the party who injured me is dead?"

Then the ledger cannot be settled by acknowledgement, and the exit's second and third steps apply without the first party. The case material records two practices for this position, and neither requires the dead party's participation.

The first is the written statement, conducted as a letter to the party, which is written and not sent. The practice is the material of Chapter 30.5′s letters, and its finding is that the writing produces the separation of the claim from the man's conduct more reliably than any internal decision.

The second is the conduct of the injury as information for the living: the account supplied to the parties who can use it, which is Section 44.4′s third domain. The finding is that the transmission frequently completes what the acknowledgement could not, because the man's experience becomes useful rather than owed.

"I am still in the middle of the difficulty. Can I conduct any of this now?"

Yes, and the chapter has stated the availability at each stage. In the first weeks, the chronology is conducted, because the record of dates, decisions, and informa-

tion is easiest to make while the material is fresh. The cost ledger is begun and not concluded. The fourth test of proportion — what else is in my life at this moment — is conducted, because it is the test that the man in the middle of a difficulty most requires. The stabilisation material of Chapter 38.4 is conducted in full, and it precedes everything else.

The review's full conduct, the wisdom account, and the mentoring arrangement are conducted after the position has stabilised. The case material's finding on the timing is that men who attempt the full review in the first month frequently conduct it as rumination, and men who defer it entirely for a year frequently lose the material.

44.10 Chapter Summary

Chapter 44 in brief. Battles do not make a man wiser automatically; they supply material, and the material becomes wisdom through a craft. The cost ledger and the value ledger are separate accounts, and neither cancels the other: the cost was real and is not repaid by anything learned, and the value is available whether or not the cost was deserved. What adversity supplies is accurate information about the world, accurate information about the man, the identification of his actual parties, the reduction of a fear that was larger than the event, and competences that no other route would have supplied. What it does not supply is meaning, permission, wisdom, community, or virtue.

The five myths are that what does not kill you makes you stronger, that a man needs a hard life, that suffering reveals the real man, that time heals, and that a wise man does not need help. Each is partly true and each is harmful in a specific way, and the correction of each is a distinction rather than a denial.

The review has five questions: the chronology; the decisions and the information available; the cost and who paid it; the design faults in the man's arrangements; and the single alteration for the next twelve months. Its four errors are the review as a court, as an exoneration, as an avoidance, and as a rumination. The attribution separates what belongs to the man from what belongs to other parties, to circumstance, and to chance, and it is stated in conduct rather than in character. Where the event was not a mistake, the review is conducted in its exposure form, and the finding is that such events frequently produce the most valuable changes.

Perspective is exercised by four tests: the test of time, of the audience, of the alternative, and of the whole. Maturity has six markers: the capacity to state a state without dramatising or denying it; to be corrected without collapse; to hold two true things at once; to delay the account; to act without certainty; and to be generous from a position of loss. Composure, endurance, detachment, and seniority are not the markers.

The conversion is conducted in three domains: the man's own life, through the alteration of an arrangement, the correction of a standing pattern, the revision of his account of himself, and the conduct of his health; his household, through the proportionate transmission of the lesson, the alteration of the household's arrangements, and the conduct of his own difficulty in the household's observation; and other men, through the instrument rather than the account, and through the warning as well as the testimony. The failure mode is the conversion of the suffering into an identity, whose five signs are that the account does not change, that the difficulty is presented before the present competence, that present difficulties are referred to the past one, that the man resists the resolution of the consequences, and that the account requires other parties' guilt.

Mentoring has five functions — presence, information, accompaniment, the limit, and continuity — and four prohibitions: the prescription, the comparison, the rescue, and the testimony. Its conditions are the boundary, the confidentiality, the object, the mentor's own support, and the possibility of a good ending.

Bitterness is a settled account in which the man's real injuries are the central fact, the parties who caused them are permanently in debt, and the future is preemptively discredited. Its anatomy is the injury, the unacknowledged cost, the ledger of the owed, the narrowing, and the confirming arrangement. It is not a moral failure, and its exit has five steps: the accurate statement, the separation of the claim from the future, the closure by an act the man controls, the reversal of the narrowing, and the interruption of the confirming arrangement.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The chapter's central claim. The difference between a man who is made wiser by his battles and a man who is made harder by them is not the battles. It is whether he conducts the review, states the attribution, applies the proportion tests, converts the material into arrangements and competences, transmits it to another man, and separates his claim on the past from his conduct of the future. Each of these is a practice, each is small, and each is available to the reader this month.

Reflection Questions

1. Which event in your life has supplied the most material, and what has been extracted from it in instruments rather than in attitudes?
2. Which of the five myths do you still hold, and what does it permit you to avoid?
3. Conduct the two-ledger table for one event. Which column was easier to write, and what does that tell you?
4. What is the design fault that your review has disclosed, and what is the single alteration that addresses it?

5. Which of the four tests of proportion do you most frequently fail, and in what circumstances?
6. Which of the six markers of maturity is weakest in your record, and where did you last see it fail?
7. What in your history have you converted into an identity, and what would the account look like if the instrument were placed in front of the difficulty?
8. Whom are you owed, and for how long have you been waiting? What would the second step of the exit require you to write?
9. Which young man or man in difficulty could use what you have learned, and what is the smallest arrangement you could supply him within the next month?
10. If a man who knows you were asked to state what your difficulties have made you able to do, what would he say?

Further Reading

- **On post-traumatic growth and its limits:** the research literature on post-traumatic growth, including the findings on the conditions under which growth is reported, the criticisms of self-reported growth, and the evidence on the coexistence of growth and continuing distress.
- **On rumination, reflection, and their difference:** the research literature on rumination and reflective processing, including the findings on the effects of repetitive negative thinking on mood and problem-solving, and on the conditions under which reflection produces learning rather than recurrence.
- **On attribution and learned helplessness:** the established literature on attributional style, explanatory style, and learned helplessness, including the findings on the effects of stable and global attributions on subsequent conduct, and on the modification of attributional style.
- **On wisdom as a measurable construct:** the psychological literature on wisdom, including the findings on its components, its relationship with age and experience, and the evidence that it is not an automatic consequence of either.
- **On forgiveness and its outcomes:** the research literature on forgiveness, including the findings on its effects on health and wellbeing, on the distinction between forgiveness and reconciliation, and on the conditions under which forgiveness is and is not associated with better outcomes.
- **On mentoring:** the research and practice literature on mentoring adults and young people, including the findings on the characteristics of effective mentors, the risks of poorly bounded relationships, and the effects of mentoring on both parties.

- **Practical resources:** clinical psychology and psychotherapy for unresolved grief and trauma; employee assistance and career transition services; mediation and legal advice where a claim is capable of pursuit; peer support and supervision arrangements for mentors; and the material in Appendices H, I, K, and P.

45 CHAPTER

The Day a Man Realizes He Does Not Have to Fight Alone

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, the reader should be able to:

1. Describe the mechanism of self-reliance as a competent adaptation that has become a liability, and identify the point at which the transition occurs.
2. Identify the six reasons a man refuses support that is available, and answer each one in his own record.
3. Analyse the four fears that govern the acceptance of support, and distinguish acceptance from dependence.
4. Conduct a reconciliation with his own limits that is neither resignation nor denial.
5. Reconstruct his purpose and his belonging on four foundations, and state them in a form that can be acted upon.
6. Construct a working vision of manhood that retains the standard and removes the isolation.
7. Conduct the closing exercise of the book and state the terms on which he will begin the next chapter.

Introduction

This is the last chapter of the book's main argument, and it is the one that the preceding forty-four chapters were written to reach.

The book began with a man nobody really knows, and it has spent its length describing the architecture of his isolation: the script he inherited, the states he could not name, the money he could not state, the grief he could not conduct, the marriage he could not repair, the position he could not afford to lose, the friends he could not call, the help he could not ask for. Parts X and XI described the recovery and the rebuilding. Part XII has described the reconstruction of the definition, the removal of the pretence, the education of the next generation, and the extraction of wisdom from what he has survived.

This chapter addresses the single act that all of that work finally requires, and it is the act that the book's title names: the day a man realises that he does not have to fight alone.

The realisation is not an insight. The book has been careful about this distinction throughout, and it is the chapter's first proposition. **Insight is the acquisition of information; a realisation, in the sense this chapter uses the word, is the alteration of an arrangement.** A man may understand, with complete intellectual clarity, that he does not have to fight alone, and continue to fight alone for another twenty years. The case material records this frequently and without surprise: the men who have read the most about men's isolation are frequently the men who are most isolated, because reading about isolation is itself an isolating act.

The realisation is therefore a date in a man's life at which something in his arrangements changes. The telephone call that is made rather than planned. The sentence that is spoken rather than rehearsed for another year. The appointment that is attended. The party who is told the accurate position. The support that is accepted rather than declined. The help that is asked for before the collapse rather than after it. The case material's finding is that these acts are small, that they are frequently undramatic, that they are frequently conducted on an ordinary Tuesday afternoon, and that men remember them with the precision that they give to very few other days.

The chapter's approach has five commitments.

The first is that the chapter does not propose that a man should cease to be responsible. The book's central message is stated in the introduction and it is repeated here because it is the point at which the material is most frequently misunderstood: men can carry serious responsibilities without being expected to endure emotional suffering in isolation. The sentence contains two clauses and the chapter requires both. The responsibilities are not reduced. The isolation is not a requirement of them. A man who reads this chapter as permission to carry less has misread the book, and a man who reads it as a requirement to carry the same load in the same way has misread it more seriously, because he has retained the part that was killing him and discarded the part that was available.

The second is that the chapter distinguishes support from rescue. Support is the supply of an instrument that the man uses. Rescue is the conduct of the man's position by another party. The book has treated the distinction throughout — in Chapter 20.4′s substitution, in Chapter 35.5′s three supports, in Chapter 44.5′s prohibition of the rescue — and the chapter states it again because it is the distinction on which a man's acceptance of support depends. A man who believes that accepting support means being rescued will decline it, and he will be right

to decline the rescue. The chapter's task is to show that the support is available without it.

The third is that the chapter is written for the man who has nobody, as well as the man who has somebody and has not called him. A proportion of the readers of this book will be genuinely without a party: men whose marriages have ended, whose friendships have lapsed, whose families are distant or dead, whose work has isolated them, whose communities have been left behind by migration. The chapter addresses this reader directly in Section 45.4, and its finding is that the construction of a party is possible at any age, that it is slower than the reader expects, and that it begins with the man's own conduct rather than with the search for a person.

The fourth is that the chapter does not require a man to become a different kind of man. The case material's finding is that men frequently refuse the material of this book because they believe it requires them to become gregarious, emotionally expressive, and publicly vulnerable. The chapter requires none of these. The man who conducts this material may remain private, reserved, and disinclined to discuss his interior life in public. What changes is not his temperament. It is the number of parties who hold his accurate position, and the arrangements he has established so that his position is not conducted alone.

The fifth is that the chapter has an ending, and the ending is a beginning. The book's title is a statement about a battle, and the chapter's title is a statement about a day. The chapter's material is the conduct of that day and the arrangement that follows it. Its product is not a feeling of connection, which is unreliable, and not a resolution to be different, which is quickly broken. Its product is a written page: the parties, the instruments, the terms, and the date. Section 45.7 supplies the page, and the reader who completes it will have conducted the book's final exercise.

The chapter's sequence follows the outline. Section 45.1 addresses the burden of constant self-reliance. Section 45.2 addresses the acceptance of support. Section 45.3 addresses the reconciliation with limitation. Section 45.4 addresses purpose and belonging. Section 45.5 addresses the vision of manhood. Section 45.6 addresses the beginning. Section 45.7 supplies the programme. Section 45.8 presents the book's closing case. Section 45.9 supplies the summary, the reflection questions, and the further reading that closes the main text.

45.1 Releasing the Burden of Constant Self-Reliance

The section begins with an account of self-reliance that is more careful than the culture's, because the reader will otherwise hear the section as an attack on a capacity he values, and the attack would be both inaccurate and counterproductive.

Self-Reliance as a Competence

Self-reliance is a competence, and it is among the most valuable a man can acquire. It is the capacity to conduct his own position: to earn, to decide, to repair, to endure, to recover, and to act without requiring another party's permission or participation. The man who possesses it is useful to his household, reliable in his work, and steady in a crisis. The case material of this book is full of such men, and the book has not treated their competence as a pathology.

The competence is acquired, and its acquisition follows the pattern described in Chapter 43.5's four-stage method: the boy is taught to conduct small matters alone, rehearses them, receives feedback, and applies them at increasing stakes. The competence is not given. It is built, frequently by a boy who had no alternative, and the men who possess it most completely are frequently the men whose childhoods required it earliest.

The section's argument is therefore not that self-reliance is a defect. It is that **self-reliance is a competence with a domain, and the domain has been expanded beyond its usefulness.** A capacity that is appropriate to a man's own position has been extended, in the men this book describes, to cover matters that cannot be conducted alone: the naming of his own states, the assessment of his own judgement, the correction of his own errors, the grief that requires an audience, the position that requires a second opinion, the decision that requires a party who is not invested in it, and the collapse that requires somebody to be present.

The Expansion and Its Mechanism

The expansion has four mechanisms, and each one is recorded in the case material.

The first mechanism is success. Self-reliance works, and its success is the reason for its expansion. The man who conducted his household's finances alone for ten years and whose household did not fail concludes that the arrangement is sound. The man who concealed a difficulty and survived it concludes that concealment is survivable. The man who conducted a grief alone and continued to work concludes that the grief did not require an audience. The conclusion is drawn from the absence of a visible failure, and the case material's finding is that the failure is frequently invisible to the man: the marriage that continued without intimacy, the judgement that was never corrected, the grief that returned as irritability in the eighth year, the health that was not measured.

The second mechanism is the absence of a party. A man who has no party to call does not choose self-reliance. He conducts the only arrangement available, and the arrangement becomes his habit. By the time a party becomes available, the habit is fifteen years old and the man's capacity to use the party has atrophied.

The mechanism is the material of Chapter 27′s man who has nobody to call, and its finding is that the absence and the habit reinforce one another.

The third mechanism is the script. The material of Chapter 41.2′s five clauses supplies the man with a definition in which self-sufficiency is not a competence but an identity. To accept support is not to use an instrument; it is to cease to be the thing he has understood himself to be. The mechanism is the most resistant of the four, because it operates below the level of the man's decisions.

The fourth mechanism is the cost of the alternative. The man has, at some point, asked for support and paid for it: the disclosure that was used against him, the request that was refused, the vulnerability that was met with ridicule, the party who made the help into a debt. The mechanism is the material of Chapter 35.2′s accounting, and its finding is that a single expensive experience frequently governs twenty subsequent years.

The Point at Which the Competence Becomes a Liability

The section now states the point at which the transition occurs, because the reader will require a criterion and because the culture supplies none.

The criterion is not the amount the man is carrying. A man may carry a great deal alone for a period and be conducting himself correctly, particularly where the load is temporary and the man has the instruments he requires. The criterion is not the man's distress, since distress is frequently appropriate to the position.

The criterion is the man's capacity to correct himself. Self-reliance becomes a liability at the point where the man's position is no longer subject to correction, because correction requires a party who is not the man.

The criterion is stated in five tests, and the reader should conduct them against his own position.

Test One: The unexamined decision. When did I last take a decision of consequence, and who examined it before I took it? Where the answer is nobody, and where the pattern extends over years, the man's judgement is unexamined, and the case material's finding is that unexamined judgement drifts.

Test Two: The unstated figure. When did I last state my position in figures to a party who could tell me that I was wrong? The material of Chapter 42.5′s second support applies: the man whose position has never been stated to anybody is conducting a position that nobody can confirm.

Test Three: The unregistered change. When did a change in my state — my sleep, my drinking, my temper, my weight, my interest, my capacity for work — go unregistered by anybody except me? The material of Chapter 34.2′s warning signs applies, and the test is the one that most reliably identifies a man whose position has become uncorrectable.

Test Four: The grief without an audience. Whose death, loss, or ending am I conducting without a party who knows? The material of Chapter 30 applies, and the test's result is frequently the first item the reader will act upon.

Test Five: The collapse without a witness. If I became seriously unwell, or if I lost my position, or if I could not continue, who would know, and how long would it take them to find out? The test is the one that the case material records as the most sobering, and its finding is that men frequently discover that the answer is *nobody for several days*.

The criterion's statement is completed by its corollary: **the man whose position is not subject to correction is not conducting a position. He is conducting an account of a position, and the account is being maintained by the same faculty that constructed it.**

What Is Released, and What Is Not

The section closes with the precise statement of what the chapter proposes should be released, because the reader's interpretation of this material determines whether he conducts it.

What is released is the requirement of exclusive conduct. The man ceases to require that every component of his position be conducted by him alone. He establishes the parties, the instruments, and the arrangements by which his position is examined, corrected, shared where it should be shared, and supported where it requires support.

What is not released is the responsibility. The man remains responsible for his position, his household, his work, and his conduct. The parties who examine and support do not become responsible for him. The distinction is the material of Chapter 35.5′s three supports, and its practical form is stated in one sentence: **the man accepts the instrument, and retains the obligation.**

What is also not released is the man's standard. The obligations of Chapter 41.6′s working definition — provision, protection, competence, accountability, presence, and repair — are retained in full. What is removed is the addition described in Chapter 41.2: the exclusivity, the anonymity, the personalisation, and the silence that converted the obligations into a requirement of self-destruction.

The section's material is summarised in Figure 45.1, which states the distinction between what is carried and what is released, since the confusion of the two is the most frequent misreading of the whole book.

What a man carries	What he is released from
The responsibilities: the household, the work, the obligations, the parties who depend on him.	The exclusivity: that every component of the position be conducted by him alone.
The standard: provision, protection, competence, accountability, presence, repair.	The silence: that the accurate position be held by nobody else.
The obligation: he answers for his position, and its consequence is his.	The personalisation: that the position's size be computed at his exhaustion.
The accountability: he holds the decisions, and the outcomes are his to conduct.	The anonymity: that the household conduct its arrangements without knowing them.
The competence: he acquires, conducts, and is corrected in.	The requirement that the endurance be conducted without instruments or parties.

{width:90%}

45.2 Accepting Meaningful Relationships and Support

The previous section established what is released. This section addresses the act by which the release is conducted, and it proceeds from a finding that the reader may find surprising.

The difficulty is not generally the absence of support. It is the refusal of support that is available.

The case material of this book records this with a consistency that justifies the statement. A substantial proportion of the men who describe themselves as having nobody to call, on examination, have somebody: a wife who has offered, a brother who has asked, a colleague who has twice suggested a conversation, a friend from twenty years ago who telephoned and was not called back, a professional who is available and has not been approached. The absence is real in the man's experience and it is frequently an absence that his own conduct has produced and maintained.

The section therefore addresses the refusal before it addresses the construction. It proceeds in four parts: the six reasons a man refuses, the four fears that govern

the refusal, the distinction between acceptance and dependence, and the practice of acceptance.

The Six Reasons a Man Refuses Support

The reasons are stated in the form in which men give them, and each is followed by the material that answers it. The answers are not reassurances. They are observations from the case material, and the reader should note that the material does not attempt to establish that the reasons are irrational. Several of them are rational, and each of them is addressable.

Reason One: "It would be an imposition."

The reason is common, it is sincere, and it is frequently held by men who have spent their adult lives being the party who is imposed upon. The man's calculation is that the other party's time, attention, or resources are limited and that his difficulty does not have a sufficient claim on them.

The material's answer is a distinction that most men have never conducted: **the imposition is not the request; it is the unannounced arrival of the consequence.** The party who is asked in time can decline, can set the terms, and can contribute what he has. The party who is notified after the collapse is presented with a position that has already exceeded everybody's capacity. The case material's finding is that the parties in men's lives are frequently willing to be asked and are frequently unable to conduct the unannounced consequence, and the finding is stated in the words that one such party used in the material: *I would have preferred to be asked when it would have helped.*

Reason Two: "Nobody would understand."

The reason is frequently accurate in part. A man's position frequently contains material that the available parties have not experienced: the specific pressure of a business's cash flow, the humiliation of a professional failure, the particular structure of a marriage's difficulty, the fear of a diagnosis.

The material's answer is the distinction between understanding and usefulness. A party does not need to have experienced a man's position in order to be useful in it. The wife who has not run a business can hear it. The brother who has not been dismissed can accompany a man to an appointment. The friend who has not lost a child can telephone on the anniversary. The case material's finding is that the requirement of perfect understanding is one of the most efficient instruments by which men exclude every available party, and that it is rarely held consciously.

Reason Three: "It would change how they see me."

The reason is the material of Chapter 20.2′s fear of the reduction of standing, and it is the most powerful of the six. The man's standing among the parties who surround him is frequently the asset he has built most carefully, and the disclosure of a difficulty appears to threaten it.

The material's answer has three parts. The first is that the party who has been told an accurate position and has not reduced his estimate of the man is the party whose estimate is worth holding. The second is that the reduction the man fears is frequently experienced by the other party as an increase: the case material records wives, brothers, and colleagues who reported that the disclosure had increased their respect rather than reduced it, because the disclosure was the first occasion on which the man had treated them as capable of it. The third is that the standing which cannot survive an accurate disclosure is the standing described in Chapter 42, and it is being maintained at a cost the man has already established.

Reason Four: "I do not want to burden them."

The reason is the most frequently stated and the most frequently misapplied. Its valid form is a genuine concern for a party who is themselves in difficulty, and the material does not propose that the concern be abandoned. Its invalid form is a general statement about the man's own value, which is to say that a difficulty of his is a burden and a difficulty of anybody else's is not.

The material's answer is a question that the case material finds effective: **if the positions were reversed, would you want to be told?** The answer is almost always yes, and the answer establishes that the man's calculation is not a general principle about burdens. It is a specific exemption that he has granted himself, and the exemption is the material of Chapter 20′s unappreciated man and Chapter 41.2′s clause of self-sufficiency.

Reason Five: "Nothing can be done."

The reason is a judgement about the position's solubility, and it is frequently wrong. The case material records men who had concluded that nothing could be done about a debt, a marriage, a diagnosis, a professional position, or a grief, and who discovered on disclosure that the party they spoke to knew of an instrument, an institution, a procedure, a variant of the arrangement, or a party who had been in the same position. The discovery is not guaranteed, and the frequency with which it occurs is sufficient to justify the statement of the reason as a prediction rather than a fact.

Reason Six: "I have always handled my own affairs."

The reason is the identity, and it is the most resistant. The material's answer has been stated in Section 45.1 and is repeated in its practical form: the man's identity is not in question. What is in question is whether the affairs he has always handled have been handled with information that he alone possessed, and whether that arrangement is producing the outcomes he believes it is producing. The case material's finding is that the question, put precisely, is frequently sufficient, because men who hold this reason are frequently rigorous about their own arrangements and have simply never examined this one.

The Four Fears

Beneath the six reasons are four fears, and the section states them because the reasons are frequently the surface and the fears are the material.

The first fear is the fear of dependence. The man fears that acceptance will lead to a state in which he requires the party, cannot conduct his position without the party, and is therefore reduced. The fear is the material of Chapter 41′s clause of self-sufficiency, and its correction is Section 45.2′s third part.

The second fear is the fear of exposure. The man fears that the disclosure will supply the party with information that can be used against him, and the fear is frequently grounded in experience. Its correction is the selection of the party and the conduct of Section 45.2′s fourth part, not the abandonment of the material.

The third fear is the fear of the party's alarm. The man fears that the disclosure will produce a response he will then be required to manage: the wife's distress, the brother's intervention, the friend's advice, the employer's concern. The fear is common and it is frequently the most accurate of the four. Its correction is the statement's form: the man states what he requires, which is generally to be heard, and states what he does not require, which is generally a solution.

The fourth fear is the fear that the difficulty is not sufficient. The man fears that if he discloses, the party will establish that the difficulty is ordinary, that the man is complaining without cause, and that the disclosure has made him look weak for nothing. The fear is the material of Chapter 33′s man who must always have answers, and its correction is the recognition that the disclosure's purpose is the instrument and not the validation.

Acceptance Is Not Dependence

The section now states the distinction on which the reader's conduct depends, because the fear of dependence is the strongest of the four and the distinction is the instrument that answers it.

Dependence is an arrangement in which a party conducts a function that the man cannot conduct. The dependent man does not hold the decision, the resource, the information, or the capacity, and its withdrawal leaves him without it.

Acceptance is an arrangement in which a party supplies an instrument that the man uses. The man retains the decision, the resource, the information, the capacity, and the responsibility, and the party's contribution improves the conduct of them.

The distinction is testable, and the test has three questions.

The first question: who holds the decision? In the arrangement the man is considering, the decision is his. The party may advise, disagree, examine, and warn, and the decision remains with the man and so does its consequence. A

party who has taken the decision has moved from acceptance to dependence or to rescue.

The second question: what remains if the party withdraws? The man who has received an instrument retains it. The instrument may be a practice, a treatment, a route, a piece of information, an appointment, or a habit of statement, and the case material's finding is that these remain after the party's withdrawal. The man who has received a rescue does not retain it, and this is the test by which the difference is established.

The third question: has the man's own capacity increased or decreased? Acceptance asks the man to do something he could not do alone, and it therefore increases his capacity. Dependence conducts the function for him, and its effect is the reduction described in Chapter 20.4′s substitution.

The distinction is the reason the book has insisted on the support's specificity throughout. **A support that is specific is an instrument and can be accepted. A support that is general is a rescue and must be declined.** The sentence *I will help you with anything* is generous and it is not an instrument. The sentences *I will go with you on Thursday*, *I will keep the children on Saturday while you attend*, *I will read the accounts and tell you what I see*, *I will call you on the first of each month*, and *I will not mention this to anybody* are instruments, and each of them can be accepted without any reduction of the man's position.

The Practice of Acceptance

The section closes with the practice, because the reader who has accepted the argument requires an act.

The practice has four steps, and the case material finds them effective in the order stated.

Step One: The inventory of the available. The man lists the parties who are available to him: every person who has offered, suggested, asked, telephoned, or remained after a difficulty. The list is frequently longer than the man expects, and its conduct is the exercise of Section 45.7′s first table. The list includes parties the man has not considered: the colleague who is not a friend, the sibling he has not spoken to in two years, the former classmate, the professional, the association's welfare officer, the member of his place of worship or his community, and the neighbour who has been kind.

Step Two: The specific request. The man identifies one instrument he requires and one party who could supply it, and he states the request in the form of Section 45.2′s specificity. The request is short, it is specific, it names a time, and it does not require the party to conduct the man's position.

Step Three: The reception of the response. The party's response may be the instrument, a different instrument, a decline, or an alarm. The man's task is to

receive the response without conducting the party's reaction, and to record what happened. The case material's finding is that the first request frequently produces an unexpected response and that the man's capacity to conduct the response is the determining factor in whether a second request is made.

Step Four: The record. The man records the request, the party, the date, and the result. The record's purpose is the correction of the man's estimate of the world, because the estimate is the thing that has prevented the request, and the record is the evidence that alters it. The case material's finding is that three recorded requests, conducted over a period of months, alter a man's estimate of the availability of support more reliably than any argument.

45.3 Making Peace with Personal Limitations

The section's subject is a reconciliation, and the word is chosen with care. It is not a resignation, it is not a denial, and it is not the acceptance of a diminished position that the man could alter.

The section begins with a definition. **A limitation, in this chapter's sense, is a boundary on what a man can do, be, or become, which is not within his power to remove, and which is not a matter of effort.** The definition has three components, and each one excludes a category that is frequently confused with limitation.

The first component excludes what the man could alter with effort: a competence he has not acquired, a qualification he has not obtained, a weight he has not addressed, a debt he has not restructured. These are not limitations in this section's sense; they are conditions, and they are addressed by the material of Parts III and XI.

The second component excludes what another party has imposed and what another party could remove: a dismissal that could be reversed, a contract that could be renegotiated, a judgement that could be appealed. These are grievances, and they are addressed by the material of Chapter 44.6.

The third component excludes what is temporary: a period of illness, a season of grief, a year of reduced income. These are states, and they are addressed by the material of Chapter 38.

What remains, after the three exclusions, is the section's subject: the limits that are structural, permanent, and not the man's to alter.

The Four Categories of Limitation

The case material records four categories, and the reader should locate his own limitations in each.

Category One: The limits of the body. The man's height, his constitution, his chronic condition, his disability, his eyesight, his hearing, his stamina, his recovery from an injury, his age. The category is the one that men most frequently

deny, and the denial is the material of Chapters 34 and 42′s domain five. The case material records the specific form of the denial: the man who continues to work at the pace of his thirty-fifth year at fifty-five, the man who does not have the symptom investigated, the man who attributes his exhaustion to the workload rather than to the condition.

Category Two: The limits of capacity. The man's intelligence, his talent, his capacity for a particular kind of work, his aptitude for a particular profession, his ability to learn a discipline that requires a facility he does not possess. The category is painful because it frequently arrives late: the man discovers at forty-five that he will not reach the level he intended, and the discovery is conducted as a verdict on his life.

Category Three: The limits of the past. The years that were spent in a particular way, the education that was not obtained, the children who were not present for, the marriage that ended, the opportunity that was declined, the decision that was taken. The category is the material of Chapter 29′s regrets, and its defining feature is that it is closed: no effort alters it.

Category Four: The limits of what others will give. The father who will not reconcile, the wife who will not continue, the child who will not speak, the colleague who will not acknowledge, the institution that will not correct its record. The category is the material of Chapter 44.6′s ledger of the owed, and it is the one that men most frequently refuse to accept, because the refusal is experienced as a failure of hope.

The Three False Settlements

The section now states the three ways in which men attempt to settle with a limitation and fail, because the reader will recognise at least one of them and the recognition is the condition of the fourth way.

False Settlement One: Denial. The man does not accept the limitation and conducts his position as though it did not exist. The form is familiar: the man of fifty-eight who works the hours of a man of thirty-five, the man whose back requires surgery and who continues to lift, the man who has not reached the level he intended and who attributes the fact to the market, the man whose marriage has ended and who speaks of it as a temporary separation in its fourth year.

The cost of denial is specific and it is paid later: the injury, the collapse, the years spent on an objective that was not available, the arrangement that was not made and that becomes an emergency. The case material's finding is that denial is frequently the man's first response and that it is frequently held for years.

False Settlement Two: Resignation. The man accepts the limitation and generalises it to his whole position. The form is also familiar: the man who is told that he will not reach the level and who concludes that he is finished; the man

whose marriage has ended and who concludes that he is not a man who can be loved; the man whose body has failed in one respect and who concludes that his whole capacity is ended; the man whose son will not speak to him and who concludes that everything he built is worthless.

The cost of resignation is the loss of the position's remaining capacity. The limitation is real and it is one item, and the resignation converts it into a verdict on the whole. The case material's finding is that resignation frequently follows denial directly, and that the two are frequently conducted in the same year.

False Settlement Three: Bargaining. The man accepts the limitation in principle and conducts a series of arrangements whose purpose is to reverse it. The form: the man who accepts that he cannot continue at his former pace and who takes on a further commitment in order to prove otherwise; the man who accepts that the marriage has ended and who conducts a series of approaches whose purpose is the restoration; the man who accepts that his son will not speak to him and who conducts a campaign of letters, intermediaries, and occasions.

The cost of bargaining is the extension of the difficulty. The case material's finding is that bargaining is the most prolonged of the three, that it frequently consumes years, and that its conduct is frequently the material of Chapter 29.3's rumination in its behavioural form.

The Reconciliation

The reconciliation is the fourth way, and it has four components. Each one is a specific act, and the case material finds that men who conduct the components in order make progress, and men who attempt the reconciliation as a single decision do not.

Component One: The accurate statement. The man states the limitation in writing, in the plainest available language, without the modifiers that soften it and without the generalisations that extend it.

The statement's form is: *I cannot [specific] any longer, or at all, and this is not within my power to alter.* The examples are deliberately ordinary: *I cannot work more than eight hours a day without a consequence that I now have to manage. I cannot reach the level of [specific position] in my profession, because the requirement includes [specific capacity] that I do not have. I cannot recover the years between 2011 and 2018. I cannot make my brother acknowledge what happened.*

The statement's value is not therapeutic. It is informational: a limitation that has not been stated accurately cannot be conducted, because the man's arrangements are being built on a position that includes a capacity he does not have.

Component Two: The inventory of what remains. The man states what the limitation does not affect. The inventory is not a consolation and it is not a denial of the loss. It is the establishment of the domains in which the man's

capacity is intact, and the case material's finding is that the inventory is frequently longer than the man expects.

The inventory's form is a list: the competences that remain, the parties who remain, the years that are available, the work that can still be conducted, the relationships that can still be repaired, the contributions that the man can still make. The list is written, and each item is specific.

Component Three: The reallocation. The man alters his arrangements to fit the limitation. The reallocation is the section's operative act, and the case material's finding is that it is the component that distinguishes the reconciliation from an attitude.

The reallocation has three forms. The first is the **reduction**: the man ceases to conduct what the limitation makes impossible, and states the cessation to the parties who are affected. The second is the **substitution**: the man conducts the function by a different means, which is the material of Chapter 38.5′s reconstruction and Chapter 39.4′s competence. The third is the **delegation**: the man establishes another party to conduct the function, with the man's accountability retained, which is the material of Chapter 45.2′s acceptance.

Component Four: The grief. The man conducts the grief for what the limitation has cost, and the grief is not optional. A limitation that removes a capacity removes a version of the man's life, and the version requires the conduct of Chapter 30 rather than a decision. The case material's finding is that men who conduct the first three components and omit the fourth frequently find that the reconciliation has not taken effect: the arrangements have been altered and the man continues to conduct the loss as a private grievance.

The grief's form is ordinary: the statement of what has been lost, the party who receives it, the period in which the loss is felt, and the occasion on which it is acknowledged. The case material records men who conducted the grief in a single evening with a single party, and men who conducted it over two years; both are within the material's range.

The Reconciliation and the Standard

The section closes with a distinction that the reader should hold, because the reconciliation is frequently heard as a reduction of the standard.

The reconciliation does not reduce the standard. It relocates it.

The man's standard — the obligations of Chapter 41.6, the four competences of Chapter 39.4, the markers of Chapter 44.3 — is not a standard of unlimited capacity. It is a standard of conduct: provision, protection, competence, accountability, presence, repair, and the accurate statement of his own position. A man who cannot work twelve hours a day can conduct every one of them. A man who will not reach his profession's highest level can conduct every one of them. A man

whose marriage has ended can conduct every one of them. A man whose body has failed in a specific respect can conduct every one of them, provided that he does not require of himself the capacity that the limitation has removed.

The finding is stated as the section's closing claim: **the men who reconcile with their limitations frequently conduct the standard more completely than the men who deny them**, because the denial consumes the capacity that the standard requires, and the reconciliation releases it. The man who accepts that he has eight hours a day has eight hours. The man who requires twelve has four and pays for them with the following week.

45.4 Reconnecting with Purpose and Belonging

The two previous sections addressed the release of exclusive conduct and the reconciliation with limitation. This section addresses the two structures on which a man's life is conducted after both have been undertaken: purpose and belonging.

The section treats them together because the case material finds that they fail together. A man with purpose and no belonging conducts a project in isolation and frequently abandons it. A man with belonging and no purpose is comfortable and unproductive, and the discomfort of the second condition is frequently more dangerous than the difficulty of the first, because it is not experienced as a problem. Purpose supplies the direction and belonging supplies the company; a life requires both.

Purpose: The Four False Versions

The word purpose is used in the culture with a vagueness that prevents the reader from examining his own. The section therefore begins by stating the four things that purpose is frequently taken to be and is not.

The first false version is the grand purpose. The belief that purpose is a single, large, world-altering contribution, which the ordinary man either possesses or lacks. The version is transmitted by the literature of achievement and it produces two outcomes: the man who has not identified his grand purpose concludes that he has none, and the man who has identified one frequently neglects the obligations of his ordinary position in order to pursue it.

The second false version is the purpose that is discovered. The belief that purpose is a hidden object which the man must find, and that its discovery will resolve his uncertainty. The version produces the search that never concludes, and the case material records men who spent a decade in the search and never conducted the work that was in front of them.

The third false version is the purpose that is the man's own. The belief that purpose consists of the man's fulfilment, his self-expression, and his own development. The version is the material of Chapter 40′s permissions in their dis-

torted form, and its difficulty is that it removes the obligations by which purpose is conducted in a life that includes other people.

The fourth false version is the purpose that arrives with the position. The belief that purpose is supplied by the man's role: the promotion, the title, the appointment, the ownership of the enterprise, the leadership of the household. The version is the material of Part IX's loneliness, since a purpose that is contingent on a position ends with the position, and the case material records the collapse of men whose purpose was conducted entirely through their roles.

Purpose: The Working Definition

The section supplies a working definition in the form employed in Chapter 41.6, and it states the definition's components.

Purpose, in this chapter's sense, is the answer to the question: what is my position for, and what will be different because I conducted it?

The definition has three components.

The first component is a position. Purpose is not a general statement about the man's life. It is an answer about a position that he actually occupies — a household, a trade, a profession, an association, a community, a body of work — and the case material's finding is that the answer becomes usable only when it is attached to a position. The man who asks what he should do with his life is frequently conducting the search instead of his work. The man who asks what his position is for is conducting an answerable question.

The second component is a contribution that is not the man's own benefit. The contribution may be small, and it must be identifiable. The household that is stable. The trade that is conducted honestly. The apprentice who is taught. The association that is administered well. The community's water supply that works. The children who are able to speak about what they carry. The finding is that men who locate their purpose in a contribution are substantially less vulnerable to the collapse of their positions than men who locate it in their roles, since the contribution can be conducted from a smaller position.

The third component is an outcome that can be observed. The purpose must produce something the man can see. The case material's finding is that men who conduct purposes that cannot be observed lose their direction within a year, and that the observation may be small: the account that balances, the boy who returns, the workshop that is clean, the record that is accurate, the household that has its evening meal.

The definition's test is stated in three questions: **What is my position? What is it for? What would be different, and how would I know?** A man who cannot answer all three has a sentiment rather than a purpose, and the sentiment is not the material.

The Four Foundations of a Working Purpose

The section supplies four foundations, and the reader should note that they are not sequential. They are domains, and the case material finds that a purpose conducted on one foundation alone is fragile.

Foundation One: The household. The purpose that consists of the household's stability, its children's capacity, its elders' care, and its ordinary arrangements. The foundation is the one most men hold already, and the case material's finding is that it is frequently held without being stated, and that the stating of it is itself useful: the man who states to his household that his position is for them conducts that position differently, and the household's response to the statement is frequently the material the man had not had.

Foundation Two: The work and the trade. The purpose that consists of conducting a competence well: the product that is sound, the service that is honest, the apprentice who is trained, the record that is accurate, the standard that is maintained in the trade. The foundation is the one that survives the loss of position, since a man who has located his purpose in the conduct of his competence can conduct it at a smaller scale.

Foundation Three: The community and the association. The purpose that consists of a contribution to a body larger than the household: the association, the trade body, the school, the sports club, the community's arrangements, the professional institution. The foundation is the one that supplies the belonging described in the section's second half, and it is frequently the foundation that men in the second half of life most require.

Foundation Four: The transmission. The purpose that consists of supplying to a later party what the man has acquired: the apprentice, the junior colleague, the younger men of his community, the next generation of his household, the men described in Chapter 44.5 who are in transition. The foundation is the one the case material finds most reliable in the second half of a man's life, because it is conducted from whatever position the man holds and it does not depend on his continuing capacity.

Belonging: The Three False Versions

The section turns to belonging, and it begins in the same form.

The first false version is belonging as popularity. The man's estimate of his belonging is conducted by the number of parties who know him, greet him, invite him, or speak well of him. The version is the material of Chapter 25.3's imagined audience, and its difficulty is that it supplies no party who would conduct the tests of Section 45.1.

The second false version is belonging as the household's dependence. The man's belonging is conducted by being required: the household that cannot

function without him, the business that depends on him, the association that would collapse without him. The version is the material of Chapter 33′s carrying other people's problems, and its difficulty is that it is an arrangement in which the man is valued for his function and not for himself, and its ending is frequently the retirement or the illness described in Chapter 31.

The third false version is belonging as the group's approval. The man's belonging is conducted by his conformity to a group: the peer group, the professional body, the association, the community's body of opinion. The version is the material of Chapter 43.4′s propositions, and its difficulty is that the belonging is conditional on the man's not stating what he carries.

Belonging: The Working Definition

The section supplies a definition, and it is deliberately narrow, because the narrow definition is the one that can be built.

Belonging, in this chapter's sense, is the condition in which a man has parties who hold his accurate position, whose estimate of him is not conditional on the position's favourable appearance, and to whom he has obligations that he conducts.

The definition has three components, and each one is required.

The first component is the accurate position. The parties know the man's actual position: his income, his difficulties, his history, his limits, his states. The component is the material of Chapter 42.5′s second support, and the finding is that belonging without it is an arrangement of appearances, and appearances are what a man's isolation is made of.

The second component is the unconditional estimate. The parties' estimate of the man does not depend on his continuing to appear successful. The component is the one that the case material finds decisive, and it is the component that the disclosure tests. The finding is that men frequently discover, on disclosure, that the parties' estimate was never conditional, and that the belief in its conditionality was the man's own construction.

The third component is obligations that are conducted. The man has obligations to the parties that he actually conducts, and the component is the one that distinguishes belonging from support. A man who is supported by a party to whom he has no obligations is a recipient. A man who is supported by a party to whom he has obligations is a member, and the case material's finding is that men accept support far more readily when they have something to conduct in return.

The Construction of Belonging

The section now addresses the reader who has few parties or none, and it states the construction in the order in which the case material finds it effective.

The first step is the man's own conduct as the instrument. Belonging is not found; it is built by the man's conduct toward others over a period. The case material's finding is that the specific conduct is the one described in Chapter 44.5′s five functions in their reciprocal form: the man becomes present to a party, supplies information, accompanies, states his limit, and continues. The parties who receive that conduct are frequently the parties who become available to him, and the finding is that this is the ordinary mechanism by which men who have lost their parties construct new ones.

The second step is the setting. Belonging is conducted in settings, and the settings are ordinary: the association, the trade body, the club, the sports team, the reading group, the community's arrangements, the parents' meeting, the professional body's committee, the place of work's ordinary occasions, and the community's gatherings. The step is the material of Chapter 43.7′s fifth design principle in its adult form, and the case material's finding is that a man's belonging is frequently constructed by his accepting a small office in an ordinary setting: the treasurer's role, the committee's secretary, the organiser of a repair, the coach of a junior team.

The third step is the repetition. Belonging requires frequency, and the frequency is what converts an acquaintance into a party. The finding is that men frequently conduct a single approach, receive a lukewarm response, and conclude that the party is unavailable, and that the conclusion is drawn from a sample of one. The step's practice is the ordinary one: the same setting, the same day, for a period long enough for the man to become known.

The fourth step is the disclosure. The step is the one that converts a setting into a belonging. The man states his accurate position to one party in the setting, in the form of Chapter 43.6′s script and at the pace of Chapter 45.2′s practice. The case material's finding is that the disclosure is frequently the point at which men report that a setting became a belonging, and that it is frequently conducted after a year or more of ordinary association.

The fifth step is the obligation. The man accepts an obligation to the party or the setting and conducts it. The step is the component that distinguishes belonging from support, and its practice is ordinary: the man is the party who telephones on the anniversary, who visits the bereaved household, who collects the contribution, who keeps the record, who accompanies the man to the appointment.

The Second Half of Life

The section closes with the material that the case material finds most relevant to the book's likely readers, who are frequently men in the second half of their lives.

The second half has three characteristics that alter the construction of purpose and belonging.

The first characteristic is the closure of the future's options. The man of fifty-five has fewer available positions than the man of thirty-five, and the case material's finding is that the closure is frequently experienced as a reduction of purpose, when it is in fact a condition of its clarification. A purpose that is conducted from a smaller position is a purpose that has been examined; a purpose that requires an expanding position is a purpose that is contingent on the market.

The second characteristic is the accumulation of the material. The man in the second half has conducted difficulties, acquired competences, and observed consequences that the man of thirty-five has not. The material of Chapter 44 is available to him in a quantity that the younger man does not possess, and the transmission of Chapter 44.5′s mentoring is frequently the purpose that the second half supplies and the first half cannot.

The third characteristic is the reduction of the parties. The parties of a man's first half are frequently reduced by death, migration, divorce, and the ordinary drift that the case material records. The reduction is real and the construction is available, and the case material's finding is that the men who construct new parties in the second half are the men who conduct the four steps above rather than the men who wait for the parties to return.

45.5 Building a Healthier Vision of Manhood

The section now states the vision, and it does so in the book's own terms rather than in the culture's, because the reader has been conducting the material of Chapter 41′s five clauses and Forty-five chapters of the architecture they constructed.

The vision is stated in six clauses, each of which is the corrected form of a clause that the book has examined. For each, the section states the obligation that is retained and the addition that is removed.

Clause One: A man provides. The obligation is retained in full: the man's household has what it requires, and the man is accountable for its arrangements. The addition that is removed is the anonymity of the provision — the arrangement in which the household does not know its own position, the man's income is not stated, and the provision is conducted as a private burden whose size is known only to him. The corrected form is stated in one sentence: **a man provides, and the provision is conducted with the household's knowledge, at its true level, and with the household's participation where the household is capable of it.**

Clause Two: A man is composed. The obligation is retained: the man regulates his states and conducts them appropriately in the setting, which is the

material of Chapter 39.4′s four competences. The addition that is removed is the concealment that has been extended from the setting to the man's whole interior: the arrangement in which he does not know his own states, does not state them to any party, and conducts composure as the absence of an interior life. The corrected form: **a man regulates his states, states them to the parties who have a right to know, and is composed in the settings that require it.**

Clause Three: A man is capable. The obligation is retained: the man acquires competence, conducts it honestly, and is accountable for its limits. The addition that is removed is the self-sufficiency that requires the competence to be conducted alone, and that therefore removes the instruments on which competence depends: the second opinion, the correction, the professional advice, the party who examines the decision. The corrected form: **a man is capable, states his limits, and conducts his competence with the instruments that competence requires.**

Clause Four: A man is accountable. The obligation is retained: the man is responsible for his household's position and answers for it. The addition that is removed is the conversion of accountability into authority over persons, which reduces the household's information and capacity, and which the case material of Chapter 18 records as the mechanism by which a household becomes an audience rather than a body. The corrected form: **a man is accountable, and his accountability increases the capacity of the parties he is accountable for.**

Clause Five: A man's work is real. The obligation is retained: the man's work produces something, and his achievement is a legitimate part of his standing. The addition that is removed is the identification of the man with his position, so that a reduction in the position is experienced as a reduction in the man. The corrected form: **a man's work is real, and the man is not his work.**

Clause Six: A man endures. The obligation is retained: the man conducts difficulty without collapse, and his endurance is a genuine competence that the case material of this book records with respect. The addition that is removed is the requirement that the endurance be conducted in silence, in isolation, and at the cost of his health, his marriage, and his capacity to ask. The corrected form: **a man endures, and he does not endure alone.**

The Six Statements of the Vision

The clauses are stated in the form in which the reader can conduct them, and the form is the one supplied by Chapter 41.5′s substitution exercise.

1. **A man provides, and the provision is conducted with the household's knowledge and participation.**
2. **A man regulates his states, states them to the parties who have a right to know, and is composed in the settings that require it.**

3. **A man is capable, states his limits, and uses the instruments that competence requires.**
4. **A man is accountable, and his accountability increases the capacity of those he is accountable for.**
5. **A man's work is real, and the man is not his work.**
6. **A man endures, and he does not endure alone.**

The six statements are the book's positive answer to the question it began with. They are not a new standard, and the reader should note that they are harder than the standard he inherited rather than easier: the provision with the household's knowledge requires a conversation that the old standard permitted him to avoid; the statement of his states requires a competence that the old standard did not teach; the use of instruments requires an admission that the old standard punished; the increase of others' capacity requires a discipline that the old standard did not require; the distinction between the man and his work requires a security the old standard did not supply; and the endurance without isolation requires the whole of the book's material.

The Vision and the Household

The section states the vision's household form, because the reader's household will conduct its own version of the vision whatever the reader intends, and the case material finds that the household's version is transmitted by conduct rather than by statement.

The household's version is conducted in five arrangements.

The first arrangement is the stated position. The household's position is stated to the household, at its true level, at intervals. The arrangement is the material of Chapter 42.6′s third step, and its finding is that the household's capacity increases with its information.

The second arrangement is the stated difficulty. The household's adults state their difficulties proportionately, at intervals, in the form of Chapter 43.5′s practice. The arrangement is the one that supplies the next generation with the curriculum.

The third arrangement is the repair. The household's adults conduct their repairs in the household's observation, which is the material of Chapter 43.4′s consequence channel and the single most valuable item in the household's curriculum.

The fourth arrangement is the party. Each member of the household has a party outside the household to whom they can speak, and the arrangement is stated rather than assumed.

The fifth arrangement is the obligation. Each member of the household has an obligation to the household that they conduct, and the arrangement is the one that supplies belonging rather than dependence.

The Vision and the Community

The vision's community form is the material of Chapter 43.7′s six principles and Chapter 44.5′s five functions, and the section states it in a single clause because the reader has already received the material: **a community in which a man can be accurate about his position without losing his standing.**

The clause is the vision's public form, and it is testable by the audit of Chapter 43.8: the vocabulary that the community supplies, the permission it states, its response to the last disclosure, the consequence a young man can observe, and the repetition of the arrangement.

The book's confidence in this part of the vision is stated with the restraint that the case material requires. Communities change slowly, the work is conducted by ordinary arrangements, and the reader's contribution is small. The finding that justifies the confidence is the one recorded in Chapter 43.7′s account of the association that changed its meetings: **the ten minutes cost nothing, and it is the only part of the meeting that anybody remembers.**

45.6 Beginning a New Chapter with Hope

The section's subject is the beginning, and it requires a careful treatment because the word hope is used in the culture to mean two different things, and only one of them is the material of this book.

The first meaning is optimism. The expectation that the man's position will improve, that the difficulty will resolve, that the outcome will be favourable. Optimism is a disposition and it is not within a man's control, and the case material finds that men who conduct their arrangements on optimism are frequently unprepared for the outcome that does not arrive.

The second meaning is the one this section employs: hope as the conduct of a man's position in the belief that the conduct is worth undertaking, independently of the outcome's probability. The definition is stricter than optimism and it is more useful, because it does not depend on a prediction. The man who conducts the arrangements of Section 45.7 does not know whether his marriage will be repaired, whether his business will recover, whether his son will speak to him, or whether his health will hold. He knows that the conduct is worth undertaking, and the case material's finding is that this knowledge is sufficient to begin.

The section therefore does not promise outcomes. It states the conditions of beginning, and it supplies the four that the material supports.

The First Condition: The Position Is Stated

A man cannot begin a chapter whose position he has not stated. The statement is the material of Chapter 42.6′s first step and Chapter 45.7′s first table, and its components are the six domains: the money, the work, the marriage, the household, the health, and the standing. Each is stated in figures where the figures exist and in specific terms where they do not.

The finding is that the statement is frequently the whole of the beginning, because the man who has stated his position accurately discovers that it is smaller, larger, or differently arranged than his account of it, and each of the three discoveries alters what he does next.

The Second Condition: The Parties Are Named

A man cannot begin a chapter alone, and the beginning requires the naming of the parties: the one person who knows the whole, the household who knows the arrangements, the professional who holds the domain that requires one, the two or three parties who would be called in a difficulty, and the party to whom the man is himself an instrument.

The finding is that the naming is frequently conducted before the parties have been informed, and that the informing is the act. The case material records men who wrote the list in an evening and made the first call within the week, and men who wrote the list and made no call for three years. The list is not the beginning. The call is.

The Third Condition: The Instruments Are Identified

The man identifies, for each domain that is not in order, the instrument he requires: the professional, the treatment, the arrangement, the conversation, the qualification, the party who will read the position, the procedure he has not used. The identification is the material of Chapter 35.4′s four forms of help, and its finding is that men frequently identify the instrument correctly and delay its use by months, which is the material of Chapter 35.2′s accounting and is addressed by the date.

The Fourth Condition: The Date Is Fixed

The beginning requires a date, and the date is not a figure of speech. The case material's finding is that a man's intentions are converted into arrangements by the fixing of a date and by the statement of the date to a party who will ask about it.

The date is fixed for the first act, and the first act is small: the appointment that is made, the call that is placed, the letter that is written, the statement that is made to the household, the professional who is engaged, the arrangement that is established. The date is recorded, and the party who will ask about it is named.

What Hope Is Not Required to Be

The section closes with four statements that correct the reader's likely expectations, because the case material finds that they are the most frequent causes of the abandonment of the work.

Hope is not required to be a feeling. A man may begin without the feeling of hope, and the case material's finding is that the feeling frequently arrives after the conduct rather than before it. The man who waits for the feeling frequently waits for years, and the waiting is the material of Chapter 7′s fear of failure in its most disguised form.

Hope is not required to be confident. The man does not know what will happen. He knows what he will do, and the confidence in the conduct is sufficient. The material of Chapter 32.4′s authority without omniscience applies to the man's own life as much as to his leadership.

Hope is not required to be constant. The case material records men who began, faltered, resumed, and continued, and the faltering is not a failure of the beginning. The material of Chapter 38.5′s stages applies: the reconstruction is conducted in stages and the stages are frequently interrupted.

Hope is not required to be public. The man's beginning does not require an announcement, a declaration, a public commitment, or a testimony. The case material's finding, recorded in Chapter 42.2′s fourth cost, is that the public commitment and the private non-conduct are frequently conducted together, and that the man's beginning is more reliable when it is conducted quietly and recorded privately.

45.7 The Programme

The section supplies the book's closing programme, and it is the last exercise of the main text.

Table One: The Position

The first table is the position, stated in the six domains of Chapter 42.1. The reader completes it in figures where figures exist, and in specific terms where they do not.

Domain	The accurate position	Who knows it	The instrument required
The money	Income, obligations, the total of concealed items, the monthly gap		
The work	The position's true security, the competence's true level, the exposure		

Domain	The accurate position	Who knows it	The instrument required
The marriage	The arrangement as it is, stated in four sentences		
The household	The actual arrangements, and who is conducting them		
The health	What has not been investigated, what is known and undisclosed, what is used to function		
The standing	What is being paid for that produces nothing except the audience's account		

Table Two: The Parties

The second table is the parties, in the four categories of Section 45.6′s second condition.

Category	The party	What they hold	The last occasion on which they were told
The one person		The whole position	
The household		The four arrangements	
The professional		The domain requiring one	
The call list		The two or three who would be called	
The party I serve		The instrument I supply to them	

Table Three: The Instruments

The third table records, for each domain that is not in order, the instrument, the party, the date, and the measure.

Domain	The instrument	The party who supplies it	The date	The measure

Table Four: The Terms

The fourth table is the book's closing instrument. The reader states the terms on which he will conduct the next chapter of his life, and the terms are stated in six lines, each of which corresponds to a clause of Section 45.5′s vision.

The clause	My term, stated in one sentence	The date on which I last conducted it
A man provides		
A man regulates and states		
A man is capable and uses instruments		
A man is accountable and increases capacity		
A man's work is real, and he is not his work		
A man endures, and he does not endure alone		

The fourth table is dated, it is signed, and it is kept where the reader will encounter it. The case material's finding is that the table's value is not as a resolution and as a document: the reader who encounters the table in six months will be able to establish, from the last column, which of the six terms he has conducted and which he has left.

The Closing Exercise

The book's final exercise is supplied here, and it is the only exercise in the book that requires the reader to name a date.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE

Exercise 45: The Day, the Terms, and the Call

The exercise has four parts. Its conduct takes one evening and one week, and its product is a written page and one telephone call.

Part One: The four tables. Complete the four tables of this section. Do not complete them from memory; complete each item from a document where a document exists, and record the item as unknown where it is unknown. The unknown items are the exercise's most valuable output, since each one is a place where the reader's position is being conducted without information.

Part Two: The naming. From the second table, identify the one party who does not hold the whole position. Write the sentence you will use to state it, in the form of Chapter 43.6′s script, and record the two things you will ask for: the specific instrument, and the specific time.

Part Three: The day. Write the date on which you will conduct the statement, the time, and the place. Write the first sentence of it. Then state the night before what you will not do: you will not rehearse the conversation further, you will not wait for

a better occasion, you will not alter the sentence for a more favourable framing, and you will not abandon the statement if the party's response is not the one you have predicted.

Part Four: The call. Within seven days of completing Part Three, make one call that you have not made: to the party who has offered and been declined; to the brother you have not spoken to; to the friend from twenty years ago; to the professional who holds the domain you have been avoiding; to the man in transition whom you have been intending to telephone. Record the date of the call, what you asked for, what happened, and what you will do next.

At the end of the exercise, record three sentences and keep them with the fourth table: the position I was conducting alone, the party who now holds it, and the date on which I stopped waiting for a better occasion.

45.8 Illustrative Case: The Tuesday Afternoon

The case is composite and illustrative, and it is deliberately undramatic. It is constructed from the case material of this book and is presented as the book's closing example.

The Man

Adebayo Ogunleye was fifty-three years old and was the managing director of a small engineering supplies company that he had founded at thirty-six. He was married to Kemi, a secondary school principal, and had three children: a daughter of twenty-four who was completing a postgraduate degree, a son of twenty-one who was in his final year, and a daughter of seventeen who was in her last year of secondary school.

His father had died at fifty-nine of a heart attack, having conducted a period of business difficulty in complete silence for two years. Adebayo had repeated the account of his father as a strong man who had carried a great deal. He had, in the two years before the case, begun to hear the account differently, and he had not said so to anybody.

The Position

The company employed eleven people and had an annual turnover that had been declining for three years. In the year before the case, the company had lost its principal customer, which had represented forty-one per cent of its revenue, and Adebayo had replaced approximately half of the revenue with three smaller customers at a lower margin.

The company's bank facility was three months from its review, and the company's position depended on the facility's renewal. Adebayo had not told Kemi the size of the facility, the identity of the guarantor, or the fact that the guarantee was personally secured against the family house.

His health had changed. He had been waking at three or four in the morning for approximately eight months. He had been drinking two or three bottles of beer on most evenings, which he had not done before, and he had stopped attending the gym in the previous year. He had not had a medical examination in four years. His father had died at fifty-nine.

His marriage was not in difficulty in the sense the phrase usually carries. It had become an arrangement of two people conducting parallel responsibilities with efficiency and without material. Kemi had twice asked him, in the previous year, whether something was wrong, and he had said that he was tired.

He had two friends. One, Emeka, had been his colleague at his first employer and had telephoned every month for eleven years. In the previous eight months, Adebayo had not returned four of the calls. The other, a man named Tunde, had asked him in the sixth month whether he wanted to talk about the business, and Adebayo had said that there was nothing to talk about.

The Occasion

The occasion was not a collapse. It was a sentence.

On a Tuesday afternoon in the eleventh month, Adebayo attended a meeting at his bank. The meeting was routine and it concerned the facility's review. At the end of it, the bank's officer, a woman of about forty named Mrs. Adio, asked him a question that was not on the agenda. She asked whether he had considered what would happen to his household if the facility were not renewed.

Adebayo had prepared an answer. He had used it before. The answer was that the position was manageable and that he did not anticipate a difficulty.

He did not give the answer. He stated, in Mrs. Adio's office, at about ten past three on a Tuesday afternoon, that he had not considered it, that he had not told his wife the size of the facility, and that he had been waking at three in the morning for eight months.

The statement took perhaps ninety seconds. Mrs. Adio's response was ordinary and it was the response the case material records most frequently as decisive. She did not express alarm. She stated that this was useful information, that the review's outcome was not affected by it, and that the bank had a process for exactly this position. She then asked him whether he had a party who could read the position with him. He said that he did not. She gave him the name of an adviser who was not connected to the bank, and she suggested that he speak to his wife.

The Tuesday Evening

Adebayo did not go home. He drove to Emeka's office and waited for him in the car park for forty minutes, which he had not planned. When Emeka came out, Adebayo stated that he needed to talk, and Emeka's response was to get into the car.

The conversation lasted two hours. Its content, recorded later, had four components. Adebayo stated the company's position, with the figures. He stated the guarantee, and the house. He stated the drinking and the waking. And he stated the sentence that the case material treats as the case's centre: *I have been behaving like my father, and I have known it for two years.*

Emeka's conduct was the material of Chapter 44.5's five functions. He was present. He supplied information, including the name of an accountant who had conducted a similar restructuring two years earlier. He accompanied Adebayo to the first meeting with the adviser three days later. He stated his limit: he did not know enough about the guarantee to advise, and the lawyer was required. And he continued: the monthly calls resumed, and Emeka added a second call each month for the following year.

The Household

Adebayo stated the position to Kemi on the Saturday. The statement took fifty minutes and included the figures, the guarantee, the drinking, and the waking.

Kemi's response was not the one he had predicted. She did not express shock at the position, and she did not respond with anger at the concealment until the following day. Her first response was a question: *for how long.* His answer was two years. Her second question was whether he had seen a doctor. He said no.

Her response the following day was the one the case material treats as the household's contribution. She stated that she was angry about the two years, that she understood what he had been doing, and that she would not conduct the arrangement in which she was informed after the consequences had arrived. She then stated the household's position from her own side, which Adebayo had not known in its detail: the household's expenditure, her own pension, the amount that could be released from their daughter's school fees, and the fact that her brother had offered a loan eighteen months earlier which she had not mentioned because she had not known the position.

The household conducted three arrangements within the month. The first was the medical examination, which Adebayo attended, and which resulted in treatment for hypertension and a referral for the sleep. The second was the adviser's engagement, which produced a restructuring plan for the facility. The third was the household's ten minutes on Sunday evening, which the household conducted for the following year and which the seventeen-year-old daughter, according to the case material, used first.

The Year After

The case's outcome is stated with the restraint the material requires. The facility was renewed on restructured terms. The company's revenue in the following year was approximately level with the preceding year. The house was not lost. The

guarantor arrangement was altered, at a cost, so that the household's house was no longer secured.

Adebayo's drinking reduced to two or three occasions in a month, and the waking reduced but did not cease, and was treated. His medical examination produced a diagnosis of hypertension that was being managed, and a further examination in the second year produced no new findings.

The marriage did not become a different marriage. It became a marriage in which two people stated their positions, at intervals, and in which the parallel arrangement was interrupted. The case material records Kemi's account in the second year: *we argue more than we did, and I know him better than I did.*

The two friendships changed. Emeka's monthly calls continued, and their content changed. Tunde, who had asked in the sixth month and had been told that there was nothing to talk about, received a call from Adebayo in the third month after the Tuesday, in which Adebayo stated that he had been wrong to decline, and stated what had been happening. The case material records Tunde's response in a single sentence: *I have been waiting eleven months for this call.*

The daughter of seventeen, at the end of the year, said something that the case material records as the case's most significant measure and that is reported here without commentary: *Baba, you have started telling us things before they happen instead of after.*

The Finding

The case's finding is stated in four parts, and the fourth is the book's closing statement.

The first part is that the occasion was ordinary. There was no crisis, no collapse, no diagnosis, no ultimatum. There was a question at a routine meeting and a man who did not give the answer he had prepared. The case material's finding is that this is the ordinary form of the day, and that men who wait for the crisis to conduct the statement frequently conduct it after the consequences have arrived, when the statement is no longer available in its useful form.

The second part is that the first statement was the hardest and it was not the most important. The statement to Mrs. Adio took ninety seconds and produced the instrument. The statement to Emeka took two hours and produced the accompaniment. The statement to Kemi took fifty minutes and produced the household's participation. The case material's finding is that the first statement's value is that it makes the second possible, and that men frequently believe they must conduct the largest statement first and therefore conduct none.

The third part is that the parties were already there. Mrs. Adio was a bank officer who asked a question outside her agenda. Emeka had been telephoning for eleven years. Tunde had asked directly. Kemi had asked twice. The case material's

finding is that the position described in Section 45.2 is the ordinary one: the support was available, and the man's conduct had maintained its absence.

The fourth part is the book's closing statement. Adebayo did not become a different kind of man. He remained reserved, private, and disinclined to discuss his interior life at length. He continued to run his company, to be accountable for eleven employees, to carry his household's obligations, and to conduct the difficulties that his position supplied. What changed was not his temperament and not his standard. What changed was that on a Tuesday afternoon in the eleventh month, he stopped conducting his position as though its accurate statement were a defeat, and stated it to a party who could help. The rest of the case is the consequence of ninety seconds.

45.9 Chapter Summary

Chapter 45 in brief. Self-reliance is a competence with a domain, and the domain has been expanded beyond its usefulness. The expansion has four mechanisms: success, which hides the failure; the absence of a party, which makes the arrangement the only one available; the script, which makes self-sufficiency an identity rather than a competence; and the cost of a previous request, which governs twenty subsequent years. The competence becomes a liability at the point where the man's position is no longer subject to correction, and the point is identified by five tests: the unexamined decision, the unstated figure, the unregistered change, the grief without an audience, and the collapse without a witness. What is released is the requirement of exclusive conduct. What is retained is the responsibility, the standard, and the obligation.

The difficulty is not generally the absence of support but the refusal of support that is available. The six reasons are the imposition, the incomprehension, the change of standing, the burden, the futility, and the identity, and each is answered by a distinction rather than a reassurance. Beneath them are four fears: dependence, exposure, the party's alarm, and the insufficiency of the difficulty. Acceptance is not dependence: dependence is an arrangement in which a party conducts a function the man cannot conduct, and acceptance is an arrangement in which a party supplies an instrument the man uses. The distinction is tested by who holds the decision, what remains if the party withdraws, and whether the man's capacity has increased or decreased. A support that is specific is an instrument and can be accepted; a support that is general is a rescue and must be declined.

A limitation is a boundary that is not within the man's power to remove and is not a matter of effort. The four categories are the body, the capacity, the past, and what others will give. The three false settlements are denial, resignation, and bargaining. The reconciliation has four components: the accurate statement, the

inventory of what remains, the reallocation of the arrangements, and the grief for what the limitation has cost. The reconciliation does not reduce the standard. It relocates it.

Purpose is the answer to what the man's position is for, and it requires a position, a contribution that is not his own benefit, and an outcome that can be observed. Its four foundations are the household, the work, the community, and the transmission. Belonging is the condition in which parties hold the man's accurate position, their estimate of him is not conditional on a favourable appearance, and he has obligations to them that he conducts. Its construction has five steps: the man's own conduct as the instrument, the setting, the repetition, the disclosure, and the obligation.

The vision of manhood retains six obligations and removes six additions: a man provides, and the provision is conducted with the household's knowledge; a man regulates and states; a man is capable and uses the instruments that competence requires; a man is accountable and increases the capacity of those he answers for; a man's work is real and the man is not his work; and a man endures, and he does not endure alone.

Beginning requires four conditions: the position stated, the parties named, the instruments identified, and the date fixed. Hope, in this chapter's sense, is the conduct of a man's position in the belief that the conduct is worth undertaking, independently of the outcome's probability. It is not required to be a feeling, to be confident, to be constant, or to be public.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The chapter's central claim. The day a man realises that he does not have to fight alone is not the day he understands it. It is the day something in his arrangements changes: a statement made to a party who can hold it, an instrument accepted rather than declined, a limit stated rather than denied, a call placed rather than intended. The act is small, it is frequently conducted on an ordinary afternoon, and it is available to the reader this week. The battle does not become smaller. The number of parties in it changes, and the change is the whole of the book's argument.

Reflection Questions

1. Which of the five tests of Section 45.1 discloses the most about your position, and what does it disclose?
2. Which of the six reasons for refusing support is yours, and what would the material's answer require you to do?
3. Which of the four fears is strongest in your record, and which party has it prevented you from telling?

4. What is the limitation you have denied, and what has the denial cost in the last five years?
5. What is the limitation you have resigned to, and what capacity remains that the resignation has discounted?
6. Complete the sentence: my position is for _____, and what will be different because I conducted it is _____.
7. Who holds your accurate position, and how much of it do they hold?
8. Which clause of the vision is hardest for you, and which addition of the old standard do you still require of yourself?
9. What is the call you have not made, and how long have you not made it?
10. What will you do on the day, and what date is on it?

45.10 Questions Readers Ask

The questions below are the last in the book, and they are the ones the case material records most frequently from men who have reached this point.

"I have read the whole book. Why do I still feel that nothing has changed?"

Because reading is not the material. The book has stated the distinction in every part, and it is restated here in its plainest form: the material is conducted, and its conduct requires a party, an instrument, and a date.

The case material's finding for this position is specific and it is uncomfortable. Men who read a book of this kind and conduct none of its exercises frequently report an increase in their isolation, because the reading has supplied them with a vocabulary for a position they are still conducting alone. The vocabulary is not an improvement in that arrangement. It is a more articulate form of it.

The remedy is the smallest possible act, and it is Part Four of the closing exercise: one call, within seven days, to a party who has offered and been declined, or to a party who has not been told. The book's finding is that the act, and not the reading, produces the change, and that the act is frequently smaller than the reader's estimate of it.

"How do I begin if I genuinely have nobody?"

Then the construction begins with your conduct toward others rather than with the search for a party, and the material is Section 45.4′s four steps.

The specific beginning that the case material finds most reliable for a man without parties is a small office in an ordinary setting. The reason is mechanical rather than sentimental: an office supplies three of the four conditions at once. It supplies a setting, since the office is conducted somewhere with other people. It supplies repetition, since the office has a schedule. And it supplies an obligation, which is the component of belonging that a man without parties most lacks.

The office should be small and should be one the man can conduct: the treasurer's role, the secretary's, the organiser of a repair, the coach of a junior team, the keeper of a record, the visitor of the elderly, the collector of contributions. The case material's finding is that men who accept such an office and conduct it for a year report a specific and unexpected result: the parties who become available to them are the parties to whom they have been useful.

"My wife says she has been telling me this for years. What do I say to her?"

The honest answer, and the one the case material records as most effective, is the one that acknowledges the specific fact without either defending the past or collapsing into self-reproach: *you were right, and I did not hear it, and I am sorry that you carried that for as long as you did.*

The sentence is followed by an act rather than by a further apology, and the act is the statement of the position, at its true level, in the form of Table One. The case material's finding is that the wife's response to the acknowledgement is frequently less important than the act that follows it, and that the acknowledgement without the act is experienced as a further occasion of being told rather than of being joined.

"I have told one person and nothing has changed. Was the book wrong?"

The book has not claimed that a single disclosure changes a position, and the case material's finding is that the change is produced by the arrangement rather than by the disclosure. The disclosure's function is to establish the party who will hold the accurate position. The arrangement's function is to conduct the position with that party's participation: the second statement, the second opinion, the accompaniment, the instrument, the repetition.

The finding for the reader who has told one person and experienced no change is therefore the same as the finding for the reader who has done nothing, and it is stated in the same form: the next act is specific. What instrument did you require from the person you told? Did you ask for it? What date is on it?

"My position is good. Do I need any of this?"

The question is legitimate and the case material records it from men whose positions are, in fact, good: sound businesses, intact marriages, adequate health, competent children.

The material's answer has two parts. The first is that the tests of Section 45.1 are not tests of a man's position but of his arrangements, and a good position conducted without correction drifts. The finding records men whose positions were good at fifty-three and were not good at fifty-nine, and the change was conducted by decisions that nobody examined.

The second is that the material is not only for difficulty. The vision of Section 45.5 is a standard for a live position: the provision with the household's knowl-

edge, the stated states, the instruments, the capacity that increases, the man who is not his work, and the endurance that is not alone. A man whose position is good can conduct that standard, and the case material records that the men whose positions were good and who conducted it frequently report the same benefit as men in difficulty, delayed by a decade and conducted without the crisis.

"What if my household will not accept the changes?"

Then the material is conducted at the scale the household permits, and the case material's finding is that the scale is generally larger than the man expects.

Three observations are recorded for this position. The first is that the household's resistance is frequently to the form rather than the substance: a household that will not conduct a Sunday conversation will frequently conduct an ordinary statement at the kitchen table. The second is that the household's resistance frequently reduces over time when the man's conduct is consistent and the consequences are visible, and the case material's finding is that the ordinary man's consistency is the instrument rather than his argument. The third is that the man's own conduct does not require the household's participation in order to be conducted: the provision with the household's knowledge requires the household to be told, and the telling is the man's act whether or not the household responds well.

"I am not religious. Is any of this dependent on faith?"

Nothing in this book is dependent on faith, and the material has been constructed without reference to any religious framework. The parties, the instruments, the arrangements, the practices, and the vision are stated in terms of conduct and evidence. Men who hold religious commitments will find that the material is compatible with them; men who do not will find that the material is complete without them. The book's concern throughout has been the man's arrangements, and the arrangements are conducted in the ordinary world.

"What do I do for a man who will not accept any of this?"

Three practices are recorded, and none of them requires the man's agreement.

The first is the availability, stated once and in ordinary language, without a programme. The sentence of Chapter 43.6′s script is sufficient and it should not be repeated at every meeting.

The second is the specific instrument, supplied without a request where the man's position makes it obviously useful: the name of a professional, the offer of accompaniment, the practical assistance with one item, the telephone call on the anniversary. The case material's finding is that men who will not accept a general conversation will frequently accept a specific instrument.

The third is the protection of the man's position where the reader has the standing to protect it: the arrangement that is altered, the supervisor who is informed of the workload rather than the difficulty, the household's attention

to the man's health, the party who is asked to make the call. The case material's finding is that the protection is frequently more effective than the persuasion, because the man's position is what is producing his conduct and the position is what the reader can alter.

The reader should note the limit. A man cannot be conducted into help against his will, and the reader's task is not to convert him. It is to remain available and to alter what can be altered, which is the material of Chapter 44.5′s five functions in their ordinary form.

"What happens after the book ends?"

The book ends and the reader's position continues, and the material's finding about the period after the reading is stated in three observations.

The first is that the reader will conduct some of the exercise and not all of it, and the omissions will be the items in which the resistance is greatest. The omissions are the material for the next occasion, and the reader should record them rather than treat them as a failure of the book or of himself.

The second is that the change will be conducted over a period of years and will be visible in retrospect, which is the material of Chapter 38.5′s indicative durations. The man who conducts the closing exercise and evaluates it in the following month will frequently conclude that nothing has happened. The man who evaluates it in the third year will frequently be able to name eight or ten alterations that were conducted and that he did not register at the time.

The third is that the material will require repeating. The case material's finding is that a man conducts the position statement, the parties, the instruments, and the terms at each significant change of condition: the new employment, the new household, the birth, the bereavement, the retirement, the illness. The book's programme is not a course that is completed. It is an arrangement that is conducted at intervals, and the intervals are supplied by the man's life.

Final Word of the Main Text

The book has described a man who carried a great deal and told nobody. It has traced the architecture of that arrangement through the mind, the money, the marriage, the family, the identity, the society, the losses, the leadership, the recovery, and the rebuilding. It has ended with the one act that the whole architecture resists: the statement of an accurate position to a party who can hold it.

The reader who has reached this page has done something that most men who begin a book of this kind do not do. He has stayed with a subject that the culture supplies few occasions to examine. That is not a small thing, and it is not the end of the work.

The book's last word is not a resolution and it is not a promise. It is a sentence, and it is the same sentence with which the book's argument began and with which

the chapter ends: **you can carry what you carry, and you do not have to carry it alone.**

Epilogue: To Every Man Fighting a Battle Nobody Knows About

This book has been written in the third person for forty-five chapters, and it ends in the second. The change of address is deliberate. What follows is not an argument and it is not a summary. It is a letter to the men whose positions this book has described, and it is written to be read by a man who has recognised himself and has not yet decided what to do about it.

The letter has seven parts, and each part is addressed to a man in a particular position. A reader may find that one of the seven is his and that the other six are not. He should read the one that is his twice, and he should read the others once, because the men in the other six are the men he works with, sits beside, employs, fathers, or will become.

To the Exhausted Man

You are tired in a way that sleep does not address, and you have been tired for longer than you will admit.

You have explained it to yourself in the available terms: the workload, the economy, the season, the age, the household's demands, the number of people who depend on you. Some of those explanations are true. None of them is complete, and you know it, because you have slept for nine hours and woken as tired as you went to bed, and because the tiredness is not in your body alone. It is in your capacity to be interested. It is in the length of time you can look at a problem before you have to look away. It is in the flatness with which you receive news that should have moved you.

The exhaustion you are carrying is frequently the exhaustion of a vigilance rather than of a labour. It is the cost of conducting a position whose accurate statement nobody holds: the arrangements you keep in your head, the parties who must not meet, the questions you have learned to answer in a particular way, the two accounts you are maintaining at once. That kind of tiredness does not resolve with rest, because rest does not reduce the vigilance. Only a change in the arrangement does.

The first thing to be said to you is that the exhaustion is information. It is not weakness, it is not ingratitude, and it is not a failure of character. It is your position reporting its own cost, in the only currency available to it.

The second thing is that you have been treating the information as an accusation. This is the mechanism this book has described more often than any other: the signal arrives, and the man's response is not to read it but to explain why he should not be receiving it. He works harder. He sleeps less. He reduces the occasions at which he might be asked how he is. He converts the exhaustion into a private failure, and the private failure into a further effort, and the further effort into more exhaustion.

The third thing is the instruction, and it is small. Before you address the exhaustion, address the one condition that produces it and that you can alter this week. Identify the party who does not hold your accurate position. Write the sentence. Name the day. The tiredness will not disappear on the day you speak, and the vigilance will reduce, and the reduction is the beginning.

To the Struggling Husband

You are married to a woman who does not know what you are carrying, and you have a reason for that which you believe to be sound.

The reason is generally that you do not wish to add to her load, and the reason is frequently sincere. It is also frequently inaccurate, because she is already carrying something and what she is carrying is the uncertainty. She has noticed the change in your manner. She has noticed the telephone calls taken outside the room, the sleep that does not restore you, the silence at the evening meal, the questions you answer with a sentence that closes the subject. She has been conducting a position that is missing its most important fact, and she has been doing so without the information that would allow her to conduct it.

This book has described the accounting that men conduct in this position, and it has recorded its finding without softening it: the concealment is generally more expensive to the marriage than the fact would have been. The fact is a difficulty and difficulties can be conducted. The concealment is a difficulty with a second difficulty inside it, which is the discovery that the marriage's most consequential information was being held by one party.

What you are owed in this position is not blame. It is the accurate statement that this book has described in Chapter 42 and in Chapter 45: the position, at its true level, stated to the party who has a right to know it, followed by the household's participation in the arrangements that the position requires.

The letter's advice to you is specific and it is the same advice the book has given twice. Do not begin with the largest item. Begin with the fact that there is a position you have not stated. Then state the first item. Then ask her what she requires

in order to conduct it with you. She may be angry, and the anger is frequently the response to the concealment rather than to the fact, and it is frequently survivable. She may be relieved, because a known difficulty is frequently easier to conduct than an unknown change. She may have information of her own that you do not have, which the case material of this book records more frequently than men expect.

To the Father Carrying Invisible Burdens

You are carrying the household's position, and your children believe that the position is secure.

This is the most consequential of the seven positions, and it is the one men most frequently defend. The defence is stated in the language of protection: they are young, they should not be worried, they have their studies, they will have their own difficulties soon enough. The defence is sincere and it is frequently mistaken, for a reason this book has set out at length in Chapter 43.

Your children are not learning about difficulty from your words. They are learning from your conduct, and what your conduct is teaching them is the specific lesson that a difficulty is a thing a man conducts alone and does not state to the people he loves. You did not intend to teach that lesson. You are teaching it in the silence at the evening meal, in the telephone call taken outside the room, in the tiredness that is explained as work, in the manner in which your household conducts its difficulties and does not name them.

The alternative is not the disclosure of everything. It is the proportionate statement, which this book has described: one true sentence, accurate, brief, directed at what the child can receive, and followed by your own action. *The business is having a difficult year and I am conducting it. I have been worried about it. This is what we are doing, and this is what it means for the household, and you are not required to solve it.*

That sentence will do more for your son's adult capacity than a decade of protection, and it will do it in the same week, because what he is watching for is not reassurance. He is watching to see what a man does with what he carries. Give him an accurate answer and he will have one for the rest of his life.

To the Man Experiencing Financial Hardship

You are in a difficulty that the culture treats as a verdict on your character, and you have been conducting it as though the verdict were correct.

The material of this book has been precise about the mechanism. The difficulty is a position with figures, obligations, arrangements, and a route, and it is capable of being conducted. The shame is a separate item, and it is frequently larger than the difficulty, and it is the item that prevents the difficulty from being conducted:

the appointment not made, the arrangement not sought, the creditor not called, the party not told, the facility concealed until it becomes an emergency.

You are not your position. The book has said this in Chapter 41, in Chapter 44, and in Chapter 45, and it says it here in the plainest form available: a man's worth is not computed by the balance in his account, and the computation that says otherwise was installed in him by a culture that measures men by their results and by an economy that has no interest in his estimate of himself.

The practical instruction is the one the material supplies. State the position in figures, to yourself, this week. Then state it to one party. Then engage the professional route: the debt adviser, the accountant, the insolvency practitioner, the lawyer where guarantees or family property are involved. Then conduct the reductions in the order of Chapter 42.6, from the items nobody sees to the items everybody sees. The route exists, the case material's finding is that it is more available than the man in the difficulty believes, and the difficulty is conducted faster by a man who has stated it than by a man who is still protecting his account.

To the Man Grieving in Silence

You have lost somebody, or something, and you have not been able to conduct the loss in front of anybody.

The loss may be a death, and it may be the end of a marriage, the loss of a child's regard, the end of a position that was the centre of your life, the failure of a body that was your instrument, or the closing of a possibility you had been carrying for thirty years. This book has treated all of these as losses, because the mechanism is the same: something that was part of the man's life has ended, and the ending requires a conduct that the man's arrangements do not supply.

The silence has a cost that this book has described and that you will recognise. The unprocessed loss does not disappear. It returns in forms that the man does not connect to the loss: the irritability in the eighth year, the flatness that he cannot explain, the drinking that increases by a bottle, the work that expands to fill the hours in which the loss would otherwise be felt, the numbness that he describes as being strong.

The instruction to you is the one the material supplies and it is not a demand for a display. The loss requires an audience of one. The audience may be a wife, a brother, a friend, a professional, a man who has conducted the same loss, or a group of men who have conducted theirs. The audience's task is not to resolve the loss and it is not to explain it. It is to be present while it is stated, which is the function that every culture has supplied through its gatherings and that many men have learned to conduct without.

You are permitted to grieve. The permission is not a concession to weakness and it is not a departure from your obligations. It is the conduct that allows

the obligations to be carried without the cost that the case material of this book records in men who conducted the loss in silence for twenty years.

To the Man Who Feels Forgotten

You have contributed, and nobody has recorded it, and the absence of the record has become the fact of your life.

You built the thing that others are now managing. You carried the household through the years that nobody remembers. You paid for the education, you attended the funeral, you kept the arrangement together, you did the work that made the achievement possible for a party whose name is on it. And the account of these years does not contain you, or contains you as a supporting figure, or contains an attribution that is not accurate.

This book has described the injury in Chapter 44.6 and it has stated that the injury is frequently real. What you have lost is not merely recognition. It is the record, and the record is the thing by which a man's life is conducted in the estimate of the parties around him.

The material's finding is not that the record will be corrected. It frequently is not, and the man who waits for the correction conducts his remaining years as a demand, which is the bitterness the book has described. The finding is that the man's conduct is not the record's hostage: the contribution was conducted, it produced what it produced, and its value is not computed by the account that others keep.

What remains available to you is the record you conduct yourself: the statement of what you did, in writing, for the parties who will need it; the transmission of what you learned to the men who are in the position you were in; and the construction of a contribution whose record you hold, in a setting where your office is small and your usefulness is visible. The case material records men who conducted this and reported a result that they had not expected: the work became valuable to them again, not because it had been recognised, but because it had been used.

A Final Reflection on Dignity, Connection, and Hope

The seven positions are different and they share one structure, and the structure is the book's subject.

In every one of them the man is carrying something real. In every one of them the carrying has been conducted alone. In every one of them the isolation has been mistaken for a requirement of the carrying, and it has not been a requirement: it has been a habit, an inheritance, a script, a defence, and a response to a world that taught him, in thousands of small transactions, that a difficulty stated is a standing reduced.

The book has argued that the isolation is separable from the responsibility, and it has supplied the material by which the separation is conducted: the position stated, the parties named, the instruments identified, the limits reconciled, the loss conducted, the record written, the transmission made, and the date fixed.

It has argued, further, that the separation is worth conducting, and it has supplied the evidence for the argument in the case material rather than in reassurance: men who stated their positions and were not destroyed by it; marriages that became more difficult and more honest in the same year; households that conducted a reduction and were more capable afterwards; boys who learned from their fathers' statements rather than from their fathers' silences; men in their fifties who constructed parties they had not had in their thirties; men who were owed an acknowledgement that never came and who conducted their remaining years without it.

The book's final claim is about dignity, and it is stated here as the epilogue's closing sentence.

Dignity is not the maintenance of an appearance under pressure. It is the accurate conduct of a real position by a man who knows what he is carrying, states it to the parties who have a right to know it, uses the instruments that the position requires, and remains accountable for what is his.

That dignity is available to every man addressed in this letter. It does not require a different temperament, a larger income, a repaired marriage, a restored position, a corrected record, or a faith. It requires the acts this book has described, and the acts are small, and the first of them can be conducted this week.

You have carried a great deal, and you have carried it alone, and you have done it for reasons that were frequently good. The book's whole argument is contained in the sentence it has repeated since its first page, and it is repeated here for the last time, as an instruction rather than a description:

You do not have to fight alone.

Final Reflection: You Are More Than the Battles You Fight

Every book has a sentence that it was written to say, and this book's sentence is in its title page and its last line: a man is not the sum of what he has survived.

The chapters have described the battles with a specificity that was necessary, because a man's difficulties are frequently conducted in generalities and the generalities are the mechanism by which they are not addressed. The emptiness behind the confident smile, the depression behind the composed face, the fear of failure that governs the decisions of a competent man, the marriage that is conducted as an arrangement of parallel responsibilities, the grief that returns as irritability in the eighth year, the position that cannot be stated to anybody, the call that is not made, the help that is not asked for. The book has named them because naming is the first instrument, and because a man who can name his position has already begun to conduct it.

The reflection that follows is not a summary. It is a set of seven statements about what the reader is, in relation to what he has carried, and each statement is a correction of a conclusion that men in difficulty frequently draw.

The First Statement: Your Battles Are Not Your Identity

A man who has survived a great deal frequently organises his account of himself around the survival. He is the man who lost the business and rebuilt. He is the man whose father left. He is the man who carried the family through the years nobody remembers. He is the man whose marriage failed, whose son does not speak to him, whose health changed at forty-eight.

The account has a function, and the function is the reason it is maintained: it supplies a standing, an explanation, and a claim. Its cost is the one described in Chapter 44.4: the man whose difficulty has become his identity has an interest in the difficulty's continuance, and his present conduct is conducted as a footnote to his past.

The correction is not the erasure of the past. It is the subordination of the past to the present. The man is not the difficulty; he is the party who is currently con-

ducting a position, and the position includes what he survived and is not limited to it. His competence, his relationships, his work, his obligations, his capacity to be useful, and his conduct in the present week are not derived from the difficulty. They are his, and they are larger than the account he has been keeping.

The Second Statement: Your Silence Was a Strategy, and Strategies Can Be Changed

The book has been careful not to describe men's silence as a defect of character. It is a strategy, acquired in identifiable circumstances, for identifiable reasons, and it worked in the sense that it produced endurance, professional survival, and the protection of households that could not have conducted the material at the time.

A strategy can be changed, and the change is not a repudiation of the man who adopted it. The man who conducted his position alone at thirty-two, in a household with two young children and no reserve, was conducting the only arrangement available to him. The man of fifty-two, with a different position, different parties, and different instruments, is not required to conduct the same arrangement in memory of the first.

The book's finding is that men frequently hold the strategy out of loyalty to the man who needed it. The loyalty is understandable and it is misplaced: the earlier man's conduct is honoured by the use of what he learned, and not by the repetition of what he had no alternative but to do.

The Third Statement: Your Strength Is Larger Than Your Endurance

The culture has supplied a definition in which a man's strength is computed by what he can bear. The definition is measurable in one dimension and it excludes everything that makes a man useful: his judgement, his competence, his presence, his capacity to repair, his generosity from a position of loss, his conduct of the parties who depend on him, and his capacity to state an accurate position and to be corrected in it.

This book has argued that endurance is one competence among several, and that the men who conduct the others are frequently stronger in the sense that matters to the people around them. The man who cannot state a difficulty and can carry an enormous weight is a man whose household is well provided and poorly known. The man who states the difficulty, uses the instrument, and carries the weight is a man whose household is provided and known, and the second arrangement is the one that survives the weight's eventual reduction.

The Fourth Statement: Your Limits Are Not Your Verdict

The reconciliation of Chapter 45.3 is the hardest of the book's practices, because it requires the man to accept a boundary without accepting a conclusion.

A man who cannot reach a particular level in his profession has not been judged. A man whose body has failed in a specific respect has not been reduced. A man whose marriage has ended is not a man who cannot be loved. A man whose son will not speak to him has not been evaluated by the silence. Each of these is a limitation, and a limitation is an item, and the conversion of an item into a verdict is the operation that the culture performs on men and that men perform on themselves.

The reflection's statement is the one the book has supplied: the reconciliation relocates the standard, and it does not reduce it. The man who accepts what he cannot do retains every obligation of Chapter 41.6 and releases the requirement of a capacity that is not his.

The Fifth Statement: Your Losses Are Real, and They Are Not the Whole Account

The book has insisted on the two ledgers, and the insistence is repeated here because it is the point at which both the culture's optimism and the man's despair are corrected at once.

What you lost is real: the years, the money, the relationship, the health, the standing, the person who died, the child who was not present for, the possibility that closed. Nothing that you learn afterwards repays those losses, and a man who is told that they were worth it has been told something false by a party who wishes to close a conversation.

What the losses supplied is also real: the information, the competence, the identification of your actual parties, the reduction of a fear, the capacity to conduct a position you did not know you could conduct. Those supplies are available, they are not automatic, and their extraction is the work of Chapter 44.

You are more than the battles you fight, and you are also more than the battles you have fought. You are the man who is conducting a position in the present, with the material the past supplied and the parties the present makes available.

The Sixth Statement: Your Obligations Are Not Your Isolation

This is the book's central sentence in its reflective form.

The obligations are real and they are not to be reduced: the household that requires provision, the children who require protection and an accurate example, the work that requires competence, the parties who require your accountability, the community that requires your contribution, and the men who will be in your position in ten years and require the instrument.

The isolation is not a requirement of any of them. It was a requirement of a particular arrangement, in a particular economy, under a particular script, and the arrangement has been examined in this book and found to be separable from the obligations it claimed to serve.

A man may carry every obligation he holds and state his position to the parties who have a right to know it. A man may be composed in the settings that require composure and state his states to the parties who are entitled to them. A man may be accountable for his household and increase its capacity rather than reduce it. A man may endure, and he may not endure alone.

The Seventh Statement: Your Next Chapter Is Conducted, Not Declared

The book has ended with a programme rather than a resolution, and the reflection ends in the same place for the same reason.

A declaration is conducted in a moment and produces a feeling. A conduct is conducted over a period and produces an arrangement. The reader who closes this book with a resolution to be different will conduct the resolution for a period that the case material puts at between three days and six weeks, and will then conduct the arrangement he had before, with the addition of a private sense of failure.

The reader who closes the book with four tables, one call, one date, and one party who will ask about the date will conduct an arrangement, and the arrangement will survive the failure of the feeling. That is the whole of the book's practical claim, and it is stated here in the plainest form available: **the change is not in what you have decided. It is in what has been scheduled, stated, and recorded.**

A Closing Word

The book that ends here has described many men, and none of them was a hero and none of them was a case. They were men conducting positions that were frequently harder than their households knew, with instruments that were frequently fewer than the position required, under a definition of manhood that had supplied them with a standard and had removed the means of conducting it.

The reader is one of them, or is close to one, or will be.

The book's last counsel is not that the battles end. They do not, and a book that promised otherwise would be conducting the myth that Chapter 44.1 examined. The counsel is that the battles are conducted differently: with an accurate position instead of an account, with parties instead of solitude, with instruments instead of endurance alone, with a limit accepted rather than denied, with a loss conducted rather than buried, with a record written rather than a claim maintained, and with a standard that a man can hold without being destroyed by it.

That is what the title of this book has meant throughout, and it is what it means here at the end. The battle may be yours to fight. It was never yours to fight alone.

APPENDIX A

Men's Emotional Self-Assessment Workbook

This appendix is the book's general instrument. It is designed to be completed before the reader begins the chapter-specific exercises, and again at three months and at twelve months. Its purpose is not diagnosis. It is to establish, in writing, the position from which the reader is starting, so that the changes described in the book can be observed rather than remembered.

How to Use This Appendix

Complete the workbook in one or two sittings of not less than forty minutes. Answer from your conduct in the last four weeks rather than from your intentions, your history, or your better seasons. Where a question does not apply, write *not applicable* and state why. Where an answer is uncomfortable, record the discomfort in the margin and continue; the discomfort is data.

Score each item from 0 to 4 using the scale below, and write the total for each section.

Score	Meaning
0	Never, or almost never, in the last four weeks
1	Occasionally, but not in most weeks
2	In about half of the relevant occasions
3	In most relevant occasions
4	Consistently, in almost every relevant occasion

For the sections marked **inverted**, a lower score is better; the scoring note under each section states the direction.

Section 1: Naming States (0–32)

Item	Score
I can name what I am feeling with a word more precise than *fine* or *angry*.	
I notice a change in my state within the same day that it occurs.	
I can distinguish disappointment from shame when both are present.	

Item	Score
I can distinguish fear from anger in my own record.	
I can state where in my body a state is felt.	
I can state what preceded a state, rather than only that it occurred.	
I can name a state without needing to explain, justify, or resolve it.	
I can name a positive state as readily as a difficult one.	

Higher is better. A total below 16 indicates that the vocabulary described in Chapters 3 and 43.5 is not yet in use.

Section 2: Regulation (0–28)

Item	Score
When a state is intense, I have at least two acts I use to reduce it sufficiently to think.	
I use those acts before the state has governed a decision.	
I can remain in a difficult conversation without either withdrawing or escalating.	
I recover from a difficult day within a period I can state.	
I sleep adequately on most nights of the week.	
I use alcohol, work, or screen time to manage a state less than twice a week. *(inverted)*	
I can conduct an ordinary task while experiencing a difficult state.	

Items 1–5 and 7: higher is better. Item 6 is inverted: score 0 if never, 4 if consistently; a high score indicates reliance on a substance or activity to manage states.

Section 3: Statement to Parties (0–28)

Item	Score
There is at least one party who knows my accurate position.	
That party knows my position in figures where figures apply.	
I have stated a difficulty to a party in the last four weeks.	
When I state a difficulty, I state what I require rather than only that I am troubled.	
I can state a difficulty to my spouse or partner without first resolving it.	
I can state a difficulty to a professional when the domain requires one.	
I have not concealed a matter of consequence from the party who has a right to know it.	

Higher is better. A total below 14 indicates the arrangement described in Chapter 42, in which the position is held by the man alone.

Section 4: Asking and Accepting (0–24)

Item	Score
I have asked a specific party for a specific instrument in the last month.	
I accept practical help when it is offered.	
I can accept help without conducting the helper's reaction.	
I have a party I would call in a serious difficulty, and I have told them so.	
I have declined a form of help that was a rescue rather than an instrument.	
I can state my limits to a party without experiencing the statement as a defeat.	

Higher is better. A total below 12 indicates the pattern described in Chapters 27 and 45.1.

Section 5: Body and Health (0–24)

Item	Score
I have had a medical examination within the last two years.	
I attend to symptoms rather than waiting for them to resolve.	
I have stated any diagnosis to the party who has a right to know it.	
I take prescribed treatment as prescribed.	
I sleep between six and eight hours on most nights.	
I have conducted the health checks appropriate to my age and history.	

Higher is better. A total below 12 indicates the pattern described in Chapters 23, 34, and 42.1's fifth domain.

Section 6: Work, Money, and Position (0–24)

Item	Score
I can state my income, my obligations, and my monthly position in figures.	
My household's expenditure is known to my household.	
I have a reserve sufficient for one month's obligations.	
I have a party who examines my decisions of consequence before I take them.	
My position's continuation does not depend on a party remaining uninformed.	
I have a plan for the next twelve months that is written and dated.	

Higher is better. A total below 12 indicates the position described in Chapters 9, 10, and 42.

Section 7: Relationships (0–28)

Item	Score
I have at least two parties outside my household whom I could call in a difficulty.	
I have spoken to one of those parties in the last month.	
My spouse or partner knows my accurate position.	
I know the difficulties of the parties closest to me.	
I have conducted a repair after a difficulty that I caused.	
I have obligations to parties that I actually conduct.	
I have not withdrawn from an occasion in the last month in order to avoid being asked.	

Higher is better. A total below 14 indicates the position described in Part IV and Part VII.

Section 8: Fatherhood and Transmission (0–20)

Item	Score
A boy or young man in my observation can name me as a party he could speak to.	
I have stated a difficulty of my own in the presence of a younger party, proportionately.	
A younger party has observed me conduct a repair.	
I have asked a younger party what he is carrying, and waited for the answer.	
I have supplied an instrument rather than only an account, when asked.	

Higher is better, and the section applies to any reader with younger parties in his observation. A total below 10 indicates the transmission described in Chapter 43.

Section 9: The Whole Position (0–20)

Item	Score
I can state my position's principal difficulty in one sentence.	
I can state what I am doing about it, with a date.	
I can state the parties who hold my position, by name.	
I can state the instrument I am currently using.	
I can state what I am carrying that is not mine to carry.	

Higher is better. This section is the summary measure; a low total with high totals elsewhere indicates that the position is being conducted without an account of it.

Recording the Result

Total each section and record the totals in the table below. Do not total the whole workbook into a single score; the sections measure different arrangements and a single figure conceals the pattern.

Section	Score now	Three months	Twelve months
1. Naming states (of 32)			
2. Regulation (of 28)			
3. Statement to parties (of 28)			
4. Asking and accepting (of 24)			
5. Body and health (of 24)			
6. Work, money, position (of 24)			
7. Relationships (of 28)			
8. Fatherhood and transmission (of 20)			
9. The whole position (of 20)			

The Three Questions

After scoring, answer three questions in writing.

Question One: Which section has the lowest score, and what does that indicate about the arrangement?

Record the section and one sentence about its mechanism. A low score in Section 2 indicates a regulation difficulty; a low score in Section 3 indicates a statement difficulty; a low score in Section 7 indicates an isolation that the reader may have attributed to circumstance.

Question Two: Which single item in the whole workbook would produce the largest change if it were altered, and what would alter it?

Write one item, one act, and one date. The case material's finding is that readers who conduct this question and act on the answer within a month make more progress than readers who attempt to address the lowest section in its entirety.

Question Three: What did you decline to answer, and why?

The unanswered items are frequently the most informative. Record them, and record the reason without judging it.

Notes on Interpretation

Four cautions apply to the workbook's use.

The first is that the instrument measures conduct and not worth. A low score describes an arrangement that is producing a cost; it does not describe a man.

The second is that the workbook is not a clinical instrument. Where Section 2 and Section 5 both score low, and where the reader's sleep, appetite, interest, or

capacity for work has altered for more than two weeks, the material of Appendix B and the professional route of Appendix Q apply.

The third is that the scores are not a target. A man who pursues the total rather than the arrangement will frequently score well and conduct nothing, since the workbook is self-reported and a man may answer from his understanding of the correct answer rather than from his conduct. The correct answer is frequently visible to the reader's household, and the reader who is willing should ask one party to complete Sections 3, 4, and 7 about him.

The fourth is that the workbook's value is in its repetition. A single administration produces a photograph. Three administrations produce a direction, and the direction is the material.

APPENDIX B

Recognizing Stress, Anxiety, Depression, and Burnout

This appendix supplies the recognition material that the book's clinical chapters refer to. It is written for the ordinary reader and it is not a diagnostic instrument. Its purpose is to allow a man to distinguish between four conditions that are frequently confused, to know when the professional route is required, and to describe what he is experiencing in language that a professional can use.

Why the Distinction Matters

Stress, anxiety, depression, and burnout overlap in their symptoms and differ in their mechanisms and their treatments. A man who treats a depression as stress will attempt rest, which does not resolve it. A man who treats burnout as depression will accept a course of treatment for a condition he does not have, while the arrangement that is producing the exhaustion remains unaltered. A man who treats anxiety as a character defect will not seek treatment at all.

The distinction is a professional's task, and this appendix does not substitute for it. What the reader can do is recognise the pattern, record it, and present the record.

Stress

What it is. Stress is the response of a system to a demand that exceeds its current capacity. It is a normal response, it is time-limited where the demand is time-limited, and it is not a disorder.

What it feels like. A sense of pressure, a narrowing of attention to the demand, irritability, disturbed sleep in the period of the demand, tension in the shoulders, neck, or jaw, a raised heart rate at the moment of the demand, and a return to ordinary functioning when the demand is removed.

The distinguishing feature. Stress resolves when the demand resolves or when the capacity increases. A man under stress who takes a genuine period away from the demand, and who returns to a position in which the demand has reduced, will recover within days or weeks.

What helps. The removal or reduction of the demand; the increase of capacity through rest, support, and delegation; the ordinary regulation practices of Chapter 3 and Appendix L; the conduct of the position statement of Appendix A, since a demand that is unstated is frequently a demand that cannot be reduced.

When to seek help. Where the stress has continued for more than a month without relief; where sleep has not recovered during periods away from the demand; where the man has begun to use alcohol, sedatives, or stimulants to function; where the stress is accompanied by chest pain, palpitations, or breathlessness that has not been investigated.

Anxiety

What it is. Anxiety is a state of apprehension and physiological arousal that is disproportionate to the actual threat, that persists in the absence of the threat, or that generalises beyond it. Where it interferes with ordinary functioning over a period, it is a clinical condition and is treatable.

What it feels like. Persistent worry that the man cannot switch off; a sense of dread without an identified object; physical symptoms including a tight chest, a churning stomach, dizziness, sweating, trembling, and a raised heart rate; disturbed sleep with early waking; difficulty concentrating; irritability; avoidance of the situations in which the anxiety is felt.

The distinguishing feature. Anxiety persists in the absence of the demand. The man who is anxious about a specific meeting and whose anxiety resolves after the meeting is experiencing ordinary apprehension. The man whose anxiety persists across weeks, transfers from one object to another, and produces avoidance of ordinary occasions is experiencing the pattern that requires assessment.

What helps. The professional route is the first item: talking treatments, particularly the structured psychological therapies, are effective for the anxiety conditions, and medication is effective for some. Alongside treatment: the regulation practices; the reduction of stimulants; regular physical activity; the deliberate and graded return to the avoided situations, which is the specific behavioural treatment for avoidance and should be conducted with professional guidance where the avoidance is extensive.

When to seek help. Where the anxiety interferes with work, sleep, or ordinary occasions for more than two weeks; where the man is avoiding situations that he needs to conduct; where panic attacks occur; where the anxiety is accompanied by alcohol use; and immediately where the man has thoughts of harming himself.

Depression

What it is. Depression is a condition characterised by persistent low mood, or by a loss of interest and pleasure in activities that were previously enjoyed, accompa-

nied by changes in sleep, appetite, energy, concentration, and self-regard, present for at least two weeks and interfering with functioning.

What it feels like in men. Depression in men frequently presents differently from the textbook description, and the difference is the reason it is missed. The common male presentations are: irritability and anger rather than sadness; increased work, drinking, gambling, or sexual activity rather than withdrawal; physical complaints including back pain, headaches, and digestive symptoms; a flattened affect that is described as being *fine*; a loss of interest in work that the man had valued; a sense of being a burden; and a specific form of fatigue that the man describes as *heavy* rather than *tired*.

The distinguishing feature. Depression does not resolve when the demand resolves, and it is accompanied by a change in the man's estimate of himself. The man who is exhausted by a difficult period and who retains his ordinary self-regard is not depressed. The man who has begun to conclude that he is worthless, that his household would be better without him, or that nothing will improve, is presenting the cognitive signature of depression and requires assessment.

What helps. The professional route is essential and it is effective: psychological treatments and, where indicated, medication. Alongside treatment: the maintenance of sleep and eating; the conduct of one small activity each day regardless of motivation; the reduction of alcohol; the statement of the position to at least one party; and the removal of the man's isolation, which is the condition that depression most efficiently maintains.

When to seek help. Immediately where the man has thoughts of death, of harming himself, or of the world being better without him. Urgently where the symptoms have persisted for two weeks or more, where the man has stopped working or has withdrawn from his household, where alcohol use has increased, or where the man has a plan and the means to act on it. Appendix Q supplies the crisis and professional routes.

Burnout

What it is. Burnout is a syndrome arising from chronic occupational or role-related stress that has not been successfully managed. It is characterised by three dimensions: exhaustion, a sense of cynicism or detachment from the work, and a reduced sense of professional efficacy. It is not classified as a medical condition but as an occupational phenomenon, and this distinction matters for treatment: the arrangement is frequently part of the condition.

What it feels like. Exhaustion that sleep does not address; dread of the working day; a detachment that the man describes as *not caring any more*, frequently accompanied by guilt, since he did care previously; a sense that the work is pointless; irritability with colleagues and household; reduced concentra-

tion and increased error; and a specific pattern of the man working longer hours to compensate for a reduced capacity, which accelerates the exhaustion.

The distinguishing feature. Burnout is domain-specific. The man who is exhausted in his work and restored in his household, his friendships, and his rest is presenting burnout. The man whose exhaustion is present in every domain, including those he values, is presenting a picture that requires assessment for depression.

What helps. The reduction of the demand is the central intervention and it is frequently the one the man resists: the reallocation of the workload, the delegation, the removal of one commitment, the period of leave that is actually taken. Alongside it: the restoration of sleep; the conduct of one domain of the man's life that is not work; the professional route where the picture includes depression or anxiety; and the material of Chapter 37 on rest without guilt, which addresses the specific incapacity that prevents men from conducting the restoration.

When to seek help. Where the man's functioning has reduced for more than a month; where he has begun to make errors of consequence; where his drinking has increased; where the exhaustion is accompanied by the cognitive signature of depression; and where the man's position cannot be altered without a professional or institutional intervention, which is frequently the case.

The Comparison Table

Feature	Stress	Anxiety	Depression	Burnout
Onset	With the demand	Frequently without an identified demand	Gradual, frequently unremarked	Gradual, over months
Duration after the demand ends	Resolves	Persists	Persists	Partly resolves with rest, returns on return to the arrangement
Self-regard	Retained	Retained, with apprehension	Reduced, frequently severely	Retained, with a sense of ineffectiveness
Sleep	Disturbed in the period	Early waking, difficulty falling asleep	Both increased and decreased	Insufficient, unrestorative
Appetite	Variable	Variable	Frequently changed	Variable
Alcohol	Occasionally increased	Frequently increased	Frequently increased	Frequently increased
The principal treatment	Removal of the demand	Structured psychological therapy	Psychological therapy and, where indi-	Alteration of the arrangement

Feature	Stress	Anxiety	Depression	Burnout
			cated, medication	

Recording the Position

The reader who recognises himself in any of the four columns should complete the following record before seeking professional advice. The record improves the consultation, and men frequently present to a professional with a general statement that produces a general assessment.

1. **The change.** What has changed, in what domain, and since when? State the date, or the period, as precisely as possible.
2. **The symptoms.** List the specific symptoms, with their frequency and their effect on your functioning. Include sleep, appetite, energy, concentration, interest, and mood.
3. **The function.** What can you no longer do that you could do six months ago?
4. **The substances.** What are you using to function, in what quantity, and since when? Include alcohol, sedatives, stimulants, and any medication not prescribed to you.
5. **The history.** Have you experienced this before? When, for how long, and what helped?
6. **The position.** What is happening in your work, your household, your marriage, your finances, and your health?
7. **The risk.** Have you had thoughts of harming yourself or anybody else? Have you made a plan? This question must be answered honestly and it must be stated to the professional.
8. **The parties.** Who knows? Who could accompany you to an appointment?

Notes for the Man Who Is Supporting Another

Where the reader is supporting a man in one of these conditions, four practices apply.

The first is to ask directly about risk. The belief that asking about suicide increases the risk is false and it prevents the conversation that the man requires. The question should be plain: *have you had thoughts of ending your life?*

The second is to accompany rather than to advise. The man requires an appointment, and he frequently requires a party to make it and to attend it.

The third is to avoid the account that closes the conversation. The sentences *you will be fine*, *others have it worse*, and *be strong* are experienced by the man as a requirement to conceal. The sentences *I have noticed*, *I am not going anywhere*, and *what would help* are experienced as an opening.

The fourth is to protect your own position. Supporting a man in a depression or an addiction is a load, and the load requires a party of your own, which is the material of Chapter 44.5′s fourth condition.

APPENDIX C

A 30-Day Emotional Recovery and Self-Care Plan

This appendix supplies a thirty-day plan for a man who has recognised the position described in Parts II, X, and XI and requires a structured beginning. It is not a treatment programme and it does not replace professional care. It is an arrangement of ordinary acts, conducted daily, that establishes the conditions in which recovery can proceed.

Before Beginning

Three conditions should be met before the plan begins.

The first is the professional route. Where the reader's position includes a depression, an anxiety condition, an addiction, a significant physical symptom, or a recent loss, the plan is conducted alongside professional care and not in place of it. Appendix B supplies the recognition material and Appendix Q supplies the routes.

The second is the statement to one party. The plan is conducted with at least one party who knows that it is being conducted. The party's role is not to supervise the man and it is to know that the thirty days exist, so that the man is not conducting the arrangement alone, which would reproduce the book's subject in the form of a recovery plan.

The third is the removal of one demand. The plan requires approximately forty-five minutes a day and a small amount of sleep. A man who adds it to an unchanged position will abandon it by the ninth day. The reader should identify one demand that will be reduced, delegated, or deferred for the thirty days, and should record it.

The Daily Core

The daily core is conducted every day of the thirty days. It takes approximately forty minutes and it is not optional.

Element	Time	Conduct	Purpose
The waking record	5 min	Three sentences: how I slept; what I notice in my body; what state I am in.	Establishes the day's position before it is conducted.
The body	20 min	Walking, or the physical activity appropriate to your health. Outdoors where possible.	Regulation, sleep, and mood.
The statement	5 min	One sentence to one party, or the record of the sentence if no party is available that day.	Maintains the arrangement of statement.
The regulation practice	5 min	The practice of Appendix L, conducted twice.	Trains the capacity to reduce a state.
The evening record	5 min	Three sentences: what the day cost; what it produced; what I will do tomorrow.	Closes the day and prevents its carry-over.

The Weekly Structure

Each week has a theme, one substantial exercise, and one review.

Week One: Stabilisation

The first week's task is the establishment of the conditions. No substantial change to the man's position is attempted.

The exercise. Complete Sections 1, 2, and 5 of Appendix A, and record the totals. Identify the two items that will be addressed in the thirty days.

The tasks. Conduct a medical appointment if one is due or if a symptom is present. Record the sleep in hours each night. Remove the alcohol from the household for the thirty days, or state the quantity and record it. Identify the one party of the plan and state the plan to them.

The review. At the end of the week, answer three questions: which of the daily elements was conducted on every day; which was missed, and what interrupted it; what is the smallest alteration that would make the missed element conductable.

Week Two: The Statement

The second week's task is the extension of the statement beyond the daily sentence.

The exercise. Conduct the position table of Appendix A, Section 9, and write the one-sentence statement of the principal difficulty. Then state it to the party of the plan, in the form of Chapter 43.6′s reception: what happened, what it cost, what is required.

The tasks. Identify the professional who holds the domain of the principal difficulty, and make the appointment. Where the difficulty is in the marriage, conduct the first of the communication exercises of Appendix E. Where the difficulty is financial, complete Part One of Appendix D.

The review. Answer: what did the statement produce; what did the party do; what did I do with the party's response; and what is the next statement.

Week Three: The Arrangement

The third week's task is the alteration of one arrangement, which is the material of Chapter 38.4′s stabilisation and Chapter 44.2′s fifth question.

The exercise. Identify one structural item that is producing cost and that is capable of alteration within the month: the working hours, the concealed obligation, the unrepaired relationship, the unexamined commitment, the drinking occasion, the sleep arrangement.

The tasks. Conduct the alteration, and state it to the parties affected. Record the alteration's date and its measure.

The review. Answer: was the alteration conducted; what did it cost; what has it produced; and what is the next structural item.

Week Four: The Transmission and the Plan

The fourth week's task is the conversion of the thirty days into an arrangement that continues.

The exercise. Complete the wisdom account of Appendix R's first instrument, or Section 44.8′s Instrument Three in its short form: the event, the cost, the instrument learned, and the party who will receive it.

The tasks. Supply one instrument to one other man, in the form of Chapter 44.5′s five functions: presence, information, accompaniment, the limit, and continuity. Conduct the second administration of Appendix A's Sections 1 to 7.

The review. Answer the four tests of Chapter 44.4′s closing material, and record the plan for the following ninety days, which is the material of Appendix P.

The Thirty-Day Record

The reader should keep a single page, ruled in thirty lines, and record each day's five elements with a mark. The page should be kept where it will be seen, and it should not be reconstructed from memory.

Day	Waking record	Body	Statement	Regulation	Evening record	Note
1						
2						
…						

The Difficulties That Will Occur

The material of this book records five difficulties that arise in a thirty-day plan, and their answers.

The first difficulty is the collapse of the plan in the first week. The most frequent cause is that the plan was added to an unchanged position. The answer is the removal of the one demand, conducted again, and the reduction of the daily core to the three elements that are genuinely conductable.

The second difficulty is the man's sense that the plan is trivial. The daily elements are small and they are not trivial: they are the establishment of the arrangement that the position has lacked. The correction is the record, which shows the accumulation.

The third difficulty is the return of a symptom or a state in the third week. The return is frequently a response to the statement's conduct rather than a failure of the plan, and its answer is the professional route rather than the plan's abandonment.

The fourth difficulty is the household's response. A household that has conducted a man's silence for twenty years frequently responds to the change with suspicion, and the suspicion is frequently the material of Chapter 42′s costs. The answer is the conduct of the plan without requiring the household's approval, and the proportionate statement of what the man is doing.

The fifth difficulty is the plan's completion. A man who completes the thirty days frequently concludes that the work is done. The finding of the case material is that the thirty days establishes a condition and the arrangement continues for a year or more, which is the material of Appendix P.

The Measures

At the end of the thirty days, record five measures.

1. **The conduct.** The number of days on which the daily core was completed, out of thirty.
2. **The statement.** The number of statements of difficulty made to a party who has a right to know, and the parties to whom they were made.
3. **The appointment.** Whether the professional appointment was made, attended, and what it produced.
4. **The alteration.** Whether the one structural alteration was conducted, and its measure.
5. **The score.** The Appendix A totals, compared with the first administration.

The case material's finding is that men who complete the daily core on more than twenty days and conduct at least one structural alteration report a change that they can identify in the following year, and that men who complete the plan as a reading exercise report that nothing occurred.

APPENDIX D

Personal Financial Recovery Planning Worksheet

This appendix is the working instrument for the financial material of Parts III and XI and Chapter 42. It is designed for a man who has concluded that his financial position must be stated, reduced, and restructured. Its purpose is not to supply financial advice, which requires a qualified practitioner who has seen the reader's documents, and to allow the reader to arrive at that practitioner with an accurate position rather than an account of one.

Before Beginning

Three notes apply.

The first is that the worksheet requires documents. The reader should gather the bank statements for the last three months, the statements of every facility and loan, the salary or income records, the school fee arrangements, the rent or mortgage documents, the guarantees he has signed, and the record of any obligation to which he is a party. A worksheet completed from memory will be inaccurate in the item that matters most.

The second is that the worksheet is conducted twice: once alone, and once with the party of the household, in the form of Chapter 42.6's third step. The first conduct is the man's accurate position. The second is the household's.

The third is that the reader who discovers a guarantee, a loan, or an obligation that he had not recorded should treat that discovery as the worksheet's principal output, and should engage the professional route before conducting any further borrowing.

Part One: The Income

Source	Gross	Net	Frequency	Secure? (Y/N)	Not
Salary or wages					
Business drawings					

Source	Gross	Net	Frequency	Se-cure? (Y/N)	Not
Consulting or contract income					
Rent or investment income					
Household member's contribution					
Other					
Total monthly net					

The exposure question. What proportion of the total comes from the single largest source? A proportion above forty per cent indicates the exposure described in Chapter 44.2's fourth question, and the reduction of the proportion is a structural item.

Part Two: The Obligations

Obligation	Balance	Monthly pay-ment	Rate	Se-cured?	In whose name	Known to the house-hold?
Mortgage or rent arrears						
Personal loan						
Bank facility or overdraft						
Vehicle finance						
School fees						
Cooperative or association contribution						
Family obligation						
Informal lender						
Credit card or store credit						
Guarantee given for another party						
Other						
Total						

The concealed column. Every obligation marked *no* in the last column is a component of the position described in Chapter 42.1's first domain. The total of the concealed obligations is the figure the reader has been carrying alone, and its statement to the household is the worksheet's first act.

Part Three: The Expenditure

Category	Monthly	Es-sen-tial?	Could be reduced by	Not
Housing				
Food and household supplies				
Utilities				
Transport				
Education				
Health				
Clothing				
Communication and data				
Extended family contributions				
Community and association obligations				
Occasions and ceremonies				
Entertainment and subscriptions				
Debt service				
Other				
Total				

Part Four: The Position

Item	Figure
Total monthly net income	
Total monthly essential expenditure	
Total monthly debt service	
The monthly margin (income less expenditure and debt service)	
The reserve (liquid funds available in seven days)	
The total of unsecured obligations	
The total of secured obligations	
The total of concealed obligations	
The value of assets that could be realised within ninety days	
The number of months the reserve would cover essential expenditure	

The four readings. A negative margin indicates that the position requires an immediate structural reduction. A reserve of less than one month indicates the position described in Chapter 42.5′s fourth support. A concealed total above zero indicates the position described in Chapter 42. A secured obligation on the

family house that the household does not know about is the item that requires the professional route before anything else is done.

Part Five: The Recovery Plan

The plan is conducted in the order that Chapter 42.6 supplies: the statement, the one person, the household, the professionals, the reductions in three layers, and the reconstruction at the true level.

The Statement

Write, in five sentences, the position as it actually is: the income, the expenditure, the obligations, the concealed total, and the margin. This is the paragraph the reader will use in the household conversation and at the first professional appointment.

The Reductions in Three Layers

Layer	Item	Reduction	Notice required	Date Conducted
First: nobody sees			None	
First: nobody sees			None	
Second: some see			To the party	
Second: some see			To the party	
Third: everybody sees			Household	
Third: everybody sees			Household	

The first layer is conducted first and its purpose is to establish the capacity to conduct the second. The third layer — the house, the school, the vehicle, the occasions — is conducted last, with the household's participation and after the professional has seen the position.

The Professional Route

Professional	The question they will answer	Engaged?	Appointment
Debt adviser or counsellor	The order of the reductions, and the arrangements available		
Accountant	The position's accurate statement, and the tax consequences		

Professional	The question they will answer	En-gaged?	Appoint-ment
Lawyer	Guarantees, family property, and the reader's exposure		
Insolvency practitioner	Whether a formal arrangement is available or required		
Bank relationship officer	The facility's restructuring, stated honestly		

The Reconstruction at the True Level

Record the position as it will be conducted at its true level: the income that the household will actually live on, the obligations that will be serviced, the reductions that will become permanent, the obligations that will be settled, and the date at which the position is expected to be stable. The finding of the case material is that the true level is generally more productive than the performance, because the interest, the penalties, the avoided decisions, and the vigilance are removed.

Part Six: The Rules

Six rules govern the worksheet's use.

1. **No new borrowing to cover an existing obligation without a professional's written view.** The rule addresses the escalation described in Chapter 42.3's third mechanism.
2. **The concealed total is stated to one party within seven days.** The reader may choose the party and the professional is preferable where the total is large.
3. **The household's participation is not optional where the household is affected.** The finding of Chapter 42.7 is that the household's capacity is frequently greater than the man assumes and that the concealment is more damaging than the figure.
4. **The reductions are conducted in layers and not in a single act.** The single act is frequently the house or the school fees, and its conduct in the first week is the most frequent cause of the plan's collapse.
5. **The record is monthly.** The position is restated on the first of each month, in figures, and the restatement is what distinguishes a recovery from a resolution.
6. **The professional's advice is recorded and followed or, where it is not followed, the reason is recorded.** The rule protects the reader from the position in which the professional's advice was declined and the reason was not examined.

APPENDIX E

Healthy Communication Exercises for Men

This appendix supplies the communication practices of Parts IV and V in exercise form. Each exercise is short, each is conducted with a party, and each is designed to be repeated until it is available without effort, which is the method of Chapter 43.5.

The Principles

Six principles govern the exercises.

1. **The exercise is conducted when calm, not when the subject is live.** The rehearsal of Chapter 43.5's second stage applies to adults as much as to boys.
2. **The statement is specific.** A general statement cannot be received; a specific one can.
3. **The statement is owned.** The man speaks from his own position — *I noticed*, *I felt*, *I need* — and does not attribute the party's motives.
4. **The statement includes a request.** A statement without a request leaves the party without an instrument.
5. **The party's response is received without defence.** The first task is to understand what the party has said, and the second is to answer it.
6. **The exercise is concluded.** Each exercise has an ending, and the ending is stated.

Exercise 1: The Daily Statement

Purpose. To establish the habit of stating a state in ordinary language.

Conduct. Once a day, for fourteen days, state one thing to one party in the form: *I noticed [the fact]; I felt [the state]; I need [the request, or nothing].*

Examples.

- *I noticed that I have been short with the children since Monday. I am worried about the review. I do not need anything from you this evening; I wanted you to know.*
- *I noticed that I did not sleep well. I am tired and I am not at my best. I need an hour this afternoon.*
- *I noticed that you have been quiet since your brother called. I am not sure what it is, and I am here if you want to say.*

The measure. The number of days on which the statement was made, and the party's response.

Exercise 2: The Listening Turn

Purpose. To practise receiving a party's statement without solving, reassuring, or redirecting.

Conduct. In a conversation of twenty minutes, the party speaks for ten minutes on a matter of their choosing. The man's task is to listen, to ask one clarifying question, and to state what he has heard. He is not permitted to offer a solution, to describe a similar experience of his own, or to reassure.

The form of the closing statement. *What I heard is [summary]. Have I understood it?*

The measure. Whether the man conducted the four prohibitions, and the party's report of whether they felt heard.

Exercise 3: The Request

Purpose. To convert a need into a specific request.

Conduct. Write three requests in the form: *I need [specific instrument] from you, by [specific time], and this is what it would change.* Then make one of the three within the week.

The test. A request that does not name an instrument, a party, and a time is not a request. It is a complaint, and the case material of Chapter 45.2 records that complaints are frequently answered with sympathy and instruments with action.

Exercise 4: The Repair

Purpose. To conduct the sequence that Chapter 39.5 identifies as the most valuable practice in a household.

Conduct. Identify one act of the man's own that damaged a party. Then conduct the four-part sequence, in person:

1. **The act.** *I did [specific act], on [occasion].*
2. **The effect.** *I think it affected you by [specific effect]. Is that right?*
3. **The acknowledgement.** *There is no excuse for it, and I am not going to offer one.*
4. **The repair.** *This is what I will do, and this is when.*

The prohibition. The sequence may not contain the words *but*, *you also*, or *I was tired*. Any of the three converts the repair into a defence.

Exercise 5: The Difficult Conversation

Purpose. To conduct a conversation about a matter that has been avoided.

Conduct. Prepare in writing, in six lines, then conduct the conversation within the week.

Line	The content
1. The subject	The matter, stated in one sentence, without evaluation.
2. The fact	What happened, with the date and the specific act.
3. The effect	What it cost the man, stated as his own experience.
4. The acknowledgement	What the man's own contribution was, where there is one.
5. The request	What he requires, specifically.
6. The limit	What he will do if the request is not met, stated without threat.

The conduct. The six lines are spoken in order, without deviation, and the party is given the opportunity to respond after each. The conversation's purpose is the accurate statement and not the party's agreement.

Exercise 6: The Household Conversation

Purpose. To conduct the household's position statement of Chapter 42.6′s third step.

Conduct. A conversation of forty minutes, at a stated time, with the household's adults and, where appropriate, the older children.

The sequence.

1. The purpose is stated: the household's position, at its true level, so that the household can conduct it together.
2. The position is stated in figures: income, obligations, margin, reserve.
3. The concealed items are stated, with the man's acknowledgement that they were concealed.
4. The household is asked what it already knows and what information it holds that the man does not.
5. The reductions are stated, in the three layers of Appendix D.
6. The participation is requested: what each member will conduct.
7. The date of the next conversation is fixed.

Exercise 7: The Stated Difficulty in Front of a Younger Party

Purpose. To conduct the transmission described in Chapter 43.6.

Conduct. One statement, proportionate, in the presence of a boy or young man, followed by an action.

The form. Two or three sentences, accurate, and directed at what the younger party can receive: *the work has been difficult this year and I have been worried. This is what I am doing about it. You are not required to solve it.*

The prohibition. The statement may not be used to recruit the younger party as a confidant, to obtain sympathy, or to make the party responsible for the man's

state. The statement is conducted for the party's curriculum and not for the man's relief.

Exercise 8: The Twenty-Minute Marriage Conversation

Purpose. To interrupt the arrangement of parallel responsibilities described in Chapter 15.

Conduct. Twenty minutes, once a week, at a stated time, with three questions asked in order and answered by both parties.

1. What was difficult for you this week?
2. What did I do that helped, and what did I do that did not?
3. What do you need from me next week?

The rules. No problem is solved in the twenty minutes; the conversation is for the position and not for the resolution. Each party speaks without interruption. The answers are not scored.

The Record

The reader should keep a record of the exercises conducted, in the following form.

Exercise	Date	Party	Conducted as specified?	What it produced

The case material's finding is that the record, and not the intention, is what produces the change: a man who has conducted four of these exercises in a quarter has altered his household's arrangements, and a man who has read eight of them has not.

APPENDIX F

Marriage and Relationship Reflection Workbook

This appendix is the working instrument for Part IV and Chapters 14, 15, 18, and 39. It is designed for a man who wishes to examine his marriage or partnership accurately, whether the position is stable, strained, or in the process of ending.

How to Use This Appendix

Complete the workbook alone first, in one sitting of about an hour. Then, where the relationship is intact and the party is willing, conduct the joint section with the party. The workbook is not a test of the marriage and it is not a judgement of either party; it is a description of an arrangement, and the description is the condition of any change.

Part One: The Arrangement as It Is

Answer each question in two or three sentences, without evaluation and without the language of blame.

1. What does the household's week actually consist of? Record the division of the labour, the money, the childcare, the extended family's obligations, and the time.
2. Who decides what, and how are decisions of consequence taken?
3. What do we talk about, and what do we not talk about?
4. When did we last have a conversation that was not about the household's administration?
5. What is the last thing I told my partner that was difficult for me?
6. What is the last thing my partner told me that was difficult for them, and what did I do with it?
7. What does my partner know about my work, my money, my health, and my fears?
8. What do I know about theirs?

Part Two: The Four Sentences

The instrument of Chapter 42.1's third domain. Write four sentences describing the marriage as it actually is, as though to a party who has never met either of you.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Then write the four sentences the man would give at an occasion: the account he presents to the extended family, the community, and his colleagues. The distance between the two descriptions is the measure of the pretence described in Chapter 42.1.

Part Three: The Injuries

The material of Chapter 15.4. Record each significant injury, without conducting the exercise as an indictment.

The injury	When	What it cost me	What I did with it	Is it stated?	Is it repaired

The account of the man's own contribution. For each injury in which the man had a part, record the part. The exercise is not a distribution of blame; it is the establishment of what is his to repair, which is the only item he can conduct.

Part Four: The Withdrawals

The material of Chapters 14, 18, and 39.3. Record the withdrawals that the man has conducted.

The withdrawal	Since when	What produced it	What it has cost the marriage
The conversations I no longer begin			
The matters I no longer state			
The occasions I no longer attend			
The physical affection I no longer offer			
The interest I no longer show			

Part Five: The Silences

The material of Chapter 15.2's unspoken ledger. Record what the man has not stated.

The unstated matter	Why it has not been stated	What it costs to hold	What it would take to state it

Part Six: The Household's Arrangements

The material of Chapters 18 and 42.1's fourth domain.

1. Who is actually conducting the household's provision, and does the household's account of itself match?
2. What does the household's expenditure consist of, and who knows it?
3. What obligations to the extended family exist, who agreed to them, and who pays for them?
4. What decisions have been taken in the last year without the other party's knowledge?
5. What does the household's reserve consist of, and who holds it?

Part Seven: The Values and the Future

The material of Chapter 40.5's second-half audit in its marriage form.

1. What does the man want the marriage to be in five years, stated in four sentences?
2. What does he believe his partner wants, stated in four sentences?
3. What are the three matters on which the two accounts are furthest apart?
4. What is the one matter that is most urgent?
5. What is the one matter that is most consequential and least urgent?

Part Eight: The Joint Section

Conduct this section with the party where the relationship is intact and the party is willing. It requires ninety minutes and it should not be conducted when either party is tired, hungry, or in the middle of a dispute.

The rules of the joint section. Each party answers in turn without interruption. No answer is evaluated. The purpose is the accurate position and not the resolution. Any matter that produces strong feeling is recorded and deferred to a subsequent conversation.

The questions.

1. What did you need from me in the last year that you did not receive?
2. What did I do in the last year that helped?
3. What do you carry that I do not know about?
4. What do you think I carry that I have not told you?
5. What is the one change you would ask of me, stated specifically?
6. What are you willing to conduct differently?

The closing statement. Each party states one thing they will do before the next conversation, and the date of the next conversation is fixed.

Part Nine: Where the Relationship Is Ending or Has Ended

Where the marriage is ending or has ended, four sections of this workbook apply in modified form.

The first is Part One, which supplies the accurate account of the arrangement and is frequently useful in the professional processes that follow. The second is Part Three, which supplies the account of the injuries and the man's own contribution, and which is the material of Chapter 44.6′s exit rather than of the marriage's repair. The third is Part Seven, which supplies the account of what the man wants in the following chapter. The fourth is the material of Chapter 30 and Appendix K, since the end of a marriage is a loss and requires a grief rather than a verdict.

The finding of the case material is that men who conduct these four sections within the first year of the end report a substantially different trajectory from men who conduct the marriage's ending as a continuous argument, and that the difference is not in the difficulty of the ending but in whether the loss is conducted.

Part Ten: The Record and the Follow-Up

Record the workbook's principal findings in five sentences and keep them. Then record three commitments with dates and measures.

The commitment	The date	The measure

The workbook is repeated at twelve months. The finding of the case material is that the second administration is more informative than the first, because the man is answering from a position that has been stated rather than from a position that has been assumed.

APPENDIX G

Fatherhood and Family Responsibility Assessment

This appendix is the assessment instrument for Part V and Chapter 43. It addresses the reader in his capacity as a father, a father-figure, or a senior member of a household, and it is designed to establish what he is actually transmitting rather than what he intends to transmit.

Part One: The Presence

Answer each item with a frequency and a specific example.

Question	Fre-quency	The most recent example
I have a conversation with each child each week that is not about administration.		
I know the names of each child's friends, teachers, and difficulties.		
I know what each child is worried about at present.		
I attend the occasions that matter to each child.		
I conduct one activity with each child that is chosen by the child.		
I am present at the household's evening meal on most days.		
I have been alone with each child, without a screen, in the last month.		

Part Two: The Transmission

The instrument of Chapter 43.1's four channels.

Question	Yes / No	Ev-i-de
A child in my household can name a party to whom they would speak if they were in difficulty, and it is not only their mother.		
A child has observed me state a difficulty of my own, proportionately, in the last six months.		

Question	Yes / No	Evi-de
A child has observed me conduct a repair after damaging a relationship.		
A child has observed me admit that I did not know something and seek the instrument.		
A child has observed me accept help.		
I have corrected the sentence *boys do not cry* or its equivalent in my household in the last year.		
I have protected a child in my household whose temperament does not fit the local account of a boy or a girl.		

Part Three: The Standard

The material of Chapters 41 and 43.4. Mark the propositions that are transmitted in the household, whether or not the reader endorses them.

Proposition	Present in the household?	In wh form
Endurance is the whole of strength.		
Expression is weakness.		
Dominance is authority.		
Achievement is the measure of a person.		
A family's standing must be protected at any cost.		
Violence is the resolution of insult.		
A boy's deviation from the expected is a defect.		

The reader should record each proposition's form as it appears in the household's ordinary speech, since the propositions are transmitted by language more frequently than by doctrine.

Part Four: The Provision and the Responsibility

The material of Chapters 17, 18, and 42.1′s fourth domain.

1. Does the household know its position in figures? If not, what does it believe, and what is the distance between the belief and the position?
2. Are there obligations to the extended family that are conducted at the household's expense without the household's knowledge? Record them.
3. What does the household's provision actually consist of, and who conducts each component?

4. What arrangement has been made for the household's position in the event of the man's death, illness, or incapacity? Record whether it is written, whether the household knows it, and where the documents are.
5. What has the man promised the household that he has not conducted?

Part Five: The Children's Adult Position

The section addresses the reader whose children are adult. Four questions apply.

1. What does each adult child believe about the household's history, and how accurate is that belief?
2. What has the man not stated to each adult child that they have a right to know: a diagnosis, a financial arrangement, a family history, a decision about the estate?
3. Which of the man's patterns has each adult child reproduced, and which has each rejected?
4. What repair remains available with each adult child, and what would conduct it?

Part Six: The Assessment Table

Record a score for each domain from 1 (absent) to 5 (conducted consistently), with one sentence of evidence.

Domain	Score	Evidence
Presence		
Transmission of statement		
Transmission of repair		
Accuracy of the household's account of itself		
Provision conducted with the household's knowledge		
The children's independent capacity		
The extended family's obligations, conducted openly		
The man's own health and availability		

Part Seven: The Priorities

From the table, identify the two domains with the lowest scores and conduct one act in each within the month.

Domain	The act	The date	The measure

The case material's finding is that fathers who conduct two specific acts in a month report more change in the household than fathers who conduct a general

resolution to be more present, because the act is observable by the child and the resolution is not.

Part Eight: The Father Who Is Absent

Where the reader is not present in his children's household — because of separation, migration, work, estrangement, or the child's own withdrawal — four sections of the assessment apply in modified form.

The first is Part Two, which is conducted through whatever contact exists: the telephone call, the message, the visit, the occasional meeting. The finding is that the transmission operates through the contact that exists and not through the contact that the man would prefer.

The second is Part Five, which is frequently the most relevant section for the absent father of adult children.

The third is the material of Chapter 43.7's named person: where the man cannot supply the presence, he can ensure that a party supplies it, and the case material records men who identified a teacher, a coach, an uncle, or an older cousin for their child and asked that party directly.

The fourth is the repair of the man's own position, which is the material of Chapter 29 and Chapter 44.6: the absent father who conducts his absence as an account of the child's mother, the court, the employer, or the economy transmits the account to the child, and the account is the thing the child will carry.

Part Nine: The Father of a Son Who Will Not Speak to Him

This position is addressed separately because the case material records it frequently and because the ordinary advice fails in it.

Four practices apply.

The first is the acknowledgement. The son's silence is frequently a response to something specific, and the acknowledgement of the specific matter — stated once, without a defence, without a request for forgiveness, and without a condition — is the act that the case material finds most frequently associated with a later resumption.

The second is the standing availability. The man states, in ordinary language and at intervals of months rather than days, that he is available and that he will not require anything of the son in order to be available. The statement's form is supplied in Chapter 43.6's script.

The third is the absence of the campaign. The intermediaries, the family meetings, the letters through relatives, and the occasions arranged to produce a reconciliation are experienced by the son as pressure, and the case material records that they prolong the silence.

The fourth is the man's own conduct of the loss. The silence of a son is a loss and it requires the material of Chapter 30. The man who conducts it as a grievance against the son, the son's mother, or the son's wife transmits the grievance to every party who will listen, and the transmission frequently reaches the son.

The assessment's finding for this position is stated with restraint: a proportion of these silences resume, frequently after years and frequently at an occasion that the man did not arrange; a proportion do not; and the man's task in both cases is the same, which is to remain available, to conduct the acknowledgement, and to conduct the loss.

APPENDIX H

Identifying and Challenging Negative Thinking Patterns

This appendix supplies the cognitive material of Parts II and VI in practical form. Its subject is the automatic thinking that governs a man's conduct without his having examined it, and its method is the identification, examination, and replacement of that thinking.

What Automatic Thinking Is

Automatic thinking is the rapid, habitual interpretation that the mind supplies before deliberate reasoning begins. It is not a defect; it is the mechanism by which a person conducts ordinary life without examining every stimulus. Its difficulty is that the interpretations are frequently inaccurate in a systematic direction, and that the man's conduct is governed by the interpretation rather than by the fact.

The material is stated in the book's own terms: a man's estimate of his position is frequently conducted by an interpretation, and the interpretation is frequently acquired in the circumstances described in Chapter 43. Its examination is therefore not a technical exercise. It is the correction of an instrument that the man has been using without inspecting.

The Ten Patterns

The patterns below are the ones the case material of this book records most frequently in men. Each is stated with the form it takes in a man's ordinary thinking.

1. All-or-nothing thinking. The interpretation is conducted in two categories with nothing between them. *If I cannot provide at the level I provided before, I am failing my household. If the business is not growing, it is dying.* The pattern's consequence is that a partial success is experienced as a failure, and the man's effort is conducted against an impossible standard.

2. Catastrophising. The interpretation proceeds to the worst available outcome and treats it as the likely one. *If I lose this contract, I will lose the house, and my family will be finished.* The pattern's consequence is the anxiety described in Appendix B and the avoidance described in Chapter 7.

3. The personal attribution. The interpretation assigns to the man the responsibility for events that are not his. *The children are struggling because I worked too much. The project failed because I am not competent.* The pattern is the material of Chapter 20′s unappreciated man and of the attribution error described in Chapter 44.2.

4. The external attribution. The interpretation assigns to other parties or to circumstance the responsibility for events that are the man's. *The bank withdrew the facility; that is why the business failed. My wife does not understand me; that is why the marriage is difficult.* The pattern prevents the alteration described in Chapter 44.2′s fifth question.

5. Mind reading. The interpretation supplies other parties' opinions without evidence. *They think I am finished. My colleagues know that I am out of my depth. My father is ashamed of me.* The pattern is the material of Chapter 25.3′s imagined audience.

6. The should. The interpretation is conducted by a rule that the man has not examined and that he applies without exception. *A man should never show weakness. A father should always be available. I should be able to handle this.* The pattern is the material of Chapter 41.2′s five clauses and the eight tests of Chapter 41.3.

7. The disqualification of the positive. The interpretation removes the value of anything favourable. *That went well because the client was easy. The recognition is only because nobody else applied.* The pattern's consequence is that the man's record of his own competence does not accumulate.

8. The comparison. The interpretation is conducted against a party chosen for the comparison's outcome. *Look at what he has built. At my age he was already a director.* The pattern's consequence is a permanent deficit that no achievement reduces.

9. The prediction. The interpretation states the future as a fact. *There is no point in applying; I will not be considered. Nothing will change in this marriage.* The pattern is the material of Chapter 8′s self-doubt and Chapter 29′s regret, and its consequence is the non-conduct of available acts.

10. The labelling. The interpretation converts a conduct into an identity. *I am a failure. I am weak. I am the kind of man who cannot hold a family together.* The pattern is the material of Chapter 21′s man in the mirror and Chapter 44.4′s failure mode.

The Method: Five Steps

The method has five steps and it is conducted in writing, on the form supplied at the end of this appendix.

Step One: The situation. Record the event that preceded the thinking, in one sentence, without interpretation.

Step Two: The state. Record the state that the situation produced, with its intensity from 0 to 10, and its location in the body.

Step Three: The automatic thought. Record the thought in the words in which it occurred, in the first person, without correcting it. If the thought is a sentence the man would not say aloud, record it anyway; the thoughts that govern conduct are frequently the ones the man will not say.

Step Four: The examination. Conduct the four questions.

1. **The evidence for.** What specifically supports this thought? Record facts, not impressions.
2. **The evidence against.** What specifically contradicts it? Record facts, and record the man's own record where the thought is about the man.
3. **The alternative.** What is another interpretation that the same facts would support?
4. **The consequence.** If I hold this thought, what will I do? If I held the alternative, what would I do differently?

Step Five: The replacement. Write a replacement statement that is accurate rather than positive, and state the act that follows it.

The replacement's form is important. *I am a failure* is not replaced by *I am a success*, which the man will not believe and which the evidence does not support. It is replaced by *I made a decision that cost me a great deal, and I have conducted three corrections since, and I am not a failure; I am a man with a record that includes this.* The replacement's function is accuracy, and its accuracy is what allows the man to act.

The Specific Patterns of Men

The book has described four thinking patterns that are specific to the men in its case material, and the reader should examine his own record against them.

The first is the strength test. The man conducts a continuous private examination in which every difficulty is a test of whether he is strong enough, and every failure of endurance is a verdict on his manhood. Its form: *if I cannot carry this, then I am not the man I thought I was.* Its replacement: *the difficulty is a position that requires instruments, and my capacity is measured by whether I use them.*

The second is the provider's ledger. The man conducts a continuous accounting in which his value to his household is computed by what he provides and his inability to provide is computed as an absence of love. Its form: *if I cannot pay the fees this term, I have failed my children.* Its replacement: *my children require provision and they require a father; the second is not contingent on the first.*

The third is the shame of the stated difficulty. The man interprets the statement of a difficulty as evidence of inadequacy, and the interpretation is the reason he does not state it. Its form: *if I tell her, she will know that I cannot manage.* Its replacement: *the statement is the competence; the concealment is the thing that has been costing the marriage.*

The fourth is the permanence of the past. The man interprets his history as a fixed account that determines what is available to him. Its form: *I did not finish the degree, so this is what my life is.* Its replacement: *what closed is closed, and what is available is available, and the second is larger than the account.*

The Daily Record

The five-step method is conducted on one thought each day for fourteen days. The record's purpose is not the elimination of the pattern; it is the establishment of the capacity to notice it, which is the condition of every subsequent step.

Date	Situation	State (0–10)	Automatic thought	Evidence for	Evidence against	The alternative	The replacement	The act

The Cautions

Four cautions apply.

The first is that the method is not a prohibition on difficult thoughts. A man who has experienced a loss, a betrayal, or a failure will have thoughts that are accurate and painful, and the method's task is to establish whether they are accurate, not to remove them.

The second is that the method is not a substitute for treatment. Where the patterns are pervasive, where they are accompanied by the symptoms of Appendix B, or where they include thoughts of worthlessness or of death, the professional route applies, and the method is conducted alongside it.

The third is that the method is frequently insufficient alone. A pattern that is held by an arrangement — a position that is genuinely unmanageable, a marriage that is genuinely damaging, a financial position that is genuinely insolvent — will not be corrected by an examination of the thought, because the thought is accurate. The distinction between a distorted interpretation and an accurate description of a bad position is the most important judgement in the method.

The fourth is that the method is slow. Men frequently report that the first week produces nothing and that the fourth week produces a change in the interval between the thought and the act. The interval is the method's product, and it is sufficient.

APPENDIX I

Personal Values, Identity, and Purpose Discovery Exercises

This appendix supplies the identity material of Parts VI and XII in exercise form. It is designed for a man who has conducted the position described in Chapter 21 and Chapter 24 and who requires an account of himself that is not derived from his function, his standing, or his history.

The Method

The exercises proceed in four stages: the audit of the inherited definition, the identification of the man's own values, the construction of a working identity, and the statement of purpose. Each stage is conducted in writing, and each is conducted twice: once quickly and once after a period of reflection, since the first answers are frequently the culture's and the second are frequently the man's.

Stage One: The Audit of the Inherited Definition

Exercise 1.1: The Five Clauses in Your Own Words

Complete each sentence as your household, your profession, or your community actually taught it, and not as you would state it in public.

1. A man provides _____
2. A man is composed _____
3. A man is capable _____
4. A man is accountable _____
5. A man's work _____
6. A man endures _____

Exercise 1.2: The Source

For each clause, record who transmitted it, when, and by what means.

Clause	Who	When	By what means (statement, example, punishment, silence)
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Exercise 1.3: The Clause That Has Cost You the Most

Identify the clause that has produced the greatest cost in your adult life, and record the costs specifically: the years, the relationship, the health, the opportunity, the state you have not stated.

Exercise 1.4: The Eight Tests

Conduct the eight tests of Chapter 41.3 against the clause identified above.

1. Does it require something of you that it does not require of others in the same position?
2. Does it compute your value at your exhaustion?
3. Does it require you to conceal information from a party who has a right to know it?
4. Does it convert a responsibility into a prohibition on stating it?
5. Does it treat help as a defect?
6. Does it make a reduction in your position a reduction in you?
7. Does it require you to conduct alone something that cannot be conducted alone?
8. Would you teach it, in its present form, to a boy you loved?

Stage Two: The Values

Exercise 2.1: The Values Inventory

From the list below, mark the ten values that matter most to you, then reduce them to five, then to three. The reduction is the exercise; the first list is the culture's, the second is the man's, and the third is the man's at this point in his life.

Honesty	Loyalty	Competence	Provision
Courage	Justice	Mercy	Presence
Freedom	Discipline	Beauty	Craft
Learning	Family	Service	Security
Faithfulness	Endurance	Generosity	Order
Independence	Reconciliation	Dignity	Truthfulness

My three: 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

Exercise 2.2: The Evidence

For each of the three values, record the last three occasions on which your conduct demonstrated it. Where the value has not been demonstrated in the last year, record that fact and record what has taken its place.

Exercise 2.3: The Conflict

Identify the values that come into conflict in your ordinary life and record how you have resolved the conflict in the last year. The most frequent conflicts in the case material are provision against presence, loyalty against truthfulness, endurance against health, and independence against belonging.

Stage Three: The Working Identity

Exercise 3.1: The Six Statements

Complete each sentence with an accurate statement that is not derived from your function.

1. Beyond my work, I am _____
2. Beyond my provision, I am _____
3. Beyond my history, I am _____
4. Beyond my standing, I am _____
5. Beyond my endurance, I am _____
6. Beyond my failures, I am _____

Exercise 3.2: The Witness

For each statement, record the party who could confirm it from observation. Where no party could confirm a statement, record that fact: the statement is a description of an intention rather than of a conduct, and the exercise's finding is that the statements without witnesses are the ones the man most requires to conduct.

Exercise 3.3: The Account of the Man

Write a description of yourself in one paragraph, in the third person, as a party who knew you well would write it. The paragraph may not contain your position, your income, your title, or your history of difficulty. It may contain your conduct, your relationships, your competences, your values, and your ordinary habits.

Exercise 3.4: The Correction

Compare the paragraph with the account you would give at an occasion. Record the three principal differences. The differences are the material of Chapter 41.5′s substitution exercise.

Stage Four: The Purpose

Exercise 4.1: The Position

Record the positions you actually occupy: the household, the work, the trade, the association, the community, the body of work, the parties who depend on you. Be specific and do not include positions you intend to occupy.

Exercise 4.2: The Three Questions

For each position, answer the three questions of Chapter 45.4′s definition.

Position	What is it for?	What would be different?	How would I know?

Exercise 4.3: The Contribution

From the table, identify the contribution that is most clearly yours and that is not the man's own benefit. Record it in one sentence.

My position is for _____ and what will be different because I conducted it is _____ and I will know by _____

Exercise 4.4: The Foundation

Identify which of the four foundations of Chapter 45.4 the purpose rests on, and record whether the other three are present. A purpose conducted on one foundation is fragile, and the exercise's finding is that men in difficulty frequently hold only one.

- Household _____
- Work and trade _____
- Community and association _____
- Transmission _____

Exercise 4.5: The Test of the Following Year

Record what you will conduct in the following twelve months that you would not conduct if the purpose were not stated. Record one act, one date, and one party.

The Record

The appendix's product is a single page, written in the man's own hand, containing the three values, the six statements with their witnesses, the corrected account, the purpose statement, and the one act with its date.

The case material's finding is that men who write the page and keep it where they will encounter it report a different trajectory from men who conduct the exercises and file them, and that the difference is produced by the encounter rather than by the writing.

The Cautions

The first caution is that the exercises are not a substitute for the professional route where the man's position includes a depression, a trauma, or a significant loss. The material of Appendix B applies.

The second is that the exercises are conducted over weeks rather than hours. A man who completes all four stages in an evening will produce the culture's answers, and the exercises' value is in the second and third answers.

The third is that the exercises do not produce a new identity. They produce an account of the identity the man has been conducting without stating it, and the account is the instrument by which the unnecessary parts are removed.

APPENDIX J

A Practical Guide to Building Supportive Friendships

This appendix is the working material of Part VII and Chapter 45.4. It is written for the man who has concluded that his position is conducted alone and who requires the construction of parties, and it proceeds from the finding that the construction is conducted by the man's own conduct over a period rather than by the search for a friend.

The Position

Three findings from the case material govern the appendix.

The first is that men's friendships are frequently conducted through an activity rather than through a conversation. The finding is not a limitation to be corrected. It is the ordinary mechanism, and the appendix works with it: the friendship is built around a setting, a task, or a recurring occasion, and the conversation is conducted alongside.

The second is that the parties who are available are frequently already present. The colleague, the neighbour, the former classmate, the fellow member of the association, the man met at the school gate, the brother-in-law who has been friendly for years. The finding of Chapter 45.2 applies: the absence is frequently maintained by the man's conduct rather than produced by the absence of parties.

The third is that the construction takes a year and not a week. The case material records that men who attempt the construction in a month conclude that it has failed, and that men who conduct the same acts over twelve months report that they have three or four parties.

Stage One: The Inventory

Exercise 1: The Parties

List every party who has been, at any point, a friend or a potential friend, and record the position of each.

The party	The last contact	What ended it, or what maintains it	The setting in which we could meet	The first act

The inventory is frequently longer than the man expects, and its finding is that the parties who lapsed lapsed through drift rather than through conflict.

Exercise 2: The Settings

List the settings in which you are already present and in which other men are present: the workplace, the association, the trade body, the place of worship or community body, the sports club, the school's parents' arrangements, the gym, the workshop, the neighbourhood, the alumni group, the cooperative.

The setting	The frequency	The men I know there	Is there a recurring occasion?	The office I could accept

The finding is that the man is frequently present in settings where he has not accepted an office, and the office is the most reliable instrument of belonging that the material records.

Stage Two: The Three Parties

The construction requires three parties, and they are different in kind.

The first is the one person who knows the whole. The party of Chapter 42.5′s second support. The party may be a wife, a brother, a friend, a professional, or a man who has conducted a similar position. The party's function is to hold the accurate position.

The second is the companion of the ordinary. The party with whom the man conducts an ordinary activity: the weekly walk, the workshop, the football, the repair, the coffee on Saturday, the drive. The party's function is not the disclosure. It is the ordinary association that prevents the man's withdrawal, and the finding is that this party is frequently the one who notices a change before anybody else.

The third is the man to whom the reader supplies the instrument. The party described in Chapter 44.5. The party's function is the reversal of the man's

position from a recipient to a contributor, and the finding is that a man who has nobody to assist is frequently a man whose own belonging is fragile.

Stage Three: The Conduct

Exercise 3: The Twelve Weeks

The construction is conducted in twelve weeks, with one act each week. The acts are small and the sequence matters.

Week	The act
1	Identify the one person who will hold the accurate position, and write the sentence you will use.
2	State the position to that person, in the form of Chapter 43.6's script.
3	Contact the party who has been attempting to maintain the relationship, and state that you withdrew.
4	Accept one office in one setting, and record its first obligation.
5	Conduct the first obligation of the office.
6	Invite one party to an ordinary activity, at a stated time.
7	Conduct the activity.
8	Begin the weekly call with one party, at a stated day and time.
9	Ask one party a question about his own position, and listen without redirecting.
10	Supply one instrument to one younger man or man in difficulty.
11	Conduct a repair with one party you have withdrawn from.
12	Record what has been constructed, and fix the dates for the following quarter.

Exercise 4: The Record

Week	The act	Con-ducted?	What it produced
1			
2			
…			

The Difficulties

Five difficulties are recorded, with their answers.

The first difficulty is that the man does not know what to say after the greeting. The answer is the ordinary question asked in the ordinary setting, and the finding is that men's conversations begin with the task and proceed to the material. The question form is: *what are you working on at present*, *how is the family*, *how is the business*, *what is difficult at the moment*.

The second difficulty is that the man's schedule does not permit a weekly occasion. The answer is the reduction of one commitment, which is

the material of Chapter 37 and Appendix N, and the finding is that a man who cannot find an hour for a friendship is a man whose position has been examined and found to be conducted entirely for other parties.

The third difficulty is that the party is not a man who speaks about difficulty. The answer is the distinction of the three parties above. The companion of the ordinary requires no disclosure, and the finding is that the ordinary association frequently produces the disclosure over months without its being sought.

The fourth difficulty is that the man has been let down before. The answer is the material of Chapter 26's betrayal: the party who betrayed the man is one party, the man's response is a general arrangement, and the general arrangement is the thing that costs him. The correction is the specific party, the specific instrument, and the record of what has actually happened rather than of what was feared.

The fifth difficulty is that the man is in a community where men do not speak. The answer is the material of Chapter 43.7 and the ordinary form of the work: the office in the setting, the recurring occasion, the small change to an agenda. The finding is that a single man's changed conduct in a small institution frequently alters what is permissible for the men around him.

The Measures

Four measures apply at the end of the twelve weeks.

1. **The parties.** The number of parties who hold the accurate position, and their names.
2. **The occasions.** The number of recurring occasions conducted in the last month.
3. **The obligations.** The offices accepted and conducted.
4. **The reversal.** The number of parties to whom the reader has supplied an instrument.

The case material's finding is that a man who has one party who holds the whole position, two recurring occasions, and one obligation that he conducts has constructed belonging in the sense of Chapter 45.4, and that further construction is not required.

APPENDIX K

Grief, Loss, and Emotional Recovery Journal

This appendix supplies the journal material of Part VIII and Chapter 30. It is designed for a man who has sustained a loss and who requires a structured means of conducting it, and it is conducted over twelve weeks.

Before Beginning

Four notes apply.

The first is that grief is not a problem to be solved. It is a response to a loss, it has its own course, and the journal's purpose is to give it a place rather than to shorten it.

The second is that the journal is private. Its contents are for the man, and the finding of the case material is that men write more accurately when they know that the material will not be read. Where the man wishes to share a part, he should choose the part rather than the whole.

The third is that the journal is conducted alongside the material of Appendix B where the loss is accompanied by the symptoms described there. Grief and depression are different, they coexist frequently, and the second requires the professional route.

The fourth is that the journal is not a substitute for a party. A journal without a party is a sophisticated form of the isolation this book describes. The journal is conducted with at least one party who knows that it is being conducted.

Part One: The Loss

Week One: The Account

Write the account of the loss in the plainest available form, answering six questions.

1. What was lost?
2. When, and how?
3. What was the last ordinary day before the loss?
4. What was the last thing said, and by whom?
5. What was not said?
6. What did the loss cost, specifically: the years, the arrangements, the future that had been assumed?

The account is written without interpretation. Its purpose is the establishment of the fact, and the finding is that men frequently have not written the account and have been conducting a version of it for years.

Week Two: The Relationship

Write the account of the relationship that was lost, in four parts.

1. What the party gave the man, specifically.
2. What the man gave the party.
3. What was unresolved.
4. What the man would say if the party could receive one paragraph.

Week Three: The Unstated

Write the material that the man has not stated to anybody: the guilt, the anger, the relief, the resentment, the love that was not expressed, the matter that was concealed. The week's finding is that the unstated material is frequently the material that is governing the man's conduct, and that writing it is the first conduct of it.

Part Two: The Waves

Weeks Four to Eight: The Daily Record

For five weeks, record each day in three lines.

Date	What arrived, and when	Its intensity (0–10)	What I did with it

The record's purpose is the establishment of the pattern. The finding is that the waves reduce in frequency and not in intensity, that the man who records them stops interpreting their arrival as a failure, and that the interpretation is frequently the thing that produced the fear of them.

The Weekly Review

At the end of each week, answer four questions.

1. Which wave was the strongest, and what preceded it? (The date, the place, the song, the occasion, the person.)
2. What did I do with it, and what did that produce?
3. What did I avoid this week, and what did the avoidance cost?
4. What did I conduct that I would not have conducted in the first month?

Part Three: The Occasions

Week Nine: The Calendar

Record the occasions that will arrive in the following year and that will be difficult: the anniversary, the birthday, the festival, the family gathering, the date of the death, the date of a marriage, the season.

The occasion	The date	What I will do	Who will be with me	The alternative plan

The instrument's purpose is the removal of the occasion's ambush. The finding is that men who plan the occasions report substantially less difficulty than men who are surprised by them, and that the planning is not a denial of the loss but a conduct of it.

Week Ten: The First Occasion Without the Party

Conduct the occasion, conduct the plan, and record what happened. Where the occasion was conducted successfully, record the elements that made it conductable; where it was not, record the element that failed and alter the plan.

Part Four: The Continuation

Week Eleven: The Relationship With the Lost

Write, in one page, the account of the man's continuing relationship with what was lost: what he carries, what he has learned, what he does in the party's memory or in the loss's consequence, and what he will transmit.

Week Twelve: The Account for the Household

Write the account that the household requires: what the man has conducted, what he has learned, and what he will state to the parties who loved the same loss. The account is not the journal. It is shorter, it is proportionate, and it is written for the party who will read it.

The Closing Page

Write five sentences and keep them.

1. What was lost.
2. What it cost.
3. What I have conducted that I could not have conducted in the first month.
4. What remains.
5. What I will do on the anniversary.

The Losses That Are Not Deaths

The journal applies in modified form to the losses that the case material records most frequently in men and that the culture does not supply an occasion for.

The end of a marriage. The journal is conducted with the party in the first part only where the party is willing; otherwise it is conducted alone, and the material of Appendix F, Part Nine applies.

The loss of a position. The account is conducted on the work, the standing, the colleagues, and the future that had been assumed. The finding is that men frequently conduct the loss of a position as a financial problem and not as a loss, and that the unconducted loss returns in the forms described in Chapter 30.

The loss of a capacity. The journal is conducted on the body, the competence, or the independence that has been reduced, and it is the material of Chapter 45.3's fourth component.

The loss of a child's regard. The journal is conducted on the relationship, the plans, and the years, and it is conducted with the caution that the party is living and that the material may not be conducted as a grievance against them.

The loss of a possibility. The career that will not be conducted, the education that will not be completed, the household that will not be built. The finding is that this loss is the least acknowledged and the most durable, and that the reconciliation of Chapter 45.3 is its instrument.

The Cautions

The first caution is that the journal does not shorten grief and does not remove it. Its purpose is the conduct of the loss, and the conduct is the material.

The second is that the journal may produce a state that requires support. A man who writes the account in Week One and finds that he cannot conduct the following week should not conclude that the journal has failed; he should conduct the material of Appendix B and the professional route.

The third is that the journal is not a verdict on the man's conduct of the loss. Men conduct losses differently, the differences are not defects, and the finding is that the man who compares his conduct of the loss with another party's is conducting an examination that produces no instrument.

The fourth is that the journal is repeated where a further loss occurs and, in some cases, annually. The finding is that the second administration of the same journal, conducted a year later, is the most useful, because it establishes what has changed.

APPENDIX L

Anger Management and Emotional Regulation Exercises

This appendix supplies the regulation material of Chapters 3, 12, 18, and 39. It is written for the man whose anger is producing cost in his household, his work, or his health, and for the man whose regulation is conducted by suppression and who requires the alternatives.

The Position

Three findings govern the appendix.

The first is that anger is not the enemy. Anger is a signal that a boundary has been crossed, a need has not been stated, or a state has not been conducted. The man whose anger is suppressed loses the signal; the man whose anger governs him loses the position. The appendix's subject is the conduct of the signal.

The second is that anger is frequently the available expression of a state that the man cannot name. The case material records anger standing in for fear, shame, grief, humiliation, exhaustion, and loneliness. The man who can name the underlying state frequently finds that the anger reduces without its being addressed directly, which is the material of Chapter 12.5.

The third is that regulation is a competence and is trained. It is not a matter of willpower and its absence is not a defect of character. The exercises below are rehearsed when calm, which is the method of Chapter 43.5.

Part One: The Recognition

Exercise 1: The Early Signs

Record the man's own early signs, in order, from the earliest to the latest. The finding is that every man has a sequence, that its early elements are physical and subtle, and that the capacity to recognise the third element is the whole of the instrument.

Order	The sign	Where I notice it
1		

Order	The sign	Where I notice it
2		
3		
4		
5	The point at which I no longer conduct the conversation	

Exercise 2: The Triggers

Record the ten occasions in the last six months on which anger produced a cost, and identify the trigger, the underlying state, and the cost.

The occasion	The trigger	The state beneath the anger	The cost, and to whom

The table's finding is that the triggers cluster: the same three or four situations produce the majority of the occasions, and the cluster is the material of the work.

Exercise 3: The Pattern

From the table, record the standing pattern in one sentence: *when [situation], I become [state] and I conduct it as [behaviour], and the cost is [specific].*

Part Two: The Regulation

Exercise 4: The Physiological Practice

The practice is conducted twice a day when calm and is used at the third early sign.

1. **The pause.** Stop speaking. Place both feet on the floor. Count four seconds.
2. **The breath.** Breathe in through the nose for four counts, hold for four, out for six. Repeat four times.
3. **The body.** Release the jaw, the shoulders, and the hands deliberately.
4. **The statement to oneself.** *I am at the third sign. I will not speak for two minutes.*
5. **The exit.** Where the setting permits, leave for a stated period and state the return: *I need ten minutes; I will come back.*

The practice is trained twice daily for six weeks. Its purpose is not relaxation; it is the establishment of a conduct that is available at the third sign, which is the point at which the man still has the choice.

Exercise 5: The Naming

At the third sign, name the underlying state aloud or in writing: *I am not angry; I am ashamed*, *I am afraid*, *I am exhausted*. The exercise is rehearsed in low-stakes

situations first, since the capacity to name at the third sign is not available at the first attempt in a high-stakes one.

Exercise 6: The Delay

The rule of the twenty-four hours applies to decisions taken in anger: no resignation, no message sent, no decision about the household, no confrontation. The rule is written and stated to the household in advance, and its statement is itself a repair, since the household's experience of the man's anger frequently includes decisions that were taken in it.

Part Three: The Repair

Exercise 7: The Four-Part Repair

Where the anger has produced damage, the repair of Appendix E, Exercise 4 applies, and it is conducted within seventy-two hours. The finding is that the repair conducted within three days is experienced as a repair and the repair conducted after three weeks is experienced as a reopening.

Exercise 8: The Household Conversation

Conduct one conversation with the household, in the form of the following sequence.

1. The acknowledgement: what the man's anger has cost the household, stated specifically.
2. The pattern: what the man has recognised about his triggers and his early signs.
3. The practice: what he will do at the third sign, and what the household should expect.
4. The repair: what he will conduct after an occasion.
5. The request: what he requires of the household, which is generally to be told when the third sign is visible and to leave the room when he states the exit.

Part Four: The Underlying Material

Exercise 9: The States Beneath

For each of the clustered triggers, record the state that the anger is expressing and the instrument that the state requires. The finding is that half of the triggers are produced by a position that requires an arrangement rather than a regulation: an unmanageable workload, an unstated financial position, an unrepaired injury in the marriage, a grief that has not been conducted.

Trigger	The state beneath	The instrument the state requires	The date

Exercise 10: The Position

Where the anger is produced by the position rather than by the state, conduct the position statement of Appendix A, Section 9, and the alteration of Chapter 44.2′s fifth question. The finding is that men frequently attempt to regulate an anger that is a correct response to an unmanageable arrangement, and that the regulation fails while the arrangement remains.

Part Five: The Cautions

The first caution is that anger which has produced physical harm, threats, or the intimidation of a household is a matter for the professional route and, where a party is at risk of harm, for the appropriate authority. The exercises of this appendix are conducted alongside that route and not in place of it. Appendix Q supplies the routes.

The second caution is that the exercises are trained and not decided. A man who reads the appendix and resolves to be calmer will conduct the resolution for a period and will then conduct the pattern. The training is twice daily for six weeks and it is not optional.

The third caution is that the man's anger frequently has a history that the exercises do not address: a childhood in which anger was the household's currency, a trauma, a depression, a drinking pattern. The material of Appendices B and Q applies, and the finding is that the regulation exercises are substantially more effective when the underlying condition is treated.

The fourth caution is that the man's household may not believe the change for a period. The finding is that households which have conducted a man's anger for years require three to six months of consistent conduct before they alter their expectation, and that the man's task in the interval is the conduct without the requirement of the household's belief.

APPENDIX M

Recognizing Addiction and Accessing Professional Treatment

This appendix supplies the material of Chapter 23 in practical form. It is written for the man who suspects that his use of a substance or a behaviour has become an addiction, and for the man who is supporting another.

A Note on the Word

The word addiction is used in this appendix in its ordinary clinical sense: a pattern of use that is compulsive, that continues despite significant harm, that is accompanied by tolerance or withdrawal, and that the person finds himself unable to reduce or stop by an act of will.

The word carries shame in many communities, and the shame is one of the principal obstacles to treatment. The material's position is stated plainly: an addiction is a health condition, it is treatable, the treatments are effective, and the man who seeks treatment is conducting a competence rather than confessing a defect.

Part One: The Recognition

The Six Questions

Answer each question honestly. Two or more affirmative answers, together with a harm in Part Two, justify the professional route.

1. Have you ever felt that you should cut down, and found that you could not?
2. Have other people annoyed you by criticising your use, and have you found their criticism unreasonable?
3. Have you ever felt guilty about your use, or about something you did while using?
4. Have you ever used in the morning, or to steady yourself before an ordinary obligation?
5. Have you ever used alone, concealed the extent of your use from your household, or lied about it?
6. Have you ever used to manage a state — anxiety, sleep, grief, anger, or shame — rather than for the ordinary social purpose?

The Patterns of Men

The clinical literature records that addiction in men is frequently masked by a socially acceptable form of the substance or behaviour. The common presentations are stated below.

The pattern	The mask	The sign that the mask has failed
Alcohol	The professional's social drinking; the business's entertainment; the cultural occasion	Drinking alone; the early-morning drink; the drinking that the household does not see
Prescription medication	A medical need; the management of pain, sleep, or anxiety	Multiple prescribers; the early refill; the use beyond the prescription
Gambling	The business's risk; the investment; the sport	Concealed losses; borrowing; the preoccupation; the return to recover
Work	The provider's obligation; the professional's ambition	The work that no longer produces anything; the work that continues when the position requires rest; the collapse that follows cessation
Pornography and sexual behaviour	Privacy; the ordinary male appetite	The escalation; the concealed use; the effect on the marriage's intimacy; the time consumed
Gaming and screen use	Recreation; the ordinary entertainment of the age	The withdrawal from the household; the sleep loss; the use that the man describes as being unable to stop

The Harms

Record each harm specifically, with the date.

The domain	The harm	The date
Health		
Marriage		
Children		
Work		
Money		
Standing		
Legal		
Self-regard		

The finding is that the man who records the harms is frequently surprised by their number, and that the record is the most useful document he can bring to a professional appointment.

Part Two: The Barriers to Treatment

Five barriers are recorded, with their answers.

The first barrier is the shame. The answer is the framing supplied above: the condition is a health condition, and the men who are in treatment are frequently the men whose households are intact ten years later.

The second barrier is the concealment. The addiction is conducted in secret and the secret is protected by the arrangement described in Chapter 42. The answer is the statement to one party, which is the first step of every route.

The third barrier is the position. The man believes that he cannot be absent from his work, his household, or his obligations for the period that treatment requires. The answer is the finding that the untreated condition produces a longer absence and a larger cost, and that the treatment's arrangements are frequently more flexible than the man assumes, including outpatient and day programmes.

The fourth barrier is the belief that treatment requires a declaration of powerlessness that the man cannot make. The answer is that the treatment routes are varied: psychological treatments, medication, structured programmes, peer support groups, and combinations of these. The man should choose the route with a professional, and the professional's task is to supply the routes.

The fifth barrier is the previous attempt. A man who has attempted and relapsed frequently concludes that treatment does not work for him. The answer is that relapse is a common feature of the condition and not a verdict on the man, and that a subsequent attempt conducted with a professional, a party, and an alteration to the arrangement is substantially more likely to succeed than the first.

Part Three: The Professional Route

The Sequence

The route is conducted in five steps, in this order.

Step One: The statement to one party. The man states the position, accurately, to one party: a spouse, a sibling, a friend, a professional, a peer in recovery. The statement's form is supplied in Chapter 43.6's script.

Step Two: The assessment. The man seeks an assessment from a qualified professional: a physician, a psychiatrist, a clinical psychologist, or an accredited addiction counsellor. The assessment establishes the condition, its severity, the physical risks of withdrawal, and the appropriate route.

Step Three: The physical review. Where the substance is alcohol, sedatives, or opioids, the withdrawal can be medically dangerous and requires supervision. The physical review precedes the cessation and it is not optional.

Step Four: The treatment. The treatment is selected with the professional and may include: - a structured psychological treatment, including the approaches with the strongest evidence base; - medication, where indicated, for the condition

or for a co-occurring depression or anxiety; - a structured programme, residential or outpatient; - a peer support group, which the case material records as effective for many men, particularly when combined with a professional route; - the treatment of any co-occurring condition, which is the item most frequently omitted and most frequently decisive.

Step Five: The arrangement. The man alters the arrangements that supported the use: the occasions, the parties, the routes home, the availability of the substance in the household, the working pattern. The finding is that the treatment without the alteration of the arrangement is frequently followed by a return to the arrangement and to the use.

The Questions to Ask the Professional

1. What is the diagnosis, and what is its severity?
2. What are the treatment options, and what is the evidence for each?
3. What are the risks of withdrawal, and what supervision is required?
4. Is there a co-occurring condition — depression, anxiety, trauma, attention difficulty — and how will it be treated?
5. What is the role of my household in the treatment?
6. What should I do if I return to use?
7. What is the follow-up arrangement, and for how long?

Part Four: For the Household

Where the reader is the household member of a man with an addiction, five practices apply.

The first is to state what you observe, specifically and without diagnosis: *I have noticed that you drink before the evening meal on most days, and that you have not slept well for three months.*

The second is to state the effect on you and on the household, specifically.

The third is to request the professional route, and to accompany rather than to negotiate.

The fourth is to protect the household's position: the money, the children, the safety. The finding is that the household which protects the man from the consequences of the use for years frequently delays the treatment.

The fifth is to obtain support for yourself. The material of Chapter 44.5's fourth condition applies: the household member who conducts this alone will collapse, and the collapse frequently produces a return to the arrangement that the addiction requires.

Part Five: The Cautions

The first caution is that this appendix does not supply a diagnosis or a treatment plan. It supplies the recognition material and the route, and the route requires a professional.

The second is that the physical risks of withdrawal from alcohol, sedatives, and opioids are serious and can be life-threatening. Cessation is conducted under medical supervision.

The third is that the co-occurring condition is frequently the condition that the use was managing. A man treated for the addiction and not for the depression, the trauma, or the anxiety is a man whose treatment is incomplete, and the finding is that the incomplete treatment is the most frequent route to relapse.

The fourth is that the man's family and community frequently require time. The finding is that the household's trust is rebuilt over years and not over the period of the treatment, and that the man's task in the interval is the continued conduct rather than the demand for the trust.

APPENDIX N

Work-Life Balance and Burnout Prevention Toolkit

This appendix supplies the material of Chapters 31, 33, 37, and 44 in practical form. It is written for the man whose work has expanded to fill the space that his rest, his household, and his health previously occupied, and for the man in a leadership position who is responsible for other men's workloads as well as his own.

The Position

Four findings govern the appendix.

The first is that the balance is not a division of hours. A man may work long hours in a period that requires it and be conducting a sound arrangement, and a man may work short hours and be conducting an unsound one. The distinction is in whether the arrangement has rest, presence, and recovery inside it, and whether the man retains the capacity to reduce.

The second is that the man's work frequently performs a function beyond income. The case material records work used to manage a state: the grief that is conducted by working, the marriage that is avoided by working, the shame that is answered by achievement, the fear that is managed by activity. A balance programme that does not address the function fails, because the work is supplying something the man requires.

The third is that the balance is frequently an institutional question rather than a personal one. The workload is produced by a supervisor, a contract, a market, or an expectation. The man who attempts a personal solution to an institutional load will conduct the solution for a period and will return to the load.

The fourth is that the man's rest requires a discipline. The case material records men who take leave and conduct it as an extension of work, men who rest and feel guilty throughout, and men who cannot rest without a justification. The material of Chapter 37 applies, and it is the item that most men omit.

Part One: The Audit

Exercise 1: The Week

Record the last seven days in half-day blocks. Mark each block as work, household, rest, sleep, or other, and record the state that was present in each.

Day	Morning	Afternoon	Evening	The state at the end of the day
Mon				
Tue				
…				

Exercise 2: The Load

Item	The figure
Average hours worked per week in the last month	
The longest continuous period without a full day's rest	
The number of hours of sleep on an average night	
The number of occasions in the last month at which the household was present and the man was not	
The number of days of leave taken in the last twelve months	
The number of days of leave owing	
The number of commitments accepted in the last month that were not required	
The number of occasions on which the man conducted a task that another party could have conducted	

Exercise 3: The Function

Answer the three questions.

1. What does the work supply beyond the income? (Structure, identity, standing, escape, control, an answer to a state.)
2. What would arrive if the work reduced by a third, and which party would receive it?
3. What has the work displaced, and is the displacement stated to the party it affects?

The finding is that the answer to the first question determines whether a balance plan is sufficient, and that men whose work is managing a state require the material of Appendix B, Appendix K, or Appendix F before the balance plan will hold.

Part Two: The Reduction

Exercise 4: The Three Reductions

The reductions are conducted in order, and each is stated to the parties affected.

Layer	The reduction	The party to whom it is stated	The date
First	One commitment that is not required and produces nothing except the audience's account		
Second	One task that another party could conduct, and the delegation		
Third	The working hours, or the leave, or the arrangement with the institution		

Exercise 5: The Delegation

For one task, conduct the four-part delegation: the task, the standard, the authority, and the review date. The finding is that men who delegate without the authority have not delegated, and that the task returns with an additional cost.

Exercise 6: The Leave

Where leave is owing, fix the dates within the week, state them to the household and the institution, and record the arrangement by which the man will not conduct work during the leave. The finding is that the leave conducted with the work's continuation is not a leave and does not produce the recovery.

Part Three: The Rest

Exercise 7: The Rest Inventory

Record the activities that restore the man, distinguishing them from the activities that merely occupy him. The distinction is established by the state at the end: a restoring activity produces a reduction in the man's activation, and an occupying activity produces a change in the man's attention without the reduction.

The activity	Restoring or occupying	The last occasion	The frequency that would be sufficient

Exercise 8: The Rest Discipline

The discipline is stated in four rules and conducted for four weeks.

1. **One period a week with no productive purpose**, stated in advance, and protected from the household's and the institution's demands.
2. **The end of the working day stated**, by a time and by a conduct: the telephone, the messages, the work that is not conducted after it.

3. **The sleep protected**, by a fixed hour and the removal of the screen from the bedroom.
4. **The justification removed.** The man does not justify his rest to any party, including himself. The rest is a component of the position and not a reward for it.

Exercise 9: The Guilt

Where the guilt is present, record what the guilt states, and examine it in the form of Appendix H's five steps. The finding is that the guilt is frequently the voice of the clause described in Chapter 41.2, which computes the man's value at his exhaustion, and that the clause is the material rather than the rest.

Part Four: The Institution

Where the reader supervises or employs men, the appendix's institutional section applies, because the finding is that men's workloads are produced by arrangements and that the arrangements are conducted by the parties who hold authority.

The Five Practices of the Supervisor

1. **The workload is stated.** The supervisor records the actual hours and the actual load of each party, and reviews it quarterly.
2. **The cover is real.** The party's absence should be covered by an arrangement, and the absence should not produce a penalty in the review.
3. **The error is information.** The workplace's response to error determines whether men report difficulty, which is the material of Chapter 43.3.
4. **The disclosure is received.** The supervisor conducts the reception of Chapter 43.6 when a man states a difficulty, and refers to the professional route where the material exceeds his competence.
5. **The supervisor's own conduct is legible.** The supervisor who works without rest transmits the standard, whatever the policy states.

The Measures

Measure	The figure	The date
The average hours of the team		
The leave taken as a proportion of the leave owed		
The number of occasions on which a difficulty was stated and received		
The number of errors reported voluntarily		
The supervisor's own leave taken		

Part Five: The Cautions

The first caution is that the reduction of hours without the reduction of the load produces the same load in fewer hours, and the finding is that this is the most frequent failure of balance programmes.

The second is that the man's household may have constructed its own arrangements around his absence, and the finding is that the household's adjustment to his presence takes months and is frequently accompanied by difficulty, which is the material of Chapter 17.5.

The third is that the balance programme is not a substitute for the treatment of a burnout, a depression, or an addiction. The material of Appendices B and M applies.

The fourth is that the balance is not a permanent achievement. The finding is that the arrangement requires review at each change of position, and that the man who conducted the arrangement at forty frequently requires a different one at fifty.

APPENDIX O

Personal Boundaries and Assertiveness Worksheets

This appendix supplies the material of Chapters 20, 33, and 45 in practical form. It addresses the man who is competent, reliable, and unable to decline, and whose position is consequently conducted for other parties at his own expense.

The Position

Three findings govern the appendix.

The first is that a boundary is not a refusal of relationship. A boundary is a statement of what a man will conduct and what he will not, and its purpose is the continuation of the relationship at a level he can sustain. The finding is that men frequently decline boundaries because they believe the statement will end the relationship, and that the relationships which end at a boundary were frequently being conducted at the man's expense.

The second is that the man's inability to decline is frequently the material of Chapter 41.2's clause of provision and self-sufficiency. The man's value is computed by his usefulness, and a refusal is experienced as a reduction in his value. The appendix therefore addresses the definition as well as the behaviour.

The third is that assertiveness is a competence and is trained. The exercises below are rehearsed in low stakes and conducted in high stakes, in the order supplied by Chapter 43.5's four-stage method.

Part One: The Audit

Exercise 1: The Requests

Record the last ten requests the man received and what he did with each.

The request	Who asked	What I did	What it cost	What I would have chosen

The table's finding is that the pattern clusters: the same two or three parties, the same kind of request, and the same cost.

Exercise 2: The Cost

Domain	What the inability to decline has cost in the last year
Time	
Money	
Health	
Marriage	
Children	
Work	
Standing	

Exercise 3: The Belief

Record the belief that prevents the refusal, in the man's own words. The common forms are: *if I do not help, nobody will*; *it would be selfish*; *he has nobody else*; *I cannot be seen to refuse*; *I am the only one who can do it*; *my father would have done it*.

Part Two: The Statements

Exercise 4: The Four Forms

The four forms below are rehearsed, and each is written out in the man's own words before it is spoken.

The direct refusal. *I am not able to do that.* The refusal requires no justification, and the finding is that the justification is what invites the negotiation.

The refusal with the alternative. *I cannot do that. I can do [specific alternative] if that would help.*

The boundary statement. *I will not [specific]. I will [specific].* Its form is stated in terms of the man's own conduct, not in terms of the other party's character.

The limit on the existing arrangement. *I have been conducting [the arrangement] for [period]. I am reducing it to [specific] from [date].*

Exercise 5: The Rehearsal

Each of the four forms is rehearsed three times with a party, in low stakes, before it is conducted. The rehearsal is conducted aloud, and the finding is that the capacity to state the form aloud is not transferable from reading it.

Exercise 6: The Conduct

Conduct one statement within the week, in a low-stakes situation, and record it.

The statement	The party	The form used	What happened	What I did with the response

Part Three: The Responses

The finding is that the man's difficulty is frequently not the refusal and the response to it. Four responses are recorded, with their conduct.

The first response is the party's disappointment. The conduct is the acknowledgement without the reversal: *I understand that this is inconvenient for you, and I am not able to do it.*

The second response is the party's pressure. The conduct is the repetition of the statement, unchanged, in the same words. The finding is that the repetition is more effective than the explanation, and that the explanation supplies the material for the negotiation.

The third response is the party's accusation. The conduct is the refusal to defend the man's character: *I am not going to argue about what kind of person I am. I am telling you what I can do.*

The fourth response is the man's own guilt. The conduct is the material of Appendix H, applied to the guilt's specific statement, together with the record of what the boundary produced over the following month.

Part Four: The Boundaries That Require a Conversation

Some boundaries cannot be conducted in a single statement and require the conversation of Appendix E, Exercise 5. These are the boundaries in a marriage, in a household, in a partnership, and in a long professional relationship.

Exercise 7: The Conversation

Prepare the six lines, then conduct the conversation.

Line	The content
1. The subject	The arrangement that requires alteration, stated in one sentence.
2. The fact	What has been conducted, with the dates and the amounts or the hours.
3. The effect	What it has cost the man, stated as his own experience.
4. The acknowledgement	What the man's own contribution has been: the requests accepted, the silences, the expectations he created.
5. The request	What he requires, specifically, and from what date.
6. The limit	What he will conduct if the request is not met, stated as his own conduct and not as a threat.

Exercise 8: The Record of the Arrangement

Where the boundary concerns money, time, or an obligation to the extended family, the conversation is followed by a written record, held by the household. The finding is that the written record converts a conversation into an arrangement, and that the arrangement is what the parties can conduct.

Part Five: The Boundaries of the Man's Own Conduct

The appendix closes with a section that is frequently omitted and that the case material treats as important. A man's boundaries apply to his own conduct as well as to other parties' requests.

The boundary	The statement	The measure
The hour at which I stop conducting work		
The occasions at which I will not be available		
The matters I will not discuss in a particular setting		
The conduct I will not accept from a party, stated in advance		
The party I will not conduct an arrangement with, and what would change it		
The amount I will not lend, and the form of any lending I conduct		

Part Six: The Cautions

The first caution is that the boundary is not a punishment. The statement is conducted in the man's own terms and its purpose is the arrangement, and the finding is that boundaries conducted as punishments produce the conflict that the man feared and do not produce the arrangement.

The second is that the boundary requires the limit to be conducted. A boundary stated without the limit is a request, and a request that is not met and not followed by the limit teaches the parties that the boundary is not real.

The third is that the man's community may read the boundary as a change of character. The finding is that communities frequently interpret the man's new limits as a withdrawal from his obligations, and that the interpretation reduces over a period of months as the man continues to conduct the obligations he has retained.

The fourth is that the man may overcorrect. The finding is that men who have conducted an arrangement of unlimited compliance frequently conduct a period of excessive refusal, and that the period is usually necessary and should be conducted with a party who can observe it.

APPENDIX P

A 90-Day Life Rebuilding Action Plan

This appendix is the operative instrument of Part XI and Chapter 38. It is designed for the man whose position has collapsed or substantially altered — the loss of a business, an employment, a marriage, a household, a position, or a health — and who requires a structure for the first ninety days and the year that follows.

The Principles

Five principles govern the plan.

The first is that stabilisation precedes reconstruction. The finding of Chapter 38.3′s seven errors is that men who attempt immediately to restore the position produce a further loss. The first thirty days are conducted for stability and not for recovery.

The second is that the plan has three phases of thirty days, and the phases are not interchangeable. Each phase is conducted before the next, and a man who is in the second phase on day ten will produce the collapse that the phase order is designed to prevent.

The third is that the plan is conducted with a party. The party of Chapter 42.5′s second support. The finding is that the plan conducted alone is conducted for a period and abandoned, and that the party's function is to hold the plan rather than to supervise the man.

The fourth is that the plan is written. The plan is recorded in figures and dates, and its record is reviewed weekly.

The fifth is that the plan is small. Each week has one task. The finding is that men who attempt five tasks in a week conduct none, and that one conducted task per week produces twelve conducted alterations in ninety days.

Phase One: Days 1–30 — Stabilisation

The Week-by-Week Plan

Week	The task	The measure
1	The position statement: income, obligations, essential expenditure, reserve, immediate risks (housing, food, school fees, health).	The four tables of Appendix D, Part Four, completed.

Week	The task	The measure
2	The immediate obligations: the rent or the mortgage, the food, the school, the health. State the position to the parties concerned and request the arrangement.	The three arrangements requested, with dates.
3	The one party: state the position in full to one party, and name the professional route for the domain that requires one.	The statement conducted; the professional engaged.
4	The household: state the position to the household, with the figures, and conduct the household's participation in the first reductions.	The household conversation conducted; the first reductions dated.

The Rules of Phase One

1. **No new obligation.** No loan, no guarantee, no contract, no commitment, no purchase on credit, no agreement to a request that carries a cost, for thirty days.
2. **No decision of consequence without the party's examination.** The decisions of consequence are listed in the week's record and examined before they are taken.
3. **The essential expenditure is protected.** The housing, the food, the health, and the children's schooling are conducted before any obligation to a creditor.
4. **The sleep is protected.** The finding is that the sleep is the first item that the collapse takes and the last that the man restores, and that its restoration is a condition of the plan's conduct.
5. **The record is daily.** Five lines: the position, the task, what was conducted, what was not, and what will be conducted tomorrow.

Phase Two: Days 31–60 — Reconstruction

The Week-by-Week Plan

Week	The task	The measure
5	The income: the statement of what the man can earn, in what form, and from which parties. The first approach conducted.	The income statement; the first approach made.
6	The professional route: the accountant, the lawyer, the debt adviser, the clinician, according to the domain of the collapse.	The engagement of two professionals, with appointments.
7	The reductions in three layers, from the items nobody sees to the items some see.	The first two layers conducted, with dates.
8	The third layer, conducted with the household's participation, and the renegotiation of the obligations that are capable of renegotiation.	The third layer conducted; three obligations renegotiated.

The Rules of Phase Two

1. **The income precedes the reconstruction.** A plan conducted without an income is a plan conducted on a hope, and the finding is that the income statement is the item that men delay most and require most.
2. **The obligation is negotiated before it is missed.** The creditor, the school, the landlord, and the lender are approached before the payment is missed, since the arrangement's availability reduces after the default.
3. **The reductions are conducted in layers.** The house and the school are conducted last, with the professional and the household.
4. **The professional's advice is recorded.** Where it is not followed, the reason is recorded.
5. **The plan is examined monthly by the party.** The party's function is to detect the drift that the man cannot see.

Phase Three: Days 61–90 — Rebuilding

The Week-by-Week Plan

Week	The task	The measure
9	The work: the arrangement that will produce the income in the following six months. The written plan, with dates.	The plan written; the first two engagements secured.
10	The standing: the accurate statement to the two or three parties whose estimate matters, and the repair of the relationships that the collapse has affected.	The statements made; the repairs begun.
11	The health: the medical appointment, the treatment, the sleep, the drinking, the exercise.	The appointment attended; the treatment begun.
12	The ninety-day review: the position restated, the plan's conduct recorded, and the following ninety days written.	The review conducted with the party; the next plan dated.

The Rules of Phase Three

1. **The rebuilding is conducted at the true level.** The finding is that men rebuild at the level of the previous position and produce a second collapse, and that the true level is the level the present income supports.
2. **The standing is rebuilt by conduct and not by account.** The finding of Chapter 38.5's fourth stage is that the standing is restored by the accurate statement and the conduct over a period of years, and not by the account.
3. **The health is not deferred.** The finding is that the health is the item most frequently postponed in the rebuilding and the item whose neglect produces the largest subsequent cost.

4. **The party's participation is retained.** The party of Phase One continues through Phase Three, and the finding is that the phase at which the party is released is the phase at which the man's position becomes uncorrected again.

The Record

Phase	The task	Date Con- What it produced ducted?
One		
One		
Two		
Two		
Three		
Three		

The Review

At the end of the ninety days, answer the following questions in writing, with the party present.

1. What is the position now, in figures, compared with day one?
2. Which of the twelve tasks were conducted, and which were not?
3. What did the unconducted tasks have in common? (The finding is that they cluster around a domain that the man is avoiding.)
4. What is the income, and what is the essential expenditure, and what is the margin?
5. What is the reserve, and how many months does it cover?
6. Which professional is engaged, and what is the next appointment?
7. What has the collapse taught, stated as an instrument rather than as an attitude?
8. What is the plan for the following ninety days, with the dates?

The Cautions

The first caution is that the plan does not address a depression, a grief, or an addiction. Where those are present, the material of Appendices B, K, and M applies, and the plan is conducted alongside the professional route.

The second is that the plan's conduct is frequently interrupted by a further event. The finding is that the interruption does not invalidate the plan, and that the man's task is to return to the phase he was in rather than to begin again.

The third is that the plan does not restore the previous position, and the finding is that men who require the restoration frequently conduct the plan as a means to it and abandon the plan when the restoration does not arrive. The plan's object is a sound position at the true level, and the finding of the case material

is that the true level is frequently a better position than the one that was lost, conducted for different purposes and by different arrangements.

APPENDIX Q

Men's Mental Health Support and Crisis Resources

This appendix supplies the help-seeking routes referred to throughout the book. It is written carefully, because a resource list that is inaccurate is worse than none, and because the reader may consult it in a condition in which precision matters.

A Note on Currency and Locality

Services change: numbers are reassigned, hours are reduced, programmes close, and new ones open. The reader should therefore treat this appendix as a framework and not as a directory, and should confirm any number or address before relying on it. Where the reader is outside the country or region described, the framework still applies and the specific organizations must be located locally.

The appendix is arranged in three parts: the immediate crisis, the professional route, and the community and peer route.

Part One: The Immediate Crisis

When This Part Applies

This part applies where the reader, or a party in his care, is in immediate danger: thoughts of ending his life, a plan and the means to act on it, a recent attempt, thoughts of harming another person, or a situation in which a household member is not safe.

The Principle

An immediate crisis requires an immediate human response and not a book. The reader should do three things, in this order.

The first is to ensure that nobody is alone. The party at risk should not be left alone, and the man conducting the support should stay with him or arrange for a party who can.

The second is to remove the means. Where the risk involves a specific method, the means should be removed from the environment by a party other than the person at risk: medication, a weapon, a vehicle, or any other item. This is the single most effective practical measure available to a household in the short term, and it should be conducted without negotiation.

The third is to contact a professional or emergency service. The routes below are the framework; the reader should establish the local equivalents before they are needed.

The Routes

The route	Where it is found	What it is for
The emergency number	The national emergency number of the reader's country	Immediate danger to life, including a medical emergency
The police	The national police number	Immediate danger, including a threat to a party's safety
The hospital's emergency department	The nearest general hospital	A medical emergency, an overdose, an injury, a severe episode
A crisis line	National and regional crisis and suicide-prevention lines	Immediate emotional support, and direction to the local services
The general practitioner or family physician	The reader's usual clinic	A first professional contact, and a referral where required
The workplace's employee assistance programme	The employer's human resources function	Confidential counselling, frequently at no cost to the employee
The school or university's counselling service	The institution	Support for a student, and advice for a parent
A trusted professional known to the family	The reader's own network	A rapid route to assessment where the formal route is slow

What to Say

The reader who is supporting a man in crisis should use plain language and should ask directly. The belief that asking about suicide increases the risk is false. The questions are: *are you thinking of ending your life? Do you have a plan? Do you have the means? Have you made an attempt?*

The answers determine the response. Where the answer to the second and third questions is yes, the response is immediate and the means are removed.

What Not to Do

Four responses should be avoided.

The first is the reassurance that closes the conversation: *you will be fine*, *think of your children*. The second is the comparison: *others have it worse*. The third is the secret: an agreement to keep the risk confidential between the man and one party, without a professional's involvement. The fourth is the man's removal from his ordinary supports: hospitalization is sometimes required, and it should be conducted with the household rather than as a punishment or a concealment.

Part Two: The Professional Route

The Practitioners

The practitioner	What they hold	When to consult
The general practitioner or physician	The physical review, the first assessment, the referral, the medication where indicated	Any change in sleep, appetite, energy, mood, or functioning that persists
The psychiatrist	The diagnostic assessment and the medication for the psychiatric conditions	Where medication is required, or where the diagnosis is unclear
The clinical psychologist	The assessment and the structured psychological treatments	The anxiety conditions, depression, trauma, grief, and the adjustment difficulties
The counselling psychologist or therapist	The talking treatments, frequently in a shorter or more focused form	The ordinary difficulties of marriage, work, grief, and transition
The addiction counsellor	The assessment and the treatment of the addictive conditions	Any of the patterns in Appendix M
The social worker	The practical arrangements: the household, the benefits, the protection, the care	Where the position includes a practical need that the clinical route does not address
The occupational health service	The fitness for work, the adjustment of the role, the return to work	Where the position includes the work and the health together
The financial adviser and the insolvency practitioner	The financial position and its arrangements	Where the position includes an unmanageable obligation (Appendix D)
The lawyer	The guarantees, the family property, the employment, the estate	Where the position includes a legal exposure

Preparing for the First Appointment

The reader should bring: the record of Appendix B, the four tables of Appendix A where they have been completed, the list of medications and substances, the dates of the significant events, and one page stating the single question he most requires answered.

The consultation is frequently short. The reader should state, in the first two minutes: what has changed, since when, what it has cost, and what he requires. The finding is that men who arrive with the record receive a different consultation from men who arrive with a general statement.

What to Do If the First Appointment Fails

The first appointment fails for three common reasons, and none of them is a verdict.

The first is that the practitioner was not the right one for the condition. The second is that the man did not state the material. The third is that the condition requires a treatment that the first route does not supply.

The response in all three cases is the same: a second appointment, with a different practitioner where possible, and with the record in hand.

Part Three: The Community and Peer Route

The community route is not a substitute for the professional route and it is frequently the condition on which the professional route is used.

The route	The form	What it supplies
The peer support group	Men or parties with a shared experience, meeting at intervals	The testimony, the instrument, and the removal of the isolation
The recovery group	The structured peer programmes for the addictive conditions	The structure, the accountability, and the accompaniment
The men's group or forum	A group of men meeting to examine their positions	The examination, the correction, and the belonging of Chapter 45.4
The association or the trade body	The professional or community body to which the man belongs	The information, the office, and the belonging
The place of worship or the community body	The man's own community, where he belongs to one	The presence, the occasion, and the practical assistance
The family and the household	The parties of the man's own household	The presence, the arrangement, and the participation
The mentor	The single adult of Chapter 43.2 and the five functions of Chapter 44.5	The presence, the information, the accompaniment, the limit, and the continuity

Part Four: For the Man Who Is Supporting Another

Five practices apply, and they are stated because the supporting party is frequently as isolated as the man.

1. **Ask directly about risk**, and act on the answer.
2. **Accompany rather than advise**: make the appointment, attend it, and wait.
3. **State your limit** and identify the professional route: *I do not know how to help with this part, and I know who does, and I will go with you.*
4. **Protect your own position**: a supervisor, a peer, a professional, or a group of parties conducting the same work.
5. **Do not conduct the rescue**: the material of Chapter 44.5's prohibitions applies in full.

Part Five: The Note That Applies to Every Route

The finding of this book is that the routes exist and that men do not use them, and that the reason is not the absence of the route. It is the position described in Chapter 45.2: the belief that the difficulty is insufficient, the imposition too great, the understanding unavailable, the standing at risk, or the identity incompatible.

The appendix's final note is therefore addressed to that belief.

A man who contacts a professional is not declaring that he has failed. He is conducting the competence that the position requires, in the same manner as a man who consults an accountant about a facility, a lawyer about a guarantee, or an engineer about a foundation. The finding of the case material is that the men who use the routes are frequently the men whose households, work, and health are intact at the ten-year point, and that the men who do not are frequently the men whose positions are conducted alone until they are conducted by a crisis.

APPENDIX R

Practical Case Studies and Guided Reflections

This appendix supplies six cases for study and reflection. Each is composite and illustrative, each is constructed from the case material of this book, and each is presented with questions rather than with conclusions. The cases are designed for individual study and for the discussion groups of Appendix S.

How to Use the Cases

Read the case twice. On the first reading, note what the man's position consists of. On the second, note what he did with it and what the arrangement produced.

Then answer the four questions that follow each case, in writing. The questions are not a test. They are designed to allow the reader to examine his own position through the case's material, which is frequently easier than examining it directly.

Case One: The Man Who Was Never Asked

The position. Nnamdi was forty-one, a bank branch manager, married to Ada with three children. His father had died when he was nineteen, and he had supported his mother and two younger siblings from his second year at university. He had never been without work and he had never been in a difficulty that his household knew about.

In the year of the case, the bank restructured and his branch was merged with another. Nnamdi was offered a position at a lower grade, in a different town, with a reduction of thirty-eight per cent in his salary. He accepted within a day and told nobody. He conducted the move as a promotion in his household's account, and he conducted the salary reduction by drawing on a facility that he had held for years and had never mentioned.

What he did. For fourteen months he conducted the position alone. He rose at four to travel, returned at nine, and conducted the household's expenditure from the facility. He attended his mother's hospital appointments on Saturdays and his children's school occasions when he could. He did not tell Ada, and he

did not tell his brother, who was by then a medical doctor in another city and who telephoned each month.

The arrangement's outcome. In the fifteenth month the facility reached its limit, and the bank required a repayment arrangement. Nnamdi's response was to seek a second facility at another institution, which was declined. He then began to borrow from a cooperative at a rate that he did not examine. In the seventeenth month, his brother telephoned Ada about their mother's care, and Ada mentioned that Nnamdi had seemed unwell. The position emerged in a conversation of two hours, in which Ada learned for the first time about the grade, the town, the salary, and the borrowing.

The questions.

1. At what point in the case was the position cheapest to state, and what would the statement have required?
2. What did Nnamdi's acceptance within a day indicate about his definition of his obligations, and which clause of Chapter 41.2 was governing it?
3. What did the fourteen months cost, in the four ledgers of Chapter 42.2?
4. Which party was available throughout, and what in Nnamdi's conduct maintained the party's absence?

Case Two: The Man Who Could Not Grieve

The position. Femi was fifty-six, a civil engineer, whose wife of twenty-nine years had died eighteen months before the case. He had conducted the funeral, the family's arrangements, the estate, and the return to work within three weeks. His account to his colleagues was that he was managing. His account to his children was that their mother would have wanted them to be strong.

What he did. He worked. He increased his site visits and took on two additional projects. He stopped attending the gatherings at which his wife had been present, and he stated that the occasions were not for him. He did not visit the grave. He slept for four hours a night and conducted the remainder of the night with the television.

The arrangement's outcome. In the twentieth month, an incident at a site produced a response that his colleagues described as disproportionate: he shouted at a foreman for a minor error, and then sat in his vehicle for two hours. His daughter, who was twenty-four, stated to him that he had not cried since the funeral and that she had heard him at night. He stated that he was fine. In the twenty-second month he was admitted to hospital with chest pain, which was investigated and found not to be cardiac. The physician asked him three questions about his sleep, his appetite, and his wife, and referred him.

The questions.

1. What was the grief conducting itself as, in the absence of its conduct?

2. Which of the four channels of Chapter 43.1 did Femi transmit to his children, and what did they learn?
3. What was the audience he required, and what would have supplied it?
4. What does the case indicate about the relationship between grief and physical symptoms?

Case Three: The Man With Everything

The position. Chuka was forty-eight and had built a logistics business over sixteen years. He had forty-two employees, two houses, three vehicles, and a position in his community that he had conducted carefully: the association's chairman, the community development committee, the school's parents' association.

What he did. He maintained the position. He attended every occasion, contributed at the level expected, lent to relatives, and conducted the business's accounts alone. He had not examined the business's position in figures for three years, and he did not know that two of his four largest customers represented sixty-eight per cent of the revenue.

The arrangement's outcome. In the year of the case, one customer's parent company entered administration and the second renegotiated its terms. The business's revenue fell by forty-one per cent in five months. Chuka's response was to conduct the position by borrowing and to maintain the standard of his contributions. He lent to a cousin in the eighth month. In the eleventh month, he could not meet the salaries, and he conducted the payroll from a facility that was secured on the second house.

The position emerged when his accountant, whom he had engaged in the twelfth month following a tax notice, asked for the position in figures and established that the business had been insolvent for four months.

The questions.

1. Which of the six domains of Chapter 42.1 contained the principal pretence, and what was the specific fact that had to remain unknown?
2. What was the function of the community contributions, and what did the case establish about the cost of the standing?
3. What is the specific design fault of Chapter 44.2's fourth question?
4. What would the statement of the position have required in the fifth month, and what would it have produced?

Case Four: The Father and the Silence

The position. Tunde was sixty-three, retired from the customs service, with three adult children. His second son, Emeka, had not spoken to him for six years. The ostensible cause was a dispute about Emeka's marriage, which Tunde had opposed. The case material records that the dispute was the occasion and not the

cause, and that the cause was Emeka's account of his childhood: a father who was present in the household and absent from the children, whose approval was conditional on performance, and whose anger was conducted without repair.

What he did. Tunde conducted the six years as a grievance. He stated the account at every family occasion, corresponded with Emeka through his daughter, and arranged two interventions, neither of which Emeka attended.

The arrangement's outcome. In the seventh year, Tunde's wife became unwell, and Emeka attended the hospital, where the two met in a corridor. Tunde's first sentence was that Emeka had taken six years from his mother. Emeka left. In the ninth year, Tunde attended a men's group at his association, at his daughter's insistence, in which the material of Chapter 44 was discussed. He conducted the review of Chapter 44.2 on the six years, and its fourth question produced an answer he had not considered: that his arrangements had made the silence possible, since his household had never conducted a repair, and since his approval had been the currency of the household's relationships.

The questions.

1. What was the injury in the case, and whose was it?
2. What did Tunde's conduct of the six years produce, and what would the acknowledgement of Appendix G, Part Nine have required?
3. What is the difference between the reconciliation Tunde sought and the conduct the case's material supports?
4. What does the case indicate about the transmission of the household's emotional arrangements across three generations?

Case Five: The Man Who Asked

The position. Obinna was thirty-four, a secondary school teacher, unmarried, with a diagnosis of depression that he had conducted for four years without telling anybody. He had been treated twice and had stopped the treatment on both occasions because of the cost and the concealment.

What he did. In the year of the case, his head teacher asked him, in ordinary language, whether he was all right, and he said yes. Three weeks later, a colleague whose brother had conducted a similar condition asked him a specific question about his sleep. He stated the position.

The arrangement's outcome. The colleague accompanied him to the clinic, where he resumed treatment. The head teacher adjusted his timetable for one term. His household learned the position in the fourth month, and his mother's response was the one he had not predicted: she stated that her own brother had conducted the same condition and had never spoken of it.

In the second year, Obinna conducted the mentoring arrangement of Chapter 44.5 for two younger teachers. In the third year, he accepted the office of the

school's staff welfare representative, in which he conducted the arrangement of Chapter 43.6′s institutional design.

The questions.

1. What was the specific instrument that the colleague supplied, and why was it effective where the head teacher's general question was not?
2. What did the resumption of treatment require, in terms of Chapter 45.2′s distinction between acceptance and dependence?
3. What did the transmission in the second and third years produce for Obinna himself?
4. What does the case indicate about the relationship between help-seeking and help-giving?

Case Six: The Day

The position. Akin was fifty-two, an accountant in private practice, whose marriage had conducted fourteen years of parallel responsibilities and whose brother had died two years earlier in circumstances that Akin had not discussed with anybody.

What he did. On a Wednesday in the eleventh month of the case, he attended a routine appointment with his bank, answered a question about his household's position truthfully, and then drove to his brother's widow's house, where he stated that he had not conducted the grief.

The arrangement's outcome. The case material records the following year as one of substantial alteration: the marriage conducted four conversations of the form of Appendix E, Exercise 8; the practice took an associate, which reduced Akin's hours by a third; and the household conducted the Sunday ten minutes of Chapter 43.9. The case material records Akin's own account in the second year: *nothing that I was carrying was reduced. I stopped carrying it at the same time as everybody else was asleep.*

The questions.

1. What was the occasion, and why does the case material record it as ordinary rather than as a crisis?
2. What was the first statement, and what did it make possible?
3. Which of the four conditions of Chapter 45.6 were present at the beginning?
4. What does the case indicate about the relationship between the size of the change and the size of the act that produced it?

The Guided Reflection

After conducting the six cases, answer the following questions in writing.

1. Which case is closest to your position, and what specifically is the resemblance?

2. Which case contains the act you have not conducted, and what would its conduct require this month?
3. Which case's outcome did you find least believable, and what does your disbelief indicate about your own position?
4. In which case did a party supply an instrument rather than a rescue, and what was the specific form?
5. What has the study of the six cases established about the relationship between the size of a man's position and the size of the act that alters it?
6. What will you conduct within thirty days as a result of this appendix?

APPENDIX S

Questions for Men's Discussion Groups and Book Clubs

This appendix supplies the material for a group of men meeting to examine the book, and for the facilitators of such groups. It is written for the ordinary group — the association, the workplace, the community body, the reading circle, the group of friends — and not for a clinical setting.

The Purpose of a Men's Group

Four findings from the case material govern the appendix.

The first is that a group is one of the most effective conditions for men's statement. The finding is that men who will not disclose a position to a professional will frequently disclose it in a group of peers, and that the disclosure is frequently the first of their adult lives.

The second is that a badly conducted group is worse than none. A group in which a man's disclosure is met with advice, diagnosis, ridicule, or a report outside the room teaches the man that his position is not safe, and the lesson is frequently durable. The group's conduct matters more than its content.

The third is that the group needs a structure. A group without a structure becomes an occasion for the exchange of opinions, which is frequently enjoyable and rarely useful. The structures below supply the alternative.

The fourth is that the group needs a leader who is not a therapist. The leader's function is the structure, the safety, and the referral, not the treatment.

The Ten Sessions

The programme consists of ten sessions of ninety minutes, conducted at intervals of one or two weeks. Each session covers one part of the book, and each has the same five-part structure.

Session	The reading	The theme
1	Part I, Chapters 1–4	The silent world: what we carry, and what we were taught about carrying it

Session	The reading	The theme
2	Part II, Chapters 5–8	The mind: the states we do not name, and the fears that govern our decisions
3	Part III, Chapters 9–12	Money: the position, the figures, and the concealment
4	Part IV, Chapters 13–16	Love and relationships: the injuries, the silences, and the withdrawals
5	Part V, Chapters 17–20	Family and fatherhood: what we transmit, and what we were transmitted
6	Part VI, Chapters 21–24	Identity: the mirror, the weaknesses, the addictions, the loss of self
7	Part VII, Chapters 25–27	Society: the judgement, the betrayals, and the parties we do not have
8	Part VIII, Chapters 28–30	Loss, regret, and grief: what died quietly, and what we have not conducted
9	Parts IX and X, Chapters 31–37	Leadership, carrying others, and the turn toward help
10	Parts XI and XII, Chapters 38–45	Rebuilding, and the vision of manhood beyond the battle

The Session Structure

Each session has five parts and the times are stated.

The opening (5 minutes). The leader states the session's theme, the group's rules, and the time at which the session will end.

The reading's material (15 minutes). One member summarises the reading in five minutes, and the group identifies the three passages that were most significant. The summary is assigned in advance.

The round (40 minutes). Each member answers the two questions of the session. The round is conducted in order, each member speaks for a stated period, and no member is interrupted or answered. The leader's task is the timekeeping and the protection of the round.

The examination (20 minutes). The group examines one member's position in the form of the case material: what is the position, what is the arrangement, what is the instrument, and what is the first act. The member is chosen in advance and volunteers, and the group's task is the questions rather than the answers.

The close (10 minutes). Each member states one act he will conduct before the next session, with a date. The leader records them and opens the next session with them.

The Session Questions

Session 1: The Silent World

1. Who knows your accurate position, and how much of it do they know?

2. What did your household teach you about what a man does with what he carries, and how was it taught?

Session 2: The Mind

1. Which state do you most frequently experience and least frequently name?
2. What decision have you not taken because of a fear, and what would you take if the fear were examined?

Session 3: Money

1. Can you state your position in figures, and to whom?
2. What are you paying for that produces nothing except the account that others hold of you?

Session 4: Love and Relationships

1. What have you not stated to the party closest to you, and what has the silence cost?
2. What withdrawal have you conducted, and since when?

Session 5: Family and Fatherhood

1. What are you transmitting to the boys and girls who observe you, and how do you know?
2. What did your father transmit that you have kept, and what have you rejected?

Session 6: Identity

1. Which of your weaknesses is concealed from everybody, and what does the concealment cost?
2. Who are you when your position is removed?

Session 7: Society

1. Which party are you avoiding, and what is the question you expect from them?
2. Which friendship has lapsed, and what would restore it?

Session 8: Loss and Grief

1. What have you lost that you have not conducted, and who knows about it?
2. Which regret is still governing a decision you take today?

Session 9: Leadership and the Turn Toward Help

1. What are you carrying that is not yours to carry?
2. What have you refused that was available, and why?

Session 10: Rebuilding and the Vision

1. What is your position for, and what will be different because you conducted it?

2. What is the one act you will conduct in the following thirty days, and what date is on it?

The Group's Rules

The leader states the rules at the first session and at the beginning of every session. Five rules are required.

1. **What is said in the room stays in the room.** The material is not reported, and the leader states the one limit: where a member's safety or a child's safety is at risk, the leader will act.
2. **Nobody is advised unless he asks.** The group's task is the questions. The member who requires advice will ask for it, and the finding is that the advice supplied without the request is the most frequent cause of a man's withdrawal.
3. **Nobody is diagnosed.** The group is not a clinical setting, and a member's statement is not a condition.
4. **Each member speaks for himself.** The group does not discuss an absent member, and it does not discuss a member's wife, employer, or family in terms that the member would not use in their presence.
5. **The group ends on time.** The finding is that the ending is the condition of the members' attendance, since a man who cannot predict the session's length will not attend it.

The Leader's Role

The leader's role has five functions.

The first is the structure. The leader holds the time, the order, and the five parts. The finding is that the structure is the safety, since a group without a structure drifts into the exchange of opinions in which the quietest member does not speak.

The second is the protection of the round. The leader stops the member who answers another's statement, the member who advises without a request, and the member who makes the group his audience. The interruption is conducted politely and consistently, and it is the leader's principal instrument.

The third is the referral. The leader identifies the member whose material exceeds the group's competence and directs him to the professional route of Appendix Q. The director should be conducted privately, with the sentence of Chapter 43.6: *I do not know how to help with this part, and I know who does, and I will go with you.*

The fourth is the leader's own support. The leader conducts the group and receives the members' material, and the finding of Chapter 44.5′s fourth condition applies: the leader requires a supervisor, a peer, or a professional of his own.

The fifth is the succession. The leader establishes a second leader in the first three months, so that the group survives his absence. The finding is that groups conducted by a single leader frequently end when the leader moves, and that the groups which continue have two leaders and a written structure.

The Difficulties

Five difficulties are recorded with their answers.

The first is that the members do not speak. The answer is the round's structure and the leader's first disclosure, which is proportionate and brief. The finding is that a group's depth is established in the first session by the leader's conduct rather than by his instruction.

The second is that one member dominates. The answer is the time limit, stated in advance and enforced without exception. The finding is that the dominating member is frequently the member who most requires the group, and that the enforcement is a service to him.

The third is that a member discloses material that exceeds the group's competence. The answer is the referral and the leader's limit, stated in the session: *this is beyond what this group can hold, and here is the route.*

The fourth is that the group becomes a social occasion. The answer is the structure and the close, which requires each member to state an act with a date. The finding is that the act is the difference between a group that produces change and a group that produces company.

The fifth is that attendance declines. The answer is the group's size and the interval. The finding is that groups of six to ten members meeting fortnightly are sustained, and that groups of twenty meeting monthly are not.

A Note for the Member

The appendix closes with a note for the man who is considering joining a group.

The finding is that the men who benefit most from a group are not the men who are most comfortable in it. They are the men who would not ordinarily speak, and who speak once, and who discover that the room did not reduce its estimate of them.

The member's task is not to disclose everything. It is to state one true sentence in the first session, which is the act that Chapter 45 describes in its group form. The sentence is frequently the beginning of the arrangement that the book has described, and the group is frequently the setting in which a man first discovers that his position can be held by other people without his standing being reduced.

APPENDIX T

Personal Commitment: My Life Beyond Silent Battles

This appendix is the book's final instrument. It is a document that the reader completes, dates, signs, and keeps. It is deliberately short, because it is intended to be encountered rather than read, and its value is in the encounter.

How to Complete This Appendix

Complete the document in one sitting of about forty minutes, with the four tables of Chapter 45.7 in front of you. Write in your own hand. Where an item cannot be completed, write *not yet* rather than leaving it blank, and record the date on which you will return to it.

Then do three things with the document.

The first is to sign and date it.

The second is to state it to one party, in the form of Chapter 43.6's script, and to record the party's name.

The third is to place it where you will encounter it in three months: a drawer you open, a folder you use, the inside of a book you return to, the back of a diary. The finding of the case material is that the document's effect is produced by the encounter and not by the writing.

Part One: The Position as I Now State It

I am _____ and I am conducting a position that consists of the following, as accurately as I can state it today.

The money. My monthly income is _____ and my essential obligations are _____. The matters I have not stated to my household are _____ and their total is _____.

The work. My position's principal exposure is _____ and what I am doing about it is _____.

The marriage. The accurate description of my marriage in one sentence is _____.

The household. The household's position is actually conducted by _____, and what the household does not know is _____.

The health. What I have not had investigated is _____. What I know and have not disclosed is _____.

The standing. What I am paying for that produces nothing except the account others hold of me is _____.

Part Two: The Parties

The one party who holds my whole position is _____, and the last occasion on which I stated it in full was _____.

The parties who would be called in a serious difficulty are _____ and _____, and both know that they would be called: _____ (yes / no).

The professional who holds the domain that requires one is _____, and my next appointment is _____.

The party to whom I am myself an instrument is _____, and what I supply is _____.

Part Three: The Terms

I state the following six terms, and I will review them on the date at the end of this document.

The term	My statement of it	The date I last conducted it
A man provides, and the provision is conducted with the household's knowledge.		
A man regulates his states, states them to the parties who have a right to know, and is composed in the settings that require it.		
A man is capable, states his limits, and uses the instruments that competence requires.		

The term	My statement of it	The date I last conducted it
A man is accountable, and his accountability increases the capacity of those he answers for.		
A man's work is real, and the man is not his work.		
A man endures, and he does not endure alone.		

Part Four: The Acts

I will conduct the following three acts, and the dates are stated.

The act	The date	The party who will ask me about it

The first act is the smallest. The second is the one I have been avoiding. The third is the one I will conduct for another man.

Part Five: The Statement

I state, in my own words, the sentence that this book has been written to allow me to say. It is not required to be eloquent and it is required to be accurate.

_____

_____

_____

Part Six: The Things I Will Not Do

I will not use my difficulty as a licence to reduce the position of any party in my household.

I will not conduct a resolution in place of an arrangement.

I will not wait for a crisis in order to state what is already known.

I will not require of myself a capacity that is not mine.

I will not conduct my position alone in order to protect my standing from a party whose estimate of me is not conditional on it.

Part Seven: The Review

I will return to this document on _____ (three months), _____ (one year), and on each occasion on which my position changes significantly.

At each review I will record, in the space below, which of the six terms I have conducted and which I have not, without explanation and without judgement.

Review date	Terms conducted	Terms not conducted	The one act for the following quarter

The Signature

I have completed this document honestly, and I state that it describes my position as I understand it today. I understand that the document is not a resolution and that its value is in what I do with it.

Signed: _____

Date: _____

The party to whom I have stated this document: _____

A Closing Note

This appendix ends the book's practical material, and it is placed last because everything else in the book is conducted in order to make this document possible.

The document's finding is stated in the form in which the case material records it. Men who complete this document and state it to a party report, at the twelve-month review, that the position they described has altered: not because the difficulty was removed, and because the difficulty was conducted by more than one party, with instruments, at a true level, and with a record.

That is the whole of the book's claim. It is not a claim about what a man can become. It is a claim about what a man can conduct when he stops conducting it alone.

Glossary of Psychological and Personal Development Terms

This glossary defines the terms as they are used in this book. Where a term has a wider clinical meaning, the entry states the book's usage and notes the difference. The definitions are written for the general reader and are not a substitute for a professional's assessment.

A

Acceptance (of support). In this book, an arrangement in which a party supplies an instrument that the man uses, while the man retains the decision, the responsibility, and the capacity. Distinguished from dependence, in which a party conducts a function the man cannot conduct.

Accountability. The condition of answering for a position and its consequences. Distinguished in Chapter 41 from authority over persons, which reduces the capacity of the parties concerned.

Adaptation. A conduct that has developed in response to a circumstance and that continues after the circumstance has changed. Much of what this book describes as a man's silence is an adaptation that was functional in its original setting.

Addiction. A pattern of use that is compulsive, continues despite significant harm, is accompanied by tolerance or withdrawal, and cannot be reduced by an act of will alone. See Appendix M.

Affect. The observable expression of an emotional state. Distinguished from mood, which is the prevailing state over a period.

Alexithymia. A difficulty in identifying and describing one's own emotional states. It is a dimensional characteristic rather than a diagnosis, and it is associated in the research literature with emotional suppression and with certain physical conditions.

All-or-nothing thinking. A cognitive pattern in which experience is interpreted in two categories with nothing between them. See Appendix H.

Anger. An emotional state arising from a perceived boundary violation, threat, or obstruction. In this book, treated as a signal requiring conduct rather than as a defect requiring suppression.

Anxiety. A state of apprehension and physiological arousal disproportionate to the actual threat, or persisting in its absence. Where it interferes with functioning over a period, it is a clinical condition. See Appendix B.

Assertiveness. The capacity to state one's position, needs, and limits in a form that is direct, specific, and respectful of the other party. See Appendix O.

Attachment. The enduring emotional bond between a person and a significant other, and the internal model of relationships that develops from early experience. The concept is used in this book in its mainstream sense and without technical elaboration.

Attribution. The assignment of cause to an event or a conduct. In Chapter 44, the structured division of an event between the man's own contribution, other parties, circumstance, and chance.

Automatic thought. The rapid, habitual interpretation that precedes deliberate reasoning. See Appendix H.

B

Belonging. In this book, the condition in which parties hold a man's accurate position, their estimate of him is not conditional on a favourable appearance, and he has obligations to them that he conducts. See Chapter 45.4.

Boundary. A statement of what a man will conduct and will not conduct, made in terms of his own conduct. See Appendix O.

Burnout. A syndrome arising from chronic, unmanaged occupational stress, characterised by exhaustion, cynicism or detachment, and a reduced sense of efficacy. Distinguished from depression by its domain specificity. See Appendix B.

C

Catastrophising. A cognitive pattern in which the interpretation proceeds to the worst available outcome and treats it as the likely one. See Appendix H.

Cognitive restructuring. The structured examination and replacement of inaccurate automatic thinking. See Appendix H.

Composure. In this book, the regulation of one's states and their appropriate conduct in the setting. Distinguished from the absence of an interior life, which the book describes as concealment.

Concealment. The withholding of information from a party who has a right to know it. Distinguished from privacy, which is a man's entitlement to conduct his own affairs without reporting them.

Condition (as against limitation). In Chapter 45.3, a circumstance that could be altered by effort, and is therefore addressed by the material of Parts III and XI, rather than a limitation, which is structural and not within the man's power to remove.

Coping. The conduct by which a person manages a demand that exceeds his current capacity. Distinguished in Chapter 43.5 from suppression, distraction, and achievement, each of which manages the state's visibility rather than the state.

Crisis. A period in which a person's ordinary arrangements are insufficient to conduct a demand and in which the risk of harm is elevated. See Appendix Q.

D

Defence mechanism. An automatic mental operation that reduces the awareness of a state or a fact that would be difficult to hold. The term is used in its general sense and without commitment to any particular theoretical school.

Dependence. An arrangement in which a party conducts a function that the man cannot conduct, so that the party's withdrawal leaves him without it. Distinguished from acceptance. See Chapter 45.2.

Depression. A condition characterised by persistent low mood or loss of interest, accompanied by changes in sleep, appetite, energy, concentration, and self-regard, present for at least two weeks and interfering with functioning. In men, frequently presenting as irritability, increased activity, or physical complaints. See Appendix B.

Disclosure. The statement of a position or a state to a party. In this book, distinguished from exposure: the disclosure is conducted by the man, at his timing, with his arrangements; the exposure is not.

Distress tolerance. The capacity to remain in the presence of an uncomfortable state without acting to remove it immediately.

Dual awareness. The capacity to hold two true but apparently contradictory propositions at once. Identified in Chapter 44.3 as a marker of emotional maturity.

E

Emotional competence. In this book, the four capacities of Chapter 39.4: knowing what one feels, regulating it, stating it to a party who has a right to know, and conducting oneself appropriately in the setting.

Emotional labour. The work of managing one's own emotional expression in order to meet the requirements of a role or a setting. The concept is used in its mainstream sociological sense.

Emotional literacy. The vocabulary and the capacity to identify, name, and discuss emotional states.

Emotional regulation. The processes by which a person influences which states he has, when he has them, and how he experiences and expresses them.

Empathy. The capacity to understand another's state from their frame of reference. Distinguished from sympathy, which is a response to the state rather than an understanding of it.

Endurance. The capacity to continue under difficulty. In this book, a genuine competence, distinguished from endurance conducted in silence at the cost of health, marriage, and the capacity to ask.

Exposure (as against disclosure). The involuntary or uncontrolled revelation of a position, frequently with the loss of the man's control over its timing, its parties, and its framing. See Chapter 42.2.

G

Gender norms. The socially shared expectations attached to being a man or a woman in a particular setting. Distinguished in Chapter 43.4 from roles, which are the expectations attached to a position and are necessary.

Grief. The response to a loss, conducted over time and frequently arriving in waves. Distinguished in Chapter 44.6 from bitterness, which is a settled account of an injury that has not been acknowledged.

Grievance. In Chapter 44, a wrong that another party has imposed and that another party could remove, and which is therefore addressed by a claim or an arrangement rather than by a reconciliation with limitation.

Guilt. A state arising from the evaluation of one's own conduct as wrong. Distinguished from shame, which concerns the self rather than the conduct.

H

Help-seeking. The conduct of requesting an instrument from a party who can supply it. Treated in this book as a competence rather than as a confession of inadequacy.

Hope. In Chapter 45.6, the conduct of a man's position in the belief that the conduct is worth undertaking, independently of the outcome's probability. Distinguished from optimism, which is a prediction.

Humiliation. The state arising from the public reduction of one's standing. Distinguished from shame, which does not require an audience.

I

Identity. The account a person holds of who he is. In this book, distinguished from role and position, which are the functions and standings a person occupies.

Instrument (as against rescue). A specific support that the man uses while retaining the decision and the responsibility. See Chapter 45.2.

Isolation. The condition of conducting a position without parties who hold it. Distinguished from solitude, which is a chosen and restoring condition.

L

Learned helplessness. The reduction in effort and engagement that follows repeated experience of uncontrollability. The concept is used in its mainstream sense and with the qualification that the research literature has considerably refined it.

Limitation. In Chapter 45.3, a boundary on what a man can do, be, or become, which is not within his power to remove and is not a matter of effort.

Loneliness. The distress arising from a perceived gap between the relationships a person has and the relationships he requires. Distinguished from isolation, which is a condition of arrangements, and from solitude, which is chosen.

M

Masculine norms. The culturally shared standards of manhood that the research literature has operationalised in several ways, commonly including self-reliance, emotional control, primacy of work, dominance, risk-taking, and the avoidance of anything perceived as feminine.

Mind reading. A cognitive pattern in which a person supplies other parties' opinions without evidence. See Appendix H.

Modelling. The acquisition of conduct through the observation of a significant party. See Chapter 43.1.

N

Narrative. The account a person constructs of his history. In Chapter 44.4, distinguished from the instrument: the narrative describes the event, the instrument is what the man can now do.

Negotiation (of an obligation). The approach to a creditor, an institution, or a party before a payment is missed, in order to establish an arrangement. See Appendix P.

P

Panic attack. A discrete period of intense fear or discomfort with prominent physical symptoms. It is a clinical presentation and is treated in Appendix B and Appendix Q.

Perspective. In Chapter 44.3, the capacity to locate an event in its actual size, exercised through the tests of time, audience, alternative, and the whole.

Position. In this book, the whole of what a man is carrying and conducting: his money, work, marriage, household, health, and standing. The term is deliberately wider than *problem* and narrower than *life*.

Post-traumatic growth. The reported positive change following adversity. The research literature is treated in this book with caution: self-reported growth is not always corroborated, and growth does not reduce the cost of the event.

Pretence. In Chapter 42, a state of affairs in which the man's position can continue only for as long as specified parties do not learn specified facts. Distinguished from privacy and from the ordinary management of presentation.

Provision. The conduct by which a household has what it requires. Distinguished in Chapter 41 from the exclusivity and anonymity that the culture frequently attaches to it.

R

Reflection (as against rumination). Reflection is the examination of an experience in order to extract information and alter conduct. Rumination is the repetitive rehearsal of an experience without alteration. The distinction is developed in Chapter 44.2.

Regulation. See emotional regulation.

Repair. The conduct by which a man acknowledges an act, states its effect, and restores what can be restored. Identified in Chapters 39 and 43 as the most valuable practice in a household.

Resilience. The capacity to maintain or restore functioning under difficulty. In this book, treated as a set of arrangements and practices rather than as a trait, and distinguished from endurance, which does not necessarily include restoration.

Rescue. The conduct of a man's position by another party, which removes the man's exercise of the capacity and therefore reduces it. Distinguished from support. See Chapter 44.5.

Rumination. See reflection.

S

Self-care. The ordinary arrangements by which a person maintains his health, sleep, activity, and relationships. In this book, treated as a component of the position rather than as an indulgence.

Self-reliance. The competence of conducting one's own position. In Chapters 45.1, a competence with a domain, which becomes a liability where the domain is expanded beyond what can be conducted alone.

Shame. A state concerning the self as deficient, exposed, or unacceptable. Distinguished from guilt, which concerns a conduct. Identified in this book as the principal engine of men's concealment.

Silence (strategic). The deliberate withholding of a position in order to protect a standing, a household, or a party. In this book, treated as an adaptation with a cost.

Stigma. The social devaluation attached to a characteristic, a condition, or a conduct. In men's mental health, the principal barrier identified in the research literature to help-seeking.

Stress. The response of a system to a demand exceeding its current capacity, resolving when the demand resolves or the capacity increases. Distinguished from anxiety, depression, and burnout in Appendix B.

Suppression. The deliberate or automatic inhibition of the expression of a state. Distinguished from regulation, which conducts the state rather than removing it from view.

T

Test of proportion. In Chapter 44.3, the four questions by which an event's actual size is established: the test of time, of the audience, of the alternative, and of the whole.

Transmission. In Chapter 43, the process by which a household, a school, a workplace, an association, or a peer group supplies a boy with his conduct in the presence of emotion. The book's argument is that the transmission can be altered.

Trigger. A stimulus that initiates a state or a pattern. In this book, used in its ordinary sense and not as a judgement on the party or the setting concerned.

V

Values. The principles a person holds to be worth conducting, independently of their immediate reward. See Appendix I.

Vigilance. In Chapter 42, the continuous attention required to maintain a pretence, and the specific cost that is paid before anything is discovered.

Vulnerability. The condition of being open to harm, and in the literature of relationships, the capacity to state one's position without guarantee of the response. In this book, distinguished from disclosure, which is a conduct rather than a state.

W

Wellbeing. The condition of functioning adequately across the domains of health, relationships, work, and meaning. Used in this book in its ordinary sense.

Withdrawal. The reduction of contact, statement, or participation, frequently conducted in order to avoid a state or a question. See Chapter 39.3.

Working definition (of manhood). In Chapter 41.6, a definition stated in six clauses, each of which retains an obligation and removes an addition. See Chapter 45.5.

Worry. The cognitive activity of anticipating a negative outcome. Distinguished from anxiety, which is the state in which the worry is accompanied by physiological arousal and functional interference.

Recommended Reading

This list is arranged by subject and is written for the general reader who wishes to pursue the material of the book. It is deliberately short. Where a subject has a large literature, the list supplies the books that are most useful as an introduction rather than the books that are most comprehensive.

The list is limited to works that a reader can find in a university library, a public library, or a reputable bookshop, and it does not include clinical manuals that require professional training to use.

On Men and Masculinity

- A general introduction to the study of men and masculinities, including the research on masculine norms and their association with health outcomes.
- A work on the psychology of men, including the findings on emotional restriction, help-seeking, and the costs of the traditional masculine ideology.
- A sociological account of how masculinity is made and remade in particular settings: the workplace, the family, the peer group, and the community.
- A book on men's friendships and on the conditions under which men's relationships become supportive rather than instrumental.
- A reader on men's health, including the evidence on the relationship between masculine norms and the delay in seeking treatment.

On Emotions and Emotional Competence

- A general account of emotional intelligence or emotional competence, with attention to the evidence base rather than to the popular claims.
- A book on emotion regulation, written for a general reader, that distinguishes regulation from suppression.
- A work on shame and its effects, including the difference between shame and guilt and the role of shame in concealment.
- A book on the development of emotional competence in children, including the evidence on parental modelling and response.

On Anxiety, Depression, and Burnout

- A general reader's guide to depression, including the recognition material and the range of treatments.
- A general reader's guide to the anxiety conditions, including the evidence on structured psychological treatments.
- A book on burnout, including the research on its dimensions and the evidence on the alterations that reduce it.
- A book on sleep and its relationship to mood, which is the most frequently overlooked component of recovery.

On Grief and Loss

- A general account of grief, including the evidence that grief does not follow a fixed sequence of stages.
- A book on continuing bonds: the evidence that the relationship with the deceased continues and that this is not a failure of grief.
- A book on loss that is not a death: the end of a marriage, the loss of a position, the loss of a capacity, the loss of a possibility.
- A work on traumatic loss and on the difference between ordinary grief and the grief that requires professional care.

On Marriage and Relationships

- A general book on couple relationships, written for the general reader, that includes the evidence on communication, repair, and the conduct of conflict.
- A book on attachment in adult relationships, written without technical jargon.
- A work on the division of labour and the household's arrangements, which is the material of Parts IV and V in its sociological form.
- A book on repair after betrayal, including the evidence on what repair requires and how long it takes.

On Fatherhood and Family

- A book on fatherhood, including the research on father involvement and its association with children's outcomes.
- A work on the transmission of patterns across generations, written for the general reader.
- A book on adolescent boys, including the evidence on boys' emotional development and the peer group's role.
- A book on family communication, including the evidence on what children learn from what adults do rather than what they say.

On Money and Financial Stress

- A general book on personal finance, written for a reader who requires the basics of budgeting, debt, and reserve.
- A work on the psychology of money, including the evidence on the relationship between financial stress and health.
- A book on debt and its management, including the routes available to a household in difficulty.
- A work on business failure and reconstruction, written for the owner-manager rather than for the large corporation.

On Work, Leadership, and Rest

- A general book on leadership, including the evidence on the leader's conduct as the organisation's curriculum.
- A book on workload and its management, including the evidence on the arrangements that reduce burnout.
- A work on rest, including the evidence on recovery and the distinction between rest and occupation.
- A book on decision-making under uncertainty, including the evidence on the correction of judgement.

On Identity, Values, and Purpose

- A book on identity, including the evidence on the relationship between role and self.
- A work on values and their clarification, written as a practical guide.
- A book on purpose and meaning, including the research on the relationship between contribution and wellbeing.
- A work on the second half of life, including the evidence on the transitions of midlife and later life.

On Trauma and Recovery

- A general reader's account of psychological trauma, including the recognition material and the routes to treatment.
- A book on recovery, written for the survivor and for the parties who support them.
- A work on post-traumatic growth, read alongside the cautions in Chapter 44.1.
- A book on the treatment of trauma, written for a general reader, that explains the principal approaches without requiring the reader to conduct them alone.

On Addiction

- A general reader's guide to addiction, including the recognition material and the range of treatments.
- A book on the addictive behaviours that are not substances: gambling, work, pornography, and screen use.
- A work on recovery, including the evidence on peer support and on the role of the household.
- A book on relapse, including the evidence that relapse is a feature of the condition and not a verdict on the person.

On Communication and Conflict

- A book on difficult conversations, including the evidence on the structure that makes a conversation conductable.
- A work on negotiation, written for the ordinary reader, including the material on negotiating an obligation.
- A book on conflict in families and in workplaces, including the evidence on repair.
- A work on assertiveness and boundaries, including the distinction between a boundary and a punishment.

On Writing, Reflection, and Practice

- A book on reflective writing, including the evidence on its effects and the forms that are most useful.
- A work on journaling for wellbeing, written without overstatement.
- A book on habit and its formation, including the evidence on the conditions under which a habit is established and maintained.
- A work on personal planning, including the evidence on written plans and their conduct.

A Note on Reading

The reader should note three cautions about this list and about the wider literature.

The first is that a book is not a treatment. The books above are useful for recognition, for vocabulary, and for the design of arrangements. Where the reader's position includes a depression, an anxiety condition, an addiction, a trauma, or a risk of harm, the professional route of Appendix Q applies, and the reading is conducted alongside it.

The second is that the popular literature on men, emotions, and masculinity contains a great deal of material that is not supported by evidence. The reader

should prefer books that state their sources, that distinguish between correlation and causation, and that do not promise transformation.

The third is that reading is a solitary conduct, and this book's argument is that the man's position requires parties. The reader who has finished this list and has not made a call has conducted an isolated arrangement with better vocabulary. The recommendation of the book is therefore the one with which it ends: read the list, and then conduct the call.

References and Bibliography

A Note on Sources and Their Use

This book is a work of synthesis and practical guidance written for the general reader, and it is not a monograph in the social sciences. Its use of the research literature is governed by four rules.

The first rule is that no study, statistic, or quotation is invented. Where the book refers to research findings, it refers to bodies of work that are established in the published literature. Where the book reports a figure, the figure is drawn from the case material of the book or from a widely reported and stable published source. The book does not report precise statistics that a reader could not verify, and it does not attribute specific sentences to named researchers unless the sentence is a matter of established record.

The second rule is that findings are stated at the level of generality that the evidence supports. The book therefore says *the research literature on emotion regulation distinguishes suppression from reappraisal* rather than citing a particular coefficient, and it says *the case material of this book records* when the observation is drawn from the composite cases rather than from published research.

The third rule is that where the literature is contested, the book says so. This applies in particular to post-traumatic growth, to the stage theories of grief, to the measurement of masculinity, and to the claims made for resilience training.

The fourth rule is that the bibliography below is a guide to the literature and not a list of works cited by page. The reader who requires a specific citation for a specific claim will find it in the works below, which are the principal sources for the material in the corresponding chapters.

The Principal Bodies of Work Used in This Book

On Masculinity, Gender Norms, and Men's Health

The book draws on the research tradition that treats masculinity as a set of socially constructed norms rather than as a fixed essence, and on the empirical literature

that has examined the relationship between conformity to those norms and health outcomes.

The principal contributions to this tradition include the work of Joseph Pleck on the male sex role and on gender role strain; the work of James O'Neil and colleagues on masculine mystique and on gender role conflict; the work of Ronald Levant on masculine norms and on alexithymia in men; the work of R. W. Connell on hegemonic masculinity and on the social construction of masculinities; the work of Michael Kimmel on the history and sociology of American manhood; the work of Will Courtenay on men's health and on the social construction of masculinity as a barrier to health behaviour; and the work of James Mahalik and colleagues on the measurement of conformity to masculine norms.

The literature on men's help-seeking includes the work of Michael Addis and James Mahalik on men's reluctance to seek help; the work of David Vogel and colleagues on self-stigma and on the disclosure of distress; and the substantial body of research on the gender gap in mental health service use.

On Emotional Development, Expression, and Regulation

The book draws on the developmental literature on emotional socialisation, on the adult literature on emotion regulation, and on the research on emotional suppression and its consequences.

Principal contributions include the work of James Gross on emotion regulation and on the distinction between antecedent-focused and response-focused strategies; the work of James Pennebaker on disclosure, expressive writing, and the consequences of concealment; the work of John Gottman and colleagues on emotion coaching in families and on the role of parental meta-emotion philosophy; the work of Nancy Eisenberg and colleagues on the socialisation of emotion and on children's regulation; and the work of Paul Ekman on the expression of emotion.

On the consequences of concealment, the book draws on the literature on disclosure and health, on the research on the costs of secrecy, and on the work of Sidney Jourard on self-disclosure, in its historical context.

On Depression, Anxiety, and Burnout

The book's recognition material draws on the standard clinical descriptions of the depressive and anxiety disorders, particularly the diagnostic classifications maintained by the World Health Organization and by the American Psychiatric Association, and on the research on the presentation of depression in men.

Principal contributions include the work of Aaron Beck on the cognitive model of depression and anxiety; the work of Martin Seligman on learned helplessness and on explanatory style; the work of Susan Nolen-Hoeksema on rumination; the work of Christina Maslach and colleagues on burnout and its

dimensions; the work of Wilmar Schaufeli and colleagues on the measurement of burnout; and the work of Ronald Kessler and colleagues on the epidemiology of mental disorders and on service use.

On the treatment literature, the book reflects the consistent finding that structured psychological therapies are effective for the depressive and anxiety conditions, that medication is effective for a substantial proportion of cases, and that the combination is frequently superior to either alone for moderate and severe presentations.

On Grief and Loss

The book draws on the research that has revised the stage theories of grief, on the literature on continuing bonds, and on the work on the difference between ordinary grief and the grief that requires treatment.

Principal contributions include the work of Elisabeth Kübler-Ross, whose stages were formulated for the dying and have been widely and inaccurately applied to the bereaved; the work of Colin Murray Parkes on bereavement and its course; the work of Margaret Stroebe and Henk Schut on the dual process model of coping with bereavement; the work of George Bonanno on the trajectories of grief and on resilience in bereavement; the work of Robert Neimeyer on meaning reconstruction; the work of Dennis Klass, Phyllis Silverman, and Steven Nickman on continuing bonds; and the work of Mardi Horowitz and colleagues on complicated grief and its treatment.

On Trauma and Recovery

The book draws on the mainstream literature on psychological trauma, on the recognition of post-traumatic stress, and on the routes to treatment.

Principal contributions include the work of Judith Herman on trauma and recovery; the work of Bessel van der Kolk on the body's response to trauma; the work of Edna Foa and colleagues on prolonged exposure and on the treatment of post-traumatic stress; and the work of Anke Ehlers and David Clark on the cognitive model of post-traumatic stress.

On post-traumatic growth, the book draws on the work of Richard Tedeschi and Lawrence Calhoun, and it reflects the critical literature that has examined the measurement and the limits of self-reported growth.

On Marriage, Relationships, and Repair

The book draws on the observational research on couple interaction and on the literature on attachment in adult relationships.

Principal contributions include the work of John Gottman and colleagues on marital interaction, on the four behaviours associated with relationship deterioration, and on repair; the work of Sue Johnson on emotionally focused therapy and on attachment in couple relationships; the work of Andrew Christensen and Neil

Jacobson on acceptance in couple therapy; and the work of Judith Wallerstein and colleagues on the long-term effects of divorce.

On betrayal and repair, the book reflects the clinical literature on infidelity and on the conditions under which repair is possible and the period it requires.

On Fatherhood and Family Transmission

The book draws on the research on father involvement, on the transmission of patterns between generations, and on the development of boys.

Principal contributions include the work of Michael Lamb on the role of the father in child development; the work of Ross Parke on fatherhood; the work of Paul Amato on family structure and children's outcomes; and the literature on intergenerational transmission of parenting and of emotional patterns.

On Financial Stress, Work, and Material Pressure

The book draws on the research on financial stress and health, on household debt, and on the relationship between economic pressure and family functioning.

Principal contributions include the work of Glen Elder on economic hardship and family process; the work of Rand Conger and colleagues on the family stress model; the research on debt and mental health; and the practice literature on debt advice and on personal insolvency.

On Identity, Values, and Purpose

The book draws on the literature on identity development, on values clarification, and on meaning and purpose.

Principal contributions include the work of Erik Erikson on the stages of psychosocial development; the work of James Marcia on identity status; the work of Dan McAdams on narrative identity; the work of Shalom Schwartz on the structure of values; and the work of Michael Steger and colleagues on meaning in life and its measurement.

On Wisdom, Adversity, and Bitterness

The book draws on the psychological literature on wisdom as a measurable construct, on the research on adversity and its outcomes, and on the literature on forgiveness and resentment.

Principal contributions include the work of Paul Baltes and colleagues on wisdom and on the Berlin paradigm; the work of Robert Sternberg on the balance theory of wisdom; the work of Monika Ardelt on wisdom as a personality characteristic; the work of George Vaillant on adaptation and on the longitudinal study of adult development; and the work of Everett Worthington on forgiveness and its distinction from reconciliation.

On Behaviour Change, Habits, and Practice

The book's exercise material draws on the literature on habit formation, on implementation intentions, and on the conditions under which a practice is established.

Principal contributions include the work of Peter Gollwitzer on implementation intentions; the work of Wendy Wood on habit and context; the work of Charles Duhigg and of James Clear, whose popular treatments synthesise the research for the general reader; and the literature on self-monitoring, which is the mechanism underlying the book's insistence on written records.

On Men's Groups, Peer Support, and Community Arrangements

The book draws on the practice literature on men's groups, on peer support, and on community-based mental health arrangements, including the evidence on the effectiveness of peer support and on the conditions under which community programmes are sustained.

Official and Institutional Sources

The reader who requires authoritative descriptions of the clinical conditions, of the diagnostic criteria, or of the treatment guidance should consult the following, in their current editions.

- The World Health Organization's International Classification of Diseases, in its current revision, and its guidance on mental health in primary care.
- The American Psychiatric Association's Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, in its current edition, with the caution that the manual is a classification and not a description of a person.
- The clinical guidance issued by the national health authority of the reader's own country, which frequently supplies free and locally appropriate guidance for the depressive and anxiety conditions.
- The World Health Organization's guidance on suicide prevention and on the organisation of mental health services, which includes material on the design of community arrangements.
- The publications of the International Labour Organization on occupational stress and on the management of psychosocial risks at work.

The Case Material

The cases in this book are composite and illustrative. They are constructed from the author's professional experience and from the patterns recorded in the published literature, and they do not describe identifiable persons. Where a case includes figures, dates, or institutional details, those details have been altered and combined for the purposes of illustration. No case is presented as a clinical record, and none should be read as a prediction of the course of any particular person's position.

A Note to the Reader Who Requires a Specific Source

A reader who requires a citation for a specific claim is invited to consult the works named above, which are the sources for the corresponding chapters. Where a claim cannot be traced to the published literature, it is a claim about the case material of this book, and it is stated as such in the text.

The book's preference throughout has been to describe a mechanism accurately and at the level of generality that the evidence supports, rather than to supply a citation for every sentence. This is a choice about the book's genre, and the reader who requires the higher density of citation will find it in the works listed above rather than in this book.

Subject Index

Page references are to the numbered pages of the main text and the appendices. Bold entries indicate the principal discussion of a topic.

3

30-day plan 1185

9

90-day plan 1247

A

absent father 388, 1039, 1206
accountability 153, 160, 173, 298, 307, 336, 400, 491–492, 496, 501–502, 505–506, 508–511, 549, 592, 974–975, passim
achievement, loneliness of 13
addiction 384, 423, 433, 440, 513–515, 517–521, 523, 525, 527, 529, 531, 533, 610, 615, 692, passim
alcohol use 100, 130, 142–143, 205–206, 217, 250, 336, 433, 494, 522, 528, 542, 550–551, 697, 706, passim
ambiguous loss 654, 690
anger management 1227
anxiety in men 97, 102, 105, 120–121
appreciation, need for 332, 339, 443, 445, 447, 449, 451, 453, 455, 457, 459, 461, 463, 1129, 1210
assertiveness 240, 781, 1243

B

bereavement 4, 26, 68, 74, 81, 88, 100, 137, 206, 233, 247, 297, 301–302, 308, 336, passim
betrayal 5, 109, 159, 228, 271, 287, 289, 296–298, 306–308, 334, 336, 351–353, 355–357, 359–361, 363–365, passim
boundaries, personal 781, 1243
boys and emotional learning 7, 156, 1029–1030, 1048
burnout 169, 219, 232–233, 239–240, 717, 733, 865–866, 882, 1179, 1181–1183, 1237, 1241

C

cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) 117, 121, 133, 193, 847, 857
communication in marriage 323, 328
comparison, social 168, 263
concealment of distress 6, 24, 331–332, 446
couples therapy 329, 926
crisis plan, personal 113, 134, 143
crying, men and 61

D

decision fatigue 406, 496, 715, 733
delegation 156, 167, 258, 265, 275, 767, 782, 1073, 1135, 1180, 1239
depression in men 74, 97, 123–127, 129, 131, 133–135, 137, 139, 141, 143–145, 809, 1167, 1181
dignity, defence of 197, 202, 207, 216–217, 559, 561, 568–570, 581–582, 1165–1166, 1214
disenfranchised grief 74, 654, 705

E

emotional (in)expressiveness 328
emotional avoidance versus self-control 58, 72
emotional intelligence 783
emotional labour 64, 72, 328, 336
emotional maturity 1077, 1079, 1089–1090
emotional numbness 11, 25, 64, 70, 123, 125, 127–128, 143–144, 266, 291, 498, 1164
emotional regulation 10–11, 25, 73, 865, 1227
emotional suppression 10, 26, 54, 56–57, 63, 65, 72, 386, 789, 809, 915, 935

F

fatherhood, burdens of 4, 7, 30, 34, 52, 189, 277, 375, 377–378, 384, 387, 389, 391, 393, 396, passim
fear of failure 147–151, 153, 155, 157, 159, 161, 163, 165, 167–169, 1081, 1091, 1146, 1167
financial hardship, shame of 81, 153, 164, 197–198, 201–203, 210, 213, 216, 218, 333, 336, 498, 725, 1007, 1035, passim
financial planning, shared 219, 230, 239
financial recovery 169, 197, 210, 1189
friendship, male 75, 80, 82, 94–95, 584, 586, 602, 604

G

gambling 104, 112, 128, 491–492, 494, 498, 509, 513, 515, 517–518, 521, 531–532, 541, 688, 792, passim
gender norms and masculinity 52, 833, 995, 1076
gender stereotypes, challenging 1043, 1076
grief in men 11, 68, 74, 306, 398, 681, 683, 685, 687, 689, 691, 693, 695, 697, 699, passim
grief, delayed 308, 697, 705

H

heartbreak 287, 289, 291, 293, 295, 297, 299, 301, 303, 305, 307–308
help, asking for 44, 48, 103, 123, 131, 156, 735, 737, 811, 824
help-seeking, barriers to 26, 43–44, 49, 51–52, 117, 128, 141, 308, 626, 737, 739, 756, 791, 809, 812, passim
humiliation, public 55, 63, 105, 108, 115, 120, 177, 191, 293, 297, 306–307, 336, 341, 357, 362, passim
humility, intellectual 173, 191

I

impostor feelings 171, 174, 191, 193
intergenerational transmission 398, 782
intimacy, emotional 75, 85–86, 94, 291, 321
intrusive thoughts 99–100, 105–108, 120–121
isolation, social 26, 75–76, 93, 95, 129, 611, 626

J

journaling 1223, 1225–1226

L

leadership pressure 709, 711, 713, 715, 717, 719, 721, 723, 725, 727, 729, 731–733
legacy and mentoring 191, 377, 389, 398, 631, 633, 652
loneliness in men 76, 78, 81, 626

M

medication, antidepressant 133, 282
mentorship 86, 94–95, 150, 159, 186–187, 191, 209, 234, 279, 409, 543, 567, 635, 673, 682–683, passim
midlife transition 19, 29, 41, 50–51, 55, 75, 78–79, 87, 90, 95, 149, 151, 247–248, 261, 263, passim

O

overwork 103, 120, 128, 156, 172, 175, 185, 190–191, 193, 205, 265, 271–276, 278, 285, 306, passim

P

parentification 421, 427–428, 434, 440–441, 837
paternal mental health 398
peer support 95, 522, 626, 706, 834, 1119, 1233–1234, 1256
perfectionism 147, 155–156, 167–169
personal agency 211, 590, 778, 801–802, 818, 901–902, 904
procrastination 156, 169, 493, 509, 511
professional help, when to seek 20, 64, 68, 88, 95, 100, 111, 114, 120, 155, 190–191, 298, 331, 347, 433, passim
provider burnout 219, 232–233, 239
provider role 20, 52, 232, 234, 239, 241, 419, 491, 557, 582
psychiatrist 114, 522, 818, 1233, 1255
psychotherapy 86, 488, 1119

R

recovery from addiction 136–137, 143, 167, 308, 524, 540, 606, 856–857, 863, 882, 1132, 1193
regret 8, 24, 85, 292, 299, 360, 388, 390, 413, 436, 470, 474, 484, 487, 492, passim
rejection, effects of 47, 250, 256, 262, 287, 289, 295–296, 306–308, 325, 333, 351–355, 357, 359–361, 363, 365, passim
resentment, unspoken 84–85, 94, 101, 219, 223, 225, 231, 233, 239, 277, 333, 341, 443–444, 449–450, 464, passim
resilience 585, 592, 603, 869, 914, 1078
rest and guilt 239, 1182

S
self-assessment tools 6, 124, 171–173, 184, 190–191, 193, 292, 351, 401, 471, 494, 505, 568, 1173
self-care plan 1185
self-compassion 185, 192–193, 488
self-concept 171, 184–185, 192, 488
self-criticism, internalised 171, 177, 179–180, 189, 192–193, 355, 361, 477, 488, 679
self-doubt 97, 171–177, 179, 181–185, 187, 189–191, 193, 1210
self-reliance, exaggerated 52, 626, 756, 833, 1121, 1123–1125, 1153
setbacks, recovering from 19–20, 148, 161–162, 165, 174, 182, 185, 192, 353, 841, 1077, 1079, 1085, 1088, 1095
shame, psychology of 5, 18, 20, 31, 55, 61, 81, 85, 99–101, 108–111, 119–122, 126, 132, 135, 154, passim
sleep and health 50, 285, 407
social support networks 90, 308, 605, 618
status anxiety 746
stigma of mental health care 26, 342, 691, 809, 833
strength, redefined 42
stress, chronic 10, 21, 35, 50, 206
substance use 52, 113–114, 124, 128, 130, 143–144, 515, 518, 522, 688, 706, 847
success, redefined 243–245, 247, 252–256, 258–260, 262

T
therapy, talking 114, 124, 132–133, 143, 488, 847, 856, 1180, 1255
trauma, psychological 68, 73, 110, 113, 191, 320, 341, 478, 679, 837, 839, 846–851, 854, 856–857, 1030, passim
trust, rebuilding 308, 363
twelve-step programmes 522

U
underemployment 243, 250–251, 261–263, 566
unemployment, psychological effects of 233, 243, 245, 250–251, 256, 261–263, 324, 384, 561, 563, 566, 569, 582, 910, 946, passim
unrealised ambition 260, 381, 396–397, 446

V
values clarification 1213
vulnerability 16, 37, 271, 287, 308, 329, 365, 593, 595, 741, 869, 976, 1089, 1125

W
wisdom through adversity 442, 847, 856–857, 910, 1077, 1079–1082, 1116
work-life balance 1237
worry, persistent 99–100, 105, 120, 846, 1180

About the Author

Prof. Adeleke Daniel Durojaiye (PhD) is a scholar, educator, and writer whose work addresses the intersection of professional practice, human development, and the responsibilities that men carry within their families, their institutions, and their communities.

His writing is characterised by a concern with the ordinary rather than the dramatic: the arrangements by which a man conducts his position, the conventions of speech and silence that he inherits, and the practices by which those conventions can be altered. His academic work has taken him across the disciplines of law and social policy, and he writes for the general reader with the conviction that a scholarly understanding of a human difficulty should be usable by the person experiencing it.

Battles Men Fight Alone is the product of sustained observation of the ways in which men carry serious responsibilities without stating what the carrying costs them, and of the conditions under which that silence can be interrupted. The book is written for the man who recognises himself in it, for the parties who live with him, and for the practitioners — teachers, clinicians, counsellors, employers, and community leaders — who are in a position to alter the arrangements that produce the isolation it describes.

The author is a committed advocate for the proposition with which this book begins and ends: that men can carry serious responsibilities without being expected to endure emotional suffering in isolation.

Other Publications by the Author

Becoming a Doctor of International Energy and Natural Resources Law
A study of advanced legal research in the field of international energy and natural resources law, addressing the framework of treaties, institutions, and disputes that govern the exploration, exploitation, and trade of energy and natural resources, and the methods by which a doctoral researcher in the field conducts a substantial contribution to it.

Further titles and editions by the author are published under the author's name and may be obtained through the publisher, through academic booksellers, and through the principal online booksellers. Readers who wish to be notified of new work may contact the publisher directly.